The Immense Ocean

al-Baḥr al-madīd fī tafsīr al-Qurʾān al-majīd

Ibn ʿAjība al-Ḥasanī (d. 1224/1809)

English translation, Qurʾānic Arabic and technical terms · author's preface, al-Fātiḥa, al-Baqara, Āl ʿImrān, and al-Nisāʾ through 4:176.

Cairo Arabic copytext: Aḥmad ʿAbd Allāh al-Qurashī Ruslān, 1419/1999, I:49–601. English translation and apparatus based on Revision XVI, with later XVII–XVIII critical research retained.

> **Editorial position, October 2026.** The English translation is complete and covers all 389 commentary units, including the preface and full al-Fātiḥa. Qurʾānic coverage, 241 Cairo editorial notes, translator annotations, index and source dossiers have been assembled and structurally checked. Thirty-seven recorded textual and interpretive questions remain documented. The Arabic copytext is based on Ruslān; source comparisons, including Dilaver Selvi's Turkish translation, do not establish independent manuscript readings. Manuscript collation, human specialist review and physical printer's proof remain outstanding. The published translation should therefore be called a scholarly Cairo-based edition, not a definitive manuscript-critical text.

How to read this volume

Each Qurʾānic unit gives its Arabic wording and English translation, followed by Ibn ʿAjība's discussion. Topic labels such as *Language*, *Outward commentary*, *Legal commentary* and *Spiritual allusion* are modern reading aids, not new divisions claimed for the author's Arabic. For uninterrupted reading, the accompanying HTML reader can hide these divisions without suppressing the text.

Authorial commentary, authorial quotations, Cairo editorial notes and translator's annotations are distinguished. An earlier source may explain an unusual phrase without proving a different authorial reading. Unresolved wordings are retained, not silently emended.

Editorial and manuscript status

Already undertaken	Still required
Complete English through 4:176; Cairo copytext aligned; analytical and topical indices; source dossiers; Turkish comparative review	Obtain and collate independent manuscripts; establish manuscript relationships and readings
Principal difficulties registered; quotations, notes, and Qurʾānic locators indexed	Resolve manuscript-dependent readings; external specialists; physical print proof and licensing checks

Subject routes into the commentary

These 12 thematic paths supplement the complete analytical index, indices of people and works, poetry, technical terms, source studies and Qurʾānic contents preserved in the main volume. References give stable sūrah/verse locators.

Reading revelation and acquiring knowledge

- Outward explanation and inward allusion — preface; 3:7–9; 1:7
- Revelation, inspiration and spiritual disclosure — 2:1; 3:44; 3:73–74
- Recitation as understanding, action and presence — 2:2; 2:3; 2:121
- Knowledge that transforms its possessor — 2:30–33; 2:44; 2:128–129

Language, grammar, rhetoric and readings

- Roots, derivation and technical definition — Introductory discussion; 3:92; 3:96–97
- Nominal predication, definiteness and substitution — Introductory discussion; 2:2; 2:177
- Fronting, restriction and changes of address — Introductory discussion; 2:40–43; 3:83
- Alternative speakers, ellipsis and parenthesis — 2:187; 2:234–235; 3:73–74

God, creation and metaphysical principles

- Divine unity and the rejection of rivals — 2:21–22; 2:23–25; 2:163–164
- The Names: lordship, mercy, life and self-subsistence — Introductory discussion; 2:255; 3:26–27
- The world as sign and dependent existence — Introductory discussion; 2:116–117; 2:186
- Origination, sustaining influx and the divine command — Introductory discussion; 2:21–22; 2:116–117

Prophets, scripture, covenant and religious identity

- Adam: knowledge, temptation and renewed vocation — 2:30–33; 2:34; 2:35–37
- Abraham: testing, leadership and surrender — 2:124; 2:125; 2:128–129
- Moses and Israel: deliverance, lapse and instruction — 2:49; 2:50; 2:51–53
- Mary, Zachariah and the formation of a sacred household — 3:33–37; 3:38–41; 3:42–43

Worship, prayer, remembrance and pilgrimage

- Worship and the dependence of the worshipper — Introductory discussion; 2:21–22; 3:42–43

- Al-Fātiḥa, the basmala and Āmīn in prayer — Introductory discussion
- Establishing prayer and guarding inward presence — 2:3; 2:45–46; 2:143–144
- Remembrance and the inward sanctuaries — 2:19–20; 2:114; 2:151–152

Moral formation and purification of the self

- Sincerity against hypocrisy and display — 2:8–10; 2:14–16; 2:198–199
- Humility against pride, self-satisfaction and contempt — 2:13; 2:34; 2:58–59
- Disciplining desire without destroying the instrument — 2:50; 2:54; 2:220
- Patience, truthfulness and constancy — 2:45–46; 2:153–157; 2:214

Spiritual realization and degrees of knowledge

- From Islam and faith to excellence — 2:2; 2:127; 2:189
- Certainty: hearing, proof, witnessing and direct vision — Introductory discussion; 2:118–119; 2:248
- Journeying, arrival and continuing ascent — Introductory discussion; 2:4–5; 2:189
- Effacement and subsistence; gathering and distinction — 2:28; 2:55–56; 2:116–117

Companionship, teaching and spiritual authority

- The qualified guide and the work of transmission — preface; 2:104; 2:135
- Spiritual nurture, aspiration and inherited formation — 2:128–129; 2:151–152; 2:233
- Veneration without confusing the guide with God — 2:215; 3:61–63; 3:64
- Recognition is not a demand for spectacle — 2:14–16; 2:106–107; 2:108

Law, justice and communal order

- Law and Reality: neither can cancel the other — Introductory discussion; 2:38–39; 2:177
- Abrogation, clarification and legal reasoning — 2:106–107; 2:180–182; 2:183–185
- Judgment, testimony and the rights of others — 2:188; 2:282; 2:283
- Leadership, fitness and the public good — 2:124; 2:142; 2:246

Wealth, work, generosity and worldly attachment

- Different callings and a single inward orientation — 2:139–141; 2:142; 2:150
- Lawful provision, need and moderation — 2:168–169; 2:172–173; 2:219
- Trade, lending, debt and investment — 2:275–279; 2:280–281; 2:282
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- Marriage, belief and formative companionship — 2:221; 2:222–223
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Providence, trial, death and the Hereafter

- Providence without abandonment of duty — 2:49; 2:150; 2:210
- Trial as purification and formation — 2:124; 2:153–157; 2:214
- Causes, extraordinary events and human limits — 2:102–103; 2:108; 2:243
- Bodily death, martyrdom and spiritual death — 2:28; 2:54; 2:153–157

The full 63-heading analytical index is in the scholarly volume. The HTML reader adds links for 226 names, 68 works and 182 poetic incipits. These guides are modern editorial tools, not an exhaustive Arabic word concordance.

IBN ʿAJĪBA

The Immense Ocean

al-Baḥr al-madīd fī tafsīr al-Qurʾān al-majīd

Volume I

Author’s preface through al-Nisāʾ 4:176

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Page numbers refer to this English volume. References to the Cairo edition accompany the passages. The indexes include subjects, people, works, poetry, thematic contents and selected Arabic terms.

Text and references

This volume comprises the author’s preface and the first four sūrahs, ending at al-Nisāʾ 4:176.

The Cairo text is the copytext. Brackets and textual notes identify supplied words, difficult constructions and differences from cited sources. A parallel in another work may clarify meaning without establishing Ibn ʿAjība’s exact authorial wording.

The Cairo editor’s notes appear as footnotes. Translator’s annotations are called by T-numbers and collected in the appendix; R-numbers refer to the report-source register. The author’s statements, his quotations and the annotations carry their respective attributions.

“Spiritual allusion” denotes the inward application following the outward exposition. Technical terms and Qurʾānic readings receive explanation where needed. The textual appendix discusses unresolved constructions and the limits of the available evidence.

Author’s Preface

Author’s preface

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 49–51

Outward commentary · The transmitted opening

In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful. God bless our master Muḥammad, his family and his Companions, and grant them peace.

The shaykh, imam, eminent and resolute scholar, God-knowing master and divinely sustained pole, exemplar of wayfarers and beacon of those who have arrived, ocean of gnosis and dawning-place of the sun of direct vision, broad highway of the Path, who unites the Sacred Law with the ocean of Reality—Abū al-ʿAbbās Aḥmad ibn Muḥammad ibn ʿAjība al-Ḥasanī, may God be pleased with him and grant him His good pleasure, amen—said:[P01]

Theology · The divine speech and the sciences of interpretation

We praise You, O You who disclose Yourself to Your servants in Your speech, in the perfection of Your splendour and beauty; who loose the tongues of consummate scholars to bring forth its pearls and precious gems, and cause springs of wisdom to gush from their hearts, sustained by its principles and foundations. As they dive into its current, they draw benefit from its unique treasures and reiterated teachings. With its dazzling signs and its manifest, overwhelming proofs, they refute the doubts of those who oppose and resist it. Yet all acknowledge their inadequacy, each drawing from the ocean of its mysteries and meanings according to the understanding and facility granted him. It is the surging ocean whose bottom cannot be reached, the delightful garden never without blossom or flower. And how could it be otherwise, when it is the speech of our Master, who knows hidden things, what has been, what now is, and what is to come?

Blessings and peace be upon our master and patron Muḥammad, the manifestation of mercies, sent with wonders that breach the customary order (خوارق العادات) and the radiance of clear proofs; and upon his family and Companions, the possessors of generosity and open-handedness, mountains of certainty amid intensifying crises and ever more difficult perplexities.

To proceed: the science of interpreting the Qurʾān (علم تفسير القرآن) is among the noblest sciences, and among the best pursuits upon which to expend the fruits of reflection and the inventive powers of understanding. Yet none should advance to this momentous undertaking except the consummate scholar whose feet are firmly planted in the outward sciences (العلوم الظاهرة) and whose thought has ranged through the Qurʾān's resplendent meanings. He must first have drunk deeply of outward learning: Arabic grammar, morphology, lexicography and rhetoric, jurisprudence, hadith and history —having received these from the mouths of men. He must then have plunged into the sciences of Sufism (علوم التصوف), in tasting, state and station (ذوقًا وحالًا ومقامًا), through the companionship of perfected people of spiritual tasting (أهل الأذواق). Otherwise, silence concerning this tremendous matter is safer for him, and occupation with whatever he can manage of the outward Sacred Law is more fitting.

Know that the mighty Qurʾān has an outward aspect (ظاهر) for the people of the outward and an inward aspect (باطن) for the people of the inward. The interpretation offered by the people of the inward is tasted only by the people of the inward: others neither understand it nor taste it. Nor is it sound to set it forth before establishing the outward meaning. Thereafter one may indicate inward knowledge through a delicate expression and a subtle allusion (إشارة). Let anyone whose understanding does not reach the tasting of those mysteries yield assent, rather than hasten to deny them. For the knowledge of spiritual tastings (علم الأذواق) lies beyond the compass of discursive intellects and is not attained through the successive transmission of reports.[P02]

Outward commentary · The inward sense does not abolish the outward sense

He says in *Laṭāʾif al-minan*: "Know that this community's interpretation"—meaning the Sufis—"of the speech of God and of His Messenger, God bless him and grant him peace, through unfamiliar meanings is not a diversion of the outward sense from its outward meaning. Rather, the outward aspect of the verse conveys what the verse was revealed for and what it indicates in the language's expression.

“There are also inward understandings apprehended on hearing a verse or a hadith by those whose hearts God has opened. It has been related that he, blessings and peace be upon him, said: ‘Every verse has an outward aspect, an inward aspect, a limit, and a point of ascent (ظاهر وباطن وحدّ ومطّلع).’ Do not let a contentious opponent turn you away from receiving unfamiliar meanings from them by saying, ‘This diverts the speech of God, mighty and majestic, and the speech of His Messenger, God bless him and grant him peace.’ It is no such diversion. It would be a diversion of God’s speech only were they to say, ‘The verse has no meaning except this.’ They do not say that. Rather, they confirm the outward senses in their outward meanings, intentions and proper applications, and understand from God what He has enabled them to understand.” End of quotation.[P03]

Saʿd al-Dīn says in his commentary upon al-Nasafī’s *Creed*, after refuting impious distortion (الإلحاد): “As for the view of certain realized authorities that scriptural texts retain their outward meanings, while also containing hidden allusions to realities unveiled to the people of wayfaring, which can be reconciled with the intended outward senses, this is of the perfection of faith and pure gnosis.”[T1] His words “can be reconciled,” and what follows, mean that these realities may be indicated within the inward dimension of the discourse in such a way that the discourse’s secret sense does not reject them, and the wording is not wholly remote from them, which would amount to distortion (تحريف).

Shaykh Zarrūq, may God be pleased with him, said: “The Sufi’s consideration is more particular than that of the exegete and the interpreter of hadith: each of those considers the ruling and the meaning, and no more, whereas the Sufi adds the search for the allusion after affirming what they have affirmed. Otherwise he is an esotericist (باطني), outside the Sacred Law, let alone the Sufis. And God knows best.” End of quotation.

Language · Outward aspect, inward aspect, limit and point of ascent

Concerning his saying, blessings and peace be upon him, “Every verse has an outward aspect, an inward aspect, a limit, and a point of ascent”: the outward aspect belongs to those concerned with the wording’s outward form, such as the grammarians, lexicographers and morphologists. The inward aspect belongs to those concerned with the wording’s meaning and what the discourse indicates of command, prohibition, narratives, reports,

the affirmation of divine unity (التوحيد), and the other sciences of the Qurʾān. This is the exegetes' consideration. The limit (الحدّ) belongs to those concerned to derive rulings from it—the jurists—who stop at what the wording indicates and the purpose for which it is expressed, without adding to it. The point of ascent (المطّلع) belongs to the people of realities (أهل الحقائق), the great Sufis: they look through the verse's outward aspect into its inward aspect, and mysteries, sciences and subtle matters are unveiled to them, disclosed when they exercise contemplative reflection (الفكرة) upon it.[P04]

He says in *al-Ṣiḥāḥ*: "In the report, 'from the terror of the place of arrival (المطّلع),' the affairs of the Hereafter upon which one is about to look are likened to a *muṭṭalaʿ*, that is, a place of approach. One says, 'Where is the muṭṭalaʿ of this affair?' meaning, 'Where is its point of approach?' It is the place from which one looks down from a height." End of quotation. For the people of realities look from the verse's outward aspect into the mysteries of its inward aspect, and dive into the surging depths of its ocean. And God Most High knows best.

Outward commentary · The commission and arrangement of this commentary

Now my shaykh, the God-knowing, divinely nurtured master Sīdī Muḥammad al-Būzīdī al-Ḥasanī, and likewise his shaykh, the all-embracing pole, master of masters, Mawlāy al-ʿArabī al-Darqāwī al-Ḥasanī, charged me to compose a commentary uniting the interpretation of the people of the outward with the allusion of the people of the inward. I answered their request and fulfilled their wish, hoping that its benefit would extend widely, and that it would delight hearts and ears. For each verse I place first the important matters of Arabic expression and language, then the outward meanings of its words, and then the inward allusions, steering a middle course between prolixity

and excessive brevity. In all this I await whatever is opened to me from the treasuries of the Generous, the All-Forgiving. I have called it *al-Baḥr al-madīd fī tafsīr al-Qurʾān al-majīd—The Vast Ocean: An Interpretation of the Glorious Qurʾān*. We ask God to clothe it in the robe of acceptance and bring to fulfilment the purpose for which it is hoped. He has power over

whatever He wills and is worthy to answer. There is no power and no strength except through God, the Most High, the Tremendous. God bless our master Muḥammad, his family and his Companions, and grant them peace.

In my larger commentary upon al-Fātiḥa I have set out ten introductions concerning the principles of the sciences and their branches, and the sciences of the Qurʾān and the sources from which they spring. Let anyone who desires them consult them there. And success is through God.

Sūrat al-Fātiḥa

Sūrat al-Fātiḥa — introduction, names and background

Cairo I:52–70

Outward commentary · Introduction: names and verse-counting

I:52

It is Meccan. It has ten names: the Opening (الفاتحة); the Complete (الوافية); the Sufficient (الكافية); the Healing (الشافية); and the Seven Oft-Repeated (السبع المثاني). It is called the Seven Oft-Repeated because, according to al-Shāfiʿī, it consists of seven verses with the basmala counted among them, whereas Mālik does not count the basmala and makes “not those upon whom wrath has fallen, nor those who are astray” the seventh verse; or because it is repeated in every prayer; or because it contains praise of God (الثناء), with an evident play upon the name al-mathānī. It is also called the Mother of the Qurʾān (أم القرآن), because it is the Qurʾān's opening and beginning, or because it contains in summary what the Qurʾān contains, as will be explained; the Sūrah of Praise and Thanksgiving; the Sūrah of Teaching How to Ask; the Sūrah of Prayer, because it is repeatedly recited therein; and the Foundation of the Qurʾān, because it is its root and beginning, upon which the rest is built.

Al-Fātiḥa 1:1 — commentary

Cairo I:52–70

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمنِ الرَّحِيمِ (1)

“In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful.”

Legal commentary · The basmala: Qurʾānic status and evidence

The written copies of the Qurʾān agree in opening it with “In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful.” The imams disagree concerning this formula. Mālik said that it is not a verse of al-Fātiḥa or of any other sūrah, except in al-Naml alone. Al-Shāfiʿī said that it is a verse of al-Fātiḥa alone. Ibn ʿAbbās said that it is a verse of every sūrah.

Mālik's evidence is the authentic report in which the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, said: “A sūrah has been sent down to me whose like is not in the Torah, the Gospel, or the Criterion.” He then said, “Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds,” without mentioning the basmala. There is likewise the authentic report that God says: “I have divided the prayer between Myself and My servant into two halves. The servant says, ‘Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds.’” He thus begins with this, without the basmala.

Al-Shāfiʿī's evidence is the authentic report that the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, used to recite: “In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful. Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds.” Ibn ʿAbbās's evidence is that the basmala is written with every sūrah in the written copy of the Qurʾān, despite the Companions' care not to introduce anything into it other than God's speech. They said: “What is between the two covers is God's speech.”

Legal commentary · Recitation and prayer rulings

When you begin at the opening of a sūrah, recite the basmala, except in Barāʾa [al-Tawba], which will be discussed in its place. When you begin within a sūrah, the majority give you a choice. When you complete one sūrah and begin another, the Qurʾānic readers differ over whether to recite or omit the basmala.

As for its ruling in prayer, Mālik said that it is disliked in obligatory prayer, but not in voluntary prayer. Al-Shāfiʿī said that it is obligatory and that omitting it invalidates the prayer. According to him, therefore, one recites it aloud in audible prayer and silently in silent prayer. With Abū Ḥanīfa it is likewise, except that he recites it silently in every case. Mālik's evidence that it is not a verse is the authentic report from Anas, who said: “I prayed behind the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, Abū Bakr, ʿUmar,

and ʿUthmān, and they used to begin with ‘Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds,’” not mentioning the basmala at all. Al-Shāfiʿī's evidence that it is a verse, in his view, is the report of its recitation already mentioned.

Outward commentary · History of the written formula

I:53

The basmala was not in use before Islam. People used to write, “In Your Name, O God,” until “In the Name of God is its sailing” [11:41] was revealed, whereupon they wrote, “In the Name of God.” Then “or call upon the All-Merciful” [17:110] was revealed, and they wrote, “In the Name of God, the All-Merciful.” Finally, “and it is: In the Name of God, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful” [27:30] was revealed, and they wrote it in this form.

Language · Grammar and derivation of the basmala

The alif of ism in bism is omitted because of frequent usage. The preposition bāʾ is connected to an elided governing element (متعلِّقة بمحذوف). According to the Basrans, the ellipsis is nominal: “My beginning is [made] in the Name of God” (ابتدائي كائن بسم الله), so its syntactic locus is nominative (موضعها الرفع). According to the Kufans, the ellipsis is verbal: “I begin” or “I recite,” so each speaker supplies the action for which the basmala is made the beginning, and its syntactic locus is accusative (موضعها النصب). The omitted element is understood after the basmala in order to convey restriction (الحصر) and exclusive specification (الاختصاص).

According to the Basrans, ism (“name”) is derived (مشتق) from sumuww (“elevation”), with the final radical - the lām of the root (لام الكلمة) - omitted. According to the Kufans it is derived from sima (“mark, sign”; السِّمة، أي العلامة), with the first radical - the fāʾ of the root (فاء الكلمة) - omitted. The Basrans appeal to the diminutive (التصغير) and the broken plural (التكسير): one says asmāʾ, not awsām, and sumayy, not wusaym.

“God” (الله) is a proper name (عَلَم) for the Essence that is Necessary in Existence (الذات الواجبة الوجود) and deserving of every praise. Whether the name is derived (مشتق) or independently coined (مرتجل) is disputed. The two positions will be discussed under “Praise belongs to God,” as will the names al-Raḥmān and al-Raḥīm.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says:

Al-Fātiḥa 1:2–4 — commentary

Cairo I:52–70

الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ رَبِّ الْعالَمِينَ (2) الرَّحْمنِ الرَّحِيمِ (3) مالِكِ يَوْمِ الدِّينِ (4)

“Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds, the Compassionate, the Merciful, Master of the Day of Recompense.”

Language · Al-ḥamd: syntax, definiteness and readings

I say: “Praise” (الحمد) is the subject (مبتدأ), and “belongs to God” (لله) is the predicate (خبر). Its underlying construction is accusative (النصب), and it has in fact been recited that way; the underlying expression is “I praise God with praise” (أحمد الله حمداً). It was shifted from the accusative to the nominative (الرفع) in order to signify the universality and abiding stability of praise, rather than its renewed occurrence and origination. The form also teaches the very words to be uttered while intimating God's independence of their praise: praise belongs to God even if you do not praise Him. Had He said, “I praise God,” this meaning would not have been conveyed. Ḥamd is one of those verbal nouns (المصادر) that are put in the accusative by implicit verbs (أفعال مضمرة) which are scarcely ever expressed alongside them.

The definite article (التعريف) may be generic (للجنس): it then denotes the reality as such, without making its universal extension a condition, and points to what everyone already recognises praise to be. Or it may be exhaustive (للاستغراق): in reality every praise belongs to God, since there is no good that He does not bestow, either through an intermediary or without one, as He says, “Whatever blessing you have is from God” [16:53]. Or it may be referential (للعهد), the referent being God's praise of Himself in His beginningless eternity.

“Praise belongs to God” has also been recited with the vowel of the dāl made to follow that of the lām, and conversely (بإتباع الدال للام وبالعكس), treating the two, because of their habitual conjunction, as though they were a single word. [1] [2]

Language · Praise and thanksgiving: technical meanings

I:53–54

In the language (في اللغة), praise (الحمد) is commendation of what is beautiful, intended as magnification and reverence. In technical usage (في العرف), it is an act that discloses magnification of a benefactor precisely insofar as he is a benefactor. Thanksgiving (الشكر), in the language, is an act that signifies magnification of the benefactor and is therefore synonymous with ḥamd in that technical sense. In technical usage, however, shukr is the servant's directing everything God has bestowed upon him - hearing, sight, and the rest - toward the purpose for which it was created and bestowed. See our larger commentary on al-Fātiḥa for the relations (النِّسَب) among these meanings, which we set out there in verse and prose.

Language · Allāh: the name and its derivation

I:54

“God” (الله) is, on this view, an independently coined (مرتجل), underived (جامد) name; the alif and lām are integral to the word and are not the definite article. Al-Wāḥidī said: “It is a name with which the Creator - glory be to Him - is uniquely named; in describing Him it functions as a proper name, and no derivation is known for it.” Al-Uqlīshī said: “If this name is not derived, it signifies the very Essence without considering in it any particular attribute. It is not a name derived from an attribute, like the Knowing, the Real, the Creator, or the Provider.” On this account the alif and lām in Allāh belong to the word itself, just as the zāʾ belongs to Zayd. A number of scholars held this view; al-Ghazālī preferred it and said that everything proposed by way of derivation is strained.

1. Cairo editor, C53.1: With a kasra [the i vowel]; this is a noncanonical reading.
2. Cairo editor, C53.2: That is, making the lām follow the dāl in taking a ḍamma [the u vowel]; this too is a noncanonical reading.

It has also been said that Allāh is derived from taʾalluh (التألّه), worship or devotion; or from walahān (الولهان), bewilderment, because intellects are bewildered concerning Him. Another view is that its original form was al-ilāh: the hamza was omitted, its vowel transferred to the lām, assimilation (الإدغام) then occurred, and the lām was pronounced emphatically in magnification, except when preceded by kasra.

Language · Rabb: nurture, lordship and meaning

"Lord" (ربّ, rabb) is an adjective qualifying (نعت) "God." In origin it is a verbal noun (مصدر) meaning nurture or bringing-up (التربية): bringing a thing to its perfection little by little. It is then used descriptively for intensification, as are ṣawm ("fasting") and ʿadl ("justice"). It is also said to be a descriptive form from rabbahu yarubbuhu, "he tended it / nurtured it"; its original form is rabab, after which assimilation (الإدغام) occurs. An owner is called rabb because he preserves what he owns and nurtures it. The term is not applied to anyone other than God without qualification, as in "Return to your lord" [12:50]. Ibn Juzayy said: "It has four meanings: deity, master, owner, and one who sets things right. All four are suitable in 'Lord of the worlds,' though the strongest meaning is 'deity,' because that is peculiar to God Most High."

Language · ʿĀlam: the cosmos as a sign of its Maker

"The worlds" (العالمين) is the plural of ʿālam (عالَم). Ibn ʿAjība explains the word morphologically: al-ʿālam is "a noun for that by which something is known" (اسم لما يُعلَم به), just as khātam is that by which something is sealed and ṭābiʿ that by which something is stamped. The term came to be used predominantly for that by which the Maker is known (ما يُعلَم به الصانع): everything other than Him, comprising substances (الجواهر) and accidents (الأعراض). Because they are contingent or possible (لإمكانها) and stand in need of an efficient cause (مؤثِّر) that is Necessary in Itself (واجب لذاته), they signify His existence. Thus the cosmos functions as a sign (علامة) of its Maker, although Ibn ʿAjība's wording here is literally "that by which [He] is known." The plural is used to include the differing genera contained beneath the term. Rational beings are given grammatical precedence, so it is pluralised with yāʾ and nūn like their other descriptions. It is therefore a true plural (جمع), not a collective noun (اسم جمع), contrary to Ibn Mālik.

It is also said that the term was coined for beings possessed of knowledge - the angels and the two weighty species (الثقلان), humankind and jinn - and that it includes other beings only by concomitant extension (على سبيل الاستتباع). Another view is that humankind is intended here: every human being is a world (عالَم), since he contains counterparts of what exists in the greater world (العالم الكبير). Hence revelation places contemplation of the two on the same footing: “And in your own selves - do you not see?” [51:21].

I:55

I say: to this the poet alludes:
O you who wander in a wilderness, estranged from your own secret,
look: you will find all existence within yourself.
You are perfection, in the Way and in the Reality,
you who gather within yourself the divine secret in its entirety.

Language · Al-Raḥmān and al-Raḥīm: form and meaning

Al-Raḥmān (الرَّحمن, “the Compassionate”) and al-Raḥīm (الرَّحيم, “the Merciful”) are two intensive forms (اسمان بُنيا للمبالغة) derived from raḥima, “to have mercy,” as ghaḍbān is formed from ghaḍiba and ʿalīm from ʿalima. In ordinary language, mercy (الرحمة) is tenderness of heart and an inclination that entails graciousness and beneficence; from the same root comes raḥim, “womb,” because of its tender enclosing of what is within it. The divine Names, however, are taken with regard to their ends (الغايات), which are acts, not their beginnings (المبادئ), which in creatures would be passive affections (انفعالات).

Al-Raḥmān (الرَّحمن) is more intensive than al-Raḥīm (الرَّحيم), because increase in morphological form indicates increase in meaning (زيادة المبنى تدل على زيادة المعنى), as with qaṭṭaʿa and qaṭaʿa. This increase may be understood quantitatively or qualitatively. Quantitatively one says: “Compassionate in this world,” because that mercy encompasses believer and unbeliever, “and Merciful in the hereafter,” because that mercy is particular to believers. Qualitatively one says: “Compassionate in this world and the hereafter, and Merciful in this world,” because all blessings of the hereafter are immense, while worldly blessings include both great and small.

Al-Raḥmān is placed first, although the normal progression (الترقي) would be from the lesser to the greater, because the mercy of this world comes first and because al-Raḥmān has become like a proper name (كالعَلَم), inasmuch as none other is described by it. Its meaning is the true Benefactor whose mercy reaches its utmost limit, and this is true of none but God Most High. See al-Bayḍāwī. The two Names will be discussed again in the running interpretation.

Language · Malik and mālik: readings and annexation

"King" (مَلِك, malik) is an adjective (نعت) qualifying what precedes. The majority recite it without alif, from mulk (المُلك, sovereignty), with ḍamma; ʿĀṣim and al-Kisāʾī recite mālik (مالِك, master/owner) with alif, from milk (المِلك, possession), with kasra. On the latter reading the ellipsis is understood as "Master of the coming of the Day of Recompense," or "Master of the affair on the Day of Recompense." Ibn ʿAjība prefers the majority reading for three reasons: first, a king is greater than an owner, for anyone may be called owner of his property whereas the king is master of the people; second, "His is the sovereignty on the day the Trumpet is blown" [6:73]; and third, the reading malik requires no ellipsis (حذف), whereas ellipsis is contrary to the default (خلاف الأصل). [3]

"The Day of Recompense" (يوم الدين) is an adverbial expression (ظرف) annexed (مضاف) to what precedes by an extended construction (على طريق الاتساع). The adverbial is treated syntactically like a direct object (مفعول به), while the meaning remains adverbial: "the King on the Day of Recompense." Or, on the mālik reading, the sense is "Master of the affair on the Day of Recompense," in which case an ellipsis (حذف) is posited. Both readings - the short form malik and the long form mālik - are transmitted from the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace.

3. Cairo editor, C55.1: There should be no preference for one reading in this matter, given that both readings are transmitted from the Messenger, God bless him and grant him peace. The two readings—as al-Ālūsī says—are two evenly matched racehorses; whenever you seek to prefer one, the proofs oppose one another.

I:56

Malik has been recited in several other ways which Ibn ʿAjība omits because they are anomalous (شاذة). If one objects: “Malik and mālik are indefinite (نكرة), because an active participle's annexation (إضافة اسم الفاعل) does not make it specific; how then can either qualify al-Raḥmān al-Raḥīm, which are definite (معرفة)?” The answer is that an active participle's annexation fails to specify only when it denotes present or future time, for then the annexation is non-pure (إضافة غير محضة). Here the meaning is continuously and eternally true, so the annexation is pure (إضافة محضة). This is Ibn Juzayy's explanation.

Outward commentary · Praise and lordship

The Real, glorious is His majesty, teaches His servants how to praise and magnify Him and then to ask of Him: “My servants, say: ‘Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds.’” That is: beautiful praise is deserved only by the Magnificent, the Majestic. None other deserves praise, since in reality there is no benefactor but God: “Whatever blessing you have is from God” [16:53]. Or: all praises whatsoever belong to God. Or: the praise already known to the mind is God's praise of Himself in His beginningless eternity, before He brought His creation into existence. When He brought His creation into existence, He said to them, “Praise belongs to God”: that is, “Praise Me with that praise already known in beginningless eternity.”

He alone deserves praise because He is “Lord of the worlds.” It is as though someone asked Him, “Why does praise belong exclusively to You?” and He answered: “Because I am Lord of the worlds. I brought them into existence through My mercy and sustain them through My bounty. There is no benefactor but Me, and so I alone deserve praise. From Me comes their being brought into existence, and upon Me rests their continually renewed sustenance. I am the Lord of the servants. All the worlds, with their many genera and differing species, are in My grasp and under My nurture and care.”

Outward commentary · Reports on the worlds and the angelic hosts

Some have said that God created eighteen thousand worlds, half on land and half in the sea. Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī said: “It has been related that the children of Adam are one tenth of the jinn; the children of Adam and the

jinn together are one tenth of the land animals; all these are one tenth of the birds; all these are one tenth of the sea animals; all these are one tenth of the angels of the earth charged with the children of Adam; all these are one tenth of the angels of the lowest heaven; and all these are one tenth of the angels of the second heaven. This progression continues to the angels of the seventh heaven.

"All of these, in comparison with the Footstool, are very few. These in turn are one tenth of the angels of a single pavilion among the hundred thousand pavilions of the Throne. Were the heavens and the earth, and all within and between them, compared with the length and breadth of one pavilion, they would be a very small and trifling thing. There is not a handspan of space without an angel prostrating, bowing, or standing, with a resounding voice glorifying God and declaring His unity. Then all these, in comparison with those who move around the Throne, are like a drop in the sea. None but God Most High knows their number: 'None knows the hosts of your Lord but He' [74:31]." Here ends the quotation.

Wahb ibn Munabbih said: "The Throne has three hundred and sixty-six supports. Between each pair of supports are sixty thousand deserts; in each desert are sixty thousand worlds; and each world is the size of the two weighty kinds."

I:56–57

All these worlds are in the grasp of the Real, beneath His nurture and preservation. He conveys sustaining influx (المدد) to each in its settled abode and place of deposit: to its spiritual dimension through the strength of sciences and gnoses (العلوم والمعارف), and to its bodily dimension through the strength of corporeal forms (الأشباح). From the Throne to the earth, their provisions are apportioned, their lifespans delimited, their bodily forms preserved, and their locations known. Nothing on earth or in heaven is hidden from Him; He is the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing.

Outward commentary · Mercy, origination and sustaining influx

I:57

This nurture (التربية) by which He nurtures His creation is mercy and beneficence from Him, not something binding or obligatory upon Him. Hence He joins to "Lord of the worlds" the words al-Raḥmān al-Raḥīm: the Compassionate through the blessing of bringing-into-existence (نعمة الإيجاد), the

Merciful through the blessing of sustaining influx (نعمة الإمداد). As the Ḥikam says: “Two blessings no existent is without, and every originated being must have them: the blessing of being brought into existence and the blessing of sustaining influx. He first favoured you with existence, then followed it with successive sustaining influx.” [4]

His Name al-Raḥmān entails the bringing of things into existence and their manifestation (الإيجاد والإبراز); His Name al-Raḥīm entails their nurture and sustaining influx (التربية والإمداد). Hence the Name al-Raḥmān may not be applied to anyone else, and no one has been named by it, because bringing into existence is not truly possible from other than Him. Al-Raḥīm differs: it may be applied to another, since the issuing of sustaining assistance from some creatures appears, metaphorically and by borrowed attribution, to be shared.

Or: He is al-Raḥmān in this world and the hereafter, and al-Raḥīm in the hereafter, because the mercy of the hereafter is particular to believers. Or: al-Raḥmān with respect to the great blessings (جلائل النعم) and al-Raḥīm with respect to their subtleties (دقائقها). The great blessings include Islam, faith (الإيمان), spiritual excellence (الإحسان), gnosis (المعرفة), guidance, unveiling the veil, opening the door, and entrance among the beloved; subtler blessings include health, well-being, lawful wealth, and the other things to be mentioned under “those upon whom You have bestowed favour.”

Outward commentary · Sovereignty on the Day of Recompense

He from whom bringing into existence and sustaining truly proceed deserves to be King over all the servants. This is therefore mentioned immediately afterwards: “King of the Day of Recompense.” He disposes of His servants as He wills: none can repel what He decrees, and none can withhold what He gives. He is King of kings and Lord of lords in this abode and the next.

Sovereignty is associated particularly with the Day of Recompense, the day of requital, because on that day God's sovereignty becomes plainly manifest to all creation. God Most High discloses Himself to judge between His servants, so that believers see Him directly. In this world, by contrast, His disposal of affairs is understood only by the perfected among the believers.

4. Cairo editor, C57.1: By Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh al-Iskandarī.

Many of the ignorant have therefore claimed sovereignty and attributed it to themselves. On the Day of Resurrection, God's sole sovereignty is evident to both the elect and the common people. God Most High says: “Whose is the sovereignty today? God's, the One, the All-Subduing” [40:16].

Spiritual allusion · Divine self-disclosure and self-praise

When the Real, glory be to Him, disclosed Himself (تجلّى) from the realm of jabarūt (عالم الجبروت) into the realm of malakūt (عالم الملكوت) - or, one may say, from the realm of the unseen into the realm of witnessing - He praised Himself by Himself, glorified Himself by Himself, and declared His own unity by Himself. How fine are al-Harawī's words:

I:57–58

No one has declared the One to be One,
for everyone who declares Him One is a denier.
The tawḥīd of one who speaks from his own description
is a borrowed thing annulled by the One.
His declaring Himself One is His tawḥīd;
the description of whoever describes Him deviates. [5]

I:58

Thus, affirming His own unity by Himself, and expressing Himself by Himself, He said: “Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds.” It is as though He says in the heading of His Book and the secret of His address: “I am the Praiser and the Praised. I sustain every existent. I am Lord of lords and, for whoever understands the address, the Cause of causes. I am Lord of the worlds, Sustainer of the heavens and the earths. Indeed, I am alone in My existence, disclosing Myself to My servants through My generosity and bounty. All the worlds are established through My establishing them, and effaced through the absolute oneness of My Essence.”

5. Cairo editor, C58.1: The purport of the verses, as Shaykh Ibn ʿAjība says in Īqāẓ al-himam, is that the Real Himself undertook to affirm His own oneness. Thus anyone who claims that he has affirmed His oneness by himself denies His oneness, because he has associated himself with Him; and anyone who describes Him by himself is lāḥid—that is, one who deviates from what is right. This is one of the meanings in whose light these verses should be understood. The verses admit other interpretations mentioned by the learned Ibn al-Qayyim; let us consult his Madārij al-sālikīn. See also Madārij al-sulūk by Abū Bakr Bannānī.

A man said in al-Junayd's presence, “Praise belongs to God,” without adding “Lord of the worlds.” Al-Junayd said to him, “Complete it, my brother.” The man replied, “What standing do the worlds have, that they should be mentioned with Him?” Al-Junayd said: “Say it, my brother. When that which has come to be is placed alongside the Beginningless, that which has come to be vanishes, and the Beginningless remains.”

He says, glory be to Him [in this spiritual interpretation]: “O you who are near to Me, ponder My secret, for it is wondrous. I am the Lover and I am the Beloved; I am the Near and I am the Answerer. I am the Ever-Merciful, the All-Merciful; I am the King, the Requiter. I am All-Merciful through the blessing of bringing into existence, and Ever-Merciful through the succession of sustaining gifts. From Me comes the bringing into existence, and upon Me rests continual sustaining. I am Lord of the servants. I am the King, the Requiter, rewarding goodness with goodness. I am King without qualification — were it not for the ignorance of the people of obstinacy and dissension! For those of humankind who understand Us, command belongs to Us perpetually.”

He says in the Greater Epistles: “What counts is not the outward appearances of things, but the hidden secret. This consists in the manifestation of the affair of the Real, the lifting of its covering, and the removal of its veils and concealment. When that self-disclosure and manifestation are realised, when effacement and passing away overcome things, and darkness is dispersed by the shining of the light, there the eye of certainty appears and the manifest Truth stands established. Then the claims of the claimants are nullified, just as ordinary people understand their nullity on the Day of Recompense, when sovereignty belongs to God, Lord of the worlds. Would that I knew at what time sovereignty belonged to another, so that it should be qualified by His saying, ‘Sovereignty on that day belongs to God’ [22:56], or ‘Command on that day belongs to God’ [82:19]! Were it not for the vast claims of diseased hearts!” Here ends the quotation. [6]

I:59

He then descended to the exposition of servanthood (العبودية), saying:

6. Cairo editor, C58.2: By Ibn ʿAbbād al-Nafzī, the commentator on the Ḥikam.

> **Translator's source note · Cairo I:55–56:** Ruslān prints mālik, "Master" or "Owner," in the Qurʾānic heading. Ibn ʿAjība explains both canonical readings and prefers malik, "King."

Al-Fātiḥa 1:5 — commentary

Cairo I:52–70

إِيَّاكَ نَعْبُدُ وَإِيَّاكَ نَسْتَعِينُ (5)

"You alone we worship, and from You alone we seek help." [1:5]

Language · The fronting of iyyāka and the worshipper's orientation

I say: "You alone" (إياك, iyyāka) is the direct object (مفعول) of "we worship" (نعبد). It is fronted (قُدِّم) for magnification and special attention, and to indicate restriction or exclusivity (الحصر); hence Ibn ʿAbbās said: "We worship You and worship none other with You." Its fronting also places first what is first in existence: the Sovereign who is worshipped (الملك المعبود). It alerts the worshipper that his regard should be directed first and essentially to the One worshipped (المعبود), and only from Him to the worship - not considering it merely as an act that proceeds from himself, but as a noble relation (نسبة شريفة) to Him and a bond (وصلة) between himself and the Real. The gnostic's arrival (وصول العارف) becomes true only when he is absorbed in attending to the Holy Presence and absent from everything besides It, so that he observes neither himself nor any state of himself except insofar as it is a self-disclosure (تجلٍّ) from His self-disclosures and a locus manifesting His Lordship (مظهر لربوبيته). For this reason what God relates of His Beloved - "Do not grieve; God is with us" [9:40] - is superior to what He relates of His interlocutor Moses - "Indeed, my Lord is with me; He will guide me" [26:62] - insofar as the latter explicitly states the object sought.

Likewise, "You alone" (إياك) is the direct object (مفعول) of "we seek help" (نستعين), and it too is fronted for exclusive specification (الاختصاص) and attention. The pronoun is repeated instead of saying, "You alone we worship and seek help," because making it explicit a second time is stronger in

manifesting reliance upon God, more decisive in bringing attachment and turning to God into presence, and more perfect in praise. Thus “Through You I prevail, through You I seek protection, and through You I attain my aims” is more forceful and laudatory than “Through You I prevail and seek protection,” and so forth.

Outward commentary · Why worship precedes asking for help

Worship is placed before seeking help so that the endings of the verses correspond, and to make it known that putting forward the means of approach before asking for one’s need is more conducive to receiving an answer. One who has entered the king’s service and begun to perform it to the extent of his capacity, then asks the king’s assistance in it, receives what he asks. This differs from one whom the king charges with his service and who says, “Give me what will help me perform it”: that is discourtesy. Moreover, one who brings those mighty attributes to mind cannot but hasten to submission and worship. Again, when the speaker ascribes worship to himself, this might suggest boasting and self-congratulation over what proceeds from him. He therefore follows it with “and You alone we ask for help,” to dispel that suggestion.

Language · Worship, assistance and the plural “we”

Worship (العبادة, ʿibāda) is the utmost limit of submission and self-abasement; hence ṭarīq muʿabbad means “a road made low and submissive [by being trodden].” Seeking help (الاستعانة, istiʿāna) is requesting assistance. What is intended is assistance in all important affairs, or specifically assistance in performing acts of worship.

The pronoun implicit in the two verbs refers to the reciter together with the guardian angels accompanying him and those present at the congregational prayer; or to him together with all other existing beings. He incorporates his worship into the midst of theirs, and mingles his need with theirs, in the hope that his worship will be accepted through its blessing and his need answered. It is for this reason that congregational prayer was prescribed. So said al-Bayḍāwī. **Source comparison:** Cairo I:59 reads لسائر الموجودين, “all other existing beings.” The inspected electronic text of al-Bayḍāwī, *Anwār al-tanzīl*, I:29, on Q1:5, instead has لسائر الموحدين, “all other affirmers of God’s unity.” The difference

changes the proposed scope of the plural “we”: Cairo gives a wider company than this source witness. The translation follows Cairo; establishing whether the difference arose in Ibn ʿAjība’s adaptation or in transmission requires further textual evidence.

Outward commentary · Worship and dependence upon God

I:60

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says, completing His instruction of His servants: “When you have praised Me, glorified Me, and magnified Me, acknowledge My lordship, manifest servanthood in yourselves, and ask My assistance at every moment. Say: ‘You alone we worship, and You alone we ask for help.’” It is as though, when He mentioned that He deserves all praise, from eternity and in time, because He is the Lord and Sustainer of the worlds, the origin of all roots and their branches, who first bestowed existence upon them and then a continuous supply of support, and who therefore possesses them absolutely, He went on to declare that none besides Him deserves worship. For there is in reality no benefactor but God. He therefore has the greatest claim to be worshipped, and is most worthy to be made the sole object of orientation and intent. He is wholly independent and draws support from no other. The sustaining supply comes from the very fountain of munificence; were that supply cut off, existence would cease.

Spiritual allusion · The shift to direct address and spiritual presence

Al-Bayḍāwī said: “When the One truly deserving praise had been mentioned and described with mighty attributes by which He is distinguished from all other essences, knowledge became attached to a determinate object of knowledge. He was therefore addressed directly: ‘O You whose affair is thus, we single You out for worship and for seeking help.’ This more strongly indicates exclusive specification (الاختصاص), and it marks an ascent from absence/third-person reference (الغيبة) to witnessing (الشهود): as though what had been known became directly seen, what had been intellectually apprehended became witnessed, and absence became presence. The opening of the discourse is built upon the beginnings of the gnostic's state: remembrance (الذكر), reflection (الفكر), contemplation of His Names, consideration of His favours, and inference from His works to the greatness of His affair and the splendour of His sovereignty. It is then followed by the culmination of his affair: that he plunge into the sea of arrival (لجة الوصول), be-

come one of the people of witnessing (أهل المشاهدة), see Him directly, and converse intimately with Him face to face. O God, make us among those who arrive at the Reality itself (العين), not those who merely follow the trace (الأثر)." **Source comparison:** Cairo I:60 has دون التابعين للأثر, "rather than those who follow the trace." The inspected electronic text of al-Bayḍāwī, *Anwār al-tanzīl*, I:29, on Q1:5, reads دون السامعين للأثر, "rather than those who hear of the trace." Both contrast arrival with an indirect relation to its evidence, but the source witness specifies hearing where Cairo specifies following. The translation retains Cairo's wording and records the difference without choosing an unverified authorial reading.

"It is the Arabs' custom to vary their speech and pass from one mode of expression to another, refreshing and enlivening the hearer. Thus they move from direct address to the third person, and from the third person to the first, as in His saying, 'Until, when you are in ships and they sail with them upon a wind …' [10:22]. He did not say 'with you.' And in His saying, 'He sent the winds, which stir up clouds, and We drove them to a land …' [35:9]": that is, He did not say, "and He drove them." Consult his discussion in full.

The rhetorical shift (الالتفات, iltifāt) here occurs in "You alone we worship." He did not say "Him alone we worship," although the apparent continuation of the preceding discourse would have been in the third person (الغيبة). The beauty of the shift lies in the fact that the One described has now become determinate and present.

Theology · Divine aid and human action

Al-Uqlīshī said: "This is the verse concerning which the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, said: 'When the servant says, "You alone we worship, and You alone we ask for help," God Most High says, "This is between Me and My servant, and My servant shall have what he asks."' Its meaning is: 'Whichever servant turns to Me in worship and asks My assistance in it, his worship is accepted, and My assistance in it is assured to him, so that he may perform it as it should be performed.' Worship is the servant's attribute, and assistance is from God Most High to the servant. For this reason He said, 'This is between Me and My servant.'"

Ibn Juzayy said: "That is, we ask Your assistance in worship and in all our affairs. This is evidence of the falsity of the positions of the Qadariyya and the Jabriyya, and that the truth lies between the two."

Spiritual allusion · Wisdom and power; effacement and subsistence

I:61

When the Real, glorious is His majesty, disclosed Himself from the realm of jabarūt (عالم الجبروت) to the realm of malakūt (عالم الملكوت), and praised Himself by Himself, He also disclosed Himself and descended from the realm of malakūt to the realm of mulk (عالم الملك) through His power (القدرة) and wisdom (الحكمة), in order to manifest the traces of His Names and Attributes. He manifested servanthood (العبودية) and concealed Lordship (الربوبية); He manifested wisdom and concealed power. He thus made the realm of wisdom (عالم الحكمة) address the realm of power (عالم القدرة), submit to it, worship, draw from it assistance and guidance, and seek protection from the path of error and misguidance.

The realm of wisdom (عالم الحكمة) is the locus of legal-moral responsibility (محل التكليف), while the realm of power (عالم القدرة) is the locus of divine disposal (محل التصريف). The realm of wisdom is the realm of bodily forms (عالم الأشباح), and the realm of power the realm of spirits (عالم الأرواح). “You alone we worship” belongs to the people of the realm of wisdom; “from You alone we seek help” to the people of the realm of power. Hence Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī, may God be pleased with him, said: “‘You alone we worship’ is Sacred Law (شريعة); ‘from You alone we seek help’ is Reality (حقيقة). ‘You alone we worship’ is islām; ‘from You alone we seek help’ is iḥsān. ‘You alone we worship’ is worship (عبادة); ‘from You alone we seek help’ is servanthood (عبودية). ‘You alone we worship’ is distinction/separation (فرق); ‘from You alone we seek help’ is gathering/unification (جمع).”

Or, if you wish: “‘You alone we worship’ belongs to those who act for God (العمل لله), the sincere; ‘from You alone we seek help’ belongs to those who act through God (العمل بالله), the people of tawḥīd. Acting for God brings reward; acting through God brings nearness. Acting for God brings realisation of worship; acting through God brings rectification of the will. Acting for God is the attribute of every worshipper; acting through God is the attribute of every seeker. Acting for God is standing by the rulings governing outward things; acting through God is standing by the rectification of inward consciences.” So said al-Qushayrī.

People are three classes with respect to witnessing power (شهود القدرة) and wisdom (الحكمة). One class is veiled by wisdom from witnessing power: these are the veiled among the heedless, who stop with “You alone we worship.” A second class is veiled by witnessing power from wisdom: these are the people of effacement (أهل الفناء), who stop with “from You alone we seek help.” A third class is veiled neither by wisdom from power nor by power from wisdom: they give every possessor of a right his right and every possessor of a share his due. These are the perfected among the people of subsistence (أهل البقاء), who combine “You alone we worship” with “from You alone we seek help.” Success is through God.

He then explained the greatest aim and the most important thing sought: asking for guidance (الهداية) and divine enabling (التوفيق) to the very essence of realisation (عين التحقيق). He said:

Al-Fātiḥa 1:6 — commentary

Cairo I:52–70

اهْدِنَا الصِّرَاطَ الْمُسْتَقِيمَ (6)

“Guide us upon the straight path.” [1:6]

Language · Guidance and the straight path: language and readings

I:61–62

I say: Guidance (الهداية, hidāya) originally means indicating or directing with gentleness (الدلالة بلطف), and for that reason it is normally used of what is good. “Guide them to the path of Hell” [37:23] is therefore ironic or derisive (على التهكم). The verb is hadā (هدى). Its normal construction takes the preposition li- or ilā; here it governs a direct object without a preposition, by analogy with “Moses chose his people” [7:155]. Ṣirāṭ (الصراط), in the language, means “road.” It is derived from saraṭa al-ṭaʿām, “he swallowed the food,” as though the road swallowed its travellers, those passing along it. The sīn was changed to ṣād to harmonise with the emphatic ṭāʾ (الإطباق); it

may also be pronounced with an admixture of zāy because their points of articulation are close. Mustaqīm (المستقيم) means “having no crookedness.” What is intended is the path of the Real (طريق الحق) that brings one to God.

Spiritual allusion · The straight path: Sacred Law and Reality

I:62

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says, teaching His servants how to seek Him and what they ought to seek: Say, “Guide us” - direct us to the straight path that brings one to the Presence of bliss (حضرة النعيم). The straight path is outwardly to travel according to the Muḥammadan Sacred Law (الشريعة المحمدية), and inwardly to divest oneself of any claim to power or strength of one's own (التبرّي من الحول والقوة). Or say: it is that your outward be Sacred Law (شريعة) and your inward Reality (حقيقة); your outward servanthood (عبودية) and your inward freedom (حرية); distinction (الفرق) present outwardly, and gathering (الجمع) witnessed inwardly. In the Ḥikam: “When He makes you outwardly obedient to His command and inwardly surrendered to His overpowering might, He has bestowed an immense favour upon you.”

The straight path that the Real commands us to seek is the conjunction of Sacred Law and Reality (الجمع بين الشريعة والحقيقة), understood from “You alone we worship, and from You alone we seek help.” Hence He joins the petition for guidance directly to those words. It is as though the Real, glorified is He, says: “My servants, praise Me and glorify Me, make Me alone your aim, and single Me out in worship. Outwardly occupy yourselves with My worship; inwardly seek assistance through My power and strength. Or outwardly observe the courtesies of My service; inwardly witness My power and the majesty of My Lordship.”

Our master ʿAlī, may God ennoble his countenance, said: “The straight path here is the Qurʾān.” Jābir, may God be pleased with him, said: “It is Islam,” meaning the generous, upright religion (الحنيفية السمحاء). Sahl ibn ʿAbd Allāh said: “It is the path of Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace,” meaning following what he brought. The substance of these statements is what preceded: rectifying the outward through Sacred Law (الشريعة) and the inward through Reality (الحقيقة). This is the straight path; whoever travels it is among those who arrive and are brought near (الواصلين المقربين), together with the prophets and the utterly truthful.

Spiritual allusion · Why the guided continue to ask for guidance

If you ask: when the servant is already proceeding upon this straight way, how can he ask for what he already possesses? The answer is that he asks for firmness in what he has attained and guidance to what he has not attained. The people of the station of islām ask for steadfastness in the islām already attained and ascent (الترقي) to the station of īmān not yet attained. This follows Sufi usage, which assigns outward action specifically to the station of islām and inward action to the station of īmān. The people of īmān ask for steadfastness in the īmān attained and ascent to the station of iḥsān not yet attained. The people of iḥsān ask for steadfastness in iḥsān and ascent into the endless unveilings of gnosis (كشوفات العرفان): “Above every possessor of knowledge is one more knowing” [12:76].

I:62–63

Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī, may God be pleased with him, said: “‘Guide us upon the straight path’: by making us firm in what is attained, and directing us towards what is not attained.” Then he said: “The generality of believers say, ‘Guide us upon the straight path,’ meaning: by making us firm in what is attained and directing us towards what is not attained. They have attained the affirmation of unity, but the degrees of the righteous have escaped them. The righteous say, ‘Guide us upon the straight path,’ meaning: we ask You to make us firm in what is attained and direct us towards what is not attained. They have attained righteousness, but the degrees of the martyrs have escaped them. The martyrs say, ‘Guide us upon the straight path,’ meaning: by making us firm in what is attained and directing us towards what is not attained. They have attained martyrdom, but the degrees of the utterly truthful have escaped them. The utterly truthful say, ‘Guide us upon the straight path,’ meaning: by making us firm in what is attained and directing us towards what is not attained. They have attained the degrees of the utterly truthful, but the degrees of the Pole have escaped them. The Pole says, ‘Guide us upon the straight path’: by making him firm in what is attained and directing him towards what is not attained. He has attained the rank of the Pole, but there remains knowledge which, if God wills to acquaint him with it, He acquaints him with.” Here ends the quotation.

I:63

Someone said: “Guidance is either to the Reality itself (العين) or to the trace (الأثر) that indicates the Reality; the first has no end.” I say: the first belongs to the people of witnessing and direct vision (أهل الشهود والعيان), the second to the people of proof and demonstration (أهل الدليل والبرهان). Guidance to the Reality itself is direction to God; guidance to the trace is direction to works. “Whoever directs you to God has counselled you sincerely; whoever directs you to works has wearied you.” The first has no end because ascent (الترقي) after gnosis (المعرفة) has no end. Direction to the trace is otherwise: its end is arrival (الوصول) at the Reality itself, provided the guide knows the path.

Outward commentary · Al-Bayḍāwī’s four kinds of guidance

Al-Bayḍāwī said: “God’s guidance takes forms beyond numbering: ‘If you count God’s blessing, you will not enumerate it’ [14:34]. Yet these fall within successively ordered kinds:

“The first is the bestowal of the faculties through which a person is enabled to find his way to what benefits him, such as the intellectual faculty, the internal senses, and the external organs of perception.

“The second is the establishment of indications distinguishing truth from falsehood, and soundness from corruption. This is indicated by His saying, ‘We guided him upon the two high ways’ [90:10], and ‘We guided them, but they preferred blindness to guidance’ [41:17].

“The third is guidance by sending messengers and sending down scriptures. This is meant by His saying, ‘We made them leaders, guiding by Our command’ [21:73], and ‘This Qurʾān guides towards that which is most upright’ [17:9].

“The fourth is that He should uncover the mysteries from their hearts and show them things as they are, through revelation, inspiration, and true dreams. The attainment of this is particular to the prophets and the saints. This is meant by His saying, ‘Those are they whom God guided; so follow their guidance’ [6:90], and ‘Those who strive in Us, We shall surely guide them upon Our ways’ [29:69].

I:64

“What is sought is therefore either an increase in the guidance already bestowed upon them and steadfastness in it, or the attainment of the degrees consequent upon it. When the gnostic who has arrived says it, he means by his words: ‘Direct us upon the path of journeying in You, that You may efface from us the darknesses of our states and remove the coverings of our bodies, so that we may be illumined by the light of Your holiness and see You through Your light.’” Here ends the quotation.

Outward commentary · Ibn ʿAjība’s clarification: journeying, arrival and ascent

I say: His wording under “the fourth” is awkward (في عبارته قلق) and overly compressed. The sounder expression would be: “The fourth is that He unveil from their hearts the darknesses and all other-than-God (الظُّلَم والأغيار), cause lights and mysteries (الأنوار والأسرار) to shine upon them, and show them things as they are through revelation and inspiration, and through employing reflection upon the majesty of the all-knowing King, until the lights of the meanings (أنوار المعاني) dominate the sensible aspect of the vessels (حسّ الأواني).” Then one should say: “This is a kind whose attainment is particular to prophets and saints.”

As for his words, “When the gnostic who has arrived says it...,” the sounder wording is: “When the disciple who is journeying (المريد السائر) says it.” For from one who has arrived (الواصل), all darknesses, coverings, and other turbidity have been effaced: God Most High has covered his description with His Description and his attribute with His Attribute, so no dark attribute remains to him. Moreover, “Direct us to the path of journeying (طريق السير)” suits the traveller (السائر), not one who has arrived. The one who has arrived has nothing left but ascent (الترقي); in Sufi technical usage (اصطلاح الصوفية), “journeying” (السير) is used only for what precedes arrival (الوصول). God Most High knows best.

He then explained the straight path, saying:

Al-Fātiḥa 1:7 — commentary

Cairo I:52–70

صِراطَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمْتَ عَلَيْهِمْ غَيْرِ الْمَغْضُوبِ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلا الضَّالِّينَ (7)

"The path of those whom You have blessed, not those upon whom wrath has fallen, nor those who are astray." [1:7]

Language · Substitution, qualification and negation

I say: the second "path" (صراط) is a substitute (بدل) for the first - specifically, substitution of the whole for the whole (بدل الكل من الكل). It is, in effect, like repeating the grammatical governor (العامل), since the substitute is what is ultimately intended by the syntactic relation (المقصود بالنسبة). Its function is confirmation (التوكيد) and explicit specification (التنصيص), in the strongest and most emphatic manner, that the path of the Muslims is the path attested to be straight. He makes the second phrase an explanation and clarification of the first, as though this were self-evident and without obscurity: the straight path is the path of the believers. "Not those upon whom wrath has fallen" (غير المغضوب عليهم) may itself be a substitute (بدل) for "those" (الذين), meaning that those blessed are precisely those kept safe from wrath and error. Or it may be an explanatory or restrictive adjective (صفة مبيِّنة أو مقيِّدة): they combine the unrestricted blessing - the blessing of faith - with safety from wrath and error. This grammatical analysis is sound only on one of two interpretations: either the relative expression (الموصول) is treated like an indefinite (النكرة), since no previously identified group (معهود) is intended, as with the formally definite expression in the poet's words, "Indeed, I pass by the base fellow who reviles me..." [7]

7. Cairo editor, C64.1: This is one hemistich; its continuation is: "I passed on, then said: it is no concern of mine."

Or ghayr (غير, “other than/not”) is treated as definite (معرفة) because it is annexed to something having a single contrary - namely, the one blessed - and so it becomes determinate in the way “motion, other than rest” is determinate. Otherwise the construction would require a definite noun (المعرفة) to be qualified by an indefinite adjective (النكرة). Reflect upon it.

I:65

Wrath (الغضب) is the soul's agitation with the will to take vengeance. When attributed to God Most High, what is intended is its end-result (غايته): punishment. “Upon them” (عليهم) stands as the deputy subject (نائب فاعل) of the passive participle al-maghḍūb. The lā in “nor” is pleonastic/additional (مزيدة) for strengthening the negation already contained in ghayr, as though He had said: “neither those upon whom wrath has fallen nor those who are astray.” ʿUmar, may God be pleased with him, recited, “and other than those who are astray.” Error (الضلال) is turning aside from the even path, deliberately or mistakenly. It has a very broad extension, and the distance between its lowest and highest degrees is great. So said al-Bayḍāwī.

The bestowal of favour is ascribed to God, whereas wrath is expressed in the passive, to teach courtesy: “Whatever good befalls you is from God …” [4:79], and the rest of the verse.

Outward commentary · The recipients of divine favour

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says, explaining the straight path: “It is the path of those upon whom I have bestowed favour through guidance, uprightness, and general and special gnosis: the prophets, the utterly truthful, the martyrs, and the righteous.” “Those upon whom favour has been bestowed” is unrestricted in the verse. It applies to everyone favoured with gnosis and uprightness in his religion, such as the Companions and their like. It has been said that the followers of our master Moses, peace be upon him, before the distortion are intended. It has also been said that the followers of our master Jesus before the alteration are intended. The sound determination is that its meaning is general.

Outward commentary · Kinds of blessings

Al-Bayḍāwī said: “Although God’s blessings are innumerable, as God says, ‘If you count God’s blessing, you will not enumerate it’ [14:34], they fall into two kinds: worldly and otherworldly.

“The first, the worldly, has two divisions: bestowed and acquired. The bestowed has two divisions. One is spiritual: the breathing of the spirit into a person and his illumination by the intellect and the faculties consequent upon it, such as understanding, thought, and speech. The other is bodily: the formation of the body with the power inhering in it and the conditions that come upon it, such as health and completeness of its members. Acquired blessings include purifying the soul of vices, adorning it with good character and virtuous dispositions, embellishing the body with pleasing appearances and comely ornaments, and acquiring standing and wealth.

“The second, the otherworldly, is that He should forgive a person’s previous faults, be pleased with him, and give him a dwelling in the highest heights, with the angels brought near, for ever and ever. It is this last division that is intended, together with whatever in the first division serves as a means of attaining it. In other things, believers and unbelievers share.” Here ends the quotation.

Spiritual allusion · Degrees of thanksgiving

I:65–66

Ibn Juzayy said: “The blessings for which thanksgiving (الشكر) is rendered are of three kinds: worldly, such as health, well-being, and lawful wealth; religious, such as knowledge, reverent fear, and gnosis (المعرفة); and otherworldly, such as abundant reward for little work.” He also said: “People occupy two stations in thanksgiving. Some give thanks for blessings that reach them personally and belong especially to them; others thank God on behalf of all His creatures for blessings reaching them all. Thanksgiving has three degrees: the common people give thanks for blessings; the elect give thanks for blessings and afflictions, in every state; the elect of the elect become absent from seeing the blessing through witnessing the Benefactor (مشاهدة المنعم).” A man said to Ibrāhīm ibn Adham, may God be pleased with him: “When the spiritual poor are given, they give thanks; when they are

denied, they are patient." Ibrāhīm replied: "Those are the manners of dogs! Our people give thanks when denied, and when given, prefer others to themselves."

Outward commentary · Wrath and straying

I:66

He then guarded against the path that is not straight, saying, "not those upon whom wrath has fallen": that is, not the path of those with whom You are angry. Do not guide us to it or lead us along its way, but keep us safe from the places to which it leads. The Jews are intended; thus the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, explained it. In its general application it holds of all those with whom God is angry. "Nor those who are astray": that is, nor the path of those who are astray, who have lost the truth. These are the Christians, as he, God bless him and grant him peace, said. Both explanations are taken from the Book of God Most High. He says concerning the Jews, "They incurred wrath upon wrath" [2:90], and concerning the Christians, "They went astray before, led many astray, and strayed from the even way" [5:77].

Theology · The divine Names and the three classes of creation

Know that the Real, glorified is He, has divided His creatures into three classes. One class He prepared for generosity and beneficence, to manifest in them His Name the Generous or the Ever-Merciful. These are those favoured with faith and uprightness. Another class He prepared for retribution and wrath, to manifest in them His Name the Avenger or the Overpowering. These are those upon whom wrath has fallen and who stray from the path of truth in understanding or in action: the unbelievers. A third class God prepared for forbearance and pardon, to manifest in them His Names the Forbearing and the Pardoner. These are the disobedient among the believers.

Whoever wishes existence to be free of these three classes, and all people to be alike in guidance or in its opposite, is ignorant of God and His Names. For the effects of His Names must appear in the human being: generosity, overpowering might, forbearance, and the rest. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The path of arrival and spiritual guidance

The straight path that the Real commands us to seek is the path of arrival (طريق الوصول) at the Presence (الحضرة): knowledge of God in the mode of witnessing and direct vision (العلم بالله على نعت الشهود والعيان). This is the station of the special tawḥīd (مقام التوحيد الخاص), the highest degree of the people of tawḥīd; above it is only the tawḥīd of the prophets and messengers. It necessarily requires spiritual formation at the hands of a perfected shaykh who knows the path of journeying (طريق السير), has traversed the stations through tasting (ذوقاً) and unveiling (كشفاً), has attained the stations of effacement and subsistence (الفناء والبقاء), and has combined attraction and wayfaring (الجذب والسلوك). The path is difficult, its travellers few and its highwaymen many; the devil of this path is learned in its stations and the occurrences that arise in them (نوازله). A guide is therefore indispensable, otherwise the traveller will stray from the even way. Ibn al-Bannāʾ alluded to this meaning:

The folk are travellers,
journeying toward the Presence of the Real.
Upon this way they therefore need a guide,
one with insight into travel and the resting-place,
who has travelled the path and then returned
to tell the people what he gained.

I:67

In Laṭāʾif al-minan it is said: “Whoever has no master to connect him with the chain of following (سلسلة الأتباع) and lift the covering from his heart is, in this affair, a foundling without a father and a claimant without lineage. If he possesses light, the usual case is that the spiritual state overwhelms him, and that he stops with whatever comes to him from God. The governance of discipline and refinement (سياسة التأديب والتهذيب) has not trained him, nor have the reins of formation and exercise (التربية والتدريب) led him.” This path is what the reciter of al-Fātiḥa should inwardly call to mind at “Guide us upon the straight path,” together with the ascent (الترقي) mentioned earlier by Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī. At “the path of those whom You have blessed,” he should inwardly apprehend: those whom You blessed with arrival (الوصول) and firm establishment (التمكين) in gnosis of You.

Spiritual allusion · Guidance, deprivation and fulfilment

Al-Wartajbī said: “Guide us to what You desire of us; the straight path is what the Real desires from creation: truthfulness and sincerity in His servanthood (عبوديته) and service.” Then: “It has been said: ‘Guide us with the guidance of direct vision (هدى العيان) after clear exposition (البيان), so that we may stand straight before You according to Your will.’ It has also been said: ‘Guide us with the guidance of one whose beginning is from You, so that his end may be unto You.’” He then quotes someone who said: “‘Guide us’ means: make us firm upon the path in which there is no crookedness, namely Islam, the straight path and upright way. ‘The path of those whom You have blessed’: the stations of those whom You blessed with gnosis, love, and beautiful courtesy in service.” He then said: “‘Not those upon whom wrath has fallen’: those expelled from the gate of servanthood. ‘Nor those who are astray’: those bankrupt of the precious treasures of gnosis.”

I say: it is better to say that “not those upon whom wrath has fallen” are those whom following their egoic shares and appetites (الحظوظ والشهوات) has halted from journeying (السير), casting them into the abysses of disobedience and opposition. “Nor those who are astray” are those whom ignorance and imitation (الجهل والتقليد) have imprisoned, so that their inner sights (بصائرهم) do not penetrate to pure tawḥīd. They have recoiled from the tawḥīd of direct vision (توحيد العيان) to the tawḥīd of proof and demonstration (توحيد الدليل والبرهان). Among the people of witnessing and direct vision (أهل الشهود والعيان), this is a kind of error, even if a person reaches the utmost possible degree of righteousness.

Spiritual allusion · Inward attentiveness when reciting al-Fātiḥa

In the Iḥyāʾ it is said: “When you say, ‘In the Name of God, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful,’ understand that all affairs are through God, and that what is intended here is the One named. If all affairs are through God, it necessarily follows that all praise belongs to God.” Then he said: “When you say, ‘The All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful,’ bring the forms of His gentleness into your heart, so that His mercy may open to you and your hope may be stirred by it. Then let your heart feel magnification and fear at your words, ‘the Day of Recompense.’” Then he said: “Renew sincerity with your saying, ‘You alone we worship,’ and renew helplessness, need, and the disclaiming of strength and power with your saying, ‘and You alone we ask for help.’

Then ask for your need by name, and say, ‘Guide us upon the straight path,’ which leads us to Your proximity and brings us to Your good pleasure. Add explanation, detail, and confirmation to it, and invoke the testimony of those upon whom He poured the blessings of guidance: the prophets, the utterly truthful, the martyrs, and the righteous, as distinct from those upon whom His wrath fell among the unbelievers, the deviating, the Jews, the Christians, and the Sabians.” Here ends the abridged quotation.

I:68

Al-Qushayrī said: “In ‘Guide us upon the straight path,’ the imperative is implicit (الأمر مضمر): that is, ‘Say: Guide us.’ The straight path is the path of the Real, the way of the people of tawḥīd. That is: ‘Direct us to the Real, lest we rely upon the intermediary means of our dealings (وسائط المعاملات) and the dust of suppositions and reckonings fall upon the face of tawḥīd; be Yourself our guide to You.’ ‘The path of those whom You have blessed’ means those who arrive through You unto You. ‘Not those upon whom wrath has fallen’: through forgetting divine enabling (التوفيق) and deliberately blinding themselves to divine support (التأييد). ‘Nor those who are astray’: from witnessing the antecedence of divine choice (سابق الاختيار) and the unfolding dispositions of the decrees (تصاريف الأقدار).”

Outward commentary · 1. Al-Fātiḥa as a summary of the Qurʾān

This sūrah gathers all the meanings of the Qurʾān, as though it were an abridged copy of it. For this reason it is called the Mother of the Qurʾān. Matters concerning divinity are contained in His saying, “Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds, the All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful”; the abode of the hereafter in His saying, “King of the Day of Recompense”; all forms of worship, comprising beliefs and the outward ordinances entailed by commands and prohibitions, in His saying, “You alone we worship”; the spiritual stations and the mysteries of inward dealings, through purification and adornment [of the soul], in His saying, “Guide us upon the straight path”; the prophets and others in His saying, “those upon whom You have bestowed favour”; and the mention of the classes of unbelievers in His saying, “not those upon whom wrath has fallen, nor those who are astray.”

Shaykh Ibn Abī Jamra, may God be pleased with him, said, explaining how it comprises the Book of God: “The word ‘praise’ includes everything in the Book of God relating to praise and thanksgiving, for praise is more general

than thanksgiving: the more general term was used to indicate both attributes. The word ‘God’ indicates what is in the Mighty Book of Names of exaltation and magnification, since it has been said to be God’s Greatest Name. The phrase ‘Lord of the worlds’ indicates what it contains of the Names of God, glorified is He, and of the worlds, their differences, their Creator, and the One who disposes their affairs. ‘The All-Merciful, the Ever-Merciful’ includes everything in the Book relating to forgiveness, mercy, the bestowal of blessings, pardon, and munificence. ‘King of the Day of Recompense’ indicates its mention of the hereafter and its terrors. ‘You alone we worship’ includes its acts of worship and the singling of Him out as God. ‘You alone we ask for help’ indicates its requests for assistance and its mention of utter need. ‘Guide us upon the straight path’ includes its requests for guidance upon the way of good. ‘The path of those upon whom You have bestowed favour’ includes its mention of the elect, those with whom God is pleased, those who are pardoned, and the people of felicity. ‘Not those upon whom wrath has fallen’ includes its kinds of unbelief and transgression, the evil qualities of those concerned, and their final end. It therefore deserves to be called a Mother.” Here ends the quotation.

I:69

It is related from ʿAlī, may God ennoble his countenance, that he said: “Moses, peace be upon him, expounded the Torah in seventy volumes. If the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, gave me leave, I would load seventy camels with an exposition of al-Fātiḥa.” I say: his mention of “seventy” is approximate, for it admits of more than that. The detail would be lengthy. We have mentioned the foundations of its sciences in our greater commentary upon it. And God Most High knows best.

Theology · 2. Praise, tawḥīd and entering Islam

Ibn Juzayy said: “According to the discerning scholars, our saying, ‘Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds,’ is superior to ‘There is no god but God,’ for two reasons. The first is what al-Nasāʾī related from the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace: ‘Whoever says, “There is no god but God,” has twenty good deeds recorded for him, and whoever says, “Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds,” has thirty good deeds recorded for him.’ The second is that the affirmation of unity entailed by ‘There is no god but God’ is contained in your saying, ‘Lord of the worlds,’ while the phrase adds your words, ‘Praise belongs to God,’ with the meanings we

have already explained. As for his saying, God bless him and grant him peace, 'The best thing that I and the prophets before me have said is: There is no god but God,' this is because of the affirmation of unity which it entails. 'Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds' shares that affirmation and adds something to it. This applies to a believer who has made his faith firm and seeks reward. For one entering Islam, however, 'There is no god but God' is specifically required." Here ends the quotation.

I say: The sound determination is that any expression indicating the affirmation of unity suffices for entering Islam, as al-Bannānī said in his gloss.

Legal commentary · 3. Reciting al-Fātiḥa in prayer

Reciting al-Fātiḥa in prayer is obligatory according to Mālik and al-Shāfiʿī, contrary to Abū Ḥanīfa. We have explained the origin of the disagreement in the greater commentary.

Outward commentary · 4. Saying Āmīn: reports and practice

Saying Āmīn upon completing al-Fātiḥa is called for because of the supplication it contains. The Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, said: "The Jews have envied you for nothing as they have envied you for the greeting of peace and for saying Āmīn." Ibn Mājah related it. He also said, God bless him and grant him peace: "God has granted me three distinctions: He granted me prayer in rows; He granted me the greeting, which is indeed the greeting of the people of Paradise; and He granted me the saying of Āmīn. He gave it to none of the prophets before me, unless God gave it to Aaron: Moses would supplicate and Aaron would say Āmīn." Ibn Khuzayma related it.

He, blessings and peace be upon him, heard a man supplicating insistently and said: "He has made it assured, if he seals it." Some of those present asked, "With what should he seal it?" He replied: "He should say Āmīn; if he seals it with Āmīn, he has made it assured." Abū Zuhayr, the transmitter, said: "Āmīn is like the seal (الطابع) upon the sheet." Ibn ʿAjība adds that this last statement may itself be traceable to the Prophet. Abū Dāwūd related the report.

Language · Āmīn: pronunciation, grammar and meaning

Āmīn may be pronounced with its initial vowel long or short (بالمد والقصر), with an ungeminated mīm; gemination of the mīm is also an attested linguistic form. It has been said to be one of the Names of God Most High. It has also been explained as "O God, answer," "thus, do [it]," or "thus, let it be." Al-Mundhirī mentions this in al-Targhīb. Al-Bayḍāwī said: "It is indeclinable with final fatḥa (مبني على الفتح), like ayna, because of the meeting of two quiescent consonants (لالتقاء الساكنين). Its alif is transmitted both long and short." The poet said: "May God have mercy upon a servant who says Āmīn." [8]

Legal commentary · Āmīn in congregational prayer

I:70

"By agreement, it is not part of the Qurʾān. It is, however, a sunna to conclude the sūrah with it, because of his saying, blessings and peace be upon him: 'Gabriel, peace be upon him, taught me Āmīn when I finished reciting al-Fātiḥa.' He said that it is like the seal upon a letter.

"The imam says it, and says it aloud in prayers recited aloud, because of the report from Wāʾil ibn Ḥujr that when he, blessings and peace be upon him, recited 'nor those who are astray,' he would say Āmīn, raising his voice with it. It is related from Abū Ḥanīfa, may God have mercy upon him, that the imam does not say it. The well-known position related from him is that the imam says it quietly, as ʿAbd Allāh ibn Mughaffal and Anas reported." I say: the well-known position of Mālik's school is that the imam does not say it in prayers recited aloud.

Then he said: "The person praying behind the imam says Āmīn with him, because of his saying, blessings and peace be upon him: 'When the imam says, "nor those who are astray," say Āmīn, for the angels say Āmīn. Whoever's saying of Āmīn coincides with the angels' saying of Āmīn will have his previous sins forgiven.'" Success is through God, and He guides to the

8. Cairo editor, C69.1: This is one hemistich. Its beginning is: "O Lord, never deprive me of love for her …" Ibn Manẓūr attributes it in the Lisān to ʿUmar ibn Abī Rabīʿa. I [the editor] say: the shaykh who wrote this commentary has omitted an example of the short form. It appears as follows in Anwār al-tanzīl and Lisān al-ʿArab: "Fuṭḥul drew away from me when I asked him; / Amīn—so may God increase the distance between us."

even way. May God bless our master and patron Muḥammad, the very reality of truth and realisation, and his family and his Companions, purified after him, the standards of the path, and grant them abundant peace.

Sūrat al-Baqara

Al-Baqara: introduction and excellence

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 71–71

Outward commentary · Revelation, extent and excellence of the sūrah

Our master ʿAlī, may God ennoble his countenance, said: “The first sūrah revealed in Medina was Sūrat al-Baqara[T2].” It contains six thousand, one hundred and twenty-one words, and two hundred and eighty-six verses—or, it is said, two hundred and eighty-seven.[B001] **Source comparison:** Al-Thaʿlabī, *al-Kashf wa-l-bayān*, I:135, independently transmits this sentence through ʿAṭāʾ al-Khurāsānī from ʿIkrima. His preceding heading mentions ʿAlī in connection with Kūfan verse enumeration, whereas the chain for the first Medinan sūrah ends with ʿIkrima. This directly inspected parallel supports the Cairo editor’s existing caution about the attribution. The English preserves Ibn ʿAjība’s attribution to ʿAlī; the source comparison establishes an attribution discrepancy rather than authenticating the reported revelation chronology. [9]

The Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, said: “Everything has a summit, and the summit of the Qurʾān is Sūrat al-Baqara. Whoever recites it in his house by day, no devil will enter it for three days; whoever recites it in his house by night, no devil will enter it for three nights. Within it is the foremost verse of the Qurʾān: the Throne Verse.” It is the summit of the Qurʾān—that is, its highest point—because it embraces a compendium of the Qurʾān’s teachings concerning the states of faith and the branches of Islam.[B002]

He also said, God bless him and grant him peace: “I was given Sūrat al-Baqara from the First Remembrance; Ṭā Hā and the Ṭawāsīn from the tablets of Moses; and the Opening of the Book and the concluding verses of al-Baqara from beneath the Throne.”[B003]

9. Cairo editor, C71.1: Al-Suyūṭī mentions it in al-Durr al-manthūr, 1:46, from ʿIkrima, and attributes it to Abū Dāwūd in al-Nāsikh wa-l-mansūkh. I have not found it attributed to our master ʿAlī—may God ennoble his countenance.

He then opens the sūrah with symbols exchanged between Himself and His Beloved, saying:

> **Translator's source note · Cairo I:71:** Ruslān's footnote questions the attribution to ʿAlī of the statement that al-Baqara was the first sūrah revealed in Medina.

2:1 · The opening letters and the descent of revelation

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 71–72

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمنِ الرَّحِيمِ

الم (1)

In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful.
1. Alif. Lām. Mīm.

Spiritual allusion · The mysteries of the opening letters

If intellects are bewildered by the symbols of sages, what then of prophets? What of messengers? What of the master of the messengers? How, then, could anyone aspire to grasp the realities of the symbols of the Lord of the worlds? Al-Ṣiddīq, may God be pleased with him, said: "Every book has a secret, and the secret of the Qurʾān is the opening of its sūrahs." End of quotation.

Knowledge of the mysteries of these letters is accessible only to the elect among the greatest saints (الأولياء). A gleam of it appears to each according to the purity of his draught (صفاء شربه).[B004]

The most plausible explanation is that they are things by which God swears because of their nobility. Thus it has been said that they are abbreviated from His Names: the alif from Allāh, the lām from al-Laṭīf, and the mīm from Muhaymin or Majīd. Others say they are abbreviated from the names of His Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace: the mīm from *al-Muṣṭafā*, as the additional ṣād in *Alif Lām Mīm Ṣād* indicates, or from *al-*

Mursal, as the additional rāʾ in *Alif Lām Mīm Rāʾ* indicates. *Alif Lām Rāʾ* is abbreviated from *al-Rasūl*. It is as though the Real Most High were saying, "O Chosen One," or "O Messenger: 'That is the Book, in which there is no doubt,'" or "'A Book sent down to you,'" or the like. The fact that the address is directed to him, God bless him and grant him peace, after these symbols supports this interpretation.

Kāf Hā Yā ʿAyn Ṣād is abbreviated from al-Kāfī, al-Hādī, al-Walī, al-ʿĀlim and al-Ṣādiq; *Ṭā Hā* from ṭāhir, "pure"; *Ṭā Sīn* from "O Pure One, O Master," with "O Muḥammad" added in *Ṭā Sīn Mīm*; and so forth.

Spiritual allusion · Letters, divine Names and the realms of manifestation

According to the people of allusion, the Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "Alif: devote your innermost secret (سرّك) exclusively to Me, as the alif stands apart from the other letters. Lām: make your limbs pliant in My worship. Mīm: abide with Me through the effacement of your outlines and attributes (محو رسومك وصفاتك), and I shall adorn you with the purity of intimacy and nearness to Me." This is reported by al-Thaʿlabī.

I say: more evidently, these letters point to the three realms (العوالم الثلاثة). Alif signifies the oneness of the Essence in the realm of jabarūt (عالم الجبروت); lām, the appearance of its mysteries in the realm of malakūt (عالم الملكوت); mīm, the pervasion of its sustaining influxes in the realm of raḥamūt (عالم الرحموت); and ṣād, the manifestation of its governance in the realm of mulk (عالم الملك).[B005]

Each of these symbolic letters indicates the appearance of the Essence's effect in the realm of witnessing (عالم الشهادة). Alif points to the pervasion of oneness in the manifestations of created things; lām, to the overflowing of the lights of malakūt from the ocean of jabarūt; and mīm, to the King's governance in the realm of mulk. It is as though the Real Most High were saying: "This Book which you recite, O Muḥammad, flows from the ocean of jabarūt into the realm of malakūt, and from malakūt into raḥamūt. The Trustworthy Spirit then brought it down to the realm of mulk and witnessing. One ought not, therefore, to doubt it." Hence He follows these letters with His words: "That is the Book, in which there is no doubt."

Language · Doubt and tranquillity

I say: *rayb* (الريب) is the heart's movement and agitation through doubts and imaginings. Its opposite is tranquillity (الطمأنينة), through abiding rest in the Real.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "O chosen Messenger and elect Prophet, that Book which We have sent down to you from the jabarūt of Our holiness and the malakūt of Our might—there is no doubt that it is from Us. Whoever doubts it or attributes it to another has merited distance from the precinct of Our mercy and incurred the severity of Our retribution. Whoever realizes that it is from Us and believes in the one who has brought it from Us has merited entry into the Presence of Our holiness, until he hears from Us and speaks through Us: 'When I love him, I am his; through Me he hears, through Me he sees, and through Me he speaks …'"—the hadith.[B006]

Thus he becomes one of the utterly truthful brought near (الصديقين المقربين), with the prophets and messengers, and reaches the summit of the degrees of those who are mindful of God (المتقين), who are guided by the clear Qurʾān's guidance. He points to this in His words:

2:2 · Guidance, God-consciousness and the degrees of recitation

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 72–73

ذلِكَ الْكِتابُ لا رَيْبَ فِيهِ هُدىً لِلْمُتَّقِينَ (2)

2. That is the Book, in which there is no doubt: a guidance for those who are mindful of God.

Language · The grammar of guidance and the degrees of taqwā

I say: “guidance” (هدى) is either the predicate (خبر) of an implicit subject (مبتدأ مضمر), or itself the subject with its predicate placed before it: “It is a guide for those mindful of God,” or “Within it is guidance for them.” Guidance (الهدى) is direction and clear explanation (الإرشاد والبيان); its meaning is an indication that brings one to the Real (الدلالة الموصلة إلى الحق).

The person mindful of God (المتقي) is one who places a safeguard (وقاية) between himself and God’s displeasure. This has three degrees: guarding the limbs against disobedience; guarding hearts against defects and lapses; and guarding the innermost secrets against stopping with sensible things.

The first belongs to the station of Islam (مقام الإسلام), to which the address “Be mindful of God as far as you are able” [64:16] is directed. The second belongs to the station of faith (مقام الإيمان), to which “Be mindful of God, O possessors of understanding” [65:10] is directed. The third belongs to the station of excellence (مقام الإحسان), to which “Be mindful of God as He ought to be regarded” [3:102] is directed.

Spiritual allusion · From guidance to hearing the Speaker

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “That Book, whose precinct neither doubt nor uncertainty approaches, is guidance itself for the God-conscious possessed of understanding.” Through it they continue to ascend in stations and states (المقامات والأحوال) until they hear it from the Great, the Most High, without an intermediary conveying or transmitting it. Outlines and forms (الرسوم والأشكال) have been effaced for them. This is guidance’s utmost attainment and the realization of antecedent providential care (سابق العناية).

Jaʿfar al-Ṣādiq said: “By God, God Most High has disclosed Himself to His creatures in His speech, but they do not perceive it.” He also said, when asked about a state that overtook him in prayer until he fell unconscious, and then recovered: “I continued repeating the verse upon my heart until I heard it from the One who speaks it. My body could not withstand the direct vision of His power.”

Spiritual allusion · The three degrees of recitation

The degrees of recitation (درجات القراءة) are three. The lowest is for the servant to recite as though he were reciting before God Most High, standing in His presence while He looks upon him and listens to him. His state is then one of petition, humble entreaty, supplication and imploring.

The second is to witness in his heart as though God Most High were addressing him with His words and speaking intimately to him through His bounty and beneficence. His station is modesty, magnification, attentive listening and understanding.

The third is to behold the Speaker in the speech, looking neither to himself nor to his recitation. Rather, he is effaced from himself (فانيًا عن نفسه), absent in witnessing his Lord: no report of himself remains to him, nor any resting with other than God.

The first belongs to the people of effacement in acts (الفناء في الأفعال); the second to the people of effacement in attributes (الفناء في الصفات); and the third to the people of effacement in witnessing the Essence (الفناء في شهود الذات). May God be pleased with them and gather us upon their way. Amen.

He then describes those mindful of God, singled out for the guidance of His clear Book, by three qualities, saying:

2:3 · Faith, prayer and spending

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 73–75

الَّذِينَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِالْغَيْبِ وَيُقِيمُونَ الصَّلاةَ وَمِمَّا رَزَقْناهُمْ يُنْفِقُونَ (3)

3. Those who believe in the unseen, establish prayer, and spend from what We have provided for them.

Spiritual allusion · The three kinds of action

I say: these qualities embrace three kinds of action. The first is an action of the heart: faith. The second is a bodily action: prayer. The third is an action involving wealth: spending in God's path. These actions are the foundations upon which God-consciousness (التقوى) turns.

Spiritual allusion · From faith in the unseen to direct witnessing

As for the heart's action, it is first faith (الإيمان) and then gnosis (المعرفة). So long as the servant is veiled by witnessing himself, confined within created things and the structure of his own person, he believes in the unseen: he believes in the existence of the Real Most High and in what He has reported of unseen matters, inferring Him from the existence of His effects. When he is effaced from himself, his sphere of sensible apprehension is subtilized, and his reflection passes beyond the circle of created things, he reaches witnessing and direct vision (الشهود والعيان). The unseen then becomes witnessed for him, mulk becomes malakūt, the future becomes present, and what is to come becomes actual. Concerning this I have said:

> Take none but God as your beloved;
> remain forever in ardent love and longing.
> You shall see the hidden matter face to face,
> and win arrival and encounter.

The *Ḥikam* says: "Were the light of certainty to shine in your heart, you would see the Hereafter nearer than that you should journey to it; and you would see the world's splendour with the garment of passing-away manifest upon it." In *al-Tanwīr* he says: "Were the veil of imagining (الوهم) torn away, direct vision would fall upon the disappearance of individual entities (فقد الأعيان), and the light of certainty would shine forth, covering the existence of created things." End of quotation.[B007]

The Real Most High mentions only faith in the unseen because that is what is required of people: it is within the capacity of the great majority of servants. Special gnosis (المعرفة الخاصة), by contrast, is within the capacity only of the elect. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Establishing prayer

The bodily action is establishing prayer (إقامة الصلاة). Establishing it means performing its conditions, pillars and reverent attentiveness (شروطها وأركانها وخشوعها) with care, and guarding the innermost secret (السر) within it. Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī, may God be pleased with him, said: "Wherever those who pray are mentioned by way of praise, the reference is to those who establish prayer—either through the actual expression 'establishing' or through a meaning that returns to it. God Most High says, 'Those who believe in the unseen and establish prayer'; 'Establish prayer'; and 'those who establish prayer' [22:35]. But when He mentions worshippers in connection with heedlessness, He says, 'Woe, then, to those who pray, who are heedless of their prayer' [107:4–5]. He does not say, 'Woe to those who establish prayer.'"

Outward commentary · Spending in God's path

Action involving wealth is spending in God's path, whether obligatory or recommended (واجبًا أو مندوبًا), and it is among the best acts of drawing near. God, blessed and exalted, says: "Son of Adam, spend, and I shall spend upon you." In another hadith: "Spend, and do not fear impoverishment from the Possessor of the Throne."[B008]

He said, God bless him and grant him peace: "In the Garden are chambers whose outside can be seen from within and whose inside can be seen from without." He was asked, "For whom are they, Messenger of God?" He replied: "For those who feed others, spread the greeting of peace, and pray by night while people sleep." He also said, God bless him and grant him peace: "Through a morsel of bread, a handful of dates, or the like from which a poor person benefits, God, mighty and majestic, brings three people into the Garden: the master of the house who orders it, the wife who prepares it, and the servant who hands it to the poor person."

He also said, God bless him and grant him peace: "Charity closes seventy doors of evil." And he said, God bless him and grant him peace: "Acts of kindness protect against evil ends; secret charity extinguishes the Lord's wrath; and maintaining kinship ties increases one's lifespan."[B009]

Spiritual allusion · Witnessing lordship and fulfilling servanthood

O you who are immersed in the ocean of the Essence and the current of the attributes: “That Book,” which you hear from the lights of Our malakūt and the mysteries of Our jabarūt—“there is no doubt” that it is from Us, so do not hear it from another. “When We recite it, follow its recitation” [75:18]. It guides to witnessing Our Essence and directs to arrival at Our Presence, for one who guards against witnessing other than Us and is immersed in the ocean of Our oneness; who believes in the unseen of Our unseen (غيب غيبنا) and the mysteries of Our jabarūt, which sciences cannot encompass and whose utmost reaches neither thought nor understanding attains.

Such a person unites witnessing lordship (مشاهدة الربوبية) with the performance of the duties of servanthood (وظائف العبودية), manifesting the secret of wisdom after realizing the witnessing of power (شهود القدرة). He is constant in his prayer, while his heart wanders in the unseen of malakūt. He spends from the mysteries of the sciences and the treasuries of understanding God has provided him, ever giving from the amplitude of his knowledge and the lights of his effusion. No wonder, then, that he stands upon clear evidence from his Lord.

After mentioning the believers among the Arabs, the Real Most High mentions those who believe among the People of the Book, saying:

2:4–5 · Revelation, certainty and success

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 75–76

وَالَّذِينَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِما أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْكَ وَما أُنْزِلَ مِنْ قَبْلِكَ وَبِالْآخِرَةِ هُمْ يُوقِنُونَ (4) أُولئِكَ عَلى هُدىً مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ وَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الْمُفْلِحُونَ (5)

4. And those who believe in what has been sent down to you and what was sent down before you, and who are certain of the Hereafter. 5. Those are upon guidance from their Lord, and those are the ones who prosper.

Language · The relative construction and belief in revelation

I say: the relative expression (الموصول) is a subject (مبتدأ), and "those" (أولئك) introduces its predicate (خبر); alternatively, it is coordinated with "those mindful of God" (المتقين). In referring to earlier scriptures, He leaves the recipient of revelation unmentioned: He does not say, "what was sent down to those before you." This indicates that belief in earlier scriptures suffices without knowing the individual recipients, except where someone is specifically named in the Book or the Sunna: belief in that person is then indispensable. As for the mighty Qurʾān, one must believe that it was sent down to our Prophet Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace. Anyone who believes it was sent down to someone else—as [he alleges of] the Rāfiḍa—is an unbeliever by consensus. Hence He states the object of the relation (المتعلَّق) in His words, "what has been sent down to you."[B010]

Outward commentary · Guidance and the protection of providence

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "Those who affirm what has been sent down to you, O Muḥammad," of reports concerning the unseen, rulings of the Sacred Law, lordly mysteries and divinely bestowed sciences (العلوم اللدنية), "and what was sent down before you" of heavenly scriptures and sacred tidings, and who are certain of resurrection, reckoning, return to Us and the final homecoming, just as I have described them in My Book and the reports of My prophets—"those" ride upon the back of guidance, raised high upon the conveyance of providential care (العناية), surrounded by a host of help and protection. "Those are" the ones who win every object sought and escape everything feared and dreaded, unlike those others for whom abandonment (الخذلان) has already been decreed,

who possess neither faith nor certainty, neither guidance nor success, neither deliverance nor prosperity. We ask God for protection by His grace and generosity.

Spiritual allusion · Those who have arrived and those still journeying

I say: it is as though the first verse [2:3] concerns those who have arrived (الواصلين), and the second [2:4] those who are journeying (السائرين). He describes the former as spending from the amplitude of their sciences, and the latter as affirming the truth in their hearts. If they persevere in journeying, they will prosper, winning what the former have won.

The people of the first verse are the people of witnessing and direct vision (الشهود والعيان); those of the second, the people of assent and faith (التصديق والإيمان). The former have tasted special election (الخصوصية), and so uphold the witnessing of lordship and the courtesies of servanthood (آداب العبودية). The latter affirm the descent and continuance of special election and have breathed something of the fragrance of its mysteries and sciences. They are certain of the existence of Reality (الحقيقة) and know the observances of the Path (رسوم الطريقة). No wonder they stand upon the highway and the way of guidance, prospering through arrival at the very source of providential care. Not so the third group, marked by denial and deprived of attaining that care, to whom the Real Most High alludes in His words:

2:6–7 · Sealed hearts and the two perspectives of wisdom and power

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 76–77

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا سَواءٌ عَلَيْهِمْ أَأَنْذَرْتَهُمْ أَمْ لَمْ تُنْذِرْهُمْ لا يُؤْمِنُونَ (6)
خَتَمَ اللَّهُ عَلى قُلُوبِهِمْ وَعَلى سَمْعِهِمْ وَعَلى أَبْصارِهِمْ غِشاوَةٌ وَلَهُمْ
عَذابٌ عَظِيمٌ (7)

6. As for those who disbelieve, it is the same for them whether you warn them or do not warn them: they will not believe. 7. God has set a seal upon their hearts and their hearing; over their eyes is a covering, and a tremendous punishment awaits them.

Language · Indifference to warning and the covering over sight

I say: "the same" (سواء) is a fronted predicate (خبر مقدّم), while "whether you warn them" supplies the subject (مبتدأ), the hamza of equivalence (همزة التسوية) allowing the expression to be construed as a verbal noun. That is, warning and not warning are equal in the case of these unbelievers. The entire clause is the predicate of *inna* (خبر إنّ). "A covering" (غشاوة) is a subject, with the preceding prepositional phrase as its predicate. A *ghishāwa* is something that envelops and covers another thing; it is used here figuratively for a barrier that forcibly prevents their believing.

Theology · Warning, predetermination and responsibility

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "O Muḥammad, those who outwardly disbelieve in what has been sent down to you, for whom wretchedness has already been determined by Me in secret, gain nothing from exhortation and warning, glad tidings or reminders. Your warning and its absence are alike for them, because banishment and wretchedness have already been determined for them by Me. Reminding them brings weariness; being absent from concern with their states brings repose and ease.

For I have sealed their hearts with the stamp of unbelief, so they find no way to Islam or faith. I have prevented their hearing from attending to exhortation and remembrance, so neither alarm nor warning avails them. I have covered their eyes with the darkness of the veil, so they see neither truth nor rightness. I have prepared them for My punishment and retribution and expelled them from the precinct of My mercy and bounty.

“I commanded you to warn them only to establish the proof against them. Although I have decreed that they belong to those who oppose and resist Me, I wrong none of My creatures or servants. ‘Say: to God belongs the conclusive proof; had He willed, He would have guided you all’ [6:149]. I have not wronged them, for I sent the messengers bearing glad tidings and warnings; rather, they wronged themselves, and it was they who did wrong. My wisdom (حكمتي) required the warning, while My power (قدرتي) required overpowering and compulsion (القهر والإجبار).

“Your duty, O servant, is therefore to have two eyes: one that looks to My wisdom and My Sacred Law, so that you observe due courtesy; and one that looks to My power and My Reality, so that you submit. Remain between security and fear. Do not feel secure from My hidden devising (مكري), even if I assure you of safety; and do not despair of My forbearance, even if I keep you distant. None encompasses My knowledge except He who encompasses all things.”

Spiritual allusion · Veils formed from habits, accomplishments and knowledge

Those who deny the existence of special election (الخصوصية) and reject the people who witness lordship through prophetic spiritual formation (التربية النبوية) gain nothing from exhortation and reminders, because of what has already been established concerning them in the knowledge of the all-powerful King. It is the same for them whether you warn them of the evil consequence of severance and veiling (القطيعة والحجاب), or do not warn them, since the door has not been opened.

God has sealed their hearts with habits and appetites, or with the sweetness of asceticism and acts of obedience, or with the precise formulation of questions and difficult problems. He has sealed their hearts’ hearing with passing thoughts and heedlessness, and placed the covering of the veil over

their sight. They perceive only sensible things, absent from the mysteries of meanings and the lights of divine self-disclosures (أنوار التجليات). Not so the hearts of the gnostics: they see mysteries of meaning invisible to ordinary observers. Concerning this the poet says:

> The hearts of the gnostics have eyes
> that see what other eyes do not;
> and tongues that converse in mysteries
> hidden from the noble recording angels;
> and wings that fly without feathers
> to the malakūt of the Lord of the worlds. [10]

Glory be to Him who veils people by their righteousness from the One who makes them righteous, and scholars by their knowledge from the One they would know; who singles out a people whose resolves penetrate to witnessing the Essence of their Beloved. They roam the gardens of His malakūt and swim the seas of His jabarūt. “For the like of this, let those who act perform their deeds” [37:61].

After mentioning those who proclaim their denial, the Real, glorious is His majesty, mentions those who conceal rejection and profess acknowledgement, saying, exalted is He:

10. Cairo editor, C77.1: These verses are attributed to al-Ḥallāj; they are also attributed to Maymūna al-Sawdāʾ in an account involving Ibrāhīm ibn Adham. Consult the book ʿUqalāʾ al-majānīn.

2:8–10 · Hypocrisy, self-deception and the diseased heart

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 77–79

وَمِنَ النَّاسِ مَنْ يَقُولُ آمَنَّا بِاللَّهِ وَبِالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَما هُمْ بِمُؤْمِنِينَ (8) يُخادِعُونَ اللَّهَ وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَما يَخْدَعُونَ إِلاَّ أَنْفُسَهُمْ وَما يَشْعُرُونَ (9) فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ مَرَضٌ فَزادَهُمُ اللَّهُ مَرَضاً وَلَهُمْ عَذابٌ أَلِيمٌ بِما كانُوا يَكْذِبُونَ (10)

8. Among people are those who say, “We believe in God and in the Last Day,” but they are not believers. 9. They seek to deceive God and those who believe, yet deceive none but themselves, without perceiving it. 10. In their hearts is a sickness, and God has increased their sickness; a painful punishment awaits them because they used to lie.

Language · Deception, perception and sickness

I say: *man* (مَن) is an indefinite qualified expression (موصوفة), functioning as the subject (مبتدأ), with the predicate placed first: “Among people are people who say such-and-such.” Deception (المخادعة) is displaying the opposite of the disagreeable thing one conceals. The root meaning of *khadʿ* (الخدع) is concealment; hence *mikhdaʿ* (المخدع), a room where possessions are hidden. It is also said to mean corruption, because the hypocrites corrupt their faith by what they conceal.

The clause “without perceiving it” (وما يشعرون) is circumstantial (حالية): “being unaware.” Perception (الشعور) is noticing or becoming aware (التفطّن); the verb is conjugated according to the patterns of *karuma* and *naṣara*. “Would that I knew” (ليت شعري) means, “Would that my awareness grasped this.” The clause “in their hearts is a sickness” explains the cause (تعليلية) of their deception. Sickness (المرض) is weakness and languor; here it is the sickness of hearts through doubt and hypocrisy. In God is refuge.

Outward commentary · The concealed condition of the hypocrites

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: among people are those charged with hypocrisy, such as some of the Jews and the hypocrites. They say with their tongues what is not in their hearts: “We believe in God and in the Last Day,” but they are not numbered among the believers. Through their profession of faith they imagine they deceive God and those who believe; in reality they deceive only themselves, for the evil consequence of their deception returns upon them. They do not perceive that their deception is to their own harm.

This deception arises because their hearts harbour the sickness of doubt and envy: their hearts waver and their souls are troubled. God increases their sickness through the verses He sends down that expose them. In the Hereafter, when they come before God, they will suffer painful punishment because they denied the Messenger of God, or because they lied against God. This is the substance of the verse.[B011]

The Real, glorious is His majesty, opens by mentioning those who make their religion sincerely God’s and whose hearts accord with their tongues. He then mentions the unbelievers, whose unbelief is unalloyed both outwardly and inwardly. Third come the hypocrites, who believe with their mouths but not with their hearts. These are the most corrupt of the unbelievers, because they mix unbelief with mockery and deception. Hence they occupy the lowest depth of the Fire.

Spiritual allusion · Claiming realization without possessing it

Among people are those who lay presumptuous claim to special election (الخصوصية) and profess to have realized the witnessing of lordship (مشاهدة الربوبية), while remaining in the lowest depth of ordinary, unillumined existence (العمومية). They display purity of faith and realized gnosis, yet wander bewildered in the valleys of doubts and passing thoughts, thirsting in the deserts of severance and separation (القطيعة والفَرْق). Their tongues run freely with claims, while their hearts are desolate of guidance. They seek to deceive God, content with their own faults and misdeeds, and deceive Muslims by adorning their outward appearance while their inward being is filled with egoic shares and inclinations. They dress in the garb of gnostics but act as the ignorant do. The poet’s words apply to them:

The tents are like their tents, indeed;
but the women of this encampment are not its women. [11]

In truth such a person deceives only himself, depriving his soul of arrival and leaving it to wander in the valleys of created things. His heart is sick with separation and severance, while he supposes himself to be among those who come to God with a sound heart. God increases his sickness because he is content with his disease and defect. He suffers the punishment of anxious grasping and weariness within the constriction of the veil and its toil, because he lies against God and rejects God's friends. His recompense is distance and abandonment, an evil end and deprivation. In God we seek refuge from hidden devising and transgression.

He then mentions their abominable words and appalling states, saying:

2:11–12 · Corruption disguised as reform

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 79–80

وَإِذا قِيلَ لَهُمْ لا تُفْسِدُوا فِي الْأَرْضِ قالُوا إِنَّما نَحْنُ مُصْلِحُونَ (11)
أَلا إِنَّهُمْ هُمُ الْمُفْسِدُونَ وَلكِنْ لا يَشْعُرُونَ (12)

11. When they are told, "Do not cause corruption on earth," they say, "We are only putting things right." 12. Surely it is they who cause corruption, but they do not perceive it.

Language · The conditional expression

I say: *idhā* (إذا) is an adverbial expression (ظرف) that places its conditional clause in a genitival relation and is itself governed in the accusative by the response (خافض لشرطه منصوب بجوابه). That is: they say, "We put things right," at the time someone tells them, "Do not cause corruption." The sentence ex-

11. Cairo editor, C78.1: Al-Qurṭubī attributes this verse to Abū Bakr al-Shiblī in an account in his commentary. It also appears in Dīwān al-Shiblī, in the section of verses that al-Shiblī quoted.

plains and confirms their deception; alternatively, it is coordinated with "those who say, 'We believe.'" The sense is: among people is a group who, when told not to cause corruption, say, "We are only putting things right."

Language · The emphatic rejection of a false claim

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when these hypocrites are told not to corrupt the earth through disobedience, obstructing faith, inciting unbelievers and transgressors against the people of Islam and faith, stirring up wars and dissension, provoking disorder, confusion and affliction, or divulging Muslims' secrets to their unbelieving enemies—for that disrupts the order of things and cuts off the means of beneficence—they make the corrupt reply, "We are only putting things right by this. It is therefore improper to address us in that fashion, for reform and guidance are our concern, and our state is free of any taint of corruption." God Most High replies: surely it is they who cause corruption there, though they have no perception of it.

I say: God rejects their claim to belong among those who put things right with the most devastating and eloquent rejection, in several ways: the sentence's independent opening (الاستئناف), its initial call to attention (التنبيه), emphasis through *inna* and the separating pronoun (ضمير الفصل) [Translator's note: Cairo I:79 prints *ḍamīr al-fiʿl* (ضمير الفعل, "the pronoun of the verb"). The nominal clause contains the separating pronoun *hum*; the closely parallel emphatic-device lists in al-Bayḍāwī's *Anwār al-tanzīl* (I:46) and al-Nasafī's *Madārik*, both on Q2:12, explicitly identify *faṣl*. The correction to *ḍamīr al-faṣl* remains a conjecture about the letters of this passage, and the origin of Cairo's reading is unestablished.], the definite form of the predicate (تعريف الخبر), and the expression denying them perception. Had they the least perception, they would recognize that they were corrupters. [B012]

This verse applies generally to anyone who occupies himself with what does not concern him and obstructs the way of the elect. Such a person has a branch of hypocrisy within him. In al-Bukhārī's *Ṣaḥīḥ*: "Three qualities, if present in someone, make him a complete hypocrite: when he speaks, he lies; when he promises, he breaks his promise; and when he is entrusted with something, he betrays the trust."[B013]

Spiritual allusion · Obstructing the path of divine love

When one who occupies himself with obstructing God's path and rejecting God's friends is told, "Desist from this corruption and turn back from this error and obstinacy: the signs of right guidance have become manifest to the people of love and affection," he says, "I am only a reformer and sincere adviser, upright in all my states." The Real, glorious is His majesty, says to him: "Rather, you have corrupted My servants' hearts, turned them back from the path of My love and affection, hindered them from entering My Presence, and deprived them of witnessing My Essence and attributes. You have shut My door in the faces of My beloveds, made them despair of the existence of spiritual formation (التربية), and presumed to pass judgement upon eternal power (القدرة الأزلية). Yet you do not perceive the calamity in which you stand."

How truly has one whom antecedent providential care embraced, and who was favoured with protection and guidance, said:

> This is the path of illumination:
> it has been, and will remain while existence remains. [12]

He also says:

> A crowd of common people denied it;
> they did not understand its purpose, and wandered astray.[B014]

Repent, then, O denier, before the opportunity passes. Seek someone to take you by the hand before death, lest you meet God with a diseased heart and fall into the lowest depth of His painful punishment. For the cause of punishment is the presence of the veil, while the fulfilment of bliss is beholding His noble Face. May God grant us the fullest share of that in this world and the Hereafter. Amen.

The Real Most High then mentions their mockery of Islam and refusal to enter it, saying:

12. Cairo editor, C80.1: The speaker is Ibn al-Bannāʾ al-Saraqusṭī, in the didactic poem.

2:13 · Faith, folly and the dignity of humility

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 80–81

وَإِذا قِيلَ لَهُمْ آمِنُوا كَما آمَنَ النَّاسُ قالُوا أَنُؤْمِنُ كَما آمَنَ السُّفَهاءُ أَلا إِنَّهُمْ هُمُ السُّفَهاءُ وَلكِنْ لا يَعْلَمُونَ (13)

13. When they are told, “Believe as other people have believed,” they say, “Shall we believe as the foolish have believed?” Surely it is they who are foolish, but they do not know.

Language · Comparison and the meaning of folly

I say: the kāf in “as they have believed” (كما آمن) qualifies an omitted verbal noun (صفة لمصدر محذوف), and *mā* is nominalizing (مصدرية). The sense is: when they are told, “Believe with a faith free of hypocrisy, like the faith of the Muslims,” or of those from their own people who have embraced Islam. Folly (السفه) is lightness and rashness of intellect; one says of a thin garment that it is *safīh*.

Outward commentary · The inversion of wisdom and folly

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when these hypocrites among the associators and Jews are told, “Leave your unbelief and denial; be watchful of the King who is worshipped; purify your hearts from unbelief and hypocrisy; desist from your estrangement and discord; and believe with a pure faith like that of the Muslims, so that you may be with them in the highest heights”—for “Whoever loves a people will be gathered with them,” and “A person is with those he loves”—they give expression to the unbelief and hypocrisy in their hearts by saying, “Shall we believe as the foolish have believed, those without intelligence?” For most of them are poor people and clients (موالي).[B015]

Refuting them and exposing the ugliness of their judgement, the Real Most High says: “Surely it is they who are foolish,” not the others, because they abandon what brings the tremendous success of abiding bliss and commit what makes them deserve perpetual residence in the lowest depth of Hell. “But they do not know.”

“Those who do wrong shall know to what place of return they will return” [26:227]. In this verse the Real says, “They do not know,” whereas in the preceding verse He says, “They do not perceive.” For corruption on earth can be grasped by the slightest perception; faith and discrimination between truth and falsehood, by contrast, require further reflection and the acquisition of knowledge. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Humility as the road to abiding dignity

When those who reject the people of special election—who seek to witness the majesty of lordship, have stripped themselves of the garments of dignity and renown, and donned the rags of lowliness and need—are told, “Believe in the path of these specially favoured ones and enter it with them, so that you may be among those brought near,” they answer, “Shall we believe as the foolish have believed, and abandon the dignity and grandeur we possess?”

Exposing the folly of their judgement and the ugliness of their condition, God Most High says: “Surely it is they who are foolish,” because they seek might in a dignity that passes away and abandon the dignity that does not pass away. The poet says:

> Humble yourself before the one you love, to gain dignity:
> how much dignity has a man attained through lowliness!
> If the one you love is mighty and you will not
> be lowly before him, bid farewell to union.

Were they to know the dignity folded within lowliness and the riches folded within poverty, they would fight for it with swords. But they do not know.

The Real Most High then makes clear the hypocrisy they conceal and the agreement they display, saying:

2:14–16 · Mockery, spiritual commerce and four responses to the Path

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 81–83

وَإِذا لَقُوا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا قالُوا آمَنَّا وَإِذا خَلَوْا إِلى شَياطِينِهِمْ قالُوا إِنَّا مَعَكُمْ إِنَّما نَحْنُ مُسْتَهْزِؤُنَ (14) اللَّهُ يَسْتَهْزِئُ بِهِمْ وَيَمُدُّهُمْ فِي طُغْيانِهِمْ يَعْمَهُونَ (15) أُولئِكَ الَّذِينَ اشْتَرَوُا الضَّلالَةَ بِالْهُدى فَما رَبِحَتْ تِجارَتُهُمْ وَما كانُوا مُهْتَدِينَ (16)

14. When they meet those who believe, they say, “We believe”; but when alone with their devils, they say, “We are with you; we were only mocking.” 15. God repays their mockery and leaves them wandering blindly in their transgression. 16. Those are the ones who have purchased error at the price of guidance: their trade has brought no profit, and they were not guided.

Language · Meeting, withdrawal and the devil

I say: meeting (اللقاء) is an unplanned encounter. Being alone with a thing or someone (الخلوّ به أو معه) means being apart with it or him. Here the verb includes the meaning “return,” and is therefore followed by *ilā* (إلى). “Devil” (الشيطان) has either the pattern *fayʿāl* (فَيْعَال), from *shaṭana*, “to be distant,” or *faʿlān* (فَعْلان), from *shāṭa*, “to perish or come to nothing.” Mocking a thing is treating its due standing lightly. Bewildered blindness (العَمَه) in inward sight is like blindness (العمى) in bodily sight.[B016]

Outward commentary · Duplicity towards the believers

Describing the hypocrites and confirming their hypocrisy, the Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when they met the Companions, they displayed faith; but when they returned to their devils—that is, their leaders obstinate in unbelief and transgression—they said, “We are with you;

we have not departed from our religion. We were merely mocking them and making sport of their affairs." This was revealed concerning ʿAbd Allāh ibn Ubayy, the leader of the hypocrites. Whenever he met Saʿd, he said, "What an excellent religion is Muḥammad's!" But when alone with the unbelieving leaders of his people, he said, "Hold firmly to the religion of your forefathers."

One day he went out with his associates and met a group of the Companions, may God be pleased with them. ʿAbd Allāh told his associates, "Watch how I keep these fools away from you." Taking Abū Bakr's hand, he said: "Welcome to al-Ṣiddīq, chief of Banū Taym, elder of Islam, the Messenger of God's companion in the cave, who gives his life and wealth for the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace!" [14]

He then took ʿUmar's hand: "Welcome to the chief of Banū ʿAdī ibn Kaʿb, al-Fārūq, strong in God's religion, who gives his life and wealth for the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace!" Then he took ʿAlī's hand: "Welcome to the cousin and son-in-law of the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, chief of Banū Hāshim apart from the Messenger of God!" [13]

ʿAlī, may God be pleased with him, replied: "ʿAbd Allāh, fear God and do not be hypocritical: the hypocrites are the worst of God's creatures." ʿAbd Allāh said: "Gently, Abū al-Ḥasan! How can you say this? By God, our faith is like yours, and our assent is like yours." The verse was then revealed.[B017]

Language · Mockery returned and the loss of spiritual capital

God Most High then answers them: "God mocks them"—that is, He treats them as a mocker would. While they are in the Fire He opens a door to the Garden, allows the believers to look upon them, and says to them, "Enter the Garden." When they race towards it, hoping to enter, it is closed against them and they return to the Fire. "So today those who believe laugh at the unbelievers" [83:34]. He prolongs their respite as they wander bewildered in their unbelief and transgression until the day they are raised.

14. Cairo editor, C82.2: The chain of transmission of this report is very weak. See al-Fatḥ al-samāwī fī takhrīj aḥādīth al-Bayḍāwī and Tanzīh al-sharīʿa al-marfūʿa.
13. Cairo editor, C82.1: A man's khatan is the man married to his daughter or sister.

For they "purchased error at the price of guidance": they exchanged away their capital, to say nothing of profit. Faith is the capital and acts of obedience are the profit; once the capital is gone, there is no profit. Hence God Most High says, "Their trade has brought no profit"—rather, their transaction has incurred loss—"and they were not guided" to the means of profit at all, because they exchanged guidance, their capital, for error, the cause of loss. And success is through God.

There are metaphors and eloquent devices here whose enumeration would be lengthy. Our purpose, however, is to nurture certainty (تربية اليقين) through the speech of the Lord of the worlds.

Spiritual allusion · Four kinds of response to the way of the elect

People fall into four groups with regard to the way of the elect (طريق الخصوص). The first are those for whom God's providential care has preceded and over whom the breeze of guidance has blown. They believe in the Path and enter it, giving their lives and wealth in God's way. They trade therein and profit. God Most High gives them in exchange the garden of gnoses (جنة المعارف), in which they settle wherever they wish. When they come before Him, He admits them to the Garden of adornments (جنة الزخارف), where they roam wherever they wish, and favours them there with the sight of His noble Face.

The second are those for whom God's guidance has preceded and whom His protection surrounds. They believe and acknowledge, but are too weak to enter, and their spiritual aspiration (الهمة) does not attach itself to arrival. They remain among the weak Muslims: "There is no blame upon the weak, the sick, or those unable to find anything to spend, provided they are sincere towards God and His Messenger. There is no ground for reproach against those who do good" [9:91].

The third openly deny, reject and disbelieve. They trade and lose: "Whoever shows enmity to a friend of Mine, I declare war upon him."

The fourth waver between these. On meeting the people of special election, they say, "We believe and affirm; you are upon the right highway." But when they return to obstinate deniers, they disparage and reject, saying, "We were only mocking them." God mocks them through the semblances of miraculous favours and gradual enticements (صور الكرامات والاستدراجات) that

He displays to them, and prolongs their immersion in habits and appetites, the pursuit of eminence and leadership, bewildered in the wildernesses of passing thoughts and heedlessness.[B018]

These have purchased estrangement from the special path of those who have arrived, at the price of the guidance that would have been theirs had they believed and entered. Their trade has brought them no profit, nor are they guided to attain what they hoped for. One of the gnostics said: "Believing in our path is friendship with God (ولاية); entering it is providential care (عناية); and attacking it is an offence (جناية)." And success is through God; He guides to the even way.

He then sets forth a likeness of the hypocrites, further rebuking them and exposing the ugliness of their condition, saying:

2:17–18 · The extinguished light

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 83–84

مَثَلُهُمْ كَمَثَلِ الَّذِي اسْتَوْقَدَ ناراً فَلَمَّا أَضاءَتْ ما حَوْلَهُ ذَهَبَ اللَّهُ بِنُورِهِمْ وَتَرَكَهُمْ فِي ظُلُماتٍ لا يُبْصِرُونَ (17) صُمٌّ بُكْمٌ عُمْيٌ فَهُمْ لا يَرْجِعُونَ (18)

17. Their likeness is that of someone who kindles a fire; when it lights up what surrounds him, God takes away their light and leaves them in darkness, unable to see. 18. Deaf, dumb and blind, they do not return.

Language · Kindling and the shift from singular to plural

I say: the prefix in *istawqada* (استوقد) may signify seeking [to kindle], or it may be additional, giving the meaning of *awqada*, "kindled." *Lammā* (لمّا) is conditional, and "God takes away" (ذهب) is its response (جواب). When a relative pronoun is singular in form but applies to a group, a subsequent pronoun may agree with its form and be singular, or with its meaning and be plural. The verse first uses the singular and then the plural. One says *aḍāʾa, yuḍīʾu, iḍāʾatan*, and *ḍāʾa, yaḍūʾu, ḍawʾan*, of giving light.

Outward commentary · The light awaited and then rejected

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the likeness of these hypocrites among the Jews is that of a man lost on a road in darkness, who kindles a fire to see the right way. When it burns and lights up his surroundings, so that he sees the road and the landmarks of sure guidance become clear, God puts out the fire and takes away its light, leaving only its embers and heat. Likewise, the Jews were in the darkness of unbelief and disobedience, awaiting and seeking the appearance of the Prophet's light, God bless him and grant him peace. When he came to them and his lights shone before them, they disbelieved in him. God therefore removed his light from them and left them in the darknesses of unbelief, doubt and hypocrisy, neither seeing nor finding guidance.

They are deaf to hearing truth, dumb in speaking it, and blind to seeing its light. They do not return from their error or desist from their going astray.

Spiritual allusion · Rejecting the guide when he appears

Consider one who lives in the darknesses of the veil, surrounded by doubts and uncertainty, seeking someone to take him by the hand and guide him to the way of right direction. When the lights of the gnostics appear, and the mysteries of those brought near surround him, until the land's regions shine with their light and the greater part of the servants is revived through them, he rejects them and stays distant. He makes himself deaf to their exhortation, dumb in affirming them, and blind to witnessing their special election. He will not return from his egoic shares and desires, nor desist from clinging to the pursuit of his worldly life.

His likeness is that of someone lost from the road in the darkness of night who kindles a fire to reveal the way. Once it burns and lights his surroundings, God takes away its light, leaving only embers and heat. This is an established pattern: only those at a distance from a saint benefit from him. In the hadith: "Those who value a scholar least are his neighbours." They have likened the saint to a flowing river: the farther it flows, the more widely it benefits others. They also liken him to a date-palm, which casts its shade only at a distance. And God Most High knows best.[B019]

He then sets forth another likeness of them, saying:

2:19–20 · The storm: fear, bewilderment and flashes of guidance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 84–86

أَوْ كَصَيِّبٍ مِنَ السَّماءِ فِيهِ ظُلُماتٌ وَرَعْدٌ وَبَرْقٌ يَجْعَلُونَ أَصابِعَهُمْ فِي آذانِهِمْ مِنَ الصَّواعِقِ حَذَرَ الْمَوْتِ وَاللَّهُ مُحِيطٌ بِالْكافِرِينَ (19) يَكادُ الْبَرْقُ يَخْطَفُ أَبْصارَهُمْ كُلَّما أَضاءَ لَهُمْ مَشَوْا فِيهِ وَإِذا أَظْلَمَ عَلَيْهِمْ قامُوا وَلَوْ شاءَ اللَّهُ لَذَهَبَ بِسَمْعِهِمْ وَأَبْصارِهِمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (20)

19. Or like people caught in a downpour from the sky, with darkness, thunder and lightning in it. They put their fingers in their ears against the thunderbolts, fearing death; but God encompasses the unbelievers. 20. The lightning almost snatches away their sight. Whenever it gives them light, they walk in it; when darkness falls upon them, they stand still. Had God willed, He would have taken away their hearing and sight. God has power over every thing.

Language · Rain, thunder and lightning

I say: “or” (أو) distinguishes different kinds of likeness (للتنويع), or has the sense of “and.” *Ṣayyib* (الصيّب) means rain, on the pattern *fayʿil* (فَيْعِل), from *ṣāba*, said when rain descends. A governing noun is omitted (حذف مضاف): “or like those caught in a downpour.” Its underlying form is *ṣaywib*, as with *sayyid*: the wāw is changed to yāʾ and assimilated (الإدغام). This form occurs only in weak-rooted words (المعتلّ), such as *mayyit*, *hayyin*, *ḍayyiq* and *ṭayyib*.

Thunder (الرعد) is the sound that comes from clouds, and lightning (البرق) the light that comes from them. Ibn ʿAzīz says: “It is related from the Messenger of God, God bless him and grant him peace, that he said: ‘God, mighty and majestic, brings clouds into being; they speak most beautifully and laugh most beautifully. Their speech is thunder and their laughter lightning.’ Ibn

ʿAbbās said: ‘Thunder is an angel driving the clouds, and lightning a whip of light with which he urges them on.’” End of quotation. Thunderbolts (الصواعق) are pieces of fire that fall from the whip in the hand of the clouds’ driver. It is also said that they fall from a fire between heaven and earth. And God Most High knows best.[B020]

Language · The structure of the storm simile

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the hypocrites are also like people caught by heavy rain, darkness and roaring thunder on a dark night in a pitch-black wilderness. Lightning flashes in it and thunderbolts strike. When thunder resounds with a mighty voice, they put their fingers in their ears in terror, fearing the death of their persons, though their spirits and hearts are already dead. When lightning flashes, it almost snatches away their sight. Its flash reveals the road, and they walk; when darkness returns, they stand bewildered, swerving from the very reality of sure guidance. God encompasses them from beyond them. Had He willed, He could have taken away their hearing through the thunder’s sound and their sight through the lightning’s flash. God has power over every thing; nothing defeats Him.

This is their likeness in bewilderment and agitation. It may be a composite simile (التشبيه المركّب), comparing one whole situation with another; or it may be a detailed comparison (المفصّل). In that case, rain represents the Qurʾān, within which unbelief and hypocrisy are mentioned, likened to darkness. The announcement of their requital and the rebuke are likened to thunder; the dazzling proofs that almost overwhelm them at times are likened to lightning. Their fear and alarm are represented by putting their fingers in their ears, lest they hear and incline towards faith. The exposure of their hypocrisy and the obligations of the Sacred Law that they dislike are the thunderbolts. And God Most High knows best.[B021]

Spiritual allusion · Spiritual influxes and resistance to transformation

When the people of special election appear among ordinary people with unfamiliar states, bestowed sciences (علوم وهبية), lordly mysteries and luminous invocations, the latter are astonished and perplexed, and fear for themselves. On hearing divinely bestowed sciences and lordly mysteries from them, they flee and put their fingers in their ears, fearing that their souls

will be parted from accustomed habits and desires. If someone among the ordinary people disputes with them, they silence him with a proof that almost carries him into the Presence. Whenever something of the truth flashes for him, he walks towards that Presence. But when opponents and passing thoughts return against him and his state darkens, he stands bewildered at the door.

Had God willed, He would have taken away his own intellect, hearing and sight, so that through Him he might see his way into His Presence. "Whoever deems it strange that God should rescue him from his appetite and bring him out of his heedlessness has deemed the divine power incapable." "God has power over all things" [18:45].[B022]

The downpour from the sky alludes to the spiritual influxes and states (الواردات والأحوال) that come upon the hearts of gnostics and show their effects upon their limbs. Its darknesses allude to the hiddenness of some of these from the people of the Sacred Law, who consequently deny them. Thunder alludes to persistence in invoking God aloud in assemblies and circles; lightning, to the unfamiliar sciences they express and the proofs they bring against opponents. When ordinary people hear these, their hearts recoil from accepting them. If they exercise fairness, they recognize their soundness, incline towards them and walk in their direction. When opponents return upon them, however, they stand in denial. Had your Lord willed, He would have guided everyone, "but they continue to differ" [11:118].

After mentioning those formed by faith outwardly and inwardly, those likewise adorned with it, and those concealing unbelief while displaying faith, the Real calls them all to affirm His oneness and worship Him, saying:[B023]

2:21–22 · Worship, creation and sustaining providence

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 86–87

يا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ اعْبُدُوا رَبَّكُمُ الَّذِي خَلَقَكُمْ وَالَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ (21) الَّذِي جَعَلَ لَكُمُ الْأَرْضَ فِراشاً وَالسَّماءَ بِناءً وَأَنْزَلَ مِنَ السَّماءِ ماء فَأَخْرَجَ بِهِ مِنَ الثَّمَراتِ رِزْقاً لَكُمْ فَلا تَجْعَلُوا لِلَّهِ أَنْداداً وَأَنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ (22)

21. O people, worship your Lord, who created you and those before you, so that you may become mindful of Him. 22. He made the earth a resting-place for you and the sky a structure, and sent down water from the sky, bringing forth fruits through it as provision for you. So do not set up rivals to God when you know.

Language · Worship and the hope of taqwā

I say: the clause expressing hope (جملة الترجّي) is circumstantial (حال), relating to the plural subject-marker in “worship” (اعبدوا). That is: worship your Lord, hoping to join the ranks of those mindful of God, who win guidance and prosperity and deserve nearness to God Most High. He thereby indicates that taqwā is the utmost degree of the wayfarers: renouncing everything other than God Most High in turning to God Most High.

“Who made” (الذي جعل) qualifies “Lord.” “So do not set up” (فلا تجعلوا) is coordinated with “worship” if understood as a prohibition; alternatively, its verb is in the subjunctive through an implicit *an* (أن), as the response to that command. “Rivals” (الأنداد) is the plural of *nidd*, with a kasra on the nūn: a likeness or equal. “When you know” (وأنتم تعلمون) is a circumstantial clause relating to the subject of “do not set up”: do not set up rivals to God while you are people possessed of knowledge.

Theology · Creation, reason and the succession of divine gifts

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “My servants, worship Me with your hearts through the affirmation of unity and faith; with your limbs through obedience and submission; and with your spirits through witnessing and direct vision. I am He who brought you forth from nonexistence—you and those before you—and spread over you abundant favours. Earth bears you, sky shelters you, and the directions surround you. I sent down water from the sky and brought forth through it various fruits as provision for you.

“You are the precious pearl of truth, enclosed within the shells of My created things; you are those to whom I have disclosed the mysteries of My hidden things. How, then, can you turn towards another, when I have enriched you through the subtleties of My beneficence and kindness? I favoured you first by bringing you into existence (الإيجاد), and then by the succession of sustaining gifts (الإمداد). I singled you out with the light of intellect and understanding, and shone upon you a glimmer from the lights of beginninglessness (القِدَم). Through Me you knew Me, and by My power you worshipped Me. There is no partner or supporter beside Me, and no need of helper or minister.”

Spiritual allusion · Worship through God, from God and towards God

The address is directed to the gnostics perfected in humanity, who worship God out of magnification of the right of lordship and fulfilment of the duties of servanthood. Concerning them the author of the ʿAyn-rhymed ode says:

> They are the people: hold to their side, if you recognize them;
> within them lie remedies for the world’s afflictions. [15]

Before that he says:

> They are the destination of the distressed, the treasure and the hope;
> from them the ardent lover gains what he desires.
> Through them the one lost in blindness finds the very Source;
> through them lovers are drawn, though the dwelling lies far away.
> They are the aim, the object sought, the petition and the wish;
> their name intercedes for the ardent one in love.[B024]

15. Cairo editor, C86.1: He is Shaykh ʿAbd al-Karīm al-Jīlī.

The worship of the gnostics is through God, from God and towards God; the worship of the ignorant is through themselves, from themselves and for themselves. The gnostics' worship is praise and thanksgiving; the heedless worship in pursuit of a personal share and reward. The gnostics' worship is inward, of the heart; that of the heedless is sensible and outward.

"O people singled out for intimacy and nearness, persevere in worshipping the Near One and witnessing the Beloved. I have lifted the veils and curtains between Me and you and made you witness wondrous subtleties and mysteries. I brought you forth into existence, admitted you through the gate of generosity and open-handedness, and granted you, by My bounty, the utmost witnessing, so that you might guard against denial and rejection and recognize Me in every witness and everything witnessed.

"I have made the earth of your souls a resting-place for the sciences of the Sacred Law, and the sky of your hearts a roof for the mysteries of Reality. From the sky of malakūt I have sent down unseen water through which the earth of souls comes alive and stirs with the influxes of the Presence of the All-Holy. It yields fruits of divinely bestowed sciences, lordly mysteries and approved states, nourishing the household of those who listen and reviving the innermost secrets of the wayfarers.

"So witness no other alongside Me, and incline towards no beneficence or kindness but Mine. You know that I alone possess existence, and that generosity and open-handedness belong especially to Me. How can another be hoped in when I have not cut off beneficence? How can attention turn to what is other than Me when I have freely bestowed the customary gifts of grace? From Me came bringing-into-existence, and upon Me rests the continuance of sustaining influx. Trust in Me as guarantor and take Me as your trustee: I shall give you richly and grant you glorious distinction."

Having commanded His servants to worship Him and affirm His oneness, He commands them to affirm His speech and believe in His Messenger, saying:

2:23–25 · The Qurʾānic challenge and the gardens of the faithful

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 87–90

وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ فِي رَيْبٍ مِمَّا نَزَّلْنا عَلى عَبْدِنا فَأْتُوا بِسُورَةٍ مِنْ مِثْلِهِ وَادْعُوا شُهَداءَكُمْ مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صادِقِينَ (23) فَإِنْ لَمْ تَفْعَلُوا وَلَنْ تَفْعَلُوا فَاتَّقُوا النَّارَ الَّتِي وَقُودُهَا النَّاسُ وَالْحِجارَةُ أُعِدَّتْ لِلْكافِرِينَ (24) وَبَشِّرِ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحاتِ أَنَّ لَهُمْ جَنَّاتٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ كُلَّما رُزِقُوا مِنْها مِنْ ثَمَرَةٍ رِزْقاً قالُوا هذَا الَّذِي رُزِقْنا مِنْ قَبْلُ وَأُتُوا بِهِ مُتَشابِهاً وَلَهُمْ فِيها أَزْواجٌ مُطَهَّرَةٌ وَهُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (25)

23. If you are in doubt concerning what We have sent down upon Our servant, then bring a sūrah like it, and summon your witnesses apart from God, if you are truthful. 24. But if you do not—and you will never do so—then guard yourselves against the Fire whose fuel is people and stones, prepared for the unbelievers. 25. Give good tidings to those who believe and perform righteous deeds: theirs shall be gardens beneath which rivers flow. Whenever they are provided with fruit from them, they will say, “This is what we were provided with before,” for they shall be given its like. There they shall have purified spouses, and there they shall abide.

Language · Conditional doubt and the force of the challenge

Should you ask, “The unbelievers’ doubt concerning the Qurʾān certainly occurred; why, then, is it expressed through *in* (إن), which indicates doubt and uncertainty?”—I say: *in* makes the conditional verb jussive, either in its expressed inflection or in its grammatical position (جازمة للفظ الشرط أو محله),

and is assigned to uncertainty about the condition. *Idhā* (إذا), by contrast, does not make the verb jussive in its expressed inflection, but indicates certainty in meaning. Hence the saying:

> When I doubt with *in*, you find me making jussive;
> when I am certain with *idhā*, I do not make jussive.

Should you ask, "The unbelievers' doubt concerning the Qurʾān certainly occurred; why, then, use *in*, which indicates doubt and uncertainty?"—I say: their doubt was misplaced. Had they reflected in the least, it would have disappeared, so clear is the matter and so radiant the proof. Their doubt is therefore treated as though its occurrence were itself doubtful and uncertain.[B025]

Shuhadāʾ (الشهداء) is the plural of *shahīd*, meaning one present, one who bears witness, or a supporter. It is applied to the idols because their worshippers claim that they testify for them. *Dūn* (دون) originally denotes a place nearer than another thing. It was then borrowed for ranks: "Zayd is below ʿAmr," that is, in honour. Its use was subsequently extended to any passing from one limit to another or crossing from one affair to another.

[Translator's print-source notes: T3]

Outward commentary · A challenge beyond their power

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: if you unbelievers doubt what We have sent down upon Muḥammad—Our servant and Messenger, chosen to receive the mystery of Our revelation—then bring a sūrah of its kind in eloquence and lucid expression, containing sciences, mysteries and disclosures of the unseen such as My Book contains. Summon everyone whose support you can obtain in producing it: the gods that you claim will testify for you on the Day of Resurrection, or the eloquent and accomplished speakers present among you whose assistance you seek apart from God, if you are truthful in claiming that they can benefit you. If you cannot do this—and you never will—then submit and acknowledge the truth. Guard yourselves against the Fire whose fuel is people and stones, meaning sulphur stones: these two are its firewood and fuel. It has been prepared for the unbelievers.

Outward commentary · The renewed delight of Paradise

Muḥammad—and anyone fit to convey good tidings—give good tidings to those who believe in God and His Messenger and perform the righteous works required of them: theirs are gardens beneath which rivers flow, that is, beneath their palaces. These are rivers of water, honey, milk, and wine delightful to those who drink it. Whenever they are provided with a kind of fruit from them, they say, “This is what we were provided with before,” in the earthly abode. Natural dispositions incline to the familiar: the appearance agrees, while the taste differs. Alternatively, “before” refers to an earlier provision in Paradise. This is explained by the report from the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace: “By Him in whose hand is Muḥammad’s soul, a man in Paradise takes a fruit to eat, and before it has reached his stomach God Most High replaces it with another like it.” Perhaps, then, on seeing it in its former shape, they say this

in astonishment and delight at the immense difference in flavour alongside the close resemblance of appearance. There they have spouses—that is, houris—purified of menstruation and every other defilement, and of blameworthy dispositions and ignoble traits. There they abide for ever, since a delight followed by extinction is embittered for its possessor. As the poet says:

> There is no good in life while its pleasures are embittered
> by remembering death and decrepit age.

Spiritual allusion · The challenge addressed to those who deny spiritual election

If you ordinary people doubt the lights with which We have specially favoured Our friend, the forms of knowledge and mysteries We have sent down upon his heart, the splendour and lights manifested upon him, and the righteous and good who have found guidance at his hands, then produce something of this yourselves. Seek all the support you can apart from God, if you are truthful in your opposition. Al-Qushayrī says: “Just as the unbelievers’ plotting dwindles away before the Messenger’s miracles, so the claims of pretenders vanish when the lights of the utterly truthful appear.” End of quotation.

If you do not accomplish the opposition We have mentioned—and you will never be able to do so—then yield and submit. Guard yourselves against the fire of severance, egoic shares, covetousness and anxious grasping, whose substance is souls and money (النفوس والفلوس). Through these two those who perish have perished, and those who triumph have triumphed. That fire is prepared for those who deny special election and reject the existence of Prophetic spiritual formation (التربية النبوية).

Give good tidings to those who affirm the existence of special election and submit to its people: theirs are gardens of gnosis in this world and gardens of adornment in the next. Beneath their inhabitants' hearts flow the lights of sciences and forms of knowledge. When the mysteries of His Essence are unveiled to them on the Day of Resurrection, they say, "This is what we knew before in the earthly abode," for existence (الوجود) is one, while knowledge of it differs in degree. They are given resembling provisions of gnosis, because one who knew Him here knows Him in the Hereafter; one who denied Him here denies Him on the Day of Resurrection, except at a particular time and in a particular manner.[B026]

In the gardens of gnosis they have bridal forms of knowledge and unveiling, purified of the defilements of sense perception and the frivolity of caprice and desires. Once firmly established in witnessing the Essence, they abide in the nest of the Presence: there they dwell, and to it they take refuge.

Al-Qushayrī says: "Just as the people of Paradise receive renewed delight at each moment, imagining the second to be like the first but, on tasting it, finding it unlike what preceded, so the states of the people of realities continually increase. When one rises beyond his station, he imagines that what he will meet in this breath is like what preceded; when he tastes it, he finds it many times greater." As one of them says: [16]

> Ever I alight at a dwelling-place of Your love
> whose approach leaves minds bewildered.

16. Cairo editor, C89.1: Al-Baghdādī mentions this verse in Tārīkh Baghdād, 5:135, in an account involving Abū al-Ḥasan al-Nūrī.

When God set forth parables in the Qurʾān concerning the hypocrites and others, some unbelievers and deniers spoke against them. The Real Most High therefore explained their purpose, saying:

2:26–27 · Parables, the covenant and the disclosure of divine wisdom

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 90–91

إِنَّ اللَّهَ لا يَسْتَحْيِي أَنْ يَضْرِبَ مَثَلاً ما بَعُوضَةً فَما فَوْقَها فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا فَيَعْلَمُونَ أَنَّهُ الْحَقُّ مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ وَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا فَيَقُولُونَ ماذا أَرادَ اللَّهُ بِهذا مَثَلاً يُضِلُّ بِهِ كَثِيراً وَيَهْدِي بِهِ كَثِيراً وَما يُضِلُّ بِهِ إِلاَّ الْفاسِقِينَ (26) الَّذِينَ يَنْقُضُونَ عَهْدَ اللَّهِ مِنْ بَعْدِ مِيثاقِهِ وَيَقْطَعُونَ ما أَمَرَ اللَّهُ بِهِ أَنْ يُوصَلَ وَيُفْسِدُونَ فِي الْأَرْضِ أُولئِكَ هُمُ الْخاسِرُونَ (27)

26. God does not refrain through modesty from setting forth a parable of a gnat, or anything beyond it. Those who believe know that it is the truth from their Lord; but those who disbelieve say, “What does God intend by this as a parable?” Through it He leads many astray, and through it He guides many; yet through it He leads none astray except the transgressors:
27. those who break God’s covenant after its binding confirmation, sever what God has commanded to be joined, and cause corruption on earth. They are the losers.

Language · Modesty, the parable and transgression

I say: modesty (الحياء) is a noble disposition that prevents its possessor from committing something for which he would be reproached. The hadith says, “God is modest and generous.” *Mathalan* (مثلاً) is an object (مفعول); *mā* (ما) is an indefinite word qualifying it; and *baʿūḍatan* (بعوضة) is an apposition (بدل). *Baʿūḍa* is a fly. The hadith says, “Were this world worth the wing of a gnat

in God's sight, He would not give an unbeliever a draught of water from it." It is also said to mean the smallest biting insects. Thus: God does not refrain from setting forth a parable—whatever sort it may be—of a gnat or anything beyond it.[B027]

Alternatively, *baʿūḍatan* is the first object and *mathalan* the second, on the pattern of *jaʿala*, "to make." *Mādhā* (ماذا) is either a subject and predicate, with *dhā* a relative expression, or the object of "intends," when the two form a compound interrogative. *Mathalan* is a circumstantial accusative or an accusative of specification (حال أو تمييز). Transgression (الفسق) means going out: one says, "The ripe date *fasaqat*," when it comes out of its skin.

Outward commentary · The purpose of sensible parables

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: God does not refrain, as a modest person might, from setting forth a parable through something lowly or something great—a fly, a spider, or anything else. Believers are certain that it is the truth from their Lord. Its wisdom lies in displaying subtle meanings in sensible forms so that understanding becomes easy. Unbelievers, however, object: "What does God intend by these parables? God is too exalted to strike parables through such lowly things." In answer, God Most High says: He intends thereby to lead one people astray through their rejection, and to guide others through their faith in them. Through such a parable He leads astray only those who depart from obedience to Him: those who break the covenant taken from them in the world of the primordial particles (عالم الذر), or covenant in its unrestricted sense; who sever what God commanded to be joined—prophets, messengers, ties of kinship and other bonds—and corrupt the earth through disobedience and obstructing faith. These are the losers, complete in their loss. We seek refuge in God from abandonment.

Spiritual allusion · Self-disclosure in the smallest and greatest things

God does not refrain from manifesting a similitude of the lights of His holiness, brought forth by His power, clad in the robe of His wisdom, invested with the mysteries of His Essence and clothed in the lights of His attributes—from the smallest particle to that which has no limit. He who discloses Himself in the ant is He who discloses Himself in the elephant. Those who affirm the Essence's self-disclosure in the lights of the attributes say: it is the Real, flowing forth from the light of lordship, veiled in the robe of majesty and the splendours of divinity. Those who deny the manifestation

of the light of the Essence of lordship reject it in its manifestation and say, “What did God intend by these manifest worlds?” The Real Most High replies: “I intended the manifestation of My power and the wonders of My wisdom, so that the mystery of My lordship might appear in the loci of My servanthood.”

Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan, God be pleased with him, said: “Servanthood is a jewel through which He manifested lordship.” Abū al-Ḥasan al-Nūrī was asked, “What are these places and manifest creatures?” He replied: “Manifest might, overpowering dominion, and creatures made manifest through Him and issuing from Him: neither connected to Him nor separated from Him. He has finished with things, but they have not finished with Him, for they need Him while He does not need them.” End of quotation.

By manifesting this cosmos, God intends that one people be led astray through it, stopping at its outward allure, and another be guided through it, penetrating to the inward lesson it offers. None is led astray through it except those who transgress beyond the circle of witnessing and deny the self-disclosures of the worshipped King; those who break God’s covenant, namely the spirit’s knowledge acquired while it was in the world of the primordial particles; and those who sever the bond God commanded to be maintained with the knowing shaykhs whom He qualified for spiritual formation and elevation. Such shaykhs will not cease to exist as long as the Muḥammadan religion remains. These people corrupt the earth through denial and obstruction of the path of the elect, neglecting its foundations: companionship with the gnostics, observing proper courtesy towards them, and honouring their sanctity. Through God is success, and He guides to the even way.

The Real Most High then calls His creatures to wonder at His hiddenness despite His overwhelming manifestation, saying:

2:28 · Life, death and return

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 91–92

كَيْفَ تَكْفُرُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَكُنْتُمْ أَمْواتاً فَأَحْياكُمْ ثُمَّ يُمِيتُكُمْ ثُمَّ يُحْيِيكُمْ ثُمَّ إِلَيْهِ تُرْجَعُونَ (28)

28. How can you disbelieve in God, when you were lifeless and He gave you life? Then He will cause you to die, then give you life again; then to Him you shall be returned.

Language · The circumstantial force of "how"

I say: "How" (كيف) has the force of a circumstantial expression (حال), because it precedes a complete statement.

Outward commentary · The successive gifts of life

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: how can you disbelieve in God and deny His successive blessings, when you were lifeless—drops in the wombs—and He gave you life by breathing the spirit into your bodies? Then He causes you to die when your appointed terms expire; then He gives you life at the resurrection for your reckoning. Thereafter He settles you in the enduring abode, either Paradise or the Fire. These effects indicate His dazzling power and perfect wisdom. The truth has become clear and manifest: "Whoever wills, let him believe; and whoever wills, let him disbelieve" [18:29].

Spiritual allusion · Awakening, effacement and renewed witnessing

How can you deny the manifestation of the Real's light in created things and remain distant from the presence of witnessing and direct vision, when you were dead through heedlessness and the gloom of the veil, and He gave you life through awakening and return? Then He causes you to die through effacement from witnessing anything other than Him; then He gives you life through returning, by God, to witness His effect. Then to Him you re-

turn in everything, witnessing His light in everything, before everything, after everything and with everything: “God was, and nothing was with Him; and He is now as He was.”[B028]

After mentioning the blessing of bringing into existence (الإيجاد), He follows it with the blessing of sustaining provision (الإمداد), saying:

2:29 · Creation for the human being and the seven spiritual stations

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 92–93

هُوَ الَّذِي خَلَقَ لَكُمْ ما فِي الْأَرْضِ جَمِيعاً ثُمَّ اسْتَوى إِلَى السَّماءِ فَسَوَّاهُنَّ سَبْعَ سَماواتٍ وَهُوَ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ (29)

29. He it is who created for you all that is on earth; then He turned to the heaven and fashioned them as seven heavens. He knows all things.

Language · The order of mention and the order of creation

I say: “all” (جميعاً) is an emphatic circumstantial expression (حال مؤكدة) referring to “what.” “Then” (ثم) indicates order in the account, not necessarily order in external occurrence (الترتيب الذكري لا الخارجي), because the spreading of the earth came after the creation of heaven. An alternative is that the coordination refers to the sentence’s sense, giving the reconstruction: He it is who created the earth for you, containing all your benefits; then He turned to heaven and created the seven; then He spread and extended the earth. [17]

Fashioning or setting in order (التسوية) means creating things free from crookedness and defect. “Seven” (سبع) is an apposition to the pronoun or an explanatory specification of it (بدل أو بيان). “He knows all things” explains

17. Cairo editor, C92.1: That is, the order in which the account is told, rather than the order of the matter itself.

what precedes: because He knows the inmost reality of all things, He created what He created according to this most perfect pattern and most beneficial manner.

Outward commentary · Outward benefit and inward reflection

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says through the tongue of the intermediary: He created for your sake everything established on earth. Outwardly you benefit from it as sustenance for your bodies, medicine for your physical frames and enjoyment for your souls; inwardly you benefit through reflection and taking heed, an increase of faith and strengthening of certainty. He then directed Himself towards the heaven with the intention of His will and created them as seven heavens, well-formed and complete, without disparity or defect. Their mass overshadows you, and their sun, moon and stars give you light. His knowledge encompasses all things; hence He created them according to this wondrous pattern and marvellous perfection.

Spiritual allusion · Created things serve you; you belong to the Presence

My servants, I created all things for your sake. The earth bears you, heaven overshadows you, the directions encompass you, animals serve you and plants benefit you. I created you for My sake: how, then, can you incline to another and forget My kindness and beneficence? All things are your servants, while you are servants of the Presence. “You are with created things so long as you do not witness their Creator; when you witness the Creator, created things are with you.”

In one of the revealed books, God Most High says: “My servant, I only bestowed My attributes upon you so that you might know Me through them. If you claim them for yourself, I deprive you of friendship with Me, though I do not deprive you of My attributes. My servant, you are My attribute, and I am your attribute: return to Me and I return to you. My servant, within you is a gate to the sciences whose key is I; and within you is a gate to ignorance whose key is you. Seek whichever gate you wish. My servant, My nearness to you is in proportion to your distance from yourself, and My distance from you is in proportion to your nearness to yourself. I have shown you the way: leave yourself and reach Me in a single movement of thought. My servant, whatever gathers you unto Me comes from Me; whatever scatters

you away from Me comes from you. Strive against yourself and reach Me: I have no need of the worlds. My servant, if you grant Me your soul, I return it to you content and well-pleasing; if you keep it with yourself, it is your greatest affliction and your most hostile enemy. Strive against it, and it returns to you bringing benefits."[B029]

Among the reports transmitted from God Most High is: "My servant, I am your indispensable need: cleave, then, to that without which you cannot be." The earth may also allude to the earth of servanthood, heaven to the heaven of reality, and the seven heavens to seven stations: patience, thankfulness, reliance, contentment, surrender, love and gnosis (الصبر والشكر والتوكل والرضى والتسليم والمحبة والمعرفة). And God Most High knows best. [18]

Having mentioned the creation of the upper and lower worlds, He recounts how the human kind that populated the lower world first began, saying:

18. Cairo editor, C93.1: Al-Daylamī records it in al-Firdaws (5:230, report 8040), from Anas, as a report attributed to the Prophet. Al-Khaṭīb also relates it in Tārīkh Baghdād, 2:242, and says: "The text of this hadith is fabricated."

2:30–33 · Adam, the names and the dignity of knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 93–95

وَإِذْ قالَ رَبُّكَ لِلْمَلائِكَةِ إِنِّي جاعِلٌ فِي الْأَرْضِ خَلِيفَةً قالُوا أَتَجْعَلُ فِيها مَنْ يُفْسِدُ فِيها وَيَسْفِكُ الدِّماءَ وَنَحْنُ نُسَبِّحُ بِحَمْدِكَ وَنُقَدِّسُ لَكَ قالَ إِنِّي أَعْلَمُ ما لا تَعْلَمُونَ (30) وَعَلَّمَ آدَمَ الْأَسْماءَ كُلَّها ثُمَّ عَرَضَهُمْ عَلَى الْمَلائِكَةِ فَقالَ أَنْبِئُونِي بِأَسْماءِ هؤُلاءِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صادِقِينَ (31) قالُوا سُبْحانَكَ لا عِلْمَ لَنا إِلاَّ مَا عَلَّمْتَنا إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ الْعَلِيمُ الْحَكِيمُ (32) قالَ يَا آدَمُ أَنْبِئْهُمْ بِأَسْمائِهِمْ فَلَمَّا أَنْبَأَهُمْ بِأَسْمائِهِمْ قالَ أَلَمْ أَقُلْ لَكُمْ إِنِّي أَعْلَمُ غَيْبَ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَأَعْلَمُ ما تُبْدُونَ وَما كُنْتُمْ تَكْتُمُونَ (33)

30. When your Lord said to the angels, “I am placing a vicegerent on earth,” they said, “Will You place there one who causes corruption and sheds blood, while we glorify You with praise and proclaim Your holiness?” He said, “I know what you do not know.” 31. He taught Adam all the names; then He presented them to the angels and said, “Tell Me the names of these, if you are truthful.” 32. They said, “Glory be to You! We have no knowledge except what You have taught us. You are indeed the Knowing, the Wise.” 33. He said, “Adam, tell them their names.” When he had told them their names, He said, “Did I not tell you that I know the unseen of the heavens and earth, and know what you disclose and what you used to conceal?”

Outward commentary · The angels’ question and the purpose of vicegerency

When God Most High willed to populate the earth, having populated the heavens with angels, He informed the angels of what He would do, to extol Adam, honour his offspring, and teach His servants the practice of consulta-

tion. He told them: “I am placing on earth a vicegerent (خليفة) who represents Me there and executes My judgements.” They replied by way of inquiry—or with the intimacy of confidence, if the speaker was among those brought near—after seeing the jinn corrupt and shed blood: “Will You place there one who causes corruption,” when a vicegerent’s task is to put things right, “while we glorify You with praise,” that is, glorify You accompanied by praising You, “and sanctify ourselves for You,” purifying ourselves for Your sake or declaring You free of whatever does not befit Your holy majesty? Thus: we are more entitled to vicegerency than they are.

The Real, exalted and sublime, replied: “I know what you do not know.” I know that among them will be messengers, prophets and friends of God, and those who are your equals or greater than you. When the Friend, Abraham, was cast into the fire, the angels cried out, “Lord, this is Your friend being burned!” He told them, “If he seeks your help, help him.” When Abraham raised his aspiration beyond them, the Real Most High said, “Did I not tell you that I know what you do not know?”

Theology · The names, humility and the priority of knowledge

The Real Most High then disclosed the ground of Adam’s entitlement to vicegerency: his ennoblement through knowledge. “He taught Adam all the names,” that is, the things named. He cast into Adam’s heart the languages and letters, and the properties and benefits of things, that his descendants would require. He then displayed these named things to the angels, revealing their inability and honouring Adam through knowledge. He said: tell Me the names of these things, if you are truthful in your claim to deserve vicegerency.

When they could not recognize those names, they replied, “Glory be to You”—we declare You free from purposeless action—“we have no knowledge except what You taught us. You are the Knowing,” of everything, “the Wise,” in Your perfect ordering of everything. This acknowledges their limitation and inability and indicates that their question was an inquiry seeking explanation of what they found difficult, not an objection.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, said: “Adam, tell them their names,” specifying for them the name of each named thing. When he told them—for example, “This is a horse, and this a camel”—and distinguished these things for them, his excellence over them in knowledge became evident, establish-

ing his entitlement to vicegerency. The Real Most High said: “Did I not tell you that I know the unseen of the heavens and earth”—what is hidden—and know what you reveal in saying, “Will You place there…?” and what you conceal concerning your own entitlement to vicegerency, and your saying, “God will not create anyone more knowledgeable than us, since we came before”? Excellence belongs to the one who is true, not simply to the one who came first.

Al-Bayḍāwī says: “Know that these verses indicate the dignity of the human being, the distinction of knowledge and its superiority to worship, and that knowledge is a condition of vicegerency—indeed, its principal foundation. They indicate that ‘teaching’ may be predicated of God, although He may not be called ‘a teacher’ (المعلّم), since that designation belongs particularly to someone who practises it as a profession; that languages are divinely instituted (توقيفية), taught by God through revelation; and that Adam, peace be upon him, is superior to these angels because he knows more than they do. The more knowledgeable is superior, according to His words, ‘Are those who know equal to those who do not know?’ [39:9]. They also indicate that God knows things before they occur.” End of the abridged quotation.[B030]

In explaining the angels, he says: “They are subtle bodies (أجسام لطيفة) capable of assuming forms and are divided into two classes. One is wholly absorbed in knowing the Real and free from occupying itself with anything else: these are the exalted ones and the angels brought near. The other administers affairs from

heaven to earth according to the established decree and the course of the divine Pen: these are those who govern affairs. Among them are heavenly and earthly angels.” End of the abridged quotation. **Source comparison:** In the fuller passage of al-Bayḍāwī, *Anwār al-tanzīl*, I:67, on Q2:30, the view that angels are subtle bodies is attributed to most Muslims. He then introduces the philosophers’ account of angels as immaterial substances and places the twofold division under that account. Ibn ʿAjība’s abridgement, Cairo I:94–95, joins the subtle-bodies description directly to the two classes. The translation follows that abridgement; the fuller source distinguishes views whose transition has been omitted here. Abū al-Suʿūd, I:80, preserves the same distinction.

Spiritual allusion · The human spirit and the disclosure of the names

Know that the spirit subsisting in this human being is a portion of the Supreme Spirit (الروح الأعظم), which is the meanings subsisting in the vessels (المعاني القائمة بالأواني). It is the Greater Adam and most ancient father. Concerning this Ibn al-Fāriḍ says:

> Though in form I am Adam's son,
> within him I have a meaning that witnesses to my fatherhood.[B031]

When the Real Most High wished to appoint this spirit as vicegerent within human embodiment, to govern it and dispose of it as intended, the angels said through the tongue of their state (بلسان حالها): how can You place within it one who corrupts it by inclining to egoic shares and desires, and sheds blood through anger and partisan passions, while we glorify You and declare You free from what does not befit You? The angels saw some spirits incline to the lowest depth, but did not see the purification and ascent of others. The Real Most High told them, "I know what you do not know." Among them are spirits that ascend to the Throne of the Presence, worship Me through contemplation and vision, embrace the whole of existence, and have the mysteries of the Essence, the lights of the attributes and the names of the named things unveiled to them.

The Real Most High says to the angels: has any of you had this concealed mystery and guarded Name unveiled to him? They reply, "Glory be to You! We have no knowledge except what You have taught us"—knowledge of the attributes, not the mysteries of the Essence—"You are the Knowing, the Wise." The Real Most High says to the gnostic's spirit, which has penetrated to the ocean of the Essence's unity and the current of the attributes: acquaint them with what is hidden from them of the mysteries of the jabarūt and the names of the malakūt. When it informs them of the mysteries unveiled to it and the lights opened before it, they acknowledge the human being's dignity and prostrate before Adam's appearance, peace be upon him. The Real says to them: "Did I not tell you that I know the unseen of the heavens and earth?"—the mysteries hidden in the heaven of spirits and the lights hidden in the earth of souls. I know the obedience you display and the belief you conceal. And God Most High knows best.

Once Adam's dignity was disclosed and his excellence became clear, He commanded them to prostrate before him, saying:

2:34 · Prostration, pride and the distinction between sin and unbelief

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 95–96

وَإِذْ قُلْنا لِلْمَلائِكَةِ اسْجُدُوا لِآدَمَ فَسَجَدُوا إِلاَّ إِبْلِيسَ أَبى وَاسْتَكْبَرَ وَكانَ مِنَ الْكافِرِينَ (34)

34. When We said to the angels, “Prostrate before Adam,” they prostrated, except Iblīs. He refused, grew proud, and was among the unbelievers.

Language · The past-time particle and the exception

I say: *idh* (إذ) is an adverbial expression for past time, the opposite of *idhā* (إذا). It is governed by an implied verb, explained by His words “Remember when you were…”: wherever it occurs in the Qurʾān, “remember” is supplied. The exception (الاستثناء) is connected if we say Iblīs was one of the angels, and disconnected if we say he belonged to the jinn. And God Most High knows best.[B032]

Theology · The cause of Iblīs’s unbelief

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember when We told the angels to prostrate before Adam. Once Adam’s excellence was apparent, He commanded their prostration, telling them, “Prostrate before Adam,” with a prostration of bowing. They all prostrated because they witnessed gathering (الجمع), not distinction (الفرق): they saw Adam as a direction of prayer or a light among the lights of His greatness. Iblīs alone refused, looking to distinction, by the wisdom of the One, the All-Subduing. He grew proud and belonged among the unbelievers. His unbelief lay in objecting to God and declaring His judgement foolish, not simply in refusing, since bare disobedience does not constitute unbelief. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · A purified spirit and the refusal to submit

When the spirit's purification is complete and its dignity becomes manifest, everything bows and humbles itself before it. Whoever has been embraced by antecedent providence and touched by the breeze of guidance submits to its command, for it has become the Greater Adam. The exception is one made an Iblīs by the divine will and driven away by power: he is too proud to submit himself to the judgement of another of his own kind, and becomes one of those who deny the existence of special election. His recompense is deprivation of witnessing the appearance of lordship and descent to the low ground of the ordinary condition.

The Real Most High then mentions Adam's entry into Paradise and his descent to the vicegerency of which He had spoken earlier, saying:

2:35–37 · Adam's lapse, repentance and descent to vicegerency

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 96–97

وَقُلْنا يا آدَمُ اسْكُنْ أَنْتَ وَزَوْجُكَ الْجَنَّةَ وَكُلا مِنْها رَغَداً حَيْثُ شِئْتُما وَلا تَقْرَبا هذِهِ الشَّجَرَةَ فَتَكُونا مِنَ الظَّالِمِينَ (35) فَأَزَلَّهُمَا الشَّيْطانُ عَنْها فَأَخْرَجَهُما مِمَّا كانا فِيهِ وَقُلْنَا اهْبِطُوا بَعْضُكُمْ لِبَعْضٍ عَدُوٌّ وَلَكُمْ فِي الْأَرْضِ مُسْتَقَرٌّ وَمَتاعٌ إِلى حِينٍ (36) فَتَلَقَّى آدَمُ مِنْ رَبِّهِ كَلِماتٍ فَتابَ عَلَيْهِ إِنَّهُ هُوَ التَّوَّابُ الرَّحِيمُ (37)

35. We said, "Adam, dwell with your spouse in the Garden, and eat freely from it wherever you wish; but do not approach this tree, lest you both become wrongdoers." 36. Then Satan caused them to slip from it and brought them out of the state they had enjoyed. We said, "Go down, enemies to one another; on earth you shall have a dwelling-place and

enjoyment for a time.” 37. Then Adam received words from his Lord, and He turned towards him in mercy. He is indeed the Ever-Relenting, the Merciful.

Language · Abundant eating and the cause of the lapse

I say: “freely” (رغداً) qualifies an omitted verbal noun: “eat an abundant, ample eating.” “Become” (تكونا) is subjunctive as the response to the injunction, or coordinated with “approach” (تقربا). “He caused them to slip” (أزلهما) means that he made them fall into error through eating, or removed them from the Garden. Ḥamza’s reading, “he removed them” (فأزالهما), supports the latter. “Enemies to one another” is a circumstantial clause: “being mutually hostile.”[B033]

Outward commentary · The temptation and the words of return

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: after the angels prostrated before Adam and he entered the Garden, We said, “Adam, dwell with your spouse Eve in the Garden.” She had been created from his left rib. “Eat of the Garden’s fruits wherever you wish, but do not approach this tree”—the vine, fig, or wheat—“lest,” by eating from it, “you wrong yourselves.” Iblīs entered secretly or in the serpent’s mouth and spoke with Adam, peace be upon him. Adam said, “How excellent this state would be, were it everlasting!” Iblīs remembered this and found in covetousness an opening. He said, “Shall I lead you to the tree of everlasting life and a dominion that never decays?” [20:120]. He directed him to eat from the tree, saying: “Your Lord only forbade you it lest

you become two angels or become immortal”; and he swore to them, “I am a sincere adviser to you both” [7:20–21]. Eve ate first, then said, “I have eaten and it has not harmed me.” Adam then ate from the kind of tree, not the particular tree itself, acting on an interpretation. The crown and clothing flew away. Satan brought them out of the ease and happiness they had enjoyed, and they were sent down to earth, to toil and hardship, so that Adam might become vicegerent according to the antecedent decree.[B034] 19

19. Cairo editor, C96.1: It is not for us to investigate how Iblīs whispered to Adam, nor to state a conclusion decisively without evidence. This is a matter of fairness.

The Real Most High told them—Adam, Eve, Iblīs and the serpent—"Go down, enemies to one another. On earth you shall have residence and enjoyment until your deaths; then you come before Me, and the doer of good is recompensed for his goodness and the evildoer for his wrongdoing." Adam received, that is, took, words from his Lord: "Our Lord, we have wronged ourselves. If You do not forgive us and have mercy on us, we shall surely be among the losers" [7:23]. The Real Most High turned towards him and chose him for His Presence, for He continually turns towards His servants and is merciful to them, more merciful than their fathers and mothers. God, grant us a mercy that protects us from seeing other-than-You: You have power over all things.

Spiritual allusion · The return from attraction to servanthood

When the spirit's refinement is complete and its formation perfected, the Real, glorious is His majesty, tells it: dwell, with the human embodiment you have married—He says, "When souls are paired" [81:7]—in the garden of gnosis. Eat of the fruits of its spiritual tastings and the rivers of its sciences, and take up residence in the palaces of its ascents, eating freely so long as you remain adorned with courtesy. Do not approach the tree of disobedience and ill courtesy, lest you become wrongdoers.

When it dwelt in the garden of permanence and greedily desired to remain there, God sent it down to the earth of servanthood and returned it to subsistence (البقاء), so that it might deserve vicegerency and fulfil the claims of lordship, through the disobedience it committed: greedy desire for perpetual freedom. "How noble a disobedience that bequeathed vicegerency!" Everything that brings the spirit down into the compelling condition of servanthood becomes a means of ascent to witnessing the light of lordship. He may decree a sin for you, and it becomes the means of arrival.[B035]

When the Real Most High wished to bring it down to the earth of servanthood through wayfaring after attraction (السلوك بعد الجذب), He told it and its adversaries—Satan, caprice, the world and the other egoic shares—"Go down, enemies to one another." After striving against your enemies, you gnostics have in the earth of servanthood a dwelling and enjoyment of the self-disclosures of the lights of lordship until the true meeting. The spirit receives from its Lord words of turning back. The breeze of guidance blows over it through the providence already bestowed upon it; He turns

towards it and brings it near to the presence of witnessing and the direct vision of the loving King's appearance. He is the Ever-Relenting, Merciful, Munificent, Generous.

The Real Most High repeats His command that they descend, saying:

2:38–39 · Guidance after descent and the inseparability of law and realization

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 97–99

قُلْنَا اهْبِطُوا مِنْها جَمِيعاً فَإِمَّا يَأْتِيَنَّكُمْ مِنِّي هُدىً فَمَنْ تَبِعَ هُدايَ فَلا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (38) وَالَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَكَذَّبُوا بِآياتِنا أُولئِكَ أَصْحابُ النَّارِ هُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (39)

38. We said, "Go down from it, all of you. Whenever guidance comes to you from Me, those who follow My guidance shall have no fear, nor shall they grieve. 39. But those who disbelieve and deny Our signs are the companions of the Fire; there they shall abide."

Language · The condition and the gift of guidance

I say: *in* (إن) is conditional; *mā* is added to strengthen the condition, and for this reason the emphatic nūn enters the verb. *In*, rather than *idhā*, is used although the coming of guidance is certain, because it is not rationally obligatory. The second conditional sentence, with its response, supplies the response to the first condition. "All together" (جميعاً) is an emphatic circumstantial expression: "descend, every one of you." It therefore does not require their descending at one and the same time.[B036]

Outward commentary · Repentance does not annul the appointed vicegerency

When the Real, glorious is His majesty, first commanded Adam to leave the Garden, he wept and implored: "Did You not create me with Your hand? Did You not make Your angels prostrate before me? Did You not admit me to

Your Garden?" He was then inspired with the words he received from his Lord, who turned towards him and had mercy on him. Hearing that his repentance had been accepted, Adam hoped to remain in the Garden. The Real, glorious is His majesty, told him: "Adam, one who has disobeyed Me does not remain My neighbour. My word has already gone forth that you descend to earth to be My vicegerent through your offspring." He therefore repeated the command to descend: "Go down from it, all of you"—the two of you together with the offspring contained in you.

Whenever guidance comes to you from Me—explanation and direction towards affirming My unity and knowing Me, at the hands of a messenger or his deputy—whoever follows that direction, is guided to My knowledge and unity, and observes My obedience and obligations shall have no fear of harm overtaking him or grief over losing something beloved. I turn every harm away from them and bring benefits to them. Those who deny Our signs, which demonstrate Our power and are sent down upon Our messengers, and are too proud to consider them or submit to their bearer, are the companions of the Fire; there they abide for ever.

Spiritual allusion · Descending with permission and remaining in the ship of the Law

When spirits dwell in the nest of the Presence and become established in witnessing and vision, the Real Most High commands them to descend to the heaven of rightful obligations or the earth of allotted enjoyments (سماء الحقوق أو أرض الحظوظ). They descend by permission and firm establishment, rooted in certainty—not to seek recompense or gratify desire. Rather, they descend by God, from God and unto God. Those who descend upon this beautiful guidance have no fear and do not grieve.

But whoever sails the ocean of unity without a knowing captain, does not take refuge in the ship of the Sacred Law, and is too proud to submit to its obligations is tossed by the waves and drowned. Such are the companions of the Fire, abiding therein. For whoever pursues realization without observing the Law falls into heresy; whoever observes the Law without Sufi purification falls into transgression; and whoever unites the two attains realization. May God make us among those who realize both and follow their way until death. Amen.[B037]

Having declared His Book's dignity and excluded doubt from its precincts, then summoned people to His unity and demonstrated His existence through the beginning of the world's creation, from its throne to its carpet, and described how it first became inhabited, the Real Most High addresses the Children of Israel. They possess knowledge of the earlier accounts and have heard these accounts from an unlettered Prophet not known for reading or instruction. The proof has therefore been established against them, and they recognize that it comes from God. Nothing prevents their embracing Islam but envy and love of leadership. For this reason the Real speaks to them at length: sometimes rebuking their failure

to believe and their treatment of their prophets, sometimes reminding them of the blessings He bestowed upon their forebears. He says:

2:40–43 · Remembering blessings and fulfilling the covenant

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 99–100

يا بَنِي إِسْرائِيلَ اذْكُرُوا نِعْمَتِيَ الَّتِي أَنْعَمْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ وَأَوْفُوا بِعَهْدِي أُوفِ بِعَهْدِكُمْ وَإِيَّايَ فَارْهَبُونِ (40) وَآمِنُوا بِما أَنْزَلْتُ مُصَدِّقاً لِما مَعَكُمْ وَلا تَكُونُوا أَوَّلَ كافِرٍ بِهِ وَلا تَشْتَرُوا بِآياتِي ثَمَناً قَلِيلاً وَإِيَّايَ فَاتَّقُونِ (41) وَلا تَلْبِسُوا الْحَقَّ بِالْباطِلِ وَتَكْتُمُوا الْحَقَّ وَأَنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ (42) وَأَقِيمُوا الصَّلاةَ وَآتُوا الزَّكاةَ وَارْكَعُوا مَعَ الرَّاكِعِينَ (43)

40. Children of Israel, remember My blessing which I bestowed upon you. Fulfil My covenant, and I shall fulfil your covenant; and fear Me alone. 41. Believe in what I have sent down, confirming what is with you; do not be the first to disbelieve in it. Do not sell My signs for a paltry price, and be mindful of Me alone. 42. Do not clothe truth in falsehood or conceal the truth while you know. 43. Establish prayer, give the purifying alms, and bow with those who bow.

Language · Israel, the covenant and the fronted pronoun

I say: Israel is Jacob, son of Isaac, son of Abraham the Friend, peace and blessings be upon them. It is a non-Arabic name; the Banū Tamīm pronounce it *Isrāʾīn*, with nūn. In Hebrew, *isrā* means servant and *īl* is a name of God Most High, so its meaning is "servant of God." The Children of Israel are Jacob's descendants.[B038]

"My covenant" is an annexation of the verbal noun to its agent (إضافة المصدر إلى فاعله), while "your covenant" annexes it to its object. "Me alone" (إياي) is accusative through an implied verb, reconstructed after it: "Me fear—so fear Me." The object of "fear Me" is omitted for the verse-endings, as also in "be mindful of Me alone." Fear (الرهبة) here is fear accompanied by self-guarding. "Conceal" (تكتموا) is coordinated with "clothe" (تلبسوا), or subjunctive through an implicit *an* after the prohibition. "While you know" is circumstantial.

Outward commentary · Gratitude, truthfulness and worship

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember the blessing with which I distinguished you: I preferred you over the people of your time and appointed prophets and messengers among you; whenever a prophet passed away, I sent another. I made you kings and governors over people before you corrupted the earth by killing the prophets and denied these blessings. Human beings are naturally prone to envy and rivalry: looking at what God gives another inclines them to resentment and ingratitude, whereas looking at what He gives them inclines them, through love of the blessing, to contentment and thanks. Remember My benefactions and secure them with gratitude.

Fulfil the covenant I made with you: should you live to encounter Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace, you must believe in him, support him, and disclose rather than hide the description of him in your Book. I shall fulfil My covenant with you by admitting you to My Garden, permitting you to behold My Face, and bestowing My good pleasure upon you among My servants. Fear none but Me, for there is no agent other than Me.

Hasten to believe in My Book sent down upon My Messenger Muḥammad, confirming the Torah you possess and standing as its guardian. Do not be the first group to disbelieve in it, bearing both your own sin and that of your followers. Do not exchange faith—the means of success in both abodes—for the passing worldly gain you take from your lower ranks. It is a paltry price followed by mighty punishment and great disgrace. Fear none but Me, for benefit and harm are in My hand. Do not mix the truth—the mention

of Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace, and his description in your Book—with the falsehood you intend through distortion and tendentious interpretation. Do not conceal the truth you possess about Muḥammad and the soundness of his mission, knowing that you distort and confuse through obstinacy and envy, lest My wrath and punishment fall upon you: "He upon whom My wrath falls has indeed fallen" [20:81].

Once you possess the foundations of religion—faith—occupy yourselves with its branches: prayer, almsgiving and the rest. Perform them according to the Muslims' way and join the believers in congregational prayer. Congregational prayer surpasses other prayer by twenty-seven degrees, together with the circulation of spiritual mysteries and the receiving of lights from the righteous and good. Through God is success.

Spiritual allusion · The successive fulfilments of the covenant

When an address is directed to a particular group, those who understand from God take its meaning as general for every hearer. When a king reproaches one people before others, his purpose is to warn everyone who hears. It is as though the Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Adam, remember My blessing upon you; reflect on its roots and branches, and thank Me by attributing it to Me alone, for none bestows blessings but I. Whoever thanks Me, I thank and sustain from the overflow of My kindness and beneficence. Whoever denies My blessing, I deprive and drive from My door.

Fulfil My covenant by discharging the duties of servanthood, and I fulfil yours by disclosing to you the mysteries of lordship. Or: fulfil My covenant by observing the forms of the Sacred Law, and I fulfil yours by guiding you to the beacon of the Path. Or: fulfil My covenant by travelling the Path, and I fulfil yours by bringing you to the very reality. Or: fulfil My covenant by immersion in the ocean of witnessing, and I fulfil yours through unceasing

ascent towards the loving King. Direct fear and desire to Me alone, turning to Me in every request and need. I embrace you with My care and love and grant you immense beneficence and support.

Believe in the gifts of My mysteries and blessings that I send down upon My friends' hearts, confirming what I bestowed on My messengers and prophets. Everything that appears upon the friends of God is a miracle of the prophets and a confirmation of them. Do not hasten to deny My friends and so become the cause of driving My servants from My door. Do not let love of leadership and rank prevent your submission to My friends; do not watch for another besides Me, lest I withhold from you the witnessing of My mystery.

Do not clothe truth in falsehood, displaying the marks of the righteous while concealing the character of transgressors, wearing the garb of God's friends while acting as the misguided do. Once you recognize special election in one of My servants, do not hide it from the people of My love and affection. Establish the prayer of hearts by submission beneath the unfolding decrees; render the alms of souls through humility and brokenness. Be with the humble and bow with those who bow: I grant you My aid and victory and pour upon you from the ocean of My kindness and goodness. "I am with those whose hearts are broken for My sake."[B039]

The Real Most High then rebukes those among the People of the Book and others who know the truth but deprive themselves of it, saying:

2:44 · Admonishing others while neglecting oneself

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 100–101

أَتَأْمُرُونَ النَّاسَ بِالْبِرِّ وَتَنْسَوْنَ أَنْفُسَكُمْ وَأَنْتُمْ تَتْلُونَ الْكِتابَ أَفَلا تَعْقِلُونَ (44)

44. Do you enjoin righteousness upon people and forget yourselves, while you recite the Book? Will you not understand?

Language · Righteousness and forgetting

I say: righteousness (*birr*, البر), with kasra, embraces every form of goodness and kind of obedience. Forgetting (النسيان) means leaving aside.

Outward commentary · A rebuke to those who know but do not act

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says in reproach to the Jewish learned men: when an Arab sought their direction, they directed him to Islam, saying that Muḥammad's religion was true, while themselves abstaining from it. Alternatively, they commanded others to give charity but were themselves miserly. He says: how do you enjoin righteousness and beneficence upon people and leave yourselves in unbelief and disobedience, although you study the authentic Torah and know this to be among the ugliest acts? Have you no understanding to restrain you from this blameworthy quality? The rational intellect distinguishes ugly from beautiful and beneficial from harmful; one who deliberately approaches what harms him does not act with understanding.

Spiritual allusion · The admonisher's responsibility to his own soul

Whoever points towards a station his own foot has not reached is addressed by this rebuke. Whoever reminds another of a fault from which he has not freed himself is told: do you enjoin righteousness upon others and forget that your own soul is empty of it? Among those who give reminders, only the rare individual possessed of purity and fidelity escapes this verse's reproach.

Al-Bayḍāwī says: "Its purpose is to urge the admonisher to purify his soul and turn to its perfection, so that it is set right and he can set others right—not to prevent a transgressor from admonishing. Neglecting one of two commanded duties does not necessitate neglecting the other." Consider his words. Reflect also upon the poet's saying:

You who teach another,
why was this instruction not for yourself?
You prescribe medicine for the sick and wasted,
while you yourself are sick with wasting and its pain.
I see you implant guidance in our minds
as counsel, while yourself devoid of guidance.
Begin with yourself: restrain it from its error;
once it desists, you are indeed wise.
Then, when you admonish, it is accepted;
your words are followed, and instruction benefits.
Do not forbid a trait and then perform its like:
great is your shame if you do so.

Yet one who possesses some purity may remind others and include himself among them. One of our shaykhs, when reminding the spiritual poor, used to say: “We are only barking at our own souls.”

The Real Most High then points to the remedy, saying:

2:45–46 · Patience, prayer and certainty of meeting God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 101–103

وَاسْتَعِينُوا بِالصَّبْرِ وَالصَّلاةِ وَإِنَّها لَكَبِيرَةٌ إِلاَّ عَلَى الْخاشِعِينَ (45)

الَّذِينَ يَظُنُّونَ أَنَّهُمْ مُلاقُوا رَبِّهِمْ وَأَنَّهُمْ إِلَيْهِ راجِعُونَ (46)

45. Seek help through patience and prayer. It is indeed burdensome, except for the humble: 46. those who anticipate meeting their Lord and returning to Him.

Language · Patience, fasting and humility

I say: patience (الصبر) is holding the heart fast to the Lord's judgement. The word may retain its outward meaning, or here denote fasting, since fasting involves patience in abstaining from desires. Humility of the limbs (الخشوع) is their stillness and abasement; submission in the heart (الخضوع) is its yielding to the Lord's judgement.

[Translator's print-source notes: T4]

Outward commentary · The disciplines that overcome love of rank

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: you who are afflicted by leadership and rank, and are too proud to submit to God's judgements brought by His messengers, seek help against your own soul through patience in cutting off familiar habits and abandoning egoic shares and desires. At the root of their branching growth lies love of leadership and rank; whoever patiently abandons these wins God's good pleasure. The hadith says, "In patience over what you dislike is much good." The poet says:

> Patience is like aloes: bitter to the taste,
> but its consequences are sweeter than honey.

Alternatively: seek help through fasting and prayer. Fasting breaks desire and purifies the soul; when purified of vices, the soul is adorned with virtues such as humility, fairness, reverence and the other noble qualities. Prayer contains spiritual and bodily forms of worship: purification, covering one's nakedness, spending money on both, facing the Kaʿba, remaining devoted to worship, displaying humility with the limbs, making the heart's intention sincere, striving against Satan, conversing intimately with the All-Merciful, reciting the Qurʾān, and withholding oneself from the two pleasures.[B040] 20

Through prayer needs are fulfilled and afflictions repaired. Hence, when a matter troubled the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, he took refuge in prayer. It is burdensome to the soul because it recurs each day

20. Cairo editor, C102.1: That is, eating and sexual intercourse. Al-Shihāb al-Khafājī says this in his gloss on al-Bayḍāwī, 2:451.

and comes at the hour when sleep is sweet—except for the humble, in whose hearts its sweetness has settled. They converse with their Lord in it until it becomes the delight of their eyes.

They are certain that they will meet their Lord and delight in beholding His noble Face; they are also certain of returning to Him through resurrection and gathering, for reward and punishment. The Real Most High here uses expectation (الظن) where certainty is intended out of consideration for sinners and indulgence towards the disobedient, who lack certainty's purity. Had He mentioned unmixed certainty, they would have been excluded. Glory be to such a forbearing Lord, such a munificent, generous One! God, favour us with pure gnosis and certainty, so that no illusion or doubt stirs in our hearts, Lord of the worlds.

Spiritual allusion · Persevering at the door of the Presence

You who seek entry into God's Presence, abase and humble yourself before His friends. Swallow the bitterness of patience in this so that they may bring you into His Presence. As the poet says:

> Humble yourself before the one you love: love is not easy.
> When the beloved is pleased, union is assured. [21]

Should love of leadership and rank prevent you, seek help through patience and prayer. Patience is the sign of victory, and prayer restrains indecency and wrongdoing. Keep knocking at the door until you enter with the beloveds. Perseverance in prayer is a weighty matter, except for one who reaches intimate converse with the Most High, the Great, realizes the meeting of witnessing and direct vision, and returns to his Master at every moment. Prayer then becomes the delight of his eye. Through God is success, and He guides to the even way.

Having commanded the foundations and branches, He reminds them of His blessings and warns them of the threatened consequence of failing to give thanks, saying:

21. Cairo editor, C102.2: I suggest that it should read: "Humble yourself before the one you love, for nothing in love is easy."

2:47–48 · Gratitude for distinction and accountability for influence

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 103–104

يا بَنِي إِسْرائِيلَ اذْكُرُوا نِعْمَتِيَ الَّتِي أَنْعَمْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ وَأَنِّي فَضَّلْتُكُمْ عَلَى الْعالَمِينَ (47) وَاتَّقُوا يَوْماً لا تَجْزِي نَفْسٌ عَنْ نَفْسٍ شَيْئاً وَلا تُقْبَلُ مِنْها شَفاعَةٌ وَلا يُؤْخَذُ مِنْها عَدْلٌ وَلا هُمْ يُنْصَرُونَ (48)

47. Children of Israel, remember My blessing which I bestowed upon you, and that I favoured you above the worlds. 48. Guard yourselves against a day when no soul can avail another in anything, no intercession will be accepted from it, no ransom taken from it, and they will not be helped.

Language · Ransom and the omitted resumptive

I say: *ʿadl* (عَدل), with fatḥa, is ransom; *ʿidl* (عِدل), with kasra, is a load. “No soul can avail…” qualifies “a day,” with the resumptive omitted: “on which no soul can avail another.”

Theology · The limits of intercession in this verse

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember My blessing upon your fathers through guidance and the sending of messengers, and My favouring you above the worlds—the people of your own time. Remember these blessings and thank Me by following this illustrious Prophet, whom you find recorded with you in the Torah and Gospel.

Fear a day when one soul cannot discharge anything for another, neither securing it benefit nor warding off harm. No intercession is accepted on its behalf, should intercession be attempted; no ransom is taken, should ransom be offered; and it cannot obtain help against punishment by appealing to its clan. Every possible means of resisting punishment is thus excluded. When a person is seized for chastisement, he contrives to escape through intercession; if that is not accepted, through ransom; or through

the support of relatives. The verse concerns unbelievers and therefore supplies no proof to those who deny intercession for sinful believers. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The blessing and danger of social standing

This reproach may be directed at scholars, righteous people and others possessing leadership, rank, honour or special distinction. The Real Most High tells them: remember My blessing of knowledge, precedence or righteousness, My preferring you over the people of your time and distinguishing you from your fellows. It is reported: “The servant is called to account for his standing as he is called to account for his wealth.” Whoever uses it in obedience to God, humbles himself before God’s servants, attends to their needs and strives to fulfil their purposes has given thanks for the blessing of influence. A hadith is reported: “Whoever strives to fulfil his Muslim brother’s need, whether it is fulfilled or not, has his past sins forgiven and receives two certificates of freedom: from the Fire and from hypocrisy.”[B041]

He takes no wage or payment for this, for such gain is illicit consumption and usury. Whoever grows proud and tyrannical through his influence, or takes payment for it, is told on the Day of Resurrection: “You have already received your wage; you have no share with Us.” Intercession will not benefit him, no ransom will be accepted, and he cannot defend himself against the inroads of humiliation and ruin. In one report, God Most High says to the spiritual poor honoured in this world for their poverty: “Did I not lower prices for you? Did I not make room for you in assemblies? Did I not incline My servants kindly towards you? You have received your reward in the world”—or words to that effect. And God Most High knows best.

The Real Most High reminds the Children of Israel of another blessing, saying:

2:49 · Deliverance from Pharaoh and the tyrannies of every age

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 104–105

وَإِذْ نَجَّيْناكُمْ مِنْ آلِ فِرْعَوْنَ يَسُومُونَكُمْ سُوءَ الْعَذابِ يُذَبِّحُونَ أَبْناءَكُمْ وَيَسْتَحْيُونَ نِساءَكُمْ وَفِي ذلِكُمْ بَلاءٌ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ عَظِيمٌ (49)

49. When We delivered you from Pharaoh's people, who subjected you to grievous torment, slaughtering your sons and sparing your women: in that was a great trial from your Lord.

Language · Pharaoh and the infliction of torment

I say: *idh* (إذ), "when," is governed by "remember." Pharaoh is the title of anyone who ruled the Copts, just as Caesar designates the ruler of the Romans and Chosroes the ruler of the Persians. The Pharaoh in Moses's time was named Muṣʿab ibn Rayyān, or, according to another account, his son al-Walīd.[B042]

Sāma, yasūmu (سام يسوم) means to seek or pursue. One says, "He subjected him to abasement," when he treated him unjustly. "Subjecting you" is circumstantial in relation to "Pharaoh's people," and "slaughtering" explains it. Grievous torment is its most appalling and ugly form.

Outward commentary · A trial in affliction or in deliverance

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember another blessing upon your forebears, known to you: We rescued you from the torment of Pharaoh and his people, who inflicted the ugliest and most terrible suffering upon you. They enslaved your men and women in arduous service and menial work. When the soothsayers told him that a child from among you would destroy his kingdom, he began slaughtering your males and sparing your women. In that was an affliction and mighty trial from your Lord; alternatively, the mighty trial lay in that deliverance. Remember this blessing and fortify yourselves through belief in Muḥammad, God bless

him and grant him peace, against another affliction. Caution does not avail against destiny: “God’s command is a determined decree” [33:38]. Through God is success.

Spiritual allusion · Those who obstruct the way to God

Every age has pharaohs and tyrants who prevent people from severing attachments for God’s sake and entering His Presence: “Their striving goes astray in worldly life, while they suppose they do good work” [18:104]. The Real, glorious is His majesty, says to those freed from them: remember My blessing when I rescued you from the pharaohs of your time. They subjected you to grievous torment—remaining in the gloom of the veil and severance from the beloveds. They kill the certainty you have cultivated in your hearts and the gnosis in your innermost selves, while keeping alive

your desires and egoic shares. “In that is a great trial from your Lord.” He says, “If you obey most of those on earth, they will lead you astray from God’s path; they follow only conjecture…” [6:116]. Through God is success, and He guides to the even way.

2:50 · The divided sea and liberation from desire

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 105–105

وَإِذْ فَرَقْنا بِكُمُ الْبَحْرَ فَأَنْجَيْناكُمْ وَأَغْرَقْنا آلَ فِرْعَوْنَ وَأَنْتُمْ تَنْظُرُونَ

(50)

50. When We divided the sea for you, delivered you, and drowned Pharaoh’s people while you looked on.

Outward commentary · Deliverance witnessed

The Real Most High reminds them of another blessing: the dividing of the sea and drowning of the enemy. He says:

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember also when We divided the sea for your sake as you fled your enemy. You travelled through twelve dry pathways until you escaped towards Syria. When your enemy overtook you

and had fully entered, We closed the sea upon them, delivering you and drowning Pharaoh's people while you watched their drowning and destruction. Give thanks for these blessings upon your forebears and follow the best of what your Lord has sent down to you upon an unlettered Prophet. He had no knowledge of this until your Lord taught him through revelation.

Spiritual allusion · Crossing the sea of customary attachments

One of the sages said: "Caprice is an ocean whose only shore is death." Only the elect cross the sea of egoic shares and habitual attachments: those whom God has favoured with travelling the Path and immersion in the ocean of Reality, at the hands of men who unite the Sacred Law and Reality. To one freed from the sea of his caprice and brought to witnessing his Master, the Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember My blessing when I freed you from the sea of desires and habits, disclosed to you the mysteries of the sciences and treasures of benefits, and drowned in it those who grew proud and transgressed. You see people suffering the gloom of the veil and an evil reckoning, in a deep sea covered by the wave of sins, above it the wave of egoic shares, and above that the cloud of created effects. When one stretches out his hand, he can scarcely see it: "He for whom God appoints no light has no light" [24:40]. Through God is success.

He then reminds them of the blessing of the Torah sent down upon Moses, including within this a rebuke for worshipping the calf, saying, glorious is His majesty:

2:51–53 · The forty nights and fidelity during the guide's absence

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 105–106

وَإِذْ واعَدْنا مُوسى أَرْبَعِينَ لَيْلَةً ثُمَّ اتَّخَذْتُمُ الْعِجْلَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ وَأَنْتُمْ ظالِمُونَ (51) ثُمَّ عَفَوْنا عَنْكُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ذلِكَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ (52) وَإِذْ آتَيْنا مُوسَى الْكِتابَ وَالْفُرْقانَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَهْتَدُونَ (53)

51. When We appointed forty nights for Moses; then, after his departure, you took the calf for worship, and you were wrongdoers. 52. Yet We pardoned you after that, so that you might give thanks. 53. When We gave Moses the Book and the Criterion, so that you might be guided.

Language · The appointed period and the omitted object

I say: “forty” (أربعين) is the object of “We appointed,” not an adverbial expression. “The calf” is the first object, while the second is omitted: “you took it as a god.” “The Criterion” is coordinated with “the Book.”

Outward commentary · The calf and the gift of the Torah

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember when We appointed for Moses forty consecutive nights, with their days, to fast. This followed your request that a Book explaining the judgements be sent down upon him. When he had fasted them—Dhū al-Qaʿda and ten days of Dhū al-Ḥijja—and came to intimate converse, you disbelieved and took the calf for worship. Al-Sāmirī had fashioned it from jewellery borrowed by the Israelite women from the Copts. They fled with it, supposing it lawful. Aaron, peace be upon him, told them, “It is not lawful for you,” so they cast it into a pit. Al-Sāmirī shaped it into a calf and cast into its hollow a handful taken from beneath the hoof of Gabriel’s horse when he crossed the sea with them. It began to low. Al-Sāmirī said, “This is your god and Moses’s god” [20:88]. You wronged yourselves by worshipping it.

Then We pardoned you through repentance and the killing that will be explained, so that you might give thanks and not use a blessing to disobey. Remember also when We gave Moses the Book you requested, the Torah: it is the Criterion by which We distinguished truth from falsehood, so that you might be guided to what is right and escape punishment.

Spiritual allusion · Forty-day withdrawal and the disciple’s fidelity

The early shaykhs and friends of God have continued to follow our master Moses’s path in observing these forty days, withdrawing to their Master in intimacy and converse. In this connection Ibn al-Fāriḍ, God be pleased with him, says:

I became the Moses of my time
when my part became my whole.

And:

My mountains became level dust
in awe of the One disclosing Himself.[B043]

They leave their families and companions to converse with the Beloved and find intimacy with the Near One. Some companions remain faithful in their shaykh's absence, continuing their striving and witnessing. Others are stolen away by the immediate world and return to worshipping the calf of their own share and desire, wronging themselves through following worldly life. If such a person hastens to repent and desist, returning to his shaykh's presence with listening and obedience, pardon and forgiveness come to him, and he may hope again for the witnessing and direct vision he sought. Otherwise he incurs punishment and loss.

Whoever withdraws from beloveds, family and companions, seeking the gathering of his heart and his Lord's pleasure, necessarily receives divine mysteries and directly bestowed gifts from a Wise and Knowing One. Through these he manifests truth, repels falsehood, and distinguishes the two. And God Most High knows best.

The Real Most High explains how those who worshipped the calf repented, saying:

2:54 · Repentance and the four deaths of the lower self

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 106–108

وَإِذْ قالَ مُوسى لِقَوْمِهِ يا قَوْمِ إِنَّكُمْ ظَلَمْتُمْ أَنْفُسَكُمْ بِاتِّخاذِكُمُ الْعِجْلَ فَتُوبُوا إِلى بارِئِكُمْ فَاقْتُلُوا أَنْفُسَكُمْ ذلِكُمْ خَيْرٌ لَكُمْ عِنْدَ بارِئِكُمْ فَتابَ عَلَيْكُمْ إِنَّهُ هُوَ التَّوَّابُ الرَّحِيمُ (54)

54. When Moses said to his people, “My people, you have wronged yourselves by taking the calf for worship. Turn in repentance to your Maker and slay one another. That is better for you with your Maker.” Then He turned towards you in mercy. He is indeed the Ever-Relenting, the Merciful.

Language · The Maker

I say: the Maker (البارئ) is He who determines things and brings them forth.

Outward commentary · The prescribed repentance in Moses’s community

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember when Moses returned from the Mount, found his people worshipping the calf, and told them: “My people, you have wronged and debased yourselves by taking the calf as your god. Repent to your Creator, who fashioned you in the finest form, and kill one another”—destroying this bodily structure I fashioned so beautifully, but which you debased by failing to recognize its worth and worshipping the dullest animal, the cow. One who fails to recognize the right of a blessing deserves to have it withdrawn.

That killing and haste to repent are better for you in your Creator’s sight, because they lead to everlasting life and perpetual joy. When killing became difficult through compassion for brother or kinsman, We cast a mist over you until the place grew dark. You fought one another from morning to evening. Moses and Aaron, peace be upon them, prayed that the cloud be lifted; it was raised when seventy thousand had been killed. You carried out the killing, and the Real Most High turned towards you, accepting the repentance of those remaining and pardoning the dead. He is the Ever-Relenting—abundant in enabling repentance or accepting it—and merciful towards His believing servants.

Spiritual allusion · Dying to caprice, not destroying the body

What our master Moses told his people is likewise said to someone who worships his caprice and persists in following his worldly desire: you who have debased your soul by giving it free rein to follow its inclination, depriving it of witnessing its Master’s beauty, repent to your Lord and awaken from heedlessness. Kill your lower self by opposing its desire, so that it may

live through witnessing its Master. So long as the lower self remains present, its shares held in view and its hopes extended, how can you expect to enter God's Presence and delight in witnessing His beauty and radiance? [B044]

> If you desire union with Us, your death is the condition:
> one in whom a remnant remains does not attain union. [22]

Al-Ḥallāj says in this sense:

> I only surrendered the soul to consuming sicknesses
> because I knew that union would revive it.

And also:

> Kill me, my trusted friends:
> in my killing lies my life.
> My life is in my death,
> and my death is in my life.
> The effacing of my self, to me,
> is among the greatest acts of generosity;
> my remaining in my own attributes
> is among the ugly wrongs.

He also says:

> If shedding my blood is your utmost desire,
> a glance from you is not dearly bought by shedding it.

Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī, God be pleased with him, says: "God is entered upon through only two doors: sensory death, which is natural death, and the death intended by this company." End of quotation. It is the death of the lower selves: one whose lower self has not died has no living spirit.

One of the gnostics said: "Entry unto God is not attained until one has died four deaths: red, black, white and green. Red death is opposing caprice; black death is enduring injury; white death is hunger"—meaning moderate hunger—"and green death is wearing patched garments, laying patches one upon another."

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22. Cairo editor, C107.1: The verse is by al-Shushtarī.

I say: the head and root of caprice is love of rank and pursuit of leadership. Whoever descends to the earth of obscurity and breaks his soul's customary habits there has the veils torn apart, the lights disclosed, and the mysteries shine upon him in a short time. Through God is success, and He guides to the even way.

The Real Most High rebukes them for demanding the vision before its time and before fulfilling its conditions, saying:

2:55–56 · The thunderbolt and revival after effacement

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 108–109

وَإِذْ قُلْتُمْ يَا مُوسى لَنْ نُؤْمِنَ لَكَ حَتَّى نَرَى اللَّهَ جَهْرَةً فَأَخَذَتْكُمُ الصَّاعِقَةُ وَأَنْتُمْ تَنْظُرُونَ (55) ثُمَّ بَعَثْناكُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ مَوْتِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ (56)

55. When you said, “Moses, we shall not believe you until we see God openly,” the thunderbolt seized you while you looked on. 56. Then We raised you after your death, so that you might give thanks.

Language · Open vision

I say: “openly” (جهرة) functions as the verbal noun of “we see,” because it denotes one kind of seeing: “we see God with direct vision.” Alternatively, it is a circumstantial expression referring to the agent—seeing Him face to face—or to the object—seeing Him openly presented to vision.

Outward commentary · The demand for sight and Moses’s intercession

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember what you told Moses after he returned from the Mount and found you worshipping the calf. He chose seventy men who had not worshipped it and went to offer an apology. When you heard My speech, you denied and distorted it, saying, “We shall not believe your claim that this is God’s speech until we see God openly.” The thunderbolt seized you because you demanded what you lacked the capacity to bear. You lost sensory awareness and your spirits departed while you witnessed what was done to you. Moses interceded for you: “Lord, had You willed, You could have destroyed them and me before. Will You destroy us for what the foolish among us have done?” [7:155]. How could he return to his people without them? We then raised you after your

death, and you lived for a time thereafter, so that you might thank Us for this blessing and render good service, acknowledging My lordship and affirming My messengers. But you did not.

Spiritual allusion · Effacement and the truth of certainty

Pure spirits naturally long for the Presence and yearn for direct sight and vision. They attain complete affirmation and certainty only after witnessing and direct vision. When the Real—glory be to Him—knows the sincerity of some spirits' seeking, He raises the veil and opens the door. The thunderbolt of amazement and bewilderment seizes them: unable to bear the shock of witnessing and vision, they are absent from forms and outward traces in witnessing the lights of the Living, the Self-Subsisting. He then favours them with resurrection from the death of effacement (الفناء) to the life of subsistence (البقاء). Secure from misery, they attain enduring life and everlasting felicity.

For the people of this art, the thunderbolt signifies absence from the self and the passing away of the sphere of sense perception: witnessing your non-being before the existence of the Real. Resurrection from it is the station of subsistence, witnessing the created effect through God. This is the station of the truth of certainty (حق اليقين): its outcome is witnessing the existence of the Real alone, neither your non-being nor your being. "God was, and nothing was with Him; He is now as He was." Through God is success.

The Real reminds them of His kindness during their wandering, saying:

2:57 · Manna, quails and the two gardens of the spirit

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 109–110

وَظَلَّلْنا عَلَيْكُمُ الْغَمامَ وَأَنْزَلْنا عَلَيْكُمُ الْمَنَّ وَالسَّلْوى كُلُوا مِنْ طَيِّباتِ ما رَزَقْناكُمْ وَما ظَلَمُونا وَلكِنْ كانُوا أَنْفُسَهُمْ يَظْلِمُونَ (57)

57. We shaded you with clouds and sent down manna and quails for you: "Eat of the good things We have provided for you." They did not wrong Us, but were wronging themselves.

Language · Cloud, manna and quails

I say: *ghamām* (الغمام) is thin cloud. Manna (المنّ) here is honey. *Salwā* (السلوى) is said to mean meat; more correctly, it is the name of a bird resembling the quail.

Outward commentary · Provision in the wandering

The Real, glorious is His majesty, reminds the Children of Israel of His blessings during the wandering: We shaded you with clouds to protect you from the heat, and sent down manna, honey descending on the trees from dawn until sunrise, from which you scooped as much as you wished. We sent down *salwā*, birds gathered by the south wind and brought down upon you. You took as many as you wished, without their resisting, slaughtering them and eating fresh meat. We said: "Eat of the good things We have provided." They did not wrong Us by disobeying their prophet and behaving discourteously towards him, saying, "Go, you and your Lord, and fight; we are sitting here" [5:24]. He punished them with forty years of wandering within five or six parasangs. They wronged themselves, bringing their own souls into affliction and trial.

It is related that, when commanded to fight the tyrants, they grew cowardly and made that reply. Our master Moses prayed against them and they fell into the wandering between Egypt and Syria. They walked by day but spent the night where they had begun the morning; they walked by night but reached morning where they had begun the evening. They asked

Moses, "Who will provide our food?" God sent manna and quails. "What of the sun's heat?" He shaded them with clouds. "How shall we have light at night?" A pillar of light was set in the middle of their encampment. "Who will give us water?" Moses was commanded to strike the stone. "Who will provide clothing?" They were granted garments that neither wore out, grew old nor became dirty, and that grew with their wearers. Alternatively, they were clothed in a covering like a fingernail. God has power over all things.

Spiritual allusion · Freedom, servanthood and the body's rightful place

When the spirits separated from the world of the jabarūt, they possessed original purity and primordial freedom from defilement, knowing the mysteries of lordship and the greatness of divinity. They had only the garden of freedom, however, not the garden of servanthood. When the Real Most

High wished them to enjoy two gardens, to right and left, He commanded them to descend to the earth of servanthood beneath the clouds of human embodiment. He favoured them with the sweetness of witnessing and the solace of intimate converse, telling them: eat of the good things We have provided—the rare treasures of sciences and fruits of understanding.

This applies to one who cares for his spirit, perfects its excellence, and opposes its caprice, so that it penetrates from the world of bodily forms to the world of spirits. The clouds of created effects do not prevent it from penetrating to witness the lights; rather, in witnessing the lights it is absent from witnessing effects. [Translator's note: Cairo I:110 prints فلم تنحجب بسحب الآثار إلى نفوذ شهود الأنوار. The connection made by إلى ("to") within this negative clause is unclear. The following contrast establishes the intended opposition between witnessing lights and being veiled by effects. Ibn ʿAjība's *Īqāẓ al-himam* (ed. al-Kayyālī, 1437/2016, p. 230, ḥikma 110) likewise describes the clouds of effects clearing so that light shines and the heart is absent from forms. This supports the contextual English, but does not explain the exact preposition or establish an emendation.] A spirit veiled from the lights by stopping at effects, caught in the net of egoic shares and desires, and tethered by secondary causes and habits has wronged itself and diminished its rightful share of witnessing its Master. The sphere of sense perception expands over it, and it does not penetrate to witnessing and intimacy. The following verses are recited:

> Perfect your reality, still imperfect,
> and put the body in the lowest place.
> Will you perfect what passes away and leave what endures
> neglected, taking no heed of its concern?
> The body is an instrument for the precious soul:
> what you do not acquire through it is not acquired.
> It perishes, while you remain for ever
> in joy, or misery and unrelenting regret.
> You were given your body as a servant, yet served it:
> will you give the inferior mastery over the superior?
> It is a thick net, and you are in its cords:
> while escape is possible, hasten!
> One capable of reaching the highest dwelling—
> why is he content with the lowest?

He then rebukes their disobedience, saying:

2:58–59 · Entering through humility

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 110–112

وَإِذْ قُلْنَا ادْخُلُوا هذِهِ الْقَرْيَةَ فَكُلُوا مِنْها حَيْثُ شِئْتُمْ رَغَداً وَادْخُلُوا الْبابَ سُجَّداً وَقُولُوا حِطَّةٌ نَغْفِرْ لَكُمْ خَطاياكُمْ وَسَنَزِيدُ الْمُحْسِنِينَ (58) فَبَدَّلَ الَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا قَوْلاً غَيْرَ الَّذِي قِيلَ لَهُمْ فَأَنْزَلْنا عَلَى الَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا رِجْزاً مِنَ السَّماءِ بِما كانُوا يَفْسُقُونَ (59)

58. When We said, “Enter this town and eat freely from it wherever you wish. Enter the gate bowing, and say, ‘Remission!’ We shall forgive your offences and increase the reward of those who do good.” 59. But the wrongdoers substituted a saying other than what they had been told. We therefore sent down upon the wrongdoers a scourge from heaven because they transgressed.

Language · Ḥiṭṭa and the relation between entering and eating

I say: *ḥiṭṭa* (حطة) is the predicate of an implied subject: “Our affair is abasement,” that is, humility and lowering ourselves. Here He says “then eat” with *fā*, whereas in al-Aʿrāf He uses *wāw*: eating follows upon entering, unlike dwelling, which can occur apart from eating, so eating is as though independently commanded.[B045]

Outward commentary · Courtesy in receiving a blessing

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember when, after your forebears left the wandering, We told them: enter this town—Jerusalem or Jericho—after fighting its people, and eat abundantly of its blessings, for it is fertile. Enter its gate bowing in humility and gratitude. On entering, say, “Our affair is *ḥiṭṭa*”: our condition is to lower and humble

ourselves before God. If you do so, We forgive your offences and add much good in this world and the Hereafter for those who obey Our command and show good courtesy towards Us.

The wrongdoers among them substituted another saying: instead of *ḥiṭṭa*, they said *ḥinṭa*, "wheat," and "a grain in a hair." We sent down upon the wrongdoers a scourge, a punishment from heaven, said to have been plague. Seventy thousand died in a single day because of their transgression and exceeding the limits.

Spiritual allusion · The unfrequented door of need

Once spirits are fully purified of residual selfhood and their excellences complete, the Real—glory be to Him—says: enter this holy Presence and delight as you wish in witnessing, discourse, face-to-face encounter, *musāwara* [a figurative encounter whose precise force remains uncertain], opening address and secret converse [Translator's note: Cairo I:111 reads *al-musāwara*. Ibn ʿAjība also includes the word in *Īqāẓ al-himam* (ed. al-Kayyālī, 1437/2016, p. 384, ḥikma 203) among figurative expressions for what spirits perceive and inward selves taste of the Real's greatness and majesty. This confirms the term, but does not define it individually. Ibn Manẓūr's *Lisān al-ʿArab*, s.v. سور, glosses *sāwarahu musāwaratan* as assailing or springing at another. Neither "intimate drawing near" nor a more forceful mystical equivalent is established as Ibn ʿAjība's precise meaning here. The technical word is therefore retained; no emendation to *musārara* or *musāmara* is warranted.] (المشاهدة والمكالمة والمواجهة والمساورة والمفاتحة والمناجاة). Enter its gate abased and humble: there is no entrance to the holy Presence except through humility and need. The following is recited:

> I did not seek entry unto Him until
> I took the station of the lowly servant,
> closed my eyelids over their discomfort,
> and guarded the soul from gossip and disputation. [23]

23. Cairo editor, C111.1: The verses are by al-Sarī al-Saqaṭī, as stated in Ibn al-Jawzī's Zād al-masīr.

Abū Yazīd was told: “Our treasuries are full of service: come to Me through the aperture of humility and need.” Another account says: “Abū Yazīd, draw near to Us with what We do not possess.” He asked, “Lord, what do You not possess?” He replied: “Humility and need.” End of quotation.

The shaykh of shaykhs, the Pole al-Jīlānī, God be pleased with him, said: “I approached every door and found crowds. I came to the door of humility and need and found it empty; I entered through it and called, ‘Come!’”—or words to that effect. The poet says:

> Humble yourself before the one you love: love is not easy.
> When the beloved is pleased, union is assured. [24]

On entering the Presence say, “Our affair is *ḥiṭṭa*”: our concern is lowliness, not loftiness. Travelling through the door of lowly conditions is necessary; otherwise there is no arrival. Whoever travels by that door is purified of residues and perfected in excellences, becoming fit for entry into the Presence

and inclusion among the people of witnessing and vision. He belongs to the excellent, those brought near; necessarily God increases his ascent in sciences and mysteries, in this abode and the next. By contrast, one who disobeys the command to follow lowly conditions and assumes lofty concerns before his formation is complete returns to the gloom of the veil and an evil reckoning, because he has left the beloveds’ road for the path of heedlessness and doubt. Through God is success, and He guides to the even way.

He reminds them of the blessing of the water He gave them during the wandering, saying:

24. Cairo editor, C111.2: See the note on this hemistich on page 102.

2:60 · The twelve springs and the diversity of spiritual gifts

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 112–113

وَإِذِ اسْتَسْقى مُوسى لِقَوْمِهِ فَقُلْنَا اضْرِبْ بِعَصاكَ الْحَجَرَ فَانْفَجَرَتْ مِنْهُ اثْنَتا عَشْرَةَ عَيْناً قَدْ عَلِمَ كُلُّ أُناسٍ مَشْرَبَهُمْ كُلُوا وَاشْرَبُوا مِنْ رِزْقِ اللَّهِ وَلا تَعْثَوْا فِي الْأَرْضِ مُفْسِدِينَ (60)

60. When Moses sought water for his people, We said, “Strike the stone with your staff.” Twelve springs gushed from it, each people knowing its drinking-place. “Eat and drink of God’s provision, and do not spread corruption on earth.”

Language · The stone and the meaning of corruption

I say: seeking water (الاستسقاء) is requesting a supply of drink. The article in “the stone” specifies a known object: either the stone that fled with his garment, or a light, square stone, the size of a man’s head, which he was commanded to carry. He kept it in his bag and struck it when water was needed. It is said to have been marble, or soft porous stone (*kadhdhān*, كدّان). It contained twelve hollows, each producing a fresh spring, according to the number of tribes. When he wanted to carry it, he struck it and the water dried up. Alternatively, the article denotes the kind: he struck any stone he found, and springs burst out, each flowing in a channel to a tribe. They said, “If we reach a land without stones, we shall thirst.” He was inspired: “Speak to it and it will obey you, so that they may take heed.”[B046] [25]

“Then they gushed forth” is coordinated with an omitted clause: “he struck, and they gushed forth.” *ʿUthūw* (العُثو) is the most intense corruption. The verbal forms are *ʿathā–yaʿthū–ʿuthūwan*, *ʿathiya–yaʿthī–ʿithiyyan*, and *ʿātha–yaʿīthu–ʿaythan*. “Corrupting” (مفسدين) is a circumstantial expression em-

25. Cairo editor, C112.1: Kadhdhān is the plural of kadhdhāna: stones with some softness, which may be hollow or worn within. I [the editor] say: no religious matter depends on identifying this stone. It is safer to entrust knowledge of it to God Most High.

phasizing its governing verb; alternatively, it restricts its meaning if *ʿuthūw* is taken more broadly than corruption, applying also to lawful retaliation, which is destructive action without corruption. See al-Bayḍāwī.

Outward commentary · A drinking-place for every tribe

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember when you thirsted in the wandering and asked Moses for water. He sought it for you, and We told him: strike with the staff received from Shuʿayb, peace be upon him. It was of Paradise's myrtle, inherited from Adam and ten cubits long. He struck, and twelve springs gushed forth, according to your tribes, each flowing to one tribe. Every group knew its appointed drinking-place, none encroaching upon another. We told them: eat the manna and quails and drink the water We have provided. Do not grow insolent through blessings and corrupt the earth with sins and disobedience: that is ingratitude deserving deprivation after bestowal. It is related that they numbered six hundred thousand and their camp extended twelve miles. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The shaykh's aspiration and the disciples' differing receptivities

Know that, when spirits are purified of impurities, freed from other-than-God, illuminated by lights and mysteries, and perfected in purification, their possessor becomes one of God's signs and proofs. If he strikes hard hearts or resistant souls with the staff of his aspiration (الهمة), they soften and burst forth with holy sciences, each according to its capacity. Some yield bestowed sciences; others, formal disciplines; others, saintly wonders and extraordinary acts; others, unveilings and disclosures. Every people knows its drinking-place according to its prior allotment.

The Real Most High tells them: eat the fruits you have gathered of the sciences and forms of knowledge We bestowed, and drink from the watering-places of the stations in which We established you. Or: eat fruits of gnosis that strengthen your inward meanings, and drink the Beloved's wine through which you become absent from your own existence. Do not exceed your bounds in fulfilling the duties of servanthood and recognizing the greatness of lordship, thereby exposing yourselves to the withdrawal of His gifts and deserving punishment. In God we take refuge from deprivation after bestowal. Amen.

When they tired of manna and quails, they sought something else instead, as the Real Most High indicates:

2:61 · Rejecting the allotted provision

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 113–115

وَإِذْ قُلْتُمْ يَا مُوسى لَنْ نَصْبِرَ عَلى طَعامٍ واحِدٍ فَادْعُ لَنا رَبَّكَ يُخْرِجْ لَنا مِمَّا تُنْبِتُ الْأَرْضُ مِنْ بَقْلِها وَقِثَّائِها وَفُومِها وَعَدَسِها وَبَصَلِها قالَ أَتَسْتَبْدِلُونَ الَّذِي هُوَ أَدْنى بِالَّذِي هُوَ خَيْرٌ اهْبِطُوا مِصْراً فَإِنَّ لَكُمْ ما سَأَلْتُمْ وَضُرِبَتْ عَلَيْهِمُ الذِّلَّةُ وَالْمَسْكَنَةُ وَباؤُ بِغَضَبٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ ذلِكَ بِأَنَّهُمْ كانُوا يَكْفُرُونَ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ وَيَقْتُلُونَ النَّبِيِّينَ بِغَيْرِ الْحَقِّ ذلِكَ بِما عَصَوْا وَكانُوا يَعْتَدُونَ (61)

61. When you said, “Moses, we cannot endure one kind of food. Pray to your Lord for us to bring forth some of what the earth grows: its herbs, cucumbers, garlic, lentils and onions.” He said, “Would you exchange what is better for what is inferior? Go down to a town; there you shall have what you asked for.” Abasement and poverty were imposed upon them, and they incurred wrath from God. That was because they denied God’s signs and killed the prophets without right; that was because they disobeyed and habitually transgressed.

Language · The foods named in the verse

I say: “one kind of food” means manna and quails. It is called one because it did not vary or change, as when one says that a prince’s table always offers one meal. Herbs (البقل) embraces all greens: low-growing herbs, cabbage, leeks and others. *Qiththāʾ* (القثّاء), plural of *qiththāʾa*, includes cucumbers, snake-cucumbers, melons and other cultivated fruits. *Fūm* (الفوم) is said to be wheat; more correctly, it is garlic. The poet says:

You are a people of base origins:
your food is garlic and onions.

He means garlic by *fūm* and onions by *ḥawqal*. The Arabs interchange *fāʾ* and *thāʾ*: they say *maʿāfīr* and *maʿāthīr*, and call a grave *jadath* or *jadaf*.

Lentils are well known. ʿAlī—God ennoble his face—relates from the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace: "Take lentils, for they are blessed and holy; they soften the heart and increase tears. Seventy prophets blessed them, the last being Jesus son of Mary."[B047] [26]

Outward commentary · Discontent and the preference for familiar habits

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember when you said, "Moses, we cannot endure one food," tiring of honey and meat and inclining towards your own bad sediment—that is, your familiar practices and bad desires, since they had been agricultural people. You said: ask your Lord to bring forth some of what He grows on earth: greens, cucumbers, lentils, garlic and onions. Moses asked: do you exchange the better—meat and honey—for the lower and baser—garlic, onions and the rest? Go down to any town and you will find your cravings, for these foods occur in villages and towns. Alternatively: return to Egypt, where you were humiliated and enslaved, and find your egoic shares and desires, for such shares and desires are bound to humiliation and abasement.

Abasement and poverty were imposed upon them, clinging as a struck coin retains its impression and engraving. Abasement is the imposition of the tribute-tax (الجزية); poverty is poverty of the soul, even when materially wealthy. These were imposed because they were not content with the Real's ordering or satisfied with His provision. Whoever is discontent with his allotted share and tires of the sameness of his sustenance [Translator's note: Cairo I:114 prints وسلم, "and was free/safe," apparently a corruption of وسئم, "and grew tired." The rendering follows the latter conjecture, supported by the passage's opening reference to weariness with manna and quails.] is in danger of abasement and poverty being imposed upon him.[B048]

26. Cairo editor, C113.1: Ibn al-Jawzī mentions this hadith in al-Mawḍūʿāt.

They also incurred God's wrath by breaking covenants and transgressing limits: they disbelieved, grew insolent and killed the prophets without right. The cause was their rebellious persistence in disobedience, for sins draw one another on until they end in unbelief. In God is refuge from His displeasure and wrath.

Spiritual allusion · Your own planning and the divine ordering

Whoever is not content with the eternal allotment and does not remain where divine power has stationed him, but inclines to his own shares and caprice and avidly pursues his aims and wishes, is asked: will you exchange the Real's ordering, which is better, for your own planning, which is lower? Will you leave the ordering of the Wise, Knowing, Compassionate and Merciful for that of your weak, ignorant, paltry and ignoble intellect? You may plan something to your benefit, only to find it against you. Joy may come from where you expected harm, and harm from where you hoped for joy.

How excellent the poet's saying: [27]

> How often I sought a thing whose turning away You chose for me:
> You have ever been kinder and more merciful to me than I.
> I resolved that no thought should stir within the heart
> unless You were placed first;
> and that You should not see me where You forbade me,
> so great and honoured are You in my heart.

You who are discontent with your Master's ordering and incline to attaining your own desire, descend to the earth of shares and appetites: there you will find the bad habits familiar to your soul. You whose soul clings to caprice and follows Satan, how can you exchange enduring dignity for humiliation and abasement? The following is recited:

> Do not follow the soul in its caprice:
> following caprice is abasement. [28]

In *al-Tanwīr*: "A beneficial observation. When the Children of Israel entered the wandering and were provided manna and quails, God had chosen that provision for them. It issued from pure favour, without toil or labour on

27. Cairo editor, C114.1: The three manuscripts read "because You" (li-annaka).
28. Cairo editor, C115.1: The verse is by Imam al-Buraʿī.

their part. Their gross souls, through ingrained habit and absence from witnessing God's ordering, returned to demanding what they had been accustomed to. They said, 'Pray to your Lord for us to bring forth what the earth grows…' He said, 'Do you exchange the better for the inferior? Go down to a town, and you will have what you asked.' Abasement and poverty were imposed upon them, and they incurred God's wrath because they abandoned what God chose for them, inclining instead to their own choice.

"They were therefore reproached: 'Do you exchange the better for the inferior?' The outward explanation is: do you exchange manna and quails for garlic, lentils and onions? The two are unequal in pleasure and freedom from toil. The inward lesson is: do you exchange God's will for you for your will for yourselves? The inferior is what you desire; the better is what God desires for you. 'Go down to a town': what you crave belongs only in towns. The mystery of the address is: descend from the heaven of entrusting yourselves and Our good ordering for you to the earth of your own planning and choice, marked by abasement and poverty because you choose alongside God's choice and plan for yourselves alongside His ordering." End of the relevant passage.

Having reminded them of His blessing and rebuked their sins, the Real Most High encourages them towards Islam, saying:

2:62 · Faith, righteous action and four forms of divine care

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 115–116

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَالَّذِينَ هادُوا وَالنَّصارى وَالصَّابِئِينَ مَنْ آمَنَ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَعَمِلَ صالِحاً فَلَهُمْ أَجْرُهُمْ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ وَلا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (62)

62. Those who believe, those who are Jews, the Christians and the Sabians—whoever believes in God and the Last Day and acts righteously shall have their reward with their Lord; no fear shall be upon them, nor shall they grieve.

Language · The conditional qualification and the communities named

I say: *inna* is emphatic and assigns the accusative to its noun. Its predicate may be the sentence beginning “whoever believes,” or “theirs is their reward,” with “whoever believes” an apposition to its noun. Alternatively, the predicate is omitted and the following relative expression begins a new nominal sentence: those who believe in Muḥammad have no fear and do not grieve; those who are Jews likewise.

“Those who became Jews” (هادوا) means those who entered Judaism. They are called Jews either after their great ancestor Judah son of Jacob, or from *hāda*, “to repent,” because they repented of worshipping the calf.

Naṣārā (النصارى) is the plural of *naṣrān*. They are so called either because they supported (نصروا) the Messiah, peace be upon him, or because they lived with him in a village called Naṣrān. The Sabians are a group of the People of the Book who left Judaism and worshipped the stars. One says *ṣabā–yaṣbū* when someone inclines and passes from one religion to another.[B049]

Outward commentary · The commentator’s interpretation of the promised reward

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those who believe in Muḥammad, those who believed in Moses or Jesus, peace be upon them, and those who left their religion and inclined away—whoever believes in God and the Last Day, follows Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace, and acts according to his Law, has his reward with his Lord upon coming before Him: abiding bliss and the vision of His noble Face. They do not fear when unbelievers fear, nor grieve when the negligent and wicked grieve: no evil consequence reaches them, and no bounty escapes them. Through God is success.[B050]

Spiritual allusion · Four groups specially embraced by providence

Those who believe with a faith untouched by illusion, doubt or uncertainty, whether through decisive proof or radiant witnessing; those who repent of whispering thoughts and inward heedlessness; those who support religion and build high the beacon of the Muslims' Law; and those who incline towards the Beloved, turning from every near or distant other—these are those whom God's antecedent care embraces and the breeze of guidance visits. They unite adorning the inward being with certainty's lights and the outward being with obedience and submission. Necessarily, when they come before their Lord, He honours their standing, makes their reward abundant, and raises their station. These are God's friends, upon whom is no fear and who do not grieve.

Those specially embraced by providence form four groups. One He establishes to nurture faith and cultivate certainty, through evidence and proof—the people of reflection and consideration—or through witnessing and direct vision—the people of witnessing and insight. Another He establishes to purify their souls and refine their states through repentance and abandoning every blameworthy quality: these are wayfarers and seekers. Another He establishes to support religion and manifest the Muslims' Law, through expounding its principles or striving against its adversaries: these are scholars and fighters in God's path. Another He establishes in His service, filling their hearts with awe: these are worshippers and ascetics. They turn from desires, find intimacy with Him in retreat, abandon homelands and part from beloveds and brethren. They incline towards the Beloved's love and delight in conversing with the Near One. These are singled out by providential care and protected with the utmost solicitude. They neither fear when people fear nor grieve when people grieve. May God realize us in all their stations through His favour and generosity. Amen.

He rebukes their breaking of covenants and failure to remain within the limits, saying:

2:63–66 · The covenant, the raised Mount and the Sabbath

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 116–118

وَإِذْ أَخَذْنا مِيثاقَكُمْ وَرَفَعْنا فَوْقَكُمُ الطُّورَ خُذُوا ما آتَيْناكُمْ بِقُوَّةٍ
وَاذْكُرُوا ما فِيهِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ (63) ثُمَّ تَوَلَّيْتُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ذلِكَ فَلَوْلا
فَضْلُ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ وَرَحْمَتُهُ لَكُنْتُمْ مِنَ الْخاسِرِينَ (64) وَلَقَدْ عَلِمْتُمُ
الَّذِينَ اعْتَدَوْا مِنْكُمْ فِي السَّبْتِ فَقُلْنا لَهُمْ كُونُوا قِرَدَةً خاسِئِينَ (65)
فَجَعَلْناها نَكالاً لِما بَيْنَ يَدَيْها وَما خَلْفَها وَمَوْعِظَةً لِلْمُتَّقِينَ (66)

63. When We took your covenant and raised the Mount above you: “Hold firmly to what We have given you, and remember what is in it, so that you may be mindful of God.” 64. Then, after that, you turned away. Had it not been for God’s bounty and mercy towards you, you would have been among the losers. 65. You knew those among you who transgressed concerning the Sabbath. We said to them, “Be apes, despised!” 66. We made it a deterrent for those present and those coming after, and an admonition for the God-conscious.

Language · Lawlā and the unfulfilled consequence

I say: *lawlā* (لولا) is a particle signifying that one thing fails to occur because another exists (حرف امتناع لوجود). It necessarily precedes a subject, whose predicate, according to Sībawayh, must be omitted: “had God’s bounty and mercy towards you not been existent…” The Kufans take what follows as the subject of an implied verb: “had God’s bounty and mercy not been established…” “You would have been” is its response. [29]

29. Cairo editor, C117.1: That is, the non-occurrence of one thing because another exists.

Outward commentary · Accepting the obligation and subsequently turning away

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember when We bound you to accept the Torah's obligations, which were burdensome to you. When you refused, We uprooted the Mount and raised it above you like a canopy, covering the extent of your camp. We told you: take the Torah We have given with seriousness and effort, and remember its admonitions and reminders, so that you may fear God and attain abundant good. You accepted unwillingly, then turned away, shedding blood and killing prophets. Were it not for God's favour in enabling your repentance and His mercy in accepting it, you would have lost both this world and the Hereafter.

You knew what befell those who violated the Sabbath in David's time, peace be upon him, in a coastal town called Ayla. They had been forbidden to fish on the Sabbath. On that day the fish appeared openly, extending their snouts towards the shore; on Sunday they returned to sea. The people dug pools and cut channels leading to them. Fish entered on Saturday and were caught on Sunday. When no punishment followed, they made fishing on the Sabbath lawful for themselves. The town divided into three groups: those who forbade, those who remained silent, and those who fished. Those who fished were transformed into apes and swine: the young into apes, the old into swine. They remained three days and died. We made that act a chastisement and deterrent for those present at its time and those who came after, and an admonition for the God-conscious of Muḥammad's community, God bless him and grant him peace.[B051]

Spiritual allusion · The guide's protective aspiration

When disciples enter a shaykh's hand and take the covenant from him, he places upon them burdens and breaks their customary habits in ways that cause their lower selves to die and their hearts to live: slaughtering selfhood, lowering their heads, and parting with money. If they incline to neglect, he overshadows them with the mountain of his aspiration and surrounds them with the hand of his protection and care. Hence Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan said: "By God, a shaykh is not a shaykh until his hand accompanies the spiritual poor wherever he goes." The hand means aspiration and protection, not the bodily hand. The shaykh continues to send these disciplines, urging them to take them up and work diligently with them, until

their lower selves die, their hearts live, their knowledge becomes rooted and their formation complete. They then pass to repose and fragrant ease in the gardens of witnessing and direct vision.

I say: our shaykh used to send us written slips in the beginning. Before opening one my lower self would tremble at its contents, knowing that he sent only what would cause its death. Were it not for God's bounty and mercy, strengthening us to act upon them, we would have been losers. Some were missed by providential care: they exceeded their shaykhs' limits or left their circle before completing their formation. Their hearts were transformed and their inscriptions erased from the register of friendship with God. God made this a lesson to others and a restraint upon those following their example. We seek refuge in God from deprivation after bestowal, ingratitude for blessings and loss of good pleasure. Through God is success, and He guides to the even way.

He rebukes what their forebears did in killing a soul and disputing with their prophet, saying:

2:67–71 · The cow and the burden of needless questioning

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 118–119

وَإِذْ قالَ مُوسى لِقَوْمِهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْمُرُكُمْ أَنْ تَذْبَحُوا بَقَرَةً قالُوا أَتَتَّخِذُنا هُزُواً قالَ أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ أَنْ أَكُونَ مِنَ الْجاهِلِينَ (67) قالُوا ادْعُ لَنا رَبَّكَ يُبَيِّنْ لَنا ما هِيَ قالَ إِنَّهُ يَقُولُ إِنَّها بَقَرَةٌ لا فارِضٌ وَلا بِكْرٌ عَوانٌ بَيْنَ ذلِكَ فَافْعَلُوا ما تُؤْمَرُونَ (68) قالُوا ادْعُ لَنا رَبَّكَ يُبَيِّنْ لَنا ما لَوْنُها قالَ إِنَّهُ يَقُولُ إِنَّها بَقَرَةٌ صَفْراءُ فاقِعٌ لَوْنُها تَسُرُّ النَّاظِرِينَ (69) قالُوا ادْعُ لَنا رَبَّكَ يُبَيِّنْ لَنا ما هِيَ إِنَّ الْبَقَرَ تَشابَهَ عَلَيْنا وَإِنَّا إِنْ شاءَ اللَّهُ لَمُهْتَدُونَ

(70) قالَ إِنَّهُ يَقُولُ إِنَّها بَقَرَةٌ لا ذَلُولٌ تُثِيرُ الْأَرْضَ وَلا تَسْقِي الْحَرْثَ مُسَلَّمَةٌ لا شِيَةَ فِيها قالُوا الْآنَ جِئْتَ بِالْحَقِّ فَذَبَحُوها وَما كادُوا يَفْعَلُونَ (71)

67. When Moses said to his people, “God commands you to slaughter a cow,” they said, “Do you make a mockery of us?” He said, “I seek refuge in God from being among the ignorant.” 68. They said, “Pray to your Lord for us to explain what it is.” He said, “He says it is a cow neither old nor young, but midway between the two. Do what you are commanded.” 69. They said, “Pray to your Lord for us to explain its colour.” He said, “He says it is a yellow cow, bright in colour, pleasing to those who look.” 70. They said, “Pray to your Lord for us to explain what it is, for the cows look alike to us; God willing, we shall be guided.” 71. He said, “He says it is a cow not trained to plough the earth or water the crops, sound and without a mark.” They said, “Now you have brought the truth.” They slaughtered it, though they had nearly failed to do so.

Language · The cow’s age, colour and markings

I say: *fāriḍ* (فارض) is an old cow that no longer bears young; *faraḍat al-baqara–tafriḍu–furūḍan* means it has grown old. *Bikr* is a young cow that has not calved. *ʿAwān* is intermediate between old and young. *Fāqiʿ* means brilliantly yellow; one says “vivid yellow” and “pitch black,” the latter meaning intensely black. *Shiya* (شية) derives from *wishya* (وِشية), like *ʿida* from its root: the first radical is dropped and compensated by the final tāʾ. *Washy* is a coloured pattern.

Outward commentary · The murder, the questions and the eventual obedience

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember when Moses spoke to his people after they disputed before him about a slain man found in a village, whose killer was unknown. A poor Israelite had killed a wealthy relative to inherit from him, cast his body into another village, and gone to demand vengeance for him. They brought their case before Moses, who told them through revelation: God commands you to slaughter a cow.

The command left its description unspecified. They asked, “Do you make us objects of mockery?” We ask you to disclose the killer, and you command us to slaughter a cow! This was obstinacy and ill courtesy. He replied, “I seek refuge in God from being among the ignorant,” for only an ignorant person mocks a matter of religion. [30]

Seeing his seriousness, they asked: pray to your Lord to explain whether it is old, young or intermediate. He replied: He says it is neither old nor young, but midway between the two. Do what you are commanded, and God will disclose the killer. They asked: pray to your Lord to explain its colour—is it red, black or yellow? He replied: He says it is yellow, brilliant in yellowness, pleasing those who look through its plumpness and the beauty of its colour. They asked again what it was, since yellow cows were numerous and the matter seemed confused.

He replied: He says it is free of labour, not broken to work. It does not turn the earth in ploughing or water crops by drawing water. It is sound, free of every defect, with no marking differing from its yellow colour. When the matter became clear, they said, “Now you have brought the clear truth.” They found it with a young man under his mother’s care; his father had placed it in safekeeping for him in a thicket. They bought it for its hide full of gold, or for its weight in gold. They slaughtered it and struck the dead man with part of it. He sat up, blood flowing from his veins, and said, “A paternal cousin of mine killed me,” then returned to death. They had nearly failed to do it, through their repeated hesitation or its exorbitant price. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, said: “Had they slaughtered the least cow, it would have sufficed; but they made things difficult, so God made them difficult for them.”[B052] [31] [32]

He then recounts the beginning of the story, saying:

30. Cairo editor, C118.1: The source copies read: “nadhbaḥū” (نذبحوا).

31. Cairo editor, C119.1: Al-sāniya: the water-drawing wheel.

32. Cairo editor, C119.2: A place where trees grow thickly.

2:72–73 · The slain man restored and the limits of legal inference

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 119–121

وَإِذْ قَتَلْتُمْ نَفْساً فَادَّارَأْتُمْ فِيها وَاللَّهُ مُخْرِجٌ ما كُنْتُمْ تَكْتُمُونَ (72)
فَقُلْنا اضْرِبُوهُ بِبَعْضِها كَذلِكَ يُحْيِ اللَّهُ الْمَوْتى وَيُرِيكُمْ آياتِهِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَعْقِلُونَ (73)

72. When you killed a person and disputed about it, God was bringing out what you concealed. 73. We said, “Strike him with part of it.” Thus God gives life to the dead and shows you His signs, so that you may understand.

Language · Why the beginning of the story is placed afterwards

I say: in narrative sequence this verse belongs before “God commands you…” The Real Most High postpones it so that the reproach reaches them twice: for failing to hasten to obey their prophet, and for killing a soul. Had it been placed first, there would have been one story and one rebuke.

Outward commentary · The sign of resurrection

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember when you killed a soul through greed for worldly gain, then disputed concerning it, each village repelling the accusation. God brings out and makes clear what you concealed of the killing and its perpetrator. We said: strike the dead man—or his grave—with part of the cow, said to be its tongue, heart, thigh or tail. They struck him; he revived and named his killer, as already mentioned. Just as He revived this slain man, God gives life to the dead from their graves and shows you the signs of His power, so that you may understand: He who can revive one soul can revive them all.

Outward commentary · A dying accusation and the killer's inheritance

The Mālikīs adduce this story for the bloodied victim's accusation (التدمية الحمراء), accepting the victim's statement before death that a particular person killed him. This requires examination, because this man revived after death, and lying could not enter his statement. They also use it to establish that the killer is deprived of inheritance. This too requires examination, because it is the law of those before us, which may be subject to abrogation. The rule that he does not inherit is, however, established in hadith. And God Most High knows best.[B053] [33]

Spiritual allusion · The death of selfhood and the fitness of the soul

If a shaykh commands disciples to slaughter their lower selves by breaking customary habits, hesitation over what brings the lower self's death indicates scant sincerity and a weak final attainment. Haste to overcome it indicates sincerity, success and a sound end. When the lower self dies entirely, the spirit lives through knowledge and perpetual witnessing, with no death thereafter: "They taste no death therein except the first death" [44:56]. Natural death is only a passage from station to station, from a narrow home to a spacious one. The following is recited:

> Do not think death is death:
> it is life, the utmost of desire.
> Do not fear death's assault:
> it is only passage from here.
> Put bodily forms off from your selves,
> and behold the Real in clear direct vision.

I say: the sword that finishes the lower self swiftly is humility and poverty. Whoever humbles himself among his fellows, breaks his own habits and renounces the world finds his lower self dead in the blink of an eye and his spirit alive. He gains the delight of the eye: knowledge of his Master and absence from all else.

The best time for this slaughter is when the lower self is between youth and age. If too young, one fears its return; if too old, its withdrawal may be difficult. It should be complete in qualities through beautiful renunciation and

33. Cairo editor, C120.1: "Red tadmiya" concerns a victim bearing a wound, evidence of a blow, or poison; if none of this is present, it is "white tadmiya."

restraint, pleasing to behold through its comely appearance. Likewise, seeing a person of witnessing and vision captivates hearts and carries them swiftly into the Presence of the Knower of unseen things, through his established witnessing of the malakūt. Whoever beholds him forgets ordinary human conditions, is overtaken by spiritual lights, and becomes absent from near and far in remembrance of the Beloved. As the hadith says: "God's friends are those whose sight brings God to remembrance."

This lower self must also be unbroken by pursuit of worldly gain and greed, sound and free of blemish, with no created thing holding it in bondage. It then becomes fit for the Presence and delights in witnessing and vision. The adversary of separation (الفرق) no longer contests or disputes with it: the adversary has acknowledged the truth, and the dispute is lifted.

He rebukes the failure of this miracle to affect their hearts, saying:

2:74 · Hardness of heart and the rivers released by repentance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 121–122

ثُمَّ قَسَتْ قُلُوبُكُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ذلِكَ فَهِيَ كَالْحِجارَةِ أَوْ أَشَدُّ قَسْوَةً وَإِنَّ مِنَ الْحِجارَةِ لَما يَتَفَجَّرُ مِنْهُ الْأَنْهارُ وَإِنَّ مِنْها لَما يَشَّقَّقُ فَيَخْرُجُ مِنْهُ الْماءُ وَإِنَّ مِنْها لَما يَهْبِطُ مِنْ خَشْيَةِ اللَّهِ وَمَا اللَّهُ بِغافِلٍ عَمَّا تَعْمَلُونَ (74)

74. Then your hearts hardened after that, becoming like stones, or harder still. Among stones are some from which rivers burst forth, some that split and release water, and some that fall down in fear of God. God is not unaware of what you do.

Language · Hardness and the senses of "or"

I say: *qaswa* and *qasāwa* mean hardness and dryness, just as *shaqwa* and *shaqāwa* are variant forms of misery. One calls a stone hard, meaning dry. The poet says:

I see no effect of remembrance upon my body,
though a rope leaves its mark upon the hard mountain.

"Or" (أَوْ) marks a transition of emphasis, means "and," or distinguishes kinds: some hearts are like stones, others harder.

Outward commentary · Stones that answer while hearts remain unmoved

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: then your hearts, Jewish people, hardened and grew dry, neither softening nor humbling themselves, despite the signs they saw: the stone gushing with water in the wandering, manna and quails descending, clouds providing shade, the dead revived, and the rest. Al-Kalbī says: "After seeing this, they denied it and said, 'We did not kill him.' Never were their hearts blinder or their denial of their prophet more intense." Their hearts are like stones—indeed, harder. Or: compare their hearts to stones and you are right; compare them to something harder and you are right. Stones possess a softness surpassing theirs: great rivers burst from some, flowing springs emerge from others, and others fall from mountain-tops in fear of God. A report says: "Every stone that falls from a mountain-top falls through fear of God." Your hearts, however, neither soften nor humble themselves nor produce good. We ask God for safety through His favour and generosity.

Spiritual allusion · Symptoms and treatment of the hardened heart

Whoever behaves discourteously towards his teacher or leaves his circle for another becomes hard-hearted, losing his spiritual state and inner substance. If he returns soon and makes good what was lost, his heart softens and his state rises; otherwise he falls into the depths of severance and nothing comes of him.

Signs of a hard heart include dry eyes, long hopes, no sorrow over missed acts of obedience or committed sins, and no joy in the obedience one performs. A believer is pleased by his good deeds and distressed by his wrongs. Its remedy is companionship with the humble spiritual poor who remember God, sitting before the perfected gnostics, regularly fasting, praying at night while people sleep, and imploring the Living, Self-Subsisting One who never sleeps. Al-Shāfiʿī, God be pleased with him, says:

When my heart hardened and my ways grew narrow,
I made my hope a ladder to Your pardon.
My sin seemed immense, but when I set it beside
Your pardon, Lord, Your pardon was greater.

His words, “Among stones are those from which rivers burst forth,” likewise apply to hardened hearts. When they soften through turning to their Lord and abandoning familiar habits, rivers of knowledge burst forth and mysteries of wisdom open within them. Some melt in awe of the One disclosing Himself, their mountains levelled and the earth of their lower selves shaken. As one says:

Had your eyes seen the day the earth of souls was shaken
and the mountains levelled,
you would have seen the sun of the Real pour out its light
amid the shaking, while the men remained men.

And God Most High knows best.

He then removes the believers’ expectation of faith from those characterized in this way, saying:

2:75–77 · Distortion after understanding and the concealment of knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 122–123

أَفَتَطْمَعُونَ أَنْ يُؤْمِنُوا لَكُمْ وَقَدْ كانَ فَرِيقٌ مِنْهُمْ يَسْمَعُونَ كَلامَ اللَّهِ ثُمَّ يُحَرِّفُونَهُ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما عَقَلُوهُ وَهُمْ يَعْلَمُونَ (75) وَإِذا لَقُوا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا قالُوا آمَنَّا وَإِذا خَلا بَعْضُهُمْ إِلى بَعْضٍ قالُوا أَتُحَدِّثُونَهُمْ بِما فَتَحَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْكُمْ لِيُحَاجُّوكُمْ بِهِ عِنْدَ رَبِّكُمْ أَفَلا تَعْقِلُونَ (76) أَوَلا يَعْلَمُونَ أَنَّ اللَّهَ يَعْلَمُ ما يُسِرُّونَ وَما يُعْلِنُونَ (77)

75. Do you then hope that they will believe you, when a group of them used to hear God's speech and then distort it after understanding it, knowing what they did? 76. When they meet those who believe, they say, "We believe"; but when they are alone together, they say, "Do you tell them what God has disclosed to you, so that they may dispute with you by it before your Lord? Do you not understand?" 77. Do they not know that God knows what they conceal and what they disclose?

Language · Believing as acknowledgement and submission

I say: believing here includes the sense of submission and acknowledgement; hence it takes the preposition *lām*. "A group of them used to…" is circumstantial relative to the subject of "believe." "When they meet…" is coordinated with "used to." The sense is: do you hope for their faith when their predecessors distorted God's speech and those now present dissemble before you in God's religion? There is no ground for such hope in one characterized this way.

Outward commentary · Knowing distortion and concealed acknowledgement

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Muslims, do you hope that the People of the Book will submit to you and affirm you, when a group of them—the seventy who accompanied Moses to offer an apology—heard God's speech as He addressed them and imposed the Torah's arduous requirements, then distorted it, saying, "He said, 'Do what you can'"? If hearing the speech without an intermediary did not bring them faith, how will these believe you when they hear only through the mediation of a messenger?

Alternatively, they heard God's speech in the Torah and distorted it by erasure or interpretation, such as the description of our master Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace, the stoning verse, and other matters, after understanding it, knowing it was God's speech—or knowing that they were changing and distorting His speech.

How can you hope for their belief while they dissemble? On meeting believers, they say, "We believe; your prophet's description is mentioned in our Book." Alone together, those who did not dissemble blame the others: "Do you tell them what God disclosed to you of the Torah's knowledge, reveal-

ing it so that they may overcome you with an argument before your Lord, in this world and the next? They will say: you knew our prophet's prophethood but denied it obstinately. Have you no understanding, that you disclose what God has opened to you?" Alternatively, the Real Most High says, "Have you no understanding, Muslims, that you hope for their faith despite these qualities?" The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: do they not know that nothing is hidden from God, that He knows their secret and public acts and recompenses both?

Spiritual allusion · The danger of repudiating a knowledge once approached

One whom the prior will assigns to abandonment and decree condemns to deprivation returns to evidence and demonstration after approaching witnessing and direct vision. He returns to seeing effects and forms, forgetting the subtle sciences he once knew. The cause is failure in courtesy towards shaykhs and companions, parting from the brethren and ceasing to maintain contact with the people of gnosis, compounded by denial of God's friends and distortion of the divine gifts heard from them. There is no expectation of his return when he has become so distant from opening and its means—especially if he adds hypocrisy, displaying agreement when meeting people of the spiritual affiliation and discord when alone with the general public. No success or joyful attainment is expected for one like this. We seek refuge in God from it.

Having mentioned the Jewish leaders, the Real Most High follows with their followers, saying:

2:78 · Uncomprehending imitation and the limits of one's own knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 123–124

وَمِنْهُمْ أُمِّيُّونَ لا يَعْلَمُونَ الْكِتابَ إِلاَّ أَمانِيَّ وَإِنْ هُمْ إِلاَّ يَظُنُّونَ (78)

78. Among them are unlettered people who know the Book only through notions; they do no more than conjecture.

Language · The range of amāniyy

I say: *amāniyy* (أمانيّ) is the plural of *umniyya*. Originally it means what a person forms within himself, from *manā*, "to determine or conceive." It is therefore applied to falsehood, what one wishes for, and what one recites. Al-Bayḍāwī says this. The exception is disconnected: "but [they know] falsehoods." One says a man *tamannā* when he lies and invents a report. Thus ʿUthmān, God be pleased with him, said: "By God, since embracing Islam I have neither fabricated tales nor sung." [34]

Outward commentary · Unexamined notions about Scripture

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: among the Jews are unlettered common people who neither read nor understand the Book. They hear false notions from their learned men, supposing things to belong to Scripture without knowing their truth—for example, the alteration of the Prophet's description,

God bless him and grant him peace, and other matters. Or they hear empty promises and groundless hopes: that none but they will enter Paradise, that the Fire will touch them for only a few days, and their other empty wishes and false expectations. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Mistaking the limits of one's understanding for the limits of reality

Those who deny the people of special election are of three kinds: arrogant people of leadership, rigid jurists and imitative commoners. His words apply to them: "Among them are unlettered people who know the Book only through notions," since they lack knowledge to distinguish the person in truth from the person in error and merely imitate. Their burden falls upon those who deprive them of the blessing of trusting acknowledgement and lead them into the ill fortune of hostile criticism. Ibn al-Bannāʾ expresses the condition of deniers well:

34. Cairo editor, C123.1: Because the reader reckons that such-and-such a word follows such-and-such another.

Know, my friend—may God protect you—
that people have turned away from realization.
They knew not souls and hearts,
and sought what was not to be sought.
They occupied themselves with the world of bodies,
all of them, near and far.
They denied what they did not know, claiming
that nothing beyond the body could be known.
They accused him of unbelief, heresy and innovation
when the intelligent, scrupulous man invited them.
Each thinks that no understanding exceeds his own,
and no knowledge lies beyond his knowledge,
veiled from seeing the degrees,
perhaps called a scholar or a seeker.
Far from it! All this is shortcoming
which the skilful and discerning reject.

He then threatens the learned men who distort, saying:

2:79 · Writing falsehood for worldly gain

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 124–125

فَوَيْلٌ لِلَّذِينَ يَكْتُبُونَ الْكِتابَ بِأَيْدِيهِمْ ثُمَّ يَقُولُونَ هَذَا مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ لِيَشْتَرُوا بِهِ ثَمَناً قَلِيلاً فَوَيْلٌ لَهُمْ مِمَّا كَتَبَتْ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَوَيْلٌ لَهُمْ مِمَّا يَكْسِبُونَ (79)

79. Woe to those who write the Book with their own hands and then say, “This is from God,” to obtain a paltry price for it. Woe to them for what their hands have written, and woe to them for what they earn.

Language · The cry of woe

I say: *wayl* (ويل) is an expression used by someone falling into destruction. Its basic sense is punishment and ruin. Originally it is a verbal noun without a corresponding verb; its supplicatory force permits it to begin a nominal sentence. Abū Saʿīd al-Khudrī relates from the Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace: “Wayl is a valley in Hell.” [Were the mountains of this world made to travel through it, they would melt.][B054] [35]

[Translator’s print-source notes: [T5]]

Outward commentary · Distortion to preserve authority

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: woe to those who write the Book with their hands, distorting God’s Book, and say, “This is from God,” fearing the loss of their leadership and the payments they receive from their lower ranks. The verse was revealed concerning the Jewish learned men: when the Prophet came to Medina, they feared losing their authority and devised means to prevent Jews from embracing Islam. His description in the Torah

35. Cairo editor, C124.1: Inmāʿat means “melted.” I say: the words between square brackets do not form part of the cited prophetic report. They are instead the words of ʿAṭāʾ ibn Yasār, as in the commentaries of al-Ṭabarī and al-Wāḥidī, or of Abū Saʿīd al-Khudrī, as in al-Baghawī’s commentary.

was: beautiful in face and hair, dark-rimmed of eye, of medium stature. They changed it to: tall, blue-eyed and straight-haired. Woe for what their hands wrote and what they earn and take from their lower ranks. However great it appears to the senses, it is little compared with the painful punishment it incurs.

Spiritual allusion · Corrupt rulings and inherited spiritual authority

Two groups should be restrained by this verse. First are scholars of legal judgements who issue opinions contrary to the established position (المشهور) out of desire for the perishable gain received for their fatwās; likewise judges who decide according to desire, seeking bribes or status. Woe to them for what their hands write and what they earn.

Second are people of leadership and rank, including descendants of the righteous. When they see someone established in friendship with God or a spiritual affiliation, they fear losing their authority and plot to prevent people entering his path. They write sophistries and nonsense that repel people from following truth. “But God will only perfect His light, though the unbelievers dislike it” [9:32].

The Real Most High mentions some of their empty wishes, saying:

2:80–82 · False assurance and the conditions of saintly intercession

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 125–127

وَقالُوا لَنْ تَمَسَّنَا النَّارُ إِلاَّ أَيَّاماً مَعْدُودَةً قُلْ أَتَّخَذْتُمْ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ عَهْداً فَلَنْ يُخْلِفَ اللَّهُ عَهْدَهُ أَمْ تَقُولُونَ عَلَى اللَّهِ مَا لا تَعْلَمُونَ (80) بَلى مَنْ كَسَبَ سَيِّئَةً وَأَحاطَتْ بِهِ خَطِيئَتُهُ فَأُولئِكَ أَصْحابُ النَّارِ هُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (81) وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحاتِ أُولئِكَ أَصْحابُ الْجَنَّةِ هُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (82)

80. They say, “The Fire will touch us only for a few numbered days.” Say, “Have you taken a covenant with God—God will not break His covenant—or do you say of God what you do not know?” 81. Rather, whoever earns evil and is encompassed by his offence—such are the companions of the Fire, abiding therein. 82. But those who believe and do righteous deeds are the companions of the Garden, abiding therein.

Language · Balā and naʿam

I say: *balā* (بلى) is a response particle like *naʿam* (نعم), but the two differ. *Balā* answers a negative and turns it into an affirmation. If asked, “Did Zayd not come?” one replies *balā*: he did come. Likewise, they said, “The Fire will not touch us,” and God replied *balā*: it will touch you. *Naʿam*, however, confirms the preceding statement, negative or affirmative. Asked “Did Zayd not come?” *naʿam* confirms that he did not. Asked “Did Zayd come?” it confirms that he came. Someone has put this into verse:

> *Naʿam* confirms what goes before,
> affirmation or negation: so they teach.
> *Balā* replies to a negative,
> but makes it affirmative: so they explain.

Outward commentary · The offence that encompasses its possessor

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the Children of Israel utter their false wish that the Fire will touch them for only a few numbered days—forty, the period of calf-worship—after which the Muslims will replace them there. The Real tells Muḥammad to ask: have you taken a covenant from God to that effect, which He will not break, or do you speak about Him without knowledge? Rather, the Fire will touch you and you will remain there, for whoever acquires an evil deed—unbelief—and dies upon it, his offence surrounding and mastering him, belongs among the companions of the Fire, abiding therein.

Those who believe what was revealed to Muḥammad and perform righteous works according to his purified Law are the companions of Paradise, abiding therein. It is His customary manner, when mentioning one group, to follow it with its opposite, for encouragement and warning. Through God is success.

Spiritual allusion · Companionship is not permission to disobey

Know that many rely upon companionship with God's friends while giving their souls free rein in disobedience and desires. They say, "We heard our master so-and-so say: whoever sees us is not touched by the Fire." This is error and delusion. The Prophet, peace and blessings be upon him, told his daughter: "Fāṭima daughter of Muḥammad, I cannot avail you against God: purchase your own soul from God." To the man who asked, "Pray that I may be your companion in Paradise," he said, "Help me against your own soul through abundant prostration."[B055]

Certainly, if this saying comes from a friend of God firmly established with Him, it is true—but on condition that the person who sees him obeys the commands and abandons forbidden things. What may be hoped from God's bounty, through His friends' blessing, is that He accepts the best of that person's deeds and overlooks his wrongs. The firmly established friends have taken a covenant with God, which He will not break: they intercede for someone who attaches himself to them while adhering to the Sacred Law.

The usual condition of one who accompanies firmly established friends of God is protection and non-persistence in sin. Such a person is not touched by the Fire. In the hadith: "When God loves a servant, sin does not harm him"—meaning that He inspires swift repentance—as the people of Badr were told, "Do what you wish: I have forgiven you." Only the people of effacement and subsistence take this covenant, because they are through God in what they say. They report nothing from their own selves and find no abiding place with other-than-God. Someone who has not reached this station has no such covenant, because he remains through himself. One attached to such a person is in danger. Through God is success.

His words, "Rather, whoever earns evil…": whoever acquires love of the world is surrounded by its occupations and attachments. He remains in the fire of severance, encompassed by the enclosure of cares and impurities, stung by the scorpions of doubts and other-than-God. By contrast, one upon whom faith's lights shine and who accompanies the people of witnessing and direct vision enjoys repose, fragrance, a garden and good pleasure. May God give us that enjoyment in both abodes. Amen.

He rebukes their breach of the covenant taken from them, saying:

2:83 · The covenant of worship and beneficence

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 127–128

وَإِذْ أَخَذْنا مِيثاقَ بَنِي إِسْرائِيلَ لا تَعْبُدُونَ إِلاَّ اللَّهَ وَبِالْوالِدَيْنِ إِحْساناً
وَذِي الْقُرْبى وَالْيَتامى وَالْمَساكِينِ وَقُولُوا لِلنَّاسِ حُسْناً وَأَقِيمُوا
الصَّلاةَ وَآتُوا الزَّكاةَ ثُمَّ تَوَلَّيْتُمْ إِلاَّ قَلِيلاً مِنْكُمْ وَأَنْتُمْ مُعْرِضُونَ (83)

83. When We took the covenant of the Children of Israel: “Worship none but God; show kindness to parents, kindred, orphans and the needy; speak kindly to people; establish prayer and give the purifying alms.” Then you turned away, except a few of you, and remained averse.

Language · A prohibition expressed as a statement

I say: “You do not worship” (لا تعبدون) is a declarative expression with prohibitive meaning, like “No scribe or witness shall be harmed” [2:282]. It is more emphatic than an explicit prohibition, suggesting that those forbidden have already hastened to desist. Alternatively, *an* is omitted and the imperfect consequently nominative. A verb of saying is also omitted: “We told them, ‘You do not worship…’” Ibn Kathīr, Ḥamza and al-Kisāʾī read the verb in the third person.

Outward commentary · Four forms of obedience and the order of their claims

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember when We bound the Children of Israel by covenant and told them: association of another with Me or inclination to another should not be conceivable from you, so worship Me alone. Show complete goodness to parents, and goodness to relatives by lineage and religion. Treat orphans and the needy with generosity and gentleness. Speak good words to people, free of empty talk and sin, containing sincere counsel and direction. Establish prayer with its conditions perfected and its courtesies complete, and give the alms to those entitled. Yet you subsequently turned away, except the few among you who embraced Islam, averting yourselves from truth after its manifestation.

The Real mentions four works in this covenant: one proper to the heart, affirming divine unity; one to the body, prayer; one to wealth, almsgiving; and one comprehensive, beneficence. He orders its recipients by priority: parents first because of their greatest and most binding right; then relatives, since kindness to them unites the reward of beneficence and maintaining kinship; then orphans because of their scant resources; then the needy because of their weakness. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The inward covenant and spiritual parenthood

A covenant like every covenant taken from the Children of Israel is taken from the Muḥammadan community. This is the wisdom of recounting their stories and faults: we should guard against falling into what destroyed them. Corresponding to each outward covenant taken from the generality, [36]

an inward covenant is taken from the elect. The Real binds those turning towards Him to direct their aspiration only to Him and rely in their hearts only upon Him; to adopt beneficence towards relatives, strangers and all the brethren, especially parents, whether of bodily or spiritual parenthood. The latter are those who practise Prophetic formation. The rights of the spiritual father take precedence over those of the bodily father: bodily fatherhood occasioned entry into the abode of passing-away and humiliation, whereas spiritual fatherhood occasioned entry into repose and fragrance. [B056]

Those turning towards Him are bound to speak gently and kindly, guide people to the Generous Bestower, establish prayer through limbs and hearts, and give their souls' alms by purifying them of faults. Whoever turns away after this is a transgressor, outside the circle of friendship with God.

He reproaches their violation of another covenant, saying:

36. Cairo editor, C127.1: The source copies read: "so that you perish" (fa-tahlikū).

2:84–85 · Killing, expulsion and selective fidelity to Scripture

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 128–130

وَإِذْ أَخَذْنا مِيثاقَكُمْ لا تَسْفِكُونَ دِماءَكُمْ وَلا تُخْرِجُونَ أَنْفُسَكُمْ مِنْ دِيارِكُمْ ثُمَّ أَقْرَرْتُمْ وَأَنْتُمْ تَشْهَدُونَ (84) ثُمَّ أَنْتُمْ هؤُلاءِ تَقْتُلُونَ أَنْفُسَكُمْ وَتُخْرِجُونَ فَرِيقاً مِنْكُمْ مِنْ دِيارِهِمْ تَظاهَرُونَ عَلَيْهِمْ بِالْإِثْمِ وَالْعُدْوانِ وَإِنْ يَأْتُوكُمْ أُسْرَى تفدوهم وَهُوَ مُحَرَّمٌ عَلَيْكُمْ إِخْراجُهُمْ أَفَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِبَعْضِ الْكِتابِ وَتَكْفُرُونَ بِبَعْضٍ فَما جَزاءُ مَنْ يَفْعَلُ ذلِكَ مِنْكُمْ إِلاَّ خِزْيٌ فِي الْحَياةِ الدُّنْيا وَيَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ يُرَدُّونَ إِلى أَشَدِّ الْعَذابِ وَمَا اللَّهُ بِغافِلٍ عَمَّا تَعْمَلُونَ (85)

84. When We took your covenant: “Do not shed one another’s blood or expel one another from your homes.” You acknowledged it, yourselves bearing witness. 85. Yet here you are, killing one another and expelling a group of your own people from their homes, supporting one another against them in sin and aggression. If they come to you as captives, you ransom them, although their expulsion was forbidden to you. Do you believe in part of the Book and disbelieve in part? Those among you who do this have no recompense but disgrace in worldly life; on the Day of Resurrection they shall be returned to the severest punishment. God is not unaware of what you do.

Language · The demonstrative and the pronoun of the affair

I say: in “then you, these…” (ثم أنتم هؤلاء), “you” is the subject, “these” its predicate, and “killing” a circumstantial expression, as when one says, “You are that man, having done such-and-such.” Alternatively, “these” is an ap-

position and “killing” the predicate; or “these” is vocative, “you people”; or accusative through specification (الاختصاص). Aggression (العدوان) is excess in wrongdoing.

“Captives” (أسارى) is circumstantial, the plural of *asīr*, also pluralized *asrā*, as in another reading: “being captives.” *Huwa* (هو) is the pronoun of the affair (ضمير الشأن), “forbidden” a predicate, and “their expulsion” a delayed subject. Alternatively, *huwa* refers to expulsion and is the subject, “forbidden” its predicate, with “their expulsion” an apposition to the pronoun. This sentence connects with “you expel a group from their homes, supporting one another against them in sin and aggression”; the intervening words are a parenthesis.

Outward commentary · A people treated as one soul

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember when We bound you by covenant and told you not to shed your blood—that is, not to shed one another’s blood—or expel yourselves from your homes: no one should drive his brother out of his dwelling

and banish him. The Real makes them one soul, which in reality they are. As the poet says:

> The source of our breaths is one;
> our bodies too are one body encompassing us.

You acknowledged this covenant, committed yourselves to it and bore witness against yourselves. Yet you Jewish people kill one another and expel a group from their homes, prevailing over them through injustice and tyranny. If they come to you as captives, you ransom them with your wealth, though that expulsion is forbidden to you.

The verse’s substance is that God bound the Children of Israel in the Torah not to kill or expel one another, and to purchase and free any Israelite man or woman found enslaved, whatever the price. Qurayẓa were allies of the Aws, and al-Naḍīr of the Khazraj. When war broke out, Qurayẓa supported the Aws against al-Naḍīr fighting with the Khazraj. The victors destroyed their opponents’ homes and expelled them. If a man from either side was captured, they collected money to ransom him. The Arabs reproached them: “You fight them and then ransom them?” They replied, “We are commanded to ransom them and forbidden to fight them.” “Why, then, fight?”

"We are ashamed to see our allies humiliated." God rebuked them: do you believe in the portion of the Book commanding ransom and disbelieve in the portion forbidding killing and expulsion?

Those who do this have no recompense but disgrace—humiliation and abasement—in worldly life: captivity and killing for Qurayẓa, exile from their homeland for al-Naḍīr; or abasement and tribute for both until the Day of Resurrection. Then they are returned to the severest punishment. What befell them is not expiation of sins, but vengeance and wrath. God is not unaware of what you do.

Spiritual allusion · Different capacities and freeing the captives of desire

People are of two kinds. The weak hold to the Sacred Law's outward aspect without penetrating its inward reality. They cannot put their lower selves to death or leave the homeland of their habits. The Real tells them: do not shed your blood in My love, for you cannot bear it; do not leave your homes through the journeying of your hearts, since you have acknowledged your weakness and inability.

He tells the strong: you people put your lower selves to death in seeking My knowledge and bring a group of you out of their accustomed homes in seeking My good pleasure, helping one another overcome your lower selves. Thus one report says: "God first tells the servant to seek well-being, Paradise, works and other things. If he says, 'No, I desire only You,' He tells him: whoever enters this with Me enters only by relinquishing allotted shares, removing the originated and affirming the eternal (رفع الحدث وإثبات القدم); that entails non-being." The following is recited:

> One not effaced from his own share,
> from effacement itself and intimacy with beloveds,
> remains standing between the stations,
> seeking a share or a beautiful destination. [37]

He also tells the strong who have overcome their lower selves and left their habits: if others come captive in the hands of their lower selves and habits, or in pursuit of the world and its desires, ransom them from captivity, free their bonds and admit them to their Master's Presence. In one report: "The

37. Cairo editor, C130.1: Al-Ṭūsī, in al-Lumaʿ, attributes the two lines to Abū ʿAlī al-Rūdhbārī.

seeker of the world is a captive; the seeker of the Hereafter a hired worker; the seeker of the Real a prince." A prince frees captives from the enemy's hands through the strength and preparedness God grants him. When the servant is freed from caprice, he enters his Master's Presence. Anyone seeking to expel him after entry is told: their expulsion is forbidden to you.

How can you believe in the Sacred Law's outward aspect while denying the science of the Path and the lights of Reality? Whoever does this receives disgrace in worldly life: greed, covetousness, fear, anxiety, long hopes and failure to rise to action. On the Day of Resurrection they return to the severest punishment: the gloom of the veil and an evil reckoning. God is not unaware of what they do.

The Real Most High states their character and what He has prepared for them, saying:

2:86 · The exchange of the lasting for the passing

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 130–130

أُولئِكَ الَّذِينَ اشْتَرَوُا الْحَياةَ الدُّنْيا بِالْآخِرَةِ فَلا يُخَفَّفُ عَنْهُمُ الْعَذابُ وَلا هُمْ يُنْصَرُونَ (86)

86. These are those who purchase worldly life at the price of the Hereafter. Their punishment shall not be lightened, nor shall they be helped.

Outward commentary · The price of a broken covenant

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: these covenant-breakers and transgressors of the limits have bought worldly life and its deceptive adornments at the price of the enduring, everlasting Hereafter. Their punishment is not lightened for an hour: humiliation and abasement in this world, entry into the fires in the next. Nor are they helped to ward it off at any time.

Spiritual allusion · The outward lure and the inward lesson

These looked at the deceptive outward appearance of created things without penetrating their inward lesson. The torment of illusion and the veil therefore does not cease, nor are they rescued from painful punishment.

The Real Most High rebukes their denying and killing the messengers, saying:

2:87 · Messengers, the Holy Spirit and opposition to the divine call

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 130–131

وَلَقَدْ آتَيْنا مُوسَى الْكِتابَ وَقَفَّيْنا مِنْ بَعْدِهِ بِالرُّسُلِ وَآتَيْنا عِيسَى ابْنَ مَرْيَمَ الْبَيِّناتِ وَأَيَّدْناهُ بِرُوحِ الْقُدُسِ أَفَكُلَّما جاءَكُمْ رَسُولٌ بِما لا تَهْوى أَنْفُسُكُمُ اسْتَكْبَرْتُمْ فَفَرِيقاً كَذَّبْتُمْ وَفَرِيقاً تَقْتُلُونَ (87)

87. We gave Moses the Book and sent messengers after him in succession. We gave Jesus son of Mary clear proofs and strengthened him with the Holy Spirit. Whenever a messenger came to you with what your souls did not desire, did you grow proud—denying some and killing others?

Language · Jesus, Mary and the Holy Spirit

I say: “We sent after” (قفّينا) means We caused to follow. *ʿĪsā* is a non-Arabic name adapted from Syriac Īshūʿ, declining without full inflection because it is a foreign proper name. *Maryam* means a servant, and its pattern is *mafʿal*, not *faʿīl*. “We strengthened him” means We fortified and supported him. The Holy Spirit (روح القدس) here is Gabriel, peace be upon him: the holy spirit, an annexation of the qualified noun to its attribute. He is called this because he is pure of the turbidity of sense perception.[B057]

Outward commentary · Rejection prompted by desire

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: We gave Moses the Torah, but you did not fulfil its right or act upon its contents. In care for you We sent messengers after him, another whenever one died. We gave Jesus son of Mary clear miracles: reviving the dead, healing congenital blindness and leprosy, reporting unseen things, and the Gospel. We supported him with Gabriel, who accompanied him wherever he went and raised him to heaven when you sought to kill him.

Whenever a messenger brought what your souls disliked—arduous obedience and abandonment of egoic shares and desires—did you grow proud and refuse belief, denying some, such as Jesus, Solomon and Muḥammad, peace be upon them, and killing others, such as Zechariah and John, peace be upon them? Al-Qushayrī says: "They listened to the callers with the ear of caprice, so their own attributes and desires became what they worshipped." End of quotation.

Spiritual allusion · The continuing callers to God

Everything the Real tells the Children of Israel in the manifest purport of the address He tells this community in its inward mystery. He gave us the Book, showing right guidance, and after its revelation sent reverent scholars and pure friends of God, judging by its judgement and guiding by its guidance. When they command renunciation of the world and abandonment of shares and desires, people reject and deny them, sometimes declaring them unbelievers and killing them, too proud to yield and accept their words. Some they deny; others they kill.

The hadith says: "You will follow the ways of those before you, span by span and cubit by cubit, so that if they entered a lizard's hole, you would enter it." They asked, "Who, Messenger of God—the Jews and Christians?" He replied, "Yes; who else?" That is: whom would you follow but them?[B058]

Callers to God do not cease while the religion remains. Some call to His judgements, others to His knowledge: the first are scholars, the second His friends. When they command departure from habits and desires, people shoot at them the arrows of reproach and opposition. No one has brought the like of what they bring without being opposed—except that one singled out by antecedent care and visited by guidance's breeze follows their traces. Few are such people.

The Real Most High mentions their appalling assertion, saying:

2:88 · Covered hearts and the refusal of discipline

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 131–132

وَقالُوا قُلُوبُنا غُلْفٌ بَلْ لَعَنَهُمُ اللَّهُ بِكُفْرِهِمْ فَقَلِيلاً ما يُؤْمِنُونَ (88)

88. They say, “Our hearts are covered.” Rather, God has cursed them for their unbelief; little indeed do they believe.

Language · Covered hearts or repositories of knowledge

I say: *ghulf* (غُلْف) is the plural of *aghlaf* (أغلف), as *ḥumr* is of *aḥmar* and *ṣufr* of *aṣfar*. It means something upon which there is a covering: our hearts are in a sheath and do not understand what you say, like the *aghlaf*, the uncircumcised person. Alternatively, its original form is *ghuluf* (غُلُف), with the lām vowelled *u*, as Ibn Muḥayṣin reads it.

It would then be the plural of *ghilāf*, “container,” like *ḥijāb/ḥujub* and *kitāb/kutub*: our hearts are repositories of every kind of knowledge, so we have no need of your knowledge or your Book.

“Little” (قليلاً) qualifies an omitted expression: they believe with little faith, or a small number believe. Alternatively, it is adverbial, since it qualifies periods of time, governed by the following verb; *mā* emphasizes the paucity: on few occasions do they believe. Or it is a circumstantial expression relating to the plural subject of “believe”: they believe while few in number.

Outward commentary · The original disposition and its frustration

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the Jews said, mocking what you invite them to, “Our hearts are enclosed and covered, so we do not understand what you say”; or, “They contain the sciences and have no need of yours.” God Most High says: rather, there is no material covering over their hearts; they are constituted upon the original disposition (الفطرة). But God has cursed, expelled and forsaken them because of their unbelief, thus frus-

trating their receptivity to knowledge. They believe with little faith, as when they believe in part of the Book; or only a few believe, such as ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and his companions. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Breaking habits and the antecedent gift of guidance

When those who summon people to God tell the worldly to slaughter their lower selves, lower their heads and part with their money, that they may become fit to enter the presence of the All-Holy—or tell them to break their habitual patterns, so that ordinary patterns may be broken for them—they take offence, become harsh, and say, "Our hearts are enclosed against what you invite us to."[B059] They are told: rather, distance and deprivation have preceded you from God, so you deny the means of witnessing and direct vision. [38]

Yet one for whom divine care has preceded, and upon whom the breeze of guidance blows, is not ultimately barred by his wrongdoing: he may join the elect even if he has been among the greatest thieves. Such a case is rare in comparison with those who struggle against themselves in seeking the way. "God has power over everything" [18:45].

He rebukes and curses them for failing to believe in the Qurʾān, although they acknowledged it before its coming, saying:

38. Cairo editor, C132.1: The first "breaking of habitual patterns" is the breaking of veils—heedlessness, darkness of heart, and the like—through which miraculous gifts may be bestowed. The second "breaking of habitual patterns" is the breaking of what the lower self has grown accustomed and attached to, so that it finds departure from it difficult: much eating and drinking, love of prestige, leadership, and praise. *[Translator: The printed note reverses the order of the two expressions in the author's sentence. There, the first means breaking the lower self's habitual attachments; the second means the extraordinary breaking of ordinary patterns granted as a consequence.]*

2:89 · Recognizing what one subsequently rejects

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 132–133

وَلَمَّا جاءَهُمْ كِتابٌ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ مُصَدِّقٌ لِما مَعَهُمْ وَكانُوا مِنْ قَبْلُ يَسْتَفْتِحُونَ عَلَى الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا فَلَمَّا جاءَهُمْ ما عَرَفُوا كَفَرُوا بِهِ فَلَعْنَةُ اللَّهِ عَلَى الْكافِرِينَ (89)

89. When a Book came to them from God, confirming what they possessed —although before this they had sought victory over the unbelievers—when what they recognized came to them, they disbelieved in it. God's curse is upon the unbelievers.

Language · Lammā and seeking victory

I say: when followed by a past verb, *lammā* (لمّا) is a particle indicating the occurrence of one thing upon the occurrence of another. It has a conditional clause and a response. Here the response is omitted, indicated by that of the second *lammā*: when a Book came to them from God, they disbelieved in it. Alternatively, the second *lammā* confirms the first, and "they disbelieved in it" is the response; or the second *lammā* with its response answers the first, as in "When guidance comes to you from Me, then whoever follows…" [2:38]. "They sought an opening" (يستفتحون) means they sought victory. In the hadith: "The Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, used to seek victory through the impoverished Emigrants"—those without possessions.

Outward commentary · Prior expectation and subsequent unbelief

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when the Qurʾān came to the Jews, confirming the Torah they possessed—that is, agreeing with it and bearing witness to its truth—they had previously sought victory over their enemies through the Prophet who brought it. They would say, "O God, give us victory over them through the Prophet sent at the end of time, whose description we find in the Torah." To their polytheist enemies they used to say, "The time of a prophet is now near: he will emerge confirming what we

have said, and with him we shall slay you as ʿĀd and Iram were slain." But when he appeared and they recognized him, they disbelieved in him. God's curse is therefore upon them.

An explicit noun replaces the expected pronoun to indicate that they were cursed for unbelief. The article in "the unbelievers" is either referential, indicating the unbelieving Jews in question, or generic: the curse then encompasses every unbeliever, and they are included first and foremost.[B060] And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Recognizing the friends of God in one's own time

You see many people acknowledge and affirm the friends of God of earlier times when they are mentioned, yet deny and reject the friends of God of their own time—even though in a general way they seek victory through contemporaries. This is a tendency resembling the Jews' conduct: believing in some and disbelieving in others.

People fall into three classes concerning the affirmation and denial of special election (الخصوصية). One class affirms it for the earlier generations and denies it to the later; these are the worst of the common people. Another acknowledges it in both earlier and later times, but says that its possessors are hidden in their own time: God deprives them of their blessing. A third acknowledges special election in people of its own time, recognizes, finds and reveres them. These are the fortunate whom God wishes to bring to Himself and draw near to His presence.

In the *Ḥikam*: "Glory to Him who has made the indication of His friends arise only from the indication of Himself, and who brings to them only those whom He wishes to bring to Himself." Through God is success.

The Real Most High points to the foolishness of the Jews' judgement in exchanging faith for unbelief and profit for loss, saying:

2:90–91 · Envy of divine favour and the relation of Law to Reality

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 133–135

بِئْسَمَا اشْتَرَوْا بِهِ أَنْفُسَهُمْ أَنْ يَكْفُرُوا بِما أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ بَغْياً أَنْ يُنَزِّلَ اللَّهُ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ عَلى مَنْ يَشاءُ مِنْ عِبادِهِ فَباؤُ بِغَضَبٍ عَلى غَضَبٍ وَلِلْكافِرِينَ عَذابٌ مُهِينٌ (90) وَإِذا قِيلَ لَهُمْ آمِنُوا بِما أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ قالُوا نُؤْمِنُ بِما أُنْزِلَ عَلَيْنا وَيَكْفُرُونَ بِما وَراءَهُ وَهُوَ الْحَقُّ مُصَدِّقاً لِما مَعَهُمْ قُلْ فَلِمَ تَقْتُلُونَ أَنْبِياءَ اللَّهِ مِنْ قَبْلُ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ (91)

90. Wretched is that for which they have sold their souls: disbelieving in what God has sent down, out of envy that God should bestow His bounty upon whomsoever He wills among His servants. They have incurred wrath upon wrath; for the unbelievers is a humiliating punishment. 91. When they are told, “Believe in what God has sent down,” they say, “We believe in what was sent down to us,” while disbelieving in what came after it, although it is the truth, confirming what they possess. Say, “Why then did you kill God’s prophets before, if you were believers?”

Language · The comprehensive force of praise and blame

I say: *biʾsa* and *niʿma* (بئس، نعم) are invariable verbs restricted to expressions indicating generality. This may be an indefinite noun, accusative as a specification (تمييز) explaining the pronominal agent, or a noun with the generic article, nominative as the agent (فاعل). Thus: *biʾsa rajulan Zaydun*, “What a bad man Zayd is”; or *biʾsa al-rajulu Zaydun*. The particular person praised or blamed follows, either as the predicate of an implied subject or as a subject with its predicate preceding. These verbs are restricted to general expressions because *niʿma* exhausts every aspect of praise, and *biʾsa* every aspect of blame. “What an excellent man Zayd is” is as though you said: Zayd deserves the praise belonging to his whole kind. The corresponding explanation applies to *biʾsa*.

The *mā* attached to *biʾsa* or *niʿma* is an indefinite expression, accusative as specification: "What a wretched thing it is for which they sold their souls"—their unbelief. Or it is a complete definite expression, nominative as the agent: "Wretched is the thing—the thing for which they sold their souls." Here *ishtaraw* means "sold," as *sharaw* does, contrary to its usual meaning. It may, however, retain its usual meaning, "bought," as will appear in the exposition.

"Out of envy" (بغياً) is an accusative of purpose explaining their unbelief. "They disbelieve" is circumstantial, relating to the subject of "they said." *Warāʾ* (وراء) was originally a verbal noun made into an adverb. When annexed to the agent, it denotes that by which he is hidden, lying behind him; when annexed to the object, it denotes what hides it, lying before it. Hence it is counted among expressions bearing opposite meanings. So al-Bayḍāwī explains.

Outward commentary · Faith professed but contradicted in practice

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says concerning the Jews: wretched is the thing for which they sold their souls' portion—unbelief in what God sent down. Alternatively, wretched is that by which, as they imagined, they purchased their souls' deliverance: they supposed that their action saved them from punishment. Their action was to disbelieve in what God revealed to His Prophet Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace, through transgression and envy that the Prophet should come from a people other than themselves.

They returned with wrath upon wrath: for unbelief and envy towards the best of creation; or for disbelieving in Muḥammad after Jesus, peace be upon them; or for neglecting the Torah and disbelieving in Muḥammad. The unbelievers have a humiliating punishment, abasing and disgracing them in this world and the next, unlike the punishment of a disobedient believer, which expiates his sins.

When these Jews are told to believe what God revealed to Muḥammad, they say that they believe the Torah revealed to them, while disbelieving what lies beyond it—the Qurʾān—which confirms and stands as guardian over the Torah they possess. Say to them, Muḥammad: why did you kill God's prophets before this time, when the Torah forbids it, if you believe in that

Book? This invalidates your claim: believing a Book entails acting upon it; otherwise it is merely a claim. Although your forefathers committed the deed, you approve it and resolve upon the same course.

Spiritual allusion · The rule of allusive interpretation

Know that the rule of those who interpret by allusion is this: every reproach addressed to those who abandon the way of faith and deny its people is addressed correspondingly to those who abandon the way of the station of spiritual excellence (الإحسان) and deny its people. Every threat directed at unbelievers is correspondingly directed at those who abandon the journey to the station of spiritual excellence. But the unbelievers' punishment is sensible and bodily, whereas the punishment of the veiled is inward and belongs to the heart.[B061]

Thus we say of those content with their faults, persisting in the sickness of their hearts, denying the physicians and the existence of masters of formation: wretched is that for which they have sold their souls—denial of the special election God bestows upon His friends' hearts, through envy and transgression, or ignorance and bad opinion, that God should bestow His bounty

upon whomsoever He wills. They incur the wrath of veiling upon that of distance and uncertainty, or the wrath of sick hearts upon that of persistence in faults and defects. As al-Shādhilī, God be pleased with him, said: "Whoever does not penetrate this science of ours dies persisting in grave sins without knowing it." One cannot properly penetrate it without accompanying its people. Those who deny special election suffer the punishment of covetousness and the prison of created things: these are the tree of abasement and humiliation.

When told to believe in the secrets of Reality (الحقيقة) and lights of the Path (الطريقة) that God has bestowed, they say, "We believe in the outward ordinances of the Sacred Law revealed to us," while denying what lies beyond them: the secrets of Reality, such as the unveiling of the Essence's mysteries and the lights of the Attributes. Yet the science of Reality is the truth, because it is the pure kernel of the Sacred Law. How fine are the words of the author of *al-Mabāḥith al-aṣliyya*:

Are the outward Law and inward science
anything but a body in which a spirit dwells?

He also says:

The intelligible and the transmitted are like
a pearl in an unknown, overflowing sea.
Even when the diver brings it forth,
the pearl is not yet free.
It is freed only by uncovering it,
removing the covering, so it lies concealed no more.
The shell is the outward, the pearl its intelligible meaning;
ignorance is that sea.

Shaykh ʿIzz al-Dīn ibn ʿAbd al-Salām used to say, “Is there anything besides what we have understood from the Book and the Sunna?” He said this when told that Shaykh al-Shādhilī had that day poured forth sciences and mysteries. But when he met the shaykh and took his hand, he said: “Yes, by God! None but the Sufis are established upon the indestructible foundations of the Sacred Law.”

To someone claiming adherence to the Sacred Law while denying what lies beyond it, one says: why occupy yourself with amassing and hoarding the world, fear poverty, worry about provision and panic at calamities, when the Sacred Law proclaims its condemnation of all this—if you are a believer? Through God is success.

He reproaches them for worshipping the calf after seeing the clear signs, invalidating their claim to believe the Torah, saying:

2:92 · Clear signs and the idol of desire

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 135–136

وَلَقَدْ جاءَكُمْ مُوسى بِالْبَيِّناتِ ثُمَّ اتَّخَذْتُمُ الْعِجْلَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ وَأَنْتُمْ ظالِمُونَ (92)

92. Moses certainly came to you with clear signs; then, in his absence, you took the calf for worship, doing wrong.

Language · The circumstantial clause

I say: “while you were wrongdoers” (وأنتم ظالمون) is a circumstantial clause relating to “you took.”

Outward commentary · Signs that did not bear fruit

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Moses came to you with manifest miracles, such as the staff, the hand and the parting of the sea. Yet they did not produce their effect in you: after he went to the Mount you took the calf as a god to worship, doing wrong. Where, then, is your claim to believe the Torah?

Spiritual allusion · The available physician and the refusal of healing

One also says to a person who persists in his fault and accepts the sickness of his heart until he meets God with a sick heart: My friends came to you with clear signs. Even if they did no more than heal the sick—I mean those whose hearts are sick—that would suffice. Yet you made desire your god and worshipped the immediate world with your hearts. Your selves and your money were too dear to you, and you wronged yourselves by persisting in your defects when the physician was present for whoever sought healing, thought well and witnessed purity. “Be a seeker and you will find a guide.” Through God is success.

The Real Most High recounts earlier faults of their forefathers that invalidate their claim to faith, saying:

2:93 · The heart imbued with love of the calf

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 136–137

وَإِذْ أَخَذْنا مِيثاقَكُمْ وَرَفَعْنا فَوْقَكُمُ الطُّورَ خُذُوا ما آتَيْناكُمْ بِقُوَّةٍ
وَاسْمَعُوا قالُوا سَمِعْنا وَعَصَيْنا وَأُشْرِبُوا فِي قُلُوبِهِمُ الْعِجْلَ بِكُفْرِهِمْ قُلْ
بِئْسَما يَأْمُرُكُمْ بِهِ إِيمانُكُمْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ (93)

93. When We took your covenant and raised the Mount above you: “Hold firmly to what We have given you, and listen.” They said, “We hear and disobey.” Through their unbelief their hearts were imbued with the calf. Say, “Wretched is what your faith commands you, if you are believers.”

Language · The omitted conditional response

I say: “if you are” is a conditional clause whose response is omitted: if you are believers, wretched is what your faith commands you.

Outward commentary · Love fixed in the heart like dye in cloth

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember also when We bound you to act according to the Torah, but you refused. We raised the Mount above you and said: hold firmly and earnestly to what We have given you, and hear what I tell you in it. They said through the tongue of their state, by failing to comply, “We have heard Your speech and disobeyed Your command”; or they said it aloud, through bad comportment.

Their hearts drank in love of the calf until it coloured them and became fixed as dye becomes fixed in cloth. For they were corporealists (مجسّمة) and had never seen a sight more wonderful than the calf fashioned by al-Sāmirī. Say to them, Muḥammad: wretched is what your alleged faith in the Torah commands you, if you are believers. Faith, however, does not command this, so you are not believers.

Spiritual allusion · The covenant to struggle against habitual patterns

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says to someone claiming perfect faith while denying the people of spiritual excellence, persisting in his soul's habits and veiled by witnessing sensible things: We took your covenant to struggle against your lower selves and break your habits, so that you might enter your Lord's presence.

We raised above your heads the swords of warning or the mountains of longing, made the level way clear, and told you to take earnestly what We gave you of breaking habits and acquiring benefits. But you refused: your selves were too dear to you. Through the tongue of your state you said, "We hear and disobey." Your hearts drank in love of the immediate world, and you preferred this world to the next. Wretched is what your faith commands you, if you are believers.

Among the Jews' claims was that Paradise belonged exclusively to them. God refuted them, saying:

2:94–95 · Longing for the meeting with God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 137–138

قُلْ إِنْ كانَتْ لَكُمُ الدَّارُ الْآخِرَةُ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ خالِصَةً مِنْ دُونِ النَّاسِ فَتَمَنَّوُا الْمَوْتَ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صادِقِينَ (94) وَلَنْ يَتَمَنَّوْهُ أَبَداً بِما قَدَّمَتْ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ بِالظَّالِمِينَ (95)

94. Say, "If the abode of the Hereafter with God belongs exclusively to you, apart from other people, then wish for death, if you are truthful." 95. But they will never wish for it, because of what their hands have sent ahead. God knows the wrongdoers.

Language · Exclusivity and the predicate

I say: "exclusively" (خالصة) is the predicate of *kāna*. On the sounder view, "with" (عند) is attached to *kāna*.

Outward commentary · An exclusive claim put to the test

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: tell the Children of Israel who claim that Paradise is theirs alone: if the abode of the Hereafter with God—that is, in His unseen knowledge—belongs exclusively to you, apart from everyone else or apart from the Muslims, wish for death, if your claim is true. For when a servant is certain that he is going to Paradise, he longs for the death that brings him there. As ʿAmmār, God be pleased with him, said when dying:

> Now I meet the beloved ones:
> Muḥammad and his company.

Ḥudhayfa, God be pleased with him, said at the approach of death: "A beloved friend has come at a time of need. May whoever regrets it not prosper"—meaning regret for wishing for it, or regret over the world.[B062]

God Most High says: they will never wish for it, because their hands have sent ahead unbelief and disobedience. None of them ever wished for it. Ibn ʿAbbās said: "Had the Jews wished for death, they would have died and seen their places in the Fire." In the *Iḥyā'*: "He, peace and blessings be upon him, invited the Jews to wish for death and told them they would not wish for it: they were prevented from uttering it." Another writer mentions that one of them did wish for it, and before nightfall a choking inflammation took him in the throat and he died. [39]

"God knows the wrongdoers" threatens them and indicates their wrongdoing in claiming what is not theirs and denying it to those to whom it belongs.

Spiritual allusion · Four attitudes towards remaining in this world

This verse contains a sound balance in which deeds and states are weighed and pretenders distinguished from true champions. Every deed that death demolishes is adulterated; every state that death defeats is defective. Whoever flees death lies in claiming love. A person claiming special election above others is tested by this verse.

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39. Cairo editor, C137.1: I have found nothing establishing this. Had it happened, it would have been transmitted and become widely known, since the motives for transmitting so momentous an event would have been abundant. On the contrary, the reports that they did not wish for death attain the level of mass transmission, as Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī says.

People fall into four classes in their love of remaining in this world. One loves to remain in order to seize its pleasures and satisfy his desires. He casts aside his Hereafter, bends over his world and takes his desire as his god; this deafens and blinds him. Mention death and he flees; admonish him and he takes offence and resists. His lifespan diminishes while his avidity grows; his body wears out while his expectations renew themselves. His death is near, his aspirations remote. Unless eternal care and an antecedent gift preserve his faith and seal his life with Islam, he is lost. [Translator's note: Cairo I:138 prints إن لم تكن له عناية أزلية ... فيمسك عليه الإيمان ... وإلا فقد هلك: "if there is no eternal care," followed by preservation of faith and "otherwise he has perished." The corresponding passage in ʿAbd al-Ḥaqq al-Ishbīlī's *al-ʿĀqiba* (ed. Khiḍr Muḥammad Khiḍr, 1406/1986, p. 29) has the same difficult negative conditional, with dual pronouns for its preceding two classes. A public manuscript facsimile of that earlier work (Wikisource file *al-ʿĀqiba fī aḥwāl al-ākhira kh.*, PDF image 7, visible folio numeral 4) omits this entire conditional and the following supplication. It supplies no variant particle and does not settle the difficulty. The English expresses the contextual warning; the exact syntax and authorial wording remain unresolved.]

Another has had the mote removed from his eye: he perceives his soul and its desires, restrains and forbids it, girds himself to make good what has passed, considers what is coming, and prepares for death and departure to the dwelling of the dead. Yet he dislikes witnessing death's events or seeing its advance guard. He dislikes it neither for its own sake nor because it destroys his pleasures, but fears being cut off from preparation for the Day of Return. He dislikes having his record of deeds rolled up before attaining his hope, or his term arriving before he has put his defects right. He wishes to remain here to fulfil these purposes. How excellent his life, how good his death! He is not included in the saying, "Whoever dislikes meeting God, God dislikes meeting him."

A third knows God through His most beautiful Names and highest Attributes. He has witnessed something of the perfection of Lordship and the beauty of the presence of Divinity; it fills his eyes and heart and carries away his reason and understanding. He yearns for that vision and hastens towards fulfilment of that promise. He knows that worldly life is a veil between him and his Beloved, a hanging curtain between him and what he

seeks. Such a person is among the passionate lovers, longing for union and encounter. He loves meeting God, and God loves meeting him. How beautiful his life and his meeting!

A fourth has witnessed what the third witnessed, perhaps more. But he entrusts the matter to his Creator and surrenders it to his Maker. He approves only what is approved for him, desires only what is desired for him, and chooses only what is decreed concerning him. If God keeps him here, He keeps him; if He takes him, that is his desire and hope. He is among the gnostics brought near. May God make us among them through His favour and generosity. Amen.

The Real Most High then mentions what refutes their claim that the Garden belongs exclusively to them: their eagerness to remain in this abode. He says:

2:96 · Lengthy expectations and present obedience

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 138–139

وَلَتَجِدَنَّهُمْ أَحْرَصَ النَّاسِ عَلى حَياةٍ وَمِنَ الَّذِينَ أَشْرَكُوا يَوَدُّ أَحَدُهُمْ لَوْ يُعَمَّرُ أَلْفَ سَنَةٍ وَما هُوَ بِمُزَحْزِحِهِ مِنَ الْعَذابِ أَنْ يُعَمَّرَ وَاللَّهُ بَصِيرٌ بِما يَعْمَلُونَ (96)

96. You will certainly find them the most eager of people for life—even more than those who associate partners with God. Each wishes to live a thousand years; yet such longevity would not remove him from punishment. God sees what they do.

Language · The omitted comparison and the infinitival construction

I say: "and of those who associate partners" involves an omitted comparative: "and more eager than those who associate partners"; one therefore pauses after this phrase. *Law* in "that he might live long" is infinitival (مصدرية): each desires a lifespan of a thousand years. "That he should live long" is the agent of "removing": his longevity would not remove him from punishment.

Outward commentary · A life prolonged does not secure deliverance

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Muḥammad, you will find the Jews most eager to remain in this lowly abode. How then do they claim greatest entitlement to Paradise? You will find them more eager to remain than the polytheists, although the latter do not acknowledge requital. This indicates that they are destined for the Fire; hence their aversion to the meeting and eagerness to remain. Each wishes to live a thousand years, but this would not remove or distance him from punishment; rather, it would increase his requital. "God sees what they do" is a warning and a threat. [40]

40. Cairo editor, C139.1: Although a temporal reprieve may occur, their commission of sins during the extended lifespan increases the severity of the punishment they face.

Spiritual allusion · The garment worn here and hereafter

The inward import of the address teaches that whoever shortens his expectations, improves his deeds, makes his soul ready to meet the Beloved, and fills this brief moment with what brings him near the Near One, draws near to God in proportion to his love of meeting Him. Whoever extends his expectations and eagerly clings to this perishable abode is distant from God in proportion to his love of remaining—except one who desires further life to increase his deeds or rise through spiritual stations and states; there is no harm in this. The address also implies that extreme eagerness for perishable life contains a tendency resembling that of the Jews described here.

Know that people are of two kinds concerning lengthy and brief expectations. One lengthens his hopes, increases his idleness and admits weakness into his works. Another shortens his hopes, makes mindfulness his merchandise and worship his craft, and lets his expectation reach no further than the present hour. Divine enabling (التوفيق) raises its banner over such a person, clothes him in its robe and bestows its beauty and splendour. Consider, God have mercy on you, which man you wish to be, which deeds you wish to perform, and which robe you wish to wear. There you will wear only what you wear here. Through God is success.

Among the most odious forms of the Children of Israel's unbelief and their worst faults was hatred of Gabriel, peace be upon him. The Real points to it, saying:

2:97–98 · Gabriel, revelation and love of God's creatures

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 139–141

قُلْ مَنْ كانَ عَدُوًّا لِجِبْرِيلَ فَإِنَّهُ نَزَّلَهُ عَلى قَلْبِكَ بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ مُصَدِّقاً لِما بَيْنَ يَدَيْهِ وَهُدىً وَبُشْرى لِلْمُؤْمِنِينَ (97) مَنْ كانَ عَدُوًّا لِلَّهِ وَمَلائِكَتِهِ وَرُسُلِهِ وَجِبْرِيلَ وَمِيكالَ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ عَدُوٌّ لِلْكافِرِينَ (98)

97. Say, “Whoever is an enemy to Gabriel—it is he who has brought it down upon your heart by God’s permission, confirming what came before it, as guidance and good tidings for the believers.” 98. Whoever is an enemy to God, His angels and His messengers, and to Gabriel and Michael—God is an enemy to the unbelievers.

Language · The conditional response and the angels’ names

I say: “whoever” (من) is conditional, with an omitted response: let him die in his rage. Or “it is he who brought it down” is the response, meaning: whoever among them opposes Gabriel has cast off the bond of fairness, or disbelieved in the Book he possesses, for Gabriel brought a Book confirming the earlier Books.

Gabriel’s name has eight forms, four occurring in the readings: جَبْرَئِيل, patterned like *salsabīl*; جَبْرَئِل, like *jaḥmarish*; جَبْرِيل with an *a* on the jīm and no hamza; and جِبْرِيل with an *i*. Four are anomalous: جِبْرَال, جَبْرَائِيل، جَبْرِائل، جَبْرِين, the last with nūn. Its meaning is “servant of God.” Michael has four forms: ميكائيل with lengthening, ميكائل shortened, ميكئل with hamza and shortening, and ميكال on the pattern of *mīʿād*.[B063]

Outward commentary · Dividing between the messengers

The Real, glorious is His majesty, replies to Jews such as Ibn Ṣūriyā and others who asked the Prophet, “Who brings you revelation?” He answered, “Gabriel.” They said, “That is our enemy among the angels, for he brings severity and punishment. Were it Michael, we would follow you, because he brings fertility and peace.” God Most High says: whoever is Gabriel’s enemy, let him die in his rage, for Gabriel brought the Qurʾān down upon your heart by God’s permission, confirming the preceding Books and bringing guidance and good tidings to believers. If he descends with severity and punishment upon unbelievers, he descends with guidance and good tidings upon believers.

An enemy of Gabriel is an enemy of God, for Gabriel is His messenger to the prophets and His chosen one among the angels. Such a person is also an enemy of Michael, Gabriel’s companion in ministry, and of the messengers, whose envoy Gabriel is. Whoever is an enemy to God, His angels and His messengers, Gabriel and Michael, has God as his enemy.

The addition of Gabriel and Michael after "angels" is the conjunction of the particular to the general (عطف الخاص على العام), enhancing their honour. In "an enemy to the unbelievers," the explicit expression replaces "to them," registering their unbelief and showing that God opposes them because of it, and that enmity towards angels and messengers is unbelief. May God preserve us from the paths of ruin. Amen.

Spiritual allusion · Love of all servants, hatred of the wrongful act

If hostility to angels and messengers is hostility to God, hostility to His friends is likewise hostility to God. Thus He says: "Whoever opposes a friend of Mine has declared war against Me." The part here is the whole. Conversely, love of angels and messengers is love of God, as is love of His friends. Love of God's servants is also love of God, and hostility to them hostility to Him: "Creation are God's dependants, and the most beloved creatures to God are those most beneficial to His dependants."[B065]

Whoever claims to love God while harbouring enmity towards a Muslim is lying; whoever claims to know God while harbouring rejection of a creature is likewise lying in his claim. The servant must love all servants. In the case of the obedient this is evident; for the disobedient he loves repentance and return; for the unbelieving he loves Islam and guidance. Nothing should be hated in the servant but his act. How fine are these words:

> My son, have mercy on every creature;
> regard them with forbearance and compassion.
> Honour their elders, be merciful to their young;
> in every creature observe the right of its Creator. [41]

Through God is success.

When Ibn Ṣūriyā told the Prophet, "Muḥammad, you have brought nothing we recognize, and God has sent down no clear sign to you that we should follow you for it," these words were revealed:

41. Cairo editor, C141.1: The shaykh who wrote this commentary attributes the two lines in Īqāẓ al-himam to al-Ḥasan al-Ḥarrānī.

2:99 · Manifest signs and inward recognition

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 141–141

وَلَقَدْ أَنْزَلْنا إِلَيْكَ آياتٍ بَيِّناتٍ وَما يَكْفُرُ بِها إِلاَّ الْفاسِقُونَ (99)

99. We have indeed sent down to you clear signs; none disbelieves in them but the transgressors.

Outward commentary · The scope of the clear signs

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: We have sent down to you, Muḥammad, manifest signs containing knowledge of the unseen, prophetic accounts, firmly established ordinances, holy lights and mysteries of the realm of Divine Omnipotence (الجبروت). None rejects them and disbelieves in them but those rebellious in unbelief and tyranny, outside obedience and faith. When "transgression" (فسق) is employed of a particular kind of disobedience, it indicates its greatest and worst form: here, unbelief. In God is refuge.

Spiritual allusion · Recognition bestowed before an external proof

Know that when divine care has preceded for a servant, God casts affirmation and guidance into his heart without need of a sign or miracle. The Real unveils to him the mystery and lights of special election. His secret bears witness to its possessor's rectitude; his spirit bows in reverence. Faith's lights appear and the suns of gnosis shine upon him without dependence on a proof or demonstration. The opposite holds for one for whom deprivation has preceded: neither proof nor demonstration benefits him. We seek refuge in God from abandonment.

When the Prophet reminded the Jews of the covenant God had taken concerning him, Mālik ibn al-Ṣayf said, "By God, no undertaking or covenant concerning Muḥammad has been made with us." Then there was revealed:

2:100 · Fidelity to covenants and the limits of a guide's authority

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 141–143

أَوَكُلَّما عاهَدُوا عَهْداً نَبَذَهُ فَرِيقٌ مِنْهُمْ بَلْ أَكْثَرُهُمْ لا يُؤْمِنُونَ (100)

100. Is it that whenever they make a covenant, a group of them casts it aside? Rather, most of them do not believe.

Language · The interrogative and repeated condition

I say: the hamza expresses disapproval. The wāw connects with an omitted clause: have they disbelieved in the signs, and whenever they make a covenant…? "Whenever" (كلما) is accusative as an adverbial expression. It includes conditional meaning and requires a response, which governs it. *Nabdh* (نبذ) is casting away, most often used of what is forgotten, according to al-Bayḍāwī.

Outward commentary · A group, not every member

The Real, glorious is His majesty, reproaches the Jews: whenever they give an undertaking and bind themselves by it, does a group cast it away? They undertook that, if they lived to see Muḥammad, they would believe in and support him; when they did see him, they cast aside and forgot the undertaking. They also promised the Prophet not to assist the polytheists against him, but Banū Qurayẓa and al-Naḍīr cast it aside. Not all broke it, but a group—the majority. Hence He says, "Rather, most of them do not believe." The majority are those who break undertakings and overstep limits. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The covenant of companionship

Breaking a covenant with God or His servants is a sign of hypocrisy and a trait of estrangement and division. Keeping it is a sign of faith and a trait of love and gnosis. Describing the successful, God says, "Those who guard their trusts and their covenant" [23:8]. This applies especially to undertakings made with shaykhs of firm establishment and deep rootedness.

Whoever enters the bond of companionship with a shaykh qualified for spiritual formation should beware of undoing it. That cuts off assistance and brings expulsion and distance. Turning to someone else lets the worm into the seed of aspiration and cuts off increase and benefit. Gathering oneself upon the shaykh, without looking or turning elsewhere, is a means to being so with God. In proportion to one's exclusive orientation to the shaykh comes one's exclusive orientation to God; in proportion to abandoning choice and surrendering self-will with the shaykh comes the same with God; in proportion to fidelity to the masters of formation comes fidelity to the rights of Lordship. One whose absorption in the shaykh is stronger, whose sheltering with him is greater, and whose collectedness upon him is more constant, is likewise with his Lord. The same applies to reverence and courtesy, and God deals with the servant accordingly.

Shaykh Zarrūq, God be pleased with him, says: "Do not move away from him, even if you see one higher than him, lest you be deprived of the blessing of both the first and the second." Hence the shaykhs used to prohibit their companions from accompanying others, even from visiting them. They recited:

> Take what you see, and leave what you have only heard about;
> the full moon's appearance dispenses with Saturn.

Visiting a shaykh other than one's own nevertheless calls for distinction. Someone whose sincerity is complete and judgement abundant, so that a visit leads him to belittle neither his own shaykh nor the one visited, may visit whom he wishes. Someone whose sincerity and judgement are incomplete, so that a visit leads him to belittle either one, should refrain from visiting another shaykh.

Spiritual allusion · Recognition does not imply infallibility

Muḥyī al-Dīn Ibn al-ʿArabī says: a disciple must believe his shaykh to know God and sincerely counsel God's creatures; he should not believe his shaykh infallible (العصمة). Al-Junayd was asked, "Can a gnostic commit fornication?" He answered, "God's command is a decree determined" [33:38]. [B064] [42]

42. Cairo editor, C143.1: The point of the story is to make clear that the disciple should not believe the shaykh to be infallible: even when the shaykh enjoys the most perfect of states, he is not infallible.

A disciple accompanied a shaykh and one day saw him commit fornication with a woman. He did not change his service, neglect any of his shaykh's prescribed practices, or diminish his respect. The shaykh knew that he had seen him and said one day:

"My son, I know that you saw me transgress with that woman. I expected you to leave me for that reason." The disciple replied: "Master, a human being is exposed to the courses of God's decrees. From the time I entered your service, I did not serve you on the assumption that you were infallible, but because you knew God's way and how to travel it, which is what I seek. Whether you disobey or not is between you and God Most High; none of it falls upon me. What happened on your part is not something that requires me to recoil and leave you. This is my conviction." The shaykh said: "You have been enabled and made fortunate: it is thus, or not at all." The disciple prospered, and from him appeared what delighted the eye: a beautiful state and a lofty station. Thus ends the quotation.

[Translator's print-source notes: [T6]]

Having characterized them by breach of covenants, the Real mentions a particular instance, saying:

2:101 · Casting the Book behind one's back

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 143–143

وَلَمَّا جاءَهُمْ رَسُولٌ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ مُصَدِّقٌ لِما مَعَهُمْ نَبَذَ فَرِيقٌ مِنَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ كِتابَ اللَّهِ وَراءَ ظُهُورِهِمْ كَأَنَّهُمْ لا يَعْلَمُونَ (101)

101. When a messenger came to them from God, confirming what they possessed, a group of those given the Book cast God's Book behind their backs, as though they did not know.

Outward commentary · Four responses to the Torah

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when a messenger from God—Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace—came to the Jews, confirming the Torah they possessed by agreeing with some of its accounts, a

group of those given the Book, the unbelieving Jewish learned men, cast God's Book, the Torah, behind their backs. They did not act upon its command to believe in the Prophet; they altered and concealed his description in it. It was as though they threw it behind their backs and knew nothing of this.

Al-Bayḍāwī says: know that through these two verses the Real indicates four classes among the Jews. One believes the Torah and fulfils its rights, like the believers among the People of the Book. These are the minority indicated by "Rather, most of them do not believe." Another openly casts aside its covenants and oversteps its limits through rebellion and transgression: these are meant by "a group of them casts it aside." A third does not openly reject it, but abandons it through ignorance of it: these are the majority. A fourth adheres to it outwardly but secretly abandons it, knowingly, through transgression and obstinacy. These feign ignorance. Thus ends his statement. I say: perhaps the last are their hypocrites.

When they cast aside God's Book, they occupied themselves instead with books of sorcery, as the Real makes clear in His words:

2:102–103 · Sorcery, trial and the enchantment of the world

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 144–147

وَاتَّبَعُوا ما تَتْلُوا الشَّياطِينُ عَلى مُلْكِ سُلَيْمانَ وَما كَفَرَ سُلَيْمانُ وَلكِنَّ الشَّياطِينَ كَفَرُوا يُعَلِّمُونَ النَّاسَ السِّحْرَ وَما أُنْزِلَ عَلَى الْمَلَكَيْنِ بِبابِلَ هارُوتَ وَمارُوتَ وَما يُعَلِّمانِ مِنْ أَحَدٍ حَتَّى يَقُولا إِنَّما نَحْنُ فِتْنَةٌ فَلا تَكْفُرْ فَيَتَعَلَّمُونَ مِنْهُما مَا يُفَرِّقُونَ بِهِ بَيْنَ الْمَرْءِ وَزَوْجِهِ وَما هُمْ بِضارِّينَ بِهِ مِنْ أَحَدٍ إِلاَّ بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ وَيَتَعَلَّمُونَ ما يَضُرُّهُمْ وَلا يَنْفَعُهُمْ

وَلَقَدْ عَلِمُوا لَمَنِ اشْتَراهُ ما لَهُ فِي الْآخِرَةِ مِنْ خَلاقٍ وَلَبِئْسَ مَا شَرَوْا بِهِ أَنْفُسَهُمْ لَوْ كانُوا يَعْلَمُونَ (102) وَلَوْ أَنَّهُمْ آمَنُوا وَاتَّقَوْا لَمَثُوبَةٌ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ خَيْرٌ لَوْ كانُوا يَعْلَمُونَ (103)

102. They followed what the devils recited concerning Solomon's kingdom. Solomon did not disbelieve, but the devils disbelieved, teaching people sorcery and what was sent down to the two angels in Babylon, Hārūt and Mārūt. They taught no one without saying, "We are only a trial, so do not disbelieve." Yet people learned from them what separates a man from his wife. They could harm no one through it except by God's permission. They learned what harmed them and did not benefit them, although they knew that whoever purchased it would have no share in the Hereafter. Wretched is that for which they sold their souls, had they but known. 103. Had they believed and been mindful, a reward from God would have been better, had they but known.

Language · Trial and the promise of lasting reward

I say: "over Solomon's kingdom" involves an omitted expression: "during the time of Solomon's reign"; or *ʿalā* means *fī*, "in." "What was sent down" is conjoined to "sorcery" as an explanatory conjunction (عطف تفسير). *Fitna* (فتنة) originally means testing. You say that you test gold or silver when you put it into the fire to distinguish its good quality from its bad. "A reward" answers *law*, "had": originally, "they would have been rewarded." The expression shifts to a nominal sentence to indicate permanence.

Outward commentary · Solomon's vindication and the two angels

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says concerning the Jews: when a Book came to them from God, they cast it aside and followed the sorcery that devils recited to people during Solomon's reign. The devils used to eavesdrop, combine what they heard with lies, and pass it to the soothsayers, who recorded it and taught it to people. This spread in Solomon's time until it was said that the jinn knew the unseen, and that Solomon's kingship de-

pended upon this, through which he subjected jinn, human beings and wind. Solomon collected the written material and buried it; the devils dug it up after his death.

God refutes their claim: Solomon did not disbelieve by practising sorcery—for sorcery magnifies another besides God through drawing near to Satan, and the prophet is protected from sin (معصوم). Rather, the devils disbelieved through practising it, teaching people sorcery to seduce and mislead them, and teaching what was sent down to the two angels in Babylon, in the cultivated region of Kūfa: Hārūt and Mārūt.[B066]

They were two of the most devoted angels. When the angels saw the foul deeds of Adam's children ascending to heaven in the time of Idrīs, peace be upon him, they reproached them: "Our Lord, do these whom You made vicegerents upon earth disobey You?" God said: "Were I to send you to earth and constitute you as I constituted them, you would commit what they commit." They replied: "Glory to You! It would not be fitting for us to disobey You." God told them to choose two of their best whom He would send down. They chose Hārūt and Mārūt, among the most devoted

angels. God implanted desire in them, commanded them to judge truly among people on earth, and forbade association, unjust killing, fornication and drinking wine. They judged between people by day; in the evening they pronounced God's greatest Name and ascended to heaven.

One day a woman called al-Zuhara, among the most beautiful women of Persia, brought a dispute before them. She captured their hearts, and they solicited her, but she refused. She returned the second day; they repeated their approach, and she refused unless they would worship what she worshipped, pray to the idol, kill a person and drink wine. They refused, saying that God had forbidden these things. She left and returned on the third day. When they solicited her, she repeated the conditions. They said: praying to another besides God is a great sin, and the lightest of the three is drinking wine. They drank, became intoxicated and lay with the woman. Afterwards someone saw them; fearing exposure, they killed him.

A report from our master ʿAlī, God ennoble his face, says: "She told them, 'You will not have me until you tell me how you ascend to heaven.' They said, 'Through God's greatest Name,' and taught it to her. She uttered it, ascended to heaven, and God transformed her into a star." Thus, when he,

peace and blessings be upon him, saw Suhayl, he used to say: "God curse Suhayl: he was a tax-collector in Yemen. God curse al-Zuhara: she tempted two angels."

I say: al-Mundhirī mentions the story of Hārūt and Mārūt in his discussion of drinking wine. Concerning its hadith he says: Aḥmad and Ibn Ḥibbān in his *Ṣaḥīḥ* transmit it through Zuhayr ibn Muḥammad; it has been said that the correct version stops at Kaʿb. Thus ends his statement. Ibn Ḥajar says: the story of Hārūt and Mārūt comes through a fair chain (سند حسن), contrary to those who consider it invalid, such as ʿIyāḍ and his followers.

The story continues: after committing the sin, they wished to ascend at evening, but their wings did not obey them. They recognized what had befallen them, went to Idrīs, told him, and asked him to intercede with God. He did so, and God offered them the choice of punishment in this world or the next. They chose this world's punishment because it comes to an end. They are punished in a well in Babylon, suspended upside down by chains from their feet, their eyes blue, only four fingers' breadth from the water, yet tormented by thirst. Thus ends the account. [43]

Should you ask, "Angels are protected from sin: how can this be true of Hārūt and Mārūt?" we reply: when God implanted desire in them, they passed from the condition of angels to that of humanity, as a trial from Him. They no longer possessed the angels' condition of protection.

Theology · Knowledge that harms and effects permitted by God

They teach sorcery to no one without counselling him: "We are only a trial for you, a test from God for His servants, so that those who refrain and those who do not may become manifest." Learning it was unbelief at that time; therefore they say, "Do not disbelieve through learning it." People learned from them what separates a man and his wife. Yet they could harm

43. Cairo editor, C145.1: Scholars of prophetic reports identified defects in these narrations, and Ibn al-Jawzī judged them fabricated in al-Mawḍūʿāt. Qāḍī ʿIyāḍ said: nothing sound or authentic at all has been transmitted concerning this. Most commentators rejected the story. The traditionist Ibn Kathīr said: the apparent course of the Qur'anic account gives the story in outline, without expansion or lengthy detail. We therefore believe what occurs in the Qur'an according to what God Most High intended. On this subject, consult Qāḍī ʿIyāḍ's al-Shifāʾ, Shaykh Aḥmad Shākir's annotations to the Musnad of Imam Aḥmad and to al-Ṭabarī's commentary, and Abū Shahba's book al-Isrāʾīliyyāt wa-l-mawḍūʿāt—may God have mercy on him.

no one except by God's permission and power: nothing produces an effect except by His permission. They learned what would harm them on the Day of Resurrection and not benefit them.

The Children of Israel knew that whoever purchased it, exchanging God's Book and obedience to it for sorcery, would have no portion in the Hereafter. Wretched was that for which they sold their souls' share of bliss, had they known. But because they did not act on their knowledge, they were like people who had none. Had they believed in God and His Messenger and guarded against unbelief and sorcery, they would have received a great reward, better than the punishment they incurred, had they known.

Spiritual allusion · The world's enchantment

Whoever bends over his worldly life, follows his desires and private portions, and abandons what comes from God, may truly be said to have cast aside God's Book and occupied himself with something else: love of the world, leadership and prestige. The world is an enchanting deceiver, bewitching hearts and drawing them away from the presence of the Knower of unseen things. In the hadith: "Beware the world: it is more bewitching than Hārūt and Mārūt."[B067] It certainly divides lovers, kindred and companions.

Whoever takes the world and its delights and bends over it knows that he has no share in the Hereafter: his heavenly bliss diminishes in proportion to the worldly delights and desires he takes. Wretched is that for which they sold their souls, preferring worldly life to the next, had they known. Had they believed in God and guarded against everything that distracts from Him, they would have become His friends. That reward to which they would have come is better, had they known.

ʿAbd al-Wāḥid ibn Zayd said: I heard of a girl called mad, living in the ruins of al-Ubulla, who uttered wisdom. I sought her and found her, head shaven, wearing a woollen gown. Seeing me, she said, "Welcome, ʿAbd al-Wāḥid. What brings you?" I said, "That you may admonish me." She answered: "How strange—a preacher being preached to! Know, ʿAbd al-Wāḥid, that when a servant has enough and inclines to something worldly, God takes away the sweetness of renunciation and he remains bewildered and distraught. If he has a portion with God, He reproaches him through an inspiration in his secret: 'My servant, I wished to raise your rank among My an-

gels and make you a guide to My friends and a director of those who obey Me. But you inclined to worldly goods and left Me. This bequeathed estrangement after intimacy, humiliation after honour, and poverty after wealth. Return to what you were, and I shall restore what you knew in yourself.'" She then turned away and left me, and sorrow at her departure remained in my heart.

The Muslims used to say to the Messenger, "Rāʿinā, Messenger of God; lend us your ear," intending consideration and waiting. Among the Jews it served as an insult derived from foolishness (الرعونة). They rejoiced and said, "We used to insult Muḥammad secretly," then openly uttered the insult, saying "Muḥammad, rāʿinā," and laughing. God forbade the Muslims this expression, saying:

> **Translator's source note · Cairo I:145:** Ruslān's footnote records serious criticisms of the Hārūt and Mārūt narrative.

2:104 · Courtesy in address

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 147–147

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا تَقُولُوا راعِنا وَقُولُوا انْظُرْنا وَاسْمَعُوا وَلِلْكافِرِينَ عَذابٌ أَلِيمٌ (104)

104. Believers, do not say "Rāʿinā," but say "Unẓurnā," and listen. For the unbelievers is a painful punishment.

Language · Choosing an unambiguous form of address

I say: to *rāʿā* something is to wait for it or attend to it. *Raʿā ilā*, *rāʿā* and *arʿā* also mean to incline one's ear and listen.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: believers, do not tell the Messenger, "Rāʿinā"—wait for us or give us time—for it supplies a means for the Jews' insult, or constitutes a lack of courtesy. Say instead, "Unẓurnā": wait for us. The unbelievers who hurt God's Messenger have a painful, distressing punishment.

Spiritual allusion · Courtesy as the condition of formation

Good address belongs to complete courtesy (الأدب), and complete courtesy is the means of reaching what is truly right. Without courtesy there is no formation; without formation, no journey; without a journey, no arrival. Whoever has not been formed at the hands of realized people cannot form others. It is said: whoever behaves badly with the beloved is expelled to the door; whoever behaves badly at the door is expelled to tending the beasts. It is also said: make your works salt and your courtesy flour.[B068]

Another said: through good character and courtesy a person reaches great degrees despite few works. Whoever is deprived of courtesy is deprived of all good; whoever is given it is entrusted with the keys of hearts. Abū ʿUthmān, God be pleased with him, says: courtesy with the great and in the gatherings of the masters among God's friends brings its possessor to lofty degrees and goodness in this world and the next.

Abū Ḥafṣ al-Ḥaddād says: Sufism is entirely courtesy. Every time, state and station has its courtesy. Whoever adheres to courtesy attains the rank of realized people; whoever lacks it is distant precisely where he supposes himself near, rejected precisely where he hopes to arrive. Dhū al-Nūn al-Miṣrī says: when a disciple abandons the practice of courtesy, he returns from where he came.

It is said: whoever fails to observe the courtesy of his time finds his time hateful. Whom lineage confines, courtesy releases. Whoever has little courtesy causes much disturbance. Courtesy is the support of the poor and the adornment of the rich. Through God is success.

Envy and rancour are also among the Jews' faults. The Real points to them, saying:

2:105 · Divine mercy is not subject to envy

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 147–148

ما يَوَدُّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ وَلا الْمُشْرِكِينَ أَنْ يُنَزَّلَ عَلَيْكُمْ مِنْ خَيْرٍ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ وَاللَّهُ يَخْتَصُّ بِرَحْمَتِهِ مَنْ يَشاءُ وَاللَّهُ ذُو الْفَضْلِ الْعَظِيمِ (105)

105. Neither the unbelievers among the People of the Book nor the polytheists wish any good to be sent down upon you from your Lord. But God singles out whomsoever He wills for His mercy; God is Possessor of tremendous bounty.

Language · Three uses of min

I say: *wudd* (وَدّ) is love of a thing together with wishing for it. “Among the People of the Book” is explanatory, like the corresponding expression in 98:1. “That there should be sent down” is governed by “wish.” The *min* in “any good” is supplementary; in “from your Lord” it indicates origin.

Theology · Bounty freely bestowed

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the unbelieving People of the Book and the polytheists do not wish good to descend upon you from your Lord, through envy. Rather, they wish you to remain in error and humiliation. God singles out whom He wills of His servants for His mercy, such as prophethood and friendship with Him. Nothing is obligatory upon Him, and no possible thing is impossible for Him. He possesses tremendous bounty, granting prophethood or friendship to whom He wills through favour and beneficence.

Spiritual allusion · Prepare for the envy that accompanies a gift

The verse contains two admonitions. First, whoever envies and denies the people of special election has a tendency resembling that of the Jews and a trait of the polytheists. Second, envy and denial of special election are widespread and follow an established pattern. Let the disciple prepare himself

for this and know that nothing is said to him but what was said to his predecessors: “You will find no alteration in God’s customary way” [33:62]. No blessing lacks someone who envies it.

Ḥātim al-Ṭāʾī said:

> Through envy my people wrong me;
> what age has passed in which they did not envy me?

Through God is success.

Another of their faults was denying the abrogation of rulings. God refuted them, saying:

2:106–107 · Abrogation and the continuing presence of God’s friends

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 148–150

مَا نَنْسَخْ مِنْ آيَةٍ أَوْ نُنْسِها نَأْتِ بِخَيْرٍ مِنْها أَوْ مِثْلِها أَلَمْ تَعْلَمْ أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (106) أَلَمْ تَعْلَمْ أَنَّ اللَّهَ لَهُ مُلْكُ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَما لَكُمْ مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ مِنْ وَلِيٍّ وَلا نَصِيرٍ (107)

106. Whatever verse We abrogate or cause to be forgotten, We bring one better than it or like it. Do you not know that God has power over everything? 107. Do you not know that the kingdom of the heavens and earth belongs to God, and that apart from God you have neither protector nor helper?

Language · Removal, forgetting and postponement

I say: *naskh* (نسخ) has two lexical meanings. One is alteration or transfer: one says, “God transformed him into an ape,” using either *masakha* or *nasakha*. Al-Farrāʾ says that copying a book belongs to this meaning. The second is removing and cancelling something: “The sun removed the shadow”—made it disappear. This is the meaning here.

Insāʾ (إنساء) is leaving or making something depart; *nasāʾ* (نساء) is postponement. *Mā* is conditional, accusative as the object of its conditional verb, and "We bring" is its response.

Outward commentary · The end of a ruling's period of application

The Real, glorious is His majesty, replies to the Jews' remark, "Look at Muḥammad: he commands his companions something and then forbids it." God answers: whatever verse We abrogate—removing its wording, its ruling or both—We bring one better in

lightness or reward. "Or cause it to be forgotten" means removed from the Prophet's heart by God's permission; alternatively, We leave it unabrogated, or postpone its revelation or abrogation, according to the different readings. We bring something better or similar. Do you not know, Muḥammad, that God has power over everything? Neither abrogation nor anything else incapacitates Him. His is the kingdom of heaven and earth; He disposes of both as He wills. None rejects His decree or reverses what He decides and establishes. He abrogates or confirms the rulings of His revealed ordinances as He wills, according to His servants' interests and what tenderness and love require.

Abrogation is possible both rationally and according to revelation. As their Law abrogated what preceded it, what followed abrogated it. Whoever dictates to God or objects to His chosen messengers has no protector against His punishment and no helper against His anger.

Abrogation concerns commands and prohibitions, not reports, since the latter would imply falsehood. It means the end of acting upon a ruling and the transfer of servants from one ruling to another for a benefit. It does not entail the emergence of previously unknown knowledge (البداء), as the Jews claim. For us abrogation is of three kinds: removal of both wording and meaning, as in the former recitation, "Do not turn away from your fathers, for that is unbelief"; removal of wording but not meaning, as in "The elderly man and elderly woman, when they commit adultery, stone them outright," whose wording was abrogated but whose ruling—stoning—remained; and removal of meaning but not wording, as in the sword verse following the command to maintain a truce with unbelievers.[B069] And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Successors among the friends of God

Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī interprets it: “We remove no substitute saint (بدل) without bringing one better or like him.” That is, no friend of God is taken away without another better or similar being brought, until the Day of Resurrection. This refutes anyone who claims that masters of formation have ceased. God’s power is universal, His kingdom endures, and the earth does not lack someone who upholds the proof until God’s command arrives.

In *Laṭāʾif al-minan*: a gnostic was asked whether the saints through whom assistance comes ever diminish. He replied: were one of them to be missing, heaven would not send its rain and earth would not bring forth its plants. The corruption of an age does not come from a reduction in their number or assistance. Rather, when an age is corrupt, God wills that they be hidden although they remain. He then cites ʿAlī’s words to Kumayl: “O God, the earth is not without someone who stands for You with Your proof. They are fewest in number, greatest in worth with God; their hearts are attached to the highest abode. They are God’s vicegerents in His lands and among His servants. How I long to see them!”

Al-Tirmidhī al-Ḥakīm transmits from Ibn ʿUmar, as a saying of the Messenger: “My community is like rain: one does not know whether its beginning or its end is better.”[B070] Through God is success.

When Rāfiʿ ibn Ḥuraymila, the Jew, asked God’s Messenger to show him a sign, such as causing water to burst forth, these words were revealed:

2:108 · A miracle is not the condition of sainthood

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 150–151

أَمْ تُرِيدُونَ أَنْ تَسْئَلُوا رَسُولَكُمْ كَما سُئِلَ مُوسى مِنْ قَبْلُ وَمَنْ يَتَبَدَّلِ الْكُفْرَ بِالْإِيمانِ فَقَدْ ضَلَّ سَواءَ السَّبِيلِ (108)

108. Or do you wish to question your messenger as Moses was questioned before? Whoever exchanges faith for unbelief has strayed from the level way.

Language · A transition in the address

I say: *am* (أم) indicates transition (الإضراب), in the sense of *bal*, "rather." This is of two kinds: departure from the preceding meaning, or only from its wording, as here; consult Ibn ʿAṭiyya's commentary. Calling him "your messenger" corresponds to the reality of the matter and explicitly establishes that he was sent to them as to others. Going astray is losing the way; *sawāʾ al-sabīl* is the middle of the road.

Outward commentary · Demanding signs through obstinacy

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Jewish people, do you wish to prescribe signs to your Prophet, whom I sent to you and to all other creatures, asking him to show miracles, as you formerly asked Moses, "Show us God openly" [4:153], through contentiousness and obstinacy? You refused faith and exchanged it for unbelief and disobedience. Whoever makes that exchange is lost from the way of truth and rectitude. His abode is Hell: an evil resting place.

Spiritual allusion · Two comprehensive graces

The appearance of an extraordinary grace (كرامة) is not a condition of being God's friend; complete uprightness (الاستقامة) is. Nor is it a condition that people be guided through him: that was not guaranteed even to the prophet, so how could it be to the friend? God says, "Will you compel people until they become believers?" [10:99]. A tendency has entered the common people like that which entered the unbelievers who said, "We will not believe you until you make a spring burst from the earth for us" [17:90].

Many will not acknowledge a friend of God until they see a sign or wonder. Yet the more firmly his foot is rooted in gnosis, the fewer the wonders appearing at his hands. A wonder is assistance, confirmation and an increase in certainty; a firmly established mountain needs no support.

The truth is what Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī said: "There are two comprehensive, all-encompassing graces: the grace of faith with increasing certainty in witnessing and direct vision, and the grace of action according to the Sunna and following the Prophet, avoiding pretension and deception. Whoever receives these and longs for something else is a fabricating liar, or

mistaken in knowledge and understanding—like someone honoured by seeing the king in approval and dignity, who then longs to tend the beasts and receive robes of favour." Or words to that effect.

Our shaykh said: "The true extraordinary grace is Prophetic character and divinely bestowed knowledge." Whoever denies the friends of God of his own time and demands proof from them other than what has been described has strayed from the level way and remains bound in the prison of demonstration and proof. Through God is success; He guides to the level way.

When the Jews' envy and efforts to oppose Islam became manifest, the Real commanded the Muslims to pardon and overlook until He permitted fighting them, saying:

2:109–110 · Pardon, worship and freedom from preoccupation with opponents

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 151–152

وَدَّ كَثِيرٌ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ لَوْ يَرُدُّونَكُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ إِيمانِكُمْ كُفَّاراً حَسَداً مِنْ عِنْدِ أَنْفُسِهِمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما تَبَيَّنَ لَهُمُ الْحَقُّ فَاعْفُوا وَاصْفَحُوا حَتَّى يَأْتِيَ اللَّهُ بِأَمْرِهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (109) وَأَقِيمُوا الصَّلاةَ وَآتُوا الزَّكاةَ وَما تُقَدِّمُوا لِأَنْفُسِكُمْ مِنْ خَيْرٍ تَجِدُوهُ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ بَصِيرٌ (110)

109. Many of the People of the Book wish to turn you back into unbelievers after your faith, out of envy arising from themselves, after the truth has become clear to them. Pardon and overlook until God brings His command. God has power over everything. 110. Establish prayer and give the purifying alms. Whatever good you send ahead for yourselves, you will find it with God. God sees what you do.

Language · Pardoning and overlooking

I say: *law* is infinitival, forming the object of "wish." "Unbelievers" is the second object of "turn back." "Out of envy" is an accusative of purpose explaining "wish," or circumstantial with respect to its plural subject. "From themselves" attaches either to "wish"—they wish it from themselves and their own inclination—or to "envy," in which case one pauses after "unbelievers": an envy arising from within, supported by neither a semblance of proof nor a demonstration. Pardoning (العفو) is refraining from punishing an offence; overlooking (الصفح) is turning away from the offender, as though showing him the side of one's neck. It is therefore more emphatic than pardoning.

Outward commentary · Fulfil the duties entrusted to you

The Real, glorious is His majesty, warns against the Jews and other unbelievers: the unbelieving People of the Book and others wish to turn you from your religion and make you unbelievers again after faith in your Prophet, astray as before entering it. This arises from their own envy that prophethood should be among others, after the truth has become clear and they know it as they know their sons. Refrain from reproaching them and turn away from their contentiousness until God brings His command concerning them, through killing and expulsion.[B071] God has power over everything.

Occupy yourselves with what He has entrusted to you: rendering the rights of servanthood and performing the duties owed to Lordship, such as perfecting prayer and paying the alms. Know that God loses none of your works. Whatever you send ahead for your day of need, you will find with Him, better and greater in reward. None of your deeds or states is hidden from Him.

The verse was revealed concerning ʿAmmār ibn Yāsir and Ḥudhayfa ibn al-Yamān, who visited the house of study (بيت المدراس). Its people spoke gently to them and hoped to divert them from their religion. God exposed them and turned their plot back upon them. And God Most High knows best. [44]

44. Cairo editor, C151.1: Al-midrās—with rāʾ before the alif—is the building in which they study. Al-Nihāya says that mifʿāl is an unusual pattern for a place noun.

Spiritual allusion · Partisanship towards one's teachers

Among the things that have crept into groups rigidly attached to imitating their shaykhs are partisanship and zeal for their shaykhs' way, even when truth appears with others—especially among descendants of the righteous. When they see someone upon whom the lights of friendship with God

and the secrets of special election have appeared, they wish to turn him from the way of truth back to mingling with people, through envy from within, after truth has become clear. Those turning towards the Real are told: pardon and overlook until truth appears. Do not attend to their contentiousness or occupy yourselves with their faults, lest you become worse than they.

A gnostic said: "Never occupy yourself with someone who harms you; occupy yourself with God and He will turn that person from you. Many have erred here: they occupied themselves with those who harmed them, and the harm lasted, accompanied by sin. Had they returned to their Master, He would have sufficed them." Someone envied or harmed should instead become absent from the envier and his plot and attend to the rights of servanthood and witnessing the grandeur of Lordship. God does not abandon one who takes refuge with Him, nor frustrate the aim of one who relies upon Him. Through God is success.

Another of the Jews' empty wishes is their claim to exclusive possession of Paradise, as the Real makes clear:

2:111–112 · Empty claims and genuine surrender

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 152–153

وَقالُوا لَنْ يَدْخُلَ الْجَنَّةَ إِلاَّ مَنْ كانَ هُوداً أَوْ نَصارى تِلْكَ أَمانِيُّهُمْ قُلْ هاتُوا بُرْهانَكُمْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صادِقِينَ (111) بَلى مَنْ أَسْلَمَ وَجْهَهُ لِلَّهِ وَهُوَ مُحْسِنٌ فَلَهُ أَجْرُهُ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِ وَلا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (112)

111. They say, “None will enter the Garden unless they are Jews or Christians.” Those are their wishes. Say, “Bring your proof, if you are truthful.” 112. Rather, whoever surrenders his face to God and acts with excellence shall have his reward with his Lord. No fear shall be upon them, nor shall they grieve.

Language · Two claims compressed into one sentence

I say: “they said” is conjoined to “those who disbelieved wished.” [Translator’s note: Cairo I:152 prints وَدَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا here; the preceding verse, 2:109, reads “many of the People of the Book wished.” The printed phrase is retained.] The pronoun refers to Jews and Christians: the Jews said that only Jews would enter Paradise, and the Christians that only Christians would enter it. *Hūd* (هود) is the plural of *hāʾid*, as *buzl* is of *bāzil* and *ḥūl* of *ḥāʾil*. *Amānī* (أماني) is the plural of *umniyya*, what someone wishes for and desires. Its original form is *umnūya*, like *uḍḥūka* and *uʾjūba*: wāw became yāʾ and was assimilated. *Hātū* (هاتوا) is an imperative verbal expression (اسم فعل): “bring!” Its past and imperfect forms are unused. To *aslama* is to submit and humble oneself. Fear concerns what is anticipated; grief concerns what has occurred.

Outward commentary · Surrender of the whole person

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the Jews claimed that none but a Jew, someone of their religion, would enter Paradise; the Christians made the corresponding claim for a Christian. These are false claims and empty wishes without evidence, merely their lying aspirations. Tell them, Muḥammad: bring your proof of exclusive entitlement to Paradise, if this wish is truthful. Rather, others enter it—people of surrender and excellence (الإسلام والإحسان). Whoever surrenders his face to God, yielding to Him in his entirety, and excels in conduct and belief, has his reward with his Lord: entry into bliss and vision of His noble Face. They fear no anticipated harm and grieve for no needed thing missed. As guests of the Generous One, joys are brought to them and harms repelled. Through God is success.

Spiritual allusion · Special election is not a school's monopoly

Among the errors that have entered some spiritual aspirants is restricting special election to themselves and those following their shaykh, denying it to others. This is a tendency resembling the Jews' claim and an attempt to dictate to divine power. They are told: those are your empty wishes; others attain it. Whoever sincerely seeks God finds Him, and He fulfils His promise faithfully. Whoever humbles himself to God and submits to His friends has his reward with his Lord—knowledge of Him. He need not fear severance or grieve over missing his portion of gnosis. Through God is success; He guides to the level way.

When the Christians of Najrān came to the Prophet, the Jews heard of them and came. They debated until they exchanged insults: the Jews denied Jesus, his religion and the Gospel; the Christians denied Moses and the Torah. God revealed concerning them:

2:113 · Mutual denigration and the presumption of one's own sufficiency

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 153–154

وَقالَتِ الْيَهُودُ لَيْسَتِ النَّصارى عَلى شَيْءٍ وَقالَتِ النَّصارى لَيْسَتِ الْيَهُودُ عَلى شَيْءٍ وَهُمْ يَتْلُونَ الْكِتابَ كَذلِكَ قالَ الَّذِينَ لا يَعْلَمُونَ مِثْلَ قَوْلِهِمْ فَاللَّهُ يَحْكُمُ بَيْنَهُمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ فِيما كانُوا فِيهِ يَخْتَلِفُونَ (113)

113. The Jews say, "The Christians have no foundation," and the Christians say, "The Jews have no foundation," although they recite the Book. Those who do not know speak in the same way. God will judge between them on the Day of Resurrection concerning their differences.

Outward commentary · A dispute that contradicts the books they read

The Real, glorious is His majesty, reports the Jews' and Christians' statements and condemns their conduct. The Jews reply to the Christians, "They stand upon nothing worth considering"; the Christians insult the Jews, "They stand upon nothing reliable." Yet they recite Scripture: the Jews read the Torah, which foretells Jesus, and the Christians the Gospel, which confirms the Torah's Law and Moses' prophethood. Each party thus disbelieves in its own Book through anger and partisanship. Those without knowledge —the polytheists—make the same assertion: the Muslims stand upon nothing. God will judge their disputes on the Day of Resurrection, admitting the people of truth to Paradise and the people of falsehood to the Fire. Through God is success.

Spiritual allusion · Do not make yourself the measure of everyone

Everything the Real recounts of others' faults is intended to deter and warn us against committing the same, and to have us cultivate the opposite. Whoever belittles and diminishes others is himself the smallest. Whoever says, "The companions of master so-and-so stand upon nothing; those of master so-and-so possess nothing," himself stands upon nothing. Some Sufis have

been afflicted by this blameworthy trait: setting up a scale over people, bringing some down and raising others, while reading God's Book and hearing His words, "Do not spy, and do not backbite one another" [49:12].

You find this especially among jurists rigidly fixed upon the outward Sacred Law, imagining no knowledge above theirs and no understanding beyond theirs. How can this be, when God says, "You have been given but little knowledge" [17:85], and "Above every possessor of knowledge is one more knowing" [12:76]? The Imām al-Ḥaramayn said: "To admit a thousand unbelievers into Islam on a doubtful ground is better than to expel one person from it on a doubtful ground."[B072]

Whoever desires safety must think well of all Muslims and believe them all righteous. In the hadith: "Two traits have no goodness above them: thinking well of God and thinking well of God's servants. Two traits have no evil above them: thinking ill of God and thinking ill of His servants." Through God is success.

The Real next reproaches the Christians for preventing people from the sanctuary in Jerusalem, harming those praying there and casting filth into it, while claiming that they alone follow truth: this is Ibn ʿAbbās's explanation. Or He reproaches the unbelieving Quraysh for preventing Muslims from praying in the sanctuary and barring the Messenger's access: this is Ibn Zayd's view. The sound conclusion is that He reproaches them all, saying:

2:114 · The sanctuaries of worship and the sanctuaries within

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 154–155

وَمَنْ أَظْلَمُ مِمَّنْ مَنَعَ مَساجِدَ اللَّهِ أَنْ يُذْكَرَ فِيهَا اسْمُهُ وَسَعى فِي
خَرابِها أُولئِكَ ما كانَ لَهُمْ أَنْ يَدْخُلُوها إِلاَّ خائِفِينَ لَهُمْ فِي الدُّنْيا خِزْيٌ
وَلَهُمْ فِي الْآخِرَةِ عَذابٌ عَظِيمٌ (114)

114. Who is more unjust than one who prevents God's name from being remembered in His places of worship and strives to ruin them? Such people ought not to enter them except in fear. They have disgrace in this world and a tremendous punishment in the Hereafter.

Language · The construction of prevention

I say: "who" is the subject and "more unjust" its predicate. "That His name should be remembered" is either accusative after the preposition is omitted and the verb governs it directly—"prevents from its being remembered"; or an apposition of inclusion (بدل اشتمال) to "places of worship"; or genitive through the omitted preposition, according to Sībawayh. "In fear" is circumstantial, relating to the plural subject of "enter."

Outward commentary · Preventing remembrance in God's mosques

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: no one commits a greater crime or injustice than one who prevents God's name from being remembered in His mosques, in groups or individually, in prayer or otherwise, and strives to ruin them by obstructing their flourishing. Such people should enter only with reverence and humility: how dare they destroy them? Alternatively, they ought to enter only fearing that the believers might seize them, far less prevent the believers from entering. Or, in God's knowledge and decree, they were to enter only in fear: this is then a promise He fulfilled.

God opened Mecca and Syria to the believers. Thereafter no unbeliever entered the Sacred House except secretly, fearing death, and no Christian entered the sanctuary in Jerusalem except in fear of the Muslims. They thus suffered worldly disgrace: the killing of a belligerent unbeliever and the imposition of the poll-tax on a protected non-Muslim. The polytheists' disgrace was their being killed on the day of the conquest and humiliated by the city's forcible entry. Whoever died in unbelief has a tremendous punishment in the Hereafter.[B073]

Although revealed concerning unbelievers, the verse applies generally to anyone preventing people from remembrance in mosques, however performed: standing or sitting, together or alone. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The presences of hearts, spirits and secrets

God's mosques are the presence of hearts, the presence of spirits and the presence of secrets. The presence of hearts belongs to the people of watchfulness among those of faith; the presences of spirits and secrets belong to those of witnessing and divine converse among the people of spiritual excellence. Whoever bars himself from these three presences, strives to ruin his inward being through private portions and desires, and inclines towards the world's deceptive adornments, is unsurpassed in injustice to himself and loss in his bargain.

Only a fear that shakes him or a longing that unsettles him can benefit such a person. Without either, he persists in error until death's signs appear. Then he longs to enter, afraid; but remorse no longer helps, and his foot has slipped. In this world he has poverty and panic; in the next, the anguish of veiling, an evil reckoning and the sorrow of reproach. We ask God for well-being in both abodes, through His favour and generosity. Amen.

Al-Qushayrī says: the worshipper's self is the homeland of worship; the gnostic's heart, the homeland of knowledge; the ecstatic's spirit, the homeland of love; and the unifier's secret, the homeland of witnessing. None is more unjust than one who ruins the worshipper's homeland through desires, that of knowledge through wishes and attachments, that of love through private portions and settling into repose, and that of the unifier through attending to acts of drawing near themselves. Through God is success.

Having mentioned the obstruction of some mosques and prevention of prayer there, the Real gives His servants breadth to pray where they may, saying:

2:115 · Wherever you turn, there is God's Face

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 155–157

وَلِلَّهِ الْمَشْرِقُ وَالْمَغْرِبُ فَأَيْنَما تُوَلُّوا فَثَمَّ وَجْهُ اللَّهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ واسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ

(115)

115. To God belong the east and the west. Wherever you turn, there is God's Face. God is All-Encompassing, All-Knowing.

Language · Turning and direction

I say: "wherever" (أينما) is conditional, "you turn" its condition, and "there is…" its response. The verb *wallā* can mean either to turn away or to turn towards: one says *wallaytu ʿan kadhā* or *wallaytu kadhā*. Here *wajh*, "face," means direction: "I travelled in the direction of such-and-such." So Ibn ʿAṭiyya explains.

[Translator's print-source notes: T7]

Outward commentary · God's possession of every direction

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: east and west belong to God, as do all directions. His dominion is not restricted to one place rather than another. If prevented from praying in mosques, wherever you are and turn towards the prayer-direction you have been commanded to face, there is His appointed direction. Or there is His holy Essence: that is, He knows and observes what is done there. God is encompassing in His knowledge of things, or in His mercy, wishing breadth for His servants; He knows their interests and their deeds in every place.

Ibn ʿUmar relates that the verse concerns a traveller's prayer on his mount, whichever way it turns. Another explanation concerns people unable to determine the prayer-direction, who prayed facing different ways and discovered their mistake in the morning. On that interpretation, one who has exercised judgement and subsequently discovers an error need not make the prayer up. Thus al-Bayḍāwī.[B074]

Spiritual allusion · The Face, the lights and the secrets

Know that places, directions and every manifested existent stand through the lights of the Attributes and are effaced by the unicity of the Essence (أحدية الذات). "God was, and nothing was with Him; He is now as He was." Nothing has existence alongside God. "Wherever you turn,

there is God's Face." The traces are effaced by the orbits of lights, the lights effaced by the unicity of secrets, and the One, the All-Subduing, alone possesses existence. How fine are these words:

> Since knowing God, I have seen no other;
> "other" is inadmissible with us.
> Since being gathered, I have feared no parting:
> today I have arrived, gathered into unity.

Another says: [45]

> All beside God, when truly examined,
> is nothing, in detail and in sum.
> What has no existence of itself from itself—
> its existence, were it not for Him, is sheer impossibility.

The author of the *ʿAyniyya* says:

> My Beloved disclosed Himself in the mirrors of His beauty;
> in everything seen, the Beloved's advance signs appear.
> When His beauty appeared in diverse forms,
> He took names, and they are its places of rising.

Al-Shushtarī says:

> My Beloved has encompassed existence
> and appeared in white and black.

One of the predecessors said: "I entered a monastery when prayer-time came and asked a Christian to show me a pure place to pray. He said, 'Purify your heart of other-than-Him, and stand where you will.' I was ashamed before him." It is related that Abū Yazīd used to pray in whatever direction he wished and recite this verse.[B074] For the people of realization, the Face is the Essence itself: the mysteries of the Essence and the lights of the At-

45. Cairo editor, C156.1: He is Shaykh Abū Madyan.

tributes. God says, “Everything is perishing except His Face” [28:88]: everything is passing away and consumed, now and in the future, except His holy Essence. They recited: [46]

> The gnostics passed away from themselves, seeing nothing
> but the Supremely Great, the Exalted.
> They saw all else truly perishing,
> in present, past and future.

In my *Tāʾiyya* on wine, describing the eternal wine, I said:

> In her description she transcends indwelling;
> [there is no other in whose form she dwells].
> A bride, she disclosed herself in mirrors of her beauty,
> and in might let fall the curtains of majesty.
> Nothing appears in the cosmos but her splendour;
> she is hidden only by veils within the heart.[B075]

[Translator’s note: Cairo I:157 reads فليس لها في سوى شكله حلت. Ibn ʿAjība quotes the same couplet again at Cairo II:22, on Q5:17, with the order فليس لها سوى في شكله حلت, “there is no other in whose form she dwells.” There the preceding prose expressly explains that the eternal wine is beyond indwelling and union because there is no second entity in which it could dwell or with which it could unite. This establishes the intended sense and pronoun references: “her/she” is the wine, and “his/its form” belongs to the hypothetical other. The bracketed English follows that internal parallel. I:157’s different word order is preserved in the Arabic companion; the full poem’s independent manuscript text has not been established.]

When the Jews said, “ʿUzayr is God’s son,” the Christians, “The Messiah is God’s son,” and the polytheists, “The angels are God’s daughters,” God Most High refuted them, saying:

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46. Cairo editor, C156.2: Facing the Sacred House is one of the conditions for the validity of prayer, because God Most High says, “Wherever you set out from, turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque.” As for the verse “Wherever you turn, there is God’s Face,” it has already been explained that it was revealed on a particular occasion; it has also been said to be abrogated. Another interpretation is: wherever you are, in east or west, there is the direction of God that we have been commanded to face, namely the noble Kaʿba. What is related about Abū Yazīd—if authentic—belongs to the category of ecstatic utterances, and we do not adopt it as a rule.

2:116–117 · Origination without dependence and creation subsisting through God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 157–158

وَقالُوا اتَّخَذَ اللَّهُ وَلَداً سُبْحانَهُ بَلْ لَهُ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ كُلٌّ لَهُ قانِتُونَ (116) بَدِيعُ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَإِذا قَضى أَمْراً فَإِنَّما يَقُولُ لَهُ كُنْ فَيَكُونُ (117)

116. They say, “God has taken a child.” Glory to Him! Rather, His is all that is in the heavens and earth; all are obedient to Him. 117. Originator of the heavens and earth: when He decrees a thing, He only says to it, “Be,” and it is.

Language · The response to the command “Be”

I say: this sentence is conjoined to “The Jews said…” [2:113]. In the reading without wāw, it begins independently. *Badīʿ* (بديع) means *mubdiʿ*, an originator; origination (الإبداع) is bringing something into being without anything preceding it. Sībawayh understands “Be, and it is” as “and so it is.” Ibn ʿĀmir reads the imperfect verb in the subjunctive (النصب). Some declared his reading grammatically faulty: a subjunctive answering a command must also work as the response to its conditional equivalent. “Strike Zayd, that he may become upright” means “if you strike him, he becomes upright,” whereas “if it is, it is” does not work here. One may reply by considering the meaning: “If I say ‘Be,’ it is.”[B076]

Theology · Why divine sonship is denied

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the Jews, Christians and polytheists claimed that God took a child. Exalted is He beyond their assertion. Sonship implies a common kind, resemblance and need; the Real transcends these. Everything in the seven heavens and seven earths is His possession and servant: how could a servant be his owner’s child? Everything manifest in existence is also obedient—submissive, compliant and worshipping God, constrained by His decree and will. This is incompatible with sonship.

Everything entering the world of formation (التكوين) is originated, invented and made by God; it cannot therefore be His child. A child also requires a consort, a process and a period of time. The Real's command is between kāf and nūn, the two letters of "Be"—indeed, swifter than the blink of an eye. When He decrees, that is wills, a thing, He only says "Be," and it is. This does not depend on uttering the word "Be"; the expression alludes to the swiftness of His power.

Al-Bayḍāwī says: the cause of this error was that adherents of earlier revealed Laws used "Father" of God as the first cause, even saying that a father was the lesser lord and God the greater Lord. The ignorant then supposed that literal generation was intended and adopted that belief through imitation. For that reason one who says it is judged unbelieving, and the expression is prohibited altogether to close the source of corruption. Thus ends his explanation.

Spiritual allusion · Effacement followed by affirmation through God

Know that when you regard all existence with the eye of insight (عين البصيرة), or with the truth of insight (حق البصيرة), you find it one reality (ذاتاً واحدة), standing in one relation to the Real: outward lights and inward secrets; His wisdom outward and His power inward; outward beauty and inward meaning; outward servanthood and the secrets of Lordship's meanings inward. Servanthood stands only through the secrets of Lordship's meanings. [B077] God says, "God holds the heavens and earth lest they pass away" [35:41], and "God is the Light of the heavens and earth" [24:35]. In the *Ḥikam*: "Created things are outwardly a delusion, inwardly a lesson. The lower self looks at their outward splendour; the heart looks at their inward lesson."

The people of separation (الفرق) affirm things as independent alongside God. Some go so far as to associate them with Him in divinity. Exalted is God far beyond that. Muḥyī al-Dīn al-Ḥātimī says: whoever sees creatures as having no action has succeeded; whoever sees them as having no life has crossed over; whoever sees them with the eye of non-existence has arrived. I say: whoever affirms them through God has become firmly established in his arrival. They recited:

Whoever sees creation like a mirage
has risen beyond the veil,
to existence seen as undivided,
without distance or proximity.
There you witness none but Him;
there you are guided to what is right.
No address is directed there to Him,
nor any pointer to that address.

When Rāfiʿ ibn Ḥuraymila, one of the Jewish learned men, told the Messenger, “Let us hear God’s speech if you are His messenger, or show us a sign confirming you,” God replied:

2:118–119 · Signs, certainty and the opening of the heart’s hearing

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 158–160

وَقالَ الَّذِينَ لا يَعْلَمُونَ لَوْلا يُكَلِّمُنَا اللَّهُ أَوْ تَأْتِينا آيَةٌ كَذلِكَ قالَ الَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِهِمْ مِثْلَ قَوْلِهِمْ تَشابَهَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ قَدْ بَيَّنَّا الْآياتِ لِقَوْمٍ يُوقِنُونَ (118) إِنَّا أَرْسَلْناكَ بِالْحَقِّ بَشِيراً وَنَذِيراً وَلا تَسْأَلْ عَنْ أَصْحابِ الْجَحِيمِ (119)

118. Those who do not know say, “Why does God not speak to us, or a sign come to us?” Those before them spoke in the same way; their hearts resemble one another. We have made the signs clear for people who possess certainty. 119. We have sent you with the truth, as a bearer of good tidings and a warner. Do not ask about the companions of the blazing Fire.

Outward commentary · Obstinacy is not a search for certainty

I say: this statement came from some Jews and polytheists through obstinacy and resistance, not a search for certainty. God therefore denies them knowledge altogether. All these verses aim to reproach the Jews.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those without knowledge ask why God does not speak to them, so that they may hear from Him that you are His messenger, or why a manifest sign does not come, visible openly, indicating your messengership as Moses had. The Jews' obstinate statement had precedents: their forefathers said, "Show us God openly" [4:153]; Christians said, "Can your Lord send down a table from heaven for us?" [5:112]; and polytheists said, "We will not believe you until you make a spring burst from the earth for us, or possess a garden of palms and vines and make rivers flow abundantly through it" [17:90–91]. Their hearts are alike in unbelief and resistance, comparable in insolence and corruption.

We have made clear the signs establishing your messengership and election for those seeking increased certainty and disclosure in direct vision. The greatest sign is the Qurʾān; then the ordinances you have clarified and the lawful and forbidden you have explained; then the unseen matters you have reported and the distresses you have lifted from hearts; then the speech of inanimate things and stones, the palm-trunk's yearning, trees' obedience, pebbles' glorification and the stone's greeting. Water also sprang abundantly from between his fingers, besides countless other signs.

We sent you with the truth, clothed in it and making it clear, bringing the abiding bliss as good news to those who affirm and follow you, and warning opponents of the punishment of the Fire. Do not ask about their condition when they reach it: it is too great to recount, too dreadful to hear. Their state cannot be explained, nor can anyone bear to hear its terrors. May God preserve us from ruin and enable us to follow truth and guidance. Alternatively, your Lord will not question you about them: He knows their condition best.[B078] Through God is success.

Spiritual allusion · Hearing from the Real

Demanding wonders and manifest signs belongs to the disposition of the ignorant and obstinate, not to those seeking guidance and direction. The road is clear for one who seeks the way, and truth evident for one who perceives its indication. Whoever anoints his inner eye with the antimony of the special realization of unity (التوحيد الخاص) sees none but the Real and knows none but Him. He sees all things standing through God—indeed, having no existence alongside Him. Whoever has the hearing of his heart opened by God hears only from the Real and only through Him. As someone said, "Through God I speak; from God I hear."

Al-Junayd said: “For forty years I have conversed intimately with the Real, while people suppose I converse with creation.” Creation is effaced for those possessing realized knowledge, but affirmed as separate by the ignorant and divisive. They ask why God does not speak to them or a sign come,

although He speaks to them at every time and hour. Those sharing their ignorance of God say the same, despite the clarity of the signs to those who know Him. God speaks the truth and guides to the way.

When Jews and Christians told the Messenger, “Make a truce between us and yourself, after which we will follow you,” while concealing the intention not to follow him until he followed their religion, God exposed them, saying:

2:120 · Seeking approval from people

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 160–161

وَلَنْ تَرْضى عَنْكَ الْيَهُودُ وَلا النَّصارى حَتَّى تَتَّبِعَ مِلَّتَهُمْ قُلْ إِنَّ هُدَى اللَّهِ هُوَ الْهُدى وَلَئِنِ اتَّبَعْتَ أَهْواءَهُمْ بَعْدَ الَّذِي جاءَكَ مِنَ الْعِلْمِ ما لَكَ مِنَ اللَّهِ مِنْ وَلِيٍّ وَلا نَصِيرٍ (120)

120. The Jews and Christians will not be pleased with you until you follow their religion. Say, “God’s guidance is the guidance.” Were you to follow their desires after the knowledge that has come to you, you would have neither protector nor helper against God.

Language · Religion and desire

I say: *milla* (ملّة) is a revealed Law, what God ordains upon the tongues of His prophets and messengers. It derives from *amlaltu al-kitāba* or *amlaytuhu*: I recited the written text. Desire (الهوى) is an opinion that follows appetite.

Outward commentary · An impossible hypothesis and a particular group

The Real, glorious is His majesty, tells His Messenger: the Jews will never be pleased with you and follow your religion, nor the Christians, until you follow theirs—on the supposition of an impossibility. The aim is to cut off his hope that they will embrace Islam of their own choice: as his following their religion is impossible, so too is their conversion. Perhaps this concerns a particular group. He further deters following them: were you, hypothetically, to follow their false desires after receiving knowledge of God and His judgements upon the straight method, you would have no protector against Us and no helper from any other. You have no protector or helper but Us, because you have befriended and loved Us and manifested Our religion; We are therefore for you as you love and approve.

Spiritual allusion · Approval as a form of dependence

Seeking people's approval is a sign of spiritual bankruptcy. People will not be pleased with you until you follow their desires; were you to follow them after recognizing their condition, you would be among the wrongdoers. Whoever seeks people's approval falls into God's displeasure; whoever seeks God's approval cuts off expectation from people. Hence someone said: whatever falls in creation's estimation rises in the Real's estimation, and whatever rises in creation's estimation falls in the Real's. Another said, "What you dislike in me is what my heart desires."

A righteous man said: "I met one of the substitute saints and asked him to show me the way. He replied, 'Do not mingle with people: mingling with them is darkness.' I said, 'I must mingle with them, since I live among them.' He said, 'Do not transact with them: dealing with them is loss.' I said, 'I must deal with them.' He replied, 'Do not rely upon them: such reliance is ruin.' I said, 'Perhaps that is possible.' He answered, 'Man, you mingle with the idle, deal with the ignorant, rely on the ruined, and wish your heart to be with God? Far from it: that can never be.' Then he disappeared from me, and I never saw him again."

After reproaching and admonishing the Children of Israel, God excepts those among them who believe, saying:

2:121 · Reading the Book as it should be read

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 161–161

الَّذِينَ آتَيْناهُمُ الْكِتابَ يَتْلُونَهُ حَقَّ تِلاوَتِهِ أُولئِكَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِهِ وَمَنْ يَكْفُرْ بِهِ فَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الْخاسِرُونَ (121)

121. Those to whom We have given the Book, who recite it as it should be recited—they believe in it. Whoever disbelieves in it, those are the losers.

Language · A circumstantial clause and the delayed predicate

I say: “they recite it” is a circumstantial clause, and “those…” is the predicate of the relative expression.

Outward commentary · Recitation without concealment

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those to whom We gave the Book, such as ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and his companions, recite it properly, neither distorting it nor concealing its contents. They truly believe it. Those who alter and conceal the Messenger’s description have disbelieved it; whoever disbelieves it is utterly a loser, having deprived himself of honour in both abodes.

Spiritual allusion · The fruits of attentive recitation

What is said of the Torah and its people applies correspondingly to the Qurʾān and its people. Those to whom God gives the Qurʾān, who recite it properly—perfecting its letters, contemplating its meanings and acting upon it—truly believe it and win the fruits of its meanings in sweetness and taste. Whoever abandons contemplation of its meanings deprives himself of the fruits of its sweetness. For the people of certainty, that is loss itself. Through God is success.

The Real returns to reminding them of His blessings, saying:

2:122–123 · Gratitude for favour and fear of the final day

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 161–162

يا بَنِي إِسْرائِيلَ اذْكُرُوا نِعْمَتِيَ الَّتِي أَنْعَمْتُ عَلَيْكُمْ وَأَنِّي فَضَّلْتُكُمْ عَلَى الْعالَمِينَ (122) وَاتَّقُوا يَوْماً لا تَجْزِي نَفْسٌ عَنْ نَفْسٍ شَيْئاً وَلا يُقْبَلُ مِنْها عَدْلٌ وَلا تَنْفَعُها شَفاعَةٌ وَلا هُمْ يُنْصَرُونَ (123)

122. Children of Israel, remember My blessing which I bestowed upon you, and that I favoured you above the worlds. 123. Be mindful of a day when no soul can avail another at all, no ransom will be accepted from it, no intercession will benefit it, and they will not be helped.

Language · Omitting the resumptive pronoun

I say: “no soul can avail…” qualifies “a day.” Its resumptive expression is omitted: “a day in which no soul can avail…”. Al-Murādī says that when a temporal noun is qualified by a sentence, its resumptive may be omitted, citing this verse. Was the whole expression omitted at once or in stages? There are two views.

Outward commentary · The favour of prophets and kings

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Children of Israel, remember My blessing: I appointed prophets to guide you and kings from among you to manage your affairs, and favoured you above the people of your time. Thank Me by believing the messenger I sent to you. Fear the terrors of the Day of Resurrection, when no soul can avail another, no ransom is accepted should it offer one, and no intercessor benefits it. No protector or helper repels that day’s terrors, except for one who has established a claim of favour with the Powerful King. Through God is success. The spiritual allusion of this verse has already appeared at its first occurrence [2:47–48].

When the Real wished to change the prayer-direction from Jerusalem back to God's Sacred House, He mentioned the special distinction of its builder and the manner of its building. Within this He set forth its honour, encouraging compliance, saying:

2:124 · Abraham's testing and the trust of leadership

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 162–163

وَإِذِ ابْتَلى إِبْراهِيمَ رَبُّهُ بِكَلِماتٍ فَأَتَمَّهُنَّ قالَ إِنِّي جاعِلُكَ لِلنَّاسِ إِماماً قالَ وَمِنْ ذُرِّيَّتِي قالَ لا يَنالُ عَهْدِي الظَّالِمِينَ (124)

124. When Abraham's Lord tested him with certain words, and he fulfilled them, He said, "I am making you a leader for people." Abraham said, "And from my descendants?" He said, "My covenant does not reach the wrongdoers."

Language · The test, the agent and the object

I say: to *ibtalā* (ابتلى) is to test. "Abraham" is the object; his name has four forms: Ibrāhām, Ibrāhūm, Ibrāhīm and a shortened form. "His Lord" is the agent. The object precedes for emphasis and to avoid a pronoun referring to something following it both in wording and grammatical rank. "My covenant" is the agent of "reaches," and "the wrongdoers" its object.

Outward commentary · The commands Abraham fulfilled

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember, Muḥammad—or remember, Children of Israel—when Abraham's Lord tested him with words to carry out. These were surrendering his body to the fires, his son to sacrifice, and his food to guests. Alternatively, they were ten practices: five concerning the head—rinsing the mouth, drawing water into the nose, trimming the moustache, using the tooth-stick and parting the hair, or, in another account, letting the beard grow—and five concerning the body: clipping the nails, shaving the pubic hair, plucking the armpits, cleansing with water after relieving oneself, and circumcision.

Or they were the rites of pilgrimage; or the trials of the star, moon, sun, fire, migration and sacrifice. The preferable explanation is three trials: migration from his homeland, leaving his son in Mecca, and sacrificing the other when he reached the age to work alongside him.[B079] He fulfilled them all. God then said: I am making you a leader whom people follow in affirming unity, or in both principles and particular ordinances. Every prophet subsequently sent was of his descendants and commanded to follow him. [47]

When God made him a leader, he asked the same for his children: make leaders from my descendants too. The Real said: My covenant of leadership does not reach the wrongdoers among them. Only the righteous and mindful are suited to leadership, for it is a trust and covenant from God. A wrongdoer is not fit for it. The verse indicates that some descendants would be wrongdoers undeserving of leadership. Al-Bayḍāwī says it also proves the prophets' protection before their mission and the unfitness of a transgressor for leadership.

Spiritual allusion · Formation through majesty before leadership

When God wishes to make one of His friends a leader to follow and a summoner to Himself, He tests him. If he is patient and content, He chooses and draws him to His presence, making him an exemplar and guide. This is God's customary way with His chosen:

He tests them by allowing creatures power over them and through various afflictions. When the remnants of self are purified and their excellences speak, He brings them before creation as callers to God and guides upon His way. Leadership may remain in their descendants if they follow their guidance.

Someone not taken through this course is not fit for leadership; should he assume it, his calling is deficient. Hence the saying: "Whoever claims to witness Beauty before being disciplined by Majesty—reject him, for he is an

47. Cairo editor, C162.1: His words, "leaving his son at Mecca and sacrificing the other," imply that the son intended for sacrifice was different from the one left at Mecca. Since the one left at Mecca was Ishmael—as is well known—the son intended for sacrifice would be Isaac. A small number of scholars adopted this view. The stronger view is that it was Ishmael, peace be upon him. This is the view transmitted from the majority of the Companions and their successors, and adopted by most traditionists and commentators, who adduce many proofs for it. Consult the commentaries of al-Rāzī and Ibn Kathīr, al-Suyūṭī's al-Qawl al-fasīḥ fī taʿyīn al-dhabīḥ [title as printed], and Dr Abū Shahba's al-Isrāʾīliyyāt wa-l-mawḍūʿāt.

impostor.” Whoever wrongs God’s servants in any way does not obtain the covenant of leadership in spiritual direction. Through God is success; He guides to the level way.

He then mentions the honour of the House, the principal subject here, saying:

2:125 · The House as return, security and purified heart

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 163–164

وَإِذْ جَعَلْنَا الْبَيْتَ مَثابَةً لِلنَّاسِ وَأَمْناً وَاتَّخِذُوا مِنْ مَقامِ إِبْراهِيمَ مُصَلًّى وَعَهِدْنا إِلى إِبْراهِيمَ وَإِسْماعِيلَ أَنْ طَهِّرا بَيْتِيَ لِلطَّائِفِينَ وَالْعاكِفِينَ وَالرُّكَّعِ السُّجُودِ (125)

125. When We made the House a place of return for people and a sanctuary: “Take Abraham’s station as a place of prayer.” We covenanted with Abraham and Ishmael: “Purify My House for those who circle it, those who dwell in devotion, and those who bow and prostrate.”

Language · A place to which people return

I say: *mathāba* (مثابة) is a place of return to which people come back every year. On the imperative reading, “take” is reported after an omitted “We said.” On the past-tense reading it is conjoined to “We made”: We made it a place of return, and people took it as a place of prayer.

Outward commentary · Purification of the Sacred House

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember, Muḥammad, when We made the Sacred House—the Kaʿba—a place to which people return yearly for visitation and circumambulation. We made it a place of security: whoever enters is safe from punishment in this world and the next. Here,

people are snatched away around it while its inhabitants are secure; hereafter, pilgrimage erases what preceded it. This indicates the House's honour and sanctity.

We told them to take Abraham's station—the stone bearing his footprints—as a place towards which to pray, behind which they perform the two units after circumambulation. We covenanted with Abraham and his son Ishmael, revealing to them: purify My House of dirt, defilement, idols and images for those who circle it, reside in it and pray there, bowing and prostrating. It was purified in their time and for a period afterwards. Then idols were brought in, until our Prophet Muḥammad purified it. Its purity remains until God's command comes. And God Most High knows best. [48]

Spiritual allusion · The heart as the Lord's House

The heart is the Lord's House. God Most High says to one of His prophets: "Purify a house for Me to dwell in." He asks, "Lord, what house can contain You?" God replies, "Neither My earth nor My heaven contains Me, but the heart of My believing servant contains Me."[B080] When the heart is purified of others,

filled with lights and firmly established in knowledge and mysteries, it becomes a refuge and place of return for servants. Whoever reaches and circles it is safe from deviation and resistance, evil suggestions and wrong belief. Whoever enters it through love and affection is safe from rejection and distance, and is among the best servants with God.

Abraham's station is absorption in the very sea of witnessing and the lifting of aspiration above everything but the worshipped King. The gnostics take this station as the Kaʿba for their hearts' prayer and the final goal of their purposes:

> Their expressions differ, but Your beauty is one;
> each points towards that Beauty.

48. Cairo editor, C163.1: The words between square brackets are an addition absent from the source copies.

God covenants with His prophets and chosen ones to purify their hearts of others and discard every impurity of other-than-Him, preparing them for the circling of inspirations and lights, the abiding of knowledge and mysteries. Outward bodies bow before their awe; hearts and spirits submit to their radiant beauty. That is not difficult for God.

The Real recounts Abraham the Intimate's prayer for the place of the House, further honouring it:

2:126 · Provision for believers and unbelievers

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 164–165

وَإِذْ قالَ إِبْراهِيمُ رَبِّ اجْعَلْ هذا بَلَداً آمِناً وَارْزُقْ أَهْلَهُ مِنَ الثَّمَراتِ مَنْ آمَنَ مِنْهُمْ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ قالَ وَمَنْ كَفَرَ فَأُمَتِّعُهُ قَلِيلاً ثُمَّ أَضْطَرُّهُ إِلى عَذابِ النَّارِ وَبِئْسَ الْمَصِيرُ (126)

126. When Abraham said, "My Lord, make this a secure town and provide its people with fruits—those among them who believe in God and the Last Day," He said, "And whoever disbelieves, I shall give him brief enjoyment, then compel him to the punishment of the Fire. An evil destination!"

Language · The town and the particularization of its people

I say: the demonstrative refers to the place or town: make this place a town possessing security. Someone explains that "town" is indefinite here but definite in Sūrat Ibrāhīm [14:35], because this prayer preceded its becoming a town, whereas that prayer followed it. This raises a chronological difficulty; its fuller discussion will come there, God willing.

"Those who believe" is an apposition of the part to "its people," particularizing them. "Whoever disbelieves" is conjoined to "those who believe," with an omitted imperfect: "and I shall provide for whoever disbelieves."

Outward commentary · Provision differs from religious leadership

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember Abraham's prayer for Mecca after settling his son there in an uncultivated valley and leaving him in God's care. "My Lord, make this place a secure town, where whoever takes shelter is safe. Provide its inhabitants with fruits of every kind, grain and all other produce—those believing in God and the Last Day." The Real says: I also provide for the unbeliever in this world, granting him a brief time or scant measure of enjoyment, then compelling him to the Fire. What an evil place to return!

Abraham the Intimate compared provision with leadership. God teaches that provision is a worldly mercy encompassing believer and unbeliever, unlike leadership and precedence in religion, which occasion heavenly bliss and are attained only by people of faith and righteousness.

Spiritual allusion · The fruits of the sciences

The prophets' prayers apply to inward meanings as to sensible realities. Abraham's prayer thus includes hearts, the towns of faith, and spirits, the mines of mysteries and excellence. They become safe from Satan's assaults and protected from stopping at the sight of created things; secure from impurities, protected from seeing others. God gives them the fruits of the sciences and opens the treasuries of understanding: those who believe the outward Law and struggle in the inward practice of the Path until the lights of directly witnessed Reality shine upon them.

But someone who denies the special path and stops at the outward texts enjoys only formal learning (علم الرسوم), whose sweetness extends no further than the tongue. He is then driven to the punishment of veiling and an evil reckoning. He has not reached the sweetness of witnessing and direct vision that delights the heart (الجَنان) until it reaches the bliss of the gardens (الجِنان), perfected by looking upon His noble Face. May God grant us an abundant share through His favour and generosity.

The Real describes the House's construction and what its builders uttered while building:

2:127 · Raising the foundations of surrender, faith and excellence

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 165–166

وَإِذْ يَرْفَعُ إِبْراهِيمُ الْقَواعِدَ مِنَ الْبَيْتِ وَإِسْماعِيلُ رَبَّنا تَقَبَّلْ مِنَّا إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ السَّمِيعُ الْعَلِيمُ (127)

127. When Abraham and Ishmael raised the foundations of the House: “Our Lord, accept this from us. You are the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing.”

Language · Foundations and the omitted circumstantial expression

I say: *qawāʿid* (قواعد) is the plural of *qāʿida*, a foundation, apparently derived from sitting in the sense of stability. By contrast, *qawāʿid* said of women [24:60] is the plural of *qāʿid* without a feminine ending: the description is particular to women and needs no tāʾ to distinguish the gender. “Our Lord” is accusative as a vocative, reported after an omitted circumstantial phrase: “while saying, ‘Our Lord…’”.

Outward commentary · Building and praying for acceptance

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember when Abraham and Ishmael raised the House’s foundations, rebuilding it after the Flood had effaced it. Adam had built it when sent down to earth, instructed by the angels. Abraham built while Ishmael handed him stones; their cooperation permits attributing the construction to both. Alternatively, each built a different side. They said: our Lord, accept this deed from us; You hear our prayer and know our intentions and inward secrets.

Spiritual allusion · The three sets of foundations

The servant should raise the foundations of his surrender and strengthen its supports by realizing its pillars: perfect the two testimonies by realizing their meanings; perfect prayer through its outward and inward pillars; perfect almsgiving through sincere payment; fasting through its courtesies; and pilgrimage, when obligatory, through its rites. He should also raise faith’s foundations by realizing its pillars: belief in God, His angels, Books,

messengers, the Last Day and the decree, good and evil, sweet and bitter—in conviction and in taste. He should likewise raise the foundations of spiritual excellence,

attaining its degrees: realize witnessing, worshipping God as though seeing Him; if unable, worship as though God sees him.[B081]

Or say: surrender's foundations are raised through repentance, mindfulness and uprightness; faith's through sincerity, truthfulness and tranquillity; excellence's through watchfulness, witnessing and gnosis. Thus al-Sāḥilī, God have mercy on him.

The Real recounts their prayer after the building:

2:128–129 · The prayer for surrender, rites and a purifying messenger

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 166–167

رَبَّنا وَاجْعَلْنا مُسْلِمَيْنِ لَكَ وَمِنْ ذُرِّيَّتِنا أُمَّةً مُسْلِمَةً لَكَ وَأَرِنا مَناسِكَنا وَتُبْ عَلَيْنا إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ التَّوَّابُ الرَّحِيمُ (128) رَبَّنا وَابْعَثْ فِيهِمْ رَسُولاً مِنْهُمْ يَتْلُوا عَلَيْهِمْ آياتِكَ وَيُعَلِّمُهُمُ الْكِتابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَيُزَكِّيهِمْ إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ (129)

128. Our Lord, make us both surrendered to You, and from our descendants a community surrendered to You. Show us our rites and turn towards us in mercy. You are the Ever-Returning, the Merciful. 129. Our Lord, raise among them a messenger from themselves, reciting Your signs to them, teaching them the Book and wisdom, and purifying them. You are the Mighty, the Wise.

Outward commentary · Surrender and repentance appropriate to one’s station

I say: Ibn ʿAbbās relates that when Abraham and Ishmael finished building the House, they prayed: our Lord, make us surrendered to Your outward commands and Your overpowering decrees. Make from our descendants a community surrendered to You. Through revelation or inspiration they knew that some descendants would disbelieve. Show us—that is, acquaint us with and teach us—our pilgrimage rites. *Nusuk* (نسك) originally means the utmost in worship; it became common for pilgrimage because of its hardships, burdens and distance from ordinary habits.

Turn towards us in mercy for what is unfitting to our state. The good deeds of the righteous are the shortcomings of those brought near: every station has something that diminishes it, however complete. Hence he, peace and blessings be upon him, asked forgiveness seventy times in a gathering. No

station lacks a preceding one containing deficiency; upon rising from it, he sought forgiveness for it. You are the Ever-Returning, the Merciful, abundant in acceptance and turning towards the repentant.

Our Lord, raise among the descendants a messenger of their own—our master Muḥammad, who said: "I am the prayer of my father Abraham and the good tidings of Jesus." He will recite and convey Your signs of unity and the truth of Your messengership, teaching them the Book—the Qurʾān—and wisdom: the Sacred Law or Sunna. Mālik says wisdom is understanding and discernment in religion, or a light God places in the heart of whichever servant He wills. He purifies them of the stain of disobedience and the turbidity of sensible fixation. You are Mighty, prevailing in judgement and dominion, Wise in fashioning and perfecting. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Three things to seek and realize

Their prayer contains three things everyone should seek and realize. First is outward and inward surrender to God: obeying His command and yielding to His irresistible decree, until it passes from the root to its branches. This is the utmost favour. In the *Ḥikam*: "When He makes you outwardly obedient to His command and inwardly surrendered to His overpowering decree, He has bestowed an immense favour

upon you." Second is knowing the way and travelling its clear course: undertaking the hardships of obedience, embracing opposition to desire and appetite, seeing one's shortcomings and seeking repentance for them. These are the rites of the hearts' pilgrimage, the road to the ʿArafa of the unseen presence.

Third is finding one who summons to God and points to Him: the great teacher, whose companionship purifies faults, whose sight enriches hearts and brings them into the unseen presence. Outwardly he fulfils the duties of wisdom; inwardly he witnesses the dispositions of power. He is the one undertaking Prophetic formation. Through God is success.

Having established Abraham's honour and made him a leader to follow, the Real warns against abandoning his religion and turning from his way:

2:130–132 · Abraham’s religion and the testament of surrender

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 167–168

وَمَنْ يَرْغَبُ عَنْ مِلَّةِ إِبْراهِيمَ إِلاَّ مَنْ سَفِهَ نَفْسَهُ وَلَقَدِ اصْطَفَيْناهُ فِي الدُّنْيا وَإِنَّهُ فِي الْآخِرَةِ لَمِنَ الصَّالِحِينَ (130) إِذْ قالَ لَهُ رَبُّهُ أَسْلِمْ قالَ أَسْلَمْتُ لِرَبِّ الْعالَمِينَ (131) وَوَصَّى بِها إِبْراهِيمُ بَنِيهِ وَيَعْقُوبُ يا بَنِيَّ إِنَّ اللَّهَ اصْطَفى لَكُمُ الدِّينَ فَلا تَمُوتُنَّ إِلاَّ وَأَنْتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ (132)

130. Who turns away from Abraham’s religion except one who makes a fool of himself? We chose him in this world, and in the Hereafter he is among the righteous. 131. When his Lord said to him, “Surrender,” he said, “I have surrendered to the Lord of the worlds.” 132. Abraham enjoined this upon his sons, as did Jacob: “My sons, God has chosen the religion for you; do not die except in surrender.”

Language · Safiha nafsahu and the testament

I say: “who” is a disapproving interrogative containing a negative sense, the subject of which “turns away…” is the predicate. “Except” overturns that implicit negation. On the preferred analysis, “one who makes a fool…” is an apposition to the subject-pronoun of “turns away.” “Himself” (نفسه) is the object of *safiha*, which includes the meaning “does not know” or “destroys,” according to al-Zajjāj. Al-Farrāʾ takes it as specification: its pronoun retains the indefiniteness of “who” and does not make it definite. Or it follows an omitted preposition, with the verb made directly transitive, like “He struck so-and-so the back and belly.”

“When” is governed by “We chose him.” *Awṣā* and *waṣṣā* both mean to enjoin, though the latter suggests repetition. “This” refers to the declaration “I have surrendered” or to the religion. “Jacob” is conjoined to “Abraham,” and “My sons” is quoted after an omitted “while saying.” Alternatively, “Jacob” is a new subject whose predicate is omitted: “Jacob said, ‘My sons…’”; on that reading one pauses after “his sons.”

Outward commentary · The immediate response to the divine command

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: who would turn from Abraham's clear religion except someone ignorant of his own worth and withholding its due, or one whose judgement is light and whose soul is foolish? How could a rational person turn from it when We chose him as a worldly leader followed by people of outward and inward knowledge, and in the Hereafter he is among those fit for Our presence and dwelling near Us?

We chose him because, when his Lord commanded surrender to Our judgement and obedience to Our command, he replied immediately: I surrender my face to the Lord of the worlds and yield myself wholly to Him. At death, Abraham enjoined this declaration or religion upon his four sons: Ishmael, Isaac, Midian and Midan.[B082] His grandson Jacob likewise enjoined it upon his twelve sons, described below among the Tribes. They said: my sons, God has chosen for you the upright, clear and exalted religion. Hold to it throughout your lives; die only in surrender, adhering to it.

Spiritual allusion · Aspiration lifted above created supports

The religion of our father Abraham is lifting aspiration above creation, directing oneself exclusively to the True King, relinquishing intermediaries and causes, and attaching oneself to the Lord of lords. Al-Shushtarī says:

> To renounce other-than-Him is our obligation,
> for we profess the way that effaces association and doubt.

His religion also includes abandoning self-direction and choice, and surrendering to the decrees of the One, the All-Subduing. Whoever fully holds these qualities and enjoins them upon those he meets is made a leader in this world: his words are followed and his lights guide. In the Hereafter he is among the righteous brought near, with prophets and messengers. Whoever turns from this upright religion loses both worlds. We ask God's protection through His favour and generosity.

When the Jews claimed that Judaism was Abraham's religion, God declared their claim false, saying:

2:133–134 · The fathers' religion and responsibility for one's own deeds

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 168–169

أَمْ كُنْتُمْ شُهَداءَ إِذْ حَضَرَ يَعْقُوبَ الْمَوْتُ إِذْ قالَ لِبَنِيهِ ما تَعْبُدُونَ مِنْ بَعْدِي قالُوا نَعْبُدُ إِلهَكَ وَإِلهَ آبائِكَ إِبْراهِيمَ وَإِسْماعِيلَ وَإِسْحاقَ إِلهاً واحِداً وَنَحْنُ لَهُ مُسْلِمُونَ (133) تِلْكَ أُمَّةٌ قَدْ خَلَتْ لَها ما كَسَبَتْ وَلَكُمْ ما كَسَبْتُمْ وَلا تُسْئَلُونَ عَمَّا كانُوا يَعْمَلُونَ (134)

133. Were you present when death came to Jacob, when he asked his sons, "What will you worship after me?" They replied, "We shall worship your God and the God of your fathers, Abraham, Ishmael and Isaac: one God. To Him we surrender." 134. That was a community which has passed away. Theirs is what they earned, and yours what you have earned. You will not be questioned about what they used to do.

Language · One God, not several

I say: *am* is disconnected (منقطعة), its interrogative expressing denial: you were not present at Jacob's death when he spoke to his sons, so how can you attribute Judaism to him? "One God" is an apposition to "the God of your fathers." It explicitly affirms unity, removes any misconception caused by repeating the annexed noun—which is necessary because one cannot here conjoin directly to the genitive pronoun—and reinforces the sense. Alternatively, it is accusative through specification or as a circumstantial expression.

Ishmael is counted among the fathers by giving the predominant class's designation to the whole (التغليب), or because he is like a father: the Prophet said, "A man's paternal uncle is the counterpart of his father," and of al-ʿAbbās, "This is what remains of my fathers." Thus al-Bayḍāwī.

Outward commentary · A covenant of unity, not an inherited claim

The Real, glorious is His majesty, reproaches the Jews for claiming that Judaism was Abraham's religion and Jacob's dying testament. Were you there to hear the testament you allege? He actually asked his sons what they would worship after him, confirming them in unity and taking their covenant of steadfastness. They answered: we worship your God, whose necessary existence and divinity are acknowledged, the God of your fathers Abraham and his sons Ishmael and Isaac—one God. We yield to His judgements and surrender to His command until death.

Jacob enjoined only what you have heard. Your descent from them does not let you profit from their deeds; only conforming to and following them does.

That community has passed: it has the good it earned, and you have what you earned. You are not questioned about their acts: neither punished for their wrongs nor rewarded for their good. This resembles the Prophet's words to Quraysh: "Do not let people come to me with their deeds while you come with your lineages."

Spiritual allusion · Ancestry does not replace realization

Someone restricting special election to his forefathers and denying it elsewhere is asked: were you present when they enjoined such a claim? They enjoined only sincere servanthood, the unity of Divinity and witnessing Lordship's grandeur. Whoever realizes these qualities possesses special election wherever he is. If he deviates and follows desire, it passes to another. He is told: your forefathers strove and found; their deeds do not benefit you in the path of special election. "That community has passed; theirs is what they earned, yours what you earned." Through God is success.

When Jews and Christians told the Muslims to follow their older religion, God replied:

2:135 · Following the guide who points to God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 169–170

وَقالُوا كُونُوا هُوداً أَوْ نَصارى تَهْتَدُوا قُلْ بَلْ مِلَّةَ إِبْراهِيمَ حَنِيفاً وَما كانَ مِنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ (135)

135. They say, “Be Jews or Christians and you will be guided.” Say, “Rather, Abraham’s religion, inclining wholly to the truth; he was not among those who associate partners with God.”

Language · The two claims and the upright inclination

I say: “they said” refers to the People of the Book; “or” distributes the statement: the Jews say “be Jews,” the Christians “be Christians.” “You will be guided” is the response to the command. “Religion” is accusative through an omitted verb and, on one analysis, an omitted annexed noun: rather, we become adherents of Abraham’s religion; or, we follow or adhere to his religion. “Inclining wholly” (حنيفاً) is circumstantial with respect to the second term of the annexation, since the first is like part of it: inclining from falsehood towards truth.

Outward commentary · The religion free of association

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the Jews tell Muslims to join them and be guided because their religion is older; the Christians tell them to join theirs because it is more correct. Say, Muḥammad: rather, we adhere to Abraham’s religion. He inclined away from falsehood, followed truth and witnessed Him alone. He was not an associator, as you associated ʿUzayr, Jesus and others. Exalted is God far above your assertions.

Spiritual allusion · Spiritual calling without recruitment and rivalry

This disposition has spread among some affiliated to spiritual paths. They entice people to their own way, eagerly seek followers and belittle other paths: a blameworthy trait. Instead, one must look with insight. Whoever points to God and makes one absent from other-than-Him, whose state

raises one and whose speech directs one to God—follow him, lower your head before him and adhere to his way, wherever and however he may be. Turn from anyone lacking this quality and seek another.

Those who call to God are not characterized by grasping after people

or enticing them to become followers. They are the least attached to people. Whoever comes, they direct to God; whoever meets them, they counsel for God. They stand upon the Messenger's footing. The Real told him, "Will you compel people until they become believers?" [10:99]; "You are not a controller over them" [88:22]; and "Perhaps you would destroy yourself because they do not believe" [26:3]. Thereafter he pointed to God and watched what God would do. Through God is success.

The Real explains the faith that must be followed and invalidates what differs from it:

2:136–138 · Faith in all the messengers and the divine dye

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 170–172

قُولُوا آمَنَّا بِاللَّهِ وَما أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْنا وَما أُنْزِلَ إِلى إِبْراهِيمَ وَإِسْماعِيلَ وَإِسْحاقَ وَيَعْقُوبَ وَالْأَسْباطِ وَما أُوتِيَ مُوسى وَعِيسى وَما أُوتِيَ النَّبِيُّونَ مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ لاَ نُفَرِّقُ بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِنْهُمْ وَنَحْنُ لَهُ مُسْلِمُونَ (136) فَإِنْ آمَنُوا بِمِثْلِ ما آمَنْتُمْ بِهِ فَقَدِ اهْتَدَوْا وَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَإِنَّما هُمْ فِي شِقاقٍ فَسَيَكْفِيكَهُمُ اللَّهُ وَهُوَ السَّمِيعُ الْعَلِيمُ (137) صِبْغَةَ اللَّهِ وَمَنْ أَحْسَنُ مِنَ اللَّهِ صِبْغَةً وَنَحْنُ لَهُ عابِدُونَ (138)

136. Say, "We believe in God, in what has been sent down to us, and what was sent down to Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob and the Tribes; in what Moses and Jesus were given, and what all the prophets were given by their Lord. We make no distinction between any of them; to Him we surrender."

137. If they believe as you believe, they are guided. If they turn away, they are only in opposition; God will suffice you against them. He is the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing. 138. God's dye—and whose dye is better than God's? We worship Him alone.

Language · Tribes, opposition and the dye of faith

I say: the *asbāṭ* (أسباط) are descendants; a *sibṭ* among the Children of Israel is like a tribe among Ishmael's descendants. The bāʾ in *bi-mithli* may be supplementary, as in "the recompense of an evil deed is its like" [10:27]; or *mithl* itself is inserted for reinforcement: if they believe what you believe, as in "a witness from the Children of Israel testified to its like" [46:10]. Opposition (شقاق) is disagreement, as though each opponent occupies a different side (شقّ).

"God's dye" (صبغة الله) is a verbal noun reinforcing "we believe," for faith dyes hearts and shows its effect upon the limbs as dye upon a dyed object, penetrating hearts as dye penetrates cloth: we believe, and God dyes us with it. It is the original disposition upon which God created people. "Dye" is used through verbal correspondence (المشاكلة), since Christians immersed children in yellow water called baptism, regarding it as purification establishing their Christianity. God replies that His dye is better.[B083] Alternatively, it is an apposition to "Abraham's religion," or an accusative of exhortation: hold to God's dye.

Outward commentary · The prophets and the descendants of Jacob

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Muslims, declare in realization of your faith: we believe in God—His existence, perfection and transcendence beyond defects; in the Qurʾān revealed to us; and in the scrolls revealed to Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob son of Isaac, and the Tribes, Jacob's sons. These are Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Zebulun and Issachar, with their sister Dinah, whose mother was Leah. He subsequently married Leah's sister Rachel, who bore Joseph and Benjamin. Two concubines bore Dan, Naphtali, Gad and Asher.

Ibn Ḥajar says their prophethood is disputed: some hold that they were prophets; others that none was a prophet, and that "the Tribes" means the tribes of Israel, among whom many prophets arose. ʿIyāḍ and the majority of commentators expressly deny their prophethood: consult the glossator al-Fāsī.[B084]

Say: we believe what was given to Moses—the Torah—and Jesus—the Gospel—and all prophets by their Lord, those we know and those we do not. We distinguish none by rejection, as Jews and Christians did. We believe God and all His prophets and surrender to His outward and inward judgements.

The Real says: if the People of the Book believe with faith like yours, they have reached truth and correctness. If they turn away, leave them until We command you concerning them. They are in opposition and disagreement; do not be troubled by them. God will suffice against their evil and grant you victory. He hears your prayer and knows your sincerity. Hold to the divine dye with which you were coloured—faith in all I have mentioned—for none is better. Say: we worship Him alone.

Spiritual allusion · Affirming every established friend of God

Just as God requires faith in all messengers on the general path, so He requires affirmation of everyone whose friendship with Him is established on the special path. Whoever divides between them denies their way; whoever denies their way is expelled from their door, and whoever is expelled from their door is expelled from God's. To strip a friend of his friendship is to hurt him; whoever hurts God's friend declares war against God. Anyone wishing to drink at their watering places must affirm them all and honour those affiliated to them, until faith's sweetness dyes his heart and the suns of gnosis shine upon him. [49]

Whoever does this reaches truth and deserves admission among the beloved. Whoever turns away is in opposition; one may fear for him the ill omen of unbelief and hypocrisy. God will suffice His friends against his evil, and God prevails in His purpose.

49. Cairo editor, C171.1: The saint does not look to created beings; his goal is God's approval of him. People's denial of a saint's sainthood therefore does not harm the saint: the harm of denial returns to the denier himself, in accordance with the report cited.

Al-Qushayrī says: hearts have a dye, spirits a dye, secrets a dye and outward forms a dye. Bodies and outward forms are dyed with the effects of divine enabling; spirits and secrets with the lights of realization. Al-Wartajbī says: “God’s dye is His special attribute upon which He created Adam,

inherited in the spirits of Adam’s prophetic and saintly descendants.” He then said: “He gave them the wine of nearness and inspired them with the special sciences of Lordship. They shone with gnosis’s light, plunged into Lordship’s sea, and from them came disclosures of the mysteries of unity; they were formed through the dye of the Attributes.” Through God is success.

When Jews and Christians claimed greater proximity to God than others because their religion was older, He rebuked them: “Say, do you dispute with us…”. Another account says the Jews told the Prophet, “All prophets are from us; were you a prophet, you would be from us.” God replied:

2:139–141 · Sincerity, not occupation or ancestry, distinguishes people

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 172–173

قُلْ أَتُحَاجُّونَنا فِي اللَّهِ وَهُوَ رَبُّنا وَرَبُّكُمْ وَلَنا أَعْمالُنا وَلَكُمْ أَعْمالُكُمْ وَنَحْنُ لَهُ مُخْلِصُونَ (139) أَمْ تَقُولُونَ إِنَّ إِبْراهِيمَ وَإِسْماعِيلَ وَإِسْحاقَ وَيَعْقُوبَ وَالْأَسْباطَ كانُوا هُوداً أَوْ نَصارى قُلْ أَأَنْتُمْ أَعْلَمُ أَمِ اللَّهُ وَمَنْ أَظْلَمُ مِمَّنْ كَتَمَ شَهادَةً عِنْدَهُ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَمَا اللَّهُ بِغافِلٍ عَمَّا تَعْمَلُونَ (140) تِلْكَ أُمَّةٌ قَدْ خَلَتْ لَها ما كَسَبَتْ وَلَكُمْ ما كَسَبْتُمْ وَلا تُسْئَلُونَ عَمَّا كانُوا يَعْمَلُونَ (141)

139. Say, “Do you dispute with us concerning God, although He is our Lord and your Lord? We have our deeds and you have yours; to Him we are sincere.” 140. Or do you say that Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob and the Tribes were Jews or Christians? Say, “Do you know better, or does God?”

> Who is more unjust than one who conceals testimony received from God? God is not unaware of what you do. 141. That was a community which has passed away. Theirs is what they earned, and yours what you earned. You will not be questioned about what they used to do.

Language · Disapproval of both claims

I say: *am* appears to be disconnected, meaning "rather," whether the verb is read in the second or third person. The intention is to reject both things, not merely one of them.

Outward commentary · Neither precedence nor ancestry secures a monopoly

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Muḥammad, ask the People of the Book whether they dispute concerning God, claiming greater entitlement to Him, when He is our Lord and yours, not restricted to one rather than another. We have deeds by which we draw near, and you have yours, by which you too draw near. How can you monopolize proximity when we are sincere to Him in deeds and hearts, whereas you associate another with Him? If you claim all prophets belonged to you and your religion, you have spoken falsely. Do you claim that Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob and his sons, the Tribes, were Jews according to your religion, Jewish people, or Christians according to yours, Christian people?

Ask them: do you know better, or God? He denied both of Abraham: "Abraham was neither Jew nor Christian, but upright in surrender" [3:67]; "The Torah and Gospel were sent down only after him" [3:65]. Those mentioned with him followed his religion, so were neither Jews nor Christians. How can you claim them all for your religion when you bear witness otherwise? None is more unjust than one concealing God's testimony

that Abraham was upright and free of Judaism and Christianity. God is not unaware of your acts: He requites even the tiniest thing. Reliance on descent from them is delusion.

That community has passed. Its deeds belong to it and do not benefit others; yours belong to you and nothing else benefits you. You are not questioned about their deeds, nor they about yours. Al-Bayḍāwī says the repetition intensifies warning against the deeply rooted habit of boasting in fath-

ers and relying upon them. Another view takes the earlier address as directed to them and this one to us, warning against imitation. Another takes the first “community” as the prophets and the second as the Jewish and Christian ancestors.

Spiritual allusion · The equality of callings before the criterion of sincerity

Whoever the Real establishes in an occupation and directs towards it works for God there and fulfils God’s purpose in it. Works differ through intentions; people differ in degree through sincerity. All creatures are servants of the Glorious King. Special distinction arises only through sincerity: whoever is more sincere to God is nearer to Him than another. In proportion to the servant’s purity comes his election.

Sufis, scholars, worshippers, renunciants and those engaged in worldly occupations of every kind all work for God. None has greater entitlement to Him than another except through sincerity and the heart’s exclusive devotion to Him. Whoever claims distinction with God on any other basis is lying. Whoever relies on another’s work is deluded and is told: “That community has passed; theirs is what they earned, yours what you earned; you will not be questioned about what they did.”

When God wished to change the prayer-direction from Syria towards the Kaʿba, He announced that people of light judgement and minds corrupted by bad imitation—the Jewish learned men, hypocrites and polytheists—would object, saying:

2:142 · Changing directions and the community of the just mean

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 173–175

سَيَقُولُ السُّفَهاءُ مِنَ النَّاسِ ما وَلاَّهُمْ عَنْ قِبْلَتِهِمُ الَّتِي كانُوا عَلَيْها قُلْ لِلَّهِ الْمَشْرِقُ وَالْمَغْرِبُ يَهْدِي مَنْ يَشاءُ إِلى صِراطٍ مُسْتَقِيمٍ (142)

142. The foolish among people will say, “What has turned them from the prayer-direction they used to face?” Say, “To God belong the east and the west. He guides whomsoever He wills to a straight path.”

Outward commentary · The disposition of places belongs to God

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when the prayer-direction changes from Jerusalem to the Kaʿba, the foolish, lacking sound judgement and religion, will ask what has turned them from their former direction, saying, “Had he remained with it, we would have followed him.” Tell them, Muḥammad: east and west belong to God. His dominion is not restricted to a place by an intrinsic property preventing another from replacing it. Places are equal before God, as creatures are equal in relation to Him. He guides whom He wills to a straight path and leads whom He wills away from the sound road: “He is not questioned about what He does, but they are questioned” [21:23].

The straight path is what wisdom approves and benefit requires: facing Jerusalem at one time and the Kaʿba at another. Announcing the objection in advance prepares the soul and readies the answer. Thus al-Bayḍāwī.

Spiritual allusion · Neither withdrawal nor return to occupations is judged by appearances

A gnostic said: “For forty years, the Real has never placed me in something I disliked or transferred me to something else with which I was discontent.” The ignorant foolish are otherwise: they object whenever states change. If they see someone withdraw from ordinary means and turn entirely to the Generous Bestower, they ask what turned him from his former condition and multiply objections. If they see someone return to ordinary means after perfection, they say he has fallen from the ranks of realized people, though he has only increased in perfection. All dominion belongs to God: He guides whom He wills to a straight path and leads whom He wills astray through His wise justice.

The Real then attests this community’s justice and excellence:

Qur’ānic continuation · 2:143a

وَكَذٰلِكَ جَعَلْنَاكُمْ أُمَّةً وَسَطًا لِتَكُونُوا شُهَدَاءَ عَلَى النَّاسِ وَيَكُونَ الرَّسُولُ عَلَيْكُمْ شَهِيدًا

Thus We made you a community of the just mean, that you may be witnesses over people and the Messenger a witness over you.

Language · The mean between excess and deficiency

I say: *wasaṭ* (وسط) means just, good and excellent. Originally it names a place equally distant from its surrounding sides; it is then borrowed for praiseworthy qualities lying between excess and deficiency, such as generosity between extravagance and miserliness, or courage between recklessness and cowardice. It then denotes someone possessing these qualities, unchanged for singular and plural, masculine and feminine. Thus al-Bayḍāwī.

Outward commentary · The community as witness

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: just as We guided you to the straight path and made your prayer-direction the best, We made you the best community—chosen, just and purified through knowledge and action—fit to bear witness over others on the Day of Resurrection. Your Prophet attests your integrity.

Al-Bayḍāwī relates: the communities on the Day of Resurrection deny that their prophets conveyed the message. God, though knowing their state, requires evidence to establish the argument against the deniers. Muḥammad’s community is brought to testify. Asked how they know, they reply: God informed us in His Book, spoken upon His truthful Prophet’s tongue. Muḥammad is then brought and questioned about his community, and attests their justice. Although this testimony is in their favour, “over” is used because the Messenger watches and oversees his community; the phrase’s position emphasizes their particular distinction in having him as witness over them.

Spiritual allusion · Knowledge, purification and the authority to attest

Excellence among people depends on knowledge and state. Whoever is stronger in knowledge of God is greater in worth before Him. The knowledge conferring honour is knowledge of His Essence, Attributes and Names, and knowledge of His rulings when joined to knowledge of Him. The more the heart's veil is lifted, the nearer it is to its Lord. Unveiling corresponds to emptying and adorning (التخلية والتحلية): as the heart relinquishes vices, withdraws from obstacles and distractions, and acquires virtues, its veil lifts and it enters among

the beloved. As distracting thoughts and occupations accumulate and defects enter it, distance from God grows and the servant is expelled from His door.

Many deeds do not establish perfection; lofty aspiration and state do. Aspiration corresponds to certainty, certainty to gnosis, gnosis to orientation and purification, and orientation follows the eternal allotment. Such is God's bounty, given to whom He wills.

Scholars of God's rulings without unveiling of His Essence are a proof against God's servants. Those knowing God, to whom His Essence has been unveiled in witnessing and direct vision, are a proof against the scholars of His rulings. As the Muḥammadan community testifies over people and the Messenger attests it, so scholars testify over people and friends of God over scholars, validating those who deserve validation and rejecting those who do not. Gnostics know the states and stations of outward scholars; outward scholars neither know the friends' stations nor smell their fragrance. As someone said:

> We left the overflowing seas behind us;
> how should people know where we have turned?

Al-Qushayrī says: God made this community the best of communities and this company the best within it—the best of the best. As the community witnesses over other communities at the Resurrection, this company is the pivot and pole through whom God preserves the whole community. Whoever their hearts accept is accepted; whoever they reject is rejected. Their discernment judges truly, their judgement is sound and their vision correct. He protects the whole community from agreeing upon error, and this com-

pany from error in perception, judgement, acceptance and rejection. Yet their affair rests upon the Messenger's Sunna: anyone not following him is rejected among them and counts for nothing.[B085] Through God is success.

The Real explains the wisdom of changing the prayer-direction:

2:143–144 · The trial of a changed direction and the Prophet's courtesy

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 175–178

وَكَذلِكَ جَعَلْناكُمْ أُمَّةً وَسَطاً لِتَكُونُوا شُهَداءَ عَلَى النَّاسِ وَيَكُونَ
الرَّسُولُ عَلَيْكُمْ شَهِيداً وَما جَعَلْنَا الْقِبْلَةَ الَّتِي كُنْتَ عَلَيْها إِلاَّ لِنَعْلَمَ مَنْ
يَتَّبِعُ الرَّسُولَ مِمَّنْ يَنْقَلِبُ عَلى عَقِبَيْهِ وَإِنْ كانَتْ لَكَبِيرَةً إِلاَّ عَلَى الَّذِينَ
هَدَى اللَّهُ وَما كانَ اللَّهُ لِيُضِيعَ إِيمانَكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ بِالنَّاسِ لَرَؤُفٌ رَحِيمٌ
(143) قَدْ نَرى تَقَلُّبَ وَجْهِكَ فِي السَّماءِ فَلَنُوَلِّيَنَّكَ قِبْلَةً تَرْضاها فَوَلِّ
وَجْهَكَ شَطْرَ الْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرامِ وَحَيْثُ مَا كُنْتُمْ فَوَلُّوا وُجُوهَكُمْ شَطْرَهُ
وَإِنَّ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ لَيَعْلَمُونَ أَنَّهُ الْحَقُّ مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ وَمَا اللَّهُ بِغافِلٍ
عَمَّا يَعْمَلُونَ (144)

143. Thus We made you a community of the just mean, that you may be witnesses over people and the Messenger a witness over you. We appointed the prayer-direction you formerly faced only that We might know who follows the Messenger and who turns on his heels. It was indeed hard, except for those whom God guided. God would not let your faith go to waste. God is Gentle and Merciful towards people. 144. We have indeed seen your face turning towards heaven; We shall turn you towards a prayer-direction pleasing to you. Turn your face towards the Sacred

Mosque. Wherever you are, turn your faces towards it. Those given the Book know this to be the truth from their Lord. God is not unaware of what they do.

Language · The appointed direction and the emphatic construction

I say: *jaʿala* means to make one thing into another. "The prayer-direction" is its first object; "which you used to face" qualifies an omitted second object: We made the prayer-direction the direction you formerly faced—Jerusalem—then turned you to the Kaʿba, only to distinguish those steadfast in faith from others. Or: We made it the direction you faced in Mecca, the Kaʿba, for he prayed towards it there. Another account, from Ibn ʿAbbās, says he faced Jerusalem with the Kaʿba between him and it.

In (إن) is the lightened emphatic particle; the lām distinguishes it from the negative. The sense is: the matter is that the change was hard for people. Tenderness (الرأفة) is intense compassion and therefore more emphatic than mercy. And God Most High knows best.

Outward commentary · Knowledge made manifest and worship not lost

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: We changed the ruling of the prayer-direction back to the one you faced in Mecca rather than the Medinan direction, Jerusalem, only that We might know with a knowledge of manifestation and witnessing who follows the Messenger in the change and who turns back through weak faith and scant certainty. Moving from the first direction to the second is hard upon souls, except those for whom guidance has preceded and care surrounds them. They turn with God's will wherever it turns and follow His Messenger wherever he goes.

For anyone who died before the change to the Kaʿba, God does not lose the reward of his deeds. "God would not let your faith go to waste" means your prayer towards Jerusalem. God is deeply tender and merciful towards people.

Spiritual allusion · Breaking habits as a test of following

Leaving habits and familiar things is hard upon souls, except those whom God guides. Hence breaking habits distinguishes the elect from the generality and opens the treasuries of knowledge and understanding. Whoever has

not broken his own habits should not hope to enter the holy presence. “How should ordinary patterns be broken for you when you have not broken your own habitual patterns?” This is the arena in which wayfarers’ journeys become real: “Were it not for the arenas of the lower selves, the wayfarers’ journey would not be realized.”

For masters of formation it is a balance distinguishing one who follows the Messenger and adheres to his path of arrival from one who turns back. When they see someone break his soul’s habits and renounce attachment to his dress and his own social kind, they recognize his entry into the holy presence—unless deprivation has preceded for him; in God is refuge from abandonment. Whoever stops at habits, settles into familiar things and inclines to dispensations and accommodating interpretations remains among the veiled, receiving his wage from behind the door with no share in entering among the beloved.

Changing effects and shifting conditions also distinguish affirmation from denial. Those who affirm know God in every state, turning and travelling with the winds of destiny. Those who deny remain ignorant in every state, objecting when conditions change. We seek God’s protection from error.

The Real describes how the change of direction began:

Qur’ānic continuation · 2:144a

قَدْ نَرَىٰ تَقَلُّبَ وَجْهِكَ فِي السَّمَاءِ فَلَنُوَلِّيَنَّكَ قِبْلَةً تَرْضَاهَا فَوَلِّ وَجْهَكَ شَطْرَ الْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرَامِ وَحَيْثُ مَا كُنْتُمْ فَوَلُّوا وُجُوهَكُمْ شَطْرَهُ

We have indeed seen your face turning towards heaven; We shall turn you towards a prayer-direction pleasing to you. Turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque. Wherever you are, turn your faces towards it.

Language · Facing the direction of the House

I say: turning (التقلب) is repeated movement. *Wallaytuhu kadhā* means I made him face it; *shaṭr* here means direction.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, addresses His Prophet when he wished to turn towards the Kaʿba, the direction of his father Abraham, more conducive to the Arabs' accepting Islam and older than Jerusalem's direction. He looked towards heaven, turning his face in expectation of revelation. His waiting without asking is perfect courtesy. The Real says: We see, at times, your face turning towards heaven awaiting revelation. We shall grant what you desire and direct you to a prayer-direction you love for religious purposes agreeing with the divine will and required by wisdom. Turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque. Believers, wherever you may be, turn towards it.

God mentions the mosque's direction rather than the exact structure of the Kaʿba because the Prophet was in Medina. For someone distant, observing the direction suffices: exact alignment with the building would be burdensome, unlike for someone near. Another explanation says Gabriel identified it precisely through revelation, hence "a revealed prayer-direction." [50]

It is related that after coming to Medina he prayed towards Jerusalem for sixteen months, then was turned to the Kaʿba after noon in Rajab, two months before Badr. He had prayed two units of the noon prayer with his companions in the mosque of Banū Salima when he turned during prayer, facing the waterspout; men and women exchanged rows. It was therefore named the Mosque of the Two Prayer-Directions. Thus al-Bayḍāwī.[B086]

Spiritual allusion · Asking, waiting and the guidance of the moment

The verse suggests that refraining from explicitly asking belongs to perfect courtesy. In the *Ḥikam*: "Courtesy may lead them to refrain from asking. How could your subsequent prayer cause His preceding decree? Exalted is the eternal judgement beyond attribution to causes!" When you wish for something or await an affair, be patient, observe courtesy and imitate your Prophet until God gives what pleases you or replaces it with the station of contentment. The question admits discussion. The precise approach is to consider what one's breast opens to at the moment: if it opens to prayer, pray; if it contracts from prayer, remain silent. God provides whom He wills without reckoning, ground or means.

50. Cairo editor, C177.1: Musāmata: facing it, being aligned with it, and standing directly opposite it.

Or say: We see your contemplation, gnostic, in the heaven of meanings, in a state of absence in the witnessing of vessels. *[Translator's note: Cairo I:178 reads* غائباً في شهود الأواني*, with fī ("in"), not ʿan ("from"). Ibn ʿAjība defines sensible forms as the vessels of inward meanings in Miʿrāj al-tashawwuf (ed. al-Khayyālī, p. 61). Absence can denote self-forgetful absorption, so witnessing such vessels need not be mere attachment to their outward forms. His discussions of Q6:103 (II:153) and Q7:143 (II:257) describe witnessing meanings behind the vessels and becoming absent from vessels by witnessing meanings. These clarify his vocabulary but do not settle the different local construction with "in." The local sentence, however, does not explicitly say what the gnostic is absent from or how that absence relates to the vessels. The literal wording is retained; neither a different preposition nor substitution of "lights" is established.]*[B088] We shall direct you towards a prayer-direction pleasing to you, delighting you through the sight of its beauty and radiance: the purified presence which is the hearts' prayer. Turn your face and aspiration towards it wherever you are, and persist in the prayer of contemplation and vision. This is the gnostics' prayer and the seekers' ultimate hope. Through God is success.

When the direction changed to the Kaʿba, the Jews angrily and obstinately objected to his leaving theirs: "Had he remained, we might have hoped he was the Prophet sent at the end of time, and followed him." God refuted their assertion, saying:

2:145–147 · Knowledge resisted and truth concealed

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 178–180

وَلَئِنْ أَتَيْتَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ بِكُلِّ آيَةٍ مَّا تَبِعُوا قِبْلَتَكَ وَما أَنْتَ بِتابِعٍ قِبْلَتَهُمْ وَما بَعْضُهُمْ بِتابِعٍ قِبْلَةَ بَعْضٍ وَلَئِنِ اتَّبَعْتَ أَهْواءَهُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَكَ مِنَ الْعِلْمِ إِنَّكَ إِذاً لَمِنَ الظَّالِمِينَ (145) الَّذِينَ آتَيْناهُمُ الْكِتابَ يَعْرِفُونَهُ كَما يَعْرِفُونَ أَبْناءَهُمْ وَإِنَّ فَرِيقاً مِنْهُمْ لَيَكْتُمُونَ الْحَقَّ وَهُمْ يَعْلَمُونَ (146) الْحَقُّ مِنْ رَبِّكَ فَلا تَكُونَنَّ مِنَ الْمُمْتَرِينَ (147)

145. Even if you brought those given the Book every sign, they would not follow your prayer-direction; you will not follow theirs, nor do they follow one another's. Were you to follow their desires after the knowledge that has come to you, you would then be among the wrongdoers. 146. Those to whom We gave the Book recognize him as they recognize their sons; yet a group of them knowingly conceals the truth. 147. The truth is from your Lord; do not be among the doubters.

Language · When an oath and condition coincide

I say: in *wa-laʾin*, the lām prepares for an oath, *in* is conditional, "you brought" its verb, and "they would not follow" answers the omitted oath, also sufficing for the conditional response. In the *Alfiyya*:

When condition and oath meet together,
omit the response of whichever comes later: this is required.

Outward commentary · A sign cannot remove deliberate resistance

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the Jewish learned men know that the change to the Kaʿba is truth from their Lord, since their Book describes the Prophet praying towards two directions, and God habitually appoints a distinct Law for each community. God is not unaware of their resistance; He only gives them respite until the Day of Return.

By God, if you brought them every argument and proof of the correctness of facing the Kaʿba, they would not follow it. They have not abandoned your direction through a doubt removable by evidence, but through obstinacy. They hoped you would return to theirs, but you never will. Theirs is Jerusalem's rock, the Christians' the sunrise; neither follows the other's direction, each party rigidly fixed in its own position, however mistaken. Leaving habits is hard upon souls unless divine care has preceded.

Were you hypothetically to follow their false desires and corrupt opinions after receiving clear knowledge and sound revelation, you would be among the wrongdoers. But you are protected, so following them is inconceivable.

Those given the Book recognize him—the Messenger, although not expressly named beforehand, since the context indicates him—or the Qurʾān, or the change of direction—as they recognize their sons. They no more

doubt his true messengership than their knowledge of their sons. ʿUmar asked ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām about the Messenger, and he replied: "I know him better than my son." Asked why, he said: "I have no doubt that Muḥammad is God's prophet, whereas my son's mother might have been unfaithful."

After attaining this knowledge they denied him and concealed his description, except those whom God protected through faith, such as Ibn Salām and his companions. A group—their learned men—knowingly concealed truth through envy and resistance. What you follow, Muḥammad, is truth from your Lord; do not doubt its truth or their knowing concealment. The address actually turns to the hearers, not the Prophet, from whom doubt is not expected. Its purpose is to establish the matter as beyond a discerning person's doubt, or most emphatically to command the community to acquire knowledge that dispels uncertainty. Thus al-Bayḍāwī.

Spiritual allusion · The cost of following inward realization

God's customary way is that people of Reality are denied by people restricted to the Law—or say, inward scholars by outward scholars—who meet them with harm and denial, although knowing Reality and inward knowledge to be true. He, peace and blessings be upon him, said: "Some knowledge is like a hidden treasure, known only to those who know God; when people deluded about God hear it, they deny its possessors"—or words to that effect. He also said: "Every verse has an outward, an inward, a limit and a point of ascent."[B087]

God is not unaware of what they do. Their recompense is deprivation of the sweetness of witnessing and direct vision. Inward people are told: even if you brought every sign, they would not follow your orientation, for it depends on the death of the lower selves, lowering heads, relinquishing money, breaking habits to gain benefits, leaving homelands and becoming absent from family and children. Nor, disciple, will you follow their orientation. Were you to follow their desires after the knowledge of realization has appeared to you, you would wrong yourself.

The scholars of the Law given the Book know the science of Reality as they know their sons: they acknowledge it generally while denying particular possessors. They may recognize it fully but conceal the truth through envy, knowing its special distinction exists. The gnostic is told:

what you follow—the clear course and the knowledge of realization—is truth from your Lord. Do not doubt that you stand upon manifest truth.

The Real explains the direction for someone far from Mecca:

2:148–149 · Every direction and the race towards good

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 180–181

وَلِكُلٍّ وِجْهَةٌ هُوَ مُوَلِّيها فَاسْتَبِقُوا الْخَيْراتِ أَيْنَ مَا تَكُونُوا يَأْتِ بِكُمُ اللَّهُ جَمِيعاً إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (148) وَمِنْ حَيْثُ خَرَجْتَ فَوَلِّ وَجْهَكَ شَطْرَ الْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرامِ وَإِنَّهُ لَلْحَقُّ مِنْ رَبِّكَ وَمَا اللَّهُ بِغافِلٍ عَمَّا تَعْمَلُونَ (149)

148. Each has a direction towards which he turns. So vie with one another in good deeds. Wherever you are, God will bring you all together. God has power over everything. 149. Wherever you set out from, turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque. This is the truth from your Lord; God is not unaware of what you do.

Language · The one who turns and the one who is directed

I say: the nunation of “each” substitutes for an omitted expression: each community has a prayer-direction, or each group of Muslims has a direction and side of the Kaʿba. “A direction” is the subject; the preceding prepositional phrase is its predicate. “He” is a subject and “turns towards it” its predicate, with an underlying shortened form. *Wallā* takes two objects, one omitted here: he turns his face towards it, if “he” refers to the omitted community or group. Alternatively, it refers to God: God directs it towards that person, making it face him when he faces its direction.

Ibn ʿĀmir reads the passive *huwa muwallāhā* (هو مُوَلّاها). Its deputy-agent is a pronoun referring to “he,” originally the first object; the second becomes the attached genitive for lightness. The sense is “he is directed towards it.”

Outward commentary · Good deeds before the arrival of death

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: each group of Muslims has a side of the Kaʿba to face wherever it may be. Multiply prayers and hasten towards good before the destroyer of pleasures descends. Wherever you are, in the earth's east or west, death comes and brings you to the gathering barefoot and naked. Only righteous deeds and good acts sent ahead benefit you then. God has power over everything: neither resurrecting servants nor gathering them from the earth's depths and distant regions incapacitates Him.

Knowing that each people has a direction, wherever you set out from or settle, turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque. By God, this is truth from your Lord, so hasten to obey. God is not unaware of good or evil deeds and requites each for what he sent ahead.

The Real repeats the command for another reason: wherever you set out from, face the Sacred Mosque, and wherever you settle, turn towards it. Al-Bayḍāwī says the ruling is repeated because its reasons are multiple. Three are given for the change: honouring the Messenger by seeking what pleases him; the divine custom of assigning every religious community and bearer of a mission a distinguishing direction; and removing opponents' arguments. Each reason is joined to its corresponding ruling. Moreover, the prayer-direction is weighty, and abrogation can occasion trial and doubt; emphatic repetition is therefore fitting.

He states the third reason, removing opponents' arguments:

2:150 · The many callings and the one inward direction

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 181–183

وَمِنْ حَيْثُ خَرَجْتَ فَوَلِّ وَجْهَكَ شَطْرَ الْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرامِ وَحَيْثُ مَا كُنْتُمْ فَوَلُّوا وُجُوهَكُمْ شَطْرَهُ لِئَلاَّ يَكُونَ لِلنَّاسِ عَلَيْكُمْ حُجَّةٌ إِلاَّ الَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا مِنْهُمْ فَلا تَخْشَوْهُمْ وَاخْشَوْنِي وَلِأُتِمَّ نِعْمَتِي عَلَيْكُمْ وَلَعَلَّكُمْ تَهْتَدُونَ (150)

150. Wherever you set out from, turn your face towards the Sacred Mosque; wherever you are, turn your faces towards it, so that people may have no argument against you, except those among them who do wrong. Do not fear them; fear Me, so that I may complete My blessing upon you and you may be guided.

Language · The exception and the implied purpose

I say: the exception is from “people”: let no one have an argument except the obstinate. “That I may complete” is attached to an omitted expression: I commanded the change to complete My blessing and will your guidance. Or it is conjoined to an omitted clause: fear Me that I may protect you and complete My blessing.

[Translator’s print-source notes: [T8]]

Outward commentary · Arguments removed, obstinacy remaining

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: I commanded you to face the Kaʿba rather than the rock to remove people’s arguments. The Jews might say that the Prophet described in the Torah faces the Kaʿba, whereas this man faces the rock; or that Muḥammad opposes their religion but faces their direction. The polytheists might say that he claims Abraham’s religion while opposing his direction. Thus I commanded the change, except that the obstinate do not cease their contentiousness. They say he turned only from inclin-

ation towards his people's religion and love of his homeland, or that he changed his mind and returned to his fathers' direction and might soon return to their religion.

Do not fear them or attend to their attacks: they do not harm you. Fear Me, and I will suffice you against them. Whoever fears Me is feared by everything; whoever does not fear Me fears everything. I also commanded your forefather's direction to complete My blessing by delighting your Prophet and willing your guidance. Thank Me for what I have granted and remember My blessings: I will increase My favour and beneficence and pour My gifts upon you.

Spiritual allusion · Different offices within the divine governance

The Wise Governor's wisdom includes ordering His great kingdom and assigning each group a service benefiting His servants, absorbing it in that work and entrusting it to it. Some He chooses for His love and presence: the gnostics. Some He establishes in service, absorbed in worship:

the worshippers and renunciants. Some He establishes to bear His Law and consolidate His religion: the practising scholars. Some preserve His Book in writing, recitation and understanding: the reciters and commentators. "We sent down the Remembrance, and We preserve it" [15:9]. Some quiet disturbances and repel oppression and hardship: rulers and those assisting their work. Some preserve the order of wisdom: those undertaking lawful occupations in all their kinds and branches. Some are prepared for His forbearance and pardon to appear in them: the disobedient and sinful. Some are prepared for requital and the manifestation of His Name the All-Subduing: the different unbelievers.

Each of these orientations is directed towards a task under the Sacred Law in which divine power has established it and which decree and destiny have determined, though the Sacred Law does not approve the last two categories.[B089] Were intentions good, all would be workers for God. They are told: vie in good by improving purposes and intentions, and hasten to obedience before death. Wherever you are, He gathers you for reckoning, and you see the punishment or reward for what you sent ahead.

Wherever you set out from, gnostic, turn your orientation and whole being to the mosque of the Presence through contemplation and vision. It is truth, and what is other is false, as the poet says:

Everything except God is false;
every delight must inevitably pass away. [51]

Wherever you are, gnostics, turn towards that Presence's direction and worship through contemplation: the prayer of hearts and key to the fields of unseen realities. As someone says:

O my direction in prayer,
when I stand to pray:
Your beauty is before my eyes;
towards it I turn my whole being. [52]

When you realize this presence and fortify yourselves in witnessing and vision, the arguments of the adversaries—the lower self and your own kind—are cut off. You walk in gardens of nearness and intimacy. Thoughts still hovering around hearts do not impair witnessing of unseen realities. Fear none but Me; direct your aspiration only towards My kindness and beneficence. I will complete My blessing, guide you to perfect knowledge of Me, and favour you with victory and assistance.

The Real mentions the blessing of the intermediary:

2:151–152 · The messenger's teaching and the degrees of remembrance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 183–185

كَما أَرْسَلْنا فِيكُمْ رَسُولاً مِنْكُمْ يَتْلُوا عَلَيْكُمْ آياتِنا وَيُزَكِّيكُمْ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ الْكِتابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمْ ما لَمْ تَكُونُوا تَعْلَمُونَ (151) فَاذْكُرُونِي أَذْكُرْكُمْ وَاشْكُرُوا لِي وَلا تَكْفُرُونِ (152)

51. Cairo editor, C182.1: The hadith master Ibn Ḥajar relates in al-Fatḥ, 7:188, that Labīd recited from his poetry, "Surely everything apart from God is vain." ʿUthmān ibn Maẓʿūn said, "You have spoken truly." Labīd then said, "And every delight must pass away." ʿUthmān said, "You have spoken falsely: the delight of the Garden does not pass away."
52. Cairo editor, C182.2: Ibn al-Fāriḍ.

151. Just as We sent among you a messenger from yourselves, reciting Our signs, purifying you, teaching you the Book and wisdom, and teaching you what you did not know. 152. So remember Me: I shall remember you. Give thanks to Me and do not be ungrateful.

Language · Purification as purpose and as result

I say: “just as” is attached to “complete”: I complete My blessing in the prayer-direction as I completed it by sending the Messenger. Or it attaches to “remember Me”: as We remembered you through sending, remember Us through speech and state.

Purification precedes teaching here according to the intended purpose, since purification is the aim of sending and teaching. It follows teaching in Abraham’s prayer [2:129] according to the order of execution, since sending and teaching precede purification. The governing verb is repeated in “teaches you what you did not know” to indicate and honour a different kind of knowledge.

Outward commentary · The many correspondences of remembrance

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: My servants, remember My kindness and beneficence. I completed My gifts by granting the change of direction, just as I completed them through the greatest blessing: sending a messenger of your own to teach you. He recites Our signs leading to Our presence, purifies faults, teaches the Book containing knowledge of unseen things and medicine for hearts, teaches wisdom—the purified Law and Prophetic Sunna—and teaches unseen sciences previously unknown to you.

Remember Me through obedience and beneficence; I remember you through reward and the bliss of gardens. The Prophet said: “Whoever obeys God remembers Him, even with little prayer, fasting and Qurʾān recitation; whoever disobeys Him forgets Him, even with much prayer, fasting and recitation.”[B090]

Or: remember Me with your inward heart, and I remember you through witnessing and direct vision; remember Me with hearts, and I unveil the curtains; remember Me through unity and faith, and I remember you through degrees in Paradise. Al-Ṣiddīq said: “Unity suffices as worship; Paradise suffices as reward.” Or: remember Me with gratitude, and I re-

member you with increase; remember Me upon the earth, and I remember you within it. Al-Aṣmaʿī saw a Bedouin standing at ʿArafāt on the Day of ʿArafa, saying: "My God, voices cry to You in different tongues, asking their needs. My need is that You remember me in affliction when the people of the world forget me."

Or: remember Me in this world, and I remember you in the next; remember Me through obedience, and I remember you through well-being—a good life. Remember Me in solitude and in company, and I remember you in a better company. The proof is the hadith: "I am as My servant thinks of Me, so let him think as he will. I am with him when he remembers Me. If he remembers Me within himself,

I remember him within Myself; if he remembers Me in a gathering, I remember him in a better gathering."

Or: remember Me in blessing and ease, and I remember you in hardship and affliction; remember Me through surrender and contentment, and I remember you through good ordering and a gentle decree: "Whoever relies on God, He suffices him" [65:3]. Remember Me through longing and love, and I remember you through union and nearness; through repentance, and I forgive offences; through prayer, and I give; through asking, and I bestow—besides correspondences without limit.

Outward commentary · Three modes and many forms of remembrance

Know that remembrance is of three kinds: tongue alone, the remembrance of the heedless; tongue and heart, that of wayfarers; and heart alone, that of those who have arrived. Remembrance is the best of deeds, as Prophetic hadiths and Qurʾānic verses indicate, and the nearest path leading to God when practised with a perfected shaykh. [53]

It has many forms: declaring unity (التهليل), magnifying God (التكبير), glorifying Him (التسبيح), praising Him (الحمدلة), declaring His sufficiency (الحسبلة), declaring that power and strength are only through Him (الحوقلة), and blessing the Messenger. Each has a property and fruit. They are gathered in remembrance of the single Name (ذكر المفرد): "God, God" (الله، الله). Its fruit is effacement in the Essence, the final end. Consult Ibn Juzayy.

53. Cairo editor, C184.1: "Heedlessness" here refers to the heart's failure to accompany the tongue in remembrance.

The Real says: thank Me for My kindness and beneficence by attributing them to Me, not another. Do not deny My goodness, lest I withdraw the gifts I entrusted to you.

Spiritual allusion · The continuing work of Prophetic formation

As God blessed the Muḥammadan community with a messenger of its own who teaches Prophetic Law, purifies them of witnessing otherness and imparts divinely bestowed sciences, so in every time He favours this community with masters of formation. They purify faults, bring people into the unseen presence, disclose witnessing of eternal power and divine wisdom, teach wondrous sciences and open treasuries of understanding. People perceive the guarded secret and learn what they did not know.

The Real tells them: remember Me through spirits and secrets; I remember you through absence from seeing your bodily forms. Remember Me through contemplation and vision; I give abiding witnessing of the Presence. Thank Me for My gifts and kindness; do not deny Me by resting upon another, lest I withdraw increased assistance and victory.

Having commanded gratitude, He commands patience, its companion in the opposite condition: gratitude in blessing, patience in affliction.

2:153–157 · Patience, the life of the martyrs and return to God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 185–188

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اسْتَعِينُوا بِالصَّبْرِ وَالصَّلاةِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَ الصَّابِرِينَ (153) وَلا تَقُولُوا لِمَنْ يُقْتَلُ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ أَمْواتٌ بَلْ أَحْياءٌ وَلكِنْ لا تَشْعُرُونَ (154) وَلَنَبْلُوَنَّكُمْ بِشَيْءٍ مِنَ الْخَوْفِ وَالْجُوعِ وَنَقْصٍ مِنَ الْأَمْوالِ وَالْأَنْفُسِ وَالثَّمَراتِ وَبَشِّرِ الصَّابِرِينَ (155) الَّذِينَ إِذا أَصابَتْهُمْ مُصِيبَةٌ قالُوا إِنَّا لِلَّهِ وَإِنَّا إِلَيْهِ راجِعُونَ (156) أُولئِكَ عَلَيْهِمْ صَلَواتٌ مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ وَرَحْمَةٌ وَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الْمُهْتَدُونَ (157)

153. O you who believe, seek help through patience and prayer. God is with the patient. 154. Do not say of those slain in God's way, "They are dead." Rather, they are alive, though you do not perceive it. 155. We shall certainly test you with something of fear and hunger, and loss of property, lives and fruits. Give glad tidings to the patient, 156. who, when a calamity strikes them, say, "We belong to God, and to Him we return." 157. Upon them are blessings and mercy from their Lord; it is they who are rightly guided.

Language · Testing makes manifest what divine knowledge already encompasses

I say: "alive" and "dead" are predicates (خبران) of an implied subject (مبتدأ مضمر). Wherever trial (الابتلاء) occurs in the Qurʾān it means testing. In relation to God Most High, its meaning is that He manifests in existence what is in His knowledge, so that the proof stands against the servant. It is not like people testing one another, for God knows what has been and what will be. Blessing (الصلاة) here means forgiveness and purification; mercy means gentleness and beneficence.

Outward commentary · Prayer, perseverance and the life beyond bodily death

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: believers, seek help in attaining My good pleasure, kindness and beneficence through patience in the difficulties of obedience and in abandoning disobedience and lapses, and through prayer, the mother of acts of worship, the place of intimate converse and the mine of pure communion. In it the dawning lights shine and the fields of spiritual secrets expand. It is the ascent of believers' spirits and their intimate converse with the Lord of the worlds. When you drink patience's bitterness, God is with the patient.

Among the greatest occasions for patience are parting from loved ones and losing kin and companions. If their death occurs in holy struggle, there should be neither sorrow nor distress on their account, for "they are alive with their Lord, provided for" [3:169]. The same applies to those joined to their rank: those who die beneath a collapsed building, through drowning or burning, in childbirth or of plague. Do not call those among them killed in God's way dead: rather, they are alive with a spiritual, not an ordinary bodily, life. You do not perceive their life because they are spirits alone, whereas you are clothed in the talisman of bodily forms, and the station of spirits is hidden from you. Likewise all believers' spirits are alive.

Martyrs are singled out because of their additional joy and honour and the provision made to flow to them, unlike others. A report says: "The martyrs' spirits are in the crops of green birds, feeding upon the leaves of the Garden"—that is, eating them. Another report says: "God creates for the martyrs bodies in the form of green birds. They are in their crops and range with them through the Garden, eating its fruits and enjoying its good things and delight, until they are raised from them on the Day of Resurrection."[B091]

No one else enters the Garden before its appointed time, except the utterly truthful (الصديقون), who are the gnostics. They are greater than all the others through their additional freedom of action and perception, their expansive repose and refreshment, and their realized witnessing and direct vision. Like the martyrs, they enjoy the Gardens' bliss; unlike them, however, they are not confined within the crops of birds. They have forms and bodies in which they range wherever they wish. So too those above them, the prophets and messengers. And God Most High knows best.

The Real then says: We shall test you, company of Muslims, with a little fear from the enemy's rising and the unbelievers' assault; hunger from high prices and scarce produce; loss of property through livestock dying, trade becoming difficult or business losses; loss of lives through death in holy struggle; and loss of fruits through disasters destroying them.

Al-Shāfiʿī is reported to have said: "Fear means fear of God; hunger, the Ramadan fast; loss of property, obligatory and voluntary alms; loss of lives, illnesses; and loss of fruits, children's deaths." The Prophet is reported to have said: "When a servant's child dies, God asks the angels, 'Have you taken My servant's child?' They answer, 'Yes.' God asks, 'Have you taken the fruit of his heart?' They answer, 'Yes.' God asks, 'What did he say?' They answer, 'He praised You and said that he belongs to You and returns to You.' God says, 'Build My servant a house in the Garden, and name it the House of Praise.'"[B092]

Give glad tidings—you who can convey them—to the patient: those who, when calamity befalls their body, family, property or companion, say, "We belong to God," as His possession and servants, over whom He rules as He wills; "and to Him we return," so that He may reward us with what no eye has seen, no ear has heard and no human heart has conceived. Beside that reward, worldly afflictions disappear.

A report says: "Whenever someone afflicted by a calamity says, 'We belong to God, and to Him we return. O God, reward me in my calamity and replace it for me with something better,' God gives him something better in its place." Umm Salama said: "When my husband Abū Salama died, I said this, and God gave me His Messenger in his place."[B093]

Upon these patient ones, returning to God, are blessings—meaning forgiveness and purification—from their Lord, and mercy—meaning tenderness and gentleness. They are guided to every good in this world and the next.

Spiritual allusion · The dying of self-will and the spirit's abiding life

You who believe in the path of the elect, seek help in travelling to Our presence and witnessing the lights of Our holiness through patience with what the lower selves dislike: abandoning their shares and desires, and their inclination to habits and familiar things. Seek help also through unceasing prayer, the prayer of hearts abiding in the presence of the unseen. God is with the patient through help, confirmation and the shining lights of unity.

Do not say of someone whom you see put his lower self to death through abasement and need, breaking customary patterns and casting off restraint, "He has died." Rather, he is alive and does not die. God Most High says:

"They taste no death there except the first death" [44:56]. When the aspirant's lower self dies, and abasement and honour, praise and blame, wealth and poverty, death and life become equal to him, his spirit comes alive. The space of witnessing opens wide before it, and it enjoys beholding the worshipped King. Bodily death only increases its union, enjoyment and witnessing. It ascends for ever and ever, though you do not perceive what these people experience in this abode or the other.[B094]

When they intend to travel the path to the very source of realization, they are told: by God, We shall test you, company of aspirants, with something of people's harm, restricted provision, loss of wealth, bodily weakness through spiritual struggle, and delay in the opening and the appearance of witnessing's fruit. This distinguishes the one sincere in seeking—steadfast in the requirements of servanthood until lordship's lights shine upon him—from the liar who returns to habits and desires and rests in concessions and accommodating interpretations.

Give glad tidings to those patient and steadfast in seeking: they shall attain all they hoped for and arrive at that towards which they travelled. When a setback or standstill befalls them, they realize servanthood's weakness and cling to lordship's strength. They turn back to God in everything, and He shelters them with Himself from everything. Upon them are tenderness and nearness from their Lord; they are guided to the Beloved's neighbourhood.

Spiritual allusion · Four forms of patience, surrender and contentment

Ibn Juzayy says, by way of a useful observation: patience is mentioned in the Qurʾān in more than seventy places because of its great importance in religion. A scholar said that all good deeds have a known reward except patience, whose reward cannot be bounded: "The patient will be paid their reward without reckoning" [39:10]. God mentions eight honours for the patient. The first is love: "God loves the patient" [3:146]. The second is support: "God is with the patient" [2:153]. The third is the Garden's lofty chambers: "They are rewarded with the chamber because they were patient" [25:75]. The fourth is abundant reward: "The patient will be paid

their reward without reckoning.” The remaining four occur in this passage: glad tidings, “Give glad tidings to the patient”; blessing, mercy and guidance, “Upon them are blessings and mercy from their Lord; it is they who are rightly guided.”

Patience has four forms. Patience with affliction prevents the soul from resentment, panic and anguish. Patience with blessings binds them with gratitude and prevents arrogance and self-exaltation through them. Patience in obedience consists in preserving and continually practising it. Patience against sins restrains the self from them.

Above patience is surrender (التسليم): abandoning outward objection and resentment, and inward aversion. Above surrender is contentment with the decree (الرضا بالقضاء), the soul’s joy in God’s action. This arises from love, for whatever the beloved does is beloved. Here ends his statement.

Having mentioned the Kaʿba and commanded people to face it, the Real appropriately mentions al-Ṣafā and al-Marwa, near it and joined to it in religious observance. The Companions hesitated to go between them because an idol named Isāf stood upon al-Ṣafā and another named Nāʾila upon al-Marwa. They feared that going between them might honour the idols. God removed that apprehension:

2:158 · Al-Ṣafā and al-Marwa: the rites and their inward allusion

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 188–189

إِنَّ الصَّفا وَالْمَرْوَةَ مِنْ شَعائِرِ اللَّهِ فَمَنْ حَجَّ الْبَيْتَ أَوِ اعْتَمَرَ فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْهِ أَنْ يَطَّوَّفَ بِهِما وَمَنْ تَطَوَّعَ خَيْراً فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ شاكِرٌ عَلِيمٌ (158)

158. Al-Ṣafā and al-Marwa are among God’s ritual signs. Whoever makes the pilgrimage to the House or performs the lesser pilgrimage incurs no blame in going between them. Whoever freely does good—God is Appreciative, Knowing.

Language · The two hills, ritual signs and voluntary goodness

I say: *al-ṣafā* (الصفا), in its original usage, is the plural of *ṣafāt*, a hard, smooth rock: *ṣafāt/ṣafā*, like *ḥaṣāt/ḥaṣā* ("pebble/pebbles"), *qaṭāt/qaṭā* ("sandgrouse") and *nawāt/nawā* ("date-stone/date-stones"). It is also said to be singular, with the dual *ṣafwān* and plural *aṣfāʾ*. *Marwa* means soft stone; its plurals are *marw* and *marwāt*, like *tamra/tamr/tamarāt* ("date/dates"). Here the two names denote two hills in Mecca.

"God's ritual signs" (شعائر الله) means the distinguishing marks of His religion. *Shaʿāʾir* is the plural of *shaʿīra* or *shiʿāra*. A *shaʿīra* is anything marking an offering by which one draws near to God: supplication, prayer, performance of an obligation or a sacrificial animal. In language, pilgrimage (الحج) means intending or making for something; the lesser pilgrimage (العمرة), visiting. In revealed usage they came predominantly to denote the two particular acts of worship.

The two brothers and Khalaf read *yaṭṭawwaʿ*, an imperfect verb jussive in its expressed form (مجزوم اللفظ), corresponding to "that he go between them." Its original form is *yataṭawwaʿ*: the tāʾ is assimilated to the ṭāʾ because their points of articulation are close. The others read a past tense, jussive in syntactic position (مجزوم المحل), corresponding to "whoever makes pilgrimage to the House."[B095]

Blame (الجناح) means sin, from *janaḥa*, "to incline," as though the sinner inclined from truth to falsehood. "Good" qualifies an omitted verbal noun, or stands in the accusative through omission of a preposition (إسقاط الخافض).

Outward commentary · A rite of pilgrimage and disagreement over its legal status

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: going between al-Ṣafā and al-Marwa belongs to the signs of His religion and the rites of His pilgrimage. Whoever makes for the House for the greater or lesser pilgrimage incurs no blame in going between them. The two idols formerly upon them in pagan times do not harm him, for God effaced that through Islam. Whoever freely performs something good for God—a greater or lesser pilgrimage, prayer or another act—God appreciates his action and makes his reward abundant.

There is disagreement over this rite's ruling. Mālik and al-Shāfiʿī call it an integral pillar (ركن), not repairable by a sacrificial offering. Abū Ḥanīfa calls it an obligation (فرض) repairable by an offering. Aḥmad calls it a Sunna. And God Most High knows best.[B096]

Spiritual allusion · Purifying spirit and soul

Al-Ṣafā and al-Marwa allude to the pure spirit and the gentle, wholesome soul. Attending to their purification and refinement is among the Path's signs; through them one travels to the very source of realization. Whoever makes for the House of the presence, for the spirit's pilgrimage through effacement in the Essence or the soul's lesser pilgrimage through effacement in the Attributes, incurs no blame in going round them and drinking their cup until he is absent from sensing them. Whoever freely does good by offering his spirit to God and becoming absent from it in witnessing his Master—God appreciates his action, spreads his excellence, manifests his goodness and takes charge of his affairs. God possesses tremendous bounty.

Having spoken of changing the prayer-direction in answer to the Jews and others denying abrogation, the Real returns to reproaching them for concealing the truth:

2:159–162 · Concealing revealed guidance and the responsibilities of knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 189–190

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَكْتُمُونَ ما أَنْزَلْنا مِنَ الْبَيِّناتِ وَالْهُدى مِنْ بَعْدِ ما بَيَّنَّاهُ لِلنَّاسِ فِي الْكِتابِ أُولئِكَ يَلْعَنُهُمُ اللَّهُ وَيَلْعَنُهُمُ اللاَّعِنُونَ (159) إِلاَّ الَّذِينَ تابُوا وَأَصْلَحُوا وَبَيَّنُوا فَأُولئِكَ أَتُوبُ عَلَيْهِمْ وَأَنَا التَّوَّابُ الرَّحِيمُ (160) إِنَّ

الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَماتُوا وَهُمْ كُفَّارٌ أُولئِكَ عَلَيْهِمْ لَعْنَةُ اللَّهِ وَالْمَلائِكَةِ وَالنَّاسِ أَجْمَعِينَ (161) خالِدِينَ فِيها لا يُخَفَّفُ عَنْهُمُ الْعَذابُ وَلا هُمْ يُنْظَرُونَ (162)

159. Those who conceal the clear proofs and guidance We sent down, after We made them plain to people in the Book—God curses them, and those who curse curse them, 160. except those who repent, make amends and make things clear. To them I turn in mercy; I am the Ever-Returning, the Merciful. 161. Those who disbelieve and die as unbelievers—upon them is the curse of God, the angels and all people, 162. abiding therein. Their punishment is not lightened, nor are they granted respite.

Language · The antecedent of "therein"

I say: the pronoun in "therein" refers to the curse or to the Fire. Referring to the latter before mentioning it magnifies its importance and the terror of its affair.

Outward commentary · Repentance requires repairing and disclosing

The Real, glorious is His majesty, speaks of the Jewish scholars who concealed the Messenger's description: those who conceal what We sent down in their Book concerning Muḥammad—God bless him and grant him peace—the clear signs about him, the account of his qualities, city and revealed law, and the guidance showing that following him and believing in him is obligatory, after We made it plain to people in the Torah: God curses these concealers and drives them from the court of His mercy. Jinn, human beings and all who can curse, including angels and others, curse them.

Except those who repent of concealment and everything requiring repentance, repair the religion they corrupted by making good what was lost, and disclose what they concealed. To them I turn in mercy and show compassion: I abundantly accept repentance and pour forth mercy. But those who die in unbelief without repenting bear God's curse and that of all whose curse counts, angels and human beings. They abide in the curse or in the Fire. Their punishment is not lightened for an hour, nor are they reprieved from it, or given time to offer excuses or ransom.

Spiritual allusion · Corrupt scholars and repentance from venal judgement

What is said of the Jewish scholars may likewise be said of this community's evil scholars: those possessed by the carrion of this world and captive to desire, who take bribes for judgements, conceal the well-established and manifest ruling, and judge according to their own appetites. Those who curse curse them. Concerning this Ibn al-Mubārak says:

> What corrupted religion but kings,
> evil scholars and its monks?
> They sold their souls, yet gained no profit;
> their price in the sale was not high.
> The people have grazed upon carrion
> whose stench is plain to anyone of reason.

Yaḥyā ibn Muʿādh al-Rāzī used to tell the scholars of his time: "Scholars! Your houses are Hāmān's, your garments Qārūn's, your mounts Pharaoh's and your banquets Goliath's. Where, then, is the Muḥammadan Sunna?" Except those who repent, repair what they corrupted and disclose what they concealed: God turns to them in mercy.

Outward commentary · When knowledge must be disclosed or concealed

Knowledge, considered with respect to the obligation to disclose or conceal it, falls into three divisions. One must be disclosed: concealing it brings one under the verse's warning. This is knowledge of the outward Sacred Law when answering becomes individually incumbent upon the person asked, because no one else is available to give a ruling on that occurrence.

Another must be concealed: knowledge of lordship's secret (سر الربوبية), meaning the elect's realization of unity (التوحيد الخاص). It must not be divulged except to its people: one who has surrendered self and money and broken the lower self's habits. From such a person it is unlawful to withhold it when he requests it.

A third is preferably concealed: the hidden secrets of destiny. These belong to extraordinary graces (الكرامات); concealing them is recommended, not obligatory. And God Most High knows best.

Here the reproach addressed to the Children of Israel and the discourse with them ends. It began at “Children of Israel, remember My favour which I bestowed upon you, and fulfil My covenant; I shall fulfil yours” [2:40]. Abraham and his sons were mentioned within it to prepare for the change of prayer-direction that they denied. The building of the Kaʿba and its honour were therefore explained; the discussion then led to al-Ṣafā and al-Marwa because of their close connection and proximity. Having finished reproaching them, He points them to unity, including others with them in the address:

2:163–164 · The signs of unity and the degrees of its realization

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 190–193

وَإِلٰهُكُمْ إِلٰهٌ واحِدٌ لاَ إِلٰهَ إِلاَّ هُوَ الرَّحْمنُ الرَّحِيمُ (163) إِنَّ فِي خَلْقِ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلافِ اللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهارِ وَالْفُلْكِ الَّتِي تَجْرِي فِي الْبَحْرِ بِما يَنْفَعُ النَّاسَ وَما أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ مِنَ السَّماءِ مِنْ ماءٍ فَأَحْيا بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِها وَبَثَّ فِيها مِنْ كُلِّ دَابَّةٍ وَتَصْرِيفِ الرِّيحِ وَالسَّحابِ الْمُسَخَّرِ بَيْنَ السَّماءِ وَالْأَرْضِ لَآياتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ (164)

163. Your God is one God; there is no god but He, the Compassionate, the Merciful. 164. In the creation of the heavens and the earth, the alternation of night and day, the ships that sail the sea with what benefits people, the water God sends down from heaven, reviving the earth after its death, His scattering every kind of creature upon it, the shifting of the wind, and the clouds held in service between heaven and earth, there are indeed signs for people who understand.

Language · Predicates, prepositions and the scattering of life

I say: “your God” is the subject and “one God” its predicate. “There is no god but He” confirms and reinforces the statement. “The Compassionate, the Merciful” are two further predicates, or predicates of an implied subject. *Fulk* (الفلك), ships, is treated as feminine because it means *safīna*, a vessel. *Min* in “from heaven” marks the starting point; in “of water” it explains the kind. “He scattered” is coordinated with “sent down” or “revived,” since animals flourish with rain and fertility. Scattering (البث) means spreading and dispersing. “The shifting of the winds” is their blowing from different directions.

[Translator’s print-source notes: T9]

Theology · Eight considerations leading to knowledge of the One

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: servants, your God, who deserves worship, is one God. He has no partner, peer, opposite or equal; no god but He exists, for none besides Him deserves worship. He is the Compassionate through the blessing of bringing into existence (الإيجاد), the Merciful through the blessing of sustaining (الإمداد). Everything besides Him is originated and created, either a recipient of blessing or a blessing; none but He therefore merits worship.

He then establishes His existence and unity through eight considerations: the creation of the heavens as distinct, separated layers raised without pillars, with their stars, zodiacal divisions and lunar stations; the earth, with its mountains, seas, rivers, trees and kinds of fruit; the difference of night and day in length and shortness, or their alternation as one departs and another arrives; and the ships sailing the sea through His power, though they could sink beneath it, carrying what benefits people through trade and otherwise. Al-Bayḍāwī says that the intention is to reason from the sea and its conditions. Ships are particularly mentioned because they provide the means of venturing upon it and observing its marvels. They therefore precede rain and clouds, whose origin is generally from it.

Consider also the water God sends from heaven without a prior material becoming visible: power brings it forth from the unseen realm, newly come from God. Hence the Prophet used to expose himself to rain, turning his face towards it when it fell to receive its blessing. Through it the Real re-

vives the earth after death and dryness, with vegetation, blossoms, varieties of flowers and fruit; and He scatters upon it every kind of creature, from ant to elephant.[B097]

Consider the winds' shifting and blowing from different directions—the four quarters and between them—with different qualities: fertilizing trees, barren or intensely cold, bringing victory or destruction. Consider the clouds subjected between heaven and earth, neither falling nor rising although natural inclination would require one of these, or subjected to the winds, which turn them about in heaven's air as God wills. In these created things are signs of His unity and resplendent power for people who understand: "Had there been gods in them other than God, both would have fallen into ruin" [21:22]. [54]

The verse urges reflection. Hence the Prophet is reported to have said: "Woe to whoever reads this verse and casts it away"—that is, does not reflect upon it. It also indicates the nobility of the knowledge of unity, both general and particular. And God Most High knows best.[B098] [55]

Spiritual allusion · Unity through proof and unity through witnessing

Al-Junayd said: "Unity is a meaning in which traces disappear and sciences are enfolded, and God is as He has ever been." I say: this is the particular realization of unity, the unity of those possessing witnessing and direct vision. He then said: "Its foundations are five: setting aside temporal origination, affirming eternity,

leaving companions, parting from homelands, and forgetting what one knew and did not know." I say: "leaving companions" means those who do not help one travel. As for companions who help one, one cannot dispense with them.

54. Cairo editor, C191.1: A ṣirr or ṣarṣar wind is intensely cold.
55. Cairo editor, C191.2: This hadith was not related concerning this verse. It concerns the Most High's words, "In the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the alternation of night and day, there are signs for people of understanding" (Āl ʿImrān, 3:190). Ibn Ḥibbān included a longer version in his Ṣaḥīḥ, from Lady ʿĀ'isha, God be pleased with her (al-Iḥsān, Book of Heart-Softening Traditions, Chapter on Repentance, 2:102).

Know that creatures' affirmation of God's unity has three degrees. First is the generality's unity, which protects life and property and delivers one from abiding for ever in the Fire: denying partners and equals, consort and children, likenesses and opposites.

Second is the elect's unity: seeing every action issue from God alone and witnessing this through unveiling, not inference. Inference is available to every believer; the elect's station is certainty in the heart through immediate knowledge (علم ضروري) requiring no proof. Its fruit is exclusive devotion to God and trust in Him alone. One hopes only in God and fears none besides Him, seeing no agent but God, discarding means and casting aside other lords.

The third degree is to see none in existence but God, and to witness no other with Him: one becomes absent from looking at created things through witnessing their Creator. This is the station of effacement (الفناء). If one is returned to witnessing the effect through God, it is called the station of subsistence (البقاء). Some of this is from Ibn Juzayy, abridged.

I say: precisely considered, there are two stations: that of people of proof and demonstration, mentioned in the verse because it is within all servants' capacity; and that of people of witnessing and direct vision, particular to rare individuals who have offered their very lives in seeking God. They sold their selves and wealth in God's way, and He gave them in this world the garden of gnoses, adding in the next the garden of adornments.

"People of proof and demonstration are the generality in relation to people of witnessing and direct vision." For those of witnessing and vision hold the Real too holy to need a proof. How should He be known through items of knowledge when through Him those items are known? How can one infer Him from what depends upon Him for its existence? Does anything other than He possess a manifestation He lacks? When was He absent, that a proof of Him should be needed? When was He distant, that effects should lead to Him? How excellent the poet's words:

> You have appeared, hidden from no one
> except one born blind, who cannot see the moon.
> Yet You are inward, veiled by what You have made appear;
> how is He seen who is concealed by might?

Another said: [56]

No place for a veil exists within Your being,
except through the secret in the words, “Look at the mountain.”
You point to Yourself, from Yourself;
Yours is a permanence expressing hidden eternity.
Through Yourself You taught this knower of You:
You are they, O life of the heart, O my hope![B099]

Love increases and decreases with the witnessing of unity. The stronger unity becomes in the heart, the stronger love grows, confined to the One. He therefore mentions love immediately after unity:

2:165–167 · Undivided love and the severing of false attachments

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 193–198

وَمِنَ النَّاسِ مَنْ يَتَّخِذُ مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ أَنْداداً يُحِبُّونَهُمْ كَحُبِّ اللَّهِ وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا أَشَدُّ حُبًّا لِلَّهِ وَلَوْ تَرَى الَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا إِذْ يَرَوْنَ الْعَذابَ أَنَّ الْقُوَّةَ لِلَّهِ جَمِيعاً وَأَنَّ اللَّهَ شَدِيدُ الْعَذابِ (165) إِذْ تَبَرَّأَ الَّذِينَ اتُّبِعُوا مِنَ الَّذِينَ اتَّبَعُوا وَرَأَوُا الْعَذابَ وَتَقَطَّعَتْ بِهِمُ الْأَسْبابُ (166) وَقالَ الَّذِينَ اتَّبَعُوا لَوْ أَنَّ لَنا كَرَّةً فَنَتَبَرَّأَ مِنْهُمْ كَما تَبَرَّؤُا مِنَّا كَذلِكَ يُرِيهِمُ اللَّهُ أَعْمالَهُمْ حَسَراتٍ عَلَيْهِمْ وَما هُمْ بِخارِجِينَ مِنَ النَّارِ (167)

165. Among people are those who take rivals apart from God, loving them as God is loved. Those who believe are stronger in love for God. If you could see the wrongdoers when they see the punishment, [you would know] that power belongs wholly to God and that God is severe in punishment! 166. When those who were followed disown their followers, they see the punishment and the bonds between them are severed. 167. The followers

56. Cairo editor, C193.1: He is al-Shushtarī.

say, “Could we but return, we would disown them as they have disowned us!” Thus God shows them their deeds as regrets weighing upon them. They will not emerge from the Fire.

Language · Rivals and the relation between knowledge and love

I say: another possible connection is that, having mentioned the proofs of unity, the Real mentions those who turn away after their clarity and associate others with Him, to introduce what He has prepared for them of punishment. Rivals (الأنداد) is the plural of *nidd*, an equal; here it means idols or leaders. “As God is loved” annexes the verbal noun to its object (إضافة المصدر إلى مفعوله). Love is the heart’s inclination towards the beloved; it will be discussed under the spiritual allusion, God willing.

Outward commentary · A love that does not change with adversity

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: some people take likenesses and equals apart from God—idols and leaders—loving and obeying them as they love God. They thus place the Most High, the Great, and a lowly, contemptible manufactured thing on equal terms in love. Those who believe in God and affirm His unity are stronger in love for Him. Believers do not turn from their Beloved in hardship or ease. Unbelievers, by contrast, worship their objects in ease but take refuge in God when affliction descends: “Then, when harm touches you, to Him you cry” [16:53]. Believers also worship God without an intermediary, whereas unbelievers worship Him through idols: “We worship them only that they may bring us nearer to God” [39:3]. Moreover, believers worship one Lord, and their love is consequently united.

Saʿīd ibn Jubayr said: “On the Day of Resurrection God commands those who worshipped idols to enter the Fire with their idols. Knowing that they will remain there, they refuse. Then, before the unbelievers, He tells the believers, ‘If you are My beloved, enter!’ They plunge into the Fire, and a caller beneath the Throne calls, ‘Those who believe are stronger in love for God.’” Concerning this Ibn al-Fāriḍ says:[B100]

> You are my beloved, whether time deals well or ill;
> be as you wish: I remain that faithful friend.

He also says: [57]

> Were he, in proud disdain, to say, “Stand upon the glowing embers,”
> I would stand in obedience, without hesitation.

Another said:

> Were You to decree my punishment in Fire,
> I would enter willingly into its midst.
> If Hell meant Your good pleasure with me,
> that Hell would be nothing but bliss.

Spiritual allusion · Definitions of love and the heart seized by God

Love (المحبة) is an enduring inclination of an enraptured heart; or watching over the Beloved in presence and absence; or the heart’s agreement with the Lord’s will; or fearing to abandon service while maintaining reverence; or counting much from oneself as little and little from one’s Beloved as much; or embracing obedience and separating from opposition. Al-Shiblī said: “It is to be jealous for the Beloved that someone like you should love Him.” The true lover is one over whose heart none but the Beloved has authority, and who has no will apart from His.

Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan said: “Love is God’s seizure of His believing servant’s heart away from everything besides Him. You see the soul inclined to obey Him, the intellect fortified by knowledge of His goodness, the spirit seized in His presence, and the innermost secret submerged in witnessing Him. The servant asks for increased love and is increased, and is opened to what is sweeter than the delight of intimate converse. He is clothed in robes of nearness upon the carpet of nearness, and touches the virgin realities and the previously known sciences. Hence it is said: God’s friends are brides, and criminals do not see the brides …” Here ends the quoted portion of his words.[B101]

57. Cairo editor, C194.1: Ghaḍā is a tree whose wood is among the hardest woods; its embers remain for a long time without going out.

Spiritual allusion · Love through beneficence and love through unveiled beauty

Know that the servant's love for his Master has two causes. The first is considering God's beneficence towards him and the many kinds of grace bestowed upon him. Hearts are naturally fashioned to love whoever treats them well. This is called love of inclination (حب الهوى), and is acquired: a person is immersed in God's beneficences and can reflect upon them. Each grace among God's innumerable, uncountable graces that he beholds is like a seed planted in his good, pure heart. He continues to behold grace after grace, each greater than the preceding one. For as he considers the graces, his heart is illuminated and his faith increases; subtleties of grace previously hidden are unveiled, their concealed aspects appear, and his love grows. [58]

The second cause is the lifting of veils and removal of obstacles from the heart's eye, until it sees the Real's beauty and perfection. Beauty is naturally loved. These are the two intended by Rābiʿa al-ʿAdawiyya:

> I love You with two loves: love of inclination,
> and a love because You are worthy of it.
> As for the love of inclination,
> it is my occupation with remembering You to the exclusion of others.
> As for the love of which You are worthy,
> it is Your lifting the veils until I see You.
> No praise in this or that is mine;
> Yours is the praise in this and that.

She reserves worthiness for love arising from witnessing beauty, although He is worthy of both, because this love proceeds from Him to Him without the servant's acquisition. The other involves acquisition, and the servant's action is subject to defect. "My occupation with remembering You to the exclusion of others" expresses an effect in place of its cause (التعبير بالمسبب عن السبب): its full sense is "its fruit is my occupation with remembering You to the exclusion of others." This is an effect of love for our own sake. "Your lifting the veils until I see You" expresses a cause in place of its effect (التعبير بالسبب عن المسبب): its expanded sense is "its cause is Your lifting the veils until

58. Cairo editor, C195.1: The Shurayshiyya is by Shaykh Aḥmad ibn Muḥammad al-Bakrī al-Shurayshī; its commentator is Aḥmad ibn Yūsuf al-Fāsī.

I saw You with the eyes of my heart." [Translator's note: Cairo I:195 prints فبسببه ("through/because of it"). The cited commentary, Aḥmad b. Yūsuf al-Fāsī's commentary on the Rāʾiyya (Cairo, 1316 AH), p. 154, reads فسببه ومنشؤه, "its cause and origin." The translation follows the cited source's clear causal construction; the different Cairo reading is expressly recorded.][B102]

"No praise …" tells us that both loves in reality proceed from Him, are directed to Him and are through Him. Considered in reality, she acquires neither; He is both the Praiser and the Praised. Everyone possessing spiritual taste necessarily apprehends the difference between these stations—love arising from witnessing beneficence and love arising from witnessing beauty—and knows that the second is stronger. This is stated in the commentary on the *Sharīshiyya*.

Ibn Juzayy says: know that the servant's love for his Lord has two degrees. The first is the general love of which no believer is altogether devoid; it is obligatory. The second is the particular love belonging to divinely instructed scholars, friends of God and the purified. It is the highest station and the ultimate object sought. The righteous people's other stations—fear, hope, trust and so forth—rest upon the lower self's shares. One who fears fears for himself; one who hopes hopes for his own benefit. Love, by contrast, is for the Beloved's sake, and is not an exchange.

Know that love of God is caused by knowledge of Him. It strengthens in proportion to knowledge and weakens as knowledge weakens. One or both of two things brings love about; in God Most High both are certainly united with utmost perfection.

The first is loveliness and beauty; the second, beneficence and gracious treatment. Beauty is naturally loved: a person necessarily loves whatever he finds beautiful. No beauty resembles God's beauty in His consummate wisdom, wondrous handiwork and beautiful, radiantly luminous Attributes, which enchant intellects and gladden hearts. His beauty is perceived by inward insight, not bodily sight.

As for beneficence, hearts naturally love whoever does good to them. God's beneficence towards His servants is unceasing, His blessings outward and inward: "If you count God's blessing, you will not enumerate it" [14:34;

16:18]. It suffices that He does good to the obedient and disobedient, believer and unbeliever. Every beneficence attributed to another is in reality from Him alone; He alone therefore deserves love.

When love of God takes firm hold in the heart, its effects appear upon the limbs: diligence in obedience, eagerness for service, care to please Him, delight in intimate converse, contentment with His decree, longing to meet Him, intimacy with His remembrance, estrangement from others, flight from people, solitude in retreats, the world's departure from the heart, love for whatever and whomever God loves, and preference for Him over all besides Him.

Al-Ḥārith al-Muḥāsibī said: "Love is your inclining wholly towards the Beloved, then preferring Him to your self and spirit, then agreeing with Him secretly and openly, then knowing your shortcoming in loving Him."

Spiritual allusion · Ibn ʿAjība's qualification: gnosis is beyond love with a remaining veil

I say: the apparent implication is that love is higher than gnosis (المعرفة). Precisely considered, however, gnosis is higher than every station, since with it no remnant of the veil remains at all. Love may coexist with a remaining veil. Do you not see that the lover feels estranged from creation, whereas the gnostic feels estranged from nothing, knowing Him in everything?

The *Ḥikam* says: "Worshippers and renunciants feel estranged from everything only because they are absent from God in everything. Had they known God in everything, they would have felt estranged from nothing." The gnostic also possesses more perfect courtesy than the lover, for gnosis is attained only after refinement and training have become complete, whereas love may arise before refinement is complete. Nevertheless, gnosis is love's goal and culmination. And God Most High knows best.

The Real then mentions the threat against one who, after the clarity of the proof of His unity, associates another with God in worship or love:

Qur'ānic continuation · 2:165b

وَلَوْ تَرَى الَّذِينَ ظَلَمُوا إِذْ يَرَوْنَ الْعَذَابَ أَنَّ الْقُوَّةَ لِلَّهِ جَمِيعًا وَأَنَّ اللَّهَ شَدِيدُ الْعَذَابِ

If you could see the wrongdoers when they see the punishment, [you would know] that power belongs wholly to God and that God is severe in punishment!

Language · An omitted consequence and deeds made visible

I say: *law* is conditional; *tarā* is its protasis. Nāfiʿ, Ibn ʿĀmir and Yaʿqūb read the verb as an address to the Prophet or every listener, "if you saw." The others read it in the third person, referring it to the wrongdoer, the intended recipient of the threat and warning. *Idh* is an adverbial expression qualifying the seeing, and *yarawna* occupies the genitive position through annexation (خفض بالإضافة). Ibn ʿĀmir reads the verb passively, with initial ḍamma: "when they are shown." God is the true agent, as "God shows them" indicates. The others read the active form, with initial fatḥa, like "when the wrongdoers see the punishment" [16:85].

"That power …" is governed by an omitted consequence (الجواب المحذوف), suppressed to magnify its importance: if you, Muḥammad—or you who listen—saw the wrongdoers when they see the punishment, or God shows it to them, you would see something dreadful and a tremendous affair, and know that power belongs wholly to God. "Wholly" is a circumstantial qualifier (حال): power belongs to Him in its entirety. Abū Jaʿfar and Yaʿqūb read *inna* with kasra in both places as a fresh statement. "When those who were followed disown …" substitutes for "when they see."

The bonds (الأسباب) are the covenants and connections upon which their worldly affection depended. Originally a *sabab* is anything through which something is reached: a rope used to ascend is so called, as is a road. The poet says:

Whoever fears the means of death will meet it,
though he seek the pathways of heaven by a ladder. [59]

"Regrets" (حسرات) is a circumstantial qualifier if "shows" means bodily seeing, according to the People of the Sunna; or a third object if it means causing to know, according to the Muʿtazila, who deny deeds' taking concrete form.[B103]

Outward commentary · Followers and leaders disown one another

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: if you, Muḥammad—or anyone capable of seeing—saw the condition of those who wronged themselves by taking equals and idols after clear evidence and radiant proof, when punishment surrounds them, its guardians overpower them and the Fire snatches them up, you would see something dreadful and a tremendous affair, and know that power belongs wholly to God. Or: if the wrongdoers saw the punishment prepared for their association of others with God, they would behold a tremendous affair and be certain that power belongs wholly to God and His punishment is severe.

This occurs when those followed—the leaders—disown their followers, the weak and insignificant, while beholding the dreadful punishment. The bonds of affection and connection that joined them in this world are severed, and their affection turns to enmity. Those weak people who followed their devils in unbelief and error say, "If only we could return to the world, we would disown our leaders as they have disowned us today." In a manner like that terrible showing, God shows them their deeds as regrets and remorse. They enter the Fire abidingly and never emerge from it.

Spiritual allusion · Companionship whose consequences appear at the end

You who turn towards your Master, making your Lord's love your aim and hope and associating no other with your Beloved in love: if you saw those who wrong themselves by following desire and joining another to God in love through pursuing worldly shares, when they see their own abasement and distance, and what God has prepared for people of love and affection—nearness to the Beloved and witnessing the beauty of the Near—you would

59. Cairo editor, C197.1: He is Zuhayr ibn Abī Sulmā.

see a tremendous affair. You would know that all power belongs to God: He brings whom He wills near through His bounty and mercy, and sets whom He wills far through His justice and wisdom.

The great in wrongdoing then disown the lesser; companions and kin are separated, except those joined in love of the Beloved and helping one another obey the Near, Responsive One: “Close friends that day will be enemies to one another, except the God-fearing” [43:67]. “Do not accompany one whose state does not raise you and whose speech does not direct you to God.” Whoever accompanies the heedless or rests upon worldly people must see this as regrets on the Resurrection Day, when remorse is useless and the foot has slipped. How excellent the author of the *ʿAyniyya*:

> Part from those you joined in heedless days;
> only one severed [from the Beloved] keeps company with reproachers.
> Avoid the stranger’s company, even if close kinship
> makes him your bedfellow in sleep.
> From its companions the soul takes every affinity;
> from the heart’s friendship come these dispositions.[B104]

Having warned against manifest and hidden association, the Real warns against following the associators in declaring things forbidden or permitted without a ruling of the Sacred Law:

2:168–169 · Lawful nourishment and the footsteps of the adversary

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 198–200

يا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ كُلُوا مِمَّا فِي الْأَرْضِ حَلالاً طَيِّباً وَلا تَتَّبِعُوا خُطُواتِ الشَّيْطانِ إِنَّهُ لَكُمْ عَدُوٌّ مُبِينٌ (168) إِنَّما يَأْمُرُكُمْ بِالسُّوءِ وَالْفَحْشاءِ وَأَنْ تَقُولُوا عَلَى اللَّهِ ما لا تَعْلَمُونَ (169)

168. O people, eat of what is lawful and wholesome upon the earth, and do not follow Satan's footsteps. He is a manifest enemy to you. 169. He commands you only to evil and indecency, and to say about God what you do not know.

Language · The plural khuṭuwāt and the meanings of evil

I say: "lawful" is a circumstantial qualifier or direct object; "wholesome" qualifies it. Footsteps (الخطوات) is the plural of *khuṭwa*. With fatḥa, *khaṭwa* is the verbal noun of stepping; with ḍamma, it names the distance between the feet. Its broken plural is *khuṭā*, its sound plural *khuṭuwāt*. The ṭāʾ admits three vowels: ḍamma by vowel-following (الإتباع), as in *ghurufāt* and *qurubāt*. Ibn Mālik says:

> In a triliteral noun whose middle radical is sound,
> make the middle radical follow the first in its vowel.

The consonant may be quiescent, preserving its form in the singular, or carry fatḥa for ease. The *Alfiyya* says:

> Make quiescent the consonant following a vowel other than fatḥa,
> or lighten it with fatḥa: both have been transmitted.

The mutawātir readings have ḍamma or sukūn, and an anomalous reading has fatḥa.[B105]

Al-Khalīl said: "Satan's footsteps are his traces and paths: do not imitate him." Evil (السوء) originally means anything that distresses and saddens its possessor. Indecency (الفحشاء) is what is ugly in speech or deed, a verbal noun from *faḥusha*, like *baʾsāʾ*, *ḍarrāʾ* and *laʾwāʾ*.

Ibn ʿAbbās said that indecency is what incurs a prescribed penalty (حد), and evil what does not. Muqātil said every mention of indecency in the Qurʾān means illicit intercourse except "Satan promises you poverty and commands you to indecency" [2:268], where it means miserliness. Al-Bayḍāwī says evil and indecency are what reason rejects and revealed law judges ugly. They are coordinated because their descriptions differ: an act is evil through the distress it causes a rational person and indecent through his finding it ugly. Another view makes evil embrace all ugly acts and indecency those exceeding the ordinary degree of ugliness.

Outward commentary · Neither invent prohibitions nor attribute them to God

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: people, eat from all We created for you upon the earth—its plants that are pleasant to eat and its animals except those We forbade—provided it is lawful, released from liabilities and free of doubts, and wholesome, agreeable to nature and approved by the Sacred Law. Do not follow Satan's paths by forbidding through your own opinion what God permitted: the *baḥīra*, *sāʾiba*, *waṣīla* and *ḥām*, and crops assigned to idols. Satan makes this attractive; he is your manifest enemy, and deception and delusion are an enemy's business.[B106]

He commands only sins that disfigure your faces, ugly acts and faults that bring you to ruin, and speech about God without knowledge: permitting the forbidden, forbidding the permitted, or claiming a child or consort for the Most Great, Most High.

Spiritual allusion · The body's food and the spirit's nourishment

Know that the Real has appointed nourishment and enjoyment for human bodily nature, and nourishment and delight for the spirit. Bodily nourishment is food and drink; its enjoyment is clothing, marriage and mounts. The spirit's nourishment is certainty, knowledge and lights; its enjoyment is witnessing, insight and ascent in gnoses and secrets. As the lower self eats what is lawful and wholesome upon earth, so does the spirit. The former's eating is sensory; the latter's is inward: reflection and taking heed, or witnessing and insight. Al-Majdhūb says:

> Creation is blossom,
> and I have grazed among them.
> They are the greatest veil;
> among them is the entrance.

Al-Shushtarī says:

> The very press of the crowd
> is the road to our quarter.

Our masters' master, Sīdī ʿAlī, used to say: "Whoever wishes to taste should go to the market." Crowding is to be expected there, and for the strong therein lies complete gain. They are told: people perfected in humanity, eat

of what is upon earth with your spirits and secrets, through witnessing and reflection, lawfully and wholesomely. Do not follow Satan's footsteps by stopping at created things' outward appearances and being veiled from witnessing and direct vision. He appears to you as a manifest enemy, but in reality drives you towards rootedness and establishment: whenever his prompting stirs you, you flee to your Lord to repel him, until He establishes you in His presence.

Satan commands only what distresses your faces and saddens your hearts: departing from witnessing the beloved and standing behind the door, and saying about God what is neither true nor right, such as affirming an other or turning towards desire. And God Most High knows best.

The Real informs us that some whose wretchedness has preceded do not leave their desire or answer one who calls them:

2:170 · Inherited custom and the refusal of guidance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 200–201

وَإِذا قِيلَ لَهُمُ اتَّبِعُوا ما أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ قالُوا بَلْ نَتَّبِعُ ما أَلْفَيْنا عَلَيْهِ آباءَنا أَوَلَوْ كانَ آباؤُهُمْ لا يَعْقِلُونَ شَيْئاً وَلا يَهْتَدُونَ (170)

170. When they are told, "Follow what God has sent down," they say, "Rather, we follow what we found our fathers following." Even though their fathers understood nothing and were not guided?

Language · The antecedent and the two objects of alfa

I say: "them" refers to those taking rivals apart from God, or to the people addressed by "O people," or to the Jews mentioned earlier. *Alfā* means found and takes two objects: here "our fathers" and the prepositional phrase, meaning "we follow in religion that upon which we found our fathers established."

Outward commentary · Ancestry does not establish the truth of a practice

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when these associators among the Arab unbelievers are told to follow what God revealed to His Messenger—unity, abandoning equals and likenesses for Him, forbidding the forbidden and permitting the lawful—they reply: rather, we follow what we found our fathers following, worshipping idols and committing sins. The Real says: do they follow them blindly and imitatively even though their fathers were ignorant, understanding nothing of religion and not reflecting upon the rightly guided path?

Ibn ʿAbbās reports that the Prophet called the Jews to Islam and encouraged them to accept it. Rāfiʿ ibn Khārija and Mālik ibn ʿAwf replied: "Rather, we follow what we found our fathers following: they were better and more knowledgeable than we are." God then revealed this verse.

Spiritual allusion · Inherited desire and the obligation to oppose it

When someone absorbed in worldly life, taking desire as his god and joining another to God in love, is told, "Leave your shares and appetites, direct yourself wholly towards your Master, and follow God's revelation requiring opposition to desire and love of the Master," he replies: "Rather, I follow what I found my fathers and ancestors following, and what most people pursue." He is asked: will you follow them in pursuing desire even though they understood nothing

of the paths of guidance? The Prophet is reported to have said: "None of you believes until his desire follows what I have brought."[B107]

The Real sets forth a likeness for one whom following desire has deafened and blinded:

2:171 · Hearing a call without understanding it

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 201–202

وَمَثَلُ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا كَمَثَلِ الَّذِي يَنْعِقُ بِما لا يَسْمَعُ إِلاَّ دُعاءً وَنِداءً صُمٌّ بُكْمٌ عُمْيٌ فَهُمْ لا يَعْقِلُونَ (171)

171. The likeness of those who disbelieve is that of one who cries out to what hears nothing but a call and a shout. Deaf, dumb and blind, they do not understand.

Language · An omitted term or an unexpressed relation

I say: “the likeness …” may involve an omitted annexed noun (حذف مضاف): “the likeness of the admonisher of those who disbelieve.” Or no such supplied term is needed, as will be explained. *Naʿaqa*—patterned like *ḍaraba*, with verbal nouns *naʿq* and *naʿīq*—means to cry out or drive away by shouting.

Outward commentary · Three explanations of the shepherd’s likeness

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the likeness of one admonishing unbelievers and calling them to God is that of a shepherd tending animals and shouting to drive or call them. They hear the call, lift their heads without understanding it, then return to grazing. They hear only a call and a shout, not comprehending what he says. Similarly, those immersed in unbelief neither attend to a caller to unity nor comprehend his words: like animals, or more astray.

Alternatively, the likeness of unbelievers immersed in imitation and ignorance, together with one calling them to God, is that of the animals of a person shouting to them: they hear only a call and a shout and do not comprehend his words. Or unbelievers calling upon idols, which neither hear nor understand, resemble one shouting to sheep and gaining nothing from his cries but the fatigue and trouble of calling.

He then describes them figuratively as deaf, dumb and blind: deaf to hearing truth, so they do not understand it; dumb concerning speaking it; blind to observing its means, or to guidance, so they do not see it. They understand and reflect upon nothing.

Spiritual allusion · When desire makes admonition ineffective

When desire establishes itself in hearts, its cure becomes difficult, its treatment arduous and the physicians' trouble great. Admonition does not benefit those immersed in heedlessness; warning and intimidation do not succeed with them. Their admonisher resembles one calling animals that hear only a call and a shout. Desire blinds them and deafens them to hearing the means of guidance:

> Desire, wherever it rules, kills or brands with disgrace. [60]

Only preceding divine care or the blowing wind of guidance removes desire from their hearts, stirring within them a fear that shakes them, a longing that troubles them, or a light that pierces through. "That is not difficult for God" [14:20; 35:17].

Having finished admonishing and warning unbelievers, He admonishes believers:

60. Cairo editor, C201.1: His word yuṣmi means "kills," from aṣmaytu al-ṣayd, used when you shoot at game and kill it while it remains in sight. His words "or yaṣimi" mean "or disgraces," from waṣm, a defect: "So-and-so has no waṣma" means he has no defect. I say [the editor]: this is half a line whose opening is, "Turn away her desire; beware of giving it authority." The line belongs to al-Būṣīrī's poem known as the Burda.

2:172–173 · Gratitude, prohibited foods and necessity

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 202–203

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا كُلُوا مِنْ طَيِّباتِ ما رَزَقْناكُمْ وَاشْكُرُوا لِلَّهِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ إِيَّاهُ تَعْبُدُونَ (172) إِنَّما حَرَّمَ عَلَيْكُمُ الْمَيْتَةَ وَالدَّمَ وَلَحْمَ الْخِنْزِيرِ وَما أُهِلَّ بِهِ لِغَيْرِ اللَّهِ فَمَنِ اضْطُرَّ غَيْرَ باغٍ وَلا عادٍ فَلا إِثْمَ عَلَيْهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (173)

172. O you who believe, eat of the good things We have provided for you, and give thanks to God, if it is He alone you worship. 173. He has forbidden you only carrion, blood, swine's flesh and that over which a name other than God's has been invoked. Whoever is compelled by necessity, neither seeking it nor exceeding the bounds, incurs no sin. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language · Compulsion, wrongdoing and transgression

I say: *uḍṭurra* (اضطر), "is compelled," was originally *uḍturira*, on the pattern *iftaʿala*, from harm (الضرر). The tāʾ becomes ṭāʾ because their articulation is close. The *Alfiyya* says:

> Change the tāʾ of *iftiʿāl* to ṭāʾ after an emphatic consonant.

The first rāʾ then loses its vowel and is assimilated to the second. Abū Jaʿfar reads the ṭāʾ with kasra wherever the word occurs, transferring the rāʾ's vowel to it. Wrongful seeking (البغي) originally means aiming at corruption: *baghā al-jarḥ* means a wound deteriorated. Hence illicit intercourse is called *bighāʾ*, and a prostitute *baghiyy*. Transgression (العدوان) originally means injustice and crossing the limit, from *ʿadā, yaʿdū*, with verbal nouns *ʿudwān* and *ʿadw*.

Outward commentary · The lawful gift and the limits of a necessity-based concession

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: believers, eat of the delightful good things We have provided. Stop at what is lawful for you; do not prohibit by your own opinion what We permitted, as earlier peoples did. Thank God for His outward and inward blessing if you worship Him exclusively. We have permitted everything We created upon the earth that carries you.

We have forbidden only what harms you: carrion because of its foulness, blood because it hardens your hearts, swine's flesh because it produces a loss of protective jealousy, and that over which another name than God's has been pronounced. The last means that the voice was raised at slaughter for another than God—an idol.[B108]

Whoever is driven and compelled to one of these prohibited things, without wrongdoing by freely choosing to eat it and without crossing from lawful to forbidden while having no need of it, incurs no sin. Alternatively, "neither seeking wrongdoing" means not a highway robber; "nor transgressing," not someone separating from the community and rebelling against its united body. Thus someone travelling to sever kinship, frighten travellers or spread corruption, or an enslaved person fleeing his master, a debtor fleeing his creditor, or anyone disobedient through his journey, cannot lawfully eat these things under necessity until he repents and then eats. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Sahl ibn ʿAbd Allāh interprets "neither seeking wrongdoing" as not departing from the community, and "nor transgressing" as not an innovator opposing the Sunna. He thus grants the innovator no concession to consume prohibited things in necessity.[B109]

Spiritual allusion · Necessity without attachment to the world

You who believe with the faith of people of gnosis, eat the good things We have provided—the sweetness of witnessing and direct vision—and thank the Generous, Gracious God, if you single Him out in worship and excellence. Or: you who believe with the faith of the pure and observe the limits like people of fidelity, eat what We have provided from the gardens of knowledge. Thank God, and He will increase you in gifts and understanding, if you worship the Living, the Self-Subsisting.

He forbids you only what obstructs these gifts or lowers you from the platforms of those ranks: inclining to the world's carrion, resting in the pursuit of desire, taking from the world what was intended for another than God, or receiving it from another hand than God's. Whoever is compelled to take something of its impurity, taking only what he needs without looking towards more, intending neither appetite nor enjoyment, incurs no sin. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Our masters' master, Sīdī ʿAlī al-Jamal, speaking of one enriched through God, said: "His mark is that he leaves the world to creation, claiming no right alongside them except what remains after them when necessity and need compel him. He leaves the hereafter to his Master, claiming no right there except looking upon God's Face. He leaves his own self to God, claiming in it no right except his Master's right, with no will except what his Master wills. He is like a supple branch: wherever the wind bends it, it yields and bends with it. He objects to no condition of creatures."

Among things joined to these prohibitions are bribes and consuming people's wealth falsely. God therefore mentions this after what He has permitted believers:

2:174–176 · Trading revelation for gain and the divided heart

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 203–205

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَكْتُمُونَ ما أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ مِنَ الْكِتابِ وَيَشْتَرُونَ بِهِ ثَمَناً قَلِيلاً أُولئِكَ ما يَأْكُلُونَ فِي بُطُونِهِمْ إِلاَّ النَّارَ وَلا يُكَلِّمُهُمُ اللَّهُ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ وَلا يُزَكِّيهِمْ وَلَهُمْ عَذابٌ أَلِيمٌ (174) أُولئِكَ الَّذِينَ اشْتَرَوُا الضَّلالَةَ بِالْهُدى وَالْعَذابَ بِالْمَغْفِرَةِ فَما أَصْبَرَهُمْ عَلَى النَّارِ (175) ذلِكَ بِأَنَّ اللَّهَ نَزَّلَ الْكِتابَ بِالْحَقِّ وَإِنَّ الَّذِينَ اخْتَلَفُوا فِي الْكِتابِ لَفِي شِقاقٍ بَعِيدٍ (176)

174. Those who conceal what God has sent down of the Book and exchange it for a small price consume nothing in their bellies but fire. God will not speak to them on the Resurrection Day or purify them; theirs is a painful punishment. 175. They have bought error at the price of guidance, and punishment at the price of forgiveness. How enduring they are of the Fire! 176. That is because God sent down the Book in truth. Those who differ concerning the Book are indeed far gone in discord.

Language · An expression of wonder or a reproachful question

I say: *mā* is exclamatory (تعجبية), an indefinite subject whose use at the beginning is licensed by the sense of wonder. The clause *aṣbarahum* is its predicate: what a tremendous thing has made them so enduring! Or it is interrogative: what has induced them to endure the Fire?

Outward commentary · What is gained by concealment becomes punishment

The Real, glorious is His majesty, speaks about Jewish leaders and scholars. They received gifts and levies from the common people and claimed that the awaited prophet would arise from among them. When our Prophet Muḥammad was sent, they feared losing their livelihood and leadership. God therefore revealed: those who conceal the description of Muḥammad that God sent down in the Torah, distort its meaning and remove it from the Book, exchanging this distortion for a small price—a contemptible compensation that soon passes away—eat nothing but Hellfire in their bellies. This is their eventual destination and the punishment for their eating.

God does not speak to them, to abase them and manifest anger against them, when He speaks to His friends and greets them. He does not purify them from their sins' pollution so that they may become fit for the presence. They have a painful, grievous punishment. They sold guidance to buy error, and exchanged the forgiveness they would have received through believing and explaining for punishment. How bold they are in plunging into the Fire by plunging into its causes! Or: how long they remain in it! Or: what has made them endure it, abandoning truth and inclining to falsehood? This is a reproachful question.

They deserve that punishment, and have dared approach it, because God sent down the Book—the Qurʾān—clothed in truth, but they disagreed about it, believing some and rejecting some. Those who differ concerning the Book are far gone in opposition and error.

Spiritual allusion · Teaching, compensation and the dispersal of concern

Whoever conceals knowledge and spreads it only in exchange for a worldly share falls under "they exchange it for a small price" and "consume nothing in their bellies but fire." It is related that a Companion taught the People of the Bench and received a bow as a gift from one of them. He brought it to the Prophet, saying: "Messenger of God, I taught the People of the Bench, and so-and-so gave me a bow, saying it was for God." The Prophet replied: "You have hung a bow of Hellfire about yourself," or words to that effect, and commanded its return. Perhaps this belongs to scrupulousness (الورع): he wished to raise that Companion's aspiration. Otherwise, a report states: "The thing for which you have the greatest right to take payment is God's Book."[B110]

One possessed by his lower self and captive to desire has bought error at the price of guidance: deviation from the path of God's friends in exchange for the guidance he would have possessed had he mastered self and desire; the punishment of severance and veiling in exchange for forgiveness and entrance among the beloved. How enduring they are of the distress of veiling and the evil reckoning! The cause is division within the heart and dispersal of its concern and understanding. The Prophet said: "Read the Qurʾān while your hearts agree upon it; when you differ, rise and leave it," or words to that effect.

The cause of the heart's dispersion and lack of presence is love of the world. The Prophet said: "Whoever makes the world his concern, God scatters his affairs, sets his poverty between his eyes, and nothing of the world comes to him except what was allotted. Whoever makes the hereafter his intention, God gathers his affairs, places his wealth in his heart, and the world comes to him unwillingly."[B111]

A heart divided in understanding the Book and dispersed away from it is in discord far from the presence. The sign of a sound heart is its gathered attention upon God's speech, reflection on His address and pleasure in hearing it. The degrees of recitation were discussed at the sūrah's beginning; consult them. Through God is success.

When the Jews and Christians claimed that righteousness belonged particularly to their prayer-direction because it was the prophets' direction, God answered them:

2:177 · Righteousness as the perfection of inward and outward life

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 205–207

لَيْسَ الْبِرَّ أَنْ تُوَلُّوا وُجُوهَكُمْ قِبَلَ الْمَشْرِقِ وَالْمَغْرِبِ وَلكِنِ الْبِرُّ مَنْ آمَنَ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَالْمَلائِكَةِ وَالْكِتابِ وَالنَّبِيِّينَ وَآتَى الْمالَ عَلى حُبِّهِ ذَوِي الْقُرْبى وَالْيَتامى وَالْمَساكِينَ وَابْنَ السَّبِيلِ وَالسَّائِلِينَ وَفِي الرِّقابِ وَأَقامَ الصَّلاةَ وَآتَى الزَّكاةَ وَالْمُوفُونَ بِعَهْدِهِمْ إِذا عاهَدُوا وَالصَّابِرِينَ فِي الْبَأْساءِ وَالضَّرَّاءِ وَحِينَ الْبَأْسِ أُولئِكَ الَّذِينَ صَدَقُوا وَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الْمُتَّقُونَ (177)

177. Righteousness is not that you turn your faces towards east and west. Rather, righteousness is in one who believes in God, the Last Day, the angels, the Book and the prophets; gives wealth, despite loving it, to kinsfolk, orphans, the needy, the traveller, those who ask, and for freeing persons in bondage; establishes prayer and gives the purifying alms; and in those who fulfil their covenant when they covenant, and those patient in adversity, affliction and the time of battle. These are the truthful, and these are the God-fearing.

Language · The pillars of religion and the verse's constructions

I say: having mentioned unity and its proofs, the head of religion, and warned against association and its branches, the Real now mentions the remaining pillars: faith (الإيمان) and Islam. This verse gives the foundations of faith and some foundations of Islam, prayer and the purifying alms. Afterwards He mentions fasting and its rulings, pilgrimage and its pillars, then holy struggle, marriage, divorce and the waiting period, then sales and their connected question of usury, and finally testimony and pledges, with which the sūrah concludes. Discourse, however, branches out, one matter drawing another after it.

"Righteousness" and "that you turn" are the subject and predicate of *laysa*. Both are definite, the first through the article and the second through annexation, since the latter means "your turning your faces." Whoever gives priority to definiteness through the article makes "righteousness" the subject and "that you turn" the predicate: this is the majority reading. Whoever gives priority to annexation makes "righteousness" the fronted predicate and the verbal-noun clause the postponed subject: this is the reading of Ḥamza and Ḥafṣ.

In "but righteousness," whoever lightens *lakin* makes it a conjunction joining clauses. "Righteousness" is then a subject and "one who believes" its predicate, with an omitted annexed term: "the righteousness of one who believes," since an entity is not predicated of an abstract meaning. Alternatively, the expression is intentionally emphatic. Whoever doubles the nūn makes *lākinn* govern the accusative, occurring between

two clauses with corrective force (استدراكية). "Despite loving it" is a circumstantial qualifier of the wealth. "Those patient" is accusative in praise (النصب على المدح), not coordinated in the nominative, because of patience's excellence and nobility.

Outward commentary · Faith, generosity, fidelity and endurance

The Real, glorious is His majesty, answers the People of the Book: righteousness is not confined to the prayer-direction. What deserves attention is faith in God and the perfections necessary to Him; the Last Day and what follows

it; the angels and what must be believed about them; the Book sent from heaven, the Qurʾān and other scriptures; and the prophets, what is necessary to them and what is impossible concerning them.

Righteousness belongs to one who believes these matters in his heart and manifests upon his limbs what confirms that belief's soundness. Thus he possesses generosity and liberality, giving wealth while loving it. Asked what charity is best, the Prophet answered: "That you give while healthy and reluctant to part with it, hoping for wealth and fearing poverty." Or he gives wealth out of love for God, seeking neither repayment nor thanks. [B112]

He gives to needy relatives, placed first because the Prophet said: "Your charity to the needy is charity; to relatives it is two things: charity and maintaining kinship." He gives to orphans because they lack care, to the needy whom poverty has made remain in their homes, and to the wayfarer —the traveller away from home, as though the road had borne him—or the guest. He gives to those whom need drives to ask. A report says: "Give to the beggar even if he is upon his horse." Another says: "God's gift to the believer is the beggar at his door." He gives to free people from slavery or captivity.[B113]

He establishes obligatory prayer and gives the known purifying alms. Among the righteous are those fulfilling their covenants with God and with people. When they promise, they perform; when they swear or vow, they fulfil; when they speak, they tell the truth; when trusted, they discharge the trust.

I especially praise the patient in adversity—poverty, abasement and people's harm—and affliction—illness and chronic disability. Or the first means terrors, and the second bodily afflictions. They are patient at the time of battle and holy struggle. They are truthful in seeking the Real and guard against whatever cuts them off from Him or distracts them from Him. [61]

This verse encompasses all human perfections: what adorns the inward life through beliefs, what adorns the outward life through dealings, and what purifies souls from vices and clothes them in good qualities and perfections. Hence

61. Cairo editor, C206.1: Zamāna: an illness that persists.

those possessing these qualities are described as truthful and God-fearing, the two foundations of the Path and the basis of realization's secrets. Through God is success; He guides to the sound road.

Spiritual allusion · Neither the outward nor the inward may be neglected

The servant is not asked to turn towards the Real in one particular respect alone, as by turning outwardly while neglecting the inward, or inwardly while neglecting the outward. Rather, he must adorn his inward life with the lights of faith and certainty and his outward life with religion's various duties. He must purify his soul from vices—greed, miserliness, fraud, betrayal, lying, fear and anguish—and adorn it with virtues: generosity, liberality, fidelity to covenants, trustworthiness, patience, courage, chastity, contentment and every other virtue.

When he empties himself of vices and adorns himself with their opposite virtues, he deserves entrance among the righteous and becomes one of the great gnostics. These have attained sincerity in seeking and thus the goal of every quest. They truly fear God and attain the highest degrees. May God grant us an abundant share through His grace and generosity.

Having praised patience and courage in battle, God commands just retaliation, lest people extend courage's scope and dare kill a Muslim:

2:178–179 · Just retaliation, mercy and the preservation of life

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 207–209

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الْقِصاصُ فِي الْقَتْلى الْحُرُّ بِالْحُرِّ وَالْعَبْدُ بِالْعَبْدِ وَالْأُنْثى بِالْأُنْثى فَمَنْ عُفِيَ لَهُ مِنْ أَخِيهِ شَيْءٌ فَاتِّباعٌ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَأَداءٌ إِلَيْهِ بِإِحْسانٍ ذلِكَ تَخْفِيفٌ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ وَرَحْمَةٌ فَمَنِ اعْتَدى بَعْدَ ذلِكَ فَلَهُ عَذابٌ أَلِيمٌ (178) وَلَكُمْ فِي الْقِصاصِ حَياةٌ يا أُولِي الْأَلْبابِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ (179)

178. O you who believe, just retaliation is prescribed for you concerning those killed: the free for the free, the enslaved for the enslaved, and the female for the female. Whoever receives any remission from his brother, let there be pursuit according to what is right and payment to him with goodness. That is a lightening and mercy from your Lord. Whoever transgresses thereafter shall have a painful punishment. 179. In just retaliation there is life for you, people of understanding, so that you may be God-fearing.

Language · A consequence opposite to its apparent cause

I say: *ʿafā* is intransitive and takes a preposition: *ʿan* introduces the offence, and *li-* the offender. One says, “I pardoned so-and-so for his offence.” “Pursuit” is the predicate of an implied subject: the required course is pursuit according to what is right. “Life” is a subject, “in retaliation” its predicate; “for you” is a second predicate, a complement of the first, or a circumstantial qualification of its implicit pronoun.

The eloquence and rhetorical force are evident: He makes something bring about its opposite, makes retaliation definite and life indefinite to signify greatness and generality—there is for you a tremendous kind of life. Knowledge of retaliation deters a killer from killing and thus preserves two lives.

Previously people killed someone other than the killer, or a group for one person, setting strife ablaze. Retaliation against the killer spares the rest and becomes a cause of their life. Thus al-Bayḍāwī.

Outward commentary · Retaliation, remission and compensation

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: believers, retaliation concerning deliberate killing is prescribed for you; submit to it. A free person is killed for a free person, not for an enslaved person; in the latter case he pays the person's value to the owner. Its proof is the reported saying:

"A Muslim is not killed for an unbeliever, nor a free person for an enslaved person." An enslaved person is killed for another enslaved person if the slain person's owner demands it. If he spares the killer, the killer's owner chooses between surrendering him and redeeming him for the value of the slain person. Likewise, if an enslaved person kills a free person, the latter's heirs choose between killing and enslaving him. If they spare him, his owner chooses between surrendering him and redeeming him with the compensation for a free person deliberately killed. A woman is killed for a woman or a man, and a man for a woman.[B114]

Concerning the verse's specification of equivalents, Mālik said: "The best explanation I have heard is that the kind is intended—the kind 'free person'—in which male and female are equal. The woman is mentioned again for emphasis and out of concern to abolish pagan practice." That is, the article in "the free" denotes the kind, embracing male and female. The woman is repeated particularly to reject the pre-Islamic refusal of retaliation for her.

The Real then says: whoever has anything, however little, remitted concerning his brother's blood, the execution falls away. The duty is then to pursue the killer for compensation according to what is right, without harshness or unreasonable pressure; and the killer must pay with goodness, without delay or short payment. This legislation of remission and compensation is a lightening from your Lord and a mercy to you. The Jews were prescribed retaliation alone, the Christians unconditional pardon, while you, the Muḥammadan community, are given the choice between compensation and retaliation.[B115]

Whoever transgresses after receiving compensation and then kills faces painful punishment in this world and the next. In this world he is necessarily executed, according to the reported saying: “I shall not spare anyone who kills after taking compensation.”

Muslims, in legislating retaliation there is tremendous life for you in this world: a would-be killer is deterred by knowing that retaliation will be exacted. People previously killed a group for one person and were spared this through retaliation’s institution. Or there is life in the hereafter: a killer against whom retaliation is carried out here is not taken to account for it there. People of complete understanding, consider the preservation of spirits and protection of lives within this wisdom, so that you fear God in maintaining retaliation, judging by it and submitting to it—or refrain from killing out of fear of God.

Spiritual allusion · Correction of inward offences

As God appoints retaliation for sensory offences, He appoints it for inward offences: injuring one’s own soul through discourtesy towards God. Whoever commits a lapse or slip receives recompense from the Real in this world, if divine care attends him: a great offence for a great one, a small for a small.

Consider the man circumambulating the Kaʿba who looked at a woman. A hand struck him from the air and his eye was lost. He cried out and was told, “A blow for a glance; if you increase, We increase.” Consider Abū Turāb al-Nakhshabī: “My soul desired an appetite only once. Travelling, I desired bread and eggs and turned aside to a village. Someone seized me, saying he had seen me with thieves, and they struck me seventy times. A man then recognized me, took me home and served bread and eggs. I told myself: eat—after seventy blows.”[B116]

Consider Abū al-Khayr al-ʿAsqalānī: he desired fish, and when he reached to eat, a fishbone pierced his finger; his hand was lost through it. Ibrāhīm ibn Shaybān said: “I desired my fill of bread and lentils, and when they became available I ate until full. Then I saw a wrong and sought to change it. They seized me, beat me a hundred times with a stick and imprisoned me for four months, until my shaykh interceded. When I emerged, he said, ‘You received it cheaply’”—that is, punishment touched his outward, not his inward, condition.

Khayr al-Nassāj said: “I covenanted with God not to eat fresh dates. My soul overcame me and I took half a raṭl. When I ate one, a man looked at me and said, ‘Khayr, where have you escaped from me?’ He owned a slave named Khayr, and I had been made to resemble him. I remained with him several months weaving *kirbās*, white cotton cloth. Then I repented, and the resemblance left me.”

Whoever receives pardon for any such offence, before or after correction, should thank God, follow His command and perform His obligations according to what is right, without excess or neglect. This is a lightening and mercy from God. Whoever transgresses thereafter and returns to what he repented of has painful punishment: expulsion from the beloved’s presence to stand at the door or tend the animals—except one who repents and acts rightly, for God accepts repentance. In recompense in this world there is tremendous life for your spirits and secrets, people of understanding, for it is care for you, so that you guard against all that distracts you from your Master.

Retaliation is an occasion of death, and death an occasion for a bequest. Having mentioned the former, He follows it with the latter:

2:180–182 · Bequests, correction and the preservation of inspired knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 209–211

كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمْ إِذا حَضَرَ أَحَدَكُمُ الْمَوْتُ إِنْ تَرَكَ خَيْراً الْوَصِيَّةُ لِلْوالِدَيْنِ وَالْأَقْرَبِينَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ حَقًّا عَلَى الْمُتَّقِينَ (180) فَمَنْ بَدَّلَهُ بَعْدَ ما سَمِعَهُ فَإِنَّما إِثْمُهُ عَلَى الَّذِينَ يُبَدِّلُونَهُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ (181) فَمَنْ خافَ مِنْ مُوصٍ جَنَفاً أَوْ إِثْماً فَأَصْلَحَ بَيْنَهُمْ فَلا إِثْمَ عَلَيْهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (182)

180. It is prescribed for you, when death approaches one of you, if he leaves wealth, to make a bequest to parents and near relatives according to what is right: a duty upon the God-fearing. 181. Whoever alters it after hearing it —the sin rests only upon those who alter it. God is Hearing, Knowing. 182. Whoever fears partiality or sin on a testator's part and makes peace between them incurs no sin. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language · The governing expression and two forms of deviation

I say: "when death approaches" is an adverbial expression governed by "is prescribed": the obligation of a bequest is directed to you when death approaches. Alternatively its governor is an omitted verbal noun understood from "bequest": making a bequest when death approaches is prescribed for you. "Bequest" is the passive subject (نائب فاعل) of "is prescribed." It cannot itself govern "when," which precedes it, because a verbal noun does not govern what comes before it, except according to al-Akhfash—or unless latitude is allowed with adverbial expressions. The consequences of both conditions are omitted: when death approaches one of you, if he leaves wealth, a bequest is prescribed for him.

Deviation (الجنف) is inclining from what is right. If mistaken, it is deviation without sin; if deliberate, sinful deviation.

Outward commentary · Bequests to relatives and alteration for a legitimate purpose

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: God prescribed that you make bequests to parents and near relatives when death approaches, if the dying person leaves good—that is, wealth. Our master ʿAlī said: "A thousand dirhams or more; no bequest below that." Al-Nakhaʿī said five hundred dirhams, not less. Al-Zuhrī held it obligatory for little or much. ʿĀ'isha is reported to have asked a man wishing to make a bequest how much wealth he had. He answered, "Three thousand." She asked how many dependants he had; he answered, "Four." She said, "No. God says only, 'if he leaves good.' This is little; leave it for your dependants."

The bequest must accord with what is right: justice, without favouring males or exceeding one-third. God has established this as a binding duty upon the God-fearing. If an executor or witness changes it after hearing and knowing it, the sin rests upon those changing it, not upon the deceased, for they oppose revealed law. God is Hearing, Knowing: no alteration is hidden from Him; He calls its author to account and punishes him.

Whoever fears—that is, knows—mistaken partiality or deliberate sinful deviation in a testator, and reconciles the beneficiaries with the heirs by bringing them into conformity with revealed law, reducing what the beneficiaries receive or increasing it for a perceived legitimate benefit, incurs no sin. This is alteration for benefit. Sinful alteration is that arising from desire. God is Forgiving, Merciful, forgiving and showing mercy to one who alters for a proper benefit.

This verse is abrogated concerning bequests to parents but remains operative for non-inheriting relatives, by the well-known report: "God has given everyone entitled his right; there is no bequest to an heir." If the parents do not inherit, as when they are unbelievers or enslaved, the verse remains operative. And God Most High knows best.[B117]

Spiritual allusion · Writing down the inspirations before their force diminishes

Know that when the aspirant restrains his lower self from appetites, preserves his heart from passing thoughts and guards his secret from heedlessness—the greatest appetites being leadership and rank—and puts the self to death, lowering it into humble conditions until death approaches it and thoughts and imaginings cease, knowledge and inspirations flow abundantly. He must firmly undertake to record this knowledge or charge someone to record it, so that the parents—the shaykhs—and near relatives—the brethren—may benefit.

Wisdom arrives in self-disclosure like a mountain. If neglected and not recorded, it becomes like a camel; neglected further, like a ram; then like a bird, then an egg, then disappears. Thus our masters' master, Sīdī ʿAlī al-Jamal, used to say. His shaykh, Sīdī al-ʿArabī ibn ʿAbd Allāh, would tell him: "When an inspiration comes to you, record it and give me a copy." Our shaykhs likewise instructed us to record inspirations. Whoever records one,

or hears it from another, must not change it by mere opinion and desire. If he establishes that it contains a deficiency or deviation from the Path and Reality and corrects it, he incurs no sin. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

After the foundations of faith, the earlier verse mentioned two pillars of Islam—"establishes prayer and gives the purifying alms." Here He mentions the third, fasting:

2:183–185 · Fasting, the month of revelation and three degrees of abstention

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 211–213

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الصِّيامُ كَما كُتِبَ عَلَى الَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ (183) أَيَّاماً مَعْدُوداتٍ فَمَنْ كانَ مِنْكُمْ مَرِيضاً أَوْ عَلى سَفَرٍ فَعِدَّةٌ مِنْ أَيَّامٍ أُخَرَ وَعَلَى الَّذِينَ يُطِيقُونَهُ فِدْيَةٌ طَعامُ مِسْكِينٍ

فَمَنْ تَطَوَّعَ خَيْراً فَهُوَ خَيْرٌ لَهُ وَأَنْ تَصُومُوا خَيْرٌ لَكُمْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ (184) شَهْرُ رَمَضانَ الَّذِي أُنْزِلَ فِيهِ الْقُرْآنُ هُدىً لِلنَّاسِ وَبَيِّناتٍ مِنَ الْهُدى وَالْفُرْقانِ فَمَنْ شَهِدَ مِنْكُمُ الشَّهْرَ فَلْيَصُمْهُ وَمَنْ كانَ مَرِيضاً أَوْ عَلى سَفَرٍ فَعِدَّةٌ مِنْ أَيَّامٍ أُخَرَ يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ بِكُمُ الْيُسْرَ وَلا يُرِيدُ بِكُمُ الْعُسْرَ وَلِتُكْمِلُوا الْعِدَّةَ وَلِتُكَبِّرُوا اللَّهَ عَلى ما هَداكُمْ وَلَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ (185)

183. O you who believe, fasting is prescribed for you as it was prescribed for those before you, so that you may be God-fearing, 184. for a limited number of days. Whoever among you is ill or travelling shall fast an equal number of other days. For those able to bear it, there is a ransom: feeding a needy person. Whoever freely does more good, it is better for him. To fast is better for you, if you but knew. 185. Ramadan is the month in which the Qur'ān was sent down, a guidance for people and clear proofs of guidance and discernment. Whoever among you is present during the month shall fast it; whoever is ill or travelling shall fast an equal number of other days. God desires ease for you, not hardship, so that you complete the number, magnify God for guiding you, and perhaps give thanks.

Language · Time, derivation and reverse-order correspondence

I say: "days" is accusative as an adverbial expression (منصوب على الظرفية). Its governor is disputed; the best view makes it "fasting." The intervening words do no harm, since adverbial expressions admit latitude not allowed elsewhere. "Numbered" qualifies it. "An equal number" is a subject: an equal number is incumbent upon him. *Ukhar* (أخر), "other," is a diptote (ممنوع من الصرف) because of adjectival force and deviation from a form with the definite article. "The month of Ramadan" may be the predicate of an implied subject, a subject whose predicate is "whoever is present …," or a substitution for "fasting," with an omitted annexed noun: the fasting of Ramadan's month.

Ramaḍān is a verbal noun of *ramiḍa*, to burn. "Month" is annexed to it; it becomes a proper name, prevented from full declension because of proper-name status and its additional alif and nūn. They so named it because

hearts burn with hunger and thirst, sins are burnt away, or the season was hot when the months were transferred from the old language. “The month” is an adverbial complement of “is present.”

“So that you complete …” gives three reasons for three rulings, in reverse-order unfolding (اللف والنشر المعكوس): to complete the number, I commanded you to make up an equal number of other days; to magnify God at the month’s completion, I commanded fasting the whole month; and that you might give thanks, I desired ease for you rather than hardship.

Outward commentary · The prescribed fast and its concessions

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: believers, fasting is imposed upon you as upon earlier prophets and communities from Adam onwards. They are an example for you, so it should not be hard, that you may guard against sins: fasting breaks appetite. Hence the Prophet said: “Whoever among you can afford marriage should marry; whoever cannot should fast, for it is a restraint for him.”[B118]

This fasting is only for a few numbered days; do not be daunted. Whoever is ill so that fasting is difficult, or travelling, and breaks the fast, must fast an equal number of other days after the month. Those able to fast without difficulty, should they wish to break it, owe a ransom: food for needy people (masākīn), one mudd for each day. A variant reading has “a ransom, food for a needy person,” meaning such food for each day; another view prescribes half a ṣāʿ. Whoever gives more than a mudd or feeds two needy people for a day does better and earns greater reward. For those capable of fasting, fasting is better, if they know its secrets and abundant good. This was then abrogated by “whoever among you is present during the month shall fast it.”[B119]

The commanded fast is the blessed month of Ramadan, in which the Qurʾān’s descent began, or in which it descended to the lowest heaven: a guidance leading people towards arrival, with clear signs of guidance and discernment distinguishing truth from falsehood. Alternatively: it guides people to the station of Islam, provides clear proofs leading to the realization of faith, and realizes discernment between the Real and falsehood—that is, whatever is other than God—thus realizing the station of spiritual excellence (الإحسان).

Whoever is present in the month, not travelling, must fast. At Islam's beginning a choice was given, since people were unused to fasting and found it difficult. Once accustomed to it and continuing in it, they were required to fast when resident and healthy. Whoever is ill with difficulty in fasting, or on a journey begun before dawn, and breaks the fast, owes an equal number of other days. God desires ease and lightening, permitting breaking the fast in illness and travel. He desires no hardship, having placed no constriction in religion. Making up the fast completes the prescribed number, the whole month. He commanded it so that you magnify Him at its completion for His guidance.

According to Mālik, the time of magnification (التكبير) runs from setting out for the prayer-ground after sunrise until the imam comes to prayer. The preferred wording is: "God is greater, God is greater; there is no god but God; God is greater, and to God belongs praise for guiding us. O God, make us among the thankful." It unites

the profession of unity, magnification and thanks, fulfilling "that you might give thanks" for Our abundant blessings and the ease We granted in fasting.

Spiritual allusion · Abstention from desire and from witnessing an other

Fasting from personal shares and appetites is prescribed for you, as for trustworthy gnostics who travelled before you: during days of struggle and discipline, until you alight in the court of witnessing's presence, that you guard against witnessing created beings and the Essence's secrets be unveiled to you.

Whoever spent earlier days of life sick with love of desire or travelling in pursuit of the world should hasten to recover in other days what was lost. Those strong enough for this fast must feed the weak with certainty and knowledge of the Lord of the worlds. Whoever freely guides servants to what strengthens certainty and raises aspiration does better for himself.

Strong ones, continuing your fast from witnessing an other and from mingling with sensory things after establishment is better and safer, if you know how sensory engagement disperses hearts and weakens aspirations. During this fast the inspiration of understanding becomes real, and lights and radiant gnosis follow one another. Whoever witnesses this should continue fasting; whoever cannot should weep over wasting his days.

Know that fasting has three degrees: the fast of the generality, the elect and the elect of the elect. The first abstains from the appetites of stomach and sexual organ, and what stands in their place, from dawn to sunset, while releasing the limbs into lapses and neglecting the heart in heedlessness. Such a faster gains only hunger: “Whoever does not abandon false speech and acting upon it, God has no need of his abandoning food and drink.”

The elect’s fast restrains every limb from superfluities—whatever distracts the servant from arrival. In sum, it guards outward and inward faculties from what does not concern them. The elect of the elect guard the heart from turning towards other than the Lord and the secret from stopping with an other. In sum, they abstain from witnessing otherness and keep the heart abiding in the Master’s presence. Such a person fasts for ever: people of the presence fast continually and are constant in prayer. May God benefit us through them and gather us with them. Amen.

Fasting softens the heart and brings nearness to the Real; He therefore mentions this immediately afterwards:

2:186 · Divine nearness, answered prayer and transcendence beyond place

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 213–215

وَإِذا سَأَلَكَ عِبادِي عَنِّي فَإِنِّي قَرِيبٌ أُجِيبُ دَعْوَةَ الدَّاعِ إِذا دَعانِ
فَلْيَسْتَجِيبُوا لِي وَلْيُؤْمِنُوا بِي لَعَلَّهُمْ يَرْشُدُونَ (186)

186. When My servants ask you about Me, I am near. I answer the supplicant’s call when he calls upon Me. Let them answer Me and believe in Me, so that they may be rightly directed.

Outward commentary · The answer in the time God wills

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says, in answer to a man asking, “Is our Lord near, so that we converse quietly with Him, or distant, so that we call aloud?”: when My servants ask you about Me, tell them I am nearer to them, in knowledge, power and encompassing, than their spirits to their

bodies and the whispers of their hearts to their hearts. I answer the caller, secretly or aloud, by night or day, in the way fitting his condition and at the time We will, not the time he wills. Let them answer Me when I call to faith and obedience, and I shall lead them on gnosis's path. Let them believe I am near, feeling shame before Me as one who sees that I am with him wherever he is, so that they are directed to travel My path and persist in loving Me.

Al-Bayḍāwī says: after commanding the month's fast, observing its count and performing the duties of magnification and thanks, God follows with this verse. It shows that He knows their conditions, hears their words, answers their prayers and repays their deeds, reinforcing and encouraging the command.

Spiritual allusion · Nearness without spatial proximity

The Real's nearness to His servants is the nearness of meanings to sensory things, or Attributes to Essence, or Essence to Attributes. When effacement and disappearance are realized, separation removed and union established, neither nearness nor distance, between-ness nor separation remains.

The great gnostic and pole, Sīdī ʿAbd al-Salām ibn Mashīsh, told Abū al-Ḥasan: "Sharpen faith's vision and you will find God in everything, at everything, with everything, before everything, after everything, near everything and encompassing everything—with a nearness that is His attribute and an encompassing that is His quality. Pass beyond containment and limits, places and directions, companionship and nearness measured by distances, and circling among created things. Efface everything through His attributes 'the First, the Last, the Outward, the Inward.' God was, and nothing was with Him; He is now as He was."[B120]

A gnostic said: "The Real transcends where, direction, how, matter and form. Yet no where or place, quantity or quality, body, substance or accident is empty of Him. Through His subtlety He pervades everything; through His luminosity He appears in everything; through His absoluteness and encompassing He assumes every modality without being restricted by it. Whoever has neither known, tasted nor witnessed this is blind in inward sight, deprived of witnessing the Real."

Only people of spiritual taste and inward meanings understand these allusions. Accompany the men of meanings, and you will taste their secrets and understand their allusions. Otherwise it suffices to affirm perfect transcendence and the falsity of assimilation, holding to “Nothing is like Him, and He is the Hearing, the Seeing” [42:11], and yielding to these men in every state.

If you have not seen the crescent, yield
to people who have seen it with their eyes.

When you realize that the Real is near, the tongue of the state (لسان الحال) suffices in place of verbal petition. Through God is success.

The Real completes the remaining rules of fasting:

2:187 · The nights of fasting, the dawn’s discernment and retreat

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 215–218

أُحِلَّ لَكُمْ لَيْلَةَ الصِّيامِ الرَّفَثُ إِلى نِسائِكُمْ هُنَّ لِباسٌ لَكُمْ وَأَنْتُمْ لِباسٌ لَهُنَّ عَلِمَ اللَّهُ أَنَّكُمْ كُنْتُمْ تَخْتانُونَ أَنْفُسَكُمْ فَتابَ عَلَيْكُمْ وَعَفا عَنْكُمْ فَالْآنَ بَاشِرُوهُنَّ وَابْتَغُوا ما كَتَبَ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ وَكُلُوا وَاشْرَبُوا حَتَّى يَتَبَيَّنَ لَكُمُ الْخَيْطُ الْأَبْيَضُ مِنَ الْخَيْطِ الْأَسْوَدِ مِنَ الْفَجْرِ ثُمَّ أَتِمُّوا الصِّيامَ إِلَى اللَّيْلِ وَلا تُبَاشِرُوهُنَّ وَأَنْتُمْ عاكِفُونَ فِي الْمَساجِدِ تِلْكَ حُدُودُ اللَّهِ فَلا تَقْرَبُوها كَذلِكَ يُبَيِّنُ اللَّهُ آياتِهِ لِلنَّاسِ لَعَلَّهُمْ يَتَّقُونَ (187)

187. Intimacy with your wives is permitted to you on the nights of fasting. They are a garment for you, and you a garment for them. God knew that you were betraying yourselves, so He turned towards you and pardoned you. Now approach them and seek what God has written for you. Eat and drink until the white thread of dawn becomes distinct to you from the black

thread; then complete the fast until night. Do not approach them while you are in retreat in the mosques. These are God's limits: do not approach them. Thus God makes His signs clear to people, so that they may be God-fearing.

Language · Rafath and intimate approach

I say: *rafath* (الرَّفَث), pronounced with consecutive fatḥas, means intercourse and indecent speech, like *rufūth*, and talk with women about intercourse, as stated in the *Qāmūs*. The lexicographer al-Azharī calls it a comprehensive term for everything a man desires of his wife. Here it includes the meaning of intimate approach (الإفضاء), and therefore takes the preposition *ilā*.[B121]

Outward commentary · A concession after an earlier prohibition

The Real, glorious is His majesty, speaks in abrogation of the initial prohibition of intercourse during Ramadan after the night prayer or sleep. ʿUmar had relations with his wife after the night prayer, regretted it and came to the Messenger apologetically. Other men rose and admitted what they had done after that prayer. Then came the revelation: on the nights of fasting before dawn, approaching your wives in intercourse is permitted. The expression *rafath* marks the ugliness of their earlier act.

He explains the permission: "They are a garment for you, and you a garment for them." I permitted intercourse because you have little patience apart from them: you embrace one another, each enveloping the other as clothing envelops its wearer. The poet says:

> When the bedfellow bends her side towards him,
> she bends and becomes his garment. [62]

In that condition patience in abstaining is slight. God knew you betrayed yourselves, exposing yourselves to punishment and depriving yourselves of reward. When you repented and acknowledged your acts, He turned to you and pardoned, effacing your sins. Now approach them. *Mubāshara* literally brings skin against skin and is a euphemism (كناية) for intercourse. Seek what God has written for you

62. Cairo editor, C215.1: He is al-Nābigha al-Jaʿdī.

of offspring: do not approach merely to satisfy appetite, but seek the child God has decreed and recorded on the Preserved Tablet. This, not merely satisfying desire, is the intention behind instituting marriage and creating appetite. A report says: “When the servant dies, his action ceases except for three: continuing charity, knowledge spread in people’s breasts and a righteous child praying for him.”

In a lengthy report from ʿĀʾisha concerning al-Ḥawlāʾ[T10], a woman of the Helpers, the Messenger tells her: “Whenever a woman conceives by her husband, from conception she has the reward of one standing in prayer at night, fasting by day and fighting in God’s way. Every labour pang brings the reward of freeing a person, and every nursing that of freeing a slave. When she weans her child, a caller from heaven says: your previous deeds have been taken care of; begin anew for what remains.” ʿĀʾisha said: “Women have been given much good; what is there for you men?” The Prophet laughed and said: “Whenever a believing man takes his wife’s hand to court her, God writes him a good deed; embracing her brings ten; lying with her twenty; and intercourse is better than the world and all it contains. When he rises to bathe, water passes over no hair on his body without a sin being effaced and a degree bestowed. What he receives for bathing is better than the world and all it contains. God glories before the angels: ‘Look at My servant, rising on a cold night to bathe from major ritual impurity, certain that I am his Lord. Bear witness that I have forgiven him.’” From al-Thaʿlabī. [B122] 63

Outward commentary · The two threads and the timing of clarification

The Real permits eating and drinking on the fasting night until dawn: “Eat and drink until the white thread becomes distinct to you from the black thread.” The first light of dawn appearing horizontally across the horizon is likened to a white thread, and the darkness of night stretching beside it to a black thread.

63. Cairo editor, C216.1: This hadith is fabricated. Ibn al-Jawzī mentions it in al-Mawḍūʿāt, and Ibn ʿIrāq in Tanzīh al-sharīʿa. The hadith master Ibn Ḥajar says in al-Iṣāba that its chain of transmission is extremely weak. Al-Dāraquṭnī says, “This is an invalid hadith.” He also relates that ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn Mahdī and Abū Dāwūd went to Ziyād ibn Maymūn—one of the men in its chain—and challenged him over this hadith. He said, “Bear witness that I have retracted it.”

"Of dawn" was not revealed until some time later. Some Companions took the words literally, putting a white and black thread beneath their pillow and continuing to eat while looking at them, unable to distinguish them. Among them was ʿAdī ibn Ḥātim. He said: "I went early to the Messenger and told him. He laughed and said, 'You are indeed broad in the nape! It means the whiteness of day and the blackness of night.'" The report is established in al-Bukhārī and elsewhere. Al-Zamakhsharī objected that this postpones clarification beyond the time of need (تأخير البيان عن وقت الحاجة), which is impermissible because it imposes what cannot be performed.

The answer given is that clarification was delayed until, not beyond, the time of need, which is permissible. When the two-thread passage was revealed, the Messenger and believers understood God's intention and acted accordingly. For them it was clear, not indeterminate (مجملة). ʿAdī, a Bedouin occupied with hunting and lacking settled people's experience, took it literally; hence "broad in the nape." The verse then clarified God's intention for him when clarification became necessary.

Yet al-Suyūṭī states otherwise in the *Tawshīḥ*: someone said ʿAdī apparently had not heard this part of the verse, which descended long before his conversion in year nine or ten. He said: "The Messenger taught me prayer and fasting: 'Pray thus and fast thus; when the sun sets, eat until the white thread becomes distinct from the black.' I took the two threads …" The Prophet asked him, "Did I not say, 'of dawn'?" This shows that "then God revealed 'of dawn'" in the report results from the narrators' handling of it. Here ends the abridged quotation.[T11] This explicitly makes the verse clear and complete upon revelation, with no delay. And God Most High knows best.[B123]

Outward commentary · The end of fasting and intercourse during retreat

The Real specifies the fast's limit: "Then complete the fast until night." Whoever breaks it while doubtful whether sunset has occurred owes expiation, unlike doubt about dawn, because the preceding state is presumed to continue (الاستصحاب).[B124]

Since retreat (الاعتكاف) is connected with fasting, He follows with part of its rulings: do not have relations with women while in retreat in the mosques. Intercourse is forbidden to one in retreat and invalidates it, whether inside

or outside the mosque. A man would go out from retreat, have relations with his wife and return; the verse was revealed. These are limits God has set for you: do not approach them, much less cross them. With such complete explanation God clarifies His signs, so that people avoid His prohibitions.

Spiritual allusion · Gifted knowledge, acquired learning and witnessing beyond both

The fast of the elect and elect of the elect has been explained: abstaining from superfluities and whatever prevents arrival, or from witnessing others and whatever produces turbidity. When the soul resolves upon this fast and forms its intention, it may approach the virgin, divinely bestowed sciences and gnostic realities, and the previously possessed formal, acquired sciences. Gifted knowledge (العلوم اللدنية الوهبية) is its inner garment; formal knowledge its outer cloak. The first clothes its inward life, the second its outward life. [64]

Abū Sulaymān al-Dārānī said: "When souls become accustomed to abandoning sins, they range through the dominion and return to their possessor with wondrous knowledge, without a scholar conveying knowledge to them."

The Real says: God knew that you betrayed yourselves through the pollution of lapses and prevented your approaching these gifted sciences. Once you resolved upon repentance and abandoning the lapses, He accepted and pardoned you. Now approach the sciences, seeking the arrival at His knowledge and abiding in His holy presence that He wrote for you. Eat their fruits and drink the wine of the Living, Self-Subsisting until unveiling's dawn rises and the day of gnosis shines upon your hearts.

Then those sciences disappear and their landmarks and traces are effaced; nothing remains but absorption in witnessing the Living, Self-Subsisting. Do not approach them while abiding in those mosques. Seeing the Beloved's Face dispenses with contemplating landmarks and scenes. These are God's limits: do not stop with those sciences and the sweetness of their traces, for

64. Cairo editor, C217.1: Shiʿār is the garment next to a person's body, beneath the other clothes. Dithār is the garment worn over the shiʿār.

they prevent witnessing the Living, Self-Subsisting. Thus God clarifies His signs showing people the path of arrival, so that they guard against witnessing other than He. And God Most High knows best.

Before speaking of pilgrimage, the Real mentions wealth, generally a condition of its obligation and of reaching it:

> **Translator's source note · Cairo I:216:** Ruslān's footnote calls the al-Ḥawlāʾ report about pregnancy, nursing and marital rewards fabricated, citing earlier traditional critics.

2:188 · Unjust wealth, judicial judgement and the hand of the Giver

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 218–219

وَلا تَأْكُلُوا أَمْوالَكُمْ بَيْنَكُمْ بِالْباطِلِ وَتُدْلُوا بِها إِلَى الْحُكَّامِ لِتَأْكُلُوا فَرِيقاً مِنْ أَمْوالِ النَّاسِ بِالْإِثْمِ وَأَنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ (188)

188. Do not consume one another's wealth falsely, nor offer it to judges in order knowingly to consume a portion of people's wealth sinfully.

Language · Lowering a bucket and presenting a bribe

I say: *idlāʾ* (الإدلاء) originally means lowering a bucket into water to draw from a well, then anything used to attain something. "He offered his wealth to the judges" means paying a bribe to obtain more; that is intended here. The *Qāmūs* gives: he invoked his kinship as a means; presented his proof; and offered his wealth to someone, meaning handed it over. Hence "offer it to judges." The verb is coordinated with "consume," and both are prohibited.

Outward commentary · A court's decision does not make the forbidden lawful

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Muslims, do not consume one another's wealth falsely, without a valid right under the Sacred Law. This may mean no right at all—usurpation, theft, betrayal, deception, short measure, fraud and the like—or a false claim to a right, as with payments for sorcery, soothsaying, omens, gambling, influence, a debtor's gift, gifts connected with loans, guarantees, [65]

bribes, usury and other things forbidden by the Lawgiver. This does not include amulets and invocations based upon Qurʾān or Sunna when healing is predominant, nor disproportion in an exchange when the seller knows the thing sold.[B125]

Or: do not consume wealth falsely by spending it on diversions, illicit intercourse, drinking, sodomy and other prohibitions. Do not use it as a means by paying bribes to judges, so that a judge awards you a portion of others' property which you take sinfully while knowing it belongs to another. A judge's judgement does not make an unlawful thing lawful.

The Prophet said: "I am only a human being like you. Perhaps one of you presents his argument more eloquently than another and I judge in his favour. Whoever I award something of his brother's wealth, I award him only a piece of the Fire."[B126]

Spiritual allusion · Receiving through creation without forgetting God

Falsehood is everything besides the Real. Whoever receives from creation's hand without witnessing the Real in them takes people's wealth falsely. The *Ḥikam* says: "Do not stretch your hands to receive from creatures unless you see that the Giver through them is your Master. When you are thus, take what knowledge permits you." Acting upon this requires great vigilance and strong witnessing, until the sight of creation disappears from one's gaze in witnessing the True King. [66]

65. Cairo editor, C218.1: A man is called midyān when he habitually incurs debt.
66. Cairo editor, C219.1: That is, exertion and earnest effort, from ʿassa yaʿussu, "to seek."

Someone sought a person of this quality. Giving to a poor man, he would say, “Take—not for you,” but heard no answer. Finally he gave to one of the poor and said, “Take—not for you.” The man replied, “I receive—not from you.”

I say: approaching rulers over worldly matters or to vindicate oneself is forbidden in the path of the elect. Rather, one waits patiently until God judges between oneself and one’s opponent; He is the best of judges. If compelled by an unavoidable need, one should appoint an agent. Through God is success.[B127]

Before the rulings of pilgrimage, the Real speaks of the crescent, considered in both performing and making up pilgrimage:

2:189 · The crescents and entering each house by its door

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 219–222

يَسْئَلُونَكَ عَنِ الْأَهِلَّةِ قُلْ هِيَ مَواقِيتُ لِلنَّاسِ وَالْحَجِّ وَلَيْسَ الْبِرُّ بِأَنْ تَأْتُوا الْبُيُوتَ مِنْ ظُهُورِها وَلكِنِ الْبِرُّ مَنِ اتَّقى وَأْتُوا الْبُيُوتَ مِنْ أَبْوابِها وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُفْلِحُونَ (189)

189. They ask you about the crescents. Say, “They mark times for people and for pilgrimage.” Righteousness is not that you enter houses from their backs; righteousness is in one who fears God. Enter houses by their doors, and fear God, so that you may prosper.

Outward commentary · The useful answer to a question about the moon

I say: Muʿādh ibn Jabal and Thaʿlaba ibn Ghanama asked him: “Messenger of God, why does the crescent appear thin as a thread, then increase until full, then diminish until it returns to a thread?” The Real said: they ask you about the crescents, [67]

about the wisdom of their increase and decrease. Tell them, Muḥammad: they mark times for people’s debts, cultivation, women’s waiting periods and fasting. They also mark pilgrimage’s times, its beginning and end, distinguishing timely performance from making it up. Were the moon always in one condition, these would not be known. The Real answers differently from what they expected, indicating that asking about the secret of the change yields no benefit under revealed law; attention should be given to what benefits religion.

Astronomers say that its light is from the sun and its body smooth. As it moves away from alignment with the sun, the sun’s light faces it. When near the sun, only part of its body receives that light. When it passes beneath the sun in the sphere, its whole back faces the sun and none of its [visible face] receives the light. As it emerges from beneath, it receives light to that extent. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The crescent of changing states and the sun of establishment

When happiness’s crescent appears on the horizon of aspiration and guidance’s wind blows from preceding divine care, the time arrives for hearts to make pilgrimage to the presence of the Knower of unseen things. Guidance’s crescent belongs to travellers, possessors of states and changing coloration (التلوين). Its light grows as certainty grows and diminishes as certainty diminishes, according to the strength or weakness of the state, until union is realized and perfection granted. They recite:

> Every day you change your colour;
> something other than this would become you better.

67. Cairo editor, C219.2: The source copies have “Ghanm”; the correct form is “Ghanama,” as in Usd al-ghāba and al-Iṣāba.

One subject to changing states passes between increase and decrease until gnosis's sun rises. Once it rises there is no subsequent increase or decrease. They recite:

> The sun of the one I love rose by night,
> shining with no sunset to follow.
> The daytime sun sets in the night,
> but the sun of hearts never disappears.

The one established (صاحب التمكين), by contrast, remains always in gnosis's radiance, fixed in happiness's constellation. Neither eclipse nor veil touches his sun; darkness and clouds do not obscure its light. Were he to ask for a veil, his request would not be granted. A gnostic said: "Were I charged to see another than He, I could not, for no other is with Him for me to witness."

The Real then warns against what the associators innovated in pilgrimage:

Qur'ānic continuation · 2:189b

وَلَيْسَ الْبِرُّ بِأَنْ تَأْتُوا الْبُيُوتَ مِنْ ظُهُورِهَا وَلَكِنِ الْبِرُّ مَنِ اتَّقَى وَأْتُوا الْبُيُوتَ مِنْ أَبْوَابِهَا وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُفْلِحُونَ

> Righteousness is not that you enter houses from their backs; righteousness is in one who fears God. Enter houses by their doors, and fear God, so that you may prosper.

Outward commentary · Ritual custom and the courtesy of asking

I say: when the Helpers made the greater or lesser pilgrimage, they would say that no roof should intervene between them and heaven until they entered their houses. On returning they climbed walls or opened holes in the backs of their houses. One man entered by the door and was reproached. The Real revealed: righteousness—obedience—is not entering from behind, climbing over or opening a hole above. Righteousness belongs to one avoiding prohibitions and opposing appetites.

Alternatively, righteousness is not reversing the proper order of your questions, asking what does not benefit you and abandoning matters of knowledge useful now and hereafter. It belongs to one avoiding this. Enter the houses of knowledge by their doors: ask well, speak courteously, and put first what matters most and benefits most. Fear God: do not alter His rulings or object to His acts, so that you prosper through His enabling and guidance.

Spiritual allusion · The three houses and their nine doors

Know that the aspirant enters three houses: Sacred Law (الشريعة), Path (الطريقة) and Reality (الحقيقة). Each has doors. Whoever comes by the door enters; whoever comes otherwise is expelled.

The house of Sacred Law has three doors. First is repentance. Once entered and realized with its pillars and conditions, the door of uprightness (الاستقامة) meets him: following the Messenger in words, acts and states. Upon realizing it, he meets God-fearing vigilance (التقوى) in its divisions. Realizing this outwardly and inwardly, he enters the purified Sacred Law's house and ranges through its beauties and meanings.

He then seeks the Path's house, also with three doors. First is sincerity (الإخلاص): directing action to God alone without reservation or personal share. Once realized, the door of emptying (التخلية) meets him: purification from inward faults, which are innumerable. Whoever finds a shaykh is shown them and taught their remedies. Then comes adornment (التحلية): patience, forbearance, truthfulness, tranquillity, generosity, preferring others and every other perfection. Realizing sincerity, emptying and adornment, he has realized the Path's house.[B128]

The house of Reality then meets him. First he knocks at watchfulness (المراقبة): guarding heart and secret from bad thoughts. Once the heart is purified of thoughts settled within it, it overlooks the door of witnessing (المشاهدة): effacing traces in witnessing the lights of the Living, Self-Subsisting, or rendering vessels subtle when meanings appear. Entering and settling there, he meets the door of gnosis (المعرفة), the place of rootedness and establishment, the goal and end. The house of Reality is the mosque of

the divine presence. Beyond it remains only ascent in stations and increasing gnoses and unveilings, for ever and ever. May God grant us an abundant share through His grace and generosity.

When pilgrimage was prescribed, unbelievers occupied the Sacred House. He therefore commands struggle against them so that Muslims may make pilgrimage:

2:190–195 · Conflict, sacred limits and the struggle against inward obstacles

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 222–224

وَقاتِلُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ الَّذِينَ يُقاتِلُونَكُمْ وَلا تَعْتَدُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ لا يُحِبُّ الْمُعْتَدِينَ (190) وَاقْتُلُوهُمْ حَيْثُ ثَقِفْتُمُوهُمْ وَأَخْرِجُوهُمْ مِنْ حَيْثُ أَخْرَجُوكُمْ وَالْفِتْنَةُ أَشَدُّ مِنَ الْقَتْلِ وَلا تَقْتُلُوهُمْ عِنْدَ الْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرامِ حَتَّى يَقْتُلُوكُمْ فِيهِ فَإِنْ قَتَلُوكُمْ فَاقْتُلُوهُمْ كَذلِكَ جَزاءُ الْكافِرِينَ (191) فَإِنِ انْتَهَوْا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (192) وَقاتِلُوهُمْ حَتَّى لا تَكُونَ فِتْنَةٌ وَيَكُونَ الدِّينُ لِلَّهِ فَإِنِ انْتَهَوْا فَلا عُدْوانَ إِلاَّ عَلَى الظَّالِمِينَ (193) الشَّهْرُ الْحَرامُ بِالشَّهْرِ الْحَرامِ وَالْحُرُماتُ قِصاصٌ فَمَنِ اعْتَدى عَلَيْكُمْ فَاعْتَدُوا عَلَيْهِ بِمِثْلِ مَا اعْتَدى عَلَيْكُمْ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ مَعَ الْمُتَّقِينَ (194) وَأَنْفِقُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَلا تُلْقُوا بِأَيْدِيكُمْ إِلَى التَّهْلُكَةِ وَأَحْسِنُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ الْمُحْسِنِينَ (195)

190. Fight in God’s way those who fight you, but do not transgress. God does not love transgressors. 191. Kill them wherever you encounter them, and expel them from where they expelled you. Unbelief (fitna) is more grievous than killing. Do not kill them at the Sacred Mosque unless they kill [some

of] you there; if they kill [some of] you, kill them. Such is the recompense of unbelievers. 192. If they desist, God is Forgiving, Merciful. 193. Fight them until there is no association of partners with God (fitna) and religion belongs to God. If they desist, there is no aggression except against wrongdoers. 194. The sacred month for the sacred month; violations of sanctities are subject to just retaliation. Whoever transgresses against you, respond to him in the same measure as he transgressed against you. Fear God, and know that God is with the God-fearing. 195. Spend in God's way, and do not cast yourselves by your own hands into destruction. Do good: God loves those who do good.

Language · Destruction and the return after al-Ḥudaybiya

[Translator's note: Cairo I:222 prints three forms of *qatala* ("kill") in the heading of 2:191; the following exposition uses *qātala* ("fight"). The translation preserves this distinction. The bracketed "some of" makes the collective plural address explicit.]

I say: destruction (التهلكة) is the verbal noun of *hallaka*, with doubled lām, according to Ibn ʿAṭiyya. "Cast" includes the meaning of bringing or leading to, hence it takes *ilā*: do not bring yourselves to destruction. There is no need to regard the bāʾ as redundant.

The occasion was the associators' barring the Messenger in the year of al-Ḥudaybiya, then making peace on condition that he return the following year and have the House vacated for three days. When he returned for the lesser pilgrimage in fulfilment of the agreement, Muslims feared that the others would break it, leading to fighting in the sanctuary and sacred month. They disliked this, and the passage was revealed.

Outward commentary · Fighting, restraint and reciprocal limits

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: fight in God's way, raising His word, those who begin fighting you. Do not transgress by beginning before they do. God neither loves, supports nor strengthens transgressors. This was then abrogated by "fight the associators all together" [9:36].[B129]

Kill them wherever you find them and do not hesitate over fighting in the sanctuary, for they barred you and initiated harm. Expel them from Mecca as they expelled you. The *fitna*—their unbelief—is more grievous than

killing them in the sanctuary. Do not initiate fighting at the Sacred Mosque until they fight you there; if they do, kill them there and elsewhere. Such is their recompense: they are treated as they treated others. If they abandon association and embrace Islam, God forgives and shows mercy to them.

Fight until there is no association and religion belongs purely to God, so that only one religion remains in the Arabian Peninsula. If they cease fighting you, do not transgress: aggression is only against wrongdoers, for it is not fitting to wrong anyone except one who has wronged.[B130]

Your fighting them in the sacred month corresponds to their barring you in a sacred month. Sanctities are reciprocally requited: as they violated the month's sanctity by keeping you from the House, violate their immunity by fighting in it. Whoever transgresses against you through fighting in sacred months or the sanctuary, respond in equal measure. Fear God and do not act merely to vindicate yourselves. Know that God protects and strengthens the God-fearing.

Spend in God's way in struggle against the enemy. Do not withhold spending and cast yourselves into destruction, allowing the enemy to overpower you. Abū Ayyūb al-Anṣārī is reported to have been at Constantinople when a man charged the enemy's army. Some said he had cast himself into destruction. Abū Ayyūb replied: "No. This verse concerned the Helpers. When God strengthened Islam and its followers multiplied, we said, 'Let us return to our families and properties, remain there and put them in order.' God revealed to us, 'Do not cast yourselves into destruction.' This man, however, is described by 'Among people is one who sells himself seeking God's good pleasure' [2:207]."[B131]

Alternatively: do not spend all your wealth, exposing yourselves to destruction or dependence upon people. Keep to moderation, the middle course. Do good by generously assisting the needy and those struggling in God's way. God loves the good-doers and preserves them and their descendants until the Resurrection Day.

Spiritual allusion · Four enemies and the danger of becoming occupied with them

Know that four enemies cut a person off from his Lord's presence: the lower self, Satan, the world and people. Struggle against the lower self opposes its desires and makes it bear what it finds heavy until disciplined.

Struggle against Satan disobeys him and becomes occupied with God instead, for remembrance melts him away. Struggle against the world renounces it and is content with what comes easily. Struggle against people becomes absent from them and turns aside from their coming and going.

The Real tells those turning to Him: fight in God's way those fighting you and barring you from His presence, but do not transgress by becoming occupied with them instead of remembering and turning towards Me. God does not love transgressors. Strike them only where they confront you. When the form of the lower self appears, discipline it, then become absent from it in God; likewise with the remaining obstacles.

Our masters' master, Sīdī ʿAlī al-Jamal, said: "True enmity towards the enemy is being truly occupied with love of the Beloved. If you become occupied with hating the enemy, you lose love of the Beloved, and the enemy gains his intention." Expel these obstacles from your hearts as they expelled you from your Lord's presence: as they expelled you in heedless days, expel them in days of wakefulness. Being tried through occupation with them is more grievous than putting them to death.

Do not fight them at the mosque of the presence while absent in God: that would turn towards other than God, like someone whose Beloved faces him while he turns towards another speaking and distracting him—utter discourtesy. Only when they fight there, trying to drive you out through whisperings, should you act. When their whisperings enter your thoughts, overcome them by remembering God and seeking refuge. God suffices you and they flee. Such is the recompense of unbelievers. If their thoughts cease, become absent from them, and God screens you from them. Persist in struggling until no disturbance from them remains in your hearts and all orientation belongs to God, uncontested by anything else. If they desist, do not provoke them: that would be transgression and wrongdoing. There is no aggression except against wrongdoers.

If your lower self inclines to the sanctity of outward obedience—teaching, struggle, prayer or another act—and tries to remove you from the holy presence's sanctity, reflection, witnessing and direct vision, resist it and draw it from that outward observance to inward obedience. Sanctities are reciprocally requited. An atom of the heart's works surpasses mountains of bodily works.[B132]

Whoever transgressed against you in idle days, respond in wakeful days with equal measure. Our shaykh al-Būzīdī said: “Be hard upon your lower selves in proportion to their hardness upon you”—put them to death in proportion to their having killed you through distance from your Lord. He also said: “Overcome imagination before it overcomes you.” Fear God, and He will assist you against them; He is with the God-fearing.

Spend your selves and very lives in God’s way, placing them in God’s hand to do with as He wills. Do not cast yourselves into destruction by planning, choosing and attending to their affairs, for that is heedlessness of your Lord. Do good: enter the station of excellence, worshipping God as though you see Him. He loves the good-doers, bringing them near, electing them for His love and knowledge. May He include us among them through His grace and generosity.

The Real commands completion of the rite once entered and urges sincerity in it:

2:196 · Completing pilgrimage and the offering of the self

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 224–227

وَأَتِمُّوا الْحَجَّ وَالْعُمْرَةَ لِلَّهِ فَإِنْ أُحْصِرْتُمْ فَمَا اسْتَيْسَرَ مِنَ الْهَدْيِ وَلا تَحْلِقُوا رُؤُسَكُمْ حَتَّى يَبْلُغَ الْهَدْيُ مَحِلَّهُ فَمَنْ كانَ مِنْكُمْ مَرِيضاً أَوْ بِهِ أَذىً مِنْ رَأْسِهِ فَفِدْيَةٌ مِنْ صِيامٍ أَوْ صَدَقَةٍ أَوْ نُسُكٍ فَإِذا أَمِنْتُمْ فَمَنْ تَمَتَّعَ بِالْعُمْرَةِ إِلَى الْحَجِّ فَمَا اسْتَيْسَرَ مِنَ الْهَدْيِ فَمَنْ لَمْ يَجِدْ فَصِيامُ ثَلاثَةِ أَيَّامٍ فِي الْحَجِّ وَسَبْعَةٍ إِذا رَجَعْتُمْ تِلْكَ عَشَرَةٌ كامِلَةٌ ذلِكَ لِمَنْ لَمْ يَكُنْ أَهْلُهُ حاضِرِي الْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرامِ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ شَدِيدُ الْعِقابِ (196)

196. Complete the greater and lesser pilgrimage for God. If you are prevented, then offer whatever sacrificial animal is within reach. Do not shave your heads until the offering reaches its appointed place. Whoever is ill or suffers an affliction of the head owes a ransom of fasting, charity or sacrifice. When you are secure, whoever enjoys the lesser pilgrimage until the greater shall offer whatever sacrificial animal is within reach. Whoever cannot find one shall fast three days during pilgrimage and seven upon your return: ten complete days. This applies to one whose household is not resident at the Sacred Mosque. Fear God, and know that God is severe in punishment.

Language · Being prevented from completing the rites

I say: the well-known linguistic distinction makes the four-letter form *aḥṣara* refer to illness and the three-letter form *ḥaṣara* to an enemy's obstruction. Some reverse this, and some make them equivalent. "Whatever is within reach" is a predicate or subject: the obligation is what is within reach, or what is within reach is incumbent upon him.

Outward commentary · Completion, obstruction and compensation for removing hair

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: complete the greater and lesser pilgrimage you have begun, as an obligation like prayer and fasting. Do so for God, not display or reputation. They are particularly urged to sincerity because corruption enters them more readily than other acts. Whoever invalidates either must make it up.

If prevented from completion, leave the consecrated state and owe whatever offering is available: a sheep. Do not shave—that is, do not leave consecration—until the offering reaches the place where it may be slaughtered. According to al-Shāfiʿī this is the place of obstruction: it is slaughtered there with the intention of leaving consecration and distributed. According to Mālik the place is Minā or Mecca: the offering is sent, and once its arrival and slaughter are established, the pilgrim leaves consecration and shaves.[B133]

One in consecration may not remove dishevelment or wear clothing sewn to fit a bodily member. Whoever is ill or suffers a headache or similar affliction and shaves or puts on ordinary clothing owes a ransom: fasting three

days, giving two mudds to each of six needy persons, or sacrificing a sheep or larger animal. He chooses among the three. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Completing a covenant and not forcing an opening

When an aspirant binds himself to his Lord by a commitment, he must complete it until he harvests its fruit. Having committed to struggle, he must struggle against his self until witnessing results. Having covenanted for companionship with a shaykh, he must continue serving until the shaykh admits him to the house of the presence and attests his maturity. Every covenant with God must be completed.

If obstructed from completion, do whatever is possible of sacrificing the self and lowering the head: “God charges no soul beyond what He has given it” [65:7]. Do not hasten an opening before its season, lest deprivation be the punishment. Many an aspirant asked his shaykh to disclose lordship’s secret before its proper time and thereby met ruin. He is told: do not shave your head of witnessing an other until your self’s offering reaches its place and is slaughtered. Only when the self is fully sacrificed is the head shaved of witnessing otherness. Al-Shushtarī says:

> If you desire union with us, your death is a condition;
> one in whom a remnant remains does not attain union.

Whoever is ill through weak resolve or afflicted by a state that will not rise, destiny not assisting his struggle, should occupy himself with outward devotion—fasting, charity, recitation or another act—until the Knowing, Wise grants His favour. Through God is success; He guides to the sound road.

After the obstruction-offering and compensation for affliction, the Real mentions the offering for combining the two pilgrimages:

Qur’ānic continuation · 2:196b

فَإِذَا أَمِنْتُمْ فَمَنْ تَمَتَّعَ بِالْعُمْرَةِ إِلَى الْحَجِّ فَمَا اسْتَيْسَرَ مِنَ الْهَدْيِ

When you are secure, whoever enjoys the lesser pilgrimage until the greater shall offer whatever sacrificial animal is within reach.

Outward commentary · Tamattuʿ and the complete count of ten

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when secure from illness or enemy and intending pilgrimage, whoever performs the lesser pilgrimage in the pilgrimage months, then the greater in the same year, owes an available offering, a sheep or larger animal. He enjoyed the benefit of dispensing with one of two journeys, not assigning each act its own journey.

Whoever finds no offering and cannot buy one must fast three days in pilgrimage's period, from consecration to standing at ʿArafa. If he does not fast then, he fasts the days of Tashrīq. He then fasts seven when he returns to Mecca or his homeland. These are ten complete days: do not suppose the seven replace the three. Hence the explicit summation (فذلكة الحساب). [68]

The offering or fast applies only when the pilgrim's household does not reside in Mecca or Dhū Ṭuwā. A resident at the Sacred Mosque owes no offering, since he enters consecration for pilgrimage from Mecca and has not dispensed with a journey. Fear God in obeying His commands, especially the many, ramifying pilgrimage rites, which accordingly receive separate treatises. Know His punishment is severe for abandoning commands and committing prohibitions. Through God is success.

Spiritual allusion · Good bearing after security in realization

The Real tells those turning to Him by way of allusion: when secure from enemies cutting you off from Our presence, from returning after union, or from loss after a gift—after establishment in witnessing the Essence's secrets and the Attributes' lights, for the Generous does not withdraw His gift—whoever enjoys the Sacred Law's lights unto Reality's secrets must offer what he can of right conduct, good bearing and good character (الهدي والسمت الحسن والخلق الحسن). He has attained perfection and taken his place forming men. Whoever does not possess this should return to whatever struggle is possible until established in good bearing and character.[B134]

68. Cairo editor, C226.1: Fadhlaka: the summation and summary of what has been set out in detail.

This concerns one not established in the eternal presence. One residing there, abiding in witnessing its lights, lies beyond such discussion: his Master has taken charge of him and removed him from witnessing self and desire. His affair is wholly through God and towards God. May God place us among them through His grace and generosity.

Yet he must not neglect God-fearing vigilance: the Prophet said, “I am the most knowing of God among you and the most God-fearing.” They say: “A sign of the endings is returning to the beginnings.” And God Most High knows best.

The Real specifies pilgrimage’s appointed time:

2:197 · Pilgrimage’s months and the heart’s perpetual pilgrimage

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 227–228

الْحَجُّ أَشْهُرٌ مَعْلُوماتٌ فَمَنْ فَرَضَ فِيهِنَّ الْحَجَّ فَلا رَفَثَ وَلا فُسُوقَ وَلا جِدالَ فِي الْحَجِّ وَما تَفْعَلُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ يَعْلَمْهُ اللَّهُ وَتَزَوَّدُوا فَإِنَّ خَيْرَ الزَّادِ التَّقْوى وَاتَّقُونِ يا أُولِي الْأَلْبابِ (197)

197. Pilgrimage is in known months. Whoever undertakes pilgrimage in them must abstain from sexual intimacy, wrongdoing and disputation during pilgrimage. Whatever good you do, God knows it. Take provision, for the best provision is God-fearing vigilance. Fear Me, people of understanding.

Language · A period of time predicated of an abstract noun

I say: “pilgrimage” is a subject with an omitted annexed noun: entering consecration for pilgrimage, or performing pilgrimage. “Months” is its predicate. When time is predicated of an abstract noun (اسم معنى), and the event occupies all or most of that time, the Kufans require the nominative. The Basrans prefer it when the time-expression is indefinite: “the journey is

a day," if travel fills all or most of it. By occupying the whole period, the event is as though identical with it. "The journey [takes] a day" in the accusative, or "is in a day," is also valid.

If the event occupies only part of the time, the accusative or genitive with *fī* is required: "the journey [occurs on] Friday" or "on Friday," though the nominative occurs rarely. The *Tashīl* says: a temporal adverb can stand in place of the predicate of an abstract noun without restriction. If the event occurs in all or most of the time and the expression is indefinite, it is generally nominative, but, contrary to the Kufans, neither accusative nor genitive with *fī* is prohibited. Sometimes a time-expression containing the event only partly is nominative. Such is "pilgrimage is known months," since most of them are suitable for consecration.

Outward commentary · Courtesy and provision for the journey

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the time for entering pilgrimage's consecration is known months: Shawwāl, Dhū al-Qaʿda and Dhū al-Ḥijja. Earlier consecration is disliked according to Mālik and invalid according to al-Shāfiʿī. Whoever imposes pilgrimage upon himself in them must maintain courtesy and dignity and avoid desire for women: neither intercourse or indecent speech, nor sins, nor disputation—even with a hired carrier or servants—or other quarrels should occur. He stands in the presence of the All-Knowing King. [69]

God knows whatever good you do: forbearance, patience and good character. Race towards good deeds and take provision before death overtakes you. Fear God as He deserves, for the best provision is God-fearing vigilance. Or: take provision for the pilgrimage journey, not travelling as a burden upon people,

for the best provision is guarding against coveting what creatures possess. Fear Me, people of understanding, and single Me out in your secret, so that I open the door and admit you among the beloved.

69. Cairo editor, C227.1: Mukārī: a person who hires out riding or pack animals; the term is used especially of hirers of donkeys and mules. Its plural is makārūn.

Spiritual allusion · Every time a Night of Power, every place an ʿArafa

Bodily dealings are assigned places and times. The dealings of hearts and spirits have no particular appointed time or place. For the pilgrimage of hearts, every season is appointed and every place an ʿArafa. Their pilgrimage is abiding in the presence of the Knower of unseen things, eternally continuous through passing nights and days. Every time is for them a Night of Power, every place an ʿArafa of exalted worth. They recite:

> But for witnessing Your beauty within me,
> I would not be content with one hour of life.
> The Night of Power, exalted in worth,
> is only when my times are filled with You.
> The lover established in ardour
> and love needs no appointed season.

Another said:

> Every moment from my Beloved
> is worth a thousand years.
> Successful is one who leaves distractions
> and turns towards his Master. [70]

Whoever undertakes the presence's pilgrimage in his heart should maintain courtesy and contemplation, silence and reflection: "Voices are humbled before the Compassionate; you hear only a whisper" [20:108]. No indecent speech, wrongdoing, disputation or contention: their path rests upon surrender and contentment. No good you do is hidden from God. Take provision by guarding against witnessing otherness, for the best provision is God-fearing vigilance. Its sum is opposing desire and loving the Master. Such is the vigilance of people of understanding whose heart-mirrors are purified, so that they perceive guidance and right judgement. Through God is success.

The Real permits trading during pilgrimage's seasons:

70. Cairo editor, C228.1: He is al-Shushtarī.

2:198–199 · Seeking bounty during pilgrimage; ʿArafāt and the Sacred Monument

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 228–230

لَيْسَ عَلَيْكُمْ جُناحٌ أَنْ تَبْتَغُوا فَضْلاً مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ فَإِذا أَفَضْتُمْ مِنْ عَرَفاتٍ فَاذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ عِنْدَ الْمَشْعَرِ الْحَرامِ وَاذْكُرُوهُ كَما هَداكُمْ وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ مِنْ قَبْلِهِ لَمِنَ الضَّالِّينَ (198) ثُمَّ أَفِيضُوا مِنْ حَيْثُ أَفاضَ النَّاسُ وَاسْتَغْفِرُوا اللَّهَ إِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (199)

198. There is no blame upon you for seeking bounty from your Lord. When you pour forth from ʿArafāt, remember God at the Sacred Monument. Remember Him because He has guided you, although before that you were among those astray. 199. Then pour forth from where the people pour forth, and ask God's forgiveness. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language · Trade during pilgrimage

I say: "That you seek" (أن تبتغوا) follows the omission of a preposition (إسقاط حرف الجر): that is, "in your seeking." The occasion of this verse's revelation was that ʿUkāẓ, Majanna and Dhū al-Majāz—names of places—were markets in the Age of Ignorance. People frequented them in the pilgrimage seasons and drew their livelihoods from them. When Islam came, they felt that trading there was sinful and were reluctant to do so. The Real, glorious is His majesty, therefore told them: there is no blame upon you—no sin or departure

from what is right—in seeking bounty from your Lord: a gift and provision obtained through trade in your pilgrimage seasons, provided your intention is sincere and your purpose of pilgrimage predominates over trade.

Outward commentary · Mixed motives and the predominant impulse

Here there is a rule mentioned by al-Ghazālī in the *Iḥyāʾ*. Its substance is that an act done entirely for something other than God causes divine loathing and punishment; one done wholly and sincerely for God causes nearness and reward. When it is mixed with ostentation (الرياء) or the lower self's interests (حظوظ النفس), consideration is given to what predominates and to the strength of the motive. If the motive of self-interest predominates, the act falls short and is nearer to punishment, although its punishment is lighter than that of an act done wholly for something other than God. If the motive of drawing near to God predominates, the reward is reduced in proportion to the self-interested motive. If the two are equal, they oppose and cancel one another: the act counts neither for nor against its doer.

He then says: "The community's agreement that someone who sets out on pilgrimage while conducting trade has a valid pilgrimage and receives reward for it bears witness to this." He continues: "The correct position is to say that whenever pilgrimage is the original impulse and the commercial aim merely follows it, the journey itself is not without reward." He then applies this consideration to fighting in God's path in relation to booty: one considers the predominant motive and the sincerity of purpose. Likewise, when fasting is undertaken for a regimen and for reward, one considers the predominant motive.[B135]

I say: this rule applies to all dealings, movements and rests, crafts and other means of livelihood. What is free of self-interested aims is accepted; what is wholly directed to such aims is rejected; and in a mixed act one considers what predominates, as already explained.

The master of masters, my lord Abū al-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī, God be pleased with him, stated another rule, subtler than this:

"When God honours a servant in his movements and rests, He sets servanthood to God (العبودية لله) before him and conceals his own interests from him. He moves within his servanthood while his interests remain hidden, although what has been decreed for him continues to run its course. He does not attend to those interests, for they are apart from him. When God abases a servant in his movements and rests, He sets the servant's own

interests before him and conceals his servanthood. He moves within his desires, while servanthood to God is apart from him, although something of it may occur outwardly."

He says: "This is one aspect of sainthood and abasement. As for the greatest veracity (الصديقية العظمى) and the greater sainthood (الولاية الكبرى), personal interests and duties are all alike for the person of insight, because he is through God in what he takes and leaves." End of quotation.

Spiritual allusion · No final limit to increase in knowledge of God

The servant cannot dispense with seeking increase, even though he attain the furthest extremity of perfection. To be content with one's portion from God is deprivation; to believe one has reached the end is deficiency. There is therefore no blame upon you, gnostics, for seeking bounty from your Lord: increase in your certainty and ascent in your inward realities. The Real's perfections have no end, and the mysteries of the Essence cannot be encompassed. He says: "They do not encompass Him in knowledge" [20:110]. God is the guardian of success.

The Real then mentions standing at ʿArafa and returning to Muzdalifa and the Sacred Monument:

Qur'ānic continuation · 2:198b–199

فَإِذَا أَفَضْتُمْ مِنْ عَرَفَاتٍ فَاذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ عِنْدَ الْمَشْعَرِ الْحَرَامِ وَاذْكُرُوهُ كَمَا هَدَاكُمْ وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ مِنْ قَبْلِهِ لَمِنَ الضَّالِّينَ ۝ ثُمَّ أَفِيضُوا مِنْ حَيْثُ أَفَاضَ النَّاسُ وَاسْتَغْفِرُوا اللَّهَ إِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ

When you pour forth from ʿArafāt, remember God at the Sacred Monument. Remember Him because He has guided you, although before that you were among those astray. Then pour forth from where the people pour forth, and ask God's forgiveness. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language · Pouring forth, ʿArafāt and the reason for remembrance

I say: *afaḍtum* (أفضتم) means "you moved forth." The original meaning of *ifāḍa* is a forceful outpouring, from water's gushing strongly; it was then used, by way of intensification, for movement forth generally. *ʿArafāt* permits both full declension and its absence (الصرف وعدمه), like *Adhriʿāt*. It was named ʿArafāt because Abraham the Friend said to Gabriel, when Gabriel taught him the rites, "I have understood" (*ʿaraftu*), or because Adam recognized Eve there. The *kāf* in "as He guided you" (كما هداكم) gives the reason (تعليلية), and *mā* is infinitival (مصدرية): remember Him on account of His guidance of you. *In* in "although you were" (إن كنتم) is the lightened form (مخففة), and the *lām* distinguishes it [from the negative]. "Or more intense" [in 2:200] qualifies an omitted verbal noun (نعت لمصدر محذوف): "or a remembrance more intense," and so forth.[B136]

Outward commentary · Standing with the people and remembering God

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when you have stood at ʿArafa and poured forth from it, descend to Muzdalifa and spend the night there. After praying the dawn prayer while it is still dark, stand at the Sacred Monument, a mountain at the end of Muzdalifa. Remember God there by declaring His unity, magnifying Him and reciting the pilgrimage response (التهليل والتكبير والتلبية), until daylight spreads. This is what the Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him, did. Remember Him because He has guided you to the landmarks of His religion, the rites of His pilgrimage and its other observances; or remember Him with a good remembrance, just as He guided you with a good guidance. Before this guidance you were among those astray.

Quraysh used not to stand with the people, considering themselves above them, but stood at Muzdalifa. The Real commanded them to stand with the people: then pour forth, company of Quraysh, from where the people pour forth—completing [the rites] with them and departing from where they depart. Ask God's forgiveness for your alteration of Abraham's and Ishmael's rites. God is Forgiving towards you, Merciful to you, if you repent, return and follow your Messenger.

2:200–202 · Remembrance after the rites and the aspirations of those who pray

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 230–232

فَإِذا قَضَيْتُمْ مَناسِكَكُمْ فَاذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ كَذِكْرِكُمْ آباءَكُمْ أَوْ أَشَدَّ ذِكْراً فَمِنَ النَّاسِ مَنْ يَقُولُ رَبَّنا آتِنا فِي الدُّنْيا وَما لَهُ فِي الْآخِرَةِ مِنْ خَلاقٍ (200) وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ يَقُولُ رَبَّنا آتِنا فِي الدُّنْيا حَسَنَةً وَفِي الْآخِرَةِ حَسَنَةً وَقِنا عَذابَ النَّارِ (201) أُولئِكَ لَهُمْ نَصِيبٌ مِمَّا كَسَبُوا وَاللَّهُ سَرِيعُ الْحِسابِ (202)

200. When you have completed your rites, remember God as you remember your fathers, or with more intense remembrance. Among people is one who says, “Our Lord, give us in this world”; he has no share in the Hereafter.
201. Among them is one who says, “Our Lord, give us good in this world and good in the Hereafter, and protect us from the punishment of the Fire.” 202. Those will have a share from what they have earned. God is swift in reckoning.

Outward commentary · Replacing ancestral boasting with remembrance

When you have completed your rites and finished your pilgrimage, remember God abundantly, as you remember your fathers, or with a remembrance more intense than your remembrance of them, when you used to boast of them after completing pilgrimage. On finishing their pilgrimage, they would stand at Minā between the mosque and the mountain, recounting their fathers’ boasts and the splendours of their former days. They were commanded

to replace this with remembrance of God, His beneficence towards them, and gratitude for the distinctions He had bestowed upon them in this world and the Hereafter, should they believe and follow His Messenger, God bless him and grant him peace.

Spiritual allusion · Returning from witnessing to servanthood

When hearts stand on the mountain of the ʿArafa of gnoses, and become established in witnessing the beauty of the meanings within those adornments, until those meanings become their spirit and secret—their destination and the goal of their journey—they are commanded to descend to the ground of servanthood and undertake the duties owed to Lordship (وظائف الربوبية). This is gratitude for the landmarks of realization to which He has guided them and the beacons of the Path He has disclosed, although before this they were among those who had strayed from arrival at the Lord of the worlds.

They are then commanded to mingle with people in their bodily forms while remaining apart in their spirits. Their forms move among created beings; their spirits pasture in the spiritual kingdom (الملكوت). If inclination towards, or repose in, sensory appearance occurs, let them ask God's forgiveness: God is Forgiving, Merciful. They are then told: when you have completed your rites—uniting inward witnessing of Lordship with outward fulfilment of servanthood's duties—remember God over everything, at everything, before everything and after everything, until no trace remains. Remember Him as you used to remember your fathers and children during your heedlessness, but with remembrance more intense, greater and more complete. God is possessed of immense bounty.

The Real then explains people's purposes and aspirations in what they seek and strive for:

Qurʾānic continuation · 2:200b–202

فَمِنَ النَّاسِ مَنْ يَقُولُ رَبَّنَا آتِنَا فِي الدُّنْيَا وَمَا لَهُ فِي الْآخِرَةِ مِنْ خَلَاقٍ ۝ وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ يَقُولُ رَبَّنَا آتِنَا فِي الدُّنْيَا حَسَنَةً وَفِي الْآخِرَةِ حَسَنَةً وَقِنَا عَذَابَ النَّارِ ۝ أُولَئِكَ لَهُمْ نَصِيبٌ مِمَّا كَسَبُوا وَاللَّهُ سَرِيعُ الْحِسَابِ

Among people is one who says, “Our Lord, give us in this world”; he has no share in the Hereafter. Among them is one who says, “Our Lord, give us good in this world and good in the Hereafter, and protect us from the punishment of the Fire.” Those will have a share from what they have earned. God is swift in reckoning.

Outward commentary · Seeking the good of both abodes

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says, explaining people’s purposes and aspirations in what they seek during pilgrimage and otherwise: among people is one whose intention is narrow and whose aspiration is low, who says, “Our Lord, give us in this world whatever our lower selves desire of their interests and appetites.” He has no share in the Hereafter, for his share has been hastened to him in this world. “God provides for a servant in proportion to his intention.”

Among them is one who desires this world’s honour and the Hereafter’s nobility, who says, “Our Lord, give us a good condition in this world”: gnosis, well-being, lawful wealth, a good wife and every kind of beauty. “And good in the Hereafter”: the vision, the wide-eyed maidens, palaces and every kind of bliss. “Protect us from the punishment of the Fire” through pardon and forgiveness.

Our master ʿAlī, God ennoble his face, said: “Good in this world is the righteous woman; in the Hereafter, the fair-eyed maiden. The punishment of fire in this world is the bad woman.” Al-Ḥasan said: “Good in this world is knowledge and worship; in the Hereafter, the Garden.” “Protect us from the punishment of the Fire” means preserve us from the desires and sins that lead to it. All these are examples of a good condition.[B137]

Those who sought the good of both abodes will have a portion and share of abundant recompense because of the righteous works they earned. God is swift in reckoning: despite the multitude of His servants and their deeds, He reckons with them in the space of a glance. ʿAlī, God be pleased with him, was asked: “How does God reckon with His servants in a single hour?” He replied: “Just as He provides for them in a single hour.” End of quotation. Or [the phrase means] that He is about to establish the Resurrection and reckon with His servants. Hasten, therefore, to seize opportunities for obedience and acquire good deeds before death’s sudden onset.

Spiritual allusion · Low, intermediate and high aspiration

People are of three kinds: one with low aspiration, one with intermediate aspiration, and one with high aspiration (الهمة). The person of low aspiration has set his aim upon the lowly world and devoted himself to collecting its perishing debris. His heart is empty of love for the Beloved; he has no share in the Hereafter.

The person of intermediate aspiration seeks safety in both abodes and soundness in both conditions. In this abode he occupies himself with what will benefit him in the abode of permanence. He has not forgotten his share of this world, so that he may accomplish his needs within it. His good in this world is sufficiency and freedom from want; his good in the Hereafter is blessing, happiness and delight.

The person of high aspiration raises his aim above the two worlds and closes his eyes to turning towards either abode. He attaches his aspiration to his Master and is satisfied with nothing other than Him. He turns from this abode with lowered gaze, departs from it and turns away; nothing distracts him from God. With the tongue of utterance, manifesting his servanthood to the Great, the Exalted, he says: “Our Lord, give us good in this world”—vision and witnessing, and the approval of the Loving King—“and good in the Hereafter”: joining the company of the Highest Companion, the near ones and the prophets, in the presence of everlasting witnessing, “in a seat of truthfulness, in the presence of an all-powerful King” [54:55]. May God, by His generosity and bounty, bestow an abundant share of this upon us and all our loved ones. Amen.

The Real then completes the remaining pilgrimage rites: casting the pebbles during the days at Minā.

2:203 · The numbered days and the freedom to depart or remain

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 232–233

وَاذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ فِي أَيَّامٍ مَعْدُوداتٍ فَمَنْ تَعَجَّلَ فِي يَوْمَيْنِ فَلا إِثْمَ عَلَيْهِ وَمَنْ تَأَخَّرَ فَلا إِثْمَ عَلَيْهِ لِمَنِ اتَّقى وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّكُمْ إِلَيْهِ تُحْشَرُونَ (203)

203. Remember God during numbered days. Whoever hastens to leave in two days incurs no sin, and whoever remains incurs no sin—provided he fears God. Fear God, and know that to Him you will be gathered.

Outward commentary · The days at Minā

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember God during numbered days. These are the second, third and fourth days counting from the Day of Sacrifice: the days of *tashrīq*, the days at Minā. The “known days” [22:28], by contrast, are the Day of Sacrifice and the second and third days counting from it. Remembrance here means magnifying God when casting the pebbles, slaughtering sacrificial offerings, after the five prayers and at other times.

Whoever hastens to leave in two days, casting on the second and third days counting from the Day of Sacrifice and returning, incurs no sin. Whoever remains to cast on the fourth day counting from the sacrifice, which is the third day at Minā, likewise incurs no sin. Negating sin here intends

to establish a choice and refute the people of the Age of Ignorance: some counted early departure sinful, while others counted remaining sinful. All this is for one who fears God during pilgrimage, engaging neither in sexual misconduct nor transgression. He leaves his sins as on the day his mother bore him, as the truthful and confirmed Messenger said. Fear God in all your affairs: it is remembrance and honour for you. Know that to Him you will be gathered and recompensed for whatever good or evil you sent before you.[B138]

Spiritual allusion · The three days of the world, the interval and resurrection

The numbered days are the days of this world, few and numbered. All of them are as one day; the days of the intermediate realm (البرزخ) are a second day; the days of resurrection and what follows it are a third. Whoever hastens in two days—folding away in his sight the days of this world and of the intermediate realm, and dwelling in his heart in the Day of Resurrection—incurs no sin. This is the person of intermediate aspiration.

Whoever remains beyond them, renouncing all three days, attaching his aspiration to his Master and turning to nothing other than Him, incurs no sin in that remaining, provided he guards against witnessing anything other and attaches his aspiration to love of the Master. He then urges this Godfearingness: “Fear God”—witness no other with Him—“and know that to Him you will be gathered.” You will then see what the Godfearing have won.

When the Real, exalted is He, commanded His servants to fear Him, He mentioned one who paid it no heed but followed his desire, and one who obeyed His command and sold himself to God.

2:204–207 · Pleasing speech, destructive conduct and the self sold to God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 233–235

وَمِنَ النَّاسِ مَنْ يُعْجِبُكَ قَوْلُهُ فِي الْحَياةِ الدُّنْيا وَيُشْهِدُ اللَّهَ عَلى ما فِي قَلْبِهِ وَهُوَ أَلَدُّ الْخِصامِ (204) وَإِذا تَوَلَّى سَعى فِي الْأَرْضِ لِيُفْسِدَ فِيها وَيُهْلِكَ الْحَرْثَ وَالنَّسْلَ وَاللَّهُ لا يُحِبُّ الْفَسادَ (205) وَإِذا قِيلَ لَهُ اتَّقِ اللَّهَ أَخَذَتْهُ الْعِزَّةُ بِالْإِثْمِ فَحَسْبُهُ جَهَنَّمُ وَلَبِئْسَ الْمِهادُ (206) وَمِنَ النَّاسِ مَنْ يَشْرِي نَفْسَهُ ابْتِغاءَ مَرْضاتِ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ رَؤُفٌ بِالْعِبادِ (207)

204. Among people is one whose speech about worldly life pleases you, and who calls God to witness what is in his heart, although he is the fiercest of adversaries. 205. When he turns away, he strives through the land to spread corruption in it and destroy crops and offspring. God does not love corruption. 206. When he is told, “Fear God,” pride carries him into sin. Hell is enough for him—an evil resting place! 207. Among people is one who sells himself in pursuit of God’s good pleasure. God is tender towards His servants.

Language · Al-Akhnas and Ṣuhayb

I say: the verses were revealed concerning al-Akhnas ibn Sharīq al-Thaqafī and Ṣuhayb ibn Sinān al-Rūmī. Al-Akhnas was a man of handsome appearance and sweet speech. He professed friendship towards God’s Messenger, God bless him and grant him peace, and claimed Islam. He then apostatized and, passing Muslim crops and donkeys, killed the animals and ruined the crops. Ibn ʿAṭiyya says: “It has not been established that he embraced Islam.” I say: rather, the *Qāmūs* lists him among the Companions; consult it. Perhaps he repented after the verse’s revelation.

As for Ṣuhayb al-Rūmī, the associators seized and tortured him to make him turn back. He told them: "I am an old man: I will not benefit you if I am with you or harm you if I am against you. Leave me and the faith I follow, and take my wealth." They accepted. He came to Medina, and when the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, saw him, he said: "Your bargain has prospered, Abū Yaḥyā!"[B139]

It is also said that the verses concern the hypocrites and those who follow their way, and Muslims who sell themselves to God in fighting in His path and changing what is wrong. "In worldly life" is attached to "speech." "Fiercest in disputation" (ألد الخصام) means intensely contentious. The Tradition says: "The man most hated by God is the stubborn, contentious adversary." *Khiṣām* is either a verbal noun (مصدر) or the plural of *khaṣīm*, an adversary.

Outward commentary · Eloquence without inward soundness

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: among people are those whose tongues are sweet and whose hearts are ruined. When one speaks of worldly affairs, his speech pleases you through its polish and eloquence. He calls God to witness: he swears that it agrees with his heart and that his exterior agrees with his interior, although he is fiercely contentious and hostile towards Muslims—or the fiercest of adversaries.

When he turns away, departing from you, he goes through the land intending corruption, to spread corruption in it and destroy crops and offspring, as al-Akhnas did; or as the unjust do, whereupon God withholds rain and crops and offspring perish through the ill consequence of their sins. God does not love corruption: He does not approve it. Beware of His wrath.

When he is told, "Fear God and turn back from your corruption," pride seizes him: indignation and disdain, because of the sin he has committed, prevent him from leaving his error. Or indignation drives him into the sin he is commanded to avoid. Hell suffices him as punishment and torment. *Jahannam* is a proper name (عَلَم) for the abode of punishment, like "the Fire." What an evil resting place it is: an evil bed he has prepared for himself.

Concerning his opposite—Ṣuhayb, or everyone who gives himself to God—it was revealed: among people is one who sells himself, offering himself to God in fighting in His path and otherwise, seeking God's good pleasure and arrival in His presence. God is tender towards servants who act thus: He averts harms from them and brings them joys wherever they dwell in either abode.

Spiritual allusion · Adorning the exterior or cultivating the heart

People are of two kinds. One kind adorn their exteriors and ruin their interiors: outwardly beautiful, inwardly ugly. If they speak about the world or sensory appearances, their speech pleases you and their appearance delights you. If they speak of the Hereafter or inward meaning, they are seized by speechlessness and bewilderment. One of the revealed books says:

"Among God's servants are people whose tongues are sweeter than honey and whose hearts are more bitter than aloes. They dress before people in the softness of sheepskins and draw the world to themselves through religion. God Most High says: 'Are they deceived about Me, and do they dare defy Me? I have sworn to set over them a trial that will leave even their forbearing ones bewildered.'"[B140]

"Dress before people," and the remainder, is an allusion (كناية) to displaying gentleness and easy manners in order to deceive and delude people and reach one's own worldly interest. At the same time, such a person claims that his exterior agrees with his interior, although he is fiercely contentious towards God's folk. When he turns away from you, he occupies himself with sins and disobedience, spreading corruption in the earth and destroying crops and offspring through his sins' ill consequence. When reminded, he disdains and grows proud, seized by the indignation of ignorance. Distance in the fire of separation suffices him.

The second kind adorn their interiors and lay their exteriors waste. They cultivate their hearts with God's love and give themselves for His good pleasure. Their hearts are in the highest heights, their bodily forms in the lowest depths. They are the ones brought near, with the prophets and messengers. A gnostic said: "The more you lower yourself, earth upon earth, the higher your heart rises, heaven upon heaven. Whatever diminishes

from your sensory appearance increases in your inward meaning." The Tradition says: "Whoever humbles himself below his rank, God raises above his rank." And success is through God.[B141]

The Real then calls His servants to enter deeply into Islam.

2:208–209 · Entering wholly into submission

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 235–236

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا ادْخُلُوا فِي السِّلْمِ كَافَّةً وَلا تَتَّبِعُوا خُطُواتِ الشَّيْطانِ إِنَّهُ لَكُمْ عَدُوٌّ مُبِينٌ (208) فَإِنْ زَلَلْتُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَتْكُمُ الْبَيِّناتُ فَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَزِيزٌ حَكِيمٌ (209)

208. You who believe, enter wholly into submission, and do not follow Satan's footsteps. He is a manifest enemy to you. 209. If you slip after the clear proofs have come to you, know that God is Mighty, Wise.

Language · Submission and completeness

I say: *salm* or *silm* (السَّلْم، السِّلْم), with either vowel, means surrender and compliance. Interpreting it here as a peace settlement is remote. *Kāffatan* (كافة), "wholly," is a circumstantial expression (حال) relating both to the subject pronoun and to "submission," as in His saying, "She brought him to her people, carrying him" [19:27].[B142]

Outward commentary · Entering all the ordinances of Islam

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: you People of the Book who have believed in Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace, enter all the ordinances of Islam, neglecting none and turning to nothing else. It was revealed concerning ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and his companions, who entered Islam but wished to venerate the Sabbath and felt reluctance to eat camel meat. Or it concerns the hypocrites, who submitted outwardly but harboured hypocrisy inwardly. The Real tells them: you who believe out-

wardly, enter Islam altogether, outwardly and inwardly. Or it concerns Muslims, whom He commands to adhere to all Islam's ordinances and investigate their rulings and mysteries.

Do not follow Satan's footsteps: his paths leading to dividing and being divided. He is a manifest enemy to you, whose hostility is plain. If you slip from the straight road, dividing the parts of the Sacred Law or turning towards another law, after clear signs have come to you establishing the religion's truth and Muḥammad's prophethood, know that God is Mighty—prevailing, not unable to punish you—and Wise in granting respite until an appointed time.

Spiritual allusion · Making peace with God's decrees

The Real commands all His servants to make peace with Him and surrender to His decrees, so that no contention with His rulings or objection to His acts issues from them. Rather, they look at what emerges from the source of power (عنصر القدرة) and receive it with contentment and surrender (الرضى والتسليم), or patience and the effort to be patient (الصبر والتصبر), whether those acts appear through intermediaries or without intermediaries. There is no agent other than He; all is from God. If

you slip and object, or become displeased, after clear signs have come to you indicating the Real's oneness in His Essence, attributes and acts, know that God is Mighty, Wise. Punishing and distancing you do not defeat Him; in His wisdom, however, He grants respite without neglecting. God prevails in His purpose. Whoever repents, God turns towards in mercy.

He then mentions the threat against whoever opposes His command.

2:210 · The coming of God and the return of all affairs

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 236–237

هَلْ يَنْظُرُونَ إِلاَّ أَنْ يَأْتِيَهُمُ اللَّهُ فِي ظُلَلٍ مِنَ الْغَمامِ وَالْمَلائِكَةُ وَقُضِيَ الْأَمْرُ وَإِلَى اللَّهِ تُرْجَعُ الْأُمُورُ (210)

210. Are they waiting for anything but that God should come to them in canopies of cloud, and the angels, and the matter be decided? To God all affairs are returned.

Language · Canopies and cloud

I say: *ẓulal* (ظُلَل) is the plural of *ẓulla*, whatever shades you from above. *Ghamām* (الغمام) is fine, white cloud.

Theology · Theophany and judgement

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those who refuse to enter Islam's ordinances await only the Hour's arising and God's coming to decide between His servants in canopies of cloud. He discloses Himself to His servants in a manner befitting His majesty, for the Real's self-disclosures (تجليات الحق) are not confined. The angels come and surround them; the matter is decided through their punishment. To God all affairs return: He alone disposes of them.

Al-Mundhirī relates at length the Tradition concerning this self-disclosure, mentioning the descent, the judgement between His servants, and the crossing of the Bridge, with people in the lights of their faith. Al-Fāsī includes it in full in his gloss. One who has anointed the eye of inward sight with the antimony of the elect's realization of unity (التوحيد الخاص) will not find this Tradition and its like difficult to understand, because of the breadth of his gnosis's compass. And God Most High knows best.[B143] [71]

Spiritual allusion · Recognizing the Real without abandoning the Law

The verse threatens the veiled who have not truly made peace with God, but dispute with Him in the manifestations of His creatures and object to His decree and judgement. The Real tells them: do those who deny Me in My acts and object to My ruling and determination await anything but My making Myself known to them in canopies of cloud—the clouds of created effects (الآثار)? When they deny Me, the angels seize them and their destruction is decided. All affairs return to God.

71. Cairo editor, C236.1: Ithmid: a stone from which kohl is made. It is also said to mean kohl itself.

Let the servant therefore observe right comportment (الأدب) with his Master and entrust all affairs to God, for no existent is other than He. Whatever proceeds from servants is wholly from God. Whoever occupies himself with reproaching them misses right comportment with God—except in what the Sacred Law commands. There let him be like a servant disciplining his master's son: his hand disciplines while his heart reveres. And God Most High knows best and is most merciful. [72]

He then threatens the Children of Israel for not entering Islam, or for not adhering to all its ordinances.

2:211 · Changing the blessing after receiving it

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 237–237

سَلْ بَنِي إِسْرائِيلَ كَمْ آتَيْناهُمْ مِنْ آيَةٍ بَيِّنَةٍ وَمَنْ يُبَدِّلْ نِعْمَةَ اللَّهِ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَتْهُ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ شَدِيدُ الْعِقابِ (211)

211. Ask the Children of Israel how many a clear sign We gave them. Whoever changes God's blessing after it has come to him—God is severe in punishment.

Language · The construction of "how many"

I say: *kam* (كم) may be declarative or interrogative (خبرية أو استفهامية). It occupies an accusative position through an omitted verb understood after it, because it must stand initially (الصدرية): "How many [We gave]—We gave them." Or it is nominative as the subject (الابتداء), with the resumptive pronoun (العائد) omitted: "We gave it to them."

Translator's note: Cairo I:237 prints كم آياتنا آتيناهم. The closely parallel grammatical discussion in Ibn ʿAṭiyya's *al-Muḥarrar al-wajīz*, at 2:211, reads كم آتينا آتيناهم. This makes explicit the supplied verb "We gave" required by

72. Cairo editor, C236.2: That is: nothing exists in the true sense.

the preceding explanation. The rendering follows that strongly supported reconstruction; the Cairo wording is recorded here, and no manuscript confirmation is claimed.

Outward commentary · Signs received and then denied

The Real, glorious is His majesty, tells His Messenger—or every hearer—to ask the Children of Israel a question of rebuke: how many clear signs We gave them! That is, many a manifest sign concerning you, indicating your message's truth, your exalted rank and the greatness of your affair, through care for them and as a blessing to those among them who lived in your time. Yet they exchanged God's blessing for unbelief, denied it, concealed that blessing and were ungrateful for it. Whoever changes God's blessing after receiving it—God is severe in punishing one who denies His blessings and rejects His messengers. We seek refuge in God from withdrawal after giving, ingratitude for blessings and deprivation of His approval.

Spiritual allusion · Depriving oneself of a saint's blessing

What was said to the Children of Israel is said to one who recognizes the sainthood of one of God's saints, then denies and conceals it, deprives himself of that saint's blessing and dies in his sickness. He is told: whoever changes God's blessing after it has come to him—God is severe in punishment. His punishment is to meet God with an ailing heart and be raised among the ordinary people of the right hand, deprived of the rank of the near ones that follows the rank of the prophets and messengers. We seek refuge in God from deprivation and the evil outcome of abandonment.

The Real then identifies the cause of this deprivation: love of the world.

2:212 · Worldly adornment and the hidden works of the heart

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 237–238

زُيِّنَ لِلَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا الْحَياةُ الدُّنْيا وَيَسْخَرُونَ مِنَ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَالَّذِينَ اتَّقَوْا فَوْقَهُمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ وَاللَّهُ يَرْزُقُ مَنْ يَشاءُ بِغَيْرِ حِسابٍ (212)

212. Worldly life has been adorned for those who disbelieve, and they mock those who believe. Those who fear God will be above them on the Day of Resurrection. God provides for whom He wills without reckoning.

Language · The unexpressed agent

I say: “Has been adorned” (زُيِّن) is passive (مبني للمفعول). Its agent is God, for there is no agent other than He.

[Translator’s print-source notes: T12]

Outward commentary · The poor mocked in this world

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: worldly life has been adorned for the disbelievers, whether People of the Book or others. It has been made beautiful in their eyes and its love made to permeate their hearts, until they throw themselves upon it and turn away from everything else. Their hearts find no leisure for reflection and taking heed; their ears do not listen to admonition and reminder. It blinds and deafens them, and they confine their aspiration to it, until they mock those who turn away from it, such as poor Muslims and the People of the Bench. They ridicule them for rejecting the world and turning towards God. God raises these

to the highest heights and lowers the disbelievers to the lowest depths. They mock them in this world, but those who fear God will be above them on the Day of Resurrection: they are in the heights, the others in the lowest depths; or they are honoured, the others abased; or they will mock the others on the Day of Resurrection as the others mocked them in this world.

He expresses their state by Godfearingness because it causes their elevation and superiority. As for being mocked for poverty, poverty is an honour to the servant. Worldly abundance does not prove his honour: it may be a gradual drawing on towards punishment (استدراج), or it may be an aid. God provides for whom He wills without reckoning—that is, without prescribed measure. He gives worldly abundance as a gradual drawing on and a trial, and constricts provision for whom He wills as a test and purification. “He is not questioned about what He does, but they are questioned” [21:23].

Spiritual allusion · Inward work and outward incomprehension

Know that the work of the inward folk (أهل الباطن) is wholly inward and of the heart: reflection and taking heed, witnessing and inward perception—or, we may say, contemplation, vision and abiding in the Presence. They display of their works only the necessary obligations. Hence someone said: "When work reaches the hearts, the limbs rest." It is known that a particle of the heart's works is better than mountains of bodily works, because the heart's works are hidden: no angel sees them to record them, and no devil sees them to spoil them. Sincerity is realized in them. [73]

Moreover, "An hour's reflection is better than sixty years' worship." The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, was asked: "Which works are best?" He replied: "Knowledge of God." They said: "Messenger of God, we asked you about work." He replied: "Knowledge of God," and then said: "When knowledge of God is attained, little work suffices"—or as he said, blessings and peace be upon him.[B144]

Because the inward folk's works are hidden, the outward folk mock and belittle them, not seeing the works they see in worshippers and ascetics. Those who guard against witnessing anything other than God, or against everything that occupies them away from Him, will be above them on the Day of Resurrection: they are among the near ones, while the others are ordinary Muslims. God provides for whom He wills in both abodes without reckoning: without measure or restriction. He provides sciences and opens the treasuries of understanding to one who turns to his Master and empties his heart of everything else. And success is through God.

The Real then mentions the wisdom of sending messengers.

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73. Cairo editor, C238.1: Al-Sarrāj al-Ṭūsī attributes it in al-Lumaʿ to Abū Sulaymān al-Dārānī. Explaining its meaning, al-Sarrāj says: What Abū Sulaymān said admits two meanings. First, he meant that the limbs rest from the disciplines and hardships of outward works when a person occupies himself with guarding his heart and watching over his inner consciousness against distracting thoughts and blameworthy intrusions that divert his heart from remembering God Most High. Alternatively, he meant that a person becomes established in spiritual discipline, works and acts of worship, and they become his familiar home, until his heart takes pleasure in them and tastes their sweetness, while the fatigue and experience of pain that he felt before fall away. *[Translator: The facsimile clips a few final letters at the extreme left edge of several lines; they are supplied from the same-edition transcription, consistent with the al-Lumaʿ parallel.]*

2:213 · The one community, disagreement and prophetic guidance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 239–240

كانَ النَّاسُ أُمَّةً واحِدَةً فَبَعَثَ اللَّهُ النَّبِيِّينَ مُبَشِّرِينَ وَمُنْذِرِينَ وَأَنْزَلَ مَعَهُمُ الْكِتابَ بِالْحَقِّ لِيَحْكُمَ بَيْنَ النَّاسِ فِيمَا اخْتَلَفُوا فِيهِ وَمَا اخْتَلَفَ فِيهِ إِلاَّ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوهُ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَتْهُمُ الْبَيِّناتُ بَغْياً بَيْنَهُمْ فَهَدَى اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لِمَا اخْتَلَفُوا فِيهِ مِنَ الْحَقِّ بِإِذْنِهِ وَاللَّهُ يَهْدِي مَنْ يَشاءُ إِلى صِراطٍ مُسْتَقِيمٍ (213)

213. People were one community. Then God sent the prophets as bearers of good news and warning, and sent down with them the Book in truth, to judge between people concerning what they disputed. None disputed it except those given it, after the clear proofs had come to them, out of mutual aggression. Then God guided those who believed, by His leave, to the truth about which they disputed. God guides whom He wills to a straight path.

Language · An omitted disagreement and an expressed motive

I say: “Then He sent” (فبعث) is coordinated with something omitted (معطوف على محذوف): “then they disagreed, so He sent.” “Out of aggression” (بغياً) is an accusative of purpose or cause (مفعول له). “Of the truth” (من الحق) explains the relative “that about which” (ما).

Outward commentary · Revelation intended to unite, and knowledge turned into rivalry

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: in Adam’s time and the period near it, people were one community, one company agreeing upon unity and obedience. Afterwards they disagreed concerning divine unity. God then sent the prophets, bringing good news of abiding bliss to the people of unity and obedience, and warning the people of unbelief and disobedience of painful punishment.

He sent down with them the Book: the kind denoted by “books,” encompassing all heavenly scriptures. That Book was clothed in truth and indicated it, so that the Real, through the messengers’ tongues, might judge between people concerning their disagreements about divine unity and other matters. They then also disagreed concerning the revealed books: some believed, while others disbelieved in them or in part of them. None disagreed concerning the revealed Book except those given it, through envy or pride. Thus the Jews believed in the Torah and disbelieved in the Gospel, and the Christians believed in the Gospel and disbelieved in the Torah, after clear signs had come to them establishing the truth of the Book they rejected and commanding faith in it.[B145]

This unbelief arose only through mutual aggression and envy. God sent down knowledge to gather and unite them in His obedience, commanding them to come together through knowledge; they envied one another and disagreed in pursuit of leadership and standing. God then guided those who believed in Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, concerning what the People of the Book disputed: the truth the messengers brought. They believed in all of it and united in God’s obedience by His leave and will. God guides whom He wills to a straight path and leads whom He wills away from His upright way. “He is not questioned about what He does, but they are questioned” [21:23].

Spiritual allusion · The spirits’ original acknowledgement and their return

The original state of all spirits is agreement and acknowledgement. Disagreement and denial arise only after their entry into the world of bodily forms and their descent from the world of spirits. God sent the prophets to remind people of the ancient covenant. Those for whom happiness had preceded acknowledged it; those for whom wretchedness had preceded denied it. Hence the Prophet said: “Every newborn is born upon the original disposition (الفطرة); its parents make it a Jew, a Christian or a Magian.”

God then sent the sages, the gnostics of God, to treat the ignorance and denial that had overtaken

the spirit. Those for whom divine care preceded believed in them, affirmed them and surrendered wholly to them. They attained arrival and reached all they hoped for. Those for whom deprivation preceded did not attain faith in them and remained always bewildered in their hearts.

This denial generally comes only from people of leadership and standing, or those enslaved to their world and desire, through their aggression and envy. God guided those who believed—the people of original disposition and intention—to the truth about which others disagreed, by His leave. They attained affirmation and reached realization itself. God guides whom He wills to a straight path: the path of arrival at the Holy Presence, which was the dwelling of pure spirits. From it they came, and to it they returned. Concerning this Ibn al-Bannā, God be pleased with him, says:

> This reality of the soul is joined to the Holy Presence;
> only its bodily substrate impedes it,
> and from here the ascent begins.[B146]

Since love and guidance to its means are joined to trial, the Real mentions trial immediately after guidance.

2:214 · Trial, trembling and the nearness of help

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 240–241

أَمْ حَسِبْتُمْ أَنْ تَدْخُلُوا الْجَنَّةَ وَلَمَّا يَأْتِكُمْ مَثَلُ الَّذِينَ خَلَوْا مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ مَسَّتْهُمُ الْبَأْسَاءُ وَالضَّرَّاءُ وَزُلْزِلُوا حَتَّى يَقُولَ الرَّسُولُ وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا مَعَهُ مَتى نَصْرُ اللَّهِ أَلا إِنَّ نَصْرَ اللَّهِ قَرِيبٌ (214)

214. Or did you think you would enter the Garden before there came to you the like of what befell those who passed before you? Hardship and distress touched them, and they were shaken until the messenger and those who believed with him said, “When will God’s help come?” Indeed, God’s help is near.

Language · Expectation and the vivid presentation of a past scene

I say: *am* (أم) is discontinuous (منقطعة), meaning "rather," and includes a reproachful question (استفهام إنكاري). *Ḥasiba*, "to suppose," takes two objects: "Did you suppose entry into the Garden to be attainable without this coming upon you?" *Lammā* originally consists of *lam* with *mā* added. Unlike *lam*, it implies expectation of what it negates.

"Until the messenger says" (حتى يقول) permits the subjunctive (النصب) through an understood *an*, because the shaking precedes the messenger's speech. It also permits the indicative (الرفع), representing the situation as present (حكاية الحال): they were shaken until their condition then was that the messenger and those with him were saying such and such. The benefit of this representation is to present what occurred in past time as occurring now, depicting that astonishing situation and bringing its image before the hearer's witnessing. The indicative is required when a present situation is intended, because the subjunctive would imply *an*, which points forward, whereas present occurrence is incompatible with that. The causal *fāʾ* (الفاء السببية) can stand where *ḥattā* introduces this present situation.

Outward commentary · The trials of earlier believers

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says to the Messenger and believers, consoling and strengthening their hearts: did you suppose that you would enter the Garden before the like of what befell earlier prophets and their communities had befallen you? Hardship touched their wealth through seizure, pillage and loss; distress touched their bodies through killing in war, illness and varieties of affliction. They were shaken: struck by trials and hardships. Their affliction lasted, and help was delayed, until their condition brought them to say, "When will God's help come to us?" They found its coming slow in the intensity of their trial.

The Real gives them good news: indeed, God's help is near. Do not be hasty; "be patient: God is with the patient" [8:46], and "the final outcome belongs to the Godfearing" [7:128].

Spiritual allusion · Beauty reached through discipline under Majesty

The Garden is surrounded by hardships. There is no difference in this between the Garden of adornments and the Garden of gnoses (جنة الزخارف، جنة المعارف). Whoever seeks entry into the Garden of gnoses before any hardship touches him seeks the impossible. Abū al-Mawāhib said: "Reject anyone who claims to witness Beauty before being disciplined by Majesty: he is an impostor." A gnostic said: "The enemy's cry is God's whip, driving His saints' hearts away from repose in anything other than Him."

The *Ḥikam* says: "He made injury reach you through them only so that you would not repose in them. He wished to dislodge you from everything, so that you would repose in nothing." *[Translator's note: Cairo I, p. 241, reads* عليهم *(ʿalayhim, "upon them"). Ibn ʿAjība's own Īqāẓ al-himam quotes the same construction and then explicitly explains that God makes the injury reach you* على أيدي الخلق إليك*, "through other people's hands" (Dār al-Maʿārif, p. 488). The English follows this authorial explanation of the intended agency; the collated Arabic retains Cairo's wording. The second sentence also retains Cairo's distinct ending, "repose in nothing," rather than the Īqāẓ/Ḥikam ending, "nothing distracts you from Him."]* Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan, God be pleased with him, said: "O God, You decreed abasement upon the folk until they became mighty, and loss upon them until they found."[B147]

Allowing creatures power over God's saints at their beginnings is an established divine way and wisdom: "You will find no change in God's way" [33:62]. When they are freed of the remnants and their excellences are completed, He spreads their merit among His servants. People acknowledge them so that they may make known the path to God and direct servants towards Him. By then He has clothed them in the garment of Beauty and the garment of Majesty. Through Beauty's garment people come together around them and incline affectionately towards them; through Majesty's garment people obey their commands and listen to their words. And God Most High knows best.

When the Real commanded expenditure in fighting in His path and elsewhere, they asked what they should spend. God explained what should be spent and where it should be given.

2:215 · Where to spend wealth and where to offer the self

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 241–242

يَسْئَلُونَكَ ماذا يُنْفِقُونَ قُلْ ما أَنْفَقْتُمْ مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَلِلْوالِدَيْنِ وَالْأَقْرَبِينَ وَالْيَتامى وَالْمَساكِينِ وَابْنِ السَّبِيلِ وَما تَفْعَلُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ بِهِ عَلِيمٌ (215)

215. They ask you what they should spend. Say, “Whatever good you spend is for parents, close relatives, orphans, the needy and the traveller.” Whatever good you do, God knows it.

Language · What to give, and to whom

I say: *mādhā* (ماذا) may be the object of “spend,” or a subject and predicate (مبتدأ وخبر) with the resumptive pronoun omitted: “What is it that they should spend?” The questioner was ʿAmr ibn al-Jamūḥ, a wealthy man, who asked: “Messenger of God, what should we spend from our wealth, and where should we place it?” The verse was revealed.

Outward commentary · Priority among recipients

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: they ask you, Muḥammad, what they should spend from their wealth. Tell them: whatever good you spend—gold, silver, food, clothing, livestock or anything else—give it in order of greatest need and priority. Parents and close relatives come first, because giving to them combines maintaining kinship with charity; then orphans whose fathers have died, because their condition is diminished; the needy, because of their weakness; and the traveller, because he is away from home and needs what will enable him to return. Whatever good you do, God will recompense you for it: none of your conditions is hidden from Him. This expenditure is other than the obligatory alms (الزكاة); thus the verse is not abrogated. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Expenditure in sense and meaning

Expenditure is of two kinds: sensible and inward (حسي ومعنوي). Sensible expenditure is giving wealth and money; inward expenditure is giving spirits and selves. Whoever gives his wealth for God receives in exchange the Garden of adornments; whoever gives himself for God receives in exchange the Garden of gnoses. One who enters the Garden of gnoses does not yearn for the Garden of adornments.

Just as expenditure of wealth has a place to be directed, as the Real mentions here, expenditure of selves has its place: serving shaykhs who know God, and brethren through whom one seeks aid in arriving at God. It also includes those who need one: orphans with no shaykh, whom one guides and counsels; the weak and needy who cannot struggle against their lower selves, whom one strengthens by one's state or speech; and the stranger separated from the brethren, who finds nothing to assist his journey. One guides him towards companionship and gathering with the people of love. Shaykh Abū Madyan, God be pleased with him, points to this meaning:

> Be ever generous to the brethren, needing nothing from them,
> in sense and meaning; lower your gaze when one stumbles.[B148]

Having mentioned Islam's pillars—prayer, obligatory alms, fasting and pilgrimage—after pointing to the declaration of unity with "Your God is One God," the Real mentions fighting in His path, which preserves its order.

2:216 · What the self dislikes and what God knows to be good

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 242–243

كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الْقِتالُ وَهُوَ كُرْهٌ لَكُمْ وَعَسى أَنْ تَكْرَهُوا شَيْئاً وَهُوَ خَيْرٌ لَكُمْ وَعَسى أَنْ تُحِبُّوا شَيْئاً وَهُوَ شَرٌّ لَكُمْ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ وَأَنْتُمْ لا تَعْلَمُونَ (216)

216. Fighting is prescribed for you, although it is hateful to you. You may dislike a thing that is good for you, and love a thing that is bad for you. God knows, and you do not know.

Language · Hardship and aversion

I say: *kurh* (كُره), with *ḍamma*, names what is hard upon the self; with *fatḥa*, *karh*, it is the verbal noun (المصدر).

Outward commentary · Duties, desires and their outcomes

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: fighting in His path has been made obligatory for you. It is difficult for you and your selves dislike it, although it holds great good for you. You may dislike something that is good for you. Fighting brings victory for your religion, raises the word of your Islam, brings booty and victory over your enemy, and great reward with your Lord. Whoever dies is a martyr; whoever lives lives happily. So too with the other religious obligations (التكاليف): the self dislikes undertaking them, although its soundness depends upon them and they cause its flourishing.

You may love something that is bad for you. You may love rest and abandoning the struggle, although this brings your abasement, the enemy's ascendancy over you, loss of reward from your Lord and deprivation of martyrdom's rank with Him. So too with all prohibited things: the self naturally loves and greedily desires them, although they lead to its abasement and humiliation.

The Real uses "may" (عسى) because, when the self is disciplined, its condition is reversed: obedience becomes easy and disobedience difficult. God knows what serves your well-being, while you do not know, because you are ignorant of your affairs' outcomes.

Spiritual allusion · The successive struggles against the lower self

Struggle (الجهاد) is of two kinds: the lesser struggle, with the sword, and the greater struggle, against the lower self. One first struggles against it to fulfil every command and abandon every prohibition. Secondly, one struggles to abandon habitual comforts and desires and avoid concessions and accommodating interpretations (الرخص والتأويلات). Thirdly, one struggles to

abandon self-directed management and choice (التدبير والاختيار), resting beneath the flow of decrees until the self chooses only what the Real chooses for it and desires only what God decrees for it. The self is ignorant of outcomes: it may dislike what is good for it and love what is bad for it.

Joys may come from where it expects harms, and harms from where it hopes for joys. It may benefit at enemies' hands and suffer at loved ones' hands. It may dislike death although death is good for it, and love life although life is bad for it. What is required is to entrust affairs to their Creator, who knows what benefits them. God knows, and you do not know.

All this precedes the self's purification and perfection. When it has been refined and its discipline completed, however, one must follow what discloses itself within it, for only the Real discloses Himself there. This is the fruit of the greater struggle. None of this is attained through the lesser struggle; hence it is surpassed in the eyes of the people of the greater struggle. And success is through God.[B149] [74]

At the beginning of Islam, fighting was forbidden in the sacred months. Some Companions fought then, regretted it and felt distress; God removed that distress from them.

2:217–218 · Fighting in the sacred month, expulsion and steadfastness in faith

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 243–245

يَسْئَلُونَكَ عَنِ الشَّهْرِ الْحَرامِ قِتالٍ فِيهِ قُلْ قِتالٌ فِيهِ كَبِيرٌ وَصَدٌّ عَنْ
سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَكُفْرٌ بِهِ وَالْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرامِ وَإِخْراجُ أَهْلِهِ مِنْهُ أَكْبَرُ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ
وَالْفِتْنَةُ أَكْبَرُ مِنَ الْقَتْلِ وَلا يَزالُونَ يُقاتِلُونَكُمْ حَتَّى يَرُدُّوكُمْ عَنْ دِينِكُمْ
إِنِ اسْتَطاعُوا وَمَنْ يَرْتَدِدْ مِنْكُمْ عَنْ دِينِهِ فَيَمُتْ وَهُوَ كافِرٌ فَأُولئِكَ

74. Cairo editor, C243.1: This does not mean belittling the struggle against the enemies of religion; the Sufis have played a large and important role in it.

حَبِطَتْ أَعْمالُهُمْ فِي الدُّنْيا وَالْآخِرَةِ وَأُولئِكَ أَصْحابُ النَّارِ هُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (217) إِنَّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَالَّذِينَ هاجَرُوا وَجاهَدُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ أُولئِكَ يَرْجُونَ رَحْمَتَ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (218)

217. They ask you about the sacred month—fighting in it. Say, "Fighting in it is grave; but barring people from God's path, unbelief in Him, barring access to the Sacred Mosque and expelling its people from it are graver before God. Unbelief and turning people away from their religion (fitna) are graver than killing." They will continue fighting you until they turn you back from your religion, if they can. Whoever among you turns back from his religion and dies an unbeliever—those people's works have come to nothing in this world and the Hereafter. They are the inhabitants of the Fire, remaining in it. 218. Those who believe, and those who emigrate and strive in God's path, hope for God's mercy. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language · An inclusive substitution and a disputed coordination

I say: "Fighting" (قتال) is a substitution of inclusion (بدل اشتمال) for "the sacred month." There has been confusion concerning the coordination (العطف) of "the Sacred Mosque." The correct explanation is that of al-Zamakhsharī and Ibn ʿAṭiyya: it is coordinated with "the path," since this is the meaning that immediately suggests itself—barring from God's path and from the Sacred Mosque is a greater offence than the expedition's killing during the sacred month. Grammatical rules describe what generally obtains; they are not without exceptions.

[Translator's print-source notes: T13]

Outward commentary · The expedition and the opponents' greater wrongs

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: they ask you, Muḥammad, about the sacred month—that is, fighting during the sacred months. Tell them: fighting during the sacred month is a grave matter. Yet the disbelievers' barring people from God's path—preventing their entry into Islam and obedience—their unbelief in God, their barring Muslims from the Sacred Mosque in the

year of al-Ḥudaybiya, and their expulsion of Muslims from Mecca, their own homeland, together with the *fitna* of their unbelief and turning people from their religion, are graver offences than the fighting that occurred in the sacred month through an interpretation and the supposition that the sacred month had not yet begun.

The Prophet, God bless him and grant him peace, had sent an expedition under ʿAbd Allāh ibn Jaḥsh at the end of Jumādā al-Ākhira. They encountered ʿAmr ibn al-Ḥaḍramī with a group of Quraysh after sunset on [the final day of] Jumādā al-Ākhira, shot ʿAmr, killed him and took the booty. The Prophet told them: "I did not command you to kill in the sacred month." They regretted it. Quraysh sent a reproach to the Prophet: "How can you consider fighting in the sacred month lawful?" This verse was revealed. The prohibition of fighting during the sacred months was then abrogated by His saying, "Fight the associators all together, just as they fight you all together" [9:36].[B150]

The Real then warns against the disbelievers: they will continue fighting you until they turn you back from your religion, if they can—but they cannot accomplish that. Whoever among you turns back from his religion and persists until he dies an unbeliever, his works become void in this world: he has no protected standing and no share in revenue or booty. In the Hereafter he sees no reward for them. Such people are inhabitants of the Fire, remaining there.

The verse's implication (مفهوم الآية) is that, if he returns before death, his work does not become void. This is al-Shāfiʿī's position. Mālik says that the reward of everything he did becomes void; he repeats pilgrimage if it preceded his apostasy. His Islam is accepted if he returns. If he does not return, he is allowed three days and then put to death.[B151]

Theology · Hope is not an entitlement earned against God

When the verse removing blame was revealed, they thought they had no reward for that fighting. The Real therefore revealed: those who believe, and those who emigrate and strive in God's path, hope for God's mercy—His reward. God is Forgiving towards them, Merciful to them, and does not waste their striving in this expedition. The relative expression is repeated to magnify the standing of emigration and struggle. He uses hope to indic-

ate that work does not make reward obligatory: it is servanthood. The affair rests with God; He rewards if He wills and punishes if He wills. “He is not questioned about what He does, but they are questioned” [21:23].

Spiritual allusion · The sanctity of a gathering and the danger of turning back

The honour of a time or place is measured by the obedience to the King, the Requiter, that occurs in it. A time when the breezes of acceptance and turning towards God blow should not be a time of wrangling or fighting. This is the time of a gathering for remembrance or reminder, or sitting with

the gnostics, possessors of the elixir. Bad comportment there is grave; preventing those who seek it from reaching it is a grave offence; barring hearts from the breaths of that presence is graver still.

The brigands of this path never cease turning back those who wish truly to follow it. Yet no tyrant or obstinate person can turn from the Real one for whom divine support has preceded. One for whom deprivation preceded and abandonment was decreed turns back, even after direct vision. They recite:

> By God, we praise no unbridled one,
> whether drunk or sober;
> even if firmly set upon a swift journey,
> even if he drinks until effaced—
> not until he is cut down within the flock
> and turns with the turning of a millstone.[B152] 75

Those who believe and affirm God’s path, leave behind their desires to please God, and struggle against their selves in love of God—those hope for God’s mercy. The Generous One will not disappoint them, for He is Forgiving, Merciful.

Wine was lawful at the beginning of Islam. People drank and traded in it, giving its proceeds and gambling winnings in charity. After commanding expenditure, the Real clarifies this, so that charity does not become a pretext for laxity in dealings.

75. Cairo editor, C245.1: A zajal by al-Shushtarī.

2:219 · Wine, gambling and the measure of expenditure

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 245–248

يَسْئَلُونَكَ عَنِ الْخَمْرِ وَالْمَيْسِرِ قُلْ فِيهِما إِثْمٌ كَبِيرٌ وَمَنافِعُ لِلنَّاسِ
وَإِثْمُهُما أَكْبَرُ مِنْ نَفْعِهِما وَيَسْئَلُونَكَ مَاذَا يُنْفِقُونَ قُلِ الْعَفْوَ كَذلِكَ يُبَيِّنُ
اللَّهُ لَكُمُ الْآياتِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَفَكَّرُونَ (219)

219. They ask you about wine and gambling. Say, “In them are great sin and benefits for people, but their sin is greater than their benefit.” They ask you what they should spend. Say, “What can be spared.” Thus God makes the signs clear to you, so that you may reflect—

Language · What wine and gambling denote

I say: in language, *khamr* (الخمر) is what conceals and covers something; from this comes a woman’s head-covering (خمار). Wine is called *khamr* because it covers the intellect. In technical usage, it is what makes the intellect absent, without eliminating the senses, together with exhilaration and delight. God’s Messenger said: “Every intoxicant is wine, and every wine is forbidden.”

Concerning *maysir* (الميسر), Ibn ʿAbbās and al-Ḥasan said: every form of gambling is *maysir*, whether chess, backgammon or the like, even children’s games with nuts and knucklebones when money is staked. It is named *maysir* because of the player’s ease or enrichment (يُسر) through the money he takes. When there is no payment and it is merely play, however, there is no harm. Ibn ʿArafa states this.[B153]

[Translator’s print-source notes: T14]

Outward commentary · Benefits outweighed by sin

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: they ask you about the ruling on wine and gambling. Tell them: in them is great sin. Gambling involves consuming people's wealth wrongfully and causes hostility and rancour. Wine removes intellect and leads to abuse, slander, injury and aggression from its drinker.

Ḥamza and al-Kisāʾī read *kathīr*, with the three-dotted letter, "much" rather than *kabīr*, "great": many sins. For the Prophet said: "God curses wine, its seller, its buyer, the person for whom it is bought, its presser, the one for whom it is pressed,

its server, its drinker, its carrier, the one to whom it is carried and the consumer of its price." These are sins. In them are benefits for people: worldly benefits such as acquiring money without toil and feeding the poor from the proceeds, as the Arabs did with gambling. Wine offers pleasure and exhilaration, as Ḥassān, God be pleased with him, says:

> We drink it, and it leaves us kings,
> and lions whom no encounter holds in check. [76]

Their sin is greater than their benefit, because their benefit is worldly, while the punishment for their sin belongs to the Hereafter. This verse was revealed before prohibition.

Outward commentary · The stages of prohibition

It is related that, when His saying was revealed in Mecca, "From the fruits of date-palms and vines you take intoxicant and good provision" [16:67], Muslims drank it. Then ʿUmar, Muʿādh and a group of Companions said: "Give us a ruling on wine, Messenger of God: it removes the intellect." This verse was revealed. Some drank and others abstained.

ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf then invited people to his home. They drank and became intoxicated. He stood to lead them in prayer and recited: "Say, unbelievers, I worship what you worship," without the negation. "Do not approach prayer while intoxicated" [4:43] was then revealed, and they avoided it at prayer times.

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76. Cairo editor, C246.1: His words, "does not deter us": nahnaha means checking or restraining. The intended meaning is that we do not fear meeting the enemy.

ʿItbān ibn Mālik then invited Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ with a group. When intoxicated, they boasted and recited poetry to one another. Saʿd recited a poem satirizing the Helpers. A Helper struck him with a camel's jawbone and wounded his head. He complained to God's Messenger. ʿUmar said: "O God, give us a conclusive explanation concerning wine." Then "Wine and gambling…" was revealed through "Will you then desist?" [5:90–91]. ʿUmar said: "We have desisted, our Lord." End of report.

When some people drank after the prohibition, the Prophet would strike them with sandals and palm stalks, without a fixed number of blows. Abū Bakr and ʿUmar gave forty. The first to prescribe eighty was our master ʿUthmān, when people rushed into drinking. And God Most High knows best.[B154] [77]

Spiritual allusion · The intellect covered by darkness or overwhelmed by light

Know that the Real has given the intellect a light by which to distinguish truth from falsehood, harmful from beneficial, and Maker from made. This light may be covered by the darkness of clay: the intoxication of sensible wine. It may also be covered by dazzling lights from the Eternal Presence when they take it suddenly. It then becomes absent from sensory perception in witnessing inward lights, which are the mysteries of the Eternal Essence. It sees only the mysteries of eternal meanings and denies sensory, originated things. The Sufis call this absence "wine" because it shares with wine the intellect's absence. They sing of it in their poems and ecstasies.[B155] Ibn al-Fāriḍ, God be pleased with him, says:

> We drank a wine in remembrance of the Beloved;
> with it we were drunk before the vine was created. [78]

He then says:

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77. Cairo editor, C246.2: The transmitted account says that our master ʿUmar, may God be pleased with him, was the first to impose eighty lashes for drinking wine. See Fatḥ al-bārī, 12:70–75.

78. Cairo editor, C246.3: This poetry rests on Sufi terminology. In their expressions they mention wine by its names and attributes, intending the knowledge—or longing and love—that God causes to circulate through their innermost minds. "We became intoxicated" is a figurative expression for paying no heed to worldly concerns and life, while knowing God, mighty and majestic. As al-Ālūsī puts it, this is the intoxication of spirits, not bodies.

Let him weep for himself whose life is lost,
having no portion or share of it.

I said in my poem rhyming in *ʿayn*:

I burn with longing for the wine: in it are my rest,
my refreshment, my sweet fragrance and abundant good.
We grew drunk, then wandered in His beauty's splendour;
we vanished from sensation, while the light shone bright.

In the mode of spiritual allusion, gambling is the wealth acquired through this wine: being rich through God, free of need for all other than Him (الغنى بالله). "Say: in them is great sin": undertaking them entails great difficulty, yet there are benefits for people after undertaking them. In them is great sin for one who seeks wages, and benefits for people who seek presence and the lifting of veils. They recite:

Had I a helper who would aid me with the wine,
I would not wait for fast-breaking before drinking.
Wine is a noble thing for you to drink;
drink, though wine should load you with burdens.
You who blame me for a pure red wine,
take the gardens, and leave me to dwell in the fire. [79]

Ibn al-Fāriḍ says:

They said: "You drank sin!" No: I drank that
whose abandonment, to me, is sin.

Another says:

Sweet is the drinking of wine in solitude;
cup-companion, give me drink in vessels.
A wine whose abandonment is forbidden us,
with neither sin nor doubtful thing within it;
aged in jars before Adam,
its origin good, among good things.
Give me a ruling, jurist, and tell me:
may it be drunk upon ʿArafāt? [80]

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79. Cairo editor, C247.1: Ṣahbāʾ: wine.
80. Cairo editor, C247.2: He is al-Shushtarī.

In them is great sin in the eyes of the veiled, and great benefit for possessors of understanding—meaning eternal wine and richness through God. “Their sin is greater than their benefit” addresses people according to their understanding. Their sin is apparent to ordinary people: what appears

upon the intoxicated person of a ruined exterior and strange states. Their benefit is particular to the elect of the elect. Only the elect understand it; indeed, it must be concealed from those unqualified for it. And success is through God, who guides to the right way.

A third question then arose concerning how much should be spent. The Real indicates it:

Qur’ānic continuation · 2:219b

وَيَسْأَلُونَكَ مَاذَا يُنْفِقُونَ قُلِ الْعَفْوَ كَذَلِكَ يُبَيِّنُ اللَّهُ لَكُمُ الْآيَاتِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَفَكَّرُونَ

They ask you what they should spend. Say, “What can be spared.” Thus God makes the signs clear to you, so that you may reflect.

Language · What is easy to give, according to the giver

I say: *ʿafw* (العفو) is the opposite of strain: what is easy. Easy ground is called *ʿafw*. The intention is to spend what can readily be given without going to the point of hardship. Grammatically it is a predicate or object (خبر أو مفعول): “it is what can be spared,” or “they spend what can be spared.”

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: they ask you what amount they should spend. Tell them: what can be spared, easily given without hardship or harm to the giver through its loss. It is related that a man came to the Prophet with gold the size of an egg and said: “Take it from me as charity.” The Prophet turned away until the man repeated his request several times. Angrily he said, “Bring it,” and threw it back so forcefully that it would have wounded him had it struck him. He said: “One of you brings all his

wealth as charity and then sits begging from people! Charity should be given from a position of sufficiency." Al-Bayḍāwī relates this in abbreviated form.

I say: this differs according to certainty. The Truthful One, God be pleased with him, gave all his wealth, and ʿUmar gave half. The Prophet approved both while rejecting another person's action. This shows that what can be spared differs between people according to their certainty.[B156]

Thus God makes the signs clear to you: with an explanation like this, He explains the signs without leaving you perplexity or illusion, so that you may reflect with your intellects and adopt what returns benefit to you. Thus you reflect—

2:220 · Reflection upon the two abodes and care for orphans

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 248–250

فِي الدُّنْيا وَالْآخِرَةِ وَيَسْئَلُونَكَ عَنِ الْيَتامى قُلْ إِصْلاحٌ لَهُمْ خَيْرٌ وَإِنْ تُخالِطُوهُمْ فَإِخْوانُكُمْ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ الْمُفْسِدَ مِنَ الْمُصْلِحِ وَلَوْ شاءَ اللَّهُ لَأَعْنَتَكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَزِيزٌ حَكِيمٌ (220)

220. —upon this world and the Hereafter. They ask you about orphans. Say, "Setting their affairs right is best." If you share your lives with them, they are your brethren. God knows the one who corrupts from the one who sets right. Had God willed, He would have burdened you. God is Mighty, Wise.

Outward commentary · The world's passing and the Hereafter's permanence

—upon this world, how quickly it passes and changes for its people. When it approaches it is a trial; when it departs it is regret. Its seeker never fulfils his purpose in it, even if he possesses it entirely. Constricted in time and place, its prosperity ends in ruin, its affairs in reversal. Swift to disappear and soon to depart: thus you renounce it and raise your aspiration above it.

The Tradition relates that the Prophet said: “What have I to do with this world? My likeness in relation to it is that of a man travelling on a hot day who takes shade beneath a tree, then moves on and leaves it.” The scrolls of Abraham say: “I marvel at one certain of death: how does he rejoice? I marvel at one certain of the Fire: how does he laugh? I marvel at one certain of destiny: how does he toil? I marvel at one who sees the world and its changes for its people: how does he find repose in it?”[B157] They recite:

> This world is only a sleeper’s dreams;
> none of its delights abides.
> Remember a pleasure you enjoyed yesterday and exhausted:
> are you anything but one who dreamed?

You reflect upon the Hereafter, its enduring bliss, spacious expanse and delightful prospect. You desire arrival there and prepare to meet it, preferring it to this perishing abode. A sage said: “Were this world gold that perishes and the Hereafter clay that remains, the intelligent person should choose what remains over what perishes. How much more when the truth is the reverse: this world is clay that perishes, the Hereafter gold that remains. Only a fool of base aspiration chooses this abode.” And success is through God.

Spiritual allusion · Moderation in states and the ascent beyond both worlds

Just as the Real forbids excess in wealth, He forbids excess in spiritual states (الأحوال). Excess, as such, leads to weariness and interruption. “The work most beloved to God is that in which its doer perseveres, though little,” as the Tradition says. By God, we have seen no one excessive in states who did not grow weary and whose state did not weaken. The Tradition says: “Let none of you be like the overdriven traveller: he neither covers the ground nor preserves his mount.”[B158] The *Mabāḥith* says:

> Use skilful means with the self: many a stratagem
> avails more for victory than a tribe.

One continues to manage the self gently, little by little, until one masters and gains it. Once gained, it becomes a net for catching sciences and gnoses. It reflects upon this world, sees it passing and departs from it. Then it reflects upon the Hereafter and sees it enduring. When it seeks to settle there,

however, it sees that the Hereafter too is a created existence, and travels to its Creator. The Real removes its veil and admits it among the beloved. It becomes absent from the two worlds in witnessing their Maker; neither world nor Hereafter remains for it. It is now in delight and radiance, "looking towards its Lord" [75:23]. May God establish us in this exalted station. Amen.

They also asked about sharing life with orphans. The Real answered:

Qur'ānic continuation · 2:220b

وَيَسْأَلُونَكَ عَنِ الْيَتَامَى قُلْ إِصْلَاحٌ لَهُمْ خَيْرٌ وَإِنْ تُخَالِطُوهُمْ فَإِخْوَانُكُمْ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ الْمُفْسِدَ مِنَ الْمُصْلِحِ وَلَوْ شَاءَ اللَّهُ لَأَعْنَتَكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَزِيزٌ حَكِيمٌ

They ask you about orphans. Say, "Setting their affairs right is best." If you share your lives with them, they are your brethren. God knows the one who corrupts from the one who sets right. Had God willed, He would have burdened you. God is Mighty, Wise.

Language · Managing an orphan's property for the orphan's benefit

I say: *ʿanat* (العنت) is toil and hardship; "He would have burdened you" means made things hard for you.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: they ask you about mixing with orphans—combining an orphan's property with that of the testamentary guardian or caretaker so that they eat together. Tell them: do what sets the orphan's affairs right and better preserves the property. If mixing it with

the guardian's property better preserves it and leaves more of it, that is best: they are only your brethren in religion. If separating their property from yours and having them eat on their own preserves more, separation is best. God knows whose purpose is corruption and whose purpose is reform, and deals with each according to his intention. Had God willed, He would have commanded you to keep them separate and preserve their

property without qualification, putting you in difficulty and hardship. God is Mighty, prevailing, nothing defeating Him; Wise, doing nothing except for wisdom and benefit.

When His saying was revealed, “Those who consume orphans’ wealth wrongfully…” [4:10], the Companions felt distress about sharing life with orphans. They asked God’s Messenger and this verse was revealed.

Spiritual allusion · Those without a guide and the intention governing association

In the folk’s path, everyone without a shaykh is an orphan without a father. If he claims any spiritual election (الخصوصية), they call him a foundling or a claimant to someone other than his father. Shaykhs have continually warned against association with ordinary people and ignorant pretenders to spiritual poverty: those without a shaykh qualified to train them. They have even said: “Association with them is a deadly poison.” Someone said: “The disciple should avoid three kinds of people: ignorant pretenders to poverty, dissembling reciters and arrogant tyrants.”

I say: likewise the specialists in legal branches who are frozen upon the outward form of the Sacred Law. Companionship with them is worse than with all the others. Whoever is tried with associating with ordinary people should counsel them and guide them towards their religious good: they are brethren in religion. God knows the corrupter from the reformer. Whoever associates with them coveting wealth or status, God corrupts; whoever associates to counsel and guide, God sets right. Had God willed, He would have commanded the spiritually poor to withdraw from them altogether, but this entails difficulty and hardship. In His wisdom, He makes them a veil for the veiled and an entrance for people of understanding: a veil for the weak, an entrance and place of witnessing for the strong. And God Most High knows best.[B159]

After completing some matters of fighting in His path and their associated questions, the Real begins discussing marriage.

2:221 · Marriage, belief and the formation of companionship

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 250–252

وَلا تَنْكِحُوا الْمُشْرِكاتِ حَتَّى يُؤْمِنَّ وَلَأَمَةٌ مُؤْمِنَةٌ خَيْرٌ مِنْ مُشْرِكَةٍ وَلَوْ أَعْجَبَتْكُمْ وَلا تُنْكِحُوا الْمُشْرِكِينَ حَتَّى يُؤْمِنُوا وَلَعَبْدٌ مُؤْمِنٌ خَيْرٌ مِنْ مُشْرِكٍ وَلَوْ أَعْجَبَكُمْ أُولئِكَ يَدْعُونَ إِلَى النَّارِ وَاللَّهُ يَدْعُوا إِلَى الْجَنَّةِ وَالْمَغْفِرَةِ بِإِذْنِهِ وَيُبَيِّنُ آياتِهِ لِلنَّاسِ لَعَلَّهُمْ يَتَذَكَّرُونَ (221)

221. Do not marry women who associate others with God until they believe. A believing slave woman is better than an associating woman, though she please you. Do not give women in marriage to men who associate others with God until they believe. A believing slave is better than an associating man, though he please you. Those invite to the Fire; God invites to the Garden and forgiveness by His leave, and makes His signs clear to people so that they may take heed.

Outward commentary · Whom one may marry

I say: the Real begins by mentioning those eligible for marriage. The account will be completed in Sūrat al-Nisāʾ, in “Forbidden to you are your mothers…” [4:23].

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: do not marry women who associate others with God until they believe. Marriage to them is forbidden, unlike marriage to women of the Book, as in Sūrat al-Māʾida. Marrying a black believing slave woman is better than marrying an associating woman, though the latter please you in beauty, ancestry or wealth. Or the meaning is: a believing woman, enslaved or free, is better than an associating woman, since all women are God’s female servants.

It is related that the Prophet sent Marthad al-Ghanawī to Mecca to bring out some Muslims. A woman called ʿAnāq, whom he had loved in the Age of Ignorance, came to him and asked: “Will you not be alone with me?” He replied: “Islam has come between us.” She asked: “Would you marry me?” He said: “Yes, but I must consult God’s Messenger.” He consulted him, and the verse was revealed. Al-Bayḍāwī relates this.[B160]

Do not give women under your guardianship in marriage to associators. This is forbidden without qualification, since men have responsibility over women (قوامون على النساء), and an unbeliever is to have no authority over a Muslim woman. Do not therefore marry them to such men until they believe. A black, enslaved believer is better than an associator, though the latter please you in ancestry and wealth: no ancestry counts alongside unbelief.

Marriage with the people of unbelief is forbidden because they invite to unbelief, which causes the Fire. Companionship binds affection, and dispositions are imperceptibly borrowed (الطباع تُسرق); one cannot be secure that unbelief will not prevail over faith. God invites to the cause of forgiveness and purification from the stain of unbelief and sins, by His leave and power. He commands only what strengthens the bond of faith and certainty and arouses obedience: companionship with people of faith and certainty. He makes clear His signs that indicate His gathering His servants to Him, so that they may take heed, benefiting from their reminder and admonition.

Spiritual allusion · Do not befriend the self while it witnesses another

The spiritually poor person should not contract companionship and affection with his own self, or look upon it with compassion and mercy, while it associates others by witnessing what is other (شهود السوى), or naturally inclines towards desire. To possess a self believing through knowledge of unity is better than to possess a self associating through seeing another, even though its obedience and manifest uprightness please you. It may display obedience and service while concealing its own interests and enjoyment in them. Suspect it while it remains associating. When it believes and realizes God’s unity, seeing no other with Him, there is no harm in contracting marriage with it: it commands only what strengthens its witnessing and realization of unity.

Likewise, one should not contract the marriage of one's self and hand it to someone who witnesses otherness, whether a shaykh or a brother, even though his obedience and exertion please you. To accompany an ignorant person dissatisfied with himself is better than to accompany a learned person satisfied with himself. Those—the people ruled by their selves—invite to the fire of desires and interests, immediate or deferred. God invites to purification from witnessing others and entry into the presence of mysteries. This is only attained by the righteous gnostics, purified of turbidities and freed from witnessing others. Thus God explains His signs of oneness to people so that they may take heed and refrain from following desire or seeing the existence of anything other. And success is through God, who guides to the right way.

Having explained what is forbidden in marriage in itself, the Real explains what is forbidden in it because of a passing condition.

2:222–223 · Menstruation, purification and the field of cultivation

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 252–254

وَيَسْئَلُونَكَ عَنِ الْمَحِيضِ قُلْ هُوَ أَذىً فَاعْتَزِلُوا النِّساءَ فِي الْمَحِيضِ وَلا تَقْرَبُوهُنَّ حَتَّى يَطْهُرْنَ فَإِذا تَطَهَّرْنَ فَأْتُوهُنَّ مِنْ حَيْثُ أَمَرَكُمُ اللَّهُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ التَّوَّابِينَ وَيُحِبُّ الْمُتَطَهِّرِينَ (222) نِساؤُكُمْ حَرْثٌ لَكُمْ فَأْتُوا حَرْثَكُمْ أَنَّى شِئْتُمْ وَقَدِّمُوا لِأَنْفُسِكُمْ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّكُمْ مُلاقُوهُ وَبَشِّرِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ (223)

222. They ask you about menstruation. Say, "It is a hurt." Keep apart from women during menstruation, and do not approach them until they are clean. When they have purified themselves, approach them where God has commanded you. God loves those who repeatedly repent and loves those

who purify themselves. 223. Your wives are a field for you: approach your field as you will, and send something ahead for yourselves. Fear God and know that you will meet Him. Give good news to the believers.

Language · The interval of abstention and purification

I say: *maḥīḍ* (المحيض) is a verbal noun (مصدر), like *maqīl*, *maʿīsh* and *majīʾ*, meaning menstruation.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: they ask you, Muḥammad, about approaching women through intercourse during menstruation. Tell them: it is a hurt—harmful, or offensive and repellent, something a person of high aspiration would not consent to approach. Abstain from intercourse with women during menstruation. Do not approach them through intercourse in its place until they become clean through the blood's cessation and wash with water. When they have purified themselves with water, approach them where God has commanded you: the vagina, which He commanded you to avoid during menstruation, since it is the place where the seed is planted.

Whoever is overcome by his self and has intercourse during menstruation or postnatal bleeding should hasten to repent. God loves those who repeatedly repent: whenever they sin, they repent. According to the well-known position, no expiation (كفارة) is obligatory upon the man. Ibn ʿAbbās and al-Awzāʿī said: "Whoever has intercourse before washing gives half a dinar in charity; whoever does so while the blood is flowing gives a dinar." Abū Dāwūd transmits it as a Tradition. Whoever remains patient and keeps clear of this—God loves those who purify themselves from all sins and faults. He repeats the governing verb (العامل) because His love for those who keep clear is greater.[B161]

Al-Bayḍāwī says: "It is related that the people of the Age of Ignorance would neither share a dwelling nor eat with a menstruating woman, like the Jews and Magians. This continued until Abū al-Daḥdāḥ and a group of Companions asked about it, and the verse was revealed. Perhaps He mentions 'they ask you' three times without *wāw*, then three times with it, because the first questions occurred at separate times and the final three at one time; He therefore mentions the latter with the conjunction of combination." End of quotation.

Outward commentary · The field and the permitted place

The Real then explains how to approach women after purification: your wives are a field for you—the place of your cultivation. He compares the drops of seed cast into their wombs to seed, and the wombs to its soil. Approach your field, the place of cultivation, namely the vagina, as you will: from whichever direction you will.

It is related that the Jews used to say: whoever approaches his wife from behind into her vagina will have a cross-eyed child. This was mentioned to God's Messenger, and the verse was revealed. It is also said that Quraysh approached women from in front, lying on their backs, while the Helpers approached them from behind, kneeling. An Emigrant married a woman of the Helpers and wished to follow his custom, but she refused and wished to follow hers. They brought their disagreement to God's Messenger. The verse was revealed, giving the man a choice, provided he approached the proper place. Anal intercourse is forbidden, and its doer is cursed. The *Qūt* says: "Approach your field as you will: at whatever time and from whichever place you will, while the place [of intercourse] remains one." End of quotation.[B162]

Outward commentary · Presence at a moment of desire

The Real then warns against following sexual appetite and forgetting God: send ahead for yourselves what you will find stored with Him in reward—remembrance of God at the places where heedlessness is likely. It is said to mean invoking God's Name before intercourse; or seeking a child. The precise realization is presence with the Real when desire surges. A gnostic said: "I do not become absent from God even during intercourse." End of quotation. This is the state of the people of gathering (أهل الجمع): they do not separate from the Presence for an hour. This is the Godfearingness commanded in "Fear God": let not desire for women make you absent from Him. Know that you will meet Him and see heedlessness's evil consequence and wakefulness's reward. Give believers good news of nearness to the Lord of the worlds.

Spiritual allusion · Cultivating servanthood in the purified self

If you, gnostic, are asked about the self in its state of major impurity through heedlessness (جنابة الغفلة), clothed in the impurity of worldly love, say: it is a hurt, filth and impurity. Whoever approaches it is stained by it. Approaching it or keeping its companionship is not lawful until it is purified from heedlessness's major impurity through wakefulness, and from worldly love's impurity through renunciation and raising aspiration above it. When it is purified, approach it and return it to its Master's presence as God has commanded you.

God loves those who repeatedly repent: it has repented and returned to its Master. He loves those who purify themselves: it has cleansed itself of heedlessness's major impurity and kept clear of the world's impurity by raising aspiration. It has become for you soil in which to cultivate servanthood's duties and a place to plant the seed of witnessing Lordship's greatness. Approach your field, gnostics, as you will: plant in the soil of your selves whatever attributes of servanthood you will, whenever you will.

In proportion to the servanthood you plant, you harvest freedom (الحرية). In proportion to the abasement you plant, you harvest might; to the poverty you plant, wealth; to the humility you plant, honour and elevation. In sum, in proportion to what you plant of lower qualities, you harvest their higher opposites. He says: "We wished to favour those oppressed in the land, to make them leaders and inheritors, and establish them in the land" [28:5–6]. Leave the self untended and it grows thorns and bitter colocynth for you.

Send ahead for yourselves attributes of servanthood whose fruit you will find before you in witnessing Lordship. Fear God: witness none other with Him. Know that you will meet Him when you become absent from your existence and lose it. Give believers, certain in faith, good news of witnessing the Lord of the worlds.

After discussing some marriage rulings, the Real turns to the oath of abstention (الإيلاء): swearing not to touch one's wife or have intercourse with her. He first prohibits frequent swearing, since it causes people to fall into such oaths.

2:224–225 · Oaths, doing good and the heart's intention

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 254–255

وَلا تَجْعَلُوا اللَّهَ عُرْضَةً لِأَيْمانِكُمْ أَنْ تَبَرُّوا وَتَتَّقُوا وَتُصْلِحُوا بَيْنَ النَّاسِ وَاللَّهُ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ (224) لا يُؤاخِذُكُمُ اللَّهُ بِاللَّغْوِ فِي أَيْمانِكُمْ وَلكِنْ يُؤاخِذُكُمْ بِما كَسَبَتْ قُلُوبُكُمْ وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ حَلِيمٌ (225)

224. Do not make God an impediment, through your oaths, to doing good, fearing Him and setting matters right between people. God is Hearing, Knowing. 225. God does not take you to task for inadvertence in your oaths, but He takes you to task for what your hearts have earned. God is Forgiving, Forbearing.

Language · Making the divine Name a target for oaths

I say: *ʿurḍa* (عُرضة) is on the pattern *fuʿla* with the sense of the passive participle (مفعولة): something exposed and set up for your oaths. You swear by Him frequently until the Name of Majesty becomes commonplace among you. "That you do good" (أن تبروا) is an accusative of purpose or cause (مفعول من أجله).

Outward commentary · Breaking an oath to do what is better

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: do not expose God—that is, the Name of Majesty—to your oaths, making it commonplace through frequent swearing. You then refrain from good because of an oath, out of aversion to doing good—that is, beneficence—or to fearing God by placing a protection between yourselves and Him through right action. A man might swear not to maintain kinship, greet someone, guarantee anyone, sell on credit, lend, or give charity. All these are goodness and Godfearingness; God forbids swearing not to do them. Or someone swears not to reconcile people: such a swearer must break his oath and expiate it.

Hence the Prophet said: “I swear an oath, then see something better than it, so I expiate my oath and do what is better.” He told Ibn Samura: “When you swear an oath and see something else better than it, do what is better and expiate your oath.”

Or the Real says: do not expose God to your oaths by swearing by Him often. I prohibit this so that you may be good, Godfearing people who reconcile others. The habitual swearer is presumptuous towards God. One presumptuous towards Him is neither good and Godfearing nor trustworthy in reconciling people. God hears your oaths and knows your intentions.

Outward commentary · Two explanations of inadvertent oaths

The Real then removes difficulty concerning the inadvertent oath (يمين اللغو), which lacks intention: God does not take you to task for inadvertence in your oaths. It is what passes upon the tongue without purpose, as when a man says in ordinary speech, “No, by God,” or “Yes, by God.” Ibn ʿAbbās and ʿĀʾisha, God be pleased with them, explain it thus, and al-Shāfiʿī adopts this position.

Abū Hurayra, al-Ḥasan and Ibn ʿAbbās, in one of his two positions, say: it is swearing to what one believes, then discovering the contrary. Mālik adopts this position. The first better suits His saying: “But He takes you to task for what your hearts have earned”—what your hearts have firmly resolved. God is Forgiving in not taking you to task for inadvertence, Forbearing in not hastening to punish deliberate oaths, allowing time for repentance.[B163]

Spiritual allusion · The Name received with reverence

The Real says: do not make God a target for your oaths. Make Him instead the object of your hearts’ reverence and your secrets’ witnessing. I did not manifest My Name so that you would make it commonplace in oaths and disputes. I manifested it so that you would receive it with reverence and awe. Whoever reveres My Name reveres My Essence. Whoever reveres My Essence, I make great in My earth and among the inhabitants of My heavens. I make him good and Godfearing, one of the people of My love and affection, a caller who invites to knowledge of Me and sets right the relation between Me and My servants. Of My forbearance and tenderness is that I do not take to task for what passes upon the tongue, but for what the heart intends.

Outward commentary · Neither habitual swearing nor artificial refusal

Frequent swearing is blameworthy and indicates levity and rashness. Refusing to swear altogether is affectation. The best affairs are the middle ones. The Prophet would sometimes swear, saying, “No, by the Turner of hearts,” or “By Him in whose hand is Muḥammad’s soul.” And God Most High knows best.

The Real then indicates the ruling on the oath of abstention.

2:226–227 · The oath of abstention and the limit of estrangement

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 255–256

لِلَّذِينَ يُؤْلُونَ مِنْ نِسائِهِمْ تَرَبُّصُ أَرْبَعَةِ أَشْهُرٍ فَإِنْ فاؤُ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (226) وَإِنْ عَزَمُوا الطَّلاقَ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ (227)

226. For those who swear to abstain from their wives there is a waiting period of four months. If they return, God is Forgiving, Merciful. 227. If they resolve upon divorce, God is Hearing, Knowing.

Language · The oath of abstention

I say: *īlāʾ* (الإيلاء) is the oath of a legally responsible husband not to have intercourse with his wife for more than four months. *Ālā* means “swore” and takes the preposition *ʿalā*. Here, however, it includes the meaning of keeping away from the woman (التضمين), and therefore takes *min*. “A waiting period” (تربص) is the subject, and “for those who swear to abstain” its predicate.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those who distance themselves from their wives and swear not to have intercourse for more than four months, through anger and the intention to harm, have a waiting period of four months. During these they are not required to return or break the oath. If

they return from what they swore, break and expiate their oaths, God forgives the harm they intended through their return, which is like repentance. He is Merciful to them in not hastening to punish them.

If they resolve upon divorce, determining upon it and not returning from their oath, God hears their divorce and knows their purpose and intention. Mālik's and al-Shāfiʿī's position is that the judge puts the husband to a decision: he must return through intercourse if able, or through a promise if unable; otherwise, according to Mālik, the judge pronounces one revocable divorce against him. Abū Ḥanīfa's position is that she becomes irrevocably separated merely through the passing of four months. The rulings of *īlāʾ* are set out in the books of jurisprudence.[B164]

Spiritual allusion · Hostility to the self is a means, not the whole of life

The servant should not spend his entire life opposing and avoiding his self. The purpose is to occupy himself with love of the Beloved, not hostility towards the enemy. Struggling against and avoiding the self therefore has a known limit and a particular time: while it remains refractory

and ignorant of God. If it returns to God and becomes disciplined for His presence, loving it and making peace with it become obligatory. Through the self, those who gain have gained; through it, those who lose have lost. Whoever knows its worth and deals skilfully with it until returning it to its Lord gains. Whoever neglects it and fails to know its worth loses.

Our shaykh's shaykh used to say: "May God reward it well on our behalf! By God, we gained only through it"—meaning his self. Among the transmitted sayings is: "Whoever knows his self knows his Lord."[B165]

"If they resolve upon divorce": worshippers and ascetics resolve never to return to their selves. God hears and knows their purpose: is it seeking their own interests or loving the Beloved? Gnostics, however, retain no hostility towards anyone at all. They have made peace with existence in its entirety; God therefore enables them to exercise disposal within existence in its entirety. God is possessed of immense bounty.

The Real then mentions the waiting period following divorce.

2:228 · The waiting period, mutual rights and the care of the self

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 256–257

وَالْمُطَلَّقاتُ يَتَرَبَّصْنَ بِأَنْفُسِهِنَّ ثَلاثَةَ قُرُوءٍ وَلا يَحِلُّ لَهُنَّ أَنْ يَكْتُمْنَ ما خَلَقَ اللَّهُ فِي أَرْحامِهِنَّ إِنْ كُنَّ يُؤْمِنَّ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَبُعُولَتُهُنَّ أَحَقُّ بِرَدِّهِنَّ فِي ذلِكَ إِنْ أَرادُوا إِصْلاحاً وَلَهُنَّ مِثْلُ الَّذِي عَلَيْهِنَّ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَلِلرِّجالِ عَلَيْهِنَّ دَرَجَةٌ وَاللَّهُ عَزِيزٌ حَكِيمٌ (228)

228. Divorced women shall wait by themselves for three periods of purity (qurūʾ). It is not lawful for them to conceal what God has created in their wombs, if they believe in God and the Last Day. Their husbands have the stronger right to take them back during that time, if they desire reconciliation. Women have rights corresponding to their obligations, according to what is right; men have a degree over them. God is Mighty, Wise.

Language · The courses and the husbands

I say: according to Mālik, *qurʾ* (القُرء) is the interval of purity after menstruation. Its plural of paucity is *aqrāʾ*, and of multitude *qurūʾ* (جمع القلة، جمع الكثرة). The latter is used here with regard to the multitude of divorced women. “Three” is an absolute accusative or adverbial expression (مفعول مطلق أو ظرف). *Buʿūlatuhunna* (بعولتهن), “their husbands,” is the plural of *baʿl*; the *tāʾ* marks the collective as feminine.[B166]

Outward commentary · The waiting period and return for reconciliation

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: divorced women wait, refraining from marriage, by themselves for three courses—that is, intervals of purity. She counts the interval during which she was divorced, then menstruates,

becomes clean, menstruates and becomes clean. When she sees the third menstruation she leaves the waiting period. This applies to one who is not pregnant; the pregnant woman's waiting period ends when she gives birth.

It is not lawful for them to conceal what God has created in their wombs: a child, to hasten completion of the waiting period, or menstruation, to keep the period going. Her word is accepted in all this. If she believes in God and the Last Day, it is not lawful to conceal what has been entrusted to her. Their husbands have the stronger right to take them back during this waiting period if the divorce is revocable; otherwise she is separated from him. The husband should take her back during the waiting period if he intends reconciliation and affection, not harm. Otherwise taking her back is forbidden, for "there is neither harming nor reciprocating harm," as the Prophet said.

Spiritual allusion · Three purifications before reconciliation

When the self has been divorced and kept at a distance until purified three times, it may be taken back and peace made with it. The first purification is from persistence in sins and disobedience; the second from faults and heedlessness; the third from repose in habits and stopping with sensible forms rather than meanings and the lights of self-disclosure.

It is not lawful for such selves to conceal what God has created in their wombs: sciences, gnoses and lights. When the self looks out upon the presence of mysteries, it overflows with sciences and wisdoms,

or what cannot be counted. It should disclose these to one who follows its example. Their husbands have the stronger right to take them back and make peace after their purification is complete, if they intend reconciliation: bringing the self into the Presence and delighting it with witnessing and vision. And success is through God.

The Real then mentions the rights of marriage, saying:[B167]

Qur'ānic continuation · 2:228b

وَلَهُنَّ مِثْلُ الَّذِي عَلَيْهِنَّ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَلِلرِّجَالِ عَلَيْهِنَّ دَرَجَةٌ وَاللَّهُ عَزِيزٌ حَكِيمٌ

> Women have rights corresponding to their obligations, according to what is right; men have a degree over them. God is Mighty, Wise.

Outward commentary · Reciprocal duties and the stated degree

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: women have rights over men, just as men have rights over women. Women's rights over men are maintenance, clothing, sexual fulfilment and good companionship. Ibn ʿUmar, God be pleased with them both, used to say: "I like to adorn myself for the woman as she adorns herself for me," and he would recite this verse.[B167]

A man's rights over a woman include preparing food and bedding, obeying her husband in every permitted thing he commands, guarding her chastity and preserving the wealth entrusted to her, together with other rights. Women therefore have rights over men corresponding to their obligations, according to what is right, without harming or reciprocating harm, neglect or excess. Men have a degree over them: a distinction, since men have responsibility over women, and an advantage in inheritance, allotment and many rights. God has preferred them over women.

God is Mighty: punishing whoever disobeys His command does not defeat Him. He gives respite, however, without neglecting. He is Wise, acting only for a benefit, manifest or hidden. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The self's rights and the preservation of bodily health

The self has rights over its owner, just as he has rights over it. The Prophet said: "Your self has a right over you, your spouse has a right over you, and your Lord has a right over you. Give everyone who possesses a right his right."

The self is a ladle carrying the secret: when it grows weary, the secret falls from it. So with a person's self: if one burdens it until it sickens and pain enters it, many acts of worship become difficult, especially contemplation. Bodily human nature (البشرية) must therefore be preserved. The self should be "put to death" only through things that do not impair its health. It owes you obedience in what you command, just as you owe it protection from

what harms it. Strong men have authority and disposal over it: it is owned in their hands, and they prevail over it. God prevails in His purpose; He is the Mighty, the Wise.[B168]

The Real then mentions the number of divorces.

2:229–230 · The limits of divorce and release by compensation

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 258–259

الطَّلاقُ مَرَّتانِ فَإِمْساكٌ بِمَعْرُوفٍ أَوْ تَسْرِيحٌ بِإِحْسانٍ وَلا يَحِلُّ لَكُمْ أَنْ تَأْخُذُوا مِمَّا آتَيْتُمُوهُنَّ شَيْئاً إِلاَّ أَنْ يَخافا أَلاَّ يُقِيما حُدُودَ اللَّهِ فَإِنْ خِفْتُمْ أَلاَّ يُقِيما حُدُودَ اللَّهِ فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْهِما فِيمَا افْتَدَتْ بِهِ تِلْكَ حُدُودُ اللَّهِ فَلا تَعْتَدُوها وَمَنْ يَتَعَدَّ حُدُودَ اللَّهِ فَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الظَّالِمُونَ (229) فَإِنْ طَلَّقَها فَلا تَحِلُّ لَهُ مِنْ بَعْدُ حَتَّى تَنْكِحَ زَوْجاً غَيْرَهُ فَإِنْ طَلَّقَها فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْهِما أَنْ يَتَراجَعا إِنْ ظَنَّا أَنْ يُقِيما حُدُودَ اللَّهِ وَتِلْكَ حُدُودُ اللَّهِ يُبَيِّنُها لِقَوْمٍ يَعْلَمُونَ (230)

229. Divorce is twice; then retain in an honourable manner or release with kindness. It is not lawful for you to take back anything you gave them, unless the two fear that they cannot keep God's limits. If you fear that they cannot keep God's limits, there is no blame upon either in what she gives to secure her release. Those are God's limits: do not overstep them. Whoever oversteps God's limits—those are the wrongdoers. 230. If he divorces her, she is not lawful to him thereafter until she marries another husband. If that husband divorces her, there is no blame upon the two returning to one another, if they think they can keep God's limits. Those are God's limits, which He makes clear to people who know.

Language · Retention as a subject or a predicate

I say: “Then retention in an honourable manner” (فإمساك بمعروف) may be a subject with an omitted predicate: “is better” or “more fitting.” Or it is a predicate: “what is required is retention in an honourable manner or release with kindness.”

Outward commentary · Two revocable divorces and the prohibition of injury

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the divorce after which return is possible occurs only twice. If he divorces a third time, no return follows it. After one or two divorces, he has a choice: retain her, taking her back with good companionship and fulfilment of marital rights according to what is right; or release her until her waiting period expires, kindly, without injury or prolonging the waiting period.

It is not lawful for you husbands to take anything from the dower you gave them as compensation for release (الخُلع), unless the two fear that they cannot keep God’s limits: husband or wife thinks their life together will be unsound and marital rights will not be fulfilled. If you judges, or those acting for them, fear that they cannot keep God’s limits, there is no blame upon either in what she gives to free herself from the marriage bond (العصمة). The husband may take compensation, even everything she owns, if the harm arises from her or from both of them. If he alone inflicts the harm, taking compensation is forbidden to him and divorce is pronounced against him.

Those are God’s limits: do not overstep them. Whoever oversteps God’s limits is a wrongdoer. The rulings We mentioned concerning the number of divorces and taking compensation in its proper manner are the limits God set for His servants; whoever transgresses them wrongs.

Outward commentary · The third divorce and a subsequent marriage

If the husband divorces a third time, she is not lawful to him thereafter until she marries another husband and that husband consummates the marriage, without a condition of making her lawful to the first (التحليل). If the second husband divorces her, there is no blame upon the first two re-

turning through a new marriage, if they think they can fulfil marital rights and live together well. These rulings are God's limits, which the Real explains to people who know: who understand and consider matters.[B169]

Spiritual allusion · Divorcing the world and returning through God

If the disciple divorces the world, then returns to it, then repents and turns towards God, then returns to it, then repents and turns a second time, his repentance is accepted. If he returns after the second divorce, his flourishing is generally not to be hoped for, because he is playing. He says: divorce is

twice. Then retain it honourably, sharing it with those who need it, or release it from one's hand through God's kindness towards one, until He admits one into the station of excellence (الإحسان).

If he divorces it a third time, it is never lawful for him until he takes it from God's hand through God, after formerly taking it through his own self. It is as though he takes it through a new bond. If he becomes established in effacement and subsistence (الفناء والبقاء), there is no blame in returning to it while rich through God and free of need for it. And God Most High knows best.[B170]

The Real then forbids retaining a wife to injure her, as the people of the Age of Ignorance used to do.

2:231 · No retention for harm and no mockery of God’s signs

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 259–260

وَإِذا طَلَّقْتُمُ النِّساءَ فَبَلَغْنَ أَجَلَهُنَّ فَأَمْسِكُوهُنَّ بِمَعْرُوفٍ أَوْ سَرِّحُوهُنَّ بِمَعْرُوفٍ وَلا تُمْسِكُوهُنَّ ضِراراً لِتَعْتَدُوا وَمَنْ يَفْعَلْ ذلِكَ فَقَدْ ظَلَمَ نَفْسَهُ وَلا تَتَّخِذُوا آياتِ اللَّهِ هُزُواً وَاذْكُرُوا نِعْمَتَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ وَما أَنْزَلَ عَلَيْكُمْ مِنَ الْكِتابِ وَالْحِكْمَةِ يَعِظُكُمْ بِهِ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ (231)

231. When you divorce women and they approach the end of their term, retain them honourably or release them honourably. Do not retain them to cause harm and transgress. Whoever does that has wronged himself. Do not make a mockery of God’s signs. Remember God’s blessing upon you and what He sent down to you of the Book and wisdom, by which He admonishes you. Fear God, and know that God knows all things.

Language · Harm as intention or circumstance

I say: “To cause harm” (ضراراً) is an accusative of purpose or cause (مفعول له), or a circumstantial expression (حال): “while inflicting harm.”

Outward commentary · Ending the cycle of injurious revocation

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when you divorce women and the end of their waiting period draws near, retain them by taking them back while treating them honourably and kindly, or release them to marry others, honourably and without injury. Do not retain them with the intention of divorcing them again to cause harm, prolonging their waiting period and transgressing against them. Whoever does this wrongs himself.

It was revealed concerning a man who told his wife: “I will neither shelter you nor let you become lawful to another.” She asked how. He said: “I divorce you; when your waiting period is nearly over, I take you back.” She complained to God’s Messenger and the verse was revealed.

Some people would divorce or emancipate, then retract and say, “I was only joking and playing.” His saying was revealed: do not make a mockery of God’s signs. The Tradition says: “Three things are serious even in jest: marriage, divorce and taking a wife back.”[B171]

Remember God’s blessing upon you through guidance and the sending of the Messenger, and the Book He sent down, containing what you need outwardly and inwardly, together with wisdom—the purified Sunna. With these He admonishes and purifies you. Fear God in what He commands and forbids, and know that God knows everything: He knows your secret and public conduct and what you earn.

Spiritual allusion · The world in the hand, not in the heart

Those disciples who have stripped themselves of attachments are told: when you divorce the world and make your selves despair of returning to it, until certainty becomes established in the heart, concern over provision is cut off and doubts and illusions disappear, then, if the world returns, either hold it honourably—in your hand, not your heart—or release it from your hand because of the station of excellence God has given in exchange for it.

Do not hold the world, spiritually poor ones, before certainty is complete: it is harmful to you. It has captured grown men, let alone children. Whoever does this wrongs himself, depriving his self of arrival and leaving it to wander in the bewilderment of imaginings. Beware its immediate sweetness because of its bitter aftermath.

Do not make a mockery of God’s signs through concessions and accommodating interpretations. Remember His blessing upon you in guiding you to the Path, and the Book He sent down, which explains realization, together with wisdom, which is hitting upon the very reality of success. Fear God; repose in nothing other than Him. If your hearts incline to something other, or are drawn towards desire’s love, know that God knows everything: He will distance you after arrival. There is no power and no strength except through God, the High, the Magnificent.

The Real then forbids preventing women from marrying in order to harm them.

2:232 · Do not obstruct a woman’s remarriage

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 260–261

وَإِذا طَلَّقْتُمُ النِّساءَ فَبَلَغْنَ أَجَلَهُنَّ فَلا تَعْضُلُوهُنَّ أَنْ يَنْكِحْنَ أَزْواجَهُنَّ إِذا تَراضَوْا بَيْنَهُمْ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ ذلِكَ يُوعَظُ بِهِ مَنْ كانَ مِنْكُمْ يُؤْمِنُ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ ذلِكُمْ أَزْكى لَكُمْ وَأَطْهَرُ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ وَأَنْتُمْ لا تَعْلَمُونَ (232)

232. When you divorce women and they reach the end of their waiting period, do not prevent them from marrying their husbands when they agree between themselves in a right manner. This is the admonition given to whoever among you believes in God and the Last Day. That is more wholesome for you and purer. God knows, and you do not know.

Language · Obstruction and constraint

I say: *ʿaḍl* (العَضْل) means preventing, constraining and making something difficult. One says *aʿḍalat al-dajāja* when a hen has difficulty laying her egg.

Outward commentary · The guardian must not prevent an agreed marriage

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when you divorce women and their waiting period expires, do not prevent them, guardians, from marrying their husbands—those who previously held them in marriage and then divorced them—or other suitors, when they agree between themselves in a right manner: the men are suitable matches and offer a dower appropriate to the women, or the woman is of sound judgment in managing her affairs (رشيدة).

The person who believes in God and the Last Day takes admonition from what We have mentioned and abides by it, for admonition is effective in him and he benefits from the reminder. This raises your standing, if you hold fast to it, and purifies you from sins and faults. God knows what is conducive to your well-being, and you do not know.

The verse was revealed concerning Maʿqil ibn Yasār. He married his sister to a man, who divorced her and left her until her waiting period expired. The man then came to seek her hand again. Maʿqil said: “He left her until she became her own mistress, then came to seek her hand! By God, I shall never marry her to him.” The woman wanted to return to him. The verse was revealed, and Maʿqil withdrew from his oath and married her to the man. This provides evidence that a woman does not contract her own marriage, contrary to Abū Ḥanīfa. And God Most High knows best.[B172]

Spiritual allusion · Mature disciples and the use of worldly means

When shaykhs have ascertained the perfection of their disciples’ certainty and signs of sound judgment have appeared in them, they should not prevent them from engaging in means of livelihood or accepting what comes to them of this world, without looking eagerly for it or coveting it. This may assist them in religion and sustain the lodge of those who remember God. It is more wholesome for them and purer for their hearts: “God knows, and you do not know.”

God Most High then mentions the ruling on nursing.

2:233 · Nursing, mutual consultation and spiritual nurture

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 261–262

وَالْوالِداتُ يُرْضِعْنَ أَوْلادَهُنَّ حَوْلَيْنِ كامِلَيْنِ لِمَنْ أَرادَ أَنْ يُتِمَّ الرَّضاعَةَ وَعَلَى الْمَوْلُودِ لَهُ رِزْقُهُنَّ وَكِسْوَتُهُنَّ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ لا تُكَلَّفُ نَفْسٌ إِلاَّ وُسْعَها لا تُضَارَّ والِدَةٌ بِوَلَدِها وَلا مَوْلُودٌ لَهُ بِوَلَدِهِ وَعَلَى الْوارِثِ مِثْلُ ذلِكَ فَإِنْ

أَرادا فِصالاً عَنْ تَراضٍ مِنْهُما وَتَشاوُرٍ فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْهِما وَإِنْ أَرَدْتُمْ أَنْ تَسْتَرْضِعُوا أَوْلادَكُمْ فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْكُمْ إِذا سَلَّمْتُمْ ما آتَيْتُمْ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ بَصِيرٌ (233)

233. Mothers shall nurse their children for two complete years, for whoever desires to complete the nursing. The father shall provide their food and clothing in a right manner. No soul is charged beyond its capacity. No mother shall be harmed on account of her child, nor any father on account of his child. The heir bears a like duty. If the two desire weaning by mutual agreement and consultation, there is no blame upon them. If you wish to have your children nursed by another, there is no blame upon you, provided you hand over what you have agreed to give in a right manner. Be mindful of God, and know that God sees what you do.

Outward commentary · Nursing, maintenance and the child's welfare

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: mothers must nurse their children for two complete years when they remain in marriage and are not women of high social standing, since this is the customary practice; or when they are divorced and the child will accept no other nurse. This is for whoever desires to complete the nursing. If the two agree to wean the child earlier, it is permissible, as will follow.[B173]

The father—the one to whom the child is ascribed—must provide the food and clothing of his children's mothers, in a right manner. God charges no soul beyond what lies within its capacity and what it can bear. A mother is therefore not to be harmed on account of her child, by having to nurse while ill or when her milk has ceased; the father must instead hire someone to nurse the child. Nor is a father to be harmed on account of his child by being charged with maintenance and clothing beyond his means. If the father dies leaving property, the adult heir bears a like duty of clothing and maintenance, paying it out of the father's property and reckoning it against the child's share. If the father leaves no property, the duty falls upon the Muslim community.

If the father and nursing woman desire to wean the child before the completion of two years, by mutual agreement and consultation, there is no blame upon them, provided that no weakening of the child is feared. If you, husbands, wish to have your children nursed by someone other than their mother, with her consent, there is no blame upon you, provided you give the nurses the payment you intend to give in a right manner, without delay or stinting. This condition is stated by way of

perfection and good conduct. Be mindful of God concerning the rights with which you have been charged, and know that nothing in your affairs is hidden from God, for He sees what you do.

Spiritual allusion · The growth of sainthood and the responsibility of the guide

Know that the nurture of sainthood (الولاية) within the disciple's heart follows the pattern of nurturing a little child. It takes root in his heart when the bond of companionship is established between him and the shaykh. It then continues to grow, while the shaykh nurses him with the milk of spiritual support (الإمداد), until his period of nursing is complete. Hence their saying: "A dead breast does not nurse." They indicate by this that a deceased shaykh does not provide this formative nurture.[B174]

The shaykh continues to nurture and sustain the spirit until it enters the country of spiritual excellence (الإحسان) and its contemplative thought is kindled. This is the completion of its two years: the time when Reality and Sacred Law are brought to perfection, for whoever desires their completion. The spirit then eats of everything, drinks of everything, and draws nourishment from all things. The shaykh continues to attend it with his spiritual aspiration (الهمة) until it reaches maturity. He then releases it to act, and it becomes fit to nurture another.

The shaykh is responsible for feeding the disciples with the sustenance of hearts and clothing them in what protects them from sins and faults—except what the decree has already determined in the knowledge of the unseen, for no one has the power to repel that. "No soul is charged beyond its capacity." If the shaykh dies and designates someone to inherit his station, the heir bears a like duty.

If a disciple wishes to separate from the shaykh, establish a centre in another place or remind God's servants, by mutual agreement and consultation with the shaykh, there is no blame upon them. If you, shaykhs, wish to have your children nursed by sending someone to remind and sustain them as your deputy, there is no blame upon you, provided you impart to him the spiritual support through which he can sustain them. Be mindful of God in the affairs of disciples: mend their brokenness and accept their excuses. Know that God sees what you do.

The Real then mentions the waiting period following a husband's death.

2:234–235 · Widowhood, guarded proposals and the time of spiritual maturity

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 262–264

وَالَّذِينَ يُتَوَفَّوْنَ مِنْكُمْ وَيَذَرُونَ أَزْواجاً يَتَرَبَّصْنَ بِأَنْفُسِهِنَّ أَرْبَعَةَ أَشْهُرٍ وَعَشْراً فَإِذا بَلَغْنَ أَجَلَهُنَّ فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْكُمْ فِيما فَعَلْنَ فِي أَنْفُسِهِنَّ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَاللَّهُ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ خَبِيرٌ (234) وَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْكُمْ فِيما عَرَّضْتُمْ بِهِ مِنْ خِطْبَةِ النِّساءِ أَوْ أَكْنَنْتُمْ فِي أَنْفُسِكُمْ عَلِمَ اللَّهُ أَنَّكُمْ سَتَذْكُرُونَهُنَّ وَلكِنْ لا تُواعِدُوهُنَّ سِرًّا إِلاَّ أَنْ تَقُولُوا قَوْلاً مَعْرُوفاً وَلا تَعْزِمُوا عُقْدَةَ النِّكاحِ حَتَّى يَبْلُغَ الْكِتابُ أَجَلَهُ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ يَعْلَمُ مَا فِي أَنْفُسِكُمْ فَاحْذَرُوهُ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ حَلِيمٌ (235)

234. Those of you who die and leave wives behind: their wives shall wait by themselves for four months and ten days. When they reach the end of their term, there is no blame upon you concerning what they do with themselves in a right manner. God is aware of what you do. 235. There is no blame upon you for hinting at a proposal of marriage to women, or for concealing it within yourselves. God knows that you will mention them, but do not make promises to them in secret, except to speak in a right manner. Do not

resolve upon the marriage bond until the prescribed term reaches its end. Know that God knows what is within yourselves, so beware of Him; and know that God is Forgiving, Forbearing.

Language · The necessary ellipsis

I say: "Those who die" is the subject (مبتدأ), and "shall wait" the predicate (خبر). An ellipsis (حذف) must be supplied for the predication to be sound, either at the beginning or at the end: "The wives of those who die …," or "Those who die—their wives shall wait …".

Outward commentary · The widow's waiting period

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those of you who die, believers, and leave wives—the wives shall not marry until they have waited by themselves for four months and ten days. This is because a male foetus generally moves after three months, and a female after four; ten days are added as a precaution. This concerns the woman who is not pregnant. A pregnant woman's waiting period ends when she gives birth.[B175] [81]

When their waiting period expires, there is no blame upon you, guardians, concerning their adorning themselves, making themselves available for marriage or marrying, in a right manner: an adornment or marriage not disapproved by the Sacred Law. God is aware of what you do and will recompense you for what you have done.

Outward commentary · Allusion to marriage without a premature contract

There is no blame upon you, suitors, for hinting at a proposal to women in their waiting period. A man might say: "I am desirous of your companionship"; "I wish to marry at this time"; "You are much sought after"; or "It is not fitting that you remain without a husband"—and similar expressions.

81. Cairo editor, C263.1: Al-Bayḍāwī mentions this in Anwār al-tanzīl. It conflicts with the agreed-upon hadith, "The creation of each of you is brought together in his mother's womb …," continuing to the Prophet's words, "Then the angel is sent and breathes the spirit into him …." The apparent sense of the hadith indicates that the breathing of the spirit occurs after this period without qualification, with no distinction between male and female. Consult al-Ālūsī's commentary. *[Translator: The biological claim and the interpretation of the hadith belong to the Cairo editor.]*

Nor is there blame for concealing within yourselves during the waiting period a wish to marry, without declaring it openly. God knows that, out of eagerness and desire, you will mention women in their waiting period and discuss marrying them. You may therefore allude to this, but do not make promises to them in secret—that is, in private—or promise marriage or intercourse, except to speak in a right manner through the indirect expressions already mentioned. [82]

Do not conclude the marriage bond or determine to do so until the woman's prescribed term has ended and the waiting period expired. Know that God knows your desire and eagerness, so beware of Him. Someone's eagerness and desire for a thing before its time may be punished by being deprived of it. What has been allotted to you will not belong to another, and what belongs to another will not be yours, whatever you do. Know that God is Forgiving concerning your haste—for the human being was created hasty—and Forbearing: He does not hasten against you or expose your secrets.

Spiritual allusion · Do not seek the sciences of Reality before their time

When the self dies to desire and abandons its interests and appetites, it should not be returned to them until it has waited for a time, so that the effects of renunciation appear in it: resting in God and finding intimacy in witnessing Him, until it is absent from everything other than Him. When it attains this quality, there is no blame upon the disciple for allowing it what it does in a right manner, without excess or inclination towards desire. Its action is then through God, from God and towards God. God is aware of what you do: nothing concerning it is hidden from Him.

There is no blame upon you, disciples, when your selves have been purified and your hearts cleansed of other things, for hinting at a proposal to the virgins of the realities and the previously wedded women of the sciences, or for concealing within yourselves gnoses and understanding. God knows that you will mention these with the tongue before their taste has reached the heart. Do not therefore declare the sciences of Reality openly to everyone, for that is the conduct of the heretics (الزنادقة), except to speak in a right manner, through indication or allusion. Our knowledge is all allusion (إشارة); when it becomes explicit expression (عبارة), it is concealed.[B176]

82. Cairo editor, C263.2: Nāfiqa: that is, sought after.

Do not seek the knowledge of realities before its appointed time: the death of selves, renunciation of money, complete nurture and perfected purification. Know that God knows your eagerness for it before its time, so beware lest He punish you by withholding it. Know that God is Forgiving, Forbearing: He does not hasten to deprive you of your aim, if your purpose is sound. And God Most High knows best; and success is through God.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, then mentions divorce before consummation.

> **Translator's source note · Cairo I:263:** Ruslān's footnotes include an explanation of the cited embryological report and a lexical clarification.

2:236–237 · Divorce before consummation, compensation and generosity

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 264–266

لا جُناحَ عَلَيْكُمْ إِنْ طَلَّقْتُمُ النِّساءَ ما لَمْ تَمَسُّوهُنَّ أَوْ تَفْرِضُوا لَهُنَّ
فَرِيضَةً وَمَتِّعُوهُنَّ عَلَى الْمُوسِعِ قَدَرُهُ وَعَلَى الْمُقْتِرِ قَدَرُهُ مَتاعاً
بِالْمَعْرُوفِ حَقًّا عَلَى الْمُحْسِنِينَ (236) وَإِنْ طَلَّقْتُمُوهُنَّ مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ
تَمَسُّوهُنَّ وَقَدْ فَرَضْتُمْ لَهُنَّ فَرِيضَةً فَنِصْفُ ما فَرَضْتُمْ إِلاَّ أَنْ يَعْفُونَ أَوْ
يَعْفُوَا الَّذِي بِيَدِهِ عُقْدَةُ النِّكاحِ وَأَنْ تَعْفُوا أَقْرَبُ لِلتَّقْوى وَلا تَنْسَوُا
الْفَضْلَ بَيْنَكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ بَصِيرٌ (237)

236. There is no blame upon you if you divorce women before you have touched them or assigned them a dower. Give them a provision: the affluent according to his means and the straitened according to his means—a provision in a right manner, a duty upon those who do good. 237. If you divorce them before you have touched them, but have assigned them a

dower, then half of what you assigned is due, unless they remit it or the one who holds the marriage bond remits it. To remit is nearer to reverence. Do not forget generosity between you. God sees what you do.

Language · The temporal construction and the feminine plural

I say: *mā* (ما) is infinitival and temporal (مصدرية ظرفية). “Or assign” is coordinated with “touch”: you incur neither liability nor sin by divorcing women before consummation, during the period in which you have neither touched them nor assigned them a dower.

“Unless they remit” (إلا أن يعفون) is indeclinable because of its attachment to the feminine plural *nūn* (نون النسوة). Its pattern is *yafʿulna*, like “Prison is dearer to me than that to which they invite me” (يدعونني) [12:33], and “The women past childbearing who do not hope for marriage” (لا يرجون نكاحاً) [24:60]. “A duty” (حقاً) is an absolute accusative (مفعول مطلق).[B177]

Outward commentary · The compensatory gift and the assigned dower

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: there is no liability upon you in respect of sin or dower if you divorce women while you have neither touched them through intercourse nor assigned them a dower. You may then divorce them, but give them a provision: something from which they can benefit and which mends their brokenness, according to the husband’s circumstances. The affluent gives according to his means—a slave woman, clothing or money appropriate to his circumstances. The straitened man, whose livelihood has been restricted, gives what he can afford. Give them a provision in a right manner, without extravagance or stinting. It is a duty upon those who do good: it is truly due from them. Mālik understood the command as recommendation (ندب), while others understood it as obligation (وجوب); the latter is the apparent meaning.[B178]

If you divorce them after consummation, the full dower is due. If you divorce them before touching them but have assigned them a dower, half of what you assigned is due from you, unless the women remit their half, or the one who holds the marriage bond remits it. According to Mālik, this is the father in the case of his virgin daughter. According to al-Shāfiʿī, it is the husband, by paying the whole dower.

For you, guardians, to remit the husband's payment and take nothing from him is nearer to reverence, since the woman has lost nothing and her "goods" remain intact. Do not forget generosity and kindness between you. Be forbearing, and forbearance will be shown to you. God sees what you do; none of your deeds is hidden from Him. He recompenses the one who does good for his goodness, and God loves those who do good.[B178]

Spiritual allusion · Attraction before or after discipline

Some disciples attain absence from their selves and attraction away from them (الجذب) after having touched them with struggle and endurance. They then allow them the enjoyment of witnessing and direct vision (الشهود والعيان). This is the usual path. Others attain absence from the self and attraction away from it before touching it or struggling against it; this is rare compared with the first. To this latter group it is said: there is no blame upon you for divorcing your selves and becoming absent from them before touching them and before imposing upon them the observances of servanthood (وظائف العبودية).

Allow them the enjoyment of witnessing and direct vision according to your capacity and the strength of your witnessing. The one granted amplitude receives the delight of witnessing according to his capacity; the one whose gnosis remains restricted receives its delight according to his capacity. This is truly due from those who do good: those who have attained the station of spiritual excellence (مقام الإحسان) and gained witnessing and direct vision.

If the attraction of divine care reaches you and you divorce your selves before touching them, having already imposed upon them litanies (أوراد) among the observances of servanthood, then retain half of what you imposed: the essential part. Their worship has become inward, of the heart (قلبية), and the essential bodily worship (قالبية) suffices them—unless they are strong enough to combine the whole with witnessing, or the one who holds their marriage bond, the shaykh, commands them to do so. Occupation with these observances does not harm them when undertaken with permission.

For you, shaykhs, to remit some sensory worship from the disciples and direct them to worship of the heart is nearer to complete reverence: guarding against everything other than God (تقوى السوى). And God Most High knows best.[B179]

Having mentioned the affairs of women, the Real Most High warns against allowing them to distract one from worship.

2:238–239 · Guard the prayers, in security and in fear

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 266–267

حافِظُوا عَلَى الصَّلَواتِ وَالصَّلاةِ الْوُسْطى وَقُومُوا لِلَّهِ قانِتِينَ (238) فَإِنْ خِفْتُمْ فَرِجالاً أَوْ رُكْباناً فَإِذا أَمِنْتُمْ فَاذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ كَما عَلَّمَكُمْ ما لَمْ تَكُونُوا تَعْلَمُونَ (239)

238. Guard the prayers, and the middle prayer, and stand before God in devotion. 239. If you are afraid, then on foot or mounted. When you are secure, remember God as He taught you what you did not know.

Outward commentary · The appointed prayers and prayer in danger

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: guard also the performance of the five prayers at their appointed times, perfecting their conditions, essential acts, humility and proper manners (شروطها وأركانها وخشوعها وآدابها). Do not let desire for women, the troublesome disputes concerning their affairs, or anything else distract you from them. Guard especially the middle prayer. According to al-Shāfiʿī, it is the afternoon prayer, as the apparent meaning of the hadith indicates. According to Mālik, it is the dawn prayer, because of its excellence or its position between the two night prayers and the daytime prayers. Every prayer has been identified as the middle prayer. It is also said that it was concealed, like the hour of Friday and the Night of Power. [B180]

Stand before God in prayer *qānitīn* (قانتين): silent. Before this verse was revealed, speaking in prayer was permissible. Alternatively, it means obedient, for *qunūt* throughout the Qurʾān signifies obedience. If you fear an enemy, a wild beast or a flood, pray standing on your feet, gesturing for prostration, or mounted on your horses, gesturing for bowing and prostration. When you become secure, during the prayer or afterwards, perform the prayer of security. Remember God in prayer and pray in the manner He taught you, which you did not previously know.

Spiritual allusion · The prayer of the heart and the prayer of the limbs

Guard the sensory prayers, fulfilling the observances of servanthood, and the prayer of the heart, witnessing the majesty of Lordship. The latter is the middle prayer because it continues at every hour. Someone was asked: "Do hearts have a prayer?" He replied: "Yes. When the heart prostrates, it never raises its head again." That is, once it has bowed before the awe of divine majesty, it never rises. The poet says concerning this:

> Prostrate before the awe of Majesty
> at the drawing near;
> and recite the verse of perfection,
> the Seven Oft-Repeated.

By "the verse of perfection," he indicates: "You alone we worship, and from You alone we seek help," joining Sacred Law and Reality. The prostration of the heart is Reality; the prostration of the limbs is Sacred Law. Stand before God observing the manners of servanthood, devoted and humble.

If you fear that you will not reach your Lord before your allotted term expires, travel towards Him on foot or mounted, lightly or heavily laden. When you become secure from severance—and this is after firm establishment (التمكين)—remember God in gratitude for what He has disclosed to you and taught you, which you did not know: the majesty of Lordship and the perfection of the manners of servanthood.

The Real Most High then returns to the discussion of women.

2:240 · The widow’s provision and the preservation of spiritual knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 267–267

وَالَّذِينَ يُتَوَفَّوْنَ مِنْكُمْ وَيَذَرُونَ أَزْواجاً وَصِيَّةً لِأَزْواجِهِمْ مَتاعاً إِلَى الْحَوْلِ غَيْرَ إِخْراجٍ فَإِنْ خَرَجْنَ فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْكُمْ فِي ما فَعَلْنَ فِي أَنْفُسِهِنَّ مِنْ مَعْرُوفٍ وَاللَّهُ عَزِيزٌ حَكِيمٌ (240)

240. Those of you who die and leave wives behind shall make a bequest for their wives: provision for a year without being turned out. If they leave, there is no blame upon you concerning what they do with themselves in a right manner. God is Mighty, Wise.

Language · The bequest and the circumstantial expression

I say: in the nominative reading, “a bequest” (وصية) is the subject, with its predicate omitted: “A bequest is incumbent upon them.” In the accusative reading, it is an absolute accusative: “Let them make a bequest.” “Without being turned out” (غير إخراج) is a circumstantial expression (حال) referring to the wives: while they are not being expelled.

Outward commentary · The year’s provision and the account of abrogation

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those of you who die and leave wives behind must make a bequest for their wives, by which they can enjoy clothing, maintenance and lodging until the completion of a year, so long as the wives do not leave the husband’s dwelling. If they leave of their own accord, no maintenance, clothing or lodging is due from you, guardians. Nor is there blame upon you concerning their adorning themselves and making themselves available for marriage after the completion of their waiting period, in a manner recognised by the Sacred Law.

The bequest was abrogated by the inheritance verse, and the year's waiting period by "four months and ten days," which occurs earlier in the arrangement but was revealed later. God is Mighty, Wise: He abrogates what He wills and decrees what He desires, in accordance with wisdom and benefit. [B181] [83]

Spiritual allusion · Record the sciences, and guard their proper recipients

Those who die to personal interests and desires, leaving sciences and mysteries behind, should enjoin their preservation and recording. When spiritual gifts poured upon Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī and he became absorbed in speaking, he would say: "Is there no man who will record these sciences from us?" This is so that travellers and seekers may benefit from them, "without being turned out"—not disclosed to those unfit for them.

If the moment decrees that they emerge unintentionally, there is no blame: it may occur through an overpowering spiritual finding (وجد) or for a disciple's guidance. "God is Mighty, Wise." His might requires jealous protection of His mystery, lest one unfit for it receive it; His wisdom requires its appearance at its proper time to those fit for it. And God Most High knows best.

He then repeats the command to give a provision, for emphasis.

2:241–242 · Provision for divorced women and the sweetness of worship

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 267–268

وَلِلْمُطَلَّقاتِ مَتاعٌ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ حَقًّا عَلَى الْمُتَّقِينَ (241) كَذلِكَ يُبَيِّنُ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ آياتِهِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَعْقِلُونَ (242)

83. Cairo editor, C267.1: That is, earlier in the order of recitation.

241. For divorced women there shall be a provision in a right manner, a duty upon those who are mindful of God. 242. Thus God makes His signs clear to you, so that you may understand.

Outward commentary · Why the command is repeated

I say: He repeats it because the first verse concerns a woman divorced before consummation and before a dower has been assigned, whereas this concerns one whose marriage has been consummated. In the first, He speaks of "those who do good," because only people of goodness give this provision before consummation: the divorcing man has received no enjoyment from his wife. In the second case, however, reverence moves the man who divorces a wife after consummation to provide for her.

It is also said that when the first verse was revealed, a Muslim man said: "If I do good, I give her a provision; otherwise I leave it." The second was therefore revealed as confirmation. It says: "A duty upon those who are mindful"—who guard against associating partners with God; that is, upon every believer.

According to Mālik, its ruling is recommendation, with the distinctions mentioned in the *Mukhtaṣar*. There, in a list of recommended acts, he says: "The consolatory provision is according to his circumstances; in a revocable divorce, after the waiting period, or to her heirs—as for every woman divorced from a binding marriage, not a dissolution, such as mutual imprecation or one spouse's acquisition of the other. Exceptions are the woman who obtains release by compensation; one assigned a dower and divorced before consummation; and one who chooses separation because of her emancipation, his defect, an option given to her or delegated power of divorce."[B182]

Spiritual allusion · Two kinds of sweetness

Everyone who divorces his self and opposes its desire enjoys the sweetness of dealings with his Lord. One who has joined a shaykh of spiritual nurture enjoys the sweetness of inward worship, such as witnessing and direct vision. One who has not joined a shaykh enjoys the sweetness of sensory worship. The first verse thus concerns disciples and those who have arrived,

and this verse worshippers and ascetics. Hence the first speaks of “those who do good” (المحسنين), and the second of “those who are mindful” (المتقين). And God Most High knows best.

He then warns against flight from death, preparing the way for encouragement to struggle in His cause.

2:243 · Flight from death, the plague and life after effacement

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 268–270

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِينَ خَرَجُوا مِنْ دِيارِهِمْ وَهُمْ أُلُوفٌ حَذَرَ الْمَوْتِ فَقالَ لَهُمُ اللَّهُ مُوتُوا ثُمَّ أَحْياهُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَذُو فَضْلٍ عَلَى النَّاسِ وَلكِنَّ أَكْثَرَ النَّاسِ لا يَشْكُرُونَ (243)

243. Have you not considered those who left their homes in their thousands, fearing death? God said to them, “Die”; then He brought them to life. God is indeed bountiful towards people, but most people do not give thanks.

Language · A question that awakens wonder

I say: the question expresses wonder and awakens interest. The seeing is of the heart (رؤية قلبية); the *wāw* introduces a circumstance (واو الحال); and “fearing” (حذر) is an accusative of purpose (مفعول من أجله).

Outward commentary · Those who fled the plague

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: have you not looked, Muḥammad, with the eye of reflection and consideration, at those who left their homes in their thousands—ten, thirty, forty or seventy thousand—fearing death at a time of plague?

They were in a village called Dāwardān. When plague struck, one group fled and another remained. Most of those who remained perished, while those who left escaped. The latter returned, and the survivors said: "Had we done as they did, we would have remained alive. If plague strikes us a second time, we shall leave." It struck the following year. They all fled and descended into a broad valley. An angel called from its lower end, and another from its upper end: [84]

"Die!" They all died. Eight days or more passed until they swelled; it is also said that they became bones. God's prophet Ḥizqīl passed them, prayed to God Most High and interceded for them. God brought them to life. They lived for a long time with the mark of death upon them: any garment they wore became like a shroud. This continued among their descendants.[B183]

Al-Aṣmaʿī said: when plague struck Basra, a man left on a donkey with his family and a slave driving the donkey. The slave began to recite: [85]

> God cannot be outstripped upon a donkey,
> nor upon a flying, shaggy-maned steed;
> God may already stand before the night-traveller.

The man returned with his family.

Outward commentary · The author's discussion of flight, entry and contagion

The verse indicates that flight from plague was forbidden in that dispensation, as it is forbidden in ours. ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf related that the Prophet said: "When you hear of this epidemic in a land, do not enter it; when it occurs in a land while you are there, do not leave it."[B184]

I say: the imams disagreed over flight and entry. Some regarded prohibition in both as the recognised position, holding to the apparent meaning of the hadith; others regarded disapproval as the recognised position. The preferred ruling for flight is prohibition. For entry, a distinction is made:

84. Cairo editor, C268.1: Afyaḥ and fiyāḥ: any spacious place; hence the expression rawḍa fayḥāʾ, a spacious meadow.
85. Cairo editor, C269.1: Al-Qurṭubī gives the second verse in full: "Or death comes at an appointed measure; God may be before the night traveller."

someone whose certainty is strong and whose affirmation of unity is pure may enter; someone whose certainty is weak, so that if something befalls him he ascribes efficacy to other than God, may not enter.[B184]

In ʿĀʾisha's report, she says: "I asked, 'Messenger of God, what is plague?' He said: 'A swelling like the swelling of a camel. One who remains in it is like a martyr, and one who flees from it is like one who flees the battle line.'" Ibn Ḥajar said: the person who remains receives a martyr's reward only on condition that he knows nothing can befall him except what God has decreed for him, entrusts his affairs to Him and is content with His decree, and remains in his place without leaving in flight. When the person who stays fulfils these conditions, he receives the reward of martyrdom.

This includes three cases. First, one who possesses these qualities, contracts plague and dies: he is a martyr. Second, one who contracts it but does not die of it: he is a martyr, even if he dies afterwards. Third, one who never contracts it and dies of something else, sooner or later: he is a martyr if these three conditions are fulfilled. One who lacks the three conditions is not a martyr, even if he dies of plague. And God knows best. Here his words end.[B185]

As for coming from a plague-stricken land to one free from it, it is permissible, and the person is not prevented from entering. Al-Bājī, Ibn Ḥajar, al-Ḥaṭṭāb and others said this, on the basis of the Prophet's words: "There is no contagion and no evil omen." As for his words,

"Flee from the leper as you flee from a lion," and "Do not bring sick animals among healthy ones," these are understood as cutting off the occasion and blocking the means (سد الذريعة), lest something similar occur to the person who mixes with the sick, and he suppose that it was caused by the mixing, thus affirming the contagion negated by the Lawgiver. This is the preferred reconciliation of the two reports. And God Most High knows best. I have prolonged this discussion only because the need is pressing: this work was composed at a time of epidemic. May God preserve us from its harm.[B184]

Outward commentary · The alternative account and gratitude amid affliction

It is also said that those who left their homes were Israelites commanded to fight. Fearing death in battle, they left their homes to escape it. God caused them to die so that they would know nothing could save them from death, then brought them to life and commanded them to fight in His words: "Fight in the path of God."

"God is indeed bountiful towards people": He sent His mercy upon them, and they fled from it, yet He did not punish them, but brought them back to life after death. "But most people do not give thanks": only a few understand the blessings folded within afflictions and therefore thank God in both ease and adversity.

Spiritual allusion · Death to personal interests, life through gnosis

Have you not considered, listener, those who left the homes of their habits and the homelands of their desires? They are the company of those stripped of attachments (أهل التجريد), seeking purity of the affirmation of unity (التوحيد) and immersion in the sea of singleness (التفريد), fearing that their spirits might die through ignorance and separation (الفرق).

God chose them for His presence and drew them to witnessing His Essence. He said to them: "Die to your personal interests and become absent from your existence." When they died to their interests and became absent from their existence, God brought them to life through knowledge and gnosis. God is indeed bountiful towards people: He opened for them the door of wayfaring and prepared them to know the King of kings. But most people do not give thanks. He discloses Himself to them and makes Himself known, while they are unaware—except those whose inward sight God opens, and few they are.

The Real then urges the believers to struggle in His cause.

2:244 · Striving in God’s path

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 270–271

وَقاتِلُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ (244)

244. Fight in the path of God, and know that God is Hearing, Knowing.

Outward commentary · The intention of struggle

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: fight the unbelievers in God’s path, raising God’s word, until religion belongs wholly to God. Know that God hears your words and prayers and knows your intentions and sincerity. He recompenses the sincere and deprives those whose motives are mixed.

Spiritual allusion · Training the self until it accepts its Lord’s decree

Struggle against your selves on the path of reaching God, and persist in travelling towards His presence, for the presence of the All-Holy is forbidden to those still possessed by their selves. Al-Shushtarī said:

> If you desire union with us, your death is a condition;
> one in whom a remnant remains does not attain union.[B186]

Struggling against the self means making it bear what it finds burdensome and keeping it from what it finds easy, until nothing burdens it and it eagerly desires nothing. Its desire then becomes whatever its Master decrees for it. Someone was asked: “What do you desire?” He replied: “Whatever God decrees.” Know, travellers, that God hears your remembrances and knows your sincerity and purposes.

Since fighting requires the expense of preparation, and not everyone can afford it, the Real Most High encourages those with means to spend upon the poor.

2:245 · The goodly loan, contraction and expansion

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 271–273

مَنْ ذَا الَّذِي يُقْرِضُ اللَّهَ قَرْضاً حَسَناً فَيُضاعِفَهُ لَهُ أَضْعافاً كَثِيرَةً وَاللَّهُ يَقْبِضُ وَيَبْصُطُ وَإِلَيْهِ تُرْجَعُونَ (245)

245. Who is it that will lend God a goodly loan, so that He may multiply it for him many times over? God contracts and expands, and to Him you will be returned.

Language · Why charity is called a loan

I say: *qarḍ* (القرض) means cutting. It is applied to a loan because the lender cuts off a portion of his property and gives it to the borrower. Here it means charity: the donor gives it, and the Real Most High returns it to him multiplied many times. It thus resembles a loan in the general respect of being returned.

Outward commentary · Giving to God through giving to His servants

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: who will deal with God Most High and lend Him a goodly loan by giving His servants a good charity with a sincere intention? God will multiply it for him many times: seven hundredfold and beyond, without end. Fear of poverty must not make him abandon charity. God restricts provision for whom He wills, even if that person gives little, and expands provision for whom He wills, even if he gives much. Rather, He restricts the one who withholds his hand through avarice and miserliness, and expands the one who opens his hand in giving and generosity. He says: “Son of Adam, spend, and I shall spend upon you”; and, “Spend, and do not fear impoverishment from the Possessor of the Throne.”[B187]

Attributing the loan to God Most High encourages giving and brings the meaning within reach of understanding. Thus the sacred report (حديث قدسي) says:

“God Most High will say on the Day of Resurrection: ‘Son of Adam, I was ill and you did not visit Me.’ He will reply: ‘Lord, how could I visit You when You are Lord of the worlds?’ He will say: ‘Did you not know that My servant so-and-so was ill, and you did not visit him? Had you visited him, you would have found Me with him. Son of Adam, I asked you for food and you did not feed Me.’ He will reply: ‘Lord, how could I feed You when You are Lord of the worlds?’ He will say: ‘Did you not know that My servant so-and-so asked you for food, and you did not feed him? Had you fed him, you would have found that with Me. Son of Adam, I asked you for drink and you did not give Me drink.’ He will reply: ‘Lord, how could I give You drink when You are Lord of the worlds?’ He will say: ‘My servant so-and-so asked you for drink, and you did not give him drink. Had you given him drink, you would have found that with Me.’”[B187]

Spiritual allusion · Raising aspiration beyond the two worlds

Who will cut his heart free from love of the two abodes and raise his aspiration beyond the two worlds? God will multiply this for him many times by granting him mastery over existence and all it contains. “You are with created things so long as you do not witness their Maker. When you witness their Maker, created things

are with you.”

“God contracts and expands”: He gathers existence beneath your judgment and aspiration if you raise your aspiration beyond it, and extends your hand to exercise disposal within it if you attach your aspiration to its Creator. Or He contracts hearts through loss and loneliness, and expands them through intimacy and joy. Or He contracts spirits through death and expands them through life.

Spiritual allusion · The states of contraction and expansion

Among the people of Sufism, contraction and expansion (القبض والبسط) are two states that alternate upon hearts as night and day alternate. When fear predominates, the heart is contracted; when hope predominates, it is expanded. This is the state of travellers. As for those who have arrived, their fear and hope are balanced. Neither contraction nor expansion affects them, for they have become masters of states.[B188]

Al-Qushayrī said: when He unveils Himself to the servant through the quality of His beauty, He expands him; when He unveils Himself through the quality of His majesty, He contracts him. Contraction brings loneliness, and expansion brings intimacy. Know that He returns the servant to his human condition and contracts him until he cannot bear a speck; at another time He takes him away from his own attributes, and he finds power and capacity to bear whatever comes upon him.

Al-Shiblī said: "One who knows God can carry the heavens and earth upon a hair of his eyelid. One who does not know God—majestic and exalted is He—would cry out if the wing of a gnat were attached to him."

The people of gnosis said: "When He contracts, He contracts until no capacity remains; when He expands, He expands until no need remains. All is from Him and to Him." Whoever knows that God is the Contractor and Expander (القابض الباسط) reproaches no creature and rests in none, whether approaching or withdrawing. He does not despair of Him in affliction or settle into complacency with Him in a gift; he therefore never engages in self-directed planning. Here the quotation ends.

Spiritual allusion · The proper conduct of each state

Each of contraction and expansion has its proper manners (آداب). The manners of contraction are stillness beneath the courses of the decrees and awaiting relief from the Generous, the Forgiving. The manners of expansion are restraining the tongue, drawing in the reins and having modesty before the Generous Bestower. Expansion is a place where men's feet slip. One of them said: "A door of expansion opened to me. I slipped once and was veiled from my station for thirty years." Hence the saying: "Stand upon the carpet (البساط), but beware of overfamiliarity (الانبساط)."

Know that contraction and expansion are above fear and hope; above contraction and expansion are awe and intimacy (الهيبة والأنس). Fear and hope belong to believers; contraction and expansion to travellers; awe and intimacy to gnostics. Then comes effacement within the existence of the very Reality (المحو في وجود العين), for those firmly established. They have neither awe nor intimacy, neither knowledge nor sensation. They recited:

Had you truly been among the people of Being,
you would have been absent from created things, the Throne and the Footstool;
you would have stood with God, without a state,
preserved from recollection of jinn and humankind. [86]

The Real then relates the story of people commanded to fight who shrank from it, warning against resembling them.

2:246 · A request to fight and the test of resolve

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 273–274

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الْمَلَإِ مِنْ بَنِي إِسْرائِيلَ مِنْ بَعْدِ مُوسى إِذْ قالُوا لِنَبِيٍّ لَهُمُ ابْعَثْ لَنا مَلِكاً نُقاتِلْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ قالَ هَلْ عَسَيْتُمْ إِنْ كُتِبَ عَلَيْكُمُ الْقِتالُ أَلاَّ تُقاتِلُوا قالُوا وَما لَنا أَلاَّ نُقاتِلَ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَقَدْ أُخْرِجْنا مِنْ دِيارِنا وَأَبْنائِنا فَلَمَّا كُتِبَ عَلَيْهِمُ الْقِتالُ تَوَلَّوْا إِلاَّ قَلِيلاً مِنْهُمْ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ بِالظَّالِمِينَ (246)

246. Have you not considered the leaders of the Children of Israel after Moses, when they said to a prophet of theirs, “Appoint a king for us, so that we may fight in the path of God”? He said, “Might you, if fighting were prescribed for you, fail to fight?” They said, “Why should we not fight in the path of God, when we have been driven from our homes and our children?” Yet when fighting was prescribed for them, they turned away, except a few. God knows the wrongdoers.

86. Cairo editor, C272.1: These two verses occur in a story involving Abū Saʿīd al-Kharrāz, which al-Qushayrī mentions in the Risāla.

Outward commentary · The request and the anticipated retreat

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: have you not considered, Muḥammad, and taken a lesson from the story of a group of Israelites after Moses' death? They sought to fight and said to a prophet of theirs called Shumwīl, or, according to another account, Shamʿūn: "Appoint a king for us to govern our affairs and to whom we may refer our decisions, for warfare cannot be conducted properly without a leader. We shall fight with him in God's path."

Their prophet said: "Might you, if fighting were prescribed for you, fail to fight?" Are you likely to turn away and flee if fighting is prescribed? That is, I anticipate that you will shrink from fighting if it is made obligatory. The underlying construction is: "You may shrink if it is made obligatory." The interrogative *hal* (هل) is introduced before the verb of anticipation, questioning them about what he expects, to make them acknowledge and confirm their intention.

They replied: "What should prevent us from fighting in God's path when the cause that calls for it exists?" Their enemy had gained power over them, driven them from their homes and taken their children captive. God Most High had subjected them to Jālūt and the Amalekites with him, who inhabited the coast of the Sea of the Romans between Egypt and Palestine. This happened when they disobeyed and shed blood. He laid Jerusalem waste, burned the Torah, took the Ark through which they had obtained victory, and captured their women and children. It is related that he captured four hundred and forty sons of their kings.[B189] [87] [88]

They therefore asked their prophet to appoint a king with whom they could fight. When fighting was prescribed and He provided them with a king to govern them, Ṭālūt, they grew afraid and turned away, except for a few: those who crossed the river with Ṭālūt. God knows the wrongdoers; He disgraces them and brings their counsels to ruin. We seek God's protection from that.

87. Cairo editor, C273.1: It is now called the Mediterranean Sea.
88. Cairo editor, C273.2: Dharārī is the plural of dhurriyya, meaning offspring.

Spiritual allusion · The wish for a guide and the response when one appears

You see many people wishing they could find a shaykh of spiritual nurture. They say: “If we found him, we would struggle against our selves more than others.” Yet when he appears and becomes known for spiritual nurture, the person turns away and retreats, making excuses through denial and allegations of unfitness—except a few whom God singles out for His care. “God singles out for His mercy whom He wills”; “God is possessed of immense bounty.”

Glory to Him who has made the indication of His saints accessible only in the same manner as the indication of Himself, and who brings to them only those whom He wishes to bring to Himself.

He then identifies the king they had requested.

2:247 · Kingship is not measured by wealth or lineage

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 274–275

وَقالَ لَهُمْ نَبِيُّهُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ قَدْ بَعَثَ لَكُمْ طالُوتَ مَلِكاً قالُوا أَنَّى يَكُونُ لَهُ الْمُلْكُ عَلَيْنا وَنَحْنُ أَحَقُّ بِالْمُلْكِ مِنْهُ وَلَمْ يُؤْتَ سَعَةً مِنَ الْمالِ قالَ إِنَّ اللَّهَ اصْطَفاهُ عَلَيْكُمْ وَزادَهُ بَسْطَةً فِي الْعِلْمِ وَالْجِسْمِ وَاللَّهُ يُؤْتِي مُلْكَهُ مَنْ يَشاءُ وَاللَّهُ واسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ (247)

247. Their prophet said to them, “God has appointed Ṭālūt as king for you.” They said, “How can he have kingship over us when we have a stronger right to kingship than he, and he has not been given abundant wealth?” He said, “God has chosen him over you and increased him in knowledge and bodily stature. God grants His kingship to whom He wills. God is All-Encompassing, Knowing.”

Outward commentary · God's choice and the qualifications of the king

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: their prophet Shumwīl told them: "God has appointed a king for you"—designated him so that you may fight with him—namely Ṭālūt, a Hebrew proper name like Dāwūd.

In obstinacy and contentiousness, they said: "How can he have kingship over us?" How is he entitled to rule us when he is not of the royal house? Kingship belonged to the descendants of Judah, whereas Ṭālūt descended from Benjamin; prophecy belonged to the descendants of Levi. They said: "We have a stronger right to kingship than he," by inheritance and power, for the royal house is among us. Moreover, he is poor and has not been given wealth with which to strengthen himself against his enemy. Ṭālūt was a poor shepherd, water-carrier or tanner.[B189]

Their prophet said: "God has chosen him over you," despite your displeasure. Wahb ibn Munabbih said: God revealed to their prophet, "When a man enters your presence and the oil in the horn begins to seethe, he is their king." When Ṭālūt entered, the oil seethed. Al-Suddī said: God sent him a staff and said, "When a man as tall as this staff enters, he is their king." This proved to be Ṭālūt, and it became clear that God Most High had chosen him for kingship. [89] [90]

"He increased him in knowledge": he was the most knowledgeable Israelite in the Torah; or, according to another account, in warfare and the science of government.[B190] He also increased his bodily stature: the tallest Israelite reached only to his shoulder. This made his standing greater in people's hearts and strengthened him to resist the enemy and endure warfare. "God grants His kingship to whom He wills," for He is the King of kings,

placing His kingship wherever He wills. God is All-Encompassing: He enriches and enlarges the poor man's means without an intermediary cause. He knows who is fit for kingship, with or without such a cause.

He then mentions another sign indicating his kingship.

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89. Cairo editor, C274.1: Of water, nashsha (yanishshu; verbal nouns nashshan and nashīshan), or nashshasha: it made a sound when boiling.
90. Cairo editor, C274.2: Qarn is the horn of a bull or another animal. Here it means the vessel containing the oil; they used to make such vessels from the horns of cattle and other animals.

2:248 · The Ark, tranquillity and the signs of spiritual election

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 275–276

وَقالَ لَهُمْ نَبِيُّهُمْ إِنَّ آيَةَ مُلْكِهِ أَنْ يَأْتِيَكُمُ التَّابُوتُ فِيهِ سَكِينَةٌ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ وَبَقِيَّةٌ مِمَّا تَرَكَ آلُ مُوسى وَآلُ هارُونَ تَحْمِلُهُ الْمَلائِكَةُ إِنَّ فِي ذلِكَ لَآيَةً لَكُمْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ (248)

248. Their prophet said to them, “The sign of his kingship is that the Ark will come to you, bearing tranquillity from your Lord and a remnant of what the family of Moses and the family of Aaron left behind, carried by the angels. In that is indeed a sign for you, if you are believers.”

Language · The form of the word tābūt

I say: al-Jawharī said that the original form of *tābūt* (التابوت) is *tābuwa* (تابوة), like *tarquwa* (ترقوة), on the pattern *faʿluwa*. When the *wāw* was made quiescent, the feminine *hāʾ* became a *tāʾ*. Quraysh’s usage has *tāʾ*, and the Helpers’ usage *hāʾ*.[B191]

Outward commentary · The return of the Ark

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when they asked for proof that Ṭālūt had been chosen as king, their prophet told them: “The sign of his kingship is that the Ark will come to you.” It was a gilded chest of boxwood, three cubits long and two cubits broad. “In it is tranquillity from your Lord”: that through which your hearts find rest and remain firm in battle. They would place it before them in warfare, not flee, and receive victory over their enemy.

It is said that it contained representations of the prophets from Adam to Muḥammad. Another account says that it contained a gold basin in which the prophets’ hearts had been washed, and that this was the tranquillity

(السكينة). It also contained a remnant of what Moses' family left: fragments of the Tablets, Moses' staff and clothes, and Aaron's turban. "Family" (آل) is inserted in both expressions.[B191] [91]

"The angels carry it." Wahb said: when the Ark came into the possession of the people who had defeated Israel, they put it in a sanctuary containing idols. Each morning the idols were found broken. They carried it to another people's village, but pains afflicted that people. They said: "This is only because of this Ark; let us return it to Israel." They placed it on a cart, harnessed two cows to it and sent them towards Israel's land. God sent angels to drive the cows until they entered among the Israelites while these were occupied with Ṭālūt's affair. They then became certain of victory. Other accounts are also given.

"In that is indeed a sign for you, if you are believers" may be the words of their prophet, or the words of the Real Most High to our Prophet.

Spiritual allusion · The greatest wonders are certainty and faithful practice

Most selves will not acknowledge spiritual election (الخصوصية) in someone until its sign appears. Hence the unbelievers demanded miracles from the messengers, and ordinary people demand extraordinary gifts (كرامات) from saints. Yet the saint's outward uprightness and inward realization of certainty suffice.

Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan said: "There are only two comprehensive, all-embracing extraordinary gifts: the gift of faith, through increased certainty and the quality of direct vision; and the gift of action in accordance with the Sunna and following the Prophet, abandoning claims and deception. Someone given these two who then longs for something else is a fabricating liar, or mistaken in knowledge and action …"—to the end of his words.[B192]

In the *ʿAwārif* it is said: someone to whom nothing of the meanings of destiny (القدر) is unveiled may be better than one to whom they are unveiled, if God unveils to him pure gnosis. Power (القدرة) is an effect of the Powerful (القادر). One made fit for nearness to the Powerful finds nothing in power strange or excessive; he sees power disclosing itself through the

91. Cairo editor, C275.1: Ruḍāḍ of a thing: its broken pieces and fragments.

clouds formed by the parts of the world of wisdom. Extraordinary gifts appear only for unsettled hearts and wavering selves. Someone whose heart rests in certainty and whose self is tranquil through direct vision needs neither evidence nor proof. Firmly rooted mountains need no supporting prop. And God Most High knows best.

Everyone who demands a sensory wonder from people of spiritual election has an Israelite tendency in him. After their prophet had identified the person whom God honoured with the distinction of kingship, they said: "How can he have kingship over us when we have a stronger right to kingship than he?" The Real Most High answered them: "God grants His kingship to whom He wills." He showed them the wonder of the Ark only after they refused the fighting incumbent upon them, as a mercy to them. And God Most High knows best.

He then completes the story of their march towards the enemy.

2:249 · The river's test and the thirst of worldly desire

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 276–279

فَلَمَّا فَصَلَ طالُوتُ بِالْجُنُودِ قالَ إِنَّ اللَّهَ مُبْتَلِيكُمْ بِنَهَرٍ فَمَنْ شَرِبَ مِنْهُ
فَلَيْسَ مِنِّي وَمَنْ لَمْ يَطْعَمْهُ فَإِنَّهُ مِنِّي إِلاَّ مَنِ اغْتَرَفَ غُرْفَةً بِيَدِهِ
فَشَرِبُوا مِنْهُ إِلاَّ قَلِيلاً مِنْهُمْ فَلَمَّا جاوَزَهُ هُوَ وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا مَعَهُ قالُوا لا
طاقَةَ لَنَا الْيَوْمَ بِجالُوتَ وَجُنُودِهِ قالَ الَّذِينَ يَظُنُّونَ أَنَّهُمْ مُلاقُوا اللَّهِ
كَمْ مِنْ فِئَةٍ قَلِيلَةٍ غَلَبَتْ فِئَةً كَثِيرَةً بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ مَعَ الصَّابِرِينَ
(249)

249. When Ṭālūt set out with the forces, he said, "God will test you with a river. Whoever drinks from it is not of me; whoever does not taste it is of me—except one who scoops a single handful." Yet they drank from it, except a few. When he and those who believed with him had crossed it,

they said, “We have no strength today against Jālūt and his forces.” Those who expected to meet God said, “How many a small company has overcome a large company by God’s leave! God is with the steadfast.”

Language · Gharfa, ghirfa and ghurfa

I say: the *Qāmūs* states: *gharafa al-māʾa yaghrifuhu* means taking water with one’s hand, as does *ightarafahu*. *Gharfa*, with *fatḥa*, denotes a single act; *ghirfa*, with *kasra*, the manner of scooping; and *ghurfa*, with *ḍamma*, what is scooped, like *ghurāfa*, for before it is scooped one does not call it a *ghurfa*. It then says that *ghurfa*, with *ḍamma*, also means an upper chamber. [92]

Outward commentary · The testing of the army

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when they agreed to Ṭālūt’s kingship, he prepared to march, saying that only active young men, free from responsibilities and without ties left behind, should accompany him. Eighty thousand of those he selected assembled; another account says thirty thousand. [93]

When he departed his town with the forces and they travelled through the wilderness, in the heat of summer, they became thirsty and asked him to make a river flow for them. By revelation, inspiration or his prophet’s command, he told them: “God will test you with a river,” because of your request. “Whoever drinks from it”—lapping directly without an intervening vessel—“is not of me,” not of my army. “Whoever does not taste it is of me—except one who scoops a handful,” which will suffice him and his horse. The exception refers back to the first clause.

They drank from it, lapping and falling upon their faces, except a few: three hundred and fourteen, corresponding to the people of Badr; or, according to another account, a thousand. It is related that those who restricted them-

92. Cairo editor, C277.1: ʿUliyya, also pronounced with kasra on the ʿayn (ʿiliyya), is a room on the second level of a house or above it; its plural is ʿalālī.

93. Cairo editor, C277.2: That is, something to which he is attached; its plural is ʿulaq. Examples include trade, a wife with whom he has not yet consummated the marriage, and other such things.

selves to one handful found it sufficient for themselves and their animals. Those who did not became overwhelmed by thirst, their lips blackened, and they could not continue.[B193]

Ibn ʿAbbās is reported to have said that they drank according to the measure of their certainty. The unbelievers drank like thirst-stricken camels, and the disobedient less than that. Seventy-six thousand turned back. Some believers remained who drank nothing, while others took a handful. Those who drank became intensely thirsty and collapsed; those who left the water fared well and were stronger than those who took a handful.

The wisdom of this test was to single out the obedient and sincere for the struggle, since victory comes only through them. When Ṭālūt and those remaining with him who had not drunk crossed the river, some said to others: "We have no strength today against Jālūt and his forces," because they are many and we are few. Those certain that they would meet God, expecting the reward of martyrdom—the pure people of inward sight—said: "Do not be alarmed by their numbers. How many a small company has overcome a large company by God's leave," His will and assistance. *Kam* (كم) expresses multitude here. God is with the steadfast through victory and assistance.

Spiritual allusion · Take from the world only what is needed

One of the sages said: this world is like Ṭālūt's river. Only someone who does not drink, or scoops a handful, escapes it. Whoever takes only what is necessary finds it sufficient and becomes energetic in worshipping his Master. Whoever takes more than he needs is confined in its prison and held captive in its hand.

Someone said: the seeker of the world resembles a drinker of seawater—the more he drinks, the thirstier he becomes. The Prophet is quoted as saying: "Someone whose heart is made to drink love of the world becomes attached through it to three things: occupation whose toil never ends, hope whose limit is never reached, and eagerness whose utmost extent is never attained." Jesus said: "The world is Iblīs's field, and its people are his cultivators."[B194] 94

94. Cairo editor, C278.1: Iltāṭa: that is, adhered.

ʿAlī said: "The world is like a snake: soft to touch, deadly in its venom. Be most wary of it when most delighted by it. Whoever rests in it through familiarity is driven from it through estrangement."

The Prophet is also quoted as saying: "A sign of the world's insignificance before God is that He is disobeyed only within it, and what is with Him is attained only by abandoning it." Our master ʿAlī, may God ennoble his face, said: "The world begins in toil and ends in passing away. Its lawful things entail an accounting; its unlawful things punishment; its doubtful things reproach. Whoever becomes wealthy in it is tried; whoever becomes poor in it grieves."[B194]

It is said: the world approaches like a seeker and retreats like a fugitive. It joins like someone easily bored, and separates like someone in haste. Its good is little, its life short, its pleasures passing and its consequences enduring.

Jesus said: "You work for this world, although you are provided for in it without work. You do not work for the Hereafter, although you will receive no provision there except through work." It is also said that God revealed to the world: "Serve whoever serves Me, and make whoever serves you serve you."[B194]

ʿUmar ibn ʿAbd al-ʿAzīz used to cite these verses:

> Your day, deluded one, is heedlessness and neglect;
> your night is sleep, while sorrow clings to you.
> You delight in what passes and rejoice in wishes,
> as a dreamer delights in pleasures during sleep.
> The aftermath of your occupation with it you will hate:
> so do the beasts live in this world. [95]

Another said:

95. Cairo editor, C278.2: The verses are by Misʿar ibn Kidām, as recorded in Ḥilyat al-awliyāʾ, 7:220.

This abode is an abode of hurt and irritation,
an abode of passing away and change.
Even were you to obtain it in its entirety,
you would die without satisfying your desire for it.
You who hope for prolonged abiding—
prolonged abiding would harm you.
When you have aged and youth has passed,
there is no good in life after old age. [96]

The Real then relates the story of Jālūt and the kingship of David.

2:250–252 · David's victory and the good through which corruption is restrained

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 279–282

وَلَمَّا بَرَزُوا لِجالُوتَ وَجُنُودِهِ قالُوا رَبَّنا أَفْرِغْ عَلَيْنا صَبْراً وَثَبِّتْ أَقْدامَنا وَانْصُرْنا عَلَى الْقَوْمِ الْكافِرِينَ (250) فَهَزَمُوهُمْ بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ وَقَتَلَ داوُدُ جالُوتَ وَآتاهُ اللَّهُ الْمُلْكَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَعَلَّمَهُ مِمَّا يَشاءُ وَلَوْلا دَفْعُ اللَّهِ النَّاسَ بَعْضَهُمْ بِبَعْضٍ لَفَسَدَتِ الْأَرْضُ وَلكِنَّ اللَّهَ ذُو فَضْلٍ عَلَى الْعالَمِينَ (251) تِلْكَ آياتُ اللَّهِ نَتْلُوها عَلَيْكَ بِالْحَقِّ وَإِنَّكَ لَمِنَ الْمُرْسَلِينَ (252)

250. When they came forth against Jālūt and his forces, they said, "Our Lord, pour steadfastness upon us, make our feet firm, and grant us victory over the unbelieving people." 251. They routed them by God's leave, and David killed Jālūt. God gave him kingship and wisdom and taught him of whatever He willed. Were God not to repel some people by means of others,

96. Cairo editor, C278.3: He is Abū al-ʿAtāhiya.

the earth would be corrupted; but God is bountiful towards all worlds. 252. These are God's signs, which We recite to you in truth; and you are indeed one of the messengers.

Outward commentary · The ordered prayer for victory

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when Ṭālūt and those with him came forth against Jālūt, appearing in the open ground and drawing near one another, they humbly supplicated God and sought His victory: "Our Lord, pour steadfastness upon us"—pour it forth abundantly—"make our feet firm" at the encounter, lest we flee, "and grant us victory over the unbelieving people."

Their supplication has an eloquent order. First they ask that steadfastness be poured into their hearts, since it is the foundation of the affair; then for firmness of foot in the slippery places of battle, which results from it; then for victory over the enemy, which ordinarily follows these two. God routed their enemy and answered their prayer by His leave and power.

[Translator's print-source notes: T15]

Outward commentary · David and Jālūt

"David killed Jālūt." The account of his killing is this. Among Ṭālūt's companions were six or seven sons of Īsh, David's father. David was a young boy tending sheep. When battle approached, he said to himself: "I shall go and see this battle." On his way he passed a stone, which called: "David, take me; through me you will kill Jālūt." Another stone called, then another. He took them, put them in his bag and continued.

When the fighting began, Jālūt came out demanding single combat. The men *kāʿū* (كاعوا): they drew back in fear. Ṭālūt said: "Whoever goes out to him and kills him, I shall marry to my daughter and give authority over my property." David came forward. Ṭālūt told him to mount his horse and take his arms. He did so and went out in splendid form. After a short distance,

however, he returned. The men said: “The youth has lost courage.” David replied: “Unless God Most High kills him and assists me against him, this horse and arms will not benefit me. I prefer to fight him [97] [98] [99] [100]

in my customary manner.”

David was among the most skilful men with a sling. He dismounted, slung his bag over himself, took his sling and went out against Jālūt, who was fully armed. Jālūt said: “You, boy, come out against me?” He replied: “Yes.” “Like this, as you would go out against a dog?” “Yes—and you are more contemptible.” Jālūt said: “Today I shall feed your flesh to birds and beasts.”

They drew near. David took his sling and reached for the stones. It is related that they joined into a single stone. He put it into the sling, named God, swung it and released it. It struck Jālūt’s head and killed him. He cut off his head and put it in his bag. The forces became intermingled, Ṭālūt’s companions charged, and the rout followed.

David then asked Ṭālūt to fulfil his promise. He replied: “Not until you kill two hundred of these Jarājima who harm people and bring me their spoils.” David killed two hundred and brought them. Ṭālūt gave him his bride and relinquished kingship to him. When David was established as king, he expelled the remaining people of Jālūt to the Maghrib. The Berbers—the Shlūḥ and the inhabitants of the other rural regions—are said here to be their remnant.[B195]

Theology · The means by which God repels corruption

God gave David kingship and wisdom: prophecy; or, according to another explanation, the craft of making coats of mail and the speech of birds. He taught him of whatever He willed: kinds of sciences, gnoses and mysteries. God repelled the might of the unbelievers and turned their plotting back upon them.

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97. Cairo editor, C279.1: Kāʿa fulān: the man became cowardly and weak.
98. Cairo editor, C280.1: One says rajul shākī al-silāḥ of a fully armed man.
99. Cairo editor, C280.2: The Jarājima: a non-Arab people in al-Jazīra. It is also said that the Jarājima are the Nabataeans of Syria.
100. Cairo editor, C280.3: All these stories have weak chains of transmission, as Ibn ʿAṭiyya said. Dr Abū Shahba said: “We have no need for these stories, given the Quran and Sunna in our possession; we need none of this to understand and reflect upon the Quran.” See Dr Abū Shahba’s al-Isrāʾīliyyāt wa-l-mawḍūʿāt; may God have mercy on him.

"Were God not to repel some people by means of others, the earth would be corrupted." Were He not to give Muslims victory over unbelievers and restrain their corruption, the latter would prevail and spread corruption on earth. Alternatively, were God not to establish rulers and judges to give the oppressed justice against the oppressor and restrain the strong from the weak, people would spring at one another, the strong consume the weak, and the order of things collapse.

Or, were God not to protect property, lives, blood and honour through witnesses, corruption would arise on earth. Or, were God not to repel affliction from the heedless and disobedient through the people of obedience and goodness, the earth would be corrupted through the ill effects of disobedience.

A report from the Prophet says: "Through those of my community who pray, God repels affliction from those who do not pray; through those who give alms, from those who do not give alms; through those who fast,

from those who do not fast; through those who make pilgrimage, from those who do not; and through those who fight in His cause, from those who do not. Were they all to abandon these things, God would not grant them respite for the blink of an eye." Another report says: "Were it not for servants of God bowing in prayer and infants suckling, punishment would be poured upon you abundantly."[B196]

Jābir related that the Messenger of God said: "Through a man's righteousness, God sets right his child, his child's child, the people of his little household and the households around him. They remain in God's protection so long as he is among them." This is God's bounty towards His servants: He sets right their corrupt through their righteous and accepts the intercession of their best for their worst. Otherwise destruction would be hastened upon them. "But God is bountiful towards all worlds."[B196]

Outward commentary · The recitation of the signs and the proof of messengership

"These, Muḥammad, are God's signs." The reference is to the account of the thousands, Ṭālūt's appointment as king, the Ark's arrival and the defeat of the tyrants who followed Jālūt. We recite—that is, relate—them to you in truth: in a corresponding account about which the People of the Book and possessors of historical knowledge have no doubt. You are indeed one of

the messengers, since you have reported them without investigation or hearing them from others; no study or acquaintance with such matters was previously known of you. None doubts that this comes from the All-Aware, the Knowing, except one whose heart God has sealed. We seek God's protection from that.[B195]

Spiritual allusion · Return to God at the beginning, and serve as a mercy at the end

"A sign of success at the end is returning to God at the beginning." When the disciple comes forth to struggle against his enemies—the self, desire, Satan and the other highwaymen—and seeks God's assistance, disavowing his own power and strength, this is a sign of his victory and triumph over his self, and a cause of success at his journey's end. Through God he gains mastery over all existence, and the treasuries of His wisdom are opened to him.

Abū Sulaymān al-Dārānī said: "When selves become accustomed to abandoning sins, they roam through the kingdom of the unseen (الملكوت), then return to their owner with rare wisdoms, without any scholar having communicated knowledge to them." A report says: "Whoever acts upon what he knows, God bequeaths to him knowledge of what he did not know." He then becomes a mercy to the servants: through his existence, God repels punishment from those of His servants who deserve it.[B197]

In a sacred report, God, mighty and majestic, is quoted as saying: "When occupation with Me predominates in My servant, I place his aspiration and delight in My remembrance and raise the veil between Me and him. He is not heedless when people are heedless. Their speech is the speech of prophets; they are the true champions. When I intend a punishment or affliction for the people of the earth, I remember them and turn it away from the people through them." May God establish us in their love and make us among them. Amen.[B197]

Having mentioned a number of prophets and messengers in this sūrah and testified that His Messenger is one of them, He speaks in general of the preference given to some over others.

2:253 · The messengers' distinctions and the mystery of human disagreement

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 282–284

تِلْكَ الرُّسُلُ فَضَّلْنا بَعْضَهُمْ عَلى بَعْضٍ مِنْهُمْ مَنْ كَلَّمَ اللَّهُ وَرَفَعَ بَعْضَهُمْ دَرَجاتٍ وَآتَيْنا عِيسَى ابْنَ مَرْيَمَ الْبَيِّناتِ وَأَيَّدْناهُ بِرُوحِ الْقُدُسِ وَلَوْ شاءَ اللَّهُ مَا اقْتَتَلَ الَّذِينَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَتْهُمُ الْبَيِّناتُ وَلكِنِ اخْتَلَفُوا فَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ آمَنَ وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ كَفَرَ وَلَوْ شاءَ اللَّهُ مَا اقْتَتَلُوا وَلكِنَّ اللَّهَ يَفْعَلُ مَا يُرِيدُ (253)

253. Those messengers: We favoured some over others. Among them are those to whom God spoke, and He raised some by degrees. We gave Jesus son of Mary the clear proofs and strengthened him with the Holy Spirit. Had God willed, those who came after them would not have fought one another after the clear proofs came to them. But they differed: some believed and some disbelieved. Had God willed, they would not have fought one another; but God does whatever He desires.

Language · The demonstrative and its predicate

I say: "Those" (تلك) is the subject; "messengers" is its adjective, substitute or explanatory apposition (نعت، بدل، بيان); and "We favoured" is the predicate. Alternatively, "messengers" is the predicate and "We favoured" a second predicate. The demonstrative refers to the company whose stories have been mentioned in the sūrah.

Theology · Preference without disparagement

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those messengers whom We have related to you, and among whom I have said that you belong—We favoured some over others through distinctive gifts and virtues not found in another. This preference, however, is expressed generally, without identifying a particular prophet as inferior, since that diminishes him and is forbidden.

Hence the Prophet said: “Do not make distinctions of superiority among the prophets,” and, “Do not prefer me over Jonah son of Mattā.” These prohibit identifying someone as inferior, which is backbiting and diminution.

The Prophet nevertheless stated his superiority over all the prophets: “I am the master of the children of Adam, without boasting.” But no individual prophet is to be designated inferior, lest this lead to diminishing him. Thus the two reports do not conflict.[B198]

“Among them are those to whom God spoke”: Moses upon Mount Ṭūr, and our master Muḥammad when he was “two bows’ lengths away or nearer.” “He raised some by degrees”: our Prophet Muḥammad, distinguished by a universal mission, abundant proofs, enduring miracles, signs succeeding one another throughout time, and virtues of knowledge and action beyond enumeration. Leaving him unnamed magnifies his standing, as though he were the well-known figure uniquely marked by this description and needing no explicit identification.

Another explanation identifies Abraham, distinguished by intimate friendship (الخلة), said to be the highest rank. I say: rather, love (المحبة) is higher than it. Another identifies Idrīs, because of “We raised him to a lofty place” [19:57]; another, the messengers of firm resolve (أولو العزم). Al-Bayḍāwī gives these explanations. [101]

“We gave Jesus son of Mary the clear proofs”: manifest signs, such as raising the dead and healing the person born blind and the leper. “We strengthened him with the Holy Spirit”: Gabriel, who accompanied him wherever he went. He is explicitly named because of the Jews’ and Christians’ excesses in belittling and magnifying him. God returns them to the right course: belief in his prophethood, not his Lordship.

Spiritual allusion · Degrees among the saints

As God favoured some messengers over others, He favoured some saints over others. The distinction lies in perfected certainty, penetration into the special knowledge of unity through taste and unveiling, and ascent in

101. Cairo editor, C282.1: Whether love or intimate friendship is higher, both belong to our Prophet and master Muḥammad, God bless him and grant him peace. On the question of which is higher, love or intimate friendship, see al-Qāḍī ʿIyāḍ’s al-Shifā’, 1:213.

gnoses and mysteries. It comes through serving the men of the path, accompanying people of perfection, complete freedom for the pursuit, and full renunciation of self, money and kindred attachments (النفس والفلس والجنس).

Some attain witnessing together with divine address (المكالمة); some attain witnessing without address; some receive manifest extraordinary gifts; and some see none of these, having no need of them because of the gift of gnosis. What was said about not identifying an inferior among the messengers applies likewise to the saints. Otherwise one falls into dreadful backbiting: the flesh of saints is poisonous. Let one believe in the perfection of them all and not explicitly designate anyone inferior, as already explained. And God Most High knows best.

The Real Most High, having mentioned the messengers' states and their differing degrees of divine care, then mentions their communities and their differing degrees of guidance.

Qur'ānic continuation · 2:253b

وَلَوْ شاءَ اللَّهُ مَا اقْتَتَلَ الَّذِينَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَتْهُمُ الْبَيِّناتُ وَلكِنِ اخْتَلَفُوا فَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ آمَنَ وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ كَفَرَ وَلَوْ شاءَ اللَّهُ مَا اقْتَتَلُوا وَلكِنَّ اللَّهَ يَفْعَلُ ما يُرِيدُ

Had God willed, those who came after them would not have fought one another after the clear proofs came to them. But they differed: some believed and some disbelieved. Had God willed, they would not have fought one another; but God does whatever He desires.

Language · The omitted object of willing

I say: when a verb of willing follows *law* (لو), its object is usually omitted. Thus "Had We willed, We would have raised him through them" [7:176] means: had We willed to raise him, We would have raised him through them. Likewise, "Had God willed, they would not have fought one another" means: had He willed their guidance, they would not have fought—and similarly elsewhere.

Theology · Disagreement, divine will and the manifestation of the Names

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: when I sent the messengers and favoured some over others, their communities differed after them and fought. All this occurred through My will and desire. Had God willed the guidance of their communities, those who came after them would not have fought after receiving the clear miracles establishing their messengership and authenticating their prophethood. But they differed through transgression and envy. Some believed, through His granting them success in following the prophets' religion; some disbelieved by opposing them and became among the wretched.

Had God willed to unite them upon guidance, they would not have fought. His wisdom, however, required disagreement to exist so that the mystery of His Names the Avenger (المنتقم) and the Subduer (القهار), and the Generous (الكريم) and the Forbearing (الحليم), might appear. God does whatever He desires. "He is not questioned about what He does, but they are questioned" [21:23].

The verse proves that all events, good and evil, are in God's hand, and that all the servants' acts occur through His power. Nothing created exercises efficacy within them. This refutes the Muʿtazilites' assertion that the servant creates his acts. How far they are from God! We ask God for protection through His grace and generosity.[B199]

Spiritual allusion · Disagreement over the saints

People's disagreement over saints is an established way and an eternal wisdom. "You will find no alteration in God's way" [33:62]; "They do not cease to differ" [11:118]. Any saint you see whom everyone agrees to honour during his lifetime is deficient or ignorant of God, for

one entering upon God is denied, while one returning to people is honoured. This is the general rule; the rare exception does not determine the judgment. Were agreement praiseworthy, the prophets would have had the strongest claim to it. Since it did not occur for prophets and messengers, it does not occur for saints, who follow in their footsteps and stand in complete inheritance from them. And God Most High knows best.[B200]

He then urges charity in God’s path, for it is a proof of faith and a sign of guidance.

2:254 · Spend before the day when worldly transactions cease

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 284–284

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا أَنْفِقُوا مِمَّا رَزَقْناكُمْ مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ يَأْتِيَ يَوْمٌ لا بَيْعٌ فِيهِ وَلا خُلَّةٌ وَلا شَفاعَةٌ وَالْكافِرُونَ هُمُ الظَّالِمُونَ (254)

254. You who believe, spend from what We have provided you before a day comes in which there is neither bargaining, nor friendship, nor intercession. The unbelievers are the wrongdoers.

Outward commentary · Prepare through giving before the accounting

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: you who believe, spend from what We have provided you, obligatorily or voluntarily, upon good causes—particularly the fighting in His cause that We are now urging. Send ahead for yourselves what you will find after death, before the day of accounting and the rendering of recompense arrives.

On that day there is no buying or selling through which one might acquire a ransom; no friendship avails except the friendship of the reverent; and no intercession may be hoped for except that of one to whom the All-Merciful gives permission and whose speech He approves. Spend, then, in God’s path from what We have entrusted to you, and struggle against the unbelievers, God’s enemies. The unbelievers are the wrongdoers: they have placed their worship where it does not belong and attributed Lordship to those unworthy of it. Only the Living, the Self-Subsisting, merits it, as the Real, glorious is His majesty, indicates in the following verse.

2:255 · The Living, the Self-Subsisting: the Verse of the Footstool

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 284–288

اللَّهُ لاَ إِلهَ إِلاَّ هُوَ الْحَيُّ الْقَيُّومُ لا تَأْخُذُهُ سِنَةٌ وَلا نَوْمٌ لَهُ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ مَنْ ذَا الَّذِي يَشْفَعُ عِنْدَهُ إِلاَّ بِإِذْنِهِ يَعْلَمُ ما بَيْنَ أَيْدِيهِمْ وَما خَلْفَهُمْ وَلا يُحِيطُونَ بِشَيْءٍ مِنْ عِلْمِهِ إِلاَّ بِما شاءَ وَسِعَ كُرْسِيُّهُ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضَ وَلا يَؤُدُهُ حِفْظُهُما وَهُوَ الْعَلِيُّ الْعَظِيمُ

(255)

255. God—there is no god but He, the Living, the Self-Subsisting. Neither slumber nor sleep overtakes Him. To Him belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on earth. Who can intercede with Him except by His permission? He knows what is before them and what is behind them; they encompass nothing of His knowledge except what He wills. His Footstool embraces the heavens and the earth, and preserving them does not burden Him. He is the High, the Tremendous.

Language · The divine Name and its predicates

I say: “God” is the subject, and the sentence “there is no god but He” its predicate. The separate pronoun “He” (هو) substitutes for the pronoun implicit in the predicate. “The Living” is either a second predicate, the predicate of an omitted subject, or a substitute for “God.” *Qayyūm* (قيوم) has the intensive pattern *fayʿūl*, from standing or subsisting (القيام). It means the One who subsists through Himself, independent of anything else.

Theology · Life, subsistence and transcendence

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: God, the Necessarily Existent, alone deserves worship. Whoever worships another has committed a tremendous wrong. “The Living”: enduring without beginning, abiding without cessa-

tion, beyond the reach of death and passing away. “The Self-Subsisting”: continually attending to the governance of His creation, conveying benefits, repelling harms, bringing provisions and the various forms of advancement.

“Neither slumber nor sleep overtakes Him.” Slumber (السنة) is the lassitude preceding sleep. Sleep is a condition that overtakes the human being when the nerves of the brain relax because of the moisture of ascending vapours, so that the outward senses cease altogether to perceive.[B201]

Slumber precedes sleep here in the order in which they occur, as in “They spend no small or great expenditure” [9:121]. Both are mentioned because negating slumber alone might suggest that sleep overcomes Him, since it is stronger; negating sleep alone might suggest that slumber affects Him, since it is lighter. The purpose is to declare Him transcendent above human afflictions and confirm that He is Living and Self-Subsisting. Someone overtaken by drowsiness or sleep has life affected by a deficiency and is limited in preservation and governance. Hence there is no coordinating conjunction here or before the subsequent sentences: each confirms the description “Living, Self-Subsisting.” [102]

Outward commentary · The invocation of the Living, the Self-Subsisting

It has been transmitted that this is God’s Greatest Name. The Prophet said to Fāṭima: “What prevents you from listening to my counsel? Say morning and evening: ‘Living, Self-Subsisting One, through Your mercy I seek relief. Set all my affairs right for me, and do not entrust me to my self for the blink of an eye.’” Al-Nasāʾī related it.[B202]

Muslim transmits from Abū Mūsā: “The Messenger of God stood among us and spoke five sayings: ‘God, mighty and majestic, does not sleep, and it is not fitting that He sleep. He lowers the balance and raises it. The work of the night is raised to Him before the work of the day, and the work of the day before the work of the night. His veil is light’—in another transmission, ‘fire’—‘and were He to unveil it, the splendours of His Face would burn everything of His creation reached by His sight.’”[B203]

102. Cairo editor, C285.1: Āfa, with the verbal nouns awf and āfa: of food, it spoiled; of a country, it was struck by a calamity such as drought, disease or something else.

Theology · Sovereignty, intercession and knowledge

“To Him belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on earth.” This confirms His sustaining governance (قيوميته) and argues for His uniqueness in divinity. What is in them includes their constituent parts and the things distinct from those parts but situated within them, rational beings and others. It is therefore more comprehensive than “To Him belong the heavens, the earth and what is in them.” He owns all this without partner or rival. *Mā* (ما) is used because the non-rational is predominant.

“Who can intercede with Him except by His permission?” This makes clear the grandeur of His standing. No one approaches His rank so as to change what He wills through intercession and entreaty, much less resist Him through opposition or hostility. The question negates the possibility: no one intercedes for someone He intends to punish except by His leave. The associators claimed that the idols would intercede for them. He therefore declares that intercession with Him occurs only by His permission—meaning the intercession of the Prophet and of certain prophets, saints and angels.

“He knows what is before them and what is behind them”: what preceded and what follows them; or the reverse, since you face the future and leave the past behind. It is also said: what is before them of this world and behind them of the Hereafter; or conversely, since they advance and leave this world behind. Or He knows the good and evil they have sent before them and the deeds still to come—or the reverse. The meaning is that He encompasses all things, and nothing is hidden from Him.

“They encompass nothing of His knowledge except what He wills”: they encompass none of the things He knows except what He wills to disclose to them. This is coordinated with the preceding statement because the two together establish His unique possession of complete, intrinsic knowledge (العلم الذاتي التام), indicating His oneness in Essence and attributes.

Language · The Footstool and its interpretations

“His Footstool embraces the heavens and the earth.” One says that someone *yasaʿu* a thing when he can bear it, has power over it and can attend to it. One also says that a thing encompasses another when it surrounds and overwhelms it, so that the second becomes insignificant beside it. This is the appropriate meaning here.

The linguistic root of *kursī* (الكرسي) concerns the joining of one part to another. Hence *kurrāsa* (الكراسة), a gathering of written sheets, because its leaves are joined one upon another. In ordinary usage it denotes something upon which one sits, so named from the joining of its pieces of wood. There is disagreement about it: some identify it with the Throne, others distinguish them.

The correct view is that it is a tremendous created thing before the Throne, above the seven heavens and below the Throne. It is said that the heavens and earth beside the Footstool are like a ring in a desert, and the Footstool beside the Throne like a ring in a desert. Ibn ʿAbbās said: "The heavens within the Footstool are like seven dirhams upon a shield." Another interpretation identifies His Footstool with His knowledge.[B204]

Al-Bayḍāwī said: it is a portrayal of His majesty and a purely figurative representation, like "They have not measured God with His true measure; the entire earth will be His handful on the Day of Resurrection, and the heavens folded in His right hand" [39:67]. There is in reality neither a seat nor someone seated. Alternatively, His Footstool is a metaphor for [103]

His knowledge or sovereignty, drawn from the seat of learning or kingship. Or it is a body before the Throne, encompassing the seven heavens, in accordance with the Prophet's saying: "The seven heavens and seven earths in the Footstool are only like a ring in a desert; the superiority of the Throne over the Footstool is like that desert's superiority over that ring." Perhaps it is the sphere known as the sphere of the zodiac. Here his words end. I say: al-Suyūṭī objected to this in his marginal commentary. God Most High knows best.[B204] [104]

"Preserving them does not burden Him": preserving the heavens and earth does not weigh upon Him or cause Him difficulty. Their contents are not separately mentioned because preserving the two entails preserving what

103. Cairo editor, C286.1: This is the view chosen by a number of later scholars to avoid any suggestion of corporealism. The truth is that the Footstool is established, as sound transmitted reports state. The position of our masters among the righteous early generations is to treat this as one of the matters that a person cannot encompass in knowledge, entrusting knowledge of it to God Most High while believing God to be transcendent and holy above such things. This is the safer course.

104. Cairo editor, C287.1: In his supercommentary on al-Bayḍāwī, entitled Nawāhid al-abkār wa-shawārid al-afkār.

is in them. “He is the High”: exalted above likenesses and equals. “The Tremendous”: immense in standing and majestic in worth, beside whose greatness everything is deemed insignificant.

Outward commentary · The principal divine questions gathered in the verse

This verse contains the principal questions concerning God (أمهات المسائل الإلهية). It indicates that He exists and is one in divinity; possesses life intrinsically; is necessarily existent through Himself and brings others into existence, since the Self-Subsisting is the One who subsists through Himself and sustains another. He is transcendent above occupying a location and indwelling (التحيز والحلول), free from change and lassitude. He does not resemble bodily forms, nor is He subject to what affects spirits.

He owns the visible dominion and the unseen kingdom (الملك والملكوت), originates roots and branches, and is possessed of mighty force. None intercedes with Him except one whom He permits. He knows all things, manifest and hidden, universal and particular. His sovereignty and power extend to everything that can be possessed and fall under power. No difficulty burdens Him; no affair distracts Him from another. He is exalted beyond the reach of imaginings, Tremendous beyond the comprehension of understandings.

Outward commentary · The verse’s excellence

For this reason it is distinguished from its fellows by splendid virtues and exceptional properties. The Prophet said: “The greatest verse in the Qurʾān is the Verse of the Footstool.” He is also quoted as saying: “Whoever recites the Verse of the Footstool after each prescribed prayer is prevented from entering the Garden only by death”—and in another transmission: “The Possessor of Majesty and Generosity Himself undertakes the taking of his spirit.” Further: “Only one utterly truthful or devoted to worship persists in it. Whoever recites it upon taking to bed is made secure in himself, his neighbour, his neighbour’s neighbour and the houses around him.”[B205]

He is also quoted as saying: “This verse is not recited in a house without the devils abandoning it for thirty days; no male or female sorcerer enters it for forty days. ʿAlī, teach it to your children, family and neighbours: no

greater verse than it has been revealed." Al-Bayḍāwī and Abū al-Suʿūd mention this. Al-Suyūṭī criticised some of these reports. Weak reports are acted upon concerning virtues. And God Most High knows best.[B205]

Spiritual allusion · Give knowledge, and meet God through God

You who believe with the faith of spiritual election: "Spend from what We have provided you" of abundant sciences and treasuries of understanding, before the day of meeting comes. On that day transactions fall away and those allusions disappear. Nothing avails except entering through the door of generosity,

so that one meets God through God, without anything else. Those who deny this wrong themselves: they rely upon their works and thus meet God with the greatest idol. The Living, the Self-Subsisting, the Great, the Exalted, is independent of benefiting from works. And success is through God.

Spiritual allusion · Attachment and taking on the appropriate character

One who knows that He is the Living who does not die relies upon Him: "Rely upon the Living who does not die" [25:58]. Attachment to this Name (التعلق) is seeking the spirit's life through knowledge and perfect love.

One who knows that He is the Living, the Self-Subsisting, trusts Him, forgets remembrance of everything through remembering Him, and witnesses no other through witnessing His sustaining governance. Attachment to this Name is seeking knowledge of His sustaining governance until one rests from the misery of self-directed planning. Taking on its appropriate character (التخلق) means attending to everything with which you have been charged: spouse, children, self, property, and all the women and men connected with you.[B206]

The Living Most High has described Himself through the attributes of perfection—grandeur, might and majesty. Their evidences are manifest in His creation, so that truth is distinguished from falsehood. He makes this clear in the following words.

2:256 · No compulsion in religion and the firmest handhold

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 288–289

لا إِكْراهَ فِي الدِّينِ قَدْ تَبَيَّنَ الرُّشْدُ مِنَ الْغَيِّ فَمَنْ يَكْفُرْ بِالطَّاغُوتِ وَيُؤْمِنْ بِاللَّهِ فَقَدِ اسْتَمْسَكَ بِالْعُرْوَةِ الْوُثْقى لا انْفِصامَ لَها وَاللَّهُ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ (256)

256. There is no compulsion in religion. Right guidance has become distinct from error. Whoever rejects false objects of worship and believes in God has grasped the firmest handhold, which will never break. God is Hearing, Knowing.

Language · Guidance, error and the handhold

I say: *rushd* (الرشد) is the verbal noun of *rashida* or *rashuda*, alongside *rashād*. *Ghayy* (الغي) is the verbal noun of *ghawā*: to go astray in belief. *Ṭāghūt* (الطاغوت) has the pattern *faʿalūt*, from transgression (الطغيان). Its original form is *ṭaghayūt*. The final root-letter is transposed into the middle position, giving *ṭayaghūt*, and the *yāʾ* then becomes *alif*. It denotes anything worshipped besides God while consenting to that worship.

The handhold (العروة) is what the hand grasps when one fears slipping, such as a rope. Its firmness is its strength; its breaking means becoming detached from its place. Originally *faṣm* (الفصم) means the cracking of an anklet or something similar without its parts separating. If they separate, it is *qaṣm* (القصم), with *qāf*. Here the handhold is a metaphor (استعارة) for sound religion.

Outward commentary · The distinction of guidance from error

The Real, glorious is His majesty, speaks concerning a man of the Helpers whose two sons became Christians before the prophetic mission. When Islam came, they visited Medina. Their father invited them to Islam, but they refused. He held them and said: “By God, I shall not leave you until you be-

come Muslims." They brought their dispute to the Messenger of God, and God revealed: "There is no compulsion in religion." It is a statement conveying a prohibition: do not compel anyone to enter religion. It applies specifically to the People of the Book.[B207]

Al-Bayḍāwī said: compulsion properly means obliging someone to perform an act in which he sees no good. But right guidance has become distinct from error: faith has been distinguished from unbelief through clear signs. The proofs establish that faith is guidance leading to everlasting happiness, while unbelief is error leading to perpetual wretchedness. Once this becomes clear to a rational person, his self hastens to faith, seeking happiness and salvation. He needs neither compulsion nor force. Here his words end.

Whoever rejects false objects of worship—distances himself from them and denies their Lordship—and believes in God, affirming His oneness and acknowledging His messengers, has grasped the firmest handhold: adhered to the strong religion that never breaks. God hears words and knows intentions. Since religion includes the tongue's confession and the heart's conviction, the attributes of hearing and knowledge are fittingly mentioned. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The clear path and the danger of desire

The *Ḥikam* says: "What is feared for you is not that the paths become confused, but that desire overcome you." Aḥmad ibn Khaḍrawayh said: "The path is clear, the Real manifest, and the caller has made himself heard. Bewilderment after this comes only from blindness."

The path of wayfaring is clear for someone preceded by divine care and remains until the Day of Resurrection.[B208] Everything other than God is a false object of worship. Whoever turns away from otherness (السوى) and attaches his heart to love of the Master has grasped the firmest handhold, which will not break throughout the ages. And success is through God; He guides to the level path.

The Real then distinguishes the condition of the people of divine care from that of the people of wretchedness.

2:257 · From darkness into light

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 289–290

اللَّهُ وَلِيُّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا يُخْرِجُهُمْ مِنَ الظُّلُماتِ إِلَى النُّورِ وَالَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا أَوْلِياؤُهُمُ الطَّاغُوتُ يُخْرِجُونَهُمْ مِنَ النُّورِ إِلَى الظُّلُماتِ أُولئِكَ أَصْحابُ النَّارِ هُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (257)

257. God is the protecting friend of those who believe: He brings them out of darkness into light. As for those who disbelieve, their protecting friends are false objects of worship, bringing them out of light into darkness. They are the people of the Fire, abiding therein.

Language · The protecting friend

I say: a *walī* (الولي) is the lover who takes charge of his beloved's affairs, or the helper who assists his beloved and does not abandon him by entrusting him to himself. The sentence "He brings them out" is a circumstance referring to the pronoun implicit in the predicate, to the relative pronoun, or to both; alternatively, it is a second predicate.

Outward commentary · Faith, original disposition and corrupt guidance

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: God is the protecting friend of those who believe—their lover and the One who takes charge of their affairs. He brings them out of the darkness of unbelief, ignorance, following desire, accepting whisperings and troubling doubts about unity, into the light of faith, certainty, sound affirmation of unity and following the caller to God.

As for those who disbelieve, their protecting friends—their beloved allies—are the false objects of worship: devils, or the misleading forces of desire, Satan and others. They bring them out of the light granted them through their original disposition (الفطرة الأصلية), or prevent them from entering faith, into the darkness of unbelief, ignorance, corrupt imitation and following desire.

They are the people of the Fire, abiding therein, because they intend to remain in unbelief until death. On the believers' side, entrance into the Garden is not mentioned, so that their worship may be servanthood, not fear or desire for gain. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The world as darkness and as light

"God is the protecting friend of those who believe": He takes charge of them through prior divine care and guards them with the eye of solicitude. First He brings them from the darkness of unbelief into the light of faith; then from the darkness of sensation and seeing created things into the light of meanings, through the attainment of witnessing and direct vision. Become effaced

from sensation, and you will see lessons.[B209]

"The whole cosmos is darkness; only the manifestation of the Real within it illuminates it." Or you may say: the whole cosmos is darkness for the veiled, whereas for the people of gnosis it is all light; the manifestation of wisdom within it is what veils it. "Whoever sees the cosmos without witnessing the light within it, before it or after it lacks the presence of lights; the suns of gnoses are veiled from him by the clouds of created effects."

Those who disbelieve—those preceded by wretchedness and sentenced to distance by destiny and decree—have false objects of worship as their protecting friends: the highwaymen of desire, Satan, the world and people. "They bring them out of light into darkness": they prevent them from witnessing the lights just mentioned and hold them at the darkness described before. Their direction is the opposite of those preceded by divine care. What the people of divine care leave, the people of error fall into. We ask God for preservation and well-being in this world and the Hereafter.

The Real then illustrates the condition of someone preceded by wretchedness.

2:258 · Abraham’s argument and the false claim to Lordship

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 290–291

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِي حَاجَّ إِبْراهِيمَ فِي رَبِّهِ أَنْ آتاهُ اللَّهُ الْمُلْكَ إِذْ قالَ إِبْراهِيمُ رَبِّيَ الَّذِي يُحْيِي وَيُمِيتُ قالَ أَنَا أُحْيِي وَأُمِيتُ قالَ إِبْراهِيمُ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْتِي بِالشَّمْسِ مِنَ الْمَشْرِقِ فَأْتِ بِها مِنَ الْمَغْرِبِ فَبُهِتَ الَّذِي كَفَرَ وَاللَّهُ لا يَهْدِي الْقَوْمَ الظَّالِمِينَ (258)

258. Have you not considered the man who disputed with Abraham concerning his Lord because God had given him kingship? Abraham said, “My Lord is He who gives life and causes death.” He said, “I give life and cause death.” Abraham said, “God brings the sun from the east; then bring it from the west.” The unbeliever was confounded. God does not guide the wrongdoing people.

Language · The cause and the time of the dispute

I say: “Because He gave him” (أن آتاه) has an omitted causal *lām* (لام العلة). “When Abraham said” (إذ قال) is an adverbial expression attached to “disputed,” or a substitute for “God gave him.”

Outward commentary · Power over subjects is not power to create life

The Real, glorious is His majesty, expresses wonder at Nimrod’s ignorance, intending to awaken the listener’s wonder: have you not considered, Muḥammad, the ignorance of the man who disputed with Abraham concerning his Lord because God had given him kingship? The arrogance engendered by kingship drove him to it.

When Abraham broke the idols, Nimrod imprisoned him for some days, then brought him out and asked: “Who is your Lord whom you worship?” Abraham replied: “My Lord is He who gives life and causes death”—creates

spirits in bodies and brings them out when their appointed terms expire. Nimrod said: “I give life and cause death.” He summoned two men, killed one and pardoned the other.

When Abraham saw his error and sophistry, he turned to another proof whose like no human could produce: “God brings the sun from the east; then bring it from the west.” You claim Lordship, and Lordship must have power over everything, with nothing beyond it. The unbeliever was confounded: defeated and bewildered. God does not guide the wrongdoing people to accept guidance, to the path of salvation or to the clear way of argument.

Spiritual allusion · Return through humility, not through arrogance

One of the sages said: the self contains a mystery which appeared in Pharaoh and Nimrod until they openly claimed Lordship. I say: this mystery belongs to the spirit in its original arising, because it came from the world of might and grandeur. Consider: “I breathed into him of My spirit” [15:29]; and, “Say: the spirit is of my Lord’s command” [17:85]—a mystery among His mysteries.

When it was placed in this bodily mould, the mould of servanthood, it sought to return to its origin. The Real, glorious is His majesty, made a door through which it could enter and return: lowliness, submission, brokenness and need. Whoever enters by this door and joins someone who makes his Lord known to him has his spirit returned to that origin and apprehends that mystery. Some spirits have room for it and can bear it; others lack the capacity to bear it and divulge it, whereupon the Sacred Law puts them to death—as with al-Ḥallāj and those like him.[B210]

Whoever seeks to return to that origin by another door and attempts to apprehend it through might and arrogance is expelled and banished. This is what occurred with Nimrod, Pharaoh and others who ignorantly claimed Lordship. And God Most High knows best.

The Real then mentions someone reached by divine care. His story also supplies a demonstration of the raising of the dead with which Abraham argued.

2:259 · The ruined town, the hundred years and the renewal of certainty

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 291–293

أَوْ كَالَّذِي مَرَّ عَلى قَرْيَةٍ وَهِيَ خاوِيَةٌ عَلى عُرُوشِها قالَ أَنَّى يُحْيِي هذِهِ اللَّهُ بَعْدَ مَوْتِها فَأَماتَهُ اللَّهُ مِائَةَ عامٍ ثُمَّ بَعَثَهُ قالَ كَمْ لَبِثْتَ قالَ لَبِثْتُ يَوْماً أَوْ بَعْضَ يَوْمٍ قالَ بَلْ لَبِثْتَ مِائَةَ عامٍ فَانْظُرْ إِلى طَعامِكَ وَشَرابِكَ لَمْ يَتَسَنَّهْ وَانْظُرْ إِلى حِمارِكَ وَلِنَجْعَلَكَ آيَةً لِلنَّاسِ وَانْظُرْ إِلَى الْعِظامِ كَيْفَ نُنْشِزُها ثُمَّ نَكْسُوها لَحْماً فَلَمَّا تَبَيَّنَ لَهُ قالَ أَعْلَمُ أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (259)

259. Or the man who passed a town fallen in ruins upon its roofs. He said, “How will God give this life after its death?” God caused him to die for a hundred years, then raised him. He said, “How long have you remained?” He replied, “I have remained a day, or part of a day.” He said, “Rather, you have remained a hundred years. Look at your food and drink: they have not changed; and look at your donkey. We have done this to make you a sign for people. Look at the bones, how We raise them together and then clothe them with flesh.” When it became clear to him, he said, “I know that God has power over everything.”

Language · The comparison and the verb of change

I say: “Or” is a coordinating conjunction, and “like the one” (كالذي) is co-ordinated with the relative expression governed by *ilā* in the preceding verse: have you not considered the man who disputed with Abraham concerning his Lord, and someone like the man who passed a town? The particle of comparison is introduced because those who deny resurrection are many, and those ignorant of its manner more numerous still; claimants to Lordship, by contrast, are few. Alternatively, the *kāf* is supplementary: have you not considered the man who disputed and the man who passed?

Annā (أنى) is an adverb attached to "give life," meaning "when," or a circumstance meaning "how." *Yatasannah* (يتسنه) means change. Its original form is *yatasannan* (يتسنن), the third *nūn* being replaced by a weak letter. The *Kāfiya* says:

> Replace the third of like consonants with a yāʾ,
> as in "Khālid conjectured"—*taẓannā Khālidun taẓanniyā*.

It thus becomes *tasannā*. The weak letter is then removed by the jussive, and the pause-*hāʾ* (هاء السكت) is added in both pause and connected recitation, as though compensating for the deleted letter. Another explanation derives it from *sana* (السنة), conveying alteration with years; on this account the *hāʾ* is radical. "To make you" is coordinated with an omitted expression: so that you may take a lesson, and so that We may make you a sign for people.[B211]

Outward commentary · The food preserved and the donkey restored

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: have you not also considered, Muḥammad, someone like the man who passed a town? He was ʿUzayr, the learned man of Israel, though another person is also proposed. He passed Jerusalem after Nebuchadnezzar had laid it waste. Its walls had fallen upon its roofs: a hundred years had passed, the roofs had fallen and the walls collapsed upon them. Seeing it deserted and the bones of the dead decayed within it, he said to himself: "When will God bring this to life after its death?"[B212]

If the speaker was ʿUzayr, this acknowledged his inability to understand the manner of restoration and marvelled at the power of the Giver of life; if an unbeliever, it expressed doubt about its possibility. God kept him dead for a hundred years, then raised him to life. Through an angel, or without intermediary, He asked: "How long have you remained dead?" He replied: "A day, or part of a day." He had died in the morning and was raised a hundred years later before sunset. Before looking at the sun, he said "a day"; turning and seeing some daylight remain, he corrected himself: "or part of a day." The Real, glorious is His majesty, said: "Rather, you have remained a hundred years."

ʿUzayr had gone to gather fruit for his family, placing a basket of grapes and a jar of juice upon his donkey. Passing the town, he tied the donkey and marvelled at its ruin and emptiness after its former habitation, saying what he said inwardly. God dealt gently with him and showed him directly how He gives life. He caused him to die for a hundred years, until the donkey's bones decayed, while the juice and grapes remained as though freshly pressed and gathered. [105]

He said: "Look at your food," the grapes, "and your drink," the juice: they have not changed through the passage of time and the long interval. Look at your donkey, whose joints have separated and bones decayed. We have done this so that you may witness Our power and become a sign for people after you. Look at the donkey's bones: how We restore them to life, according to the reading *nunshiruhā* (ننشرها), from "God raised the dead"; or how We lift and assemble them, according to *nunshizuhā* (ننشزها), with *zāy*. Then We clothe them with flesh.[B211]

He looked at the bones, and each bone stood in its place. They were clothed with flesh and skin, and the donkey began to bray. When what had seemed strange and difficult became clear to him, he said: "I know with certain knowledge that God has power over everything." Alternatively, when the truth—His power over all things—became clear, he said to himself: "Know that God has power over everything," according to the imperative reading. [B211]

It is related that he returned to his people upon his donkey and said: "I am ʿUzayr." They disbelieved him, so he recited the Torah from memory, which no one before him had memorised. They recognised him by this and said that he was God's son—exalted is He above their saying. Another account says that he returned home as a young man and found his children elderly. Whenever he told them something, they said: "That is a story from a hundred years ago." And God Most High knows best.[B212]

105. Cairo editor, C292.1: Kharafa, yakhrufuhu: a man took some fruit. Ikhtarafa: he went to gather dates and fruit.

Spiritual allusion · From knowledge of certainty to its direct vision

This verse and the next indicate the command to cultivate certainty and ascend from knowledge of certainty (علم اليقين) to the eye of certainty (عين اليقين). So long as the spirit remains veiled by stopping with causes and customary patterns, seeing sensory forms and remaining with intermediaries, it is not free of invading doubts and thoughts.

When it devotes itself entirely to its Lord and breaks through the customary habits of its self, the Real Most High uncovers for it the curtains of His unseen, reveals the hidden treasures of His mystery, unveils the secrets of the unseen kingdom and shows it the radiance of the world of divine omnipotence (الجبروت). It beholds the power of the Living who does not die and delights in witnessing the Essence and the lights of the attributes, in this life and after death. Doubts and imaginings then cease; it is purified of intrusive thoughts, and its illnesses and ailments disappear.

The *Ḥikam* says: "How should customary patterns be broken for you while you have not broken the customary habits of your self?" Consider ʿUzayr: the Real did not show him His power directly until He broke customary patterns for him, causing him to die and then bringing him to life. Likewise, disciple, do not hope that customary patterns will be broken for you, so that you witness the Real's power or Essence directly, until you die to your interests and desire. Then your spirit and secret come to life; you witness your Lord's mysteries and the curtains are lifted from the eye of your heart. And success is through God; He guides to the level path.

The Real then relates His intimate friend's request to see power itself in the raising of the dead, so as to ascend from knowledge of certainty to its direct vision.

2:260 · Abraham’s four birds and the four deaths of the self

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 293–295

وَإِذْ قالَ إِبْراهِيمُ رَبِّ أَرِنِي كَيْفَ تُحْيِ الْمَوْتى قالَ أَوَلَمْ تُؤْمِنْ قالَ بَلى وَلكِنْ لِيَطْمَئِنَّ قَلْبِي قالَ فَخُذْ أَرْبَعَةً مِنَ الطَّيْرِ فَصُرْهُنَّ إِلَيْكَ ثُمَّ اجْعَلْ عَلى كُلِّ جَبَلٍ مِنْهُنَّ جُزْءاً ثُمَّ ادْعُهُنَّ يَأْتِينَكَ سَعْياً وَاعْلَمْ أَنَّ اللَّهَ عَزِيزٌ حَكِيمٌ (260)

260. When Abraham said, “My Lord, show me how You give life to the dead,” He said, “Do you not believe?” He replied, “Yes indeed, but so that my heart may be at rest.” He said, “Then take four birds and draw them to you. Place a portion of them upon each mountain, then call them: they will come to you swiftly. Know that God is Mighty, Wise.”

Language · Seeing, showing and drawing near

I say: *raʾā*, when it denotes visual seeing, governs one object. Introducing the causative *hamza* makes it govern two. Here the interrogative suspends its direct government of the second object (التعليق بالاستفهام). “Draw them to you” (صرهن إليك) means incline and gather them towards yourself. There are two verbal forms, *ṣāra yaṣīru* and *ṣāra yaṣūru*, hence the readings with *kasra* and *ḍamma* on the *ṣād*. “Swiftly” (سعياً) is a circumstantial expression: coming swiftly.

Outward commentary · Adding direct witnessing to revelation and proof

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: remember, Muḥammad—or listener—when Abraham said: “My Lord, show me how You give life to the dead.” Let me see its manner directly. He wished to pass from knowledge

of certainty to the eye of certainty. Another account says that when he told Nimrod, “My Lord is He who gives life and causes death,” Nimrod asked whether he had witnessed it. Unable to say yes, he moved to another proof. He then asked his Lord to show it to him, so that his heart would be at rest concerning his answer if questioned again.[B213]

The Real, glorious is His majesty, asked: “Do you not believe that I can give life by restoring the composition and life?” Although He knew the reality of Abraham’s faith, He asked so that Abraham would give the answer he gave, making his purpose known to the listeners. Abraham replied: “Yes indeed, I believe that You have power over everything. I ask only that my heart may be at rest.” A report is not like direct vision, nor is knowledge of certainty like the eye of certainty. He wished to add witnessing and direct vision to revelation and demonstration (الوحي والبرهان).

The Real said: “Take four birds”: a peacock, a cock, a raven and a pigeon; some name a vulture instead of the pigeon. Draw them to you, examine them and know their forms, so that their forms will not be confused for you after restoration. Then divide them and place portions upon the mountains near you—said to have been four, or seven. Call them, saying, “Come by God’s leave,” and they will come swiftly.

It is related that he was commanded to slaughter them, pluck their feathers, cut them up, mix their parts, distribute them upon the mountains and retain their heads. Then he was to call them. He did so. Each part flew to another and joined its counterpart until bodies were formed. They approached him, and he gave each bird its head; it flew into the air. Glory to Him whom nothing defeats and from whose knowledge nothing is absent. He then directs attention to reflection upon the wonders of His power and wisdom: “Know that God is Mighty”—nothing defeats Him—“Wise,” possessed of consummate wisdom in what He does and leaves undone.

Spiritual allusion · Four qualities to be overcome

Whoever wishes his spirit to live the everlasting life and to pass from knowledge of certainty to the eye of certainty must have his self die four deaths.

First, it must die to love of appetites and worldly adornments: the peacock's quality. Second, to aggression and the powers of the lower self: the cock's quality. Third, to baseness, lowliness of character and far-reaching hopes: the raven's quality. Fourth, to self-exaltation and hastening towards desire: the pigeon's quality.[B213]

When he slaughters these qualities in his self, his spirit lives and his self becomes refined and obedient to his hand. Whenever he calls it to obedience, it comes swiftly and eagerly. Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī indicates this meaning in his Great Litany (الحزب الكبير): "Make our intellects a support for us, our spirits a guardian over us, and our selves subject to us, so that we may glorify You much and remember You much. You have ever seen us."

The spirit's life depends upon two things: offering up the self and giving away money. Having indicated the first through "Fight in the path of God," He now indicates the second.

2:261–262 · The seven hundred grains and giving without injury

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 295–296

مَثَلُ الَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوالَهُمْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ كَمَثَلِ حَبَّةٍ أَنْبَتَتْ سَبْعَ سَنابِلَ فِي كُلِّ سُنْبُلَةٍ مِائَةُ حَبَّةٍ وَاللَّهُ يُضاعِفُ لِمَنْ يَشاءُ وَاللَّهُ واسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ (261) الَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوالَهُمْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ ثُمَّ لا يُتْبِعُونَ ما أَنْفَقُوا مَنًّا وَلا أَذىً لَهُمْ أَجْرُهُمْ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ وَلا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (262)

261. The likeness of those who spend their wealth in the path of God is a grain that grows seven ears, in every ear a hundred grains. God multiplies for whom He wills. God is All-Encompassing, Knowing. 262. Those who

spend their wealth in the path of God, then do not follow what they spend with reminders of generosity or injury, have their reward with their Lord. No fear shall be upon them, nor shall they grieve.

Language · The implied term in the comparison

I say: "The likeness of those" is the subject, and "like a grain" the predicate. A term in a possessive construction must be supplied on one side or the other: the likeness of the expenditure of those who spend is like a grain; or the likeness of those who spend is like someone sowing a grain—and so forth.

Outward commentary · The multiplication of sincere charity

The Real, glorious is His majesty, encourages expenditure in His path: the likeness of those who spend their wealth in His path, giving charity for such purposes as fighting in His cause, is a sower whose grain produces seven ears, with a hundred grains in each: seven hundred altogether. The Prophet said: "A good deed is multiplied tenfold, up to seven hundredfold, and many times beyond."[B214]

Ascribing the growth to the grain is figurative (مجاز); the One who causes growth is God. This is an illustration, not a claim that such growth must actually occur, though it may occur with sorghum or millet in good soil: a grain produces a stalk branching into seven, each branch bearing an ear. God grants this multiplication through His bounty to whom He wills, according to the giver's sincerity and effort. Accordingly, deeds differ in the amount of their recompense. God is All-Encompassing: what He bestows of recompense does not restrict Him. He knows the giver's intention and the measure of his giving. [106]

He then mentions two further conditions for accepted expenditure: those who spend in God's path must not follow it with reminders of their favour or injury (منّ وأذى). Reminding someone of a favour means counting one's beneficence against its recipient, saying, "I did such-and-such for him," to display one's superiority. Injury means lording it over him because of it,

106. Cairo editor, C295.1: Millet is an herbaceous plant of the grass family. Its grain is small and smooth, like sesame seed; it grows both wild and cultivated.

saying, for example: “Without me, you would have amounted to nothing.” Whoever does this has made his charity scattered dust. Those free from it, who spend seeking God’s Face, shall have no fear and shall not grieve.

Zayd ibn Aslam said: “If you give someone something and think that your greeting weighs upon him, withhold even your greeting from him.”

Language · Generosity and the promised reward

The verse is said to have been revealed concerning ʿUthmān and ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf. ʿUthmān equipped the Army of Hardship with a thousand camels, complete with saddles and saddlecloths. ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn Samura said: “‘Uthmān brought a thousand dinars for the Army of Hardship and poured them into the Prophet’s lap. I saw him put his hand among them and turn them over, saying: ‘Nothing Ibn ʿAffān does after today will harm him.’” Abū Saʿīd’s transmission adds: “I saw the Prophet raise his hands in prayer for ʿUthmān, saying: ‘Lord of ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān, I am pleased with him; be pleased with him.’”[B214]

ʿAbd al-Raḥmān brought four thousand dirhams to the Prophet as charity and kept four thousand for his dependants. The Prophet said: “May God bless what you have given and what you have retained.”[B214]

Although the relative expression contains a conditional meaning, the *fā’* is not introduced before “No fear shall be upon them.” This suggests that they deserve it even had they not acted thus—how much more when they do. Al-Bayḍāwī says this.

Spiritual allusion · The unbounded recompense of inward acts

Drawing near to God Most High occurs through bodily, financial and inward acts. Bodily acts include acts of the tongue. Their multiplication is reported as ten, twenty, thirty, fifty, a hundred, more or less. Financial acts are reported to be multiplied up to seven hundredfold. This varies according to intentions and purposes.

Inward acts, however, have no circumscribed reward: “The steadfast are paid their reward without reckoning” [39:10]. Patience, fear, hope, scrupulousness, renunciation, reliance, love, contentment, surrender, gnosis, good character, contemplation and the other praiseworthy qualities receive di-

vine good pleasure, turning towards the servant, drawing him near and beautiful communion. “God’s good pleasure is greater” [9:72]: greater than sensory recompense, such as palaces and heavenly companions.

The saying attributed to the Prophet, “An hour’s contemplation is better than seventy years’ worship,” expresses abundance and intensification, as in “Even if you seek forgiveness for them seventy times, God will not forgive them” [9:80]. The poet’s words are similar:

> Every moment from my Beloved
> is worth a thousand ḥijjas— [107]

that is, years. And God Most High knows best.[B215]

The Real then explains that good character and gentleness are better than charity mixed with impurity.

2:263 · A gracious word and forgiveness

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 296–297

قَوْلٌ مَعْرُوفٌ وَمَغْفِرَةٌ خَيْرٌ مِنْ صَدَقَةٍ يَتْبَعُها أَذىً وَاللَّهُ غَنِيٌّ حَلِيمٌ

(263)

263. A gracious word and forgiveness are better than charity followed by injury. God is Independent, Forbearing.

Language · An indefinite subject qualified by an adjective

I say: “A word” is the subject and “better” the predicate. The adjective makes the indefinite subject admissible.

Outward commentary · Gentleness towards the person who asks

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: a gracious word spoken to someone asking, when one has nothing to give and must turn him away, is better before God than charity followed by reminders and injury. Such words in-

107. Cairo editor, C296.1: He is al-Shushtarī.

clude: “May God provide us and you with a good provision”; “May God enrich us and you from His immense bounty”—and the like, without frowning or aversion.

Forgiving the person who asks, overlooking his roughness and insistence, is also better than charity followed by reminders or injury. The Real knows that being sent away empty-handed is hard for the poor person. He may therefore loose his tongue and complain. The person asked is consequently commanded to pardon and show humility.

Had the Real willed, He would have enriched everyone. He gives to the rich so that their gratitude may appear, and tests the poor to see how they endure. God is independent of expenditure accompanied by reminders or injury, and Forbearing in not hastening to punish those who remind or injure. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The divine Names educate giver and petitioner

The verse teaches that good character, gentleness, humility, refraining from harm, bearing rough treatment and witnessing purity are among the best deeds, purest states and finest qualities. The hadith says: “Good character equals fasting and standing in prayer.”[B216]

“God is Independent, Forbearing” educates both the petitioner and the person asked. The petitioner is taught to find sufficiency in the Great, Independent One rather than ask a needy servant, and to be content with His knowledge of the situation instead of speaking. The person asked is taught to bear the petitioner’s roughness patiently, address him gently and make a gracious response.

The commentary on the divine Names says: taking on the appropriate character of this Name—the Forbearing—means overlooking offences and being generous towards the wrongs people commit against one. Rather, one repays them with goodness, realizing forbearance and forgiveness.[B216]

The Real then warns against reminders and injury in charity.

2:264 · The smooth rock and charity performed for display

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 297–298

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا تُبْطِلُوا صَدَقاتِكُمْ بِالْمَنِّ وَالْأَذى كَالَّذِي يُنْفِقُ مالَهُ رِئاءَ النَّاسِ وَلا يُؤْمِنُ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ فَمَثَلُهُ كَمَثَلِ صَفْوانٍ عَلَيْهِ تُرابٌ فَأَصابَهُ وابِلٌ فَتَرَكَهُ صَلْداً لا يَقْدِرُونَ عَلى شَيْءٍ مِمَّا كَسَبُوا وَاللَّهُ لا يَهْدِي الْقَوْمَ الْكافِرِينَ (264)

264. You who believe, do not nullify your charities through reminders and injury, like one who spends his wealth to be seen by people and does not believe in God and the Last Day. His likeness is a smooth rock with soil upon it: a downpour strikes it and leaves it bare. They gain nothing from what they have earned. God does not guide the unbelieving people.

Language · The comparison and the bare stone

I say: the *kāf* in “like the one” is accusative as an expression qualifying an absolute accusative: a nullification like that of one who spends his wealth to be seen by people. Alternatively, it is circumstantial: resembling the one who spends for display. “To be seen” (رئاء) is an accusative of purpose. *Ṣafwān* (صفوان) is a smooth stone; *ṣald* (صلد), bare and uncovered by soil. The pronoun in “they gain nothing” is plural in accordance with the meaning of “the one,” which denotes the class.

Outward commentary · A charitable appearance stripped away

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: you who believe, do not nullify the reward of your charity by reminding its recipient of it or injuring him—for example, by mentioning it to other people. Your charity would then be void, like that of someone who spends his wealth to be seen by people and does not believe in God and the Last Day. His recompense on the Day of Resurrection becomes scattered dust.

His worldly benefit from charity, the concealment it affords him here and his exposure at the Resurrection resemble a smooth stone covered in soil. An observer supposes it to be good ground fit for cultivation. Then a heavy downpour strikes it and leaves it a dry, bare stone, free of soil. Likewise, those who make a display of their deeds benefit in this world through people's praise and the concealment of their condition. When they arrive at the Resurrection, they find the deeds void and cannot benefit from anything they earned.

God does not guide the unbelieving people to their right course and the well-being of their religion. This indirectly warns that display, reminders and injury are unbelieving characteristics, which the believer must avoid. And success is through God.

Spiritual allusion · The inward conditions of pure action

The purification of deeds corresponds to the purification of hearts; the purification of hearts to watchfulness before the Knower of the unseen; watchfulness to gnosis; gnosis to witnessing; and witnessing is attained according to struggle. "Those who struggle for Us, We shall guide them to Our paths" [29:69].

The *Ḥikam* says: "Good deeds are the fruits of good states; good states come from realization in the stations of alighting (مقامات الإنزال)." In sum, someone who has not realized the station of effacement cannot have works altogether free from an admixture of defect. One who has realized passing away ascribes to himself neither giving nor withholding, movement nor stillness. Nor does he see another as existent, so as to hope for benefit or good from him.[B217]

One of the allusive sayings declares: "You who act for show: the affairs of the person before whom you display yourself are in the hand of the One you disobey." The comparison with a stone indicates hardness of heart and dryness of disposition. No good at all is to be expected from such a person. God is our refuge.

The Real then describes the opposite of these people: the sincere.

2:265 · The garden on rising ground

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 298–299

وَمَثَلُ الَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوالَهُمُ ابْتِغاءَ مَرْضاتِ اللَّهِ وَتَثْبِيتاً مِنْ أَنْفُسِهِمْ كَمَثَلِ جَنَّةٍ بِرَبْوَةٍ أَصابَها وابِلٌ فَآتَتْ أُكُلَها ضِعْفَيْنِ فَإِنْ لَمْ يُصِبْها وابِلٌ فَطَلٌّ وَاللَّهُ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ بَصِيرٌ (265)

265. The likeness of those who spend their wealth seeking God's good pleasure and from firm conviction within themselves is a garden on rising ground. A downpour strikes it and it yields its produce twice over. If no downpour strikes it, a light rain suffices. God sees what you do.

Language · The elevated garden and the two rains

I say: *rabwa* (ربوة), whose *rāʾ* may take any of the three short vowels, is elevated ground. *Wābil* (وابل) is abundant rain; *ṭall* (طل), light rain. The poet in *rajaz* metre says:

> Ṭall is the light kind of rain;
> wābil is abundant, pouring rain.

"Seeking God's good pleasure" and "from firm conviction" are either circumstantial expressions referring to the subject of "spend," or accusatives of purpose. *Tathbīt* (تثبيت) here means *tathabbut* (تثبت), being firmly convinced or assured, as "devote yourself to Him with complete devotion" [73:8] uses *tabtīl* where *tabattul* is meant.

Outward commentary · The growth of a gift given with certainty

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the likeness of those who spend their wealth in God's path seeking His good pleasure, inwardly certain of His reward—or assured that giving their wealth in pursuit of His approval leads to His good pleasure—is, in growth and increase, a garden upon rising ground. Its trees are more beautiful to behold and its fruit more abundant.

A downpour strikes it, and it yields twice its ordinary produce: in one year it bears what another garden bears in two, because of the rain. If no downpour strikes it, light rain suffices because of its good soil and elevated position. The least thing is enough for it.

The meaning is that, because of their sincerity and perfect certainty, these people's gifts are abundant and fruitful before God. Though small in sensory measure, they are great in inward meaning. The hadith says: "Whoever gives in charity, even a morsel, it falls into the palm of the All-Merciful, who nurtures it as one of you nurtures his foal or young camel, until it becomes like a mountain."[B218] "God sees what you do" warns against display and encourages sincerity. And God Most High knows best. [108]

Spiritual allusion · The measure of action is the station from which it comes

The growth of deeds corresponds to the purification of states, and the purification of states to realization in the stations of alighting: that is, realizing one's alighting in the stations of certainty. Whoever is established in these stations, with firm footing in them, has all his deeds made great and multiplied many times.[B217]

A single glorification or declaration of unity from a gnostic equals the whole of existence and cannot be weighed by a balance. So too all his other works are great and multiplied, for they are through God, from God and towards God. What is through God and from God is not visited by deficiency or mixed with defect.

For this reason all their times become the Night of Power; all their places, ʿArafāt; all their breaths, pure; all their companionship, breaths of divine grace; all association with them, blessings. May God benefit us through remembering them and thread us into their company. Amen.

The Real then warns against the intrusion of defects after a work has been completed.

108. Cairo editor, C299.1: A falūw is a young foal; a faṣīl is a she-camel's young after it has been separated from its mother.

2:266 · The garden destroyed when it is needed most

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 299–300

أَيَوَدُّ أَحَدُكُمْ أَنْ تَكُونَ لَهُ جَنَّةٌ مِنْ نَخِيلٍ وَأَعْنابٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ لَهُ فِيها مِنْ كُلِّ الثَّمَراتِ وَأَصابَهُ الْكِبَرُ وَلَهُ ذُرِّيَّةٌ ضُعَفاءُ فَأَصابَها إِعْصارٌ فِيهِ نارٌ فَاحْتَرَقَتْ كَذلِكَ يُبَيِّنُ اللَّهُ لَكُمُ الْآياتِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَفَكَّرُونَ (266)

266. Would any of you wish to have a garden of palms and vines, with rivers flowing beneath it and every kind of fruit within it, while old age has overtaken him and his offspring are weak—then a whirlwind containing fire strikes it and it burns? Thus God makes the signs clear to you, so that you may reflect.

Language · The whirlwind

I say: an *iʿṣār* (إعصار) is a column of wind containing dust, revolving and rising.

Outward commentary · A lifetime's works lost at its end

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: would any of you wish to have a garden of palms and vines—its predominant trees because of their many benefits—with rivers flowing beneath them? A perfect garden includes cool water and extended shade. Within it he has every kind of fruit besides palms and vines. Then old age overtakes him, weakening his ability to tend it, and he has young, weak children who cannot look after themselves. A strong whirlwind containing fire strikes the garden and burns it.

Do not ask how great the owner's grief would be, fearing ruin for himself and his dependants. This illustrates someone who performs abundant good works—prayer, fasting, charity, pilgrimage, fighting in God's cause and others—then admires and boasts of them, or reminds recipients of his charity and injures them. The works become void and disappear, and he grieves

over them at the Resurrection when he most needs them. Or he acts obediently throughout his life, then near death acts disobediently and ends in that state, so that the works are lost. God is our refuge.[B219]

Thus God makes the signs clear so that you may reflect, take a lesson, act sincerely and fear an evil end. May God preserve us from that.

Spiritual allusion · Returning to habit after approaching the garden of gnosis

The verse warns the disciple against returning to his habitual ways and looking back towards the worlds of sensation, becoming occupied with the world after looking out upon the garden of gnoses, with rivers of knowledge flowing through his heart. He breaks the covenant with his shaykh or behaves improperly towards him, and does not repent until the trees of his gnosis wither. The wind of desire plays with him, and his heart burns in the fire of appetites.

Al-Bayḍāwī said: the person who most resembles this is one whose secret roamed the unseen kingdom and whose thought ascended to the precinct of divine omnipotence, then turned back towards the world of falsehood, looked to other than the Real and made his striving scattered dust.

The Real then encourages giving charity from good earnings, whether obligatory or voluntary.

2:267 · Give what is good, and seek knowledge through a sound spiritual state

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 300–302

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا أَنْفِقُوا مِنْ طَيِّباتِ ما كَسَبْتُمْ وَمِمَّا أَخْرَجْنا لَكُمْ مِنَ الْأَرْضِ وَلا تَيَمَّمُوا الْخَبِيثَ مِنْهُ تُنْفِقُونَ وَلَسْتُمْ بِآخِذِيهِ إِلاَّ أَنْ تُغْمِضُوا فِيهِ وَاعْلَمُوا أَنَّ اللَّهَ غَنِيٌّ حَمِيدٌ (267)

267. You who believe, spend from the good things you have earned and from what We have brought forth for you from the earth. Do not deliberately select the bad to spend, when you would not accept it yourselves unless you overlooked its defects. Know that God is Independent, Praiseworthy.

Language · Intention and the circumstantial clauses

I say: *tayammamū* (تيمموا) originally has two initial *tā'*s: *tatayammamū*, "intend" or "deliberately seek." "You spend" is an anticipated circumstance (حال مقدرة) referring to its subject. "From it" (منه) may attach to "spend" or "the bad": do not select the bad, intending to spend it; or do not select bad property from which to spend. "You would not accept it" is likewise a circumstance referring to the subject of "spend."

Outward commentary · Lawful earnings and acceptable quality

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: you who believe, spend from the good property you earn through trade and other means. The Prophet is quoted as saying: "Company of traders, you are sinful except those who are mindful of God, act uprightly, speak truthfully and distribute wealth this way and that."[B220] [109]

"From the good things you have earned" means their lawful portion, or their good quality. In obligatory alms this is binding, since giving inferior goods is not valid; in voluntary charity it is a matter of perfection. Spend also from the good things We have brought forth from the earth: the different grains, crops and fruits. The Prophet said: "No Muslim plants a tree or sows a crop from which a human, animal or bird eats without it being a charity for him until the Day of Resurrection."[B221]

109. Cairo editor, C301.1: That is, he spent wealth on good causes. Ibn al-Athīr said: the Arabs use "saying" to express all kinds of actions, applying it to things other than speech and the tongue. Thus they say "he said with his hand," meaning he took it, and "he said with his foot," meaning he walked. All of this is figurative.

Do not deliberately select the bad—the inferior part of your property—to spend, when you would not accept it in payment of debts unless you closed your eyes to it and took it through embarrassment, reluctance or indulgence. The verse was revealed concerning people who gave bad and inferior dates in charity; they were forbidden to do so.

He disciplines them with: "Know that God is Independent." He needs none of your expenditure; He commands it only for your benefit. He praises you by accepting and rewarding it. Here *ḥamīd* (حميد), on the pattern *faʿīl*, has the intensive sense of an active participle: He commends and thanks you for your deed if you perform it well.

The Messenger of God is quoted as saying: "God has apportioned your characters as He apportioned your provisions. God is good and accepts only what is good. A servant does not earn unlawful wealth and give charity from it with acceptance, nor spend from it with blessing. If he leaves it behind him, it becomes his provision for the Fire. God does not erase evil through evil, but erases evil through good; the impure does not erase the impure."[B222]

Spiritual allusion · A sound state is the soil of sound knowledge

You who believe with the faith of the elect: spend the divinely bestowed sciences and lordly mysteries from the good fruits of purifying your secrets and refining your spirits. Spend also the sciences of Sacred Law and the lights of the Path, from what We have brought forth from the earth of your selves, purified by pure deeds and pleasing states.

Do not seek an impure deed or impure state, intending to impart any of these sciences from it. That only increases the self's ignorance and distance. As a seed grows only in good earth, so the self is to be buried only in an approved state. Divinely bestowed knowledge is not drawn from the self until it has been buried in the earth of obscurity (أرض الخمول). The earth of obscurity is the approved states that accord with the principles of the Sacred Law.

This is indicated by "you would not accept it": you do not receive divinely bestowed knowledge from an impure state, unless you have become absent within it from your sensory awareness. One overcome by a state is beyond reproach for that state. On this basis the story of the thief at the bathhouse

is explained: he is not to be imitated, because a state had overcome him. [B223] Know that God is Independent, Praiseworthy; one draws near to Him only through what is praiseworthy. And God Most High knows best. [110]

He then warns against avarice.

> **Translator's source note · Cairo I:301:** Ruslān's footnote cautions against treating the anecdote's extreme action as a legal precedent.

110. Cairo editor, C301.2: He was a man known for asceticism to whom people flocked. He entered a bathhouse, put on someone else's clothes, went out and stood in the road until people recognised him. They seized and beat him, recovered the clothes and shunned him. I say: what this man did was an excess and a departure from moderation that the Sacred Law does not approve. As the author says, he is not to be followed, because his spiritual state had overwhelmed him. Al-Ghazālī recounts the story in the Iḥyāʾ, 3:305, and Ibn ʿAbbād in his commentary on the Ḥikam, 1:80.

2:268 · The threat of poverty and the promise of grace

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 302–303

الشَّيْطانُ يَعِدُكُمُ الْفَقْرَ وَيَأْمُرُكُمْ بِالْفَحْشاءِ وَاللَّهُ يَعِدُكُمْ مَغْفِرَةً مِنْهُ وَفَضْلاً وَاللَّهُ واسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ (268)

268. Satan threatens you with poverty and commands you to indecency. God promises you forgiveness from Him and bounty. God is All-Encompassing, Knowing.

Language · Promise, threat and indecency

I say: one says *waʿadtuhu khayran*, "I promised him good," and *waʿadtuhu sharran*, "I threatened him with evil," when the good or evil is specified. Without specifying it, *waʿadtuhu* denotes promising good, while *awʿadtuhu* denotes threatening evil. The poet says:

> Whether I threaten him or promise him,
> I fail to carry out my threat and fulfil my promise. [111]

"Indecency" (الفحشاء) here means miserliness and avarice.

Outward commentary · The whispering that restrains generosity

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: Satan threatens you with poverty because of expenditure. In his whispering he says: "If you give away your property, you will become poor, holding out your hand to people." He commands you to miserliness and avarice; the Arabs call a miser *fāḥish*. A report says: "The miser is far from God, far from people, far from the Garden and near the Fire. The generous person is near God, near people, near the Garden and far from the Fire. An ignorant but generous person is dearer to God than a miserly worshipper." Another says: "God takes the generous person by the hand whenever he stumbles."[B224]

111. Cairo editor, C302.1: The verse is by ʿĀmir ibn al-Ṭufayl.

God promises you, through expenditure, forgiveness for your sins, concealment of your faults and bounty: a replacement better than what you spent, in this world and the Hereafter. “Whatever you spend, He replaces it” [34:39]. God is expansive in bounty and giving. He knows what you spend, why you spend it and where your sincerity lies. Nothing in your affairs is hidden from Him.

Spiritual allusion · The test on the path of detachment

When a disciple turns towards God Most High and wishes to travel the path of detachment, renunciation and complete devotion to Him, Satan confronts him as a test and trial from God. The Presence is guarded by obstacles, so that the truthful seeker may be distinguished from the false.

He frightens him with poverty and commands him to remain with causes and customary patterns—the most indecent disobedience in the eyes of the elect, for lofty aspiration disdains occupation with anything other than the divine Presence. God promises you who turn towards Him forgiveness of sins and concealment of faults. He covers your quality with His quality and your attribute with His attribute, bringing you to Himself through the bounty and generosity that come from Him to you, not through the struggle and endurance that come from you to Him. “Were it not for God’s bounty and mercy upon you, not one of you would ever become pure” [24:21]. God is expansive in generosity and goodness, knowing who is fit for bounty and grace.

One fruit of renunciation and complete devotion is the coming of wisdom upon the servant’s tongue and heart, as He indicates next.

2:269 · Wisdom and the union of power with wisdom

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 303–304

يُؤْتِي الْحِكْمَةَ مَنْ يَشاءُ وَمَنْ يُؤْتَ الْحِكْمَةَ فَقَدْ أُوتِيَ خَيْراً كَثِيراً وَما يَذَّكَّرُ إِلاَّ أُولُوا الْأَلْبابِ (269)

269. He gives wisdom to whom He wills. Whoever is given wisdom has been given abundant good. None takes heed except those possessed of understanding.

Language · Knowledge realized and action perfected

Al-Bayḍāwī said: wisdom (الحكمة) is realizing knowledge and perfecting action. Other definitions are: readiness in answering and correctness in judgment; or every substantial excellence of speech or deed.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: He gives wisdom to whom He wills among His servants—understanding religion and seeing clearly into affairs. The Prophet said: "Whomever God desires good for, He gives understanding in religion and inspires with right guidance."[B225] Wisdom is also explained as sound judgment, understanding God's Book, or understanding from God.

Whoever is given wisdom has received abundant good, for he has obtained the good of both abodes. One who realizes knowledge of God and His rulings and perfects the action He commands has surely purified his heart and cleansed his secret. He becomes one of those possessed of understanding (أولو الألباب). Hence the verse continues: "None takes heed except those possessed of understanding."

Spiritual allusion · Wisdom as perfected perception and conduct

Wisdom is witnessing the Essence clothed in the lights of the attributes: the reality of gnosis. Whoever knows God stands in awe of Him. Hence the saying attributed to the Prophet: "The beginning of wisdom is fear of God." Wisdom is also defined as stripping the secret free to receive inspiration; the light distinguishing satanic whispering from inspiration; or witnessing the Real Most High in every state.[B225]

The precise account is that wisdom means bringing a thing into being and perfecting it until it reaches the utmost completeness. This applies to knowledge, action, spiritual state and gnosis.

Al-Qushayrī said: wisdom is that an impulse from the Real should govern you, not a caller to falsehood; that the Real's overpowering forces should rule, not Satan's goads. Wisdom is also said to be correctness in affairs, or freedom from the dominance of human follies. Whoever has no rule over

his own self has no rule over another. Wisdom is accord with God's command, and folly is opposition to it. Wisdom is witnessing the Real, and folly is witnessing other than Him. The marginal commentator gives these sayings.

Spiritual allusion · Power, wisdom and the complete gnostic

Know that, in their technical usage, the Sufis call the mysteries of the Essence "power" (القدرة), and the lights of the attributes—the manifestation of their effects—"wisdom" (الحكمة). The whole of existence stands between wisdom and power. Power brings things forth; wisdom conceals them.[B226]

The connection of things and their association with causes is what they call wisdom. The execution of the command and its manifestation is called power. Someone who remains with wisdom is veiled from

witnessing power and is veiled from God. Someone who penetrates to witnessing power without remaining bound to causes and customary patterns is a beloved gnostic.

The complete gnostic unites witnessing power with acknowledging wisdom. He gives everyone possessing a right his right and renders everyone possessing a portion his portion. This must, however, be through taste and unveiling, not merely knowledge and imitation. And success is through God Most High.

He then encourages sincerity and warns against mixing expenditure with personal interests.

2:270–271 · Vows, open giving and hidden charity

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 304–305

وَما أَنْفَقْتُمْ مِنْ نَفَقَةٍ أَوْ نَذَرْتُمْ مِنْ نَذْرٍ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ يَعْلَمُهُ وَما لِلظَّالِمِينَ مِنْ أَنْصارٍ (270) إِنْ تُبْدُوا الصَّدَقاتِ فَنِعِمَّا هِيَ وَإِنْ تُخْفُوها وَتُؤْتُوهَا الْفُقَراءَ فَهُوَ خَيْرٌ لَكُمْ وَيُكَفِّرُ عَنْكُمْ مِنْ سَيِّئاتِكُمْ وَاللَّهُ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ خَبِيرٌ (271)

270. Whatever expenditure you make or vow you undertake, God knows it. The wrongdoers have no helpers. 271. If you disclose your charities, how excellent they are! If you conceal them and give them to the poor, that is better for you, and He will efface some of your evil deeds. God is aware of what you do.

Language · Vows and the readings of niʿimmā

I say: a vow (النذر) is a legally responsible person's imposing upon himself something not already obligatory: "For God, I must give such-and-such in charity," "pray such-and-such," "fast such-and-such," or "If God heals my sick person, such-and-such is due from me." Whoever utters one of these is bound by it; whoever makes it conditional is bound when the condition occurs.

Niʿimmā (نعمّا) is originally *niʿma mā hiya*, with one *mīm* assimilated into the other. The verb has three forms: *naʿima*, with *fatḥa* on the *nūn* and *kasra* on the *ʿayn*, the original form; *naʿma*, with quiescent *ʿayn*; and *niʿma*, with *kasra* on the *nūn* and quiescent *ʿayn*.

The reading with *kasra* on both consonants follows the form with *kasra* on the *ʿayn*, making the *nūn* conform to it. A reduced vowel (اختلاس) points towards the form with quiescence. The reading with *fatḥa* on the *nūn* and *kasra* on the *ʿayn* retains the original and assimilates the two identical consonants. The reading with *fatḥa* on the *nūn* and quiescent *ʿayn* follows

naʿma and then assimilates, disregarding the meeting of two quiescent consonants because it is incidental, or because the second is doubled, making it easier. And God knows best.[B227]

The jussive reading of "We efface" (نكفّرْ) is coordinated with the syntactic position of the conditional consequence. The indicative reading begins a new statement: "We efface," or "He effaces," according to the two pronominal readings.

Outward commentary · The intention and manner of expenditure

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: whatever you spend, little or much, secretly or openly, rightly or wrongly; or whatever vow you undertake, conditionally or unconditionally, in obedience or disobedience—God knows it and will recompense you. Whoever spends in obedience or vows a pious act is among those who do good. Whoever spends in disobedience or vows disobedience is among the wrongdoers, who have no helpers to save them from God's punishment.

If you disclose your charities sincerely, how excellent their disclosure is—especially for someone whose example is followed, for whom it is preferable. If you conceal them and give to the poor secretly, that is better, being nearer to sincerity. This concerns

voluntary charity: its secrecy surpasses its publicity seventyfold. Obligatory giving requires a distinction. Someone fearing an admixture of ostentation should conceal it or act through a deputy; someone secure from that should make it public. It is transmitted that the publicity of an obligatory gift surpasses its secrecy twenty-fivefold.[B228]

If you do as commanded in either manner, you have acted well, and "We efface some of your evil deeds": We conceal some of your sins. It is transmitted that the giver of secret charity is shaded by God on the day when there is no shade except His shade. God is aware of what you do. Neither the one who conceals nor the one who discloses escapes His knowledge, nor the sincere person or the one with mixed motives. The words therefore encourage and warn. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Seeking wages, seeking unveiled communion

The servant's dealings with his Master are either to seek rewards or to lift veils. The first is given his wages from behind the door; the second enters with the beloved. Someone who works for this world wrongs himself, and the wrongdoers have no helpers. A transmitted saying declares: "The seeker of the world is a captive; the seeker of the Hereafter a hired worker; the seeker of the Real a prince."

People fall into three classes in their dealings with the Real. Concealment and secrecy befit disciples travelling in search of sincerity. Disclosure befits sincere scholars whose example is followed. A third class stops at neither disclosure nor concealment, but at what the moment brings forth: the complete gnostics.

Hence Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās said: "Whoever loves to be seen is a servant of being seen. Whoever loves concealment is a servant of concealment. For someone who is God's servant, it is the same whether He makes him manifest or conceals him."[B229]

All guidance is in God's hand; no other possesses any of it, as the Real, glorious is His majesty, explains next.

2:272 · Guidance belongs to God; the fruits of giving return to the giver

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 305–306

لَيْسَ عَلَيْكَ هُداهُمْ وَلكِنَّ اللَّهَ يَهْدِي مَنْ يَشاءُ وَما تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَلِأَنْفُسِكُمْ وَما تُنْفِقُونَ إِلاَّ ابْتِغاءَ وَجْهِ اللَّهِ وَما تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ يُوَفَّ إِلَيْكُمْ وَأَنْتُمْ لاَ تُظْلَمُونَ (272)

272. Their guidance is not your responsibility; God guides whom He wills. Whatever good you spend is for yourselves, and you spend only seeking God's Face. Whatever good you spend will be repaid to you in full, and you will not be wronged.

Theology · The messenger indicates; God creates guidance

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says to His Prophet: their guidance is not your responsibility, Muḥammad. You are not required to create guidance in their hearts, nor is that your function. You are only a warner, pointing towards good, such as expenditure and other acts, and forbidding evil, such as reminders, injury, giving inferior things and other faults.

God, however, guides whom He wills through His bounty and goodness. All affairs, good and evil, are in God's hand. As a matter of proper manners, however: "Whatever good befalls you is from God, and whatever evil befalls you is from your self" [4:79]. And success is through God.

Spiritual allusion · The inheritors' task is to make the path clear

What is said concerning the Messenger applies to his inheritors among those who give reminders. Guidance and enabling success are not in their hands. Their task is direction and clarification of the path. Those who call to God should not be anxiously intent upon bringing creation to guidance;

their task is to make the truth clear. "However eager you are for their guidance, God does not guide those He leaves astray" [16:37]. And God Most High knows best.

The Real Most High then returns to encouraging charity and sincerity within it.

Qurʾānic continuation · 2:272b

وَما تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَلِأَنْفُسِكُمْ وَما تُنْفِقُونَ إِلَّا ابْتِغاءَ وَجْهِ اللَّهِ وَما تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ يُوَفَّ إِلَيْكُمْ وَأَنْتُمْ لا تُظْلَمُونَ

Whatever good you spend is for yourselves, and you spend only seeking God's Face. Whatever good you spend will be repaid to you in full, and you will not be wronged.

Language · The claim of sincerity and its demands

I say: these three sentences all encourage giving what is good with a sincere intention.

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: whatever good you spend, little or much, is for yourselves; its benefit accrues to you, not another. If it is good, it is for yourselves; if it is bad, its recompense is yours. If you remind the recipient or injure him, you wrong yourselves; if you act sincerely, it is for yourselves.[B230]

Moreover, you claim that you spend only seeking God's Face. How, then, can you deliberately select the bad and make it an offering for His Face? How can you remind or injure through a gift supposedly given for His Face? That belies the claim.

Whatever good you spend, little or much, will be repaid in full at the Resurrection, seven hundredfold and many times beyond; He also replaces it for you in this world. You will be wronged in none of your deeds if you act sincerely or well. The spiritual allusion to this will follow together with the next verse.

He then identifies the recipients.

2:273 · The unobtrusive poor and support for those devoted to God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 306–308

لِلْفُقَراءِ الَّذِينَ أُحْصِرُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ لا يَسْتَطِيعُونَ ضَرْباً فِي الْأَرْضِ يَحْسَبُهُمُ الْجاهِلُ أَغْنِياءَ مِنَ التَّعَفُّفِ تَعْرِفُهُمْ بِسِيماهُمْ لا يَسْئَلُونَ النَّاسَ إِلْحافاً وَما تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ بِهِ عَلِيمٌ (273)

273. Give to the poor who are constrained in God's path and cannot travel through the land. Someone unaware supposes them wealthy because of their restraint. You recognise them by their marks. They do not ask people insistently. Whatever good you spend, God knows it.

Language · The recipients and persistent asking

I say: “For the poor” attaches to an omitted expression: this is given to the poor, or assign what you spend to the poor. *Ilḥāf* (الإلحاف) means insistence in asking: remaining with the person asked until he gives. It is accusative as an absolute accusative or a circumstance.

Outward commentary · Those who cannot pursue a livelihood

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: assign what you spend to the poor who have confined themselves to God’s path—fighting in His cause—and cannot travel through the land for trade or means of livelihood. Fighting and exclusive devotion to worship have occupied them away from earning. These are the People of the Bench (أهل الصفة), about four hundred poor Emigrants who lived on the mosque’s covered platform. They devoted their time to knowledge, remembrance and worship, and went out with every expedition sent by the Messenger of God.[B231]

Ibn ʿAbbās related: “The Prophet stood one day before the People of the Bench and saw their poverty, hardship and purity of heart. He said: ‘Rejoice, People of the Bench. Whoever of my community remains in the condition you are in, content with it, is among my companions.’”[B231]

Another explanation takes the verse to concern the poor generally, whose poverty prevents travel for trade. Someone ignorant of their situation supposes them wealthy because of their restraint from asking. You recognise them by their marks: weakness and a shabby appearance. The address is to the Messenger or to everyone.

“They do not ask people insistently”: they do not ask, or, if necessity makes them ask, they do not persist. Another explanation negates both asking and insistence: they make no request in which insistence could occur. It resembles the poet’s words:

> Upon a clear path by whose beacons one is not guided— [112]

112. Cairo editor, C307.1: This is the first half of a verse whose second half is: “When the old Nabataean camel scents it, it rumbles.” It is from a poem by Imruʾ al-Qays. Lāḥib means a broad road.

where, according to this explanation, there is neither clear path nor beacon: both are negated. A report from the Prophet says: “Whoever asks while possessing forty dirhams has asked insistently.”[B231]

Whatever good you spend, God knows it, recompensing little and much. This encourages expenditure, especially upon such people.

Spiritual allusion · Giving oneself and one’s means

Those who succeed and those who lose do so through their self and their money. Whoever gives both, or either, gains success and obtains his aim. Giving the self is greater and entails giving money. Giving money, if sustained, leads to giving the self.

Giving the self means surrendering it to the shaykh, who acts upon it as he wills; a mere indication from him suffices without explicit instruction. Whoever withholds both or either loses and fails on the path of the elect. The recipients are the shaykh or the poor devoted entirely to God, who have confined themselves to His path: the greater struggle.

Spiritual allusion · Supporting contemplatives and scholars

The *Qūt* relates that a virtuous man preferred poor Sufis over others in giving. Asked why, he replied: “Their concern is God, mighty and majestic. When need appears, one of their hearts becomes scattered. Restoring one person’s aspiration to God is dearer to me than giving to a thousand others whose concern is the world.” These words were reported to Abū al-Qāsim al-Junayd, who said: “These are the words of one of God’s saints. I have heard no finer words.”

It reached the author that this man’s worldly circumstances became so straitened

that he considered closing his shop. Al-Junayd sent him money that had come to him, saying: “Put this into your stock and do not abandon the shop. Trade does not harm someone like you.” It is said that he would not take payment from the poor for what they bought from him. Here the quotation ends.

ʿAbd Allāh ibn al-Mubārak directed his expenditure towards scholars. He said: “After prophecy, I know nothing better than scholars. If one of their hearts becomes occupied with need and dependants, he cannot devote him-

self to knowledge or turn towards teaching people. I therefore thought it best to relieve them of worldly concerns and free them for knowledge." And God Most High knows best.

He then encourages expenditure generally.

2:274 · Giving by night and day

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 308–308

الَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوالَهُمْ بِاللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهارِ سِرًّا وَعَلانِيَةً فَلَهُمْ أَجْرُهُمْ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ وَلا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (274)

274. Those who spend their wealth by night and day, secretly and openly, have their reward with their Lord. No fear shall be upon them, nor shall they grieve.

Language · The conditional force of the relative expression

I say: the relative expression is the subject and "they have their reward" the predicate. The *fāʾ* expresses causation and appears because the relative expression contains a conditional meaning. Alternatively, the predicate is omitted: "Among them are those who spend …"; "they have" then begins an explanatory new sentence (استئناف بياني).

Outward commentary · A life filled with good deeds

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those who spend their wealth by night and day, secretly and openly, filling their times with good deeds, have their reward with their Lord when they come to Him. They have no fear of something harmful overtaking them and do not grieve over a beloved thing lost. Rather, they have found God, who makes them independent of everything.

The verse is said to concern Abū Bakr, who gave forty thousand dinars in charity: ten thousand by night, ten thousand by day, ten thousand secretly and ten thousand openly. Another account identifies ʿAlī, who possessed only four dirhams and gave one by night, one by day, one secretly and one openly. The verse applies generally to anyone who acts as they did.[B232]

Spiritual allusion · Beyond reward at the door

The reward of giving wealth is recompense from behind the door, and security from punishment and an evil return. The reward of giving the self is entrance into the presence of the All-Holy and intimacy with the beloved within the veil. Whoever continually gives his self to God is made secure from veiling in the Abode of Peace. No fear reaches them in either abode, and no grief befalls them in either world. And success is through God.

Having encouraged charity, which is generally attained through the means of earning wealth—buying and selling—He warns against usury, lest eagerness to give charity make people lax about dealing in it.

2:275–279 · Usury, the lawful exchange and the purity of one's sustenance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 309–311

الَّذِينَ يَأْكُلُونَ الرِّبا لا يَقُومُونَ إِلاَّ كَما يَقُومُ الَّذِي يَتَخَبَّطُهُ الشَّيْطانُ مِنَ الْمَسِّ ذلِكَ بِأَنَّهُمْ قالُوا إِنَّمَا الْبَيْعُ مِثْلُ الرِّبا وَأَحَلَّ اللَّهُ الْبَيْعَ وَحَرَّمَ الرِّبا فَمَنْ جاءَهُ مَوْعِظَةٌ مِنْ رَبِّهِ فَانْتَهى فَلَهُ ما سَلَفَ وَأَمْرُهُ إِلَى اللَّهِ وَمَنْ عادَ فَأُولئِكَ أَصْحابُ النَّارِ هُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (275) يَمْحَقُ اللَّهُ الرِّبا وَيُرْبِي الصَّدَقاتِ وَاللَّهُ لاَ يُحِبُّ كُلَّ كَفَّارٍ أَثِيمٍ (276) إِنَّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحاتِ وَأَقامُوا الصَّلاةَ وَآتَوُا الزَّكاةَ لَهُمْ أَجْرُهُمْ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ وَلا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (277) يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ

وَذَرُوا ما بَقِيَ مِنَ الرِّبا إِنْ كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ (278) فَإِنْ لَمْ تَفْعَلُوا فَأْذَنُوا بِحَرْبٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ وَإِنْ تُبْتُمْ فَلَكُمْ رُؤُسُ أَمْوالِكُمْ لا تَظْلِمُونَ وَلا تُظْلَمُونَ (279)

275. Those who consume usury will rise only as one whom Satan has confounded through his touch. That is because they say, “Trade is only like usury,” although God has permitted trade and forbidden usury. Whoever receives an admonition from his Lord and desists may retain what is past; his affair belongs to God. Whoever returns—such are the people of the Fire, abiding therein. 276. God diminishes usury and causes charities to grow. God does not love any persistently ungrateful sinner. 277. Those who believe, do good deeds, establish prayer and give the alms have their reward with their Lord. No fear shall be upon them, nor shall they grieve. 278. You who believe, be mindful of God and abandon what remains of usury, if you are believers. 279. If you do not, then be warned of war from God and His Messenger. If you repent, your principal is yours: you shall neither wrong nor be wronged.

Language · The root of ribā and its two kinds

I say: *ribā* (الربا) originally means increase: property *rabā yarbū* when it increases. It is written with *wāw* in consideration of its original form as a verbal noun. Al-Farrāʾ said: they wrote it with *wāw* because the people of the Ḥijāz learned writing from the people of al-Ḥīra, whose usage was *ribū*. They taught them the letter-forms. Abū al-Sammāl al-ʿAdawī recited it thus. The two brothers recited it with vowel inclination (الإمالة), because of the *kasra*; the others without inclination (التفخيم).[B233]

In the technical usage of the Sacred Law, usury has two kinds: surplus usury (ربا الفضل) and deferred usury (ربا النَّساء). The first is an unequal exchange of foods or currencies within one genus; when the genera differ, there is no objection to inequality. The second is the exchange of foods or currencies with delayed delivery; this is forbidden even when the genera differ.[B233]

Outward commentary · The inverted comparison

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: those who consume usury—that is, take it; consumption is specified because it is the greatest use of wealth—will rise from their graves at the Resurrection only as one bereft of reason whom Satan throws into confusion through his touch, rising and falling. It is related that their bellies will be before them like enormous houses, so that each time they rise their bellies incline and throw them down. Abū Hurayra related that the Messenger of God said: "When I was taken by night to heaven, I saw men with bellies like houses, containing snakes visible from outside. I asked, 'Who are these, Gabriel?' He replied, 'Those who consume usury.'"[B233]

This punishment is because they declared usury lawful and said: "Trade is only like usury," placing both in one category. The comparison is inverted (عكس التشبيه). The expected form would be "Usury is like trade"; for emphasis, they make usury the original case and compare trade with it.

In the age of ignorance, when a debt fell due, the debtor would say: "Extend my term, and I shall increase the sum." They would do so, saying: "An increase as profit at the beginning of the sale and an increase when the debt falls due are the same; both rest upon mutual consent." The Real Most High declares this false: "God has permitted trade and forbidden usury." Analogy in the face of an explicit text is invalid, and the distinction is manifest. Someone who sells a dirham

for two dirhams makes the other lose a dirham without benefit. Someone who buys merchandise for a dirham and sells it for two is different: pressing need, desire for the goods and the prospect of their marketability may compensate for the price disadvantage.

Outward commentary · Desisting, persistence and the growth of charity

Whoever receives an admonition from his Lord, such as the prohibition of usury, and desists, retains what preceded the prohibition and need not return it. His affair belongs to God, not any of you; he is not to be interfered with. Whoever returns to declaring usury lawful after the prohibition has reached him is among the people of the Fire, abiding therein, because he has disbelieved and treated God's command as foolish.[B234]

God diminishes usury: removes its blessing and destroys the wealth into which it enters. He causes charities to grow: multiplies their reward and blesses the wealth from which they were taken. It is reported that the Prophet said: “Wealth is not diminished by charity,” and that God nurtures charity until it becomes like a mountain. Yaḥyā ibn Muʿādh said: “I know no grain weighing as much as the mountains of the world except a grain given in charity.”[B234]

God does not love any persistent rejecter—one who persists in declaring forbidden things lawful—or sinner, immersed in prohibited acts. He does not approve his condition or love him as He loves those who repent.

He then describes their opposite: those who believe in God and affirm what comes from Him, do righteous deeds, perfect prayer and pay the alms completely have their reward with their Lord when they come to Him. They fear nothing to come and grieve over nothing past; they have missed nothing, having found God.

He then reinforces the prohibition of usury:

Qur’ānic continuation · 2:278–279

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَذَرُوا ما بَقِيَ مِنَ الرِّبا إِنْ كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ
فَإِنْ لَمْ تَفْعَلُوا فَأْذَنُوا بِحَرْبٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ وَإِنْ تُبْتُمْ فَلَكُمْ رُؤُسُ
أَمْوالِكُمْ لا تَظْلِمُونَ وَلا تُظْلَمُونَ

You who believe, be mindful of God and abandon what remains of usury, if you are believers. If you do not, then be warned of war from God and His Messenger. If you repent, your principal is yours: you shall neither wrong nor be wronged.

Outward commentary · Abandon the outstanding increment

You who believe, be mindful of God and leave the outstanding usury you stipulated against people; do not collect it, if you are believers. The evidence of faith is compliance with what you are commanded. It is related that Thaqīf had money owed to them by some of Quraysh. When it fell due, they demanded the principal and usury, and the verse was revealed.

If you do not abandon what you have been forbidden, know of war from God and His Messenger. The reading *fa-ādhinū* (فآذنوا), with lengthening, means inform others of it. When the verse was revealed, Thaqīf are reported to have said: "We have no power to wage war against God and His Messenger." [113]

If you repent of taking usury and believing it lawful, your principal is yours. You do not wrong the debtor by taking an increment, and you are not wronged by a reduction in your principal. The implication is that one who does not repent has no entitlement, because he is an apostate. And God Most High knows best.[B234]

Spiritual allusion · Purity of sustenance and purity of inward reception

Pure dealings with God turn upon purifying one's morsel. Whoever makes his food pure has pure dealings; their purity reaches his heart. Whoever mixes impurity into his morsel clouds his dealings, and that clouds his heart. Hence the saying: "Whoever eats lawful food obeys God, willingly or unwillingly; whoever eats unlawful food disobeys God, willingly or unwillingly."

Likewise, divine incoming inspirations (الواردات الإلهية) arrive only upon someone whose food and drink are pure. One of them said: "Someone who does not know what enters his belly cannot distinguish lordly impulses from satanic ones." Sīdī ʿAlī al-Khawwāṣ said: "Know that spiritual support continually overflows upon every human heart and takes its colour according to the heart. The heart takes its colour accordingly, in keeping with the goodness or corruption of its sustenance."[B235]

113. Cairo editor, C310.1: One says "I have no two hands for this matter," meaning: I have no power to deal with it. Because repelling something is done with the hand, it is as though his hand were absent, owing to his inability to repel it.

Those who eat unlawful things, such as usury and its like, rise to their dealings with the Real only as a person bereft of reason with whom Satan plays, not knowing what he says or what is said to him. He is deprived of the delight of intimate converse and the sweetness of pure dealings. If he argues in his own defence and resorts to analogy, no success is to be hoped for him on the path of the elect. Whoever receives an admonition from his Lord, desists and seeks purity has his past pardoned. Whoever returns to following the desire he had abandoned has the fire of severance as his dwelling and refuge.

The Real's way with His servants is that when someone seeks an increase in the sensory dimension of his outward being, God diminishes the light of his inward being. When someone cuts off the supply feeding this outward sensory increase, God strengthens the inflow of lights within him. "God diminishes usury and causes charities to grow": He strengthens the support conveyed by charity's reward. God does not love any persistent rejecter and sinner, but every obedient one who returns to Him: someone who believes with the faith of realized people and follows those granted success. Such a person is necessarily threaded into the company of divine care and taken upon the path of protecting friendship (الولاية): those upon whom there is no fear and who do not grieve.

You who believe, be mindful of God as He should be, and leave whatever traces of sensory attachment and its causes remain within you, if you seek the faith of direct witnessing and arrival at the worshipped King. If you do not, know that you remain distant without realising it, opposing without being aware. If you return to your Lord, your principal is yours: the light of unity. You neither diminish it nor add to it—unless you direct yourselves wholly towards Him and seek arrival through Him at Him. God does not disappoint one who hopes for His generosity or turn away one who stands at His door, through His grace and bounty.

He then mentions the debtor in hardship.

2:280–281 · Respite for the debtor and the final return

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 311–313

وَإِنْ كانَ ذُو عُسْرَةٍ فَنَظِرَةٌ إِلى مَيْسَرَةٍ وَأَنْ تَصَدَّقُوا خَيْرٌ لَكُمْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ (280) وَاتَّقُوا يَوْماً تُرْجَعُونَ فِيهِ إِلَى اللَّهِ ثُمَّ تُوَفَّى كُلُّ نَفْسٍ مَّا كَسَبَتْ وَهُمْ لا يُظْلَمُونَ (281)

280. If the debtor is in hardship, grant respite until ease. To remit the debt as charity is better for you, if you know. 281. Be mindful of a day when you will be returned to God. Then every soul will be paid in full for what it earned, and they will not be wronged.

Language · The complete and incomplete verb kāna

I say: *kāna* (كان) is complete (تامة), meaning "be present." Ubayy and Ibn Masʿūd read "one in hardship" in the accusative (ذا عسرة), making *kāna* incomplete (ناقصة). "A respite" is a subject whose predicate is omitted: "A respite is incumbent upon you," or "What is obligatory is a respite." It is a verbal noun meaning granting delay. *Maysara* (ميسرة) has two forms, with *fatḥa* or *ḍamma* on the *sīn*. It is formed from ease: *ḍamma* is the usage of the Ḥijāz, and *fatḥa* that of Tamīm, Qays and Najd.

Outward commentary · Give time, or forgive the principal

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: if the debtor appears in hardship, you must grant him time until he has means. It is not lawful to constrain him or demand what he does not possess if he establishes his hardship by evidence. Giving him your principal as charity, without demanding it, is better for you, if you know the abundant good and beautiful remembrance that this brings.

Abū Hurayra related that the Prophet said: "Whoever grants respite to someone in hardship or remits his debt, God shades him beneath His Throne on the day when there is no shade except His shade." He is also

quoted as saying: “Whoever wishes his prayer answered and distress relieved should make things easy for someone in hardship”; and, “Whoever grants respite to a debtor in hardship has, for every day, a charity equal to the sum he deferred.”[B236]

Concerning debt, it is transmitted that the Prophet said: “God is with the debtor until he discharges his debt, provided it is not for something God dislikes.” ʿAbd Allāh would say: “I dislike passing a night without God Most High being with me,” and would instruct his servant to purchase on credit. [B236] 114

Prompt repayment without delay is also encouraged. The Prophet is quoted as saying: “Whoever walks to his creditor with what is due has the animals of the earth and fish of the water pray for him. For every step, a tree in the Garden is recorded for him and a sin forgiven. If he does not do so but delays, he is a transgressor.” He also said: “Delay by someone with means is wrongdoing. If one of you is referred to a solvent debtor, let him accept the transfer.”[B236]

Outward commentary · The final accounting

“Be mindful of a day when you will be returned to God”: the Day of Resurrection. Prepare for your return through charity and all other good deeds. Every soul will then receive the full recompense of what it sent ahead, without diminished reward or increased punishment.

Ibn ʿAbbās said: “This was the last verse Gabriel brought down. He said, ‘Place it after the first two hundred and eighty verses of al-Baqara.’ The Messenger of God lived twenty-one days after it.” Other accounts give eighty-one days or other intervals. And God Most High knows best.T16 [B237]

Spiritual allusion · The poverty that is relieved by a glance

If someone is poor in the light of certainty and gnosis, let him look towards those rich through God, accompany them and attach himself to them: the gnostics, who enrich through a glance. A transmitted saying declares that

114. Cairo editor, C312.1: He is ʿAbd Allāh ibn Jaʿfar ibn Abī Ṭālib, may God be pleased with them both.

God has men whom someone need only see to receive a happiness never followed by wretchedness. God has men who enrich by looking. The author of the poem rhyming in *ʿayn* says:

> Make ready and seek refuge with the saints:
> theirs are those encounters from God's Book.
> They are provision for the distressed, a treasure for hope;
> from them the ardent lover gains what he desires.

Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās said: "By God, between me and a man there is only my looking at him, and I have enriched him." His shaykh said of him: "What an excellent man is Abū al-ʿAbbās! A rustic who urinates upon his own leg comes to him, and before evening he has brought him to his Lord."

Our teachers' teacher, Sīdī al-ʿArabī ibn ʿAbd Allāh, said: "Were a Jew or Christian to come to me, evening would not fall before I had brought him to God." In every age there are men who enrich through a glance. I have encountered and accompanied them, and praise belongs to God.[B238]

"To remit as charity is better for you" addresses those rich through God: let them give to the poor through their glance and aspiration until the latter attain richness through God. And God Most High knows best.

The Real then commands the safeguarding of wealth by recording debts and having them witnessed.

2:282 · Recording debts, truthful testimony and the gift of knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 313–315

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا إِذا تَدايَنْتُمْ بِدَيْنٍ إِلى أَجَلٍ مُسَمًّى فَاكْتُبُوهُ وَلْيَكْتُبْ بَيْنَكُمْ كاتِبٌ بِالْعَدْلِ وَلا يَأْبَ كاتِبٌ أَنْ يَكْتُبَ كَما عَلَّمَهُ اللَّهُ فَلْيَكْتُبْ وَلْيُمْلِلِ الَّذِي عَلَيْهِ الْحَقُّ وَلْيَتَّقِ اللَّهَ رَبَّهُ وَلا يَبْخَسْ مِنْهُ شَيْئاً فَإِنْ كانَ الَّذِي عَلَيْهِ الْحَقُّ سَفِيهاً أَوْ ضَعِيفاً أَوْ لا يَسْتَطِيعُ أَنْ يُمِلَّ هُوَ فَلْيُمْلِلْ

وَلِيُّهُ بِالْعَدْلِ وَاسْتَشْهِدُوا شَهِيدَيْنِ مِنْ رِجالِكُمْ فَإِنْ لَمْ يَكُونا رَجُلَيْنِ فَرَجُلٌ وَامْرَأَتانِ مِمَّنْ تَرْضَوْنَ مِنَ الشُّهَداءِ أَنْ تَضِلَّ إِحْداهُما فَتُذَكِّرَ إِحْداهُمَا الْأُخْرى وَلا يَأْبَ الشُّهَداءُ إِذا ما دُعُوا وَلا تَسْئَمُوا أَنْ تَكْتُبُوهُ صَغِيراً أَوْ كَبِيراً إِلى أَجَلِهِ ذلِكُمْ أَقْسَطُ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ وَأَقْوَمُ لِلشَّهادَةِ وَأَدْنى أَلاَّ تَرْتابُوا إِلاَّ أَنْ تَكُونَ تِجارَةً حاضِرَةً تُدِيرُونَها بَيْنَكُمْ فَلَيْسَ عَلَيْكُمْ جُناحٌ أَلاَّ تَكْتُبُوها وَأَشْهِدُوا إِذا تَبايَعْتُمْ وَلا يُضَارَّ كاتِبٌ وَلا شَهِيدٌ وَإِنْ تَفْعَلُوا فَإِنَّهُ فُسُوقٌ بِكُمْ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ اللَّهُ وَاللَّهُ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ (282)

282. You who believe, when you contract a debt with one another for a specified term, write it down. Let a scribe write between you justly. No scribe should refuse to write as God has taught him; let him write, and let the debtor dictate. Let him be mindful of God, his Lord, and diminish nothing from it. If the debtor lacks sound judgment, is weak or cannot dictate himself, let his guardian dictate justly. Call two witnesses from among your men. If there are not two men, then one man and two women from witnesses you approve, so that if one of the two errs, the other may remind her. Witnesses should not refuse when called. Do not tire of writing the debt down, small or great, with its term. That is more equitable before God, firmer for testimony and nearer to preventing doubt—unless it is immediate trade you conduct among yourselves; then there is no blame upon you for not writing it down. Take witnesses when you trade. No scribe or witness shall be harmed. If you do that, it is disobedience on your part. Be mindful of God; God teaches you; and God knows all things.

Outward commentary · The term, the record and the debtor’s dictation

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: you who believe, when you contract a debt with one another through sale or loan, for a term specified by days or months—not by harvest or the pilgrims’ return, except in a forward

purchase (السَّلَم)—write it down. This is more secure and more effective in preventing dispute. The majority understand the command as recommendation.[B239]

Let a scribe write between you justly, adding and omitting nothing. He must be upright (عدل), so that his document is trustworthy. No scribe should refuse to write as God has taught him. Let him write in accordance with what God has taught him about recording contracts; or let him not refuse to benefit people through writing as God benefited him by teaching it.

Let the debtor dictate, since he is the one acknowledging the obligation before the witnesses. *Amlala* and *amlā* (أملل، أملى) both mean setting out what one holds or owes. Let him—the dictator or scribe—be mindful of God, his Lord, and diminish nothing of the debt in dictation or writing.

If the debtor lacks sound judgment and is wasteful, or is weak—an elderly man whose mind has become impaired, or a young child—or cannot dictate because he cannot speak or does not know the language, let his guardian, testamentary guardian or agent dictate justly on his behalf.

Call two Muslim men to witness the transaction. If two men cannot be brought, one man and two women or more take their place, from witnesses whose uprightness you approve. The plurality of women is stipulated so that if one loses track of the testimony and forgets, the other reminds her, since she is described here as deficient in intellect and religion.[B239]

He then warns witnesses against refusing to undertake or give testimony.

Qur'ānic continuation · 2:282b

وَلا يَأْبَ الشُّهَداءُ إِذا ما دُعُوا وَلا تَسْئَمُوا أَنْ تَكْتُبُوهُ صَغِيراً أَوْ كَبِيراً
إِلى أَجَلِهِ ذلِكُمْ أَقْسَطُ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ وَأَقْوَمُ لِلشَّهادَةِ وَأَدْنى أَلَّا تَرْتابُوا إِلَّا أَنْ
تَكُونَ تِجارَةً حاضِرَةً تُدِيرُونَها بَيْنَكُمْ فَلَيْسَ عَلَيْكُمْ جُناحٌ أَلَّا تَكْتُبُوها
وَأَشْهِدُوا إِذا تَبايَعْتُمْ وَلا يُضَارَّ كاتِبٌ وَلا شَهِيدٌ وَإِنْ تَفْعَلُوا فَإِنَّهُ
فُسُوقٌ بِكُمْ وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَيُعَلِّمُكُمُ اللَّهُ وَاللَّهُ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ

> Witnesses should not refuse when called. Do not tire of writing the debt down, small or great, with its term. That is more equitable before God, firmer for testimony and nearer to preventing doubt—unless it is immediate trade you conduct among yourselves; then there is no blame upon you for not writing it down. Take witnesses when you trade. No scribe or witness shall be harmed. If you do that, it is disobedience on your part. Be mindful of God; God teaches you; and God knows all things.

Language · Weariness and the active or passive verb

I say: *sa'am* (السأم) means weariness. "Shall not harm or be harmed" (لا يضار) may be active, originally *yuḍārir* with *kasra*, or passive, with *fatḥa* in the original unassimilated form.[B240]

Outward commentary · Witnesses, immediate trade and the prevention of injury

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: witnesses must not refuse to undertake testimony when called, where the duty falls specifically upon them. They are called witnesses in view of what they will become. The duty becomes individual only if no others are available. Or the prohibition concerns refusing to deliver testimony where no harm is involved.

Do not tire of writing down an obligation when it recurs, whether small or great. Record it with its term. Such recording is more equitable before God, since it better prevents dispute and safeguards rights; firmer for testimony, making it more established and easier to deliver; and nearer to preventing doubt about the debt's kind, amount and term. Once these are written, no one remains uncertain about them.

An exception is immediate trade, with no deferred term, conducted for ready payment among yourselves. There is no blame for not writing it because dispute is less likely. Take witnesses whenever you trade, whether on credit or for cash, as a precaution against denial. The majority regard the commands in this verse as recommendations.

On the active construction, neither scribe nor witness should harm another by distorting or altering the document or testimony. On the passive construction, neither should be harmed by being hurried away from an im-

portant affair, required to give testimony from a far-off place or denied his fee. If you commit such injury and what you have been forbidden, it is departure from uprightness on your part.

Be mindful of God by avoiding opposition to His commands and prohibitions. God teaches you the divinely bestowed sciences. God knows all things: the reverent and the disobedient alike are not hidden from Him.

Language · Teaching is a gift, not an effect produced by reverence

The divine Name is repeated in the three clauses because each is independent: the first urges reverence; the second promises teaching; the third magnifies His standing. Explicit naming also conveys greater magnification than a pronoun. Al-Bayḍāwī says this.

The *wāw* is introduced in the response to the command to show that God's teaching of the reverent is not an effect caused by their reverence, but pure bounty and generosity. Reverence is a path leading to that generosity, not a cause producing it. "The judgment of eternity is too exalted to be attributed to causes." And God Most High knows best.[B240]

The Real then mentions the ruling on pledges.

2:283 · Pledges, trust and recording the gifts of the heart

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 315–316

وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ عَلى سَفَرٍ وَلَمْ تَجِدُوا كاتِباً فَرِهانٌ مَقْبُوضَةٌ فَإِنْ أَمِنَ
بَعْضُكُمْ بَعْضاً فَلْيُؤَدِّ الَّذِي اؤْتُمِنَ أَمانَتَهُ وَلْيَتَّقِ اللَّهَ رَبَّهُ وَلا تَكْتُمُوا
الشَّهادَةَ وَمَنْ يَكْتُمْها فَإِنَّهُ آثِمٌ قَلْبُهُ وَاللَّهُ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ عَلِيمٌ (283)

283. If you are travelling and find no scribe, let there be a pledge taken into possession. If one of you trusts another, let the one entrusted discharge his trust and be mindful of God, his Lord. Do not conceal testimony. Whoever conceals it has a sinful heart. God knows what you do.

Language · The implied predicate or subject

I say: “A pledge” (رهان) may be predicate or subject: “The security is a pledge,” or “A pledge is incumbent upon him.”

Outward commentary · Possession of security and honouring trust

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: if you are travelling and find no scribe to record testimony to a sale or debt, the security replacing formal witnessing is a pledge taken into possession. Travel is not a condition of a valid pledge: the Prophet “pledged his coat of mail with a Jew in Medina for barley.” Travel is mentioned as the usual circumstance in which scribes are unavailable.[B241]

The majority require taking possession. If this has not occurred before an impediment arises, the creditor has no exclusive claim to the pledged asset against his debt. If one of you trusts another and dispenses with a pledge because he trusts his honesty, lending without security, let the one entrusted discharge his trust—that is, his debt. It is called a trust because he was trusted without pledge or witnesses. Let him be mindful of God, his Lord, by repaying and not denying the debt.

Do not conceal testimony, witnesses—or debtors, concerning their acknowledgment against themselves. Whoever refuses to give the testimony he undertook, or to pay the debt he owes, has a sinful heart, concealing what it knows. Concealment is an act of hearts, so the sin is attached to the heart. A parallel is: “The eye commits fornication, and its fornication is looking.” Alternatively, the sin is ascribed to the heart for emphasis, since it is chief among the limbs. If the heart sins, the whole person sins: the sin has taken firm hold of his noblest part and surpassed his other sins.

He then threatens those who conceal:

“God knows what you do.” Neither what you reveal nor what you hide is concealed from Him. It is related that the Prophet said: “Whoever conceals testimony when called is like someone who gives false testimony.”[B241]

Spiritual allusion · Record inspiration, then submit it to its witnesses

As God commands the recording of worldly debts and care for them, He commands the recording of divinely bestowed sciences and sacred incoming inspirations, and rejoicing in them. These deserve it even more, for their fruits endure and their results abide.

A wisdom may come to the heart from the world of holiness, immense as a mountain. If you neglect it and do not promptly record it, it shrinks to the size of a camel. Delay further and it becomes like a bird, then an egg, then is erased from the heart. In this sense it is said:

> Knowledge is game, and writing its tether;
> bind your catches with strong cords.
> It is ignorance to catch a dove
> and leave it loose among its companions.[B242]

Someone unable to write should dictate it to someone who can, diminishing nothing but dictating as it came to his heart. If his expression is weak, let someone who expresses himself well dictate justly on his behalf, without adding or subtracting meaning. Let him call men skilled in this art—the gnostics—to witness it; failing them, whoever is present among firmly established spiritual poor, lest the wisdom contain a defect arising from its recipient's deficiency.

Or let him call two upright witnesses to the incoming inspiration: the Book and the Sunna. If it accords with them, it is accepted; otherwise it is rejected. Al-Junayd said: "A subtle point may fall into my heart, but I do not accept it without the testimony of two upright witnesses: the Book and the Sunna."

If you are in haste and find no scribe, entrust these inspirations as pledges within one another's hearts until they can be recorded. Whoever conceals incoming inspirations from his shaykh or brothers has a sinful heart, for that is a kind of betrayal on the path of spiritual nurture. And God Most High knows best.

The Real then warns His servants against opposing His commands.

2:284 · The reckoning of what is within

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 316–317

لِلَّهِ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ وَإِنْ تُبْدُوا ما فِي أَنْفُسِكُمْ أَوْ تُخْفُوهُ يُحاسِبْكُمْ بِهِ اللَّهُ فَيَغْفِرُ لِمَنْ يَشاءُ وَيُعَذِّبُ مَنْ يَشاءُ وَاللَّهُ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (284)

284. To God belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is in the earth. Whether you disclose what is within yourselves or conceal it, God will call you to account for it. He then forgives whom He wills and punishes whom He wills; and God has power over all things.

Language · Reckoning and its consequence

I say: whoever reads “then He forgives” (فيغفر) in the jussive (الجزم) coordinates it with the conditional response (الجواب). Whoever reads it in the indicative (الرفع) takes it as a fresh statement (الاستئناف): that is, “He, then, forgives.”

Outward commentary · Being called to account is not necessarily being punished

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “To God belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is in the earth,” as His creation, possession and servants. He disposes of them as He wills, showing mercy to whom He wills by His bounty and punishing whom He wills by His justice. “Whether you disclose”—make manifest—“what is within yourselves” of evil and resolve to commit it, “or conceal it” in your hearts, “God will call you to account for it” on the Day of Resurrection. “He then forgives whom He wills” to forgive “and punishes whom He wills” to punish. “God has power over all things”: neither punishing nor forgiving anyone is beyond His power. The Real, exalted is He, expresses this by “calling to account” (المحاسبة), not by “holding culpable” (المؤاخذة): He did not say, “God will hold you culpable for it.” Calling to account is more general, and can be fulfilled by making sins acknowledged without exacting punishment for them. For the Prophet, bless-

ings and peace be upon him, said: “The believer draws near to his Lord until He places His shelter over him and makes him acknowledge his sins, saying, ‘Do you recognize

such-and-such?’ He says, ‘My Lord, I recognize it.’ Thus He confronts him with his sins, one by one; then God, exalted is He, says, ‘I am the One who concealed them for you in the world, and I forgive them for you today.’” To God belong bounty and gracious favour, and to Him belong praise and thanksgiving.[B243]

Spiritual allusion · Clearing the heart of otherness

“Whether you disclose what is within yourselves” of evil incoming thoughts (الخواطر الردية) and satanic visitations, or conceal it in your hearts until it interposes between you and witnessing your Beloved, “God will call you to account for it. He then forgives whom He wills”: He effaces its darkness from that person’s heart by inspiring repentance and a swift return to wakefulness. “And He punishes whom He wills” by leaving him with the darkness of those other things, plunging into the seas of those troubles. Nothing prevents hearts from witnessing the lights but their occupation with the darkness of otherness (الأغيار). Empty your heart of otherness, and you will fill it with recognitions and mysteries. To become the very eye of the Eye (عين العين), efface from your heart the dot of the letter ghayn (الغين): it is the dot of all that is other (السوى). How excellent is the poet’s saying:[B244]

> When the cosmos vanishes from the eye of my unveiling,
> the inmost secret witnesses its unseen in my disclosure.
> Cast the cosmos from your direct vision, and erase
> the dot of ghayn, should you wish to see me.

Know that incoming thoughts are of four kinds: angelic, lordly, from the lower self, and satanic (ملكي، رباني، نفساني، شيطاني). The angelic and the lordly command only good; those from the lower self and Satan command only evil. The latter may command good when a concealed means to evil lies within it. The difference between the thought arising from the lower self and the satanic thought is that the former persists: neither seeking refuge nor anything else removes it, except antecedent divine care. The satanic thought, by contrast, departs with remembrance of God and returns with heedlessness of God. And God, exalted is He, knows best.

Outward commentary · The Companions' submission and the ensuing relief

When His words, "Whether you disclose what is within yourselves …," were revealed, they weighed heavily upon the Companions—God be pleased with them. Al-Ṣiddīq, al-Fārūq, ʿAbd al-Raḥmān, Muʿādh and some of the Anṣār came, sank to their knees and said: "Messenger of God, no verse more burdensome than this has been sent down to us. If we are taken to task for what we say within ourselves, we shall perish!" The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said, "Thus has it been revealed." They said, "We have been charged with deeds beyond our power." He said, blessings and peace be upon him: "Are you, then, perhaps saying what the Children of Israel said, 'We hear and disobey'? Say, 'We hear and obey.'" They said, "We hear and obey," and their tongues yielded to these words. God then sent down relief and related their faith and submission, saying:[B245]

2:285–286 · Faith, capacity and the final supplication

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 317–320

آمَنَ الرَّسُولُ بِما أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْهِ مِنْ رَبِّهِ وَالْمُؤْمِنُونَ كُلٌّ آمَنَ بِاللَّهِ وَمَلائِكَتِهِ وَكُتُبِهِ وَرُسُلِهِ لاَ نُفَرِّقُ بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِنْ رُسُلِهِ وَقالُوا سَمِعْنا وَأَطَعْنا غُفْرانَكَ رَبَّنا وَإِلَيْكَ الْمَصِيرُ (285) لا يُكَلِّفُ اللَّهُ نَفْساً إِلاَّ وُسْعَها لَها مَا كَسَبَتْ وَعَلَيْها مَا اكْتَسَبَتْ رَبَّنا لا تُؤاخِذْنا إِنْ نَسِينا أَوْ أَخْطَأْنا رَبَّنا وَلا تَحْمِلْ عَلَيْنا إِصْراً كَما حَمَلْتَهُ عَلَى الَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِنا رَبَّنا وَلا تُحَمِّلْنا ما لا طاقَةَ لَنا بِهِ وَاعْفُ عَنَّا وَاغْفِرْ لَنا وَارْحَمْنا أَنْتَ مَوْلانا فَانْصُرْنا عَلَى الْقَوْمِ الْكافِرِينَ (286)

285. The Messenger believes in what has been sent down to him from his Lord, and so do the believers. Each believes in God, His angels, His books and His messengers: "We make no distinction between any of His messengers." They say, "We hear and obey. Your forgiveness, our Lord! To

You is the return."
286. God charges no soul beyond its capacity. To its credit is what it has earned, and against it is what it has acquired. "Our Lord, do not take us to task if we forget or err. Our Lord, do not lay upon us a burden such as You laid upon those before us. Our Lord, do not make us bear what we have no strength to bear. Pardon us, forgive us and have mercy on us. You are our Master: give us victory over the unbelieving people."

Language · Collective reference and the plea for forgiveness

I say: in the reading "we make no distinction" (لا نفرق), with nūn, a verb of saying is understood: "They say, 'We make no distinction.'" In the reading with yāʾ, the reference is to "each": each one of them makes no distinction "between any of His messengers." "Between" (بين) is a relational adverb (الظروف النسبية), occurring only between two or more things. You say, "I sat between Zayd and ʿAmr," "between two men," or "between men," but not "between Zayd" alone. Here it is annexed to "any one" (أحد) because that word has a collective meaning: "We make no distinction between individuals among them." Compare the Prophet's saying, blessings and peace be upon him, "Spoils were never made lawful to anyone—black-haired heads—other than you."[B246] "Your forgiveness" (غفرانك) is an absolute accusative (مفعول مطلق): "Forgive us with Your forgiveness." Alternatively, "[We seek] Your forgiveness," in which case it is a direct object (مفعول به).

Theology · The degrees and objects of faith

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "The Messenger believes in what has been sent down to him from his Lord," with the faith of realization and witnessing (تحقيق وشهود); "and the believers," each according to his certainty. "Each" one of them "believes in God" as befits him: through witnessing and direct vision (شهود وعيان), or evidence and demonstration (دليل وبرهان). Each believes in His angels: that they are honoured servants, who "do not disobey God in what He commands them, and do what they are commanded" [66:6]. And in "His books": that they are God's speech, containing command and prohibition, promise and warning, narratives and reports. Those known by name—the Torah, Gospel, Psalms and Criterion—must be believed in individually; those not known must be believed in collectively. And in "His messengers": that they are human beings endowed with perfec-

tions and free from defects in a manner appropriate to their condition. The Messenger and believers say, “We make no distinction between any of His messengers”; or, in the other reading, each one “makes no distinction between any of His messengers.” They do not affirm some and deny others, as the Jews and Christians made distinctions. “They say”—the believers—“We hear and obey”: we hear Your word and obey Your command. We seek “Your forgiveness, our Lord! To You is the return,” through resurrection and rising from the dead. This is their acknowledgement of resurrection, which completes the pillars of faith.

Theology · Capacity, acquisition and divine pardon

When their faith was realized and their submission established, God lightened their burden by saying, “God charges no soul beyond its capacity”: only what lies within its strength and the extent of its ability. This indicates that imposing the impossible does not occur; it does not establish that such imposition is itself impossible. As for what is impossible according to ordinary custom (المحال العادي), imposing it is admissible; what is rationally impossible (المحال العقلي) cannot be imposed, since its occurrence is inconceivable.[B247] When God charges His servants with what they can bear, each soul has “to its credit what it has earned” of good, and is paid its reward in full; “and against it what it has acquired” of evil, whose recompense it will see, unless the Possessor of Majesty and Generosity pardons it. On the side of good He uses “earning” (الكسب), and on the side of evil “acquiring” (الاكتساب), teaching reverent propriety (الأدب) in attributing good to God and evil to the servant. So consider this. They then complete their supplication: “Our Lord, do not take us to task if we forget or err.” That is, do not take us to task for the negligence or lack of concern that has led us into forgetfulness or error. The report says: “God has lifted from my community error, forgetfulness and what it says within itself.”[B248] 115 116

Alternatively, the intended meaning is error and forgetfulness themselves. Punishment for these is not rationally impossible. Sins resemble poisons: just as taking poison leads to destruction even when it is taken in error, so committing sins might conceivably lead to punishment even without delib-

115. Cairo editor, C318.1: An impossibility according to the customary course: for example, a human lifting a mountain.

116. Cairo editor, C318.2: A rational impossibility: for example, combining two opposites.

erate resolve. But He, exalted is He, has promised to overlook them in mercy and bounty. A person may continue to pray for this in order that the favour endure, and in acknowledgement of it. This is supported by the implication of the Prophet's words, "Error and forgetfulness have been lifted from my community": those outside this community were taken to task for them, which shows that such punishment is not impossible. So says al-Bayḍāwī. They then say, "Our Lord, do not lay upon us a burden": a heavy covenant that weighs upon our backs, so that You punish us for abandoning it and failing to carry it; "such as You laid upon those before us." An example is the Jews' being required to kill themselves in repentance, cut away the place affected by impurity, and undertake other arduous obligations. "Our Lord, do not make us bear what we have no strength to bear": obligations exceeding our capacity. This indicates the admissibility of imposing what is ordinarily beyond one's capacity; otherwise, deliverance from it would not be requested. "Pardon us": efface our sins. "Forgive us": veil our faults. "Have mercy on us": turn tenderly towards us. Or: pardon our lesser sins, forgive our greater sins, and have mercy upon us in hardships and regrets. "You are our Master," our Lord and Helper: "give us victory over the unbelieving people," for it is the master's part to help those attached to him against their enemies.

Outward commentary · The closing verses and the merit of al-Baqara

Al-Bayḍāwī says: "It is related that when the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, made these supplications, he was told, 'I have done so.'" It is also related from him: "Two verses were sent down from the treasures of Paradise, written by the All-Merciful with His hand two thousand years before He created creation. Whoever recites them after the final evening prayer, they suffice him in place of standing in prayer through the night." And from him: "Whoever recites the two verses at the end of Sūrat al-Baqara in a night, they suffice him."[B249] The latter report refutes the view of one who disliked saying "Sūrat al-Baqara," maintaining that one should say, "The sūrah in which the cow is mentioned." Compare his words, blessings and peace be upon him: "The sūrah in which the cow is mentioned is

the pavilion of the Qurʾān. Learn it: learning it is a blessing, abandoning it a cause of regret, and the baṭala cannot withstand it." When asked who the baṭala were, he answered, "Sorcerers."[B250] 117

Spiritual allusion · Returning to God in difficulty

From the verse's inward meaning it is understood that anyone for whom a matter becomes difficult, a need hard to obtain, or upon whom hardship or affliction descends, should return to God, cast himself down before his Master and believe that all affairs are in His hand. God, exalted is He, will not leave him without assistance and support: He will lighten what has befallen him, or strengthen him to bear it. When the Companions—God be pleased with them—found reckoning for incoming thoughts burdensome, they submitted and yielded to their Master's command. He then sent relief upon them and removed the obligation in that respect. Whoever returns all his affairs to God has all his needs fulfilled through God. "Among the signs of success at the ends is returning to God at the beginnings."[B251]

Spiritual allusion · Love, overwhelming states and settled realization

Regarding His words, "Our Lord, do not make us bear what we have no strength to bear," it has been said that what is meant is love for God. A servant should therefore ask his Master for no more of His love than he can bear. Consider the story of the man who asked our master Moses, peace be upon him, to ask God to bestow His love upon him. When Moses asked his Lord, the man wandered distraught, rent his clothes, and his limbs were torn apart until he died. Moses privately addressed his Lord concerning him, and He said: "Moses, a thousand men all asked Me what this man asked. I divided a portion of My love among them, and that share fell to him"—or words to that effect from Him, exalted is He.[B252] One of the righteous said: "I attended Dhū l-Nūn's gathering in Fusṭāṭ, Egypt. I estimated those present at seventy thousand. That day he spoke of love of God, and eleven men died in the gathering. A disciple cried, 'Abū l-Fayḍ, you have spoken of love of God; speak now of the love of created beings.'T17 Dhū l-

117. Cairo editor, C319.1: Al-Shihāb al-Khafājī, in his supercommentary on al-Bayḍāwī, reconciles those who deem saying "Sūrat al-Baqara" objectionable with the majority who permit it: the prohibition applied only in the early period of Islam, when foolish polytheists mocked Sūrat al-ʿAnkabūt and similar names. The usage was prohibited to counter the obstinate opponents. Then, when religion became established and God cut off the wrongdoing people, the usage became widespread and permissible.

Nūn gave a deep groan, reached towards his shirt, tore it in two, and said: ‘Ah! Their pledges are forfeit, their eyes overflow. They have allied themselves with sleeplessness and parted company with slumber. Their nights are long, their sleep little. Their sorrows do not run out, their cares do not depart. Their affairs are hard, their tears abundant, their eyes weeping, their eyelids sore. Time, family and neighbours have become their enemies.’”[B252] I say: this is the condition of worshippers and ascetics, people of strenuous effort and exertion, overcome by disturbing fear or unsettling longing. As for the gnostics who have arrived (العارفون الواصلون), this weariness has left them, and after toil they have passed into repose. They have reached the witnessing of the Beloved and intimate converse with the Near. Their worship is of the heart, their works inward: now contemplation, now vision, while abiding in the Presence. Their longing has grown still and their disquiet departed. They have drunk and been quenched, become intoxicated and returned to sobriety. States no longer move them, nor do words excite them; rather, they are like firmly rooted mountains. May God benefit us through their remembrance and make us of their company. Amen. On His words, “Pardon us,” al-Wartajbī says: “‘Pardon us’ our slight knowledge of You; ‘forgive us’ our shortcoming in worshipping You; and ‘have mercy on us’ through communion with You and witnessing You.” And success is through God. He guides to the even path. Peace be upon the messengers, and praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds. [118]

118. Cairo editor, C320.1: Ḥazara a thing, with the verbal noun ḥazr: he estimated it by conjecture; the person doing so is a ḥāzir.

Sūrat Āl ʿImrān

Sūrat Āl ʿImrān — The Family of ʿImrān

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 321–321

Outward commentary · Rebuke, revelation and the three communities

It is Medinan. Its verses number two hundred; it has also been said, one hundred and eighty-seven. Its words number three thousand four hundred and eighty.[A001] Its connection with the preceding sūrah is His saying near its beginning, “Those who disbelieve in God’s signs …”: this is, as it were, a completion and explanation of “give us victory over the unbelieving people.” Its contents direct reproach towards three groups: the Christians, for their excess concerning Jesus, peace be upon him, and their refusal to enter Islam—it was on their account that the sūrah was revealed, namely the Christians of Najrān; the Jews, for their failure to follow the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him; and the Muslims, for the loss of resolve that befell them on the day of Uḥud.[A002] For this reason He opens the sūrah by mentioning the three books: had they fulfilled their obligations towards them, no reproach would have been directed at them. Thus He says:

3:1–3 · The Living, the Self-Subsisting and the revealed books

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 321–322

الم (1) اللَّهُ لاَ إِلهَ إِلاَّ هُوَ الْحَيُّ الْقَيُّومُ (2) نَزَّلَ عَلَيْكَ الْكِتابَ بِالْحَقِّ مُصَدِّقاً لِما بَيْنَ يَدَيْهِ وَأَنْزَلَ التَّوْراةَ وَالْإِنْجِيلَ (3)

1. Alif. Lām. Mīm.
2. God—there is no god but He, the Living, the Self-Subsisting.
3. He has sent down upon you the Book in truth, confirming what came before it; and He sent down the Torah and the Gospel …

Language · The opening letters

I say: all the sūrahs' opening letters are pronounced in pause and have no syntactic inflection (الإعراب), since that which would occasion and require it is absent. They are therefore paused upon with sukūn, as when one enumerates "one, two." In the well-known recitation, the mīm here is given fatḥa only because the vowel of the following hamza is transferred to it. Consult al-Bayḍāwī.[A003] Ibn ʿAbbās—God be pleased with him—said: "Alif is His favours (آلاؤه), lām His gentleness (لطفه), and mīm His dominion (ملكه)." I say: perhaps each letter points to one of the groups to whom the reproach is directed. The favours are for those Christians who embraced Islam; the gentleness for those Jews who embraced it; and dominion for the Companions who embraced Islam—God's good pleasure be upon them—for God gave them possession of the earth's east and west. And God, exalted is He, knows best.

Outward commentary · The Qurʾān confirms the earlier revelation

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: O exalted sovereign, O magnified Messenger, convey to your people that God is One in His dominion. There is no deity beside Him, nor does He love that another be worshipped with Him. None deserves worship but the Living, the Self-Subsisting (الحي القيوم), whom intellects and the apprehensions of understanding cannot encompass. He attends to His servants' affairs and disposes of them according to His will. He has left them without excuse through the messengers' tongues and sent down books as clarification for those seeking guidance. Thus "He has sent down upon you the Book," in instalments over twenty years,[A004] "in truth": clothed in truth, so that "falsehood cannot come to it from before it or behind it" [41:42]; or clothed in proofs that repel every falsehood; or in justice, through which the oppression of every deviating person is removed. It is "confirming" the divine books that preceded it, agreeing with their narratives and reports, and so bearing witness to their truth and rectitude.

"And He sent down the Torah and the Gospel …"

3:4 · Guidance, discernment and the warning to unbelievers

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 322–322

مِنْ قَبْلُ هُدىً لِلنَّاسِ وَأَنْزَلَ الْفُرْقانَ إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا بِآياتِ اللَّهِ لَهُمْ عَذابٌ شَدِيدٌ وَاللَّهُ عَزِيزٌ ذُو انْتِقامٍ (4)

4. … before, as guidance for humankind; and He sent down the Criterion. Those who disbelieve in God's signs will have a severe punishment. God is Mighty, Possessed of requital.

Outward commentary · The Criterion and the earlier books

He sent them down before it, as guidance for those people charged with following them; or for all, on the principle that the Sacred Law of those before us is law for us, the community of Islam. He then sealed revelation by sending down "the Criterion" (الفرقان), charging humans and jinn with believing in it. Through it He distinguished truth from falsehood and dispelled the darkness of every unbeliever and ignorant person. He mentioned it before the other books because of its immense honour, and mentioned it last because it was the last to descend. And God, exalted is He, knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Understanding the mysteries of revelation

When the Real, glorious is His majesty, wished to point to the unity of the Essence and the manifestation of the lights of the Attributes, He first set forth symbols and allusions understood only by one who has dived into the depths of the ocean of the Essence and been submerged in the current of the Attributes. Through his contemplation he brings out precious jewels of knowledge and subtle understandings at which minds stand bewildered and for which the tongue's expression fails. Then he understands the subtleties of the symbols and the secrets of the allusions, and gains insight into the mysteries of the Essence and lights of the Attributes. He understands the mysteries of the heavenly books and the divinely bestowed sciences (العلوم اللدنية) and lordly gifts they contain. The lights of discernment shine in

his heart until he rises to the realization of those possessed of witnessing and direct vision. May God make us among them through His gracious favour and generosity.

He then threatens those who disbelieve in the Criterion after the radiance of the proof has become clear, saying:

Qurʾānic continuation · 3:4b

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا بِآيَاتِ اللَّهِ لَهُمْ عَذَابٌ شَدِيدٌ وَاللَّهُ عَزِيزٌ ذُو انْتِقَامٍ

Those who disbelieve in God's signs will have a severe punishment. God is Mighty, Possessed of requital.

Language · Requital

I say: intiqām and niqma (الانتقام والنقمة) mean the punishment of an offender. The verb is naqima or naqama, with kasra or fatḥa on the qāf.

Outward commentary · Might, punishment and gentleness

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "Those who disbelieve in God's signs," sent down to His Prophet or to all His prophets, or in the signs indicating His oneness, "will have a severe punishment" on the day when promise and warning are seen to take effect. God will then exact requital from the offenders and turn tenderly towards His believing servants. For "God is Mighty": no vanquisher overcomes Him and no fugitive escapes Him. He is possessed of great requital and abundant gentleness. May God show gentleness to us and to all Muslims. Amen.

Spiritual allusion · The loss of the blessing of God's friends

The appearance of God's friends is a gracious manifestation of God's signs. Whoever rejects them is deprived of their blessing, remaining in the torment of the veil and an ill reckoning. Requital and affliction become manifest upon him when God raises those brought near into the highest heights, while the heedless remain with the ordinary Muslims. "That is the Day of Mutual Loss and Gain" [64:9]. And God, exalted is He, knows best.

Having described Himself by oneness, life and self-subsistence—which entail absolute independence—the Real, glorious is His majesty, also describes Himself by encompassing knowledge and effectual power, saying:

3:5–6 · Knowledge, power and formation in the womb

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 322–323

إِنَّ اللَّهَ لا يَخْفى عَلَيْهِ شَيْءٌ فِي الْأَرْضِ وَلا فِي السَّماءِ (5) هُوَ الَّذِي يُصَوِّرُكُمْ فِي الْأَرْحامِ كَيْفَ يَشاءُ لاَ إِلهَ إِلاَّ هُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ (6)

5. Nothing in the earth or in heaven is hidden from God.
6. He it is who forms you in the wombs as He wills. There is no god but He, the Mighty, the Wise.

Outward commentary · Nothing escapes His knowledge or power

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “Nothing is hidden from God” concerning His creatures: belief or unbelief, obedience or disobedience. His knowledge encompasses whatever is in the high heavens and the lower earths, universal or particular, sensible or intelligible. He knows the number of pebbles and grains of sand, the measures of the waters and the weights of the mountains. He knows the occurrences of inward consciousness and the stirrings of thoughts, with beginningless, eternal knowledge. His power is effectual and His wisdom consummate. By His power He formed the drops in the wombs however He willed, with deficiency or completeness, perfected them through His wisdom, and brought them forth to the sustenance He had made available to them. Glory to the Disposer who is Knowing, Mighty and Wise! Nothing incapacitates Him and nothing falls outside the compass of His knowledge. There is no existent besides Him, and we worship none but Him.[A005] Success is through God, who guides to the even path.

Spiritual allusion · Trust in the One who first formed you

Whoever realizes that God is One in His dominion, without associate in His Essence, Attributes or acts; that He encompasses him in knowledge, hearing and sight; and that His command is between kāf and nūn—"when He wills a thing, He says to it, 'Be,' and it is" [compare 36:82]—how could he complain to anyone else of what descends upon him from Him? How could he raise his needs to other than his Master? How could he nurse anxiety, when his Master does not forget to bestow His goodness upon him? He who cared for you in the darkness of the inward parts, formed you in the wombs as He willed, and gave you all you ask and wish: how would He forget to show you His goodness and beneficence? How would He place you outside the compass of His gentleness and favour? Concerning this, the tongue of Reality (لسان الحقيقة) says:

> Remember My kindness to you when you were a drop;
> do not forget My forming your person in the womb.
> Trust Me in all your affairs:
> I shall suffice you against what is feared and dreaded.
> Surrender the affair to Me, and know that I
> dispose My decrees and do whatever I will.

He then describes His book, the Criterion, as containing what is decisive and clearly explained, and what is ambiguous, known only to God and to those firmly grounded among the people of gnosis, saying:

3:7–9 · The decisive, the ambiguous and those firmly grounded in knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 323–326

هُوَ الَّذِي أَنْزَلَ عَلَيْكَ الْكِتابَ مِنْهُ آياتٌ مُحْكَماتٌ هُنَّ أُمُّ الْكِتابِ وَأُخَرُ مُتَشابِهاتٌ فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ زَيْغٌ فَيَتَّبِعُونَ ما تَشابَهَ مِنْهُ ابْتِغاءَ الْفِتْنَةِ وَابْتِغاءَ تَأْوِيلِهِ وَما يَعْلَمُ تَأْوِيلَهُ إِلاَّ اللَّهُ وَالرَّاسِخُونَ فِي الْعِلْمِ يَقُولُونَ آمَنَّا بِهِ كُلٌّ مِنْ عِنْدِ رَبِّنا وَما يَذَّكَّرُ إِلاَّ أُولُوا الْأَلْبابِ (7) رَبَّنا لا

تُزِغْ قُلُوبَنا بَعْدَ إِذْ هَدَيْتَنا وَهَبْ لَنا مِنْ لَدُنْكَ رَحْمَةً إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ الْوَهَّابُ (8) رَبَّنا إِنَّكَ جامِعُ النَّاسِ لِيَوْمٍ لا رَيْبَ فِيهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ لا يُخْلِفُ الْمِيعادَ (9)

7. He it is who sent down upon you the Book. In it are decisive verses: they are the foundation of the Book; and others are ambiguous. Those in whose hearts is deviation follow what is ambiguous in it, seeking discord and seeking its interpretation. None knows its interpretation but God and those firmly grounded in knowledge, saying, "We believe in it; all is from our Lord." None takes heed but those possessed of understanding.
8. "Our Lord, do not cause our hearts to deviate after You have guided us. Grant us mercy from Your presence: You are indeed the Bestower.
9. Our Lord, You will gather humankind for a day of which there is no doubt. God does not fail the promise."

Language · Where the sentence ends

I say: "In it" (منه) is a preceding predicate (خبر مقدم), and "verses" is the subject (مبتدأ); one therefore pauses at "the Book." It has also been said that "in it" qualifies "a book," but that is remote. Ibn al-Subkī says: "The decisive (المحكم) is that whose meaning is clear; the ambiguous (المتشابه) is that whose knowledge God reserves to Himself, although He may acquaint some of His chosen ones with it."[A006] "They are the foundation of the Book" is a sentence. Normally the predicate should agree in number, giving "foundations" (أمهات). It is singular here either with the sense "each one [is a foundation]," or because the whole is treated as one verse. Zaygh (الزيغ) is deviation from truth. "Those firmly grounded in knowledge" (الراسخون في العلم) is coordinated with "God"; or it begins a new sentence, if the ambiguous is understood as that whose knowledge God reserves to Himself, such as how long the world will endure and when the Hour will arise, or that whose apparent meaning decisive proof shows not to be intended. So says al-Bayḍāwī. "When You guided us" (إذ هديتنا) is an adverbial expression in the genitive through annexation, construed as a verbal noun: "after Your guidance of us."[A007]

Outward commentary · The labour and rank of interpretation

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the One who alone possesses oneness and self-subsistence, from whom nothing in the higher or lower world is hidden, “is He who sent down upon you the clear Book.” Some of it consists of “decisive verses,” clear in meaning, without ambiguity or indeterminacy. “They are the foundation of the Book”: its root, to which the rest is referred. Some consists of “other ambiguous verses,” admitting possibilities: their intent is not clear, because of indeterminacy or an apparently conflicting sense, without examination and sound reflection. This is so that the excellence of discerning scholars may appear, and their eagerness to exert themselves in pondering these verses and acquiring the sciences necessary to derive their intent may increase. Through this, through tiring their minds in extracting their meanings and reconciling them with the decisive verses, they attain the highest degrees and loftiest stations. In *Nawādir al-uṣūl*, in discussing the ambiguous, its author divides it into two kinds. One is that whose knowledge is withheld except from the elect, such as the knowledge of the sūrahs’ opening letters. The other is that which none of the messengers, nor anyone beneath them, has attained: the mystery of predestination (سر القدر). This is not compatible with their servanthood: were it unveiled, servanthood would be impaired. He therefore concealed it from the messengers and angels, since they are in servanthood. When servanthood passes away, they will be able to bear it—that is, the mysteries of predestination. End of quotation.[A008] Sahl’s saying points to something of this kind: “Divinity has a mystery which, if disclosed, would nullify prophethood; prophethood has a mystery which, if disclosed, would nullify knowledge; and knowledge has a mystery which, if disclosed, would nullify the rulings.” End of quotation. I say: it follows that the Mighty Book contains the decisive and the ambiguous. As for His words, “A Book whose verses have been made firm” [11:1], they mean that the verses are preserved from corrupt meaning and feeble expression. His words “a mutually resembling Book” [39:23] mean that its parts resemble one another in soundness of meaning and strength of expression.

Outward commentary · Deviation and steadfast understanding

People’s relation to the ambiguous is of two kinds. “Those in whose hearts is deviation”—doubt or a turning from truth, such as innovators and their like—“follow what is ambiguous in it.” They attach themselves to its appar-

ent sense, or to a false interpretation, "seeking discord": seeking to turn people from their religion through doubt and deception, setting the ambiguous against the decisive. And "seeking its interpretation" according to their desires, so that it agrees with their innovation.

It is related from ʿĀʾisha—God be pleased with her—that the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, recited this verse and said: "When you see those who ask about what is ambiguous in it and dispute concerning it, they are those whom God meant. Beware of them, and do not sit with them."[A009] "None knows its interpretation" in reality "but God," exalted is He. Yet He may acquaint some of His specially chosen friends with it: they are "those firmly grounded," established "in knowledge," the gnostics of God, the people of effacement and subsistence (الفناء والبقاء), the people of the distinctive realization of unity. He has acquainted them with the mysteries of His unseen, so that nothing ambiguous remains for them in the Book or the Sunna. They say, "We believe in it," affirming that it is His speech. "All is from our Lord," decisive and ambiguous alike, and we have understood His intention in both. These are those possessed of understanding, whom He praises by saying, "None takes heed but those possessed of understanding": hearts purified of the darkness of desire and the haze of sense-perception.[A010] The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, was asked who the firmly grounded in knowledge were. He replied: "One whose oath proves true, whose tongue is truthful, whose heart is upright, and whose belly and private parts are chaste: that is one firmly grounded in knowledge."[A011] Nāfiʿ ibn Yazīd said: "Those firmly grounded in knowledge are those humble before God, abasing themselves in seeking God's good pleasure. They do not exalt themselves against those above them, nor despise those beneath them." End of quotation. It has also been said: one firmly grounded in knowledge is one in whom four things are found—godfearingness between himself and God, humility between himself and creatures, renunciation between himself and the world, and struggle between himself and his lower self. End of quotation. I say: the gnostic of God unites these qualities; he is therefore the one firmly grounded in knowledge, as stated above.

Theology · Mercy, steadfastness and the promised gathering

In their supplication to God they also say: "Our Lord, do not cause our hearts to deviate" from the way of truth by inclining to follow desire, "after You have guided us" to the path of arrival in Your Presence. "Grant us

mercy from Your presence," gathering our hearts through You and joining our spirits to the witnessing of Your oneness. "You are indeed the Bestower": You give the hopeful more than he hopes. "Our Lord, You will gather humankind for a day" of recompense "of which there is no doubt." Gather us, then, with those brought near, for You "do not fail the promise." Fulfil for us what You have promised on that day. Failure to fulfil a promise is impossible for Him, exalted is He. There is no difficulty concerning the promise of good. As for a threat of evil, if it concerns a specified individual, He does not fail to fulfil it; if it is general, He may forgo it through pardon. And God, exalted is He, knows best.[A012] The *Nawādir* also says: when those firmly grounded in knowledge referred knowledge of the ambiguous to the One who knows it, saying, "We believe in it; all is from our Lord," they feared the souls' avid appetite for seeking it. Knowledge is pleasurable, and the temptation of that pleasure incurs reproach. They therefore fled to their Lord, saying, "Our Lord, do not cause our hearts to deviate after You have guided us. Grant us mercy from Your presence," knowing that mercy extinguishes that temptation. Since the mystery of predestination will be unveiled on the Day of Resurrection, they yearned towards it, saying, "Our Lord, You will gather humankind …." They quieted their souls in expectation of that day, when wisdom will be inwardly concealed and power outwardly manifest. End of the passage, rendered in sense.

Spiritual allusion · The understanding of inward visitations

When hearts become pure and repose in the Presence of the Knower of unseen things, divine visitations (الواردات الإلهية), divinely bestowed sciences and holy gifts descend upon them. Some are decisive in construction and clear in meaning; others are indeterminate when first received,

and clarification follows their assimilation: "When We recite it, follow its recitation; then its explanation rests upon Us" [75:18–19]. They may also lie beyond the intellects' powers of apprehension. Those disposed to deviation and criticism follow what is ambiguous in these visitations, seeking to disturb ordinary people and turn them from the way of the elect, and seeking its interpretation in order to establish the Sacred Law's case against it. "None knows its interpretation but God," or one whose effacement in God has been realized: these are those firmly grounded in the knowledge of God. They say, "We believe in it; all is from our Lord," for hearts purified of desire do not speak from desire. These are the masters of hearts. They say:

“Our Lord, do not cause our hearts to deviate” from Your holy Presence “after You have guided us” to arrival there. “Grant us mercy from Your presence” to protect us from looking towards other than You. “You are indeed the Bestower.”[A010] “Our Lord, You will gather humankind”—those journeying towards You—“for a day” whose attainment admits no doubt: the day of meeting. “You do not fail the promise.” Join us to You, then, and interpose between us and whatever cuts us off from You. “You have power over all things.”

He then threatens the people of deviation and corruption, saying:

> **Translator’s source note · Cairo I:323–324:** Ibn ʿAjība discusses both grammatical constructions of wa-l-rāsikhūna fī l-ʿilm: a new clause and a continuation of the preceding clause.

3:10–11 · What wealth cannot replace

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 326–327

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا لَنْ تُغْنِيَ عَنْهُمْ أَمْوالُهُمْ وَلا أَوْلادُهُمْ مِنَ اللَّهِ شَيْئاً وَأُولئِكَ هُمْ وَقُودُ النَّارِ (10) كَدَأْبِ آلِ فِرْعَوْنَ وَالَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِهِمْ كَذَّبُوا بِآياتِنا فَأَخَذَهُمُ اللَّهُ بِذُنُوبِهِمْ وَاللَّهُ شَدِيدُ الْعِقابِ (11)

10. Those who disbelieve—their wealth and their children will avail them nothing against God. They are the fuel of the Fire.
11. Like the way of Pharaoh’s people and those before them: they denied Our signs, so God seized them for their sins. God is severe in punishment.

Language · Fuel and habitual conduct

I say: waqūd (الوقود), with fatḥa, means firewood; with ḍamma, wuqūd, it is the verbal noun. “Like the way of Pharaoh’s people” is a predicate: their way is like that of Pharaoh’s people. Daʾb (الدأب) is the verbal noun of daʾaba, “to persist”; it was then transferred to mean one’s condition and habitual

practice. “They denied” is either a circumstantial clause (حال), with qad understood, a fresh statement explaining their condition, or a predicate if “those before them” begins a new sentence.

Outward commentary · Neither wealth nor children can ransom them

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “Those who disbelieve” in what I have sent down upon our Prophet Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him—when they behold punishment, “their wealth and their children will avail them nothing” in place of God’s mercy or obedience to Him, or instead of His punishment. They are the firewood of Hell. Their condition is like that of Pharaoh’s people and those before them: “they denied Our signs, so God seized them for their sins,” destroying them and intensifying their punishment. “God is severe in punishment” towards whoever turns away from Him and relies on another.

Spiritual allusion · No substitute for the Beloved

Whoever rejects the people of spiritual election (أهل الخصوصية), losing his share in witnessing the grandeur of lordship, so that he suffers expulsion and remoteness and misses the companionship of the people of love and affection—neither wealth nor children will replace what he has lost. Sorrows and troubles adhere to him. As the poet says:

> Whoever misses communion with You has regret for his portion;
> whoever makes You his concern is raised by his aspirations.

Another says:

> One who has missed seeking arrival and attaining it
> from Him—tell me, what is he seeking?
> It is enough for the lover to be effaced from all besides
> his Beloved, whether present or absent.

And another:

> Everything you part with has a substitute;
> but part from God, and there is no substitute for Him.

In the *Ḥikam*: “What has one found who has lost You? What has one lost who has found You? Disappointed indeed is one content with another as a substitute for You; at a loss indeed is one who seeks to turn away from

You.” Everyone who stops with anything other than Him, failing to direct himself towards knowledge of the Master, is in the fire of estrangement and desire, with pharaonic souls and people of low aspiration. We ask God, exalted is He, for well-being.

He then begins reproaching the Jews, having set forth the nature of His Mighty Book and its decisive and ambiguous contents in preparation for addressing them, saying:

3:12–13 · Two armies and the sign of victory

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 327–328

قُلْ لِلَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا سَتُغْلَبُونَ وَتُحْشَرُونَ إِلى جَهَنَّمَ وَبِئْسَ الْمِهادُ (12)
قَدْ كانَ لَكُمْ آيَةٌ فِي فِئَتَيْنِ الْتَقَتا فِئَةٌ تُقاتِلُ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَأُخْرى
كافِرَةٌ يَرَوْنَهُمْ مِثْلَيْهِمْ رَأْيَ الْعَيْنِ وَاللَّهُ يُؤَيِّدُ بِنَصْرِهِ مَنْ يَشاءُ إِنَّ فِي
ذلِكَ لَعِبْرَةً لِأُولِي الْأَبْصارِ (13)

12. Say to those who disbelieve: “You will be overcome and gathered into Hell—an evil resting-place!”
13. You have already had a sign in two companies that met: one fighting in God’s way, and another unbelieving. They saw them as twice their number, with the very sight of the eye. God strengthens with His help whom He wills. In that is surely a lesson for those possessed of sight.

Outward commentary · The address at the market of Banū Qaynuqāʿ

I say: when the Messenger of God, blessings and peace be upon him, returned from Badr victorious and helped, with spoils and prisoners, he gathered the Jews in the market of Banū Qaynuqāʿ. He said: “Jews, fear God and embrace Islam. You know that I am truly God’s Messenger. Beware lest God bring down upon you the requital He brought upon Quraysh at Badr.” They said: “Muḥammad, do not be deceived because you encountered inex-

perienced men with no knowledge of war. If you fight us, you will certainly learn that we are the men." God then revealed this verse concerning them. [A013]

Outward commentary · The perceived numbers at Badr

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "Say," Muḥammad, "to those who disbelieve," among the Children of Israel or generally: "You will be overcome" if you fight the Muslims, "and gathered," after death and defeat, "into Hell —an evil resting-place": the punishment you have prepared for yourselves. His promise was fulfilled through the killing of Qurayẓa, the expulsion of Banū l-Naḍīr, the conquest of Khaybar, and the imposition of jizya upon the others. They were overcome wherever encountered and gathered into Hell, except those among them who embraced Islam.[A014] He then urges them to take a lesson from the Muslims' victory at Badr: "You," Jews, "have already had a sign"—a manifest lesson and indication of the truth of My saying that you will be overcome—"in two companies" that met on the day of Badr. These were

the Muslims, numbering three hundred and fourteen, and the idolaters, numbering about a thousand. "One company fighting in God's way" was the believers, "and another unbelieving" was the idolaters. In the reading with tāʾ, "you see them as twice their number," you Jews see the unbelievers as twice the Muslims' number, with certain perception. Nevertheless God strengthened the Muslims with victory and reinforcement until He made them prevail over their enemy. He will do the same for them against you. On this interpretation, "seeing" means knowing.[A015] In the reading with yāʾ, the pronoun may refer to the unbelievers: the unbelievers saw the Muslims as twice their own number. This occurred after God had made the Muslims appear few in their eyes, so that they dared to advance upon them. When they met them, however, the Muslims appeared numerous in their eyes until they were defeated: this was reinforcement from God for the believers. Alternatively, the believers saw the idolaters as twice the believers' number, though they were three times as many, so that they might stand firm against them and be certain of the victory God had promised in His words, "If there are twenty steadfast among you, they will overcome two hundred …" [8:65]. "God strengthens"—fortifies—"with His help whom He wills" to help, as He strengthened the people of Badr. "In that is surely a

lesson for those possessed of sight," whose eyes are open: God helped a people with neither numbers nor equipment against a people possessing both, neither of which availed them anything against God.

Spiritual allusion · The armies of light and otherness

When the heart turns towards its Master, two armies present themselves to it: the army of lights (جند الأنوار), which is the heart's army, and the army of otherness (جند الأغيار), which is the lower self's army. Battle joins between them. The army of lights seeks to raise the spirit to its homeland, the Presence of mysteries; the army of otherness seeks to bring the lower self down to the earth of pleasures and appetites and confine it in the prison of created things. When God wills a servant's happiness, He strengthens for him the army of lights and weakens the army of otherness. The latter is routed and the army of lights takes possession of his heart. Lights continue to descend upon him until the lights of face-to-face encounter shine upon him. He enters the Presence of mysteries—the Presence of witnessing—and finds protection in the neighbourhood of the Loving King. The voices of unseen callers address him: "Gnostic, say to those who disbelieve"—the army of otherness—"You will be overcome and gathered into Hell—an evil resting-place!" When God wills, in His justice, to abandon a servant to himself, He cuts off the reinforcement of lights and strengthens before him the army of otherness. The darkness of the lower self overcomes the heart's light, confining it in the prison of created things and imprisoning it in the darkness of the human frame. "God strengthens with His help whom He wills." Thus the meeting of the armies of light and otherness contains a lesson for those possessed of sight.

The Real, exalted is He, then explains the reinforcement of the army of otherness, which prevents eyes from taking heed, saying:

3:14 · Desires and their proper limit

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 328–331

زُيِّنَ لِلنَّاسِ حُبُّ الشَّهَواتِ مِنَ النِّساءِ وَالْبَنِينَ وَالْقَناطِيرِ الْمُقَنْطَرَةِ مِنَ الذَّهَبِ وَالْفِضَّةِ وَالْخَيْلِ الْمُسَوَّمَةِ وَالْأَنْعامِ وَالْحَرْثِ ذلِكَ مَتاعُ الْحَياةِ الدُّنْيا وَاللَّهُ عِنْدَهُ حُسْنُ الْمَآبِ (14)

14. Adorned for humankind is love of desires: women, sons, heaped-up stores of gold and silver, marked horses, livestock and cultivated land. That is the enjoyment of the life of this world; with God is the finest place of return.

Language · Adornment, wealth and its names

I say: “Adorned” (زُيّن) has its agent omitted. In reality (حقيقة), the agent is God, for there is no agent but He; according to the Sacred Law (شريعة), it is Satan, who serves as the cloth upon which the filth of impurities is wiped.[A016] A qinṭār is abundant wealth. It has been said to be a hundred thousand dinars, or the contents of a bull’s hide. It is related from the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, that he said, “A qinṭār is a thousand dinars”; another version says, “two thousand dinars.” In our usage today it is a thousand mithqāls.[A017] “Heaped-up” (المقنطرة) means arranged in piles one above another. Gold is called dhahab (ذهب) because it goes away and perishes, or because it carries hearts away from the Presence of unseen things. Silver is called fiḍḍa (فضة) because it disperses, or because it disperses the hearts of those occupied with it. “Marked” (المسوّمة) means bearing marks, grazing, or finely formed and beautiful.

[Translator’s print-source notes: T18]

Outward commentary · Desire that distracts, and enjoyment received with permission

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “Adorned for humankind is love of desires,” and reliance upon familiar pleasures, until this turns them from reflection and taking heed, or from witnessing and inward perception. This concerns those who stop at their enjoyment and are deceived by the appetite for their pleasure. Those reminded by them of the bliss of the Gardens and helped by them to obey the Requiting King do not stop at their enjoyment or turn towards their immediate pleasure. Rather, they descend to them with permission and firm establishment, grounded in certainty. The verse’s warning does not encompass them, in view of the Prophet’s saying, blessings and peace be upon him, “Three things from your world have been made dear to me ….”[A018] One of God’s friends said: “Every appetite veils the heart from God, except the appetite for intercourse”—meaning lawful intercourse. Al-Wartajbī says: “He tries them so that the truthful one, who leaves these appetites, may be distinguished from the false one, who embarks upon seeking them.” It has been said: whoever occupies himself with these things is cut off by them from the path of the Real. Whoever regards them as small and turns from them receives, in exchange, safety from them, and the way to the realities is opened to him. End of quotation.

Outward commentary · Women, children and the danger of attachment

He begins with the foremost of the desires, “women.” This concerns one captivated by them and thereby turned from God’s remembrance, or one who approaches them unlawfully. It is reported from the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him: “I have left after me no temptation more harmful to men than women.” Another report says: “Looking at a woman’s beauties is one of Satan’s arrows.” Thus they are represented in the Qurʾān as the very objects of appetite: “Adorned for humankind is love of desires: women ….”[A019] One of the gnostics said: “Whenever Satan has despaired of a person, he has approached him by way of women.”[A020] ʿAlī—God be pleased with him—is quoted as saying: “People, do not obey women’s commands or let them manage an affair of livelihood. If they are left to do as they wish, they ruin the domain and disobey its master. We have found them without religion in their seclusion and without scruple in their appetites. Pleasure with them is little; perplexity through them is great. Their

righteous ones are sinful, their wicked ones promiscuous"—that is, adulteresses—"and those protected from fault are nonexistent. They complain of injustice while

being unjust; they withhold themselves while desirous; they swear oaths while lying. Seek God's protection from their wicked ones, and be apprehensive of their good ones. Peace." End of quotation.[A021] "And sons": the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: "They are indeed the fruit of hearts and the delight of eyes, yet they are also a cause of cowardice, miserliness and sorrow."[A022] 119

Outward commentary · Horses, livestock and cultivation

"And heaped-up stores"—collected and piled—"of gold and silver; and marked horses": those with distinguishing marks, such as piebald horses, or others. It is reported from the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him: "Good is tied to horses' forelocks until the Day of Resurrection: reward and spoils." Anas said: "Nothing after women was dearer to the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, than horses."[A023] Abū Wahb al-Jushamī reports the Prophet's words: "Keep horses tethered; stroke their forelocks and put neck-bands upon them, but do not neck-band them with bowstrings. Choose a bay with a white forehead and white lower legs, or a chestnut with a white forehead and white lower legs, or a black horse with a white forehead and white lower legs." Khabbāb—God be pleased with him—reports: "Horses are of three kinds: a horse for the All-Merciful, a horse for a human being, and a horse for Satan. The horse for the All-Merciful is kept for God, in God's way, and used to fight God's enemies. The horse for a human being is ridden upon the road"—in going about one's needs. "The horse for Satan is staked in betting and gambling." There is material in al-Bukhārī supporting this.[A024] Also adorned for people is love of "livestock"—camels, cattle, sheep and goats—when it occupies them away from God's remembrance and they withhold God's due from it; and "cultivated land," farming and planting. "That" which has been mentioned "is the en-

119. Cairo editor, C330.1: The attribution of these words to our master ʿAlī, may God honour his face, is doubtful. Anyone who looks into the history of the righteous forebears will find many and numerous examples of righteous women who surpassed many men in righteousness.

joyment of the life of this world," perishing and passing away. "With God is the finest place of return": the abode of permanence, whose bliss does not perish and whose life never ends, for ever and ever. [120]

Spiritual allusion · Even lights and spiritual states can become an appetite

Everything that cuts the heart off from witnessing, or weakens its journey towards the worshipped King, is an appetite (شهوة), whatever it may be: otherness or lights, knowledge or states, or anything else. The women are otherness; the sons, lights; the heaped-up stores of gold, the sciences of the Path; silver, the sciences of the Sacred Law; marked horses, spiritual states; livestock, remembrances; and cultivated land, the exercise of contemplation. Whoever stops with the sweetness of any of these and fails to pass into the repose of witnessing and direct vision has made it an appetite for himself. Having mentioned kinds of desire, the Real, exalted is He, encourages detachment from them: "That is the enjoyment of the life of this world; with God is the finest place of return." Abū Hāshim al-Zāhid—God be pleased with him—said: "God has marked the world with estrangement, so that the disciple's intimacy may be with his Lord rather than with it, and the obedient may advance by turning away from it. Those who know God feel estranged from the world and long for God." End of quotation.

The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, sought refuge from the evil of its trial, both its wealth and its poverty. Most of the Qurʾān contains censure of it and warnings against it. Indeed, every caller to God has warned against it and encouraged desire for the hereafter. This is the principal purpose in explaining the revealed laws. How could it be otherwise? The world is God's enemy, because it cuts off the way of communion with Him; for that reason He has not looked at it since creating it.[A025] It is the enemy of His friends, adorning itself until they have to swallow the bitterness of patience in breaking with it. It is also the enemy of His enemies: it draws them on by its deception and captures them in its net. They trust it, and it abandons them when they most need it. May God suffice us against its evil through His gracious favour and generosity.

The Real, exalted is He, then points to the supremely important aim for anyone of ample intelligence, saying:

120. Cairo editor, C330.2: Kumayt: a horse whose colour is between black and red.

3:15–17 · The higher gifts and those who seek them

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 331–332

قُلْ أَأُنَبِّئُكُمْ بِخَيْرٍ مِنْ ذلِكُمْ لِلَّذِينَ اتَّقَوْا عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ جَنَّاتٌ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ خالِدِينَ فِيها وَأَزْواجٌ مُطَهَّرَةٌ وَرِضْوانٌ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ بَصِيرٌ بِالْعِبادِ (15) الَّذِينَ يَقُولُونَ رَبَّنا إِنَّنا آمَنَّا فَاغْفِرْ لَنا ذُنُوبَنا وَقِنا عَذابَ النَّارِ (16) الصَّابِرِينَ وَالصَّادِقِينَ وَالْقانِتِينَ وَالْمُنْفِقِينَ وَالْمُسْتَغْفِرِينَ بِالْأَسْحارِ (17)

15. Say: “Shall I tell you of something better than that? For those who are mindful of God there are, with their Lord, gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding there, purified spouses, and good pleasure from God.” God sees His servants:
16. those who say, “Our Lord, we believe: forgive us our sins and guard us from the punishment of the Fire”;
17. the steadfast, the truthful, the devoutly obedient, those who spend, and those who seek forgiveness before dawn.

Language · The promise and its recipients

I say: “For those” is the predicate, and “gardens” the subject. This begins a new statement explaining the superiority. Riḍwān (الرضوان) has two pronunciations, with ḍamma or kasra, like ʿudwān and ṭughyān. “Those who say” is an apposition (بدل) to “those who are mindful of God,” a predicate of an understood subject, an accusative of praise (المدح), or an apposition to “the servants.” “The steadfast” and what follows qualify the relative expression.

Outward commentary · From worldly enjoyment to divine good pleasure

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “Say,” Muḥammad, “Shall I tell you of something better” than the perishing desires and passing pleasures I have mentioned? It is what God has prepared for the godfearing when they meet

their Lord: “gardens beneath” whose palaces “rivers flow”—water, milk, honey and wine—“abiding there,” unlike the perishing bliss of this world. They have “spouses” from among the wide-eyed maidens, purified of menstruation, childbirth bleeding and all that is repellent, “and good pleasure from God,” the greatest of blessings. Consider how the Real, glorious is His majesty, mentions the lowest, middle and highest bliss. The lowest is worldly enjoyment, adorned for people; the middle, the bliss of the Gardens; the highest, the good pleasure of the All-Merciful. In the sound report from the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him: “God says to the people of the Garden, ‘People of the Garden!’ They answer, ‘At Your service, our Lord, and gladly; good is in Your hands.’ He says, ‘Are you satisfied?’ They say, ‘How should we not be satisfied, when You have given us what You have given none of the worlds?’ He says, ‘Shall I give you something better than that?’ They say, ‘Our Lord, what could be better than that?’ He says, ‘I shall cause My good pleasure to rest upon you, and shall never be angry with you thereafter.’”[A026]

“God sees His servants”: none of their deeds is hidden from Him, and He rewards the one who does well and punishes the one who does ill; or He sees the conditions of the godfearing, “those who say, ‘Our Lord, we believe: forgive us our sins and guard us from the punishment of the Fire.’” Basing the request upon faith alone indicates that faith suffices to merit forgiveness and to make one ready for it.

Outward commentary · Truthfulness and the hours before dawn

He then describes the godfearing as “the steadfast”: in performing commands, avoiding prohibitions, and bearing deprivation, adversity and the time of battle. “The truthful” in words, deeds and states, whose secret and public life agree. “The devoutly obedient”; “those who spend” their wealth in God’s way; and “those who seek forgiveness before dawn.” Supplication then is nearer to acceptance, because worship at that time is harder, the soul clearer and the spirit more collected, especially for those who keep night vigil. It is said that they used to pray until the time before dawn and then seek forgiveness and supplicate. The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is reported to have said: “God, exalted is He, says, ‘I am about to punish the earth’s people; but when I look upon those who frequent My houses, those who keep night vigil, those who love one another for My sake, and those who seek forgiveness before dawn, I turn punishment away from

them.’”[A027] Sufyān said: “God has a wind called the Cry, which blows before dawn, carrying remembrance and pleas for forgiveness to the Compelling King.” He said: “We have been told that at the beginning of the night a caller cries, ‘Let the devoutly obedient arise!’ They rise and pray until before dawn. Then a caller cries, ‘Where are those who seek forgiveness before dawn?’ Those people seek forgiveness, and others rise and pray, joining them. When dawn breaks a caller cries, ‘Let the heedless arise!’ They rise from their beds like the dead raised from their graves.”[A027]

Spiritual allusion · The Gardens of recognition

For those who guard against witnessing anything other than God there are, with their Lord, gardens of recognition, beneath which flow rivers of knowledge and varieties of wisdom, purified of defects and free from flaws. The breeze of good pleasure blows upon them, bearing repose and fragrance. They abide in the bliss of witnessing and direct vision. God sees His sincere servants, purified of faults and cleansed of the stain of sins: steadfast in continual struggle, truthful in seeking witnessing, obedient to the rulings of servanthood, expending themselves and their lifeblood in seeking to witness the lights of lordship, and asking forgiveness for witnessing otherness —especially when the breeze before dawn blows. For many worshippers and ascetics have been occupied by the sweetness of that breeze away from contemplating the mysteries of the Compeller: the mysteries of unity to which He points by saying:

3:18 · God’s testimony to His oneness

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 332–334

شَهِدَ اللَّهُ أَنَّهُ لاَ إِلهَ إِلاَّ هُوَ وَالْمَلائِكَةُ وَأُولُوا الْعِلْمِ قائِماً بِالْقِسْطِ لاَ إِلهَ إِلاَّ هُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ (18)

18. God bears witness that there is no god but He, as do the angels and those possessed of knowledge, while He upholds justice. There is no god but He, the Mighty, the Wise.

Language · The circumstantial clause and the following affirmation

I say: "Upholding" (قائماً) is a circumstantial qualifier (حال) of "God." Its restriction to one of the coordinated elements is admissible because there is no confusion, as in "We bestowed upon him Isaac, and Jacob as an additional gift" [21:72]. One cannot say "Zayd and ʿAmr came riding," with the singular qualifier, without an indication of which is meant. Alternatively, it qualifies "He" (هو), and the sentence governs it, because it is a confirmatory circumstantial qualifier (حال مؤكدة): He alone is God, upholding justice; or it is established of Him while He upholds justice. Qisṭ (القسط) means justice. "Indeed, the religion …" [3:19] is a new sentence confirming the first: no religion is pleasing to God except acknowledgement of the testimony and entering what Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, brought. In the reading with fatḥa, anna, it is apposition to "that He" (أنه): complete apposition (بدل الكل) if Islam is interpreted as faith, or apposition of inclusion (بدل الاشتمال) if it is interpreted as the Sacred Law.[A028]

[Translator's print-source notes: T19]

Outward commentary · Signs, testimony and the honour of knowledge

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "God bears witness that there is no god but He": He makes His oneness clear by setting up indications of it and sending down verses declaring it, or through His wondrous governance, perfected workmanship and well-ordered affairs. Concerning this the poet says:

> How astonishing that God should be disobeyed,
> or denied by one who denies!
> In every movement and every stillness
> there is always a witness to God.
> In everything He has a sign
> indicating that He is One. 121

One of the Arabs was asked for the proof that the world has a Maker. He replied: "Dung points to a camel and footprints to a traveller. Do not a celestial structure of such subtlety and a lower centre of such density point to

121. Cairo editor, C333.1: The verses are by Abū l-ʿAtāhiya; see his Dīwān, p.122. Al-Aṣbahānī included them in Muḥāḍarāt al-udabāʾ,3:398, attributing them to Labīd.

the All-Aware Maker?"[A029] "The angels" also bear witness, acknowledging and declaring oneness; and "those possessed of knowledge"—the prophets and those who know God—through believing it and adducing proof for it. In its clarification and disclosure, this is likened to a witness's testimony. It indicates the honour and excellence of the people of knowledge, since He joins their testimony to His own. Knowledge is God's exalted attribute and His greatest gift. Scholars are the standards of Islam, the foremost on the way to the Abode of Peace, the lamps of places and the proofs of their times. Jābir reports the Prophet's words: "An hour in which a scholar reclines upon his bed considering his knowledge is better than a worshipper's worship for seventy years." Muʿādh reports: "Learn knowledge: learning it for God is reverent fear; studying it is glorification; investigating it is struggle; teaching it to one who does not know is charity; and recalling it among its people is a means of nearness." At the end of the report he says of the people of knowledge: "The angels desire their friendship, stroke them with their wings and seek forgiveness for them in their prayers. Every moist and dry thing seeks forgiveness for them: the fish and creatures of the sea, the beasts and livestock of the earths, the heaven and its stars. Knowledge is the life of hearts from blindness, the light of sight from darkness, and the strength of bodies from weakness. It brings the servant to the rank of the free and the companionship of kings. Reflection upon it equals fasting, and studying it equals standing in prayer. Through it the lawful and unlawful are known, and kinship ties maintained. Knowledge is the leader; action follows it. The fortunate are inspired with it, and the wretched deprived of it."[A030]

The Real, exalted is He, is "upholding justice": governing His creation with justice in what He decrees and settles. "There is no god but He." He repeats the testimony for emphasis, further consideration of oneness, and affirmation of it after establishing its proof. Jaʿfar al-Ṣādiq says: "The first is description and affirmation of unity; the second is prescription and instruction"—that is, say, "There is no god but He." Alternatively, it is repeated to attach to it "the Mighty, the Wise," making clear that He is described by both. He places "the Mighty" first, so that knowledge of His power precedes knowledge of His wisdom.

3:19 · Submission, division and reverent disagreement

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 334–335

إِنَّ الدِّينَ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ الْإِسْلامُ وَمَا اخْتَلَفَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ إِلاَّ مِنْ بَعْدِ مَا جاءَهُمُ الْعِلْمُ بَغْياً بَيْنَهُمْ وَمَنْ يَكْفُرْ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ سَرِيعُ الْحِسابِ (19)

19. The religion in God's sight is al-islām (submission). Those given the Book differed only after knowledge had come to them, through mutual rivalry. Whoever disbelieves in God's signs—God is swift in reckoning.

Outward commentary · The religion pleasing to God

"The religion with God is Islam": the religion pleasing to Him is submission to the affirmation of unity and yielding to the one who brought it. Anas—God be pleased with him—reports the Prophet's words: "Whoever recites this verse [3:18] when going to sleep, God creates seventy thousand creatures who seek forgiveness for him until the Day of Resurrection." It is the greatest testimony in God's Book. "Whoever recites it as far as 'the Wise,' then says, 'I too bear witness to what God has borne witness to, and I entrust this testimony to God: it is a deposit for me with Him,' the Real, exalted is He, says, 'This servant of Mine has a covenant with Me, and I am most entitled to fulfil a covenant. Admit My servant to the Garden.'"[A031] 122 123

122. Cairo editor, C334.1: Ibn ʿIrāq mentioned it in Tanzīh al-sharīʿa,1:298, and attributed it to Abū Nuʿaym, as a report from Anas. Its chain includes Mujāshiʿ ibn ʿAmr, of whom Ibn Maʿīn said: "One of the liars."

123. Cairo editor, C334.2: Al-Ṭabarānī transmitted it in al-Kabīr, and al-Bayhaqī in al-Shuʿab. Al-ʿIlal al-mutanāhiya,1:110, says: "This report is not sound. ʿUmar ibn al-Mukhtār alone transmitted it, and ʿUmar relates false reports."

Spiritual allusion · Distinction, gathering and obedience

The opening of the verse [3:18] points to distinction (الفرق), and its conclusion to gathering (الجمع), as is His customary manner in His Mighty Book: He sets forth the Sacred Law first and realization second. The Real, glorious is His majesty, affirms the testimony of angels and people of knowledge alongside His testimony, establishing the mystery of the Sacred Law. He then effaces it with "There is no god but He, the Mighty, the Wise," by the ruling of Reality. Affirming created outlines (الرسوم) is Sacred Law; effacing them is Reality.[A032] The unification of those concerned with outlines and forms is an indication from behind the veil. The unification of the people of effacement and disappearance is testimony from within the veil. The former is indication and demonstration; the latter testimony and direct vision. People of evidence and demonstration are ordinary people in relation to those of witnessing and direct vision. Affirmation of outlines is Islam and faith; their effacement is witnessing and spiritual excellence (الإحسان). Every affirmation of unity whose fruit fails to appear in the limbs as yielding and submission to the rulings of servanthood is deficient. For He says, "The religion with God is Islam": outward and inward submission to the rulings of overpowering divine governance and of obligation. Whoever lacks submission lacks complete religion. [124]

He then mentions those for whom abandonment was already decreed despite the radiance of evidence and demonstration, saying:

Qurʾānic continuation · 3:19b

وَمَا اخْتَلَفَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ إِلاَّ مِنْ بَعْدِ مَا جاءَهُمُ الْعِلْمُ بَغْياً بَيْنَهُمْ وَمَنْ يَكْفُرْ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ سَرِيعُ الْحِسابِ

124. Cairo editor, C334.3: Khidāj means deficiency. Its original use is in khadajat al-nāqa: a she-camel gave birth before the proper time, before the days of gestation were complete, even if the young was fully formed; or she expelled it incompletely formed even though its days were complete. She is called mukhdij and the young mukhdaj.

Those given the Book differed only after knowledge had come to them, through mutual rivalry. Whoever disbelieves in God's signs—God is swift in reckoning.

Language · The cause of division

I say: "Through rivalry" (بغياً) is an accusative of purpose or cause (مفعول له), giving the cause of the disagreement.

Outward commentary · Knowledge contradicted by rivalry

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: the Jews and Christians differed concerning the truth of Islam and adherence to it only after knowledge had come to them: after they had the means to know its soundness and that the religion with God is Islam. They denied it unjustly and enviously. Alternatively, the possessors of earlier books differed concerning Islam—some affirming it, others saying it was restricted to the Arabs, and others denying it altogether—only after knowledge of its truth and the universality of its summons had been established for them. Or they differed concerning unity: Christians asserted a trinity and Jews said, "'Uzayr is God's son," changing what they had soundly known of unity.[A033] Al-Rabīʿ said: "When death approached Moses, peace be upon him, he called seventy learned men of his people and entrusted the Torah to them. After the first, second and third generations had passed, division arose among them: these were 'those given the Book,' the descendants of the seventy. They shed blood, and evil and disagreement arose among them." This was after knowledge—the explanation contained in the Torah—had come to them, "through mutual rivalry": seeking dominion and leadership and envying one another. He therefore gave tyrants power over them. "Whoever disbelieves in God's signs," revealed to His Messenger or indicating His oneness, "God is swift in reckoning": one affair does not distract Him from another. This threatens the people of division.

Spiritual allusion · Two motives for criticizing the Sufis

Disagreement with the Sufis and repudiation of them, when arising from rivalry, envy or fear that the critic will lose his leadership, exposes him to God's abhorrence. He has declared war against God, and its evil outcome is an ill ending—God protect us. Concerning this the poet says:

> Their aspirations give judgment according to the moment's ruling;
> their repudiator exposes himself to abhorrence.

But when criticism arises from protective concern for the Sacred Law and blocking the means to wrongdoing (سد الذريعة), its author is excused, or rewarded if his intention is sound. He is included among the weak: "There is no blame upon the weak, the sick, or those who find nothing to spend, provided they are sincere towards God and His Messenger" [9:91]. A spiritual pauper is to be censured only for what is unanimously prohibited and admits no interpretation, such as illicit intercourse with a specified woman, sodomy and the like. The believer seeks excuses; the hypocrite seeks faults. [A034] Success is through God, who guides to the even path.

The Real, exalted is He, then explains the remedy for the critic's harm: turning away from him. He says:

3:20 · The duty to convey and the surrender of the whole person

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 335–336

فَإِنْ حَاجُّوكَ فَقُلْ أَسْلَمْتُ وَجْهِيَ لِلَّهِ وَمَنِ اتَّبَعَنِ وَقُلْ لِلَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ وَالْأُمِّيِّينَ أَأَسْلَمْتُمْ فَإِنْ أَسْلَمُوا فَقَدِ اهْتَدَوْا وَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَإِنَّما عَلَيْكَ الْبَلاغُ وَاللَّهُ بَصِيرٌ بِالْعِبادِ (20)

20. If they dispute with you, say: "I have submitted my face to God, and so have those who follow me." Say to those given the Book and to the unlettered: "Have you submitted?" If they submit, they are guided; if they turn away, your duty is only to convey. God sees His servants.

Language · Those who follow

I say: "Those who follow me" is coordinated with the pronominal subject of "I have submitted." [125]

125. Cairo editor, C335.1: That is, the tāʾ in aslamtu ("I have submitted").

Outward commentary · Submission after the proof has been established

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “If they dispute with you” concerning religion, contesting it after the proofs of its truth have been established, say: as for me, “I have submitted my face to God.” I have yielded my entire being to Him and held fast to His upright religion, whose truth has been demonstrated; and so have the believers who follow me. The face is singled out for submission because it is the noblest limb and the place where beauties appear. When the face submits, the whole submits. “Say to those given the Book,” Jews and Christians, “and to the unlettered,” idolaters without a book: “Have you submitted,” as I have, now that the proof is clear? Or do you remain in unbelief through rivalry and envy? The interrogation has the sense of a command, like “Will you, then, submit?” [compare 11:14]: submit! “If they submit, they are guided” and have saved themselves from destruction. “If they turn away,” rejecting it, “your duty is only to convey.” Their obstinacy does not harm you: you have conveyed what you were commanded. “God sees His servants”: those who submit and those who turn away are not hidden from Him. It is related that the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, recited this verse to them and said to the Jews, “Do you testify that ʿUzayr is God’s servant, His messenger and His word?” They replied, “God forbid!” He said to the Christians, “Do you testify that Jesus is God’s servant and messenger?” They replied, “God forbid that Jesus should be a servant!” Then “If they turn away, your duty is only to convey …” was revealed.[A035]

Spiritual allusion · Do not become occupied with the one who harms you

When repudiation, disputation and attempts to prevail in argument are directed against the spiritual pauper, nothing befits him but silence, acknowledgement and the surrender of his entire being to the rulings of the One, the Subduer. He sees no agent but God and therefore relies upon nothing else. In the *Ḥikam*: “He caused harm to come to you through them only so that you would not rest in them. He wished to disturb you away from everything, so that you would not rest in anything.” One of the gnostics said: “Never occupy yourself with the one who harms you. Occupy yourself with God, and He will repel him from you. Many have erred here: they occupied themselves with their assailant, so their harm continued, together

with sin. Had they returned to their Master, He would have sufficed them in their affair." End of the passage, in sense. This is what the shaykh commands his followers. If they submit to the Real's rulings, they are guided to the path of arrival. If they turn away, your duty is only to convey; guidance is in the hand of the All-Hearing, All-Seeing.

He then reproaches the Jews for the aggression and corruption committed by their predecessors, with which they are content, saying:

3:21–22 · Killing the prophets and those who command justice

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 336–337

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَكْفُرُونَ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ وَيَقْتُلُونَ النَّبِيِّينَ بِغَيْرِ حَقٍّ وَيَقْتُلُونَ الَّذِينَ يَأْمُرُونَ بِالْقِسْطِ مِنَ النَّاسِ فَبَشِّرْهُمْ بِعَذابٍ أَلِيمٍ (21) أُولئِكَ الَّذِينَ حَبِطَتْ أَعْمالُهُمْ فِي الدُّنْيا وَالْآخِرَةِ وَما لَهُمْ مِنْ ناصِرِينَ (22)

21. Those who disbelieve in God's signs, kill the prophets without right, and kill people who command justice—give them tidings of a painful punishment.
22. They are those whose works have come to nothing in this world and the hereafter; they have no helpers.

Language · A predicate carrying conditional force

I say: fāʾ enters the predicate of inna because its subject carries a conditional sense, owing to the generality and indeterminacy of the relative expression. This is peculiar to inna, not layta or laʿalla: inna does not alter the meaning of the initial nominal construction, but confirms it. Alternatively, the predicate is "They are those ...."

Outward commentary · The consequence of violent rejection

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "Those who disbelieve in God's signs"—His proofs of oneness and the truth of His messengers' prophethood, or His speech, namely the Jews—"kill the prophets without right," rather through aggression, "and kill people who command justice," the learned men who enjoin fairness and abandoning oppression: "give them tidings of a painful," agonizing, "punishment." They are those whose works are nullified in this world and the hereafter, benefiting them in neither abode. They have no helpers to protect them from punishment. Abū ʿUbayda ibn al-Jarrāḥ—God be pleased with him—said: "I asked the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, which people will suffer most severely

on the Day of Resurrection. He replied, ‘A man who killed a prophet, or a man who commanded wrong and forbade right.’ He then recited ‘and kill the prophets without right …,’ and said, ‘Abū ʿUbayda, the Children of Israel killed forty-three prophets in a single hour at the beginning of a day. A hundred and twenty of their worshippers then stood up, commanding them to do right and forbidding them to do wrong. They killed them all by the end of that same day. These are those God mentioned in His Book, concerning whom He revealed the verse.’” End of the quotation from al-Thaʿlabī. [Translator’s note: Cairo I:337 reads “commanded wrong and forbade right” and “a hundred and twenty.” The electronic text of al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān III:36–37, shares the first wording but gives one hundred and twelve. Al-Baghawī, Maʿālim al-tanzīl II:21, instead describes a man who killed a prophet or someone who commanded right and forbade wrong, and likewise gives one hundred and twelve. The English retains Cairo. These source differences do not establish Ibn ʿAjība’s original wording or authenticate the report.][A036]

Spiritual allusion · The encouragement of disciples and the warning to persecutors

The preceding verse encouraged disciples and commanded patience and submission before the harm inflicted by others. Here He mentions the evil outcome for those who harm and deny the spiritual election of those brought near. God’s friends and the scholars are the prophets’ heirs. Whoever harms them has a painful punishment: in this world, the distress of veiling and an ill return; in the hereafter, remoteness from the precinct of those brought near and descent to the lowest depth. And God, exalted is He, knows best.

Another of the Jews’ faults is their turning away from truth when it is directed towards them, as the Real, exalted is He, indicates, saying:

3:23–25 · The Book, false reassurance and the coming reckoning

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 337–338

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا نَصِيباً مِنَ الْكِتابِ يُدْعَوْنَ إِلى كِتابِ اللَّهِ لِيَحْكُمَ بَيْنَهُمْ ثُمَّ يَتَوَلَّى فَرِيقٌ مِنْهُمْ وَهُمْ مُعْرِضُونَ (23) ذلِكَ بِأَنَّهُمْ قالُوا لَنْ تَمَسَّنَا النَّارُ إِلاَّ أَيَّاماً مَعْدُوداتٍ وَغَرَّهُمْ فِي دِينِهِمْ ما كانُوا يَفْتَرُونَ (24) فَكَيْفَ إِذا جَمَعْناهُمْ لِيَوْمٍ لا رَيْبَ فِيهِ وَوُفِّيَتْ كُلُّ نَفْسٍ مَّا كَسَبَتْ وَهُمْ لا يُظْلَمُونَ (25)

23. Have you not seen those given a share of the Book, summoned to God's Book so that it may judge between them? Then a group of them turns away in aversion.
24. That is because they say, "The Fire will touch us only for a limited number of days." What they used to fabricate has deceived them in their religion.
25. How will it be when We gather them for a day of which there is no doubt, and every soul is paid in full what it has earned, without being wronged?

Language · The indefinite "share"

I say: the indefinite form of "a share" (نصيب) may diminish or magnify it; the first is nearer. "While they are averse" (وهم معرضون) is a circumstantial clause qualifying "a group," since the latter is specified by its qualification.

Outward commentary · Refusing the judgment one professes to acknowledge

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "Have you not seen," Muḥammad—or anyone capable of seeing—"those given a share of the Book," namely the Jews, who held to something of the Torah without acting upon all of it? See how they are summoned to God's Book, the Qurʾān, to judge between them

concerning their disagreement over unity and the truth of the Prophet's mission, yet they turn away. Alternatively, God's Book here is the Torah. Ibn ʿAbbās—God be pleased with him—said: "The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, entered among a group of Jews and called them to God. Nuʿaym ibn ʿAmr and al-Ḥārith ibn Zayd asked, 'What religion do you follow, Muḥammad?' He answered, 'The way of Abraham.' They said, 'Abraham was

a Jew.' The Prophet said, 'Come, then, to the Torah: let it stand between us and you.' They refused, and the verse was revealed." It is also said that it was revealed concerning stoning, as will be discussed in al-ʿUqūd.[A037] "That" aversion is caused by their self-deception and their making light of punishment: they say, "The Fire will touch us only for a limited number of days," forty days, corresponding to their worship of the calf, after which the Muslims will take their place. "What they used to fabricate has deceived them in their religion," through their false supposition and empty expectation. The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: "How will it be when We gather them for a day of which there is no doubt?" This makes their situation terrifying and magnifies what will encompass them. "Every soul is paid in full what it has earned," good or evil, "without being wronged": nothing of its deeds is withheld, neither good deeds diminished nor evil deeds increased. This indicates that the believer does not remain eternally in the Fire. Ibn ʿAbbās said: "The first banner raised for the people standing that day is the Jews' banner. God exposes them before all witnesses, then orders them into the Fire."[A038]

Spiritual allusion · Claims of election tested by correction

You see many who claim affiliation to learning and religion readily asserting spiritual election and inclusion among those brought near. Yet when summoned to truth, or shown a fault of their own soul, they turn away. Their lower self deceives them and desire overcomes them. They defend themselves by appealing to their learning or religion, or to the righteous people to whom they claim affiliation. What will their condition be when they come before God with a sick heart and see the stations of the people of purity, who met Him with a sound heart? Those people's degrees are raised among those brought near, while they themselves remain among the ordinary people of the right hand. He says: "There will appear to them from God what they had not reckoned upon" [39:47].

The Real, exalted is He, then mentions the removal of the People of the Book's dominion, the stripping away of their might, and its transfer to the Muslims, saying:

3:26–27 · The Master of dominion

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 338–341

قُلِ اللَّهُمَّ مالِكَ الْمُلْكِ تُؤْتِي الْمُلْكَ مَنْ تَشاءُ وَتَنْزِعُ الْمُلْكَ مِمَّنْ تَشاءُ وَتُعِزُّ مَنْ تَشاءُ وَتُذِلُّ مَنْ تَشاءُ بِيَدِكَ الْخَيْرُ إِنَّكَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (26) تُولِجُ اللَّيْلَ فِي النَّهارِ وَتُولِجُ النَّهارَ فِي اللَّيْلِ وَتُخْرِجُ الْحَيَّ مِنَ الْمَيِّتِ وَتُخْرِجُ الْمَيِّتَ مِنَ الْحَيِّ وَتَرْزُقُ مَنْ تَشاءُ بِغَيْرِ حِسابٍ (27)

26. Say: "O God, Master of dominion, You give dominion to whom You will and take dominion from whom You will. You exalt whom You will and abase whom You will. In Your hand is good. You have power over all things. 27. You cause night to enter day and day to enter night. You bring the living from the dead and the dead from the living. You provide for whom You will without reckoning."

Language · The invocation Allāhumma

I say: Allāhumma (اللهم) is a vocative (منادى), indeclinably built upon ḍamma. The vocative yā', which contains a suggestion of separation (الفرق), has been omitted and replaced by mīm, intimating gathering (الجمع), so that no separation remains between caller and Called.[A039] "Master" (مالك) qualifies the syntactic position of the vocative, since the vocative is an object. According to Sībawayh it is a second vocative, because for him the mīm prevents an adjectival qualification. [126]

126. Cairo editor, C338.1: This is an allusive interpretation.

Outward commentary · Dominion, exaltation and abasement

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “Say,” Muḥammad, when seeking help against your enemy: “O God, Master of dominion,” the dominion of this world and the hereafter, “You give dominion,” and victory, “to whom You will, and take dominion from whom You will.” Grant us, then, the dominion of both abodes,

and victory over enemies everywhere. Take dominion from our enemy’s hand and transfer it to us and to those who follow us until the Day of Recompense. Qatāda said: “We have been told that the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, asked his Lord to place the dominion of Persia and Byzantium in his community, and God revealed this verse.” “You exalt whom You will,” through faith and obedience, “and abase whom You will,” through unbelief and disobedience. Or: You exalt whom You will through gnosis and abase whom You will through reflection.[A040] Or: through contentment and scrupulousness, as against avidity and greed; or through divinely granted success and submission, as against laziness and abandonment. “In Your hand is good,” all of it. Give us, then, of Your abundant good, and shelter us from grievous evil, for all affairs are in Your hand.

Theology · Good, evil and the promise at the Trench

Al-Bayḍāwī says: “He mentions good alone because it is decreed in itself (بالذات), whereas evil is decreed incidentally (بالعرض): no particular evil exists without encompassing a universal good. Or it is out of reverent propriety in address, or because the discourse concerns good.”[A041] For it is related that when the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, marked out the Trench, allotting forty cubits to every ten men, they began digging and encountered a great rock upon which the picks made no impression. They sent Salmān to inform the Messenger. He came, took the pick from him and struck a blow that split it. A flash shone from it, lighting the space between the town’s two lava tracts like a lamp in a dark house. He proclaimed God’s greatness and the Muslims did likewise. He said, “The palaces of al-Ḥīra have been illuminated for me through it, like dogs’ fangs.” He struck again and said, “The red palaces in the land of Byzantium have been illuminated for me.” At the third blow he said, “The palaces of Ṣanʿāʾ have been illuminated for me, and Gabriel has told me that my community will prevail over them all. Receive the good tidings!” The hypocrites said: “Are you not astonished? He fills you with hopes and false promises, telling you that from

Yathrib he sees al-Ḥīra's palaces and that they will be conquered for you, while you are only digging the Trench out of fear!" The verse was then revealed. By "You have power over all things," He draws attention to the fact that evil too is in His hand. End of al-Bayḍāwī's passage.[A042] 127 128

Outward commentary · The alternation of life and its conditions

He then adduces evidence for His effectual power: "You cause night to enter day," one entering the other through succession, or increase and decrease. Night enters day when day lengthens to fifteen hours and night has nine; day enters night when night lengthens correspondingly. This indicates that One able to do this is able to replace might with abasement, and dominion with its removal.[A043] "You bring the living from the dead and the dead from the living": animals from seminal drops and vice versa, plants from seeds and vice versa; or the believer from the unbeliever and the learned from the ignorant, and conversely. "You provide for whom You will," with nourishment, knowledge and mysteries, "without reckoning," measure or limit. O God, give us the fullest share of this: You have power over all things.

Outward commentary · Invocation, debt and the verses after prayer

Muʿādh—God be pleased with him—reports that the Prophet said to him: "Muʿādh, would you like God to discharge your debt?" He answered, "Yes, Messenger of God." He said: "Recite 'O God, Master of dominion …' as far as 'without reckoning,' then say, 'All-Merciful and Ever-Merciful of this world and the hereafter, You give from them what You will and withhold from them what You will: discharge my debt.' Even if you owed the earth's fill of gold and silver, God would discharge it for you."[A044] It is related from ʿAlī —God be pleased with him—that when God wished to send down al-Fātiḥa, the Throne Verse, "God bears witness …," and "O God, Master of dominion …" as far as "without reckoning," they clung to the Throne and said, "Will You send us down to the abode of sins?" God, mighty and majestic, replied: "By My might and majesty, no servant recites you after every prescribed prayer without My settling him in the holy precinct, whatever his condition; without My looking upon him with My hidden eye seventy times each

127. Cairo editor, C339.1: Lāba means ḥarra: the black stones [of a lava tract]. "Its two lābas" are the two lava tracts that flank Medina.
128. Cairo editor, C339.2: Faraq—with fatḥa on both consonants—means fear.

day, fulfilling seventy needs for him each day, and strengthening him against every enemy and granting him victory over him ….” Consult al-Thaʿlabī for the report.[A045] 129

Spiritual allusion · Self-mastery, contentment and true sovereignty

Whoever masters his lower self and desire has been given by God dominion over both abodes. Whoever is mastered by his lower self and desire has been abased by God in both abodes. Whoever masters himself for God is enabled by God to exercise disposal throughout the cosmos, and is truly free. Concerning this the poet says:

> They called me to their dominion; when I answered,
> they said, “We called you to sovereignty, not to possession.”[A046]

Whoever abases himself before God is exalted by God. The poet says:

> Be humble before the one you love, to gain might:
> how much might a person has gained through humility!
> If the one you love is mighty and you will not
> be humble before him, bid farewell to communion.

Ibn al-Mubārak said: “I asked Sufyān al-Thawrī, ‘Who are the people?’ He answered, ‘The jurists.’ ‘Who are the kings?’ ‘The ascetics.’ ‘Who are the noble?’ ‘The godfearing.’ ‘Who are the rabble?’ ‘Those who write down hadith in order to consume people’s wealth through it.’ ‘Tell me, who are the base?’ ‘The oppressors.’” Al-Shiblī said: “Sovereignty is being independent of both worlds through their Maker.” Al-Warrāq said: “You exalt whom You will by subduing the lower self and opposing desire, and abase whom You will by following desire.” I say: al-Buraʿī—God be pleased with him—says of this:

> Do not follow the soul in its desire:
> following desire is abasement.

129. Cairo editor, C340.1: The report was transmitted by Ibn al-Sunnī in ʿAmal al-yawm wa-l-layla, from our master ʿAlī, ascribed to the Prophet. Its chain includes al-Ḥārith ibn ʿUmayr al-Baṣrī. Ibn Ḥibbān said: “He relates fabricated reports from reliable transmitters.” Al-Dhahabī cited this report among his transmissions by way of criticism.

Wahb said: “Wealth and might went wandering, met contentment, and settled there.” Jesus, peace be upon him, told his disciples: “You are richer than kings.” They asked, “Spirit of God, how, when we possess nothing?” He answered: “You have nothing and desire nothing; they have things, and those things do not suffice them.” End of quotation.

Al-Shāfiʿī—God be pleased with him—said:

> My soul, if you are content with sustenance,
> you are forever mighty and rich.
> Leave greed and wishful hopes aside:
> how many a hope has brought death!

Another says:

> Contentment has given me every kind of might:
> what might is mightier than contentment?
> Make it your capital,
> then make godfearingness your merchandise.
> You will gain might, need no base person,
> and journey to the Gardens through an hour’s patience. [130]

The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: “Whoever awakens secure in his dwelling, sound in body, possessing that day’s sustenance, has, as it were, the whole world gathered for him.”[A047]

Spiritual allusion · Contraction, expansion, servanthood and freedom

You cause the night of contraction (القبض) to enter the day of expansion (البسط), and the day of expansion to enter the night of contraction. In both You provide knowledge and mysteries to whom You will without reckoning or measure. Or You cause the night of servanthood to enter the day of freedom, and the day of freedom to enter the night of servanthood. Whoever is in freedom’s day exults above existence; whoever is in servanthood’s night is so humbled that his abasement eclipses that of the Jews.[A048] The servant is never without these two states: they alternate over him as night and day alternate. And God, exalted is He, knows best.

130. Cairo editor, C341.1: He is Bishr ibn al-Ḥārith, known as al-Ḥāfī. The verses occur in Tārīkh Baghdād,7:76, and Tahdhīb Tārīkh Dimashq,3:243.

Since might is acquired through the companionship of the mighty, and abasement likewise, the Real, exalted is He, warns against keeping company with the abased, saying:

3:28–30 · Allegiance, watchfulness and the day of disclosure

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 341–343

لا يَتَّخِذِ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ الْكافِرِينَ أَوْلِياءَ مِنْ دُونِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَمَنْ يَفْعَلْ ذلِكَ فَلَيْسَ مِنَ اللَّهِ فِي شَيْءٍ إِلاَّ أَنْ تَتَّقُوا مِنْهُمْ تُقاةً وَيُحَذِّرُكُمُ اللَّهُ نَفْسَهُ وَإِلَى اللَّهِ الْمَصِيرُ (28) قُلْ إِنْ تُخْفُوا ما فِي صُدُورِكُمْ أَوْ تُبْدُوهُ يَعْلَمْهُ اللَّهُ وَيَعْلَمُ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ وَاللَّهُ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (29) يَوْمَ تَجِدُ كُلُّ نَفْسٍ مَّا عَمِلَتْ مِنْ خَيْرٍ مُحْضَراً وَما عَمِلَتْ مِنْ سُوءٍ تَوَدُّ لَوْ أَنَّ بَيْنَها وَبَيْنَهُ أَمَداً بَعِيداً وَيُحَذِّرُكُمُ اللَّهُ نَفْسَهُ وَاللَّهُ رَؤُفٌ بِالْعِبادِ (30)

28. Let not believers take unbelievers as allies instead of believers. Whoever does that has no share with God—unless you guard yourselves against them as a precaution. God warns you of Himself; to God is the return.
29. Say: “Whether you conceal what is in your breasts or disclose it, God knows it. He knows what is in the heavens and what is in the earth. God has power over all things.”
30. On the day when every soul finds present whatever good it has done, and whatever evil it has done, it will wish there were a far distance between itself and it. God warns you of Himself; God is tender towards His servants.

Language · Precaution and the day of disclosure

I say: tuqāt (تقاة) is a verbal noun of taqā, on the pattern faʿal. It has two other verbal nouns, tuqā and taqiyya (تقيّة), with doubled yāʾ; Yaʿqūb recites the latter. The original of tuqāt is tuqaya: yāʾ changes to alif because it is vocalized and preceded by fatḥa. "The day" is an adverbial expression governed by an understood "remember" or "beware," or by "the return" or "will wish." "Whatever it has done" is a subject, with "will wish" its predicate; alternatively, it is coordinated with the first "whatever it has done," and "will wish" is a circumstantial clause.[A049]

Outward commentary · Loyalty and outward accommodation under fear

The Real, glorious is His majesty, addresses a group of the Anṣār who maintained bonds with Jews because of kinship or friendship dating from the pre-Islamic period: "Let not believers take unbelievers as awliyāʾ," friends. Love should be for God and hatred for God. Or: do not seek their assistance in warfare or otherwise. Do not therefore love them "instead of believers," who are more entitled to affection and provide an alternative to allegiance with unbelievers. Whoever does this has no share in God's friendship, since friendship with God and friendship with His enemy cannot be combined.[A050] The poet says:

> You love my enemy, yet claim that I
> am your friend: foolishness has not departed from you.

Nūk (النُّوك), with ḍamma, means foolishness. Do not ally yourselves with unbelievers "unless you guard yourselves against them as a precaution": unless you fear something from their side that must be guarded against. Then there is no harm in outward accommodation while remaining inwardly distant. As Jesus, peace be upon him, said, "Be in the midst, but walk to the side." Ibn Masʿūd—God be pleased with him—said: "Mix with people and remain distinct from them; meet them with what pleases them, but do not impair your religion." Jaʿfar al-Ṣādiq said: "I may hear a man insulting me in the mosque and conceal myself behind a pillar so that he does not see me." End of quotation. "God warns you of Himself": He makes you fear His punishment for taking unbelievers as allies, opposing His command and committing what He forbids. Arabs say, "Beware of so-and-so," meaning his

harm, not his person. Mentioning “Himself” intensifies the threat, indicating punishment proceeding from Him without intermediary. “To God is the return”: each people will be gathered with those it loved.

Outward commentary · The order of concealment and disclosure

“Say: Whether you conceal what is in your breasts,” of allegiance to His enemies, “or disclose it, God knows it.” No good or evil concealed in breasts is hidden from Him. In al-Baqara [2:284] He puts disclosure first, whereas here He puts it last. Reckoning has no such order, unlike knowledge: what a person brings forth is first inwardly conceived in his heart, then appears. God’s knowledge is related to it before it appears. Thus concealment comes first here because it exists in the breast beforehand; it comes last in al-Baqara because reckoning has no such order.[A051] “He knows what is in the heavens and what is in the earth”: nothing escapes Him. “God has power over all things,” and can therefore punish you if you do not desist. This verse explains “God warns you of Himself”: the Exalted Essence is characterized by knowledge encompassing everything knowable and power encompassing everything possible. Do not venture to disobey Him: there is no act of disobedience of which He is unaware, or which He is unable to punish on the Day of Resurrection. “On the day when every soul finds present whatever good it has done,” before it for its benefit, and whatever evil it has done, “it will wish there were a far distance between itself and it,” as between east and west. Regret does not avail after the foot has slipped. “God warns you of Himself”: repeated for emphasis and further warning; the wisdom of its repetition will be given in the allusion. “God is tender towards His servants,” warning them against what harms them and commanding what brings them near. Everything proceeding from Him, glory to Him, is of utmost perfection.

Spiritual allusion · Companionship and the two warnings

The sincere disciple should not mix with the heedless or cultivate their affection, for this cuts him off from his Lord and diverts him from his heart’s remedy. The author of the *ʿAyniyya* says:

Break with those you kept company with in heedlessness:
only one who severs communion keeps company with reproachers.
Avoid the outsider's side, even if through close kinship
he shares your sleeping-place.
The soul receives every affinity from its companions,
and from friendship the heart receives those dispositions.

The exception is necessary precaution, when need compels such association. He then mixes with them bodily and parts from them in his heart. The Sufis have warned against accompanying four groups: arrogant tyrants, compromising reciters, ignorant pretenders to spiritual poverty, and rigid scholars. These are addicted to attacking God's friends, regarding it as a deed that brings them near to God.[A052] He then says, "God warns you of Himself": against seeking another together with Him. This addresses the wayfarers, as is shown by the following words, "To God is the return": in Him the journey ends, and to Him is arrival. He then intensifies the demand for watchfulness (المراقبة): "Whether you conceal what is in your breasts," of inclination towards another, reliance upon another or halting on the journey, "or disclose it, God knows it." Reinforcement is diminished in proportion to that inclination. This becomes manifest on the day of entering the lands of witnessing, "the day when every soul finds" what it has put forward of struggle: according to the struggle is the witnessing. He then addresses those who have arrived: "God warns you of Himself," against witnessing another together with Him. Were the arrived one charged with witnessing another, he could not: there is no other with Him to witness. That this addresses those who have arrived is indicated by its being followed by affection and tenderness, appropriate to the beloved who have arrived, the perfected gnostics. May God include us in their company through His gracious favour and generosity.

There is no path to attaining all this except following the greatest Messenger, as He indicates in His words:

3:31–32 · Love proved by following the Messenger

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 343–345

قُلْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ تُحِبُّونَ اللَّهَ فَاتَّبِعُونِي يُحْبِبْكُمُ اللَّهُ وَيَغْفِرْ لَكُمْ ذُنُوبَكُمْ وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (31) قُلْ أَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ لا يُحِبُّ الْكافِرِينَ (32)

31. Say: “If you love God, follow me: God will love you and forgive you your sins. God is Forgiving, Merciful.”
32. Say: “Obey God and the Messenger.” If they turn away, God does not love the unbelievers.

Theology · Love, perfection and obedience

I say: the reality of love has already been discussed at “they love them as God is loved” [2:165]. Al-Bayḍāwī says here: “Love is the soul’s inclination towards something because it perceives perfection in it, so that this inclination carries it towards what brings it near. When the servant knows that true perfection belongs only to God, and that whatever perfection he sees in himself or another is from God, through God and to God, his love can only be for God and in God. This entails the will to obey Him. Love is therefore interpreted as the will to obey, and is made to require following the Messenger in his worship and eagerly complying with him.” End of quotation.

Language · “If they turn away”

“If they turn away” (فإن تولوا) is a past verb occupying a jussive syntactic position. Al-Bazzī does not assimilate it here, in keeping with his treatment of the past tense, because the condition requiring assimilation is absent.[A053]

Outward commentary · The claim of love and the lifting of the veil

The Real, glorious is His majesty, says: “Say,” Muḥammad, to those who claim to love God without following His Messenger: “If you love God,” as you assert, “follow me” in my words, deeds and states. “God will love you”:

He will be pleased with you and bring you near. “He will forgive you your sins”: through forgiving sins and effacing faults, He will lift the veil from your hearts, bring you near the precinct of His might and settle you in His holy neighbourhood. “God is Forgiving, Merciful” to those who seek His love through obeying Him and following His Messenger. “Say: Obey God,” in what He commands and forbids, “and the Messenger,” in what he establishes for you and encourages you to do. “If they turn away,” rejecting him, they expose themselves to God’s abhorrence and anger through their unbelief in him. “God does not love the unbelievers”: He is neither pleased with them nor turns favourably towards them. He does not merely say, “He does not love them,” in order to generalize, show that turning away from the Messenger is unbelief and devoid of love for God, and indicate that His love belongs specifically to believers. It is related that the Christians of Najrān said: “We magnify and worship the Messiah only out of love and reverence for God.” He therefore said, “Say: If you love God, follow me ….” When the verse was revealed, ʿAbd Allāh ibn Ubayy told his companions: “Muḥammad makes obedience to himself like obedience to God and commands us to love him as the Christians loved Jesus.” Then “Say: Obey God and the Messenger …” was revealed.[A054] The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: “Whoever obeys me obeys God; whoever obeys the imam obeys me. Whoever disobeys me disobeys God; whoever disobeys the imam disobeys me.”[A055]

Spiritual allusion · Following the Prophet as a foundation of the Path

Following the Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him, is a pillar of the Path and a condition for the dawning of the lights of Reality. Whoever does not follow has no path; whoever has no path has no arrival. Shaykh Zarrūq —God be pleased with him—said: “The foundations of the Path are five: fear of God in private and public; following the Prophet in words and deeds; turning from creatures whether they approach or withdraw; returning to God in ease and hardship; and being content with God in little and much.”[A056] The Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him, is the veil and doorkeeper of the Presence. Whoever comes through his door, loving and following him, enters the Presence and dwells there. Whoever turns aside from it is expelled and distanced. As the poet says:

> You are God’s door: whoever
> approaches Him other than through you does not enter.

In the *Mabāḥith*:

> The scholar follows him in words,
> the worshipping ascetic in deeds.
> The Sufi races ahead in both,
> but adds the qualities of character.[A057]

Whoever claims love for God or His Messenger, but does not obey them or take on their qualities of character, makes a false claim. Ibn al-Mubārak says of this:

> You disobey God while displaying love for Him:
> this is an impossibility, astonishing by every measure.
> Were your love truthful, you would obey Him:
> the lover obeys the one he loves. [131]

The Real, exalted is He, then explains Jesus' formation, his origin and his mother's upbringing, preparing to address the Christians and refute their belief about him. Al-Bayḍāwī says: having made obedience to the messengers obligatory and shown that it brings God's love, He follows it with an account of their excellences to encourage that obedience, saying:

3:33–37 · The chosen households and Mary's consecration

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 345–349

إِنَّ اللَّهَ اصْطَفى آدَمَ وَنُوحاً وَآلَ إِبْراهِيمَ وَآلَ عِمْرانَ عَلَى الْعالَمِينَ (33) ذُرِّيَّةً بَعْضُها مِنْ بَعْضٍ وَاللَّهُ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ (34) إِذْ قالَتِ امْرَأَتُ عِمْرانَ رَبِّ إِنِّي نَذَرْتُ لَكَ ما فِي بَطْنِي مُحَرَّراً فَتَقَبَّلْ مِنِّي إِنَّكَ أَنْتَ السَّمِيعُ الْعَلِيمُ (35) فَلَمَّا وَضَعَتْها قالَتْ رَبِّ إِنِّي وَضَعْتُها أُنْثى وَاللَّهُ أَعْلَمُ بِما وَضَعَتْ وَلَيْسَ الذَّكَرُ كَالْأُنْثى وَإِنِّي سَمَّيْتُها مَرْيَمَ وَإِنِّي

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131. Cairo editor, C345.1: These verses are attributed to more than one person.

أُعِيذُها بِكَ وَذُرِّيَّتَها مِنَ الشَّيْطانِ الرَّجِيمِ (36) فَتَقَبَّلَها رَبُّها بِقَبُولٍ حَسَنٍ وَأَنْبَتَها نَباتاً حَسَناً وَكَفَلَها زَكَرِيَّاءُ كُلَّما دَخَلَ عَلَيْها زَكَرِيَّا الْمِحْرابَ وَجَدَ عِنْدَها رِزْقاً قالَ يا مَرْيَمُ أَنَّى لَكِ هذا قالَتْ هُوَ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَرْزُقُ مَنْ يَشاءُ بِغَيْرِ حِسابٍ (37)

33. God chose Adam and Noah, the family of Abraham and the family of ʿImrān above the worlds—34. offspring, some descended from others. God is All-Hearing, All-Knowing. 35. When the wife of ʿImrān said, "My Lord, I vow to You what is in my womb, set free [for Your service]. Accept it from me: You are the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing." 36. When she gave birth to her, she said, "My Lord, I have given birth to a girl"—God knew best what she had borne—"and the male is not like the female. I have named her Mary, and I seek Your protection for her and her offspring against Satan, the accursed." 37. Her Lord accepted her graciously, caused her to grow in a beautiful manner, and Zachariah took charge of her. Whenever Zachariah entered the sanctuary to see her, he found provision with her. He said, "Mary, whence has this come to you?" She said, "It is from God. God provides for whomsoever He wills without reckoning."

Language · "Offspring" and the meaning of dedication

I say: "Offspring" (ذُرِّيَّةً) is an accusative of state (حال), or a substitute (بدل) for the two families, or for Noah: that is, they are one offspring, branching forth, some from others. "When the wife [of ʿImrān] said" (إذ قالت) is an adverbial expression (ظرف) governed by "Knowing" (عليم), or by an understood "remember" (اذكر). "Consecrated" (محرَّرًا) is an accusative of state (حال). *Taḥrīr* (التحرير) means setting free or purifying. One says "I freed the slave" when I released him from bondage; and "I revised [or purified] the writing" when I corrected it and made it sound, leaving nothing that still required amendment. A free man (حُرّ) is one unencumbered by another's claim; pure clay is clay free of black mud. Her saying "I have named her Mary" (وإني سميتها مريم) is coordinated (عطف) with "I have given birth to her" (إني وضعتها);

what intervenes is a parenthesis (اعتراض). On the reading in the first person, this is part of her speech; on the reading in the third-person feminine, it is speech from God. [T20]

Outward commentary · The families singled out for divine election

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "God chose Adam"—through the vicegerency (الخلافة) and messengership (الرسالة); "and Noah"—through messengership and warning (النذارة); "and the family of Abraham"—through prophecy and messengership, including Isaac, Jacob, the tribes, Ishmael, and his descendant, our Prophet Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, the master of Adam's offspring, distinguished by prophecy, messengership and love that gathers all [excellences].

"And the family of ʿImrān": either Moses and Aaron—peace be upon them—their father being ʿImrān son of Yiṣhar son of Qāhith son of Levi son of Jacob; or ʿImrān son of Ashham son of Umawī, a descendant of Solomon, who was the father of Mary the mother of Jesus. It is also said that the reference is to ʿImrān son of Māthān, an ancestor of Mary's father ʿImrān. These are singled out because the prophets descend from them. Some hold that Abraham and ʿImrān themselves are intended and the word *āl* ("family") is inserted, as in "the relics left by the family of Moses and the family of Aaron" [2:248], meaning Moses and Aaron themselves. The Real, exalted is His majesty, favoured those prophets in bodily and spiritual characteristics "above the worlds"—each over the people of his own age. This has also been used as an argument for their superiority over angels.

They are "offspring, some from others," their lineages and their religion connected. "And God is All-Hearing" of the servants' words and acts, "All-Knowing" of their outward and inward conditions; He therefore selects for prophecy and messengership those whose speech and works are pure and whose innermost secret is sincere.

Outward commentary · Ḥanna's vow and Mary's birth

He then turns to Mary's upbringing as a preliminary to speaking of her son: "Remember when the wife of ʿImrān"—Ḥanna daughter of Fāqūdhā, Jesus' grandmother—said, "My Lord, I have vowed to You what is in my womb, consecrated" (محرَّرًا) for the service of the Sacred House (بيت المقدس): I shall occupy this child with nothing else; or, wholly devoted to worship. "So ac-

cept it from me, for You are the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing." Among them, a child dedicated in this way was assigned to care for and sweep the place of worship; he did not leave it until puberty, when he could choose to remain or depart. Only boys were customarily dedicated, since girls were considered unsuitable for this service on account of menstruation. Mary's mother made her vow without knowing what she carried.

The account is that Zachariah and ʿImrān married two sisters: Zachariah married Ashyāʿ daughter of Fāqūdhā; ʿImrān married Ḥanna daughter of Fāqūdhā. Jesus and John were accordingly sons of maternal aunts. Ḥanna had been barren. One day in the shade of a tree she saw a bird feeding its young, and the sight stirred in her a longing for a child. She invoked God: "O God, should You grant me a child, I pledge to dedicate the child to the Sacred House as one of its custodians and servants." She conceived Mary; ʿImrān died while Ḥanna was pregnant. [132]

"When she gave birth to her"—to the one she had vowed, or to what had been in her womb—she said, "My Lord, I have given birth to a female." She spoke out of sorrow and disappointment before her Lord, for she had hoped for a boy suitable for service, which was why she had made the vow. "And God knew best what she had borne": this magnifies the one born and draws attention to her rank. Alternatively, on the reading "and God knows best what I have borne" (with "I have borne" in the first person), it belongs to the mother's words as consolation: perhaps God has placed a hidden purpose in this.

"And the male is not like the female": the boy she sought is not like the girl she was given. Alternatively, these are the mother's words: a boy and a girl are not alike in the service she had vowed. She then said, "I have named her Mary," hoping her conduct would accord with her name, which in their description signified one who worships and serves. Mary was the fairest and most excellent woman of her age. The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is reported to have said: "Sufficient for you, among the women of all the worlds, are four: Mary daughter of ʿImrān, Āsiya the wife of Pharaoh, Khadīja daughter of Khuwaylid, and Fāṭima daughter of Muḥammad."

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132. Cairo editor, C346.1: That is, this is the side on which they are related: the maternal side.

Ḥanna, Mary's mother, continued: "I seek Your protection for her"—that is, I shelter her with You—"and her offspring from Satan the accursed," either stoned with shooting stars or driven away. The Prophet is reported to have said: "No child is born without Satan touching him at birth, causing him to cry out by his touch, except Mary and her son." Its meaning is that Satan seeks to mislead every newborn, so that the child is affected by him; Mary and her son are excepted by virtue of this invocation for protection. I say: likewise with all the prophets: he does not touch them on account of their protection from sin (العصمة). And God knows best. T21

Translator's note: Cairo I:346 prints وينكسها. The rendering "sweep" follows ويكنسها in al-Baghawī's closely parallel account at3:35. The Cairo form appears to transpose two consonants; it is preserved in the Arabic transcription, and the reconstruction is disclosed here without claiming manuscript confirmation.

Outward commentary · Acceptance, growth and Zachariah's guardianship

"Her Lord accepted her with a gracious acceptance": He was satisfied to receive her in the fulfilment of the vow in place of a boy. The manner of this acceptance was beautiful: He put her in the boy's position and received her into service immediately after her birth, before she had grown fit for custodianship (السدانة). It is related that Ḥanna wrapped the child in a cloth, carried her to the sanctuary, placed her before the learned custodians, and said: "Here is the child I have dedicated." They vied to take charge of her, for she was the daughter of their leader and the man who presided over their offerings. The family of Māthān were leaders and kings among the Children of Israel. Zachariah said, "I have the strongest claim to her, for her maternal aunt is in my house." They refused except by lot. All twenty-seven of them went to a river and cast their pens into it; Zachariah's pen remained afloat on the water, while the others sank. So he took charge of her. T22 133

"And caused her to grow with a beautiful growth": God gave her a fine upbringing (تربية حسنة). She is said to have grown in a day as an ordinary infant grows in a year. "And Zachariah took her into his care" (وَكَفَّلَهَا زَكَرِيَّا): he

133. Cairo editor, C347.1: Sidāna is a verbal noun meaning service; a sādin is a servant or custodian.

took her into his care and attended to her. In the reading transmitted from ʿĀṣim through Ibn ʿAyyāsh, the fāʾ is doubled (كَفَّلَهَا): God made Zachariah her guardian and fosterer. It is related that when he took her into his care, he built her a home and arranged for her to be nursed. When she came of age, he built her a sanctuary within the place of worship, its doorway partway up so that it could be reached only by a ladder. He alone could ascend to her. He brought her food and drink each day, locking seven doors when he left.

"Whenever Zachariah entered the sanctuary to see her" and bring food, "he found provision with her"—fruit out of season: winter fruit in summer, and summer fruit in winter. "He said, Mary, whence is this for you?" How did such provision reach you out of season, with the doors locked? "She said, It is from God"; there is nothing unlikely in that. Some say she spoke while still a child; others that she was never suckled, contrary to the earlier account. Her provision, they say, descended from the Garden.

"God provides for whomsoever He wills without reckoning" (بغير حساب): without measure or without anything being owed, solely through His grace. The expression "whenever" (كلما) implies repetition. It also indicates that Zachariah never abandoned his care of her or relied upon what he found: he continually inspected her circumstances. Extraordinary graces granted to God's friends (كرامات الأولياء) are not bound to continue; they may be manifested constantly or may cease. Zachariah therefore did not cease looking after her. He kept asking "Mary, whence is this for you?" because what arrived today might have come in a different fashion from yesterday. Nothing is incumbent upon God—exalted is He. Thus al-Qushayrī. [T23]

Outward commentary · Fāṭima's provision

Jābir son of ʿAbd Allāh relates that the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, went without food for several days. He visited the homes of his wives and found nothing, then went to Fāṭima and asked, "My daughter, do you have anything?" She replied, "No, by God—may my father and mother be your ransom." After he left, a neighbour sent her two loaves and a piece of meat. She sent Ḥasan and Ḥusayn to fetch the Prophet. He arrived, and she uncovered the dish: it was full of bread and meat. She was astonished and knew it to be a blessing from God. He asked, "Whence is this for you, my daughter?" She answered, "It is from God. God provides for whomso-

ever He wills without reckoning." He praised God and said, "Praise belongs to God who has made you like the foremost lady of the Children of Israel. Whenever God provided her with something, she said, 'It is from God. God provides for whomsoever He wills without reckoning.'" The Prophet then sent for ʿAlī. The whole household and all the Prophet's wives ate, yet the dish remained as before; she shared with the neighbours, and God bestowed abundant goodness and blessing in it. End of report. [T24] [134]

Spiritual allusion · The chosen renewers and consecration of the self

"God chose Adam and Noah and the family of Abraham and the family of ʿImrān above the worlds." The Real, exalted is He, chose these messengers because they made the religion visible again after its lights had become effaced, and renewed it after its mysteries had lain dormant. They are guides of right guidance and lamps from which the light of emulation is kindled. Whoever in this Muḥammadan community follows in their footsteps, renewing the religion for people, explaining the landmarks of the way and the path of spiritual travelling (السلوك) towards the very reality of realization (عين التحقيق), is among those whom God has chosen above the people of his own age.

The hadith states: "At the head of every hundred years God sends one who renews this community's religion." Al-Ḥarīrī relates: "Al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī died on a Friday afternoon—that is, after the sun had passed its zenith. After the Friday prayer people carried him [to burial], and for the first time since Islam came to Basra, the congregational ʿaṣr prayer was not held in its mosque: all had followed his funeral procession. I heard a caller proclaiming, 'God chose Adam and Noah and the family of Abraham and the family of ʿImrān above the worlds, and chose al-Ḥasan above the people of his age.'" I say: al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī was the one who made the science of Sufism (علم التصوف) manifest, spoke of it, and refined it. The *Qūt* says of him: "He is our imam in this science," meaning Sufism. [T25]

As for the verse "When the wife of ʿImrān said ...": everyone who vows his self to God and sets it free (حرّرها) for the service of his Master is accepted graciously. God causes gnosis (المعرفة) to grow beautifully within him, assumes his protection and care, draws him near through preceding

134. Cairo editor, C348.1: Here ends the omission previously indicated in the Taymūriyya manuscript.

solicitude (سابق العناية), and provides him with rare insights of wisdom and fruits of knowledge beyond the scope of intellects and the utmost of understanding. When he asks himself, “Whence has this come to you?” his soul replies, “It is from God. God provides for whomsoever He wills without reckoning.”

They recited:

> No work of mine earned it from Him;
> it came as sheer grace, whose gift no cause can explain.

Al-Qushayrī says concerning “Her Lord accepted her graciously”: “Part of His gracious acceptance was that He did not place her entire burden and care upon Zachariah. Whenever Zachariah went to bring food, he found provision already there; thus those with knowledge might learn that God does not cast the burden of His friends upon others. Whoever serves one of His friends is himself under the friend’s kindly care: the friend is not under his.” This is an allusion for those who serve the poor [in the spiritual sense, الفقراء], teaching them that they are within those servants’ care, not that the servants depend upon theirs. End of quotation.

The commentators say: When Zachariah saw how fruits out of season came to Mary, he said to himself: The One who can bring fruit to Mary outside its season can restore my wife’s fertility and grant me a child in old age. So he sought a child, as the Real, exalted is He, indicates in what follows:

3:38–41 · Zachariah’s prayer and the promise of John

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 349–351

هُنالِكَ دَعا زَكَرِيَّا رَبَّهُ قالَ رَبِّ هَبْ لِي مِنْ لَدُنْكَ ذُرِّيَّةً طَيِّبَةً إِنَّكَ سَمِيعُ الدُّعاءِ (38) فَنادَتْهُ الْمَلائِكَةُ وَهُوَ قائِمٌ يُصَلِّي فِي الْمِحْرابِ أَنَّ اللَّهَ يُبَشِّرُكَ بِيَحْيى مُصَدِّقاً بِكَلِمَةٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَسَيِّداً وَحَصُوراً وَنَبِيًّا مِنَ الصَّالِحِينَ (39) قالَ رَبِّ أَنَّى يَكُونُ لِي غُلامٌ وَقَدْ بَلَغَنِيَ الْكِبَرُ

وَامْرَأَتِي عاقِرٌ قالَ كَذلِكَ اللَّهُ يَفْعَلُ ما يَشاءُ (40) قالَ رَبِّ اجْعَلْ لِي آيَةً قالَ آيَتُكَ أَلاَّ تُكَلِّمَ النَّاسَ ثَلاثَةَ أَيَّامٍ إِلاَّ رَمْزاً وَاذْكُرْ رَبَّكَ كَثِيراً وَسَبِّحْ بِالْعَشِيِّ وَالْإِبْكارِ (41)

38. There Zachariah called upon his Lord: “My Lord, grant me, from Yourself, good offspring. You are indeed the Hearer of prayer.” 39. The angels called to him while he stood praying in the sanctuary: “God gives you glad tidings of John, who will confirm a Word from God, and will be a noble leader, restrained, and a prophet among the righteous.” 40. He said, “My Lord, how shall I have a boy, when old age has overtaken me and my wife is barren?” He said, “Thus does God do whatsoever He wills.” 41. He said, “My Lord, appoint for me a sign.” He said, “Your sign is that you shall not speak to people for three days except by gesture. Remember your Lord abundantly, and glorify Him in the evening and early morning.”

Language · “There,” the sanctuary, and the angelic announcement

I say: “There” (هنالك) is a demonstrative (اسم إشارة) indicating something distant. The kāf is a particle of address (حرف خطاب) which ordinarily agrees with the addressee in gender and number. *Miḥrāb* (المحراب) follows the pattern *mifʿāl* and derives from *ḥarb*, warfare. It names a place set aside for worship, such as a mosque, because it is where Satan is fought.

“The angels” (الملائكة) is a broken plural (جمع تكسير). Its verb may be masculine or feminine, though the latter is preferable; thus one may say *qāma al-rijāl* or *qāmat al-rijāl*, “the men arose.” The reading “the angels called to him” with a feminine verb construes them as a group (الجماعة); the masculine reading, “he [or they] called,” is intended to keep the angels free from feminine description, in reply to the unbelievers. What is intended here is Gabriel, as in “He sends down the angels with the Spirit” [16:2] and “When the angels said, O Mary …” [3:42]. In *bashshara*, “he gave glad tidings,” two forms occur: the light, ungeminated form, the idiom of Tihāma, *bashara yabshuru* (with ḍamma on the shīn of the imperfect), and the geminated form *bashshara yubashshiru*, which is more eloquent. [T26]

Outward commentary · A child from the barren and the aged

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says concerning Zachariah, upon him peace: "There"—at the time he witnessed the extraordinary provision with Mary—"Zachariah invoked his Lord." He entered his sanctuary, shut its doors and said in intimate address: "My Lord, grant me, from Yourself, good offspring," just as You granted a child to Ḥanna, the elderly barren woman; "You are the Hearer of prayer"—its Answerer. Hear my supplication, O Answerer!

"The angels called him"—that is, Gabriel, the chief of angels. Arabs refer to a leader in the plural, since he is not ordinarily without companions —"while he was standing in prayer in the sanctuary." It is related that as he prayed a youth wearing white entered, and Zachariah was alarmed. The visitor called out, "God gives you glad tidings of John" (يحيى). He was so called because God gave new life through him to his mother's barrenness; or because God brought his heart to life through gnosis (المعرفة), so that he never inclined towards an act of disobedience; or because he died a martyr, and martyrs are alive.

"Confirming a Word from God": the Word is Jesus, who came to be by the divine command "Be!" (كُنْ), without the customary natural cause. "A lordly leader" (سيّدًا): he will surpass and preside over his people. "Restrained" (حصورًا): one who exercises exceptional restraint over the self's desires and diversions. It is reported that children invited him to play in his youth, and he replied: "I was not created for play." Or it has been interpreted as a man incapable of sexual intercourse. It is related that "he had a male organ like a mote"; Ibn ʿAbbās transmits this. The *Asās* defines a *ḥaṣūr* as "a man who has no desire for women." It is said that this was an excellence under his religious law, unlike the law of our Prophet Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him. Al-Wartajbī explains: the *ḥaṣūr* is one who rules [his impulses] without being ruled by them. Al-Qushayrī says: "Restrained" means set free from passions, spared the compulsion of ordinary human appetites even while remaining human. "A prophet among the righteous": those fitted for prophecy and worthy of the [divine] Presence. T27

On hearing the glad tidings, joy stirred him, and he exclaimed: “My Lord, how shall I have a boy?”—How can a son come to me? He spoke in wonder or amazement, or to ask how the birth would occur: with old age and barrenness remaining, or after their removal? “Old age has overtaken me”: he was ninety-nine, some say a hundred and twenty; “and my wife is barren” (عاقر), unable to conceive. The text does not say *ʿāqira*, since the adjective in this usage is particular to women. Gabriel said to him: “Thus does God do whatever He wills”—wonders and extraordinary events, bringing forth a child from a barren woman and an aged man. Or the sense is “The matter is as I have told you,” followed by a new sentence, “God does whatever He wills.”

Having become certain of the promise, he asked for its sign: “My Lord, appoint for me a sign” by which I shall know of my wife’s pregnancy and greet it with delight and gratitude. “Your sign is that you shall not speak to people for three days”: you will be incapable of ordinary conversation during those three days. His tongue was withheld from speech but not from remembrance and thanksgiving, so that the time might be devoted entirely to them; “except by gesture,” with hand, head, eyebrow or eye. “Remember your Lord abundantly” in those days of speechlessness: the instruction indicates the purpose of his inability to speak. Specifying abundance also indicates that the bare imperative does not, by itself, entail repeated performance. “And glorify Him in the evening” (العشيّ), either from noon until sunset or from the late afternoon into the beginning of night, “and in the early morning” (الإبكار), from dawn to the forenoon. Some say that their prayers consisted of two cycles at dawn and two at sunset, supported by “He signalled to them to glorify [God] morning and evening” [19:11]. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Spiritual children and the transmission of the Path

Spiritual lineages (الأصلاب الروحانية) resemble bodily lineages (الأصلاب الجسمانية). Some remain without offspring despite their own perfection; some have one or two, while some have many. Zachariah’s story teaches the appropriateness of seeking offspring when a friend of God (وليّ) fears that his knowledge or state may disappear with the interruption of his spiritual descent. There is unquestionably merit in the continuation of offspring, sensible or spiritual. The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: “When a ser-

vant dies, his work comes to an end except for three: ongoing charity, a righteous child praying for him, or knowledge from which people benefit." T28

The "child" includes the bodily and the spiritual. The Prophet said to our master ʿAlī, may God ennoble his face: "For God to guide one person through you is better for you than red camels." A poet said:

> A man's followers are weighed with him:
> estimate, then, the rank of the Prophet Muḥammad! [135]

The pole Ibn Mashīsh pursued this course in asking for spiritual offspring. In his well-known invocation of blessings he said: "Hear my call as You heard the call of Your servant Zachariah." The Real, exalted is He, answered him through the shaykh of shaykhs, the pole al-Shādhilī. Many a friend of God has entered the sanctuary of the Presence (محراب الحضرة) and called secretly in the prayer of contemplation (صلاة الفكرة), only to receive an immediate response from unseen calls, by the tongue of state (لسان الحال) or that of utterance (لسان المقال): "God gives you glad tidings of one who will revive your knowledge and inherit your state, confirming a Word from God"—that is, [one of] God's friends—"a leader, restrained" from the preoccupations of sensory existence, immersed in witnessing nearness and intimacy, making known the knowledge of hidden things and restoring disordered hearts. Should the seeker regard this as extraordinary or impossible, he will be told: "Thus it is. God does whatsoever He wills. When He decrees a thing, He only says to it 'Be!' and it is" [3:47]. Let it suffice you to occupy yourself with God's remembrance and to be absent from all besides Him. And success is through God; He guides to the even path.

He next speaks of Mary's particular election after the general mention of election, saying:

135. Cairo editor, C351.1: He is Shaykh al-Būṣīrī.

3:42–43 · Mary’s election and the stages of servanthood

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 351–352

وَإِذْ قالَتِ الْمَلائِكَةُ يَا مَرْيَمُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ اصْطَفاكِ وَطَهَّرَكِ وَاصْطَفاكِ عَلى نِساءِ الْعالَمِينَ (42) يا مَرْيَمُ اقْنُتِي لِرَبِّكِ وَاسْجُدِي وَارْكَعِي مَعَ الرَّاكِعِينَ (43)

42. When the angels said, “Mary, God has chosen you, purified you, and chosen you above the women of the worlds. 43. Mary, be devoutly obedient to your Lord; prostrate and bow with those who bow.”

Theology · The two elections of Mary

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Remember when the angels said”—Gabriel, or a company of angels, addressing Mary directly as a grace (كرامة) bestowed upon her. This establishes extraordinary graces for God’s friends (كرامات الأولياء). Mary was not a prophet, because of the consensus that God did not appoint a woman to prophecy, as indicated by “We sent before you only men to whom We revealed” [21:7]. [Translator’s note: The assertion of consensus is the author’s. The Cairo editor directs the reader to *Fatḥ al-bārī*, 6:542, on the question of Mary’s prophethood.] The angels said: “Mary, God has chosen you” for service in His House; before you He had not accepted a female for that service. He has freed you for His worship and sufficed you with His provision, without needing that of anyone else. “He has purified you” of blameworthy qualities and of what is considered impure in women; “and has chosen you” again through guidance, through addressing you by the angels, and through the annunciation of a son without a father. Thus He has chosen you above the women of the worlds. T29 136

The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is reported to have said: “Many among men have attained perfection; among women only Mary daughter of ʿImrān, Āsiya daughter of Muzāḥim, and Khadīja daughter of

136. Cairo editor, C351.2: On the question of Mary’s prophethood, see Fatḥ al-Bārī,6:542.

Khuwaylid attained perfection …" Ibn ʿAzīz says that "the worlds" means the people of her age, just as Khadīja and Fāṭima daughter of the Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him, were favoured above the women of Muḥammad's community. Abū ʿUmar even maintained that Fāṭima was favoured above all women, pointing to the report that she is the foremost woman of Paradise; but another report excepts Mary. God knows best. In the *Istīʿāb* there is a report from ʿImrān ibn Ḥuṣayn that the Prophet visited Fāṭima when she was ill and asked how she was. She replied that she was in pain, made worse by having nothing to eat. He asked whether she would not be content to be the foremost woman of the worlds. She said, "Father, then where is Mary daughter of ʿImrān?" He replied that Mary was the foremost woman of her world, while Fāṭima was foremost in hers, and that he had married her to a master in this world and the next. End of note from the glossator. [T30]

Outward commentary · Devotion, bowing and prostration

"Mary, be devoutly obedient to your Lord" (اقنتي): prolong your prayer in gratitude for what He has singled you out to receive. "Prostrate and bow with those who bow": pray with those who pray. The verse mentions prostration before bowing either because that was the sequence in their religious law, or to show that the conjunction *wa-* (و) does not itself impose an order, or so that "bow" may stand next to "those who bow," indicating that those whose prayer does not include bowing are not among those who pray [in this sense]. It has also been said that *qunūt* is continual obedience, as in "one devout during the night, prostrating and standing" [39:9]; *sujūd* denotes prayer, as in "after prostrations" [50:40]; while *rukūʿ* signifies humility and lowliness. Thus al-Bayḍāwī. Al-Awzāʿī relates that when the angels had said this to Mary, she stood in prayer until her feet swelled and discharged blood and pus. [T31]

Spiritual allusion · Purification, obedience and opening to the unseen

God does not choose the servant for His Presence before purifying him of vices (الرذائل), adorning him with the various virtues (الفضائل), cutting off the heart's distracting occupations, and establishing him in the tasks of servanthood (وظائف العبودية) and the appropriate adab before the majesty of Lordship (الربوبية). The servant bows beneath the courses of destiny and yields to the decrees of the One, the Overpowering. The aspirant (المريد) has

three breaths [or phases]: worship (عبادة), then servanthood (عبودية), then utter servantness (عبودة); from there he ascends to the contemplation of knowledge of hidden things, to which the Real alludes in what follows:

3:44 · Unseen reports and four kinds of revelation

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 352–353

ذلِكَ مِنْ أَنْباءِ الْغَيْبِ نُوحِيهِ إِلَيْكَ وَما كُنْتَ لَدَيْهِمْ إِذْ يُلْقُونَ أَقْلامَهُمْ أَيُّهُمْ يَكْفُلُ مَرْيَمَ وَما كُنْتَ لَدَيْهِمْ إِذْ يَخْتَصِمُونَ (44)

44. That is among the tidings of the unseen which We reveal to you. You were not with them when they cast their pens [to decide] which of them would take charge of Mary, nor were you with them when they disputed.

Outward commentary · The story as a sign of prophecy

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says to His beloved, blessings and peace be upon him: “That” account, which I have enabled you to know, belongs to “the tidings of the unseen” (أنباء الغيب), of which you had no previous awareness and which you knew only through Our revelation and communication. None therefore doubts your prophecy except one whose inward vision has been utterly extinguished. “You were not with them”—present among them—when they “cast their pens” to draw lots for “which of them would take charge of Mary.” “Nor were you with them when they disputed” over her guardianship, so as to have reported something you witnessed. None of that happened. It must therefore have been a true revelation (وحي), since the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, was unlettered (أميّ): he had not studied historical books or sat with scholars acquainted with them, as both the learned and the public agreed. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Dream, inspiration, legislation and disclosure

Know that *waḥy* (الوحي) is of four kinds: revelation in a dream (وحي منام), revelatory inspiration (وحي إلهام), revelation of rulings (وحي أحكام), and revelation conveying information (وحي إعلام). God’s friends share with the proph-

ets in three of them: inspiration, dreams, and disclosure of information—provided that the last does not come through an angel. The meaning of *waḥy al-iʿlām* (وحي إعلام) is God's acquainting a prophet with concealed matters. If it comes through an angel it belongs especially to prophets, just as revelation of rulings belongs especially to them. If, however, it comes by inspiration, dream or direct understanding from God (الفهم عن الله), it can also occur to God's friends: once the spirit is clarified and cleansed of sensory defilement, God may disclose something of the unseen to it in a general way. Its particulars, however, none knows except the Knower of unseen things. And God knows best. [T32]

The Real then mentions the good news concerning Jesus, upon him peace—the chief purpose of this narrative, since it prepares the rebuttal to the Christians' mistaken claim about him—saying:

3:45–51 · The annunciation, miracles and mission of Jesus

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 353–357

إِذْ قالَتِ الْمَلائِكَةُ يَا مَرْيَمُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُبَشِّرُكِ بِكَلِمَةٍ مِنْهُ اسْمُهُ الْمَسِيحُ عِيسَى ابْنُ مَرْيَمَ وَجِيهاً فِي الدُّنْيا وَالْآخِرَةِ وَمِنَ الْمُقَرَّبِينَ (45) وَيُكَلِّمُ النَّاسَ فِي الْمَهْدِ وَكَهْلاً وَمِنَ الصَّالِحِينَ (46) قالَتْ رَبِّ أَنَّى يَكُونُ لِي وَلَدٌ وَلَمْ يَمْسَسْنِي بَشَرٌ قالَ كَذلِكِ اللَّهُ يَخْلُقُ ما يَشاءُ إِذا قَضى أَمْراً فَإِنَّما يَقُولُ لَهُ كُنْ فَيَكُونُ (47) وَيُعَلِّمُهُ الْكِتابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَالتَّوْراةَ وَالْإِنْجِيلَ (48) وَرَسُولاً إِلى بَنِي إِسْرائِيلَ أَنِّي قَدْ جِئْتُكُمْ بِآيَةٍ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ أَنِّي أَخْلُقُ لَكُمْ مِنَ الطِّينِ كَهَيْئَةِ الطَّيْرِ فَأَنْفُخُ فِيهِ فَيَكُونُ طَيْراً بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ وَأُبْرِئُ الْأَكْمَهَ وَالْأَبْرَصَ وَأُحْيِ الْمَوْتى بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ وَأُنَبِّئُكُمْ بِما تَأْكُلُونَ وَما تَدَّخِرُونَ فِي بُيُوتِكُمْ إِنَّ فِي ذلِكَ لَآيَةً لَكُمْ إِنْ

كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ (49) وَمُصَدِّقاً لِما بَيْنَ يَدَيَّ مِنَ التَّوْراةِ وَلِأُحِلَّ لَكُمْ
بَعْضَ الَّذِي حُرِّمَ عَلَيْكُمْ وَجِئْتُكُمْ بِآيَةٍ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ فَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَأَطِيعُونِ
(50) إِنَّ اللَّهَ رَبِّي وَرَبُّكُمْ فَاعْبُدُوهُ هذا صِراطٌ مُسْتَقِيمٌ (51)

45. When the angels said, “Mary, God gives you glad tidings of a Word from Him, whose name is the Messiah, Jesus son of Mary, distinguished in this world and the Hereafter, and one of those brought near. 46. He shall speak to people in the cradle and in maturity, and shall be among the righteous.” 47. She said, “My Lord, how shall I have a son when no man has touched me?” He said, “Thus does God create whatever He wills. When He decrees a thing, He only says to it ‘Be!’ and it is.” 48. He will teach him the Book and Wisdom, the Torah and the Gospel. 49. And [He will make him] a messenger to the Children of Israel [saying], “I have come to you with a sign from your Lord: I fashion for you from clay something in the shape of a bird, breathe into it, and it becomes a bird by God’s leave. I heal the one born blind and the leper, and bring the dead to life by God’s leave. I tell you what you eat and what you store in your houses. Surely in this is a sign for you, if you are believers. 50. And I confirm what came before me of the Torah, and [have come] to make lawful for you some of what was forbidden to you. I have come to you with a sign from your Lord; so be mindful of God and obey me. 51. God is my Lord and your Lord; therefore worship Him. This is a straight path.”

Language · The Messiah, the Word, and the syntax of the annunciation

I say: “When the angels said” (إذ قالت) is a substitute (بدل) for the earlier “when they said.” Taking it as a substitute for “when they disputed” is remote. “The Messiah” (المسيح), and what follows, gives information about the child’s name; alternatively “Jesus” (عيسى) is the predicate (خبر) of an omitted subject, “son of Mary” (ابن مريم) being its attribute (صفة).

“Messiah” (المسيح) follows the pattern *faʿīl* with a passive sense (*mafʿūl*): he was wiped or cleansed of impurities and so purified; or he was anointed with blessing; or the sole of his foot was flat without an arch; or Gabriel wiped him with his wing to protect him from Satan. Or *masīḥ* has an active

sense (*fāʿil*), because he passed his hand over the ill and they recovered, or over the blind person's eyes and they saw; or because he travelled (يسيح) through the earth, without settling in one place, in which case the initial mīm is additional. As for the Antichrist, *al-masīḥ al-dajjāl*, one of his eyes is effaced, or he traverses the earth save Mecca and Medina. In short, Jesus is the Messiah of good and the Antichrist the messiah of evil. It is therefore said, "The Messiah will slay the messiah." [T33]

"Distinguished" (وجيهًا) is an accusative of state (حال) modifying "Word," which has been sufficiently specified by its qualification. "In the cradle" and "in maturity" (في المهد وكهلًا) are two circumstantial expressions: as an infant and as a mature man. The cradle (*mahd*) is the bedding prepared for an infant. "A messenger" (رسولًا) is the object of an omitted verb: "And We shall make him a messenger." "Confirming" (مصدقًا) is coordinated (عطف) with "a messenger." "So that I may make lawful" (ولأحل) depends upon an omitted verb, "I have come to make lawful," or is coordinated with the implied meaning of "confirming," as in the idiom "I came to you apologizing—or to please your heart."

Outward commentary · The Word, speech from the cradle, and the divine creative command

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "Remember when the angels said" in giving Mary good news, "Mary, God gives you glad tidings of a Word from Him"—a son formed by God's Word "Be!" (كُنْ) and thus brought into being. Some say he was called a "Word" because he manifested the creative Word (كلمة التكوين), realized it, and exercised effect through it. That is why extraordinary events appeared at his hands more often than at those of other prophets. "His name is the Messiah, Jesus son of Mary." Although Mary herself is being addressed, he is called "son of Mary" to signal that he will be born without a father: children are ordinarily attributed to their fathers, except when the father is absent.

"Distinguished in this world and the Hereafter": noble in this world through prophecy and messengership, and in the Hereafter through intercession for his followers. "And one of those brought near" to God in both abodes.

"He will speak to people in the cradle," as an event that breaches the customary order (خرق العادة), vindicating his mother; "and in maturity," after his understanding has become complete, before his being raised, or after his return, since maturity is after forty. The sound interpretation is that she was given tidings of Jesus' prophecy and his speech in the cradle as a miracle, and of his mission of calling people in maturity before and after his being raised. What closely approaches a state may be treated under its ruling. He is "among the righteous"—those fit for the Presence of the Lord of the worlds.

When Mary heard the good news, she was astonished. "She said, My Lord, how shall I have a son when no man has touched me?" She addressed God, having become absent from awareness of the intermediary Gabriel (فانية عن الواسطة), whether in wonder or inquiring how: through marriage or without it? The angel said, "Thus does God create whatever He wills"; or: "The matter is as you say, yet God creates whatever He wills." He needs neither intermediaries nor causes (الوسائط والأسباب). "When He decrees a thing, He merely says to it 'Be!' and it is." He will teach him "the Book"—writing and the script—"and Wisdom"—prophecy or sound judgment—"and the Torah and the Gospel."

Outward commentary · The signs granted to Jesus

"And [He will make him] a messenger to the Children of Israel." Joseph was the first of the messengers among the Children of Israel, Jesus the last—upon them peace. A report attributed to the Prophet says: "I was sent after eight thousand prophets, four thousand of them from the Children of Israel." When Jesus was sent to them, he said, "I have come to you with a sign from your Lord." They asked what it was. He replied: "I fashion for you from clay something in the form of a bird; then I breathe into it and it becomes a bird, **by God's leave**." He used to form for them the shape of a bat, because it is the most complete of birds: it has breasts and teeth, menstruates and flies, making the miracle more striking. It flew while people looked at it and fell dead when out of their sight, to distinguish the act of the Real from that of the creature. [Translator's note: These are transmitted exegetical descriptions; their claims about natural history have not been independently established.] [T34]

He then said: "And I heal the one born blind" (الأكمه)—and all the more one whose blindness came later—"and the leper" (الأبرص), one afflicted with whitish skin disease. These two were singled out because they were considered especially difficult to cure. Medicine was predominant in Jesus' age, so he displayed a miracle of that kind. It is related that at times thousands of sick people gathered around him in one day: those able to come to him did so, and he visited those unable to move. He healed through supplication, on condition that they enter Islam [i.e., submit to God]. [137] [138]

"And I bring the dead to life **by God's leave**"—not by my own power, lest divinity be wrongly imputed to him, for the restoration of life lies beyond human capacity. It is related that he raised four people: Lazarus (*al-ʿĀzir*), his friend, after his sister sent word that he was dying. Jesus arrived after a journey of three days, only to find him dead. He went with the sister to the sealed rock-tomb, invoked God, and Lazarus stood up, his bodily fat dripping; he lived on and had children. The second was the son of an old woman whose funeral passed by Jesus. Through his prayer the young man sat up on the bier, descended from the men's shoulders, dressed himself, carried the bier on his own shoulder and returned home, living long enough to have children. The third was the daughter of a collector of tithes: on being asked whether he could restore one who had died the day before, he prayed, and she lived and had offspring. [139]

The fourth was Shem son of Noah. Jesus invoked God by His Greatest Name, and Shem came out of his grave, half his head white-haired. He asked, "Has the Hour come?" Jesus said, "No, but I invoked God and He gave you life. Why is your hair grey when it was not so in your time?" He answered that hearing the cry he supposed the Hour had come, and terror turned his hair grey. It is said Jesus raised the dead by the invocation "O Living, O Self-Subsisting" (يا حي يا قيوم). [T35]

"And I tell you what you eat and what you store in your homes." After witnessing his cures, some said that these were sorcery and demanded to know what they ate and saved. He would tell a man what he had eaten for his morning and evening meals. It is related that when he attended school,

137. Cairo editor, C355.1: It is a whiteness that affects the skin.
138. Cairo editor, C355.2: That is, the sick person's reaching the place where Jesus, peace be upon him, was.
139. Cairo editor, C355.3: Wadak: the fat or grease of meat.

he told the boys what food their parents had prepared: “Go—your family’s meal today is such and such.” Asked how they knew, they said Jesus had informed them. Their parents confined them and warned them not to play with “this sorcerer.” When Jesus came looking for them, they denied the boys were there. He asked what the house contained. They said “Pigs.” Jesus said: “Then so shall they be.” When the door was opened, the boys were pigs. The people then intended to kill him, and his mother fled with him to Egypt. So relates al-Suddī. [T36]

“Surely in that is a sign for you, if you are believers.” Those stubborn in unbelief gain nothing from miracles. “Confirming what came before me of the Torah”: I have come as its confirmer, attesting its truth, “and to make lawful for you some of what was forbidden to you” under Moses’ law—such as certain fats and fatty parts, camel flesh, and work on the Sabbath. This shows that Jesus superseded certain Torah rulings (ناسخ للتوراة), without compromising his confirmation of the Torah’s truth, just as one Qurʾānic ruling’s supersession of another does not compromise the truth of either. In reality abrogation (النسخ) means clarifying that the operative period of a ruling has ended. [140]

“I have come to you with a clear sign from your Lord,” which your own eyes have witnessed. Nothing remains but your obstinacy. “So be mindful of God and obey me.”

Theology · Divine unity and the straight way

He then calls them to divine unity (التوحيد) after establishing the evidence: “God is my Lord and your Lord; so worship Him,” and none besides Him. “This is a straight path,” without crookedness. Al-Bayḍāwī says: Having come with compelling miracles and manifest signs, “be mindful of God” by avoiding opposition “and obey me” in what I call you to. Jesus then begins his call, summed up in the words “God is my Lord and your Lord,” indicating the perfection of the theoretical power (القوة النظرية) through true belief, whose highest end is divine unity; and “so worship Him,” indicating the perfection of the practical power (القوة العملية) by persevering in obedience, performing commands and avoiding prohibitions. Uniting these two

140. Cairo editor, C356.1: Thurūb is the plural of tharb: a thin layer of fat covering the rumen and intestines.

completes the path attested as straight. Its counterpart is the saying of the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him: "Say, 'I believe in God,' and then remain upright." T37

Spiritual allusion · Mary's consecration and the healing of hearts

Whoever turns wholly to his Master, withdrawing from his personal portions (حظوظه) and passions, spends his youth obeying his Lord and seeks throughout life the remedy of the heart, obtains the promised good in this world and the next, is purified of the stains of faults and vices, and is provided fruits of knowledge before whose comprehension the utmost reach of understanding dwindles. Mary the Virgin spent her youth obeying her Master. He drew her near, took charge of her, announced her election and purification, and commanded her to strive diligently out of gratitude. He then announced a second gift: an immaculate son, a distinguished master, the Spirit of God and the Word of God, with no father, ordinary cause, contrivance or toil. By God's command he cured the blind and the leper and restored the dead by His leave. This was all through the blessing of complete devotion (الانقطاع) and the secret of following faithfully (الاتباع).

The Prophet is reported to have said: "Whoever devotes himself wholly to God, God suffices him for every burden and provides him from whence he does not expect; whoever gives himself over to the world, God leaves him to it." One of the masters said: "The truth of spiritual struggle (صدق المجاهدة) is turning to Him, leaving everything besides Him." Devotion to God in youth serves a person in old age, while youthful acts of disobedience draw calamity into old age.

Just as Jesus cured the blind and lepers by God's leave, so the person wholly devoted to God cures sick hearts **by God's leave**, gives life to dead hearts through God's remembrance, and speaks of inwardly hidden matters and what the consciences of hearts conceal. He directs others to obedience and calls to God by state and speech, guides people to the straight path, and leads those who follow him into the Presence of bliss (حضرة النعيم). And success is through God; He guides to the straight way.

Once the announcement of Jesus was complete, he entered the world and reached the time of his mission. God sent him to the Children of Israel; they disbelieved in him. When their unbelief became manifest, he sought those who would help him towards God, as the Real indicates:

3:52–54 · The disciples, divine stratagem and the Path's companions

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فَلَمَّا أَحَسَّ عِيسى مِنْهُمُ الْكُفْرَ قالَ مَنْ أَنْصارِي إِلَى اللَّهِ قالَ الْحَوارِيُّونَ نَحْنُ أَنْصارُ اللَّهِ آمَنَّا بِاللَّهِ وَاشْهَدْ بِأَنَّا مُسْلِمُونَ (52) رَبَّنا آمَنَّا بِما أَنْزَلْتَ وَاتَّبَعْنَا الرَّسُولَ فَاكْتُبْنا مَعَ الشَّاهِدِينَ (53) وَمَكَرُوا وَمَكَرَ اللَّهُ وَاللَّهُ خَيْرُ الْماكِرِينَ (54)

52. When Jesus sensed unbelief in them, he said, "Who are my helpers towards God?" The disciples said, "We are God's helpers. We believe in God; bear witness that we submit." 53. "Our Lord, we believe in what You have sent down and we follow the Messenger; so write us among the witnesses." 54. They plotted, and God planned; and God is the best of planners.

Language · "My helpers towards God" and "disciples"

I say: in "Who are my helpers towards God?" (من أنصاري إلى الله), the preposition attaches to an omitted circumstantial expression (حال): "as one going to God," that is, to the aid of His religion; or "as one attaching himself to God"; or "as one seeking refuge in God." Alternatively it attaches to "my helpers," understood in the sense of joining or attaching oneself: "Who will join himself to God in helping His religion?"

A man's *ḥawārī* (حواري) is one of his intimates upon whose assistance he relies in adversity. The Prophet said: "Every prophet has a *ḥawārī*; my *ḥawārī* is al-Zubayr." Jesus' *ḥawāriyyūn* (الحواريون) were the companions who supported him. They were so called because of their pure intentions and unblemished innermost dispositions. The root *ḥawar* denotes pure white-

ness: anything you whiten, you have *ḥawwarta*; a fair-complexioned woman can be called *ḥawāriyya*. Some say they were launderers or fullers (قصّارون) who whitened cloth; others say they were kings dressed in white. [141]

Outward commentary · The disciples' confession and the attempt upon Jesus

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "When Jesus sensed unbelief" among the Children of Israel—apprehending it with the certainty of something perceived by the senses—after his mission had begun and they intended to kill him, he fled and sought assistance against them. "He said: Who will help me, turning towards God?" Or: who will go to the aid of His religion? "The disciples replied: We are helpers of God," meaning helpers of His religion. "We believe in God, and bear witness that we submit" (مسلمون), so that you may testify on our behalf on the Day of Resurrection, when messengers testify concerning their communities.

"Our Lord, we believe in what You have sent down" of rulings upon Your prophet "and follow the Messenger," Jesus—peace be upon him. "Write us among the witnesses": witnesses to Your oneness (وحدانيتك); or among those who testify to the truthfulness of Your prophets; or with the prophets who bear witness for their followers; or among Muḥammad's community, who are witnesses over people.

ʿAṭāʾ relates that Mary handed Jesus over to learn various crafts, the last apprenticeship being with the disciples, who worked as cloth-finishers and dyers. When Jesus' teacher was about to travel, he left him many garments of different colours to dye. Jesus heated a single vat, placed all the garments in it and bade them take the colours he wished. On the teacher's return, the man feared that all had been ruined. Jesus took out yellow, red, green and other garments, each according to its intended colour. Amazed, the teacher knew that the act was from God, called people to him, and they believed and gave him support; hence they became disciples. [T38]

After the Children of Israel expelled him, Jesus returned with the disciples and proclaimed his mission to them. They sought to kill him and conspired: "They plotted" (مكروا), contriving means to put him to death; "and God

141. Cairo editor, C357.1: A qaṣṣār is a bleacher of cloth: one who finishes fabric after it is woven by wetting it and beating it with a qaṣra, a piece of wood.

planned against them," allowing them to kill one of their own party while Jesus was raised. In its original usage *makr* (المكر) is a device by which one draws another into harm. It is predicated of God only in response and correspondence (على سبيل المقابلة والازدواج), as in "They seek to deceive God, but He is their deceiver" [4:142] and "God mocks them" [2:15]. "God is the best of planners" means either the mightiest in strategic action, most able to bring about punishment from unsuspected quarters, or the best in recompensing wrongdoing, since none is more able than He.

Theology · Why "planning" is predicated of God

Notice (تنبيه). Al-Junayd was asked: "How can He accept *makr* for Himself when He reproves it in others?" He answered, "I do not know—but so-and-so recited for me verses of al-Ṭabarāniyya":

> For you I would give myself: I was fashioned in desire for you,
> and my soul yearns for none besides you.
> I love you not with one part, but with my whole being,
> though love for you should leave no movement in me.
> In another I find an act reprehensible;
> you do that very act, and from you it seems fair. [142]

The questioner protested: "I ask you about the Qurʾān and you answer with the poetry of al-Ṭabarāniyya?" Al-Junayd replied: "Alas for you! I have answered you, if you can understand. God's letting them persist in their plotting was itself His *makr* against them." End of quotation.

I say: the relevant witness is "you do that very act, and from you it seems fair." The answer implies that every act of God is good and perfectly accomplished, without deficiency or defect. The poet of the *ʿAyniyya* says:

> Whenever you trace the ugly thing to His beauty,
> meanings of beauty hasten forth within it.
> His beauty perfects what seemed defective;
> no deficiency is left, nor any ugliness.

142. Cairo editor, C358.1: Abū Ḥayyān mentions the story in abridged form in his commentary,2:496, quoting only the third verse.

His leaving them to their intrigue resulted in Jesus' being raised to heaven and preserved alive until the last age, when he descends as the deputy of our Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him. This was an act of the highest perfection and wisdom, although only the people of gnosis (أهل العرفان) discern it. [T39]

Spiritual allusion · Fleeing denial and finding helpers on the Way

The sincere aspirant who seeks a remedy for the heart ought to flee a land where denial prevails to one where affirmation is widespread; flee towards righteous ones brought near to God who help him defend the religion—the disciples of religion whom God has appointed. The sound hadith says: "The best wealth of a Muslim is sheep with which he follows the mountain peaks, fleeing tribulations." The believer flees with his religion from one mountain summit to another until death overtakes him. The eminent masters, too, have withdrawn to the mountains, away from the sensible clamor of the world. They accompany only those who help them remember God: the people of detachment (أهل التجريد), chosen for pure divine unity (خالص التوحيد). They fled towards God, and He sheltered them. [143]

"We believe in God. Bear witness that we submit"—we yield to what You desire of us. "Our Lord, we believe in what You have sent down" in decrees of majesty and beauty (الأحكام الجلالية والجمالية); we have known You in every condition. "Write us among the witnesses"—those who witness Your Presence, graced with witnessing Your Essence (شهود ذاتك). Whatever hidden impediments (القواطع الخفية) plot against us, make us absent from them through witnessing Your holy lights. Help us, for You are the best of helpers; do not abandon us to the schemes of schemers, Lord of the worlds.

The Real then mentions Jesus' elevation to heaven:

143. Cairo editor, C359.1: Shaʿaf, with fatḥa on shīn and ʿayn, is the plural of shaʿafa, the uppermost part of anything. Here it means the mountain peaks.

3:55–58 · Jesus’ elevation and the purification of the spirit

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إِذْ قالَ اللَّهُ يا عِيسى إِنِّي مُتَوَفِّيكَ وَرافِعُكَ إِلَيَّ وَمُطَهِّرُكَ مِنَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَجاعِلُ الَّذِينَ اتَّبَعُوكَ فَوْقَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا إِلى يَوْمِ الْقِيامَةِ ثُمَّ إِلَيَّ مَرْجِعُكُمْ فَأَحْكُمُ بَيْنَكُمْ فِيما كُنْتُمْ فِيهِ تَخْتَلِفُونَ (55) فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا فَأُعَذِّبُهُمْ عَذاباً شَدِيداً فِي الدُّنْيا وَالْآخِرَةِ وَما لَهُمْ مِنْ ناصِرِينَ (56) وَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحاتِ فَيُوَفِّيهِمْ أُجُورَهُمْ وَاللَّهُ لا يُحِبُّ الظَّالِمِينَ (57) ذلِكَ نَتْلُوهُ عَلَيْكَ مِنَ الْآياتِ وَالذِّكْرِ الْحَكِيمِ (58)

55. When God said, “Jesus, I shall take you fully and raise you to Me and purify you of those who disbelieve, and I shall set those who follow you above those who disbelieve until the Day of Resurrection. Then to Me you shall return, and I shall judge between you in that about which you differed. 56. As for those who disbelieve, I shall punish them severely in this world and the Hereafter, and they shall have no helpers. 57. But those who believe and perform righteous deeds, He will give them their rewards in full. God loves not the wrongdoers.” 58. This is what We recite to you from the signs and the wise Remembrance.

Language · The meanings of tawaffī and the demonstrative

I say: “When He said” (إذ قال) is governed by something understood: “remember”; or, “that took place when He said”; or it depends on “they plotted.” “I shall take you fully” (مُتَوَفِّيكَ) may mean “I shall raise you to Me complete and intact”: one says *tawaffaytu* or *istawfaytu* something when one receives it in full. Or it means “I shall cause you to die to the desires that impede ascent to the world of malakūt” (عالم الملكوت). Or it means “I shall

cause you to sleep," as indicated by "He it is who takes you [in sleep] by night" [6:60]. It is related that he was raised while sleeping. Ibn ʿAjība states a consensus that Jesus did not die, citing "They did not kill him or crucify him, but it was made to appear so to them" [4:157]. T40

"This" (ذلك) is the subject (المبتدأ) and "We recite it" (نتلوه) the predicate (الخبر); "from the signs" (من الآيات) may be an accusative of state (حال). Alternatively "from the signs" is the predicate and "We recite it" a circumstantial clause; or there are two predicates.

[Translator's print-source notes: T41]

Outward commentary · The raising, judgment and recompense

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "Remember when God said" to Jesus, as He intended to raise him: "Jesus, I shall take you fully"—receive you to Myself, body and all, without diminution—"and raise you to Me," to the place of My honour and the abode of My angels, "and purify you of those who disbelieve," freeing you from companionship polluted by their unbelief. "I shall set those who follow you," who believe in your prophethood, Christians and Muslims; though Qatāda, al-Shaʿbī and al-Rabīʿ say it means the Muslims. End of report. By God, whoever claims Jesus as Lord has not truly followed him. Those who really follow his religion are placed "above those who disbelieve" in him, the Jews, "until the Day of Resurrection," overcoming them in argument and by the sword. He adds: This matter has been realised concerning them, for the Jews have not raised a standard, nor possessed kingship or a state, down to our own time. T42 144

"Then to Me is your return" through resurrection, "and I shall judge between you concerning that in which you differed" over religion and Jesus. "Those who disbelieve, I shall punish with a severe punishment in this world and the Hereafter"—joining the punishment of the next world to the killing and captivity they endured here. "Those who believe and perform righteous deeds, He will give their rewards in full" in the two abodes: help and honour here, satisfaction and good pleasure in the next. "God loves not the wrongdoers": He does not approve their acts or draw them near.

144. Cairo editor, C360.1: That is, up to the author's time. In our own time, a state has been established for them in the heart of our Islamic world, in Arab Palestine, with the aid of the unbelieving states. O God, bring down their state and scatter their unity. Amen.

“This” narrative that I have told you about Jesus, Mary and those before them “We recite to you from the signs,” indications of your truthfulness because they recount events you did not witness or read in books; indeed it is of “the Wise Remembrance” (الذِّكْر الحكيم), the clear Qur’ān.

Spiritual allusion · Ascending beyond desires and enduring through transmission

Whoever purifies the innermost secret (السرّ) of turbidity, sanctifies the spirit from the impurity of otherness (الأغيار), and lifts his aspiration beyond this abode, God causes his spirit to ascend to the heaven of malakūt and elevates his secret to the witnessing of the splendour of jabarūt (مشاهدة سنا الجبروت). His renown remains alive after death, and those attached to him enjoy care, reverence, dignity and honour. The Prophet is reported to have said: “Emigrate, and you will gain honour for your children.” Whoever leaves the homeland of personal portions and passions (الحظوظ والشهوات) and reliance upon habits and familiar comforts ascends in spirit to the heaven of holiness and the abode of intimacy; there he obtains honour that does not perish, extending to his offspring and associates until God inherits the earth and its inhabitants—He is the best of inheritors. [T43]

This is God’s established way with His creation. For they supported His religion and raised His Word, so He helped and raised them. “If you help God, He will help you” [47:7]. “He made the word of those who disbelieved the lowest, while the Word of God is the highest” [9:40]. In the *Ḥikam*: “If you desire an honour that does not perish, do not seek honour through what perishes.” God Most High knows best.

Al-Qushayrī says in allusion: “I shall take you away from yourself, seize you from yourself, raise you beyond human qualities, and purify you altogether of your self-will, until you attest to Us through Us. Nothing of your independent choice will remain, and the cloak of Our care shall rest upon you. It was in this state that the raising of the dead appeared at his hand; these events came about only through the Power governing him.” End of quotation. Al-Wartajbī says: “I shall take you away from the vestiges of contingent being (رسم الحدوثية), raise you to Me through the attribute of Lordship (نعت الربوبية), and purify you from the admixtures of human nature.” End of quotation.

He then recounts Jesus' coming to be and his creation:

3:59–60 · Jesus and Adam; the human composite and the ascent of spirit

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 361–362

إِنَّ مَثَلَ عِيسى عِنْدَ اللَّهِ كَمَثَلِ آدَمَ خَلَقَهُ مِنْ تُرابٍ ثُمَّ قالَ لَهُ كُنْ فَيَكُونُ (59) الْحَقُّ مِنْ رَبِّكَ فَلا تَكُنْ مِنَ الْمُمْتَرِينَ (60)

59. Truly, the likeness of Jesus with God is as the likeness of Adam: He created him from dust, then said to him, "Be!" and he was. 60. The truth is from your Lord; so be not among those who doubt.

Outward commentary · Adam without parents and Jesus without a father

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "Truly, the likeness of Jesus with God"—the wonder of his having come into existence without a father—"is as the likeness of Adam." God then explains Adam's case: "He created him from dust," that is, fashioned his bodily frame from earth; then He breathed the spirit into him, and said to him "Be!"—"and he is," meaning he came to be. Adam's case is more extraordinary than Jesus', since Adam existed without father or mother, whereas Jesus had a mother. Thus only one whose heart God has sealed, who regards divine power as incapable, finds Jesus' case inexplicable and exalts him beyond proper measure. "God has power over everything" [18:45]. "That is the truth from your Lord: be not among the doubters"—those who doubt that Jesus is a created being. The address is directed to the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, to stir others to heed; or to every hearer.

As the occasion of revelation it is related that the delegation from Najrān said to the Prophet, "Why do you insult our master by calling him a servant?" He replied: "Yes, he is God's servant and His Messenger, His Word cast to Mary, the Virgin." They grew angry and asked: "Have you ever seen a human being without a father? If you speak truth, show us another." Then

the verse was revealed: “The likeness of Jesus with God is as the likeness of Adam.” Adam is more remarkable, having come to be with no parental intermediary whatever. T44

It is related that Mary conceived Jesus when she was thirteen; God revealed to him when he reached thirty, and raised him from Jerusalem on the Night of Power when he was thirty-three; his mother lived six years after his being raised. A lengthy report attributed to the Prophet says: “I am the closest of people to Jesus son of Mary, for no prophet came between him and me. He will descend among my community and act as my deputy in it. When you see him, recognize him: he is a man of medium stature, reddish and white in complexion, with straight hair, as though water dripped from it even when it was not wet. He will break the cross and kill the pig, and wealth will become abundant. He will pass through al-Rawḥāʾ as a pilgrim or performer of ʿumra, perhaps combining both. He will fight people for Islam, until God brings all other religions to an end in his time and destroys in his time the false Messiah, the lying Dajjāl. Peace will spread upon the earth, so lions will graze with camels, leopards with cattle and wolves with sheep, and children will play with snakes. He will remain on earth forty years; then he will marry, have offspring and die, and the Muslims will pray over him.” The narration adds that they will bury him in the Prophet’s chamber. [Translator’s note: Such statements belong to the transmitted report, and individual details require their own authentication.] T45 145

Spiritual allusion · Spirit and clay in the human being

Know that the Real, exalted is His majesty, manifested this human being in a wondrous form and with an extraordinary mystery. He joined two opposites in him and entrusted to him the mystery of two worlds: luminous and dark, spiritual and bodily, heavenly and earthly, of malakūt and of mulk, intelligible and sensible. Into a human (ناسوتية) drop He placed a luminous, divine (لاهوتية) spirit. Thus a conflict arose between the opposites: the spirit yearns for its divine home, while the clay-formed drop yearns for its human home. T46

145. Cairo editor, C361.1: Al-Rawḥāʾ: a road between Mecca and Medina, taken by the Messenger of God, blessings and peace be upon him, on his way to Badr and to Mecca in the year of the conquest and the year of the pilgrimage.

Whoever allows the spiritual nature to prevail over the clay joins the spiritual beings and becomes among those brought near in the highest heights. His aspiration is turned to obedience to his Master and ascent to the witnessing of His light and splendour, effaced from his personal portion and passion (فانيًا عن حظوظه وهواه). Whoever lets the clay nature prevail over the spirit resembles beasts or devils and falls to the lowest depths. His aspiration remains turned towards his pleasures and passions, absent from remembrance of his Master, having taken his passion as his god.

Consider our master Jesus, peace upon him: because he did not originate from a mingled drop (نطفة أمشاجية), his spiritual nature prevailed; he had nothing drawing him towards the lowliness of clay, so he did not turn to this dark world at all. Likewise the prophets, who were purified of its residues from the outset, and the friends of God, who purified them through spiritual struggle (المجاهدة): their spirits desired only invocations, knowledge and mysteries, effaced in love of the One, the Overpowering, until they rejoined their home and returned to their origin—the station of witnessing (المشاهدة), intimate speaking (المكالمة), supplication (المناجاة) and mutual confidence (المسارة).

“This is the truth from your Lord; do not be among those who doubt” that the spirit can attain this station, provided the realm of clay (عالم الصلصال) does not dominate it. And God Most High knows best.

After the argument against the Christians had been established and their obstinacy exposed, he invited them to a mutual invocation of judgment (*mubāhala*, المباهلة), saying:

3:61–63 · The challenge of mutual invocation and devotion to the spiritual master

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 362–364

فَمَنْ حَاجَّكَ فِيهِ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَكَ مِنَ الْعِلْمِ فَقُلْ تَعالَوْا نَدْعُ أَبْناءَنا وَأَبْناءَكُمْ وَنِساءَنا وَنِساءَكُمْ وَأَنْفُسَنا وَأَنْفُسَكُمْ ثُمَّ نَبْتَهِلْ فَنَجْعَلْ لَعْنَتَ اللَّهِ عَلَى الْكاذِبِينَ (61) إِنَّ هذا لَهُوَ الْقَصَصُ الْحَقُّ وَما مِنْ إِلهٍ إِلاَّ اللَّهُ وَإِنَّ اللَّهَ لَهُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ (62) فَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلِيمٌ بِالْمُفْسِدِينَ (63)

61. Whoever disputes with you concerning him after knowledge has come to you, say: “Come, let us call our sons and your sons, our women and your women, ourselves and yourselves; then let us earnestly invoke [God] and call God’s curse upon the liars.” 62. This is surely the true account. There is no deity save God, and God is truly the Mighty, the Wise. 63. If they turn away, God knows those who spread corruption.

Language · The derivation of “come” and the meaning of mubāhala

I say: the original of “Come!” (تعالَوا, *taʿālaw*) is *taʿālayū*, on the pattern *tafāʿalū*, from *ʿuluww* (العلوّ), height or elevation. The yāʾ changed to alif because it was vocalized; the alif was subsequently elided. In the reading with ḍamma, the vowel has been transferred [from the yāʾ to the lām]. Its original meaning was “rise up,” after which it became a general imperative meaning “come.” Mutual invocation (*ibtihāl*, الابتهال) means humbling oneself intensely and striving earnestly in prayer.

Outward commentary · Najrān and the challenge of mubāhala

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Whoever disputes with you,” Muḥammad, “concerning him,” Jesus, after the knowledge concerning his servanthood has come to you ... Those who disputed are said to have been al-Sayyid and al-ʿĀqib, who came with the Christians of Najrān. The Prophet

said to them, “Submit [become Muslims].” They answered, “We submitted before you.” He replied: “You speak falsely: your calling Jesus God’s son, worshipping the cross and eating pork prevents your submission.” They asked, “If Jesus is not God’s son, who is his father?”

The Prophet then asked whether a child does not resemble its father; whether God is living and never dies, while Jesus is subject to passing away; whether God sustains, protects and provides for all things, while Jesus cannot exercise such sovereignty; and whether nothing in earth or heaven escapes God’s knowledge, whereas Jesus knows only what he has been taught. They acknowledged each point. He continued: “God formed Jesus in the womb as He willed. God neither eats, drinks nor expels waste. Was Jesus not borne by his mother, delivered as other children are, fed and nourished, and himself subject to eating, drinking and the needs of the body?” When they assented, he asked how Jesus could be as they claimed. They fell silent. The narrative says that the opening of this sūrah was then revealed down to the present passage. [T47]

Thus God said to His Prophet: Whoever disputes with you over Jesus, “after knowledge has come to you,” say to them: “Come, let us invoke a curse upon the liar among us. Let us call our sons and your sons, our women and your women, ourselves and yourselves”—that is, each party should bring itself and the dearest members of its family, those most closely bound to its heart, for the *mubāhala*. They are named before the individual himself because a man will hazard his own safety sooner than theirs, making the summons a more forceful test. “Then let us earnestly pray” against the party who lies, “and place God’s curse upon the liars.”

When the Prophet recited the verse and invited the delegation to mutual invocation, they requested time to consult. They asked al-ʿĀqib, their adviser, what he thought. He said: “You know that Muḥammad is a messenger, and that he has brought a decisive judgment concerning your master. No people who entered into mutual imprecation with a prophet ever had their elders survive or their children grow up. If you do so, you will perish; make peace with the man.” They then came to him while he held al-Ḥasan close, took al-Ḥusayn by the hand, and walked with Fāṭima behind him and ʿAlī behind her, telling them, “When I invoke, say ‘Amen.’” Their bishop is reported to have warned that these were faces whose prayer could move a mountain and that the delegation should not invoke destruction upon themselves. They declined the *mubāhala*.

The Prophet invited them again to enter Islam and receive the rights and responsibilities of Muslims. When they refused, he said that he would oppose them. They answered that they could not wage war against the Arabs, but sought terms by which he would not attack them or compel them to leave their religion. The reported settlement required two thousand garments each year, one thousand in Ṣafar and one thousand in Rajab, together with thirty iron coats of mail. The narrative adds the Prophet's warning that, had they undertaken *mubāhala*, they would have been transformed into monkeys and pigs, their valley consumed in fire, Najrān and its people uprooted, and no year would have elapsed before all the Christians perished. [Translator's note: All these details are presented as reports in the source, not as independent archival proof of the encounter or treaty.] [T48]

The Real says: "This" account revealed to you "is the true narration. There is no deity but God," contrary to the Christian trinitarian claim as Ibn ʿAjība construes it. "God is the Mighty" in His kingship, "the Wise" in His creation. None equals Him in perfect power or consummate wisdom. "If they turn away" from faith, "God knows the corrupters," those who worship other than Him. The explicit noun "the corrupters" stands in place of a pronoun to indicate that turning away from proofs and from divine unity (التوحيد) corrupts religion and leads to disorder in the world. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Loyalty to one's shaykh and the trial of denial

The aspirant (المريد) who has become certain of his shaykh's particular spiritual distinction (خصوصية شيخه), Ibn ʿAjība says, should engage in mutual imprecation with anyone who disputes with him about that shaykh, keep his distance from them, and not soften towards them, lest they gain mastery over him. He should defend his shaykh to the extent of his ability; this reverence is a cause of happiness upon the Path. He should not listen to those who disparage the helpers of religion.

I say: Someone associated with learning in Fez came to me and said, "The scholars of Fez have agreed that your shaykh is an innovator." I replied: "If all the inhabitants of the seven heavens and the seven earths agreed that he was an innovator, I would still say he belonged to the Sunna. For I have realized his particular spiritual distinction as clearly as the sun in the sky, unobscured by any cloud." May God grant us excellent comportment (حسن

الأدب) towards them and reverence until the Day of Judgment. Amen. Whoever of the deniers turns away from God's friends: "God knows the corrupters." T49

He then calls them to the divine unity on which the religious traditions agree, saying:

3:64 · A common word; many paths and the single aim of realization

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 364–365

قُلْ يا أَهْلَ الْكِتابِ تَعالَوْا إِلى كَلِمَةٍ سَواءٍ بَيْنَنا وَبَيْنَكُمْ أَلاَّ نَعْبُدَ إِلاَّ اللَّهَ وَلا نُشْرِكَ بِهِ شَيْئاً وَلا يَتَّخِذَ بَعْضُنا بَعْضاً أَرْباباً مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ فَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَقُولُوا اشْهَدُوا بِأَنَّا مُسْلِمُونَ (64)

64. Say: "O People of the Book, come to a word equitable between us and you: that we worship none but God, associate nothing with Him, and do not take one another as lords apart from God." If they turn away, say: "Bear witness that we submit to God."

Language · Sawāʾ: equity, levelness and the middle

I say: "Equitable" (سواء) is a verbal noun (مصدر) used as an adjective (نعت) qualifying "word." Verbal nouns [used in this way] are not put into the dual or plural, nor made feminine. With an a-vowel on the sīn, its ending is long: sawāʾ; with a u- or i-vowel, it is short: suwā or siwā, as in "a level place" (مَكَانًا سُوًى) [20:58], meaning an even place. The sawāʾ of anything is its middle. God Most High says, "He saw him in the midst of Hell" [37:55], that is, in its middle.

Theology · Worship, religious authority and the call to a common word

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "Say," Muḥammad, "O People of the Book"—Jews and Christians—"come," that is, approach, "to a word equitable," just and even-handed, "between us and you," concerning which mes-

sengers, scriptures and communities do not differ. It is “that we worship none but God”: that we single Him out in worship and acknowledge His oneness; “associate nothing with Him”: assign no other being a share in the right to be worshipped; “and do not take one another as lords apart from God”: do not say that Ezra is God’s son or that the Messiah is God’s son, and do not obey the rabbis in the prohibitions and permissions they have newly introduced, for they are human beings like ourselves.

When the words of God Most High, “They have taken their rabbis and monks as lords apart from God” [9:31], were revealed, ʿAdī ibn Ḥātim said: “We did not worship them, Messenger of God.” He replied: “Did they not declare things lawful and unlawful for you, and you accepted what they said?” He answered: “Yes.” He said: “That is it.” [T50]

“If they turn away,” turning aside from the affirmation of God’s oneness, “say: ‘Bear witness that we submit to God.’” The proof has now become binding upon you; acknowledge, therefore, that we submit and you do not, and that you disbelieve what the scriptures have declared and the messengers have unanimously affirmed.

Outward commentary · The successive stages of the argument

Admonition (تنبيه): consider the force and skilful progression of the argument in this verse. First, He explained Jesus’ circumstances and the successive conditions he underwent that are incompatible with divinity. Then He set out what would unravel their difficulty and remove their doubt. When He saw their obstinate insistence, He invited them to the mutual invocation of a curse (المباهلة), involving a kind of miraculous challenge. When they declined it and yielded to some extent, He returned to guiding them and took an easier, more compelling route: He invited them to that upon which Jesus, the other prophets and the scriptures agreed. When this too availed them nothing, and He knew that the signs and warnings would not benefit them, He turned away from them, saying: “Say: ‘Bear witness that we submit to God.’” Thus al-Bayḍāwī.

Spiritual allusion · The paths are many; their aim is one

The paths (الطرق) are many, but the aim is one: the special realization of divine oneness (التوحيد الخاص), by which I mean the station of effacement and subsistence (الفناء والبقاء). All who call to God agree in calling to this aim. A

path that does not lead to it is of no account, and every caller who fails to bring one to this beauty is an impostor. If he is content to receive people's veneration but has not built his path upon its foundation, his companion gains nothing but bankruptcy. Whoever obeys a created being in disobedience to God has taken that being as a lord apart from God. Whoever turns from the path of right guidance has brought expulsion and remoteness upon himself. Those who have arrived, or those still journeying, say to him: "If they turn away, say: 'Bear witness that we submit to God.'" Success comes through God, and He guides to the even way.

When the delegation from Najrān came to Medina, they met the Jews and disputed about Abraham, peace be upon him. The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, came to them. They said: "Muḥammad, we have disagreed about Abraham and his religion." The Christians said he was Christian; the Jews said he was Jewish, and that they had the closest claim to him. The Prophet said: "Both parties are disassociated from Abraham. Rather, Abraham was a ḥanīf, one submitting to God, and I follow his religion. Follow, then, his religion: submission to God." So God revealed: [T51]

3:65–68 · Abraham, submission and the limits of partisan claims

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 365–367

يا أَهْلَ الْكِتابِ لِمَ تُحَاجُّونَ فِي إِبْراهِيمَ وَما أُنْزِلَتِ التَّوْراةُ وَالْإِنْجِيلُ إِلاَّ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ أَفَلا تَعْقِلُونَ (65) ها أَنْتُمْ هؤُلاءِ حاجَجْتُمْ فِيما لَكُمْ بِهِ عِلْمٌ فَلِمَ تُحَاجُّونَ فِيما لَيْسَ لَكُمْ بِهِ عِلْمٌ وَاللَّهُ يَعْلَمُ وَأَنْتُمْ لا تَعْلَمُونَ (66) ما كانَ إِبْراهِيمُ يَهُودِيًّا وَلا نَصْرانِيًّا وَلكِنْ كانَ حَنِيفاً مُسْلِماً وَما كانَ مِنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ (67) إِنَّ أَوْلَى النَّاسِ بِإِبْراهِيمَ لَلَّذِينَ اتَّبَعُوهُ وَهذَا النَّبِيُّ وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَاللَّهُ وَلِيُّ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ (68)

65. O People of the Book, why do you dispute about Abraham, when the Torah and the Gospel were sent down only after him? Will you not reason? 66. There you are: you have disputed about matters of which you have knowledge. Why, then, do you dispute about matters of which you have no knowledge? God knows, and you do not know. 67. Abraham was neither a Jew nor a Christian, but a ḥanīf, one submitting to God; he was not one of those who associate partners with Him. 68. Those with the closest claim to Abraham are surely those who followed him, this Prophet, and those who believe. God is the protecting friend of the believers.

Language · The particles and predicates in “there you are”

I say: the underlying form of hā antum (ها أنتم) is antum, to which the attention-calling hāʾ (هاء التنبيه) has been prefixed. Al-Akhfash says its underlying form is a-antum (أأنتم), with the first hamza changed into hāʾ, as in haraqtu (هرقت). The explanations of the variant readings are known in their proper place. Antum is the subject (مبتدأ), hāʾulāʾ its predicate (خبر), and ḥājajtum, “you disputed,” a clause explaining the first. Alternatively, ḥājajtum is the predicate and hāʾulāʾ is a vocative (منادى) with the particle of address omitted. “A ḥanīf” is a circumstantial accusative (حال), meaning one who turns away from all religions except the religion of submission to God.

Theology · Abraham precedes the later communal designations

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “O People of the Book, why do you dispute about Abraham,” each party claiming that he followed its religion, “when the Torah and the Gospel were sent down only after him?” How could he have been Jewish, when your religion arose only a thousand years after Abraham? How could he have been Christian, when Christianity appeared only two thousand years after Abraham? “Will you not reason,” instead of asserting what is impossible? [T52]

“There you are,” you foolish people: “you have disputed about matters of which you have knowledge”—Muḥammad’s case and his prophethood, blessings and peace be upon him, which you found in the Torah and the Gospel, but denied out of obstinacy and envy. Why, then, do you dispute

about something you do not know, concerning Abraham, for which your scripture contains no statement? “God knows” the matter you dispute, “and you do not know”; rather, you are ignorant.

He then expressly declares both parties’ claims false: “Abraham was neither a Jew nor a Christian, but a ḥanīf,” turning away from false beliefs, “one submitting to God,” obedient to his Lord’s ordinances. It does not mean that he belonged to the [later] religious community of Islam (ملّة الإسلام); otherwise the same objection would apply, since the religion of Islam also came later. Abraham was the imam of those who affirm the One. “He was not one of those who associate partners with Him,” as do the Jews, Christians and polytheists. This indirectly rebukes them and refutes their claim to follow his religious way. [T53]

He then states who has the closest claim to him: “Those with the closest claim to Abraham”—those most particularly related and nearest to him —“are surely those who followed him,” of his community in his own time, “this Prophet,” Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, “and those who believe,” since they agree with him in most ordinances. The Prophet said: “Every prophet has protecting friends among the prophets, and my protecting friend among them is my father and my Lord’s intimate friend,” meaning Abraham, peace be upon him. “God is the protecting friend of the believers”: He supports them against the other religions and recompenses them with the utmost beneficence.

Spiritual allusion · Following the prophetic way rather than claiming exclusive perfection

You see many who profess spiritual poverty (المتفقرة) confining perfection to their own path and disputing about the paths of others. This is a tendency of the People of the Book, departing from sound guidance and correctness. The one with the closest claim to the truth is he who follows the Muhammadan Sunna, acquires praiseworthy character, renounces the two abodes, lifts his aspiration beyond the two worlds, and removes the veil of heedlessness from his heart until his Lord’s lights shine upon him. He joins those who impart prophetic spiritual training (التربية النبوية); they cast him into the seas of absolute oneness (الأحدية), then return him to the station of sobriety and the perfecting of others (الصحو والتكميل). What an exalted station! This is the religious way of Abraham, the intimate friend, and it is

what the noble Messenger brought: the beloved of the All-Merciful, the pole of the circle of time, the master of the messengers, the imam of the knowers, and the Messenger of the Lord of the worlds. God's blessings and peace be upon him continually until the Day of Judgment.

He then began to rebuke the Jews and recount their faults, saying:

3:69–71 · Concealment, envy and the preservation of religious status

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 367–367

وَدَّتْ طائِفَةٌ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ لَوْ يُضِلُّونَكُمْ وَما يُضِلُّونَ إِلاَّ أَنْفُسَهُمْ وَما يَشْعُرُونَ (69) يا أَهْلَ الْكِتابِ لِمَ تَكْفُرُونَ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ وَأَنْتُمْ تَشْهَدُونَ (70) يا أَهْلَ الْكِتابِ لِمَ تَلْبِسُونَ الْحَقَّ بِالْباطِلِ وَتَكْتُمُونَ الْحَقَّ وَأَنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ (71)

69. A group among the People of the Book would like to lead you astray, but they lead none astray except themselves, though they do not perceive it. 70. O People of the Book, why do you disbelieve in God's signs when you yourselves bear witness? 71. O People of the Book, why do you mix truth with falsehood and conceal the truth while you know?

Language · Law introducing the content of a wish

I say: law (لو) has the force of a verbal-noun clause (مصدرية): that is, they wished for your being led astray.

Outward commentary · Knowing testimony and deliberate concealment

The Real, exalted is His majesty, addresses certain Muslims—Ḥudhayfa, ʿAmmār and Muʿādh—whom the Jews had invited to their religion and hoped to win over: "A group," that is, a party "among the People of the Book would like to lead you astray": tempt you from your religion and ruin you

by turning you from the way of truth. “But they lead none astray except themselves,” since the Muslims do not accept this from them: the misguidance recoils upon them, its evil consequence returns to them, and its punishment is multiplied against them. “They do not perceive” that its evil consequence returns to themselves.

The Real Most High then expressly rebukes them: “O People of the Book, why do you disbelieve in God’s signs,” sent down to His Prophet Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, and deny his mission, “when you yourselves bear witness” that they come from God and that he is God’s prophet, described in your Torah and Gospel? Those meant are their rabbis. Alternatively, you bear witness through the clear miracles that he is God’s prophet. “O People of the Book, why do you mix truth with falsehood,” by alteration and by displaying falsehood in the form of truth, concealing and changing Muḥammad’s description and putting in its place the falsehood your souls have enticed you to devise? “And conceal the truth”—Muḥammad’s prophethood—“while you know” that he truly is God’s Messenger and that his religion is true; or, while you know that you are concealing it.

Spiritual allusion · Envy of living spiritual distinction

You see many people of leadership and standing, among the descendants of the righteous and those affiliated with them, who, when they see someone manifest special spiritual distinction (الخصوصية) in their own time, wish to lead him astray and extinguish his lights, fearing the loss of their own leadership. Yet they mislead only themselves and do not perceive it: “God will bring His light to completion, though the unbelievers dislike it” [61:8]. This is a Jewish tendency caused by envy; the envious man does not attain mastery. Some recognize the special distinction of others, yet conceal it while bearing witness inwardly to its truth. They are asked: Why do you disbelieve in God’s signs when you bear witness? Why do you mix truth with falsehood and conceal the truth while you know?

The Real Most High then mentioned the deceptions of the People of the Book and their futile stratagems, saying:

3:72 · Calculated withdrawal and the instability of spiritual commitment

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 367–368

وَقالَتْ طائِفَةٌ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ آمِنُوا بِالَّذِي أُنْزِلَ عَلَى الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَجْهَ النَّهارِ وَاكْفُرُوا آخِرَهُ لَعَلَّهُمْ يَرْجِعُونَ (72)

72. A group among the People of the Book said: “Believe at the beginning of the day in what was sent down to those who believe, and reject it at its end, so that they may turn back.”

Outward commentary · The stratagem of professing belief and then withdrawing

Al-Ḥasan and al-Suddī said: twelve men among the Jews of Khaybar—that is, their rabbis—conspired together, saying to one another: “Enter Muḥammad’s religion at the beginning of the day in speech, not in conviction; reject it at the end. Say: ‘We examined our books and consulted our learned men, and found that Muḥammad is not the one described; his falsehood became clear to us.’ We shall do this only to make his companions doubt.” End of the quotation. [T54]

God Most High therefore warned the Muslims against their statement. He, exalted is His majesty, said: “A group among the People of the Book”—their rabbis—“said: ‘Believe in what was sent down to those who believe,’” outwardly professing entry into their religion, “at the beginning of the day, and reject it at its end.” Say: “We examined our books and consulted our learned men, and did not find Muḥammad to have the description in the Torah,” so that his companions might come to doubt him. May God curse them and bring their endeavour to nothing.

Another account says that the verse was revealed concerning the Kaʿba. Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf and Mālik ibn al-Ṣayf, who were Jews, told their companions: “Pray with them towards the Kaʿba at the beginning of the day; then

pray towards the Rock at its end. Perhaps they will say, ‘These people know more than we do and have turned back,’ and they too will turn back.” God exposed them and nullified their feeble stratagem.

Spiritual allusion · Entering the path without a settled commitment

You see many people enter the path of the Folk (طريق القوم), only to find its burdens heavy and leave it: either because they lack the strength to bear them, or because they entered merely to test it, with a precarious commitment, or as a stratagem against others. When one of them withdraws, people say: “Had it been sound, so-and-so would not have left it.” They then deter people from entering it and persevering in it. This is an Israelite tendency: “Believe at the beginning of the day and reject it at its end, so that they may turn back.” The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: “You will follow the ways of those before you, span for span and cubit for cubit, until, were they to enter a lizard’s hole, you would enter it.” They asked: “The Jews and Christians?” He said: “Yes; who else, then?” Success comes through God. [T55]

The Real Most High then mentioned another of their objectionable statements, saying:

3:73–74 · The distribution of divine bounty and the safeguarding of spiritual knowledge

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 368–370

وَلا تُؤْمِنُوا إِلاَّ لِمَنْ تَبِعَ دِينَكُمْ قُلْ إِنَّ الْهُدى هُدَى اللَّهِ أَنْ يُؤْتى أَحَدٌ مِثْلَ ما أُوتِيتُمْ أَوْ يُحاجُّوكُمْ عِنْدَ رَبِّكُمْ قُلْ إِنَّ الْفَضْلَ بِيَدِ اللَّهِ يُؤْتِيهِ مَنْ يَشاءُ وَاللَّهُ واسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ (73) يَخْتَصُّ بِرَحْمَتِهِ مَنْ يَشاءُ وَاللَّهُ ذُو الْفَضْلِ الْعَظِيمِ (74)

73. “Believe only one who follows your religion.” Say: “Guidance is God’s guidance.” “[Do not believe] that anyone is given the like of what you were given, or that they might dispute with you before your Lord.” Say: “Bounty

is in God's hand; He gives it to whom He wills. God is all-encompassing, knowing." 74. He singles out for His mercy whom He wills. God is the possessor of immense bounty.

Language · The disputed construction of an yuʾtā and the parenthetical reply

I say: "that anyone is given" (أن يؤتى) may be the object (مفعول) of "believe" (تؤمنوا), while "Say: 'Guidance is God's guidance'" is a parenthesis (اعتراض). The lām in li-man (لمن) is an additional linking particle (صلة), and "or that they might dispute with you" is coordinated with yuʾtā. The reconstructed sense (التقدير) is: do not believe that anyone is given the like of what you were given, except someone of your own religion; and do not believe that they can dispute with you before your Lord—rather, you are the ones who dispute with others. God answers them: "Say: 'Guidance is God's guidance,'" and "[Say:] 'Bounty is in God's hand.'"

Alternatively, "that anyone is given" is an expression of purpose or cause (مفعول لأجله), governed by an omitted expression (عامل محذوف). The reconstructed sense is: did you devise what you devised because you disliked anyone being given what you were given, and feared that they might dispute with you before your Lord? [T56]

Outward commentary · Three readings of the argument and its speakers

The Real, exalted is His majesty, relates the Jews' words: "And" they said, "do not believe"—do not acknowledge or credit—"that anyone is given the like of what you were given," of knowledge, wisdom, the parting of the sea and other favours, "except one who follows" Judaism and belongs to "your religion." Do not believe "that they might dispute with you before your Lord," for your religion is sounder than theirs. The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "Say" to them, "Guidance is God's guidance"—by it He guides whom He wills—and "Bounty is in God's hand; He gives it to whom He wills."

Alternatively, the Real, exalted is His majesty, says: they said, do not believe or submit "except to one who follows your religion" and is of your own people, for prophethood belongs exclusively to you. The Real refutes them:

"Say: 'Guidance is God's guidance.'" He assigns it to whichever of His servants He wills. How, then, can you confine it to yourselves? Because "anyone might be given the like of what you were given," you said what you said and contrived what you contrived, out of envy and transgression; "or" because you feared that "they might dispute with you before your Lord," overcoming you in argument through the manifest ascendancy of their religion. "Say," Muḥammad: "Bounty is in God's hand; He gives it to whom He wills." No device or deception can turn it back.

Alternatively, the Real, exalted is His majesty, addresses the believers to make them steadfast and strengthen their hearts: do not believe, company of believers, that anyone is given the like of the bounty and upright religion you have been given, except someone who follows your true religion and brings it from the Real. Do not believe that they can dispute with you about your religion "before your Lord," or that anyone is capable of this. Guidance is God's guidance and bounty is in God's hand: "He gives it to whom He wills. God is all-encompassing" in bounty and generosity, "knowing" who merits special distinction and bounty. "He singles out for His mercy whom He wills," as with prophethood and other gifts. "God is the possessor of immense bounty": His bounty has no limit, just as His Essence has no limit.

Spiritual allusion · Preparation, confidentiality and the danger of disclosure without realization

The Real—majestic is His Essence and mighty His power—says to the people of special distinction (أهل الخصوصية): acknowledge that distinction only to someone who shares your religion and path, has adopted your manner, and has expended himself and his means in your companionship. This is for fear that someone might be given the like of the distinction you have received without being qualified for it, and take it merely as knowledge; he might then fall into heresy or transgression. Or they might argue against you by the religious Law (الشريعة) and shed your blood, as happened to al-Ḥallāj, God be pleased with him. Concerning this the poet says:

Whoever has witnessed the Reality, let him guard it,
or he will be slain by the spear;
like the Ḥallāj of love, when there appeared to him
the sun of Reality through drawing near. T57 146

Another says:

If they divulge the secret, their blood is made forfeit;
thus is the blood of those who divulge it made forfeit.

Say, knower of God, to one who seeks special distinction before fulfilling its conditions, or denies its presence in those who do fulfil them: guidance is God's guidance; by it He guides whom He wills. Bounty is in God's hand; He gives it to whom He wills. Mercy—which here is special distinction—is in God's grasp; He singles out whom He wills for it. "God is the possessor of immense bounty." Whoever desires special distinction should seek it at its source: those who know it. Let him expend himself and his means in their service until they acquaint him with it. Success comes through God.

The Real Most High then mentioned the description of the Jews as betraying trusts, saying:

3:75–76 · Trustworthiness, the rights of others and false claims of spiritual exemption

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 370–371

وَمِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ مَنْ إِنْ تَأْمَنْهُ بِقِنْطارٍ يُؤَدِّهِ إِلَيْكَ وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ إِنْ تَأْمَنْهُ بِدِينارٍ لا يُؤَدِّهِ إِلَيْكَ إِلاَّ ما دُمْتَ عَلَيْهِ قائِماً ذلِكَ بِأَنَّهُمْ قالُوا لَيْسَ عَلَيْنا فِي الْأُمِّيِّينَ سَبِيلٌ وَيَقُولُونَ عَلَى اللَّهِ الْكَذِبَ وَهُمْ يَعْلَمُونَ (75) بَلى مَنْ أَوْفى بِعَهْدِهِ وَاتَّقى فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ الْمُتَّقِينَ (76)

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146. Cairo editor, C369.1: The two verses are from a poem by Shaykh Muḥyī l-Dīn ibn ʿArabī in his book al-Isrāʾ ilā l-maqām al-asrā. There the wording is: "Let whoever understands the allusion keep it concealed."

75. Among the People of the Book is one who, if you entrust him with a great sum, will return it to you; and among them is one who, if you entrust him with a single dinar, will not return it unless you keep standing over him. That is because they say: “We are not answerable concerning the unlettered.” They knowingly speak falsehood against God. 76. Rather, whoever fulfils his covenant and is mindful of God—God loves the God-fearing.

Language · The preposition of entrusting and the jussive form yuʾaddihi

I say: the bāʾ in bi-qinṭārin (بقنطار) has the meaning of ʿalā. “He will return it” (يؤدّه) is the response to the condition (جواب الشرط), made jussive (مجزوم) by deletion of the yāʾ. In the reading that leaves the pronoun unvowelled, the pronoun is put in the place of the deleted letter and made quiescent in compensation for it. Al-Farrāʾ says that some Arabs leave the hāʾ unvowelled when the preceding letter is vowelled; they say, for example, ḍarabtuh ḍarban shadīdan, “I struck him a severe blow.”

Outward commentary · An entrusted deposit remains another person’s right

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Among the People of the Book” are those who have submitted and believed, becoming people of faith. If you entrust such a person with “a great sum” of money, or more, he returns it to you without betraying any part of it. A hadith states: “Whoever is entrusted with a trust and returns it, although he could have withheld it, God will marry him to as many of the wide-eyed maidens as he wishes.” Among them are also those who remain in their religion, people of treachery and loss: entrust such a person with “a single dinar,” or less, and “he will not return it to you unless you keep standing over him,” insistently demanding it. [T58]

The verse was revealed concerning ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām: a Qurashī deposited twelve hundred ūqiyyas of gold with him, which he returned. It also concerned Finḥāṣ ibn ʿĀzūrāʾ, the Jew: another Qurashī deposited a dinar with him, which he denied. Another explanation takes the verse to concern Christians and Jews, saying that trustworthiness predominates among the Christians and treachery among the Jews.

Their treating this as lawful arose because “they say: ‘We are not answerable concerning the unlettered.’” That is: with respect to people who are not People of the Book and do not share our religion, there is no blame or sin upon us in taking their property or denying it. “They knowingly speak falsehood against God”: they know they are lying, since they make it lawful to wrong those who differ from them and say that the Torah grants such people no inviolability.

Another account says that Jews had dealings with some men of Quraysh. When those men became Muslim and demanded payment, they replied: “Your right has lapsed because you abandoned your religion.” The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: “God’s enemies have lied. Everything belonging to the Age of Ignorance is beneath my feet, except a trust: it must be returned to the righteous and the unrighteous alike.”

The Real Most High then declares them false: “Rather,” they are indeed answerable in this matter. “Whoever fulfils his covenant and is mindful of God,” avoiding association of partners and acts of disobedience—“God loves the God-fearing.” How could the property of someone God loves be made lawful to take, or his inviolability lapse? Rather, whoever abolishes his inviolability has made war upon God and His Messenger. Alternatively: whoever among the People of the Book fulfils God’s covenant, believes in Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, avoids treachery and returns the trust—“God loves the God-fearing.”

He puts the explicit noun (المظهر) in the place of a pronoun referring back to “whoever” (مَن), to make the statement general. “The God-fearing” is a general expression applying to returning deposits and to other things, indicating that God-fearingness (التقوى) is the governing principle of the matter and the cause of preservation. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Realization does not cancel the Law or people’s rights

We have seen some of the spiritually poor enter the land of Reality (الحقيقة), whereupon reverence for the religious Law (الشريعة) falls away from their hearts. They become careless with people’s property, and the inviolability of God’s servants loses its hold upon them, until you cannot trust them to protect either property or family. Deposit something with such a person, or entrust him with capital in a profit-sharing investment (قِراض), and he will

not return it unless you keep standing over him. This is heresy (زندقة), an Israelite tendency that even the lowest of people would not accept—how much less someone claiming to be the highest! [T59]

Among the sayings of wisdom is: "The perfection of religious integrity is to abandon treachery." The greatest bankruptcy is betraying people. A hadith states: "Three qualities make a person a hypocrite, even if he prays, fasts and claims to be a believer: when he speaks he lies, when he promises he breaks his promise, and when entrusted he betrays the trust." If he argues on behalf of his soul that commands evil (النفس الأمّارة), saying, "We are not answerable concerning the possessions of ordinary people," he has cast the bond of Islam from his neck and deserves the sharp sword to fall upon the crown of his head. And God Most High knows best.

One form of treachery is consuming people's property through wicked oaths, as the Real Most High indicates, saying:

3:77 · Selling the covenant; worldly inducement and the covenant of spirits

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 371–372

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَشْتَرُونَ بِعَهْدِ اللَّهِ وَأَيْمانِهِمْ ثَمَناً قَلِيلاً أُولئِكَ لا خَلاقَ لَهُمْ فِي الْآخِرَةِ وَلا يُكَلِّمُهُمُ اللَّهُ وَلا يَنْظُرُ إِلَيْهِمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ وَلا يُزَكِّيهِمْ وَلَهُمْ عَذابٌ أَلِيمٌ (77)

77. Those who exchange God's covenant and their oaths for a paltry price have no share in the Hereafter. God will not speak to them or look upon them on the Day of Resurrection, nor will He purify them. Theirs will be a painful punishment.

Outward commentary · The paltry price of concealing a binding trust

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "Those who exchange God's covenant"—who barter away fidelity to it, such as belief in the Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him, the covenant taken from the Children of Israel

in the Torah, disclosure of his description, and the discharge of trusts. They concealed this and exchanged it for “a paltry price”: the perishing debris of this world that they received from their common followers. They feared that disclosing it would cost them these receipts. Likewise, they broke the oaths God had taken from them that, should they live to encounter Muḥammad, they would believe in him and support him, for fear of losing their leadership. In place of fidelity, they took a paltry, perishing price.

“They have no share”—no portion—“in the Hereafter. God will not speak to them” with anything that pleases them, or will not speak to them at all: only the angels question them. He will not “look upon them on the Day of Resurrection” with a look of mercy, but will turn from them in anger and make them abased. He will not “purify them” of their sins, or praise them. “Theirs will be a painful,” grievous, “punishment.”

ʿIkrima said: it was revealed concerning Abū Rāfiʿ, Kināna ibn Abī al-Ḥuqayq, Ḥuyayy ibn Akhṭab and other Jewish leaders. They concealed what God had entrusted to them in the Torah concerning disclosure of the Prophet’s description, wrote something else, and swore that it came from God, so that they would not lose their followers’ bribes.

Al-Kalbī said: some Jewish scholars with a share of knowledge of the Torah were afflicted by a year of famine. They went to Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf to seek provisions—that is, food. Kaʿb asked them: “Do you know that this man is a messenger in your scripture?” They answered: “Yes. Do you not know it yourself?” He said: “No.” They replied: “We testify that he is God’s servant and Messenger.” Kaʿb said: “You came to me when I intended to provision and clothe you; God has now deprived you of much good.” They said: “We were confused about him. Give us a little time to meet him.” They went away and wrote a description different from his. Then they went to God’s Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, and spoke to him. Returning to Kaʿb, they said: “We used to think he was God’s Messenger, but when we visited him, he did not match the description given to us.” They produced what they had written, and Kaʿb rejoiced and supplied them with provisions. The verse was then revealed. I say: look at avarice and what it does to its possessor! In God we seek refuge.

Another account says it was revealed concerning a man who displayed his merchandise in the market and swore that he had been offered such-and-such a price for it. Another says it concerned al-Ashʿath ibn Qays, who had a dispute with a man upon whom the oath then devolved; the man intended to swear it. And God Most High knows best. [T60]

Spiritual allusion · The covenant that no other should share the heart's devotion

God took the covenant from the spirits (الأرواح) that they should worship none with Him and incline to nothing other than Him. Whoever inclines to a thing, or rests in love upon someone other than God, has broken his covenant with God. He has no portion in the station of knowledge of God (المعرفة), nor does witnessing (المشاهدة) or divine converse (المكالمة) come to him until he returns and turns in his entirety towards his Master. And God Most High knows best.

Another of their faults is altering God's scripture, as the Real Most High indicates in His words:

3:78 · Distorting scripture, corrupt judgments and the imitation of spiritual knowledge

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وَإِنَّ مِنْهُمْ لَفَرِيقاً يَلْوُونَ أَلْسِنَتَهُمْ بِالْكِتابِ لِتَحْسَبُوهُ مِنَ الْكِتابِ وَما هُوَ مِنَ الْكِتابِ وَيَقُولُونَ هُوَ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ وَما هُوَ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ وَيَقُولُونَ عَلَى اللَّهِ الْكَذِبَ وَهُمْ يَعْلَمُونَ (78)

78. Among them is a group who twist their tongues with the scripture so that you might think it belongs to the scripture, though it does not belong to the scripture. They say, "It is from God," though it is not from God. They knowingly speak falsehood against God.

Outward commentary · Presenting altered words as revealed scripture

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Among” the People of the Book “is a group”—Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf, Ḥuyayy ibn Akhṭab, Mālik ibn al-Ṣayf, Abū Yāsir and Shuʿba ibn ʿĀmir—“who twist,” that is, turn and contort, “their tongues with the scripture,” the Torah, when reciting it. They turn from what was revealed to what has been altered, “so that you might think it belongs to the scripture”: suppose that the altered material belongs to the Torah, “though it does not belong to the scripture.” They say, “‘It is from God,’ though it is not from God.” They “knowingly speak falsehood against God” in what they attribute to Him, knowing that it is not from Him.

Ibn ʿAbbās said: it was revealed concerning both Jews and Christians, who altered the Torah and the Gospel, added what did not belong to them, and removed the upright religion; God made their falsehood clear. Another account concerns stoning: they concealed it, and the reader of the Torah put his hand over the verse on stoning while reciting what surrounded it. Ibn Salām told him to lift his hands, whereupon the verse on stoning was plainly visible. And God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Worldly gain behind scholarly and spiritual appearances

This verse extends to corrupt scholars who issue rulings contrary to the established predominant position (المشهور) for a worldly portion they receive, and to unjust judges who judge by desire and rely on unsound opinions, saying, “It is from God,” although it is not from God. [T61]

So too with certain people affiliated with the spiritually poor: they put on a performance for the public, coveting the worldly debris in their hands. They display sciences, spiritual knowledge and words of wisdom, twisting their tongues around them, while their hearts are empty of their meaning. Their outward appearance suggests that these things correspond to their hearts and that they act upon them, but their inward state gives them the lie. “God guides whom He wills to a straight path.”

God Most High then refuted the misconception of the Jews and Christians concerning the worship of Jesus, Ezra and others, saying:

3:79–80 · God-centred teachers; veneration, spiritual training and the limits of mediation

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 373–374

ما كانَ لِبَشَرٍ أَنْ يُؤْتِيَهُ اللَّهُ الْكِتابَ وَالْحُكْمَ وَالنُّبُوَّةَ ثُمَّ يَقُولَ لِلنَّاسِ كُونُوا عِباداً لِي مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ وَلكِنْ كُونُوا رَبَّانِيِّينَ بِما كُنْتُمْ تُعَلِّمُونَ الْكِتابَ وَبِما كُنْتُمْ تَدْرُسُونَ (79) وَلا يَأْمُرُكُمْ أَنْ تَتَّخِذُوا الْمَلائِكَةَ وَالنَّبِيِّينَ أَرْباباً أَيَأْمُرُكُمْ بِالْكُفْرِ بَعْدَ إِذْ أَنْتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ (80)

79. It is not for a human being to whom God gives scripture, judgment and prophethood then to say to people, “Be servants of me apart from God.” Rather, [he says,] “Be God-centred teachers, through your teaching of the scripture and through your study of it.” 80. Nor does he command you to take angels and prophets as lords. Would he command you to disbelieve after you have submitted to God?

Language · Bashar, rabbānī and the readings of “he commands you”

I say: bashar (البشر) is a collective expression (اسم جمع) with no singular form of its own; it is applied to a group and to an individual. A rabbānī is someone who nurtures people, trains their conduct and refines them through knowledge and action. Ibn ʿAbbās said: “He is one who nurtures people through the elementary matters of knowledge before its major ones.” The nūn in it conveys intensification, as in liḥyānī and raqabānī. [T62]

With the indicative (الرفع), “nor does he command you” (ولا يأمركم) begins a new statement (استئناف). With the subjunctive (النصب), it is coordinated with “say” (يقول), and lā is additional (مزيدة): it is not for a human being whom God makes a prophet then to command worship of himself and command the taking of angels as lords. Alternatively, lā is not additional, and the reconstructed sense is: he may neither command worship of himself nor the taking of angels as lords.

Outward commentary · Teaching that directs worship to God rather than the teacher

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: it would not be fitting for “a human being to whom God gives scripture, judgment”—adjudication between His servants—“and prophethood”—revelation of ordinances—“then to say to people: ‘Be servants of me apart from God,’” or alongside God, or to consent to being worshipped apart from God. Rather, he tells them: “Be God-centred teachers (ربّانيين)”: knowers of God, discerning in His religion and forbearing towards people, nurturing them through knowledge, action, spiritual aspiration (الهمّة) and spiritual state (الحال), by virtue of what you know of God’s scripture and what you study of it; or by virtue of the good you teach people through God’s scripture and what you rehearse to them. When Ibn ʿAbbās, God be pleased with him and his father, died, Muḥammad ibn al-Ḥanafiyya said: “The rabbānī of this community has died.” T63

“Nor does he command you”—that human being whom God has specially favoured with prophethood—“to take angels and prophets as lords” apart from God. “Would he command you to disbelieve after you have submitted to God,” that is, yielded to His ordinances?

One account gives this occasion for the verse’s revelation: the Christians of Najrān said, “Muḥammad, do you want us to worship you and take you as a lord?” The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, answered: “God forbid that we worship anyone other than God, or command the worship of another.” Another says that a man asked: “Messenger of God, we greet you as we greet one another; should we not prostrate ourselves before you?” He answered: “No one should prostrate himself before anyone apart from God. Rather, honour your prophet and acknowledge the due of those to whom it belongs.”

Spiritual allusion · Honouring the guide without making the intermediary the goal

The spiritually poor have always venerated their shaykhs, going so far as to kiss their feet and the ground before them, and exerting themselves in their service. When the shaykhs see them doing so, they do not forbid them, because this is the disciples' gain and a cause of their spiritual opening (الفتح). Of this someone has said: T64 147

> Through the slaughter of the lower selves and the lowering of heads,
> the cups are made clear.

Yet the shaykhs guide them to the Presence (الحضرة), until they efface them from witnessing the intermediary (الواسطة). Their veneration and lowering of their heads are then for God, not another. At that point they become rabbānīs: knowers of God, brought near. Our shaykh used to say: "Do not visit me on the basis that I am your shaykh. Rather, recognize [God] in us and be effaced from seeing our sensible appearance, so that the veneration is for God, our Lord." End of the quotation. T65

Thus, when shaykhs direct the spiritually poor to veneration and right conduct (الأدب), they do not intend this for their own persons—far be it from them! It is not for a human being whom God gives special spiritual distinction then to tell people, "Be servants of me apart from God." Rather, he tells them: "Be rabbānīs, knowers of God," so that your veneration is for God alone. Nor does he command separation (الفرق), so that they take things as lords apart from God. Rather, he commands gathering in unity (الجمع), so that they become absent from all that is other than God. How could he command separation when he is pointing them to gathering? Would he command them to disbelieve after they had submitted? And God Most High knows best.

He then mentioned the covenant taken from the prophets and their communities to believe in the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, saying:

147. Cairo editor, C374.1: This is conditional—as the shaykh has repeatedly explained—on remaining within the limits of the noble Sacred Law.

3:81–82 · The prophetic covenant and the inseparability of Law and Reality

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 374–375

وَإِذْ أَخَذَ اللَّهُ مِيثاقَ النَّبِيِّينَ لَما آتَيْتُكُمْ مِنْ كِتابٍ وَحِكْمَةٍ ثُمَّ جاءَكُمْ رَسُولٌ مُصَدِّقٌ لِما مَعَكُمْ لَتُؤْمِنُنَّ بِهِ وَلَتَنْصُرُنَّهُ قالَ أَأَقْرَرْتُمْ وَأَخَذْتُمْ عَلى ذلِكُمْ إِصْرِي قالُوا أَقْرَرْنا قالَ فَاشْهَدُوا وَأَنَا مَعَكُمْ مِنَ الشَّاهِدِينَ (81) فَمَنْ تَوَلَّى بَعْدَ ذلِكَ فَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الْفاسِقُونَ (82)

81. When God took the covenant of the prophets: “Whatever scripture and wisdom I give you, then a messenger comes to you confirming what is with you, you shall surely believe in him and support him.” He said: “Do you acknowledge this and accept My binding covenant upon it?” They said: “We acknowledge it.” He said: “Then bear witness; I am with you among the witnesses.” 82. Whoever turns away after that—it is they who are the transgressors.

Language · Oath, condition and the binding covenant

I say: the lām in la-mā (لما) prepares for an oath (موطئة للقسم), since taking the covenant has the force of exacting an oath (الاستحلاف). Mā may be conditional (شرطية); “you shall surely believe” (لتؤمنن) is the response to the oath (جواب القسم), also taking the place of the response to the condition. Thus: whatever scripture and wisdom We give you, then a messenger of God comes to you, you shall surely believe in him. [T66]

Mā may instead be relative (موصولية), with “you shall surely believe” as its predicate (خبر). A condition indicated by the context has been omitted: with respect to the scripture and wisdom I have given you, then, if a messenger comes confirming what you have, you shall surely believe in him. In the reading with a kasra on the lām, the phrase supplies the reason for the command to believe in the messenger: because of what I have specially granted you, when a messenger comes confirming what you have, you shall

surely believe in him. If God took the covenant from the prophets, it applies all the more to their followers; alternatively, mentioning the prophets suffices instead of mentioning their followers, since they fall under the same ruling.

Outward commentary · Acknowledgment, support and mutual witness

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: remember when We took the covenant from the prophets, from Adam to Jesus, peace be upon them. We told them: by God, with respect to the scripture and wisdom with which I have specially favoured you, should a messenger appear "confirming what is with you, you shall surely believe in him and support him"—you and your communities. Alternatively: because of the favour already described, should you encounter Muḥammad, you shall surely believe in him and support him.

Our master ʿAlī, God ennoble his face, said: "God sent no prophet, Adam or any after him, without taking his pledge concerning Muḥammad and commanding him to take his people's pledge that they would believe in him, and that, should he be sent while they were alive, they would support him."

The Real, exalted is His majesty, said to those from whom He took the pledge: "Do you acknowledge" and accept it, "and accept My binding covenant (إصري) upon it"—My pledge and covenant? "They said: 'We acknowledge'" and accept. He said: "Then bear witness" against yourselves, or let each bear witness to the others' acknowledgment; or, bear witness against them, My angels. "I am with you among the witnesses." This contains emphatic confirmation and a mighty warning. "Whoever turns away after" that acknowledgment and witnessing, refusing belief in him and support for him after his appearance, "it is they who are the transgressors": departing from faith and rebelliously persisting in unbelief.

Spiritual allusion · The religious Law as body and Reality as spirit

Just as God took the pledge from the prophets and their communities to believe in him, blessings and peace be upon him, He took a covenant from the scholars and their ordinary followers: should they encounter one of God's friends bearing the banner of Reality (الحقيقة), confirming the religious Law (الشريعة) they possess, they must believe in him and support him. Those who

turn away and refuse to yield to them are the transgressors, outside the circle of friendship with God (الولاية) and deprived of antecedent divine care (سابق العناية).

Reality is the very kernel and distillation of the Law. Their relation is that of spirit to body: the Law is like the body, Reality like the spirit. Law without Reality is a body without spirit; Reality without Law is a spirit without body. Neither can stand without the other. Whoever adheres to the Law without realizing Reality falls into transgression; whoever realizes Reality without adhering to the Law falls into heresy; whoever brings both together attains realization. Whoever departs from both has departed from God's religion and sought another. To him is directed the reproach in His words:

3:83 · Willing and unwilling submission; outward obedience and inward acceptance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 375–376

أَفَغَيْرَ دِينِ اللَّهِ يَبْغُونَ وَلَهُ أَسْلَمَ مَنْ فِي السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ طَوْعاً وَكَرْهاً وَإِلَيْهِ يُرْجَعُونَ (83)

83. Do they seek a religion other than God's, when to Him has submitted whoever is in the heavens and the earth, willingly or unwillingly, and to Him they will be returned?

Language · The fronted object and the circumstantial expressions

I say: "other than" (أفغير) is a fronted object (مفعول مقدّم). "They seek" (يبغون) is coordinated with an omitted expression: do you turn away and so seek a religion other than God's? The governed expression (المعمول) is placed first because it is the target of the reproach. "Willingly and unwillingly" (طوعاً وكرهاً) are two circumstantial expressions (حالان): being willing or unwilling.

Outward commentary · No creature stands outside God's rule

The Real, exalted is His majesty, addresses the Christians and Jews when they brought their dispute to the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, each claiming to follow Abraham's religion. He told them: "You are both disassociated from his religion; I follow his religion, so take hold of it." They grew angry and said: "By God, we will neither accept your judgment nor adopt your religion." The Real, exalted is His majesty, rebukes them: do you seek a religion other than God's, which He approved for His intimate friend and His beloved, when whoever is in the heavens and the earth has yielded to Him, willingly or under compulsion?

The inhabitants of the heavens yield willingly. Of the inhabitants of the earth, some yield willingly through reflection and following proof, or by another means; others yield unwillingly, or through witnessing what compels submission, such as the raising of the mountain, being overtaken by drown-

ing, or approaching death. Alternatively, “willingly” describes the angels and believers, who willingly submit to what is required of them; “unwillingly” describes the unbelievers, who unwillingly submit to what is willed concerning them. All return to Him: none stands outside the circle of His judgment. Alternatively, they return to Him through resurrection and the raising of the dead. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The two forms of yielding and the physician of the heart

Know that true religion is yielding to God outwardly and inwardly. Outward yielding consists in fulfilling His commands and avoiding His prohibitions. Inward yielding consists in contentment with His judgment (الرضا بحكمه) and surrender to His overpowering might (الاستسلام لقهره).

Whoever falls short in outward obedience or inwardly resents the majestic decrees (الأحكام الجلالية) has fallen short of the perfection of religion. He is asked: do you seek a religion other than God’s, when whoever is in the heavens and earth has yielded to Him, willingly or unwillingly? Either yield willingly or return to Him unwillingly. In certain transmitted reports, God—blessed and exalted—says: “Whoever is not content with My decree and does not patiently bear My trial, let him leave the shelter of My heaven and take a lord other than Me.” [T67]

The reason the heart chafes at the descent of overpowering decrees is its sickness and the weakness of the light of its certainty (اليقين). Whoever disdains the physician’s companionship has a share in this reproach. God’s friends are His proof against the scholars; the scholars are His proof against ordinary people. Whoever’s outward conduct is not upright is reproached for neglecting the companionship of the scholars. Whoever’s inward state is not upright is reproached by God Most High for abandoning the companionship of the friends of God—that is, the knowers of Him. Success comes through God, and He guides to the even way.

The Real Most High then explained the reality of faith and submission that all people must follow, saying:

3:84 · Faith in all the prophets and respect for the friends of God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 376–377

قُلْ آمَنَّا بِاللَّهِ وَما أُنْزِلَ عَلَيْنا وَما أُنْزِلَ عَلى إِبْراهِيمَ وَإِسْماعِيلَ وَإِسْحاقَ وَيَعْقُوبَ وَالْأَسْباطِ وَما أُوتِيَ مُوسى وَعِيسى وَالنَّبِيُّونَ مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ لاَ نُفَرِّقُ بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِنْهُمْ وَنَحْنُ لَهُ مُسْلِمُونَ (84)

84. Say: “We believe in God, in what has been sent down upon us, in what was sent down upon Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob and the Tribes, and in what Moses, Jesus and the prophets were given from their Lord. We make no distinction between any of them, and to Him we submit.”

Language · Revelation “upon” and “to” its recipients

I say: unzila (أُنزل), “was sent down,” takes ilā because revelation reaches the messengers, and takes ʿalā because it comes from above, with the sense of being over them. Some distinguish the use of ʿalā here from ilā in al-Baqara [2:136]: here the address is specifically to the Messenger, and revelation was sent down upon him directly; there the address is to the Muslims, and revelation was directed to them through an intermediary, not sent down directly upon them. And God Most High knows best.

Outward commentary · Acknowledging revelation without selective rejection

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Say,” Muḥammad, to the People of the Book who distinguish between messengers in their belief: as for us, we believe in what was sent down upon us and in what was sent down upon all the prophets and messengers. “We make no distinction between any of them,” as you have distinguished and so gone astray. “To Him we submit”: yield to His outward and inward ordinances; or, devote all our actions sincerely to Him. What was sent down upon us is placed before what was sent

down upon others because it is the criterion by which the latter is measured and the means by which it is made known. And God Most High knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Veneration without denigrating other saints

The spiritually poor person should greatly venerate his shaykh. He may go far in esteeming him, so long as he does not raise him beyond the human condition or thereby violate the honour of other friends of God through disparagement or anything else. The inviolability of the friends of God is like that of the prophets: whoever discriminates between them is deprived of the blessing of them all. Success comes through God.

The Islamic religious way brought by our Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is the one that has secured this sound belief. Whoever departs from it has strayed from manifest truth, as the Real Most High indicates, saying:

3:85–86 · Turning from recognized truth and the corruption of the primordial disposition

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 377–378

وَمَنْ يَبْتَغِ غَيْرَ الْإِسْلامِ دِيناً فَلَنْ يُقْبَلَ مِنْهُ وَهُوَ فِي الْآخِرَةِ مِنَ الْخاسِرِينَ (85) كَيْفَ يَهْدِي اللَّهُ قَوْماً كَفَرُوا بَعْدَ إِيمانِهِمْ وَشَهِدُوا أَنَّ الرَّسُولَ حَقٌّ وَجاءَهُمُ الْبَيِّناتُ وَاللَّهُ لا يَهْدِي الْقَوْمَ الظَّالِمِينَ (86)

85. Whoever seeks a religion other than submission to God—it will not be accepted from him, and in the Hereafter he will be among the losers. 86. How shall God guide a people who disbelieved after their belief, after bearing witness that the Messenger is true, and after the clear proofs came to them? God does not guide the wrongdoing people.

Language · Coordination with the verbal meaning of a noun

I say: “and they bore witness” (وشهدوا) is coordinated with the verbal meaning contained in “their belief” (إيمانهم). The reconstructed sense is: after they believed and bore witness.

Theology · Rejecting proof after acknowledging it

The Real, exalted is His majesty, addresses some men of the Helpers who renounced Islam and went to Mecca, including al-Ḥārith ibn Suwayd al-Anṣārī: whoever seeks “a religion other than Islam” to profess will never have it accepted from him; “in the Hereafter he will be among the losers.” He has nullified the sound primordial disposition (الفطرة السليمة) upon which people were created, exchanging it for corrupt imitation (التقليد الرديء), after beholding the blazing proofs and inwardly bearing witness to the truth and its clarity.

Thus the question expresses astonishment at, and the remoteness of, his being guided: “How shall God guide a people who disbelieved” after believing, “bore witness that the Messenger is true, and received the clear proofs”—the manifest miracles? One who turns from truth after it becomes clear is immersed in error and far from right guidance. He has wronged and diminished his own soul. “God does not guide the wrongdoing people,” who wrong themselves by defective reflection and put unbelief in the place of faith. Perhaps this concerns a particular people whose wretchedness was already decreed.

He then mentioned their recompense, saying:

3:87–88 · The consequence of rejection and the opening towards repentance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 378–378

أُولئِكَ جَزاؤُهُمْ أَنَّ عَلَيْهِمْ لَعْنَةَ اللَّهِ وَالْمَلائِكَةِ وَالنَّاسِ أَجْمَعِينَ (87)

خالِدِينَ فِيها لا يُخَفَّفُ عَنْهُمُ الْعَذابُ وَلا هُمْ يُنْظَرُونَ (88)

87. Their recompense is that upon them rests the curse of God, the angels and all people, 88. abiding therein. Their punishment will not be lightened, nor will they be granted respite.

Outward commentary · The referent of “abiding therein”

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Their”—those who have renounced Islam—“recompense” is that the angels and all people curse them, believers and unbelievers alike. For the unbeliever curses whoever abandons the true religion, even if he does not recognize who actually follows the truth. They abide in the curse; or in the Fire, which the context indicates; or in the punishment. Their punishment is not lightened for an hour, nor are they given a moment’s respite from it.

Then al-Ḥārith regretted what he had done and sent to his people, asking them to ask the Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him, whether repentance was open to him. Thereupon the following words of God Most High were revealed:

3:89 · Repentance, spiritual lineage and the return to companionship

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 378–378

إِلاَّ الَّذِينَ تابُوا مِنْ بَعْدِ ذلِكَ وَأَصْلَحُوا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (89)

89. Except those who repent after that and set things right: God is forgiving, merciful.

Outward commentary · Repentance joined to repair

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: except one who repents after renunciation, submits to God and repairs what he has corrupted. God forgives what he has done and has mercy upon him when he repents.

When the verse was revealed, a man from al-Ḥārith's people carried it to him and recited it. Al-Ḥārith said: "By God, I have known you to speak truth. The Prophet is more truthful than you, and God Most High is the most truthful of the three." Al-Ḥārith returned to Medina, embraced Islam and became a good Muslim.

Spiritual allusion · The source of spiritual distinction and the possibility of returning

Whoever seeks special spiritual distinction (الخصوصية) from those who do not possess it, or claims it without receiving it from its source, will not have it accepted from him. Among the Folk he is one of the losers in the special path. Whoever has no shaykh in this matter is a foundling without a father, a pretender without a lineage. [T68]

Those who possess it are the knowers of God: the people of effacement and subsistence (الفناء والبقاء), attraction and wayfaring (الجذب والسلوك), intoxication and sobriety (السكر والصحو), who drank the wine and became intoxicated, then returned to sobriety and attained completion. With them is the source of special spiritual distinction. Whoever has not accompanied them or drunk of their wine is not to be taken as a guide, however far his extraordinary gifts (الكرامات) extend.

Still more bereft is one who accompanied the people of this wine, bore witness that their path is true, and then turned back from it. He has suffered loss and is accursed among all creatures—that is, driven away from witnessing the Real—except one who repents and returns to their companionship and to right conduct with them. God is forgiving, merciful.

The Real Most High then mentioned one who renounced belief and remained in unbelief until death, saying:

3:90 · Persistence in rejection, repentance and the danger of spiritual relapse

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 378–379

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا بَعْدَ إِيمانِهِمْ ثُمَّ ازْدادُوا كُفْراً لَنْ تُقْبَلَ تَوْبَتُهُمْ وَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الضَّالُّونَ (90)

90. Those who disbelieve after having believed, and then increase in unbelief—their repentance will not be accepted. Those are the ones who have gone astray.

Outward commentary · Several explanations of repentance that is not accepted

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: those who turn back from faith and then increase in unbelief, saying, “We shall wait for the turns of fortune to overtake Muḥammad”—“their repentance will not be accepted.” That is, they will have no repentance that could be accepted, because wretchedness has already been decreed for them; or because they repent only when the death-rattle comes; or their repentance will not be accepted for as long as they remain in their unbelief. “Those are the ones who have gone astray”: those who have plunged deeply into error.

It is said that this was revealed concerning the companions of al-Ḥārith ibn Suwayd mentioned above. They were eleven men. When al-Ḥārith returned, they said: “We shall remain in Mecca in unbelief for as long as it suits us; whenever we wish to return, we shall return.” When the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, conquered Mecca, some of them entered Islam and their repentance was accepted, while the others remained in unbelief. The verse was revealed concerning those who remained.

It is also said that it was revealed concerning the Jews: they disbelieved in Jesus after believing in their prophets, then increased in unbelief by disbelieving in Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him. Or concerning the Christians: they disbelieved in Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, after believing in Jesus, then increased in unbelief by persisting in it.

Or concerning both groups together: they disbelieved in our Prophet Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, after believing in him before his appearance, then increased in unbelief by obstinately rejecting him and persisting in acts of disobedience. And God Most High knows best. [T69]

Spiritual allusion · Returning before an acquired habit becomes entrenched

Know that someone may enter the path of spiritual training (التربية) and begin to discipline his soul and cleanse it of faults and the stains of sensible attachment (الحس), but then overpowering might (القهرية) prevails over him and he turns back from it. If he repents promptly and returns to the path, returning will be easy for him; his success may be hoped for, and his repentance will be accepted. But if he persists in abandoning it until his soul has grown accustomed to idleness, his repentance can no longer be hoped for, and he becomes one of those who have gone astray.

He resembles a vessel from which you have poured out milk or honey and which you have filled with tar. If you promptly pour out the tar, the vessel is easy to wash. But if you leave it until it has stained the vessel, washing it becomes difficult and removing its smell becomes impracticable.

"If he dies having turned back, he will not be gathered in the Hereafter with the people of this companionship, even if a thousand knowers intercede for him. Rather, the consummation of the hidden divine ruse (المكر) against him is that his likeness should be cast upon another in the Hereafter, so that those among the people of gnosis who knew him suppose that the other is he. Thus it does not occur to [the knower] to intercede for him." So said al-Qushayrī.

The glossator says: "What he mentions perhaps has in view the Friend's encounter with his father, when he meets him covered in darkness and desires to intercede for him. His father is transformed into a filth-smeared *dhīkh* (ذيخ)—that is, a pig—and he no longer recognizes him, as in the authentic report. So remember and take heed." End of quotation. [Translator's

note: The gloss “a pig” is the quoted glossator’s; the Cairo editor defines *dhīkh* here as “a male hyena” (I:379, n. 1).] [T70] Success is through God, and He is the guide to the even path. [148]

He then mentioned one who dies in unbelief, saying:

3:91 · The ransom that cannot avail and the lost rank of nearness

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 379–380

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَماتُوا وَهُمْ كُفَّارٌ فَلَنْ يُقْبَلَ مِنْ أَحَدِهِمْ مِلْءُ الْأَرْضِ ذَهَباً وَلَوِ افْتَدى بِهِ أُولئِكَ لَهُمْ عَذابٌ أَلِيمٌ وَما لَهُمْ مِنْ ناصِرِينَ (91)

91. Those who disbelieve and die as unbelievers—an earthful of gold will not be accepted from any one of them, even if he offers it as a ransom. For them is a painful punishment, and they will have no helpers.

Language · Specification and an understood ransom

I say: “gold” (ذهباً) is an accusative of specification (تمييز). “Even if he offers it as a ransom” is construed according to the sense, as though it had been said: “No ransom will be accepted from any one of them, even if he ransoms himself with an earthful of gold.” Alternatively, the clause is co-ordinated with something omitted: “An earthful of gold will not be accepted from any one of them, whether he offered it to draw near [to God] in this world or offered it as a ransom from punishment in the Hereafter.” So said al-Bayḍāwī.

Outward commentary · No purchase of release after death

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: those who disbelieve and persist in their unbelief until they die will have no ransom accepted from them, even if they ransom themselves with an earthful of gold. Rather, despair of God’s

148. Cairo editor, C379.1: Dhīkh—with kasra on dhāl followed by an unvocalized yāʾ—means a male hyena. Its plurals are adhyākh, dhuyūkh and dhīkha. “Smeared” means smeared with its excrement or with mud.

mercy overtakes them. For them is a painful punishment: neither ransom, intercession nor an intimate friend will avail them against it. They have no helpers to defend them against the punishment of the Lord of the worlds.

The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: “The unbeliever will be brought on the Day of Resurrection and asked: ‘Tell Me: had you possessed an earthful of gold, would you have offered it as a ransom?’ He will answer: ‘Yes, yes.’ He will be told: ‘You were asked for something easier than that.’” He means: “There is no god but God.” May God make us steadfast in this word until death, knowing its meaning. Amen. T71

Spiritual allusion · Salvation distinguished from the station of the near ones

Whoever denies the path of those possessed of special spiritual distinction (أهل الخصوصية), deprives himself of entry into the Holy Presence (الحضرة القدوسية), and persists in that denial until death will undoubtedly feel regret after his footing has slipped. For he has died persisting in grave sins without realizing it. When he is gathered with ordinary Muslims and dwells in the outskirts of Paradise with the people of the right hand, then sees the dwellings of those brought near in the highest ʿIlliyyūn, he regrets and grieves; but the decree has prevailed over him. 149

Were he to purchase a station among them with an earthful of gold, it would not avail him. He remains there in the grief of the veil and the pain of separation, cut off from witnessing the beloved ones in unveiling and clarity (الكشف والبيان), deprived of witnessing and direct vision (الشهود والعيان). And success is through God. T72

After the Real Most High had ruled that ransom would not avail on the Day of Resurrection, He mentioned the best thing by which the servant may ransom himself in the abode of this world, where such a ransom does avail. He said:

149. Cairo editor, C380.1: This refers to their failure to attain the stations of those brought near, although admission to Paradise itself is triumph and success. God, exalted is He, says: “Whoever is kept away from the Fire and admitted to Paradise has succeeded ….”

3:92 · Spending what one loves: property, service and the gift of oneself

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 380–382

لَنْ تَنالُوا الْبِرَّ حَتَّى تُنْفِقُوا مِمَّا تُحِبُّونَ وَما تُنْفِقُوا مِنْ شَيْءٍ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ بِهِ عَلِيمٌ (92)

92. You will not attain righteousness until you spend of what you love. Whatever you spend, God knows it.

Language · The meaning of birr

I say: righteousness (البرّ) is the perfection of obedience.

Outward commentary · Wealth, influence, bodily service and life itself

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: you will not attain perfection in obedience and drawing near until you spend of what you love. Or: you will not attain God's goodness (برّ الله), namely His approval and good pleasure (الرضى والرضوان), until you spend some of what you love, whether wealth or something else. This includes giving the benefit of one's influence to help people, provided it is accompanied by sincerity (الإخلاص); giving one's bodily effort in obedience to God; and giving one's very life in God's path.

When the verse was revealed,

Abū Ṭalḥa came and said: "Messenger of God, the property dearest to me is Bayruḥā'"—a garden behind the Prophet's mosque—"and it is a charitable gift for God. I hope for its goodness and its stored reward." He, blessings and peace be upon him, replied: "Excellent, excellent! That is a profitable property"—*rābiḥ* (رابح), or *rā'iḥ* (رائح), literally "going forth," in the other wording—"and I consider that you should give it to your near relatives." Abū Ṭalḥa therefore divided it among his relatives. [T73]

Zayd ibn Ḥāritha brought a horse that he loved and said: “This is for God’s path.” The Messenger of God, blessings and peace be upon him, gave it to Zayd’s son Usāma to ride. Zayd said: “I only intended to give it in charity.” He, blessings and peace be upon him, replied: “God Most High has accepted it.” This indicates that charity to relatives is preferable.

A woman freed an enslaved woman whom she loved and who was her only possession, on condition that she should remain with her. Once freed, the woman departed. He, blessings and peace be upon him, said: “Let her go: she has screened you from the Fire.”

ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb ordered that an enslaved woman from among the captives of Iraq be purchased. When she was brought to him and he saw her, he found her exceedingly pleasing. He said: “God Most High says: ‘You will not attain righteousness until you spend of what you love,’” and he freed her.

Ibn ʿUmar recalled this verse and found nothing he possessed dearer to him than an enslaved woman with whom he had sexual relations. He freed her and said: “Were it not that I do not take back anything I have given for God, I would marry her.” Whenever a beggar stood at al-Rabīʿ’s door, he would give him sugar. When questioned about this, he said: “Al-Rabīʿ loves sugar.” T74

God Most High nevertheless accepts charity whether it consists of something loved or something else. Hence He says: “Whatever you spend, God knows it,” and He recompenses you accordingly.

Spiritual allusion · The self as the dearest gift

The spiritual wayfarer (الفقير) possesses nothing dearer to him than the self within him; indeed, this is true of all people. Whoever gives his spirit in seeking God’s pleasure attains God’s good pleasure and knowledge of Him, which is the utmost righteousness. Whoever humbles his self for God is ennobled by God; whoever makes his self poor for God is enriched by God; and whoever humbles himself before God is raised by Him.

Giving the self to God means presenting it to a shaykh of spiritual training (شيخ التربية), who does with it what he wills. Whatever he directs the disciple to do, the disciple hastens to do without hesitation. Whoever does this has attained the utmost righteousness and spent the dearest thing he loves.

Whoever gives his self will all the more readily give everything else, for nothing is dearer than it. [T75] Concerning this, Ibn al-Fāriḍ, may God be pleased with him, says:

> I have nothing but my spirit; one who gives himself
> for love of his beloved is no squanderer.
> If you are pleased with it, you have granted my desire;
> how fruitless the striving if you do not grant it! [150]

Shaykh Abū ʿAbd Allāh al-Qurashī said: "The reality of love is to give your entire being to the one you love, until nothing of you remains for you." End of quotation.

Al-Junayd, may God be pleased with him, said: "You will not attain the love of God until you give yourselves generously to God." End of quotation.

When he, blessings and peace be upon him, told the Jews, "I follow the religious way of Abraham," as stated above, they said: "How can you follow the way of Abraham when you consume camels' flesh and milk, although these were forbidden to Abraham?" Thereupon God Most High revealed:

3:93–95 · Israel's food prohibition, Abraham's religious way and the discipline of desire

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 382–383

كُلُّ الطَّعامِ كانَ حِلاًّ لِبَنِي إِسْرائِيلَ إِلاَّ ما حَرَّمَ إِسْرائِيلُ عَلى نَفْسِهِ مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ تُنَزَّلَ التَّوْراةُ قُلْ فَأْتُوا بِالتَّوْراةِ فَاتْلُوها إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صادِقِينَ (93) فَمَنِ افْتَرى عَلَى اللَّهِ الْكَذِبَ مِنْ بَعْدِ ذلِكَ فَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الظَّالِمُونَ (94) قُلْ صَدَقَ اللَّهُ فَاتَّبِعُوا مِلَّةَ إِبْراهِيمَ حَنِيفاً وَما كانَ مِنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ (95)

150. Cairo editor, C381.1: In the original: "his spirit" [rūḥahu, in place of "himself"].

93. All food was lawful to the Children of Israel, except what Israel forbade himself before the Torah was sent down. Say: "Bring the Torah and recite it, if you are truthful." 94. Whoever, after that, fabricates a lie against God—it is they who are the wrongdoers. 95. Say: "God has spoken the truth; so follow the religious way of Abraham, inclining to the truth. He was not one of those who associate others with God."

Language · Israel is Jacob

I say: "Israel" (إسرائيل) is Jacob, peace be upon him.

Outward commentary · A personal abstention is not an original universal prohibition

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "All food was lawful to the Children of Israel," just as it was lawful to all the prophets, "except what Israel"—that is, Jacob—"forbade himself," such as camel meat and its milk. It is said that he suffered from sciatica (عرق النسا) and vowed that, if God healed him, he would no longer eat the food he loved most; camel meat and milk were dearest to him. It is also said that he abstained from them as a treatment at the physicians' direction. His children continued to abstain, although those foods were not forbidden to them in the Torah: this was something they had forbidden themselves. T76 151

Thus all kinds of food had been lawful to the Children of Israel, as to all prophets, before the Torah was sent down. When the Torah came down, God prohibited certain good things to them because of their wrongdoing and oppression. If, therefore, they claim that camel meat was forbidden to Abraham, and that everything later forbidden to them had already been forbidden to Abraham and the prophets before him, say to them: "You have lied. Bring the Torah and recite it." Do you find such a prohibition there? Do so "if you are truthful" in claiming that everything forbidden to you was also forbidden to Abraham.

It is related that when the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, challenged them in this way they were confounded and dared not produce the Torah, whereupon their fabrication against God became manifest. "Who-

151. Cairo editor, C382.1: The nasā is the sciatic nerve: a nerve extending from the hip to the ankle, which is affected by this ailment.

ever fabricates a lie against God" by alleging that God had forbidden camel meat and milk before the Torah was sent down, "after that"—after this explanation and the argument that has been brought home to them—"it is they who are the wrongdoers," stubbornly maintaining falsehood after the truth has become clear. [T77]

Say to them, O Muḥammad: "God has spoken the truth" in what He has revealed, and you have lied in what you have asserted. It has thus become clear that Abraham's religious way (ملة إبراهيم) is the submission (الإسلام) brought by Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him. Submit, then, and follow "the religious way of Abraham, inclining to the truth (حنيفاً)." The religious way of Islam agrees with Abraham's way—or is that way itself. Enter it, and be rid of the Judaism which has led you into alteration and obstinate contention and has obliged you to prohibit good things God made lawful to Abraham and those who followed him. You have departed from the very Torah to which you profess adherence and associated Ezra and others with God, whereas Abraham was one who inclined to the truth, submitted to God, "and was not one of those who associate others with God."

Al-Bayḍāwī says: In this is an indication that following Abraham is obligatory in pure affirmation of divine unity (التوحيد الصرف), uprightness in religion, and avoidance of excess and deficiency; it also contains an indirect censure of Jewish associationism. End of quotation.

Spiritual allusion · Permission, watchfulness and the differing states of the wayfarer and the knower

When the spiritual poor one (الفقير) has attained sincerity (الإخلاص) and realized the particular affirmation of unity (التوحيد الخاص), all food becomes lawful to him, because he receives it through God, takes it from the hand of God, and expends it for God, while remaining in conformity with the revealed Law (الشريعة). His lights of the spiritual path (الطريقة) are not diminished; greed and covetousness do not accompany him. ʿAbd Allāh ibn ʿUmar used to say: "Eat what you wish and wear what you wish, so long as two things avoid you: extravagance (سرف) and vainglory (مخيلة)."

Worshippers and ascetics refrained from permissible enjoyments because they feared that their souls would carry them into pursuing the means of those enjoyments and so interrupt their worship. Likewise, beginners

travelling the path (المريدون السائرون) ought to take little of them, lest their hearts become attached to anything therein and thus be impeded in their journeying (السير). Those who have arrived and know God (الواصلون العارفون), however, have realized their effacement and subsistence (الفناء والبقاء); they take through God, from God's hand, as stated above.

In sum: so long as the soul has not submitted and yielded to the witnessing of its Lord (مشاهدة ربها), it must be struggled against and opposed. Once it has submitted and yielded to its Lord, reconciliation with it is required, and one must agree with it in what becomes manifest within it (فيما يتجلى فيها). And God Most High knows best. [T78]

Since the Jews did not perform pilgrimage to God's Sacred House, built by Abraham the Friend of God, despite claiming to follow his religious way, God refuted them by saying, "Truly the first House ..." It is also said that the Muslims and the Jews disputed which sanctuary was superior. The Jews said that Jerusalem was superior because it was a place to which prophets migrated; the Muslims said that the Kaʿba was superior because it was the first House placed upon the earth. God Most High revealed:

3:96–97 · Bakkah, the first House, the obligation of pilgrimage and the inner sanctuary

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 383–385

إِنَّ أَوَّلَ بَيْتٍ وُضِعَ لِلنَّاسِ لَلَّذِي بِبَكَّةَ مُبارَكاً وَهُدىً لِلْعالَمِينَ (96) فِيهِ آياتٌ بَيِّناتٌ مَقامُ إِبْراهِيمَ وَمَنْ دَخَلَهُ كانَ آمِناً وَلِلَّهِ عَلَى النَّاسِ حَجُّ الْبَيْتِ مَنِ اسْتَطاعَ إِلَيْهِ سَبِيلاً وَمَنْ كَفَرَ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ غَنِيٌّ عَنِ الْعالَمِينَ (97)

96. Truly the first House established for humankind was that at Bakkah, blessed and a guidance for the worlds. 97. In it are clear signs—the Station of Abraham. Whoever enters it is safe. Pilgrimage to the House is a duty owed to God by people who are able to find a way to it. As for whoever disbelieves, God is independent of all the worlds.

Language · Bakkah, the circumstantial accusative and the Station of Abraham

I say: "Bakkah" (بكة) is a dialectal form of "Makkah"; Arabs interchange bāʾ and mīm, as when they say ḍarba lāzim and lāzib for a decisive blow, or aghbaṭat ʿalayhi al-ḥummā and aghmaṭat, concerning a fever. It is also said that "Makkah," with mīm, names the whole town, whereas "Bakkah" names the location of the House. It was given that name because it "breaks" (تبك), that is, crushes, the necks of tyrants: no tyrant has intended it evil without God breaking him. [T79]

"Blessed" (مباركاً) is a circumstantial accusative (حال) referring to the pronoun in the prepositional expression, with the implied state of being established or located (الاستقرار) as its governor (العامل): that is, "the one situated in Bakkah, being blessed." "The Station of Abraham" (مقام إبراهيم) may be a subject (مبتدأ) whose predicate (خبر) is suppressed: "among them is the Station of Abraham." Or it may be a part-for-whole substitute (بدل البعض من الكل) for "signs" (آيات), or an explicative apposition (عطف بيان), if the signs intend the impression of his foot in the solid rock, its sinking into it as far as the ankles, the rock's being distinguished from other rocks by this property, the preservation of this impression rather than other prophets' traces, and its survival for thousands of years despite his many enemies. Thus the Station of Abraham, though singular, has the force of a plural. Supporting this is a variant reading with the singular "a sign" (آية). [T80]

It is also said that the "signs" are the Station of Abraham and the security of whoever enters. On this explanation, "whoever enters it" is coordinated with "the Station"; on the former interpretation it begins a new sentence (استئناف). "Pilgrimage to the House" (حج البيت) is a subject (مبتدأ), and "belongs to God" (لله) is its predicate (خبر). The vowel fatḥa [in ḥajj] is the idiom of the

Ḥijāz and kasra [ḥijj] the idiom of Najd. “Whoever is able” (من استطاع) is an appositional substitute (بدل) for “the people” (الناس); it is also said to be the subject/agent (فاعل). [T80]

Outward commentary · The Kaʿba, its signs and reported virtues

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Truly the first House” placed upon the earth “for humankind” was the one established at Makkah, followed by the House of Jerusalem, with forty years between them. The angels built the first facing the Inhabited House (البيت المعمور), and God commanded the inhabitants of earth to circumambulate it as the dwellers of heaven circumambulate the Inhabited House; then the second was built. It is also said that Adam built both, and that Abraham later renewed the first. It is “blessed,” because good deeds are multiplied there, each one by a hundred thousand; sins are expiated there, mercies descend, and spiritual gifts (النفحات) arrive in succession. [Translator’s note: These are explanations and reports transmitted by the commentator, not claims independently established here about construction chronology.] [T81]

“In it are clear signs,” conspicuous proofs, including the stone that is “the Station of Abraham,” upon which Abraham stood while he raised the foundations of the House. Whenever the building grew higher, the stone rose with him into the air until he completed the building, and his foot sank into it as though it were clay. Other signs are said to include birds not passing above it, the destruction of the People of the Elephant, the repelling of tyrants, the emergence of Zamzam for Hagar through Gabriel’s striking it, its later rediscovery by ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib after it had been obscured, and the benefit of its water for whatever purpose it is drunk. [T81]

“Whoever enters it is safe”: from punishment in the two abodes, through the Friend’s prayer, “My Lord, make this land secure” [14:35]. In the pre-Islamic period anyone who committed an offence and then took refuge there was neither attacked nor punished while within it. In Islam, however, the sacred precinct does not bar the prescribed penalties (الحدود) or retaliation (القصاص). Abū Ḥanīfa holds that the earlier rule remains: if someone liable

to a prescribed penalty or retaliation enters the sacred precinct, he is not attacked, but pressure is applied to him—he is not fed or sold provisions—until he goes out. T82 152

The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: “Whoever dies in one of the two sanctuaries will be raised among those who are safe.” He also said: “Whoever performs pilgrimage to this House and neither commits obscenity nor transgresses comes forth from his sins like the day his mother gave birth to him.” T83

“Pilgrimage to the House is a duty owed to God by people”: an individual obligation (فرض عين) upon “whoever is able to find a way to it,” meaning able to reach it with a healthy body, on foot or mounted, having the provisions needed to arrive there, and being secure in person, property and religion. Another explanation of ability (الاستطاعة) is provisions and a mount.

“Whoever” abandons it and “disbelieves” in it—such as Jews, Christians, and anyone who denies its obligation—“God has no need” of that person, his pilgrimage, or any of the worlds; or “disbelief” is used for abandoning it as an intensification, as in the saying: “Whoever abandons prayer has disbelieved.” It is related that when the opening of the verse came down, the Prophet assembled the religious communities and said, “God has prescribed the pilgrimage for you; so perform it.” One community believed him and five denied him; so “whoever disbelieves ...” was revealed. [Translator’s note: The report is cited as a report, without independent authentication.] T84

Spiritual allusion · The physical House and the heart as an inward sanctuary

God has established two houses for humankind. One is sensible (حسي), the Kaʿba; the other is intelligible or spiritual (معنوي), the heart, which is the House of the Lord (بيت الرب). As long as the house of the heart is empty of the Lord’s light, it longs to make pilgrimage to the sensible House. But when the house has been built up with the light of its Indweller, it becomes a direction of orientation (قبلة) for others and ceases to turn towards anything other than the light of its Lord. Rather, it becomes a Kaʿba around which spiritual visitations (الواردات) and lights make their circumambulations, surrounded by gnoses, sciences and secrets. Then it becomes a pole (قطب) of

152. Cairo editor, C384.1: That is, he is not fought.

the circle of existing things, around which they turn from every side and place. How could such a person long for the sensible Kaʿba when the circle of cosmic visitors revolves around him? T85 153

How splendidly al-Ḥallāj, may God be pleased with him, put it:

> O you who blame me, blame me not for love of Him; had you beheld what I beheld, you would not blame.
> Other people have a pilgrimage, and I a pilgrimage to my Beloved, in whom I find rest: they offer sacrifices, while I offer my life-blood and blood.
> People circumambulate the House without bodily limb: they circumambulate through God, who makes them free of need for the Sanctuary. 154

[Translator's note: The printed سكني (sakanī) is retained. "My Beloved, in whom I find rest" draws on the sense of sakan defined by Ibn Fāris as a beloved in whom one finds repose (Maqāyīs al-lugha, root s-k-n, III:88), also attested in Ibn Manẓūr's Lisān al-ʿArab. All three lines occur together in Ibn ʿArabī's Muḥāḍarat al-abrār (II:147, electronic texts inspected), following two other verses about the Beloved. Their order there is pilgrimage, circumambulation, then blame; the circumambulation verse reads "through love" (bi-l-ḥubb) where Cairo has "through God" (bi-llāh). That passage gives the poem without an attribution to al-Ḥallāj. It establishes an earlier literary parallel. Al-Shībī's *Sharḥ Dīwān al-Ḥallāj*, poem 48, pp. 487–488 (Jamal facsimile inspected), explicitly disputes the attribution: the cited *Taqyīd* introduction describes recitation from al-Ḥallāj, which does not establish composition. Al-Shībī assembles his seven-line text from several recensions; it is not a single continuous witness. The attribution here therefore remains Ibn ʿAjība's, with this critical disagreement disclosed. The word also permits an echo of a dwelling or resting place; no Arabic emendation is proposed.]

In this inward house are clear signs: the shining of the suns of gnosis and lights in the open heaven of spirits and secrets; the brightness of the moon of divine unity upon the earth of detachment and singleness (التجريد والتفريد); and the appearing of the stars of knowledge and wisdom in the horizon of

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153. Cairo editor, C385.1: The righteous in every age long for the honoured Kaʿba, for it is their direction of prayer. Those among them who are able perform pilgrimage to it. It is in the town where our master, God's Messenger—blessings and peace be upon him—was born. How, then, could they not long for it?!

154. Cairo editor, C385.2: Had God made anyone free of need for the Sacred Precinct, He would have done so for our master Muḥammad—blessings and peace be upon him.

exalted aspirations. This is the station of Abraham, the imam of those who affirm divine unity. Whoever enters it is secure from rejection and remoteness until the Day of Judgment. Whoever denies its existence—God is independent of all the worlds.

It is said in the marginal commentary concerning “Whoever enters it is safe”: the same may be said of whoever enters the heart of one of God’s friends (ولي): the heart of the knower (العارف) is a sanctuary of watchful awareness and witnessing (المراقبات والمشاهدات). End of citation. Through God is success, and He is the Guide to the even way.

The Real Most High then returned to reproaching the People of the Book, saying:

3:98–99 · Concealing the way of God and denying the presence of spiritual distinction

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 385–386

قُلْ يا أَهْلَ الْكِتابِ لِمَ تَكْفُرُونَ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ شَهِيدٌ عَلى ما تَعْمَلُونَ (98) قُلْ يا أَهْلَ الْكِتابِ لِمَ تَصُدُّونَ عَنْ سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ مَنْ آمَنَ تَبْغُونَها عِوَجاً وَأَنْتُمْ شُهَداءُ وَمَا اللَّهُ بِغافِلٍ عَمَّا تَعْمَلُونَ (99)

98. Say: “O People of the Book, why do you reject God’s signs when God is witness to what you do?” 99. Say: “O People of the Book, why do you turn those who believe away from God’s path, seeking to make it crooked, while you yourselves are witnesses? God is not heedless of what you do.”

Language · The circumstantial clause and two senses of crookedness

I say: “Seeking to make it crooked” (تَبْغُونَها) is a circumstantial clause (جملة حالية) describing the state of the subject represented by the plural wāw; that is, “Why do you obstruct the path while seeking crookedness for it?” The

noun ʿiwaj (عِوَج), with kasra, applies to religion, speech and action, while ʿawaj (عَوَج), with fatḥa, applies to a wall, boundary wall or other upright physical object.

Outward commentary · Open rejection and concealed obstruction

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: Say, O Muḥammad, in reproaching the Jews, “O People of the Book, why do you disbelieve in God’s signs”—the transmitted and rational signs (السمعية والعقلية) that show the truthfulness of His Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, in what he summons you to of Islam? “God is witness to what you do”: He knows its concealed and manifest aspects and will requite you for it. Your alterations and secrecy therefore cannot profit you.

“O People of the Book, why do you turn those who believe” in the signs and follow the messenger who brought them “away from God’s path, seeking to make it crooked?” That is, seeking to give the path a distortion: you confuse people and make them imagine that it deviates from the truth by claiming that the Torah cannot be abrogated (النسخ), by changing the Messenger’s description, or by stirring up discord among the Muslims so that their word becomes divided and their religious affairs disordered. And “you are witnesses” that this path is true and obstruction of it is error; or you are reputable upright witnesses (عُدول) in the eyes of your own community, who trust your testimony and summon you as witnesses in legal cases. “God is not heedless of what you do”: He must surely requite you for your deeds, for He grants respite but does not neglect.

The address and question are repeated twice to heighten rebuke, remove excuse and indicate that each offence is reprehensible in itself and independently attracts punishment. Since the action denounced in the first verse is their unbelief, which they openly declare, it closes with “God is witness to what you do.” Since the second denounces the obstruction of believers from Islam, which they concealed and contrived secretly, it concludes with “God is not heedless of what you do.” Al-Bayḍāwī explains it thus. [T86]

Spiritual allusion · Recognizing the special spiritual realization of one's contemporaries

Whoever denies the existence of special spiritual distinction (الخصوصية) among those who possess it, and obstructs seekers from entering it, undoubtedly merits this reproof. And God Most High knows best.

He then warned the believers against listening to them, saying:

3:100–102 · Communal discord, holding fast to God and the degrees of Godfearingness

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 386–388

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا إِنْ تُطِيعُوا فَرِيقاً مِنَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ يَرُدُّوكُمْ بَعْدَ إِيمانِكُمْ كافِرِينَ (100) وَكَيْفَ تَكْفُرُونَ وَأَنْتُمْ تُتْلى عَلَيْكُمْ آياتُ اللَّهِ وَفِيكُمْ رَسُولُهُ وَمَنْ يَعْتَصِمْ بِاللَّهِ فَقَدْ هُدِيَ إِلى صِراطٍ مُسْتَقِيمٍ (101) يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ حَقَّ تُقاتِهِ وَلا تَمُوتُنَّ إِلاَّ وَأَنْتُمْ مُسْلِمُونَ (102)

100. O you who believe, if you obey a group of those who were given the Book, they will turn you back into disbelievers after your faith. 101. How could you disbelieve while God's signs are recited to you and His Messenger is among you? Whoever holds fast to God has indeed been guided to a straight path. 102. O you who believe, be mindful of God as He is truly worthy of being regarded, and do not die except in submission to Him.

Outward commentary · An attempt to revive the feud between Aws and Khazraj

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "O you who believe." The address is general but those intended are a group of the Aws and Khazraj. "If you obey a group of those who were given the Book"—namely Shās ibn Qays the Jew. He was an elderly man deeply entrenched in unbelief and intensely resent-

ful of the Muslims. He passed some men of the Aws and Khazraj sitting together in conversation; there had formerly been enmity between the two clans during the pre-Islamic period (الجاهلية). Their affection and gathering angered him. He said: "The leading men of the Banū Qayla have gathered here; if they remain united we shall have no place among them." He commanded a Jewish youth to sit with them, remind them of the Day of Buʿāth —a battle between them before Islam—and recite some of the verses composed about it. The Aws had prevailed on that day. The youth did as instructed; they began to dispute and boast, then became angry and shouted, "To arms! To arms!" Many from both clans assembled.

The Messenger of God, blessings and peace be upon him, went out to them with his companions and said: "Do you call with the call of the Age of Ignorance while I am here among you, after God has honoured you with Islam, cut off from you the affair of ignorance, and brought you together?" They recognized it as an incitement from Satan and a stratagem of their enemy. They threw down their weapons, sought forgiveness, embraced one another, and returned with the Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him. Then the verse was revealed. [Translator's note: This is the occasion-of-revelation narrative transmitted by Ibn ʿAjība; its historical details require separate assessment.] T87

"O you who believe, if you obey a group" of Jews, "they will turn you back into disbelievers after your faith," making one another's blood licit again as in the Age of Ignorance. "How could you disbelieve while God's signs"—which declare bloodshed and rancour forbidden—"are recited to you, and His Messenger is among you," guiding you to the straight path? This is both repudiation and astonishment at the possibility of unbelief after all the causes inviting them to faith and diverting them from unbelief have been assembled. God now addresses the believers directly, after commanding the Messenger to address the People of the Book, in order to make manifest their exalted worth: they are more deserving that God should address and speak to them, unlike those distant from receiving the Generous Bestower's direct address. "Whoever holds fast to God," cleaving to His religion, "has indeed been guided to a straight path" without deviation. The basic sense of holding fast (الاعتصام) is taking protection against something (التمنع).

Outward commentary · “As He should be feared” and the question of abrogation

God then urged perfect Godfearingness (التقوى الكاملة) and constancy in submission, discouraging them from listening to anyone who would remove them from these. “O you who believe, be mindful of God as He is truly worthy of being regarded.” The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is reported to have said: “His true due is that He should be obeyed and not disobeyed for the blink of an eye, remembered and not forgotten, thanked and not denied.” When the verse came down, they asked, “Messenger of God, who can bear this?” It was difficult for them; then “Be mindful of God as far as you are able” [64:16] was revealed and abrogated it, according to this explanation. [T88]

Muqātil said its meaning is: “Be mindful of God as He truly deserves; if you cannot, then do not die except as Muslims.” From Anas ibn Mālik it is related: “No servant is mindful of God as He truly deserves until he stores up [restrains] his tongue.” Others say that it is not abrogated: whoever avoids what God has forbidden and performs of obedience whatever he is able has been mindful of God as He truly deserves; the meaning of the two verses is therefore one. We shall explain its exact application in the spiritual allusion, God willing.

Al-Bayḍāwī says: It is also said that the meaning of “as He truly deserves” is to purify obedience of looking at one’s obedience and of expecting recompense for it. The command reinforces the prohibition on obeying the People of the Book. “And do not die except while you are Muslims” means: remain in no state but Islam until death overtakes you. End of quotation. May God cause us to die with a good end, in abiding safety and wellbeing.

Spiritual allusion · Holding fast through companionship and the certainty of realization

Just as God forbade obedience to one who turns people back from faith (الإيمان), He forbade obedience to anyone who diverts them from the station of spiritual excellence (مقام الإحسان), whoever that person might be. How can anyone return from the station of realized certainty (التحقيق), once the signs of the path have appeared to one for whom divine care and success were decreed? Someone said: “By God, no one turns back except someone who

was still on the road. As for one who has arrived, he never turns back," for it is impossible to return from the eye of certainty (عين اليقين) to the knowledge of certainty (علم اليقين), or from certainty to conjecture (الظن).

Whoever desires permanence in certainty should hold fast to God's strong cord, which is companionship with the knowers (صحبة العارفين). Whoever holds fast to them has held fast to God: "Whoever holds fast to God has indeed been guided to a straight path."

Then He addressed the people of spiritual excellence (أهل الإحسان): "O you who believe, be mindful of God as He truly deserves," by being absent to everything other than Him; "and do not die except while you are Muslims," yielding to the determinations of Lordship (أحكام الربوبية) and fulfilling the functions of servanthood (وظائف العبودية). This verse, then, is addressed to the people of iḥsān, while "Be mindful of God as far as you are able" [64:16] is addressed to the people of Islam and faith. Or the former is for the people of detachment (أهل التجريد) and the latter for those occupied with secondary causes (أهل الأسباب); or the former is for the inward people (أهل الباطن) and the latter for the outward people (أهل الظاهر). Each verse has its people and its proper place: there is therefore no abrogation (نسخ) and no contradiction (تعارض). [T88]

Shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās, may God be pleased with him, said: "Whoever wishes to reconcile the two verses should be mindful of God as He truly deserves inwardly (بباطنه), and mindful of Him as far as possible outwardly (بظاهره)." End of quotation. And success is through God.

The Real, exalted is His majesty, then urged unity and forbade the division that their enemy had sought among them, saying:

3:103 · The rope of God, the reconciliation of hearts and the unity of the spiritual path

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 388–389

وَاعْتَصِمُوا بِحَبْلِ اللَّهِ جَمِيعاً وَلا تَفَرَّقُوا وَاذْكُرُوا نِعْمَتَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ إِذْ كُنْتُمْ أَعْداءً فَأَلَّفَ بَيْنَ قُلُوبِكُمْ فَأَصْبَحْتُمْ بِنِعْمَتِهِ إِخْواناً وَكُنْتُمْ عَلى شَفا حُفْرَةٍ مِنَ النَّارِ فَأَنْقَذَكُمْ مِنْها كَذلِكَ يُبَيِّنُ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ آياتِهِ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَهْتَدُونَ (103)

103. Hold fast, all together, to the rope of God, and do not divide. Remember God's blessing upon you: you were enemies, and He joined your hearts, so that through His blessing you became brothers. You were upon the brink of a pit of fire, and He rescued you from it. Thus God makes His signs clear to you, that you may be guided.

Language · The rope as a means of attaining the end

I say: The original sense of "rope" (الحبل) in language is a means (السبب) by which one reaches the object sought; faith or the Qurʾān is so named because it leads to unending happiness. "The edge of a pit" (شفا حفرة) means its rim. Its original form is shafw (شفو), the wāw being changed into alif in the masculine and omitted in the feminine, whence the word shafa (شفة), "lip."

Outward commentary · God's cord and the reversal of inherited enmity

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "Hold fast," O company of Muslims, that is, cling "to the rope of God," meaning faith or God's Book, according to the Prophet's saying: "This Qurʾān is God's strong rope, the manifest light, the beneficial healing, and a protection for whoever holds fast to it ..." and

the remainder of the report. Do so "all together," united upon it; "and do not divide" as you were divided in the Age of Ignorance, or do not part from the truth through discord among yourselves as the People of the Book did. T89

The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said, as cited here: "The Children of Israel split into seventy-one sects, and my community will split into seventy-two sects, all of them in the Fire except one." Asked, "Messenger of God, which is the one?", he clasped his hand and said: "The community (الجماعة)." Then he recited: "Hold fast, all together, to the rope of God, and do not divide." [Translator's note: The numbers and wording here must be kept distinct from Ibn ʿAjība's other version of the report in his very next section.] T89

"Remember God's blessing upon you," one of its forms being guidance to Islam, which brings about affection and removes rancour, "when you were enemies" in the Age of Ignorance, killing one another, "and He joined your hearts" through Islam, "so that by His blessing you became brothers," loving one another and united in brotherhood for God's sake. The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: "Do not envy one another, hate one another or turn your backs on one another; be, servants of God, brothers. A Muslim is the brother of a Muslim; he does not wrong him or abandon him." The remainder of the report follows. It is related that Aws and Khazraj were originally two full brothers whose descendants became enemies and warred for a hundred and twenty years, until God extinguished this through Islam and united them by His Messenger; the verse was revealed about them. T90

He then says to them: "You were upon the brink of a pit of fire," almost falling into Hell; had death overtaken you, you would have fallen in. "And He rescued you from it," through His Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him. It is related that a Bedouin heard Ibn ʿAbbās reciting this verse and said: "By God, He did not rescue them from it in order to cast them into it." Ibn ʿAbbās replied: "Take this from someone who is not a jurist." End of report. "Thus God makes His signs clear to you," in such a manner He explains them, "that you may be guided" to the good and increase in steadfastness upon it. T90

Spiritual allusion · Concord among the paths of realization and the healing of the heart

All schools (المذاهب) have experienced disagreement and division in fundamentals and branches, save the ways of the Sufis (مذاهب الصوفية): these, says Ibn ʿAjība, agree in their beginning and their end, for their beginning is spiritual struggle (المجاهدة) and their end is witnessing (المشاهدة). The author of *al-Mabāḥith* alludes to this:

> The schools of people stand in disagreement;
> The school of the Folk stands in concord.

Even if they disagree over particular ways (الطرق) of reaching the aim, they agree concerning the end. This is unlike the people of outward inquiry (أهل الظاهر), whom, in Ibn ʿAjība's characterization, one finds agreeing only on a few questions, for their method is built upon the preponderance of conjecture (غلبة الظن), while the method of the Folk (القوم) is grounded in realization through tasting and unveiling (التحقيق ذوقاً وكشفاً). Their hearts and spirits, likewise, are united: all are formed by compassion, tenderness, affection, harmony and purity, because they have entered Paradise—the Paradise of gnoses (جنة المعارف)—and adopted the character traits of the inhabitants of Paradise. God says: "We shall remove whatever rancour is in their breasts, as brothers upon couches facing one another" [15:47]. [T91]

Thus after spiritual opening (الفتح) it is said to them: Remember God's blessing upon you, when you were enemies before being connected to the healer (الطبيب); He united your hearts, and by His blessing you became brothers who love one another. You were at the brink of a pit of the fire of severance and veiling (القطيعة والحجاب), and He rescued you from it. By such an explanation God makes His signs—that is, His self-disclosures (تجلياته)—clear, so that you may be guided to witness His Essence in the lights of His attributes. And God Most High knows best.

He then commanded them to enjoin what is recognized as good and forbid what is reprehensible. Its connection with the preceding verses is that they remained silent when the Jews stirred discord among them, until they almost fought, and not one of them commanded restraint. God therefore

warned them against that provocation, urged unity and commanded them to enjoin right and forbid wrong whenever they saw anything of the kind, saying:

3:104 · Enjoining good, collective obligation and the command of spiritual presence

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 389–391

وَلْتَكُنْ مِنْكُمْ أُمَّةٌ يَدْعُونَ إِلَى الْخَيْرِ وَيَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَيَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ وَأُولئِكَ هُمُ الْمُفْلِحُونَ (104)

104. Let there be from among you a community who call to what is good, enjoin what is recognized as right, and forbid what is reprehensible. Those are the ones who prosper.

Language · Whether “from among you” denotes a subset or the whole community

I say: “From among you” (مِنْكُمْ)—the particle min (مِنْ)—can be partitive (للتبعيض), because enjoining right and forbidding wrong is among the collective obligations (فروض الكفاية), not every person being suited to it. Or min can be explanatory (للبيان): that is, “Be a community that enjoins what is right,” as in “You are the best community brought forth for humankind: you enjoin what is right …” [3:110]. “They enjoin what is right and forbid what is wrong” is coordinated with the predicate (الخبر), the mention of the particular after the general (عطف الخاص على العام) to show its special merit. [T92]

Outward commentary · Calling to every form of good that leads to religious flourishing

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Let there be from among you,” O community of Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him, “a community,” that is, a party, “who call to what is good (الخير),” meaning whatever brings about religious wellbeing, or worldly wellbeing when it leads to religious wellbeing, or the wellbeing of heart and spirit. “They

enjoin what is recognized as right (المعروف),” which sound disposition finds beautiful and the revealed Law approves, “and forbid what is reprehensible (المنكر),” which sound nature and the upright Law repudiate. Those who do so “are the ones who prosper,” especially distinguished by the perfection of success.

The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is reported to have been asked, “Which people are best?” and to have replied: “Those who most enjoin what is right, most forbid what is wrong, are most mindful of God, and most maintain family ties.” He is also quoted as saying: “Whoever enjoins right and forbids wrong is God’s vicegerent on His earth, the vicegerent of His Messenger, and the vicegerent of His Book.” [T93]

ʿAlī, may God be pleased with him, said: “The best striving (الجهاد) is to enjoin right, forbid wrong, and detest the transgressors”—that is, hate them. “Whoever enjoins right strengthens the believer’s back; whoever forbids wrong humiliates the hypocrite; and whoever detests the transgressors and grows angry for God, God grows angry on his behalf.” Abū al-Dardāʾ said: “You shall surely enjoin right and forbid wrong, or God will set over you an unjust ruler who will neither honour your elders nor show mercy to your young. Your best people will pray against him without being answered, seek help without receiving it, and seek forgiveness without being forgiven.” Ḥudhayfa said: “A time will come when the corpse of a donkey will be more beloved to people than a believer who enjoins them to right and forbids them from wrong.” [Translator’s note: The chains of these cited sayings have not been individually authenticated.] [T93]

Outward commentary · Capacity, knowledge and the distinction between required and recommended action

The person who undertakes the duty requires qualifications: knowledge of the rulings (العلم بالأحكام), of the degrees of moral intervention (مراتب الاحتساب), of how to carry it out, and the ability to discharge it. That is why the Real addresses all but requests action from some: only a portion are fitted for it. This is the nature of a collective obligation (فرض الكفاية), which rests on everyone in such a way that, if all neglect it, all are liable, but whose performance by some discharges the rest. [T92]

Enjoining what is right can be obligatory or recommended, depending on what is being enjoined. Forbidding what is wrong is entirely obligatory, since whatever the Law condemns in this technical sense is forbidden (حرام). As for what is merely disliked (المكروه), it is not "wrong" in that sense, so encouraging one to leave it is recommended. The stronger view, he says, is that a person who himself commits a sin must nevertheless forbid that same sin to others, because he has two duties—to desist from it and to forbid it—and neglect of one does not remove the obligation of the other. The Prophet is quoted as saying: "Command right even if you do not perform all of it; and forbid wrong even if you do not desist from all of it." [T94]

Spiritual allusion · Those whose state itself calls others to God

"Let there be from among you a community": a company whose spiritual state (حال) impels others to rise, and whose words point towards God. They summon to the greatest good, the witnessing of the Essence of the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing (شهود ذات السميع العليم); they enjoin right through their exalted spiritual aspiration (الهمة العلية) and forbid wrong through the strength of their state (الحال القوية). Whoever sees them in purity obeys and refrains; whoever accompanies them in fidelity obtains his full share of spiritual wealth. God has men at the sight of whom someone attains a happiness after which he shall never be wretched. Such men enjoin right and forbid wrong through their state rather than through speech (بالحال دون المقال).

It is related that a shaykh once passed with his companions by some men drinking wine beneath a tree. His companions wished to rush upon them. He said: "If you are men, change their conduct by your state, not by your speech." They directed their spiritual aspirations toward God and the men immediately broke their vessels and came to the shaykh in repentance.

So too is the incident of Maʿrūf al-Karkhī and the people on a boat who were occupied with amusement and play. His companions told him to pray against them. He said: "O God, just as You have made them happy in this world, make them happy in the Hereafter." All of them repented through him. Through God is success, and He is the Guide to the even way. [T95]

He then repeated the prohibition on division, underscoring his censure of it, saying:

3:105–109 · Division after proof, the illumination of faces and the mercy of salvation

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 391–392

وَلا تَكُونُوا كَالَّذِينَ تَفَرَّقُوا وَاخْتَلَفُوا مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَهُمُ الْبَيِّناتُ وَأُولئِكَ لَهُمْ عَذابٌ عَظِيمٌ (105) يَوْمَ تَبْيَضُّ وُجُوهٌ وَتَسْوَدُّ وُجُوهٌ فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ اسْوَدَّتْ وُجُوهُهُمْ أَكَفَرْتُمْ بَعْدَ إِيمانِكُمْ فَذُوقُوا الْعَذابَ بِما كُنْتُمْ تَكْفُرُونَ (106) وَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ ابْيَضَّتْ وُجُوهُهُمْ فَفِي رَحْمَتِ اللَّهِ هُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (107) تِلْكَ آياتُ اللَّهِ نَتْلُوها عَلَيْكَ بِالْحَقِّ وَمَا اللَّهُ يُرِيدُ ظُلْماً لِلْعالَمِينَ (108) وَلِلَّهِ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ وَإِلَى اللَّهِ تُرْجَعُ الْأُمُورُ (109)

105. Do not be like those who split apart and differed after clear proofs had come to them. For them is a mighty punishment. 106. On the Day when some faces become white and others become black: to those whose faces turn black it will be said, “Did you disbelieve after your faith? Taste the punishment, then, for your disbelief.” 107. Those whose faces become white will be in God’s mercy, abiding there forever. 108. These are God’s signs, which We recite to you in truth; God does not desire injustice for the worlds. 109. To God belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on earth; to God all affairs are returned.

Language · The position of “the Day” and an omitted speech formula

I say: “The Day” (يوم) depends on the implied state of subsistence (الاستقرار) in the predicate (خبر) of “those” (أولئك), or on an unexpressed command “remember” (اذكر) with [its governing expression] omitted. As for “Did you disbelieve?” (أكفرتم), it is a quotation introduced by an unexpressed verb of saying that constitutes the answer to ammā (أما): that is, “It will be said to them: Did you disbelieve?”

Outward commentary · Division in fundamentals versus plurality in derivative judgments

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Do not be like” the Jews and Christians, “those who split apart” concerning divine unity and God’s transcendence (التوحيد والتنزيه), “and differed” about the states of the Hereafter. The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is cited as saying: “The Jews divided into seventy-one sects, the Christians into seventy-two, and my community will divide into seventy-three; all are in the Fire except one.” Asked which one it was, he replied: “What I and my Companions are upon.” Ibn ʿAjība says that this version is sounder than the version quoted earlier, and adds that the Companions transmitted hadith according to its meaning, so perhaps the first transmitter forgot part of it. And God knows best. [T96]

He then says the prohibition concerns division over fundamentals (الأصول), not disagreements over derivative matters (الفروع), adducing the saying “Disagreement within my community is a mercy,” as well as the saying that the one who exercises legal effort (اجتهاد) and reaches the correct conclusion receives two rewards, while one who exercises it and errs receives one. [Translator’s note: The first saying’s status is disputed and should not be treated as an authenticated Prophetic report simply because Ibn ʿAjība quotes it.] [T97]

The People of the Book divided “after clear proofs had come to them,” meaning verses and demonstrations revealing the truth and demanding agreement upon it. “For them is a mighty punishment”: this punishment shall abide for them “on the Day when some faces become white,” those of believers who were mindful of God and upheld unity; “and some faces become black,” those of unbelievers divided concerning unity. Or the whitened faces are those of the sincere (المخلصين), and the darkened faces those of the hypocrites (المنافقين); or the former are those who follow the Sunna and the latter the people of innovation. Whiteness and blackness of faces may be metonymies (كنايتان) for the manifest radiance of happiness and the gloom of fear. Another interpretation takes the marks literally: the people of truth are distinguished by whitened faces and records, bright complexions and light moving before them and on their right, while the people of falsehood receive the corresponding opposites. [T98]

“As for those whose faces turn black,” it is said to them on that Day: “Did you disbelieve in Muḥammad,” blessings and peace be upon him, after his appearance, “after your faith” in him before his appearance? These are the Jews; or it refers to apostates (أهل الردة) who believed during his life and disbelieved after his death. Or it means all unbelievers: they believed and acknowledged [God] in the realm of particles (عالم الذر), then disbelieved in the realm of visible testimony (عالم الشهادة). To them it is said: “Taste the punishment for what you used to disbelieve.”

“As for those whose faces become white, they will be in God’s mercy,” that is, His Garden, “abiding there forever.” He calls the Garden “mercy” to indicate that, even if a believer spends his whole life obeying God Most High, he enters the Garden only through God’s mercy and favour. One might have expected the adornment of the believers to come first because they were mentioned first, but [the passage] is designed so that both the opening and close of the discussion are concerned with the believers’ adornment and reward.

“These are God’s signs,” concerning His promise and warning (الوعد والوعيد); “We recite them to you in truth,” without uncertainty. He has made the excuse impossible and given warning. “God does not desire injustice for the worlds,” since nothing is incumbent upon Him such that deprivation of it would wrong someone; and nothing is forbidden to Him such that His doing it would be unjust. He clarifies this by saying: “To God belongs whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on earth,” by ownership, creation and servitude. He recompenses each according to what He has promised or threatened. “To God all affairs are returned”: He disposes them according to His will and His prior choice. “He is not questioned about what He does, but they shall be questioned” [21:23]. [T99]

Spiritual allusion · The faces of realization and the pain of veiling

God Most High has forbidden the people of gathering (أهل الجمع) to resemble the people of separation (أهل الفرق), in the differing of their hearts, their faces, their opinions and their ways of seeing, after clear proofs have come to them concerning gathering the heart upon God, affection for God’s sake, and directing the gaze towards the witnessing of God. For those divided people there is a great punishment—and what punishment is greater than the veil (الحجاب)?

On the Day when the faces of the knowers (العارفين) become white, like the brilliant sun, they roam in the gardens wherever they wish. The faces of the ignorant darken with regret. Their darkness is relative to the faces of the knowers: they may be white with the light of faith (نور الإيمان), but they lack the light of spiritual excellence (نور الإحسان). It is said to them: “Did you disbelieve in special spiritual distinction (الخصوصية) in your own time after believing that it existed among those before you?” Taste, then, the punishment of severance (القطيعة) from witnessing the Beloved at every moment. [T100]

As for those whose faces become white and shine with the light of subsistence (نور البقاء), they are in God’s mercy: that is, the Garden of gnoses (جنة المعارف), “in a seat of truth, in the presence of an all-powerful Sovereign” [54:55]. The path has been made clear and the waymarks of realization manifest, but guidance is in God’s hand, just as all affairs lie in His hand. He guides whom He wills and leaves astray whom He wills. “Your Lord is not unjust to His servants” [41:46]. Through God is success.

He then praised the Muhammadan community for obeying His command to enjoin right and forbid wrong, saying:

3:110–112 · The best community, degrees of spiritual knowledge and protection under covenant

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 392–396

كُنْتُمْ خَيْرَ أُمَّةٍ أُخْرِجَتْ لِلنَّاسِ تَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَتَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ وَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَلَوْ آمَنَ أَهْلُ الْكِتابِ لَكانَ خَيْراً لَهُمْ مِنْهُمُ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ وَأَكْثَرُهُمُ الْفاسِقُونَ (110) لَنْ يَضُرُّوكُمْ إِلاَّ أَذىً وَإِنْ يُقاتِلُوكُمْ يُوَلُّوكُمُ الْأَدْبارَ ثُمَّ لاَ يُنْصَرُونَ (111) ضُرِبَتْ عَلَيْهِمُ الذِّلَّةُ أَيْنَ مَا ثُقِفُوا إِلاَّ

بِحَبْلٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَحَبْلٍ مِنَ النَّاسِ وَباؤُ بِغَضَبٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَضُرِبَتْ عَلَيْهِمُ الْمَسْكَنَةُ ذلِكَ بِأَنَّهُمْ كانُوا يَكْفُرُونَ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ وَيَقْتُلُونَ الْأَنْبِياءَ بِغَيْرِ حَقٍّ ذلِكَ بِما عَصَوْا وَكانُوا يَعْتَدُونَ (112)

110. You were the best community brought forth for humankind: you enjoin what is right, forbid what is wrong, and believe in God. Had the People of the Book believed, it would have been better for them. Among them are believers, but most of them are defiantly disobedient. 111. They will not harm you, except by causing hurt; and if they fight you, they will turn their backs upon you, and then they will not be helped. 112. Humiliation has been laid upon them wherever they are found, unless they hold to a covenant from God and a covenant from people. They have incurred wrath from God, and poverty has been laid upon them. This is because they rejected God's signs and killed prophets without right. That was because they disobeyed and kept transgressing.

Language · The force of "you were" and the beneficiaries of goodness

I say: "You were" (كُنْتُمْ): kāna (كان) may retain its normal force indicating the past (المضي): you were [so designated] in the Preserved Tablet (اللوح المحفوظ), or in God's knowledge, or among earlier peoples. Or it may be an expletive connective (صلة), meaning simply "You are the best community." "For humankind" (للنّاس) may depend upon "brought forth" (أخرجت), or upon "you were" (كنتم), yielding "You were the best of people *for* people."

[Translator's print-source notes: T101]

Outward commentary · The virtue of the Muhammadan community

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says to the community of our Prophet Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him: "You were," in My prior knowledge, "the best community brought forth for humankind," leading people into Paradise even in chains. He then states the reason for their excellence: "You enjoin what is right, forbid what is wrong, and believe in God," and in everything it is obligatory to believe.

Reports praising the Muhammadan community include the Prophet's words, as cited here: "Paradise was withheld from the prophets until I enter it, and withheld from the communities until my community enters." And: "My community is a community shown mercy. On the Day of Resurrection God gives each man of this community another man, and it is said: This is your ransom from the Fire." T102

Anas is reported as saying: "I went out with the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, and a voice was coming from a mountain pass. He said: 'Anas, get up and find out what this voice is.' I went, and there was a man praying toward a tree and saying: 'O God, make me one of Muḥammad's community, the community that receives mercy, is forgiven, is answered and whose repentance is accepted.' I told the Prophet. He said: 'Go and tell him that God's Messenger sends his greeting and asks: Who are you?' I conveyed the message. He said: 'Send my greeting to God's Messenger and say to him: Your brother al-Khiḍr asks you to pray that God make me a member of your community—the community shown mercy and forgiven.'" T103 155

It was said to Jesus son of Mary: "Will there be a community after this one?" He answered: "Yes, the community of Aḥmad." Asked about its character, he said: "They are scholars, wise ones, righteous and Godfearing, like prophets in their understanding of religion. They are content with a little provision, and God is content with a little work from them. He admits them into Paradise by their testimony that there is no god but God." End of cited account. T103

The earliest members of the community do not have an exclusive claim to praise over its later members, in view of the saying: "My community is like rain: one does not know whether its beginning is better or its end." Another report describes the Prophet saying: "I long for my brothers." His companions asked: "Are we not your brothers, Messenger of God?" He replied: "You are my companions. My brothers are people who will come after me, believe in me without having seen me, and one of them would desire to see me even in exchange for everything he owns. The work of one of them is equal to the work of seventy of you." They asked: "Of them or of us?" He

155. Cairo editor, C393.1: Al-Ḥāfiẓ Ibn Ḥajar mentions it in different wording in al-Iṣāba, II: 122, attributing it to Ibn ʿAsākir, Ibn Shāhīn and Ibn ʿAdī in al-Kāmil.

said: “Of you.” “Why is that, Messenger of God?” “Because you found helpers in goodness and they found no helpers in it,” or words to that effect, as Ibn ʿAjība himself qualifies the quotation. T104

I say: This preference concerns the rewards of deeds. Regarding certainty and gnosis (اليقين والمعرفة), the Companions are the best of creation after the prophets, peace be upon them. The evidence is that the Prophet spoke of one person’s *work* being equal, not of that person’s faith being equal. And God Most High knows best. 156

Spiritual allusion · The Sufis as a community calling to direct witnessing

“You were,” O company of Sufis, “the best community brought forth for humankind”: you enjoin gathering upon God (الجمع على الله) and being absent to everything other than Him; you forbid anything that distances one from God and divides the servant from his Master. You believe in God and in what He promised with the faith of witnessing and direct vision (إيمان الشهود والعيان), the station of spiritual excellence (مقام الإحسان).

Al-Qushayrī says in his *Risāla*: “God has made this company the elect among His friends and preferred them to all His servants after His messengers and prophets.” Al-Junayd said: “If we knew of a knowledge more noble, beneath the canopy of the sky, than the knowledge about which we speak with our companions, I would strive for it even if I had to crawl.” He often recited:

> The science of Sufism is a science known only
> To the discerning one who is recognized through the Real;
> One who does not witness it does not behold it—
> How should a blind man witness the sunlight?

Al-Shaykh al-Ṣiqillī said: “Whoever believes this knowledge belongs to the elect (الخاصة); whoever understands it belongs to the elect of the elect (خاصة الخاصة); and whoever can express and speak of it is like a star that cannot be reached or a sea that cannot be drained.”

156. Cairo editor, C393.2: Al-Ḥāfiẓ Ibn Ḥajar says: The majority hold that no deed equals the excellence of being a Companion, because of seeing God’s Messenger—blessings and peace be upon him. He then says that a greater reward does not entail absolute superiority. See the remainder of his discussion in al-Fatḥ, VII:9; see also al-Qurṭubī’s commentary.

In the *Iḥyāʾ*, when speaking of knowing God and the science of God (معرفة الله والعلم بالله), al-Ghazālī says: "The highest rank in that belongs to the prophets, then to the friends of God who know Him, then to scholars deeply established in knowledge, then to the righteous." He thereby places the friends of God before the scholars. Ibn Rushd says, according to the source cited by Ibn ʿAjība, that what al-Qushayrī and al-Ghazālī say is agreed upon. He adds: "No rational person doubts that those who know God and what perfection must be attributed to Him are better than those who know God's legal rulings." Consult the complete discussion in *al-Miʿyār*. T105

The author of *al-Mabāḥith* says:

> The argument that sets the Sufis above others
> Is a strong argument indeed.
> They follow, more than all other people,
> The best of all humankind.

And then:

> Two further things establish the proof:
> That they surely follow the clear road,
> And what they display of extraordinary gifts,
> Uncustomary among other people.
> They have renounced sins and faults,
> And purified their bodies and hearts.
> They have attained the reality of faith
> And walked the pathways of spiritual excellence. 157

Language · The covenant as an exception to all circumstances

He then called the People of the Book to faith and made light of their power, saying: "Had [the People of the Book] believed …"

I say: The exception "except by a cord" (إلا بحبل) is from the most general class of circumstances (أعم الأحوال): humiliation is laid upon them in every condition save when they are clothed in a protection granted by God and a protection granted by people.

157. Cairo editor, C394.1: The maḥajja is the straight road.

Outward commentary · Security, limits on harm and the cause of moral deterioration

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Had the People of the Book believed” with a belief such as yours, “it would have been better for them” than their present condition. Yet they are not all alike: “Among them are believers,” such as ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and his companions, “but most of them are defiantly disobedient,” rebellious in unbelief and transgression.

Do not be awed by them. “They will not harm you, except by causing hurt”—slight harm from the tongue, such as reviling, insult and stirring discord among you. They have no power to fight; “if they fight you” they will be defeated and “turn their backs on you, and then will not be helped” against you.

Ibn ʿAjība calls this a prediction of unseen events that subsequently matched what occurred with Banū Qurayẓa, Banū al-Naḍīr, Banū Qaynuqāʿ and Khaybar. In his account, they never raised a victorious standard. Instead, “humiliation has been laid upon them,” shame and abasement surrounding them like a tent spread over its occupants—or adhering to them like the imprint of a stamped coin—“wherever they are found.” They enjoy security only “through a cord from God,” meaning a covenant or guarantee from God, expressed in the dhimma contract (عقد الذمة) that God prescribed. When those under it pay the poll tax (الجزية), this contract safeguards them: **it is forbidden to attack their property, blood or families**. The other is “a cord from people,” a covenant granted by other human authorities to those residing under their protection. In sum, humiliation clings to them, and they obtain security only beneath a covenant, either from Muslims or from unbelievers. T106 158

“They have incurred wrath from God,” that is, they have returned deserving it; “poverty has been laid upon them,” encircling them. Jews are generally poor and needy, because their hearts are empty of certainty; poverty and anxiety cling to them, even if they possess the entire world. [Translator’s note: This is the commentator’s historically situated polemic.] T106

158. Cairo editor, C395.1: The Jews established a state for themselves with the help and protection of the unjust, as the British and Americans have provided. Yet abasement clings to the Jews, and God sends against them those who subject them to grievous punishment, even while they are fortified within their state.

"That"—humiliation, need and incurred wrath—"is because they rejected God's signs," revealed to His messenger or indicating divine unity, "and killed the prophets without right," with injustice and aggression. Their unbelief, he says, arose from disobedience and crossing God's bounds: persistence in minor sins leads to major sins, and persistence in major sins leads to unbelief, for sins are the forerunners of unbelief. God protect us.

Spiritual allusion · Hostility to the friends of God and testimony from the author's own trials

Had the people of outward learning (أهل العلم الظاهر) believed in the path of particular realization (طريق الخصوص) and humbled themselves before those endowed with special spiritual distinction (أهل الخصوصية), it would have been better for them. Their circle of knowledge would have widened and treasuries of understanding opened. Some acknowledge the existence of such particularity but lack the strength to bear its conditions. Most of them deny it and justify themselves by citing someone who said that spiritual training (التربية) ended in the eighth Islamic century; they die persisting in denial and disobedience.

Yet their denial will not harm you, O spiritual poor (الفقراء): they have no power over you because of the protection surrounding you, apart from harm caused by their tongues. Even if visible harm reaches you, God will make you inwardly absent from its pain, as we ourselves have witnessed concerning some of the spiritual poor. If they threaten you with killing and exile, God will generally not help them achieve it.

I say: They threatened to beat us, report us to the ruler, and banish us to the land of the Christians, yet they accomplished none of it. Some Sufis have indeed undergone such treatment, which only increased their honour and dignity. One who censures the Sufis, says Ibn ʿAjība, remains in distress, sorrow, humiliation and need because his inward being is ruined of the light of certainty. Criticism of God's friends is a wrongdoing, whereas belief in them brings care. If one persists in injuring them, one will meet a bad end and incur God's anger by wronging His friends: "Whoever harms a friend of Mine is on notice of war." [Translator's note: Cairo I:396 prints فقد أذن بالحرب, without a first-person verb. This is read here in the attested sense of *adhina bi-*,

“became aware of,” rather than silently supplying *ādhantuhu*, “I have notified him”; see *Lisān al-ʿArab*, s.v. أذن.] May God grant us good manners towards them and allow us to die loving them. Amen. [T107] [159]

Since some Jews did submit and became good Muslims, God Most High distinguished them as an exception, saying:

3:113–115 · The upright People of the Book and the successive callings of learned people

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 396–397

لَيْسُوا سَواءً مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ أُمَّةٌ قائِمَةٌ يَتْلُونَ آياتِ اللَّهِ آناءَ اللَّيْلِ وَهُمْ يَسْجُدُونَ (113) يُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَيَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَيَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ وَيُسارِعُونَ فِي الْخَيْراتِ وَأُولئِكَ مِنَ الصَّالِحِينَ (114) وَما تَفْعَلُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَلَنْ تُكْفَرُوهُ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ بِالْمُتَّقِينَ (115)

113. They are not all alike. Among the People of the Book is an upright community, reciting God’s signs through the hours of the night while they prostrate themselves. 114. They believe in God and the Last Day, enjoin what is right, forbid what is wrong, and hasten to good deeds. They are among the righteous. 115. Whatever good you do, you shall not be denied it; God knows those who are mindful of Him.

Language · The upright community, hours of night and “denying” recompense

I say: “Upright” (قائمة) means straight or sound (مستقيمة), as in aqamtu al-ʿūd fa-qāma, “I set the stick straight, so it stood upright”; or it means “carrying out God’s command.” “Through the hours of the night” (آناء الليل) is an

159. Cairo editor, C396.1: That is, Sufis who observe their obligations, not “Sufis of the flute.” *[Translator: The body has note marker 2; the footnote is numbered 1.]*

adverbial time expression (ظرف); the singular is *iny* (إِنْي), with kasra on the hamza and an unvowelled nūn, like *niḥy/anḥāʾ* (نِحْي/أَنْحَاء); or *inā* (إِنًى), like *miʿā/amʿāʾ* (مِعًى/أَمْعَاء), according to the forms transmitted here. "You shall not be denied it" (لن تكفروه) means "you shall not be deprived of it." Kafara is here used with two objects (مفعولين) because it incorporates the meaning of "deprive" (حرم) or "withhold" (منع). T108

Outward commentary · The worshippers among the People of the Book

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: The People of the Book "are not all alike" in unbelief and hostility. Rather, among them is "a community," that is, a group, "upright," practicing justice and steadfast in religion, or rising to fulfil God's command, or standing in prayer, "reciting God's signs" during their night vigil "through the hours of the night," meaning its periods, "while they prostrate" in their prayers. Or the reference is to the night prayer (صلاة العشاء), which the People of the Book do not perform: it is related that the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, once delayed that prayer, then came out while the people were waiting and said, "Rejoice, for there is no one among the inhabitants of earth praying at this hour other than you." T109

He then describes them through faith: "They believe in God and the Last Day, enjoin what is right, forbid what is wrong, and hasten to good deeds." They are ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and his companions who accepted Islam from among the Jews. God Most High has described them with distinctive qualities not found among the Jews: the latter deviate from the truth and are not devoted to worship; they associate partners with God and deviate concerning His attributes; they describe the Last Day with qualities other than its own; they compromise in enjoining right and forbidding wrong; and they are slow to do good—unlike the description given of those among them who embraced Islam. [Translator's note: These generalized contrasts belong to the commentator's polemic.] "They are among the righteous": those whose condition is sound before God, who deserve His pleasure and praise. Such is God's practice towards His servants: when a servant draws near to Him by a handspan, He draws near by an arm's length. T109

Therefore He says: "Whatever good you do, you shall not be denied it." You shall not be deprived of its reward or have its recompense refused; God will recognize it gratefully and repay you for it. Denial of recompense is

called “ingratitude” (كفران), just as bestowal is called “gratitude” (شكر). “God knows those who are mindful of Him”: their stations in Godfearingness (مقاماتهم في التقوى) are not hidden from Him. This intimates that Godfearingness is the beginning of goodness and among the best of works, and that the successful before God are the people of Godfearingness. May God, through His bounty, grant us its fullest share. Amen.

Spiritual allusion · Learning for gain, teaching, action and realization

The people of learning are not all alike. Some make knowledge into a net with which to catch the world, selling their religion for a small worldly advantage: these are corrupt scholars and unjust judges. Others study knowledge for God and teach it for God, spending their lives teaching and recording it. Some devote their aspiration to gathering and composing it; others devote themselves to acting upon it and become worshippers and ascetics, “reciting God’s signs through the hours of the night while they prostrate.” Still others refine and realize it, then turn towards inward knowledge (علم الباطن), accompany the knowers (العارفين) and become among those brought near (المقربين). All these “hasten to good deeds and are among the righteous.” To them it is said: “Whatever good you do shall not be denied you; God knows those who are mindful of Him.”

The Real Most High then mentioned their opposites, saying:

3:116 · Wealth, children and the loss of direct knowledge of God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 397–398

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا لَنْ تُغْنِيَ عَنْهُمْ أَمْوالُهُمْ وَلا أَوْلادُهُمْ مِنَ اللَّهِ شَيْئاً وَأُولئِكَ أَصْحابُ النَّارِ هُمْ فِيها خالِدُونَ (116)

116. As for those who disbelieve, neither their wealth nor their children will avail them anything against God. They are the companions of the Fire, abiding therein.

Outward commentary · Possessions offer no exemption from divine judgment

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Those who disbelieve,” denying what the Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him, has brought, will find that “neither their wealth nor their children will avail them anything” against God’s punishment. “They are the companions of the Fire”: they remain inseparable from it, as a man remains with his companion; “they abide therein.” T110

Spiritual allusion · Denying the friends of God and losing the opportunity for witnessing

Those who deny the distinctive spiritual realization (الخصوصية) of the people of their time, thereby missing the opportunity to receive some of their lights, will find that neither their wealth, their children, nor even their acquired sciences can compensate for the knowledge of God (معرفة الله) they have missed. What has the one who lost God found? And what has the one who found God lost? The poet says:

> For everything, once you part from it, there is a replacement;
> But if you part from God, there is nothing that can replace Him.

There is no path to the special knowledge of the Real (معرفة الحق المعرفة الخاصة) —by which I mean direct, first-hand knowledge (معرفة العيان)—except through companionship with people of witnessing and direct vision (أهل الشهود والعيان). Thus whoever rejects them has deprivation as his ultimate lot, and idleness and abandonment cling to him. Let him put it to the test: experiment discloses the realities. Whoever is deprived of their companionship remains exposed to the fire of separation (نار القطيعة), the torment of veiling (عذاب الحجاب), and the misery of grasping effort. We seek refuge in God from that.

He then offered a similitude for the works of the disbelievers.

3:117 · The wind that destroys a harvest; sincerity and the diseases of deeds

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 398–399

مَثَلُ ما يُنْفِقُونَ فِي هذِهِ الْحَياةِ الدُّنْيا كَمَثَلِ رِيحٍ فِيها صِرٌّ أَصابَتْ حَرْثَ قَوْمٍ ظَلَمُوا أَنْفُسَهُمْ فَأَهْلَكَتْهُ وَما ظَلَمَهُمُ اللَّهُ وَلكِنْ أَنْفُسَهُمْ يَظْلِمُونَ (117)

117. The likeness of what they spend in this worldly life is that of a wind bearing a bitter cold, striking the cultivation of people who wronged themselves and destroying it. God did not wrong them; rather, they wrong themselves.

Language · An implied verb of destruction and the meanings of ṣirr (صِرّ)

I say: An ellipsis (حذف) is present in the discourse: “The likeness of the *loss* of what they spend is like the *destruction* brought about by a wind,” and so forth. The **ṣirr** (الصِّرّ) is piercing cold. Or the phrase signifies a wind containing a sound and cold; or a scorching, poisonous hot wind (السموم الحارة). T111

Outward commentary · The expenditure that yields no lasting benefit

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: What the unbelievers expend, whether as a devotional offering (قربة) or for boasting and reputation (مفاخرة وسمعة); or what the lowly among the Jews expend upon their learned authorities; or what the hypocrites expend ostentatiously (رياء) or out of fear—is like a wind containing severe cold that strikes the cultivated land (حَرْث) of some people, that is, their growing crops, and ruins and destroys them. The intended comparison is between their expenditure and deeds, in their perishing, being wasted and bringing them no benefit, and the cultivation of unbelievers struck by a freezing wind that lays it waste. It becomes a smooth, bare expanse, yielding no benefit in this world or the next. God did

not wrong them by letting their works go to waste without a cause: they wronged themselves by committing the unbelief that made their works fruitless. [T112]

Spiritual allusion · Acts unpurified by sincere intention

Whoever has not realized the station of sincerity (مقام الإخلاص) and has not accompanied the people of purification and special spiritual realization (أهل التخليص والاختصاص) cannot keep his works free of hidden defects (علل), nor his spiritual states free of adulteration (دخل). His works are empty and light; the slightest wind uproots them and casts them down from the rank of being taken into account. Ordinary people have long said: “What is sound stays sound; what is hollow the wind carries away.” And success is through God.

The Real then warned against association with people who bring about confusion and mixture.

3:118–120 · Intimate confidants, the concealment of enmity and the safeguarding of spiritual secrets

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 399–401

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا تَتَّخِذُوا بِطانَةً مِنْ دُونِكُمْ لا يَأْلُونَكُمْ خَبالاً وَدُّوا ما عَنِتُّمْ قَدْ بَدَتِ الْبَغْضاءُ مِنْ أَفْواهِهِمْ وَما تُخْفِي صُدُورُهُمْ أَكْبَرُ قَدْ بَيَّنَّا لَكُمُ الْآياتِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ تَعْقِلُونَ (118) ها أَنْتُمْ أُولاءِ تُحِبُّونَهُمْ وَلا يُحِبُّونَكُمْ وَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِالْكِتابِ كُلِّهِ وَإِذا لَقُوكُمْ قالُوا آمَنَّا وَإِذا خَلَوْا عَضُّوا عَلَيْكُمُ الْأَنامِلَ مِنَ الْغَيْظِ قُلْ مُوتُوا بِغَيْظِكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلِيمٌ بِذاتِ الصُّدُورِ (119) إِنْ تَمْسَسْكُمْ حَسَنَةٌ تَسُؤْهُمْ وَإِنْ تُصِبْكُمْ سَيِّئَةٌ يَفْرَحُوا بِها وَإِنْ تَصْبِرُوا وَتَتَّقُوا لا يَضُرُّكُمْ كَيْدُهُمْ شَيْئاً إِنَّ اللَّهَ بِما يَعْمَلُونَ مُحِيطٌ (120)

118. O you who believe, do not take as intimate confidants those outside yourselves, who will spare no effort to corrupt your affairs. They wish you hardship. Hatred has already appeared from their mouths, and what their breasts conceal is greater. We have made the signs clear to you, if you use reason. 119. Here you are: you love them, whereas they do not love you, and you believe in the entire Book. When they meet you, they say, “We believe”; but when they are alone, they bite their fingertips in rage at you. Say: “Die in your rage!” God knows what lies within breasts. 120. If something good touches you, it grieves them; if something bad befalls you, they rejoice in it. But if you are patient and mindful of God, their plotting will not harm you in the least. God encompasses all that they do.

Language · Biṭāna (بِطانة), alw (أَلْو), ʿanat (عَنَت), and the jussive lā yaḍurrukum

I say: A man’s **biṭāna** (بطانة) comprises his intimates, whom he allows to see his inner affairs and secrets. The word is derived by comparison with the garment next to his belly—the inner garment (شِعار). The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said, as quoted here: “The Helpers (الأنصار) are the close garment (شعار), whereas other people are the outer covering (دثار).” This noun can designate an individual or a group, masculine or feminine alike.

Alw (الألو) means failing or falling short. Ordinarily the verb is construed with a preposition: “I do not fall short *in* counselling you” (لا آلو في نصحك). Here it is made to govern two objects, as in “I will not deprive you of counsel” (لا آلوك نصحاً), through its implication of preventing or diminishing. **Khabāl** (الخبال) is corruption or ruin.

In “what brings you hardship” (ما عنتم), **mā** (ما) is a particle converting the clause to a verbal-noun sense (مصدرية); **ʿanat** (العنت) signifies fatigue and hardship. **Anāmil** (الأنامل) is the plural of **anmula** (أنملة), pronounced with either ḍamma or fatḥa on the mīm. **Ḍayr** (الضير) and **ḍurr** (الضر) mean much the same: their imperfect verbs are respectively **yaḍīru** (يضير) and **yaḍurru** (يضر). The latter occurs here in the jussive (مجزوم). Its underlying form is

yaḍrurkum (يضرُركم); the vowel of the first rāʾ is transferred to the ḍād and the remaining rāʾ is given ḍamma to agree with the ḍād's vowel, producing a phonetic harmony (مشاكلة). T113

Outward commentary · The reported setting and exposure of concealed resentment

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "O you who believe, do not take intimate confidants (بطانة)"—friends and chosen intimates to whom you disclose your secrets—from people outside your religious community, since "they will not spare any effort to corrupt your affairs," striving to introduce disorder through confusion and malicious tales, and revealing your vulnerable places to unbelievers. According to one report on the occasion of revelation, it concerned Muslims who maintained close ties with certain Jewish men through kinship and friendship. According to another, it concerned hypocrites whom some Muslims associated with closely. T114

He then describes them with qualities designed to repel such intimacy: "They wish you hardship," meaning your suffering, ruin and misguidance. "Hatred has already appeared from their mouths": signs of hostility have surfaced through attacks on Muslims, revelation of their vulnerabilities to the idolaters, or words of rage addressed to Muslims. The force of their hatred leaves them unable to contain themselves. "What their breasts conceal" of hostility and rancour "is greater" than what has slipped into public expression, because their spoken displays spring not from careful deliberation or free choice, but from overpowering rage. "We have made the signs clear to you," O believers—those indicating the need to avoid unbelievers and be loyal to the faithful—"if you understand" what has been set before you. 160

"Here you are," those being addressed: "You love them" because of marriage connections or friendship, "and they do not love you" because of your religious differences. Alternatively, you desire Islam for them, while they desire disbelief for you. You "believe in the Book," that is, in the category of revealed books—and "all of it," meaning all the revealed books—while they do not believe in your Book. How, Ibn ʿAjība asks, can you love those who reject your Book and Messenger? They also dissemble in your presence: "When they meet you they say, 'We believe,'" but "when they are alone"

160. Cairo editor, C400.1: Ḥanaq: intense rage.

they “bite their fingertips in rage” at the concord they see among believers and their own inability to gain satisfaction against you. This is a figurative expression (كناية) for the intensity of their resentment, even if no physical biting actually occurs.

The Real says to the Prophet, “Say to them, ‘Die in your rage!’” That rage can injure only yourselves—or remain in it until you die, for the strength of Islam will continue to grow until you perish. “God knows what lies in breasts”: the reality of the animosity and wrath in their hearts, or all the good and evil that hearts contain. This may be part of what the Messenger says to them; alternatively it may be God’s own renewed statement (استئناف): Do not be astonished that I disclosed their secrets to you, for I know even what lies more deeply hidden within them.

In the excess of their hostility, “If good touches you,” such as victory or spoils, it saddens them. “If something bad befalls you,” such as defeat, death, an enemy’s attack or dissension among you, they rejoice. “But if you are patient” in the face of their hostility and injury, “and are mindful of God” and abstain from what He has forbidden, “their plot will not harm you at all,” through God’s gracious protection promised to those who patiently persevere and remain mindful. “God is with the patient”; and “God is with those who are mindful.” Whoever has the Real with him cannot be harmed by anything. “God encompasses what they do”: the deeds of the unbelievers, their hatred and hostility, do not escape His knowledge, and He will recompense them accordingly.

Spiritual allusion · The discipline of confidence among the spiritually realized

It does not befit the people of special realization (أهل الخصوصية) to choose intimates outside their company from the common people (العامة) and unveil their secret (سرّ) to them. Indeed, divulging secrets, even when they are not secrets of special realization, betrays a weak intellect and poor judgment. Hence the saying:

> Whoever makes his private secret known to people
> Deserves to be branded upon the forehead.

To reveal the secret of Lordship (سر الربوبية) to those unfit for it, however, is forbidden. The common people stand opposed, in Ibn ʿAjība's spiritual analogy, to the people of special realization: they do not cease to sow corruption in their hearts and disperse their focused reflection. If they accompany them, they wish that the Sufis might live as they do, in hardship and the toil of secondary causes (تعب الأسباب).

If some deficiency or flaw appears among the spiritual poor (الفقراء), enmity appears in the critics' speech, and the feelings they conceal are worse. You, spiritual poor, desire good for them, yet they desire the opposite for you. You acknowledge their adherence to the revealed Law (شريعة), but they do not acknowledge your spiritual reality (حقيقة); instead they deny it to you. Some behave hypocritically: when they meet the people of special realization they profess belief and affection, but when alone with the crowd they manifest hostility and resentment.

If good touches you, O spiritual poor—honour, an opening (فتح), witnessing (شهود) or knowledge of God (معرفة)—it distresses them; if an ordeal or calamity befalls you, they rejoice. But if you patiently endure their harshness and estrangement, and guard against the perception of anything-other-than-God (شهود السوى) in them, their plotting will not harm you. "God encompasses all that they do." T115

Having concluded His reproach of the two People of the Book, the Real begins to rebuke some Muslims for the faltering that occurred at the Battle of Uḥud.

3:121–122 · Uḥud: consultation, steadfastness and the guides who prepare the soul for struggle

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 401–402

وَإِذْ غَدَوْتَ مِنْ أَهْلِكَ تُبَوِّئُ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ مَقاعِدَ لِلْقِتالِ وَاللَّهُ سَمِيعٌ عَلِيمٌ (121) إِذْ هَمَّتْ طائِفَتانِ مِنْكُمْ أَنْ تَفْشَلا وَاللَّهُ وَلِيُّهُما وَعَلَى اللَّهِ فَلْيَتَوَكَّلِ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ (122)

121. And [remember] when you went forth early from your household, assigning the believers positions for battle. God is Hearing, Knowing. 122. When two groups among you almost lost courage—though God was their Protector—and in God let the believers put their trust.

Outward commentary · The dispositions at the beginning of Uḥud

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: Remember, O Muḥammad, when you went forth early from your household—from ʿĀʾisha's lodging, where you were staying at Uḥud, having gone there with her—while you were "assigning the believers positions for battle," arranging the positions where they would stand and fight. "God is Hearing" of your utterances and "Knowing" of your sincerity.

Al-Wāqidī relates that the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, walked from ʿĀʾisha's lodging to Uḥud and arranged the Companions for fighting as carefully as one straightens an arrow-shaft. When he saw a chest projecting out beyond the line, he said, "Step back." The idolaters had encamped at Uḥud on Wednesday. Upon learning of their arrival, the Prophet consulted his Companions, and invited ʿAbd Allāh ibn Ubayy ibn Salūl for consultation—something he had not done before. [161] [162] [163] [164] [165]

Ibn Ubayy and most of the Helpers said: "Messenger of God, remain in Madīna; do not march out to them. By God, whenever we have gone out from it to meet an enemy, that enemy has inflicted losses on us; and whenever an enemy has entered it, we have inflicted losses on him. How much more so with you among us? Leave them! If they stay, they stay in a very bad place of confinement; if they enter, our men will fight them face-to-face, while our women and children cast stones at them; and if they retreat, they will go back humbled." The Prophet approved this judgment. [T116]

161. Cairo editor, C401.1: Qidḥ, with kasra: an arrow before its head and feathers are fitted.
162. Cairo editor, C401.2: In one copy: al-kilāb. Both forms are correct: kalb has the plurals kilāb and aklub.
163. Cairo editor, C401.3: Thalm: a break.
164. Cairo editor, C402.1: Laʾma, spelled with hamza: a coat of armour.
165. Cairo editor, C402.2: At the explanation of God's words, "Muḥammad is only a messenger" [3:144].

Other Companions urged him: “Messenger of God, lead us out against those dogs, so that they do not think we have proved cowardly or weak before them.” The Prophet replied: “I saw in my dream cattle being slaughtered, and interpreted them as men from my Companions who would be killed. I saw a chip at the point of my sword, and interpreted it as defeat. I saw myself placing my hand inside a strong coat of mail, and interpreted it as Madīna. If you think it best to remain in Madīna and leave the enemy where they are, do so.” T117

Some men who had missed Badr, whom God would honour with martyrdom at Uḥud, insisted upon marching out against the enemy. They pressed the case until the Prophet entered and put on his coat of armour (لأمة). When they saw him armed they regretted their insistence, saying: “We did badly in advising the Prophet when revelation comes to him.” They stood and apologised: “Do whatever seems best to you.” The Prophet replied: “A prophet should not put on his coat of mail and then take it off until he has fought.” T117

He departed after the Friday prayer and was at the ravine of Uḥud by Saturday, the middle of Shawwāl, in the third year after the Hijra. He took position on one side of the valley, with Uḥud behind himself and his camp, and straightened the ranks as already described. He appointed ʿAbd Allāh ibn Jubayr to command the archers, instructing them: “Drive them off from us with arrows; do not let them reach us from behind.” Then what God decreed came to pass, as will be related subsequently.

About one thousand men marched out with the Prophet for Uḥud. He had promised victory if they persevered. Upon reaching al-Shawṭ, a certain location [**Translator’s note:** The Cairo print spells the place-name الشواط (al-Shawāṭ). The reading al-Shawṭ (الشوط) used here is an explicit correction, supported by Ibn al-Mulaqqin’s *al-Tawḍīḥ*, XXI, p. 145, in its account of Uḥud.], Ibn Ubayy withdrew with three hundred, saying: “Why should we get ourselves killed?” Abū Jābir al-Sulamī pursued the men, imploring them by God for the sake of their Prophet and themselves. Ibn Ubayy answered, “Had we known there would be a battle, we would have followed you.” The clans of Banū Ḥāritha and Banū Salama were on the verge of turning back with him, but remained firm beside the Prophet. Thus God reminded them of His grace in the verse:

“When two groups among you almost lost courage, though God was their Protector”—He supported and protected the two from following the hypocrites.

Jābir said: “We would not be pleased if the verse had not been revealed, because of the words ‘God was their Protector.’” Banū Salama belonged to the Khazraj and Banū Ḥāritha to the Aws. “In God let the believers put their trust,” and not in anything else, for there is no other true Helper. [T118]

Spiritual allusion · A teacher maps the inward battle with the ego-self

Part of the vocation of spiritual teachers (شيوخ التربية) is to guide disciples (المريدين) in struggling against their own souls (محاربة النفوس), and to disclose to them the soul’s hidden plots and deceptions, thereby furnishing them with battle-stations from which to confront it. God observes their sincerity and intentions. Some grow weary, become exhausted, and return to the homeland of their habitual patterns (وطن عوائدهم); others persevere until they win the greatest booty and supreme felicity. As the poet says:

> They strove with all intensity, until most grew tired;
> But the one who carried on and endured embraced honour.

Someone said: “The travelers’ journeying (سير السائرين) ends with gaining the upper hand over their own souls. If they prevail over them, they arrive (وصلوا).” Some disciples experience weariness and faltering and contemplate withdrawing and turning back; then God makes them stand firm and grants them victory, and they catch up with those who patiently went before them. The chief resource of the disciple in struggling against his soul (مجاهدة النفس) is reliance upon God alone (التوكل على الله والاعتماد عليه). “A sign of success at the endings is returning to God at the beginnings.” “And in God let the believers put their trust.”

He then reminded the people of Uḥud of the victory granted them at Badr, despite their small numbers, to strengthen their resolve.

3:123 · Badr and the paradox of strength through abasement

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 402–403

وَلَقَدْ نَصَرَكُمُ اللَّهُ بِبَدْرٍ وَأَنْتُمْ أَذِلَّةٌ فَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ (123)

123. God certainly helped you at Badr when you were in a humbled condition. So be mindful of God, that you may give thanks.

Language · The well of Badr and the circumstantial clause

I say: **Badr** (بدر) is a well between Mecca and Madīna that belonged to a man named Badr, after whom the well was named. The expedition in which God gave His Messenger, blessings and peace be upon him, victory occurred at that place; the battle was accordingly named after its location. “While you were humbled” (وَأَنْتُمْ أَذِلَّةٌ) is a circumstantial clause (جملة حال) referring back to the object-pronoun **-kum** (الكاف) in “He helped you.” **Adhilla** (أذلة) is the plural of **dhalīl** (ذليل), just as **aʿizza** (أعزة) is the plural of **ʿazīz** (عزيز). [T119]

Outward commentary · Victory without the ordinary means of strength

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “God certainly gave you victory at Badr when you were humbled,” having neither riding animals nor much weaponry, while your enemy was strong in equipment and numbers. “So be mindful of God,” remain firm with His Messenger, and await God’s victory as He has accustomed you to do, “that you may give thanks” for the honour and triumph He has granted you, whereupon He will increase it, as He has promised.

Spiritual allusion · Created things hidden within their opposites

God, glorified and exalted, has placed things hidden within their contraries. Therefore whoever seeks honour and victory should realize abasement and destitution (الذل والمسكنة); whoever seeks richness should realize poverty (الفقر); whoever seeks elevation should realize lowliness and the laying aside of rank; and whoever seeks strength should realize weakness. And so it continues: “Realize your own attributes, and He will assist you with His at-

tributes” (تحقق بأوصافك يمدك بأوصافه). O company of disciples, be mindful of God and seek things in their opposites so that you may attain them; thank God for what He has bestowed and He will increase you from His grace and generosity. [T120]

The author next mentions the manner in which God assisted them at Badr.

3:124–125 · Angelic reinforcement at Badr and the unseen aid of spiritual endeavor

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 403–404

إِذْ تَقُولُ لِلْمُؤْمِنِينَ أَلَنْ يَكْفِيَكُمْ أَنْ يُمِدَّكُمْ رَبُّكُمْ بِثَلاثَةِ آلافٍ مِنَ الْمَلائِكَةِ مُنْزَلِينَ (124) بَلى إِنْ تَصْبِرُوا وَتَتَّقُوا وَيَأْتُوكُمْ مِنْ فَوْرِهِمْ هذا يُمْدِدْكُمْ رَبُّكُمْ بِخَمْسَةِ آلافٍ مِنَ الْمَلائِكَةِ مُسَوَّمِينَ (125)

124. When you said to the believers, “Will it not suffice you that your Lord should reinforce you with three thousand angels sent down?” 125. Yes indeed: if you are patient and mindful of God, and they come against you immediately, your Lord will reinforce you with five thousand angels bearing distinguishing marks.

Language · The position of idh and the meaning of taswīm

I say: “When” (إذ) is an adverbial of time (ظرف) attached to “He helped you” (نصركم) if we consider the reinforcement to have occurred solely on the day of Badr. Alternatively, it is a substitute (بدل) for “when you went forth” (إذ غدوت) if we consider the reinforcement to have been promised at Uḥud *conditional upon patience*. When they failed to remain patient, it did not take place. **Taswīm** (التسويم) means marking or designating (التعليم). [T121]

Outward commentary · The three and five thousand angels

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: God certainly helped you at Badr "when you said to the believers," after they saw the many troops of the enemy and the fewness of their own equipment and numbers: "Will it not suffice you," in strength and numbers, "that your Lord reinforce you with three thousand angels," sent down within clouds? "Yes," that will suffice you as He has promised, provided that "you are patient" and stand firm, "and are mindful of God," and the enemy comes against you "at once" (من فورهم), meaning swiftly and at this very time, then "your Lord will reinforce you with five thousand angels" without delay or postponement, "marked out" (مُسَوِّمِينَ). They were marked with white turbans, except Gabriel, whose turban was yellow. Alternatively, they marked themselves or their horses. It is said that the horses had docked tails; or that they were piebald. **Translator's note:** These are differing transmitted descriptions, not a single established visual account. [T122]

If you ask: Why is only one thousand mentioned in Sūrat al-Anfāl, whereas here there are five thousand? The response is that God initially reinforced them with one thousand; their number then reached three thousand; and finally it rose to five thousand. Ibn ʿAbbās said: "The angels fought only on the day of Badr; on other occasions they are present at the battle with us, but do not fight." End of the cited report. [T122]

Spiritual allusion · Hidden lights, angelic support and an episode from the author's circle

Whoever turns toward struggling against his own soul for the sake of God (جهاد النفس), and occupies himself with the remembrance of his Master (ذكر مولاه), receives from God, inwardly, assistance in lights and mysteries (الأنوار والأسرار), and outwardly, the help of noble angels (الملائكة الأبرار). This, Ibn ʿAjība says, has been witnessed among the spiritual poor (الفقراء) of his own circle: when there were three of them, the common people saw thirty; when thirty, they saw three hundred. "We were once seventy on a journey, but people saw us as seven hundred, according to what they told us." "And God strengthens with His help whom He wills." [T123]

He then explains the wisdom of that reinforcement.

3:126–129 · Victory from God, the limit of Prophetic control and the stations of effacement and subsistence

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 404–405

وَما جَعَلَهُ اللَّهُ إِلاَّ بُشْرى لَكُمْ وَلِتَطْمَئِنَّ قُلُوبُكُمْ بِهِ وَمَا النَّصْرُ إِلاَّ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ الْعَزِيزِ الْحَكِيمِ (126) لِيَقْطَعَ طَرَفاً مِنَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا أَوْ يَكْبِتَهُمْ فَيَنْقَلِبُوا خائِبِينَ (127) لَيْسَ لَكَ مِنَ الْأَمْرِ شَيْءٌ أَوْ يَتُوبَ عَلَيْهِمْ أَوْ يُعَذِّبَهُمْ فَإِنَّهُمْ ظالِمُونَ (128) وَلِلَّهِ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ يَغْفِرُ لِمَنْ يَشاءُ وَيُعَذِّبُ مَنْ يَشاءُ وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (129)

126. God made it only glad tidings for you, so that your hearts might be at rest through it. Victory is only from God, the Mighty, the Wise—127. that He might cut off a portion of those who disbelieve, or suppress them so that they turn back frustrated. 128. You have no part in deciding the matter, whether He turns toward them in mercy or chastises them; they are wrongdoers. 129. To God belongs whatsoever is in the heavens and whatsoever is on the earth. He forgives whom He wills and chastises whom He wills; God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language · An inserted clause between coordinated possibilities

I say: “You have no part in the matter” (ليس لك من الأمر شيء) is a parenthetical clause (جملة معترضة) inserted between “or suppress them” (أو يكبتهم) and “or turn toward them” (أو يتوب عليهم). Alternatively, the particle **aw** (أو) may carry the force of “except” (إلا): “You have no part in the matter, except that if He accepts their repentance you may bring them glad tidings, or if He punishes them you may take satisfaction in their punishment.” This second grammatical account is attributed to al-Bayḍāwī. [T124]

Outward commentary · The means of victory and the Prophet's relation to his enemies

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: God made the reinforcement only "glad tidings" of victory, so that your hearts might rest secure through it and you stand firm in battle. "Victory is only from God": He can give you victory without any intermediary, but He desired to reward you and to ascribe distinction to you by causing the enemies to be killed at your hands. He is Mighty (عزيز), none can overcome Him, and Wise (حكيم) in what He determines and orders. He gave victory at Badr "to cut off a portion of those who disbelieve," killing some and taking others captive—seventy, he reports, being killed that day and seventy taken prisoner—or "to suppress them," distressing and enraging them. **Kabṭ** (الكبت) is intense rage: "so they return frustrated," their hopes unfulfilled.

When the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, was wounded in the face, cut near his eyebrow and suffered a broken front tooth, he intended to pray against the unbelievers—indeed, he prayed against them. God then revealed: "You have no part in the matter." You are only a messenger sent to them, charged with warning them and struggling against them, while their destiny rests in the hands of their Owner. If He wills, He guides them; if He wills, He punishes them. God forbade him to call down punishment on them because He knew that some of them would accept Islam and strive in God's way. Ibn ʿAjība says that this did happen: most entered Islam and fought in its cause, including Khālid ibn al-Walīd, "God's sword upon His earth." T125

The phrase "or He turns toward them in mercy" is then coordinated with "to cut off a portion of those who disbelieve or suppress them": He may accept their repentance if they submit, "or chastise them" if they do not, "for they are wrongdoers," having incurred punishment through their injustice. All matters rest in God's hands: "To God belongs whatsoever is in the heavens and whatsoever is on the earth," by creation, ownership and servitude. "He forgives whom He wills" to forgive "and chastises whom He wills" to chastise; nothing is incumbent upon Him. "God is Forgiving, Merciful" to His servants, so do not hasten to call down punishment on them.

Spiritual allusion · Affliction as preparation for freedom from dependence

The support (التأييد) that God sends down upon the people of detachment (أهل التجريد), when He confronts them with trial and hardship in order to bring them to the purity of tawḥīd (صفاء التوحيد), is only glad tidings of their spiritual opening (فتح), and serves to give their hearts repose in knowing Him. Secure establishment (الامتكان) comes in proportion to testing (الامتحان); every ordeal adds to one's capacity to stand firm (مكنة).

This is God's practice with His friends: at their beginnings He grants other creatures power over them and intensifies their trials until they have been purified of their residues (البقايا) and their merits have reached completion. Then He restrains the harm, and Majesty (الجلال) turns to Beauty (الجمال). This is His solicitude for them and His victory for them over their own souls. All victory comes from "God, the Mighty, the Wise." T126

He does this "to cut off" from them some of the distractions and attachments (الشواغل والعلائق) that keep them from rising to the heaven of realities (سماء الحقائق). When the spirit lies at ease in the shade of honor and status (العز والجاه), it finds it hard to leave this world; when constrained and thwarted, it travels to the world of Dominion (عالم الملكوت). All matters are in God's hands. You, spiritual poor one, "have no part in the matter": you are commanded to set the means in motion, while God opens the door. You, spiritual teacher, likewise "have no part in the matter": you only give reminder, while bringing [them] to the goal rests with God. Neither grieve over what has escaped you nor exult over what He has given you. The Dominion of the heavens and earth is God's: "He forgives whom He wills and chastises whom He wills; God is Forgiving, Merciful." 166

[Translator's note: The printed phrase وعلى الله البلاغ is retained. Balāgh can denote reaching an end or bringing something to it, as well as conveying a message (Ibn Manẓūr, Lisān al-ʿArab, root b-l-gh, II:144). The present rendering follows the immediate context: the disciple sets the means in motion, God opens the door, and the teacher gives reminder. The same idiom appears in a travel anecdote quoted by Ibn al-Jawzī, *Talbīs Iblīs*, I:290: "Walking is my part; bringing me there is God's." This is linguistic

166. Cairo editor, C405.1: In [copy] A: "the means" (al-sabab), singular.

corroboration, not a claim that the anecdote is authenticated or is Ibn ʿAjība's source. The supplied object "[them]" makes the contextual interpretation visible; no emendation of the Arabic is proposed.]

Al-Qushayrī says: "He stripped him"—the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him—"of every other thing and cause, once He had made Himself known to him, telling him that he had no part in the matter." Then he says: "It is also said that at one moment He established him in a station in which he cast a handful of dust that struck every face, and God said, 'You did not throw when you threw, but God threw' [Q 8:17]. At another moment He said, 'You have no part in the matter.'" End of quotation.

The glossator explains that these indicate two stations: acting as God's deputy *through God* (نيابة عن الله بالله), and God acting in the place of His servant (نيابة الله عن عبده). The first is subsistence (بقاء), the second effacement (فناء), according to the gloss. I say: The first belongs to the station of expansion (البسط), and the second to that of contraction (القبض). Thus they have said: "When He expands [the heart], there is no destitution; when He contracts it, there is no power." God Most High knows best. [T127]

Since victory in striving is attained only through consuming the lawful (أكل الحلال) and obedience to the Most High, he introduces these matters before returning to the command to fight in connection with Uḥud.

3:130–134 · Usury, generosity, forbearance, forgiveness and the station of iḥsān

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 406–409

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا تَأْكُلُوا الرِّبَوا أَضْعافاً مُضاعَفَةً وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُفْلِحُونَ (130) وَاتَّقُوا النَّارَ الَّتِي أُعِدَّتْ لِلْكافِرِينَ (131) وَأَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُرْحَمُونَ (132) وَسارِعُوا إِلى مَغْفِرَةٍ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ وَجَنَّةٍ عَرْضُهَا السَّماواتُ وَالْأَرْضُ أُعِدَّتْ لِلْمُتَّقِينَ (133) الَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ فِي السَّرَّاءِ وَالضَّرَّاءِ وَالْكاظِمِينَ الْغَيْظَ وَالْعافِينَ عَنِ النَّاسِ وَاللَّهُ يُحِبُّ الْمُحْسِنِينَ (134)

130. O you who believe, do not consume usury, doubled and redoubled; and be mindful of God, that you may prosper. 131. And guard against the Fire prepared for those who disbelieve. 132. Obey God and the Messenger, that you may receive mercy. 133. Hasten toward forgiveness from your Lord, and a Garden whose breadth is the heavens and the earth, prepared for those who are mindful. 134. Those who give in ease and hardship, restrain their anger and pardon people: God loves those who do what is beautiful (al-muḥsinīn).

Language · Kaẓm (الكظم) as restraint and containment

I say: **Kaẓm** (الكظم) means restraining and holding back. Thus one says, “I sealed the water-skin” (كظمت القربة) when one filled it and stopped up its opening.

Outward commentary · Redoubled interest and the disposition of God-consciousness

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "O you who believe, do not consume usury" (الرِّبا) by increasing the debt when its due date arrives, "doubled and redoubled." Perhaps this specification reflects the customary practice at the time: when a debt fell due, the creditor would tell the debtor, "Either settle it or add to it." The creditor would grant repeated delays and repeatedly increase what was owing, until the debt swallowed all of the debtor's property. They were forbidden this. God then commends mindfulness (التقوى), which is enrichment in both abodes: "Be mindful of God" regarding what I have forbidden you, "that you may prosper" in this world and the next. T128

He then makes them fear the Fire if they do not desist: "Guard against the Fire prepared for the unbelievers." This also suggests, Ibn ʿAjība argues, that the Fire already exists, since something nonexistent cannot be prepared; that it is prepared for unbelievers primarily (بالذات) and for sinful people incidentally (بالعرض). Al-Wartajbī says the verse indicates that the Fire was not prepared or created *for believers*, but that God has warned them with it as a deterrent and admonition, just as a kind father may frighten his son with a lion or sword without intending to strike the child with the sword or throw him to the lion. In this interpretation the verse manifests gentleness and care toward His servants. End of quotation. T129

"Obey God" in what He commands and forbids, "and the Messenger" in what he legislates and establishes as Sunnah, "that you may receive mercy." Forms such as **laʿalla** (لعل) and **ʿasā** (عسى), "perhaps" or "so that," in such contexts indicate the assistance granted in reaching the end to which a path has been established.

Outward commentary · The immensity of the Garden

"Hasten" (وسارعوا), that is, make haste "toward forgiveness from your Lord," such as Islam, repentance, sincerity (الإخلاص), and all other obedient deeds entailing forgiveness. Nāfiʿ and Ibn ʿĀmir read the command without the conjunction **wāw** (و), treating it as a fresh sentence (استئناف). And hasten toward "a Garden whose breadth is the heavens and the earth"—if the one were joined to the other. Mention of breadth, rather than length, intensifies its vastness, because breadth is less than length. Another explanation says

this does not mean breadth in contrast with length, but simply extraordinary magnitude: it is as great as the seven heavens and seven earths could seem to you; its extent is beyond description. “Prepared” means made ready “for the mindful.” This, Ibn ʿAjība adds, proves that Paradise is already created and lies outside the present cosmos. T130

Outward commentary · Giving in ease and adversity

Then the Real describes the perfected attributes of those mindful people who will inhabit the Garden: “Those who spend in ease and hardship,” namely in prosperity and adversity and indeed in all circumstances, as is the way of the generous. The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is cited as saying: “The Garden is the dwelling of the generous.” Also: “The generous person is close to God, close to the Garden, close to people and far from the Fire; the miser is far from God, far from the Garden, far from people and close to the Fire. An ignorant but generous person is dearer to God than a learned miser.” And again: “Generosity is a tree in Paradise whose branches are in the world. Whoever clings to one of its branches is led by it into Paradise. Miserliness is a tree in the Fire whose branches are in the world; whoever clings to one of those branches is led by it into the Fire.” **Translator’s note:** These are reports quoted by the author, with their individual degrees of authenticity still to be established. T131

“And those who restrain their anger” (والكاظمين الغيظ): they desist from carrying it into effect despite being capable of doing so. He cites the Prophet as saying: “Whoever suppresses anger, while having the power to act upon it, God fills his heart with security and faith.” One poet says:

> When you become angry, be dignified, restraining wrath;
> Then you will perceive what you are saying and hearing.
> It is honour enough to persevere for an hour,
> For which God will be pleased with you and raise you high. 167

“And those who pardon people,” meaning those who have wronged them. The Prophet is quoted as saying of such people: “In my community these are few, apart from those God has protected, though they were many among the communities that passed.” T132

167. Cairo editor, C407.1: The two verses are by Abū al-Qāsim ibn Ḥabīb, as stated in the commentary al-Baḥr al-muḥīṭ, III:63.

Abū Hurayra related that Abū Bakr sat in the Prophet's company when a man came and insulted Abū Bakr. While Abū Bakr kept silent, the Prophet smiled. But when Abū Bakr responded to a portion of the abuse, the Prophet became angry and stood up. Abū Bakr followed him, saying, "Messenger of God, he insulted me while you smiled; when I answered him in part, you became angry and rose." He replied: "While you were silent, an angel was with you answering him. When you spoke, Satan came, and I would not sit in a gathering with Satan. Abū Bakr, three things are true: no servant suffers a wrong and pardons it without God thereby strengthening His support for him; no servant opens the door of begging to increase his wealth without God increasing his want; and no servant opens the door of giving or maintaining kinship without God increasing his abundance thereby." T133

"God loves those who do beautiful good (الْمُحْسِنِينَ)," who act well in their dealings with God and with God's servants. The definite article **al-** (أل) may be generic (للجنس), embracing everyone who practices iḥsān, or it may refer to a known class (للعهد), meaning those just described. T134

Spiritual allusion · The multiplication of sense-life as an inward form of ribā

Whatever increases the strength of sensory existence (مادة الحس) is, spiritually speaking, *ribā*: it multiplies the sensory realm and reinforces the substance of heedlessness (مادة الغفلة). The disciple (المريد) should not augment it or practise methods that cause it to grow, but should flee its three sources: direct engagement with the sensory realm, thought occupied with it, and speech about it with those devoted to it. Three things strengthen the inward order of meaning (مادة المعنى): companionship with those who live by inward meaning (أهل المعنى), reflection upon meanings (الفكرة في المعاني), and remembrance of God in the heart (ذكر الله بالقلب). T135

Be mindful of God when engaging with the sensible, "that you may prosper" through reaching the purity of spiritual meanings. Fear the fire of separation prepared for whoever rejects the special spiritual station (الخصوصية). "Obey God and the Messenger" in what they have encouraged, "that you may receive mercy," by enlivening your hearts and spirits with the mysteries of meaning. "Hasten" toward whatever veils your defects, until God's description conceals your description and His attribute covers

yours, thereby bringing you to Him through what comes from Him to you, not through what comes from you to Him. Thus you enter the Garden of direct knowledge (جنة المعارف), whose expanse of witnessing has no limit, prepared for those who guard against what is other than Him (المتقين السوى). Such people expend their very lives and property under both Majesty and Beauty (الجلال والجمال).

They "restrain anger," having mastered their selves and states, and "pardon people," because, in the uncompromising ascetic idiom quoted here, "the Sufi's property is freely available and his blood is without recompense" (الصوفي ماله مباح ودمه هدر). Some Sufis used to say: "If you wish to know the condition of a spiritual poor person (حال الفقير), anger him and see what emerges." The shaykh of our shaykhs said: "The pivot of Sufism (قطب التصوف) is: do not grow angry and do not cause anger." End of quotation. [T136]

These verses are ascribed to ʿUrwa ibn al-Zubayr:

> People, however noble their stock, do not reach honour
> Until they abase themselves before others, though they were mighty;
> And when they are insulted, their faces remain bright—
> Not the pardon of weakness, but the pardon of self-command.

"God loves those who do beautiful good": those who have attained the station of spiritual excellence (مقام الإحسان) and worship God through witnessing and direct vision (الشهود والعيان). Their good reaches those who wrong them and those who treat them well, humankind and jinn alike. Al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī said: "Iḥsān is for one's beneficence to be general, not like the sun, the wind and the rain"—meaning, as Ibn ʿAjība explains, not to favour one land and exclude another. **Translator's note:** Cairo transmits a negative comparison with the sun, wind and rain, followed by Ibn ʿAjība's gloss about favouring one land over another. An earlier version attributed to al-Ḥasan in al-Thaʿlabī's al-Kashf wa-l-bayān (Ibn ʿĀshūr ed., first edition, 1422/2002, III:167; printed page inspected) says that beneficence should be general and not exclusive, like wind, sun and rain. This is a material difference between the two texts. The translation retains Cairo's wording and explanatory gloss; independent manuscripts are needed to determine whether the change is authorial or arose in transmission. [T137]

Sufyān al-Thawrī said: "Iḥsān is not to do good to the one who does good to you; it is to do good to the one who wrongs you. Doing good to a benefactor is commerce, like the ready money of the market: take from me and give me in return." Al-Sarī al-Saqaṭī said: "Iḥsān is to do good when one can, for one cannot do good at every moment." They recited:

> The making of deeds of kindness is not possible
> At every moment and in every hour;
> So when the opportunity presents itself, hasten to it,
> Lest that opportunity disappear. [168]

Al-Wartajbī said about "Hasten toward forgiveness from your Lord and a Garden …": the Real knows creatures' ailments and their inclination toward what their lower selves desire, so He summoned them, through obedience to Him, toward these two aims—pardon and Paradise. He summoned the elect (الخاصة) to Himself, saying: "Flee to God" [Q 51:50]. He then showed that all beings lie within the ordeal of culpability. Through the verse, he attributed a fault to everyone: though some are protected from slipping, their deficiency is their inadequate recognition of the full majesty due to God. As the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, said: "Were God to punish the angels, He would be justified." It was asked, "But they are protected from sin." He replied, blessings and peace be upon him: "Because of how little they know their Lord." Accordingly He called them to forgiveness. **Translator's note:** The quotation and its attribution to the Prophet reproduce the author's cited exposition. The dialogue also appears in Rūzbihān's *ʿArāʾis al-bayān* (al-Mazīdī ed., 1429/2008, I:196; printed page inspected). Its modern footnote cites Ibn ʿAjība's *Baḥr* (1/336), so that note supplies no independent authentication. The Cairo editor likewise reports that he did not locate the report. T138 [169]

[Translator's note: The Arabic repeats عِلَل and العلتين (ʿilal, "ailments," and al-ʿillatayn, "the two motives/causes"). Rūzbihān's fuller source passage contrasts these desired benefits with seeking God Himself and then calls seeking forgiveness a pursuit of the self's portion (*ʿArāʾis al-bayān*, al-Mazīdī ed., first edition, 1429/2008, I:196, on 3:133;

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168. Cairo editor, C408.1: The verses are by Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Ḥimmānī, as al-Qurṭubī states in his commentary.

169. Cairo editor, C409.1: I have not located it. Al-Muttaqī al-Hindī mentions in al-Kanz the report: "Were God to punish the inhabitants of His heavens and earth, He would punish them without wronging them; and were He to show them mercy, His mercy would be better for them than their deeds…." He attributes it to Aḥmad, ʿAbd ibn Ḥumayd, al-Tirmidhī and Ibn Ḥibbān. See al-Kanz, I:130, no. 613.

printed page inspected). Thus “aims” here carries a suggestion of motives that still concern the self. The prepositions distinguish the means—obedience—from the two ends sought.]

The marginal commentator explains: saying that the verse attributes a fault to all creatures refers to the inclusion, in “He forgives whom He wills,” of those in the heavens, which includes the angels. Forgiveness presupposes fault, but each creature has a deficiency appropriate to it. The summons to forgiveness is apparently taken from “Hasten toward forgiveness from your Lord,” with its address understood to include those in heaven. Even the angels may be thought of as judging by outward appearances, disagreeing and disputing, matters that allow for error and occasion forgiveness. Moreover, falling short of knowing the full measure of God’s Majesty is a shortcoming no creature can escape, for comprehending Him through knowledge is impossible. For this reason there can never, for all eternity, be a final limit to advancement in knowledge of Him (الترقي في المعرفة). End of marginal gloss. [T139]

He next describes the condition of the People of the Right (أهل اليمين).

3:135–136 · Repentance, persistence in sin and eight named fruits of spiritual witnessing

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 409–411

وَالَّذِينَ إِذا فَعَلُوا فاحِشَةً أَوْ ظَلَمُوا أَنْفُسَهُمْ ذَكَرُوا اللَّهَ فَاسْتَغْفَرُوا لِذُنُوبِهِمْ وَمَنْ يَغْفِرُ الذُّنُوبَ إِلاَّ اللَّهُ وَلَمْ يُصِرُّوا عَلى ما فَعَلُوا وَهُمْ يَعْلَمُونَ (135) أُولئِكَ جَزاؤُهُمْ مَغْفِرَةٌ مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ وَجَنَّاتٌ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ خالِدِينَ فِيها وَنِعْمَ أَجْرُ الْعامِلِينَ (136)

135. And those who, when they commit an indecency or wrong themselves, remember God and seek forgiveness for their sins—and who forgives sins but God?—and do not knowingly persist in what they have done: 136. Their

recompense is forgiveness from their Lord and Gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding therein. How excellent is the reward of those who work!

Theology · Indecency, wrongdoing and the refusal to persist in sin

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Those who, when they commit an indecency (فاحشة),” that is, an act of extreme obscenity or ugliness, such as illicit sexual intercourse (الزنا), “or wrong themselves,” through any sin whatsoever. This may distinguish major and minor sins; or an indecency affecting another person as against wrongdoing confined to oneself; or indecency enacted through deeds as against wrongdoing committed in speech.

“They remember God”: His punishment, wrath and the Great Presentation (العرض الأكبر); or they call to mind that God will interrogate them, and that He observes them; or they remember God with the tongue. “Then they seek forgiveness for their sins” through remorse and repentance (الندم والتوبة). “And who forgives sins but God?” No one other than God forgives them. Its purpose is to describe the breadth of His mercy, the universality of His forgiveness and the encouragement to seek it.

“And they do not persist in what they have done,” that is, they do not continue in it without asking forgiveness. The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is quoted as saying: “One who seeks forgiveness has not persisted [in sin], even if he returns to it seventy times in a day,” provided that his seeking forgiveness is joined with remorse. Another reported saying runs: “There is no major sin in the presence of seeking forgiveness, and no minor sin in the presence of persistence.” Qatāda warned: “Beware of persistence: those who persisted before you were ruined by advancing further in disobedience to God, without repenting until death came to them.” End of quotation. [T140]

“While they know” that persistence injures them; or while they know they have a Lord who forgives sin. The Prophet is quoted as saying: “Whoever commits a sin and knows that he has a Lord who forgives sins is forgiven, even if he has not expressly asked forgiveness.” A divine saying (حديث قدسي) is also cited: “Whoever knows that I possess the power to forgive, I forgive him and do not mind.” In some revealed books there is the declaration: “Son of Adam, so long as you call upon Me and place your hope in Me, I will

surely forgive you for whatever you have done, and I do not mind." Alternatively, "while they know" refers to their recognition that repentance erases sins. **Translator's note:** The reports are transcribed here as cited; the wording, attribution and transmission of each require independent hadith review. [T141]

"Their recompense is forgiveness from their Lord," the covering over of their sins, "and Gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding therein." The fact that Paradise is prepared for the repentant does not mean that it is exclusively theirs, just as the preparation of the Fire for unbelievers does not mean it is exclusively theirs. He then praises the recompense of the repentant: "How excellent is the reward of those who work!"

Contemplate the enormous distinction between those who practice iḥsān (المحسنون) and the People of the Right (أهل اليمين). Of the former He says, "God loves the doers of beautiful good"; of the latter, "How excellent is the reward of those who work." The people of the first verse belong among the beloved elect (خواص الأحباب), whereas those of the present verse receive their reward from beyond the door. God grants success, and He guides to the very heart of verification (عين التحقيق). [T142]

Spiritual allusion · People of spiritual excellence and People of the Right

For the people of the station of iḥsān (أهل مقام الإحسان), work belongs principally to the heart: generosity, forgiveness and restraining anger. For the People of the Right, work belongs to the bodily life, alternating between obedience and disobedience, heedlessness and wakefulness. When they commit indecency they repent and seek forgiveness; when they obey they rejoice and take comfort.

The people of iḥsān are absent from contemplating their works and their separate existence (غائبون عن رؤية أعمالهم ووجودهم). The People of the Right rely upon their works: when they obey, hope grows; when they slip, hope diminishes. The people of iḥsān are effaced from themselves (فانون عن أنفسهم), subsisting through their Lord (باقون بربهم); the People of the Right remain conscious of their individual selves and observe their own works. The people of iḥsān are beloved (محبوبون), while the People of the Right are lovers (مُحِبُّون). For the first, formal marks and shapes (الرسوم والأشكال) vanish, and they behold only the existence of the Great and Exalted One (وجود الكبير

المتعال). For the second, the created world still stands as independently present before them and the suns of gnosis (شموس المعارف) are absent from their hearts. The people of iḥsān worship through witnessing and direct vision (الشهود والعيان); the People of the Right worship from behind the veil of demonstration and discursive argument (الدليل والبرهان). From the viewpoint of those who witness directly, those who have only proof and argument are counted among the generality (العموم). T143

Spiritual allusion · Fruits of knowledge through witnessing: eight of eleven are given here

Know that the knowledge of witnessing and direct vision (معرفة الشهود والعيان) bears fruits and consequences (ثمرات ونتائج). One author has enumerated **eleven qualities**; Ibn ʿAjība states eight here and directs the reader to *Bughyat al-Sālik* (بغية السالك) for the rest. T144

First: Freedom (الحرية). The knower (العارف) becomes a solitary servant of the One Alone (فرداً لِفَرْد), without falling under the bondage of any existent thing, neither worldly aims nor aims attached to the Hereafter. Freedom thus means the ultimate refinement and purification of the self (غاية التصفية والطهارة). Someone said: "One who still has as much left to purify in his soul as can be sucked from a date-stone is not free." A slave buying his freedom through a manumission contract (المكاتب) remains a slave as long as a single dirham is outstanding.

[Translator's note: Cairo I:410 prints فص نواة (faṣṣ nawāt). The translation follows the source reading مص نواة (maṣṣ nawāt, "sucking a date-stone"), physically verified in al-Sāḥilī's *Bughyat al-sālik* (al-Mazīdī ed., Beirut, 1440/2019, p. 258). The earlier *Risāla* of al-Qushayrī, chapter on freedom (II:372, Dār al-Maʿārif; electronic primary text), likewise has *maṣṣ* in a question put to al-Junayd and follows it with the manumission comparison. An electronic *Bughya* apparatus reports omission of *maṣṣ* in witness B; that apparatus is not reproduced in the 2019 edition, and no image of B has been checked. The English expands the image of the slightest remaining worldly attachment. This remains a disclosed source-based correction of Cairo, not manuscript proof of Ibn ʿAjība's wording; *faṣṣ* is preserved in the Arabic transcription.]

Second: Finding or realization (الوجود). Attainment of the reality of things in their origin (الفوز بحقيقة الأشياء في الأصل), namely realizing a station in which formal traces (الرسوم) are effaced through total immersion in the pre-eternal Reality (الحقيقة الأزلية).

Third: Complete gathering (الجمع الأتم). A state that entails ceasing to indicate by signs and passing beyond visible indicators and marks (الأمارات والعلامات), after stable realization (التمكين) and freedom from variability of spiritual state (التلوين).

Fourth: Sobriety (الصحو). The stabilized and enduring state of witnessing (تمكين حال المشاهدة واتصالها), in which the spirit is healed of the piercing shocks of bewilderment (الدَّهَش). Sobriety does not reach perfection unless the spirit is enlivened through the continual influx of gathering (وارد الجمع الدائم).

Fifth: Verification (التحقيق). Arrival at knowledge of God that cannot be grasped through the senses: the spiritual draught is purified "from the Real, through the Real, within the Real" (من الحق بالحق في الحق), until acts of witnessing fall away, verbal expressions lose their hold, and indicative gestures are effaced.

Sixth: Expansion (البسط). The freeing of the spirit through an unbroken witnessing of meanings when the containers of sense (الأواني) have fallen away. Ibn al-Fāriḍ says:

> Never has [this wine] dwelt with sorrow in one place for a day;
> Thus distress cannot remain where melodies sound.

Seventh: Veiling or disguise (التلبيس). The covering of spiritual mysteries (الأسرار) beneath the outward veils of causes (أستار الأسباب), so that the wisdom of the ordering of things may remain in place and the inner matters be hidden from the common people.

Eighth: Subsistence (البقاء). Emerging from the effacement involved in witnessing (فناء المشاهدة) into the abiding permanence of knowledge (بقاء المعرفة), without any setting that dims the sun of witnessing and without returning to the evidences of sense. Rather, it is a carrying-forward of

gathering (استصحاب الجمع), while the spirit takes delight in the sweetness of meanings. Thus the realized person is "separate yet near" (كبائن دانٍ). Consult *Bughyat al-Sālik* for the remaining qualities. And God grants success. [T144]

He then strengthened the hearts of the people of Uḥud after they had been broken by defeat.

3:137–139 · Lessons from earlier nations and strength after defeat

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 411–412

قَدْ خَلَتْ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ سُنَنٌ فَسِيرُوا فِي الْأَرْضِ فَانْظُروا كَيْفَ كانَ عاقِبَةُ الْمُكَذِّبِينَ (137) هذا بَيانٌ لِلنَّاسِ وَهُدىً وَمَوْعِظَةٌ لِلْمُتَّقِينَ (138) وَلا تَهِنُوا وَلا تَحْزَنُوا وَأَنْتُمُ الْأَعْلَوْنَ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ (139)

137. Ways of God have passed before you. So journey through the land and consider how the deniers came to their end. 138. This is a clear exposition for humankind, and guidance and an admonition for those mindful of God. 139. Do not lose heart and do not grieve: you shall be uppermost, if you are believers.

Language · Sunan (سُنَن) as paths and recurring precedents

I say: **Sunan** (السُّنَن) means paths that have been trodden; according to another explanation, it refers to the nations themselves. [T145]

Outward commentary · The fate of those who deny and the patience of those who believe

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: Before you, patterns (سُنَن) took their course among peoples who denied their prophets, and "you shall never find any alteration in God's pattern" [Q 33:62]. It belongs to His way that He gives them respite, leading them on by stages (إمهال واستدراج), until the appointed term He has written for them comes. Once it arrives, He destroys them and grants His prophets and their followers victory over them. After

their destruction, their ruins remain as an admonition to those who follow. “Journey through the land” and discover their accounts; “consider how the deniers came to their end,” those who denied their prophets before you. The same will hold in your struggle with those who deny you.

“This”—the reflection I have commanded you to undertake—“is an exposition for humankind,” for those among the disbelievers who wish to draw a lesson; and it is still further “guidance and admonition for the mindful.”

Then He consoled the believers and gave them glad tidings: “Do not lose heart,” meaning do not become too weak to fight your enemy on account of what has happened to you; “and do not grieve” over those killed among you. Ibn ʿAjība counts seventy Helpers and five Emigrants, naming Ḥamza ibn ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib, Muṣʿab ibn ʿUmayr (bearer of the Prophet’s standard), ʿAbd Allāh ibn Jaḥsh, ʿUthmān ibn Shammās and Saʿd, the freedman of ʿUtba, may God be pleased with them. Alternatively, “do not grieve” over lost booty. “You shall be uppermost”: the final outcome and victory will be yours, or you are already above them in rank because you stand upon the truth and fight for God, your dead enter Paradise, while they stand upon falsehood and fight for Satan and their dead enter the Fire. Do not fail in your striving “if you are believers,” for faith entails a heart strengthened by trusting and relying upon God—or if you believe what I promised of elevation and victory. God knows best. [T146]

Spiritual allusion · The trials of the saints and the perseverance of disciples

Before you, O disciples (المريدون), God’s established ways took effect among His friends (أوليائه) and those ordinary servants who rejected them. Such people were kept far from the court of His Presence and deprived of the solicitude He had previously offered, until they died at a distance, their traces disappearing and their dwellings falling to ruin. Travel the earth and look at the fate of those who denied His friends: this is an exposition for those willing to reflect, and added guidance and admonition for the mindful.

Do not grow weary, O spiritual poor (الفقراء), or weaken in the quest for the Real by turning back from earnestness and effort because of injuries inflicted by obstinate people. You are the higher ones through divine help, reinforcement and the elevation of your ranks among the elect of the people of tawḥīd (خواص أهل التوحيد), if you truly believe the promise of the Glorious

King. Whoever seeks God finds Him, and He fulfils what He has pledged—but only after one has drunk the bitter cups of patience and maintained praise and gratitude. They recite:

> Do not suppose glory is a ripe date you merely eat;
> You shall not attain glory until you lick bitter patience. [170]

He then consoled them by recalling that those who had denied them had likewise suffered injury.

3:140–143 · The alternation of fortune, testing and the meaning of perseverance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 412–414

إِنْ يَمْسَسْكُمْ قَرْحٌ فَقَدْ مَسَّ الْقَوْمَ قَرْحٌ مِثْلُهُ وَتِلْكَ الْأَيَّامُ نُداوِلُها بَيْنَ النَّاسِ وَلِيَعْلَمَ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَيَتَّخِذَ مِنْكُمْ شُهَداءَ وَاللَّهُ لا يُحِبُّ الظَّالِمِينَ (140) وَلِيُمَحِّصَ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَيَمْحَقَ الْكافِرِينَ (141) أَمْ حَسِبْتُمْ أَنْ تَدْخُلُوا الْجَنَّةَ وَلَمَّا يَعْلَمِ اللَّهُ الَّذِينَ جاهَدُوا مِنْكُمْ وَيَعْلَمَ الصَّابِرِينَ (142) وَلَقَدْ كُنْتُمْ تَمَنَّوْنَ الْمَوْتَ مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ تَلْقَوْهُ فَقَدْ رَأَيْتُمُوهُ وَأَنْتُمْ تَنْظُرُونَ (143)

140. If a wound touches you, a like wound has already touched the other people. Such days We cause to alternate among humankind, so that God may make manifest those who believe and take witnesses from among you —and God does not love wrongdoers—141. and so that God may purify those who believe and wipe out the disbelievers. 142. Or did you imagine that you would enter the Garden before God had made manifest those

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170. Cairo editor, C412.1: The verse is by al-Sulamī.

among you who strove and made manifest those who were patient? 143. You used to wish for death before you met it; now you have seen it with your own eyes.

Language · Qarḥ (قَرْح), alternation of victory and the syntax of purpose

I say: **Qarḥ** (القرح), pronounced with fatḥa or ḍamma, means a wound. Alternatively, with fatḥa it is a wound and with ḍamma the pain and suffering of that wound. **Mudāwala** (المداولة) is the form expressing reciprocal action (مفاعلة) from **dawla** (دولة), a turn of victory or mastery. “These days” (الأيام) may be an adjective (نعت) or predicate (خبر), while “We cause them to alternate” (نداولها) may be the predicate (خبر) or a circumstantial clause (حال). “So that God may know” (وليعلم) is attached to an omitted expression (محذوف): “He did what He did in turning the fortunes of war so that He might know.” Or it may be coordinated with another omitted purpose: “We cause the days to alternate in order that such-and-such may happen, and that He might know ...,” indicating that there is more than one purpose and that believers’ sufferings involve benefits not fully known to us. “And know the patient” (ويعلم الصابرين) is in the subjunctive (منصوب) through an understood **an** (أن), the **wāw** (و) expressing accompaniment: the two acts of knowing occur together. [T147]

Outward commentary · The two battles and the alternating fortunes of nations

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “If a wound touches you” at Uḥud—whether through deaths or bodily injuries—“a similar wound has touched the other people,” your opponents, at Badr. If seventy-five of you were killed at Uḥud, seventy of them had been killed and seventy captured at Badr. Or it means that a similar injury touched them during Uḥud itself: at first you struck them and put them to flight, before disobeying the Messenger’s command, just as they later struck you. [T148]

“These days We cause to alternate among humankind”: We turn the possession of victory among them, giving it at one time to these people and another time to those. As the poet says:

One day is against us, another day is ours;
One day we suffer, another day we rejoice. [171]

The Muslims prevailed at Badr, and mastery was theirs; at Uḥud the idolaters prevailed. "Days" here may mean days of worldly life generally, or more particularly days of victory and mastery. God granted the idolaters a turn at Uḥud so that the believers might be distinguished from the hypocrites and their reality become publicly evident—"so that God may know those who believe," in the sense of their state being manifested to people—and "take from among you witnesses" (شهداء), those who died in holy striving and were honoured with martyrdom (شهادة). The idolaters' temporary success does not prove divine love for them: "God does not love wrongdoers." He permitted their advantage "so that God may purify those who believe," cleansing and refining them of sins. In turn, He grants the believers power over their opponents "so that He may wipe out the disbelievers." **Maḥq** (المحق) means the gradual diminution of a thing until it disappears. [T149]

Then He admonished the Muslims: "Or did you imagine that you would enter the Garden before God knew those who strove among you," knowledge manifest in actual events (علم ظهوره), "and knew those who were patient?" Do not imagine that you can enter Paradise in the way those killed among you have entered without displaying striving and steadfastness like theirs under killing and injury, until your striving and patience become apparent in the world.

"Before you went out to struggle, you used to wish for death," meaning for battle, since battle can bring death. You would say, "If only we could have a day like Badr!" Now you have encountered what you wished for and seen it at Uḥud "while you looked on" as your brothers were killed. Why did some of you lose courage and flee when you saw it? This was a reproach of those who insisted upon going out at Uḥud but then retreated from combat. Yet God subsequently restored them through repentance and pardon, as will be explained, God willing. God Most High knows best.

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171. Cairo editor, C413.1: The verse is by al-Namir ibn Tawlab, as given in Sībawayh's al-Kitāb, I:86.

Spiritual allusion · The testing of seekers as purification and disclosure

If a wound touches you, company of the spiritual poor, whether imprisonment, beating, detention, hardship or exile, a similar affliction has touched ordinary people. But through your knowledge of God within the affliction you advance toward Him, whereas they do not journey toward Him through it because they lack that knowledge. Or the verse can mean that a similar affliction touched earlier people of special spiritual realization (أهل الخصوصية): their example should reassure you. This is God's practice with His friends: He grants others the upper hand over them until they are cleansed and purified, and only thereafter grants them the upper hand. At first they are tested so that what remains of their attachments (البقايا) may be cleansed and their gifts completed; the sincere seeker is distinguished from the insincere, for love of God is accompanied by trial.

"He takes martyrs from among you" if they die in such tribulations, like al-Ḥallāj and others; or He takes witnesses of the Dominion (شهداء الملكوت) from those who persevere until they attain direct witnessing (الشهود). "God does not love wrongdoers," those who injure His friends: rather, He detests them and sets them far away. "So that God may purify those who believe" along the path of special realization: He gives people power over them to cleanse them of the residues of sensory attachment (بقايا الحس). "And He may wipe out" those who reject them by reason of the wrongs they commit against them. The author compares someone who rejects the spiritually affiliated (أهل النسبة) to a person who thrusts his hand into successive caves. Having emerged safe from the first two, he says, "Nothing in them can harm me"; he then reaches into a third cave, where a snake bites and kills him. T150 172

"Or did you think," disciples, "that you would enter the Garden of direct knowledge (جنة المعارف) before God had made manifest those among you who struggle against their own souls (جاهدوا نفوسهم) and those who patiently endure others' injuries?" You formerly desired the death of your ego-selves (موت نفوسكم) and sought what might help to bring it about. Now you have met Majesty (الجلال), seen it with your own eyes and witnessed what befell other saints. Why then do you panic at it and flee the places where it ap-

172. Cairo editor, C414.1: Ghīrān is a plural of ghār (a cave or hole); it also has the plural aghwār.

pears? The shaykh of our shaykhs used to say: “How utterly astonishing is a person who asks for knowledge of God, yet when God makes Himself known to him, he rejects Him.”

In the *Ḥikam* (الحكم) one reads: “When God opens for you a direction through which He makes Himself known (وجهة من التعرف), do not concern yourself if your work is slight. He opened it only because He wants to make Himself known to you through it. Do you not know that self-disclosure (التعرف) is what He brings to you, while works are what you offer Him? How incomparable are what you offer Him and what He brings to you!” And God grants success. [T151]

He then reproached them for the faltering that followed their hearing the news that the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, had died.

3:144–145 · The Prophet’s mortality, the field of Uḥud and dependence upon the One who does not die

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 414–416

وَما مُحَمَّدٌ إِلاَّ رَسُولٌ قَدْ خَلَتْ مِنْ قَبْلِهِ الرُّسُلُ أَفَإِنْ ماتَ أَوْ قُتِلَ انْقَلَبْتُمْ عَلى أَعْقابِكُمْ وَمَنْ يَنْقَلِبْ عَلى عَقِبَيْهِ فَلَنْ يَضُرَّ اللَّهَ شَيْئاً وَسَيَجْزِي اللَّهُ الشَّاكِرِينَ (144) وَما كانَ لِنَفْسٍ أَنْ تَمُوتَ إِلاَّ بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ كِتاباً مُؤَجَّلاً وَمَنْ يُرِدْ ثَوابَ الدُّنْيا نُؤْتِهِ مِنْها وَمَنْ يُرِدْ ثَوابَ الْآخِرَةِ نُؤْتِهِ مِنْها وَسَنَجْزِي الشَّاكِرِينَ (145)

144. Muḥammad is no more than a messenger; messengers have passed away before him. If he should die or be killed, would you turn back upon your heels? Whoever turns back upon his heels cannot harm God in the least, and God will reward the thankful. 145. No soul can die except by God’s permission, at a term prescribed in writing. Whoever desires the reward of this world, We grant him some of it; whoever desires the reward of the Hereafter, We grant him some of it. We shall reward the thankful.

Language · Kitāban muʾajjalan (كِتاباً مُؤَجَّلاً)

I say: “In writing, at an appointed time” (كتاباً مؤجلاً): **kitāban** (كتاباً) is a verbal noun (مصدر), meaning, “He wrote or decreed death as a writing whose time has been appointed.” T152

Outward commentary · A report of death does not abolish the message

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “Muḥammad is only a messenger,” susceptible to what befell the messengers before him: “Messengers have passed away before him”; he too shall pass away as they did, through death or killing. “If he dies or is killed, will you turn back upon your heels,” after his revealed Law (شريعة) has been established and his proofs made manifest? God rebukes them for the possibility of an actual reversal should the Prophet die or be killed—or for the remarks already made by certain hypocrites while the others remained silent. T153

According to the authors of the military narratives (أصحاب المغازي), the Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, marched to the ravine of Uḥud with seven hundred men. He appointed ʿAbd Allāh ibn Jubayr over fifty archers and instructed them: “Drive the attackers away with arrows so that they do not come upon us from behind. Do not leave your post whether we win or lose, for we shall remain victorious as long as you stay in your positions.” The Quraysh arrived, Khālid ibn al-Walīd on their right wing and ʿIkrima on their left, with women accompanying the forces. T154

When the fighting began the Prophet asked: “Who will take this sword and discharge its right?” A number of men came, but he withheld it until Abū Dujāna approached. “What is its right, Messenger of God?” he asked. He answered: “That you strike the enemy with it until it bends.” Abū Dujāna was courageous and moved proudly in battle. Taking the sword, he wrapped a red turban around his head and strode between the two armies with a swagger. The Prophet said: “God hates such a way of walking, except in this place.” T154

The Prophet and his Companions then charged the idolaters and put them to flight. Al-Zubayr said: “I saw Hind and her companions fleeing up the mountain.” When the archers saw the enemy retreat, they cried, “The spoils! The spoils!” Some among them warned: “Do not abandon the Prophet’s instruction!” Most paid no heed and left. Seeing that few archers re-

mained, Khālid called his cavalry of the idolaters, charged the Muslims from the rear and killed ʿAbd Allāh ibn Jubayr. Men became entangled in the confusion and some killed others of their own side. [173]

ʿAbd Allāh ibn Qamiʾa al-Ḥārithī struck the Prophet with a stone, breaking his nose and an incisor, wounding his face and breaking the helmet upon his head. Muṣʿab ibn ʿUmayr, who carried the standard, defended him, but Ibn Qamiʾa killed Muṣʿab believing he had killed the Prophet. He returned to his people crying, "I have killed Muḥammad." Another cry spread: "Muḥammad has died!" Some said the cry came from Satan. The Muslim fighters fell back. The Messenger called, "Come to me, servants of God!" Thirty Companions rallied around him, formed a protective ring and drove off the idolaters. Ṭalḥa ibn ʿUbayd Allāh's hand was wounded and became paralysed while protecting him; Qatāda ibn al-Nuʿmān's eye was struck so that it fell upon his cheek. The source relates that the Prophet restored it to its place and it became better than before. T155

The rumour of the Prophet's death spread. Some Muslims said, "If only Ibn Ubayy could obtain for us a guarantee of safety from Abū Sufyān." Some hypocrites said: "Had he been a prophet, he would not have been killed. Return to your former religion." Anas ibn al-Naḍr, the uncle of Anas ibn Mālik, replied: "If Muḥammad has been killed, the Lord of Muḥammad does not die. What would you do with life after him? Fight for what he fought for, until you die upon what he died upon." He then prayed: "God, I offer my apology for what these"—meaning the Muslims—"have done, and I dissociate myself before You from what these"—meaning the unbelievers—"have done." He took up his sword and fought until killed. May God show him mercy. T156

Concerning the hypocrites' speech God revealed: "Whoever turns back upon his heels," by abandoning his religion, "will not harm God in the least," but will only injure himself. "God will reward the thankful," those who thank Him for the gift of Islam by remaining steadfast, as Anas ibn al-Naḍr and others like him did.

"No soul can die except by God's permission": through His will and volition, or through His permission to an angel charged with taking that soul. Every soul has a named term within God's knowledge and decree; it cannot be

173. Cairo editor, C415.1: Bayḍa: a helmet.

delayed by an hour nor brought forward, either by holding back from battle or by plunging into it. This encourages steadfastness in fighting and promises preservation of the Messenger until his appointed term has elapsed. God has written death “as a writing with an appointed time”: its term neither advances nor retreats. T157

Concerning the archers who forsook their assigned position for the sake of booty, God revealed: “Whoever desires the reward of this world, We give him some of it; and whoever desires the reward of the Hereafter, We give him some of it,” a noble recompense. “We will reward the thankful”: those who truly thank God for His gifts, letting nothing divert them from striving in His path and desiring nothing but the pleasure of God and His Messenger.

Spiritual allusion · The death of a master and the independence of the disciple’s vision

The disciple should seek sufficiency in God (الاستغناء بالله), resting upon none other than Him. His spiritual insight (بصيرة) should penetrate so deeply that he is absent to the intermediary (الواسطة) through witnessing the One mediated (الموسوط). If his spiritual master dies, he will not turn back upon his heels. If he is firmly established in witnessing (الشهود), he has become independent of every created existent. If he has not attained establishment, he seeks someone who can bring him to completion. To remain fixed on the intermediaries is to remain at the gifts without witnessing the Giver (المنعم). He is not fully thankful to the Giver until nothing can veil Him from him. T158

When the Prophet died, people were stunned and bewildered because they stood at the gift and what they had witnessed of it. The Truthful One (الصدِّيق), however, had passed beyond witnessing the gift to witnessing the Giver. He addressed the people, saying: “Whoever worshipped Muḥammad should know that Muḥammad has died; whoever worships God should know that God is Ever-Living and does not die.” He then recited: “Muḥammad is only a messenger ...” down to “He shall reward the thankful.” These are those who pass through to the witnessing of the Giver and do not remain with the gift. T159

One of the knowers (العارفين) visited a spiritual poor man (فقير) and found him weeping. “Why are you weeping?” he asked. “My teacher has died,” the man replied. The knower asked: “Why did you make your teacher one who dies? Why not make your teacher the Living One who does not die?” He awakened him to the need to penetrate through to the Giver rather than stopping at the gift. For the authentic spiritual teacher is the one who makes his companion independent of the teacher himself and of all others by directing him to his Lord.

He then called them to patience through the example of what earlier followers had endured.

3:146–148 · The ribbiyyūn: steadfast followers, devotion after losing one’s teacher and competing Qurʾānic readings

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 416–418

وَكَأَيِّنْ مِنْ نَبِيٍّ قُتِلَ مَعَهُ رِبِّيُّونَ كَثِيرٌ فَما وَهَنُوا لِما أَصابَهُمْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَما ضَعُفُوا وَمَا اسْتَكانُوا وَاللَّهُ يُحِبُّ الصَّابِرِينَ (146) وَما كانَ قَوْلَهُمْ إِلاَّ أَنْ قالُوا رَبَّنَا اغْفِرْ لَنا ذُنُوبَنا وَإِسْرافَنا فِي أَمْرِنا وَثَبِّتْ أَقْدامَنا وَانْصُرْنا عَلَى الْقَوْمِ الْكافِرِينَ (147) فَآتاهُمُ اللَّهُ ثَوابَ الدُّنْيا وَحُسْنَ ثَوابِ الْآخِرَةِ وَاللَّهُ يُحِبُّ الْمُحْسِنِينَ (148)

146. How many a prophet was killed while many devoted followers were with him; they did not lose heart because of what befell them in God’s path, nor weaken, nor submit in abasement. God loves those who are patient. 147. Their words were nothing but: “Our Lord, forgive us our sins and our excess in our affairs, make our feet firm, and help us against the disbelieving people.” 148. God gave them the reward of this world and the excellent reward of the Hereafter; and God loves those who do beautiful good.

Language · Kaʾayyin (كَأَيِّن), ribbiyyūn (رِبِّيُّون), and qātala/qutila

I say: **Kaʾayyin** (كَأَيِّن) originally consisted of **ayy** (أي) preceded by **kāf** (ك), becoming a word meaning "how many" (كم). Its tanwīn was established as a nūn in a way that does not follow the usual analogy (على غير قياس). Ibn Kathīr's reading is **kāʾin** (وكائن), on the pattern of an active participle (فاعل). It can be explained by metathesis (قلب), the yāʾ coming before the hamza, yielding **kayāʾ** (كياء); when the yāʾ acquired a vowel and the preceding letter had fatḥa, it became **kāʾin**. These are two attested linguistic forms. One poet combined them in a single verse:

> How many an enemy (كَأَيِّن) we destroyed through our might,
> And how many a weak and fearful person (كَائِن) we protected.

Ribbiyyūn (الرِبِّيُّون) is explained as the plural of **rubba** (رُبَّة), meaning a company or group; hence "many companies fought with him." Other explanations make the word "devout, Godfearing scholars" (العلماء الأتقياء), or rulers (الولاة). The noun may be the subject (مبتدأ) of a new clause if one stops at a reading meaning "was killed" (قُتِل), or it may be the passive subject (نائب فاعل) of that form, or the agent/subject (فاعل) if one reads the verb in the active (بالبناء للفاعل). "Many" (كثير) qualifies **ribbiyyūn**, as in "and the angels, after that, are supporters" [Q 66:4]; a word on the pattern **faʿīl** can be predicated of singulars and plurals alike. [T160]

Outward commentary · The followers of former prophets

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: "How many a prophet was killed" in battle, with great companies or Godfearing scholars accompanying him, and they did not fail or grow weak. Rather, they stood firm in their faith and in their struggle against the enemy. Or the verse may be understood as: how many prophets had numerous devoted followers who were killed fighting alongside them? The survivors remained steadfast and did not grow languid or weak before the enemy. The first interpretation is strengthened by the cry heard at Uḥud that Muḥammad had died, for God set before them an exemplary contrast through "how many a prophet was killed"; the other is said to gain support from the assertion that no prophet was ever killed in open battle. [T161]

Alternatively, “How many a prophet fought” means that many devoted followers struggled alongside him; even after their prophet or some of their own number were killed, “they did not lose heart because of what befell them in God’s path.” They did not slacken or lose cohesion because of their prophet’s death or the killing of some of their men; “nor did they weaken” in fighting or adhering to their religion; “nor did they submit,” meaning yield to their enemy. Ibn ʿAjība connects **istakānū** (استكانوا) with **sukūn** (السكون), the stillness of someone who submits to an opponent and lets that opponent do whatever he wishes, regarding the alif as an added prolongation. Rather, they persevered, and “God loves the patient,” granting them victory, dignity and exalted standing.

“Their words,” when their prophet was killed and they had remained firm in his religion, “were nothing but: ‘Our Lord, forgive us our sins,’” meaning lesser sins, “and our excess in our affair,” the ways in which they exceeded the bounds through graver sins; “and make our feet firm” where footing slips in battle so that we do not flee; “and grant us victory over the disbelieving people,” our enemies. Why did you not do as they did and pray thus, O Companions of Muḥammad, blessings and peace be upon him?

“God gave them,” in recompense for seeking forgiveness and seeking refuge in Him, “the reward of this world”: victory, booty, honour and good repute; and “the excellent reward of the Hereafter,” everlasting bliss. The latter reward is specially called excellent to mark its superiority and the weight it carries with Him. “God loves those who do beautiful good (المحسنين),” those who stand firm in their religion, for they treated their Lord well by safeguarding His religion, and God therefore loved them and brought them near to His Presence.

Spiritual allusion · A disciple’s steadfastness after the death of a master

How many disciples and followers (المريدين والأتباع) have had their shaykh die or be killed, yet held fast to their path! They neither lost heart nor weakened nor submitted to those who would sever them from their Lord. Instead they patiently persevered in the journey toward God (السير إلى ربهم) or in the ascent through stations (الترقي في المقامات). Whoever had not yet re-

ceived complete guidance sought another to complete it. “God loves the patient”; and when He loves them, He becomes their hearing and sight, as the hadith puts it. [T162]

On losing their shaykh they had no recourse but to turn toward their Lord, seek forgiveness for the faults still remaining in them, and ask to be made firm upon the battlegrounds where they fought their own souls. God accordingly gave them honour in both abodes: honour in this world through faith and gnosis (الإيمان والمعرفة), and honour in the next through perpetual witnessing (دوام المشاهدة). Thus they were among God’s beloved: “God loves those who do beautiful good.”

God then warned them not to rely upon their adversaries.

3:149–150 · Allegiance under pressure and steadfastness in spiritual detachment

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 418–418

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا إِنْ تُطِيعُوا الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا يَرُدُّوكُمْ عَلى أَعْقابِكُمْ فَتَنْقَلِبُوا خاسِرِينَ (149) بَلِ اللَّهُ مَوْلاكُمْ وَهُوَ خَيْرُ النَّاصِرِينَ (150)

149. O you who believe, if you obey those who disbelieve they will turn you back upon your heels, and you will turn back as losers. 150. Rather, God is your protecting Master, and He is the best of helpers.

Outward commentary · Competing identifications of those to be obeyed

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: “O you who believe, if you obey those who disbelieve”—understood here as the hypocrites who, at the time of the defeat, said to Muslims, “Return to your former religion; if he had been a prophet, he would not have been killed”—“they will turn you back upon your heels,” away from your faith, “so you will return as losers,” seduced from your religion so that your works become futile and you lose both abodes. Rather, remain firm in faith: “God is your protecting Master (مولاكم)”; He will grant you help and honour, “and He is the best of helpers.”

According to another explanation: if you seek reassurance and protection from Abū Sufyān and his followers and rely upon them, they will bring you back to their religion. Or the wording is general: obeying unbelievers and submitting to their decisions leads to agreement with them in religion, particularly when the dependence extends over a long period. T163

I say: This is the cause of the apostasy of the Muslims who remained in al-Andalus, until they and their children became Christians. We seek refuge in God from an evil decree. **Translator's note:** This reproduces the author's historical generalization; it is not independently verified here for every surviving Andalusi Muslim or family. T164

Spiritual allusion · Steadfastness in tajrīd when the world calls one back

O disciples, especially those who have entered detachment (المتجردين): if you obey the common people and rely upon them, they will turn you back upon your heels, and you will become losers through seeking worldly life and occupying yourselves with its means. A foot slips after it had been firmly planted, and high aspiration (الهمة العالية) sinks into the low. Natures borrow from one another (الطباع تُسرق); a person follows the religion or way of his intimate friend (المرء على دين خليله).

Rather, remain firm in detachment (التجريد) and in realizing divine unity (تحقيق التوحيد), for "God is your protecting Master, and He is the best of helpers." He will help, honour and enrich you without dependence on external means, as He has promised: "Whoever is mindful of God, He grants him a way out and provides for him from where he did not reckon" [Q 65:2–3]. T165

When Abū Sufyān withdrew from Uḥud, he said: "How badly we acted! We killed the men and only a few remain. Let us return and destroy them utterly." God cast terror into his heart, as the following verse describes.

3:151 · Terror, idolatry, and the safety of the spiritual poor

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 419–419

سَنُلْقِي فِي قُلُوبِ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا الرُّعْبَ بِما أَشْرَكُوا بِاللَّهِ ما لَمْ يُنَزِّلْ بِهِ سُلْطاناً وَمَأْواهُمُ النَّارُ وَبِئْسَ مَثْوَى الظَّالِمِينَ (151)

151. We shall cast terror into the hearts of those who disbelieve, because they have associated with God that for which He has sent down no authority. Their refuge is the Fire; how evil is the abode of the wrongdoers.

Language · The pronunciation of ruʿb and the causal construction

I say: **Ruʿb** (الرُّعْب) is fear; its middle consonant may be pronounced with ḍamma or without a vowel (السكون), as with **quds, ʿusr, yusr** and other triliteral nouns with a vowelless middle consonant. In **bimā ashrakū** (بِمَا أَشْرَكُوا), **mā** is **maṣdariyya** (مصدرية), making the clause equivalent to a verbal noun.

Outward commentary · Fear caused by association without authority

The Real, exalted is His majesty, says: We shall cast terror and fear into the hearts of those who disbelieve, such as Abū Sufyān and his companions, so that they withdraw from you even without some outward cause. This comes because they associate with God that for whose entitlement to worship He has revealed no authority (سلطان) or proof (حجة). Their refuge and dwelling is the Fire. “How evil is the abode of the wrongdoers!” The explicit noun “wrongdoers” stands in place of the pronoun (إظهار في موضع الإضمار), making the reason for condemnation more forceful.

Spiritual allusion · God's protection of the spiritual poor

This offers consolation to the spiritual poor (الفقراء): whoever intends to injure them finds God casting fear into his heart, so that he cannot accomplish what he hoped against them. I have seen people resolve to kill, beat or imprison them, exerting themselves and fabricating what they considered

evidence entailing their execution. God sufficed them against such men, cast fear into their hearts, and they returned disappointed and died as wrongdoers. God is the protecting Friend of the Godfearing.

Then He reminded the believers of the victory He had promised them.

3:152 · The reversal at Uḥud: obedience, spoils and the conditions of arrival

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 419–421

وَلَقَدْ صَدَقَكُمُ اللَّهُ وَعْدَهُ إِذْ تَحُسُّونَهُمْ بِإِذْنِهِ حَتَّى إِذا فَشِلْتُمْ وَتَنازَعْتُمْ فِي الْأَمْرِ وَعَصَيْتُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما أَراكُمْ ما تُحِبُّونَ مِنْكُمْ مَنْ يُرِيدُ الدُّنْيا وَمِنْكُمْ مَنْ يُرِيدُ الْآخِرَةَ ثُمَّ صَرَفَكُمْ عَنْهُمْ لِيَبْتَلِيَكُمْ وَلَقَدْ عَفا عَنْكُمْ وَاللَّهُ ذُو فَضْلٍ عَلَى الْمُؤْمِنِينَ (152)

152. God certainly fulfilled His promise to you when, by His leave, you were cutting them down, until you lost courage, disputed over the command and disobeyed, after He had shown you what you loved. Some of you desired this world and some desired the Hereafter. Then He turned you away from them to try you. Yet He has pardoned you, and God is full of bounty toward the believers.

Language · Ḥassa (حسّ), the suppressed answer and wāw

I say: To **ḥassa** (حسّ) someone is to kill him, abolishing his sensation (حِسّ). The answer (جواب) of **idhā** is omitted (محذوف): “until, when you lost courage, disputed and disobeyed, We tried you by defeat.” The conjunction **wāw** (الواو) does not itself specify chronological order. The sequence of events is understood as: when you disputed, disobeyed and lost courage, We withdrew victory from you.

Outward commentary · The archers, the booty and divine pardon

God proved truthful in His promise of victory if you remained patient and mindful of Him: you were striking down your enemies with swords, killing and routing them by His leave and will. But then your resolution weakened, your judgment faltered and you inclined towards the spoils. The archers disputed whether to stay at their station after the idolaters fled. Some cried, “The spoils! The spoils! Why remain here?” Others replied, “Do not violate the Messenger's command.” Then you abandoned your station and disobeyed the Messenger, after seeing the triumph and spoils you loved, and at that point He tried you with defeat.

Among you were those seeking the world *in order to employ it for the Hereafter*—those who left their post for the spoils. Among you were others who desired the Hereafter without admixture: those who remained with ʿAbd Allāh ibn Jubayr in fidelity to the Messenger's command. God then turned you away from the enemy because you violated that command, to try you and disclose the patient and the distressed, the sincere and the hypocrite. Yet He pardoned you: He did not annihilate you after your disobedience and opposition, although you merited punishment; or He forgave your offence and favoured you with repentance and mercy. His bounty towards believers is immense: He favours them with forgiveness in every circumstance, whether fortune alternates against or in their favour; trial itself is mercy and purification. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Leaving the country of particular realization for ordinary life

The Real addresses the spiritual poor (الفقراء) who had approached the country of particular realization (بلاد الخصوصية) but then weakened and returned to ordinary existence (بلاد العمومية): God fulfilled His promise that you would attain the rank of the elect, if only you had persevered. While you struggled against the lower selves, cutting them down with the swords of contravention (سيوف المخالفة), the lights of witnessing (أنوار المشاهدة) flashed before you. But when you weakened, your hearts scattered, and you disobeyed your spiritual teachers, the reinforcements granted you diminished and your hearts darkened, after you had seen the beginnings of witnessing. You inclined to the vanishing world.

Among those affiliated to the path (المنتسبين) is one who desires this world and accompanies realized masters only precariously, "on an edge"; he is the one who turns back. Among them is one who seeks the Hereafter and relinquishes hope of returning to worldly preoccupation; he remains until he obtains the goal. God then diverts those still seeking the world away from the company of realized masters to test whether they accompanied them for God or another motive. Yet He has pardoned you and made you ordinary Muslims, without stripping you of faith as a penalty for abandoning the realized masters. Or His forgiveness is yours when you return to their company and observe good manners (الأدب). God is generous towards believers and does not hasten their punishment. And success is through God.

Spiritual allusion · Rūzbihān al-Baqlī on possession and transcendence

Al-Wartajbī [Rūzbihān] interprets "Some of you desire this world" as referring to those immersed in the ocean of pre-eternal richness (غنى القدم), established in it and seeing blessings with gratitude to their Giver, like Solomon. "And some of you desire the Hereafter" refers to those plunged in the ocean of transcendence (التنزيه) and the sanctification of pre-eternity (تقديس الأزلية), so overtaken by holiness and purity that they emerged in the guise of poverty (الفقر) and detachment (التجريد), affirming the unique pre-eternity of God apart from contingent being (الحدث), like Muḥammad, upon him blessings and peace, who is here quoted as saying, "Poverty is my pride[T166] ." [174]

He then specified the time of humiliation that required forgiveness.

174. Cairo editor, C420.1: The ḥāfiẓ Ibn Ḥajar said: "It has no foundation." See al-Asrār al-marfūʿa.

3:153 · Flight from the Prophet and flight from the teachers

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 421–422

إِذْ تُصْعِدُونَ وَلا تَلْوُونَ عَلى أَحَدٍ وَالرَّسُولُ يَدْعُوكُمْ فِي أُخْراكُمْ فَأَثابَكُمْ غَمًّا بِغَمٍّ لِكَيْلا تَحْزَنُوا عَلى ما فاتَكُمْ وَلا ما أَصابَكُمْ وَاللَّهُ خَبِيرٌ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ (153)

153. When you were fleeing far across the land, looking back at no one, while the Messenger called you from your rear, He repaid you with grief upon grief, so that you would not grieve over what escaped you or over what befell you. God is fully aware of what you do.

Language · Iṣʿād (إصعاد) and ṣuʿūd (صعود)

I say: **Idh** (إذ) is a temporal adverb (ظرف) related to “He pardoned” or to an understood imperative “remember.” **Aṣʿada** (أصعد) means to go far across the land; **ṣaʿida** (صعد) means to ascend a mountain. Accordingly **iṣʿād** (الإصعاد) is departing over level ground, and **ṣuʿūd** (الصعود) is rising to higher ground. Both readings have been transmitted, for both occurred: some fled over the land and others climbed the mountain. **Li-kay-lā** (لكيلا) is attached to **athābakum** (أثابكم).

Outward commentary · The griefs of Uḥud and the Messenger's constancy

God pardoned you as you fled the Prophet, moving away in defeat, without one of you turning toward or waiting for another. Yet Muḥammad, the Messenger, was calling to you from your rear guard: “To me, servants of God! I am God's Messenger! Paradise to whoever returns to the fight!” The account praises his courage and steadfastness: he stood at the rear of the retreating men, the station of heroes; flight is inconceivable in his case.

God "rewarded" you for flight with grief: the enemy gained superiority over you and your brothers were killed, because you caused grief to the Prophet through disobedience and flight. He ordained that this should befall you lest you grieve over missed booty or over wounds and defeat. One who understands that an offence deserves correction does not lament what he has lost or suffered, perceiving the affliction as less than his wrongdoing merited, and his burden becomes easier.

Alternatively, He gave you grief joined to grief: first the lost victory and booty, then death and defeat; or first the deaths and wounds, then the rumours that the Prophet had been killed. It was to accustom you to trials and hardship so that you would not panic when struck. Kaʿb ibn Zuhayr described such people in his *lāmiyya*:

> They do not exult when their spears strike home,
> nor do they panic when they themselves are struck.

One seasoned by affliction bears it lightly and is not undone by what he suffers or loses. God knows your deeds and intentions and recompenses you accordingly.

Spiritual allusion · The call of the spiritual guides and the grief of veiling

Inviters to God, bearing the inheritance of Prophetic spiritual education (أهل التربية النبوية), have never ceased calling people to God, teaching the way to Him and pointing them towards the very reality of realization (عين التحقيق). People nevertheless distance themselves and flee. The guides call behind them, by speech or by their state: "Servants of God, come to us; we shall make God known to you and guide you to Him." No one turns to them or looks towards them except those preceded by divine solicitude (العناية), whom the Real intends to bring to sainthood (الولاية). As the saying has it: "Glory be to Him who provided no proof of His friends save what is itself proof of Him, and who brought none to them except one He wished to bring to Himself."

For fleeing them, people receive the grief of being veiled (غم الحجاب), added to the grief of worldly causes (غم الأسباب). They do not grieve over the gnosis (المعرفة) they missed, because they never recognized its worth, or over the

heedlessness and idleness that befall them, because they do not notice them. God knows, O servants, whether your deeds proceed from affection or obstinacy. Success comes from God, the guide to the straight path.

God then sent security upon the people of Uḥud after their difficulty and ordeal.

3:154 · Security after grief, destiny and the rest of the realized

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 422–424

ثُمَّ أَنْزَلَ عَلَيْكُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ الْغَمِّ أَمَنَةً نُعاساً يَغْشى طائِفَةً مِنْكُمْ وَطائِفَةٌ قَدْ أَهَمَّتْهُمْ أَنْفُسُهُمْ يَظُنُّونَ بِاللَّهِ غَيْرَ الْحَقِّ ظَنَّ الْجاهِلِيَّةِ يَقُولُونَ هَلْ لَنا مِنَ الْأَمْرِ مِنْ شَيْءٍ قُلْ إِنَّ الْأَمْرَ كُلَّهُ لِلَّهِ يُخْفُونَ فِي أَنْفُسِهِمْ ما لا يُبْدُونَ لَكَ يَقُولُونَ لَوْ كانَ لَنا مِنَ الْأَمْرِ شَيْءٌ ما قُتِلْنا هاهُنا قُلْ لَوْ كُنْتُمْ فِي بُيُوتِكُمْ لَبَرَزَ الَّذِينَ كُتِبَ عَلَيْهِمُ الْقَتْلُ إِلى مَضاجِعِهِمْ وَلِيَبْتَلِيَ اللَّهُ ما فِي صُدُورِكُمْ وَلِيُمَحِّصَ ما فِي قُلُوبِكُمْ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ بِذاتِ الصُّدُورِ (154)

154. Then, after the grief, He sent down upon you security, a drowsiness enveloping a group among you; while another group was preoccupied with itself, thinking of God what was not true—the thinking of the Age of Ignorance. They said, “Do we have any part in the affair?” Say, “The whole affair belongs to God.” They conceal within themselves what they do not disclose to you. They say, “If we had any say in the affair, we would not have been killed here.” Say, “Even if you had been in your houses, those for whom killing was decreed would have gone forth to their resting places.” This was so God might test what is in your breasts and purify what is in your hearts; God knows what hearts contain.

Language · Nuʿās (نعاسًا) and amana (أمنة)

I say: “Drowsiness” (نُعاسًا) may stand as a substitute (بدل) for “security” (أمنة), or it may be the object (مفعول), with **amana** an anticipatory circumstantial accusative (حال مقدمة), or an accusative of purpose (مفعول له): He sent down drowsiness on account of security. It can also be a circumstantial expression linked to the pronoun **-kum** (كم) in “upon you”: He sent it while you were secure. **Amana** is a verbal noun (مصدر) from **amina** (أمِن), like **ʿaẓama** and **ghalaba**.

Outward commentary · Drowsiness among the believers, anxiety among the hypocrites

After the grief of losing your brothers and hearing rumours of your Prophet's death, God sent you security and tranquillity, to the point that drowsiness overcame you while still drawn up in battle. Abū Ṭalḥa said that sleepiness overtook them in the ranks so that a sword would fall from a man's hand, he would retrieve it, and it would fall again. Al-Zubayr said that amid the danger God sent them sleep and he heard Muʿattib saying, “If we had any part in the matter, we would not have been killed here,” as though he heard it only in a dream.

This drowsiness—or this security—overtook only one group: the believers. Another group, the hypocrites, were plunged into worry and sorrow by their own souls; or it means that they cared only for themselves, planning how to escape and survive; their hearts fluttered with fear, and sleep was impossible for them. They entertained false thoughts about God, imagining He would not help the Prophet, that his cause would perish, or that he had already been killed: the presumptions of the pagan Age of Ignorance (ظن الجاهلية). They asked one another whether they had any share in directing events, as though they had been deprived of all control over their own destiny. Ibn ʿAjība attributes this to Ibn Ubayy after he heard of Khazraj casualties.

“Say: the affair in its entirety belongs to God.” No management (تدبير) or choice (اختيار) lies in anyone else's hands. Meanwhile they concealed their unbelief and hypocrisy, saying privately that, had the choice rested with them, they would not have marched with Muḥammad only to be killed and lose their chiefs. Say to them: divine power brought you out under the

chain of decreed events (سلسلة المقادير), despite yourselves. Even if you had stayed secure in your houses, those appointed to die would have gone forth to their places of death (مصارع / مضاجع). God arranged events in His pre-eternal knowledge, and His judgment admits no reversal. He brought you to battle to make manifest what is in your breasts—good or evil—and to disclose what is in your hearts—hypocrisy or sincerity. Thus the corruption of their inner disposition and the malady of hypocrisy became visible. God knew what lay hidden before its disclosure; the verse contains promise, threat and the reminder that He has no need to learn through trial. Rather, He distinguishes believers from hypocrites and makes their conditions publicly apparent. Ibn ʿAjība cites al-Bayḍāwī.

Spiritual allusion · The composure of those who arrive and the worry of seekers without guidance

After the grief of spiritual struggle (المجاهدة) and the labour of vigilance (المراقبة), God sends security into the hearts of those who have arrived and become firmly established (الواصلون المتمكنون), and those wayfarers attached to them: peace in witnessing God, and rest in the bodily faculties after the strain of serving Him along the path. Having arrived, they sleep beneath the shade of safety and remain at peace in the vicinity of the Generous Bestower. One gnostic says: “When dealing [with God] passes into the heart, the limbs come to rest.” [175]

Such rest belongs to realized masters and disciples connected to them. Another group, however, are ignorant people who affect spiritual poverty (المتفقرة الجاهلون) without a spiritual teacher. Their selves consume their attention: at times they are overcome by them; at times they overcome them. At times the lights of orientation (أنوار التوجه) shine, and hope of opening (الفتح) grows strong; at others the lights are withheld and they think false thoughts of God. They ask whether spiritual opening is possible for them.

Tell them that the whole affair is God's: He brings to Himself whom He wills and keeps distant whom He wills. They conceal defects and harmful inner thoughts which they do not disclose. When opening is delayed and poverty weighs on them, they regret missing worldly ease and say, “Had we any

175. Cairo editor, C423.1: The meaning of this expression was explained earlier in the allusion on verse 212 of Sūrat al-Baqara.

choice, we would not have been killed here by humiliation, poverty and hunger.” Say to them: this was already in God's knowledge and none escapes it; the truthful seeker must be distinguished from the pretender. “Be truthful, and you will find a guide” (كن صادقاً تجد مرشداً): with sincerity He would have directed you to one who could bring you to Him and relieve the toil. God grants success and guides to the straight path.

Then He named the reason for the flight of those who fled.

3:155 · The slip of the archers and forgiveness after withdrawing from a teacher

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 424–424

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ تَوَلَّوْا مِنْكُمْ يَوْمَ الْتَقَى الْجَمْعانِ إِنَّمَا اسْتَزَلَّهُمُ الشَّيْطانُ بِبَعْضِ ما كَسَبُوا وَلَقَدْ عَفَا اللَّهُ عَنْهُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ غَفُورٌ حَلِيمٌ (155)

155. Those of you who turned back on the day the two hosts met—it was only Satan who made them slip on account of some of what they had earned. Yet God has pardoned them. God is truly Forgiving, Clement.

Outward commentary · The causes of the retreat and the delay of punishment

Those who turned back and fled when the two armies met at Uḥud did so because Satan caused them to slip (استزلهم): he sought to make them stumble and they obeyed him. He adorned flight for them because of some of the sins they had committed—disobeying the Prophet, being eager for booty, or offences committed before fighting. Acts of disobedience lead to further disobedience, just as acts of obedience lead to further obedience. Yet God pardoned their flight because they repented and offered their apologies. He forgives sins and is Clement (حليم), not hastening a sinner's punishment, so that repentance remains possible.

Spiritual allusion · A disciple's conflict and restoration through repentance

O spiritual poor, those who turned away from accompanying their teachers did so when two adversaries met in their hearts: one inviting them to remain, another urging return to ordinary pursuits. The latter prevailed and they withdrew. Satan caused their lapse through their poor manners (سوء الأدب). If they repent and return to the teachers, the teachers should welcome them and God accepts their repentance and pardons them, for He is Forgiving, Clement.

He then warned against resembling hypocrites in weakness of certainty and the language arising from it.

3:156 · Death, travel, destiny and the tranquility of acceptance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 424–425

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا تَكُونُوا كَالَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَقالُوا لِإِخْوانِهِمْ إِذا ضَرَبُوا فِي الْأَرْضِ أَوْ كانُوا غُزًّى لَوْ كانُوا عِنْدَنا ما ماتُوا وَما قُتِلُوا لِيَجْعَلَ اللَّهُ ذلِكَ حَسْرَةً فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ وَاللَّهُ يُحْيِي وَيُمِيتُ وَاللَّهُ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ بَصِيرٌ (156)

156. O you who believe, do not be like those who disbelieved and said of their brothers when they journeyed through the earth or went out to fight, “Had they remained with us, they would not have died or been killed.” Thus God makes this a cause of regret in their hearts. God gives life and causes death, and God sees what you do.

Language · Ghuzzā (غُزّى) and the historical present

I say: **Ghuzzā** (غُزّى) is the plural of **ghāzī** (غازٍ, one engaged in fighting), like **ʿāfin**/**ʿufā**. Here **idhā** (إذا) stands for **idh** (إذ) to represent a past event as if occurring before us (حكاية الحال).

Outward commentary · False counterfactuals about travel and death

Do not be like those who disbelieved and practiced hypocrisy, such as ʿAbd Allāh ibn Ubayy and his companions. They spoke concerning their brothers—brothers by kinship or creed, that is, on their behalf or about them—who had travelled for commerce or another purpose and died, or who had gone out on a campaign and been killed: “Had they stayed with us, neither death nor killing would have overtaken them.” Their utterance arises from corrupt belief (الاعتقاد الفاسد) and becomes a cause of remorse: grief for what has passed and regret for what never came to be. God gives life and causes death without a cause, whether one stays at home or journeys. No

precaution wards off destiny (لا يمنع حذر من قدر). He sees your deeds, believers; the statement therefore warns you not to adopt the same mistaken notion. With the reading in the third person (بالياء), the threat is directed towards the hypocrites. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The predetermined term and the release of anxiety

People strong in certainty should not resemble those weak in certainty—scholars, righteous people or wrongdoers—when they say of brothers travelling to a dangerous country or one afflicted by disease: “Had they remained with us, they would neither have died nor been killed.” They fail to realize that God has determined allotted lifespans as He determined livelihood, affairs and circumstances, and appointed their times in eternity. Every decree emerges at its appointed hour. As the saying has it: “No breath do you exhale but that it contains a decree carried out in you” (ما من نفس تبديه إلا وله قدر فيك يمضيه). What His prior knowledge has decreed must occur; what He did not decree cannot be brought about by motion or stillness.

The poet says:

> What is not decreed no contrivance can bring;
> what is to be will certainly be.
> What is to be will come at its appointed hour;
> only the ignorant are wearied and grieved.
> The greedy man runs but gains nothing through greed;
> the weak and the lowly may receive their share.
> So put away cares; strip off their garments,
> if you hold firm certainty in divine decree.
> Be at ease and place your trust in your Lord:
> the one realized in truth makes matters light.

Our master ʿUmar, God be pleased with him, used to recite these lines:

> Make things easier upon yourself, for their measures
> rest in the hand of God.
> What He turns from you shall never reach you;
> what He decrees for you shall never be far away.

Whoever has not realized faith in decree remains caught in remorse and distress. Whoever seeks enduring delight should cool the breast with acceptance (الرضا) and surrender (التسليم); whoever seeks ease and sweet repose should enter the gardens of gnosis (العرفان). Success is through God, the guide to the straight path.

He then encouraged them concerning death in striving, and preferred death more generally to worldly life.

3:157–158 · Death in God's way and the spiritual gain of meeting Him

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 425–426

وَلَئِنْ قُتِلْتُمْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ أَوْ مُتُّمْ لَمَغْفِرَةٌ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَرَحْمَةٌ خَيْرٌ مِمَّا يَجْمَعُونَ (157) وَلَئِنْ مُتُّمْ أَوْ قُتِلْتُمْ لَإِلَى اللَّهِ تُحْشَرُونَ (158)

157. If you are killed in God's way or die, then forgiveness and mercy from God are better than what they gather. 158. And whether you die or are killed, to God you shall surely be gathered.

Language · When an oath precedes a conditional

I say: When an oath (قسم) and a condition (شرط) occur together, the answer to the first suffices for the second. Thus “forgiveness” (**la-maghfira**, لَمَغْفِرَة) is the answer to the oath (جواب القسم) and takes the place of the answer to **in** (إن): “If you are killed in God's way, God will forgive you,” with the express formula “forgiveness … is better” standing in its place. One reading of “you die” has kasra on the **mīm** (**mittum**, مِتُّم), from **māta/yamātu**, like **hāba/yahābu/hibtu** and **khāfa/yakhāfu/khiftu**; another has ḍamma (**muttum**, مُتُّم), from **māta/yamūtu**, like **qāla/yaqūlu/qultu**.

Outward commentary · Why killing is named first, and why death follows

Travel and battle neither cause death nor advance its appointed term. But if your term comes during striving and you are killed by the sword in God's cause—or if you die naturally—the forgiveness, mercy, repose and delight awaiting you are better than the perishable worldly gains they might have accumulated had they lived. In either case, death or killing, you are gathered to God alone, who completes your recompense and magnifies your reward. No one, traveller or stay-at-home, can hope to remain forever in the world.

God places being killed before ordinary death in the first verse because forgiveness and mercy are promised in a special measure to the one killed in divine striving, so killing is advanced in honour of that promise. In the second verse, where the outcome is simply resurrection and gathering, death is named first because there is no difference between the two ways of dying with respect to that destiny. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The fruit of dying to the self before bodily death

If you kill your lower selves (أنفسكم), offering your lives in seeking the Beloved, and achieve arrival (الوصول) before death—or die during wayfaring (السير) before arriving—the perfection of certainty (كمال اليقين) and witnessing of the Lord of the Worlds that you attain, or the forgiveness and mercy which bring you near Him, are better than the worldly possessions gathered before you turned to Him. Death and resurrection are decreed for every creature; then the success of those who struggled and turned towards God, and the loss of those who delayed and remained behind, will become plain. Success is through God.

Despite what occurred at Uḥud—the opposition to the Messenger and the flight—he did not reproach the guilty, but addressed them gently and pardoned them, as God declares.

3:159 · Gentleness, consultation and the three degrees of trust

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 426–428

فَبِما رَحْمَةٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ لِنْتَ لَهُمْ وَلَوْ كُنْتَ فَظًّا غَلِيظَ الْقَلْبِ لانْفَضُّوا مِنْ حَوْلِكَ فَاعْفُ عَنْهُمْ وَاسْتَغْفِرْ لَهُمْ وَشاوِرْهُمْ فِي الْأَمْرِ فَإِذا عَزَمْتَ فَتَوَكَّلْ عَلَى اللَّهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ الْمُتَوَكِّلِينَ (159)

159. It was by a mercy from God that you were gentle with them. Had you been harsh and hard of heart, they would have scattered from around you. So pardon them, seek forgiveness for them, and consult them in the affair. Then, when you have resolved, trust in God; truly God loves those who trust in Him.

Language · Fabi-mā, faẓẓ and faḍḍ

I say: The **mā** of **fa-bi-mā** (فَبِمَا) is additional for emphasis (صلة). **Faẓẓ** (فظّ) means coarse or rough; its noun forms include **faẓāẓa** and **fuẓūẓ**. A man may be called **faẓẓ** and a woman **faẓẓa**. **Faḍḍ**, written with **ḍād** (ض) rather than **ẓāʾ** (ظ), means dispersal, and may also mean breaking, whence the blessing “May God not break your mouth.”

Outward commentary · Forgiveness, esteem and prudent decision

By divine mercy and favour you were gentle, approachable and kind. When they disobeyed and fled, you still showed kindness, indeed feeling grief on their account. Had you been coarse in manners and hard-hearted, speaking harshly, they would have dispersed and found no ease with you. Pardon their wrong towards you; seek God's forgiveness for what concerns His right, so that your intercession might benefit them; and consult them in matters legitimately open to consultation. This consoles them, honours their judgment, draws counsel from them and establishes a precedent of consultation (المشاورة) for others, especially rulers.

The Prophet, blessings and peace be upon him, is quoted as saying: “No servant is made wretched by consultation, nor happy by relying solely upon his own opinion.” He also said: “One who seeks guidance [by istikhāra] does not fail, and one who consults does not regret.” He also said: “When your rulers are the best among you, your wealthy people are the generous among you, and your affairs are settled by consultation among you, the surface of the earth is better for you than its interior. When your rulers are the worst among you, your wealthy people are the misers among you, and your affairs are not settled by consultation among you, the earth’s interior is better than its surface.” After consulting, once you resolve upon a course, trust in God as your protecting Agent (وكيل), who loves those exercising trust (المتوكلين), guides them and grants what benefits them.

Spiritual allusion · The inheritance of Prophetic gentleness and the meaning of tawakkul

The realized friends of God and firmly rooted scholars inherit our Prophet's gentleness and consideration, so that they may summon people to God or teach His rulings. If they were coarse and hard, people would scatter and neither making God known (تعريف) nor teaching (تعليم) would succeed. They must therefore pardon and forgive, bear others' harshness patiently, ask pardon on their behalf, consult them in their affairs and, when resolved, put their trust in God.

Al-Junayd says: “Trust is to turn entirely to your Lord and turn away from all beneath Him.” Al-Thawrī calls it annihilating one's own management (تدبير) within His management and accepting God as Agent and Director of affairs. God says: “God suffices as a Trustee.” Dhū al-Nūn speaks of casting off other lords and cutting away secondary causes; al-Khawwāṣ, of severing fear and hope with regard to everything but God; al-ʿArjī, of reducing one's concern for subsistence to the present day and putting aside tomorrow's care. Sahl defines it as knowing who provides all created beings. One cannot realize trust, he says, until one could see the heavens as copper and the earth as iron—no rain descending and no growth emerging—and still know that God will not neglect the livelihood He has guaranteed. Another definition is the humble servant's sufficiency in the Majestic Lord, like Abraham's

sufficiency in his intimate Friend when he did not look to Gabriel's offer. Asked when the servant trusts, Buhlūl replied: “When he is a stranger to creatures in himself, but near to the Real in his heart.” [176]

The Prophet is quoted as saying: “Whoever wishes to be the noblest of people should fear God; whoever wishes to be the richest should be more confident in what lies with God than in what lies in his own hand.” [T167]

Spiritual allusion · Three degrees, three sorts of means and tafwīḍ beyond tawakkul

Ibn Juzayy explains that **tawakkul** (التوكل) is reliance upon God in obtaining and preserving benefits, and repelling or removing harms. It is among the highest stations (المقامات), as God loves those who rely upon Him [Q 3:159] and guarantees sufficiency to whoever does so [Q 65:3]. It may even be obligatory, because God links it to faith [Q 5:23], and the scriptural imperative indicates an obligation.

There are three degrees. First, a servant relies on the Lord as a man on a trusted attorney who can be counted upon to protect his interests. Second, he is with God like a child with its mother, knowing and seeking refuge in none besides her. Third, he is with God like a corpse before the washer of the dead, having surrendered himself wholly. The first still notices his own interest, unlike the second; the second retains something of personal choice, unlike the third. These stages rest upon particular or realized tawḥīd (التوحيد الخاص), previously discussed at Q 2:163, and grow or decline with its strength.

Must reliance entail abandoning outward causes (الأسباب)? No single answer applies. Causes are of three kinds. First are means known with certainty through God's established order: these may not be abandoned, like eating to relieve hunger or dressing against cold. Second are probable means, such as trading or seeking livelihood: using them does not impair trust, which belongs to the acts of the heart, not to bodily acts; someone strong enough may also leave them. Third are remote, imaginary means (الأسباب الموهومة البعيدة): pursuing these impairs tawakkul. Ibn ʿAjība suggests searches for alchemy, buried treasure, divinatory “knowledge of fire” or sorcery as examples.

176. Cairo editor, C427.1: Ṣufr means copper.

Above tawakkul lies **tafwīḍ** (التفويض), consigning the whole affair to God in utter surrender. The one who trusts still has an aim and choice, asking God to realize that aim; the one who consigns has no preference or choice, having entrusted choice itself to God. Such a person displays more complete **adab** (أدب) towards God. Ibn ʿAjība attributes the underlying account to al-Ghazālī and refers readers to Q 25:58 for further treatment. Success comes from God.

Having commanded His Prophet to trust, God commends that trust to all His servants.

3:160 · Victory, reliance and the defeat of the lower self

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 428–429

إِنْ يَنْصُرْكُمُ اللَّهُ فَلا غالِبَ لَكُمْ وَإِنْ يَخْذُلْكُمْ فَمَنْ ذَا الَّذِي يَنْصُرُكُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ وَعَلَى اللَّهِ فَلْيَتَوَكَّلِ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ (160)

160. If God helps you, none can overcome you; but if He forsakes you, who can help you after Him? In God alone, then, let the believers put their trust.

Outward commentary · The conditional structure of divine assistance

If God helps you, as at Badr, no human being can defeat you. If He leaves you without help, as at Uḥud, who besides Him can grant victory? There is no helper apart from Him. The verse encourages reliance (التوكل), and the conduct that brings help—dependence upon God—while warning against what leads to being forsaken: disobeying His command, opposing His Messenger or relying upon another. Therefore, "Upon God let the believers place their trust," for they know no protector besides Him.

Spiritual allusion · Seeking assistance to overcome the self

If God supports you in struggling against your lower selves (مجاهدة النفوس) and constantly travelling towards the Presence of the Most Holy, neither self, fellow human, passion nor Satan can master you. But if He forsakes

you—God preserve us—who could help after that? The disciple must depend on his Lord and ask His support in severing self-interest and passion, for no other supporter exists. As the poet says:

> When God's help becomes a man's supporter,
> all difficulty is made ready for his desire.
> If God's help does not support a young man,
> his own exertion is what harms him most.

Success is through God, the guide to the straight path.

When the archers hastened toward the spoils, they suspected that the Prophet might deny them their share, an accusation of **ghulūl** (غلول) incompatible with Prophethood. God cleared His Prophet of it.

3:161 · The accusation of ghulūl, variant readings and the rights of prophets

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 429–430

وَما كانَ لِنَبِيٍّ أَنْ يَغُلَّ وَمَنْ يَغْلُلْ يَأْتِ بِما غَلَّ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ ثُمَّ تُوَفَّى كُلُّ نَفْسٍ مَّا كَسَبَتْ وَهُمْ لا يُظْلَمُونَ (161)

161. It is not for a prophet to misappropriate spoils. Whoever misappropriates shall bring what he misappropriated on the Day of Resurrection. Then every soul shall be paid in full what it earned, and none shall be wronged.

Language · Two vocalizations of yaghulla

I say: **Ghulūl** (الغلول) is secretly stealing from the war booty. Reading the verb with fatḥa on **yā**ʾ and ḍamma on **ghayn** (يَغُلَّ) gives “It does not befit a prophet to take some booty secretly,” vindicating the Messenger. Reading ḍamma on **yā**ʾ (يُغَلَّ) admits two interpretations: a prophet should not be betrayed by his community in the distribution of spoils—likewise command-

ers, although betrayal of a prophet is specially heinous; or a prophet should not be accused of treachery, just as "they do not call you a liar" can mean "they do not impute lying to you."

Outward commentary · Vindicating the Prophet and the warning against misappropriation

It cannot befit a prophet to take spoils secretly, for it is betrayal and incompatible with prophecy. The verse vindicates the Messenger—as in God's saying, "It is not for God to take a child" [19:35]—and removes the archers' suspicion. It is reported that, when they abandoned the station, he said to them: "Did I not charge you not to leave the station until my order came to you?" They answered: "We left the rest of our brothers standing there." The Prophet replied: "Rather, you thought that we would misappropriate the spoils and allot you no share." Then the verse was revealed. Another account says that he dispatched scouts, then the Messenger of God acquired spoils and divided them only among those with him. The verse was revealed, and he recovered those spoils from them. A third locates the occasion in a missing red cloak at Badr which hypocrites insinuated that the Prophet had taken. **Translator's note:** Ibn ʿAjība cites these as alternate accounts, not a single harmonized event.

The verse then warns against ghulūl: whoever takes anything secretly will arrive carrying it on his neck on the Day of Resurrection. The Prophet said: "Let me not encounter any of you on the Day of Resurrection coming with a bellowing camel, a lowing cow or a bleating sheep upon his neck." He then said, "O God, have I conveyed [the message]?" three times, as related in al-Bukhārī. Each soul then receives the full recompense for what it earned, no obedient person losing reward and no offender suffering more than is deserved. Whereas one might have expected "Then what he earned will be paid," the verse generalizes to every soul, giving the argument greater force: if *every* earner is recompensed, how much more the one guilty of grave misappropriation. Ibn ʿAjība cites al-Bayḍāwī. [177]

177. Cairo editor, C430.1: Tayʿaru means "it cries out"; yuʿār is the cry of a sheep.

Spiritual allusion · Presuming well of the inheritors of Prophets

What is said of the Prophet applies in an appropriate measure to his noble heirs—the friends of God (الأولياء) and scrupulous scholars (العلماء الأتقياء). They inherit the work of prophets: the friends of God direct people to knowledge of Him, and scholars to His ordinances. One should think of them in the best ways and seek the best explanations of their conduct; one must not attribute imperfection, defect, misappropriation or corruption to them. They have a share in the reverence owed to the prophets, especially the elect among the friends of God. Whoever stores up suspicion against them will see its bitter consequence on the day secrets are exposed, for each soul is paid what it has earned. The "flesh" of the friends of God and scholars is deadly poison, and thinking ill of them is betrayal. God knows best.

Belief in the perfection of prophets and the friends of God brings God's good pleasure, while finding fault with them brings His abhorrence.

3:162–163 · Divine pleasure and wrath, degrees of nearness and distance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 430–431

أَفَمَنِ اتَّبَعَ رِضْوانَ اللَّهِ كَمَنْ باءَ بِسَخَطٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَمَأْواهُ جَهَنَّمُ وَبِئْسَ الْمَصِيرُ (162) هُمْ دَرَجاتٌ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ بَصِيرٌ بِما يَعْمَلُونَ (163)

162. Is one who follows God's good pleasure like one who incurs wrath from God and whose refuge is Hell? What an evil destination! 163. They are degrees with God, and God sees what they do.

Outward commentary · Riḍwān, sakhaṭ, maṣīr and marjiʿ

Is someone who seeks God's satisfaction by believing His Prophet to be perfect and obeying him in the manifestations of both Majesty and Beauty—namely the believers, who reject blameworthy imputations and, if any such thought occurs in their hearts, immediately repent and then become endowed with the perfection of special qualities—like one who comes burdened with His wrath? The latter are the hypocrites who impugned the

Messenger and suspected ghulūl. Or the contrast is broader: obedient submission versus disobedience and corrupt belief. The latter's destination is Hell, an evil end. Al-Bayḍāwī observes that **maṣīr** (مصير) implies becoming different from one's former state, unlike **marjiʿ** (مرجع), which simply means return.

“They are degrees with God”: those enjoying His pleasure have differing degrees according to their striving to please Him, and those incurring wrath also differ according to their acts of rebellion. A possessed noun is understood (حذف مضاف): **dhawū darajāt** (ذوو درجات, possessors of degrees). God sees their works and rewards or judges each accordingly.

Spiritual allusion · Respect for the spiritual path and graded distance from God

Can one who seeks divine pleasure by revering the friends of God, scholars and people affiliated with the path be like one who incurs wrath by insulting those whom God has ordered to be honoured? Such a person's dwelling is the veil of sensory existence (حجاب الحس) and the anguish of distance, an evil end. People of nearness have degrees according to their approach to their Lord; people of distance likewise differ in their remoteness, as their faults and poor manners diverge. God knows their actions and what their hearts contain.

God next explains why the Messenger should be honoured: his coming is a divinely sent favour.

3:164 · The Messenger's three offices and the continuing masters of formation

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 431–432

لَقَدْ مَنَّ اللَّهُ عَلَى الْمُؤْمِنِينَ إِذْ بَعَثَ فِيهِمْ رَسُولاً مِنْ أَنْفُسِهِمْ يَتْلُوا عَلَيْهِمْ آياتِهِ وَيُزَكِّيهِمْ وَيُعَلِّمُهُمُ الْكِتابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَإِنْ كانُوا مِنْ قَبْلُ لَفِي ضَلالٍ مُبِينٍ (164)

164. God has bestowed a favour on the believers in raising up among them a messenger from their own selves, reciting to them His signs, purifying them and teaching them the Book and Wisdom, though previously they were in manifest error.

Outward commentary · Recitation, purification and instruction

God bestowed a great favour upon believers by sending them a messenger **from among themselves**: one of their own kind, or of their own lineage, an Arab like them, so that they would readily understand his words and find distinction through him. Though his mission benefits all, the believers are singled out because they profit from it more fully and attain honour and renown through it. He recites God's signs to them—the Qurʾān—when they had lived in the Age of Ignorance without knowledge or experience of revelation. He purifies them (يُزَكِّيهِمْ) of the contamination of sins and defects; teaches them the Book (الكتاب), the Qurʾān, and Wisdom (الحكمة), the Sunna. Before his mission they were plainly astray. The construction "though they were …" (**wa-in kānū**) can carry an understood matter or affair (ضمير الشأن).

Spiritual allusion · The enduring favour of spiritual educators

Likewise God favours those turning to Him and seeking gnosis (معرفة) by sending people who take them by the hand and fold away the distance separating them from Him: the spiritual educators (شيوخ التربية). These recite signs showing how the veil can be removed and the door opened; purify seekers of faults that impede knowledge of the Unseen, then cleanse them of attachment to sensory limitation (درن الحس) until they witness intimacy and nearness; and teach the Book as the locus of realized truth (عين التحقيق) and Wisdom as the locus of practical legislation (التشريع) and clarification of the road. Thus they unite spiritual Reality (الحقيقة) and Revealed Law (الشريعة), while previously their disciples were plainly astray about bringing the two together. This favour continues in every age: earth never lacks an inviter to God. Whoever says this possibility has ceased denies God's favour, treats His power as impotent and closes the gate of divine mercy against His servants—God protect us.

As the Companions wondered at Uḥud in view of the promised victory, God reminded them that the defeat arose through their own disobedience.

3:165 · The loss at Uḥud, self-accounting and the interplay of power and wisdom

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 432–433

أَوَلَمَّا أَصابَتْكُمْ مُصِيبَةٌ قَدْ أَصَبْتُمْ مِثْلَيْها قُلْتُمْ أَنَّى هذا قُلْ هُوَ مِنْ عِنْدِ أَنْفُسِكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (165)

165. What! When a calamity befell you, though you had inflicted twice as much, did you say, “Whence is this?” Say, “It is from yourselves.” Truly God has power over all things.

Language · The interrogative hamza and lammā

I say: The interrogative **hamza** (الهمزة) marks an inferential continuation (*tafrīʿ*). **Translator’s note:** Cairo I:432 prints للتفريع, “for inferential continuation,” retained here. Al-Bayḍāwī’s parallel exposition of 3:165 (II:47) instead has *taqrīʿ*, “rebuke,” together with *taqrīr*, “eliciting acknowledgement.” **lammā** (لما) is an adverb (ظرف), its following condition governed by it in the genitive relation and the whole governed by its answer. The expression is connected with an omitted preceding phrase: “Did what happened at Uḥud happen, and when a calamity befell you did you say what you said?” “Though you had inflicted [twice as much]” (قد أصبتم) is a circumstantial sentence (جملة حالية).

Outward commentary · The conditions of the promise

When seventy of you were killed at Uḥud, though at Badr you had slain seventy enemies and taken seventy prisoners, you asked, “How could this calamity have overtaken us, when victory was promised?” Say: “It comes from yourselves,” from your disobedience in abandoning the appointed post. Victory was promised on the condition of steadfast obedience (الثبات والطاعة); when the condition (الشرط) failed, so did the conditioned outcome (المشروط). God could give victory with or without such conditions, for He is

powerful over all things, but His Wisdom (الحكمة) willed there should be causes and conditions: this world subsists between divine Power (القدرة) and Wisdom (الحكمة).

Another explanation relates the loss to the Muslims' decision to accept ransom after Badr. ʿAlī is reported to have said that Gabriel offered them the option of killing the captives or ransoming them on condition that a corresponding number of their own be killed the following year; they chose the ransom and accepted the consequence. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Every affliction considered against the gifts already received

When calamities befall a disciple he should neither find them strange nor resent them: this is an abode marked by affliction and grief. As the *Ḥikam* says: “Do not be surprised that sorrows occur so long as you remain in this abode: it has only brought forth what belongs to its description and is entailed by its nature.” If he is afflicted at one time, at many other times he has received blessings beyond reckoning. Let him thank God for the gifts and remain patient in the trial: then he is one who is both patient and grateful (صبّار شكور).

Abū al-Ḥasan says: “The gnostic knows his offences amid God's kindness towards him, and knows the severity of time amid the gracious favours flowing to him. Remember God's benefits, that you may prosper.” Whatever misfortune befalls a believer comes by what his hands have earned, yet God pardons much. Nor should one conclude that a promise of preservation was absolute when it may have concealed conditions unknown to him. Those conditions may fail, allowing the divine decree to take effect: God's command is a destiny already decreed (قدراً مقدوراً).

Thus the truthful are distinguished from the liar and the sincere from the hypocrite.

3:166–168 · The disclosure of hypocrisy and the test of the spiritual poor

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 433–435

وَما أَصابَكُمْ يَوْمَ الْتَقَى الْجَمْعانِ فَبِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ وَلِيَعْلَمَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ (166)
وَلِيَعْلَمَ الَّذِينَ نافَقُوا وَقِيلَ لَهُمْ تَعالَوْا قاتِلُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ أَوِ ادْفَعُوا
قالُوا لَوْ نَعْلَمُ قِتالاً لاتَّبَعْناكُمْ هُمْ لِلْكُفْرِ يَوْمَئِذٍ أَقْرَبُ مِنْهُمْ لِلْإِيمانِ
يَقُولُونَ بِأَفْواهِهِمْ ما لَيْسَ فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ وَاللَّهُ أَعْلَمُ بِما يَكْتُمُونَ (167)
الَّذِينَ قالُوا لِإِخْوانِهِمْ وَقَعَدُوا لَوْ أَطاعُونا ما قُتِلُوا قُلْ فَادْرَؤُا عَنْ
أَنْفُسِكُمُ الْمَوْتَ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صادِقِينَ (168)

166. What befell you on the day the two hosts met was by God's leave, and so that He might make manifest the believers, 167. and make manifest those who acted hypocritically. They were told, “Come, fight in God's way, or at least defend.” They replied, “Had we known there would be fighting, we would have followed you.” That day they were closer to unbelief than to faith. They say with their mouths what is not in their hearts, and God knows best what they conceal. 168. They are those who, sitting back, said of their brothers, “Had they obeyed us, they would not have been killed.” Say, “Then avert death from yourselves, if you speak the truth.”

Language · The referent of alladhīna and the circumstantial clause

I say: “And it was said to them, ‘Come …’ ” (وقيل لهم تعالوا) may begin a new sentence (استئناف) or be coordinated with “they acted hypocritically” (عطف). “Those who said of their brothers” (الذين قالوا لإخوانهم) may be a substitute (بدل) for the pronoun governed by **lahum** (لهم), explaining whom the summons addressed. Alternatively it replaces the plural pronoun in **yaktumūn** (يكتمون), or is in the accusative of censure (نصب على الذم), or is a subject (مبتدأ)

answered by “Say …” as predicate (خبر), if one allows a performative command to serve as predicate. **Wa-qaʿadū** (وقعدوا) is a circumstantial sentence (حال) with an understood **qad** (قد).

Outward commentary · The retreat of Ibn Ubayy and the limits of human control

All the killing, injury and defeat at Uḥud, where the Muslim and opposing armies met, came by divine permission (بإذن الله) and decree, which no one can overturn. It served to disclose the believers and hypocrites, making the faith of some and the unbelief of others manifest in the world of appearance (عالم الشهادة), as when some three hundred withdrew with ʿAbd Allāh ibn Ubayy. He had opposed going out to meet the idolaters, and when the Prophet went forth at the urging of others, Ibn Ubayy complained, “He listened to them and disobeyed me,” and withdrew with his followers.

Abū Jābir ʿAbd Allāh ibn ʿAmr ibn Ḥarām followed them, begging them to return: “Fight in God's way, or at least defend”—in other words, add to the visible numbers of the Muslim force. Ibn Ubayy replied that he expected no real fighting, and that if they had known there would be fighting, they would have followed. The Qurʾān says that on that day they were closer to unbelief than faith, since the signs of unbelief in their words were more numerous than those of belief. Or they were closer to helping the unbelievers than to supporting the believers, as their withdrawal emboldened the one party and discouraged the other. They speak with their mouths what their hearts do not share; specifically mentioning mouths intensifies the charge. God knows their inner hypocrisy in full and necessarily, whereas people can infer it only generally from outward signs.

The same hypocrites said while sitting out the battle that their brethren would not have been killed had they stayed home. Say: if your calculations could avert a decree of death, avert your own when the appointed hour arrives. Remaining at home cannot ward off death, for its causes are many: staying may itself be the circumstance of death when the term arrives, and going out may be the circumstance of safety when it has not arrived. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Trial reveals who can endure the quest for God

O spiritual poor, what befalls you when turning from creatures to the Real, as you approach gathering (الجمع) and the gathering of gathering (جمع الجمع), occurs by God's permission. Whoever approaches God is the object of public censure, while one who returns to ordinary life is praised. This exposes the sincere and the false claimant: love for God is attended by trial, and the path is surrounded by hardships and requires the struggle against the lower self, the lowering of one's pride, and the release of attachments and obstacles.

When ordinary people are told, “Fight your lower selves for God's sake to enter His Presence; remove attachments so the lights of realities may dawn,” they answer that the path has ended and those who possess realized knowledge are gone. “Had we known a struggle remained that could bring us to our Lord,” they claim, “we would follow you.” That day they are closer to unbelief than to faith: they limit pre-eternal divine Power and close the gate of mercy. They say this only to make excuses for themselves and preserve their worldly portions. Their mouths profess what their hearts do not contain.

When people of the path suffer a calamity, those who remained among ordinary people tell their friends who entered the way, “Had they listened to us, they would not have been killed or tormented.” The disciple should reply that divine decree runs through everyone: let those critics avert unwelcome events from their own lives if they truly believe hardship touches only people striving against themselves. God knows best the secrets of His Book.

When the martyrs of Uḥud were honoured in a manner beyond speech, they wished their people could know of their state and become eager to fight in God’s way. God declared He would tell them.

3:169–171 · Martyrdom, the enduring soul and the martyrs of the spiritual world

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 435–436

وَلا تَحْسَبَنَّ الَّذِينَ قُتِلُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ أَمْواتاً بَلْ أَحْياءٌ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ يُرْزَقُونَ (169) فَرِحِينَ بِما آتاهُمُ اللَّهُ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ وَيَسْتَبْشِرُونَ بِالَّذِينَ لَمْ يَلْحَقُوا بِهِمْ مِنْ خَلْفِهِمْ أَلاَّ خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ (170) يَسْتَبْشِرُونَ بِنِعْمَةٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَفَضْلٍ وَأَنَّ اللَّهَ لا يُضِيعُ أَجْرَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ (171)

169. Do not think those killed in God's way dead. Rather they are alive with their Lord, provided for, 170. rejoicing in what God has given them of His bounty, and glad for those still behind them who have not joined them—that no fear shall be upon them and they shall not grieve. 171. They rejoice in a blessing and bounty from God, and that God does not waste the reward of the believers.

Language · Allā khawfun ʿalayhim and yastabshirūn

I say: The clause **allā khawfun ʿalayhim** (ألا خوف عليهم) may stand as a substitute (بدل) for "those who have not joined them," or as an accusative of cause (مفعول لأجله). **Yastabshirūn** (يستبشرون) is repeated to express both the bounty and blessing associated with rejoicing; alternatively the first concerns the condition of their brothers, and the second concerns their own.

Outward commentary · The perceiving reality beyond the body

Do not think, Messenger—or any hearer—that those killed in God's way are dead. They are alive: God places their spirits in the crops of green birds that roam wherever they wish in Paradise. They dwell in God's nearness and favour and receive its fruits and delights. Thus they resemble living people in enjoyment of the provisions of Paradise, unlike other dead believers who, according to Ibn Juzayy's account, do not enjoy its provisions until they

enter it. Ibn ʿAjība adds: the martyrs of the angelic or spiritual domain (شهداء الملكوت), the realized knowers (العارفون), are even higher in rank than martyrs of the sword; consult his earlier discussion in al-Baqara. [178]

They rejoice at divine generosity, nearness, and delights that do not perish, and rejoice concerning brothers left behind who have not yet been killed and joined them. The good news is that those brothers too will have neither fear nor grief; or rejoicing occurs *because* there will be no fear or grief. Having discovered the honour of the next life, the martyrs know that those remaining will live after death or being killed in a life without dread of threatened harm or sorrow for desired good lost.

The verse therefore points, Ibn ʿAjība argues, to a distinction between the person and the perceptible bodily structure (الهيكل المحسوس). The person is a substance capable of perception in its own right (جوهر مدرك بذاته): its being does not perish with the body's dissolution, nor does its capacity to perceive, suffer or delight depend on the continuing existence of that body. He cites the Qurʾānic account of Pharaoh's people being exposed to the Fire morning and evening [Q 40:46], and Ibn ʿAbbās's report that the Prophet said: "The spirits of martyrs are in the insides of green birds; they come to the rivers of Paradise, eat of its fruits and shelter in lamps suspended in the shade of the Throne." He attributes the substance of the discussion to al-Bayḍāwī.

Now God speaks of the gladness that concerns the martyrs themselves: "a blessing," the bodily reward of their works (ثواب أعمالهم الجسماني), and "bounty," their spiritual delight (نعيم أرواحهم الروحاني), which consists in gazing upon the Generous Face. They also rejoice that God does not forfeit any believer's reward, whether that believer dies on the battlefield or in bed, provided inward and outward conduct have been sound. The Prophet said: "God has servants whom He keeps from being killed, from earthquakes and from illnesses. He prolongs their lives in good works, makes their provision

178. Cairo editor, C435.1: At the allusion on verse 154 and what follows.

good, grants them life in well-being and death in well-being upon their beds, and gives them the stations of martyrs." Ibn ʿAjība suggests they may be the realized gnostics, praying to be counted among them. [179]

Spiritual allusion · Death to customary desire and life through witnessing

Do not think dead those who offered their life's essence (مُهَجهم) and killed their lower selves through breaking habits (خرق العوائد) and acting against habitual desires (عكس المرادات), seeking knowledge of God until their selves died and their spirits came alive through witnessing the Beloved, a life without subsequent death—even should they die bodily. As the poet says:

> The death of the Godfearing is a life that does not pass away;
> some people have died who are alive among humankind.

They remain with their Lord in witnessing while they subsist, fed with the fruits of gnosis and the sciences of the heart; they rejoice in divine nearness and in the concealed secret (السر المكتوم). They have glad tidings concerning those connected to them who have not yet reached their degree: these too will arrive at knowledge of the Ever-Living, Self-Subsisting One. With the wine of love and nearness settled in their hearts, fear, grief, care and sorrow depart. Ibn al-Fāriḍ says:

> If she but passed for a day across a person's thought,
> joys would remain with him and cares depart.

They rejoice in the grace of the manners of servanthood (أدب العبودية) and in the bounty of witnessing the secrets of Lordship's majesty (أسرار عظمة الربوبية). God does not waste the reward of believers who love the path of the elect: loving the path is itself divine solicitude, and affirming it is sainthood. Success is through God, the guide to the straight path.

When Abū Sufyān reached al-Rawḥāʾ after Uḥud, he contemplated returning; the Prophet urged his Companions to pursue him, saying: "No one is to come out with us except those who were present yesterday." Seventy

179. Cairo editor, C436.1: Al-Haythamī attributes it in Majmaʿ al-zawāʾid, 10:203, to al-Ṭabarānī, from Ibn Masʿūd as a report attributed to the Prophet. Its transmitters include Jaʿfar ibn Muḥammad al-Wāsiṭī al-Warrāq. Al-Haythamī says: "I did not recognize him; the rest of its transmitters are trustworthy."

wounded men set out with him to Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad, eight miles from Medina, shouldering their injuries to obtain the reward, until God cast fear into their opponents and they withdrew. The following verses concern those who answered the call.

3:172 · The wounded believers who answered and the unity of Reality and Law

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 436–437

الَّذِينَ اسْتَجابُوا لِلَّهِ وَالرَّسُولِ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما أَصابَهُمُ الْقَرْحُ لِلَّذِينَ أَحْسَنُوا مِنْهُمْ وَاتَّقَوْا أَجْرٌ عَظِيمٌ (172)

172. Those who responded to God and the Messenger after the wound had afflicted them—those among them who did good and were mindful of God —have a mighty reward.

Language · The position of alladhīna

I say: “Those who” (الذين) may be the subject (مبتدأ), with “for those who did good” (للذين أحسنوا) as predicate (خبر); or it may qualify “believers” in the preceding verse (صفة); or be set in the accusative in praise (نصب على المدح).

Outward commentary · They followed despite injury

They responded to God's call and obeyed His Messenger when he urged pursuit of the idolaters to deter them, even after the wound (القرح) they suffered. They forced themselves onward despite injury and accompanied their Prophet. Those who acted well by carrying out the command and were mindful of God by not disobeying His Messenger possess a great reward when they come before Him.

Spiritual allusion · Answering both the call to divine Presence and the prophetic way

They respond to God by seeking arrival at His Presence (الوصول إلى حضرته) and to the Messenger by following his Sunna. They make their hearts an abode for that Presence and their bodily members instruments of the revealed Law (الشريعة). Even when seeking this conjunction brings wounds, beatings, imprisonment or humiliation, they persevere until they unite Reality and Law (الجمع بين الحقيقة والشريعة). Those who persist in travelling to the Real and guard against whatever returns them to the vision of mere separation (شهود الفرق) receive great reward: abiding in the Presence and delighting in witnessing and contemplation.

Then God said:

3:173–175 · God suffices: two historical settings and the meaning of spiritual fortitude

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 437–439

الَّذِينَ قالَ لَهُمُ النَّاسُ إِنَّ النَّاسَ قَدْ جَمَعُوا لَكُمْ فَاخْشَوْهُمْ فَزادَهُمْ إِيماناً وَقالُوا حَسْبُنَا اللَّهُ وَنِعْمَ الْوَكِيلُ (173) فَانْقَلَبُوا بِنِعْمَةٍ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَفَضْلٍ لَمْ يَمْسَسْهُمْ سُوءٌ وَاتَّبَعُوا رِضْوانَ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ ذُو فَضْلٍ عَظِيمٍ (174) إِنَّما ذلِكُمُ الشَّيْطانُ يُخَوِّفُ أَوْلِياءَهُ فَلا تَخافُوهُمْ وَخافُونِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ (175)

173. Those to whom people said, “People have gathered against you, so fear them,” but this only increased them in faith, and they said, “God suffices us, and excellent is the Trustee.” 174. So they returned with a blessing and bounty from God; no evil touched them. They followed God's good pleasure, and God possesses immense bounty. 175. That is only Satan frightening [you] with his allies; so do not fear them, but fear Me, if you are believers.

Language · The two objects of yukhawwifu

I say: The relative pronoun (الموصول) is a substitute (بدل) for the relative pronoun before it. **Yukhawwifu** (يخوّف) takes two objects (مفعولان) because of the causative doubling. Either the first object is omitted (حذف الأول): "he frightens *you* with his allies among the unbelievers"; or the second is omitted (حذف الثاني): "he frightens *his allies*, those who stayed behind from facing the enemy."

Outward commentary · Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad after Uḥud

Two explanations of the historical setting are given. The first continues the account of Uḥud and, Ibn ʿAjība thinks, best connects the verses. When Abū Sufyān thought of returning to destroy the Muslims, Maʿbad al-Khuzāʿī met him and declared that Muḥammad had set out to pursue him with an assembly unmatched in size. Terror entered Abū Sufyān's heart. When a caravan of ʿAbd al-Qays travelling to Medina for provisions met him, he promised them a camel-load of raisins if they discouraged Muḥammad from further pursuit. The caravan warned the Muslims. They replied, "God suffices us and is an excellent Trustee" (حسبنا الله ونعم الوكيل), continued to Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad, and returned home.

On this account, "the people" speaking are the ʿAbd al-Qays caravan; those said to have gathered are Abū Sufyān and his men. The warning deepened the believers' faith, certainty and steadfastness. This shows, Ibn ʿAjība says, that faith (الإيمان) increases and decreases: it grows through turning to God, relinquishing other preoccupations, obedience and reflection, and declines through worldly distraction, sin, heedlessness and delusion. Their words meant that God alone is sufficient and no other need be feared—words that repel feared and hated things, also spoken by Abraham when cast into the fire. They returned in good health and safety, an outward blessing (نعمة), and with greater faith and certainty, an additional favour (فضل), uninjured by their enemy and following the pleasure of God, whose bounty made their steadfastness and response to the Messenger possible.

Those who tried to deter them—the ʿAbd al-Qays caravan—are likened to Satan: either Satan frightened believers with his polytheist allies, or frightened his own allies, the hypocrites who refused the campaign. Do not fear them, since their affairs are in God's hands; fear God above people if you truly believe.

Outward commentary · The later rendezvous at lesser Badr

The second interpretation places the episode in the later lesser Badr (بدر الصغرى). Abū Sufyān, on leaving Uḥud, called out for a meeting at Badr the following year. The Prophet replied, “God willing.” When that year came, Abū Sufyān marched from Mecca to Marr al-Ẓahrān, where fear entered his heart and he decided to return. He met Nuʿaym ibn Masʿūd al-Ashjaʿī performing the lesser pilgrimage (ʿumra), offered him ten camels to tell Medina that the Meccans had gathered in overwhelming numbers and to discourage the Muslim departure. Nuʿaym's message troubled the Companions. The Prophet declared, “By Him in whose hand is my soul, I will go out even alone.” The hesitant turned back but the courageous prepared; the Muslims reached lesser Badr while Abū Sufyān returned to Mecca with the army nicknamed “the army of meal” (جيش السويق). The Muslims found a market at Badr, traded profitably and returned to Medina. [180]

On this second reading, the response of Q 3:172 belongs to the later appointment, after injuries sustained at Uḥud the year before. “The people” giving warning means Nuʿaym alone—called “people” by reference to his kind, as when one says a man rides horses though he rides one horse—or those who assisted in spreading his message. The threatening “people” are Abū Sufyān's Meccans, and the “bounty” includes profit from trade. Here “Satan” means Nuʿaym, who frightens you with his allies. Ibn ʿAjība retains both alternatives.

Spiritual allusion · Fear of others and the increase of the disciples’ certainty

When strong disciples (أهل القوة من المريدين) are told that people have gathered to harm or turn them back, their faith and certainty grow, for they recognize the established path of those tested before them: “Do people imagine

180. Cairo editor, C438.1: The majority of Qurʾān commentators hold that the verse was revealed concerning the episode at Ḥamrāʾ al-Asad. See al-Ṭabarī and al-Muḥarrar al-wajīz.

they will be left alone to say ‘We believe’ ... ?” [Q 29:2]. They content themselves with God's knowledge, gaze, protection and support, and return with the blessing of witnessing (نعمة الشهود) and the favour of advancing in the greatness of the loving King (فضل الترقي). Their inward selves suffer neither harm nor diminishment, and they become deserving of divine satisfaction. It is Satan who urges them to retreat from the station of direct witnessing (مقام الشهود والعيان). They must not fear, for their desired station is iḥsān (مقام الإحسان), sought at the cost of lives and bodies. Success comes from God.

God then diminished the stature of the disbelievers and assured the Muslims of safety from their harm.

3:176–177 · Rejection does not diminish the truth: denial and the path of God

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 439–440

وَلا يَحْزُنْكَ الَّذِينَ يُسارِعُونَ فِي الْكُفْرِ إِنَّهُمْ لَنْ يَضُرُّوا اللَّهَ شَيْئاً يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ أَلاَّ يَجْعَلَ لَهُمْ حَظًّا فِي الْآخِرَةِ وَلَهُمْ عَذابٌ عَظِيمٌ (176) إِنَّ الَّذِينَ اشْتَرَوُا الْكُفْرَ بِالْإِيْمانِ لَنْ يَضُرُّوا اللَّهَ شَيْئاً وَلَهُمْ عَذابٌ أَلِيمٌ (177)

176. Let not those who hasten into unbelief grieve you. They shall not harm God in anything. God desires to give them no portion in the Hereafter, and theirs is a tremendous punishment. 177. Those who have bought unbelief at the price of faith shall not harm God in anything, and theirs is a painful punishment.

Language · Two constructions of ḥuzn

I say: Both **ḥazana/yaḥzunu** (حَزَنَ يَحْزُنُ), like **balagha/yablughu**, and **aḥzana/yuḥzinu** (أَحْزَنَ يُحْزِنُ), like **akrama/yukrimu**, occur; the former is more eloquent.

Outward commentary · Neither God nor His friends can be harmed by unbelief

Do not be overwhelmed by those hastening into unbelief, hypocrites or openly unbelieving people, rushing to embrace it. They cannot hurt God in the slightest—that is, they cannot harm God's friends. Rather the damage returns to themselves. God's will is that, on account of their manifest rushing to unbelief and the misery already allotted to them, they should die in it and have no share in the next world's reward. Mentioning divine will here signals that their unbelief has reached the utmost extreme, to the point that the Most Merciful of the merciful wills that they have no share in His mercy. Beyond that deprivation awaits a great punishment.

He repeats the warning for emphasis: those who exchange faith, by which they could have escaped punishment had they embraced it, for unbelief that entails punishment cannot hurt God; theirs is painful torment. Or the first verse refers to those originally unbelieving and the second to apostates (المرتدين). God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The claims of ordinary people against the elect

Denial by ordinary people (العوام) cannot reduce the station of the elect (الخصوص); rather, their attacks increase the elect in elevation, dignity and nearness. “Do not consider it evil for yourselves; rather it is good for you” [Q 24:11]. I heard our teacher al-Būzīdī say, “People's talk against a friend of God is like a gnat blowing upon a mountain.” Such an attack harms them no more than the gnat's breath harms a mountain. God wills that the deniers have no portion of nearness, and they suffer distance, weariness, veiling and a difficult reckoning, especially if they once recognized realized masters and then exchanged their company for that of ordinary people. Their deprivation is grave—God preserve us.

The respite granted to unbelievers and their enjoyment of long life do not show that God wills them good; they are only a gradual enticement (استدراج) and increased wrongdoing.

3:178 · The long life that benefits or ensnares

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 440–441

وَلا يَحْسَبَنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا أَنَّما نُمْلِي لَهُمْ خَيْرٌ لِأَنْفُسِهِمْ إِنَّما نُمْلِي لَهُمْ لِيَزْدادُوا إِثْماً وَلَهُمْ عَذابٌ مُهِينٌ (178)

178. Let not those who disbelieve imagine that the respite We give them is better for their souls. We grant them respite only so that they increase in sin; theirs is a humiliating punishment.

Language · The subject of yaḥsabanna

I say: With the third-person reading (بالتحتية), “those who disbelieve” is the subject (فاعل), and **anna** with its following clause takes the place of the two required objects (سد مسد المفعولين). With the second-person reading (بالفوقية), “those who” is the first object (مفعول أول), while **annamā** takes the place of the second. Here **mā** is **maṣdariyya** (مصدرية). **Imlāʾ** (الإملاء) denotes granting time, deferring or giving respite, as in “Leave me for a long while” [Q 19:46]. **Translator’s note:** Cairo I:440 prints الإملال (*imlāl*). The translation reads الإملاء (*imlāʾ*), in accordance with the Qur’anic verb *numlī* and the author’s explicit gloss “granting respite and delay”; compare *Lisān al-ʿArab*, s.v. ملا, on *amlā Allāhu lahu*.

Outward commentary · The danger of a respite mistaken for favour

Disbelievers must not imagine that God's granting them respite and extending their lives is good for them. He gives such respite as gradual enticement (استدراج), so that they increase in sin and punishment. Their end is a humiliating punishment on the day believers are honoured.

Spiritual allusion · A lifetime’s blessing is measured by realization

If the servant's extended years are spent in obedience, wakefulness (اليقظة) and deeper gnosis, they are good. Blessing in one's life lies in divine enabling (التوفيق) and increase of knowledge of God. As the *Ḥikam* says: “One whose life is blessed can obtain in a short span of time what words cannot express and indication cannot encompass.” If life is instead spent in heedlessness, idleness and growing disobedience, death would be preferable. The Prophet is cited as saying that the best people are those whose lives are long and works good, and the worst those whose lives are long and works evil. God knows best.

When the Prophet said, “God has disclosed to me who will believe in me as distinct from those who will disbelieve,” the hypocrites said, “We are with him, yet he does not know us.” Then God revealed the following verse.

3:179 · Trial as disclosure: hidden sincerity and the unseen

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 441–442

ما كانَ اللَّهُ لِيَذَرَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ عَلى ما أَنْتُمْ عَلَيْهِ حَتَّى يَمِيزَ الْخَبِيثَ مِنَ الطَّيِّبِ وَما كانَ اللَّهُ لِيُطْلِعَكُمْ عَلَى الْغَيْبِ وَلكِنَّ اللَّهَ يَجْتَبِي مِنْ رُسُلِهِ مَنْ يَشاءُ فَآمِنُوا بِاللَّهِ وَرُسُلِهِ وَإِنْ تُؤْمِنُوا وَتَتَّقُوا فَلَكُمْ أَجْرٌ عَظِيمٌ (179)

179. God would not leave the believers in the condition you are in, until He separates the corrupt from the good. Nor would God disclose the unseen to you; rather God chooses from His messengers whom He wills. So believe in God and His messengers; if you believe and are mindful of Him, yours will be a mighty reward.

Language · Māza and mayyaza

I say: **Māza/yamīzu** (ماز يميز) and **mayyaza/yumayyizu** (ميّز يميّز) share the sense of distinguishing, but the doubled form conveys intensity or multiplicity (التكثير).

Theology · Disclosure in action is not a grant of unrestricted foreknowledge

God addresses believers and hypocrites together: He would not leave them mixed in a condition where sincere believers could not be distinguished from pretenders. He tests them until the hypocrite and sincere person become recognizable: through revelation or demands difficult enough that only the sincere persevere, such as offering property and lives in His cause. Such trials bring hidden dispositions to light and allow judgments about belief from actual deeds. The words and conduct displayed at Uḥud were just such signs.

God does not disclose the unseen (الغيب) to all people, so that they could directly read unbelief or faith in hearts, or know in advance whether they would win or lose. He chooses whom He wills for messengership, informs them by revelation of some hidden things, or establishes indications of them. Believe in God, who alone possesses knowledge of the unseen in the true sense, and in His messengers, who learn only what He teaches them. Some unbelievers are reported to have demanded that Muḥammad name who among them would believe; another account associates the revelation with the hypocrites' challenge just mentioned. In either case the conduct at Uḥud manifested their differing conditions. If you truly believe and guard against hypocrisy and idolatry, a great reward awaits you.

Spiritual allusion · The wind of sifting spiritual communities

When the numbers of those turning to God increase and claims of spiritual strength multiply, God sends among them a wind of sifting (ريح التصفية): the sound person stands firm, while the empty is scattered. He does not leave them untested but distinguishes whose aspiration (هِمّة) is God from whose aspiration is another. The future perseverance or retreat of seekers, and the majestic (جلال) or beautiful (جمال) disclosures they will encounter, are hidden. This is reserved for the messengers; God may disclose something of it to some of their noble elect heirs. The disciple must believe in what divine decree keeps hidden instead of demanding to see it. As the *Ḥikam* says: “Your looking out for the defects hidden within you is better than your looking out for the unseen things withheld from you.” Faith in the workings of decree, with avoidance of despair and distress, brings the promised great reward.

Because miserliness is the measure distinguishing the sincere from those of mixed conduct, he mentions it immediately after distinguishing believers from hypocrites.

3:180 · Withholding wealth, reputation and the self

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 442–443

وَلا يَحْسَبَنَّ الَّذِينَ يَبْخَلُونَ بِما آتاهُمُ اللَّهُ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ هُوَ خَيْراً لَهُمْ بَلْ هُوَ شَرٌّ لَهُمْ سَيُطَوَّقُونَ ما بَخِلُوا بِهِ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ وَلِلَّهِ مِيراثُ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاللَّهُ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ خَبِيرٌ (180)

180. Let not those who are miserly with what God has given them of His bounty think it good for them. Rather it is evil for them. What they withheld will be bound around their necks on the Day of Resurrection. To God belongs the inheritance of the heavens and the earth, and God is fully aware of what you do.

Language · Second- and third-person readings

I say: Under the second-person reading (بالخطاب), the relative pronoun is the first object (مفعول أول), **khayran** (خيرًا) the second (مفعول ثان), and the intervening pronoun separates them (ضمير الفصل); the address is to the Messenger. A possessed noun is omitted: “Do not think the *miserliness* of those who withhold … is good for them.” Under the third-person reading (بالغيب), “those” is the subject (فاعل), with an understood first object indicated by “they withhold”: “Let the miserly not suppose their withholding good for them.” A **ṭawq** (طوق) is something encircling the neck.

Outward commentary · Zakat, constriction and divine ownership

Those who withhold the wealth God has given them and fail to pay its alms (زكاة) must not imagine their miserliness helps them. It draws punishment upon them. They shall be bound to the evil consequences of what they withheld, as a collar encircles a neck. Or they will literally be encircled by it: the Prophet is quoted explaining that the withholder’s wealth is represented on the Day of Resurrection as a bald venomous snake with two spots,

which coils around its owner, seizes his jaws and says, “I am your hoard; I am your wealth”; then the Prophet recited the verse. Another account describes a collar of fire.

All the wealth kept back belongs ultimately to God, “the inheritance of the heavens and the earth”; He survives the whole earth and those upon it. How can the servant cling to God's property, knowing he will die and leave it behind for others to enjoy? A poet asks:

> O gatherer of wealth, how much harm you suffer through it!
> By God, do you hope to remain with it forever?
> Did anyone dying carry wealth away?
> Do you not see he gathered it for another?

[Translator’s note: Cairo prints bi-llāh, rendered “by God.” Its use as an oath or adjuration, and the question punctuation, are interpretive. Ibn Ḥibbān’s Rawḍat al-ʿuqalāʾ, p. 227, likewise reads bi-llāh; al-Thaʿālibī’s Yatīmat al-dahr, V:292, has wa-llāh. These electronic primary texts also differ from Cairo in other words. The Yatīma places its version under Abū Manṣūr Naṣr b. Aḥmad b. Saʿd al-Saʿdī (entry182, V:291–292); the earlier Rawḍa introduces its version through a recitation chain ending with Mahdī b. Sābiq. These are different forms of the poem, and neither establishes the authorship of Cairo’s anonymous version or conclusively explains its bi-llāh.]

God sees both what you withhold and what you give and recompenses everyone accordingly.

Spiritual allusion · Offering social status and the burden of reputation

Those who withhold the bounty of leadership, prestige and social standing (الرئاسة والجاه), refusing to spend it in the quest for knowledge of God, should not suppose this helps them. To spend it means to lay it aside in favour of obscurity (الخمول), humility before God and relinquishing rank among people. Hoarding status leads to remorse on Resurrection when they see the nearness of the elect shining like the sun in the highest stations, while they remain with ordinary people of the Right, veiled from witnessing the Lord of the Worlds except at an appointed time.

Whoever withholds wealth is raised among sinners; whoever withholds self and prestige but offers wealth is raised among the righteous; whoever offers both wealth and self is raised among the chosen and elect. Domin-

ion's final outcome belongs to the One, the Overpowering, who is absolutely free of need (الغني بالإطلاق). To ascribe the opposite to Him leads to estrangement and opposition, as the next verse makes clear.

3:181–183 · Claims about God's poverty, rejected signs and the demand for marvels

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 443–445

لَقَدْ سَمِعَ اللَّهُ قَوْلَ الَّذِينَ قالُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ فَقِيرٌ وَنَحْنُ أَغْنِياءُ سَنَكْتُبُ ما قالُوا وَقَتْلَهُمُ الْأَنْبِياءَ بِغَيْرِ حَقٍّ وَنَقُولُ ذُوقُوا عَذابَ الْحَرِيقِ (181) ذلِكَ بِما قَدَّمَتْ أَيْدِيكُمْ وَأَنَّ اللَّهَ لَيْسَ بِظَلاَّمٍ لِلْعَبِيدِ (182) الَّذِينَ قالُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَهِدَ إِلَيْنا أَلاَّ نُؤْمِنَ لِرَسُولٍ حَتَّى يَأْتِيَنا بِقُرْبانٍ تَأْكُلُهُ النَّارُ قُلْ قَدْ جاءَكُمْ رُسُلٌ مِنْ قَبْلِي بِالْبَيِّناتِ وَبِالَّذِي قُلْتُمْ فَلِمَ قَتَلْتُمُوهُمْ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صادِقِينَ (183)

181. God has heard the words of those who said, “God is poor and we are rich.” We shall record what they said, and their slaying of the prophets without right, and We shall say, “Taste the burning punishment.” 182. That is because of what your hands sent ahead, and because God does not wrong His servants. 183. Those who said, “God made a covenant with us that we should not believe any messenger until he brings an offering consumed by fire,” say: “Messengers before me came to you with clear proofs and with what you mention. Why, then, did you kill them, if you are truthful?”

Language · Wa-qatlahum, wa-anna Allāha and alladhīna

I say: “Their killing” (وقتلهم) is coordinated with the object (ما) or what stands for the subject under the passive reading, according to the two readings in accusative and nominative. “And because God ...” (وأن الله) is coordinated with *mā* in “because of what your hands sent ahead” [3:182]: the punishment is on account of your past acts and because God is utterly re-

moved from injustice—He necessarily recompenses the wrongdoer and the righteous. “Those who said, ‘God made a covenant ...’ ” is a modifier (صفة) or substitute (بدل) for the preceding “those who said, ‘God is poor’,” in the same genitive construction.

Outward commentary · The taunt about a 'loan to God'

God heard the words attributed to a Jewish scholar, Finḥāṣ ibn ʿĀzūrāʾ, and companions who said, “God is poor and we are rich.” According to the narrative, the Prophet sent Abū Bakr with a letter to the Jews of Banū Qaynuqāʿ, inviting them to Islam, prayer, alms and a goodly loan to God. Abū Bakr entered their study hall (مِدْرَاس), where many had gathered around Finḥāṣ and another scholar, Ayshaʿ. Abū Bakr said to Finḥāṣ: “Fear God and embrace Islam. By God, you know that Muḥammad is God’s Messenger and has brought you the truth from God. Embrace Islam, affirm him, and lend God a goodly loan: He will admit you to Paradise.” Finḥāṣ—God curse him—retorted that if God requested their property as a loan, He must be poor and they rich, for a rich man would not need a loan. Abū Bakr struck him and said that, were it not for their covenant, he would have struck off his head. Finḥāṣ complained to the Prophet. The Prophet asked Abū Bakr, “What prompted you to do what you did?” He replied, “Messenger of God, the enemy of God spoke an outrageous word: he claimed that God is poor and that they are rich.” Finḥāṣ denied saying it. The verse, in the report, exposed the denial. [181]

Outward commentary · Recording the insult and the moral argument against false claims

God will write their vile utterance on their records, or preserve it in His knowledge without neglect: it contains unbelief, derision of revelation and rejection of His Messenger. It is placed alongside the killing of prophets to show that grievous crimes have preceded this one. Those who dared to kill prophets cannot be thought incapable of such utterance. On Resurrection God will tell them to taste the burning punishment. **Dhawq** (الذوق, tasting) can designate apprehension of what is sensory, such as food, or of what is not literally tasted, as here. The image suits an offence issuing from miserli-

181. Cairo editor, C443.1: For the meaning of midrās, see the note on the commentary on verse 109 of Sūrat al-Baqara.

ness and an excessive attachment to money, which people chiefly need to obtain food; most of their miserliness arises from fear of losing that money. Their punishment comes from what their hands sent ahead—prophet-killing, the blasphemous utterance and their other acts. Hands are named because most actions are carried out with them. God never wrongs servants: they have wronged themselves.

A second reported deputation—Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf, Mālik ibn al-Ṣayf, Ḥuyayy ibn Akhṭab, Finḥāṣ and Wahb ibn Yahūdhā—said that their Torah required a claimant to prophecy to produce an offering devoured by heavenly fire. Such an offering might be an act of charity or a ritual sacrifice. According to the account, former Israelites were not permitted to consume sacrificial offerings or war spoils: when they presented an offering or acquired spoils, if it was accepted and none of the spoils had been misappropriated, a white fire descended from heaven and consumed that offering or those spoils as a sign of acceptance. If it was not accepted, it remained as it was. But requiring this particular marvel alone was obstinacy. Its evidential force lay simply in being a miracle (معجزة); other true miracles provide the same kind of proof. God therefore commanded the Messenger to reply that earlier messengers came with clear wonders *including the very sign demanded*, and yet were denied and killed, such as Zachariah and John: why murder them, if the absence of that sign was really the only obstacle to faith? God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Concealing the station of the saints and demanding miracles

Some of the outwardly accomplished among ordinary believers persist in denying the most elect (خواص الخاصة). They eavesdrop upon their utterances and, when they hear a saying beyond the reach of their knowledge that contains something that would diminish their standing [apparently, that of the elect], they preserve, distort and broadcast it to extinguish their light and expose their defects. God preserves the record of what they say and intend against His friends; the punishment in the allusive register is distance and veiling. One pretext for denial is demanding from present-day saints exactly the miracles attributed to earlier saints: “We shall not believe in them until they do what so-and-so did.” But earlier saints were themselves attacked even while such wonders were manifest. This is an enduring pattern. God guides whom He wills to a straight path.

God then consoled His Prophet.

3:184 · Prophets and saints opposed despite signs

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 445–445

فَإِنْ كَذَّبُوكَ فَقَدْ كُذِّبَ رُسُلٌ مِنْ قَبْلِكَ جاؤُ بِالْبَيِّناتِ وَالزُّبُرِ وَالْكِتابِ الْمُنِيرِ (184)

184. If they deny you, messengers before you were also denied, though they brought clear proofs, scriptures and the illuminating Book.

Language · Zubur (زُبُر) and mazbūr

I say: **Zubur** (الزُّبُر) is the plural of **zabūr**, in the sense of **mazbūr** (مزبور), what has been written. It comes from **zabartu**, "I wrote." Any written book can in this sense be called **zabūr**. Imruʾ al-Qays speaks of a ruinous dwelling:

> Whose traces did I see, grieving me,
> like script in a codex on a Yemeni palm-stalk?

Outward commentary · The continuity of revelation and rejection

To console the Messenger in the face of denial by Jews and others, God says that denial is not unprecedented. Messengers like him were denied before, though they came to their people with clear miracles (البينات), revealed scriptures (الزبر) containing admonitions, and an illuminating Book (الكتاب المنير) that conveys the rulings of the Revealed Law (الأحكام الشرعيات).

Spiritual allusion · Denial as a recurrent experience of the friends of God

As prophets were denied, so are God's friends (الأولياء) denied, even when remarkable sciences, evident wisdoms and clear gifts (الكرامات) appear through them, the greatest gift being knowledge of God (المعرفة). This is an enduring way of God which does not change. Ultimately disputants meet before Him,

the truthful and false are made manifest, and everyone receives the reward or consequence of what they sent ahead, knowing for certain their public and hidden acts.

The next verse returns all disputants to the certainty of death.

3:185 · Every self tastes death, and the contrast between the world and arrival

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 445–446

كُلُّ نَفْسٍ ذائِقَةُ الْمَوْتِ وَإِنَّما تُوَفَّوْنَ أُجُورَكُمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ فَمَنْ زُحْزِحَ عَنِ النَّارِ وَأُدْخِلَ الْجَنَّةَ فَقَدْ فازَ وَمَا الْحَياةُ الدُّنْيا إِلاَّ مَتاعُ الْغُرُورِ (185)

185. Every soul shall taste death, and you shall be paid your recompense in full only on the Day of Resurrection. Whoever is drawn away from the Fire and admitted to the Garden has succeeded. The life of this world is nothing but the enjoyment of delusion.

Language · Zaḥzaḥa (زحزح) as removal from danger

I say: **Zaḥzaḥa** (زحزح) means to remove or distance. **Zaḥzaḥa** (الزحزحة) also denotes drawing something out or away swiftly.

Outward commentary · Full recompense, deception and escape

Every living self must taste the heat of death and drink its cup. On the day people rise from their graves they receive the full requital of their deeds, good or evil. Al-Bayḍāwī observes that “paid in full” (التوفية) suggests that some payment may precede the final completion, and cites the saying that the grave may be a garden from Paradise's gardens or a pit from the Fire's pits. Whoever is drawn away from the Fire and enters Paradise has attained deliverance and the hoped-for goal. The Prophet is cited as saying

that whoever would be spared the Fire and enter Paradise should meet death believing in God and the Last Day and treating others as he would wish to be treated.

Worldly adornments and pleasures are only **matāʿ al-ghurūr** (متاع الغرور), the wares of deception. A deceitful seller displays whatever is attractive and hides defects. So the world presents sweetness and desire to its seeker until it distracts him from remembering and obeying God, so that he prefers it to the Hereafter; then he leaves it when he is most in need of it, and departs remorseful and sorrowing. The poet says:

> Whoever praises the world for something that delights him
> will soon condemn her when hardship comes.
> When she withdraws she leaves sorrow behind;
> when she approaches her many cares remain.

Spiritual allusion · The death of appetite and entry into the gardens of Presence

The lower self (النفس), considered as such, can indeed die when a seeker struggles against and overcomes it; failure lies with those responsible for its cultivation. Whoever draws it back from the fire of lusts (نار الشهوات), kills it with the swords of contrary discipline (سيوف المخالفات), and brings it into the gardens of divine Presences (جنات الحضرات) attains a great victory and noble profit. Success is through God.

God next enjoins patience at the loss of property and brethren, and at harm from the Jews and the polytheists.

3:186 · Trial in wealth and persons, harm from others, and the discipline of endurance

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 446–447

لَتُبْلَوُنَّ فِي أَمْوالِكُمْ وَأَنْفُسِكُمْ وَلَتَسْمَعُنَّ مِنَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ وَمِنَ الَّذِينَ أَشْرَكُوا أَذىً كَثِيراً وَإِنْ تَصْبِرُوا وَتَتَّقُوا فَإِنَّ ذلِكَ مِنْ عَزْمِ الْأُمُورِ (186)

186. You shall surely be tried in your wealth and yourselves, and you shall hear much hurtful speech from those given the Book before you and from those who associate others with God. If you are patient and mindful of God, that is among the matters requiring firm resolve.

Language · The reinforced passive tub-lawunna (تُبْلَوُنَّ)

I say: The underlying form of **tublawunna** (تُبْلَوُنَّ) was **tublawūna** (تُبْلَوُونَ), like **tunṣarūna** (تنصرون). The wāw was changed into an alif, then elided to avoid two adjacent consonants without vowels (التقاء الساكنين), yielding **tublawna**. The emphatic **nūn** (نون التوكيد) was added, producing three nūns; the indicative nūn of the plural (نون الرفع) was deleted, and the remaining wāw received a ḍamma to separate the two vowelless sounds, as the consonant marking the passive plural subject (النائبة عن الفاعل). The analysis retains Ibn ʿAjība's sequence of morphological operations.

Outward commentary · The kinds of hardship and forewarning as preparation

God swears that believers will be tried in wealth through disasters and through obligatory expenditure, and in their persons through being killed, wounds, capture, illness and other afflictions. They will hear many hurtful things from Jews, who received Scripture, and from the Meccan idolaters: the allegation that God is poor, attacks on the Prophet, criticism of the religion, incitement of unbelievers against the Muslims and other injuries. God tells them before the trials arrive so they can prepare for patience and en-

durance rather than being bewildered when hardship strikes. If they persevere and remain mindful of His commands, that is among matters on which resolve must be fixed (عزم الأمور), or what God has definitively ordained for His servants. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The testing of the sincere entrant to the particular path

Anyone who enters the path of the elect (طريق الخصوص) with sincerity and firm intention to arrive must be tested in wealth and self so that his sincerity becomes evident; he must also hear much injury from people. If he perseveres, he prevails; if he turns back, he loses. The Qurʾān says that believers are tried until those who strive and endure are manifested [Q 47:31]. Al-Wartajbī says that wealth is a test through acquiring it, withholding it or neglecting God's rights in it; the self is tested by obeying desires, leaving its discipline, preoccupation with worldly means and forgetting the Return. Another account holds that wealth tests one by continual occupation with receiving and disbursing it.

God then reproaches the concealment of truth and presentation of falsehood.

3:187 · The scholar’s duty to disclose knowledge and the danger of rank

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 447–448

وَإِذْ أَخَذَ اللَّهُ مِيثاقَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ لَتُبَيِّنُنَّهُ لِلنَّاسِ وَلا تَكْتُمُونَهُ فَنَبَذُوهُ وَراءَ ظُهُورِهِمْ وَاشْتَرَوْا بِهِ ثَمَناً قَلِيلاً فَبِئْسَ ما يَشْتَرُونَ (187)

187. And when God took the covenant of those who had been given the Book: “You shall certainly make it clear to the people and not conceal it,” they cast it behind their backs and sold it for a small price. How evil was what they purchased!

Language · The object of nabadhūhu (نَبَذُوهُ)

I say: The pronoun in “they cast it away” (نبذوه) refers either to the Book (الكتاب) or to the covenant (الميثاق).

Outward commentary · Learning obliges teaching

Remember when God took a covenant from those given Scripture—here Ibn ʿAjība names the Jews—to explain to people what their Book said about the Prophet and not conceal it. They put the covenant or the Book behind their backs, concealing his description out of fear that their leadership might disappear. They exchanged their trust for a paltry price of perishable worldly gain and the offerings collected from those beneath them. How evil that exchange!

The warning extends to anyone who conceals knowledge when asked by those entitled to receive it. The Prophet is quoted: “Whoever withholds knowledge from those entitled to it will be bridled with a bridle of fire.” ʿAlī says: “God did not command the ignorant to learn before commanding the learned to teach.” Muḥammad ibn Kaʿb declares that a scholar must not be silent about knowledge, nor an ignorant person silent about his ignorance.

Spiritual allusion · When scholars conceal recognition of spiritual excellence

When scholars recognize a saint's particular realization (الخصوصية), yet conceal it out of envy and fear for their leadership, they fall under the warning. Ordinary people follow them; when they conceal or deny it, followers imitate them in that. Thus they carry their own burdens along with additional burdens caused by leading others astray [cf. Q 29:13]. God knows best.

When the Prophet asked the Jews about something in the Torah, they concealed it and told him something else. They departed having made him think that they had answered his question, sought his praise and rejoiced; God then revealed the next verse concerning them.

3:188–189 · Joy in self-praise, divine agency and the moral quality of gratitude

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 448–449

لا تَحْسَبَنَّ الَّذِينَ يَفْرَحُونَ بِما أَتَوْا وَيُحِبُّونَ أَنْ يُحْمَدُوا بِما لَمْ يَفْعَلُوا فَلا تَحْسَبَنَّهُمْ بِمَفازَةٍ مِنَ الْعَذابِ وَلَهُمْ عَذابٌ أَلِيمٌ (188) وَلِلَّهِ مُلْكُ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاللَّهُ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ (189)

188. Do not suppose those who rejoice in what they have done and love to be praised for what they have not done—do not suppose them safe from punishment. For them is a painful punishment. 189. To God belongs the dominion of the heavens and the earth; God has power over all things.

Language · The possible constructions of taḥsabanna

I say: In the second-person reading (بالخطاب), “those who” is the first object (مفعول أول), and the second is omitted—“safe from punishment”—or supplied by the next clause, “do not suppose them ...,” which then reinforces the first verb. Under the third-person reading (بالغيب), “those who” is subject (فاعل) and both objects are omitted but recoverable from the repeated construction: they are not to suppose themselves saved. With fatḥa on **tā’** in **fa-lā taḥsabannahum**, the address is to the Messenger and the form is understood as fixed; with **yā’**, the construction concerns those who rejoice, and the verb is inflected: they must not suppose themselves safe from punishment.

Outward commentary · Misrepresentation and undeserved praise

The Prophet is told not to suppose secure from punishment those who rejoice at what they have done in concealing and falsifying the truth, while longing to be praised as if they had fulfilled the covenant, made truth plain and conveyed it honestly. They will not escape painful punishment. The entire dominion of heaven and earth belongs to God, who may punish or pardon as He wills and whose power nothing can frustrate.

Abū Saʿīd al-Khudrī is quoted as relating the verse to hypocrites who stayed behind when the Prophet departed, then offered excuses on his return, rejoicing when accepted and craving praise for deeds they never performed. The earlier account concerning concealment is traced to Ibn ʿAbbās. Ibn Ḥajar observes that the warning can encompass anyone who does a good deed and exults in it through self-admiration while seeking praise for qualities not possessed. God knows best. [182]

Spiritual allusion · Rejoicing in grace rather than claiming authorship of works

People confined to separation (أهل الفرق) attribute deeds to their own selves, forgetting the Real's activity, and seek praise for what belongs to another Agent. They have not escaped the pain of separation or the veil of self-admiration (حجاب العجب): there is no agent save the Real. God's favour is complete in that He creates action *within* you and attributes it *to* you.

There is no harm in joy at obedience insofar as it appears in the servant as a sign of divine solicitude (عنوان العناية), while the servant sees himself as an instrument (آلة), borne along by pre-eternal power, and sees himself removed from performing it. Such joy increases humility and gratitude. But delight in action as proceeding from oneself, coupled with boasting over others, is self-admiration itself. As the *Ḥikam* says: “Do not rejoice in obedience because it issued from you; rejoice because it came to you as a gift from God: ‘Say: in the bounty of God and His mercy, in that let them rejoice’ ” [Q 10:58].

He then points to the signs of the Power disclosed by the final description “powerful over all things.”

182. Cairo editor, C448.1: That is, on a military expedition.

3:190 · The signs of created change and the unity disclosed through opposites

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 449–449

إِنَّ فِي خَلْقِ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلافِ اللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهارِ لَآياتٍ لِأُولِي الْأَلْبابِ (190)

190. In the creation of the heavens and the earth, and the alternation of night and day, are signs for those endowed with understanding.

Outward commentary · From change to divine agency

In the creation and manifestation of the heavens and earth are evident signs of the Creator's existence and the perfection of His power and knowledge, discernible by complete and purified intellects (أولو الألباب), freed from the impurities of sense (الحس) and imagination or estimation (الوهم). Al-Bayḍāwī suggests that the verse may be limited to these three because change itself supplies the basis of inference (مناط الاستدلال): alteration may occur in a thing's own state, like night and day; in its parts, like growing beings whose forms develop; or through something external to it, like celestial spheres changing their positions. The Prophet is quoted as warning: “Woe to one who recites this and does not reflect upon it.”

Spiritual allusion · Power and Wisdom; the sensory vessel and its meaning

Creation (الخلق) is origination (الاختراع) and manifestation (الإظهار). The four manifestations here—heaven, earth, night and day—show that the Real discloses Himself to servants through pairs of apparent contraries: light and darkness, Power and Wisdom (القدرة والحكمة), sense and meaning (الحس والمعنى). He creates pairs so that people may flee from the apparent twoness of their sensory appearance (إثنينية حسهما) to the singularity of their meaning (فردية معناهما): “Flee, therefore, to God” [Q 51:50]. The heavens and daytime are luminous, earth and night dark, yet their unity of meaning points

beyond their differing forms. Do not stop at the vessels (الأواني): enter the sea of meanings (بحر المعاني) so that, perhaps, you may behold Me. Success comes from God.

God describes the people of understanding who can grasp these purified meanings.

3:191–194 · Remembrance, contemplation and the passage from intellectual signs to witnessing

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 450–453

الَّذِينَ يَذْكُرُونَ اللَّهَ قِياماً وَقُعُوداً وَعَلى جُنُوبِهِمْ وَيَتَفَكَّرُونَ فِي خَلْقِ السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ رَبَّنا ما خَلَقْتَ هذا باطِلاً سُبْحانَكَ فَقِنا عَذابَ النَّارِ (191) رَبَّنا إِنَّكَ مَنْ تُدْخِلِ النَّارَ فَقَدْ أَخْزَيْتَهُ وَما لِلظَّالِمِينَ مِنْ أَنْصارٍ (192) رَبَّنا إِنَّنا سَمِعْنا مُنادِياً يُنادِي لِلْإِيمانِ أَنْ آمِنُوا بِرَبِّكُمْ فَآمَنَّا رَبَّنا فَاغْفِرْ لَنا ذُنُوبَنا وَكَفِّرْ عَنَّا سَيِّئاتِنا وَتَوَفَّنا مَعَ الْأَبْرارِ (193) رَبَّنا وَآتِنا مَا وَعَدْتَنا عَلى رُسُلِكَ وَلا تُخْزِنا يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ إِنَّكَ لا تُخْلِفُ الْمِيعادَ (194)

191. Those who remember God standing, sitting and upon their sides, and reflect upon the creation of the heavens and the earth: “Our Lord, You did not create this in vain. Glory be to You! Preserve us from the punishment of the Fire. 192. Our Lord, whoever You cause to enter the Fire You have disgraced, and wrongdoers have no helpers. 193. Our Lord, we heard a caller calling to faith, ‘Believe in your Lord,’ and we believed. Our Lord, forgive us our sins, efface our evil deeds and take us in death with the righteous. 194. Our Lord, give us what You promised us through Your messengers, and do not disgrace us on the Day of Resurrection. Surely You never break the promise.”

Outward commentary · Continual dhikr and reflective reasoning

Those endowed with understanding remember God continually (الذكر), standing, sitting and reclining. The Prophet is quoted urging abundant remembrance as grazing in Paradise's gardens. Or the verse describes prayer in the three postures permitted according to capacity, as in the Prophet's instruction to the ill ʿImrān ibn Ḥuṣayn: pray standing if able, otherwise sitting, otherwise lying upon your side and indicating the movements.

They contemplate (يتفكرون) the creation of heaven and earth as proof and admonition. Ibn ʿAjība calls reflection (التفكر) the greatest worship, citing sayings that no worship resembles it and that a man reclining on his bed looked at the sky and stars and said, “I testify that you have a Creator. O God, forgive me”; God then looked upon him and forgave him. Reflection is particular to the heart and is itself the purpose of creation. Al-Bayḍāwī sees in this testimony to the nobility of the theological sciences of principles (علم الأصول) and their scholars; further discussion comes in the allusion below.

Outward commentary · Why the created order is not in vain

Reflecting upon the marvels of created things, they say, “Our Lord, You did not create this in vain”—aimlessly, without Wisdom. Rather it exists for wondrous wisdom: it provides the basis for human existence and livelihood, serves as a sign leading to the knowledge of God and urges obedience, through which everlasting life and happiness in His presence may be attained. “Glory be to You!” declares His transcendence from futility. “Protect us from the Fire” which awaits those who turn away from inquiry and fail to fulfil what its conclusions demand under God's command. There are no helpers to save wrongdoers from it. Placing the explicit noun “wrongdoers” where a pronoun might stand (إظهار في موضع الإضمار) indicates that wrongdoing itself is the reason for punishment and loss of help.

The “caller” to belief can be the noble Messenger or the Qurʾān: “Believe in your Lord, affirm His oneness.” They answer and ask forgiveness for major sins (ذنوبنا), the effacement of lesser misdeeds (سيئاتنا), and to be taken in death among the excellent and chosen (الأبرار), counted with them. This expresses love of meeting God and so being loved in that meeting. They ask for the reward promised to believers through acceptance of the messengers, or the mercy and beautiful return promised *upon their tongues*. This is

not distrust of God's promise: rather it arises from fear of failing the conditions, a disastrous final outcome, insufficient fulfilment, worshipful devotion or humility. Al-Bayḍāwī mentions these readings.

"Do not disgrace us on the Day of Resurrection" asks that their failings not bring humiliation; God does not break the promise of rewarding believers and answering supplications, or of resurrection and reckoning. **Rabbanā** (رَبَّنا) is repeated to intensify supplication and mark the separate significance of each request. An early report states: "If someone is beset by a matter and says 'Our Lord' five times, God delivers him from what he fears"; Ibn ʿAjība quotes it through al-Bayḍāwī. T168 183

Spiritual allusion · The ascent of dhikr from tongue to heart, spirit and secret

God sets remembrance (الذكر) before reflection (الفكر), according to the sequence of wayfaring (ترتيب السير). A disciple first practices remembrance by the tongue (ذكر اللسان) until it penetrates the inner heart (الجنان); then it passes to the heart (القلب), the spirit (الروح), which is the domain of contemplation, and at last the secret (السر), the station of witnessing and direct seeing (الشهود والعيان). Here the tongue falls silent and the human subject disappears amid lights of direct witnessing. A poet says:

> Whenever I invoke You, my secret, spirit and heart
> all but curse me when I remember You;
> as if a watchman of Yours called to me,
> "Beware! Woe to you—beware of recollection!"
> Do you not see the Real's signs now shining,
> and the whole, through its meaning, has joined your meaning?

[Translator's note: The Cairo print vocalizes al-kullu ("the whole") in the nominative, making it the subject of wāṣala ("has joined"), with maʿnāka ("your meaning") as its object. Ibn ʿAjība repeats the poem in Īqāẓ al-himam, pp. 120–121, within an account of the disappearance of awareness of the separate rememberer. The fuller discussion in Ibn ʿAbbād's Ghayth al-mawāhib, pp. 73–74, quotes Ibn al-Bannā's express rejection of indwelling or identity when explaining this state. These contexts support an inward account of remembrance, but do not identify the exact scope of "the whole" or the antecedent of "its

183. Cairo editor, C451.1: In these verses the Qurʾān relates that the people of understanding said "Our Lord" five times. Concerning the report cited by the author, al-Munāwī says in al-Fatḥ al-samāwī: "I have not located it."

meaning"; the prepositional phrase remains tentative. Al-Qushayrī's Risāla (II:377) and al-Sulamī's Jawāmiʿ ādāb al-ṣūfiyya preserve only the preceding two lines and cannot settle this third line. A longer, anonymous five-line version in al-Qaṣd al-mujarrad, published under Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh's name (ed. Maḥmūd Tawfīq al-Ḥakīm, Cairo, 2002, pp.119–120), adds verses about witnessing the meeting and remembrance free of uncertainty. It corroborates the difficult line and its nominative subject, but supplies no explicit gloss of its referents.]

On reaching the station of singleness (مقام الإفراد), separate daily litanies (الأوراد) become a single *wird*: the heart remains in the Presence between thinking and looking (فكرة ونظرة), wholly directed to God and absent from all besides Him.

Spiritual allusion · Al-Ghazālī on the realized person's wird

In the *Iḥyāʾ*, in the Book of Litanies, al-Ghazālī describes the unifier entirely concentrated upon the One, the Eternal Refuge: all concerns become one; he loves and fears none but God, expects provision only from Him, and sees God in whatever comes before him. Such a person no longer needs a variety of arranged litanies; after obligatory prayer his continual practice is presence of heart with God. Nothing occurs, is heard or seen without becoming an occasion for reflection, admonition and growth. Since God moves and stills all things, every circumstance increases him, and no distinct form of worship is isolated from another. He has fled to God [Q 51:50] and says, "I am going to my Lord" [Q 37:99]. This is the furthest degree of the truthful (الصديقين).

Yet, al-Ghazālī insists, a disciple must not hear this and presumptuously claim it, abandoning assigned acts of devotion. He describes its signs as freedom from distracting whispers, sinful thoughts, overwhelming changes of state and worldly distractions—and remarks how rare this rank is. **Ibn ʿAjība expressly qualifies one criterion**: the assertion that no thought of sin ever enters the heart is not necessary; the gnostic's heart can receive luminous and dark self-disclosures (التجليات النورانية والظلمانية), but the latter diminish and do not settle there.

Al-Ghazālī also says elsewhere that the worship of people of understanding does not go beyond remembering God and contemplating Him in love of His Majesty and Beauty; other works reinforce these acts. Those who work for Paradise's reward occupy the rank of the simple-hearted (*bulh*), and attain it by their works, since most of the people of Paradise are simple-

hearted. In the *Kīmiyāʾ al-saʿāda* he warns against treating beginners' disciplines as identical with those of realized people. A Sufi teacher was once said to appear a supremely truthful one (*ṣiddīq*) at the beginning, when strenuous outward practice was evident, but a heretic at the end, when inward absorption had become dominant and outward movement less conspicuous. That is not contempt for worship, but attention to its kernel and goal; the bat's eyes cannot bear the sun. [184]

Ibn ʿAjība then cites a teaching of his teacher's teacher, Sīdī ʿAbd al-Raḥmān, on the inwardly realized performing acts that gather rather than scatter their concentration. Al-Junayd reportedly preferred that the Sufi should neither read nor write, because that better gathers his purpose, and for the disciple not to be distracted by earning or collecting hadith, lest his state change. Ibn ʿAjība adds the operative qualification: whoever has been granted a teacher of spiritual formation (شيخ التربية) should take as his practice whatever that teacher specifically assigns; this is his very dhikr and carries him onwards, whatever it may be. [T169]

Spiritual allusion · Thinking that assents and thinking that witnesses

Reflection (التفكر) is the greatest devotional act and an exalted form of nearness, the worship of realized knowers and the limit of those drawn near. The report “An hour's reflection is better than seventy years of worship” is invoked. *[Translator’s note: Its attribution requires verification.]* Al-Junayd calls the noblest gathering the sitting of contemplation in the field of tawḥīd (ميدان التوحيد), breathing the breeze of knowledge (المعرفة), drinking the cup of love from the ocean of affection, and gazing with a favourable opinion of God. He then exclaims: “What gatherings—how exalted they are! What a drink—how delicious it is! Blessed is whoever is granted it.” Al-Qushayrī calls thinking a characteristic of every seeker: its fruit, when supported by knowledge and cleared of impurities, is arrival at the springs of realization (مناهل التحقيق).

Asked about her husband’s worship, Abū Dharr’s wife said that he spent his entire day apart in contemplation; Abū Bakr’s wife said the same of his entire night, and the wife of Abū al-Dardāʾ is cited similarly. Jesus is quoted as praising a person whose speech is remembrance, silence contemplation and gaze a lesson; al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī says speech without wisdom is idle, si-

184. Cairo editor, C452.1: See the note on the allusion on verse 212 of Sūrat al-Baqara.

lence without reflection heedless, and seeing without learning vain. The *Ḥikam* says that nothing benefits the heart like seclusion entering the field of thought; reflection is the lamp of the heart and without it the lamp gives no light; and there are two forms: **reflection of affirmation and faith** (فكرة تصديق وإيمان), for those who draw conclusions, and **reflection of witnessing and immediate vision** (فكرة شهود وعيان), for those who see directly and understand. The latter is the worship of the gnostics. Its value cannot be quantified by sixty or seventy years: Ibn ʿAjība speaks of a moment equal to a thousand years, quoting:

> Every moment of my Beloved
> is worth a thousand years.

Their hours are all Laylat al-Qadr. Those still far away should lament their deficiency, while those attaining it may rejoice. Another poet says: “They are the men; it is an injustice to call a man / one who has not acquired the inward meanings of their qualities.” Ibn ʿAjība prays for realization of their state and a share in their refreshment.

He concludes by returning to the verses spiritually. “You have not created this in vain”: it stands in being by Your giving it standing (ثابت بإثباتك), yet is effaced by the oneness of Your Essence (ممحُوّ بأحدية ذاتك). What is false is impossible, while everything besides Him is vain, as the Messenger—blessings and peace be upon him—affirmed. [T170] “We heard a caller ... and believed”: we belonged to the first company of the people of faith; He then made a way for us to the station of iḥsān. “Give us what You promised”: arrival at direct witnessing (الوصول إلى العيان). Success is through God. [185]

He then recounts God's answer to their prayer.

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185. Cairo editor, C453.1: When he said, “The truest words spoken by a poet are: ‘Everything other than God is vain.’” Al-Bukhārī records the hadith in “Virtues of the Anṣār,” chapter “The Days of Ignorance,” and Muslim in “Poetry,” on the authority of Abū Hurayra.

3:195 · The answer to supplication and the equal recompense of women and men

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 453–454

فَاسْتَجابَ لَهُمْ رَبُّهُمْ أَنِّي لا أُضِيعُ عَمَلَ عامِلٍ مِنْكُمْ مِنْ ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنْثى
بَعْضُكُمْ مِنْ بَعْضٍ فَالَّذِينَ هاجَرُوا وَأُخْرِجُوا مِنْ دِيارِهِمْ وَأُوذُوا فِي
سَبِيلِي وَقاتَلُوا وَقُتِلُوا لَأُكَفِّرَنَّ عَنْهُمْ سَيِّئاتِهِمْ وَلَأُدْخِلَنَّهُمْ جَنَّاتٍ تَجْرِي
مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ ثَواباً مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ عِنْدَهُ حُسْنُ الثَّوابِ (195)

195. Their Lord answered them: “I shall not let the work of any worker among you be lost, male or female; you belong one to another. Those who migrated, were driven from their homes, suffered harm in My way, fought and were killed—I shall surely efface their misdeeds and admit them to gardens beneath which rivers flow, as a reward from God. With God is the fairest reward.”

Language · Istajāba and ajāba

I say: **Istajāba** (استجاب) has a more specific sense than **ajāba** (أجاب): it implies acting upon what was requested, whereas **ajāba** may consist in a promise alone. The verb can govern directly or take the preposition **lām** (لام). “You belong one to another” (بعضكم من بعض) is a parenthetical sentence (جملة معترضة). Ibn ʿAjība cites al-Bayḍāwī and invites verification of the grammatical judgment.

Outward commentary · No effort lost through sex or circumstance

Their Lord responded to their request, for hopes are not disappointed with Him. He will not let the work of any servant be lost, male or female: each sex is born from the other, both stem from one origin, and both are joined in religion. A report states that Umm Salama asked why God spoke of men in connection with migration but not women; the verse was then revealed.

The workers are specified: those who migrated from the abode of idolatry, left homeland, companions and clan, were driven from their homes and harmed on account of faith, fought disbelievers and were killed—that is, died while striving. Another reading reverses the verbs, for **wāw** does not necessarily establish sequence (الواو لا ترتب); or some were killed and the survivors went on fighting without weakening. God will efface their misdeeds, bring them into gardens with flowing streams, and bestow reward from Himself in favour and generosity. Nothing is beyond His power, and with Him is the best reward.

Spiritual allusion · Migration from customary attachments and fighting the lower self

Because they turned their high aspirations (همم علية) and firm resolve toward God, knocked at His gate with unceasing dhikr and reflection on His Essence's greatness and the beauty of His bounty, and entreated Him through humility, brokenness and need, He opened the gate before them and admitted them into His Presence with His beloved, for He answers those who ask and does not disappoint their hopes. They migrated from homelands and separated from kindred and companions—except those who increased their movement towards the Merciful—and fought their lower selves until these died and then came alive through union, in the presence of the Great, Most Exalted. As the poet says:

> If you desire union with us, your death is a condition;
> no one retains a portion of self and attains union.

God then erased from their inward sight the evil of all otherness (سيئات الأغيار) and purified their hearts of troubles, until they entered the gardens of knowledge (جنة المعارف), indescribable in their beauty, with rivers of sciences flowing beneath and treasuries of understanding opening within. This is reward from the Living, Self-Subsisting One. God knows best.

When God extended worldly prosperity to the Jews and idolaters as a gradual drawing toward ruin (*istidrāj*), some believers said, “God’s enemies appear to us to enjoy good fortune, while we have perished from hunger and hardship.” God then revealed the next verses.

3:196–198 · Worldly prosperity, true hospitality and the degrees of nearness

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 454–456

لا يَغُرَّنَّكَ تَقَلُّبُ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا فِي الْبِلادِ (196) مَتاعٌ قَلِيلٌ ثُمَّ مَأْواهُمْ جَهَنَّمُ وَبِئْسَ الْمِهادُ (197) لكِنِ الَّذِينَ اتَّقَوْا رَبَّهُمْ لَهُمْ جَنَّاتٌ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ خالِدِينَ فِيها نُزُلاً مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ وَما عِنْدَ اللَّهِ خَيْرٌ لِلْأَبْرارِ (198)

196. Let not the movement of those who disbelieve throughout the land delude you. 197. It is but a little enjoyment; then their refuge is Hell—an evil resting place! 198. But those who are mindful of their Lord have gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding therein, as hospitality from God; and what is with God is better for the righteous.

Language · Nuzul (نُزُل) as hospitality

I say: **Nuzul** (النُّزُل), also pronounced with a vowelless middle consonant, is the food, drink and gift offered to an arriving guest. Its accusative ending may make it a circumstantial expression (حال) relating to “gardens,” governed by the preceding locative expression (ظرف), or a cognate accusative (مصدر مؤكد): “They are welcomed with a full welcome.”

Outward commentary · The difference between transitory abundance and lasting provision

Let not the outward prosperity of unbelievers bewilder the Prophet or another hearer: their ability to travel freely, trade, farm, and enjoy comfort, abundance and ease is not a measure of ultimate success. The address confirms the Prophet in the absence of such deception, as “Do not obey those who deny” [Q 68:8] confirms an existing refusal. All such enjoyment is small and passing, provision for a short journey, shifting shade and a dis-

solving cloud. The Prophet is quoted saying that this world's proportion to the next is as the drop remaining on a finger dipped in the sea. Departure is inevitable; then Hell is their destination and miserable resting place.

The wise instead consider what God has prepared for those who fear His punishment and are mindful of Him: gardens with rivers flowing, for everlasting residence. That is God's reception (نُزُل), the hospitality first presented to the guest; what He has prepared *beyond* that first reception cannot be expressed by the tongue. “What is with God,” bodily and spiritual delight without end, is better for the righteous than the fate of wrongdoers. It is said that true **birr** (البر) is to refrain even from injuring an ant.

Spiritual allusion · The contrast with worldly kings and the divine feast

O spiritual poor, be not seduced by impressive houses and richly furnished beds. The world's wares are few; its mighty are small, its wealthy poor and its eminent insignificant. Remember the Prophet's life. Anas reports entering when he lay on a simple woven bedstead with a leather cushion stuffed with palm fibre. ʿUmar entered and wept at the marks left on the Prophet's side by the weaving, contrasting his condition with the comfort enjoyed by Chosroes and Caesar. The Prophet is quoted asking whether ʿUmar was not content that they should have the world and the believers the Hereafter, a report attributed here to al-Bukhārī.

Look rather at what God has prepared for the righteous who endured a brief daytime hour of striving and then attained the nearness of the Generous Forgiver in the enduring abode, above all the realized masters. Al-Wartajbī says that after clearly announcing the high rank of those mindful of God in the gardens, God leaves the subtleties of solicitude partly hidden: what is with Him—the delight of witnessing (نعيم المشاهدة), the graces of nearness (لطائف القربة) and the sweetness of union (حلاوة الوصلة)—is better than the joys of Paradise. He also sees ranks of sainthood (مراتب الولاية): mindful discipline purifies the inward person of the stains of nature and protects conduct from disobedience, the first degree; the righteous (الأبرار) are firm in gnosis. Thus the mindful are in the Garden, whereas the fully righteous abide in the Presence.

Since some People of the Book deserved no reproach and did follow the truth, God now explicitly distinguishes them.

3:199 · The faithful People of the Book and two rewards for scholarship and love

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 456–457

وَإِنَّ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ لَمَنْ يُؤْمِنُ بِاللَّهِ وَما أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْكُمْ وَما أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْهِمْ خاشِعِينَ لِلَّهِ لا يَشْتَرُونَ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ ثَمَناً قَلِيلاً أُولئِكَ لَهُمْ أَجْرُهُمْ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ سَرِيعُ الْحِسابِ (199)

199. Among the People of the Book are those who believe in God, in what has been sent down to you and in what was sent down to them, humbling themselves before God. They do not sell God's signs for a small price. These have their reward with their Lord; truly God is swift in reckoning.

Outward commentary · Faith, humility and rejection of worldly exchange

Among the People of the Book are those like ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and his companions among Jews who embraced Islam: they genuinely believe in God, the Qurʾān sent to you and the Torah given to them. They are humble, submissive and faithful to the covenant, and do not exchange God’s signs for a paltry price, as the distorters among the Jewish rabbis did. God promises them reward increased twofold. His reckoning is swift: He hastens to pay their rewards in full and honour their return, for He knows deeds and the bounty they merit, without needing deliberation or precaution.

An alternative report applies the verse to Christians—forty from Najrān and thirty-two from Abyssinia—who came to the Prophet and accepted Islam. Another associates it with the Negus (al-Najāshī), whose death Gabriel informed the Prophet of; the Prophet went out to offer the funeral prayer, while the hypocrites said, “Look at this man, praying over a Christian foreign infidel (*ʿilj*)!” Then the verse was revealed. *[Translator’s note: Ibn ʿAjība presents these as alternative reports of the occasion of revelation.]* God knows best. [186]

186. Cairo editor, C456.1: ʿIlj: a large, strong man.

Spiritual allusion · Jurists who recognize the saints but cannot accompany them

I have seen some jurists attain faith in the particularity of the friends of God of their own age (خصوص أهل زمانهم), recognize their sainthood and gain a measure of love for them, even though the decrees of destiny did not permit them to enter their company. Yet traces of their light appeared in these jurists, who drew something from their secrets. Their inward character was illumined and their practice of the Sacred Law perfected; signs of reverence and humility appeared, with contentment and scrupulousness (القناعة والورع). The anguish and panic that afflicted others had left their hearts. Such jurists have two rewards: one for carrying the burden of the Sacred Law to benefit ordinary people, and one for the love they gained for the spiritual people. “A person is with those whom he loves.” Success comes from God.

Patience is to religion as the head to a body: if it were constantly present in people, no reproach would be addressed to anyone. God therefore closes this sūrah, in which He has rebuked most of His servants, by commanding it.

3:200 · The closing injunction: patience, rivalry in steadfastness and the stations of Islam, faith and iḥsān

Cairo print · Volume I, pp. 457–457

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اصْبِرُوا وَصابِرُوا وَرابِطُوا وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُفْلِحُونَ (200)

200. O you who believe, be patient; persevere in patience against others; maintain vigilant readiness at the frontier; and be mindful of God, that you may prosper.

Language · Murābaṭa (مرابطة) at the frontier

I say: **Murābaṭa** (المرابطة) originally referred to each of two opposing groups tethering their horses in readiness for combat. The term then extended to any person remaining in a frontier post (ثغر), defending those behind him even without a mount, whether with his family or alone, provided the intention is the protection of Muslims. Sincerity of intention (خلوص النية) is decisive; Ibn ʿAjība explicitly disagrees here with a restriction ascribed to Ibn ʿAṭiyya, promising to correct it in the exposition. [187] [188]

Outward commentary · Four commands addressed to believers

Be patient (اصبروا) through the labour of obedience, the difficulties and crises that touch you, abstaining from sins and violations, and giving thanks for divine gifts. Compete in perseverance (صابروا) against the enemy, steadfast when the field of battle is perilous. Guard the frontier (رابطوا), positioning your bodies and horses there to protect Muslims and win abundant reward. The Prophet is quoted saying that a day and night in frontier defence are rewarded like a month's fasting and standing in prayer, without breaking the fast or leaving prayer except for a necessity, and that one who dies in such service continues to be rewarded until judgment. Waiting for one prayer after another is also included under the name **ribāṭ**, as reported in another hadith. Finally, fear God concerning what He commands and forbids, so that you attain success beyond which no loss follows. [189]

Spiritual allusion · Fourfold patience and the uniting of law, path and Reality

"O you who believe," with the faith of the elect (إيمان أهل الخصوص): be patient in preserving the observances of the Sacred Law (مراسم الشريعة); persevere in acquiring the lights of the Path (أنوار الطريقة); and station your hearts at the witnessing of the secrets of Reality (شهود أسرار الحقيقة). Or: patience is the performance of worship (العبادة); mutual perseverance is realization of servanthood (العبودية); stationing is acquisition of **ʿubūda** (العبودة), which he

187. Cairo editor, C457.1: After an intervening discussion, Ibn ʿAṭiyya says: "As for those who permanently inhabit the frontier with their families, building and earning their living there: although they are protectors, they are not murābiṭs."
188. Cairo editor, C457.2: The source copies read: "its reward" (thawābahu).
189. Cairo editor, C457.3: Infatala: he turned away or departed.

glosses as freedom (الحرية). Or: patience establishes Islam; perseverance perpetuates faith; and stationing consists in continual abiding at the station of iḥsān (مقام الإحسان). Or: patience is to purify deeds, perseverance to reject self-interest and desires, stationing to fix one's inward secrets upon the lights of witnessing (أنوار المشاهدات). Be mindful of God, and do not witness anything other than Him along with Him, so that you succeed through realized knowledge of Him (معرفة الله). Success is through God, the guide to the straight path.

Sūrat al-Nisāʾ

The six matters to be safeguarded

Cairo Arabic edition I:459

Outward commentary · The scope and governing principle of Sūrat al-Nisāʾ

This sūrah is Medinan. Al-Thaʿlabī says that it contains sixteen thousand and thirty letters, three thousand seven hundred and forty-five words, and one hundred and sixty verses. Al-Bayḍāwī gives one hundred and seventy-five verses. [T171]

Its subject matter encompasses the injunction to safeguard six things: property (حفظ الأموال), lineage and kinship (حفظ الأنساب), bodies or lives (حفظ الأبدان), religion (حفظ الأديان), speech (حفظ اللسان), and faith (حفظ الإيمان). Before these the command to have Godfearing awareness (التقوى) is placed first, for it is the governing principle of them all. Thus He says:

4:1 — One origin, kinship, vigilance and the two fruits of murāqaba

Cairo Arabic edition I:459–461

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمنِ الرَّحِيمِ

يا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ اتَّقُوا رَبَّكُمُ الَّذِي خَلَقَكُمْ مِنْ نَفْسٍ واحِدَةٍ وَخَلَقَ مِنْها زَوْجَها وَبَثَّ مِنْهُما رِجالاً كَثِيراً وَنِساءً وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ الَّذِي تَسائَلُونَ بِهِ وَالْأَرْحامَ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَلَيْكُمْ رَقِيباً (1)

1. O people, be mindful of your Lord, who created you from a single soul, and from it created its mate, and spread forth from the two of them many men and women. Be mindful of God, in whose name you ask one another, and of the bonds of kinship. God is ever watching over you.

Language · The accusative and genitive readings of al-arḥām (الأرحام)

I say: Whoever reads "and the ties of kinship" (والأرحامَ) in the accusative (النصب) coordinates it with the divine Name: "And guard against severing kinship ties." Ḥamza reads it in the genitive (الخفض), coordinated with the pronoun in "by Him" (به), like the poet's verse:

> Today you have taken to reviling and insulting us;
> Go, then—for there is nothing to wonder at in you or in the days! [190]

Most Basran grammarians do not allow coordination with a governed pronoun unless the preposition (الجار) is repeated. Thus they say: "I passed by him and by Zayd" (مررت به وبزيد). But Ibn Mālik says:

> I do not consider it obligatory, since it has indeed been found
> In sound poetry and sound prose alike.

The sound prose here is the reading transmitted from Ḥamza: this is the correct analysis. To take the conjunction wāw as an oath-particle (واو القسم) is far-fetched. T172

Outward commentary · Creation from a single soul and the duty of kinship

The Real—majestic is His greatness—addresses "O people," meaning all created persons. "Be mindful of your Lord" in what He has charged you to do. He then declares why such mindfulness is incumbent: "Who created you from a single soul," meaning Adam, "and from it created its mate," meaning Eve, from one of his ribs, "and scattered from them many men and women": from the single soul He brought forth sons and daughters. Al-Bayḍāwī says that men alone are explicitly qualified as numerous, without similarly qualifying women, because wisdom requires women to be more

190. Cairo editor, C459.1: Sībawayhi cited this verse. See Ibn ʿAqīl's commentary on the Alfiyya, chapter "Conjunction by Coordination" (ʿaṭf al-nasaq).

numerous; “many” agrees with the plural. The command to fear God follows this narrative because it demonstrates overwhelming power, which rightly inspires awe, and manifest beneficence, which requires obedience to its Bestower. Thus concludes his statement.

“And be mindful of God, by whom you appeal to one another”: one of you says to another, “I ask you by Almighty God.” “And of kinship ties”: fear severing them, for one who severs them is cut off by God and one who maintains them is joined by Him, as stated in the report [R1]. Alternatively, you make appeals through God and the ties of kinship: “I ask you by the kinship between us,” or “by the relationship that joins us.” Then He warns them against abandoning His command: “God is ever a watcher (رقيب) over you”—guarding, observing, and witnessing you in every state.

Spiritual allusion · From witnessing to servanthood; combining fanāʾ and baqāʾ

At the end of the previous sūrah God led them through the ascending stations of the way (مدارج السلوك) until He brought them into the Presence of the King of Kings. He commanded them to guard against what removes them from witnessing the darkness of the lights of Lordship [Textual note: the Cairo text reads *ẓulmat anwār al-rubūbiyya*, literally “the darkness of the lights of Lordship.” The wording is preserved without emendation. A possible contextual analogy occurs in Ibn ʿAjība’s *Īqāẓ al-himam*, pp. 120–121: immersion in divine light removes awareness of other things, and a definition he attributes to al-Qushayrī speaks of the innermost secret’s darkening at the Remembered’s appearance. This suggests an eclipse of separate awareness, but it is not an exact gloss of the present phrase or evidence for changing its letters], and at the beginning of this sūrah brings them down again to the courtesy and disciplines of servanthood (آداب العبودية), through witnessing the effects of divine power in the original creation. He thereby teaches them to combine the proprieties of vigilant awareness (المراقبة) with continual witnessing (المشاهدة); or, otherwise stated, effacement and subsistence (الفناء والبقاء).

Ibn Juzayy here discusses the principles of *murāqaba*. He says: Once a servant realizes this verse and others like it, he acquires the station of vigilance (مقام المراقبة). This noble station begins with knowledge (علم) and a state (حال), which then produce two fruits. Its knowledge is the servant's re-

cognition that God looks upon him in all his works, hears everything he utters, and knows whatever passes through his mind. Its state consists in the heart's continually retaining that knowledge until it prevails and he does not become heedless of it. Knowledge by itself, without this state, does not suffice.

Once knowledge and state are joined, their fruit among the People of the Right (أصحاب اليمين) is modest reverence before God (الحياء من الله), which necessarily brings abandonment of sins and zeal in obedience. Among those brought near (المقربون), their fruit is witnessing (المشاهدة), which necessarily produces reverence and magnification of the Lord of Majesty.

The Messenger points to both fruits in his saying: “That you worship God as though you see Him; if you do not see Him, He sees you” [R2] . “That you worship God as though you see Him” designates the second fruit, producing reverence, as one who actually stands before a mighty sovereign cannot but magnify him. “If you do not see Him, He sees you” designates the first: if you are not among the people of witnessing, the station of the brought-near, know that He sees you and become one of the people of reverent shame, the station of the People of the Right. Having first explained *iḥsān* by the higher station, and recognizing that many may not reach it, the Prophet descended to the other station.

Know also that vigilance (المراقبة) does not become established until stipulation with oneself (المشارطة) and binding covenant (المرابطة) precede it, and reckoning with oneself (المحاسبة) and reproach (المعاتبة) follow it. Stipulation is the servant's imposing on himself the obligation of obedience and abandonment of disobedience. Covenant is his undertaking before his Lord to do so. After stipulation and covenant at the outset come vigilance, and afterwards the servant takes account of how he has fulfilled what he stipulated and pledged. If he finds himself faithful to his covenant with God he praises God; if he has dissolved the stipulation and broken the pledge of vigilance, he disciplines his self severely, restraining it from returning to such things. Then he returns to stipulation and covenant, perseveres in vigilance, examines himself by reckoning, and continues in this way until he meets God Most High. This concludes Ibn Juzayy's words, drawn from the *Iḥyāʾ*. And God knows best.

The Most High then began to speak of safeguarding property, beginning with the property of orphans on account of their weakness.

4:2 — The orphan's property and the transformation of spiritual novices

Cairo Arabic edition I:461–462

وَآتُوا الْيَتامى أَمْوالَهُمْ وَلا تَتَبَدَّلُوا الْخَبِيثَ بِالطَّيِّبِ وَلا تَأْكُلُوا أَمْوالَهُمْ إِلى أَمْوالِكُمْ إِنَّهُ كانَ حُوباً كَبِيراً (2)

2. Give the orphans their property; do not exchange the bad for the good, and do not consume their property along with your own. Truly that is a grievous sin.

Language · The orphan (يتيم) and grievous sin (حوب)

I say: An orphan (اليتيم) is one who has lost his father; in established usage the description applies only before puberty. Here it is figurative (مجاز): someone who *was* an orphan. *Ḥūb* (الحوب) means sin. Its verbal noun (مصدر) is transmitted with both ḍamma and fatḥa, and with wāw or alif: ḥāba, ḥūban, ḥawban, or ḥāban.

Outward commentary · Returning property promptly and without substitution

The Real—majestic is His greatness—says: "Give the orphans their property" when they attain maturity and discernment (الرشد) has been perceived in them. He still calls them orphans after maturity by extended usage (اتساع), because their childhood is recent, and in order to hasten payment once maturity is reached and good judgment observed, rather than waiting until the designation "orphan" no longer fits. This is supported by one reported occasion of revelation: a man of Ghaṭafān held a large sum belonging to his nephew; when the nephew matured and asked for his fath-

er's property, his uncle refused, and the verse was revealed. Hearing it, the uncle said: “We obey God and His Messenger, and seek refuge with God from great sin (الحوب الكبير).” [T173]

Others say that Arabs had prevented children from inheriting alongside adults, and were ordered to give them their inheritance. On this account “orphan” retains its primary meaning. According to the first explanation the addressees are guardians (الأوصياء); according to the second, Arabs who did not give children their inheritance.

“Do not exchange the bad for the good”: do not substitute unlawful property taken from orphans for lawful property belonging to you; or do not take their valuable things and hand over your inferior things in exchange. Some would substitute a thin sheep of their own for a fat sheep belonging to the orphan, or a counterfeit dirham for a sound one. “Do not eat their property along with your own”: do not add their property to yours and spend the two together, while the orphan does not consume as much as an adult—except where the expenditure has been proportioned to the orphan's consumption or is for legitimate benefit. “That,” meaning such consumption, “is a great *ḥūb*”: a grave sin.

Spiritual allusion · The alchemy of spiritual education and receiving every seeker

The Real—majestic is His greatness—commands those enriched in their hearts, the great friends of God rooted in knowledge of the unseen (أغنياء القلوب), to give those attached to them, including the poor and weak, of the wealth-in-God which God has granted them, until they look to none besides Him. They should receive whoever comes to them, whether belonging to love and affection or to resistance and obstinacy. They must not “exchange the bad for the good” by receiving only those they find to have good character and rejecting those of bad character. This does not belong to the people of prophetic spiritual training (أهل التربية النبوية). Their way is to receive people on equal terms and transform the very substances (الأعيان) within them: the disobedient becomes obedient, the unbeliever a believer, the heedless one a person of remembrance, the miser generous, the impure pure, the evildoer a benefactor, and the ignorant a knower of God.

They possess the elixir (الإكسير), the primordial wine (الخمرة الأزلية), whose property is to transform substances, as Ibn al-Fāriḍ says in describing it:

> It refines the manners of the drinking companions, so that through it
> One without resolve is guided to the path of resolve;
> The hand that never knew generosity becomes open-handed,
> And one without forbearance becomes forbearing in anger.

His words, “Do not consume their property along with your own,” mean here: wait until you have ascertained that wealth of heart has reached them. Once you have ascertained this, accept from the property they freely offer you. And God knows best.

When some guardians had an orphan girl with property under their care, they might fear an outsider entering the household, so they married her themselves or to their sons to gain her property, without giving her a just bridal gift (صداق), and might mistreat her in expectation of her death. God prohibited this, saying:

4:3 — Justice toward orphan girls, marriage limits and restraint in spiritual states

Cairo Arabic edition I:462–463

وَإِنْ خِفْتُمْ أَلاَّ تُقْسِطُوا فِي الْيَتامى فَانْكِحُوا ما طابَ لَكُمْ مِنَ النِّساءِ مَثْنى وَثُلاثَ وَرُباعَ فَإِنْ خِفْتُمْ أَلاَّ تَعْدِلُوا فَواحِدَةً أَوْ ما مَلَكَتْ أَيْمانُكُمْ ذلِكَ أَدْنى أَلاَّ تَعُولُوا (3)

3. If you fear that you cannot act equitably toward orphan girls, then marry other women who are lawful and pleasing to you, two, three or four; but if you fear you cannot be just, then one, or those whom your right hands possess. That is nearer to your not acting unjustly.

Language · Mā (ما), the distributive numerals and the rhetorical construction

I say: The relative particle *mā* (ما) normally designates what is not rational, whereas here it refers to women. Ibn ʿAjība explains this in terms of women's alleged deficiency of intellect, as though they were assimilated to non-rational beings. “Two, three and four” (مَثْنى وَثُلاثَ وَرُباعَ) are circumstantial qualifiers (أحوال) of *mā*, excluded from full declension for two reasons (ممنوعة من الصرف): being descriptive and modified from their simple numerical form (الوصف والعدل). Their meaning is distributive: two by two, three by three and four by four. T174 191

Outward commentary · Orphan girls, bridal gifts and the maximum of four wives

The Real—majestic is His greatness—says: “If you fear,” guardians, “that you will not deal justly with orphan girls” under your charge by marrying them in pursuit of their wealth when you find them less beautiful, and then abandoning or ill-treating them, “marry other women who please you.” Alternatively: If you fear that you will fail to give those orphans a just bridal gift when they attract you through their property, which is already in your hands, and their beauty, marry others instead; do not marry them unless you pay a bridal gift like that given to their equals.

ʿĀ’isha, may God be pleased with her, said: “This refers to an orphan girl in the custody of her guardian. He desires her wealth and beauty and wishes to marry her for less than a proper bridal gift. They were therefore prohib-

191. Cairo editor, C462.1: His statement, “It ordinarily refers to what is not rational,” is questionable, since mā refers to rational and non-rational beings alike. God Most High says of the righteous, “Except those who believe and do righteous deeds—and few are they” (Sūrat Ṣād, verse 24), besides many other verses. Indeed, God’s words “Marry those women who please you” explicitly establish that mā can refer to rational beings. As for his statement “[until they are assimilated to non-rational beings],” many verses and hadiths contradict it. God Most High says, “I do not let the work of any worker among you be lost, male or female; you are of one another” (Āl ʿImrān 195), and the Prophet said, “Women are the counterparts of men.” The commentators offer other explanations of this verse that are preferable to that of our shaykh Ibn ʿAjība. Note that mā in this verse may be a relative pronoun, an indefinite pronoun qualified by what follows, or a particle introducing a verbal noun. Consult the commentaries of al-Qurṭubī, Ibn ʿAṭiyya and al-Ālūsī.

ited from marrying such girls unless they gave the full, just bridal gift; they were commanded to marry women other than them." Al-Bukhārī transmits the report. [R3]

Ibn ʿAbbās said that previously a man might marry ten or more women; if he became short of money he would take from the property of an orphan in his care. Thus the verse prohibited that injustice. "Two, three or four" means that each man may marry two or three or four, and not more. The verse prohibits the pre-Islamic practice of exceeding four, and consensus (الإجماع) is established upon this limit. Those who would allow nine by treating the numbers as additive should not be heeded: the purpose is to offer alternatives, not to sum the numbers. Were addition intended, the text would simply say "nine," rather than choosing a longer and less explicit expression.

"If you fear that you will not act justly" between two, three or four wives, restrict yourselves to one, or to whatever number of enslaved women your right hands possess: he holds that the same equality requirement is not obligatory in that latter case. "That," namely limiting oneself to one, "is nearer to your not turning aside (تَعُولُوا)," that is, not wronging others or inclining unjustly, or not exceeding what has been required of fairness. It can also mean, in the Ḥimyarite dialect, not burdening yourselves with a large household that brings poverty. And God knows best. [T175]

Spiritual allusion · Each guide should remain within his gift: knowledge, states or stations

Know that God Most High has given His friends differing specializations. Some are distinguished by an overflowing of sciences (فيض العلوم), others by an irruption of spiritual states (هجوم الأحوال), and yet others by the verification of spiritual stations (تحقيق المقامات). The shaykh Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī said: "Al-Junayd was a pole (قطب) in the sciences; Abū Yazīd a pole in states; and Sahl ibn ʿAbd Allāh a pole in stations." Each specialized in one while partaking also of the other two. Everyone should pursue the field in which God has specially gifted him, without taking responsibility for what belongs to another.

Thus, by way of allusion, the Real says to those whose predominant gift is states or stations: “If you fear that you will not treat fairly the orphan girls of the sciences (يتامى العلوم)”—the branches of knowledge specially entrusted to others—“then marry” the mature women of states and the virgin realities (ثيبات الأحوال وأبكار الحقائق) proper to you, whether few or many. If you fear that an excess of states or a descent among stations will overcome you and prevent balance, remain with one state and one station, the station you actually possess and have verified. That is nearer to your not deviating from equilibrium, for too many changing states can harm the seeker (المريد), as is explained in the discipline. And God knows best.

Having commanded marriage, He then commanded the giving of the bridal gift.

4:4 — Bridal gifts, willing relinquishment and the rights of the self

Cairo Arabic edition I:463–464

وَآتُوا النِّساءَ صَدُقاتِهِنَّ نِحْلَةً فَإِنْ طِبْنَ لَكُمْ عَنْ شَيْءٍ مِنْهُ نَفْساً فَكُلُوهُ هَنِيئاً مَرِيئاً (4)

4. Give women their bridal gifts willingly as an outright gift. If they freely remit to you any part of it, then enjoy it with good pleasure and without harm.

Language · Niḥla (نِحلة), nafsan (نفسًا) and hanīʾan marīʾan

I say: *Niḥla* (نِحْلَةً) is a verbal noun (مصدر) governed by “give them” (آتوهن), since the two have the same sense: one says *naḥalahu kadha niḥlatan wa-naḥlan* when one gives something gladly, without expecting a return or acting under a judicial command. The pronoun in “something of it” (منه) refers either to the bridal gift (الصداق) or to the act of giving (الإيتاء). “Of their own souls” (نفسًا) is an accusative of specification (تمييز). “Wholesomely and agreeably” (هنيئاً مريئًا) are adjectives qualifying an omitted verbal noun: a

wholesome eating (أكلاً هنيئًا). These come from the verbs describing food that is easy to swallow and brings no trouble. It is also said that *hanī'* is what gives pleasure, and *marī'* what has a praiseworthy consequence.

Outward commentary · Full ownership of the bride's gift

The Real—majestic is His greatness—addresses husbands: give the women you have married their bridal gifts (صَدُقاتِهِنَّ) as an outright donation (نِحلة), without delay or injustice. "If they are pleased to remit to you anything of it"—from the bridal gift, willingly and freely—"then consume it with enjoyment (هنيئًا)," without liability, "and agreeably (مريئًا)," lawfully, without any suspicious element. It is reported that some people felt religious scruples about accepting anything from their wives, and this verse was revealed. Others say that the addressees are guardians, since some guardians appropriated the bridal gifts of women under their care. They are commanded to hand the gifts over to the women, unless the women willingly offer a portion. And God knows best. [192]

Spiritual allusion · Giving the soul its due without making indulgence its master

Give the selves (النفوس) their rights to rest and the sustenance proper to human embodiment, as a freely conceded gift, and do not burden them beyond what they can bear. If the selves willingly undertake some act or spiritual state with an expansive breast and activity, partake of it gladly and wholesomely. Worship undertaken with readiness and joy in God is greater and likelier to endure. This applies to tranquil selves (النفوس المطمئنة); as for souls that command evil (النفوس الأمارة), nothing fits them but the stern discipline of spiritual striving (قهرية المجاهدة), tempered by prudent direction lest they weary.

Or the meaning is: whoever God establishes in a particular spiritual state (حال) or station (مقام) should remain there, stand where the Real has stationed him, and give that state its right. When his appointed moment (وقته) becomes pleasant through the arrival of some state, he should enjoy it wholesomely. The poor seeker is the son of his moment (الفقير ابن وقته); he observes what provision manifests for him within it. Everything in which his

192. Cairo editor, C464.1: Batl: cutting off.

heart finds its nourishment is his provision; let him hasten to take it lest its apportioned benefit pass him by. God Most High knows best the secrets of His Book.

He then forbade guardians from putting orphans in control of their property before the attainment of sound judgment.

4:5 — Guarding the resources of the vulnerable and the gradual transmission of secrets

Cairo Arabic edition I:464–466

وَلا تُؤْتُوا السُّفَهاءَ أَمْوالَكُمُ الَّتِي جَعَلَ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ قِياماً وَارْزُقُوهُمْ فِيها وَاكْسُوهُمْ وَقُولُوا لَهُمْ قَوْلاً مَعْرُوفاً (5)

5. Do not hand over to those without sound judgment the wealth God has made a means of support for you; provide for them and clothe them from it, and speak to them with kind and appropriate words.

Language · Qiyāman (قِيامًا): property as support

I say: *Qiyāman* (قِيَامًا) is the verbal noun of *qāma* (قام), also *qīman* (قِيمًا); its underlying form is *qiwāman* (قوامًا), with the wāw changed into yāʾ. [193]

[Translator's print-source notes: T176]

Outward commentary · Preserving capital and providing support

The Real—majestic is His greatness—addresses guardians: "Do not give the people without sound judgment (السفهاء)" who are under your protection "your property," meaning their property which is held in your hands. Their property is attributed to you to exhort you to preserve and increase it as carefully as if it were your own. Do not allow them uncontrolled access to their wealth before they are fit to manage it. God has made the property the means of sustaining their livelihoods (قيامًا لمعاشهم), and entrusted you with

193. Cairo editor, C464.2: Nāfiʿ and Ibn ʿĀmir read qīman; the majority read qiyāman.

their support. Preserve it, trade with it, and make the provision of their food and clothing appropriate to customary needs. If they demand it before the proper time, promise them kindly; say with gentle speech, "When you have grown up and attained discernment (رشد) you will be able to handle it," or the like.

He says "provide for them *in* it" (فيها) rather than "*from* it" (منها), because the former suggests that the wealth should remain as an ongoing source of support, preserved and increased through trade, rather than consumed as a diminishing principal.

Another view holds that the address is to husbands: they are forbidden to hand over all the resources God granted them to their wives and children and then become dependent upon them. Ibn ʿAjība presents this view in terms of a dismissive estimate of women's intellect, comparing the use of the relative particle *mā* in the previous verse. He transmits from Abū Umāma a report attributed to the Prophet: "The Fire was created for the foolish[T177] ," repeated three times, "and the foolish are women, except the woman who obeys the one responsible for her." A woman, he says, objected: "Messenger of God, you have called us the foolish!" and he answered that God had used this designation in the Book. [R4] [194] [195] [196]

Abū Mūsā al-Ashʿarī is also reported as saying: "Three people call upon God without receiving a response: a man with a woman of bad conduct whom he does not divorce; a man who lends money without having it witnessed; and a man who places his wealth in the hands of someone incapable of sound judgment—when God has said, 'Do not give the foolish your property.'" [R5] I say: their prayers are not granted because they have neglected the appointed requirements (مراسم) of the Law. God knows best. [T178] [197]

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194. Cairo editor, C465.1: See the note on the commentary on the third verse of Sūrat al-Nisāʾ.
195. Cairo editor, C465.2: Ibn Kathīr mentions a similarly worded report in his commentary and attributes it to Ibn Abī Ḥātim.
196. Cairo editor, C465.3: Al-Ālūsī cites it in his commentary as transmitted by Mujāhid and Ibn ʿUmar from Anas. Al-Ṭabrisī says, "There is no substantial basis for its authenticity."
197. Cairo editor, C465.4: Bad conduct here is to be understood as conduct that compromises chastity and modesty. Otherwise, the apparent sense of these words conflicts with the Prophet's saying: "A believing man should not hate a believing woman: if he dislikes one trait of hers, he is pleased with another."

Spiritual allusion · The right moment to disclose metaphysical understanding

A shaykh should not disclose to the disciple (المريد) the secrets of divine unity (أسرار التوحيد)—the secrets of meanings that God Most High has made subsist in things—until the disciple's intellect matures, his manners (أدب) become sound, and his sincerity becomes manifest. If he demands those secrets before their proper time, the shaykh should promise him what is near and speak to him encouragingly. How often has the disciple who hastened an opening (الفتح) before its time been punished by being deprived of it! How often has one who gained insight into the secrets of Reality (الحقيقة) before completing the requisite service been expelled, or even killed! The time to communicate them is when they begin to disclose themselves and bring him to a state of bewilderment (الحيرة).

There is an exception if the shaykh judges him ready to bear them through the strength of his intellect and the perfection of his sincerity. Then he can show them before they emerge of themselves, and train him within them. This is what we witnessed from our shaykhs, so generously did they give. May God be pleased with them, and grant us beautiful manners in their company.

Thus the Real uses “wealth” by way of allusion for the secrets of meanings. He commands teachers to give their students something of these, little by little, through training and gradual progression (التدريب والتدريج), and to clothe them in the outward prescriptions of the Law (الشرائع). It is also possible to retain “property” in its literal sense and to read the injunction as forbidding shaykhs to let disciples acquire wealth before firm establishment (التمكين). Al-Wartajbī alludes to this interpretation; consult his discussion.

God Most High then specifies the time for handing orphans their property.

4:6 — Testing for maturity, the guardian's expenses and the discernment of a spiritual heir

Cairo Arabic edition I:466–467

وَابْتَلُوا الْيَتامى حَتَّى إِذا بَلَغُوا النِّكاحَ فَإِنْ آنَسْتُمْ مِنْهُمْ رُشْداً فَادْفَعُوا إِلَيْهِمْ أَمْوالَهُمْ وَلا تَأْكُلُوها إِسْرافاً وَبِداراً أَنْ يَكْبَرُوا وَمَنْ كانَ غَنِيًّا فَلْيَسْتَعْفِفْ وَمَنْ كانَ فَقِيراً فَلْيَأْكُلْ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ فَإِذا دَفَعْتُمْ إِلَيْهِمْ أَمْوالَهُمْ فَأَشْهِدُوا عَلَيْهِمْ وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ حَسِيباً (6)

6. Test the orphans until they reach marriageable age. If you perceive sound judgment in them, then hand over their property. Do not consume it extravagantly, hastening before they grow up. Whoever is well-off should abstain from taking any; whoever is poor may consume an appropriate amount. When you hand their property over, take witnesses to the transaction. God suffices as Reckoner.

Language · Testing (ابتلاء), perception (إيناس) and the accusatives of cause

I say: *Ibtilā'* (الابتلاء) means testing or examination (الاختبار); *ānas* (آنس) means perceived or saw (أبصر). Sound judgment (الرشد) is the completion of intellectual maturity such that a person recognizes his own interests and manages property without extravagance or corruption. "Extravagantly" (إسرافًا) and "in haste" (بِدارًا) may be circumstantial accusatives (حالان) describing the subject pronoun in the verb, or accusatives expressing purpose or motive (مفعولان لأجله). "Lest they grow up" (أن يكبروا) is the object of "hastening" (بدارًا).

Outward commentary · Testing, investment and the proper use of orphan wealth

The Real—majestic is His greatness—addresses guardians: test the orphans *before* they attain maturity by observing their conduct in handling wealth. Give them a dirham or two: if good management appears, increase what you entrust to them gradually; if wastefulness appears, withhold the prop-

erty. “Until they reach the age of marriage,” meaning puberty as established by its legal signs; “then if you perceive sound judgment in them”—ability to understand their interests and manage property, even if they are not religiously upright (أهل الدين), although some made the latter a condition —“hand their wealth over to them,” without delay.

“Do not consume it wastefully, hastening before they grow up”: do not consume it while being extravagant or hastening to use it up before maturity removes it from your hands; or do not consume it out of extravagant desire and eagerness before they grow. “Let the wealthy guardian abstain” from taking compensation from the wealth for administering it. “Let the poor one consume according to what is recognized as proper (بالمعروف),” to the extent of his need and the recompense due for his labor.

A man is reported to have asked the Prophet: “I have an orphan under my care; may I eat from his property?” He replied: “According to what is right, without accumulating wealth from it, nor protecting your own property by expending his.” [R6] “When you hand their wealth over,” have witnesses attend their receipt of it from you. That removes suspicion and reduces litigation. Some take witnessing to be recommended (ندب), while others regard it as obligatory (فرض) and will not accept a guardian's assertion of payment without evidence. “God suffices as Reckoner (حسيب)”: do not violate His commandments or exceed the limits He has set. [198]

He says “Reckoner” (حسيب) rather than “Witness” (شهيد), though the latter might seem particularly fitting, as a warning to guardians not to conceal any of the property. Once they know that God will reckon with them even over the tiniest scrap (النقير والقطمير), and will punish them for it, they will be deterred from concealment. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · When the teacher should release the disciple to act and to teach

The spiritual teacher should test the disciple in his knowledge and in the realization of what he seeks. When he has reached maturity and the qualities of perfection become evident—his effacement (فناؤه) realized, his subsistence (بقاؤه) complete, and his knowledge of God (معرفته) perfected—so

198. Cairo editor, C466.1: That is, without accumulating.

that his every action takes place by God, from God and toward God, he understands what comes from God in everything. He receives the allotted portion of every thing without taking *for himself* anything from his portion. He is adorned with scrupulous restraint (الورع); agitation (الجزع) and covetousness (الطمع) have passed away; fear of creatures and anxiety about livelihood have disappeared from his heart; and the regard of the True King has become sufficient for him. He takes Reality (الحقيقة) from its proper source and the Law (الشريعة) from its proper place.

When these marks appear and his good judgment has been discerned, the shaykh should allow him to act for himself; indeed, if he judges him suitable, he may charge him with training others. After his maturity has become evident he should not continue to restrict him, nor demand excessive service before maturity in fear that the disciple will slip from his grasp.

If the shaykh has no need of the student's service, let him abstain from it and make his training purely for God's sake, following the prophets, for the Qur'ān says, "I ask you no reward for it," and, "I ask you no fee." If he needs his service, let him use it only in what is fitting (بالمعروف), without requiring what brings hardship. When he entrusts the spiritual secret (السرّ) to him, the disciple becomes firmly established in it, and he charges him with teaching or reminding others, let him witness and acknowledge this, commending him as a successor (خلافة) so hearts may be at peace in learning from him: "God suffices as Protector, and God suffices as Helper."

Having commanded the protection of orphans' wealth, the Real commands that women's property be protected. He mentions them next on account of their shared vulnerability in the arrangements he is discussing.

4:7 — The right of women to inherit and their share in spiritual inheritance

Cairo Arabic edition I:467–468

لِلرِّجالِ نَصِيبٌ مِمَّا تَرَكَ الْوالِدانِ وَالْأَقْرَبُونَ وَلِلنِّساءِ نَصِيبٌ مِمَّا تَرَكَ الْوالِدانِ وَالْأَقْرَبُونَ مِمَّا قَلَّ مِنْهُ أَوْ كَثُرَ نَصِيباً مَفْرُوضاً (7)

7. Men have a share in what parents and near relatives leave, and women have a share in what parents and near relatives leave, whether little or much—an allotted and obligatory share.

Language · A substitutive phrase and a fixed allotted portion

I say: “Whether little or much of it” (مِمَّا قَلَّ …), etc., is a substitute (بدل) for “of what was left” (مِمَّا تَرَكَ). “An allotted share” (نصيبًا) is a confirming verbal noun (مصدر مؤكّد), like “an obligation from God” (فريضة من الله): He establishes for them a fixed, prescribed portion. Alternatively it is circumstantial (حال) or an accusative of specification (اختصاص): “I mean a fixed share.”

Outward commentary · The inheritance rights of women and minors

The Real—majestic is His greatness—says: when someone dies leaving property, men are entitled to a portion of what their parents and relatives have left, and women are equally entitled to a portion of what their parents and relatives—including brothers and sisters—have left, whether the estate is small or large. It is “a prescribed share,” compulsory and inescapable.

It is related that Aws ibn Thābit al-Anṣārī died leaving a wife, Umm Kaḥḥa, and three daughters. His two male cousins appropriated the estate, giving neither wife nor daughters anything. In the Jāhiliyya, it is said, women and minors—even male minors—were denied inheritance on the ground that the inheritor should be someone who fights and defends the deceased's interests. Umm Kaḥḥa came to the Messenger of God in the mosque of al-Faḍīkh and said: “Messenger of God, Aws ibn Thābit has died, leaving three daughters; I am his wife and have nothing with which to maintain them. Their father left a good estate, but it is in the hands of Suwayd and ʿArfaja.” The Prophet summoned them. They replied: “Her children do not ride horses, bear weapons or injure enemies.” He said: “Depart, until I see what God Most High brings about.”

According to the account, the verse then descended and established a right without yet specifying its amount. The Prophet sent word to Suwayd and ʿArfaja: “Distribute nothing from Aws's estate. God Most High has allotted a share to his daughters but has not yet declared its amount, so I shall wait to see what He reveals.” Then “God enjoins upon you concerning your chil-

dren” (4:11), through “the great victory” (4:13), was revealed. He summoned them again: “Give Umm Kaḥḥa an eighth, the daughters two-thirds, and retain the remainder.” [T179]

Spiritual allusion · The secret of sainthood is available to women

Just as God gives women a portion of material inheritance, so He gives them a portion of spiritual inheritance (الميراث المعنوي), namely the secret (السرّ), when they keep company with the people of the secret and have a spiritual father (أبو الروحانية), the shaykh. Men receive an allotted portion of what their shaykhs leave them of the secret of sainthood (سرّ الولاية), and women likewise receive according to what the primordial apportioning (القسمة الأزلية) ordained for them, whether little or much, a share fixed in God's knowledge and decree.

God has placed women alongside men in the verse concerning spiritual wayfaring: “The Muslim men and Muslim women, the believing men and believing women …” (Q 33:35). A woman who reaches their station attains what they attain. And success is through God.

He then commanded those receiving inheritance to show generosity toward people present at the division.

4:8 — Generosity at the distribution of inheritance and the legacy of knowledge

Cairo Arabic edition I:468–469

وَإِذا حَضَرَ الْقِسْمَةَ أُولُوا الْقُرْبى وَالْيَتامى وَالْمَساكِينُ فَارْزُقُوهُمْ مِنْهُ وَقُولُوا لَهُمْ قَوْلاً مَعْرُوفاً (8)

8. When relatives, orphans and the poor attend the division [of an estate], provide something for them from it and speak kindly to them.

Language · The antecedent of minhu (منه)

I say: The pronoun in "of it" (منه) returns to what is being divided (المقسوم), understood from the mention of division (القسمة).

Outward commentary · Giving an appropriate portion to those present

The Real—majestic is His greatness—says: when relatives who are not heirs —such as maternal uncles and aunts or paternal aunts—together with orphans and poor people are present as an estate is divided, "provide for them" (فَارْزُقُوهُمْ): give them something of the distributed wealth, bringing comfort to their hearts. If the estate belongs to others, or the heirs have not attained maturity, address the visitors kindly instead: explain that the property is not yours to give; had it belonged to you, you would have given, and God provides both for you and them.

There is disagreement whether the command expresses recommendation (الندب)—the well-known view—or obligation (الوجوب) later abrogated by the inheritance verses. Others deny abrogation; in their judgment this is a command many people neglect. God knows best. [T180]

Spiritual allusion · Sharing the wine of divine knowledge without violating spiritual propriety

The Real addresses the elect among His beloved: When the cups of wine of the All-Holy Sovereign (خمرة الملك القدوس) circulate among you, and you divide the draught between your spirits until your bodily forms are filled and your veins are drenched, and some people who are not of your own spiritual kind are present—people who do not consider drinking your wine lawful—then, if they are people of love and affection, or are connected with you, do not deprive them of your wine or the fragrant breath of your company. You are a company whose companion is not rendered wretched. Give them fruit from your sciences, let them drink from your wine, remind them of God, and speak to them in words directing them to God and bringing them to His Presence. This is the "kind word" (القول المعروف), characterized by sincere counsel.

It is related that Abū Hurayra once called out in the market of Medina: "Traders, go to the mosque! Muḥammad's inheritance is being distributed there; go claim your share before it is exhausted." The merchants went to the Prophet's mosque and found it filled with people praying, reciting, remembering God and teaching knowledge. "Abū Hurayra," they protested, "we found nothing of the inheritance being distributed!" He replied: "That is Muḥammad's inheritance—not your accumulation of money," or words to that effect. [R7]

Then He urged guardians to be tender with other people's children under their care.

4:9 — The moral imagination of guardians, succession and leaving children with God

Cairo Arabic edition I:469–470

وَلْيَخْشَ الَّذِينَ لَوْ تَرَكُوا مِنْ خَلْفِهِمْ ذُرِّيَّةً ضِعافاً خافُوا عَلَيْهِمْ فَلْيَتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَلْيَقُولُوا قَوْلاً سَدِيداً (9)

9. Let those who would fear for their own weak children if they left them behind be fearful [for the children of others]. Let them be mindful of God and speak upright words.

Language · Law (لو) and the omitted object of “fear”

I say: *Law* (لو) here is conditional (شرطية) and concerns what lies ahead. Its consequent (جوابها) is “they would fear” (خافوا). The object of “let them fear” (لْيَخْشَ) has been omitted for generality: depending on the hearer's state, fear can concern punishment (العذاب), reproach (العتاب), or distance from the beloved (البعد عن الأحباب).

Outward commentary · Treat an orphan as you would wish others to treat your child

The Real—majestic is His greatness—addresses guardians of other people's children. Let them preserve their property, cultivate it for them and avoid wasting it; let them fear the children's destitution as they fear for their own children. If they themselves died leaving vulnerable children, they would fear for them; let them therefore fear for other people's children in the same fashion. “Let them be mindful of God” regarding them, protect their property, treat them gently and address them with tenderness just as they would wish their own children to be treated. “Let them speak sound words” (قولًا سديدًا): speech that is just and correct, shaped by compassion and good manners.

Another interpretation makes the addressees those visiting a sick person who is composing a will. They urge him to free a slave, give alms, and assign this or that sum until the estate is exhausted. God prohibits such encouragement: as you would fear for your own children, fear for the children of others. Be mindful of God when urging a dying man to dispose of his whole estate; recommend instead an upright and just disposal, namely the one-third allowed for a bequest. A third view makes the address general to believers in their own approach to death: they should consider the heirs, and not overstep the one-third in making bequests. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Preparing spiritual children for the teacher's death

God—majestic is His greatness—commands the people of prophetic spiritual education (أهل التربية النبوية), if they fear that their spiritual children will lose their way after the teachers die, to transmit to them the resplendent spiritual assistance (المدد الأبهر) and guide them to the greater wealth, that they may be left enriched by God and in need of no one besides Him, lest the disciple later fall into the hands of someone who treats him as a plaything. Let teachers fear God in this and direct their children to their Lord: this is upright speech (القول السديد).

The same principle extends to children by bodily descent. Whoever fears for his children after death should fear God, multiply acts of obedience and serve God's servants in both their bodily and spiritual dimensions. For their bodily needs he should feed them from what God has bestowed upon him. A report attributes to the Prophet: “Whenever a servant gives charity excellently from his wealth, God makes excellent provision for those left behind in his estate.” [R8] In serving their spirits, he should direct them to God, guide them to obedience and teach them the rulings of religion. Whoever does this, God takes charge of his children after him, and they live under divine protection, care, strength and succor, as may be observed among the children of the righteous. God says, “He is the Protector of the righteous” (Q 7:196), and recall His saying, “Their father was righteous” (Q 18:82).

Al-Qushayrī says concerning this verse: What the Muslim should store up for his family is mindfulness of God and righteousness, not mere wealth. It does not say to accumulate property and buildings and means for them, or to leave slaves and furnishings; it says “Let them be mindful of God,” for He guards the righteous. Such is the substance of his words.

God then spoke of the threat against those who unjustly consume orphan property.

4:10 — The grave sin of consuming an orphan's estate and the abuse of spiritual authority

Cairo Arabic edition I:470–471

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَأْكُلُونَ أَمْوالَ الْيَتامى ظُلْماً إِنَّما يَأْكُلُونَ فِي بُطُونِهِمْ نارًا وَسَيَصْلَوْنَ سَعِيراً (10)

10. Those who wrongfully consume the property of orphans consume nothing but fire into their bellies, and they will enter a blazing Fire.

Language · The accusative ẓulman (ظلمًا)

I say: "Wrongfully" (ظلمًا) is an accusative of specification (تمييز) or an accusative of purpose or cause (مفعول لأجله).

Outward commentary · The fire concealed in wrongful consumption

The Real—majestic is His greatness—says: "Those who consume the wealth of orphans wrongfully," without any lawful entitlement, "consume only fire within their bellies," meaning what inevitably draws them toward the Fire and leads to it. Abū Barza relates that the Prophet said: "God will raise a people from their graves with fire blazing from their mouths." Asked, "Who are they, Messenger of God?" he replied: "Have you not seen that God says, 'Those who wrongfully consume the wealth of orphans consume only fire within their bellies, and shall burn in a Blaze'?" [R9]

That is, they will burn in fire—and what a fire! *Ṣaly* (الصَّلْي) is roasting. One says "I roasted the thing" (صليت الشيء), and the causative forms are *aṣlaytuhu* and *ṣallaytuhu*. Mentioning the bellies heightens the depiction and makes their conduct seem all the more repellent. [T181]

Spiritual allusion · False claims to teaching and the exploitation of disciples

The Real—majestic is His greatness—warns those who make false claims (أهل الدعوى), who establish themselves as shaykhs and claim the station of spiritual education while remaining ignorant of God and veiled from wit-

nessing the secrets of divine unity, not to accept wealth from the weak who have attached themselves to them. Such people give their property in the hope of being brought to God. Those false teachers are unqualified for what they claim; in taking the offerings, they consume only fire in their bellies, and their end is a blazing flame—here, a thickening of the veil (تكثيف الحجاب) and an increase in painful labor and distress. When people turn toward them, they exult; when people turn away, they grieve and rage. What torment could exceed this?

The sense of the discussion from the beginning of this group of verses to its close is thus that God commands the people of the greater wealth—those truly fitted for prophetic education because they have travelled the way and the suns of verification (شموس التحقيق) have shone upon them through a perfected teacher—to abstain from taking from the wealth of those who attach themselves to them, except to the measure of need. He closes the door to pretenders, for their reception of offerings amounts to consuming other people's property falsely: the gift is offered in exchange for a spiritual reality that the supposed recipient does not possess. The exception is a gift made as purely voluntary alms (صدقة محضة), although even then the recipient may not be worthy of receiving alms. God knows best.

He then set forth the division of inheritance.

4:11 — The portions of children and parents; grammar, inheritance and spiritual giving

Cairo Arabic edition I:471–475

يُوصِيكُمُ اللَّهُ فِي أَوْلادِكُمْ لِلذَّكَرِ مِثْلُ حَظِّ الْأُنْثَيَيْنِ فَإِنْ كُنَّ نِساءً فَوْقَ اثْنَتَيْنِ فَلَهُنَّ ثُلُثا مَا تَرَكَ وَإِنْ كانَتْ واحِدَةً فَلَهَا النِّصْفُ وَلِأَبَوَيْهِ لِكُلِّ واحِدٍ مِنْهُمَا السُّدُسُ مِمَّا تَرَكَ إِنْ كانَ لَهُ وَلَدٌ فَإِنْ لَمْ يَكُنْ لَهُ وَلَدٌ وَوَرِثَهُ

أَبَواهُ فَلِأُمِّهِ الثُّلُثُ فَإِنْ كانَ لَهُ إِخْوَةٌ فَلِأُمِّهِ السُّدُسُ مِنْ بَعْدِ وَصِيَّةٍ يُوصِي بِها أَوْ دَيْنٍ آباؤُكُمْ وَأَبْناؤُكُمْ لاَ تَدْرُونَ أَيُّهُمْ أَقْرَبُ لَكُمْ نَفْعاً فَرِيضَةً مِنَ اللَّهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَلِيماً حَكِيماً (11)

11. God instructs you concerning your children: a male shall receive the equivalent of the share of two females. If the children are women, more than two, then they receive two-thirds of what is left; but if there is only one daughter, then hers is half. As for the deceased's two parents, each of them receives a sixth of what is left if the deceased has a child. But if there is no child and the two parents inherit, his mother receives a third; if he has siblings, his mother receives a sixth—all after any bequest made or debt due. Your fathers and your children: you do not know which of them is nearer to you in benefit. This is an ordained allocation from God. Truly God is Knowing, Wise.

Outward commentary · Shares of sons and daughters, and the report of their revelation

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: "God instructs you" (يُوصِيكُمُ اللَّهُ), that is, commands you and entrusts you with a charge, "concerning your children" (فِي أَوْلَادِكُمْ), meaning the specification of their inheritance. He then sets out the shares: "for the male the equivalent of the share of two females" (لِلذَّكَرِ مِثْلُ حَظِّ الْأُنْثَيَيْنِ). In reckoning one male as two females, if a person leaves one son and one daughter, the estate is divided into three shares: two for the son and one for the daughter. If he leaves one son and two daughters, there are two portions for him and one for each of them. The same principle applies in analogous cases. Ibn Juzayy says that this verse was revealed on account of Saʿd ibn al-Rabīʿ; it is also said to concern Jābir ibn ʿAbd Allāh when the Messenger of God visited him in his illness. It abolished the pre-Islamic practice of withholding inheritance from women and children. Some say that it abrogated the earlier testamentary provision concerning parents and close relatives. [R12]

Outward commentary · Why “He instructs you,” why “children,” and why the male is named first

He said “God instructs you” (يُوصِيكُمُ اللَّهُ) in the form of an ongoing verb rather than “God instructed you” (أَوْصَاكُمْ), to call attention to the supersession of the previous ruling and the commencement of another. He used the explicit divine name “God” (اللَّهُ) rather than “We instruct you” (نُوصِيكُمْ) to magnify the importance of the injunction, bringing the greatest of the divine names. He said “concerning your children” (فِي أَوْلَادِكُمْ) rather than “concerning your sons” (فِي أَبْنَائِكُمْ), because the term “son” can also be used of a foster-son through suckling, the son of a daughter, or an adopted son, none of whom inherits on that basis alone. If someone asks why the formulation was not “the two females have the equivalent of the male’s share,” or “the female has half the male’s share,” the answer is that the male is put first because of the preference he is accorded [in this legal exposition], and because the purpose is to state his share; the reverse expression would entail preferring the females. Here ends the statement cited from Ibn Juzayy. T182 199

Spiritual allusion · The teacher’s attention and the distribution of spiritual support

Just as God has given instructions concerning the children of bodily humanity (أولاد البشرية), so has He enjoined care concerning the children of spiritual parentage (أولاد الروحانية). Preference in distributing the flow of spiritual assistance (الإمداد) depends upon the degree of esteem, love and affectionate care that the shaykh has for a disciple. In proportion to the place the disciple occupies in the shaykh’s heart, assistance flows to him. He may receive the share of two men or more, according to what was established for him in the eternal allotment (القسمة الأزلية). And God, exalted is He, knows best.

He then mentioned the ruling concerning daughters where there are no sons, saying:

199. Cairo editor, C472.1: The preceding discussion is from Ibn Juzayy.

Language · The feminine plural, and wāḥida in the nominative or accusative

I say: The pronoun in “if they are” (كُنَّ) is feminine by reference to the predicate, or it refers to the [female children] left behind. The explanation given by al-Zamakhsharī is far-fetched. In the reading with “one” (وَاحِدَةٌ) in the nominative (الرفع), it is the subject (فاعل) of the complete *kāna* (كان التامة); in the accusative (النصب), it is the predicate (خبر) of *kāna*.

Outward commentary · Two or more daughters and the dissent of Ibn ʿAbbās

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: If the children left behind are females, with no males among them, “above two” (فَوْقَ اثْنَتَيْنِ), meaning two or more, “they have two-thirds of what he left,” and the residue belongs to the residuary heir (العاصب). Ibn ʿAbbās took the apparent sense of the verse literally, assigning two daughters one-half, as for a sole daughter. The majority disagreed with him, treating the expression “above” (فَوْقَ) as additional, as in “strike above the necks” (فَاضْرِبُوا فَوْقَ الْأَعْنَاقِ), or saying that the two-thirds share for two daughters is established by the Sunna. If the deceased leaves “one daughter” alone, “hers is half,” the remainder going to the residuary heir. This also indicates that a single son takes the entire estate when he is the only heir, since his share is the equivalent of that of two daughters.

Spiritual allusion · Solitude in the presence of the teacher, and worship during heedlessness

Consider the daughter: on her own she receives half, while, when she is joined by others, her own portion is diminished. So, too, with the spiritual gifts (أمداد) of the shaykhs: a person who alone enjoys their attention may receive more than when others gather with him, because the shaykh’s gaze is concentrated upon him. Our shaykh—may God be pleased with him—said that his own shaykh used to tell him, when he was alone, “Men will go on coming to you,” meaning his fellow brethren among the poor (الفقراء). He replied, “May God not let anyone come until we have eaten our fill.” Similarly, the assistance associated with a servant’s worship while others are

heedless is greater than when he worships alongside them, just as the fighter who holds his ground behind those who flee. Likewise the Prophet said, “Glad tidings to the strangers” (طُوبَى لِلْغُرَبَاءِ). [R10] And God knows best.

He then mentioned the inheritance of the parents, saying:

Language · A sixth for each: the function of badal

I say: “The sixth” (السُّدُسُ) is a subject (مبتدأ), and “to his two parents” (لِأَبَوَيْهِ) is a predicate (خبر). “To each one of them” (لِكُلِّ وَاحِدٍ مِنْهُمَا) is a substitute or appositional replacement (بدل) for “to his two parents.” The point of this substitution is to show that they do not share one sixth between them; the wording “his two parents have the sixth” could have suggested that.

Outward commentary · Both parents, siblings, wills and debts

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: If a child dies leaving both parents, “to each of them a sixth of what he left, if he has a child,” male or female, one or many, directly descended or the child of a son. All of these reduce each parent’s prescribed allotment to a sixth. But “if he has no child, and his two parents inherit from him” alone, “then his mother has a third,” and the rest goes to the father. “If he has siblings” (إِخْوَةٌ), that is, two or more brothers or sisters—of the same father and mother, or of the father only, or mother only, or from several such categories—“then his mother has a sixth,” and the remainder goes to his father. The siblings themselves receive nothing while the father is present. Ibn ʿAbbās took the apparent expression “siblings” in its plural force, and did not reduce the mother to a sixth in the presence of two, regarding two as he would one: the minimum plural, on his view, is three. The response given is that a plural expression can be applied to two, as in the verses “And We witnessed their judgment” (وَكُنَّا لِحُكْمِهِمْ شَاهِدِينَ) [Q 21:78] and “when they climbed over the wall of the sanctuary” (إِذْ تَسَوَّرُوا الْمِحْرَابَ) [Q 38:21], and in the reported saying, “Two and more constitute a group” (الاثنان فما فوقهما جماعة). [R11] All this takes effect after execution of the bequest and payment of the debt. God mentions the bequest before the debt, although a debt is satisfied first from the estate, because creditors already have strong legal claims, whereas those receiving a bequest are more vulnerable, so their interest is mentioned first out of special solicitude.

Spiritual allusion · The father as spirit, the mother as embodied humanity, and companionship as a child

The spirit (الروح) is like the father, embodied humanity (البشرية) like the mother, and the bond of companionship with the shaykh like a child. If someone has a bond of companionship with a shaykh of spiritual formation (شيخ التربية)—meaning he has a regular practice received from him (وِرْد)—then his bodily and spiritual aspects receive equally: each is refined and illumined by proper conduct (الأدب) and gnosis (المعرفة). Conduct belongs to the bodily aspect and gnosis to the spiritual. When the outward draws assistance through obedience, the inward also receives it, and conversely. If there is no bond of companionship, bodily humanity receives a stronger inheritance from the sensory realm (الحس), like the mother's greater portion when there is no child. Or say: a human being is composed of the sensory (حس) and the intelligible or meaningful (معنى). The sensory is like the mother, and meaning like the father, since meanings subsist in sensory things; the spirit draws aid from them both and thus is like their child. If the spirit is alive with gnosis, it draws from both together; but if dead, it receives more from the sensory, like the loss of a child [which increases] the mother's inheritance. Or say: the human being stands between divine power (القدرة) and wisdom (الحكمة). Power is like the father, wisdom like the mother, and the heart like the child between them. If the heart is present, the spirit draws from both power and wisdom, and its regard toward both becomes equal. If the heart is absent, wisdom's inheritance predominates in the spirit, just as in the mother's inheritance when the child is absent. If the heart has brethren among lights and secrets that strengthen it, then the spirit takes a sixth from the inheritance of wisdom and the rest belongs entirely to power. This is intelligible only to one who has realized knowledge of power and wisdom by direct taste (ذوق) and unveiling (كشف). Otherwise, one should defer to the people of gnosis. And God, exalted is He, knows best.

God then disclosed the wisdom in His allotment of the father's and son's inheritance, which He alone knows: "Your fathers and your sons…"

Outward commentary · Why God alone assigns the shares

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: I have explained what a father inherits from his son and what a son inherits from his father. Had I left the matter to you, you would have spoiled the division: you do not know which is

closer to the other in benefit. Is the father more beneficial to his son, so you should give him the whole inheritance to the exclusion of the dead man's child? Or is a child of greater benefit to his father than a father is to his child, so that you should reserve the inheritance for him? I therefore ordained the shares of father and son and did not leave the decision to you. An allotted portion "ordained by God" (فَرِيضَةً مِنَ اللَّهِ): truly God knows His servants' interests and is wise in what He apportions and determines. Ibn ʿAbbās said: You do not know who among your parents and children is more obedient to God or more exalted in rank on the Day of Resurrection, for God permits believers to intercede for one another. A child whose station is higher than that of his parents intercedes for them and God raises them to his rank. Parents more exalted than their child likewise intercede for him, so that he is raised to them and their eyes are gladdened. Here ends the substance, paraphrased, of Ibn ʿAbbās's statement.

Spiritual allusion · Embodiment and spirit: neither can dispense with the other

A person's spiritual reality (روحانية) cannot stand without his bodily humanity (بشرية), nor bodily humanity without spirituality. So one does not know which of the two is nearer to him in benefit: bodily humanity is the locus for servanthood (العبودية), whereas spirituality is the locus for witnessing the majesty of Lordship (الربوبية). Both must be joined. Likewise sensory manifestation (الحس) cannot subsist without meaning (المعنى), nor meaning without sensory manifestation; you, seeker (مريد), do not know which is more beneficial to you so as to prefer it. Although meanings are what one journeys towards, they cannot be established without the sensory; it must therefore be attended to. Al-Wartajbī writes here, in his own words: "The question concerning these two parties has been left obscure: which of them will attain the station of sainthood (الولاية) and gnosis (المعرفة) that yields witnessing of God and nearness to Him? Were a single atom of it to fall to anyone in this community, seventy thousand might be delivered by his intercession without reckoning. In other words: serve your fathers and be tender towards your children, for from among them may emerge a person endowed with sainthood, who will intercede for you before God. The wisdom of leaving the matter unspecified here is to extend kindness and compassion throughout the community in anticipation of the true friend of God

(الولي الصادق).” Here ends his statement. I say: He interprets fathers and sons as those related by bodily kinship, but the verse also embraces fathers and sons in meaning and in spiritual relationship. And God knows best.

He then mentioned the inheritance of husbands and wives.

4:12 — Spousal inheritance, the meaning of kalāla, and the shared inheritance of spiritual brethren

Cairo Arabic edition I:475–477

وَلَكُمْ نِصْفُ مَا تَرَكَ أَزْواجُكُمْ إِنْ لَمْ يَكُنْ لَهُنَّ وَلَدٌ فَإِنْ كانَ لَهُنَّ وَلَدٌ فَلَكُمُ الرُّبُعُ مِمَّا تَرَكْنَ مِنْ بَعْدِ وَصِيَّةٍ يُوصِينَ بِها أَوْ دَيْنٍ وَلَهُنَّ الرُّبُعُ مِمَّا تَرَكْتُمْ إِنْ لَمْ يَكُنْ لَكُمْ وَلَدٌ فَإِنْ كانَ لَكُمْ وَلَدٌ فَلَهُنَّ الثُّمُنُ مِمَّا تَرَكْتُمْ مِنْ بَعْدِ وَصِيَّةٍ تُوصُونَ بِها أَوْ دَيْنٍ وَإِنْ كانَ رَجُلٌ يُورَثُ كَلالَةً أَوِ امْرَأَةٌ وَلَهُ أَخٌ أَوْ أُخْتٌ فَلِكُلِّ واحِدٍ مِنْهُمَا السُّدُسُ فَإِنْ كانُوا أَكْثَرَ مِنْ ذلِكَ فَهُمْ شُرَكاءُ فِي الثُّلُثِ مِنْ بَعْدِ وَصِيَّةٍ يُوصى بِها أَوْ دَيْنٍ غَيْرَ مُضَارٍّ وَصِيَّةً مِنَ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ حَلِيمٌ (12)

12. You, husbands, receive half of what your wives leave if they have no child. But if they have a child, yours is a quarter of what they leave, after any bequest they have made or debt. And wives receive a quarter of what you leave if you have no child; but if you have a child, theirs is an eighth of what you leave, after any bequest you have made or debt. If a man or woman is inherited from as one leaving neither direct descendants nor ascendants (kalāla), and has a brother or sister, each of them receives a sixth; but if there are more than that, they share in a third, after any bequest made or debt, without causing injury. This is an injunction from God; and God is Knowing, Forbearing.

Outward commentary · The husband's and wife's prescribed shares

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: "To you," husbands, from the inheritance of your wives, belongs "half of what they leave, if they have no child." But if they have a child entitled to inherit, male or female, one or several—whether born directly of her or descended through sons, sons' sons and so on, whether related to you or to another husband—"yours is a quarter of what they leave," after the debt is discharged and the bequest executed. "And to them," the wives, belongs "a quarter" of what the husband leaves if he has no descendant entitled to inherit, male or female, on the same basis as stated previously regarding the wife. But "if you have a child, theirs is an eighth," which a single wife takes alone, or which several wives divide among themselves. The prescribed shares (السهام) are not diminished except by proportional adjustment (العَوْل), according to the majority school, contrary to Ibn ʿAbbās, who did not accept *ʿawl* (العَوْل). If it is asked why the clause "after any bequest" (مِنْ بَعْدِ وَصِيَّةٍ) is repeated for the inheritance of both husband and wife, while it was mentioned only once with the children's and parents' inheritance in the preceding verse, the answer is that, in the case of the husband's inheritance, the deceased is his wife, while, in the wife's inheritance, the deceased is her husband. Each therefore constitutes a separate legal case, and the clause appears with each. In the former case, the deceased was one person whose children's and parents' shares were set out together, so it was mentioned once. This is Ibn Juzayy's explanation. Al-Bayḍāwī says: The man is assigned twice the share of a woman by virtue of marriage, as in kinship. Such is the analogy wherever a man and woman share the same cause and proximity of inheritance, except for siblings through the mother and for emancipators, male and female. Here ends his statement.

Spiritual allusion · When the bodily self dies and acquired knowledge becomes freely bestowed

When the self (النفس) dies and no remainder of it survives, the spirit (الروح) inherits what it possessed of acquired knowledge (العلوم الكسبية), whether transmitted (نقلية) or rational (عقلية). It joins this to its own freely bestowed knowledge (العلوم الوهبية), and all is transformed into something bestowed. One of our earlier masters' masters said: "I used to know fourteen sciences. When I entered the science of Reality (علم الحقيقة), I swallowed all of that, un-

til only the Book and Sunna remained"—or words to that effect. Abū Sulaymān al-Dārānī said: "When souls resolve to give up sins, they travel through the Dominion (الملكوت) and return to their owners bearing wondrous sciences, though no learned person transmitted knowledge to them." If some remainder of the self subsists, the spirit's inheritance of its knowledge decreases in proportion to that remainder, just as the husband's share decreases when his wife leaves a descendant. Conversely, if the spirit dies by turning back from the path of earnest striving (طريق الجدّ), the self inherits the freely bestowed sciences, meanings and sacred mysteries that had belonged to it. It consumes them and transforms them into things transmitted and sensory after they had been freely bestowed and tasted directly. It makes meanings sensory and vessels dense. We seek God's protection from dispossession after having received a gift (السلب بعد العطاء). Yet the self's inheritance from the spirit is stronger: if something remains of the spirit's life, the self's share is reduced, as the wife's inheritance from her husband decreases when he leaves a descendant. And God knows best.

He then mentions the inheritance of a sibling from a sibling: "And if a man …"

Language · Kalāla (الكلالة), the network of kinship and alternative syntactic analyses

I say: *Kalāla* (الكَلَالَة) is the severance of the line of descent, such that the deceased has neither descendants nor ascendants, male or female. It is a verbal noun (مصدر) derived from the expression "kinship encircled him" (تكلّله النسبُ), like a wreath (الإكليل), because his heirs surround him rather than issuing from him. A poet gave its meaning in verse:

> If someone asks about kalāla,
> It is the severance of the line of descent, without doubt:
> No parent is left and no offspring,
> Sons and grandfathers have passed away.

The expression may here denote the deceased, the heirs, the act of inheritance, kinship itself, or the property inherited. If it denotes the deceased, it is the predicate (خبر) of *kāna* (كان) while "is inherited from" (يُورَثُ) is an adjective (صفة). Alternatively, "is inherited from" is the predicate of *kāna* and *kalāla* is a circumstantial qualifier (حال) of its implicit pronoun, or *kāna*

is complete (تامة), with "is inherited from" adjectival and *kalāla* again a circumstantial qualifier. If it denotes the heirs, it is the predicate of *kāna* with a suppressed annexed noun (مضاف محذوف): "one possessed of [the relationship of] kalāla" (ذا كلالة). If it denotes the inheritance, it is a verbal noun functioning as a circumstantial qualifier. If it denotes kinship, it is an accusative of cause (مفعول لأجله)—one is inherited from by reason of the kinship. If it denotes the property, it is the second object (مفعول ثانٍ) of "is inherited from." Each construction admits *kāna* as complete or incomplete. This is Ibn Juzayy's grammatical analysis. The phrase "without causing injury" (غَيْرَ مُضَارٍّ) is accusative as a circumstantial qualifier (حال), or its governor (عامل) is "he enjoins [a bequest]" (يُوصَى). "One causing injury" (مُضَارّ) is an active participle (اسم فاعل). "A bequest" (وَصِيَّةً) is a verbal noun (مصدر) of "enjoins," or the object (مفعول) of "causing injury."

Outward commentary · Maternal siblings, equal shares and harmful wills

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: If the deceased, a man or woman, is inherited from as a *kalāla* (كَلَالَة), with neither descendant nor ascendant—his direct line of descent having ended—and has a brother or sister **through the mother**, "each of them has a sixth." But "if they are more numerous, they are partners in a third"; male and female take equal shares, because their link with the deceased runs through the maternal line alone. The implication is that they do not inherit alongside the mother or grandmother, nor alongside a daughter or son's daughter, since the deceased is then not a *kalāla* in the required sense. [Source and textual note: This is a prima facie inference (*mafhūm*), not the final inheritance rule. Al-Bayḍāwī on 4:12 gives the same "mother and grandmother" wording, then adds that the implication is restricted by consensus. That qualification is absent from Cairo I:477. Mālik's *Muwaṭṭaʾ*, Book of Inheritances, chapter on maternal siblings, excludes those siblings in the presence of descendants, the father or paternal grandfather, and allows them to inherit otherwise. The earlier parallel therefore explains the wording without replacing "mother and grandmother" by "father and grandfather." The origin of Cairo's omitted qualification remains unestablished.] We restrict brother and sister here to those related through the mother because the full or paternal brother's inheritance will be explained at the end of the sūrah. The sister's half-share has already been mentioned. Furthermore, Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ and Ibn

Masʿūd read: “and he has a brother or sister **through the mother**” (وله أخ أو أخت لأم). All these shares are distributed “after any bequest made or debt,” on condition that no harm is caused (غَيْرَ مُضَارٍّ) through bequest or debt—for example, a bequest of more than a third, an unauthorized testamentary allocation to an heir, or a contrivance designed to defeat others’ rights. Where the intention to inflict harm is known, any excess above a third is set aside; the jurists disagreed, in two reported opinions, whether the third itself should also be invalidated. This is Ibn Juzayy’s account. “A bequest from God” (وَصِيَّةً مِنَ اللَّهِ) means “We enjoin this upon you as an injunction,” or means “without violating an injunction from God.” Ibn ʿAbbās said, “Causing harm in a bequest is one of the grave sins.” God knows what serves His servants’ welfare, apportions wealth accordingly, and is Forbearing (حَلِيمٌ): He does not immediately inflict punishment upon those who violate His bounds.

Spiritual allusion · Brethren under the same teacher share spiritual nourishment

Know that brotherhood through the shaykh (الأخوة في الشيخ) is like brotherhood through kinship, for they suckle at one breast and drink one milk. If one of them dies, his brother inherits the spiritual provision (المدد) he used to receive from their teacher. Likewise if a disciple turns back [from the path]—which is a kind of death—the influx is diverted to his brother. It resembles water divided among conduits (القواديس): if one conduit is blocked, the water flows towards the others. If there are several spiritual brethren, they become partners in that spiritual influx. And God knows best.

Then the Real—exalted is He—warned against transgressing the limits He had established for bequests and inheritances.

4:13–14 — The limits of the revealed law and the bounds of spiritual discipline

Cairo Arabic edition I:477–478

تِلْكَ حُدُودُ اللَّهِ وَمَنْ يُطِعِ اللَّهَ وَرَسُولَهُ يُدْخِلْهُ جَنَّاتٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ خالِدِينَ فِيها وَذلِكَ الْفَوْزُ الْعَظِيمُ (13) وَمَنْ يَعْصِ اللَّهَ وَرَسُولَهُ وَيَتَعَدَّ حُدُودَهُ يُدْخِلْهُ نارًا خالِداً فِيها وَلَهُ عَذابٌ مُهِينٌ (14)

13. Those are God's limits. Whoever obeys God and His Messenger, He will admit to gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding therein; and that is the great triumph. 14. But whoever disobeys God and His Messenger and transgresses His limits, He will admit to a fire, abiding therein, and his will be a humiliating punishment.

Language · Agreement with man (مَن) and prospective circumstantial qualifiers

I say: The singular pronoun in "We admit him" (نُدْخِلْهُ) observes the grammatical form of "whoever" (مَنْ). The plural circumstantial form "abiding" (خَالِدِينَ) observes its sense, since it includes a multitude of persons. The forms "abiding" (خَالِدِينَ) and "abiding" (خَالِدًا) are prospective circumstantial qualifiers (حال مقدرة) of the object pronoun in "We admit him," like saying, "I passed a man with a falcon, who will be hunting with it tomorrow." They are not adjectives of "gardens" (جَنَّات) and "fire" (نَارًا): were they adjectives predicated of something other than their grammatical possessor, the pronoun would have to be made explicit. [Reading note: the Cairo verse headings print *yudkhilhu*, "He admits him," while this grammatical discussion and the following exposition quote *nudkhilhu*, "We admit him." The Cairo editor attributes the nūn reading to Nāfiʿ and Ibn ʿĀmir, and the yāʾ

reading to the other readers. The verse translation follows its displayed heading; the translations of the grammatical discussion and exposition follow the forms they actually quote.] [200]

Theology · Obedience, disobedience, and the duration of punishment

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: The ordinances We have established for you concerning bequests and inheritance "are the limits of God" (حُدُودُ اللَّهِ), which He marked out for you so that you should stand by them and not transgress them. "Whoever obeys God" in what He commands and limits, "and His Messenger" in what he legislates and establishes by his Sunna, "We will admit him to gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding therein." "That is the great triumph" (الْفَوْزُ الْعَظِيمُ), the supreme success. But "whoever disobeys God" in what He commands or forbids, "and His Messenger" in what he legislates, "and transgresses His limits," departing from those bounds to pursue desire, "We will admit him to a fire, abiding therein; and for him is a humiliating punishment." This everlasting punishment applies where the transgressor rejects the legitimacy of the injunctions and thereby becomes an unbeliever. Otherwise he is a sinner subject to the divine will (المشيئة). According to the doctrine of the People of the Sunna (أهل السنة), he does not remain eternally in the Fire; they interpret the verse as applying to the unbeliever, or take the term to indicate a very long stay, as in the verse concerning the murderer. And God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The limits of outward law and of inner spiritual realization

The Real—majestic is His glory—has established limits for the people of the outward Law (الشريعة الظاهرة), which the scholars (العلماء) have undertaken to clarify. He has likewise established limits for the people of inward Reality (الحقيقة), which is the secret of sainthood (سر الولاية), and the Friends of God (الأولياء) undertake to maintain them. Whoever observes the limits of outward Law belongs among the righteous believers; whoever exceeds them belongs among sinners and wrongdoers. Whoever observes the bounds of inward Reality and keeps company with its people belongs among the spiritually excellent, the knowers drawn near (المحسنين العارفين المقربين), and

200. Cairo editor, C477.1: Nāfiʿ and Ibn ʿĀmir read nudkhilhu with nūn; the other readers read it with yāʾ.

enters the Garden of gnoses (جنة المعارف). Whoever transgresses the bounds of Reality, or fails to accompany its people, belongs to the ordinary People of the Right (عوام أهل اليمين) and suffers the punishment of veiling (عذاب الحجاب) amid the distress of reckoning. The marginal commentary says: In the designation of His limits lies an indication of servanthood (العبودية): removing every person from self-regard and autonomous choosing, then submitting with humility to the judgment of his Lord and stopping at His bounds. Al-Wartajbī says: It has been said that "those are God's limits" means the states which are made manifest to seekers (المريدين) according to their capacity to bear them; to overstep those capacities destroys them. Abū ʿUthmān said: "No one has perished who kept to his limit and did not exceed his station." Here ends the quotation. God grants success and guides to the even path.

Having completed the command to preserve property, the Real now begins His discussion of the preservation of lineage (حفظ الأنساب). He first treats illicit intercourse because it confuses descent and disrupts its protection, then speaks of marriage and of those women who are prohibited or permitted in it.

4:15–16 — Early discipline for sexual offences and the purification of the self

Cairo Arabic edition I:478–479

وَاللاَّتِي يَأْتِينَ الْفاحِشَةَ مِنْ نِسائِكُمْ فَاسْتَشْهِدُوا عَلَيْهِنَّ أَرْبَعَةً مِنْكُمْ فَإِنْ شَهِدُوا فَأَمْسِكُوهُنَّ فِي الْبُيُوتِ حَتَّى يَتَوَفَّاهُنَّ الْمَوْتُ أَوْ يَجْعَلَ اللَّهُ لَهُنَّ سَبِيلاً (15) وَالَّذانِ يَأْتِيانِها مِنْكُمْ فَآذُوهُما فَإِنْ تابا وَأَصْلَحا فَأَعْرِضُوا عَنْهُما إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ تَوَّاباً رَحِيماً (16)

15. As for those women among you who commit an indecency, summon four witnesses from among yourselves to testify against them; if the witnesses testify, confine them within the houses until death takes them or

God appoints for them another way. 16. And the two among you who commit it, inflict a penalty upon them; but if they repent and amend themselves, then leave them alone. Truly God is Ever-Relenting, Merciful.

Outward commentary · Four witnesses, seclusion and subsequent penal provisions

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: "Those women who commit indecency" (الْفَاحِشَةَ), that is, unlawful sexual intercourse (الزنا), so called because of its extreme moral repulsiveness and the gravity of its prohibition in the Sacred Law, "from among your women"—Muslim women—"summon four witnesses to testify against them." Require those who accuse them to produce four upright believers who witnessed the act unmistakably, as [the classical legal simile says] the kohl-stick entering its container. Four witnesses are required as an exceptional protection of the believer's reputation and privacy, or so that the proof may consist of two witnesses for each party. "If they testify" to that effect, "then confine the women in houses": make the houses their places of imprisonment "until death takes them," completing their lifespan, or the Angel of Death takes them, "or God appoints some way for them" (سَبِيلًا), such as a specified fixed penalty (حدّ) which releases them from confinement. That was the early rule of Islam, subsequently abrogated by the prescribed penalties in Sūrat al-Nūr. It is also possible to understand the verse as recommending confinement even after flogging, so that the women do not return to illicit relations through going outside and meeting men. Their fixed penalty is then left to the verse of al-Nūr. Confinement was specifically mentioned for women, as is clear from the following words, "The two who commit it among you," meaning [on his interpretation] the man and woman who commit fornication: "inflict a penalty upon them," by admonition and reproach. "If they repent and amend themselves, turn away from them": stop imposing reproach, or refrain from recalling and disclosing their past wrongdoing. Some say that the second verse was revealed before the first: the succession of punishments for fornication was then admonition, confinement, and finally flogging. Others apply confinement to women engaging in same-sex acts and admonition to men engaging in same-sex acts, leaving the provisions in Sūrat al-Nūr for illicit intercourse. What appears to Ibn ʿAjība to have been the earliest ruling concerning fornication is that women were confined to their homes after admonition until death, or until God provided them a

way through marriage to someone who would keep them chaste; and that men were subjected to reproach, public condemnation and [social] restraint until their repentance became manifest. All this was then abrogated by the fixed penalties: one hundred lashes and one year of exile for an unmarried offender, and stoning for an offender previously married in the relevant legal sense (المحصن). And God knows best. [T183]

Spiritual allusion · Confine destructive desires, not the body itself

When the servant's self (النفس) grows rebellious and wishes to perpetrate indecencies, he should call upon the recording guardians (الحفظة)—those who register his misdeeds—to testify against it. If it is still unashamed, he should discipline it by confining it in the prison of hunger, spiritual seclusion (الخلوة) and silence until it dies to those desires, or until God creates a path for it through the servant's reaching a shaykh who makes him absent from his self, or by a powerful spiritual arrival (وارد) of disturbing fear or unsettling longing. If the self repents and is reformed, he should cease his reproach of it and occupy himself in remembrance of God (الذكر), until he is absent from everything besides Him. And God grants success.

Then the Real mentions the time at which repentance is accepted.

4:17–18 — Repentance before death and the different accountability of ordinary and advanced seekers

Cairo Arabic edition I:479–481

إِنَّمَا التَّوْبَةُ عَلَى اللَّهِ لِلَّذِينَ يَعْمَلُونَ السُّوءَ بِجَهالَةٍ ثُمَّ يَتُوبُونَ مِنْ قَرِيبٍ فَأُولئِكَ يَتُوبُ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِمْ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَلِيماً حَكِيماً (17) وَلَيْسَتِ التَّوْبَةُ لِلَّذِينَ يَعْمَلُونَ السَّيِّئاتِ حَتَّى إِذا حَضَرَ أَحَدَهُمُ الْمَوْتُ قالَ إِنِّي تُبْتُ الْآنَ وَلا الَّذِينَ يَمُوتُونَ وَهُمْ كُفَّارٌ أُولئِكَ أَعْتَدْنا لَهُمْ عَذاباً أَلِيماً (18)

17. God's acceptance of repentance is for those who do wrong in ignorance and then repent soon afterwards; these are the ones to whom God turns in mercy. And God is Knowing, Wise. 18. But repentance is not for those who persist in wrongdoing until, when death comes to one of them, he says, "Now I repent," nor for those who die while denying the truth. For these We have prepared a painful punishment.

Theology · Wrongdoing in ignorance and the point at which repentance is barred

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: "God's acceptance of repentance" (إِنَّمَا التَّوْبَةُ عَلَى اللَّهِ)—the repentance whose acceptance God has graciously undertaken, as a favor and kindness—is for those who do evil, that is, acts of disobedience, "in ignorance" (بِجَهَالَةٍ), in the sense of foolishness, lack of discernment, and failure in proper conduct. Everyone engaged in wrongdoing is in that moment ignorant of God; faith has been withdrawn from him until he ceases, even if he knows that what he does is a sin. "Then they repent soon afterward" (مِنْ قَرِيبٍ), meaning before the onset of death, as clarified by the later words "until death comes to one of them." The Prophet said, "God accepts the repentance of the servant so long as he has not begun to gasp at death" (إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَقْبَلُ تَوْبَةَ الْعَبْدِ مَا لَمْ يُغَرْغِرْ). [R13] The verse describes that interval as

“near” because this world passes swiftly: its goods are few and its lifetime short. “Those are the ones to whom God turns in mercy,” fulfilling His earlier promise; He knows the sincerity of their repentance and is wise in not punishing the repentant, for wisdom is to put each thing in its right place. A narration attributed through al-Ḥasan says that the Prophet reported: When Iblīs was brought down, he said, “By Your might and majesty, I shall not leave the son of Adam until his spirit leaves his body.” God said: “By My might and majesty, I shall not withhold repentance from My servant until he reaches the death-rattle.” [R14] And from Abū Saʿīd al-Khudrī, the Prophet is reported to have said: “The Devil said, ‘By Your might, I shall not cease misleading Your servants as long as their souls are in their bodies.’ God—exalted is He—said, ‘By My might and majesty and the loftiness of My station, I shall continue forgiving them so long as they seek forgiveness from Me.’” [R15] Ibn Juzayy says: When the servant repents with genuine repentance, fulfilling its conditions, most scholars hold that he can be certain of its acceptance. Abū al-Maʿālī held instead that acceptance is strongly probable, rather than certain. Here ends the quotation.

Outward commentary · Repentance deferred until the death-rattle

“Repentance is not accepted” for those who persist in sinful deeds “until, when death comes to one of them,” that is, when it reaches his throat, “he says, ‘Now I have repented,’” nor for those who “die while unbelievers.” For these no repentance remains; “We have prepared for them a painful punishment.” Al-Bayḍāwī says: God equates those who delay repentance until the presence of death, although sinful believers, with those who die in unbelief, in negating the acceptance of repentance, to emphasize how little such last-minute repentance counts at that point—as though the one’s repentance and the other’s lack of it are alike. Another interpretation understands those who do “wrong” as disobedient believers, those who persist in “evil deeds” as hypocrites on account of the doubling of their unbelief, and those who die as unbelievers as unbelievers openly so. Here ends the quotation.

Spiritual allusion · Repentance in proportion to one's degree of nearness

Repentance among ordinary people (توبة العوام) is not like repentance among the elect (توبة الخواص). God grants respite to the ordinary to encourage them to return, but calls the elect to account for delay in proportion to their station of proximity to the divine Presence (الحضرة). The greater the nearness, the greater the reckoning for neglecting watchfulness (المراقبة): some are indulged for an instant, others for an hour, still others for two hours, according to their station; then they are reproached and returned to the Presence. Our masters' master, Sīdī ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Fāsī, says in his marginal commentary concerning "repentance is upon God" (إِنَّمَا التَّوْبَةُ عَلَى اللَّهِ): This means that guidance after abasement belongs to God, for it is He who releases people from His irresistible power (قهر) through abundant generosity and through His mercy that prevails over His wrath, as He says, "Your Lord has prescribed mercy upon Himself" (كَتَبَ رَبُّكُمْ عَلَى نَفْسِهِ الرَّحْمَةَ) [Q 6:54]. The expression draws attention to how sin overtakes them under overpowering circumstances, after which He reaches them with guidance and penitence, as a grace arising from His knowledge of how to educate them and bring them by degrees into knowing Him. Hence His words, "God is Knowing, Wise." Here ends the note.

He then begins the rules governing marriage, starting with unjust obstruction (العَضْل), because it prevents the contract from being concluded.

4:19 — Women's rights in marriage; reciprocal kindness and gentleness toward the disciplined self

Cairo Arabic edition I:481–483

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا يَحِلُّ لَكُمْ أَنْ تَرِثُوا النِّساءَ كَرْهاً وَلا تَعْضُلُوهُنَّ لِتَذْهَبُوا بِبَعْضِ مَآ آتَيْتُمُوهُنَّ إِلاَّ أَنْ يَأْتِينَ بِفاحِشَةٍ مُبَيِّنَةٍ وَعاشِرُوهُنَّ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ فَإِنْ كَرِهْتُمُوهُنَّ فَعَسى أَنْ تَكْرَهُوا شَيْئاً وَيَجْعَلَ اللَّهُ فِيهِ خَيْراً كَثِيراً (19)

19. O believers, it is not lawful for you to inherit women against their will; nor may you constrain them in order to take away part of what you have given them, unless they commit a manifest indecency. Live with them in a manner recognized as good. If you dislike them, it may be that you dislike something in which God has placed much good.

Language · The derivation of ʿaḍl (العَضْل)

I say: The root meaning of *ʿaḍl* (العَضْل) is constraint or making a thing narrow. One says that a hen is *ʿaḍilat bi-bayḍihā* (عضلت ببيضها) when it cannot pass its egg because of constriction. In conventional usage the word came to refer to preventing a woman from marrying.

Outward commentary · The Qurʾānic prohibition of treating widows as property

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: "O believers, it is not lawful for you to prevent women from marrying in order to inherit what they own, against their will." Ibn ʿAbbās relates that in the age of ignorance, when a man died leaving a wife, a male relative from his agnatic family (عصبته) regarded himself as more entitled to her than she was to herself or anyone else. If he wished he married her without a new bridal payment (صداق), beyond what the deceased had given her. If he wished he married her to another and took her bridal payment for himself; or he impeded and constrained her, so that she would redeem herself with the property inherited from the

deceased, or eventually die and leave him her wealth. If she escaped to her family before her deceased husband's relative cast his garment over her, she was entitled to decide for herself. Ibn ʿAjība relates that this custom persisted into the earliest Islamic period until Abū Qays ibn al-Aslat al-Anṣārī died, leaving his widow Kabsha bint Maʿn al-Anṣāriyya. A son of his from another wife cast his garment over Kabsha and then abandoned her, not consummating a marriage or providing maintenance, so that she might be compelled to purchase her freedom from him. She came to the Prophet and said: "Messenger of God, Abū Qays has died and his son has inherited control of my marriage. He has harmed and delayed me; he neither supports me nor cohabits with me, nor will he let me go." The Prophet is reported to have replied: "Stay in your house until God makes His command regarding you." Women in Medina learned of this and came to the Prophet while he was in the Mosque of al-Fuḍaykh, saying: "Our situation is like Kabsha's, except that it is not sons who marry us but cousins." Then the verse was revealed. [R16] On this interpretation the verse means: You are not permitted to treat women as possessions inherited from men as money is inherited. A second explanation addresses husbands who keep wives within the marriage bond solely in hope of inheriting their money when they die, without finding any affection or benefit in the marriage. A third addresses guardians who prevent female wards from marrying to ensure that their wealth comes to the guardian rather than to their eventual husbands.

Outward commentary · Forbidding coercion to recover the dower; the specified exception

Nor is it lawful for husbands to "constrain" their wives, retaining them without wishing to fulfil their marital rights, "so as to take away part of what you gave them," meaning the bridal gift (الصداق), by harming them until they surrender it in return for release. Ibn ʿAbbās says that this, too, concerns husbands who keep their wives while mistreating them until they offer the bridal gift to free themselves. "Unless they commit a manifest indecency" (فَاحِشَةٍ مُبَيِّنَةٍ), such as rebellious misconduct (النشوز), abusive behaviour or unchastity, in which case, on the Mālikī view Ibn ʿAjība records, a husband may constrain her until she redeems herself by a return of the bridal gift in a divorce by compensation (خُلْع). God knows best. [T184]

Spiritual allusion · The self requires nourishment as well as spiritual training

The seeker (المريد) must not constrict his own self (النفس) so harshly that he brings it to destruction. The self is like a working animal: feed it and make use of its service. The Prophet is reported as saying, “Let none of you be like the traveler whose mount collapses: he neither traverses the land nor preserves his mount.” [R17] Some people hear that one who constrains his self will inherit knowledge from it, and therefore impose such severe hardship upon it that they seek to seize that knowledge by force. The right course is only to prevent desires exceeding what is required for the body’s continued existence (قيام البنية). If the self commits a manifest indecency, growing excessively rebellious, it may be restrained, but never to a degree that leads to destruction. All this benefits the disciple only if his ownership and discipline of the self are established by a sound contract with a complete shaykh (الشيخ الكامل); without that, the toil is vain, like a person seeking to see another’s wife or riding animal. [Textual note: Cairo prints يرى, “see.” The point of this analogy is difficult in that wording; “possess” is not what the printed verb says, and no alternative reading is independently attested.] And God knows best.

The Real then commanded good companionship with women, saying: “Live with them in the recognized manner …”

Outward commentary · Good companionship (المعاشرة بالمعروف)

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: “Live with women in the recognized good manner” (وَعَاشِرُوهُنَّ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ), by speaking gently to them and treating them kindly in your conduct; or by adorning yourself for your wife just as she adorns herself for you. Al-Wartajbī comments: In living with your wives, dwell in intimacy (الأنس), the spirit of love and the joy of ardent affection once you have been singled out for establishment (التمكين), uprightness (الاستقامة) and sainthood (الولاية). The companionship of women is proper to the one intimate with God, like the Prophet and all the saints (الأولياء) and substitutes (الأبدال) intimate with Him. For the Prophet disclosed the perfection of his intimacy with God and his vision of the beauty of witnessing (المشاهدة) when he said: “Of your world, three things have been made beloved to me: perfume, women; and the coolness of my eye was placed in

prayer." R18 Al-Wartajbī further transmits from Dhū al-Nūn that a person intimate with God finds delight in every beautiful thing and pleasing face, every fine voice and agreeable scent. From Ibn al-Mubārak he gives: "Good companionship is that which causes no remorse, either immediately or in the future." Abū Ḥafṣ says: "Living together in the recognized good manner means showing good character towards one's family even in what displeases one." Here ends his report. "If you dislike them," bear patiently: "It may be that you dislike something and God places much good in it," perhaps a righteous child or a good outcome for your religion. Ibn ʿUmar says: A man asks God to choose what is best for him, and God chooses; he is then displeased with his Lord, but before long he sees the outcome and discovers that what was chosen was best for him. Here ends his statement. A story is told that the father of Imām Mālik married a woman, entered to meet her and found her dark-skinned. He remained thoughtful and did not approach her. She asked: "Did you seek your Lord's guidance (استخارة)?" He replied, "Yes." She said: "Do you suspect your Lord?" He then consummated the marriage, and she conceived Imām Mālik, the founder of the school. T185 The Prophet said, "Let no believing man despise a believing woman: if one trait of hers displeases him, another will please him" (لَا يَفْرَكْ مُؤْمِنٌ مُؤْمِنَةً...). R19 Al-Wartajbī transmits an anonymous saying: "Future outcomes are concealed from you so that you will not rest complacently in what is familiar nor flee everything disliked." 201

Spiritual allusion · When the self becomes obedient, reconcile with it

When the self has been purified of its remnants, its virtues perfected, and it submits entirely to its Master, it becomes necessary to treat it with kindness, make peace with it and live with it in the recognized good manner. Its struggle and discipline (مجاهدة) are required only while it remains unbelieving; when it has submitted in Islam and become obedient, love and kindness towards it become incumbent. If, while still crooked, you dislike it and struggle to train it until it grows upright, its final state will bring much good; it will return bearing divinely bestowed knowledge (العلوم اللدنية), and you will behold lordly mysteries within it. Al-Wartajbī says: Every command of God which runs contrary to the self is an examination and trial.

201. Cairo editor, C482.1: Aḥmad, al-Nasāʾī, al-Ḥākim and others record this hadith without the word "three." Al-Ḥāfiẓ Ibn Ḥajar says: "The word 'three' is not found in any of its transmission routes." See al-Fatḥ al-samāwī.

The self dislikes servanthood (العبودية); but if you impose upon it God's rights through spiritual training (الرياضة) and struggle (المجاهدة), until it grows upright in His service, the first thing to dawn upon the heart is the lights of the gardens of nearness and witnessing. God says, "And forbade the self its caprice: the Garden shall be its dwelling" (وَنَهَى النَّفْسَ عَنِ الْهَوَى فَإِنَّ الْجَنَّةَ هِيَ الْمَأْوَى) [Q 79:40–41]. In the inward depths of the darkness of struggling, the knowers behold suns of spiritual combat and moons of unveiling[T186] (المكاشفات). Here ends the substance of his remarks.

If the husband cannot bear the harm he finds in living with his wife and wishes to separate, he must nonetheless pay her the bridal gift, as the Real indicates in the following verse.

4:20–21 — Return of the bridal gift, the solemn marital covenant, and fidelity to spiritual renunciation

Cairo Arabic edition I:483–484

وَإِنْ أَرَدْتُمُ اسْتِبْدالَ زَوْجٍ مَكانَ زَوْجٍ وَآتَيْتُمْ إِحْداهُنَّ قِنْطاراً فَلا تَأْخُذُوا مِنْهُ شَيْئاً أَتَأْخُذُونَهُ بُهْتاناً وَإِثْماً مُبِيناً (20) وَكَيْفَ تَأْخُذُونَهُ وَقَدْ أَفْضى بَعْضُكُمْ إِلى بَعْضٍ وَأَخَذْنَ مِنْكُمْ مِيثاقاً غَلِيظاً (21)

20. If you wish to exchange one wife for another, even if you have given one of them a vast sum, take back none of it. Would you take it by slander and manifest sin? 21. How could you take it when you have drawn intimately near to one another, and they have taken from you a solemn covenant?

Language · Buhtānan (بُهْتَانًا) as a circumstantial qualifier or an omitted prepositional construction

I say: "By slander" (بُهْتَانًا) is accusative as a circumstantial qualifier (حال), or because a preposition has been omitted (على إسقاط الخافض).

Outward commentary · The bridal payment cannot be recaptured by an invented accusation

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: "If you wish to exchange one wife in place of another," divorcing the first to marry someone else, and you have given one of your wives a *qinṭār* (قِنْطَارًا)—a great quantity of property—or less or more, "do not take any part of it back"; pay it to her in full. He then rebukes practices of the age of ignorance: "Would you take it by slander and manifest sin?"—that is, acting as slanderers and sinners, or using open calumny and wrongdoing. *Buhtān* (بُهْتَان) is a lie that astonishes or confounds the falsely accused. It is related that when a man wanted to marry a new wife he would accuse his existing wife falsely of indecency, forcing her to pay him compensation from the bridal gift he had given her, which he would use to finance the new marriage. The Qurʾān forbade this. The divine address magnifies the wrong: "How could you take it, when you have come intimately into one another's presence?" (وَقَدْ أَفْضَى بَعْضُكُمْ إِلَى بَعْضٍ), by touching and marital intercourse, through which the bridal gift is confirmed and the wife's entitlement completed. "And they have taken from you a solemn covenant" (مِيثَاقًا غَلِيظًا): this may mean the duty of good companionship; or retaining the wife with recognized kindness and separating with graciousness; or her giving herself to him, which she did only trusting in the fulfilment of the promised bridal gift and continued companionship. And God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · Do not reclaim what you relinquished for God

If a servant was formerly occupied gathering worldly possessions and immersed in his own shares and desires, then exchanged all that for withdrawal to his Master and remembrance of God (ذكر الله), until he came to witness the lights of divine sanctity and radiance, he should not return to anything he relinquished for God. He should not glance back towards worldly matters he abandoned: returning to what one has renounced is a mark of the ignoble, not the generous. Consider the poet's words:

> When my soul has turned away from a thing,
> It never turns its face back toward that thing, throughout time.

How could you seize again what you gave up for God after attaining the witnessing of the lights of His Beauty and dwelling in His protected precinct? All existence has become unified for you in that vision, and everything has vanished from the sight of your inner eye, after He took solemn covenants from you never to return to what once barred you from the Presence of witnessing (حضرة الشهود). God grants success and guides to the straight way.

He now begins explaining which women are prohibited in marriage.

4:22 — Marriage to a father's former wife and the boundaries of imitating a shaykh

Cairo Arabic edition I:484–485

وَلا تَنْكِحُوا ما نَكَحَ آباؤُكُمْ مِنَ النِّساءِ إِلاَّ مَا قَدْ سَلَفَ إِنَّهُ كانَ فاحِشَةً وَمَقْتاً وَساءَ سَبِيلاً (22)

22. Do not marry women whom your fathers married, except for what has already passed. It was a vile indecency, an abomination, and an evil path.

Language · Mā for persons; the exceptional phrase illā mā qad salaf

I say: "What" (مَا) is applied here to rational beings, and Ibn ʿAjība again explains it—following his earlier discussion—as owing to women's alleged deficient intellect; or it may be a particle introducing a verbal noun (مصدرية). The exception (الاستثناء) may be disconnected (منقطع), or connected by way of rhetorical exaggeration: "Do not marry those your fathers married, except whatever marriages of theirs lie in the past, if you could do so"; compare the poet: [202]

> They have no defect—except that their swords
> Are nicked from striking ranks of fighters. [203]

202. Cairo editor, C484.1: See the commentary on "If you fear that you will not deal justly with the orphans…"—verse 3 of this sūrah.
203. Cairo editor, C484.2: The verse is by al-Nābigha al-Dhubyānī.

Here a supposed exception serves to intensify the prohibition rather than remove it. T187

Outward commentary · A father's wife is prohibited to the son

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: Do not marry any woman whom your fathers have married, whether by valid contract (العقد) where free women are concerned or by sexual access (الوطء) in the historical case of women held in bondage, "except what has already passed," which God has forgiven you after it was dissolved and annulled. "It was an indecency" (فَاحِشَةً), exceedingly grave before God, and not permitted, he says, to any previous community; "and an abomination" (مَقْتًا), whose perpetrator is detested before God and among people of honour. A man born from a union with his father's wife was known as *maqīt* (مَقِيت) or *maqtī* (مَقْتِي). "And an evil path" indeed for anyone choosing it after the prohibition. On this reading "marriage" (النِّكَاح) means the contract. It follows, according to the predominant doctrine Ibn ʿAjība reports, that if the father committed illicit intercourse with a woman this does not by itself render her forbidden in marriage to the son. As the *Risāla* says, "An unlawful act does not render lawful [relations] forbidden" (ولا يحرم بالزنا حلال). Here ends his report. T188

Spiritual allusion · The etiquette of the shaykh is not identical with a legal prohibition

What holds of fathers by bodily descent has a parallel among spiritual fathers (آباء الروحانية), by way of spiritual etiquette (الأدب), **not by way of the revealed law** (لا من طريق الشرع). A disciple should not marry the widow or former wife of his shaykh; such conduct is regarded as offensive and blameworthy by those concerned with proper spiritual etiquette. With the shaykh's daughter there is no objection, provided he can fulfil the duty of honouring her. Our master ʿAlī married the daughter of the Messenger of God, yet safety is more likely in refraining. A subtler indication reads "women" (النساء) as spiritual states (الأحوال). The poor seeker (الفقير) should not claim or imitate his shaykh's states as though those states were his own: the shaykh occupies one station and he another. If a shaykh returns to ordinary means (الأسباب), or engages with elevated matters, the disciple should not imitate him until he has reached a comparable station. Our shaykh's shaykh used to say: "Do not imitate the shaykhs in their acts; imitate them

in their words. Their words are for you and for them, but their acts are particular to them." "Except what is past," meaning the states the masters passed through during their own spiritual journeying (السير): take up those stages and journey from where they began until you have reached what they reached; then do as you wish. And God knows best.

He then mentioned the remaining prohibited relationships.

4:23 — Prohibited degrees of kinship, fosterage and affinity

Cairo Arabic edition I:485–486

حُرِّمَتْ عَلَيْكُمْ أُمَّهاتُكُمْ وَبَناتُكُمْ وَأَخَواتُكُمْ وَعَمَّاتُكُمْ وَخالاتُكُمْ وَبَناتُ الْأَخِ وَبَناتُ الْأُخْتِ وَأُمَّهاتُكُمُ اللاَّتِي أَرْضَعْنَكُمْ وَأَخَواتُكُمْ مِنَ الرَّضاعَةِ وَأُمَّهاتُ نِسائِكُمْ وَرَبائِبُكُمُ اللاَّتِي فِي حُجُورِكُمْ مِنْ نِسائِكُمُ اللاَّتِي دَخَلْتُمْ بِهِنَّ فَإِنْ لَمْ تَكُونُوا دَخَلْتُمْ بِهِنَّ فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْكُمْ وَحَلائِلُ أَبْنائِكُمُ الَّذِينَ مِنْ أَصْلابِكُمْ وَأَنْ تَجْمَعُوا بَيْنَ الْأُخْتَيْنِ إِلاَّ مَا قَدْ سَلَفَ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ غَفُوراً رَحِيماً (23)

23. Forbidden to you are your mothers and your daughters; your sisters; your paternal aunts and maternal aunts; your brothers' daughters and sisters' daughters; your mothers who suckled you and your sisters through suckling; your wives' mothers; your stepdaughters in your care born of wives with whom you have consummated marriage—but if you have not consummated marriage with them, there is no blame upon you; and the wives of sons who come from your own loins; and that you unite two sisters in marriage, except what has already passed. Truly God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language · Kitāba Allāhi ʿalaykum as the confirming verbal noun

I say: “God’s ordinance upon you” (كِتَابَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ) is an emphatic verbal noun (مصدر مؤكد): “God has written this prescription upon you as an ordinance” (كتب الله ذلك كتابًا); or it may be a construction of direct exhortation (الإغراء).

Outward commentary · Women prohibited through descent

The Real—majestic is His glory—says: Several classes of women are prohibited to you in marriage, whether by blood relationship (النسب), suckling (الرضاع), or marriage affinity (المصاهرة). Those prohibited by descent include “your mothers,” meaning one’s own mother and the maternal and paternal grandmothers however high the line ascends; “your daughters,” meaning one’s daughter, son’s daughter and daughter’s daughter however far the line descends; “your sisters,” including full sisters, sisters by the father and sisters by the mother; “your paternal aunts,” including the father’s sisters and grandfathers’ sisters of every higher generation, full or half-sisters; “your maternal aunts,” the mother’s or grandmothers’ sisters of every higher generation, full or half-sisters; “your brother’s daughters,” daughters of full or paternal brothers and of their descendants; and “your sisters’ daughters,” including daughters and further descendants of full sisters and maternal or paternal half-sisters. The governing principle is that a man cannot marry his ancestors however high, his descendants however low, the descendants of his own parents however low, or the first generation of descendants of any ancestor higher than his parents [i.e. his aunts].

Outward commentary · Prohibition arising through suckling

He then lists what is prohibited by suckling: “Your mothers who suckled you and your sisters through suckling.” God names two classes in the verse, while the Sunna establishes that every category prohibited by blood is likewise prohibited by suckling. The Prophet said: “What is prohibited through suckling is what is prohibited through lineage” (يَحْرُمُ مِنَ الرَّضَاعِ مَا يَحْرُمُ مِنَ النَّسَبِ). [R20] Accordingly, the seven categories are: foster-mother, foster-daughter, foster-sister, foster-paternal aunt, foster-maternal aunt, foster-niece through a brother and foster-niece through a sister.

Outward commentary · Affinity: mothers-in-law, stepdaughters and daughters-in-law

He then speaks of the women forbidden by marriage affinity: “Your wives’ mothers.” The prohibition on a father’s wife has been mentioned, and that of a son’s wife follows. “Your stepdaughters who are in your care, from wives with whom you have consummated marriage”: the mention of being “in your care” is not a restrictive condition on the majority interpretation, but corresponds to what most often occurs. The daughter is prohibited whether she grew up in his household or not. ʿAlī is reported to have permitted marrying such a stepdaughter if she had not been brought up under the husband’s care. The phrase “with whom you have consummated marriage” (اللَّاتِي دَخَلْتُمْ بِهِنَّ) is, however, operative by consensus as reported here: if a man merely contracts marriage with a woman but does not consummate it, he may divorce her and marry her daughter. Hence the words: “If you have not consummated marriage with them, there is no blame upon you” in marrying the daughters. [T189] “And the wives of your sons,” that is, a woman with whom a son has contracted a marriage and to whom he thereby becomes lawfully married. She becomes prohibited to the father by the contract alone. In sum, a father’s wife, a son’s wife and a wife’s mother become prohibited by the contract, whereas the wife’s daughter becomes prohibited only upon consummation with her mother. Contracting marriage with the daughter prohibits her mother; consummation with the mother prohibits the daughter. “Those [sons] who come from your loins” excludes a woman divorced by an adopted son from this particular prohibition, as in the account of Zayd and the Messenger of God.

Outward commentary · Combining two sisters

“And [it is forbidden] to join two sisters” in marriage, whether full sisters or paternal or maternal half-sisters. This applies to marriage. In the historical institution of ownership of enslaved women without intercourse, no such objection was raised; regarding intercourse with two sisters under that institution, Mālik, al-Shāfiʿī and Abū Ḥanīfa forbade it, while Ibn ʿAjība reports the Ẓāhirīs as permitting it. “Except what has already passed,” meaning what happened in the age of ignorance, has been forgiven. “Truly God is Forgiving, Merciful.” [T190] Ibn ʿAbbās says: The Arabs had treated as for-

bidden all the unions prohibited by the Sacred Law, except a father's wife and the simultaneous marriage of two sisters; that is why the divine speech specifically says "except what has already passed" in these two cases.

4:24 — Marriage impediments, the inward severance of attachments, and the bridal gift

Cairo Arabic edition I:485–489

وَالْمُحْصَناتُ مِنَ النِّساءِ إِلاَّ مَا مَلَكَتْ أَيْمانُكُمْ كِتابَ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ وَأُحِلَّ لَكُمْ مَّا وَراءَ ذلِكُمْ أَنْ تَبْتَغُوا بِأَمْوالِكُمْ مُحْصِنِينَ غَيْرَ مُسافِحِينَ فَمَا اسْتَمْتَعْتُمْ بِهِ مِنْهُنَّ فَآتُوهُنَّ أُجُورَهُنَّ فَرِيضَةً وَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْكُمْ فِيما تَراضَيْتُمْ بِهِ مِنْ بَعْدِ الْفَرِيضَةِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَلِيماً حَكِيماً ﴿24﴾

Also forbidden to you are women already married, except those whom your right hands possess. Such is God's ordinance upon you. And He has made lawful to you those beyond these, provided that you seek them with your wealth in chastity, not in fornication. So for the women with whom you have enjoyed marital intimacy, give them their bridal gifts as an obligation. There is no blame upon you concerning whatever you mutually agree upon after the obligation has been fixed. God is ever Knowing, Wise.

Outward commentary · The prohibition concerning married women

God also prohibited *al-muḥṣanāt* (المحصنات) among women: that is, women bound by marriage to their husbands. It is therefore not lawful to marry them while the marriage bond remains in force, **"except those whom your right hands possess"** from the spoils of war. Thus, when a non-Muslim woman is captured while she has a husband, the person who becomes her owner, according to the rule Ibn ʿAjība is describing, may have intercourse with her by reason of ownership after *istibrāʾ* (الاستبراء), the ascertainment that her womb is free [from a previous pregnancy]. In the *Mukhtaṣar* it is said: "Captivity annuls marriage—except that, if she is captured and embraces Islam during her waiting period (*ʿidda*, العدة), he [her previous husband] has the prior claim to her." [T191]

The Messenger of God, blessings and peace upon him, sent an army to Awṭās. They took captive women from the enemy who had husbands among the polytheists. The Muslims felt religious scruple (*taʾaththum*, التأثم) about intercourse with them, and this verse was revealed permitting it [under the legal conditions understood by the commentator]. [R21] **"God's ordinance upon you"** means that God prescribed this for you as an ordinance: the prohibition of the women named in the verse.

Spiritual allusion · the three births and the renunciation of former attachments

Know that a human being does not become a perfected knower (*ʿārif kāmil*, عارف كامل) until he is born three times after his birth from his bodily mother. The first is his emergence from the womb of love for this lowly world; then [he emerges] from heedlessness and bodily appetites; then from the narrowness of the darkened created orders (*al-akwān al-ẓulmāniyya*, الأكوان الظلمانية), into the open expanse of witnessing and direct vision (*al-mushāhada wa-l-muʿāyana*, المشاهدة والمعاينة). One of the saints said: "One who has not been born twice is not of us." Here he counted the first and the third [of the births just described]. When a person has emerged from these wombs, God has made it forbidden for him to "marry" them or return to them. [T192]

In the same way, returning to the lapses and dark states born from him is forbidden for him; likewise the vain pursuits and customary attachments with which he had formerly made himself intimate and brotherly, and the partisanships, heated loyalties and claims to eminence in which he found his forebears established. There is no difference here between what confronts him through the fathers and what confronts him through the mothers. So too with what he has suckled from the breast of appetites—the milk of heedlessness—and with the veils (*akinna*, أكنة) that have accumulated over him: let him hasten to prohibit such things to himself and wean his soul from them before they gain mastery over it. As al-Būṣīrī, may God be pleased with him, said: [204]

> The soul is like a child: neglect it, and it will grow up loving to suckle;
> **wean it, and it will be weaned.**

204. Cairo editor, C487.1: Akinnāt: coverings.

Likewise forbidden to him is the companionship of the brothers and sisters who suckled alongside him from that breast before weaning. The “mothers of sins,” too, are love of this world, command, and standing among people (*al-jāh*, الجاه). Likewise the “stepdaughters” of entanglements and obstacles (*al-ʿalāʾiq wa-l-ʿawāʾiq*, العلائق والعوائق) have been forbidden to you, so that you may enter the lands of realities (*al-ḥaqāʾiq*, الحقائق). If you are not among the people of realities, however, there is no blame upon you, for you belong to the ordinary company of created beings. Equally forbidden to [the advanced seeker] are occupations with worldly means (*al-asbāb*, الأسباب)—though permissible for people of his own kind—when they distract him from serving the Lord of lords, and also the combining of love of the world with love of the Master. Al-Shāfiʿī, may God be pleased with him, is reported to have said: “Whoever claims to have joined love of the world with love of its Creator has lied.” [T193]

“Except what has gone before” during the days of idle distraction. Similarly, a seeker (*murīd*) who has become detached (*mutajarrid*, متجرد) and is looking toward the inward meanings must not busy himself with the exoteric sciences which the people of the outward have entered and whose virginity they have taken—except what he acquired before detachment: such knowledge does not harm him if he becomes absent from it in the secrets of divine unity (*asrār al-tawḥīd*, أسرار التوحيد). God knows best the secrets of His Unseen.

He then speaks of the women who are lawful to marry

Language · The grammar of “made lawful,” seeking with wealth, and chastity

“And made lawful to you …” I say: Ibn ʿAjība first construes **“and made lawful”** in an active reading, *wa-aḥalla* (وأَحَلَّ), as coordinated (*ʿaṭf*, عطف) with the unexpressed verb governing **“God’s ordinance upon you”**: that is, God prescribed the prohibition of those mentioned and made lawful what lies beyond them. In the passive reading *wa-uḥilla* (وأُحِلَّ), the verb is instead coordinated with **“prohibited [to you]”** (*ḥurrimat*, حرمت). [T194] **“That you should seek”** (*an tabtaghū*, أن تبتغوا) is an object of purpose (*mafʿūl li-ajlih*, مفعول لأجله)—“with the intention that you seek”—or a substitute (*badal*, بدل) for **“beyond these”**. **“In chastity”** (*muḥṣinīn*, محصنين) is a circumstantial

accusative (*ḥāl*, حال) relating to the plural pronoun. *Sifāḥ* (السفاح) is fornication, derived from *safḥ* (السفح), "pouring out," because semen is poured where it does not belong.

Outward commentary · Lawful marriage, dowers, and the question of temporary marriage

The Real—majestic is His majesty—says: **"And made lawful to you what lies beyond these"**: marrying women other than those listed as prohibited, apart also from the prohibitions established by the Sunna through suckling, as mentioned earlier, and the prohibition of combining marriage to a woman and her paternal aunt, or to a woman and her maternal aunt. These the Sunna has prohibited. [R31] God permitted the marriage of women in order that you might seek what is lawful through your wealth, devoting it to women's bridal gifts (*muhūr*, مهور), while being **"chaste"** (*muḥṣinīn*): preserving your modesty and securing yourselves by marriage against what is forbidden, **"not fornicators"** (*musāfiḥīn*, مسافحين), who cast their water where it does not belong.

"So for those of them with whom you have enjoyed [marital intimacy], give them their wages as an obligation": that is, give the women you have married their bridal gifts, for the bridal gift corresponds to marital enjoyment; it is an obligatory, stipulated amount, neither unknown nor ambiguous. **"There is no blame upon you in what you mutually agree upon after the obligation"**: in an increase above the contractually stipulated bridal gift or a reduction of it, after the amount upon which the marriage contract was made. **"God has ever been Knowing"** of His creatures' welfare and **"Wise"** in the rulings He has prescribed.

Another view says that **"So for those of them with whom you have enjoyed …"** to the end was revealed concerning *nikāḥ al-mutʿa* (نكاح المتعة), the fixed-term marriage said to have been permitted for three days at the conquest of Mecca and then abrogated (*nusikha*, نُسخ). This is supported by what is transmitted of the Prophet, blessings and peace upon him: having permitted it, he then said the following morning, "People! I had allowed you to seek temporary enjoyment with these women, but God has forbidden this until the Day of Resurrection." [R22] It is a marriage stipulated for a known time, called *mutʿa* because the object is enjoyment alone, to-

gether with the woman's enjoyment of what she is given. Ibn ʿAbbās permitted it and then, according to this report, withdrew his permission. God knows best. T195

Spiritual allusion · knowledge beyond discursive transmission

The Real—majestic is His majesty—says by way of allusion: When you have emerged from the womb of appetites, abandoned your previous habits and familiar attachments, and renounced the conventional, formally transmitted sciences (*al-ʿulūm al-rasmiyyāt*, العلوم الرسميات) that preoccupy your thought, then there becomes lawful for you what lies beyond them: the God-given sciences (*al-ʿulūm al-ladunniyya*, العلوم اللدنية) and lordly secrets (*al-asrār al-rabbāniyya*, الأسرار الربانية), which transcend the reach of discursive intellects and cannot be grasped from written pages (*ṭurūs*, طروس) or transmitted reports (*nuqūl*, نقول). Ibn al-Fāriḍ, may God be pleased with him, alluded to these when he said: [205]

> Be not among those whom their pages have made giddy, so that they have unsettled their intellect and swept it away.
>
> For beyond transmission there is knowledge too subtle for the furthest comprehension of sound intellects.
>
> I received it from myself and took it from myself, while my soul was sustained by a gift.

We wished you, through the expenditure of your wealth and your very lives (*muhaj*, مهج), to seek those holy sciences and purified secrets, safeguarding yourselves against the taint of sense perception (*al-ḥiss*, الحس) and caprice (*al-hawā*, الهوى), neither touching the impurity of the world nor keeping company with its people, so that you may delight in witnessing Our secrets and the lights of Our holiness. Whatever you have enjoyed of these, guard it from those unworthy of it; yet there is no blame upon you in mutually agreeing to give it to those worthy of it, once you have protected it from those who have no rightful claim. And God knows best.

He then gives the ruling concerning someone unable to afford the bridal gift of a free woman

205. Cairo editor, C489.1: Ṭurūs: written sheets or pages.

4:25–28 — Marriage under constraint, the degrees of knowledge, and divine accommodation

Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493

وَمَنْ لَمْ يَسْتَطِعْ مِنْكُمْ طَوْلاً أَنْ يَنْكِحَ الْمُحْصَناتِ الْمُؤْمِناتِ فَمِنْ مَّا مَلَكَتْ أَيْمانُكُمْ مِنْ فَتَياتِكُمُ الْمُؤْمِناتِ وَاللَّهُ أَعْلَمُ بِإِيمانِكُمْ بَعْضُكُمْ مِنْ بَعْضٍ فَانْكِحُوهُنَّ بِإِذْنِ أَهْلِهِنَّ وَآتُوهُنَّ أُجُورَهُنَّ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ مُحْصَناتٍ غَيْرَ مُسافِحاتٍ وَلا مُتَّخِذاتِ أَخْدانٍ فَإِذا أُحْصِنَّ فَإِنْ أَتَيْنَ بِفاحِشَةٍ فَعَلَيْهِنَّ نِصْفُ مَا عَلَى الْمُحْصَناتِ مِنَ الْعَذابِ ذلِكَ لِمَنْ خَشِيَ الْعَنَتَ مِنْكُمْ وَأَنْ تَصْبِرُوا خَيْرٌ لَكُمْ وَاللَّهُ غَفُورٌ رَحِيمٌ (25) يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ لِيُبَيِّنَ لَكُمْ وَيَهْدِيَكُمْ سُنَنَ الَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ وَيَتُوبَ عَلَيْكُمْ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ حَكِيمٌ (26) وَاللَّهُ يُرِيدُ أَنْ يَتُوبَ عَلَيْكُمْ وَيُرِيدُ الَّذِينَ يَتَّبِعُونَ الشَّهَواتِ أَنْ تَمِيلُوا مَيْلاً عَظِيماً (27) يُرِيدُ اللَّهُ أَنْ يُخَفِّفَ عَنْكُمْ وَخُلِقَ الْإِنْسانُ ضَعِيفاً (28)

25. Whoever among you lacks the means to marry free believing women may marry believing young women from among those whom your right hands possess. God knows best your faith; you are one of another. Marry them with their people's permission and give them their bridal gifts in accordance with what is right, as women living chastely in marriage, not committing fornication or taking secret lovers. Once they are married, if they commit an indecency, they incur half the punishment prescribed for free women. This permission is for whoever among you fears falling into sin; but that you remain patient is better for you. God is Forgiving, Merciful.
26. God wishes to make things clear to you, guide you in the ways of those before you, and turn toward you in mercy. God is Knowing, Wise.

27. God wishes to turn toward you in mercy, while those who follow their desires wish you to turn far aside.
28. God wishes to lighten your burden; the human being was created weak.

Language · Means, syntactic objects, circumstance, and companionship

I say: *Ṭawl* (الطول) means wealth and ample means; it can also mean exaltedness. It is a verbal noun (*maṣdar*, مصدر) of *ṭāla ṭawlan*. It functions either as the direct object (*mafʿūl*, مفعول) of **“is able”** or as a cognate verbal noun (*maṣdar*), since the meanings are closely related. **“To marry”** (*an yankiḥa*, أن ينكح) is, on the first analysis, a substitute (*badal*, بدل) for that object, or, on the second, the direct object—“[has the means] to marry.” **“Chaste, not fornicators”** are two circumstantial accusatives (*ḥālān*, حالان), governed by **“marry them”** (*ankiḥūhunna*, أنكحوهن). And *khidn* (الخدن) means a lover or intimate companion.

Outward commentary · Marriage to an enslaved woman and the diversity of legal conditions

The Real—majestic is His majesty—says: **“Whoever among you lacks the means”**, namely, does not possess the wealth that would enable him to marry **“chaste believing women”**, that is, free believing women, may marry from among **“those whom your right hands possess, of your believing young women”**: enslaved believing women, but not unbelieving ones. If one of these women makes an outward profession of faith, that is sufficient: knowledge of the inward state belongs to God alone, for **“God knows best your faith.”** Nor should fear of social disgrace deter you from marrying them, for you are of one kind and of one religion: **“You are one of another.”** Do not be too proud to marry them.

“Marry them with the permission of their people” means with the consent of their owners, who conclude the marriage contract for you. **“Give them their bridal gifts”** (*ujūrahunna*, أجورهن), which, in Mālik’s school as presented here, belong more properly to the women themselves rather than to their masters, **“in the recognized manner”** (*bi-l-maʿrūf*, بالمعروف): without delaying payment or diminishing it, as required by the Sunna. They are to be **“chaste”** (*muḥṣanāt*, محصنات), that is, modest, **“not fornicators”**, and **“not taking secret lovers”** (*akhdān*, أخدان), namely, companions with

whom they commit fornication. In pre-Islamic times, some women took one exclusive partner for illicit intercourse, while others rejected no man who approached them.

Ibn Juzayy says: “According to Mālik and most of his companions, a free man may marry an enslaved woman only on two conditions. One is the absence of means (*ʿadam al-ṭawl*, عدم الطول)—that he lack enough to marry a free woman. The other is fear of hardship (*khawf al-ʿanat*, خوف العنت), namely fornication, because of what follows: **‘That is for one among you who fears hardship.’** Ibn al-Qāsim allowed their marriage even in the absence of both conditions, on the view that the *dalīl al-khiṭāb* (دليل الخطاب)—inference from what a statement leaves unsaid—is not legally probative. They agreed upon requiring that the enslaved woman be Muslim, on the strength of **‘of your believing young women’**, except the jurists of Iraq, who did not impose that condition.” End of quotation. [T196]

Spiritual allusion · the “virgins” of reality and formal learning

Whoever is unable to marry the virgins of spiritual realities (*abkār al-ḥaqāʾiq*, أبكار الحقائق), because he cannot drive distractions and attachments (*shawāghil wa-ʿalāʾiq*, شواغل وعلائق) from his heart, should descend to the marriage of formal sciences (*al-ʿulūm al-rasmiyya*, العلوم الرسمية) and sense-based acts (*al-aʿmāl al-ḥissiyya*, الأعمال الحسية). He should receive these from their masters, protect his acquisition of them with sincerity (*ikhlāṣ*, إخلاص), fulfil their rights to the extent he can by sharing them with those qualified for them, and patiently disseminate them. God does not waste the reward of anyone who acts well. If his intention is sound and his action sincere, God will appoint for him one of His friends (*walī*, ولي) who enriches him through God, until he becomes among those rich through Him. Then he will become qualified to marry free women and will join the great friends of God. “And that is not difficult for God.”

When Shaykh Abū al-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī, may God be pleased with him, spoke about the fruits of love, he said: “You will see the soul inclined toward His obedience, the intellect fortified by knowledge of Him, the spirit taken up into His Presence, and the secret immersed in witnessing Him. The servant seeks an increase [in love] and receives an increase; he is opened to what is sweeter than the delight of intimate conversation with Him; he is clothed in the robes of nearness upon the carpet of nearness;

and he touches the virgins of realities and the previously married women of the sciences." End of quotation. Thus the knowledge of realities is "virgins"; the sciences of the Path that lead to them are "free, previously married women"; and the remaining formal disciplines are, by comparison, "enslaved women." God knows best. T197 206 207

He then describes the penalty concerning the enslaved woman who commits fornication

Language · Different readings of the verb "protected by marriage"

I say: *Aḥṣana al-rajul* (أحصن الرجل), with either fatḥa or ḍamma on the initial hamza, means that the man became *muḥṣan* (محصن), with either fatḥa or kasra [in that derived form]; in this instance the active and passive constructions (*al-binā' li-l-fā'il wa-l-maf'ūl*, البناء للفاعل والمفعول) coincide. According to another account, the form with fatḥa signifies embracing Islam, while that with ḍamma signifies marrying.

Outward commentary · The juristic rule on the reduced penalty

The Real—majestic is His majesty—says: If enslaved women are married, then **"if they commit an indecency"** (*fāḥisha*, فاحشة)—fornication—their prescribed punishment is half of that imposed upon a free woman: fifty [lashes], because the punishment of an unmarried [free] person is one hundred. One may also infer that they do not undergo stoning, since stoning admits of no division into halves. Likewise enslaved males receive half of the prescribed penalties, and there is no stoning for them. God calls the prescribed penalty "chastisement" (*'adhāb*, عذاب), as in **"Let a group of believers witness their chastisement"** [Q 24:2]. T198

Spiritual allusion · the closer the station, the finer the discipline

As rank (*maqām*, مقام) rises, punishment becomes more severe; as nearness increases, good comportment (*ādāb*, آداب) is required more strictly. A lapse far from God is not like a lapse in nearness, and what is expected of

206. Cairo editor, C490.1: The source copies read "by His assistance" (bi-ma'ūnatihi). The reading printed here is that found in al-Iskandarī's Laṭā'if al-minan.
207. Cairo editor, C490.2: The words within square brackets were inserted by the shaykh commentator in transmitting the quotation.

someone far away is not what is expected of someone close. Consider the wives of the Prophet, blessings and peace upon him, to whom God said: **"O wives of the Prophet, whoever among you commits a manifest indecency shall have her chastisement doubled"** [Q 33:30]. This is only because of their favor and extraordinary nearness to God. Therefore none enters the Presence (*al-ḥaḍra*, الحضرة) except those of comportment and refinement, after gradual education and training. Reflect on the case of al-Junayd: he was told in a dream, "Such a thing cannot be accepted from someone like you," after the thought of objecting to a petitioner had crossed his heart. Yet those drawn near are reproved and brought back into the Presence, while those remote become still more remote without perceiving it. God knows best. T199

He next returns to the condition for marrying an enslaved woman when means are lacking

Language · The term ʿanat and the purpose-lām in "God wishes to clarify"

I say: *ʿAnat* (العنت) means hardship and harm; no harm is greater than falling into sin, especially the gravest sexual indecency, fornication. **"God desires to explain to you"** (*yurīdu Allāhu li-yubayyina lakum*, يريد الله ليبين لكم) means "so that He may explain"; the *lām* is an additional particle (*lām zāʾida*, لام زائدة) in an object construction, reinforcing the prospective sense that necessarily belongs to intending.

Outward commentary · Fear of fornication, patience, and reports about marriage

The Real—majestic is His majesty—says: **"That"**—the marriage of enslaved women—"is for whoever among you fears hardship": I have only permitted it for one who fears falling into fornication, the vilest of indecencies. Under the historical law being described, the marriage of an enslaved woman, with the prospect that her child would also enter slavery and be sold in the markets, is treated as less harmful than fornication. **"But that you should remain patient is better for you"**: refrain from such a marriage while abstaining from fornication, so that your children do not become enslaved. T200

Anas said: "I heard the Prophet, blessings and peace upon him, say, 'Whoever wishes to meet God pure and purified, let him marry free women.'" Abū Hurayra said: "I heard him say, 'Free women are the well-being of the household, and enslaved women the destruction of the household.'" [Translator's note: Both reports are transmitted in the tradition literature, but neither may safely be treated as an authenticated Prophetic saying.] R23 R24 208

"And God is Forgiving" toward you for whatever contravention has passed; **"Merciful"** to you because He granted a dispensation (*rukhṣa*, رخصة) to marry an enslaved woman when you fear sin. **"God desires to make clear to you"** the ordinances of your religion and the welfare of your affairs, **"and to guide you to the ways of those who came before you"**, the paths of the rightly guided—prophets and righteous people—so that you follow their ways: protecting property and descent, and prohibiting marriage to mothers, daughters and sisters, just as these were prohibited to those before you. **"And to turn to you"** means to forgive your past sins, or guide you to repentance, or preserve you from disobedience through protection (*ʿiṣma*, عصمة). **"God is Knowing"** of all your past and future acts and **"Wise"** in what He disposes and determines.

"God desires to turn toward you" is repeated to prepare for the contrast **"while those who follow desires wish you to incline tremendously"**, away from truth, so that you conform to them in pursuit of appetites and treating forbidden acts as lawful. It is as though God says: We wish your repentance and right guidance; those who follow appetites desire your deviation and ruin. He means fornicators, who would like everyone to be like themselves. As for someone who satisfies sexual desire in a lawful marriage, he follows the truth and not them. The Prophet, blessings and peace upon him, is reported to have said: "Marry and beget children; I will boast of your numbers before the nations on the Day of Resurrection." R25 Our master ʿAlī—may God ennoble his face—was among the most ascetic of the Companions, yet he had four free wives and seven women kept as concubines; another report gives seventeen. Another interpretation takes **"those who follow appetites"** as Jews and Christians, on the ground that Jews permit marriage within certain close relations, such as paternal relatives and

208. Cairo editor, C491.1: Al-Suyūṭī classified this hadith as weak in al-Jāmiʿ al-ṣaghīr.

brothers' and sisters' daughters; still another says that it means the Magians. [Translator's note: These are Ibn ʿAjība's transmitted identifications, not a definition established by the verse itself.] T201

"God desires to lighten things for you": He accordingly ordained the easy, broad and upright religious law (*al-sharīʿa al-ḥanīfiyya al-samḥa al-sahla*, الشريعة الحنيفية السمحة السهلة), and in circumstances of pressure He allowed the dispensation of marrying an enslaved woman. **"The human being was created weak"** in every respect. He was created in weakness and will return to weakness; a single bout of hunger enslaves him, and a full meal can strike him down. Particularly in matters of sexual desire, he is unable to endure indefinitely without intercourse; in no matter, says the author, is a man weaker than with respect to women.

ʿUbāda b. al-Ṣāmit, may God be pleased with him, reportedly said: "Do you not see that I can stand only with support, and eat only what has been softened for me? My companion"—meaning his male organ—"has been dead for some time. Yet it would not please me to be alone with a woman not lawful to me, even if I possessed everything upon which the sun rises, for fear that Satan should come and stir it, though it has neither hearing nor sight." T202 209

Ibn ʿAbbās said: "There are eight verses in Sūrat al-Nisāʾ better for this community than everything upon which the sun rises and sets": **"God desires to explain to you"** [4:26], **"God desires to turn toward you"** [4:27], **"God desires to lighten things for you"** [4:28], **"If you avoid the grave sins you are forbidden"** [4:31], **"God does not forgive the association of partners with Him"** [4:48], **"God does not wrong [anyone] by so much as an atom's weight"** [4:40], **"Whoever does evil or wrongs his own soul"** [4:110], and **"What would God gain from punishing you?"** [4:147]. End of report. T203

Spiritual allusion · overload, concession, and return to the path

The disciple (*murīd*, مريد) descends to the formal sciences or sensible activities only if he fears being blotted out (*inmiḥāq*, انمحاق) or overwhelmed (*iṣṭilām*, اصطلام) in the sea of realities. If he can remain patient and hold firm until strengthened to carry its burdens, that is better for him, because

209. Cairo editor, C492.1: That is, only with someone else's assistance.

after returning to sensible experience (*al-ḥiss*, الحس) there is no certainty that he will not be detained there (*al-ḥabs*, الحبس). Yet God is Forgiving to one who descends for the reason just given, Merciful in having established the dispensation for him.

“God desires to explain to you” the journey of the Path (*sulūk al-ṭarīq*, سلوك الطريق) toward the very reality of realization (*ʿayn al-taḥqīq*, عين التحقيق), and guide you along the roads of arrival (*ṭuruq al-wuṣūl*, طرق الوصول), as He guided those before you; He forgives the pause or stagnation (*fatra aw waqfa*, فترة أو وقفة) that might cross your mind, and He seeks to turn tenderly toward you so that you return to Him with your entire being. But the heedless who are submerged in appetites wish you to deviate from the way of arrival into your Lord’s Presence. God wishes to lighten your burden: He will not lay upon you spiritual visitations (*wāridāt*, واردات) beyond what your strength can bear, for you are weak unless He strengthens you. O God, strengthen us for what we desire and support us in what You desire; You have power over all things.

After speaking of protecting the estates of orphans and women, and being led into the legal boundaries concerning women, he now resumes the protection of people’s property

4:29–30 — Trading by consent, preservation of life, and the spiritual meaning of self-destruction

Cairo Arabic edition I:493–495

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا تَأْكُلُوا أَمْوالَكُمْ بَيْنَكُمْ بِالْباطِلِ إِلاَّ أَنْ تَكُونَ تِجارَةٌ عَنْ تَراضٍ مِنْكُمْ وَلا تَقْتُلُوا أَنْفُسَكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ بِكُمْ رَحِيماً (29) وَمَنْ يَفْعَلْ ذلِكَ عُدْواناً وَظُلْماً فَسَوْفَ نُصْلِيهِ نَاراً وَكانَ ذلِكَ عَلَى اللَّهِ يَسِيراً (30)

29. O you who believe, do not consume one another's wealth unjustly, except through commerce conducted by mutual consent among you; and do not kill yourselves. God is indeed Merciful to you.
30. Whoever does that in aggression and wrongdoing, We shall make him enter a Fire; and that is easy for God.

Language · The disconnected exception and the two analyses of kāna

I say: The exception (*al-istithnāʾ*, الاستثناء) is disconnected (*munqaṭiʿ*, منقطع), meaning "but [let there be] trade." In the reading with the nominative (*raf*ʿ, رفع), **"be"** (*kāna*, كان) is complete (*tāmma*, تامة), meaning "occur"; in the accusative reading (*naṣb*, نصب), it is incomplete (*nāqiṣa*, ناقصة), with a pronoun referring to property as its subject after supplying an omitted construct: "except that the property be property of trade."

Outward commentary · Unlawful enrichment, lawful trading, and disagreement over the option to rescind

The Real—majestic is His majesty—says: **"O you who believe, do not consume one another's property unlawfully"** (*bi-l-bāṭil*, بالباطل): by any means the religious law does not permit, such as usury, gambling, violent appropriation, theft, betrayal of trust, divination, sorcery, and the like. **"Except that there be trade by mutual consent among you"**: that is, rather, when a valid commercial transaction occurs through mutual agreement on the sale. The Mālikīs draw from this the conclusion that a sale is constituted by the contract even before the two parties physically separate.

Al-Shāfiʿī says that the sale is completed only once the parties separate physically, relying on the Prophet's saying, blessings and peace upon him: "The seller and buyer retain their option [to annul the contract] so long as they have not separated." [R26] Mālik interprets "separation" as separation of speech [the ending of negotiation]. According to most exegetes, the "option" (*takhyīr*, تخيير) means each party formally offering the other a choice once the contract is concluded. ʿAmr b. Jarīr reportedly bought a horse and then gave his counterpart the choice after the sale, saying: "I heard Abū Hurayra say that trade must be by mutual consent." Al-Bayḍāwī says: "Trade is singled out among the means by which another's property may lawfully pass [to one] because it is the most common, and most fitting for

people of dignity. It is also possible that 'trade' is intended to mean transfer [of property] in general." Another interpretation takes the prohibition as forbidding spending wealth on what God does not approve, and "trade" as spending it on what He does approve. End of quotation. T204

Spiritual allusion · the profitable exchange

Do not expend your wealth—or your spiritual states (*aḥwāl*, أحوال)—on anything that does not draw you nearer to the Real (*al-Ḥaqq*, الحق), for everything besides the Real is vain. As the poet said:

> Truly everything apart from God is vain; and every delight will surely vanish.
>
> 210

There is an exception when the expenditure becomes profitable trade, bringing you near to the Beloved and drawing you into the Presence of the Near One: that is a profitable trade and a beneficial bargain. God knows best.

He then turns to one aspect of preserving bodily life, a topic completed later in the discussion of "It is not for a believer …"

Outward commentary · The prohibition on killing oneself and the precedent of ʿAmr b. al-ʿĀṣ

"Do not kill yourselves" by strangling, severing the spinal cord, or inflicting a wound that brings death; nor by throwing yourselves into destruction. ʿAmr b. al-ʿĀṣ, may God be pleased with him, reported: "The Messenger of God sent me on the expedition to Dhāt al-Salāsil. I became ritually impure on a cold night; fearing for my life [if I washed], I performed *tayammum* (التيمم) and led my companions in the dawn prayer. When I returned I mentioned this to the Messenger of God. He said, 'Amr, did you lead them in prayer while you were in a state of major ritual impurity?' I said, 'Yes,

210. Cairo editor, C493.1: See the note on this verse at the allusion on verse [150] of Sūrat al-Baqara.

Messenger of God. I feared that washing would destroy me, and I remembered the saying of God: **Do not kill yourselves. God has indeed been merciful to you.**' The Prophet laughed and said nothing." R27 211

Alternatively, **"Do not kill yourselves"** can mean: do not kill your brothers in Islam, for the believers are like one soul. Al-Bayḍāwī says that by joining the preservation of life and wealth, which is its companion because life depends on it, God enjoins the continued safety of both. End of quotation. It is only out of kindness and mercy that God has forbidden you to kill yourselves: **"God has ever been Merciful to you."** He commanded the Children of Israel to kill themselves [in a particular account], whereas He forbade it to you.

"Whoever does that"—meaning the killing, or all the prohibited acts just mentioned—**"in aggression and wrongdoing"**: that is, excessive transgression of a limit and doing what one has no right to do, or trespassing against another while wronging oneself by exposing oneself to punishment, **"We shall soon expose him to a Fire"**, that is, burn and roast him in it. **"And that is easy for God."** The Prophet, blessings and peace upon him, is reported to have said: "Whoever kills himself by something will be punished by it in the Fire of Hell, remaining there forever." R28 This is a threat expressed with extraordinary severity, or, Ibn ʿAjība says, it applies to someone who declares the act lawful. The warning given here for killing oneself, he observes, is lighter than the warning later given for killing another human being, where wrath, the curse, and a tremendous punishment are added. As for Ibn ʿAṭiyya's assertion that the exegetes unanimously agreed that this verse refers to killing one another, Ibn ʿAjība says that assertion is not correct. God knows best. T205

Spiritual allusion · preserving the soul's real life

Do not kill your souls by following appetites and allowing heedlessness to accumulate over you, for these deprive the soul of true life. Al-Fuḍayl b. ʿIyāḍ, may God be pleased with him, said: "Do not be heedless of your soul's portion; one who neglects his soul's portion is as if he had killed it." The

211. Cairo editor, C494.1: Nakhʿ is a violent killing; the word derives from severing the spinal cord.

soul's portion is its purification (*tazkiya*, تزكية) and adornment with perfections, or its nourishment with certain knowledge (*ʿilm al-yaqīn*, علم اليقين), gnosis (*maʿrifa*, معرفة), and sound establishment (*tamkīn*, تمكين).

By "soul" here [the author] means spirit (*rūḥ*, روح). When Sufis say that the soul must be "killed," they intend the commanding soul (*al-nafs al-ammāra*, النفس الأمارة). So long as the spirit remains darkened by sins and caprice it is called *nafs* (نفس); when purified and refined it is called *rūḥ* (روح). This is the sense intended here: the verse calls it *nafs* in view of what it had previously been. God knows best.

Killing oneself is one of the grave sins; avoidance of the grave sins brings forgiveness of lesser ones

4:31 — Major sins, lesser sins, and nearness to the Divine Presence

Cairo Arabic edition I:495–496

إِنْ تَجْتَنِبُوا كَبائِرَ مَا تُنْهَوْنَ عَنْهُ نُكَفِّرْ عَنْكُمْ سَيِّئاتِكُمْ وَنُدْخِلْكُمْ مُدْخَلاً كَرِيماً

﴿31﴾

If you avoid the major sins you are forbidden, We shall efface your lesser misdeeds and admit you through a noble entrance.

Language · The two forms and senses of mudkhal

I say: *Mudkhal* (مدخل), with ḍamma on the mīm, is a verbal noun (*maṣdar*, مصدر) meaning "causing to enter" (*idkhāl*, إدخال); with fatḥa it denotes the place of entry, although it can also be a verbal noun.

Theology · How the major sins are enumerated—or defined

The Real—majestic is His majesty—says: **“If you avoid the grave sins of what you are forbidden”**, the major sins (*kabāʾir al-dhunūb*, كبائر الذنوب), **“We shall efface your evil deeds”**, that is, your minor sins, **“and admit you through a noble entrance”**: into the Garden, or through an act of admission attended by honor and magnification. There is disagreement about grave sins: are they known by enumerating (*ʿadd*, عد) them or by defining their limit (*ḥadd*, حد)? Some say seven, others seventy, others seven hundred; others again say that every act of disobedience is grave.

The Prophet, blessings and peace upon him, said: **“Avoid the seven destructive sins”** (*al-sabʿ al-mūbiqāt*, السبع الموبقات): associating others with God, sorcery, killing a life without right, taking usury, consuming an orphan’s wealth, fleeing the advance of battle, and slandering chaste, unsuspecting believing women. [R29]

Ibn Juzayy says: “These are undoubtedly among the grave sins, for the Lawgiver expressly named them. Others add matters explicitly called grave sins in hadith: disobedience to parents, false witness, the oath that plunges one into wrongdoing (*al-yamīn al-ghamūs*, اليمين الغموس), fornication, theft, drinking wine, plunder, despair of God’s mercy, feeling secure from God’s plan, refusing a traveler access to water, profaning the Sacred House, tale-bearing, failing to safeguard oneself from urine, embezzlement of communal spoils (*ghulūl*, غلول), violating one’s brother’s reputation, and ruling unjustly.”

Another definition is any offence indicating diminished religious seriousness and weakened religious commitment. Another says outward sins are minor and inward sins are grave. Another says every offence involving another person’s right is grave, while what remains between a servant and God is minor. Its proponents cite a report attributed to the Prophet: “On the Day of Resurrection a caller from within the Throne will proclaim: ‘Community of Aḥmad! God says: As for the claims I had against you, I have granted them to you; claims belonging to others remain, so grant them freely to one another, and enter the Garden.’” [Translator’s note: This report

is weak and is presented as an argument cited by a particular group, not an authenticated foundation for cancelling the rights of injured persons.] [R30] T206 212

Spiritual allusion · the greatest sin is whatever bars the Presence

Everything that drives the servant away from his Lord's Presence is among the greatest grave sins. Whoever avoids it and guards against everything that distracts him from God is admitted by God through a noble entrance: the Presence of witnessing (*ḥaḍrat al-shuhūd*, حضرة الشهود), delight in beholding the Worshipped One, and advancing in the secrets of the Beloved, the All-Loving. Al-Wartajbī says: "Abū Turāb said: God commanded the avoidance of grave sins, and these are corrupt pretensions, false allusions, and the utterance of words without their reality." End of quotation.

After God divided inheritances, some women reportedly wished to have the same portions as men, or two portions because of their greater need. At this point Ibn ʿAjība introduces the following verse, Q 4:32.

4:32 · Allotted gifts, work, and the stations of the friends of God

Cairo I:496–497

وَلا تَتَمَنَّوْا مَا فَضَّلَ اللَّهُ بِهِ بَعْضَكُمْ عَلى بَعْضٍ لِلرِّجالِ نَصِيبٌ مِمَّا اكْتَسَبُوا وَلِلنِّساءِ نَصِيبٌ مِمَّا اكْتَسَبْنَ وَسْئَلُوا اللَّهَ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيماً (32)

> Do not long for what God has given some of you in preference to others. Men have a share of what they have earned, and women have a share of what they have earned. Ask God of His bounty: God has knowledge of everything.

212. Cairo editor, C495.1: Buṭnān al-ʿarsh means from its midst. Alternatively, buṭnān is the plural of baṭn: it means from the interior parts of the Throne. See al-Nihāya.

Outward commentary · Inheritance and the limits of comparison

The Real, majestic is His glory, says: Do not wish for what God has bestowed upon some of you beyond others in inheritance, such as the male receiving twice the female's share. "Men have a share of what they have earned" means what they have received and taken possession of in the division; women too have a share of what they receive from it, whether small or great. Let each be content with what God has allotted to her rather than objecting to the rulings of the Sacred Law. Instead, "ask God of His bounty": He may grant you something other than inheritance. Ibn ʿAbbās explained the verse in this way. [213]

Outward commentary · The reported circumstances of revelation

Mujāhid, however, related that Umm Salama said: "Men go out on military expeditions while we do not. If only we were men, so that we could fight and attain what the men attain." Then the verse was sent down. On this reading, its meaning is: Do not desire the advantages God has assigned to men over women, such as participation in battle and similar matters. Men have the reward of their military striving and other works, and women have the reward of obedience to their husbands, guarding their chastity, and the rest of their works.

Outward commentary · A general teaching about all worldly and religious ranks

The more exact determination (التحقيق) is that the verse is general, embracing every rank in religion and worldly affairs. Wishing for another's allotted rank can lead to envy and hostility; it betrays dissatisfaction with what God has apportioned and a desire to obtain something without seeking its proper means. That is blameworthy. To wish for what has not been decreed for oneself is to challenge the wisdom of the decree (حكمة القدر). To wish for what has been decreed through work while neglecting the work is idleness and the squandering of one's opportunity. To wish for what has been decreed independently of work is a futile loss of effort. Al-Bayḍāwī makes this observation.

213. Cairo editor, C496.1: The shaykh will state below that the verse is general.

Thus men obtain a portion on account of the deeds they perform and the hardships they undergo, and God grants them according to what they earn; women likewise have a portion according to their deeds. There is no benefit in coveting what belongs to others. Ask God of His inexhaustible bounty, and He can give you the like of it or more. “God has knowledge of everything”: He knows what each person merits and favours whom He wills with what He wills, in knowledge and discernment.

The verse is connected to the preceding discussion as follows: abstaining from grave sins is itself God’s grace and favour, and those who avoid them are better off than those who fall into them. One should not merely wish for such a condition without acting; one should ask God of His bounty that He may join one to those He preserves. And through God comes success.

Spiritual allusion · Different degrees of sainthood without disparagement

Degrees of excellence exist among the stations of God’s friends, as they do among the prophets. Yet one should not insist on ranking this saint above that one: the resulting disparagement can lead to backbiting (الغيبة). Distinction may arise through an increase in certainty (اليقين), the soundness of established realization (التمكين), progression through the lights of divine oneness (أنوار التوحيد) and the mysteries of singularization (أسرار التفريد), through guiding others by one’s hand, or through manifest generosity and benefit.

When someone observes that he has not attained the station of another, he should not wish for that precise station. His own degree may be greater in God’s knowledge, or less; such wishing may therefore violate proper comportment (الأدب). The entire good lies in servanthood (العبودية) and contentment with the ordinances of Lordship (الربوبية). The strong have a share of what they have gained through the strength and spiritual struggle (المجاهدة) God created in them as wisdom and grace; the weak have a share of what they have gained by divine allotment and justice. Let all ask of God’s vast bounty, for He knows every thing. He may bestow without apparent means and bring a person to arrival without toil.

Spiritual allusion · Asking, rather than choosing one's portion

A report attributed to the Prophet, blessings and peace upon him, says: "Ask God of His bounty, for God loves to be asked." [R32] Another states: "Whoever does not ask God, He becomes angry with him." [R33] Al-Wartajbī says: "He commands asking and forbids wishing, because asking is confession of poverty (افتقار), while wishing is an act of choosing (اختيار)." End of quotation. God knows best.

He then spoke of the inheritance of an ally, as this had existed at the beginning of Islam.

4:33 · Heirs, contractual alliances, and the inheritance of spiritual guidance

Cairo I:497–498

وَلِكُلٍّ جَعَلْنا مَوالِيَ مِمَّا تَرَكَ الْوالِدانِ وَالْأَقْرَبُونَ وَالَّذِينَ عَقَدَتْ أَيْمانُكُمْ فَآتُوهُمْ نَصِيبَهُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ شَهِيداً (33)

For each [estate] We have appointed heirs from what parents and near relatives leave. And those with whom you have bound your right hands by pledge: give them their due portion. God is witness over everything.

Language · The substitution in kull, and two readings of the syntax

I say: The tanwīn (التنوين) of "each" (كُلٍّ) stands in place of an omitted term (للعوض); "of what was left" (مِمَّا تَرَكَ) explains what that omitted term represents. Thus: "For every property left by parents and relatives, We appointed heirs (مَوَالِيَ)," namely children and agnatic relatives (العصبة), who inherit from that property. On this analysis "the parents" (الوالدان) is the subject (فاعل) of "left."

Alternatively, "the parents" (الوالدان) may be construed as the subject of a nominal sentence (مبتدأ), while the tanwīn stands in for "the deceased person": "For every deceased person We appointed heirs who inherit what that

deceased person leaves”; those heirs are the parents and near relatives. In that case one pauses after “left” (ترك), and “from what” (مما) depends upon an omitted expression (محذوف). “Those with whom your right hands have contracted” (الذين عقدت أيمانكم) is a subject (مبتدأ), and “give them their share” (فآتوهم نصيبهم) its predicate (خبر). The fāʾ (الفاء) enters the predicate because of the generality expressed by the subject.

Legal commentary · Allies, the first inheritance rule, and its reported replacement

The Real, majestic is His glory, says: For every deceased person We have appointed inheritors from what that deceased person leaves, namely parents and near relatives. Or: every estate has its own heirs, who inherit what parents and kin leave.

“As for those with whom your right hands have contracted” (الذين عقدت أيمانكم), these are the allies joined by a pact (موالي الحلف). In the Age of Ignorance they formed compacts of mutual protection and assistance. A man might say to another, “My blood is your blood, my injury your injury, and my vengeance your vengeance.” They would then clasp or strike one another’s hands in concluding the pact; hence the reference to what their “right hands have contracted.” At the beginning of Islam an ally inherited a sixth from his fellow ally; “give them their share” referred to that provision, which was later abrogated (نُسخ).

Legal commentary · Brotherhood between emigrants and helpers; a contrary account

It is also said that the verse came concerning the brotherhood (المؤاخاة) established by the Messenger of God between the Emigrants (المهاجرين) and Helpers (الأنصار): one would inherit a sixth through that bond, until this was abrogated by “Relatives are nearer to one another in God’s Book” [Q 8:75]. According to a report from Abū Ḥanīfa, if a man became Muslim at another man’s hand and the two contracted to bear indemnity and inherit from one another, this was valid and they inherited. Ibn ʿAbbās, however, explained “give them their share” as referring to the support due under their mutual undertaking, which must still be fulfilled; on this interpretation there is no abrogation. The exegetical report of Ibn ʿAbbās has a close transmitted parallel in al-Bukhārī [R34].

“God is witness over everything” warns against transgressing prescribed bounds or breaking undertakings. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The inheritance of walāya and the trust placed in disciples

In every age We have appointed great friends of God who inherit from their teachers the special grace of sainthood (خصوصية الولاية) and the mystery of divine solicitude (سر العناية) until the Resurrection. The earth is never without someone who establishes the proof and discloses the clear way. To those who have bound themselves to you through companionship (الصحبة), whose sincerity and service have become manifest, give a share of the mystery of sainthood and the kindness of divine solicitude that God has specially granted you. “God is witness over everything”: He knows who merits succession (الخلافة) and inherits the mystery of sainthood. God knows best.

He then explains the rationale given for the preference of men over women in inheritance and other matters.

4:34 · Marital responsibility, contested disciplinary reports, and spiritual mastery of the self

Cairo I:498–500

الرِّجالُ قَوَّامُونَ عَلَى النِّساءِ بِما فَضَّلَ اللَّهُ بَعْضَهُمْ عَلى بَعْضٍ وَبِما أَنْفَقُوا مِنْ أَمْوالِهِمْ فَالصَّالِحاتُ قانِتاتٌ حافِظاتٌ لِلْغَيْبِ بِما حَفِظَ اللَّهُ وَاللاَّتِي تَخافُونَ نُشُوزَهُنَّ فَعِظُوهُنَّ وَاهْجُرُوهُنَّ فِي الْمَضاجِعِ وَاضْرِبُوهُنَّ فَإِنْ أَطَعْنَكُمْ فَلا تَبْغُوا عَلَيْهِنَّ سَبِيلاً إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَلِيًّا كَبِيراً (34)

Men are charged with responsibility for women by what God has favoured some of them with over others and by what they spend from their wealth. Upright women are devout, guarding what is unseen as God guards. As for

those whose defiance you fear, admonish them, leave them alone in their beds, and strike them. If they obey you, seek no means against them. God is exalted, great.

Language · The subject al-ṣāliḥāt; causation; a variant reading

I say: “The upright women” (الصالحات) is a subject (مبتدأ), and what follows gives information about it (خبر). The prefixed fāʾ (الفاء) indicates consequence and derivation (السببية والتفريع), as though He were saying: Men are charged with responsibility for women; whoever is upright is to receive the good treatment she deserves, and whoever is recalcitrant is dealt with through admonition and the other measures indicated. Every mā (ما) in the verse is verbal-noun forming (مصدرية), except on Abū Jaʿfar’s reading “by what has safeguarded God [His rights]” (بما حفظ الله), where “God” is in the accusative; here mā is understood as a nominal relative (موصولة اسمية): through that which safeguards God [His rights], namely her obedience to God, by which He in turn protects her. It has also been analysed as a maṣdariyya. Consult al-Thaʿlabī.

Outward commentary · Two grounds of household responsibility in Ibn ʿAjība’s account

The Real, majestic is His glory, says: “Men are charged with responsibility for women”—that is, they stand in relation to them as governors to those in their care with respect to discipline, expenditure and teaching. Ibn ʿAjība describes two grounds for this in the social and legal order he expounds: one bestowed (وهبي) and the other acquired (كسبي). Under the former he places what he considers the greater strength, planning and discernment of men in works and acts of worship, and the historically male offices of prophecy, leadership, public guardianship, certain acts of worship, testimony in judicial proceedings, military obligation, Friday prayer, agnatic inheritance, larger inheritance shares and unilateral pronouncement of divorce. The acquired ground is “what they spend of their wealth” in dowries (المهور), maintenance (النفقة), and clothing.

A husband is therefore obliged to discharge his dealings with his wives justly (بالعدل). An upright woman (صالحة) devoted in obedience (قانتة)—to God and, within the account being given, to her husband—guards in his absence

his household property, her chastity and his confidence. God has preserved her by giving her trustworthiness and constancy and by fixing religion firmly in her heart. Or, because she preserves God's right, God protects her: as the Prophet is quoted as saying, "Be mindful of God and He will guard you." R35

Legal commentary · Reciprocal good treatment, nushūz and its limits

Such a wife, Ibn ʿAjība says, is owed good conduct by her husband: he must respond to her beneficence with equally good care. He cites the report, "The best woman is she who pleases you when you look at her, obeys when you instruct her, and in your absence safeguards you in respect of her property and herself." R36 He says that the Prophet then recited this verse.

Regarding women whose nushūz (نشوز)—rising up in disobedience against the husband—is feared or, on one interpretation, known, Ibn ʿAjība glosses the successive expressions as verbal admonition (وعظ), if that proves ineffective, withdrawal in the sleeping place (هجر في المضاجع), that is not sharing the cover or refraining from intercourse, and, if that too proves ineffective, finally **ḍarb** (ضرب), which he constrains as a blow that is neither painful nor disfiguring (غير مؤلم ولا شائن). He quotes, "Hang the whip where the household can see it" R37, and relates from Asmāʾ daughter of Abū Bakr an account of al-Zubayr striking one of his four wives with a wooden clothes-rack rod until it broke R40. [Translator's note: the latter is a report about al-Zubayr, not a saying attributed here to the Prophet.]

"If they obey you"—or resolve to repent of what has passed—"do not seek a way against them": do not look for a pretext to injure them. Treat any preceding nushūz as though it had not occurred; "one who repents of sin is like one without sin" R38. Ibn ʿUyayna explained that husbands are not to demand that their wives love them. Al-Wartajbī likewise says that when the outward form of compliance occurs, requiring their inward natural dispositions to match one's own would be a quarrel with providence. He cites "There is no changing God's creation" [Q 30:30] and the report "Souls are like enlisted companies" R39.

Finally, “God is exalted, great” is a warning to husbands: He has greater power over you than you possess over those in your care; despite His greatness He overlooks your faults, and you have still stronger reason to pardon theirs. Or the verse teaches that God is too great and exalted to wrong anyone or withhold anyone’s due.

Reports / sources · A reported occasion of revelation—its evidential limits

As the occasion of revelation Ibn ʿAjība relates a story that Saʿd ibn al-Rabīʿ, one of the Medinan representatives, slapped his wife Ḥabība bint Zayd ibn Abī Zuhayr after a dispute. Her father accompanied her to the Messenger of God and said, “I gave him my precious daughter as wife, and he has slapped her!” The Prophet is reported first to have said that she should take equivalent retaliation; they departed, but he called them back and stated that Gabriel had brought the verse “Men are charged with responsibility for women.” He is then reported to have said, “We intended one thing and God intended another; what God intended is better,” whereupon the retaliation was abandoned. A second account attributes the occasion to another similar marital dispute. [Translator’s note: These transmitted narratives are **not verified Prophetic hadith with secure isnāds**; the core story is found in early tafsīr reports, several of which are disconnected.] [R41] God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · The strong wayfarer governs the lower self

Strong men, in the inward meaning, are those who stand firmly over their lower selves (نفوس), mastering them through the strength God enables and through the spiritual struggles (المجاهدات) and disciplines (الرياضات) they expend. They watch and question the self at every moment. If it becomes upright, obeying and yielding to the demands of servanthood (أحكام العبودية) and carrying out the obligations that proceed from Lordship (وظائف الربوبية), they treat it honourably and graciously and release it from severity and chastisement. If it rebels and exalts itself, they train it, remove it from the places of its desires and repose, and impose correction proportionate to its obstinacy and heedlessness.

Ibn ʿAjība then transmits accounts of exceptional ascetic practices: Abū Yazīd, he says, would enter seclusion with a handful of twigs and strike himself when inattentive until he had broken them all; one of the author's companions took a wooden implement into seclusion and struck his own head whenever his attention lapsed, until his whole head was battered. He also relates having been informed of a person who injured his own leg with a knife during distraction. **Ibn ʿAjība himself rejects the excess**, stating: "This is going to extremes (إغراق); the best of matters is their middle course." [Translator's note: these anecdotes are historical claims in the source, not practical instructions to the reader.] Through God comes success.

After addressing the compliant wife and one described as rebellious, he turns to cases in which the matter is disputed or unclear.

4:35 · Two arbiters, reconciliation and the dialogue of soul and spirit

Cairo I:500–501

وَإِنْ خِفْتُمْ شِقاقَ بَيْنِهِما فَابْعَثُوا حَكَماً مِنْ أَهْلِهِ وَحَكَماً مِنْ أَهْلِها إِنْ يُرِيدا إِصْلاحاً يُوَفِّقِ اللَّهُ بَيْنَهُما إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَلِيماً خَبِيراً (35)

If you fear a breach between the two of them, appoint an arbiter from his family and an arbiter from hers. If the two desire reconciliation, God will bring accord between them. God is knowing, fully aware.

Language · Shiqāq, ellipsis and the referents of the pronouns

I say: *Shiqāq* (الشقاق) signifies opposition and conflict. Its annexation to an adverbial expression (إضافة إلى الظرف) is an extension of usage, like "the plotting of the night" (مكر الليل); the underlying wording would be "a rupture between them." The dual pronoun in "if they both desire" (إن يريدا) refers to the two arbiters, whereas that in "He will reconcile between them" (بينهما) refers to husband and wife. Some apply both pronouns to the arbiters; others apply both to the spouses.

Legal commentary · Appointment and powers of the two arbitrators

The Real, majestic is His glory, says: If you, the authorities (الحكام), perceive a dispute between the spouses and cannot tell oppressor from wronged party, appoint two trustworthy men to adjudicate between them, one from his family and one from hers. Relatives generally know their inner circumstances better and are more eager to effect reconciliation. It remains valid if a magistrate appoints two outsiders, and likewise if the spouses themselves appoint the pair.

What the two arbiters agree upon, whether khulʿ (خلع), divorce (طلاق), or accommodation, binds the couple according to the view presented here. Abū Ḥanīfa, by contrast, holds that they cannot effect divorce unless authorized to do so. If the arbiters disagree, nothing binds the spouses and the adjudication must be undertaken afresh. Ibn Juzayy says: “The well-known position in Mālik’s school is that the magistrate appoints the two arbiters, though another opinion assigns that appointment to the spouses. In judicial practice a trustworthy woman is sometimes sent instead of the two arbiters; some scholars called this a change to the Qurʾān and the established sunna.” End of quotation.

Outward commentary · Right intention and divine help in reconciliation

When the two arbiters are appointed and sincerely seek reconciliation, God brings harmony between the spouses through the blessing of their intention. This points to a general principle: whoever makes his intention sound in what he pursues, God makes the goal of his pursuit sound. “God is knowing, fully aware”: He knows outward states and inward thoughts and knows how to lift the estrangement and establish concord.

Spiritual allusion · Fear and longing as arbiters between the lower soul and the spirit

If, spiritual teachers, you fear conflict between the lower soul (النفس) and the spirit (الروح) in a companion—when the soul races towards the lowest depths by following its passion and disobeying its Lord, while the spirit rises towards the highest heights by striving against passion and witnessing

its Master—send powerful inward arrivals of two kinds (واردان): either a disquieting yearning (شوق مقلق) that draws the spirit toward its Master, or an unsettling fear (خوف مزعج) that restrains the lower soul from its passion.

If God intends reform for the servant, He sends both in harmony for the servant's liberation and ascent. Fear comes first, disturbing the soul and curbing it; longing then catches up, so that the servant joins the people of realization (أهل التحقيق) and divine enabling (أهل التوفيق). This is no great matter for God. As a saying in the *Ḥikam* has it: "Nothing drives desire from the heart except a fear that unsettles or a longing that disquiets." [R42] God knows best.

After discussing the preservation of wealth, lineage, and some matters of bodily security, the Real begins to discuss the preservation of religion and what pertains to it.

4:36 · The rights of parents, neighbours and dependants; service as an expression of tawḥīd

Cairo I:501–503

وَاعْبُدُوا اللَّهَ وَلا تُشْرِكُوا بِهِ شَيْئاً وَبِالْوالِدَيْنِ إِحْساناً وَبِذِي الْقُرْبى وَالْيَتامى وَالْمَساكِينِ وَالْجارِ ذِي الْقُرْبى وَالْجارِ الْجُنُبِ وَالصَّاحِبِ بِالْجَنْبِ وَابْنِ السَّبِيلِ وَما مَلَكَتْ أَيْمانُكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ لا يُحِبُّ مَنْ كانَ مُخْتالاً فَخُوراً (36)

Worship God and associate nothing with Him. Show good conduct to parents, relatives, orphans, the poor, the near neighbour, the distant neighbour, the companion at your side, the traveller, and those whom your right hands possess. God does not love anyone who is arrogant and boastful.

Language · Junub and mukhtāl: lexical and morphological explanations

I say: *Junub* (الجُنُب), with ḍamma, means “distant.” One may say junub, ajnab, or ajnabī. A person in a state of major ritual impurity is called *junub*, it is said, because he remains away from the mosque, prayer, and Qurʾānic recitation. *Mukhtāl* (مختال, arrogant or vainglorious) is an active participle (اسم فاعل). Its underlying form is *mukhtayil* (مختيل) from *khuyalāʾ* (الخيلاء), pride.

Outward commentary · The divine rights and kindness to parents and vulnerable people

The Real, majestic is His glory, says: “Worship God”: affirm His oneness (وحّدوه) and obey Him. “Do not associate anything with Him,” openly or covertly, in creed or worship. Ibn ʿAjība gives as an example a person intending pilgrimage and commerce simultaneously: on the rigorous interpretation of purity of intention presented here, such a person mixes another aim into his worship.

“Show kindness to parents” means to honour them and fulfil their claims; to relatives, by blood or in religion; to orphans, on account of the weakness of their state; and to the poor, because of their scarce resources. It is reported that someone complained of a hard heart to the Prophet, who replied, “If you wish your heart to soften, feed the needy, stroke the head of an orphan, and feed him.” [R43] [Source note: The Aḥmad 7576 route located in the source register passes through an unnamed intermediary. This is a limitation of that chain, not a verdict on every parallel. The additional words “and feed him” in Ibn ʿAjība’s quotation are not present in that short Aḥmad wording.]

Outward commentary · Near and distant neighbours and the long catalogue of obligations

“The near neighbour” is one whose dwelling or kinship is close; “the distant neighbour” is one whose place or ancestry is further away. Some defined neighbourhood as extending forty houses in every direction. Ibn ʿAbbās said that the near neighbour is the one connected to you by kin, while the distant neighbour belongs to another group.

When someone asked the Messenger of God about a neighbour's rights, Ibn ʿAjība quotes an extended report: "If he invites you, accept his invitation; if he falls into need, provide for him; if he seeks a loan, lend to him; if good comes to him, congratulate him; if he becomes sick, visit him; if misfortune befalls him, console him; if he dies, attend his funeral. Do not raise your building above his so as to deprive him of the breeze without his permission. Do not distress him with the smell of your cooking unless you give him a portion. If you buy fruit, give some to him; otherwise bring it indoors discreetly, and do not let your child carry it out in sight of his child so as to provoke longing." He then quotes its classification of neighbours according to three, two, or one right: the Muslim neighbour who is also a relative, the Muslim neighbour, and a polytheist neighbour from the People of the Book. R44

Translator's source note. The extended version is transmitted through a route whose narrators Suwayd b. ʿAbd al-ʿAzīz, ʿUthmān b. ʿAṭāʾ and his father are criticized by al-Bayhaqī; al-Dhahabī also identifies weaknesses in this route and a disconnection in a separate Muʿādh version. The shorter report in al-Bukhārī 6014 supports the general duty towards neighbours R47 .

Outward commentary · Companions, spouses, travellers, and historically dependent persons

"The companion at one's side" (الصاحب بالجنب) is anyone accompanying one in a good undertaking: learning, work, a craft, or a journey. ʿAlī interpreted this expression as "the wife"; then the call to excellence towards her is especially emphatic, in addition to the command to associate with her honourably. Someone said: "The first step upon the path of sainthood is to withhold harm and to bear harshness; the test is one's good conduct towards spouse and children." The Prophet is quoted as saying, "The best of you are those best to their wives, and I am the best of you to my wives." R45

"The wayfarer" is a traveller or guest who is a stranger in the place. "Those whom your right hands possess" denotes female and male slaves within historical slaveholding institutions. Ibn ʿAjība adds a last injunction attributed to the Prophet: "Prayer, prayer—and those whom your right hands possess!" R46 [Source note: Ibn Mājah 2698 transmits the last-words frame and the injunction, with "prayer" stated once. Source attribution does not by itself establish the strength of this particular chain or its separate parallels.] "God does not love the arrogant, boastful person": one who disdains

relatives, neighbours and companions and pays no attention to them, and boasts over them about wealth, office, and God's gifts, exposes himself to the withdrawal of those gifts.

Spiritual allusion · Servanthood as poverty, trust and purified intention

"Worship God" means to carry out the functions of servanthood (وظائف العبودية) while witnessing the majesty of Lordship (عظمة الربوبية). Some sages said: "Servanthood is relinquishing personal choice, adhering to humility, and acknowledging need." Another definition gives four components: fulfilment of covenants, preservation of limits, contentment with what is present, and patience concerning what is absent. The mark that gathers these is the purity of the realization of oneness (صفاء التوحيد). Thus "associate nothing with Him" means: do not see any other alongside Him. As a poet said:

"Since I knew the Godhead, I have seen no other; / Indeed, for us any 'other' is ruled out."

Someone else said: "If I were commanded to behold something other than Him, I could not, for there is no other alongside Him for me to witness." Once servanthood is established outwardly and oneness inwardly realized, noble character appears in the servant. He does good to relatives and strangers and gives to them both materially and spiritually, because generosity of soul (الفتوة) is a characteristic of the people of oneness and of spiritual detachment (التجريد). May God benefit us through their remembrance and number us among them. Amen.

Spiritual allusion · Parents and neighbours as metaphors for relationships of spiritual training

Al-Wartajbī explains "parents" as the teachers of divine knowledge. He transmits from al-Junayd: "My father gave me one command and al-Sarrī gave me another. I put al-Sarrī's command before my father's, and everything I have found has come through its blessing." Kin are one's brothers in the spiritual guide. Orphans are those untrained, needy seekers who approach them; the poor are the people of weak certainty among the

generality. God has commanded those granted special realization (أهل الخصوصية) to treat them with beneficence: to confirm them in their path and gather them toward their Lord.

The near neighbour is someone who lives next to you and is joined to you in spiritual affiliation; an additional share of good conduct is owed him. The distant neighbour is an ordinary person living nearby: advise and guide him. The companion at one's side is an ordinary person accompanying you in travel or another affair. The wayfarer is a guest staying with the people of special realization; such a guest has rights of hospitality, material and spiritual. "Those whom your right hands possess" signifies, in the author's social order, the family members, children, and persons under one's care whom one can affect; bring them near to the Presence of the glorious King. Finally, humility and openness towards both the special and the general is demanded by "God does not love the arrogant, boastful." God knows best.

He then describes those who behave in the contrary way.

4:37–39 · Miserliness, ostentation, and sincerity

Cairo I:503–504

الَّذِينَ يَبْخَلُونَ وَيَأْمُرُونَ النَّاسَ بِالْبُخْلِ وَيَكْتُمُونَ ما آتاهُمُ اللَّهُ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ وَأَعْتَدْنا لِلْكافِرِينَ عَذاباً مُهِيناً (37) وَالَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوالَهُمْ رِئاءَ النَّاسِ وَلا يُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَلا بِالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَمَنْ يَكُنِ الشَّيْطانُ لَهُ قَرِيناً فَساءَ قَرِيناً (38) وَماذا عَلَيْهِمْ لَوْ آمَنُوا بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَأَنْفَقُوا مِمَّا رَزَقَهُمُ اللَّهُ وَكانَ اللَّهُ بِهِمْ عَلِيماً (39)

"Those who are miserly, command people to be miserly, and conceal what God has given them of His bounty—and We have prepared for the unbelievers a humiliating punishment. And those who spend their wealth to be seen by people, while believing neither in God nor in the Last Day: whoever has Satan for a companion—what an evil companion! What harm

would there have been to them had they believed in God and the Last Day and spent from what God had provided them? God has always known them well."

Language · Construction (qultu)

"Those who" (*alladhīna*) may be a substitute (*badal*) for "whoever was" (*man kāna*) in the preceding verse; alternatively it is in the accusative of censure (*naṣb ʿalā l-dhamm*) or nominative of censure, with an understood "they are." It may also be an initial subject (*mubtadaʾ*) whose predicate has been omitted: "We shall punish them with a humiliating punishment," or "they deserve every reproach." "And those who spend" is coordinated with the first relative phrase, or begins a further sentence with an omitted predicate: "Satan is their companion." The Arabic noun for miserliness is pronounced both *bukhl* and *bakhal* (with both vowels sounded in the latter form).

Outward commentary · The outward interpretation (yaqūlu l-Ḥaqq)

God—majestic and exalted is He—speaks of those who withhold their wealth from their relatives and neighbours, tell others to be miserly, and conceal the abundance He has given them, making themselves appear poor and needy. Alternatively, they conceal their knowledge of the Prophet's description, God bless him and grant him peace. Such people deserve reproach on every account. "We have prepared for the unbelievers among them a humiliating punishment": one that disgraces and abases them. The passage was revealed concerning Jews who, according to the account cited here, advised the Anṣār not to spend because they feared poverty for them, and concealed the Prophet's description. God places the explicit word "unbelievers" where a pronoun, "them," might have stood; this indicates that one who acts in this way has denied God's blessing, and whoever denies and dishonours His blessing deserves a humiliating punishment.

Those who spend "to be seen by people" seek their praise and fear their blame; they do not believe in God or the Last Day [so as to] seek His good pleasure through their expenditure. [Source and textual note: Al-Bayḍāwī and Abū al-Suʿūd on 4:38 explicitly connect this phrase to belief with *li-yataḥarraw*, "so as to seek": genuine belief would direct expenditure toward God's pleasure. Cairo I:504 instead prints *yataḥarrawna* without

that connective. The bracketed words recover the relation supported by both earlier texts; “His” remains divine, and no assertion that ostentatious spending pleases God is intended. This is a disclosed explanatory supply, not a claim that Cairo prints the connective.] Satan is the companion who does not leave them. He beautifies for them a ruinous attachment to wealth and ostentation (*riyāʾ*) in their works. Ibn ʿAjība says that the ostentatious are joined to the miserly in the warning because they occupy the two opposite extremes of falling short and going too far (*tafrīṭ* and *ifrāṭ*): alike in their ugliness and in provoking blame.

“What harm would there have been to them had they believed in God and the Last Day and spent from what God had provided them?” Had they made their faith sincere and given of what the Generous Bestower had provided, no blame or harmful consequence would attach to them. Al-Bayḍāwī remarks that a person invited to something entailing no harm ought prudently to accept it—how much more when it entails benefits. He also explains the different ordering of belief in this passage and another: here belief is mentioned first to mark specification, there later to give [the reason]. [Textual note: Cairo I:504 attributes *al-taqlīl*, “diminution,” to al-Bayḍāwī. His commentary on 4:39 instead reads *al-taʿlīl*, “giving the reason”: the preceding verse’s unbelief explains the ostentation. The bracketed rendering follows the checked earlier source; the different Cairo word is expressly recorded.] “God has always known them well”: nothing of their deeds or intentions escapes Him.

Spiritual allusion

A Sufi once said, “Among the ugliest of all ugly things is a miserly Sufi.” The Sufis who know God, the elect of His servants, have acquired the qualities opposite to those with which God describes obstinate people. They give generously of themselves and of the divinely bestowed knowledges (*ʿulūm laduniyya*) and holy mysteries (*asrār qudsiyya*) entrusted to them, to those ready to receive them through emptying themselves of vices (*takhliya*) and adorning themselves with virtues (*taḥliya*). They summon people to liberality and noble character, speak of the gifts granted by the Creator, and show themselves rich through God and sufficient with Him against everything else.

When they give their wealth, they give it for God, by God, from God, toward God, seeking His good pleasure. Certainty (*yaqīn*) has overtaken them, and they are established in witnessing (*shuhūd*) the Lord of the worlds. Thus Satan cannot approach their precinct; in either abode they behold only the Sovereign, the Judge. The angels of the Merciful love them; human beings and jinn long for them. May God profit us through love for them and enroll us in their way. Amen.

God now encourages expenditure joined to sincerity, the distinguishing mark of the way of the elect.

4:40 · The smallest good deed and its immeasurable recompense

Cairo I:504–505

إِنَّ اللَّهَ لا يَظْلِمُ مِثْقالَ ذَرَّةٍ وَإِنْ تَكُ حَسَنَةً يُضاعِفْها وَيُؤْتِ مِنْ لَدُنْهُ أَجْراً عَظِيماً (40)

“God does not wrong anyone even by an atom's weight; and if there is a good deed, He multiplies it and grants, from His own presence, a tremendous reward.”

Language · Readings (qultu)

A *dharra* is a tiny red ant; the word is also used for a particle of dust in the air. In the reading in which *ḥasana* (“good deed”) is accusative, it is the predicate of *kāna* (“be”), and the feminine pronoun is accounted for either by this predicate or by the genitive construction “weight of a *dharra*,” which lends feminine agreement to the phrase. In the nominative reading, *kāna* is complete, meaning “exist”; the dropping of its final *nūn* is irregular and likened to the elision of a weak letter. The two verb forms *ḍāʿafa* and *ḍaʿʿafa* both mean “to multiply.”

Outward commentary

God does not wrong anyone by diminishing the reward for an action or increasing the punishment beyond what is deserved, even to the weight of a minute particle. Rather, He recompenses each according to what has been done. If the deed is righteous, however small, its recompense becomes great. He may multiply it tenfold, seven hundredfold, and many times beyond that according to the measure of sincerity. Abū Hurayra is cited as saying that he heard the Prophet, peace be upon him, say: "God gives the believer, for one good deed, two million good deeds," and then recite the verse beginning "God does not wrong anyone by an atom's weight."

"And He grants, from His own presence, a tremendous reward": a great good bestowed as sheer favour and beneficence. Ibn ʿAjība also quotes the Prophet: "God does not wrong a believer regarding a single good deed: he is provided for on account of it in this world and rewarded for it in the Hereafter. The unbeliever receives [the recompense of] his good deed in this world, so when the Day of Resurrection comes there is no good deed left for him."

Spiritual allusion

Just as God neither wrongs those who seek rewards nor fails to multiply the recompense that brings the *ḥūr* and the palaces of Paradise, so He does not diminish the portion of those who seek nearness (*qurb*), presence (*ḥuḍūr*), and the lifting of veils and coverings. For every kind of spiritual striving (*mujāhada*) He multiplies the lights of direct witnessing (*mushāhada*). Whenever they lose so much as a particle of the sensible world (*ḥiss*), He increases their inward meaning (*maʿnā*), indeed by more than its measure, through further witnessing and insight. Every time they subdue the lower soul (*nafs*), even by the measure of a thread, they drink that measure and more of the wine of the Majestic One.

All this, however, is with the companionship (*ṣuḥba*) of the masters of spiritual training (*mashāyikh ahl al-tarbiya*); without it, a person's striving only adds to his veils and distance from the special proximity of God (*khuṣūṣiyya*). God knows best.

God next mentions the place where the true measures of deeds will become manifest.

4:41–42 · Witnesses at the Resurrection

Cairo I:505–506

فَكَيْفَ إِذا جِئْنا مِنْ كُلِّ أُمَّةٍ بِشَهِيدٍ وَجِئْنا بِكَ عَلى هؤُلاءِ شَهِيداً (41)
يَوْمَئِذٍ يَوَدُّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَعَصَوُا الرَّسُولَ لَوْ تُسَوَّى بِهِمُ الْأَرْضُ وَلا
يَكْتُمُونَ اللَّهَ حَدِيثاً (42)

"How will it be when We bring from every community a witness and bring you as witness over these? On that Day those who disbelieved and disobeyed the Messenger will wish that the earth were levelled over them, but they will conceal no statement from God."

Language · Grammar and readings (qultu)

When what follows the interrogative *kayfa* ("how?") forms a complete proposition, it is parsed as a circumstantial accusative (*ḥāl*), as in "How did Zayd come?" When the proposition is incomplete, it is the predicate (*khabar*), as in "How is Zayd?" It is a predicate here: "How will the matter be when ...?" Its form is indeclinable because it contains the sense of interrogation. The governing element of *idhā* ("when") is the meaning implied by the subject or predicate: "How will the matter stand or occur when We bring [the witnesses]?" In the doubled reading *tassawwā*, the original is *tatasawwā*, with "the first assimilated into the second"; in the passive reading *tusawwā*, "the second has been omitted."[T207]

Outward commentary

What will become of the unbelievers and the Jews whom the passage addresses when the Resurrection occurs, when We bring from each community a witness to its good and evil deeds—the prophet sent to that community—and bring you, Muḥammad, as a witness over the people to whom you were sent? Alternatively, you witness the truthfulness of the other witnesses, that they did deliver their messages, through your knowledge of their teachings and because your revealed law gathers together their fundamental principles. It is also said that "these" means the unbelievers

whose circumstances are being questioned, or else the believers, as in “that you may be witnesses over humankind and that the Messenger may be a witness over you” [Q 2:143].

On that Day those who joined unbelief to disobedience will wish the earth were level with them and they became dust, because of the terror confronting them. When the messengers bear witness against them, they will say, “By God, our Lord, we were not idolaters” [Q 6:23]. But their tongues, hands and feet are made to speak of their idolatry and expose them. Not a single statement can be concealed from God: whenever they intend concealment, their own limbs testify to unbelief and disobedience. Another explanation is that the Resurrection has distinct stations: at one there is no speaking, and nothing is heard but a whisper; at another they speak, saying, “By God, our Lord, we were not idolaters,” and so on. This explains the apparently different descriptions of their condition. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion

Remorse is unavoidable for one who dies without having enjoyed the company of the people of special spiritual election (*ahl al-khuṣūṣiyya*), veiled from witnessing the mysteries of divine lordship (*asrār al-rubūbiyya*). The remorse is particularly acute if they compounded this deprivation by rejecting the special station of those people and denouncing them. At the unveiling of their luminous rank and elevated state, they are seen in the company of those brought near, beside the prophets and messengers, whereas the others remain in the station of the People of the Right. The latter are reproached for what they hid of great sins—the sins of hearts and inner consciences. [Textual note: Cairo I:506 prints أسر عليه, with *sīn*, here provisionally rendered as concealment. The familiar أصر عليه would mean “persisted in it.” Ibn ʿAjība himself speaks at I:550, on 4:97–99, of “persistence in diseases of the heart” as among the gravest sins. That parallel strengthens the latter interpretation contextually, but does not attest a different letter in this sentence; the local reading remains unresolved.] That is if they die in Islam; otherwise, Ibn ʿAjība warns, hostility to God's friends can carry the ill omen of a bad ending. God protect us from it.

It has already been stated that those who know God bear witness concerning the scholars, and the scholars concerning the generality of people, while the Prophet, peace be upon him, confirms whoever is in need of confirmation. God knows best.

The exposition turns to prayer, the pillar on which religion rests.

4:43 · Intoxication, major impurity, and dry ablution

Cairo I:506–509

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا تَقْرَبُوا الصَّلاةَ وَأَنْتُمْ سُكارى حَتَّى تَعْلَمُوا ما تَقُولُونَ وَلا جُنُباً إِلاَّ عابِرِي سَبِيلٍ حَتَّى تَغْتَسِلُوا وَإِنْ كُنْتُمْ مَرْضى أَوْ عَلى سَفَرٍ أَوْ جاءَ أَحَدٌ مِنْكُمْ مِنَ الْغائِطِ أَوْ لامَسْتُمُ النِّساءَ فَلَمْ تَجِدُوا ماءً فَتَيَمَّمُوا صَعِيداً طَيِّباً فَامْسَحُوا بِوُجُوهِكُمْ وَأَيْدِيكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَفُوًّا غَفُوراً (43)

"O believers, do not approach the prayer when you are intoxicated, until you know what you are saying; nor in a state of major ritual impurity—save when passing along a way—until you have washed. If you are ill, or travelling, or one of you has come from the privy, or you have touched women, and you find no water, then seek clean earth and wipe your faces and hands with it. God is indeed Pardoning, Forgiving."

Language · Grammar and language (qultu)

"While you are intoxicated" (*wa-antum sukārā*) is a circumstantial clause (*ḥāl*). *Sukārā* is a plural of *sakrān* ("intoxicated"); alternative plural forms are *sakārā*, with initial fatḥa, and *sakrā*, with sukūn on the kāf. "Nor [being] *junub*" is coordinated with the circumstantial phrase. *Junub*, a person in major ritual impurity, is unchanged for singular, dual and plural, masculine and feminine, because it behaves like a verbal noun (*maṣdar*) rather than an ordinary adjective. "Except those passing along a way" is an exception from all the possible circumstances. *Ghāʾiṭ* first meant a low place in the ground and came to mean what is expelled there by a person.

Outward commentary

Do not rise for prayer in a state of drunkenness through wine, overpowering sleep, or profound heedlessness; wait until you know what you say in it and reflect on what you recite. Prayer without presence (*ḥuḍūr*) is empty, and for the elect, Ibn ʿAjība says, it is invalid [in the spiritual sense]. It is related that ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf held a feast and invited several Companions when wine was still permitted. They ate and drank until drunk. When the time for sunset prayer came, one of them led the others but recited "I worship what you worship," omitting the negation. The verse was revealed before wine was prohibited outright; the prohibition subsequently came in Sūrat al-Māʾida.

Nor are you to approach the prayer in a state of *janāba* until you wash, except as travellers without water, as explained by the following words; such a traveller performs *tayammum* and prays despite remaining in major impurity. This, Ibn ʿAjība argues, indicates that *tayammum* does not itself remove the state of ritual impurity. Another interpretation takes "prayer" here to mean its places—the mosques—so a person in *janāba* may pass through a mosque without remaining there. This is attributed to al-Shāfiʿī. Abū Ḥanīfa does not permit passage except when water and the way to it are within the mosque. Mālik does not permit entry or passage at all, except entry after *tayammum*. Thus the instruction is not to approach prayer in major impurity until washing has been performed.

"If you are ill": ill such that water may cause injury, worsen an illness, delay recovery, or cannot be reached. "Or on a journey": travelling and unable to find water. "Or one of you has come from the privy": this includes the need to purify after urination or another cause of minor ritual impurity. "Or you have touched women": according to Mālik's view, when your skin has met theirs with an intention of pleasure or when pleasure occurs. Al-Shāfiʿī holds that skin contact invalidates ablution absolutely, whether intended or not and whether pleasure occurs or not, even with a dead woman. In the view presented here as Abū Ḥanīfa's, intimate contact that produces an erection invalidates it. Ibn ʿAbbās, al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī and Muḥammad ibn al-Ḥasan are reported here as holding that mere touching does not invalidate ablution at all.

The other causes of ritual impurity can be assimilated to touching in this legal discussion. The disjunctive *aw* (“or”) should therefore retain its ordinary force of differentiating situations. On this reading the verse expressly permits a healthy person at home to perform *tayammum* when no water is available. Mālik holds that he need not repeat the prayer; al-Shāfiʿī holds that he prays with *tayammum* and later repeats it; and Abū Ḥanīfa, as represented here, holds that he waits to pray until finding water. Making *aw* mean “and” would abandon the ordinary linguistic meaning without necessity.

The subsequent clause restricts *tayammum* in these conditions to absence of sufficient water or inability to use it. *Fa-tayammamū* means “direct yourselves toward” clean *ṣaʿīd*: something pure that rises to the earth's surface and belongs to its substance. Ibn ʿAjība lists soil (which is preferable), snow, mud, stone, and clods of earth. [Textual note: “mud” renders خضخاض in this purification context; compare the Mālikī *Mudawwana*, I:148, on الطين الخضخاض. The Cairo editor instead glosses the word as a thin black tar used to coat mangy camels. That editorial gloss is distinguished here from the contextual body translation.] He excludes trees, grasses, gold and silver minerals, and substances resembling compounded drugs, such as alum, salt, sulphur, and *ghāsūl* [a cleansing plant], or similar materials. He reports Abū Ḥanīfa as permitting *tayammum* with everything of the earth and things joined to it, naming trees, kohl, orpiment, alum, lime, gypsum and minerals, but excluding sifted particles of gold, silver and lead. Al-Shāfiʿī permits only earth capable of supporting plant growth, interpreting “pure” in this way, and requires dust to adhere to the hand; the others do not make that condition. [214] [215]

“Wipe your faces and your hands.” Mālik takes *yad* (“hand”) here to mean the palm, citing the extent of the hand at which a thief's hand is cut, and therefore regards wiping to the elbows as recommended (*sunna*). Al-Shāfiʿī regards it as obligatory, by analogy with ablution in water. “God is Pardoning, Forgiving”: this is why He has facilitated purification and given the dispensation of *tayammum*.

214. Cairo editor, C507.1: Khaḍkhāḍ is a kind of thin black tar with which mangy camels are coated.

215. Cairo editor, C507.2: Ghāsūl is a plant that grows in the desert.

Spiritual allusion

O believers, do not approach the prayer of the holy divine Presence (*ṣalāt al-ḥaḍra al-qudsiyya*) while drunk with love for this paltry world, until its intoxication has left you and you know what you are saying in your intimate address (*munājāt*) to its Creator. Neither approach in the *janāba* of heedlessness, except for passing thoughts that come only rarely, until you wash with the water of the Unseen (*māʾ al-ghayb*), through which the heart is purified and one who washes with it becomes absent from the vision of created beings (*al-akwān*).

To this is related a poem that al-Shaʿrānī's *Ṭabaqāt* attributes to Ibn al-ʿArabī al-Ḥātimī, although others attribute it—and Ibn ʿAjība considers this more accurate—to al-Junayd:

> Wash for prayer with the water of the Unseen, if you possess a secret;
> otherwise perform *tayammum* with soil or rock.
>
> Set before you an imam whose imam you yourself once were,
> and pray the noon prayer at the beginning of the afternoon.
>
> Such is the prayer of those who know their Lord;
> if you are among them, sprinkle the land with the sea.

That is, if you cannot attain the original purification—absence from created events—turn to outward, perceptible worship. Set the revealed law (*sharīʿa*), or one who bears it through prophetic spiritual training, before you as imam, though before you knew him he once sought you out. Join the noon (*ẓuhr*) of the revealed law to the afternoon (*ʿaṣr*) of spiritual reality (*ḥaqīqa*). This is the prayer of those who know God. If you are among them, pour the ocean of your inner reality over the land of your outward form, so that what lay hidden in the inward secrets appears in the visible outward world.

The same meaning is indicated in the rest of the verse. “If you are ill” with the love of passions (*hawā*), “or travelling” in the haste of worldly occupation, or someone comes from the *ghāʾiṭ* of sensory entanglement (*ḥiss*), or you have touched the formal disciplines (*ʿulūm rasmiyya*) and their imagined forms have become impressed on your hearts, and you find no one to

offer you the water of the Unseen—the pre-eternal wine—then aim at outward works: perhaps they will lead you to inward works. “God is Pardoning, Forgiving.”

In the *Ḥikam* [of Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh] it is asked: “How can a heart shine when the forms of created things are imprinted upon its mirror? How can it journey to God while bound in the chains of its appetites? How can it hope to enter God's Presence without having cleansed itself of the major impurity of its heedlessness? How can it hope to grasp the subtleties of the secrets without repenting of its slips?”

God warns of the hostility of those among the Jews who rejoice on hearing believers make mistakes comparable to the distortion of recitation just mentioned. The warning follows in the next passage.

4:44–45 · Those who purchase error and God's protection

Cairo I:509

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا نَصِيباً مِنَ الْكِتابِ يَشْتَرُونَ الضَّلالَةَ وَيُرِيدُونَ أَنْ تَضِلُّوا السَّبِيلَ (44) وَاللَّهُ أَعْلَمُ بِأَعْدائِكُمْ وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ وَلِيًّا وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ نَصِيراً (45)

“Have you not considered those given a portion of the Book? They purchase error and desire that you should stray from the way. Yet God knows best your enemies; God suffices as protector, and God suffices as helper.”

Language

The preposition *bi-* enters the grammatical subject in *kafā bi-llāhi* (“God suffices”), because the expression also implies “I deem God sufficient as my protector” (*aktafi bi-llāhi wakīlan*).

Outward commentary

Have you not considered, Muḥammad—or anyone who hears—with bodily sight or inward vision the condition of those given a little of the knowledge of the Book, namely the Torah? They are the Jewish scholars whom Ibn ʿAjība has been discussing. They buy error in place of guidance, replacing guidance with error after they had ordinarily been capable of retaining guidance. They wish that you would stray from the road leading to the Real (*al-Ḥaqq*). When they hear of a happening that might divert you from that road they rejoice, for they themselves diverted from it, altered their Book, and substituted other things for its contents; they would like you to become like them.

Take care, then, of what your enemies anticipate from you. God knows them better than you do, and He will suffice you against their designs. Trust Him and place your reliance on Him (*tawakkul*). "God suffices as protector, and God suffices as helper": He will take charge of your affairs and grant you victory over your opponents. From God comes success (*tawfīq*).

Spiritual allusion

Those who denounce the spiritual path (*ahl al-inkār*)—especially if their forebears enjoyed positions of eminence or public recognition—are apt to rejoice when they hear that distress has befallen the people of authentic spiritual connection (*ahl al-nisba*). They would like every one of them to deviate from the path of the Real. But God sees what is secret in them and is sufficient against their might and harm. God suffices as a protector for His friends (*awliyāʾ*) and a helper for His beloved ones. God knows best.

The passage next describes these opponents more specifically, or speaks of a party among them.

4:46 · Distorting words and the necessity of adab

Cairo I:509–510

مِنَ الَّذِينَ هادُوا يُحَرِّفُونَ الْكَلِمَ عَنْ مَواضِعِهِ وَيَقُولُونَ سَمِعْنا وَعَصَيْنا وَاسْمَعْ غَيْرَ مُسْمَعٍ وَراعِنا لَيًّا بِأَلْسِنَتِهِمْ وَطَعْناً فِي الدِّينِ وَلَوْ أَنَّهُمْ قالُوا سَمِعْنا وَأَطَعْنا وَاسْمَعْ وَانْظُرْنا لَكانَ خَيْراً لَهُمْ وَأَقْوَمَ وَلكِنْ لَعَنَهُمُ اللَّهُ بِكُفْرِهِمْ فَلا يُؤْمِنُونَ إِلاَّ قَلِيلاً (46)

"Among those who profess Judaism are some who displace words from their proper settings and say, 'We heard, and we disobeyed'; and 'Hear, without being made to hear'; and 'Rāʿinā'—twisting their tongues and attacking the religion. Had they said, 'We heard and we obeyed,' and 'Hear,' and 'Look upon us,' it would have been better and more upright for them. But God has cursed them for their unbelief, so they believe only a little."

Language

"From those who are Jews" (*min alladhīna hādū*) can be the predicate of an omitted subject—"among them are people who distort"—or can explain the persons described in the previous verse, or can depend on "your enemies."

Outward commentary

Ibn ʿAjība says that among the Jews are people, especially their scholars, who rebel in unbelief and distort the words of the Torah from the places in which God established them. They do so either by removing their wording or by interpreting them inappropriately. He quotes Ibn ʿAbbās: "No one can alter God's words, but they explain them contrary to their true meaning."

When the Messenger, peace be upon him, calls them to the truth, they say, "We heard your statement and disobeyed your command." They say, "Hear us, while not being made to hear": either "We will pay no attention to what you say," or as an imprecation for deafness, "May you not hear!" Alternatively it can outwardly mean "Hear, with nothing unpleasant said to you," as

a hypocritical appearance of courtesy. They also say *rāʿīnā* instead of "look upon us" (*unẓurnā*), intending abuse and ridicule by associating the word with *ruʿūna*—foolishness or boorishness.

The Companions had addressed the Messenger with *rāʿīnā* in the sense "take notice of us," or "attend to us with your heart." The Jews then found in the expression an opportunity to insult him; God prohibited the Companions from using it, while those who mocked continued to use it as an insult. "Twisting their tongues" means turning the word away from the intended meaning of seeking attention to their own suggestion of foolishness; "attacking the religion" means making it an object of ridicule. Had they said "We heard and we obeyed," instead of "We heard and we disobeyed," simply "Hear" instead of "Hear, without being made to hear," and "Look upon us" instead of *rāʿīnā*, their speech would have been better, more just, and more upright. Instead, their unbelief caused them to be driven away from divine mercy. "They believe only a little" signifies a belief of no account: accepting some verses and messengers while rejecting others. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion

By God, no one who has attained success has done so except by *adab*—propriety, reverence, and giving others their due—and honouring what deserves honour. No one who has suffered spiritual loss has done so except through lacking these. Someone said: "Make your actions the salt and your *adab* the flour." The outward manners (*ādāb al-ẓāhir*) reveal the inward manners (*ādāb al-bāṭin*). *Adab* appears in gracious speech, an appropriate answer, excellent actions, and the manifestation of beautiful character. God knows best.

Having described their disobedience, God summons them to belief.

4:47 · Recognising revelation and the dangers of rejection

Cairo I:510–511

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ آمِنُوا بِما نَزَّلْنا مُصَدِّقاً لِما مَعَكُمْ مِنْ قَبْلِ أَنْ نَطْمِسَ وُجُوهاً فَنَرُدَّها عَلى أَدْبارِها أَوْ نَلْعَنَهُمْ كَما لَعَنَّا أَصْحابَ السَّبْتِ وَكانَ أَمْرُ اللَّهِ مَفْعُولاً (47)

"O you who were given the Book, believe in what We have sent down, confirming what is with you, before We obliterate faces and turn them backward, or curse them as We cursed the people of the Sabbath. God's command is always carried out."

Outward commentary

God addresses those of the Jews who possess the Scripture: believe in the Qurʾān We have sent down, which confirms the Torah you possess, before We efface faces, removing their outlines so that eyes, nose and brows no longer remain, and make them resemble the backs of heads. Or He could turn the faces round to the back in this world. Alternatively He could disgrace them by bodily transformation, as happened, according to the interpretation given here, to the people of the Sabbath who were changed into apes and swine. God's command cannot be repelled.

Perhaps the warning was conditional on none of them coming to believe. Or "effacement of faces" can signify the humiliation and abasement that comes over them, and the curse can mean its literal sense: they would be cursed by the Prophet's tongue as others were cursed through David and Jesus son of Mary. Ibn ʿAjība relates that hearing this verse from certain Companions occasioned the conversion of Kaʿb al-Aḥbār in the time of ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb.

He adds that bodily transformation remains possible within this community, citing a report in the *Book of Drinks* in al-Bukhārī. The Prophet says: "There will indeed be people of my community who regard as lawful

illicit sexual intercourse, silk, wine and musical instruments. People will lodge beside a mountain, and someone will come to them in the evening with their grazing herd, asking for something he needs, and they will say, 'Come back tomorrow.' God will destroy them by night and bring the mountain down on them, and He will transform others into apes and swine until the Day of Resurrection."

Spiritual allusion

Bearers of the outward religious law (*ḥamalat al-sharīʿa*) are called to acknowledge the people of inner reality (*ahl al-ḥaqīqa*), since *ḥaqīqa* is the kernel and purified essence of *sharīʿa*. If they refuse to believe in this inward knowledge and submit to its people, God effaces the faces of their hearts, fills them with fear, agitation and love of the world, and turns them backwards. They can no longer understand the secrets of the Book or comprehend the allusions (*ishārāt*) in revelation. If they also fail in the rights of the outward law and alter its rulings, they are transformed into apes and swine.

Ibn ʿAjība cites *Nawādir al-uṣūl*, with its chain to the Prophet: "A small cloud [*qazaʿa*] will arise in my community, and the people will resort to their scholars, only to find them apes and swine." [Textual note: the Cairo editor reports فزعة (with initial *fāʾ*, "a fright" or "an alarm") in the source copies, but prints *qazaʿa* from al-Suyūṭī's *al-Jāmiʿ al-kabīr* and *Kanz al-ʿummāl*, glossing it as a piece of cloud. The translation above preserves that printed reading.] He then quotes al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī: Transformation (*maskh*) is a change of form away from its proper configuration. It befell them because they changed the truth from its proper position and distorted words away from their places. They became transformed in the sight of creatures, while their hearts were [transformed] away from beholding the Real. God changed their outward forms, just as they had changed the truth into falsehood. Here ends the citation. *[Translator's source note: The cited Nawādir al-uṣūl, II:196, principle 150, reads* فمسخوا قلوب الخلق وأعينهم عن رؤية الحق*: "they transformed people's hearts and eyes, turning them away from seeing the truth." The scholars are the agents of this inward distortion, which explains their ensuing outward transformation. Cairo's wording, translated*

above, changes that construction. This comparison identifies a consequential source variant; it does not establish which wording Ibn ʿAjība wrote.] With God lies success. [216]

After calling them to faith, God tells them that if they persist in unbelief they have no claim to forgiveness.

4:48 · The unforgiven association and hidden shirk

Cairo I:511–512

إِنَّ اللَّهَ لاَ يَغْفِرُ أَنْ يُشْرَكَ بِهِ وَيَغْفِرُ مَا دُونَ ذلِكَ لِمَنْ يَشاءُ وَمَنْ يُشْرِكْ بِاللَّهِ فَقَدِ افْتَرى إِثْماً عَظِيماً (48)

"God does not forgive that partners be associated with Him, but He forgives what is less than that for whom He wills. Whoever associates a partner with God has fabricated a tremendous sin."

Outward commentary

God does not forgive the setting-up of partners (*shirk*) beside Him, for He has definitively ruled that its punishment abides. God is jealous in His majesty; none is more jealous than He, as the ḥadīth says. By the custom of rulers, if a subject leaves his own sovereign and supports another, only return or death is accepted; no intercession then benefits him unless he abandons his disloyalty. But God forgives whatever is below *shirk*—grave as well as lesser sins—to whomsoever He wills, whether the sinner has repented or not. Thus disobedient believers who do not repent stand within God's will. "Whoever associates a partner with God has fabricated a tremendous sin": such a person has committed an offence before which other sins seem small. This points to the essential distinction between *shirk* and other sins. God knows best.

216. Cairo editor, C511.1: The source copies read fazʿa [«فزعة»], with fāʾ. The reading printed here is that of al-Suyūṭī's al-Jāmiʿ al-kabīr and Kanz al-ʿummāl. A qazaʿa is a piece of cloud; its plural is qazaʿ. See al-Nihāya fī gharīb al-ḥadīth, under q-z-ʿ.

Spiritual allusion

The Sufis saw that no amount of *shirk*, whether manifest (*jalī*) or hidden (*khafī*), could be excused [in the strict spiritual demand for perfect sincerity]. So they sought to make their sincerity (*ikhlāṣ*) complete and refined their dealings with their Lord. They searched their own hearts to discover whether any love remained for other than their Master or any fear of something below Him. They purified their affirmation of unity (*tawḥīd*) from attributing efficacy (*taʾthīr*) to any created being, turning to God to remove this from them.

Someone related: "I drank milk and developed a swelling, so I said, 'That milk harmed me.' One day, while reciting, I came upon this verse and said, 'My Lord, I associate nothing with You.' Then an unseen caller said to me, 'Not even on the day of the milk?' I hastened to repent." The story is reported here by sense rather than verbatim (*bi-l-maʿnā*). God knows best.

God next reproaches them for claiming purity on their own behalf.

4:49–50 · Self-praise and the discipline of distrust of the nafs

Cairo I:512

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِينَ يُزَكُّونَ أَنْفُسَهُمْ بَلِ اللَّهُ يُزَكِّي مَنْ يَشاءُ وَلا يُظْلَمُونَ فَتِيلاً (49) انْظُرْ كَيْفَ يَفْتَرُونَ عَلَى اللَّهِ الْكَذِبَ وَكَفى بِهِ إِثْماً مُبِيناً (50)

"Have you not considered those who declare themselves pure? Rather, God purifies whom He wills, and they will not be wronged even by a thread. Look how they invent a lie against God! That alone is sufficient as an evident sin."

Outward commentary

God addresses Muḥammad concerning those who praise themselves as pure. Ibn ʿAjība identifies them as Jews who said, “We are God's children and His beloved.” It is also related that a group of them came to the Messenger with their children and asked, “Do these have any sin?” “No,” he answered. They then said, “By God, we are just like them: what we do in the daytime is expiated at night, and what we do at night is expiated by day.” The verse was said to have been revealed about them. Its sense extends to anyone who praises or declares the lower soul pure before truly knowing it.

“Rather, God purifies whom He wills,” for He alone knows the concealed places and hidden stores of souls, and what ugly or beautiful dispositions they contain. He purifies those deserving purification and exposes pretenders. “They are not wronged by a *fatīl*”: the *fatīl* is the fine thread in the cleft of a date-stone, proverbial for something negligible. God does not wrong anyone by an atom's weight. “Look how they invent a lie against God”: by claiming to be God's children or to have guaranteed forgiveness. Such fabrication is sufficient as a plain, manifest sin.

Spiritual allusion

A Sufi said that the lower soul (*nafs*) has as many deficiencies as God has perfections. A servant therefore must not proclaim the purity of the *nafs*, however far its purification has progressed, nor be satisfied with it, however many actions it has performed. Abū Sulaymān al-Dārānī said: “For forty years I have held my own *nafs* suspect.”

In the *Ḥikam* it is said: “The root of every act of disobedience, every heedlessness and every desire is being satisfied with oneself. The root of every obedience, wakefulness and chastity is not being satisfied with oneself. It is better that you accompany an ignorant person dissatisfied with himself than a scholar satisfied with himself. What knowledge does a scholar who is satisfied with himself possess? And what ignorance does an ignorant person dissatisfied with himself possess?”

God rebukes those who prostrated before idols and testified that people of unbelief were better guided than the people of Islam.

4:51–52 · Jibt, ṭāghūt, and the contrast between scholarship and gnosis

Cairo I:513–514

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا نَصِيباً مِنَ الْكِتابِ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِالْجِبْتِ وَالطَّاغُوتِ وَيَقُولُونَ لِلَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا هؤُلاءِ أَهْدى مِنَ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا سَبِيلاً (51) أُولئِكَ الَّذِينَ لَعَنَهُمُ اللَّهُ وَمَنْ يَلْعَنِ اللَّهُ فَلَنْ تَجِدَ لَهُ نَصِيراً (52)

"Have you not considered those given a portion of the Book? They believe in jibt and ṭāghūt , and say of those who disbelieve, 'These are better guided in their way than the believers.' Those are the ones God has cursed; and whomever God curses, you will find no helper for him."

Language · Lexical discussion (qultu)

Jibt originally designated an idol; it was then applied to everything worshipped apart from God. *Ṭāghūt* names any false object of worship or other false authority. Alternatively, *jibt* is sorcery and *ṭāghūt* a sorcerer. Generally it means whatever is worshipped or obeyed in defiance of God. Al-Jawharī says that *jibt* is a name for any idol, transgressor, sorcerer, or one who misguides. *Ṭāghūt* is Satan; in its derivation the original *ṭaghyūt* is built on the *faʿalūt* pattern from *ṭughyān* (transgression), undergoes transposition to *ṭayghūt*, and then changes the *yāʾ* into an *alif*.

Outward commentary

"Have you not considered those granted a portion of the knowledge of the Book"—that is, the scholars of the Jews—"who believe in *jibt* and *ṭāghūt*": they concede the validity of worshipping them. They tell unbelievers that they are more rightly guided than those who believe. Ibn ʿAjība reports that the verse was revealed about Jews who preferred idol worship to the religion proclaimed by Muḥammad. Another account names Ḥuyayy ibn Akhṭab and Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf. After Uḥud they travelled to Mecca with sev-

enty riders, intending an alliance with Quraysh against the Messenger and breaking their earlier agreement with him. Kaʿb stayed with Abū Sufyān, who hosted him generously, and the other Jews stayed in Quraysh's houses.

The Meccans said: “You are people of Scripture, and Muḥammad is a man of Scripture. We cannot know that you are not deceiving us. If you wish us to march with you, prostrate yourselves to these two idols and acknowledge them.” They did so, says the report, and this is what is meant by “They believe in *jibt* and *ṭāghūt*.”

Abū Sufyān then said to Kaʿb: “You read the Scripture and possess knowledge; we are unlettered. Which of us is nearer the truth and better guided: ourselves or Muḥammad?” Kaʿb asked them to describe their religion. Abū Sufyān replied: “We slaughter large, well-fleshed camels for the pilgrims, supply water, honour guests, release captives, maintain kinship bonds, tend the House of our Lord, and circumambulate it; we are the people of the Sacred Precinct. Muḥammad has departed from his ancestors' religion, severed ties of kinship, and departed from the Precinct.” Kaʿb is reported to have answered: “By God, you are better guided.” Thus ends the narrative.

“These are the ones whom God has cursed”: God has removed them far from His mercy. “Whoever God curses will have no helper” against His punishment. Ibn ʿAjība adds that these persons died violent deaths and descended into perdition. He seeks refuge in God.

Spiritual allusion

Al-Wartajbī writes that God reproached people whose knowledge remains merely outward, who chose worldly leadership, rejected the people of sanctity (*ahl al-wilāya*), preferred the fellowship of their opponents, and followed the impulses of their lower souls—their *jibt*—and the tracks of their *ṭāghūt*, Satan. Here ends his statement.

Ibn ʿAjība adds that the reproach extends to those who prefer the outward people (*ahl al-ẓāhir*) to the inward people (*ahl al-bāṭin*) and rank scholars above the friends of God (*awliyāʾ*), saying “These are better guided.” Far from it, he exclaims: the distance between them is like that between earth and heaven. He carefully specifies that the comparison is between knowers of God (*ʿārifūn bi-llāh*) who unite effacement (*fanāʾ*) and subsistence (*baqāʾ*),

on the one side, and scholars and the God-fearing on the other. As for ordinary worshippers, ascetics and righteous people, he has no doubt that God-fearing scholars are superior to them.

He cites the prophetic saying: “The superiority of the scholar over the worshipper is as my superiority over the least of you,” together with other reports favouring the learned. Those who know God, however, are the greatest scholars, because their knowledge concerns God's very Essence through unveiling (*kashf*) and tasting (*dhawq*), whereas the scholars of the outward disciplines know God's rulings. Their attention is dispersed away from God (*mufarraqūn ʿan Allāh*); indeed, he says, they are more veiled from God than others. A saintly person reportedly said: “The people most veiled from God are first the scholars, then the worshippers, then the ascetics,” because delight in their present achievements prevents them from moving beyond them. Ibn ʿAjība refers readers to his earlier discussion of “You were the best community brought forth for humankind” [Q 3:110]. God knows best. [217]

The next verse replies to the claim that political rule will pass to these opponents.

4:53 · Sovereignty, stinginess, and the gifts of the self

Cairo I:514

أَمْ لَهُمْ نَصِيبٌ مِنَ الْمُلْكِ فَإِذاً لا يُؤْتُونَ النَّاسَ نَقِيراً (53)

“Or do they possess a share in the dominion? If so, they would not give people even a speck.”

Language

Am is disconnected (*munqaṭiʿa*), equivalent to “rather,” with the interrogative hamza expressing rejection. It denies the claim—attributed here to Jews—that sovereignty will become theirs. When *idhan* is separated from a present-tense verb by *lā*, both operation and non-operation of the particle

217. Cairo editor, C514.1: See the spiritual allusion on verse 110 of Sūrat Āl ʿImrān.

are allowed; the reading *wa-idhan lā yalbathū* is cited by way of comparison. A *naqīr* is the little pit on the back of a date-stone; it serves here as an image of the smallest possible gift, exposing extreme miserliness.

Outward commentary

Ibn ʿAjība paraphrases the divine reproach: Could they obtain any part of dominion or public authority? Far from it! Such a thing will never happen, he writes in this polemical context. How, he asks, can power be theirs when they are so miserly? Even given a share of sovereignty, they would not bestow a *naqīr* upon other people, let alone something greater. In Ibn ʿAjība's moral argument, political authority and victory depend on generosity, open-handedness, courage, sound judgment and good government: he portrays the people criticized in the verse as lacking these virtues.

Spiritual allusion

God grants strength, victory and the power to act (*taṣarruf*), outwardly or inwardly, only to the generous. One who gives freely of his wealth without being concerned about how much he gives or to whom is enabled to enjoy outward honour and effective action (*taṣarruf ḥissī*). One who gives away his own self and standing (*nafs* and *jāh*) and expends both in pursuit of his Lord's good pleasure is granted spiritual dignity, victory and inward effective action (*taṣarruf maʿnawī*): his spiritual aspiration (*himma*) acts throughout existence, from the Throne to the earth beneath it. His honour and victory endure perpetually. God knows best.

As envy and miserliness are two especially blameworthy vices, the exposition proceeds to reproach envy as well. [218]

218. Cairo editor, C515.1: That is, envy; miserliness was mentioned in the preceding verse.

4:54–57 · Envy, divine favour, fire, and the shelter of contentment

Cairo I:515–517

أَمْ يَحْسُدُونَ النَّاسَ عَلى ما آتاهُمُ اللَّهُ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ فَقَدْ آتَيْنا آلَ إِبْراهِيمَ الْكِتابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَآتَيْناهُمْ مُلْكاً عَظِيماً (54) فَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ آمَنَ بِهِ وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ صَدَّ عَنْهُ وَكَفى بِجَهَنَّمَ سَعِيراً (55) إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا بِآياتِنا سَوْفَ نُصْلِيهِمْ ناراً كُلَّما نَضِجَتْ جُلُودُهُمْ بَدَّلْناهُمْ جُلُوداً غَيْرَها لِيَذُوقُوا الْعَذابَ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَزِيزاً حَكِيماً (56) وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحاتِ سَنُدْخِلُهُمْ جَنَّاتٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ خالِدِينَ فِيها أَبَداً لَهُمْ فِيها أَزْواجٌ مُطَهَّرَةٌ وَنُدْخِلُهُمْ ظِلاً ظَلِيلاً (57)

“Or do they envy people for what God has bestowed upon them of His bounty? We gave the House of Abraham the Book and wisdom, and We bestowed upon them a mighty dominion. Among them are those who believe in him and those who turn away from him; Hell is sufficient as a blazing fire. Those who disbelieve in Our signs—We shall make them enter a fire; whenever their skins are consumed, We shall replace them with other skins so that they may taste the punishment. God is Mighty, Wise. But those who believe and do righteous deeds—We shall admit them to gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding therein for ever. There they shall have purified spouses, and We shall bring them into abundant, sheltering shade.”

Language

The particle *am* here has the force of “rather,” and *saʿīran* (“blazing fire”) is a specification (*tamyīz*).

Outward commentary

In rebuking envy, God says: Do they envy "people"—that is, the Arabs, to whom prophethood has now come after being among the ancestors of those addressed—for the bounty He has given them? The bounty is the manifestation of prophethood among them. Or "people" can mean the Messenger himself, peace be upon him, in whom have been gathered qualities that are separately distributed among other people. According to the story Ibn ʿAjība transmits, his opponents envied him for the prophethood and other favours God had bestowed and said, disparagingly: "He has no concern but women; if he were a prophet, the labour of prophethood would occupy him rather than women."

God contradicts them: "We gave the House of Abraham"—Ibn ʿAjība names Joseph, David and Solomon—"the Book and wisdom," which he here explains as prophethood, "and bestowed upon them a mighty dominion." He then relates numerical claims that David had one hundred women, and Solomon one thousand: three hundred wives married with a dower (*mahīra*) and seven hundred concubines. He reports the Prophet as answering those critics, when the verse descended, by comparing these numbers with his nine wives, after which they fell silent. [Translator's note: The numerical claims belong to reports cited in the commentator's argument; their historical accuracy is unestablished.] [219]

"Among them"—meaning the Jews—"are those who believe in him," namely Muḥammad, such as ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and his companions, and others who turn away from him. Alternatively, the pronouns concern the House of Abraham: some believed in Abraham, others rejected him; just as this did not diminish Abraham's standing, their rejection does not diminish your mission. A third interpretation contrasts earlier people who accepted the Book, wisdom and kingship given to Abraham's family with others who rejected them, as they had rejected Solomon and others. "Hell is sufficient as a blazing fire" for those who reject what any messenger brings. If their punishment is not hastened in the present world, the fire reserved for them is sufficient.

219. Cairo editor, C515.2: See al-Baghawī's commentary.

God then describes the end of those who reject His revealed signs or the signs of His unity. “We shall make them enter fire”: that is, burn and roast them. “Whenever their skins are consumed,” softened and burned, “We replace them with other skins.” Ibn ʿAjība quotes a saying attributed to the Prophet that they are changed a hundred times in an hour. Al-Ḥasan is cited as saying that the fire consumes them seventy thousand times a day; every time it consumes and cooks them, they are told to return and return as they were. Mujāhid is cited as describing worms between skin and flesh, in commotion and growling like wild asses. From Abū Hurayra Ibn ʿAjība transmits the prophetic report: “The thickness of an unbeliever's skin will be forty-two cubits, and his molar tooth like Uḥud.”

The replacement of skins makes the pain endure, by creating other skin in the place of what was consumed. The actual subject of punishment, he observes, is the disobedient soul and not the instrument through which it perceives; therefore he sees no difficulty in this replacement. God is “Mighty”: none can prevent Him from acting as He wills; and “Wise”: He punishes in accordance with His wisdom.

God then contrasts the destiny of the believers. Those who believe and act rightly enter gardens with flowing rivers and abide there for ever; their spouses are purified of everything repellent; and they enjoy a shade that is perpetual, never removed by sunshine and never accompanied by cold. The warning to unbelievers comes first because they are the immediate subject of the discourse, while the believers are mentioned by contrast. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion

Envy (*ḥasad*) is a blameworthy disposition from which only the most truthful (*ṣiddīqūn*) become completely purified. Anyone in whom a trace of envy remains cannot smell the fragrance of true knowing (*maʿrifa*). Had the person known God, there would be no object of envy left to him. The saying goes: “The envious person never rises to leadership” (*al-ḥasūd lā yasūd*). Ibn ʿAjība quotes as a prophetic saying: “Envy consumes good deeds as fire consumes firewood.” Sufyān also reports that it reached him that God says: “The envious person is an enemy of My blessing, dissatisfied with the portion I have divided among My servants.”

Poets have said:

Say to one who envies me: Do you know against whom you have offended in courtesy?
You have offended against God in His act, since you disapprove of what He has given me.
Your recompense from Him is an increase for me, and that you will not obtain what you seek.

And another:

If you envy me, I do not blame you: before my time, those of excellence were envied.
May what is in me and in them remain with each of us; and may the greater number of us die from the anger they feel.

[Translator's note: The poet wishes that his merit and their envy should persist, as al-Fārisī explains in his commentary on the *Ḥamāsa*, p. 224. Al-Marzūqī, *Sharḥ Dīwān al-Ḥamāsa*, I:294, takes "the greater number of us" as the enviers, who are many against one. Another grammatical construal of *aktharunā ghayẓan* is "the one of us most enraged." The wish and the parties' different conditions are clear; the latter construction is not treated here as uniquely determined.]

Enmity born from envy cannot be removed and is not benefited by treatment: the envious person oppresses another yet complains as though oppressed. A poet rightly said:

Every hostility may admit the hope of removal,
except the hostility of one who opposes you out of envy.

And a master of poets said:

The most unjust of God's creatures is one who lies awake in envy
of a person who lies surrounded by His blessings.

And another:

I pity my enviers for all the rancour their breasts contain.
They saw God's handiwork in me: their eyes were in a garden,
while their hearts were in a fire.

A wise person said that the envious inflicts three kinds of injury on himself. First, he accumulates sins, for envy is forbidden. Second, he violates *adab* toward God, since envy is essentially dislike of God's giving blessings to someone else and an objection to the divine act. Third, he suffers pain of heart, recurring distress and sorrow. May God protect us from all this. The envious person remains in the fire of veiling (*nār al-ḥijāb*) and the anguish of accounting (*ghamm al-ḥisāb*). The one purified of envy enters the garden of contentment (*riḍā*) and surrender (*taslīm*) in the neighbourhood of the Beloved: the place of rest and security in both abodes, the "abundant shade" of the verse. God knows best.

Since the order of religion cannot be maintained without struggle (*jihād*), and such struggle cannot be organized without appointing an imam, God turns first to what concerns rulers, and then later speaks of struggle.

4:58 · The trust of government and the trust of spiritual knowledge

Cairo I:517–518

إِنَّ اللَّهَ يَأْمُرُكُمْ أَنْ تُؤَدُّوا الْأَماناتِ إِلى أَهْلِها وَإِذا حَكَمْتُمْ بَيْنَ النَّاسِ أَنْ تَحْكُمُوا بِالْعَدْلِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ نِعِمَّا يَعِظُكُمْ بِهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ سَمِيعاً بَصِيراً

(58)

"God commands you to deliver trusts to those entitled to them and, when you judge between people, to judge justly. Excellent indeed is what God admonishes you with. God has always been All-Hearing, All-Seeing."

Language

In the expression *niʿimmā* ("excellent indeed is what ..."), *mā* may be a specifying accusative (*tamyīz*) or the grammatical subject, while what is specially commended is unexpressed. Thus it is either "excellent is the thing

with which He admonishes you" or "excellent is that with which He admonishes you: namely, this command." The commanded good is the restoration of trusts and equity in adjudication.

Outward commentary · Occasion and scope

Zayd ibn Aslam and Shahr ibn Ḥawshab are cited as saying that the verse concerns rulers. Ibn ʿAjība adds that even if its occasion was ʿUthmān ibn Ṭalḥa, custodian (*sādin*) of the Kaʿba, it is general in scope. The one first addressed is the Messenger, peace be upon him, the foremost of rulers. God commanded him to return the keys to ʿUthmān. Ibn ʿAjība relates that at the conquest of Mecca ʿUthmān had locked the Kaʿba's door and refused to hand over the keys so the Messenger might enter, saying, "Had I known he was God's Messenger, I would not have prevented him." ʿAlī then twisted his arm and took the keys. The Messenger entered and prayed two cycles. When he emerged, al-ʿAbbās requested the keys, so that custody of the Kaʿba (*sidāna*) and the provision of water to pilgrims (*siqāya*) might be combined in him. God commanded that the keys be returned to their holder; the Prophet ordered ʿAlī to return them and apologise. The incident became the occasion of ʿUthmān's embracing Islam, and the guardianship, according to this account, was assigned to his descendants perpetually. [220]

Outward commentary

God commands rulers to restore what has been entrusted to its rightful owners, whether among themselves or among their subjects. They must give redress to the oppressed against the oppressor, until the rights of people are discharged: a loan or debt, a deposit, goods seized by force or theft, or other claims among human beings. They must give *zakāt* to its lawful recipients and distribute the public treasury (*bayt al-māl*) to those entitled to it, neither wronging its beneficiaries nor diverting any of it to an undeserving purpose. They must judge with equity those who are subject to their jurisdiction. "God admonishes you most excellently": His command is indeed excellent advice. God is All-Hearing and All-Seeing: none of their judgments nor any trusts they have concealed can escape Him.

220. Cairo editor, C518.1: That is, he is sent by God.

Spiritual allusion

God likewise commands the teachers of spiritual training (*shuyūkh al-tarbiya*) to hand over the secret (*sirr*) to those *fuqarāʾ* [disciples of the path] entitled to it, when the teachers have become certain of their readiness (*ahliyya*). This occurs when the aspirants have emptied themselves of vices such as envy and pride and have adorned themselves with the virtues: purity of heart, generous souls, good character, and other marks of completeness. Once *takhliya* and *taḥliya* have been realized in them, they become qualified to receive the secrets of lordship (*asrār al-rubūbiyya*), held in trust by the people of special spiritual election. Teachers must also judge justly between the *fuqarāʾ*, extending to each the measure of help appropriate to his truthfulness (*ṣidq*) and service (*khidma*). God knows best.

After commanding rulers to be just and to return trusts, God commands obedience to those rulers.

4:59 · Obedience, juristic reasoning, and the authority of the shaykh

Cairo I:518–520

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا أَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَأَطِيعُوا الرَّسُولَ وَأُولِي الْأَمْرِ مِنْكُمْ فَإِنْ تَنازَعْتُمْ فِي شَيْءٍ فَرُدُّوهُ إِلَى اللَّهِ وَالرَّسُولِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ تُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ ذلِكَ خَيْرٌ وَأَحْسَنُ تَأْوِيلاً (59)

“O believers, obey God, and obey the Messenger, and those entrusted with authority among you. If you dispute about anything, refer it back to God and the Messenger, if you believe in God and the Last Day. That is better and more excellent in its outcome.”

Language · Grammar and principle of interpretation

The governing verb “obey” is repeated before “the Messenger,” marking his independent right to obedience. It is not repeated before “those entrusted with authority,” indicating that there may be among them persons whose

commands are not binding. This is then clarified by "If you dispute about anything," as though the verse said: if they do not act in accordance with the truth, do not obey them in that matter; return the point of disagreement to the judgment of God and His Messenger. Ibn ʿAjība attributes this explanation to al-Ṭībī and promises to elaborate it.

Outward commentary

O believers, obey God in what He commands and forbids, and obey His Messenger likewise. "And those in authority among you" means those who administer your affairs, including just governors such as the caliphs and rulers who followed them. They must be obeyed in commands entailing obedience to God, not in sins, although Ibn ʿAjība makes an exception concerning the fear of civil disorder (*harj*). He adds that if a ruler does not act justly, obedience remains required for fear of sedition (*fitna*), and calls this the sounder position. The Prophet said: "Obedience is only in what is right" (*innamā l-ṭāʿatu fī l-maʿrūf*).

He also quotes a report attributed to Abū Hurayra: "Governors will rule you: the virtuous will govern through their virtue and the wicked through their wickedness. Listen to them and obey them in everything that accords with the truth; pray behind them. If they do well, the benefit is theirs; if they do wrong, it is for you [the merit of your proper conduct] and against them [the sin]."

Another ḥadīth says: "Unless you see manifest unbelief (*kufr bawāḥ*) for which you have a proof from God." [Textual note: Cairo I:519 prints لا أن تروا, whereas the report in *Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī*, nos. 7055–7056, reads إلا أن تروا ("unless you see"). The English follows the latter reading here; the apparent omission in the Cairo print is expressly disclosed.] Ibn ʿAjība glosses this as requiring the removal of such rulers. He further quotes a question which the Cairo text attributes to Abū Wāʾil: "Messenger of God, what if we have rulers who withhold our rights but demand their own?" The Prophet replies: "Listen and obey; they bear the burden entrusted to them, and you bear the burden entrusted to you." [Source note: Muslim 1846a names Salama b. Yazīd al-Juʿfī as the questioner, in a report transmitted through ʿAlqama b. Wāʾil from his father; 1846b explicitly assigns the reply to the Prophet. Al-Thaʿlabī on 4:59 likewise gives ʿAlqama's report from his father, but leaves the questioner unnamed. This earlier tafsīr parallel separates

narrator from questioner and supports Muslim's report structure. Cairo's Abū Wāʾil is retained as its own attribution; the exact origin of that different name is unestablished.]

Jābir ibn ʿAbd Allāh, al-Ḥasan, al-Ḍaḥḥāk and Mujāhid are also reported as holding that *ulū l-amr* signifies the jurists and scholars, people of religion and excellence, who teach the foundations of faith, command what is right and forbid what is wrong. The proof offered is "If they had referred it to the Messenger and to those in authority among them ..." [Q 4:83]. Abū l-Aswad remarked: "Nothing is dearer than knowledge. Kings judge their peoples, and scholars judge kings."

"If you dispute"—whether between yourselves and rulers or amongst yourselves—over the ruling of a matter of religion, and you do not know what its judgment is, "refer it to God," that is, to God's Book, and "the Messenger," either to him during his lifetime or to his *sunna* after his death. If there is no explicit text, one returns it by analogy (*qiyās*). Rules therefore fall into three classes: established by the Book, established by the *sunna*, and established by being referred to both through a valid *qiyās*.

Ibn ʿAjība then cites from Ibrāhīm ibn Yasār a saying attributed to the Prophet: "Act according to the Qurʾān: deem lawful its lawful things, deem unlawful its forbidden things, believe in it, and reject none of it. Whatever is unclear to you, refer to God Most High and to those who possess knowledge after me, so that they may inform you of it." The continuation reads: "Let the Qurʾān and the clarification within it suffice you, for it is an intercessor whose intercession is granted, an accuser whose testimony is accepted, and for every letter of it there is a light on the Day of Resurrection." *[Translator's source note: An earlier close parallel in al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān, III:337, under Q4:59, introduces this report through "Abū al-Malīḥ al-Hudhalī, from Maʿqil ibn Yasār" (أبو المليح الهذلي عن معقل بن يسار). Cairo instead names Ibrāhīm ibn Yasār. The parallel locates the report but does not establish which attribution Ibn ʿAjība wrote or authenticate the transmitted saying.]* [221]

221. Cairo editor, C519.1: Māḥil muṣaddaq means a credible adversary. The meaning is that it intercedes for whoever acts according to its contents, and its testimony against him concerning the faults it reports is believed if he fails to act according to it. See al-Nihāya.

Refer the rulings, then, to God and the Messenger "if you believe in God and the Last Day," for faith itself demands this. Such referral is better for you and "more excellent in *taʾwīl*"—better than applying your own interpretation without reference to revelation, and better in final consequence and issue. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion

For the Sufis, those charged with authority (*ulū l-amr*) are the spiritual masters who know God (*shuyūkh al-tarbiya al-ʿārifūn bi-llāh*). Aspirants (*murīdūn*) are obliged, within the discipline of the path, to obey them in ease and hardship and in everything they instruct. Ibn ʿAjība says that one who objects or asks "Why?" does not prosper, and that for perceptive aspirants a gesture suffices without a fully explicit command.

If a command of rulers conflicts with a command of the shaykhs, the disciple, according to Ibn ʿAjība, gives precedence to the shaykh, except when doing so would occasion a grave public disturbance: the shaykh himself then commands obedience to rulers to avoid disorder affecting the *fuqarāʾ*. Should you, people of the path, dispute about a question of outward law (*sharīʿa*) or the inner way (*ṭarīqa*), refer it to the Book and the *sunna*. Al-Junayd said: "This path of ours is supported by the Book and the *sunna*. Whoever has not read the Qurʾān and learned the ḥadīth is not to be followed in this affair." For each person, the essential portion is what his acts of worship require. God knows best.

God next speaks of those who turn away from His and His Messenger's judgment and consent to judgment by another.

4:60–63 · Appeal to false judgment, repentance, and private admonition

Cairo I:520–522

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِينَ يَزْعُمُونَ أَنَّهُمْ آمَنُوا بِما أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْكَ وَما أُنْزِلَ مِنْ قَبْلِكَ يُرِيدُونَ أَنْ يَتَحاكَمُوا إِلَى الطَّاغُوتِ وَقَدْ أُمِرُوا أَنْ يَكْفُرُوا بِهِ وَيُرِيدُ الشَّيْطانُ أَنْ يُضِلَّهُمْ ضَلالاً بَعِيداً (60) وَإِذا قِيلَ لَهُمْ تَعالَوْا إِلى ما أَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ وَإِلَى الرَّسُولِ رَأَيْتَ الْمُنافِقِينَ يَصُدُّونَ عَنْكَ صُدُوداً (61) فَكَيْفَ إِذا أَصابَتْهُمْ مُصِيبَةٌ بِما قَدَّمَتْ أَيْدِيهِمْ ثُمَّ جاؤُكَ يَحْلِفُونَ بِاللَّهِ إِنْ أَرَدْنا إِلاَّ إِحْساناً وَتَوْفِيقاً (62) أُولئِكَ الَّذِينَ يَعْلَمُ اللَّهُ ما فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ فَأَعْرِضْ عَنْهُمْ وَعِظْهُمْ وَقُلْ لَهُمْ فِي أَنْفُسِهِمْ قَوْلاً بَلِيغاً (63)

“Have you not seen those who claim to believe in what has been sent down to you and what was sent down before you? They wish to take their disputes for judgment to the ṭāghūt , although they were commanded to reject it. Satan wishes to lead them far astray. When they are told, ‘Come to what God has sent down and to the Messenger,’ you see the hypocrites turning resolutely away from you. How, then, when a misfortune strikes them on account of what their own hands have sent ahead, and they come to you swearing by God, ‘We intended nothing but kindness and reconciliation’? Those are the people whose hearts God knows. Turn away from them, admonish them, and address to them words that penetrate their innermost selves.”

Language · Construction (*qultu*)

In “you see the hypocrites” the explicit noun replaces the pronoun one might have expected, “you see them”; it brands them with hypocrisy and censures them for it. *Ṣudūdan* (“turning away”) is either a verbal noun (*maṣdar*) or what the grammarians call an *ism al-maṣdar*, corresponding to

ṣadd; Ibn ʿAjība distinguishes the verbal noun as naming the event or meaning and the *ism al-maṣdar* as naming its perceptible verbal expression. *Yaḥlifūna* ("swearing") is circumstantial (*ḥāl*). The phrase *fī anfusihim* ("within themselves," or "concerning their very selves") is related syntactically to "say." A proposed attachment to *balīghan* ("penetrating") is weak, because a dependent of an attributive expression should not ordinarily precede it, except under a broader allowance for adverbial expressions.

Outward commentary · The outward interpretation (*yaqūlu l-Ḥaqq*)

God—exalted is His majesty—addresses Muḥammad: Have you not observed those hypocrites who merely *claim* faith in the revelation given to you and the books revealed before you? They nevertheless seek the judgment of the *ṭāghūt*: here Ibn ʿAjība identifies him as Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf because of the magnitude of his transgression. The expression includes, by extension, everyone who judges according to falsehood. Yet these people were commanded to disown false authority, believe in God, and accept His judgment. Satan wishes to deflect them from the judgment of God and His Messenger into a remote error.

Ibn ʿAjība then relates an account attributed to Ibn ʿAbbās. A hypocrite and a Jewish man were in dispute. The Jewish litigant proposed that the Prophet decide their case, while the hypocrite proposed Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf. They nevertheless went to the Messenger, who gave judgment in favour of the Jewish man, according to what was right. The hypocrite refused to accept it and proposed that they appeal to ʿUmar. The Jewish man agreed. On hearing that the Messenger had already judged and that the hypocrite rejected the decision, ʿUmar asked the latter whether it was so. When he answered yes, ʿUmar told them to wait, entered his house, took up his sword, and—according to **this transmitted story**—struck off the hypocrite's head, saying, "Thus do I judge one who will not accept God's and His Messenger's judgment." The story associates the descent of the verses with this event and relates that Gabriel described ʿUmar as the one who distinguished truth from falsehood, whence the epithet *al-Fārūq*. [Translator's note: This is an exegetical report, **not** an established ruling or an authorization of private violence.] [Translator's note: Its transmission requires the separate historical scrutiny recorded in the notes.] [222]

222. Cairo editor, C521.1: That is, he died.

When they are summoned to God's revelation and the Messenger, some of these hypocrites avert themselves, refusing his judgment. What will become of them if misfortune strikes them—in the account just recited, the killing of their companion—as a consequence of rejecting the divine decision? They then come asking compensation for their companion, swearing that in going to ʿUmar they wanted only kindness to both litigants and reconciliation between them, so as to settle the dispute. But God knows the hypocrisy within their hearts; alternatively He knows their desire for blood compensation. Their concealment and false oaths cannot avail them before Him. Therefore the Messenger is told neither to accept their excuses nor permit them to obtain what they covet. He is to admonish them and speak to them privately, with words that reach the heart and restrain them from pursuing the claim. Privacy makes advice more effective and easier to accept. Hence the maxim: “Whoever counsels you when you are alone has counselled you; whoever counsels you before people has exposed you to shame.” God knows best.

Spiritual allusion

Whoever has placed himself under the spiritual authority (*wilāya*) of a shaykh of training (*shaykh al-tarbiya*) should, within that relationship, refer his disputes and affairs to him and accept his direction. Ibn ʿAjība criticizes certain *fuqarāʾ* who profess to be under a shaykh's training but then turn to the unjust rulers and judges of their time over worldly affairs and related matters. He says that they have strayed far astray, unless they repent and repair the harm by reconciling the shaykh's heart with them, so that he may mend their fracture. He says that the truthful aspirant will not go to a judge even if all his wealth is lost; if recourse is absolutely unavoidable, he should appoint a representative. [Translator’s note: This states Ibn ʿAjība's demanding counsel on discipleship, not a substitute for legal rights or a general rule barring access to justice.]

If such aspirants experience the calamity of a darkened heart and entanglement in worldly turmoil because they have crossed from their shaykh's ruling to another's, they may come insisting that they intended only to safeguard their property and reconcile with their opponent. The shaykh should refrain from reproach and instead remind them so that they repent. If they do repent, God is Forgiving, Merciful.

The command to obey the Messenger and seek his judgment in all affairs is repeated, combining warning with encouragement.

4:64–68 · Prophetic judgment, inward surrender, and the fruit of obedience

Cairo I:522–524

وَما أَرْسَلْنا مِنْ رَسُولٍ إِلاَّ لِيُطاعَ بِإِذْنِ اللَّهِ وَلَوْ أَنَّهُمْ إِذْ ظَلَمُوا أَنْفُسَهُمْ جاؤُكَ فَاسْتَغْفَرُوا اللَّهَ وَاسْتَغْفَرَ لَهُمُ الرَّسُولُ لَوَجَدُوا اللَّهَ تَوَّاباً رَحِيماً (64) فَلا وَرَبِّكَ لا يُؤْمِنُونَ حَتَّى يُحَكِّمُوكَ فِيما شَجَرَ بَيْنَهُمْ ثُمَّ لا يَجِدُوا فِي أَنْفُسِهِمْ حَرَجاً مِمَّا قَضَيْتَ وَيُسَلِّمُوا تَسْلِيماً (65) وَلَوْ أَنَّا كَتَبْنا عَلَيْهِمْ أَنِ اقْتُلُوا أَنْفُسَكُمْ أَوِ اخْرُجُوا مِنْ دِيارِكُمْ ما فَعَلُوهُ إِلاَّ قَلِيلٌ مِنْهُمْ وَلَوْ أَنَّهُمْ فَعَلُوا ما يُوعَظُونَ بِهِ لَكانَ خَيْراً لَهُمْ وَأَشَدَّ تَثْبِيتاً (66) وَإِذاً لَآتَيْناهُمْ مِنْ لَدُنَّا أَجْراً عَظِيماً (67) وَلَهَدَيْناهُمْ صِراطاً مُسْتَقِيماً (68)

“We have sent no messenger except that he should be obeyed, by God's leave. Had they, when they wronged themselves, come to you and asked God for forgiveness, and had the Messenger asked forgiveness for them, they would have found God Ever-Returning in forgiveness, Merciful. No—by your Lord! They do not believe until they make you judge in whatever has arisen between them, and then find no constriction within themselves concerning your judgment, but surrender in complete surrender. Had We prescribed for them, ‘Kill yourselves’ or ‘Leave your homes,’ none but a few of them would have done it. Had they done what they were admonished to do, it would have been better for them and more firmly established them. Then We would have given them from Our presence a tremendous reward and guided them upon a straight path.”

Language

If *wajada* (“find”) is treated as a verb of cognition, the sense is “they would have known God to be accepting of repentance and merciful.” [Grammatical and textual note: On this analysis *Allāh* is the first object, with acceptance of repentance and mercy predicated of Him. Cairo I:522 instead calls *tawwāban* and *raḥīman* “the two objects” of *wajada*, a faulty formula because it leaves the already expressed first object, *Allāh*, unaccounted for. The explanatory English follows the contrast made explicit by al-Bayḍāwī and al-ʿUkbarī on 4:64; it does not claim to reproduce a corrected Arabic witness.] If *wajada* means to encounter or come upon, *tawwāban* is circumstantial, while *raḥīman* is either substitutive (*badal*) or another circumstance tied to the relevant pronoun.

Outward commentary

From Adam's day to Muḥammad's, God has sent no messenger but that the messenger should be obeyed by His leave and command. Ibn ʿAjība says that one who rejects a messenger's authority and refuses his judgments thereby rejects him. Had the hypocrites come repentantly to the Messenger after wronging themselves by seeking another tribunal and appealing to the *ṭāghūt*, and had they asked God's pardon while the Messenger sought forgiveness on their behalf, they would have experienced God's readiness to receive repentance and His mercy. The verse speaks of “the Messenger” rather than simply “you”—“had you asked forgiveness for them”—to magnify his station, and to indicate that he should receive the apology of sincere penitents, however grave their offence, and intercede for them. That he may intercede in matters of the greatest sins belongs to the dignity of his office.

God then swears by His Lordship that those who refuse the Messenger's judgment do not possess faith in its true sense. They must bring their disputes to him, willingly accept what he rules, and experience neither inward narrowness nor doubt about it; rather their breasts should expand at his decision, for it is truth from God. Their surrender must be outward and inward together.

If they had been charged to kill themselves by way of repentance, as the children of Israel were charged in the episode invoked here—or to risk their lives in striving in God's way—or ordered to abandon their homes, as

Israel was ordered to migrate from Egypt, only a few, the sincerely devoted, would have complied. Abū Bakr is reported to have said that had emigration been enjoined he would have been the first to leave. Thābit ibn Qays ibn Shammās is said to have declared that if the Messenger ordered him to kill himself, he would obey. Similar expressions of resolve are attributed to ʿUmar, ʿAmmār ibn Yāsir, Ibn Masʿūd, and other Companions. When this reached the Prophet, the account reports him saying that some men of his community have faith in their hearts firmer than immovable mountains. Ibn ʿAjība counts them among the "few." [Translator's note: These extraordinary hypothetical declarations belong to the account's rhetorical illustration of obedience; they are not instructions addressed to the reader.]

Concerning the occasion of verse 65, he recounts the dispute of al-Zubayr with Ḥāṭib over irrigation channels in the stony ground (*shirāj al-ḥarra*). They watered date palms from the same supply. The Messenger first said, "Water, Zubayr, then release [the water] to your neighbour." The neighbour retorted that this was because al-Zubayr was the son of the Messenger's paternal aunt. The Prophet then told al-Zubayr to water fully, holding back the flow until it reached the boundary banks (*judur*), and thus to take his complete due. Another report links the verse to the Jewish litigant and hypocrite discussed above, which Ibn ʿAjība judges more fitting to the immediate sequence. [Translator's note: The irrigation report's sound core and Ibn ʿAjība's identification of its other litigant are distinct questions.] [223] [224]

If the people had practised the exhortation to obey the Messenger and accept his judgment, it would have been better for their affairs in this world and the next, firmer for their religion and stronger for their faith; alternatively, it would have secured the reward for their works. In that event God would bestow immense reward from His own presence and guide them on the straight road, leading them to the holy Presence and continual intimacy, opening to them the mysteries of the sciences and treasuries of understanding. Ibn ʿAjība cites the saying ascribed to the Prophet, "Whoever acts according to what he knows, God bequeaths to him knowledge of what he did not know." [Source note: Abū Nuʿaym, *Ḥilyat al-awliyāʾ* X:14–15, explains that a saying transmitted from Jesus through a Successor was mistakenly

223. Cairo editor, C523.1: Shirāj is the plural of shirja, a watercourse running from the ḥarra down to level ground. A ḥarra is land covered with black stones.
224. Cairo editor, C523.2: Jadr is the wall surrounding a cultivated plot, smaller than a jidār [a full wall].

attributed to the Prophet and furnished with a chain. He rejects that chain as a basis for attributing it through Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal. This criticism concerns that attribution and chain; it does not decide the maxim's use by Sufi teachers.] God knows best.

Spiritual allusion

Just as God commanded obedience to His Messenger during his lifetime, He has commanded obedience after the Prophet's passing to his heirs: God-fearing scholars who exercise justice in judgments and the saints who know God and judge through inspired understanding (*waḥy al-ilhām*). The scholars judge for the community at large; the saints judge concerning their particular disciples and those who voluntarily attach themselves to their training. Whoever resists the just decision of learned authorities and feels inward constriction has a trait of hypocrisy. Whoever rejects the direction of the saints withdraws from their circle and from the sphere of their training. For, Ibn ʿAjība says, the judgment of the Messenger and that of his heirs is God's judgment; whoever does not accept God's judgment has departed from the circle of faith.

Faith reaches perfection only when a servant ceases to find constriction in the workings of God's determinations, whether irresistible (*qahriyya*) or prescriptive (*taklīfiyya*), and submits to whatever manifests from eternal power: poverty or wealth, humiliation or honour, withholding or gift, contraction (*qabḍ*) or expansion (*basṭ*), illness or health, and the remaining variations of destiny. To accept them both outwardly and inwardly is to surrender the management (*tadbīr*) of one's affairs and one's self-directed choosing (*ikhtiyār*) to the choice of one's Master, who knows the servant's true good more fully and is more merciful to him than his mother or father. God grants success and guides to the even road.

God next promises the obedient a splendid reward to encourage them in obedience to the Messenger.

4:69–70 · Prophets, truthful ones, martyrs, and the degrees of companionship

Cairo I:524–526

وَمَنْ يُطِعِ اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَأُولئِكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِمْ مِنَ النَّبِيِّينَ وَالصِّدِّيقِينَ وَالشُّهَداءِ وَالصَّالِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُولئِكَ رَفِيقاً (69) ذلِكَ الْفَضْلُ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ عَلِيماً (70)

"Whoever obeys God and the Messenger—those shall be with the ones upon whom God has bestowed favour: the prophets, the utterly truthful, the martyrs, and the righteous. How excellent are they as companions! Such is the favour of God, and God suffices as Knower."

Language

Rafīqan ("as companion") is a specification (*tamyīz*) explaining the commendatory or exclamatory force of *ḥasuna*. The singular is used with reference to several people because the adjective *faʿīl* may be applied to singular and plural alike; alternatively the intention is to commend each of them individually.

Outward commentary

Those who obey God and the Messenger, accept their judgments, carry out their commands and shun their prohibitions, will be among God's most honoured creatures, those upon whom He has bestowed grace. These are the prophets and messengers; the *ṣiddīqūn*, whose truthfulness, affirmation of truth and certainty have become great—identified here with the saints who know God; the martyrs (*shuhadāʾ*) who have died fighting in God's path; and the righteous (*ṣāliḥūn*), including devout scholars and the upright among Muslims generally.

Al-Bayḍāwī, whom Ibn ʿAjība quotes at length, divides them into four groups in correspondence with their stations of knowledge and action, urging everyone not to lag behind. The prophets possess perfection in both knowledge and practice, and pass beyond the attainment of perfection in

themselves to perfecting others. Next come the *ṣiddīqūn*, whose souls rise toward the summit of knowing: at one time ascending by examination of arguments and signs, at another by purification and spiritual exercises, until they perceive things and give account of them as they are. Then come the martyrs, whose ardour for obedience and striving to manifest the truth leads them to offer their very lives to exalt God's word. Finally come the righteous, who devote their years to His obedience and their circumstances to what pleases Him. *[Translator's source note: Bayḍāwī's Anwār al-tanzīl, II:83, under Q4:69, reads* وأموالهم في مرضاته*, "and their wealth to what pleases Him." Cairo instead prints* وأحوالهم*, "and their circumstances," retained above. The cited source therefore differs in meaning at this word; it does not by itself establish Ibn ʿAjība's intended wording.]*

Al-Bayḍāwī offers another classification: those favoured are people who know God, and their knowing occurs either by reaching immediate vision (*ʿiyān*) or while remaining in inference and demonstration (*istidlāl* and *burhān*). Those who behold directly may have, in addition, an intimate nearness analogous to seeing something close at hand: these are the prophets. Or they may be like a person who sees from a distance: these are the *ṣiddīqūn*. Those who remain with proofs may know through decisive demonstrations, and thus are deeply rooted scholars, God's witnesses on earth; or through indications and persuasive reasons in which their souls rest, and thus are the righteous. Here ends the cited discourse.

Ibn ʿAjība raises **two objections**. First, al-Bayḍāwī applies the name *ʿārif*—one possessing realized knowledge—to those who have knowledge through inference, while Sufis reserve it for those who pass beyond mere inference; otherwise the person is an *ʿālim*, a scholar. Second, he locates the *ṣiddīqūn* among those seeing from afar. But, says Ibn ʿAjība, people of self-effacement (*fanā'*) no longer experience remoteness: they have become lost in nearness, to the point that their name and trace are effaced. What distance or separation can remain to the knower? He remarks that this mistake comes from lacking direct taste (*dhawq*), and each discipline has its own masters. He promises further clarification in the *ishāra*.

"How excellent are these companions" in the lofty paradises! Those who accompany them enjoy seeing, visiting and being present with them even when the companions occupy higher degrees. Sharing company need not mean equality of rank. The marginal commentary adds that even one be-

low a prophet's station may have a sort of companionship through nearness to his inward state and unveiling without being veiled from him, though he cannot aspire to the prophet's own degree. It adduces the illumination, intimacy and profit obtained by others when they inwardly perceive him. Ibn ʿAjība transmits a report that those of the higher ranks in Paradise visit the lower, but not the reverse, except that one who visited another for God's sake in this life may visit where he wishes in Paradise. The transmission of this specific report remains to be examined.

He also narrates that Thawbān, the Prophet's freedman, came to him one day with changed countenance and a wasted body. Asked what was wrong, he replied that he was not physically ill: when he could not see the Prophet he felt an overwhelming longing and estrangement until they met again. He then thought of the hereafter and feared that, while the Prophet would be elevated among the prophets, he himself would either enter Paradise on a lower level or not enter it at all, and so might never see him again. The verse "Whoever obeys God and the Messenger…" was then revealed, according to the report.

"This is the favour of God": the expression includes the recompense promised to the obedient and the further gifts of nearness (*qurb*) and presence (*ḥuḍūr*). It is bestowed freely by God. He knows the degrees of works and stations and recompenses each according to his place. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion

Outward, bodily obedience brings sensory companionship in the bodily bliss of Paradise; inward obedience of the heart brings spiritual companionship in spiritual felicity. The one whose companionship remains merely sensory experiences separation (*farq*), while the possessor of inward companionship is gathered in unity (*jamʿ*) and never absent from the Beloved for a moment. These are the *ṣiddīqūn*, the brought-near; above them stand the prophets, below them the martyrs and righteous.

Knowledge of God arises either through the removal of the veil and dispersal of the cloud—the cloud of created effects (*athar*)—and these are the people of direct witnessing (*shuhūd*) and vision (*ʿiyān*); or from behind the veil, where seekers receive their reward beyond the doorway, proceeding from effects to the One who acts (*muʾaththir*) through evidence and demonstration. Those of the first class may attain the direct address of

revelation and sight of the noble angels: these are the prophets and messengers. Others stop short of prophetic revelation, yet receive inspiration (*ilhām*): these are the *ṣiddīqūn*, people of spiritual states and established stations (*aḥwāl* and *maqāmāt*). Both share the station of direct vision, but the expanse of the Presence is immeasurable, and ascent through the mysteries of divine unity has no end. Where the saint's foot comes to rest, the prophet's ascent begins.

Those behind the veil know God either through decisive demonstrations and scriptural evidences: these are the rooted scholars, corresponding in this inner classification to the station of witnesses (*shuhadāʾ*); or through discipline (*riyāḍa*), struggle (*mujāhada*) and repeated extraordinary graces (*karāmāt*): these are the worshippers and renunciants, the station of the righteous. Ordinary Muslims are joined to the latter class, for within each named station are innumerable degrees and lesser stations known fully only to the One who knows them. God knows best.

The discourse now encourages striving in God's way, the immediate subject toward which the preceding directions have been leading.

4:71–74 · Vigilance, the reluctant self, and the struggle for sincerity

Cairo I:526–528

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا خُذُوا حِذْرَكُمْ فَانْفِرُوا ثُباتٍ أَوِ انْفِرُوا جَمِيعاً (71)
وَإِنَّ مِنْكُمْ لَمَنْ لَيُبَطِّئَنَّ فَإِنْ أَصابَتْكُمْ مُصِيبَةٌ قالَ قَدْ أَنْعَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَيَّ إِذْ
لَمْ أَكُنْ مَعَهُمْ شَهِيداً (72) وَلَئِنْ أَصابَكُمْ فَضْلٌ مِنَ اللَّهِ لَيَقُولَنَّ كَأَنْ لَمْ
تَكُنْ بَيْنَكُمْ وَبَيْنَهُ مَوَدَّةٌ يا لَيْتَنِي كُنْتُ مَعَهُمْ فَأَفُوزَ فَوْزاً عَظِيماً (73)
فَلْيُقاتِلْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ الَّذِينَ يَشْرُونَ الْحَياةَ الدُّنْيا بِالْآخِرَةِ وَمَنْ
يُقاتِلْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ فَيُقْتَلْ أَوْ يَغْلِبْ فَسَوْفَ نُؤْتِيهِ أَجْراً عَظِيماً (74)

> “O believers, take your precautions: go forth in detachments or go forth all together. Among you there is certainly one who hangs back; if a calamity befalls you, he says, ‘God has been gracious to me, for I was not there with them to witness it.’ But if favour from God reaches you, he will surely say—as though there had been no affection between you and him—‘Would that I had been with them, so that I might have won a mighty success!’ Let those who sell the life of this world for the hereafter fight in God's way. Whoever fights in God's way and is killed or prevails, We shall give him a tremendous reward.”

Language · (*qultu*)

The words *ḥidhr* and *ḥadhar* (“caution”) are variants, like *shibh* and *shabah*. The verb *baṭuʾa* is intransitive, “to be slow, heavy”; the doubled form *baṭṭaʾa* is transitive, “to delay another.” In *la-man la-yubaṭṭiʾanna* the first *lām* emphasizes the opening of the statement, while the second indicates an oath: “Among you—by God, I swear—is one who will certainly cause delay.” The phrase *ka-an lam yakun baynakum wa-baynahu mawadda* (“as though there had never been any affection between you and him”) is parenthetic between the verb “he will say” and the saying reported, drawing attention to the shallowness of his attachment to the believers.

Outward commentary

God tells believers to prepare themselves for the struggle against their enemies, taking every precaution of equipment and numbers rather than casting themselves to destruction. The text, says Ibn ʿAjība, offers no proof for the view he attributes to the Qadarites, because precaution is one of the causes with which God veils the mysteries of divine power. The Prophet himself was told that nothing would befall the believers except what God had decreed, and the saying “Tie it and place your trust [in God]” brings tranquillity to hearts not yet at rest and gives a practical ordinance to those whose faith is weak. Having prepared, believers may go forth in separate units, expedition following expedition (*thubāt*), or together with the Prophet or their commander.

Among those outwardly counted with Muslims, however, were the hypocrite ʿAbd Allāh ibn Ubayy and others of his kind. Such a person either holds others back from fighting or becomes sluggish and declines to go. If

killing or defeat befalls the believers, he rejoices that God spared him by keeping him away from the battle. If they receive victory and spoils, he regrets not being there, wishing for the wealth and worldly honour they gained. Despite the affection he professes, his conduct is that of an estranged enemy: he waits for calamities to strike them, delights in their adversity, and grieves at their success.

If such a person hangs back or hinders others, the people of genuine faith and sincerity should be the ones to struggle in God's way. They "sell the life of this world for the hereafter," preferring what endures to what passes away. Whoever contends to make God's word uppermost, whether he is killed as a martyr or God grants him victory, receives a mighty reward. Ibn ʿAjība, following al-Bayḍāwī, draws attention to the wording "is killed or prevails": the participant must remain steadfast, honouring himself through martyrdom if it occurs, or honouring the religion through victory. His immediate purpose should not be his own death, but the manifestation of the truth and the honour of the religion.

Spiritual allusion

"O you who believe with the faith of the elect, take precautions against the deceits of your lower souls (*nufūs*), lest they prevent you from reaching the holy Presence. Go forth against them in detachments or together." He adduces the saying that God's hand is with the community, emphasizing the condition of companionship (*ṣuḥba*) in Sufi training. The people of the path say that no one attains success without keeping company with someone who has attained it. A living ego-self does not die while living among egoselves; it dies in the company of those who are themselves dead to selfishness. A fish remains alive while still in the water with other fish, but if removed from its element it quickly dies. Ibn ʿAjība says this image came from his own shaykh.

Within each of you is a self that delays departure toward the sanctity of the Presence. It flees places of hardship and trial, although there, if it understood, lies its true life. When members of the path meet a reversal or a severe manifestation of divine dealing (*taʿarruf*), while that self has escaped it, it congratulates itself on having been spared. If later the people of the path receive divine breaths (*nafaḥāt rabbāniyya*) and the wine-like delights of eternity, it wishes it had joined them and attained their success. Whoever desires victory in reaching the Presence should set his soul to endure what

it dislikes and withhold from it the desires it finds easy. He proceeds in this struggle until he dies or conquers the ego and so obtains mastery over it. A shaykh said that the course of wayfarers ends in victory over their lower selves: when they conquer those selves, they arrive. Burdens and afflictions then depart, and every season becomes a festival.

Ibn ʿAjība cites verses:

> Time becomes obedient to you and humankind your servants;
> live each day of your days as a feast.

And further poetry:

> A secret has appeared to you whose concealment from you endured so long;
> a dawn has gleamed whose darkness you yourself had been.
>
> You are the veil upon the heart, concealing the mystery of its unseen;
> but for you, its seal would never have been impressed upon it.
>
> When you vanish from the heart, the secret settles in it,
> and its tents are pitched above the guarded procession of unveiling.
>
> Then comes a discourse never wearisome to hear,
> lovely to us in its prose and its measured verse.
>
> When the soul hears it, its delight becomes sweet,
> and the afflicted heart is relieved of its consuming passion.

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God next reproves the servants for not rising to the defence of the weak.

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225. Cairo editor, C528.1: Ṭunub, with two ḍammas, is the rope used to secure a tent or something similar.
226. Cairo editor, C528.2: The verses are by Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī. See Īqāẓ al-himam.

4:75 · The oppressed and the spiritual treasures held captive within the self

Cairo I:528–529

وَما لَكُمْ لا تُقاتِلُونَ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَالْمُسْتَضْعَفِينَ مِنَ الرِّجالِ وَالنِّساءِ وَالْوِلْدانِ الَّذِينَ يَقُولُونَ رَبَّنا أَخْرِجْنا مِنْ هذِهِ الْقَرْيَةِ الظَّالِمِ أَهْلُها وَاجْعَلْ لَنا مِنْ لَدُنْكَ وَلِيًّا وَاجْعَلْ لَنا مِنْ لَدُنْكَ نَصِيراً (75)

"What is the matter with you that you do not fight in God's way, and for the oppressed among men, women, and children, who say: 'Our Lord, bring us forth from this town whose inhabitants are unjust. Appoint for us, from Your presence, a protector; and appoint for us, from Your presence, a helper.'"

Language

The interrogative *mā* is the initial nominal subject (*mubtadaʾ*); *lakum* ("with you") is its predicate (*khabar*); "while you do not fight" is a circumstance (*ḥāl*). "The oppressed" (*al-mustaḍʿafīn*) is coordinated with the divine name, in the sense: what has befallen you that you do not struggle in God's way **and** for the deliverance of the oppressed? The adjective *al-ẓālim* ("unjust") qualifies "town" (*qarya*) but stands in the masculine because its grammatical agent is the masculine noun *ahl* ("its inhabitants"). When an active participle is predicated through a noun other than its actual agent it behaves like a verb, agreeing in gender by reference to the agent.

Outward commentary

God asks the Muslims why they do not fight in His way and liberate their weak brothers and sisters left in Mecca. Those people have been detained or captured by enemies and prevented from migrating; they include men, women, and children, bound and tormented in their hands. Al-Bayḍāwī says that naming the children intensifies the appeal and indicates how far the idolaters' wrongdoing reached, even harming children. It also shows

that the oppressed people's prayer was answered because the children joined in it, so that all shared in asking for mercy to descend and for affliction to be averted.

Those oppressed people cry: “Our Lord, bring us forth from this town”—Mecca—“whose inhabitants are unjust” through idolatry and aggression, reaching even women and children. “Appoint for us a protector” who will safeguard us from their harm, and a “helper” to free us from being held back from migration to Your Messenger. God answered by opening a way for some to leave for Medina. For those who remained, He ultimately appointed the greatest protector and helper through the conquest of Mecca granted to His Prophet. The Prophet supported them and placed ʿAttāb ibn Asīd in authority over them. He protected and honoured them until they became honoured members of the city. Such, Ibn ʿAjība says, is God's custom in answering the supplications of people in dire need.

Spiritual allusion

Why, he asks the worshippers—and especially striving aspirants (*murīdūn*)—do you not contend against your own selves on the path of arrival at God, so that you may behold His beauty and radiance, and rescue the secrets concealed within you and the knowledge and lights which the self contains? The “town of corporeal humanity” (*qaryat al-bashariyya*) has captured these treasures, shrouding them beneath the darkness of its appetites, weakening them through layers of heedlessness and the thick veil of sensible appearance (*ḥiss*). Whoever contends against it extracts the jewels of knowledge and spiritual mysteries from their shell.

He cites Ibn al-Bannāʾ's *Mabāḥith*:

> All living souls have ever been knowing,
> endowed with discernment of the things;
> it is bodies that hinder them,
> and souls that pull backward, and Satan.
> Whoever gives them the taste of his struggle
> shows even the one who sat still a breach in ordinary habit.

And another of Ibn al-Bannāʾ's couplets:

> These [knowledges] lie concealed within the souls,
> as kernels lie concealed within branches.

In this allusion, the men are spiritual mysteries and lights (*asrār* and *anwār*); the women are branches of knowledge and remembrances (*ʿulūm* and *adhkār*); and the children are wisdoms born as daughters of reflection (*ḥikam banāt al-afkār*). All are oppressed beneath the coercion of the human self, whose inhabitants are unjust—the regressive souls and tempting devils. Whoever struggles against these obstructing influences makes the sciences and bright lights emerge, frees the spirit from imprisonment within the veil of created beings, and reaches the open space of witnessing and direct vision. God guides to the even path.

Believers are next urged to strive against the allies of Satan.

4:76 · Fighting for God rather than for the *ṭāghūt*: the test of intention

Cairo I:529–530

الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا يُقاتِلُونَ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَالَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا يُقاتِلُونَ فِي سَبِيلِ الطَّاغُوتِ فَقاتِلُوا أَوْلِياءَ الشَّيْطانِ إِنَّ كَيْدَ الشَّيْطانِ كانَ ضَعِيفاً (76)

“Those who believe fight in God's way, while those who disbelieve fight in the way of the ṭāghūt . So fight the allies of Satan; surely Satan's stratagem has always been weak.”

Outward commentary

God praises the sincere believers who fight seeking His good pleasure and to exalt His word. The unbelievers—among the people of Mecca and elsewhere—fight for the *ṭāghūt*, identified here as Satan. Thus the allies of God should resist the allies of Satan and not be overawed by Satan's plans. His device is weak, whereas God's counteraction against unbelievers is powerful and unshakable. The allies of Satan rest their hopes on what is weakest and most frail; the believers have placed their dependence on what is strongest and most enduring.

Spiritual allusion

Everything other than God is a *ṭāghūt*. One whose struggle or other acts aim at God's pleasure and arrival in His Presence, without seeking anything besides Him, belongs to the friends of God (*awliyāʾ Allāh*). One whose fighting or work aims instead at some worldly gain—or even at a self-regarding reward in the hereafter—has left the circle of the elect saintly station and belongs either among believers at large or among those whose allegiance is to Satan, according to his intention. [Translator's note: The description is a searching critique of spiritual motivation, not a declaration that all ordinary hopes for reward amount legally to unbelief.]

Ibn ʿAjība cites the Prophet's saying: "Works are only according to intentions, and each person has only what he intended. So whoever's migration was to God and His Messenger, his migration is to God and His Messenger; and whoever's migration was to a worldly thing he would obtain or a woman he would marry, his migration is to that for which he migrated." He also quotes Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh's *Ḥikam*: "Do not journey from one created being (*kawn*) to another, lest you be like the mill-donkey: it goes on walking while the place it left is the very place to which it comes. Instead journey from created things (*akwān*) to their Originator (*al-Mukawwin*): 'To your Lord is the final destination' [Q 53:42]."

God then reproves those who had sought the imposition of fighting but, when it was prescribed, experienced the human temperament's fear of death.

4:77 · When the command to fight comes: human fear and the smallness of this world

Cairo I:530–531

أَلَمْ تَرَ إِلَى الَّذِينَ قِيلَ لَهُمْ كُفُّوا أَيْدِيَكُمْ وَأَقِيمُوا الصَّلاةَ وَآتُوا الزَّكاةَ فَلَمَّا كُتِبَ عَلَيْهِمُ الْقِتالُ إِذا فَرِيقٌ مِنْهُمْ يَخْشَوْنَ النَّاسَ كَخَشْيَةِ اللَّهِ أَوْ أَشَدَّ خَشْيَةً وَقالُوا رَبَّنا لِمَ كَتَبْتَ عَلَيْنَا الْقِتالَ لَوْلا أَخَّرْتَنا إِلى أَجَلٍ قَرِيبٍ قُلْ مَتاعُ الدُّنْيا قَلِيلٌ وَالْآخِرَةُ خَيْرٌ لِمَنِ اتَّقى وَلا تُظْلَمُونَ فَتِيلاً (77)

"Have you not seen those to whom it was said, 'Hold back your hands; establish prayer and give the prescribed alms'? But when fighting was prescribed for them, suddenly a party among them feared people as they fear God—or more intensely still—and said, 'Our Lord, why have You prescribed fighting for us? If only You had given us respite until a near term!' Say: The enjoyment of this world is little, and the hereafter is better for one who is mindful of God; you will not be wronged so much as the thread of a date-stone."

Language

Aw ashadda ("or more intense") is coordinated with the comparative *kāf* which stands in the place of an implied verbal noun: "a fear like fear of God, or a greater fear." Here the verbal noun is in a genitive construction with its object; the underlying meaning is "as they fear God."

Outward commentary

God points out a group who had eagerly requested that the Prophet make fighting obligatory for them. They had then been told, through the Messenger, to keep their hands from fighting until it was commanded and to occupy themselves with their current duties of prayer and almsgiving. But when battle was actually enjoined, fear entered their hearts. Some now

feared being killed by enemy people as intensely as they feared God's punishment—or more. They inwardly cried out, “Why has fighting been commanded at this very time? Could You not postpone it for a little while, so that we may enjoy our lives, or until our appointed deaths arrive?”

Ibn ʿAjība introduces an interpretive caution: if these verses concern the Companions, it seems to him that the words were **thoughts passing through their hearts**, not objections they pronounced aloud. If they concern hypocrites, however, it is possible they spoke them explicitly. God replies that this world's enjoyment is little, its livelihood abject, and its term near, whereas the hereafter is better and longer-lasting for the one who is God-fearing. They will return to their Master, who will honour their dwelling and give them the full reward of their actions. Not a *fatīl*, the fine fibre or thread of a date-stone, will be subtracted from their reward; nor will their allotted lifespans be diminished whether they fight or remain seated.

Outward commentary · Interpretive continuation

The commentary extends directly into the opening of verse 78, where Ibn ʿAjība supplies both an account of its occasion and the spiritual application of this earlier reproach. The next unit keeps this original textual sequence rather than inventing a separate *ishāra* in verse 77.

4:78 · Death cannot be evaded; good and bad fortune ascribed to the Prophet

Cairo I:530–532

أَيْنَما تَكُونُوا يُدْرِكْكُمُ الْمَوْتُ وَلَوْ كُنْتُمْ فِي بُرُوجٍ مُشَيَّدَةٍ وَإِنْ تُصِبْهُمْ حَسَنَةٌ يَقُولُوا هذِهِ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ وَإِنْ تُصِبْهُمْ سَيِّئَةٌ يَقُولُوا هذِهِ مِنْ عِنْدِكَ قُلْ كُلٌّ مِنْ عِنْدِ اللَّهِ فَمالِ هؤُلاءِ الْقَوْمِ لا يَكادُونَ يَفْقَهُونَ حَدِيثاً (78)

“Wherever you may be, death will overtake you, even if you are inside strongly built towers. If good befalls them, they say, ‘This is from God’; but if ill befalls them, they say, ‘This is from you.’ Say: All is from God. What ails these people, that they hardly understand any discourse?”

Outward commentary · The outward interpretation, continuing 4:77

Death will meet people at the expiration of their appointed terms, even if they fortify themselves in high and defended towers. Since death is unavoidable, the commentary says, dying in God's path is preferable: it is a life after which there is no death. Al-Kalbī reports that the earlier reproach concerned certain Companions, among them ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf, al-Miqdād and Qudāma ibn Maẓʿūn. They suffered mistreatment in Mecca and asked permission to fight, but the Prophet instructed them to restrain their hands until permission came. After the emigration to Medina and the subsequent command, some felt a natural human aversion to fighting, and thoughts of the kind mentioned in the verse passed through their minds. Because they occupied, says Ibn ʿAjība, a place of divine care and closeness, even those thoughts met with rebuke; others further away would have been excused them. Another report says the verses concern believers whose cowardice led them to behave hypocritically and refuse the struggle. Ibn ʿAjība thinks this reading better suits the subsequent reference to those who attribute misfortune to the Prophet. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · , arising from 4:77

Some *fuqarāʾ* strive eagerly for *tajrīd*—stripping away worldly attachments—and combat with their selves before their certainty is fully formed. When they are actually directed to that way and see the battlefields and the fires of slaying egoic desires, and are called to patience under painful things—being criticized, shamed, brought low and reduced to poverty—they grow timid and exhausted and retreat. To them it is said: The world is little; its honoured person is abased, its wealthy person is poor, its great person is insignificant. What God grants as recompense for struggling against oneself is better and more lasting. Not a thread's weight of their striving will be lost. Had they remained patient, they would have arrived in the Presence of their Lord; having retreated in cowardice, their recompense is exclusion from what the people of realized knowing attain.

Ibn ʿAjība quotes Ibn al-Fāriḍ:

> Some exposed themselves to love, then turned aside
> from my health in it, and made excuses.
> They were content with mere wishes and were tried by their own shares;
> they crossed the seas of love in claim—yet never became wet.
> On the night journey they never left their place;
> they did not depart from it upon the road, for they grew weary.

Translator's note: Al-Būrīnī, in his commentary on this poem (*Sharḥ Dīwān Ibn al-Fāriḍ*, II:161–162), explains "my health" as steadfastness in love, and *iʿtallū* as offering reasons for turning away. The verb also means "fell ill," allowing a possible play on health and illness.

Outward commentary · The outward interpretation, concerning the remainder of 4:78

God now reports a saying that exposes the hypocrites. If they encounter prosperity, abundant crops and manifest blessings, they say that these come from God directly. But if they suffer drought, hunger, deaths or killing, they tell the Messenger that this is due to the ill omen of his arrival and the arrival of his Companions. Ibn ʿAjība attributes a similar accusation to some Jews of Medina: since Muḥammad entered the city, they allegedly said, its fruit diminished and prices rose. The commentator answers indignantly that its fruit rather flourished, prices became favourable, its lights shone and its mysteries appeared. The Prophet had prayed for Medina for blessings like those Abraham prayed for Mecca, and several times as much. Ibn ʿAjība says its blessings have continued to arrive, sensible and spiritual, until the Day of Resurrection.

Other peoples used the same language about their prophets: Ṣāliḥ's people claimed an evil omen from him and his companions [Q 27:47], and Pharaoh's people took bad events as omens from Moses and his followers [Q 7:131]. The Qurʾān declares that earlier messengers were subjected to comparable accusations [cf. Q 41:43]. "Say: All is from God": the good comes by His generosity and the adverse by His justice. Those who fail to understand this are reproved as being like cattle, or more straying still; they do not comprehend or ponder the Qurʾānic address. Were they to reflect, they would recognise God as Creator and determiner of everything.

Ibn ʿAjība then distinguishes the metaphysical statement that all is from God from an *adab* of speech: attribute perfections directly to God, but attribute deficiencies to the baleful effects of one's sins. He begins expounding “Whatever good befalls you is from God” and notes that a servant's obedience could never adequately repay even one divine blessing. He cites the Prophet: “None of you will enter Paradise by his deed.” When asked, “Not even you, Messenger of God?” he replied, “Not even I, unless God enfolds me in His mercy.” The remainder of this explanation continues with verse 79 in the next unit.

4:79–80 · Divine causality, the ethics of attribution, and obeying the Messenger

Cairo I:532–534

مَّآ أَصابَكَ مِنْ حَسَنَةٍ فَمِنَ اللَّهِ وَما أَصابَكَ مِنْ سَيِّئَةٍ فَمِنْ نَفْسِكَ وَأَرْسَلْناكَ لِلنَّاسِ رَسُولاً وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ شَهِيداً (79) مَنْ يُطِعِ الرَّسُولَ فَقَدْ أَطاعَ اللَّهَ وَمَنْ تَوَلَّى فَما أَرْسَلْناكَ عَلَيْهِمْ حَفِيظاً (80)

“Whatever good befalls you is from God, and whatever ill befalls you is from yourself. We have sent you to humankind as a messenger; God suffices as witness. Whoever obeys the Messenger has obeyed God; and whoever turns away—We have not sent you to be a keeper over them.”

Outward commentary · The outward interpretation, continuing from 4:78

Whatever adversity (*sayyiʾa*) comes upon a person, says Ibn ʿAjība, is due to his own self: the baleful consequence of sin. He cites a report attributed to the Prophet saying that even a scratch from a stick, a twitching vein, or another minor affliction occurs because of a sin, while God forgives much more. This does not contradict “Say: All is from God” [4:78]. Every event comes from God in the sense of being brought into existence and originated (*ījād* and *ikhtirāʿ*); yet good is His beneficence, whereas the adverse is requital and chastisement. He also attributes to ʿĀʾisha a report that no

Muslim suffers fatigue, illness, the prick of a thorn, or even the snapping of a sandal-strap except through some sin, while God forgives far more. [Translator's note: The specific extensions in these two attributions require comparison with their transmitted witnesses.]

Ibn ʿAjība notes a wording attributed to the codex of Ibn Masʿūd, adding "They said" at the start of "Whatever good befalls you is from God." On that reported reading, the sentence is understood as continuing the speech of the hypocrites. [Translator's note: This is cited as an early exegetical reading, not presented as part of the standard transmitted Qurʾānic text.] Neither this verse nor the preceding, he insists, furnishes an argument for the Muʿtazilites as against his theological account of divine creation. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · , concerning attribution and purification

Ibn ʿAjība mentions the report that only a few escape three traits: taking evil omens (*ṭiyara*), envy (*ḥasad*) and suspicion (*ẓann*). In its cited form the Prophet advises: "If you take an omen, proceed; if you envy, do not transgress; if you suspect, do not investigate [as if it were certainty]." The aspirant must cleanse himself of these habits and purify the drink of his tawḥīd. He sees only his Lord in being, attributing no efficacy to anything besides Him. Seeing a blessing in himself or another, he says, "It is from God." Seeing calamity, he still holds inwardly that it comes by God's decree, as the Qurʾān says, "All is from God," while in speech he courteously attributes deficiency to his own self and passions. The self and Satan, in Ibn ʿAjība's bold image, are the "cloths of the Presence" upon which the stains of decreed contingencies are wiped. "Your Lord creates what He wills and chooses" [Q 28:68]. God knows best.

Language · Grammar, now on the Messenger (*qultu*)

The Exalted One then bears witness to His Messenger's mission, urging reverence for him and obedience to him, and warning against discourtesy toward him such as the hypocrites displayed.

If the prepositional phrase "to humankind" depends on the verb "We sent," the word "messenger" (*rasūlan*) is a confirming circumstantial accusative (*ḥāl muʾakkida*). If it depends instead on "messenger," it is an establishing

circumstance (*ḥāl muʾassisa*) which expresses universality: We sent you **as messenger to all humankind**. “Keeper” (*ḥafīẓan*) is a circumstance of the second-person object-pronoun.

Outward commentary · The outward interpretation, concerning 4:79b–80

God has sent Muḥammad to humankind to teach divine unity and guide people into proper comportment (*adab*). The inward place of tawḥīd is the heart: it recognises action as coming only from God. The outward place of adab is conduct and speech: the servant assigns imperfection to his own self and its cravings. God's testimony to the Messenger's mission suffices without anyone else's endorsement—“God suffices as witness”—a testimony given by clear miracles, decisive demonstrations and transmitted proofs. Once the mission is established, people are bound to obey him. Whoever obeys the Messenger obeys God, for he transmits God's command and does not speak by mere caprice. Ibn ʿAjība reports the saying: “Whoever obeys me has obeyed God; whoever loves me has loved God,” and a polemical anecdote in which hypocrites objected that the Messenger sought to be made a lord like Jesus among Christians. The revelation replied that obedience to him is obedience to God. But the one who turns away is not entrusted to the Messenger as a keeper of every deed and its reckoning: his commission is to convey, whereas the account belongs to God.

Spiritual allusion · , concerning 4:80

As God testified to the mission of His messengers through miracles (*muʿjizāt*), so, says Ibn ʿAjība, He testifies to the sanctity (*wilāya*) of His friends through extraordinary graces (*karāmāt*). The *karāma* that matters to those of realization is the attainment of knowing God (*ʿirfān*) through experience and taste (*dhawq* and *wijdān*), the uprightness of outward and inward conduct, the refinement of character, and the guidance of people through a saint toward the All-Knowing Creator. These, rather than wonders for their own sake, constitute the grace esteemed by the accomplished. Whoever obeys them has obeyed God; to turn away from them is to turn away from knowing God. Whoever loves them has loved God, and whoever hates them has hated God, because they are a light among God’s lights and an eye among God’s eyes: no trace of anything other than God remains in

them. Their footsteps follow the footsteps of the Messenger. Ibn ʿAjība adduces [Q 48:10], “Those who pledge allegiance to you pledge allegiance only to God,” and closes: Understand. God knows best.

The discourse returns to the conduct of hypocrites.

4:81 · Profession of obedience and secret contradiction

Cairo I:534

وَيَقُولُونَ طاعَةٌ فَإِذا بَرَزُوا مِنْ عِنْدِكَ بَيَّتَ طائِفَةٌ مِنْهُمْ غَيْرَ الَّذِي تَقُولُ وَاللَّهُ يَكْتُبُ ما يُبَيِّتُونَ فَأَعْرِضْ عَنْهُمْ وَتَوَكَّلْ عَلَى اللَّهِ وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ وَكِيلاً (81)

“They say, ‘Obedience!’ But when they have gone forth from your presence, a group of them plots by night something other than what you say. God records what they plot at night. So turn away from them, and put your trust in God; God suffices as guardian.”

Language

Ṭāʿa (“obedience”) stands in the nominative as a predicate, its implied subject being “our affair”: “Our business is obedience.” Its underlying form could have been an accusative verbal noun, *ṭāʿatan*, but the nominative suggests permanence and established character. To *bayyata* something is to devise it at night and conceal it inwardly.

Outward commentary

The hypocrites say, when they sit with the Messenger, that their affair is complete obedience to whatever he commands. But once they leave him, a faction arranges matters secretly at night and conceals hypocrisy contrary to its outward declaration of faith and acceptance of obedience. Or they distort and fabricate something different from the command he had given them. God writes down their nocturnal designs in their scrolls and will re-

compense them for them. The Messenger should turn aside from them, pay them no heed and trust in God, who will suffice against their malice. God is enough as trustee (*wakīl*), and will exact a reckoning on his behalf.

Spiritual allusion

Ibn ʿAjība finds an analogous trait among some ordinary people. In the company of people distinguished by spiritual realization they display agreement and obedience; on leaving they secretly prepare criticism and repudiation. The appropriate response is not to struggle with them, but to turn aside and become absent in God from concern over them. God's care and protection will suffice against their harm. God knows best.

The Qurʾān now directs such people to a remedy for the disease of their hearts.

4:82 · Contemplating the Qurʾān and the unveiling of meaning

Cairo I:534–535

أَفَلا يَتَدَبَّرُونَ الْقُرْآنَ وَلَوْ كانَ مِنْ عِنْدِ غَيْرِ اللَّهِ لَوَجَدُوا فِيهِ اخْتِلافاً كَثِيراً (82)

"Will they not contemplate the Qurʾān? Had it been from anyone other than God, they would have found within it much inconsistency."

Outward commentary

Why do these hypocrites not reflect on (*yatadabbarūn*) the Qurʾān—its eloquence and lucidity, the sciences and mysteries contained in its meanings, the wonders of its narratives and accounts, and the concord of its verses and judgments? Attentive study would disclose that such a discourse lies beyond human capacity and is from God, the One, the Overpowering. Had it originated from another than God, its laws and verses would reveal frequent conflict: inequalities of diction, contradictions of meaning, some parts eloquent and others poor, some passages difficult to imitate and oth-

ers easy, some predictions agreeing with subsequent events and others failing, some assertions agreeing with reason and others not. Human discourse, when extended long enough, is bound, as induction shows, to exhibit faults or inconsistencies.

Al-Bayḍāwī adds that the verse may be intended to show that differences among the judgments previously mentioned do not indicate contradictory legislation; they arise from differences in circumstances, with their respective purposes of wisdom (*ḥikam*) and benefits (*maṣāliḥ*). Ibn Juzayy says that if someone encounters a troubling question and supposes some disagreement exists within the Qurʾān, he should first suspect his own reading, consult people of knowledge and examine their works until he understands that the appearance is not an actual contradiction. Here end the cited observations.

Spiritual allusion

The capacity to ponder the Qurʾān corresponds to the cleanness of the heart (*ṣafāʾ al-janān*). In the measure that the heart is purified of love of the world and passionate inclination (*hawā*), the mysteries of the Lord's speech are disclosed within it. In the measure that images of created things accumulate upon the heart's mirror, the deeper significations of the Qurʾān are hidden from it—even if its possessor is among the greatest experts in the Arabic language. Because the Qurʾān is a medicine for diseased hearts, the hypocrites are commanded to contemplate its meanings in the hope that their disease may be uprooted. Yet the locks upon their hearts have kept them from understanding the speech of the Knower of all unseen things.

Only people of *tajrīd*, whose hearts have been emptied of other-than-God (*aghyār*) and cleansed of clouding impurities (*akdār*), who have plunged into the streaming seas of divine unity (*tawḥīd*), taste the sweetness of God's words. First they enjoy the sweetness of the speech (*kalām*); then they enjoy the sweetness of witnessing the One who speaks (*al-Mutakallim*). God knows best.

Among the blameworthy acts of the hypocrites is the disclosure of the believers' secrets.

4:83 · News, *istinbāṭ*, the guarding of secrets, and the complementarity of knowledge

Cairo I:535–538

وَإِذا جاءَهُمْ أَمْرٌ مِنَ الْأَمْنِ أَوِ الْخَوْفِ أَذاعُوا بِهِ وَلَوْ رَدُّوهُ إِلَى الرَّسُولِ وَإِلى أُولِي الْأَمْرِ مِنْهُمْ لَعَلِمَهُ الَّذِينَ يَسْتَنْبِطُونَهُ مِنْهُمْ وَلَوْلا فَضْلُ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ وَرَحْمَتُهُ لاتَّبَعْتُمُ الشَّيْطانَ إِلاَّ قَلِيلاً (83)

"When news concerning safety or fear comes to them, they broadcast it. Had they referred it to the Messenger and to those entrusted with authority among them, those capable of drawing it out from among them would have known it. Were it not for God's bounty toward you and His mercy, you would have followed Satan, except for a few."

Language · Construction (*qultu*)

Istinbaṭa means to extract or draw something out of another thing. The underlying image is taking out *nabaṭ*—water issuing from a well when it is first dug. The phrase "from among them" (*minhum*) may explain the relative pronoun: "those who could extract it, namely the holders of authority." Alternatively it depends on "would have known": the people who draw the information out for others would have known it *from the holders of authority*.

Outward commentary · The outward interpretation: broadcasting without discernment

God censures hypocrites, or weaker Muslims, who receive news of military detachments that have gone out on campaigns: tidings of victory, booty and safety, or of danger, killing and defeat. Immediately they publicize the information, spreading alarming rumours before it has reached the Messenger and the senior Companions. These people of discernment (*ahl al-baṣāʾir*), who are holders of authority (*ulū l-amr*), know when and how such matters should be communicated. Had the news-bearers reported it privately to the Prophet, or kept silence until it came to him, or referred it

to the senior Companions, those capable of drawing its real significance from the reports would have known what to convey. They would have communicated it in its proper form, without spreading rumour or frightening people. Alternatively the verse means that these competent authorities would first establish its meaning and only then tell the public, so that neither intimidation nor lack of propriety would result.

There is another possible reference. News may come from heavenly revelation, bearing warning or reassurance, and be circulated before the Prophet himself has announced it. Had people kept silent and left it to the Messenger to proclaim, and to the leading Companions to explain, those able to derive its meaning from its source—the Messenger and his senior companions—would have known and communicated it properly. Ibn ʿAjība offers the incident of ʿUmar: on hearing that the Prophet had divorced his wives, he entered and asked, "Have you divorced your wives?" The Prophet replied, "No." ʿUmar then stood at the mosque entrance and announced that the Messenger had **not** divorced them. He connected the revelation of this verse to that event and said, "I was the one who drew it out (*istanbaṭtuhu*)." God knows best.

Translator's source note: The central first-person narrative, including the direct question, public announcement and connection with 4:83, is preserved in Muslim 1479a. This source identification is an editorial observation.

Spiritual allusion · the grave of secrets

The sages say, "The hearts of free people are the graves of secrets" (*qulūb al-aḥrār qubūr al-asrār*). The fault reproved here is widespread: some people, hearing something favourable or unfavourable, hasten to disclose it—especially when the story touches those affiliated with a spiritual way (*ahl al-nisba*) or those specially favoured (*ahl al-khuṣūṣiyya*). It may also arise among the *fuqarāʾ*. Ibn ʿAjība calls it heedlessness and a needless curiosity (*fuḍūl*). The truthful *faqīr* does not occupy himself with the passing reports of his time or with its people. He has left the people to whatever occupies them; absence in God may become so powerful that even the days pass beyond his notice. Someone who continually listens out for news and hunts it down possesses only the name of spiritual poverty without its reality.

Some *fuqarāʾ*, he continues, bring their brothers' defects to the ears of their shaykhs, which can lead to expulsion from their company—God protect us. He quotes the Prophet as saying, "Do not bring me reports of the bad acts of

my Companions," because such news grieves the hearer. There is great good in bringing joy to the hearts of spiritual teachers. [Source note: Al-Tirmidhī 3896 transmits a longer report from Ibn Masʿūd containing the request, calls his route *gharīb*, and notes an additional intermediary in al-Walīd b. Abī Thawr's transmission. Cairo's "Do not bring me reports of the bad acts of my Companions" is an abbreviated wording.] [227]

The verse applies also to those who expose secrets of divine lordship (*asrār al-rubūbiyya*) and disclose to the *fuqarāʾ* matters of the inner reality (*ḥaqīqa*). It is better to refer the matter to the shaykh and let him disclose it. When *ḥaqīqa* is received from a teacher, a profound secret accompanies that transmission; this is not the case when it comes from someone else, except where that person has received the teacher's authorization (*idhn*), so that he acts, as it were, in his place. God knows best.

Al-Wartajbī, al-Kharrāz, and knowledge beyond the formulated report. Ibn ʿAjība then quotes Rūzbihān al-Wartajbī, who quotes Abū Saʿīd al-Kharrāz: God has servants upon whom a defect or disturbance enters; without it they would become spoiled and remain idle. They have reached an extreme degree in knowledge and arrived at knowledge of what is not formulated in a revealed book or transmitted account (*ʿilm al-majhūl*), but discerning knowers can still argue for it from the Book and sunna through subtle derivation (*ḥusn al-istinbāṭ*) and realized understanding. Al-Kharrāz invokes "those who draw it out among them would know it" [4:83].

Ibn ʿAjība comments upon this as follows. God has occupied the scholars of outward learning (*ʿulamāʾ al-ẓāhir*) with establishing the science of differentiation (*ʿilm al-farq*). Without that occupation they would become idle, for, in his characterization, they do not possess the ability to practise the inward work of hearts—reflection (*fikra*) and contemplative looking (*naẓra*). Yet the knowers recognise and justify their undertaking by the scriptural rewards attached to teaching and disseminating knowledge. These scholars maintain the ordering of the science of wisdom (*ʿilm al-ḥikma*) and keep the banner of the *sharīʿa* upright. Were they not to do it,

227. Cairo editor, C536.1: I have not found the report in this wording. The following is related from him, God bless him and grant him peace: "Let none of my Companions convey anything about anyone to me, for I like to come out to you with an untroubled heart." Abū Dāwūd records it in the Book of Conduct, chapter on conveying reports from a gathering, and al-Tirmidhī in the Book of Merits, chapter on the merits of the Prophet's wives, from the report of Ibn Masʿūd.

the people of inward knowing would have to perform that task, and their hearts would become disturbed by it. Ibn ʿAjība recalls the approximate words of the teacher of his teachers, Sīdī ʿAlī al-Jamal al-ʿImrānī: "May God reward them on our behalf with goodness! They have held high for us the banner of the *sharīʿa*. We plunge into the sea, and then raise our heads and see that the banner is still standing, then return to the sea." He expressly says that he reports the sense, not a verbatim quotation. God knows best.

Guidance belongs to God. He establishes some in differentiation (*farq*) and guides others into gathered unity (*jamʿ*).

Outward commentary · God's bounty and those guided before the mission

"Were it not for God's bounty…" If God had not bestowed upon the community the Prophet of mercy, rescuing people from the pursuit of Satan and the worship of idols, they would have remained in unbelief and wandering and continued following Satan in unbelief and sin. The exception, in one outward explanation, concerns a small number who found guidance before the prophetic mission: Quss ibn Sāʿida, Zayd ibn Nufayl and Waraqa ibn Nawfal. God endowed them with exceptional understanding, so they reasoned and reflected until they recognised God and kept apart from what their families worshipped. Ibn ʿAjība relates that Quss withdrew from his people, worshipped God alone, preached divine unity and reproved idol-worship, and that he lived **seven hundred years**. **Translator's note:** The seven-hundred-year figure is the author's transmitted historical claim; it has not been independently corroborated. Zayd adhered to the *ḥanīfiyya*, the religion of Abraham, until he died before the mission. Waraqa, in Ibn ʿAjība's description, followed an uncorrupted Christianity, lived to the start of the mission and believed in the Messenger before he was ordered to issue public warning. Ibn ʿAjība cites the Prophet as saying that he saw Waraqa in Paradise dressed in green garments. **Translator's source note:** The green garments occur in Ibn Abī Shayba, *al-Muṣannaf* 37710, in a mursal narrative from Abū Maysara. A related version in al-Bayhaqī's *Dalāʾil* II:158 has silk garments and is explicitly called disconnected by its compiler. Al-Tirmidhī 2288 gives white garments through a different route, which he calls gharīb while criticizing a transmitter. These witnesses establish the source history without warranting a change to Cairo's green.

Spiritual allusion · on bounty and unity

Were it not for God's bounty in sending you someone who points you toward Him and makes Him known, and His mercy in leading you out of the narrowness of differentiation into the openness of gathering (*faḍāʾ al-jamʿ*), you would follow separation in both knowledge and action. But through His bounty and mercy He has concealed the differentiated appearances from your vision by granting you witnessing of the True King. Only a little *farq* remains by which you maintain the visible form of servanthood (*rasm al-ʿubūdiyya*) and preserve due propriety before lordship (*adab maʿa l-rubūbiyya*).

Al-Wartajbī says that divine bounty and mercy extend to people in general, while God's special love belongs to the elect—the “few” exempted in the verse. Al-Qushayrī says that but for divine bounty God's friends would wander through every valley of dispersion like others in their own day. He thus construes the verse allusively with regard to the saints. On this reading “except a few” means the small amount of differentiated awareness that overtakes them for their training, safeguarding their outward human form and preserving the locus on which legal responsibility (*taklīf*) rests. Ibn ʿAjība notes that this last interpretation comes from the marginal commentary. God knows best.

These realizations become manifest only through the greater and lesser struggles (*al-jihād al-akbar wa-l-aṣghar*), the subject of the next verses.

4:84–86 · Striving, intercession, and the ethics of returning greetings

Cairo I:538–540

فَقاتِلْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ لا تُكَلَّفُ إِلاَّ نَفْسَكَ وَحَرِّضِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ عَسَى اللَّهُ أَنْ يَكُفَّ بَأْسَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَاللَّهُ أَشَدُّ بَأْساً وَأَشَدُّ تَنْكِيلاً (84) مَنْ يَشْفَعْ شَفاعَةً حَسَنَةً يَكُنْ لَهُ نَصِيبٌ مِنْها وَمَنْ يَشْفَعْ شَفاعَةً سَيِّئَةً يَكُنْ لَهُ كِفْلٌ مِنْها وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ مُقِيتاً (85) وَإِذا حُيِّيتُمْ بِتَحِيَّةٍ فَحَيُّوا بِأَحْسَنَ مِنْها أَوْ رُدُّوها إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَلى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ حَسِيباً (86)

“Fight in God's way; you are responsible for none but yourself, and encourage the believers. Perhaps God will restrain the force of those who disbelieve. God is stronger in force and more severe in punishment. Whoever makes a good intercession shall have a share of it; whoever makes an evil intercession shall bear a portion of it. God has always had power over every thing. And when you are greeted with a greeting, respond with one better than it or return it in kind. God has always been a Reckoner over every thing.”

Language

Nafsaka (“yourself”) is a second object, while the first functions as the deputy subject of the passive verb, understood as “you”. The underlying sense is: “God charges you with none but your own self.”

Outward commentary · The outward interpretation: duty and encouraging others

God tells Muḥammad to fight in His way even alone if others hang back from the struggle: he has been charged with the duty pertaining to his own self. He should nevertheless encourage the believers, for encouragement is what is incumbent upon him with regard to them. Their struggle aims to make God's word uppermost. God may thereby ward off the power of the

unbelievers and overturn the false religion to which they cling. God is stronger in warfare and sterner in chastisement than any opponent. Ibn ʿAjība sees this promise fulfilled in the Prophet's triumph over the tribes of Arabia, the disappearance of idolatry from among them, and the later extension of Muslim rule by the Companions across other lands, guiding inhabitants except those he says withdrew to inaccessible mountain heights. [Translator's note: These are the commentator's retrospective historical generalizations, not a critical survey of the conquests.]

The command to encourage others is joined to the maxim that "one who directs to good is like the one who does it." Such direction includes beneficial intercession between people and guidance toward the restoration of good relations. Whoever intercedes well on someone's behalf—in order to avert harm or secure a benefit, seeking God's face—receives a substantial share of reward, for he has directed the person addressed toward good and conveyed benefit to the beneficiary. In recompense he receives a reward like theirs. Another instance is supplication for an absent person; Ibn ʿAjība quotes a report that one who prays for a Muslim in his absence is answered, and an angel says, "And the like of that for you."

Whoever makes a bad intercession, conversely, intending corruption among people through malicious tale-bearing, false witness or the institution of blameworthy innovation, receives a *kifl*, a portion of the resulting burden. Ibn ʿAjība cites the prophetic saying that one who introduces a good precedent (*sunna ḥasana*) receives its recompense and that of those who act upon it until the Resurrection, while one who initiates an evil precedent bears its burden and that of those who follow it. God's being *muqīt* over everything may mean that He has power over it (from *aqāta*, "to be able"), or that He watches and preserves it, recompensing actions in due measure.

Greetings as an instance of good mediation. Peaceful greeting becomes an occasion for the reward earned by the one who responds; therefore it is mentioned alongside directing people to good. When greeted, one may reply with a more complete formula, "And upon you be peace, God's mercy and His blessing," or with one equivalent to the original, "And upon you be peace." Ibn ʿAjība quotes a report according to which "Peace be upon you" brings ten good deeds, adding "and God's mercy" brings twenty, and adding "and His blessings" brings thirty. The responder receives equivalent recom-

pense. When the first speaker has already mentioned both mercy and blessing, Ibn ʿAjība's suggested response is simply "And upon you," since no further element remains to add.

He says that answering the greeting is a collective obligation (*farḍ ʿalā l-kifāya*) where the greeting is legally appropriate. He lists occasions in which, in his account of the law and Sufi propriety, a reply is not due: during a sermon, Qurʾān recitation, remembrance, reflection, spiritual consideration or contemplative witnessing (because a greeting would interrupt or unsettle the person); in a bathhouse when people are undressed; during sexual intercourse, eating or drinking; and other exceptional cases. He quotes instructional verse:

> Returning peace is obligatory—save for one
> engaged in prayer, or occupied with eating,
> or drinking, reciting, supplicating,
> remembering, preaching, or reciting the *talbiya*.

[Translator's note: These are **Ibn ʿAjība's stated exemptions**; their scope differs among jurists and is not offered here as a settled universal legal ruling.] He describes *salām* as the distinctive greeting of the people of Islam. Thus, he says, al-Khiḍr was surprised when Moses greeted him with peace and asked, "How does peace come to be in your land?" Likewise, he explains Abraham's surprise at the angels' greeting by reference to the unbelieving people among whom he lived. As for Abū Dharr greeting the Prophet in this Islamic manner before he himself became Muslim, Ibn ʿAjība suggests that he heard the expression from some Companions or received it through divine prompting.

"God is Reckoner over all things": He calls people to account concerning greetings and every other matter. With God is success.

Spiritual allusion

"Strive, O human being, against your own self in God's way. You are responsible for its reformation and purification, and should encourage believers who hear you to contend with their selves." God may then remove their impediments (*qawāṭiʿ*) and entangling attachments (*ʿalāʾiq*), preparing their hearts to shine with the lights of the realities (*anwār al-ḥaqāʾiq*), for

nothing can overcome God. Whoever recalls God's servants to Him and conveys them toward His Presence acquires a great share with God; one who directs them away from God betrays their trust and is abased.

If a greeting is offered to members of the Sufi way, those engaged in ordinary travelling along the path (*sālikūn*) and not occupied with remembrance should answer in a better form. If they are absorbed in remembrance, contemplation, or spiritual intoxication in witnessing the Beloved, Ibn ʿAjība holds that an answering greeting is not required. Nor, he says, is a response required when the greeting is given to test, provoke or torment them. God knows best.

Having spoken of reckoning (*ḥisāb*), the Qurʾān turns to the appointed time of reckoning.

4:87 · The gathering on the Last Day and the unity of the seeker's intention

Cairo I:540

اللَّهُ لاَ إِلهَ إِلاَّ هُوَ لَيَجْمَعَنَّكُمْ إِلى يَوْمِ الْقِيامَةِ لا رَيْبَ فِيهِ وَمَنْ أَصْدَقُ مِنَ اللَّهِ حَدِيثاً (87)

"God—there is no god but He—shall certainly gather you on the Day of Resurrection, about which there is no doubt. And who speaks more truthfully than God?"

Language

"God" (*Allāh*) is an initial subject (*mubtada'*), with "there is no god" (*lā ilāha*) as predicate (*khabar*). Alternatively the declaration of divine unity is parenthetic, and "He will certainly gather you" (*la-yajmaʿannakum*) is the predicate; this more closely suits the context. "There is no doubt in it" (*lā rayba fīhi*) is either a circumstance (*ḥāl*) or an adjective qualifying an unexpressed verbal noun: "a gathering in which there is no doubt."

Outward commentary

God alone deserves worship. By God, He will certainly raise you out of your graves and assemble you on the Day of Resurrection to face the accounting He has promised. There is no doubt about that day or His promise, for the promise is true. Who could speak more truthfully than God? No one, because lying is a defect, and defect is impossible of God.

Spiritual allusion

The True (*al-Ḥaqq*) is one in His kingdom, and no one tastes His oneness except a person who becomes single in his aim and spiritual concern. Whoever gathers his heart, intention (*qaṣd*) and spiritual aspiration (*himma*) into a single pursuit of God, turning his entire being toward Him,

God gathers him into His Presence and favours him with the witnessing of His Essence (*shuhūd dhātihi*). This is His real promise and truthful word, free from doubt and ambiguity. None is truer in speech than God.

Ibn ʿAjība next returns to the matter of the hypocrites.

4:88 · Disagreement over the hypocrites

Cairo I:540

فَما لَكُمْ فِي الْمُنافِقِينَ فِئَتَيْنِ وَاللَّهُ أَرْكَسَهُمْ بِما كَسَبُوا أَتُرِيدُونَ أَنْ تَهْدُوا مَنْ أَضَلَّ اللَّهُ وَمَنْ يُضْلِلِ اللَّهُ فَلَنْ تَجِدَ لَهُ سَبِيلاً (88)

Why have you become two parties concerning the hypocrites, when God has cast them back on account of what they have earned? Do you wish to guide one whom God has led astray? For one whom God leads astray you will find no path.

Language

I say: *fiʾatayn* (“two parties”) is a circumstantial accusative (*ḥāl*); its governing expression is the implicit idea of being or remaining conveyed by the preceding prepositional phrase. To *arkasa* something is to turn it upside down or throw it back. God, exalted is His majesty, reproaches the Companions for dividing into two groups over the status of certain hypocrites, instead of agreeing concerning their unbelief. God had cast those people back into unbelief after they had displayed Islam, as the consequence of their sins. Do you propose to guide people whose wretched destiny God already knew? Whoever God leads astray will find no way to guidance.

Ibn ʿAbbās is cited as saying that the verse concerned people in Mecca who claimed to have embraced Islam but did not emigrate. When some journeyed to Syria on business, Muslims differed: should they be killed and their merchandise taken because they had not emigrated, or spared because they professed belief? Another report concerns men who embraced Islam but found Medina unhealthy. They asked permission to return to the desert, and, once away, travelled on until they joined the polytheists;

Muslims then disputed their religious status. [Translator's note: These are reported occasions of revelation, not independent conclusions concerning contemporary persons.] [228]

4:89–90 · Emigration, hostility, and protected parties

Cairo I:540–542

وَدُّوا لَوْ تَكْفُرُونَ كَما كَفَرُوا فَتَكُونُونَ سَواءً فَلا تَتَّخِذُوا مِنْهُمْ أَوْلِياءَ حَتَّى يُهاجِرُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ فَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَخُذُوهُمْ وَاقْتُلُوهُمْ حَيْثُ وَجَدْتُمُوهُمْ وَلا تَتَّخِذُوا مِنْهُمْ وَلِيًّا وَلا نَصِيراً (89) إِلاَّ الَّذِينَ يَصِلُونَ إِلى قَوْمٍ بَيْنَكُمْ وَبَيْنَهُمْ مِيثاقٌ أَوْ جاؤُكُمْ حَصِرَتْ صُدُورُهُمْ أَنْ يُقاتِلُوكُمْ أَوْ يُقاتِلُوا قَوْمَهُمْ وَلَوْ شاءَ اللَّهُ لَسَلَّطَهُمْ عَلَيْكُمْ فَلَقاتَلُوكُمْ فَإِنِ اعْتَزَلُوكُمْ فَلَمْ يُقاتِلُوكُمْ وَأَلْقَوْا إِلَيْكُمُ السَّلَمَ فَما جَعَلَ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ عَلَيْهِمْ سَبِيلاً (90)

They wish you to disbelieve as they disbelieve, so that you would be equal. Do not take them as protecting friends until they emigrate in God's way. If they turn back, seize and kill them wherever you encounter them, and take no protector or helper from among them—except those who reach a people with whom you have a covenant, or those who come to you with hearts constrained from fighting you or fighting their own people. Had God willed, He would have given them power over you and they would have fought you. If they withdraw, do not fight you, and offer you peace, then God has provided you no way against them.

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228. Cairo editor, C541.1: That is, they were afflicted by jawā: illness and a prolonged internal ailment. This was because its air did not agree with them and they found it unhealthy. One also says, "I found the town disagreeable," when one dislikes remaining there, even while enjoying comfortable circumstances. See al-Nihāya fī gharīb al-ḥadīth, under j-w-ā.

Outward commentary · Running commentary

Continuation of the previous exposition. God describes those persons as wishing that the believers would become unbelievers like themselves, thus becoming their equals in error and unbelief.

Spiritual allusion · to the previous verse

Whoever entered the path of the specially chosen and righteous but was not helped by the winds of decree should not become the subject of speculative talk or intrusive inquiry. His case rests with his Lord: no one can misguide a person God guides, and no one can assist a person left astray. God gives success and directs to the straight path.

Language

I say: *ḥaṣirat* means that their breasts were constricted. The sentence is circumstantial (*ḥāl*) in relation to the plural pronoun. This is corroborated by Yaʿqūb's reading *ḥaṣiratan* in adjectival form, “constricted.”

Outward commentary

God prohibits taking the people just described as close allies and protectors before their faith is manifest in emigration from the abode of unbelief to the abode of Islam, for God's sake rather than for a worldly advantage. If they turn away from manifesting faith through emigration in God’s way, Ibn ʿAjība explains the command as: ‘Take them captive and kill them wherever you find them, like the other unbelievers.’ He adds that they are to be shunned. They are not to be relied upon as helpers in the believers' military expeditions. Yet people who attach themselves to a party with whom Muslims have a treaty share the protections of those bound by the treaty: they are neither to be killed nor taken captive.

He identifies the treaty partners in one report as Khuzāʿa, with whom the Prophet made a peace agreement, and those joining them as Banū Mudlij. The command not to fight the latter held while they remained protected by that agreement. On this account the grammatical exception is disconnected (*istithnāʾ munqaṭiʿ*), since Banū Mudlij were openly unbelievers, not the hypocrites first mentioned. Alternatively it is connected, referring to those among the first group who joined a treaty-bound people. Ibn ʿAjība adds the traditional exegetical claim that the early rule was later abrogated by the

verse “Kill the polytheists wherever you find them” (9:5). [Translator’s note: This is a report of his exegetical position; it is not an unrestricted legal instruction, and the conditions and debates over abrogation require independent juristic examination.]

A second protected class consists of people who come unwilling either to fight the Muslims or to fight their own kin. Their hearts recoil from both engagements. They too are not to be fought, for God has restrained the harm they might otherwise have done. Had He removed their fear and strengthened their resolve, they could have fought. But if they keep apart, refrain from hostilities and offer peaceful submission or a peace agreement, there is no legitimate cause to attack them.

Spiritual allusion

The prohibition can also be applied to intimate accommodation of one's lower soul (*nafs*), until it emigrates from the dwelling places of its desires to the Presence of its Lord. If it turns away from this emigration and becomes accustomed to idleness and heedlessness, Ibn ʿAjība enjoins seizing and slaying it wherever its form appears, never settling with it or befriending it. Yet if it reaches the spiritual master's presence and he directs gentleness toward it, if it desists from tyranny, or if a divine attraction (*jadhb*) or incoming spiritual impulse (*wārid*) drives it out of its habits and repels its appetites, it should no longer be treated in that manner. Such help proceeds from the Presence of the All-Subduer: it strikes nothing without crushing it. This is care from the All-Merciful. Were God to give the soul unrestricted power, it would bolt toward the shallows of the Fire. Once it restrains its passions and yields to its Lord, no one has a cause against it: it has entered the sanctuary of the Sovereign. God knows best.

4:91 · Those who seek protection from both sides

Cairo I:542

سَتَجِدُونَ آخَرِينَ يُرِيدُونَ أَنْ يَأْمَنُوكُمْ وَيَأْمَنُوا قَوْمَهُمْ كُلَّما رُدُّوا إِلَى الْفِتْنَةِ أُرْكِسُوا فِيها فَإِنْ لَمْ يَعْتَزِلُوكُمْ وَيُلْقُوا إِلَيْكُمُ السَّلَمَ وَيَكُفُّوا أَيْدِيَهُمْ فَخُذُوهُمْ وَاقْتُلُوهُمْ حَيْثُ ثَقِفْتُمُوهُمْ وَأُولئِكُمْ جَعَلْنا لَكُمْ عَلَيْهِمْ سُلْطاناً مُبِيناً (91)

You will find others who wish to feel secure with you and with their own people. Whenever they are returned to sedition, they are cast headlong into it. Unless they withdraw from you, offer peace and restrain their hands, seize and kill them wherever you encounter them. Against such people We have given you clear authority.

Outward commentary

God speaks of another class of hypocrites, identified in the report as men of Asad and Ghaṭafān. On coming to Medina they professed Islam and told the Prophet they followed his religion, seeking security. On returning to their kin, when asked why and whom they worshipped, one answered derisively that he worshipped a monkey, a scorpion and a beetle. Such persons sought safety with both sides. Each time they were summoned to unbelief they plunged into it more shamefully. If they refuse separation from hostilities, decline to offer peace and do not restrain their hands from attacking, the text commands, “Seize them and kill them wherever you find them,” and states that clear authority has been granted against them, because their unbelief is manifest and their hostility established. [Translator’s note: This interpretation is Ibn ʿAjība's description of the passage's historical combatants.]

Spiritual allusion

Lower souls fall into three classes. Some are wholly unrestrained in crime and disobedience—the commanding soul (*al-nafs al-ammāra*), alluded to by the preceding verses. Others vacillate: they display obedience and submission to reassure their possessor, then return to error and disobedience whenever temptation calls. So long as they refuse to desist, Ibn ʿAjība declares struggle against them and their "slaying" obligatory until they yield wholly to their Lord. As for the soul at peace (*al-nafs al-muṭmaʾinna*), there is no conflict with it: its submission has become real, and it must be left alone and loved. Having treated the safeguarding of religion, the commentary next turns to the safeguarding of human lives.

4:92 · Unintentional killing and compensation

Cairo I:543–545

وَما كانَ لِمُؤْمِنٍ أَنْ يَقْتُلَ مُؤْمِناً إِلاَّ خَطَأً وَمَنْ قَتَلَ مُؤْمِناً خَطَأً فَتَحْرِيرُ رَقَبَةٍ مُؤْمِنَةٍ وَدِيَةٌ مُسَلَّمَةٌ إِلى أَهْلِهِ إِلاَّ أَنْ يَصَّدَّقُوا فَإِنْ كانَ مِنْ قَوْمٍ عَدُوٍّ لَكُمْ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَتَحْرِيرُ رَقَبَةٍ مُؤْمِنَةٍ وَإِنْ كانَ مِنْ قَوْمٍ بَيْنَكُمْ وَبَيْنَهُمْ مِيثاقٌ فَدِيَةٌ مُسَلَّمَةٌ إِلى أَهْلِهِ وَتَحْرِيرُ رَقَبَةٍ مُؤْمِنَةٍ فَمَنْ لَمْ يَجِدْ فَصِيامُ شَهْرَيْنِ مُتَتابِعَيْنِ تَوْبَةً مِنَ اللَّهِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَلِيماً حَكِيماً (92)

It is not for a believer to kill another believer, except by mistake. Whoever kills a believer by mistake must free a believing slave and pay compensation (diya) delivered to the victim's family, unless they remit it as charity. If the slain believer belongs to a people hostile to you, then a believing slave must be freed. If the victim belongs to a people with whom you have a covenant, compensation must be delivered to the family and a

believing slave freed. Whoever cannot find the means must fast two consecutive months, as a repentance granted by God. God is All-Knowing, All-Wise.

Language

I say: “It is not for a believer” uses formal negation with the force of prohibition, as in “It is not for you to hurt the Messenger of God.” “Except by mistake” can be a disconnected exception (*istithnāʾ munqaṭiʿ*): killing a believer is not permitted in any circumstance, but where it accidentally happens the following ruling applies. *Khaṭaʾan* can be parsed as a circumstantial expression, an accusative of cause, or the qualification of a suppressed verbal noun; some construe the exception as connected—compare Ibn Juzayy—or supply “except a killing committed by mistake.” “Unless they remit it” describes the circumstance of voluntary renunciation. *Tawbatan* can express purpose (“to bring about repentance”) or be a verbal noun (“He turned toward you in repentance”).

Outward commentary

God forbids one believer to kill another. Mistaken killing may occur when someone takes a believer to be an unbeliever or a projectile meant for someone else strikes the believer. Ibn ʿAjība relates the verse to ʿAyyāsh ibn Rabīʿa's killing of al-Ḥārith ibn Zayd: al-Ḥārith had formerly tormented him for accepting Islam, then himself converted and emigrated, but ʿAyyāsh did not know of the conversion.

For unintentional killing, the killer must emancipate a believing slave free of disqualifying defects and of any partial freedom, at his own expense. Blood-money (*diya*) is delivered to the family and borne by the *ʿāqila*, the kin-group financially responsible for accidental homicide, as clarified in the Prophetic practice. Ibn ʿAjība records the Mālikī calculation as one hundred camels for camel owners, a thousand legally reckoned gold dinars for those using gold, or twelve thousand silver dirhams for those using silver, distributed over three years. If there is no *ʿāqila*, the public treasury bears the amount. The recipients share according to inheritance shares unless the heirs, or the victim before dying, freely remit it to the killer, in which case it lapses.

If the slain believer belongs to a hostile people, emancipation remains obligatory but, on one account, no blood-money is paid to the enemy, since it could strengthen them militarily; Mālik is reported to require its payment instead to the public treasury. If a believing victim is from a treaty-bound community, both compensation to the family and emancipation are due. Ibn ʿAjība also distinguishes the case of a nonbelieving victim in such a community, for whom he does not require the same expiation and assigns half the compensation of a Muslim according to the school position he reports. If a believing slave is unavailable or unaffordable, the substitute is two consecutive months of fasting. God instituted this as repentance for the killer's neglect of due caution; He knows what He has imposed and judges wisely. [Translator's note: These are historical legal positions; their application depends upon the relevant legal jurisdiction and juristic conditions.]

Spiritual allusion

God encourages reviving souls both outwardly and inwardly, and forbids killing them in either respect. This is because of His particular love for human souls and His special care for them. Nothing in existence is dearer to God than this human manifestation when the human being stands upright in servanthood to his Lord. He is the heart of existence; for his sake every existent has appeared. He is the one regarded in this lower world and the intended addressee of the religious charge, particular and general. He is the very point of it all, the one beloved to God above the rest of His servants. "I have fashioned you for Myself" (20:41) is cited. To give sensory life is to save from bodily destruction; to give inward life is to rescue from ignorance and heedlessness so that one lives by knowledge, faith and awakening. Bodily killing is to destroy the person; inward killing is to draw someone into sins or unbelief or to humiliate and abase them. The Prophet's reported saying "Cursing a believer is like killing him" illustrates this dignity.

The one who kills unintentionally is therefore told to restore life to another human being by liberating that person from the humiliation of slavery. If incapable of this, one revives one's own spiritual life by bringing its arrogance low through hunger, so that repentance and watchfulness renew it. The financial compensation also repairs the distress of the bereaved family.

Such provisions answer the negligence and want of care that led to the accidental killing. Deliberate murder receives the much more severe warning of the next verse.

4:93 · Deliberate murder and its warning

Cairo I:545

وَمَنْ يَقْتُلْ مُؤْمِناً مُتَعَمِّداً فَجَزاؤُهُ جَهَنَّمُ خالِداً فِيها وَغَضِبَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَلَعَنَهُ وَأَعَدَّ لَهُ عَذاباً عَظِيماً (93)

Whoever kills a believer deliberately—his recompense is Hell, abiding in it; God is angry with him, has cursed him, and has prepared for him an immense punishment.

Outward commentary · Outward interpretation and the theological dispute

Ibn ʿAjība adds the qualification “regarding his killing as lawful” (*mustaḥillan li-qatlihi*). This supplies one Sunni answer to the Muʿtazilite inference that a believer guilty of grave sin, including murder, must abide eternally in Hell. In the Sunni position he describes, none except an unbeliever remains there forever. He supports this answer with the verse’s occasion of revelation, saying that it concerned an unbeliever, Miqyās ibn Ḍubāba al-Kinānī. Finding his brother Hishām murdered among Banū al-Najjār, Miqyās complained to the Prophet. A messenger was sent with him, directing the clan to surrender the known murderer for retaliation, or, if the killer was unknown, to pay blood-money. They said they did not know the perpetrator and paid a hundred camels. On the return journey, Satan suggested to Miqyās that accepting compensation would bring disgrace; Miqyās killed the accompanying messenger and kept the camels. The verse is said to have been revealed concerning this deed.

Another explanation takes “abiding” to mean a very long sojourn rather than eternity. The majority, says Ibn ʿAjība, accept the murderer's repentance, contrary to one reported position of Ibn ʿAbbās, from whom acceptance of repentance is also transmitted. He proposes that repentance was

not repeated here because it was already mentioned in al-Furqān (25:68–70), where a threat is followed by “except those who repent.” The assertion that this earlier passage has been abrogated by the present verse is, in his account, unsound because abrogation does not apply to straightforward reports. Or the expression may mean “that will be his recompense *if he is recompensed with it*.” God's waiving a threatened punishment by pardon is not impossible, for “He forgives what is less than that for whom He wills” (4:48). Threats of punishment presuppose the absence of pardon or repentance. A promise of beneficence is fulfilled, but a threatened penalty may be remitted by mercy. Ibn ʿAjība cites a reported Prophetic saying, attributed through *al-Qūt*, that God necessarily fulfils a promised reward but may either forgive or punish where He has threatened punishment. [Translator’s note: The source and strength of this particular wording require checking.]

He concludes that, on the well-known view, the murderer is not eternally punished unless he has declared the killing lawful. He adds that worldly retaliation, when carried out, is understood by the majority to expiate the crime, adducing the Prophetic teaching that punishment suffered in this life is an expiation. He says the same applies when the heirs entitled to retaliation pardon him, because it is a right they have inherited.

Spiritual allusion

Faith is properly the quality of the heart: the heart, in its reality, is the true believer. To kill the heart by the pursuit of passions and the accumulation of heedlessness merits the fire of separation, imprisonment within the created world and remoteness from direct recognition and witnessing. The *Ḥikam* is cited: the existence of a veil is the cause of torment, while bliss is completed by looking upon the face of the Generous One. The tongue translates the heart; hence outward profession of faith deserves protection, as the next verse makes clear.

4:94 · Discernment before taking action

Cairo I:546

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا إِذا ضَرَبْتُمْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ فَتَبَيَّنُوا وَلا تَقُولُوا لِمَنْ أَلْقى إِلَيْكُمُ السَّلَمَ لَسْتَ مُؤْمِناً تَبْتَغُونَ عَرَضَ الْحَياةِ الدُّنْيا فَعِنْدَ اللَّهِ مَغانِمُ كَثِيرَةٌ كَذلِكَ كُنْتُمْ مِنْ قَبْلُ فَمَنَّ اللَّهُ عَلَيْكُمْ فَتَبَيَّنُوا إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ خَبِيراً (94)

O believers, when you journey in God's way, investigate carefully. Do not say to one who offers you submission, “You are not a believer,” seeking the fleeting goods of this worldly life. With God are abundant gains. You yourselves were like this before, and God bestowed His favour upon you. Therefore verify carefully: God is fully aware of what you do.

Language

I say: *salam* or *silm* without lengthening denotes yielding and submission; *salām* with a long vowel means the greeting of peace. “Seeking” (*tabtaghūna*) forms a circumstantial clause exposing the motive that might prompt hasty action.

Outward commentary

When travelling for struggle in God's way, the believers must scrutinise the facts and establish them instead of rushing to judgment, for haste is from Satan. Whoever manifests peaceful submission or offers the Islamic greeting must not be dismissed as an unbeliever merely suspected of speaking out of fear; otherwise the listener may kill him in desire for his goods, that perishing merchandise of worldly life. God has promised many lawful benefits not presently within reach; wait for what is free of suspicion instead of grabbing at doubtful spoils. Believers too once concealed their conversion out of fear of their own people; God then granted them dignity, victory and public recognition. Accordingly, they should extend protection to new entrants just as God protected them. He adds: “Sparing a thousand unbe-

lievers is less grave in God's sight than killing one believer." Repeating the command to verify underscores the gravity of the matter. He knows hidden intentions and cautions against rash killing.

Ibn ʿAjība relates an expedition against Fadak: the people fled, but Mirdās, a Muslim, stayed with his sheep, trusting in his religion. Seeing cavalry approach, he led his flock into a bend in the mountain and climbed above it. When the soldiers pronounced *takbīr*, he did likewise, came down proclaiming the two testimonies and greeted them. In the report, Usāma killed him and took his sheep. The Prophet was deeply distressed and asked three times, "What will you do with 'There is no god but God' when it comes on the Day of Resurrection?" Usāma wished his conversion had occurred only after that event. The account adds a prayer for forgiveness and an instruction to emancipate a slave. Another account says the verse concerned al-Miqdād: he passed a man among his sheep and intended to kill him; the man said, "There is no god but God," but al-Miqdād killed him and took possession of his family and property. Another report names the killer as Muḥallim ibn Jaththāma and the victim as ʿĀmir ibn al-Aḍbaṭ. [Translator's note: The accounts differ in their chains and details.] [229]

Spiritual allusion

Two praised dispositions are drawn out, especially for Sufis. First, deliberation, gravity, tranquillity and freedom from haste, fickleness and impulsiveness. A reported saying has it that the deliberate person is right, or nearly so, while the hasty person errs, or nearly so. Do not undertake a matter before understanding God's ruling concerning it and discerning what God wills of you at that moment. Second, cultivate good opinion of all God's servants. Assume the best rather than probing their inner secrets. Ibn ʿAjība quotes the Prophet as saying, "I have been commanded to judge by outward appearances, while God takes charge of the inner secrets." The Prophet is reported to have asked Usāma—or, Ibn ʿAjība adds, someone else— "Did you split open his heart?" Ibn ʿAjība additionally transmits the saying that nothing exceeds good opinion of God and of God's servants in goodness, or exceeds bad opinion of them in evil. [Translator's note: Its Prophetic attri-

229. Cairo editor, C547.1: That is, a bend in the mountain.

bution also requires independent verification.] God knows best. The next passage urges active striving lest the warning against precipitancy be misunderstood as a rejection of decisive effort. [230]

4:95–96 · Those who strive and those who remain

Cairo I:548

لا يَسْتَوِي الْقاعِدُونَ مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ غَيْرُ أُولِي الضَّرَرِ وَالْمُجاهِدُونَ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ بِأَمْوالِهِمْ وَأَنْفُسِهِمْ فَضَّلَ اللَّهُ الْمُجاهِدِينَ بِأَمْوالِهِمْ وَأَنْفُسِهِمْ عَلَى الْقاعِدِينَ دَرَجَةً وَكُلاًّ وَعَدَ اللَّهُ الْحُسْنى وَفَضَّلَ اللَّهُ الْمُجاهِدِينَ عَلَى الْقاعِدِينَ أَجْراً عَظِيماً (95) دَرَجاتٍ مِنْهُ وَمَغْفِرَةً وَرَحْمَةً وَكانَ اللَّهُ غَفُوراً رَحِيماً (96)

Believers who stay behind, apart from those suffering disability, are not equal to those who strive with their possessions and themselves in God's way. God has raised those who strive with their wealth and lives above those who sit back by a degree. To each God has promised the finest recompense; yet over those who stay behind He has preferred the striving ones with a tremendous reward: degrees from Him, forgiveness and mercy. God is Ever-Forgiving, Merciful.

Language

I say: “Among the believers” is circumstantial in relation to those who remain behind. *Ghayr* (“apart from”) may be nominative, as an adjective of “those remaining”; accusative, as a *ḥāl*; or genitive, as a substitute (*badal*) for “believers.” *Darajatan* (“a degree”) may depend on an omitted preposition, express the meaning of the verbal action of preferring, or describe persons possessing a degree. *Ajran ʿaẓīman* (“a mighty recompense”) may be a verbal equivalent of “preferred,” or its second object when it means

230. Cairo editor, C547.2: It has not been transmitted in this wording. Consult Kashf al-khafā, I:221, and al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana, p.91.

"granted"; "degrees," "forgiveness" and "mercy" are each construed as a substitute (*badal*) for "recompense". He offers further possibilities, including an accusative of verbal action (*maf'ūl muṭlaq*), a circumstantial expression placed before its referent because that referent is indefinite, and supplied verbal nouns for forgiveness and mercy.

Outward commentary

In encouraging struggle, God denies that those who sit out fighting and those who expend property and life for His cause possess equal degrees or recompense. Ibn ʿAjība reports that, upon revelation of the initial wording, the two blind men Ibn Umm Maktūm and ʿAbd Allāh ibn Jaḥsh came to the Prophet, desiring to strive but asking what concession their condition allowed. "Except those suffering injury or disability" was then revealed; on account of their inability and sincere intention they were awarded the recompense of those who strove. The striving combatant gives possessions to help other combatants and offers his life in God's way. He excels the one staying behind for a genuine excuse by one degree on account of fatigue, travel and risk of death. Both such categories have been promised Paradise. Those who stay behind without an excuse are contrasted with combatants who receive a vastly greater reward. Ibn ʿAjība cites the report in al-Bukhārī of one hundred degrees God has prepared for those who strive in His way, separated like heaven and earth. These degrees issue from His generosity; forgiveness removes sins, and mercy brings one near to Him.

Spiritual allusion

The person content to sit with personal pleasures and inclinations, increasing position and wealth and pursuing private hopes while neglecting the journey to his Lord, is not equal to the one who draws the sword of determination against the lower soul and submits his life to the search for divine acceptance until he witnesses the lights of divine beauty. The living and the dead cannot be equal. One detained by genuine incapacity but loving the path and acknowledging its special people is beneath those who struggle against their souls by one degree—that of direct witnessing and immediate knowledge of the Loving Sovereign. Someone staying away without excuse while denying the people of the special way is separated by many degrees from those who keep advancing, with forgiveness and mercy. Ibn ʿAjība re-

ports from al-Bayḍāwī a distinction between a degree for outward struggle and degrees for the greater struggle against the soul, as explained by a cited tradition. God knows best.

4:97–99 · The oppressed and emigration

Cairo I:549

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ تَوَفَّاهُمُ الْمَلائِكَةُ ظالِمِي أَنْفُسِهِمْ قالُوا فِيمَ كُنْتُمْ قالُوا كُنَّا مُسْتَضْعَفِينَ فِي الْأَرْضِ قالُوا أَلَمْ تَكُنْ أَرْضُ اللَّهِ واسِعَةً فَتُهاجِرُوا فِيها فَأُولئِكَ مَأْواهُمْ جَهَنَّمُ وَساءَتْ مَصِيراً (97) إِلاَّ الْمُسْتَضْعَفِينَ مِنَ الرِّجالِ وَالنِّساءِ وَالْوِلْدانِ لا يَسْتَطِيعُونَ حِيلَةً وَلا يَهْتَدُونَ سَبِيلاً (98) فَأُولئِكَ عَسَى اللَّهُ أَنْ يَعْفُوَ عَنْهُمْ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَفُوًّا غَفُوراً (99)

Those whom the angels take at death while they are wronging themselves are asked, “In what condition were you?” They reply, “We were powerless in the land.” The angels say, “Was God's earth not spacious enough for you to emigrate?” Their refuge is Hell—an evil destination—except for genuinely powerless men, women and children who possess no means and cannot find a way. God may pardon these; God is Pardoning, Forgiving.

Outward commentary

The angels here are the angel of death and his assistants, taking the souls of people who had wronged themselves by neglecting emigration and remaining in the company of unbelievers. “What were you in?” may question the state of their religion—doubt or certainty—or the land in which they stayed, a land of unbelief or Islam. They plead that fear of the polytheists prevented outward profession of their faith and escape. The angels reply reproachfully: God's earth is broad; others emigrated to Abyssinia and Medina. Attachment to possessions and self-preservation kept these people be-

hind. In the initial historical circumstances, says Ibn ʿAjība, they incurred the warning because they failed to make a then-obligatory emigration and assisted unbelievers against Muslims.

He recounts that the verse concerned Meccans who spoke of accepting Islam but had not emigrated. They went with the polytheists to Badr and, seeing how few the Muslims were, remarked that religion had deceived them; they were killed, and the angels struck their faces and backs, as explained elsewhere. He concludes that residing under the rule of unbelief is impermissible when one is able to leave: emigration is obligatory, with no excuse for remaining. One prevented by an impediment ought not become content with the inability, but remain ready to leave. Otherwise, he says, affliction will encompass him, as happened to the people of Andalusia until their children became unbelievers, and extends the objection to settings where wrongdoing and neglect of religion predominate.

Al-Bayḍāwī is cited for the obligation to migrate from any place where one cannot establish one's religious practice. Ibn ʿAjība transmits a reported saying that one who flees a land for the sake of religion, even a short distance, earns Paradise and the companionship of Abraham and Muḥammad. [Translator's note: Its isnād is not verified here.] In a special inward sense, this includes moving from a place of excessive appetites, habitual attachments and distracting relationships to one more favourable for purification of the heart and knowledge of the Lord. The inward migrant hopes for companionship with the prophets in the sanctuary of divine nearness. [231]

The exception is for those demonstrably weak or powerless: men, women and children, including enslaved persons and minors in the commentary's social setting. Ibn ʿAjība adds that reaching maturity and acquiring ability makes emigration incumbent when its original conditions obtain, and that the responsible families should take the vulnerable with them when possible. Ibn ʿAbbās is reported to have identified himself and his parents as among those excepted. Such persons lack the resources and physical capacity for travel or cannot find a route or a guide. The word "perhaps" attached to divine pardon, Ibn ʿAjība says, reminds even the excused that the obligation is grave: they should wait attentively for an opening. "God has always been Forgiving, Merciful": He pardons and forgives those overcome

231. Cairo editor, C550.1: Al-Thaʿlabī transmits it in his Tafsīr from al-Ḥasan as a mursal report. See al-Fatḥ al-samāwī, II:515.

by an excuse. [Textual note: Cairo I:550 gives *ghafūran raḥīman*, “Forgiving, Merciful,” here, whereas the Q4:99 verse block at I:549 correctly has *ʿafuwwan ghafūran*, “Pardoning, Forgiving.” The former wording also ends Q4:100, printed next. The difference is retained as a feature of the exposition; it is not presented as a variant Qurʾānic reading, and its origin has not been established.]

[Translator’s print-source notes: T208]

Spiritual allusion

One who never penetrated inward knowledge dies having wronged the soul by depriving it of the delight of direct witnessing and recognition of the Worshipped Sovereign. His inward being is not free from persistence in diseases of the heart, which are among the greatest sins. At death the angels ask why this person did not emigrate to a guide able to remove defects and bring him to the Presence of the Knower of the Unseen. He says he was weak in the knowledge of certainty (*ʿilm al-yaqīn*) and could not accompany people of the eye or truth of certainty (*ʿayn al-yaqīn*, *ḥaqq al-yaqīn*): love of native country, wife and children detained him. The reply is that God's earth was broad enough to seek one who would remove the veil and dispel uncertainty. Thus his home is the prison of created forms and deprivation of direct witnessing, except for one who recognises his weakness and urgently implores his Master for deliverance from his self: his Lord may then have compassion on him and bring him to a knower among His saints, so that he may join His beloved and elect. Such a thing is not difficult for God.

4:100 · The reward of leaving for God

Cairo I:550

وَمَنْ يُهاجِرْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ يَجِدْ فِي الْأَرْضِ مُراغَماً كَثِيراً وَسَعَةً وَمَنْ يَخْرُجْ مِنْ بَيْتِهِ مُهاجِراً إِلَى اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ ثُمَّ يُدْرِكْهُ الْمَوْتُ فَقَدْ وَقَعَ أَجْرُهُ عَلَى اللَّهِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ غَفُوراً رَحِيماً (100)

> Whoever emigrates in God's way will find abundant places of refuge and breadth upon the earth. Whoever leaves his house, emigrating to God and His Messenger, and death then overtakes him, his recompense has fallen due with God. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language

I say: *Murāgham* means an escape or destination, according to *al-Qāmūs*. Al-Bayḍāwī explains it as a place to which one can transfer, connecting it with *rughām*, dust. It can also mean a road taken in defiance of one's people, separating from them to their vexation.

Outward commentary

One who emigrates to exalt God's word and uphold religion finds abundant room for movement, relief from the constraints of hostile rule and prevention of religious practice, and perhaps enlarged livelihood. He therefore has no excuse for remaining in a place where his religious life is constrained. If someone sets out from home intending emigration to God and His Messenger and struggle for His cause, but dies before reaching the destination, the reward has nevertheless been established. God, through His free beneficence—not through a compulsion upon Him—grants the person the intended end, forgives the delay that preceded departure, and shows mercy by fulfilling the hope.

Ibn ʿAjība relates a report about the elderly, sick Jundaʿ ibn Ḍamra. Hearing the revelation about emigration, he swore that he was not among the excused, had sufficient means to reach Medina, and would not pass another night in Mecca. He was carried on a bed as far as al-Tanʿīm, where death overtook him. He struck one hand upon the other, declaring, “O God, this is for You and this is for Your Messenger; I pledge to You what Your Messenger pledged.” Some Companions said he would have received a fuller reward had he arrived; polytheists mocked his failure to reach his goal. The verse was revealed, according to this report. Another account concerns Khālid ibn Ḥizām, bitten by a snake on the way to Abyssinia and dying before arrival.

Spiritual allusion

One who emigrates from the homeland of personal self-indulgence and appetite toward the Presence of the Lord finds in the land of the soul spaciousness for sciences, keys to treasures of understanding and expanses of witnessing, until all existing things are encompassed in inner insight and the Necessary Existent is witnessed. One who departs from the house of the lower soul and the prison of bodily form in search of God and His Messenger but dies before reaching established mastery (*tamkīn*) still has the reward with God; the person is raised with the firmly established *ṣiddīqūn*, whose station follows that of the prophets. Likewise the seeker of outward religious knowledge who dies before completing its acquisition is raised with the scholars. Ibn ʿAjība cites a saying that only one rank separates a person dying in pursuit of knowledge from the prophets, and identifies that rank as the *ṣiddīqūn*. [Translator's note: The transmission requires source criticism.]

A sincere person who dies in pursuit of any good attains the intended reward after death through the excellence of intention. Al-Qushayrī says that the true emigrant leaves behind the lower self and its appetites, which requires the shedding of all one's private aims. One whose aim is God and who dies before reaching Him arrives at nothing but the courtyards of union and the resting-place of nearness. Some inherited reports distinguish a lesser emigration—bodily removal from a displeasing home to a pleasing one—from a greater emigration: the soul's transfer from familiar habits and selfish claims to knowledge of its Lord and its own rights. [Textual note: the Cairo text reads *ḥuqūqihā*, "its rights," with a feminine pronoun referring back to the soul. This preserves the printed wording; the source does not read "His rights."] God knows best.

4:101 · Shortening prayer on the road

Cairo I:552

وَإِذا ضَرَبْتُمْ فِي الْأَرْضِ فَلَيْسَ عَلَيْكُمْ جُناحٌ أَنْ تَقْصُرُوا مِنَ الصَّلاةِ إِنْ خِفْتُمْ أَنْ يَفْتِنَكُمُ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا إِنَّ الْكافِرِينَ كانُوا لَكُمْ عَدُوًّا مُبِيناً (101)

When you travel through the land, there is no blame upon you for shortening the prayer if you fear the unbelievers will subject you to trial. The unbelievers are openly hostile to you.

Outward commentary · Outward interpretation and the law of travel

This permission applies to journeying for struggle or another permissible or praiseworthy purpose. The four-cycle prayers may be shortened to two cycles. The absence of blame suggests a concession (*rukhṣa*), says Ibn ʿAjība, who attributes this view to al-Shāfiʿī. He cites reports that the Prophet at times completed prayer while travelling, and a report in which ʿĀʾisha says she completed while he shortened and fasted while he broke his fast; the Prophet responded approvingly. Abū Ḥanīfa, on the other hand, is said to make shortening obligatory, supported by ʿUmar's statement that the travelling prayer is two complete cycles rather than a truncated prayer, and by ʿĀʾisha's report that prayer was first imposed in two cycles, retained as such in travel and increased at home. Mālik treats shortening as a Sunna because of the Prophet's consistent travel practice, allowing that he completed once to demonstrate permissibility. [Translator's note: These reports and their legal uses are reproduced as Ibn ʿAjība gives them; the claimed reports about completion and the school formulations require independent detailed checking before normative reliance.] [232]

The wording "if you fear" appears to make danger a condition. Ibn ʿAjība attributes this view to ʿĀʾisha and ʿUthmān, but says the majority do not require fear: it was mentioned because it commonly accompanied journeys

232. Cairo editor, C552.1: The source copies read: "You have acted correctly."

at the time, or else the permission under conditions of safety is taken from the Sunna. Yaʿlā ibn Umayya asked ʿUmar why shortening persisted after people had become safe, given the condition in the verse; ʿUmar had asked the Prophet the same question and received the reply: “It is a charity God has bestowed upon you, so accept His charity.” The Prophet also shortened while secure.

The verse gives no numerical limit on the distance: it speaks simply of travel. Thus the Ẓāhirīs permit shortening on every journey however short or long. Mālik and al-Shāfiʿī prescribe four *burud*, adducing reports from Ibn ʿUmar and Ibn ʿAbbās; Abū Ḥanīfa is reported here to prescribe six *burud*. Nor does the wording restrict the journey to one free of sin. Thus Abū Ḥanīfa permits shortening on any journey; Mālik denies it for travel undertaken to commit a sin, and Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal is reported to disallow it both for sinful and merely permissible travel. In the clause about causing *fitna*, the feared trial means conflict and other hostile harm.

Spiritual allusion

When you traverse the fields of your own soul and journey toward the Most Holy Presence, there is no blame in restricting yourselves to the essential part of sensory prayer while persisting in the prayer of the heart, which is dwelling in the sacred Presence—if you fear that the sweetness of outward observance could distract you from witnessing. A knower said, “Beware the sweetness of devotional practice, for it is a deadly poison.” Ibn Mashīsh is cited as saying, even concerning spiritual stations such as contentment and surrender, “I fear their sweetness will distract me from God.” [Translator’s note: This is mystical application, not a legal licence to omit prescribed acts of worship.] God knows best.

4:102 · The prayer performed under danger

Cairo I:553

وَإِذا كُنْتَ فِيهِمْ فَأَقَمْتَ لَهُمُ الصَّلاةَ فَلْتَقُمْ طائِفَةٌ مِنْهُمْ مَعَكَ وَلْيَأْخُذُوا أَسْلِحَتَهُمْ فَإِذا سَجَدُوا فَلْيَكُونُوا مِنْ وَرائِكُمْ وَلْتَأْتِ طائِفَةٌ أُخْرى لَمْ يُصَلُّوا فَلْيُصَلُّوا مَعَكَ وَلْيَأْخُذُوا حِذْرَهُمْ وَأَسْلِحَتَهُمْ وَدَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا لَوْ تَغْفُلُونَ عَنْ أَسْلِحَتِكُمْ وَأَمْتِعَتِكُمْ فَيَمِيلُونَ عَلَيْكُمْ مَيْلَةً واحِدَةً وَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْكُمْ إِنْ كانَ بِكُمْ أَذىً مِنْ مَطَرٍ أَوْ كُنْتُمْ مَرْضى أَنْ تَضَعُوا أَسْلِحَتَكُمْ وَخُذُوا حِذْرَكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ أَعَدَّ لِلْكافِرِينَ عَذاباً مُهِيناً (102)

When you are among them and lead them in prayer, let one group stand with you, taking their weapons. After they prostrate, let them move behind you; another group that has not prayed should come and pray with you, also taking their precautions and arms. The unbelievers wish you to neglect your weapons and belongings so they could fall upon you in one assault. If rain causes hardship or you are ill, there is no blame in setting your weapons aside, but remain cautious. God has prepared a humiliating punishment for unbelievers.

Outward commentary

The instruction to the Prophet concerns the prayer of fear (*ṣalāt al-khawf*) and applies also, says Ibn ʿAjība, to the leaders who act in his place. One detachment joins the imām while another faces the enemy on guard. The praying group carries weapons. Once its portion of prayer is concluded, it completes the remainder under the imām's continuing prayer and moves out to guard. The second group comes and joins him for the remaining portion and completes its own prayer when he pronounces the closing salutation.

In the two-cycle prayer the leader performs a first cycle with one group, then remains standing—silent or reciting—while they complete a cycle and finish; the second group joins and performs one cycle with the leader, who concludes, and they complete their last cycle. In prayers of three or four cycles the leader performs two cycles with the first group; they finish the remainder, move to guard, and the second group joins the leader for the remaining cycles, completing any cycles they still owe. Ibn ʿAjība attributes this to Mālik and al-Shāfiʿī. Abū Ḥanīfa's transmitted procedure differs: the first group prays one cycle and retreats while still in prayer, the second joins for the next and moves back after the imām's salutation, and each group subsequently returns to complete its unperformed cycle. Ten views of the fear-prayer are reported, reflecting different Prophetic implementations and traditions. The Mālikī-Shāfiʿī form, he says, was practised in the expedition of Dhāt al-Riqāʿ.

Both detachments must remain cautious, for their enemies would seize any moment when Muslims abandoned equipment or watchfulness and attack as one. A report says the polytheists regretted not assaulting them during the noon prayer and waited for the afternoon prayer, which Muslims loved especially; Gabriel then brought the revelation describing prayer under threat. If rain, sickness or a similar impediment causes harm, the arms may be laid aside, but vigilance and guarding remain required. Another report associates this concession with ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf, who put down his arms while ill and was rebuked until the verse was revealed. God's promise of humiliating punishment for unbelievers, al-Bayḍāwī observes, follows the command to take precautions in order to strengthen believers' hearts: vigilance is not a confession of weakness but the proper observance of intelligent preparation.

Spiritual allusion

If you are among the troops of lights, enveloped by the Presence of mysteries, and descend again to the heaven of duties or the earth of ordinary satisfactions, let a detachment of those spiritual lights remain with you, guarding against the army of distractions and the troops of sorrows. Thus your return to created effects remains clothed in illumination and insight, and you return *through God*, not through self-reliance. When the heart prostrates before the Presence, the lights are behind it and the mysteries ahead, while “God encompasses them from behind” (85:20). Other people have not

yet experienced this prayer because they have not attained the station: let them join you in order to partake of its illumination, while guarding against thoughts and worldly preoccupations which could disrupt their presence before the Exalted. One whose heart is sick with appetite or other ailments is only charged with the degree of inward presence he can bear; the cat is not required to carry the camel's load. God knows best.

4:103 · Prayer, remembrance and appointed times

Cairo I:554

فَإِذا قَضَيْتُمُ الصَّلاةَ فَاذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ قِياماً وَقُعُوداً وَعَلى جُنُوبِكُمْ فَإِذَا اطْمَأْنَنْتُمْ فَأَقِيمُوا الصَّلاةَ إِنَّ الصَّلاةَ كانَتْ عَلَى الْمُؤْمِنِينَ كِتاباً مَوْقُوتاً (103)

When you have completed prayer, remember God while standing, sitting and lying on your sides. Once you are secure, establish the prayer in its ordinary form. Prayer has been prescribed for believers at appointed times.

Outward commentary

After completing prayer, remember God in every bodily state to protect your hearts and receive help against adversaries. Or, if in the heat of battle you need to fulfil prescribed prayer, perform it as possible: standing on foot or mounted, gesturing as necessary. In extreme necessity walking, running, thrusting, facing away from the qibla, holding stained equipment and giving urgent warnings may be permitted. The healthy pray as they can; the wounded or sick may pray seated or upon their sides. Ibn ʿAjība attributes this account of prayer during direct combat (*ṣalāt al-musāyafa*) to most jurists; Abū Ḥanīfa is reported to postpone such prayer until safety returns. [233]

Once the danger has passed, the prescribed form, conditions and pillars of prayer are to be observed completely. Prayer is a timed obligation (*kitāban mawqūtan*) and may not be taken outside its time in any circumstances. Al-Bayḍāwī takes the context to show that “remembrance” here can mean prayer itself, and that even amid actual hand-to-hand conflict it is to be performed by whatever means are possible.

233. Cairo editor, C555.1: Musāyafa: facing one another in combat with swords.

Spiritual allusion

On finishing the bodily prayer, immerse your states in the prayer of the heart until your hearts become settled in the sacred Presence. Then establish the prayer of witnessing and direct vision, the unceasing prayer: "Those who remain constant in their prayer" (70:23). Al-Wartajbī says that when you are established in spiritual mastery, filled with the lights of God's remembrance, you should leave behind the mere conveniences of concessions and resting in spiritual expansiveness and return to the station of prayer. He ends in the divine first person: "The end of your journey in My Lordship is the first beginning of your servanthood to Me." God knows best.

4:104 · Do not lose resolve

Cairo I:555

وَلا تَهِنُوا فِي ابْتِغاءِ الْقَوْمِ إِنْ تَكُونُوا تَأْلَمُونَ فَإِنَّهُمْ يَأْلَمُونَ كَما تَأْلَمُونَ وَتَرْجُونَ مِنَ اللَّهِ ما لا يَرْجُونَ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَلِيماً حَكِيماً (104)

Do not weaken in seeking out the opposing people. If you suffer pain, they suffer as you do; but you hope from God for what they do not hope. God is Knowing, Wise.

Language

I say: *wahn* means failure, feebleness and weakness. Do not flag in pursuing the enemy in the circumstances of the conflict. The suffering and injuries of war fall on both parties. If wounds cause you pain, they too are in pain; yet you seek victory and honour in this life and exalted ranks in the next, hopes not shared by them. Believers should therefore show greater patience and resolve. God knows actions and motives and acts with wisdom in what He commands and forbids.

Spiritual allusion

Do not grow weary in overcoming your lower souls or abandon the journey toward your Lord. Opposition to the appetites of the soul pains you, but it pains the soul too while it has not yet been disciplined in the divine Pres-

ence. When trained and beautified, what was bitter becomes sweet—after its figurative death and revived life. Continue its management and discipline: your hope is arrival at God, while its own inclination is toward familiar habits and indulgences. Reverse its wishes until it becomes peaceful in its Lord's Presence and its dangers no longer threaten. After true arrival there is no reverting to habitual self-indulgence. God prevails in His affair. The exposition next turns to guarding the tongue, the fifth theme treated in the sūrah.

4:105–109 · Justice and the treachery accusation

Cairo I:556–558

إِنَّا أَنْزَلْنا إِلَيْكَ الْكِتابَ بِالْحَقِّ لِتَحْكُمَ بَيْنَ النَّاسِ بِما أَراكَ اللَّهُ وَلا تَكُنْ لِلْخائِنِينَ خَصِيماً (105) وَاسْتَغْفِرِ اللَّهَ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ غَفُوراً رَحِيماً (106) وَلا تُجادِلْ عَنِ الَّذِينَ يَخْتانُونَ أَنْفُسَهُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ لا يُحِبُّ مَنْ كانَ خَوَّاناً أَثِيماً (107) يَسْتَخْفُونَ مِنَ النَّاسِ وَلا يَسْتَخْفُونَ مِنَ اللَّهِ وَهُوَ مَعَهُمْ إِذْ يُبَيِّتُونَ ما لا يَرْضى مِنَ الْقَوْلِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ بِما يَعْمَلُونَ مُحِيطاً (108) ها أَنْتُمْ هؤُلاءِ جادَلْتُمْ عَنْهُمْ فِي الْحَياةِ الدُّنْيا فَمَنْ يُجادِلُ اللَّهَ عَنْهُمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ أَمْ مَنْ يَكُونُ عَلَيْهِمْ وَكِيلاً (109)

We have sent down the Book to you with truth so that you may judge between people by what God has shown you. Do not plead for those who betray trust. Seek God's forgiveness: God is Forgiving, Merciful. Do not argue for people who betray their own souls; God does not love one persistently treacherous and sinful. They conceal themselves from people but do not conceal themselves from God, who is with them as they devise by night words He does not approve. God encompasses all that they do. Here you are, pleading their case in this life; but who will plead with God on their behalf on the Day of Resurrection, and who will act as their defender?

Language

I say: *arā* in "what God has shown you" means to acquaint someone with or make something known (*ʿirfāniyya*), not the construction denoting learned knowledge that takes three objects. Hence it does not govern three objects here.

Reported occasion. God addresses the Prophet when he was about to defend Ṭuʿma ibn Ubayriq. The report says Ṭuʿma stole a coat of mail belonging to his neighbour Qatāda ibn al-Nuʿmān, which was in a sack of flour. Flour trickled through a tear and marked the route. He concealed the armour in a Jewish man's house. When searched, Ṭuʿma swore he neither possessed nor knew of it. The flour trail led to the Jewish man's home. The latter said Ṭuʿma had entrusted him with the armour, and other Jews testified to it. Ṭuʿma's clan, Banū Ẓafar, asked the Prophet to defend their man, asserting that otherwise he would be disgraced and the Jewish man vindicated. Relying on appearances and not knowing the actual events, the Prophet considered speaking on his behalf. Then the revelation came.

Outward commentary

The Book was sent enveloped in truth so the Prophet could judge justly through what God makes known to him, whether by revelation or juridical effort (*ijtihād*). Ibn ʿAjība sees support here for analogy (*qiyās*) as recognised by the majority, although the exercise of independent judgment by prophets is itself disputed. "Do not be a disputant for traitors" means do not contend against the innocent for their sake or undertake their defence. "Ask forgiveness" concerns what had been contemplated, not a knowingly unjust judgment. He takes the verse as evidence that representing a protected non-Muslim is prohibited, as Ibn Shaʿbān also held, and records Ibn ʿĀt's suggestion that Ibn Shaʿbān may have intended abstention as a recommendation, and Mālik ibn Dīnār's saying that being the trusted agent of traitors is itself sufficient treachery. Advocacy is a trust. Nevertheless the Chosen Prophet did not knowingly intend treachery or comprehend the hidden facts until God revealed them; his initial wish to help, resting on the apparent evidence, does not detract from his station or entail liability. The verse discloses the actual circumstances of the dispute. [234]

234. Cairo editor, C557.1: Darak: liability.

The people who "betray themselves" are Ṭuʿma's associates, identified by al-Suhaylī as Bishr, Bashīr, Mubashshir and Usayr. God does not love one repeatedly deceitful and persistent in sin. Ibn ʿAjība transmits that Ṭuʿma later fled to Mecca, apostasised and tried to burgle another house through its wall, which collapsed upon and killed him. From the verse Ibn ʿAjība infers, all the more, a prohibition on arguing for someone whose treachery is known, or who is an object of suspicion of treachery, such as an unbeliever and the like. He cites Ibn al-ʿArabī's *Aḥkām al-Qurʾān*: "Representing a party in the wrong who is suspected in the dispute is not permissible, as evidenced by this verse."

People ashamed before their neighbours yet unashamed before God behave irrationally, since God is ever with them and knows what is hidden. Escape from His judgment comes only by abandoning what deserves censure inwardly and outwardly. To "devise words by night" means plotting false accusation of an innocent person, perjury and fabricated testimony. God encompasses their acts. They may have defended their associates in this world and concealed their disgrace, but no defender can protect them from judgment when concealed intentions are exposed and neither kinship nor friendship can avail them.

Spiritual allusion

The verses reproach judges and governors who discern signs and evidence pointing toward justice but rigidly cling to superficial legal appearance out of partisanship or bribery: judgment, says Ibn ʿAjība, relies considerably upon penetrating discernment (*firāsa*). They also admonish masters of formation who detect a defect in a disciple but conceal it out of embarrassment or pity. Hence their saying, "Pity does not befit a master of formation (*shaykh al-tarbiya*)." Yet the failing should be described generally without publicly naming the disciple, who recognises the admonition. Finally the verses censure Sufi poor (*fuqarāʾ*) who monitor people's approval, displaying what others like while hiding what would displease them. Instead, they should do the reverse of this. One of the people of the path said, "What you dislike in me is precisely what my heart desires." God knows best.

4:110 · Repentance and mercy

Cairo I:558

وَمَنْ يَعْمَلْ سُوءاً أَوْ يَظْلِمْ نَفْسَهُ ثُمَّ يَسْتَغْفِرِ اللَّهَ يَجِدِ اللَّهَ غَفُوراً رَحِيماً (110)

Whoever commits an evil or wrongs his own soul, then asks God to forgive him, will find God Forgiving, Merciful.

Outward commentary

Evil may refer to a shameful sin that harms someone else, while wronging oneself denotes a private transgression. Alternatively evil can mean a sin other than associationism and wronging the soul can mean associationism; or evil denotes a major sin and self-wrong a lesser sin. Whoever then seeks forgiveness through repentance finds God forgiving sins and merciful in accepting repentance. The wording urges Ṭuʿma and his associates to repent.

Spiritual allusion

Whoever commits wrong by inclining to appetite, or wrongs the soul by turning to what is other than God (*siwā*); whoever stumbles in fleeting thoughts or falls into prolonged inattentiveness; whoever stops at extraordinary spiritual graces (*karāmāt*) or the sweetness of devotions, or wrongs himself by contentment with his present rank and refusal to advance through the stations—then immediately seeks pardon, finds God forgiving and merciful. He has not cast that person from His Presence or abandoned him to heedlessness.

4:111–112 · The burden of wrongdoing

Cairo I:558

وَمَنْ يَكْسِبْ إِثْماً فَإِنَّما يَكْسِبُهُ عَلى نَفْسِهِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَلِيماً حَكِيماً (111) وَمَنْ يَكْسِبْ خَطِيئَةً أَوْ إِثْماً ثُمَّ يَرْمِ بِهِ بَرِيئاً فَقَدِ احْتَمَلَ بُهْتاناً وَإِثْماً مُبِيناً (112)

Whoever earns a sin earns it against himself; God is Knowing, Wise.
Whoever commits a fault or sin and then casts its blame upon an innocent person has borne a slanderous falsehood and a manifest sin.

Outward commentary

Theft, false oaths and laying a crime upon another are sins whose liability returns to the perpetrator. God knows the inward secrets of His servants and is wise in granting respite and concealing their faults. A “fault” (*khaṭīʾa*) may be an offence injuring another, whereas “sin” (*ithm*) can name wrongdoing confined to its perpetrator. If the guilty person then accuses an innocent person, as Ṭuʿma accused the Jewish man Zayd, he carries a *buhtān*: a slander which stuns the accused with a deed he never committed. He thereby bears an obviously abominable sin.

Spiritual allusion

Sin is what troubles the breast, remains unsettled there and meets no inward acceptance; its opposite, *birr* (righteous goodness), expands the breast and brings the heart peace. One who undertakes an action rejected by the inward conscience darkens the light of the soul and spirit. If he then projects his own defect upon another through suspicion, he compounds wrongdoing with false accusation. The traveller on the path should see purity in other people and locate the shortcoming in himself. The one who has arrived (*wāṣil*) sees perfection everywhere because the One truly recognised is seen through everything. God knows best.

4:113 · Divine protection and instruction

Cairo I:559

وَلَوْلا فَضْلُ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكَ وَرَحْمَتُهُ لَهَمَّتْ طائِفَةٌ مِنْهُمْ أَنْ يُضِلُّوكَ وَما يُضِلُّونَ إِلاَّ أَنْفُسَهُمْ وَما يَضُرُّونَكَ مِنْ شَيْءٍ وَأَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْكَ الْكِتابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَعَلَّمَكَ ما لَمْ تَكُنْ تَعْلَمُ وَكانَ فَضْلُ اللَّهِ عَلَيْكَ عَظِيماً (113)

Were it not for God's grace and mercy upon you, a party of them would have tried to lead you astray. Yet they mislead none but themselves and cannot harm you at all. God sent down to you the Book and wisdom and taught you what you had not known; God's favour toward you is immense.

Language

I say: the expression “in anything” (*min shay’*) has the syntactic force of an accusative verbal noun, “not the least amount of harm.” God's grace upon the Prophet consists in safeguarding from error (*‘iṣma*) and His mercy in providential care. The thief's associates, although aware of the events, tried to divert judgment from the truth. God's prior care prevented their plan from affecting the Prophet. The verse does not deny that they intended deception; it denies that the intention achieved its effect. Their error returns upon themselves. The contemplated defence rested only on the apparent circumstances, which is what the Prophet is charged to judge; God knows the inner realities. The Book is the Qur’ān, wisdom includes the wisdom voiced by the Prophet, and what was taught includes hidden matters and ordinances not previously known. Among the immeasurable divine favours upon him, none is greater than prophethood, above all when accompanied by his pre-eminence among creation, universal mission and the guidance God brought about through him as He had not through any prophet before him.

Spiritual allusion

Without the prior divine grace and protection surrounding God's saints, ordinary society would turn them from direct verification and attachments would destroy their progress along the path. When divine care precedes a person, the arrow of wrongdoing does not strike him. God makes their feet firm until landmarks of realised knowledge appear, removes the tarnish of veils from their hearts, opens to them the secrets of the Book, and causes fountains of wisdom and mystery to spring from them. They become acquainted with sciences not encompassed by book or register. Thus they acquire great good in both worlds; God's favour toward them is immense. After Ṭuʿma's theft became known, the text turns to the excessive whispering about his affair.

4:114 · Private talk, charity and reconciliation

Cairo I:560

لا خَيْرَ فِي كَثِيرٍ مِنْ نَجْواهُمْ إِلاَّ مَنْ أَمَرَ بِصَدَقَةٍ أَوْ مَعْرُوفٍ أَوْ إِصْلاحٍ بَيْنَ النَّاسِ وَمَنْ يَفْعَلْ ذلِكَ ابْتِغاءَ مَرْضاتِ اللَّهِ فَسَوْفَ نُؤْتِيهِ أَجْراً عَظِيماً (114)

There is no good in much of their private whispering, except in the speech of one who enjoins charity, an acknowledged good, or reconciliation among people. Whoever does this seeking God's pleasure, We shall grant a tremendous reward.

Language

If *najwā* denotes whispered speech, the exception “except one who commands...” is grammatically disconnected unless a noun is understood: “except the confidential speech of someone who commands...” If it denotes the company of whisperers, the exception is connected. This is Ibn Juzayy's observation.

Outward commentary

God encourages silence. There is no good in much of their private talk about the thief or others; indeed, Ibn ʿAjība says, there is no good in speech as a whole except when one enjoins charity, obligatory or voluntary, recognised right action (*maʿrūf*), or reconciliation. One who enjoins charity has a reward equal to that of its giver. *Maʿrūf* is what the revealed law approves and sound reason recognises, such as lending, rescuing someone in distress, educating the ignorant or guiding the lost. Reconciling those in conflict includes the dispute involving Ṭuʿma and the Jewish man. Mujāhid is cited for interpreting the verse universally, addressing conversations among all people. Whoever actually performs charity, beneficence or peacemaking, seeking God's satisfaction with sincerity, receives an abundant reward.

Al-Bayḍāwī notes the rhetoric: the verse praises commanding good yet attaches the reward to *doing* it. The one who enjoins good is included among the good, but the performer merits that description even more; commanding is important because it leads to action. Seeking God's pleasure is made a condition because actions are judged by intentions. A deed performed for display or reputation does not earn this divine reward. Calling that reward tremendous draws attention to how paltry worldly objectives are beside it.

Spiritual allusion

Silence is a strong pillar of Sufi formation and one of its four disciplines, joined by solitude, hunger and vigil. These mark the way of beginners; one without a beginning will have no completion. They say that the garden of the heart is cultivated as the tongue becomes quiet and is devastated as speech proliferates. As knowledge increases, talk decreases; with less knowledge, words abound. Whoever knows God finds the tongue exhausted before Him. Asked whether there had been more knowledge in former times or now, a scholar replied, “Knowledge was more abundant before, but speech is more abundant today.” The phrase “whoever does this” also indicates the superiority of action over learning that never produces practice. God knows best.

4:115–116 · Opposing the Messenger and the believers

Cairo I:561

وَمَنْ يُشاقِقِ الرَّسُولَ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما تَبَيَّنَ لَهُ الْهُدى وَيَتَّبِعْ غَيْرَ سَبِيلِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ نُوَلِّهِ ما تَوَلَّى وَنُصْلِهِ جَهَنَّمَ وَساءَتْ مَصِيراً (115) إِنَّ اللَّهَ لاَ يَغْفِرُ أَنْ يُشْرَكَ بِهِ وَيَغْفِرُ مَا دُونَ ذلِكَ لِمَنْ يَشاءُ وَمَنْ يُشْرِكْ بِاللَّهِ فَقَدْ ضَلَّ ضَلالاً بَعِيداً (116)

Whoever opposes the Messenger after guidance has become clear to him, and follows a path other than that of the believers, We shall leave him to what he has chosen and consign him to Hell—an evil destination. God does not forgive associating partners with Him, but forgives what is less than that to whomever He wills. Whoever associates anything with God has strayed very far indeed.

Language

I say: *mushāqqa* is opposition and estrangement, as if the two opponents occupied different sides (*shiqq*) of a division. Whoever departs from the Messenger after recognising his guidance through his miracles, and follows beliefs or conduct contrary to the believers' path, is left to the allegiance he selected and to the misguidance he embraced. Ibn ʿAjība, following al-Bayḍāwī, treats the two prohibited acts—opposing the Messenger and following a different communal path—as evidence that violating authoritative consensus (*ijmāʿ*) is forbidden, and consequently that the believers' agreed path is binding.

The next verse is also said to have been revealed concerning Ṭuʿma after his apostasy, or to repeat the condemnation of associationism for emphasis. Another report concerns an old man who asked the Prophet about long-standing sin, explaining that he had never associated partners with God, had never relied on another patron, had not sinned in deliberate defiance, had always known he could not elude God, and was repentant. The verse

was revealed, according to this report. Associationism constitutes the furthest departure from truth and rectitude. Al-Bayḍāwī explains that the earlier use of "fabricated a monstrous lie" fits the preceding controversy with the People of the Book, whose particular error involved making a claim about God.

Spiritual allusion

Whoever opposes his shaykh and follows a path other than his, God leaves him to what he has chosen and gradually draws him toward ruin without his noticing. A person may suppose that continuing spiritual gifts prove no error of conduct occurred, even though the gifts have been cut off without his awareness—or even though he is simply being left alone to his desires. In Ibn ʿAjība's account, leaving a master through whom openings and guidance have appeared, even for another imagined to be more perfect, is expulsion and estrangement, corrupts the seed of aspiration, and yields no result at all. [Translator's note: this claim concerns Ibn ʿAjība's school of discipleship and should be distinguished from the independent juristic limits of a teacher's authority.] God knows best.

4:117–121 · False objects of devotion and Satan's promises

Cairo I:562

إِنْ يَدْعُونَ مِنْ دُونِهِ إِلاَّ إِناثاً وَإِنْ يَدْعُونَ إِلاَّ شَيْطاناً مَرِيداً (117) لَعَنَهُ اللَّهُ وَقالَ لَأَتَّخِذَنَّ مِنْ عِبادِكَ نَصِيباً مَفْرُوضاً (118) وَلَأُضِلَّنَّهُمْ وَلَأُمَنِّيَنَّهُمْ وَلَآمُرَنَّهُمْ فَلَيُبَتِّكُنَّ آذانَ الْأَنْعامِ وَلَآمُرَنَّهُمْ فَلَيُغَيِّرُنَّ خَلْقَ اللَّهِ وَمَنْ يَتَّخِذِ الشَّيْطانَ وَلِيًّا مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ فَقَدْ خَسِرَ خُسْراناً مُبِيناً (119) يَعِدُهُمْ وَيُمَنِّيهِمْ وَما يَعِدُهُمُ الشَّيْطانُ إِلاَّ غُرُوراً (120) أُولئِكَ مَأْواهُمْ جَهَنَّمُ وَلا يَجِدُونَ عَنْها مَحِيصاً (121)

What they invoke apart from Him are only female beings, and what they invoke is a rebellious Satan, cursed by God. He said, “I shall take an appointed share of Your servants. I shall surely mislead them, fill them with vain hopes, command them to slit the ears of cattle, and command them to change God's creation.” Whoever takes Satan as a patron instead of God has plainly lost. Satan promises and tempts them with hopes, but his promises are deception. Their refuge is Hell, from which they shall find no escape.

Language

I say: *marīd* or *māri*d can describe something to which no good adheres. The root’s basic sense is [smoothness], with the examples of a smooth palace, a beardless youth and a tree whose leaves have fallen; this is attributed to al-Bayḍāwī. [Translator’s textual note: Cairo I:562 prints *li-l-mulābasa*, “association” or “intermingling,” as does the checked electronic text of al-Bayḍāwī. Abū al-Suʿūd on 4:117 explicitly has *li-l-malāsa*, “smoothness,” beside the same palace and bare-tree examples. Those examples and the exact earlier parallel establish the intended lexical explanation. The bracketed English adopts it openly; it does not claim that Cairo or an independently checked manuscript of Ibn ʿAjība prints the corrected word. See source check XII-S062.] Another explanation is defiant and intensely rebellious, departing from obedience.

Outward commentary

The female entities invoked apart from God may be idols named with feminine nouns—al-Lāt, al-ʿUzzā and Manāt—or lifeless objects capable only of being acted upon, whereas divinity demands an agent, not something passively acted upon. Or the verse may mean the angels, falsely regarded by their worshippers as divine daughters. In reality such worship answers Satan, who encouraged it and, in some reports, spoke from the interior of the idols. God cursed Satan, distancing him from mercy. Satan claimed an allotted share of servants, resolved to mislead them and promised false hopes of long life, denial of resurrection or immunity from judgment.

His command to slit livestock ears refers to the custom of marking *baḥīra* and *sāʾiba* animals and prohibiting what God permitted. By extension it refers to wrongfully forbidding permitted things and damaging an integrity God created, whether actually realised or latent. “Changing God's creation”

may concern bodily alteration or change of attributes. Ibn ʿAjība lists castration of slaves, tattooing and plucking eyebrows; al-Bayḍāwī adds sodomy (*liwāṭ*) and female same-sex sexual activity (*musāḥaqa*), worship of the sun and moon, replacing the primordial disposition (*fiṭra*) of Islam, and employing limbs and capacities in ways that bring the soul no perfection or divine nearness. Although the verse's generality seems to prohibit castration, jurists made an exception for castrating animals where a recognised need existed. The four clauses reporting Satan's resolutions may recount words actually spoken or deeds through which the intentions were expressed.

To take Satan as a protecting companion by obeying his commands in preference to God's is a manifest loss: the person forfeits the capital of life and substitutes a place in Hell for the promised place in Paradise. Satan makes promises he cannot fulfil, arouses desires for things never to be given, and disguises harm as benefit, including the delusion that his followers are right and best entitled to Paradise. Such people will find no turning away (*maḥīṣ*) from the consequence; *ḥāṣa* means to turn aside.

Spiritual allusion

Whatever you love, you become its slave. Beware of serving “female idols” in the sense of loving the lower soul and preferring its appetite to the Lord's claim. Likewise do not become the slave of a woman, a fine garment, an animal, or any other object of appetite that you love. Nor yield to Satan's efforts to make you estranged from the Most Generous. The *Ḥikam* warns: “When you know that Satan does not neglect you, do not neglect the One who holds your forelock.” Occupy yourself with love of the Beloved: it suffices against the enmity of the enemy. Take God as intimate patron and companion, put Satan aside and become absent from his suggestions through immersion in the Presence of direct witnessing. God gives success. [235]

235. Cairo editor, C563.1: Khamiṣa: a garment of khazz cloth or wool.

4:122 · The promise to believers

Cairo I:563

وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحاتِ سَنُدْخِلُهُمْ جَنَّاتٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهارُ خالِدِينَ فِيها أَبَداً وَعْدَ اللَّهِ حَقًّا وَمَنْ أَصْدَقُ مِنَ اللَّهِ قِيلاً (122)

Those who believe and perform righteous works—We shall admit them to gardens beneath which rivers flow, abiding there forever: God's truthful promise. Whose word is truer than God's?

Language

I say: *waʿda llāhi* is a confirming verbal noun reinforcing its own action —"He promised them a promise." *Ḥaqqan* confirms the substance of the preceding statement, as al-Bayḍāwī explains. Those who profess God's unity and perform the works imposed upon them are admitted to eternal gardens. No speech is more truthful than God's. The verse counterposes God's dependable promise to His intimates against the false promises Satan offers his associates, and encourages attaining the means of that promise.

Spiritual allusion

Those who unite recognition of the oneness of majestic Lordship (*rubūbiyya*) with the actual duties of servanthood (*ʿubūdiyya*) will enter the garden of direct knowledges (*jannat al-maʿārif*), beneath which flow rivers of sciences, abiding there in enduring felicity. The promise is true, but it is not obtained through fantasies joined to idleness: it is acquired through upright works and purified intentions, as the following verse makes plain.

4:123 · Merit, religion and accountability

Cairo I:564

لَيْسَ بِأَمانِيِّكُمْ وَلا أَمانِيِّ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ مَنْ يَعْمَلْ سُوءاً يُجْزَ بِهِ وَلا يَجِدْ لَهُ مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ وَلِيًّا وَلا نَصِيراً (123)

It is not according to your wishes, nor the wishes of the People of the Book. Whoever commits an evil shall receive its recompense, and will find no protecting friend or helper apart from God.

Language

I say: the suppressed subject of *laysa* is “the matter,” so the sense is: “the matter is not governed by your wishes.” The promise given to believers is not attained by the Muslims' hopes alone or by those of the People of the Book. God will judge between servants by deeds. A report tells of mutual boasting: the People of the Book argued their prophets and scriptures preceded those of Muslims; Muslims claimed precedence because their Prophet was the Seal and their Book confirmed and governed earlier books. Another interpretation addresses polytheists who denied Paradise and Hell, or who imagined they would fare better than believers should the hereafter prove true. The People of the Book's wishful claims include that the Fire would touch them only briefly and that Paradise was reserved for Jews or Christians.

Wrongdoing must be accounted for, whether now or later. Abū Bakr is reported to have feared, when the verse was revealed, that no one could be saved if every wrong brought retribution. The Prophet reminded him that sorrow, sickness and life's severe difficulties themselves answer part of that account. Outside God no guardian or helper can repel His judgment. [236]

236. Cairo editor, C564.1: Laʾwāʾ: hardship and straitened living.

Spiritual allusion

High stations cannot be reached by empty wishing and boasts. They require lofty aspiration (*himam*), vigorous spiritual exertion (*mujāhada*), good works and purified states. Verses are recited:

> Sublimity is won in proportion to the toil;
> whoever seeks honour spends the nights awake.
> You desire exaltation, yet sleep through the night—
> the seeker of pearls must dive into the sea.

According to the report, the People of the Book responded that Muslims and themselves had been made equal; the following verse then makes the distinctive requirements of belief and work clear.

4:124–126 · Faithful works and the Garden

Cairo I:565–566

وَمَنْ يَعْمَلْ مِنَ الصَّالِحاتِ مِنْ ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنْثى وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَأُولئِكَ يَدْخُلُونَ الْجَنَّةَ وَلا يُظْلَمُونَ نَقِيراً (124) وَمَنْ أَحْسَنُ دِيناً مِمَّنْ أَسْلَمَ وَجْهَهُ لِلَّهِ وَهُوَ مُحْسِنٌ وَاتَّبَعَ مِلَّةَ إِبْراهِيمَ حَنِيفاً وَاتَّخَذَ اللَّهُ إِبْراهِيمَ خَلِيلاً (125) وَلِلَّهِ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ مُحِيطاً (126)

Whoever does righteous deeds, male or female, being a believer, such people shall enter the Garden and will not be wronged even by the mark on a date-stone. Who is better in religion than one who submits his whole face to God, acts excellently and follows Abraham's upright way? God took Abraham as His intimate friend (khalīl). To God belongs whatever is in the heavens and the earth; God encompasses all things.

Language

I say: “Male or female” and “being a believer” are circumstantial expressions qualifying the performer; *ḥanīfan* is circumstantial concerning Abraham, since the annexed noun (“way”) is a part of that to which it is annexed (Abraham). Whoever performs some of the righteous deeds—namely, the important duties imposed upon him, since a human being cannot accomplish every such action—whether male or female, enters the promise equally: women are the counterparts of men in works. Faith is the condition for the acceptance of these deeds. Those who act in faith enter Paradise, whether the verb is construed as their doing so or God admitting them. They are deprived of no amount of reward, not even the *naqīr*, the tiny indentation on a date-stone. Al-Bayḍāwī observes that if the obedient do not lose the least of their reward, sinners will still less have their punishment increased unjustly, for the Rewarder is the Most Merciful.

The finest religion belongs to one who yields the whole self to the Lord, practices excellence (*iḥsān*) through divine unity and behaves rightly both toward God and toward His servants, and follows the upright religion of Abraham. In Ibn ʿAjība's presentation this is achieved by entering the Muḥammadan religion, which accords with Abraham’s religion—indeed, is that very religion; anyone who claims to follow Abraham’s religion but has not entered it has, he says, lied. God took Abraham as *khalīl*: He selected him and singled him out for an honour resembling that of an intimate friend with his friend. Repeating Abraham's proper name magnifies him and identifies the one praised. He is called *khalīl* because love of God permeated every part of his being.

Ibn ʿAjība reports that Abraham was known as the father of guests because his home stood beside a road and he fed travellers. In a famine crowds came to his door. Every year a friend in Egypt normally sent him supplies. Abraham sent servants with camels, but the Egyptian friend replied that even he lacked provisions: he would help Abraham personally but could not feed all of Abraham's guests. Ashamed to return with empty sacks, the servants filled them with soft sand as they passed through a valley. Abraham learned their news and worried about his hungry visitors, then slept. Sarah awoke and said, “Glory be to God! Have the servants not arrived?” They replied, “Yes.” She went to the sacks and found in them the purest white flour. They baked bread and fed the guests. Abraham awoke and

smelled bread. Told it had come from his Egyptian friend, he answered, “It is from my intimate Friend, God.” It was then, the report says, that God named him His intimate friend. [Cairo editor’s note: citing Ibn Kathīr, the editor questions this story’s authenticity and occurrence. At most, he says, it is an Israelite report, neither affirmed nor denied. Abraham was called God’s intimate friend because of his intense love for God, expressed in obedience that God loves and approves.] Al-Zajjāj explains *khalīl* either as one whose love has no flaw (*khalal*) or one who refers his need (*khalla*) wholly and sincerely to God. Since all heavens and earth are God's created possessions and servants, He chooses whom He wills for love, intimacy and service. His knowledge and power encompass all things and He recompenses every intention and striving. [237]

Spiritual allusion

Direct vision corresponds to the measure of struggle and hardship; endings correspond to beginnings. A beginning radiant with sincere aspiration leads to a radiant end. Reward is proportioned to aspiration (*himma*): one who works for a garden of outward delights enjoys it, and one who works for the garden of divine knowledges enjoys that; God wrongs no one. No one is finer than the person entirely surrendered to the Lord. One clinging to Abraham's upright way, understood inwardly as total severance from everything but God, grasps the firmest handle and reaches a summit of reverent godliness. Whoever takes on the Beloved's moral qualities becomes nearer to God than any other who is near. God gives success. Giving a *fatwā* in accord with the truth is one of the matters concerning guarding the tongue. It is therefore mentioned after the command to judge justly; the intervening discussion is a digression into which the discourse was drawn.

237. Cairo editor, C566.1: Ibn Kathīr said: The authenticity of this and its occurrence are questionable. At most it is an Israelite report, neither to be affirmed nor denied. He was called God’s intimate friend only because of his intense love for his Lord—exalted and majestic—and the obedience he rendered Him, which He loves and approves.

4:127 · Justice toward orphan women

Cairo I:566–568

وَيَسْتَفْتُونَكَ فِي النِّساءِ قُلِ اللَّهُ يُفْتِيكُمْ فِيهِنَّ وَما يُتْلى عَلَيْكُمْ فِي الْكِتابِ فِي يَتامَى النِّساءِ اللاَّتِي لا تُؤْتُونَهُنَّ ما كُتِبَ لَهُنَّ وَتَرْغَبُونَ أَنْ تَنْكِحُوهُنَّ وَالْمُسْتَضْعَفِينَ مِنَ الْوِلْدانِ وَأَنْ تَقُومُوا لِلْيَتامى بِالْقِسْطِ وَما تَفْعَلُوا مِنْ خَيْرٍ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ بِهِ عَلِيماً (127)

They seek your legal ruling concerning women. Say: God gives you a ruling about them, and also what is recited to you in the Book concerning orphan girls to whom you do not give what is prescribed for them and whom you desire—or refuse—to marry, and the helpless children. You are commanded to deal justly with orphans. Whatever good you do, God knows it.

Language

I say: “What is recited to you” (*mā yutlā*) is coordinated with “God”: God gives the ruling, as does what is recited in the Book. The preposition governing *targhabūna an tankiḥūhunna* (“you desire to marry them”) has been omitted and can be either *fī* or *ʿan*, so that it condemns both wishing to marry an attractive orphan at an unfair dower and declining to marry an unattractive one while obstructing her marriage. “The helpless children” can be coordinated with “orphan girls” in the preceding reference, pointing to “God instructs you concerning your children” (4:11), or to the pronoun in “concerning them.” “That you act justly” can be coordinated with the same object or depend upon an omitted expression meaning “and He commands you to deal justly.”

Outward commentary

People ask the Prophet for rulings on women's inheritance and other rights. God commands granting them their rightful shares, already specified earlier in the sūrah, including provisions on the wealth of orphans, marriage of

wards and children's inheritance. Guardians must not withhold the dower prescribed for orphan girls and then marry them for less than the dower customarily owing to their peers. If the guardian wishes to marry a beautiful, wealthy orphan, justice requires giving her a suitable dower, otherwise marrying someone else. If he refuses to marry a girl because she is considered unattractive, he may not obstruct her marriage to others in order to inherit her property. In pre-Islamic practice, says Ibn ʿAjība, guardians sought attractive and wealthy orphans without appropriate dowers, while neglecting and obstructing those without beauty or means. Both practices are prohibited.

The helpless children too must be given inheritance shares along with adults, although people had formerly withheld inheritance from minors. He transmits that ʿUyayna ibn Ḥiṣn objected to children and women inheriting when custom had rewarded only those who could fight and gather booty; the Prophet replied that this was what he had been commanded. God also addresses the leaders (*al-aʾimma*), commanding them to administer orphans' affairs with justice, protect their rights and take precautions for them in all their affairs. God knows the good they perform and rewards them accordingly.

Spiritual allusion

The question can be understood as concerning the "feminine" forms of formal sciences and the "orphan" fruits of the heart, arising from contemplation: divinely granted inward knowledge (*ʿilm ladunnī*) and lordly secrets of the science of reality (*ḥaqīqa*). These are fitting only for those deemed weak among created beings. The saying is cited that the people of Paradise include a weak, despised person whose oath God would fulfil. The response directs the seeker to acquire from formal sciences what is needed to perform worship correctly, to desire the science of the path (*ṭarīqa*) that concerns the heart and establishes servanthood, and to seek from contemplative insights what reveals the Lord's majesty. Justice requires giving the revealed law (*sharīʿa*) its right, the path its right, and guarding the secrets of reality from those unfit to receive them. God does not squander the reward of those who excel.

4:128 · Marital reconciliation and avarice

Cairo I:568

وَإِنِ امْرَأَةٌ خافَتْ مِنْ بَعْلِها نُشُوزاً أَوْ إِعْراضاً فَلا جُناحَ عَلَيْهِما أَنْ يُصْلِحا بَيْنَهُما صُلْحاً وَالصُّلْحُ خَيْرٌ وَأُحْضِرَتِ الْأَنْفُسُ الشُّحَّ وَإِنْ تُحْسِنُوا وَتَتَّقُوا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ خَبِيراً (128)

If a woman fears aversion or neglect from her husband, there is no blame on the two if they arrange reconciliation between themselves; reconciliation is better. Avarice has been made present to human souls. If you act with excellence and reverent care, God is fully aware of what you do.

Language

I say: *imraʾa* is the subject of an understood verb explained by the verb following. The original form of "reconcile" (*yaṣṣālaḥā*) is *yataṣālaḥā*, with assimilation; *ṣulḥan* is a verbal noun. The Kūfan reading *yuṣliḥā* is the causative fourth form, in which *ṣulḥan* may be an object or an accusative of action. "Between them" can be adverbial or circumstantial. "Reconciliation is better" and "avarice has been made present to souls" are parenthetic clauses; hence their different formal constructions cause no difficulty.

Outward commentary

A wife may expect *nushūz*, an aloofness that refuses intimate companionship or neglects her rights because her husband dislikes her, or *iʿrāḍ*, turning away from her in visits or conversation. They may establish an agreed settlement: for example, she may freely waive part of a dower or a share of alternating nights with another wife, or offer something intended to renew their relationship. Ibn ʿAjība reports several occasions of revelation: Saʿd ibn al-Rabīʿ is said to have favoured a younger woman he married over an existing wife. Another report concerns an older mother who asked not to be divorced, but to remain with her children and receive an occasional night or none. When this was mentioned to the Prophet, he said, "God has

heard what you say; if He wills, He will answer you." The verse was then revealed, according to the report. A further report concerns Sawda: when she grew old, the Prophet wished to separate from her, but she asked to remain among his wives and, according to the account, gave her allotted turn to ʿĀ'isha, saying that she wished to be raised at the Resurrection among his wives.

Reconciliation is better than separation, acrimony or continual hostile cohabitation, and has intrinsic goodness. It can occur only when one of the disputants relinquishes some personal right, which is why the soul finds it burdensome and clings to that right. A wife may not readily surrender claims, and a husband who dislikes her may struggle to maintain kind companionship. God's command nevertheless requires goodness in marital treatment and watchfulness against rejection, neglect and deficient performance of the wife's rights, despite personal aversion. God sees generosity as well as injustice and recompenses accordingly. Ibn ʿAjība also cites an edifying report promising a reward like Job's to one who endures a spouse's hurt. [Translator's note: the precise attribution of this report has not been verified here.]

Spiritual allusion

Know that the lower soul is like a woman when a man marries her. If she sees her husband earnest in his affairs and reserved toward her, she stands in awe of him and obeys his command. If she sees softness and pliancy in him, she makes light of his command and gains the upper hand over him; awe of him falls from her heart, and she pays no heed to his commands and prohibitions. Likewise, when the lower soul sees the novice's earnestness at the beginning and his forcefulness toward it, it stands in awe of him and listens and obeys. If it sees laxness and leniency in him, it gains the upper hand, and making it obey and struggling against it become difficult. If, after he has assailed and subdued it, it wants to make peace with him on condition that he indulges it in certain matters and it accommodates him in what he wants from it, there is no blame in their making peace, and peace is better: continued severity may lead to weariness. Once you know it, deal well with it and fear God in managing and training it until it brings you into the Presence of its Lord. [Translator's note: this paragraph applies a marital analogy to training the lower soul; it does not formulate a legal ruling on marital conduct.]

4:129 · Equity between wives and human limitation

Cairo I:569

وَلَنْ تَسْتَطِيعُوا أَنْ تَعْدِلُوا بَيْنَ النِّساءِ وَلَوْ حَرَصْتُمْ فَلا تَمِيلُوا كُلَّ الْمَيْلِ فَتَذَرُوها كَالْمُعَلَّقَةِ وَإِنْ تُصْلِحُوا وَتَتَّقُوا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ غَفُوراً رَحِيماً (129)

You shall never be able to deal with wives in perfect equality, however earnestly you seek it. But do not incline entirely to one and leave another suspended, neither truly married nor free. If you restore matters and remain mindful of God, God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Outward commentary

Husbands cannot achieve absolute equality in speech, actions, spending, clothing and inward affection, no matter how they strive, because of the weakness of the human condition. He then says, in the divine first person, “I have lightened [the requirement] for you and removed hardship from you,” followed in the printed text by, “Equality in the house alone is not obligatory.” [Textual note: Cairo I:569 reads فلا يجب العدل في البيت فقط. Besides “house,” *bayt* can mean spending the night: *Lisān al-ʿArab*, II:16, lists it among the verbal nouns of *bāta*. The following account of dividing turns among wives makes that sense plausible here. It does not settle the scope of “not” and “only,” however. Earlier parallels in Ibn Juzayy and al-Bayḍāwī explain the concession for unattainable perfect equality but do not supply this disputed clause.] Ibn ʿAjība cites the reported supplication of the Prophet when distributing his turns among his wives: “O God, this is my division concerning what I control; do not hold me to account for what I do not control,” meaning the heart's leaning. ʿUmar is quoted similarly: the heart is not his to command, but in other affairs he hopes to act justly. Ibn ʿAjība says absolute equality in intercourse is not imposed, though a husband must not deliberately reserve all his sensual energy for one wife to the neglect of another.

Do not incline so completely toward a favoured younger or more attractive wife in clothing, maintenance and attention that the other is left "suspended"—not enjoying actual married companionship, yet not divorced and free to form a new household. The Prophet is reported to warn that the man who shows unjust partiality toward one of two wives will appear on the Day of Resurrection with one side inclined. If husbands correct previous unfairness and abstain from injustice in future, God is merciful and forgives what has passed.

Spiritual allusion · capacity and moderation

Weakness and incapacity are among the essential marks of servanthood. However diligent a person becomes, complete perfection in all responsibilities is beyond him. He should recognise his proper condition, return to the Lord and do what is within capacity, without surrendering entirely to laziness or trying to accomplish what he has no power to bear. Excessive self-imposed complication is not the way of the people of divine unity; they consent to decrees and rest beneath the judgment of the irresistible One. Do not incline wholly to spiritual severity, leaving the soul suspended and imprisoned. The veiled can become detained within spiritual stations and states, distracted from God by their sweetness; losing those states then leaves them bereft. Those enriched through God do not stop with any state or station: whatever the divine power unfolds, they receive it and assume its appropriate colour. This is *talwīn*—responsive change—after *tamkīn*, spiritual establishment.

Another spiritual allusion. Divine power (*qudra*) and wisdom (*ḥikma*) are like two spouses to the heart, which dwells for a time with one and then with the other. With wisdom it is in the station of servanthood, marked by ignorance, heedlessness, weakness and lowliness; with power it witnesses lordship, characterised by knowledge, awakening, strength and dignity. The human being cannot deal equally with the two, yet should not abandon one wholly for the other. Both must be recognised and given their appropriate rights. If you purify your hearts and remain attentive to what distracts from the Lord, He forgives your leaning toward one of the two sides. God knows best.

4:130 · Separation and God’s sufficiency

Cairo I:570–571

وَإِنْ يَتَفَرَّقا يُغْنِ اللَّهُ كُلاًّ مِنْ سَعَتِهِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ واسِعاً حَكِيماً (130)

If the two separate, God will enrich each out of His abundance. God is Vast and Wise.

Outward commentary

If husband and wife separate, God will make each independent of the other by another suitable partner, consolation or sustaining provision from His boundless generosity. He is vast in power and precise in every ordinance and deed. The following declaration that everything in the heavens and earth belongs to Him explains the source of that abundance: every creature lives under His will, protection and governance. He gives each whatever is necessary to sustain them and frees them from dependence upon another. God knows best.

Spiritual allusion

So long as the spirit remains imprisoned beneath the domination of bodily human nature and veiled from the witnessing of lordship, it remains hungry, thirsty and needy, attaching itself passionately to created objects. When it separates from that tyranny and departs from the prison of bodily form, its reflective faculty leaves the imprisonment of created appearances. God makes it wealthy through the witnessing of His Essence, granting it the ample space of direct vision and presence. It comes to possess all created things. It is said: “You are with created things as long as you do not witness their Creator; once you witness the Creator, created things are with you.” God also frees bodily nature from the fatigue of service, and it rests in the shade of knowledge. Through that separation each receives sufficiency out of God's bounty, for He is boundless in generosity and wise in arranging provision for every existent.

4:131–133 · The imperative of reverent awareness

Cairo I:570–573

وَلِلَّهِ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ وَلَقَدْ وَصَّيْنَا الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتابَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ وَإِيَّاكُمْ أَنِ اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَإِنْ تَكْفُرُوا فَإِنَّ لِلَّهِ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ غَنِيًّا حَمِيداً (131) وَلِلَّهِ مَا فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ وَكِيلاً (132) إِنْ يَشَأْ يُذْهِبْكُمْ أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ وَيَأْتِ بِآخَرِينَ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَلى ذلِكَ قَدِيراً (133)

Everything in the heavens and earth belongs to God. We instructed those given the Book before you, and you yourselves, to remain mindful of God. If you disbelieve, whatever is in the heavens and earth belongs to God, who is Self-Sufficient and Praiseworthy. Everything in the heavens and earth belongs to God, and God is enough as Guardian. If He wills, He can remove you, O humanity, and bring others in your place. God is fully able to do so.

Spiritual allusion · Abiding through God

Ibn ʿAjība finds an allusion in “To God belongs whatever is in the heavens and the earth”: whoever abides through God and attains the witnessing of His Essence, God gives him dominion over whatever is in the heavens and the earth, and he becomes God’s deputy in His kingdom. “That is not difficult for God.”

After speaking of women, whom he calls “Satan’s snares,” Ibn ʿAjība says that their temptation distracts from remembrance of the All-Merciful. He says that God therefore warns against their temptation, as is His custom in His Book whenever He mentions them. [Translator’s note: this description of women belongs to the historical source’s ascetic rhetoric.] God then commands *taqwā*, the protection against every trial.

Language · The construction of the instruction

I say: “before you” may attach either to “were given” or to “We instructed”; “and you” is coordinated with “those.” “To fear God” may have an omitted governing preposition, or *an* may introduce what the instruction consists in. “If you disbelieve” follows an understood “We said to them and to you.”

Outward commentary

All preceding communities entrusted with revelation—the communities of Torah, Gospel and Psalms, and others—were instructed, as Muslims are now, to obey God's commands and avoid His prohibitions inwardly and outwardly. They are told that He has no need for either their unbelief or thanksgiving. All heavens and earth and obedient angels already belong to Him. Their denial does not diminish Him and their gratitude does not increase Him: the instruction proceeds from mercy for their welfare, not from divine need. “Self-Sufficient, Praiseworthy” means entirely independent of creation and intrinsically deserving praise, whether anyone praises Him or not.

The repetition of the ownership of heavens and earth for a third time, al-Bayḍāwī explains, strengthens both attributes: the neediness of creatures demonstrates His sufficiency, while the existence and particular perfections He bestows disclose why He is praised. As *Wakīl*, He protects those who entrust themselves to Him. If human beings resist the demand for *taqwā*, He can replace them with another people more devoted and obedient. Al-Bayḍāwī sees a further proof of God's sufficiency and power and a warning to those who deny His command. One interpretation addresses Arabs opposing the Prophet, alongside “If you turn away, He will replace you with another people” (47:38). Ibn ʿAjība cites the report that the Prophet placed his hand on Salmān's back and said, “These are that man's people.”

Spiritual allusion · the degrees of *taqwā*

God-consciousness is the foundation of the path and the method of those who realise the truth. Through it wayfarers travel and people of arrival reach their goal; God enjoined it upon earlier and later communities and by it brought His chosen servants near. It has five degrees: guarding against unbelief, the station of Islam; guarding against prohibited deeds, the station of repentance; guarding against doubtful matters, the station of

scrupulousness (*waraʿ*); guarding against permissible things, the station of renunciation (*zuhd*); and guarding against witnessing what is other than God and sensory appearances, the station of witnessing (*mushāhada*).

He enumerates fifteen virtues associated with *taqwā* from Qurʾānic verses (following Ibn Juzayy): guidance (2:2); divine help and victory (16:128); God's protective friendship (45:19); divine love (3:76); illumination and discernment (*furqān*, 8:29); an exit from distress and provision from unexpected sources (65:2–3); ease in difficult affairs (65:4); removal of sins and augmentation of reward (65:5); acceptance of good works (5:27); success (5:100); glad tidings in this life and the next (10:64); gardens of bliss (68:34); and salvation from the Fire (19:72). [Translator's note: the count of fifteen separates the paired effects—relief from distress and unexpected provision, and forgiveness of sins and enlargement of reward—rather than counting the cited verses.]

A poem attributed to Ibn Mashīsh is then cited:

> Hold fast to God-consciousness in secret and in public,
> if you desire success upon the pathways of the good;
> reverent care is the root of every act of righteousness,
> so grasp it and obtain each kind of excellence.
> The best provision is that which our Lord declared:
> my brother, therefore, obey God's command.

Since all sovereignty belongs to Him, the next verse encourages people to take their needs directly to Him.

4:134 · Reward in this world and the next

Cairo I:573

مَنْ كانَ يُرِيدُ ثَوابَ الدُّنْيا فَعِنْدَ اللَّهِ ثَوابُ الدُّنْيا وَالْآخِرَةِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ سَمِيعاً بَصِيراً (134)

Whoever desires the reward of this world—with God rests the reward of this world and of the next. God is Hearing, Seeing.

Language

I say: *man* is conditional, with its answer omitted but made clear by what follows: whoever desires worldly reward should ask for it from God, since He possesses both worlds; or one seeking worldly recompense should not confine the aspiration to that alone, since the reward of both worlds is with God. A person who desires worldly ease should seek it from God, or better should also seek the hereafter, praying "Our Lord, grant us good in the world and good in the hereafter" (2:201). God gives both together to whoever seeks them. The second understanding is more uplifting than the first. More complete than either is the person who turns away from both and seeks the Lord Himself. God hears and sees the intentions of creatures and bestows what accords with their purposes.

Spiritual allusion

Aspirations (*himam*) are three: lowly aspiration attached to the lower world; middle aspiration seeking the delights of the hereafter; and high aspiration directed to the Most High. God provides to a servant in proportion to the scope of aspiration, and through aspiration stations rise or fall. Whoever desires the lowest is correspondingly low in rank. The middle aspirant passes from one created condition to another, like a mill-donkey turning around its wheel and arriving again at the same place. A person of lofty aspiration rises high, attains what both worlds contain, and in addition receives vision of their Creator. May God make us among them through bounty and generosity. The commentary next extends the demand for justice from marriage to all judgments.

4:135 · Testimony, impartiality, and justice

Cairo I:573–575

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا كُونُوا قَوَّامِينَ بِالْقِسْطِ شُهَداءَ لِلَّهِ وَلَوْ عَلى أَنْفُسِكُمْ أَوِ الْوالِدَيْنِ وَالْأَقْرَبِينَ إِنْ يَكُنْ غَنِيًّا أَوْ فَقِيراً فَاللَّهُ أَوْلى بِهِما فَلا تَتَّبِعُوا الْهَوى أَنْ تَعْدِلُوا وَإِنْ تَلْوُوا أَوْ تُعْرِضُوا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ بِما تَعْمَلُونَ خَبِيراً (135)

O believers, stand firmly for justice, bearing witness for God's sake even against yourselves, your parents or your nearest kin. Whether the person concerned is rich or poor, God has a greater claim over both. Do not follow desire, lest you depart from justice. If you distort your testimony or turn away, God is fully aware of what you do.

Language

I say: *shuhadāʾ* may be a second predicate of “be” or a circumstantial expression. “God has a greater claim” supplies the reason: do not avoid testimony against the wealthy out of reverence or the poor out of pity, for God is more concerned for each than you are. The dual pronoun in “both” refers to the two classes of rich and poor, not simply to a singular person connected by “or,” which would require a singular pronoun. “That you act justly” is an expression of purpose, understood either as desire for justice or as aversion to deviating from the truth. The reading *talū*, with a *ḍamma* on the *lām*, is explained by transferring the *wāw*’s *ḍamma* to the *lām* and deleting one of the two *wāw*s; alternatively it derives from *wilāya*, exercising a governing charge.

Outward commentary

God commands persistence and strenuous commitment to equitable judgment. Witnesses are to give truthful testimony for God's pleasure, not for a gift or material return. This applies when giving the testimony is incumbent on that particular person and undertaking it causes no hardship; oth-

erwise, compensation for his trouble is permitted. Even against themselves they must acknowledge debts or other facts, since testimony communicates the truth whether the fact favours the speaker or not. Filial respect and compassion must not prevent evidence against parents or relatives; still less should deference to strangers. Wealth must not awe the witness, and poverty must not lead to the suppression of truth through indulgent pity. God knows what benefits each and has instituted lawful testimony for their welfare. Do not follow passion by favouring either party. Twisting the tongue to deform testimony or turning away and suppressing it is known to God, who recompenses both the witness and the concealer.

Ibn ʿAjība reports that, when this verse was revealed, the Prophet said: "Whoever believes in God and the Last Day, let him give his testimony against whomever it concerns. Whoever believes in God and the Last Day must not deny a right owed by him; let him discharge it willingly, without forcing the claimant to appeal to the ruler and contest the matter in order to recover his right. Any man who brings a case before me, and for whom I award a right against his brother that is not owed to him, must not take it: I am only allotting him a piece of Fire." [Translator's note: the final warning resembles the well-attested tradition concerning a judgment that awards another person's right and thereby gives the recipient a piece of Fire; the combined wording as quoted warrants separate authentication.]

Spiritual allusion

Justice must be upheld in every matter, and concern for human approval must be abandoned. The seeker should watch the Real Sovereign rather than make people his audience, exercising firmness in truth against himself and others. Vigilance toward the Real does not coexist with vigilance toward created beings. Whoever watches the Real becomes absent from preoccupation with people; whoever watches people becomes absent from God and lives distressed by their opinions. The poet says:

> The watcher of people's judgments dies of grief;
> the courageous one wins the joys of life.

Ibn ʿAjība reports his grand-shaykh's aphorism: "Vigilance toward created beings is a great matter for the people of the outward; absence of that vigilance is a great matter for the people of the inward." Justice toward the self means not allowing it to incline toward concessions and interpretations; to-

ward parents it means gentle remembrance and guidance to God; toward kin and strangers it means sincere advice for their true welfare, whether they are wealthy or poor. God gives success. With this treatment of the tongue complete, the next topic is safeguarding faith, the sixth theme contained in the sūrah.

4:136 · Belief and revealed scriptures

Cairo I:575

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا آمِنُوا بِاللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ وَالْكِتابِ الَّذِي نَزَّلَ عَلى رَسُولِهِ وَالْكِتابِ الَّذِي أَنْزَلَ مِنْ قَبْلُ وَمَنْ يَكْفُرْ بِاللَّهِ وَمَلائِكَتِهِ وَكُتُبِهِ وَرُسُلِهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ فَقَدْ ضَلَّ ضَلالاً بَعِيداً (136)

O you who believe, believe in God and His Messenger, the Book sent down to His Messenger, and the Book He sent down before. Whoever rejects God, His angels, His books, His messengers or the Last Day has wandered far astray.

Outward commentary

Ibn ʿAjība reports an occasion involving certain Jews who embraced Islam, naming ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām, Asad and Usayd sons of Kaʿb, Thaʿlaba ibn Qays, Sallām, the son of ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām's sister, Salama, the son of his brother, and Yāmīn. They professed belief in Muḥammad, the Qurʾān, Moses, Torah and Ezra, but asked whether they could reject the remaining revealed books. The Prophet, according to the account, commanded them to believe in God, Muḥammad, the Qurʾān and all scriptures revealed before it. The verse then instructed those who had accepted Muḥammad after Moses to affirm the entire genus of revealed scripture without dividing God's messengers into accepted and rejected. The report says they affirmed belief in all without distinction, unlike those Jews and Christians who divided the prophetic succession.

Another explanation addresses hypocrites: you have professed belief with your tongues; now believe sincerely in your hearts. A further interpretation speaks to believers themselves: continue steadfastly in the faith already received. Whoever rejects any of these has gone so far astray that he scarcely returns to the path.

Spiritual allusion

The call to believe commands the renewal and deepening of faith. Maintain what you already possess and seek instruction in what has not yet been realised. The lights of faith increase in succession upon hearts in proportion to their purification, contemplation, obedience and approach to God. As the servant draws nearer, the lights of *tawajjuh* (turning toward God) arrive until the lights of *muwājaha* (direct encounter), the lights of witnessing, shine forth. The appearance of lights corresponds to purification of inward secrets; spiritual aid (*imdād*) descends according to readiness (*istiʿdād*). As attention withdraws from what is other than God, gifts and mysteries are bestowed upon the heart. All of this belongs to one who accompanies the knowers, learns from them and places the reins of his soul in their hands; otherwise he must content himself with faith in the unseen, whatever deeds he performs. God gives success.

4:137–139 · Repeated disbelief and hypocrisy

Cairo I:576

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا ثُمَّ كَفَرُوا ثُمَّ آمَنُوا ثُمَّ كَفَرُوا ثُمَّ ازْدادُوا كُفْراً لَمْ يَكُنِ
اللَّهُ لِيَغْفِرَ لَهُمْ وَلا لِيَهْدِيَهُمْ سَبِيلاً (137) بَشِّرِ الْمُنافِقِينَ بِأَنَّ لَهُمْ عَذاباً
أَلِيماً (138) الَّذِينَ يَتَّخِذُونَ الْكافِرِينَ أَوْلِياءَ مِنْ دُونِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ
أَيَبْتَغُونَ عِنْدَهُمُ الْعِزَّةَ فَإِنَّ الْعِزَّةَ لِلَّهِ جَمِيعاً (139)

Those who believed, then disbelieved, then believed again, then disbelieved and increased in disbelief—God will not forgive them or guide them to a path. Announce to the hypocrites the painful punishment awaiting them: those who take unbelievers as close allies instead of believers. Do they seek dignity with them? All dignity belongs to God.

Outward commentary

One reading concerns hypocrites who alternate profession of faith and unbelief, eventually persisting in denial. God will not forgive them because wretchedness has already been allotted to them. Another interpretation concerns Jews: they believed in Moses, disbelieved through worship of the calf, repented and believed again, rejected Jesus, and increased unbelief by rejecting Muḥammad. Ibn ʿAjība prefers the first in view of the verses about hypocrisy that follow. The denial of forgiveness and guidance is explained by how unlikely their repentance is: their hearts are imbued with unbelief and their inner sight is blind, beyond treatment. It does not mean that sincere faith, were they to embrace it, would not benefit them. God's leading them astray may also be a punishment for their evil deeds.

The hypocrites sought intimate protection from unbelievers rather than believers because, before the visible rise of Islam, those unbelievers held power and prestige. The hope was to acquire dignity by association. God rebukes such dependence: all lasting dignity belongs to Him, His Messenger and those attached to Him. Dignity that ends in humiliation is unworthy of the name.

Spiritual allusion

One whose confidence in the people of special spiritual knowledge is weak alternates between entering their company and leaving, believing them one moment and denying them the next. Success for such a person in the special path is not to be hoped for. Joining those who reject its people makes the failure worse. If a person borrows prestige from opponents of the friends of God, abasement follows. Dignity comes from divine unity, faith, inward recognition and excellence, and companionship of knowers honoured by the Merciful. Borrowed dignity dies when its source perishes; di-

vine dignity endures. The net with which honour is caught is humility before God, displayed among God's servants. One person said, "By God, I have only seen honour in abasement." A poet says:

> Humble yourself before the one you love and acquire honour;
> how much dignity has one obtained by humble surrender!

4:140–141 · The company one keeps

Cairo I:577–578

وَقَدْ نَزَّلَ عَلَيْكُمْ فِي الْكِتابِ أَنْ إِذا سَمِعْتُمْ آياتِ اللَّهِ يُكْفَرُ بِها وَيُسْتَهْزَأُ بِها فَلا تَقْعُدُوا مَعَهُمْ حَتَّى يَخُوضُوا فِي حَدِيثٍ غَيْرِهِ إِنَّكُمْ إِذاً مِثْلُهُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ جامِعُ الْمُنافِقِينَ وَالْكافِرِينَ فِي جَهَنَّمَ جَمِيعاً (140) الَّذِينَ يَتَرَبَّصُونَ بِكُمْ فَإِنْ كانَ لَكُمْ فَتْحٌ مِنَ اللَّهِ قالُوا أَلَمْ نَكُنْ مَعَكُمْ وَإِنْ كانَ لِلْكافِرِينَ نَصِيبٌ قالُوا أَلَمْ نَسْتَحْوِذْ عَلَيْكُمْ وَنَمْنَعْكُمْ مِنَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ فَاللَّهُ يَحْكُمُ بَيْنَكُمْ يَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ وَلَنْ يَجْعَلَ اللَّهُ لِلْكافِرِينَ عَلَى الْمُؤْمِنِينَ سَبِيلاً (141)

He has already revealed to you in the Book that, when you hear God's verses denied or mocked, you must not sit with those doing so until they turn to another conversation, or else you become like them. God will gather hypocrites and unbelievers together in Hell. They wait to see what befalls you: when you gain a victory from God they say, "Were we not with you?" But when unbelievers gain an advantage they say, "Did we not gain the upper hand over you and protect you against the believers?" God will judge between you on the Day of Resurrection, and He will not grant unbelievers a way against believers.

Language

I say: *an* is “lightened”; Cairo then prints the difficult words نافية، فاعل نزل, literally “negative; the subject of نزل.” [Translator’s textual note: The heading reads active *nazzala*, “He has revealed,” while the gloss is inconsistent as printed. Al-Bayḍāwī on 4:140 explicitly distinguishes ʿĀṣim’s active reading from the others’ passive reading, calls *an* lightened, and makes its clause stand as the passive subject. That documented analysis explains the proposed conjecture نائبة فاعل, “standing as the passive subject.” It does not establish that these were Ibn ʿAjība’s own words: Cairo prints neither that phrase nor a passive verb in the heading. Both difficulties remain disclosed; the text is not recast as an analysis of explanatory *an*. See source check XII-S063.] The verbal expressions “denied” and “mocked” describe the circumstances of the divine verses. The pronoun “them” refers to those who deny, implied by the passive verb; “other than it” refers to the combined activity of disbelief and mockery. Later “those who wait” is an adjective describing hypocrites or is accusative as an expression of censure. *Nastaḥwidh* means “we gain mastery,” retaining an older verbal form whose consonantal pattern did not undergo the expected phonological alteration, as *istaʿādha* normally does.

Outward commentary

Muslims had already been instructed in al-Anʿām (6:68) to turn aside from people indulging in the derision of divine signs. If unable to denounce it, they should leave the conversation until it changes. If you sit with them while they engage in that talk, you are like them in sin if you do not approve of it, or in unbelief if you do approve of it. The verse is said to concern hypocrites who sat with Jewish scholars mocking and distorting the Qurʾān. Ibn ʿAbbās says that this verse includes everyone who introduces a novelty in religion and every innovator until the Day of Resurrection.

God will gather those who engage in derisive talk and those who sit with them together in Hell, where they will abide. Hypocrites, meanwhile, wait for reversals in Muslim fortunes. If believers gain victory and spoils, they demand a share on the ground of their professed membership. If opponents gain ground, they claim to have spared them, weakened the Muslims' resolve through deception, and were slow to support the believers against them, and demand reward from the other side. The text calls Muslim

success a *fatḥ*, an opening, but unbelievers' momentary success only a *naṣīb*, a worldly portion: Ibn ʿAjība treats the former as the strengthening of true religion and the latter as a paltry worldly share, involving gradual enticement to ruin and a stratagem. Ultimately God decides the dispute, admitting the people of truth into the Garden and the deliberate mockers into punishment. He interprets "no way" as no proof or dominance in this world or the next and additionally deduces historical juristic rules forbidding non-Muslim ownership of a Muslim slave and requiring the sale of such a slave if acquired, as well as dissolving his marriage if he marries a Muslim woman. [Translator's note: these are juristic deductions recorded in this historical commentary.]

Spiritual allusion

God's saints are among His signs. In Ibn ʿAjība's spiritual application, anyone who derides them has made himself deserving of God's abhorrence. It is obligatory to flee any place where they are repudiated or their rank is disparaged, for it is a place of wrath, destruction and ruin. He says, "The flesh of the saints is a deadly poison, and the curse falls upon those who disparage them." Remaining without excuse makes one a participant; departing protects one; speaking against the slander is a kind of struggle. "A person is with those whom he loves": love of contentious mockers joins them, love of the pure joins the sincere, and opportunistic vacillation attaches one to confused companions. Such a weakly grounded person joins Sufi poor (*fuqarāʾ*) when their recognition brings influence and falls back among their deniers when the latter hold power. Such a person has no share with God. The hadith says, "A two-faced man is not esteemed before God." God raises the people of purity with those brought near, and brings the mockers to the consequences of their acts. Those denying the people of purity have no genuine argument against them. "God is with those who are reverently mindful and excel" (16:128).

4:142–143 · Hypocrisy in prayer and remembrance

Cairo I:578

إِنَّ الْمُنافِقِينَ يُخادِعُونَ اللَّهَ وَهُوَ خادِعُهُمْ وَإِذا قامُوا إِلَى الصَّلاةِ قامُوا كُسالى يُراؤُنَ النَّاسَ وَلا يَذْكُرُونَ اللَّهَ إِلاَّ قَلِيلاً (142) مُذَبْذَبِينَ بَيْنَ ذلِكَ لاَ إِلى هؤُلاءِ وَلا إِلى هؤُلاءِ وَمَنْ يُضْلِلِ اللَّهُ فَلَنْ تَجِدَ لَهُ سَبِيلاً (143)

The hypocrites attempt to deceive God, while He turns their deception against them. When they stand for prayer, they stand reluctantly, showing themselves to people and remembering God only a little—wavering between the two groups, belonging wholly neither to these nor to those. Whoever God leads astray, for him you will find no path.

Language

I say: “They remember God only a little” is circumstantial to the subject of “they display themselves,” as is “wavering”: they make a show while not truly remembering, suspended between alternatives. Alternatively “wavering” may be accusative in censure. *Mudhadhdhab* denotes one disturbed, oscillating and unable to settle.

Outward commentary

The hypocrites profess faith and conceal unbelief. God is said to “deceive” them in the sense of a corresponding punishment, named after their act: in the hereafter they are shown a light to walk by upon the bridge, as the faithful are; when they move on, the hypocrites' light is extinguished while the believers' light remains, and they call for light before falling into punishment (cf. 57:13). They undertake prayer lazily because God is not their intention. If watched, they pray; if unseen, they abandon it. They seek reputation by their actions and remember God only when observed, which occupies the smaller part of their time. Or remembrance within their prayer is slight, restricted to the opening and closing formulas without inward at-

tention. Ibn ʿAbbās says their act is designed for display and reputation: if performed for God it would be much remembrance. Qatāda says rejected remembrance is small no matter how abundant its appearance; accepted remembrance is great even if externally slight. Such hypocrites oscillate between denial and faith, genuine believers and open polytheists, at ease with neither. God has known their state, and whoever is left astray has no other guide, like the verse, "Whoever God gives no light has no light" (24:40).

Spiritual allusion

A desire that people should admire one's good deeds or spiritual states contains a branch of hypocrisy and ostentation (*riyāʾ*). Its mark is decorating the outward appearance while neglecting the inner state, attending to people rather than God. One of the sages used to say, "God Most High says: 'You who show off, the affairs of those before whom you show off are in the hands of the One you disobey.'" All his outwardly gigantic deeds are inwardly small; the sincere person's little work is great. *Al-Qūt* is cited for understanding abundant remembrance as pure remembrance, for sincerity makes it abundant. "Wavering" also describes mere claimants to realisation who glimpse inward truth intellectually but belong fully neither to the special people nor to ordinary religious society. Without divine guidance onto the path of actual verification (*taḥqīq*), they have no way to its goal.

4:144 · Taking unbelief as patrons

Cairo I:580

يا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لا تَتَّخِذُوا الْكافِرِينَ أَوْلِياءَ مِنْ دُونِ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ أَتُرِيدُونَ أَنْ تَجْعَلُوا لِلَّهِ عَلَيْكُمْ سُلْطاناً مُبِيناً (144)

O believers, do not take unbelievers as your patrons instead of believers. Do you wish to give God an unmistakable argument against you?

Language

I say: *ittakhadha* governs two objects, and “instead of” is circumstantial. Do not imitate the hypocrites by seeking protection and friendship through enemies of the believing community, as though worldly power were the source of dignity. God has already ennobled believers through faith and victory. Such a choice would provide manifest evidence for their censure and punishment.

Spiritual allusion

Ibn ʿAjība reiterates his warning against alliance with those who denounce God's saints and immersion in companionship devoted to worldly ambition. This is clear evidence of returning to them and ingratiating oneself with them; for sincere seekers that split allegiance is a form of inward hypocrisy. God knows best.

4:145–147 · The lowest depth and the opening of repentance

Cairo I:580

إِنَّ الْمُنافِقِينَ فِي الدَّرْكِ الْأَسْفَلِ مِنَ النَّارِ وَلَنْ تَجِدَ لَهُمْ نَصِيراً (145) إِلاَّ الَّذِينَ تابُوا وَأَصْلَحُوا وَاعْتَصَمُوا بِاللَّهِ وَأَخْلَصُوا دِينَهُمْ لِلَّهِ فَأُولئِكَ مَعَ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ وَسَوْفَ يُؤْتِ اللَّهُ الْمُؤْمِنِينَ أَجْراً عَظِيماً (146) مَّا يَفْعَلُ اللَّهُ بِعَذابِكُمْ إِنْ شَكَرْتُمْ وَآمَنْتُمْ وَكانَ اللَّهُ شاكِراً عَلِيماً (147)

Hypocrites are in the lowest depth of the Fire; no helper will you find for them—except those who repent, repair their conduct, hold fast to God and make their religion sincerely His. They are then with the believers, whom God shall grant a tremendous reward. Why would God punish you if you are thankful and have faith? God appreciates and knows.

Language

I say: *darak* and *dark* are two vocalisations, like *ẓaʿan/ẓaʿn*, *nahar/nahr*, and *nashar/nashr*. *Darakāt* are the successive descending layers, in contrast with rising *darajāt*. Hypocrites occupy the lowest depth because their denial was compounded by ridicule and deliberate deception of believers. Ibn Masʿūd is reported to describe them as locked in coffins of Fire. Ibn ʿUmar is quoted: “The three kinds of people punished most severely on the Day of Resurrection are the hypocrites, those of the People of the Table who disbelieved, and Pharaoh’s people,” citing: “The hypocrites are in the lowest depth of the Fire” [4:145]; concerning the People of the Table, “I shall punish him with a punishment with which I punish no other being” [5:115]; and “Admit Pharaoh’s people to the severest punishment” [40:46]. *[Translator’s note: These descriptions of the unseen are presented in the source as reports.]*

The exception is real. Those who repent of hypocrisy, correct outward deeds and inward dispositions, trust in and attach themselves to God alone, and purify worship of ostentation and the wish for reputation, are joined to believers. Al-Farrāʾ takes "with the believers" as meaning "among the believers," while al-ʿUtbī supposes the wording deliberately avoids saying "they are believers" to indicate God's displeasure. Ibn ʿAjība responds: "He says 'with the believers,' not 'from among them,' because escape from hypocrisy is difficult. One does not belong among the believers until freed from all its branches, and this is rare." He cites the familiar Prophetic warning about lying when speaking, breaking promises and betraying trusts, even if a person fasts, prays and asserts Islam.

Sincere people receive great reward, and the repentant share in it. God has no need to inflict punishment for personal gratification, since He is not harmed by sin or benefited by worship. Persisting in disbelief produces a spiritual disease; faith and thanksgiving cure it. Al-Bayḍāwī explains that gratitude precedes faith in the verse because a person first experiences benefits and offers rudimentary gratitude, then reflects until recognising the Giver. Al-Thaʿlabī instead takes the sequence as transposed: belief precedes gratitude, since gratitude without faith brings no saving benefit. God is *Shākir*, accepting slight deeds and repaying them many times over, and *ʿAlīm*, knowing the true degree of sincerity.

Spiritual allusion

No vice is harder for the self to uproot than ostentation: cut it back in one guise and it returns in another. It is fully purified only by effacement (*fanāʾ*) and complete absence from what is other than God. Ibn ʿAjība quotes al-Shushtarī:

> With flowing tears, cleanse the eye
> of witnessing all else: every sickness departs.

A saying holds that sincerity never grows in the heart until one falls from people's gaze and lets people fall from one's own. Sincerity belongs to inward actions, whose reality is known to the Knower of the Unseen alone. Accordingly no one should simply declare another person ostentatious because a devotional act has been made visible. Ostentation can be present in secrecy and absent from public action. The *Ḥikam* warns that ostentation may enter even where no creature sees one. When the seeker is purified of

its finer traces, restores the relationship with God and takes refuge in Him alone, he joins the sincerely devoted brought-near; his acts are valued and his endeavour gratefully received.

The marginal commentary cites the *Iḥyāʾ* and comments upon it. The hypocrites' lowest depth reflects denial after knowledge: the scholar's sin is aggravated because it knowingly violates what he understands. The marginal commentator connects this with the reported statement that, without the Prophet's intercession, Abū Ṭālib would have been in the lowest depth, on account of his refusal despite recognition. He also reports al-Ghazālī's explanation that open denial is one evil but concealed denial adds another, because the hypocrite values the judgment of people more than God's awareness of the heart. The severity of ostentation and hypocrisy thus concerns elevating human observation above divine observation; it is therefore graver than open unbelief. Here ends the material from the marginal commentary.

4:148–149 · Wronged speech and divine pardon

Cairo I:582

لا يُحِبُّ اللَّهُ الْجَهْرَ بِالسُّوءِ مِنَ الْقَوْلِ إِلاَّ مَنْ ظُلِمَ وَكانَ اللَّهُ سَمِيعاً عَلِيماً (148) إِنْ تُبْدُوا خَيْراً أَوْ تُخْفُوهُ أَوْ تَعْفُوا عَنْ سُوءٍ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ كانَ عَفُوًّا قَدِيراً (149)

God does not love public utterance of evil speech, except where someone has suffered wrong. God is Hearing, Knowing. Whether you make goodness public or conceal it, or pardon an evil committed against you, God is Pardoning and Fully Powerful.

Language

I say: “Except one wronged” is a disconnected exception: the one who suffers injustice is permitted to complain against or pray against the wrongdoer, but this does not mean God positively loves such speech, since forgive-

ness is better, as the next verse shows. In a variant reading *ẓalama* is active —"except the one who wronged"—that is, the offender engages in speech displeasing to God.

Outward commentary

God does not approve of crying out in evil words, an act of coarseness and ignorance. A person who has been oppressed may publicly complain or invoke judgment against the oppressor; 42:41 similarly excuses proportionate self-defence. Mujāhid applies it to a guest denied appropriate hospitality or badly treated, who may recount the treatment received. A report attributes its revelation to such a guest's complaint. God hears the prayer of the oppressed and his response to the oppressor —so raised speech is unnecessary—and knows the oppressor, whom He punishes in proportion to his wrongdoing.

Yet the highest response is pardon. Showing goodness openly through virtue, gentleness and obedience, or performing it secretly, are valuable, but the point of the passage is pardon of the person who has wronged you. These other kinds of goodness prepare its mention. God is repeatedly forgiving, although possessed of perfect power to avenge; people should imitate that moral generosity. Thus, after granting the oppressed permission to protest, He encourages the more excellent character of pardon.

Spiritual allusion

Once inward purification and illumination are established, the outward character displays generosity, softness, gracious speech and an end to reproach. What lies in inward secrecy becomes manifest in outward conduct: what is hidden within appears upon the tongue. Ibn ʿAjība cites these lines about them:

> Easy and gentle, generous, sons of ease;
> stewards of noble deeds, sons of the generous.
> When they speak, they speak only truth;
> nor, when they dispute, do they dispute at length.
> Whomever you meet among them, you say, "That is their chief,"
> like the stars by which the night traveller is guided.

The divine Presence educates and refines: no empty or sinful speech remains there, like the Paradise where only “Peace, peace” is heard (56:25–26). Those continuously near the Beloved stand in the audience of the Most High; loud self-assertion does not fit that station. God says, “Voices are humbled before the All-Merciful, so you hear only a whisper” [20:108]. Among the Sufis, raising the voice is reprehensible and ugly, indicating the speaker’s remoteness whatever his condition. When the Prophet asked Abū Bakr why he recited so quietly, he is reported to have answered, “The One I address is not far away.” The Prophet instructed him to raise the voice a little, which Ibn ʿAjība interprets as training him not to become attached to his own chosen manner. God knows best.

4:150–151 · Refusing to distinguish between messengers

Cairo I:583

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ يَكْفُرُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَرُسُلِهِ وَيُرِيدُونَ أَنْ يُفَرِّقُوا بَيْنَ اللَّهِ وَرُسُلِهِ وَيَقُولُونَ نُؤْمِنُ بِبَعْضٍ وَنَكْفُرُ بِبَعْضٍ وَيُرِيدُونَ أَنْ يَتَّخِذُوا بَيْنَ ذلِكَ سَبِيلاً (150) أُولئِكَ هُمُ الْكافِرُونَ حَقًّا وَأَعْتَدْنا لِلْكافِرِينَ عَذاباً مُهِيناً (151)

Those who disbelieve in God and His messengers and wish to distinguish between God and His messengers, saying, “We believe in some and reject others,” and seek a path in between—those are truly unbelievers. For those who deny, We have prepared a humiliating punishment.

Language

I say: *ḥaqqan* is an emphatic verbal noun reinforcing the whole judgment or qualifying an understood noun: they have disbelieved with real, certain unbelief. *Aʿtadnā* was originally *aʿdadnā*, the first dāl being replaced by tāʾ because their places of articulation are close. Those who affirm God but reject His messengers attempt an incoherent separation; the verse speaks es-

pecially, in Ibn ʿAjība's exposition, of Jews accepting Moses, Ezra and Torah but rejecting Jesus and Muḥammad. Such people seek an imagined middle way between belief and denial. Yet belief in God is completed by accepting the messengers and what they authentically communicate, each in the proper degree, in detail or generally. Denial of one legitimate messenger undermines the whole principle. He interprets the emphatic judgment as censuring those who made their own preferences an authority over God's choice, effectively treating whim as a deity and disputing divine decree. A humiliating punishment is contrasted with God's honouring and elevating of His friends. He prays that God include us with the latter.

Spiritual allusion

Saints follow in the footsteps of prophets. Ibn ʿAjība carries the verse over analogically: one who makes distinctions among the friends of God loses the blessing of their company, whereas one who respects them all receives illumination from each. God is jealous for His friends, as for His prophets. As He drove away those who distinguished between His prophets, so He drives away someone who disparages some of His saints while exalting others, for the part is the whole. God knows best.

4:152 · Those who believe in all messengers

Cairo I:584

وَالَّذِينَ آمَنُوا بِاللَّهِ وَرُسُلِهِ وَلَمْ يُفَرِّقُوا بَيْنَ أَحَدٍ مِنْهُمْ أُولئِكَ سَوْفَ نُؤْتِيهِمْ أُجُورَهُمْ وَكانَ اللَّهُ غَفُوراً رَحِيماً (152)

> Those who believe in God and His messengers and make no distinction among any of them—We shall give them their rewards. God is Forgiving, Merciful.

Language

I say: *bayna* (“between”) normally implies more than one referent, but here it governs “any one” (*aḥad*) because that word occurs in a negative context and therefore signifies the whole plurality. This is al-Bayḍāwī's explanation.

Outward commentary

Those who affirm God's due perfections and the truthful mission and rank of His messengers without excluding one of them, believing what each communicated from the Lord, are promised a reward that raises and honours them in the gardens of bliss. The particle *sawfa* emphasises the promised reward's certainty, even if its appearance lies in the future. Because no servant is free of shortcomings, the verse adds that God is Forgiving of what they have neglected and Merciful in multiplying their good deeds. [238]

Spiritual allusion

Those who acknowledge all genuine saints, honour them and benefit from their several illuminations receive their portion too. They will enjoy the gardens of divine knowledge in this world and, upon death, be placed in the high gardens, “in an abode of truth with a Sovereign fully powerful” (54:55). God knows best. The next passage returns to the People of the Book.

4:153–154 · Scripture, Israel and the demand for signs

Cairo I:585

يَسْئَلُكَ أَهْلُ الْكِتابِ أَنْ تُنَزِّلَ عَلَيْهِمْ كِتاباً مِنَ السَّماءِ فَقَدْ سَأَلُوا مُوسى أَكْبَرَ مِنْ ذلِكَ فَقالُوا أَرِنَا اللَّهَ جَهْرَةً فَأَخَذَتْهُمُ الصَّاعِقَةُ بِظُلْمِهِمْ ثُمَّ اتَّخَذُوا الْعِجْلَ مِنْ بَعْدِ ما جاءَتْهُمُ الْبَيِّناتُ فَعَفَوْنا عَنْ ذلِكَ وَآتَيْنا مُوسى سُلْطاناً مُبِيناً (153) وَرَفَعْنا فَوْقَهُمُ الطُّورَ بِمِيثاقِهِمْ وَقُلْنا لَهُمُ ادْخُلُوا الْبابَ سُجَّداً وَقُلْنا لَهُمْ لا تَعْدُوا فِي السَّبْتِ وَأَخَذْنا مِنْهُمْ مِيثاقاً غَلِيظاً (154)

238. Cairo editor, C584.1: Ḥafṣ, transmitting from ʿĀṣim, reads yuʾtīhim ("He will give them") with yāʾ; the other readers read with nūn ("We will give them").

The People of the Book ask you to bring down a book from heaven to them. They asked Moses for something even greater: “Show us God openly.” The thunderbolt seized them for their wrongdoing. Then, even after clear signs had come, they took the calf for worship. We pardoned that and granted Moses manifest authority. We raised the Mount over them on account of their covenant, ordered them to enter the gate bowing, and commanded them not to transgress on the Sabbath. We took from them a solemn covenant.

Language

I say: one reading of *lā taʿdū* has a quiescent consonant and derives from *ʿadā*. Another doubles the *dāl*, deriving from *iʿtadā*: the original *lā taʿtadū* underwent a transfer of vowel and assimilation. A reading with an incompletely pronounced vowel preserves an indication of that origin.

Outward commentary

Certain Jewish religious leaders, named as Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf and Finḥāṣ ibn ʿĀzūrāʾ, demanded that Muḥammad produce a complete heavenly book at once, or written celestial tablets as those associated with Moses. God responds that previous generations had demanded something more extraordinary: direct sensible vision of the divine Essence. The acts of their ancestors are addressed to these later claimants because they had adopted their inherited posture and participated in its defiance. Their rejection should not surprise the Prophet.

Their forebears said, “Show us God openly,” seeking a sensory manifestation for which they had not been prepared. The thunderbolt, described as fire from heaven, destroyed them, and they were restored to life in response to Moses' supplication. Ibn ʿAjība insists this punishment does not mean the vision of God is altogether impossible; their request was untimely and wrong in its circumstances. Those forebears then worshipped the calf after proofs of divine unity had come. God accepted repentance and pardoned, bestowing on Moses manifest authority over them and evident proofs of prophecy, including the nine signs. Moses’ manifest authority over them is illustrated by his command that they kill themselves in repentance for taking the calf as a god.

God raised Mount Sinai above them when they resisted the Torah's stipulations, obliging them through solemn covenant. They were told to enter the gate of the sacred city bowing, but in the traditional account they entered dragging themselves on their buttocks in obstinacy and mockery. They were forbidden to violate the Sabbath, through David, but transgressed by fishing; the text recalls the traditional narrative of punishment by transformation into apes and swine. A weighty covenant encompassed all these commands, which they broke; alternatively it included a stipulation that, should they live to meet Muḥammad, they would recognise and proclaim his traits, but they concealed them.

Spiritual allusion

Demand for signs and extraordinary miracles from saints is an old pattern. Saints walk in the prophets' footsteps and encounter analogous objections. People are often reluctant to acknowledge a saint without a *karāma*; yet extraordinary phenomena do not by themselves prove an established uprightness (*istiqāma*). A marvel can occur before a person is perfected, and can even be a trial or a deceptive elevation (*istidrāj*). Ibn ʿAjība quotes his shaykh: what miracle is greater than divinely granted knowledge (*ʿulūm ladunniyya*) and Prophetic virtues? Miracles appeared with earlier saints and did not end opposition to them.

The desire to behold God during this life is not, in Ibn ʿAjība's inward interpretation, absolutely excluded. The Israelites were punished because they demanded it before its proper season, without the requisite perfection of training and purification from the defilement of sensory perception. When insight has been completely purified, it witnesses the Real so fully that it cannot be forced to witness anything other than Him. The inward eye comes to govern the outward eye, and the latter witnesses what the inward eye had first perceived. The *Ḥikam* is cited for three gradations: the ray of insight shows God's nearness; the eye of insight witnesses one's own nonexistence before His existence; and the truth of insight witnesses the existence of the Real. Such witnessing is attained only by someone who has attached himself to a shaykh of spiritual training; otherwise there is no hope of it. God knows best.

4:155–158 · Covenant, transgression, and the Messiah

Cairo I:586

فَبِما نَقْضِهِمْ مِيثاقَهُمْ وَكُفْرِهِمْ بِآياتِ اللَّهِ وَقَتْلِهِمُ الْأَنْبِياءَ بِغَيْرِ حَقٍّ وَقَوْلِهِمْ قُلُوبُنا غُلْفٌ بَلْ طَبَعَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْها بِكُفْرِهِمْ فَلا يُؤْمِنُونَ إِلاَّ قَلِيلاً (155) وَبِكُفْرِهِمْ وَقَوْلِهِمْ عَلى مَرْيَمَ بُهْتاناً عَظِيماً (156) وَقَوْلِهِمْ إِنَّا قَتَلْنَا الْمَسِيحَ عِيسَى ابْنَ مَرْيَمَ رَسُولَ اللَّهِ وَما قَتَلُوهُ وَما صَلَبُوهُ وَلكِنْ شُبِّهَ لَهُمْ وَإِنَّ الَّذِينَ اخْتَلَفُوا فِيهِ لَفِي شَكٍّ مِنْهُ ما لَهُمْ بِهِ مِنْ عِلْمٍ إِلاَّ اتِّباعَ الظَّنِّ وَما قَتَلُوهُ يَقِيناً (157) بَلْ رَفَعَهُ اللَّهُ إِلَيْهِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَزِيزاً حَكِيماً (158)

For their breaking of the covenant, denying God's signs, killing prophets without right, and saying, “Our hearts are covered”—rather, God sealed their hearts because of their unbelief, so that few believe; and for their denial and their monstrous slander against Mary; and for saying, “We killed the Messiah, Jesus son of Mary, the Messenger of God.” They did not kill him and did not crucify him, but it was made to appear so to them. Those who differ concerning him are in doubt, possessing no knowledge beyond following conjecture. They certainly did not kill him; rather God raised him to Himself. God is Mighty, Wise.

Language

I say: *mā* in *fa-bi-mā naqḍihim* strengthens the expression. “Their breaking” is a verbal noun governed by *bi-* and related either to a suppressed verb —“because they broke the covenant, We dealt with them as We did”—or to the later “We prohibited good things for them”; in the latter parsing the “because of the wrongdoing” of 4:160 restates the cause, with the prohibitions following covenant-breaking and its associated offences. “Except following conjecture” is a disconnected exception because genuine knowledge and conjecture are opposed.

Outward commentary

Israel's former commitments were broken, so consequences followed. Ibn ʿAjība includes the later removal of previously permitted good things, the denial of divine signs in Scripture or Qurʾān, the unjust killing of prophets, and the claim "Our hearts are wrapped," as though unable to receive the Prophet's message. God answers that their continued denial has veiled the hearts from understanding and withheld success in contemplating signs and accepting admonition. "Few believe" may refer to a minority such as ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and his associates; alternatively it means a meagre faith too deficient to count. He also cites rejection of Jesus, the monstrous accusation of sexual misconduct made against Mary, and the boast of killing Jesus, called "the Messenger of God" either mockingly by the speakers or by God as an insertion honouring Jesus amid their words, as al-Bayḍāwī explains.

In Ibn ʿAjība's theological telling, God decisively denies that they killed or crucified Jesus. He recounts one narrative in which hostile Jews insulted Jesus and his mother; after Jesus prayed against them, they were transformed into apes and swine, and the Jews assembled to kill him. He told them, "Company of Jews, God hates you." They became angry and rose to kill him. Gabriel led Jesus into an enclosure with an opening in its roof, through which God lifted him. An attacker named Ṭīṭānūs was sent inside; God caused him to resemble Jesus, and when the others entered they mistook him for Jesus and killed and crucified him. A different account attributed to Qatāda reports that Jesus asked his companions who would receive his resemblance and be killed; a volunteer accepted, Jesus was raised, clothed in feathers and in light *[Translator's note: The close earlier version in al-Thaʿlabī's commentary, III:410, also places him among angels circling the Throne. This context supports "feathers" for rīsh; "fine apparel" remains a lexical alternative. This preference concerns the narrative's wording, not its historical authenticity.]*, and deprived of the pleasure of food and drink, living among angels in heaven, human and angelic, earthly and heavenly.

Those who disputed about the death were uncertain. Some wondered how the figure could be Jesus if their companion was missing, or their companion if Jesus had escaped. Another report says only the substitute's face, not his body, resembled Jesus, provoking their suspicion. They followed conjecture, not certainty. God, says Ibn ʿAjība, raised Jesus to heaven, where the

commentator places him in the second heaven with John. God is mighty in His vengeance upon the Jews and wise in His judgment of curse and anger upon them. *[Translator's note: The competing substitution accounts are transmitted exegetical narratives. Their historical particulars are additional to the Qurʾānic phrase shubbiha lahum, "it was made to appear so to them."]*

Spiritual allusion

Breaking commitments made to spiritual guides is among the causes of God's abhorrence and of distance from Him, as can hostile denunciation of them and refusal of their admonitions. The contrary acts—respecting their dignity, abiding by their commands, defending them against slander, maintaining proper nearness and serving appropriately—are portrayed as means to proximity and love. *[Translator's note: This is Ibn ʿAjība's application of the passage to spiritual formation. It does not establish prophetic infallibility or unlimited immunity for human teachers.]* God gives success.

4:159 · The People of the Book and Jesus

Cairo I:588

وَإِنْ مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتابِ إِلاَّ لَيُؤْمِنَنَّ بِهِ قَبْلَ مَوْتِهِ وَيَوْمَ الْقِيامَةِ يَكُونُ عَلَيْهِمْ شَهِيداً (159)

There is none among the People of the Book who will not believe in him before his death, and on the Day of Resurrection he will be a witness against them.

Outward commentary

On the first reading, every Jew and Christian living at Jesus' descent will believe in him before Jesus' death. Ibn ʿAjība transmits a traditional account in which Jesus descends when the Antichrist appears, destroys him, and all the surviving People of the Book recognise Jesus, leaving one religious community of Islam. Peace becomes so complete that lions graze with camels, leopards with cattle and wolves with sheep, while children safely play with

snakes. Jesus remains for forty years, dies, receives the Muslim funeral prayer and is buried. *[Translator's note: The timescale and illustrative details belong to the report quoted by the commentator.]*

A second reading makes "his death" refer to each member of the People of the Book rather than Jesus: every such person will acknowledge before their own death that Jesus is God's servant and messenger, upon seeing the angel of death and learning truth from error. This final compulsory recognition, Ibn ʿAjība says, cannot replace faith freely attained earlier. He mentions a reading in which the pronoun denotes the plurality of those dying, and understands the passage as warning them to believe before death. On the Day of Resurrection Jesus will bear witness that some denied him and others ascribed divine sonship to him.

Spiritual allusion

Death exposes realities and distinguishes truth from error, often bringing remorse when the opportunity for purposeful change has passed. The aim is to attain established faith and inward recognition (*ʿirfān*) now, before the foot slips and the person is left alone, held in pledge in his grave by his sin. God knows best.

4:160–161 · Wrongdoing, usury and forbidden things

Cairo I:589

فَبِظُلْمٍ مِنَ الَّذِينَ هادُوا حَرَّمْنا عَلَيْهِمْ طَيِّباتٍ أُحِلَّتْ لَهُمْ وَبِصَدِّهِمْ عَنْ سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ كَثِيراً (160) وَأَخْذِهِمُ الرِّبَوا وَقَدْ نُهُوا عَنْهُ وَأَكْلِهِمْ أَمْوالَ النَّاسِ بِالْباطِلِ وَأَعْتَدْنا لِلْكافِرِينَ مِنْهُمْ عَذاباً أَلِيماً (161)

For wrongdoing among those who became Jews, We forbade them good things previously permitted, and because they often obstructed God's way, took usury although forbidden it, and consumed people's wealth without right. For the deniers among them We have prepared a painful punishment.

Outward commentary

Because of covenant-breaking, denial of God's signs and the murder of prophets, Ibn ʿAjība says, food formerly permitted was prohibited to the Children of Israel: kinds of fat, clawed animals and other desirable foods. In his account, whenever they committed a grave sin, He prohibited some good thing to them. They also turned from the divine way themselves or obstructed many other people from entering it, accepted usury (*ribā*) despite its prohibition in their own dispensation, and took wealth unjustly through bribes and illegitimate demands upon ordinary people. Usury is prohibited in the Muḥammadan dispensation as well. The punishment falls upon those who persist in denial, not those who repent and truly believe.

Spiritual allusion

Every heedlessness, sin and breach of spiritual courtesy (*sūʾ al-adab*) deprives its perpetrator, to a corresponding degree, of the sweetness of worship and the delights of witnessing, whether the person notices or not. One may be distanced from divine presence without realising it, in an imperceptible spiritual trial. If he persists, he is stripped of the station of protecting friendship (*wilāya*) altogether, and his faith continues to weaken little by little until it escapes him. God preserve us. Immediate repentance offers hope of restoration. Conversely, every awakening, obedient act and refinement of conduct brings a person nearer and increases the sweetness of devotional work and direct vision. By supererogatory good deeds a servant draws near until God loves him and becomes his hearing and sight, as the famous divine saying relates. God gives success.

4:162 · Those grounded in knowledge

Cairo I:589

لكِنِ الرَّاسِخُونَ فِي الْعِلْمِ مِنْهُمْ وَالْمُؤْمِنُونَ يُؤْمِنُونَ بِما أُنْزِلَ إِلَيْكَ وَما أُنْزِلَ مِنْ قَبْلِكَ وَالْمُقِيمِينَ الصَّلاةَ وَالْمُؤْتُونَ الزَّكاةَ وَالْمُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ أُولئِكَ سَنُؤْتِيهِمْ أَجْراً عَظِيماً (162)

Yet those of them deeply rooted in knowledge, and the believers, believe in what was revealed to you and before you; especially those who establish prayer, give alms, and believe in God and the Last Day. Such people We shall give a tremendous recompense.

Language

I say: "The believers" is coordinated with "those firmly rooted in knowledge"; "they believe" is circumstantial. *Al-muqīmīn* ("those who establish prayer") is in the accusative to express praise (*naṣb ʿalā l-madḥ*). Arabs sometimes depart from a repeated case construction in an extended encomium or censure, as in the Qurʾānic switch in 2:177. Ibn ʿAjība reports a statement attributed to ʿĀʾisha regarding an error by scribes, while noting that Ibn Masʿūd's codex is reported to read the expected nominative *al-muqīmūn*. *[Translator's note: These are reports of textual history; the received reading is accusative.]* [239]

Outward commentary

Not every person among the People of the Book belongs to the earlier condemned classes. Some have deep familiarity with earlier Scripture, such as ʿAbd Allāh ibn Salām and Mukhayrīq, and others in the same communities sincerely accept Muḥammad. They believe in what was sent to him and in preceding revelations without dividing the messengers, establish prayer properly, pay obligatory alms, and accept bodily resurrection and judgment and the doctrinal matters transmitted by the Qurʾān and Sunna. They re-

239. Cairo editor, C590.1: Scholars and commentators responded to this report, including Imam Ibn Jarīr al-Ṭabarī, who said: "Had this been an error by the scribe, the reading in all codices other than ours—the one copied for us by the scribe who erred in his writing—would necessarily have been [different]. The agreement of our codex and Ubayy's codex on this point indicates that what our codex contains is correct, not an error. Moreover, had it been an error in writing, the Companions of God's Messenger, from whom the Qur'an was received, would not have taught those Muslims whom they instructed an ungrammatical form; they would have corrected it and taught the community the correct form. The fact that all Muslims transmit it in recitation as it is represented in writing is the clearest proof of its validity and correctness, and that the scribe had no hand in producing it." See al-Ṭabarī's commentary with Shaykh Shākir's annotations, al-Suyūṭī's al-Itqān, and al-Rāzī's commentary.

ceive abundant recompense. On another parsing “those rooted in knowledge” denotes learned people of earlier Scripture while “the believers” refers to believing Arabs, with the other qualifications describing the latter.

Spiritual allusion

Whoever truly repents of past disobedience, wakes from heedlessness and becomes firmly grounded in knowledge of God, His attributes and His names, is joined to those who have preceded on the spiritual path and raised with the brought-near. Such people receive a tremendous reward. Praise belongs to God, Lord of the worlds. The next passage answers the demand for a book descending whole from heaven.

4:163–165 · The continuity of prophetic revelation

Cairo I:590

إِنَّا أَوْحَيْنا إِلَيْكَ كَما أَوْحَيْنا إِلى نُوحٍ وَالنَّبِيِّينَ مِنْ بَعْدِهِ وَأَوْحَيْنا إِلى إِبْراهِيمَ وَإِسْماعِيلَ وَإِسْحاقَ وَيَعْقُوبَ وَالْأَسْباطِ وَعِيسى وَأَيُّوبَ وَيُونُسَ وَهارُونَ وَسُلَيْمانَ وَآتَيْنا داوُدَ زَبُوراً (163) وَرُسُلاً قَدْ قَصَصْناهُمْ عَلَيْكَ مِنْ قَبْلُ وَرُسُلاً لَمْ نَقْصُصْهُمْ عَلَيْكَ وَكَلَّمَ اللَّهُ مُوسى تَكْلِيماً (164) رُسُلاً مُبَشِّرِينَ وَمُنْذِرِينَ لِئَلاَّ يَكُونَ لِلنَّاسِ عَلَى اللَّهِ حُجَّةٌ بَعْدَ الرُّسُلِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَزِيزاً حَكِيماً (165)

We have revealed to you as We revealed to Noah and the prophets after him, and to Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob, the tribes, Jesus, Job, Jonah, Aaron and Solomon; and We gave David a Psalter. We have told you of some messengers before and have not told you of others. God spoke to Moses directly. Messengers brought glad tidings and warnings so that, after their coming, people would have no argument against God. God is Mighty, Wise.

Language

I say: those reading *zabūran* with an open initial vowel refer to the Psalter as one book, whereas *zubūran*, with a rounded vowel, is understood as the plural of *zibr*—something written—thus implying several writings given to David. “Messengers” in the accusative may depend upon a suppressed verb indicated by “We revealed,” i.e. “We sent messengers,” or be explained by “We have narrated to you.” “Messengers bearing good news” can be appositional, accusative in praise, governed by an implicit “We sent,” or a preparatory circumstantial qualification for the words that follow, as when one says, “I passed Zayd, a righteous man.”

Outward commentary

God's revelation to Muḥammad resembles His revelation to Noah and later prophets; their scriptures did not necessarily descend as completed books at a single instant, despite the People of the Book's challenge. Revelation came piece by piece. Noah is named first, says Ibn ʿAjība, because he was humanity's ancestor after Adam, the first prophet of revealed law and the first to warn against associating partners with God, the first messenger whose community was punished in response to his prayer, and the prophet of exceptional longevity and patience. His very longevity was miraculous: Ibn ʿAjība transmits the description of a thousand-year life without loss of teeth, strength or hair colour, and of great endurance under insults and blows from his people.

Abraham, Ishmael, Isaac, Jacob and the *asbāṭ* (the Israelite tribal descendants), Jesus, Job, Jonah, Aaron and Solomon are named with special honour though all belong to the wider prophetic class. Abraham is described as the first of their prophets of firm resolve (*ulū l-ʿazm*) and Jesus as the last; the others are distinguished and famous. God gave David the Psalter or written leaves. Many messengers have been narrated already, while others remain unnamed; a report is quoted assigning them a number of 314. *[Translator’s note: This number is presented as a transmitted report.]* God spoke to Moses with actual divine address. Ibn ʿAjība understands this as a special distinction of Moses and adds that Muḥammad received both speech and vision.

Al-Wartajbī's inward comparison says Moses hastened to request vision and was held at the station of hearing His speech and barred from unalloyed witnessing of His vision, whereas Muḥammad patiently bore the

weight of spiritual secrets without demanding a public manifestation and was brought to witnessing and to speech heard without a mediating veil. He cites the verses of Sūrat al-Najm: “He revealed to His servant what He revealed; the heart did not falsify what it saw” (53:10–11). Ibn ʿAṭiyya affirms God’s speech to Moses without assigning it a modality or limit: God exists without resembling existents, is known without resembling known things, and speaks without His speech resembling created speech.

Messengers announce good and warn of evil, removing people's plea that they were never told about divine unity and the responsibilities of servanthood. Ibn ʿAjība cites the Prophetic report: “No one is more jealous than God, and for this reason He forbids indecencies, outward and inward. No one loves praise more than God, and for this reason He praises Himself. No one loves an excuse more than God Most High, and for this reason He sends messengers and reveals books.” God is mighty and under no external compulsion; His wisdom determines the forms of prophethood, revelation and miraculous sign appropriate for each messenger's time.

Spiritual allusion · inspiration, divine address and witnessing

The scholars of this community are compared analogically to Israel's prophets, and among them the knowers of God (*ʿārifūn*) to the messengers, because they guide people toward truth. *[Translator’s note: This analogy does not confer new prophethood or legislative revelation.]* Ibn al-Fāriḍ says:

> Our scholar is a prophet among them, and whoever calls
> to the Real from among us discharges the messenger’s task.
> Our gnostic in this Aḥmadan age of ours is among
> their people of firm resolve, holding fast to resolute purpose.
>
> 240

They share with the prophets in the revelation of inspiration (*waḥy al-ilhām*) and can, according to the Sufi testimony he records, experience inward divine address joined to witnessing. Al-Shushtarī sings:

> Through God I speak;
> from God I hear.

240. Cairo editor, C592.1: In the source copies: bi-l-risāla. I say: al-rusliyya means carrying out the message.

Some hearing comes through intermediaries and some without them, understood by those who have tasted these states. Those without experience are asked not to deny reflexively:

> If you do not see the crescent, accept the word
> of those who have seen it with their own eyes.

Al-Wartajbī says that when God wills a prophet or saint to hear divine speech He grants the person a hearing from His hearings, as in the divine saying "When I love him, I become his hearing..." He lets him hear His speech: there are no letters or sounds there. Rather, He lets him hear through the "letter of power" and the "voice of eternity," which is beyond the murmuring of breaths and the stirrings of insinuation. He also speaks of the unity of the hearer and the One who makes him hear in the aspect of love, not from the standpoint of gathering and separation (*jamʿ wa-tafriqa*).

Ibn ʿAjība then adds an important qualification rather than merely repeating al-Wartajbī. People of gathered vision (*jamʿ*) witness but one true Speaker, multiplicity and duality having vanished from their vision. Nonetheless they distinguish the discourse of divine power (*kalām al-qudra*) from the discourse of wisdom (*kalām al-ḥikma*). Speech of power bursts forth without the human speaker's discretionary control, as the speaker is seized in a state beyond ordinary choice; speech of wisdom accompanies an exercise of agency. Those in such states may, as a *karāma*, hear the speech of power through extraordinary unseen voices or inanimate things, in ways involving audible letters and sounds. Inward prompts arising in the heart and hidden divine disclosures can also be wordless and soundless, or communicable through indication alone.

Accordingly Ibn ʿAjība accepts al-Wartajbī's account where it concerns purely inward disclosures, but disputes any suggestion that all speech God allows His prophets and saints to hear must be without letters or sounds. The statement that nothing belonging to the temporal world remains within the "realm of eternity" means, for Ibn ʿAjība, that no traces of temporally originated things remain in the realm of those who witness eternity. They remain affirmed at the level of divine wisdom while effaced in the vision of divine power. Such effacement does not prevent human speech from being uttered and heard with letters and sounds: human nature cannot bear hearing the speech of the Real without the mediation of wisdom. God knows best.

4:166 · God’s witness to the revelation

Cairo I:593

لٰكِنِ اللَّهُ يَشْهَدُ بِما أَنْزَلَ إِلَيْكَ أَنْزَلَهُ بِعِلْمِهِ وَالْمَلائِكَةُ يَشْهَدُونَ وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ شَهِيداً (166)

But God Himself testifies concerning what He has revealed to you: He sent it down with His knowledge, and the angels bear witness too. God is sufficient as Witness.

Language

I say: *lākin* marks a correction of what the previous discourse implies—as if it said, “They refuse to acknowledge your revelation; yet God acknowledges it.” The Prophet's opponents among certain Jews are reported to have said they would not testify that revelation had come to him. If they withhold their acknowledgment, God's own testimony and that of the angels suffice. “With His knowledge” may mean that the Qurʾān embodies a special divine knowledge, including an inimitably ordered composition beyond any eloquent human capacity; or that it provides knowledge people need for life and the hereafter; or that it was revealed with God's knowledge of the person fit to receive Scripture.

The angels’ testimony indicates that they wish people to know the truth of the claim to prophethood in a way that dispenses with reflection and deliberation.[T209] This kind of knowledge is characteristic of angels. Al-Bayḍāwī says that human beings have no way to know such matters except through thought and reflection: had these opponents reasoned correctly, they would have recognized your prophethood and testified to it, as the angels recognized it and testified. Ibn ʿAjība adds that God can also create knowledge in a human heart directly, without preceding argument, through free guidance. God's testimony is enough without anyone else's assent.

Spiritual allusion

Just as God bears witness to the Messenger's prophethood, He bears witness to the special heirs of the Messenger who attain sanctity and recognition of God. The signs are divinely given sciences, profound inward secrets, luminous Prophetic manners, fine moral qualities, and extraordinary graces accompanied by fidelity to the revealed law. Such testimony is recognised only by those granted a share of prior divine care. Ibn ʿAjība cites the *Ḥikam*: "Glory to the One who made the evidence of His saints none other than the evidence of Himself, and who leads to Him none except whom He wishes to lead." God gives success.

4:167–169 · Disbelief, obstruction and distant wandering

Cairo I:594

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَصَدُّوا عَنْ سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ قَدْ ضَلُّوا ضَلالاً بَعِيداً (167)

إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا وَظَلَمُوا لَمْ يَكُنِ اللَّهُ لِيَغْفِرَ لَهُمْ وَلا لِيَهْدِيَهُمْ طَرِيقاً

(168) إِلاَّ طَرِيقَ جَهَنَّمَ خالِدِينَ فِيها أَبَداً وَكانَ ذلِكَ عَلَى اللَّهِ يَسِيراً

(169)

Those who disbelieve and bar others from God's way have indeed strayed far into error. Those who disbelieve and act unjustly—God will not forgive them nor guide them to any path save the path of Hell, in which they will abide for ever. That is easy for God (4:167–169).

Language

I say: *khālidīn* ("abiding") is a circumstantial accusative (*ḥāl muqaddara*), a condition anticipated with reference to their future abode.

Outward commentary

God, exalted is His majesty, says: Those who disbelieve in what He sent down upon His Messenger, whether Jews or others, and obstruct people from God's path, which leads to Him, have gone far astray. Their error is grave because they combine going astray themselves with causing others to go astray. One who misguides is more deeply immersed in error and further from casting it off.

Those who disbelieve and commit injustice may be understood as wronging other people by barring them from what would set them right and save them; or as wronging the Messenger by denying his prophethood and concealing the descriptions identifying him; or as wronging themselves through immersion in disbelief. God does not forgive them or guide them to a path other than that of Hell, where they remain for ever. His preceding judgment and truthful promise concern **the one who dies in disbelief**: it is that condition at death that Ibn ʿAjība explicitly specifies when he speaks of abiding in the Fire. Such judgment is neither difficult nor imposing for God.

Spiritual allusion

Those who deny the *khuṣūṣiyya*—the special spiritual distinction of the friends of God (*awliyāʾ*)—condemn those who possess it, and obstruct others from seeking or entering their company have strayed far from the path of arrival (*wuṣūl*). Ibn ʿAjība says that there is no arrival at God except at the hands of God's saints, for they are the door to the Divine Presence (*bāb al-ḥaḍra*), and approach to them requires courtesy (*adab*) and humility. *[Translator's note: This is his Sufi application of the verse, not a replacement of its outward subject.]*

Those who reject God's friends thereby wrong themselves and deprive themselves of arrival, leaving their hearts wandering through the valleys of passing thoughts (*khawāṭir*). They are not brought to the covering of faults, the sanctification of inward secrets, the path of direct witnessing (*mushāhada*), or knowledge of spiritual striving (*mujāhada*). Instead they remain on the way of exhaustion and toil, until they encounter God with an ailing heart. God is the refuge from such a condition.

After establishing the matter of prophethood, showing the way by which it is known and warning those who deny it, Ibn ʿAjība says the discourse turns to a universal summons to believe in the Messenger.

4:170 · The Messenger and the universal summons

Cairo I:595

يا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ قَدْ جاءَكُمُ الرَّسُولُ بِالْحَقِّ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ فَآمِنُوا خَيْراً لَكُمْ وَإِنْ تَكْفُرُوا فَإِنَّ لِلَّهِ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَكانَ اللَّهُ عَلِيماً حَكِيماً (170)

O humankind, the Messenger has come to you with the truth from your Lord. Therefore believe: it is better for you. If you disbelieve, all that is in the heavens and the earth belongs to God. God is All-Knowing, Wise (4:170).

Language

I say: the expressions *fa-āminū khayran lakum* (“so believe—it is better for you”) and, in the next verse, *intahū khayran lakum* (“desist—it is better for you”) present a problem concerning the accusative *khayran*. Sībawayh explains it through an omitted verb: “come to that which is better for you.” Al-Khalīl connects the accusative with the command “believe” or “desist” through its sense: “seek/aim at what is better.” Al-Farrāʾ takes it as an adjective of an understood verbal noun: “believe with a believing better for you.” Certain Kūfan grammarians make it the predicate of an elided *kāna*: “let belief be better for you.”

Ibn ʿAjība calls the last interpretation the clearest in meaning, though the Baṣrans object that *kāna* is not normally omitted with its subject except under specified conditions. He adduces Ibn Mālik's grammatical verse: “They omit it, leaving the predicate; after *in* and *law*, this is well known.” Perhaps the construction here departs from what is most familiar in order to signal the possibility of such ellipsis. *[Translator’s note: The discussion records competing grammatical accounts; Ibn ʿAjība gives his preference above.]*

Outward commentary

God's Messenger, Muḥammad—God bless him and give him peace—has come bearing truth from the Lord. Belief in him would be better than the error in which his hearers presently stand. If they choose denial, everything contained in and constituted by the heavens and the earth belongs to God in ownership, creation and servanthood. God needs nothing from them: their unbelief does not injure Him, just as their faith does not benefit Him. He knows their conditions and is wise in what He ordains for them.

Spiritual allusion

What the Messenger brought includes the perfecting of the station of *islām*, the rectification of the station of *īmān*—among whose foundations is belief in destiny, its good and evil, its sweet and bitter—and the realisation of the station of *iḥsān*, which is the station of beholding and direct witnessing (*shuhūd wa-ʿiyān*).

The full realisation of this, says Ibn ʿAjība, requires companionship with the people of experiential knowledge (*ahl al-ʿirfān*). They have rectified the station of passing away (*fanāʾ*) and emerged into abiding (*baqāʾ*); they have ventured into the seas of unity (*tawḥīd*) and become singularly devoted to the secrets of making-one (*tafrīd*). The stations of contentment and surrender (*riḍā wa-taslīm*) have become firm within them, so that they meet every divine apportionment with an unharmed heart. Without keeping company with them and being formed by their manners, a person's faith remains, in Ibn ʿAjība's assessment, incomplete and liable to admonition.

He then reformulates the Qurʾānic address **in the language of allusion**, as though God were saying, “My friend, the successor to My Messenger, has come to you: acknowledge his particular spiritual distinction, yield to his direction and training; that would be better for you than the defects and illnesses in which you live, lest you encounter Me with an unsound heart.” *[Translator’s note: This is an analogical Sufi application, not an assertion that a saint possesses the Messenger’s legislative status.]* Success comes through God.

Having addressed all people, the Qurʾān next addresses and admonishes the People of the Book in particular.

4:171 · Jesus as messenger, Word, and spirit

Cairo I:596

يا أَهْلَ الْكِتابِ لا تَغْلُوا فِي دِينِكُمْ وَلا تَقُولُوا عَلَى اللَّهِ إِلاَّ الْحَقَّ إِنَّمَا الْمَسِيحُ عِيسَى ابْنُ مَرْيَمَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ وَكَلِمَتُهُ أَلْقاها إِلى مَرْيَمَ وَرُوحٌ مِنْهُ فَآمِنُوا بِاللَّهِ وَرُسُلِهِ وَلا تَقُولُوا ثَلاثَةٌ انْتَهُوا خَيْراً لَكُمْ إِنَّمَا اللَّهُ إِلهٌ واحِدٌ سُبْحانَهُ أَنْ يَكُونَ لَهُ وَلَدٌ لَهُ ما فِي السَّماواتِ وَما فِي الْأَرْضِ وَكَفى بِاللَّهِ وَكِيلاً (171)

People of the Book, do not exceed the proper bounds in your religion, and say nothing of God except what is true. The Messiah, Jesus son of Mary, is only God's messenger, His Word conveyed to Mary, and a spirit from Him. So believe in God and His messengers and do not say “Three.” Desist; that is better for you. God is only one God; transcendent is He above having a child. To Him belongs all that is in the heavens and earth, and God suffices as Trustee (4:171).

Language

I say: the root of *ghulūw* is passing beyond the limit in anything. The Arabs say that a young girl has rapidly advanced in flesh and bone beyond those of her age when she has quickly attained adolescence and outstripped her contemporaries; the verb is *ghalā–yaghlū–ghulūwan*. The grammatical explanation of *khayran lakum* (“better for you”) was given under the preceding verse.

Outward commentary

The rebuke is addressed, in view of what follows, to Christians among the People of the Gospel. They are forbidden to exaggerate religion by transgressing its bounds and regarding Jesus as God or the son of God: intending to honour him, they carried their praise beyond its proper limit. They are not to say anything about God except the truth, which includes proclaiming Him exalted above a consort and offspring.

The Messiah, Jesus son of Mary, is God's messenger—not, as Ibn ʿAjība reports the Jewish denial, one who is no messenger, and not, as he describes the Christian affirmation, God or God's son. He is God's servant and messenger. He is God's Word cast to Mary: the divine command "Be!" was conveyed and realised within her, and through it he was formed in her womb; for this reason he is designated the Word. He is a "spirit from Him" through Gabriel's breathing into the opening of Mary's garment, through which she conceived. The breath is called *rūḥ*, as a moving breath issuing from a living spirit, and Jesus' spirit is connected with the Holy Spirit's breath.

Ibn ʿAjība invokes the parallel with Adam: "I breathed into him of My Spirit," and "The likeness of Jesus with God is as the likeness of Adam." In reality, since Gabriel breathed by God's command, the action may be ascribed to God Himself: for those with realised vision the intermediary is effaced in relation to the divine originating command. It is thus in this respect that Jesus' spirit, like Adam's, is attributed to God. *[Translator's note: This language is not being understood here as establishing shared divinity.]*

"Believe in God and His messengers" means maintaining the uniqueness of God in His deity. "Do not say 'Three'" excludes a plurality of gods. Here Ibn ʿAjība paraphrases the three as God, the Messiah and Mary, then insists upon divine unity of essence, attributes and acts. *[Translator's note: This is Ibn ʿAjība's polemical representation of Christian doctrine; it does not describe the Nicene formulation of Father, Son and Holy Spirit.]* God is free from having a child: nothing shares His genus, extinction cannot touch Him, and everything in heaven and earth belongs to Him as creation, property and servants. Servanthood is inconsistent with the sonship Ibn ʿAjība has in view. God needs no heir or representative, whereas a human son may succeed or act for a father; God Himself maintains all things and needs neither helper nor successor because He necessarily endures and is absolutely independent.

Ibn ʿAjība inserts a historical taxonomy, dividing Christians into Nestorians, Jacobites, Melkites and "Marqūsites," adding the Christians of Najrān. He ascribes to Nestorians a formulation of Jesus as son of God, to Jacobites and Melkites his being God, and to "Marqūsites" the assertion that he is the third of three; he judges them all in error. *[Translator's note: These labels and formulations are the author's assertions; their accuracy as descriptions of the named communities' historical doctrines is unestablished.]*

Spiritual allusion

All excess is blameworthy, for the best of matters is the middle way. Ibn ʿAjība cites the Prophetic instruction: "Do not exaggerate in praising me as the Christians exaggerated in praising Jesus son of Mary; rather say, 'God's servant and messenger.'" A Sufi disciple (*faqīr*) may be allowed elevated language in praising his shaykh only so long as it does not remove the shaykh from his true created station or demean others through the praise. The deeper purpose is to guard the station of divine unity and to proclaim God beyond opposites and rivals.

A poet says: "A Lord and a servant, and denial of an opposite? / I said to him: 'That is not my view.' / He asked: 'What do you hold?' We replied: / 'The existence of loss, and the loss of existence.'" If independent and self-subsisting creaturely being were posited over against Lordship, that would establish an opposite to it; that is what the poet rejects. Ibn ʿAjība cites the *Ḥikam*: "Created things subsist through His establishing them and are effaced through the oneness of His Essence." *[Translator's note: This is understood here as concerning creaturely dependence in the vision of divine unity; the distinction governing religious obligation and practice is not being denied.]*

A narrative follows: when the Christians of Najrān reportedly protested that the Prophet disparaged their master Jesus, he asked whom they meant. Told that it was Jesus and that they objected to his calling Jesus the servant of God, he replied, "It is no dishonour that Jesus be a servant of God." Ibn ʿAjība introduces the next verse as revealed in this connection. *[Translator's note: The narrative is reproduced as a report in the commentary; its chain and historical circumstances are unestablished.]*

4:172–173 · Servanthood, angels, and its four marks

Cairo I:597

لَنْ يَسْتَنْكِفَ الْمَسِيحُ أَنْ يَكُونَ عَبْداً لِلَّهِ وَلا الْمَلائِكَةُ الْمُقَرَّبُونَ وَمَنْ يَسْتَنْكِفْ عَنْ عِبادَتِهِ وَيَسْتَكْبِرْ فَسَيَحْشُرُهُمْ إِلَيْهِ جَمِيعاً (172) فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحاتِ فَيُوَفِّيهِمْ أُجُورَهُمْ وَيَزِيدُهُمْ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ وَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ اسْتَنْكَفُوا وَاسْتَكْبَرُوا فَيُعَذِّبُهُمْ عَذاباً أَلِيماً وَلا يَجِدُونَ لَهُمْ مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ وَلِيًّا وَلا نَصِيراً (173)

The Messiah will never disdain to be God's servant, nor will the angels brought near. Whoever disdains His worship and acts arrogantly—He will gather them all to Himself. As for those who believe and do good, He will give them their rewards in full and increase them from His bounty. As for those who disdain and are arrogant, He will punish them with a painful punishment, and apart from God they shall find neither protecting friend nor helper (4:172–173).

Language

I say: *istinkāf*, "refusing out of disdain," originally refers to moving something away: one says *nakaftu l-damʿ*, "I wiped away the tears with my finger," so that their trace could not be seen. It subsequently denotes proud distaste. Al-Bayḍāwī says *istikbār* (self-exaltation) is less intense than *istinkāf*, which is why it is conjoined to it. *Istinkāf* is used only where there is no entitlement, whereas *istikbār* may occur where there is entitlement. These are al-Bayḍāwī's lexical distinctions as cited by Ibn ʿAjība.

Outward commentary

Against those who exalt Jesus beyond servanthood, God declares that the Messiah never recoils from being God's servant. Indeed, his servanthood is the honour in which he may glory; humiliation would be servitude to someone other than God. Neither do the angels brought near recoil from such servanthood: their dignity is rooted precisely in serving Him.

Some theologians invoked the coordination of the angels after Jesus in this verse to argue that angels are superior to prophets: they said an additional member in such a construction should signify a higher rank, so that the angels' lack of disdain confirms all the more strongly that Jesus cannot disdain servanthood. Ibn ʿAjība responds that the conjunction may instead serve amplification and generalisation. One says, 'Today neither chief nor subordinate disobeys the prince,' even though the chief has the higher rank; the conjunction does not entail a ranking of its second member above its first.

He then gives what he considers the sound ranking: prophets and messengers outrank the specially favoured or "near" angels; these special angels outrank specially favoured humans, the saints; such humans outrank ordinary angels, who outrank ordinary humanity. Thus one who subordinates appetite to intellect may be like the angels or above them, whereas one in whom appetite dominates intellect may be like cattle or further astray. Ibn ʿAjība ends the comparison with "God knows best." *[Translator's note: This theological ordering is reported from the commentary; a universal consensus is unestablished.]*

God warns the one who rejects servanthood arrogantly that all will be gathered for divine recompense. Those whose belief expresses itself in sound works, and who do not recoil from His worship, receive their wages in full, with an increase of grace beyond what eye has seen, ear heard or mind conceived. Those who reject worship through disdain and arrogance receive a painful punishment, understood in the outward commentary as the Fire; no protecting ally or helper will then be found apart from God.

Al-Qushayrī offers an inward elaboration: for such people an even more painful punishment is never to arrive in God's Presence after His majesty has become known to them by an unavoidable, overpowering knowledge. Their regrets over what they have missed are then their most severe punishment.

Ibn ʿAjība raises a grammatical and argumentative objection. The threat of being gathered initially concerns the arrogant, but the subsequent distribution of recompense covers **all** people, including the believers. He replies that the wider scope is already implicit in the force of the statement: they will be gathered for recompense on the day when God recompenses all His servants. Thus a ruler may assemble his whole kingdom, honouring the scholars and cutting the tyrants off. *[Translator's note: Cairo I:598 prints faqaṭaʿahum, "so he cut them off," without specifying the punitive act. Al-Zamakhsharī on 4:173 offers a related illustrative contrast: an imam rewards those who did not rebel and punishes those who did. It explains the distribution of recompense between two groups; it does not establish the exact physical or political act intended by Ibn ʿAjība's different verb. The translation therefore preserves that lack of specification.]* God knows best.

Spiritual allusion · the four marks of servanthood

ʿUbūdiyya (servanthood) is the most noble condition and the highest station: through it the honoured become honourable and the exalted are raised. God addresses His beloved servants only by their servanthood: "Glory to Him who carried His servant by night," "Remember Our servants Abraham, Isaac and Jacob," "Remember Our servant David," and "Remember Our servant Job—what an excellent servant; he ever turns back," among other examples.

Ibn ʿAjība names four qualities of servanthood: **abasement (*dhull*), poverty (*faqr*), weakness (*ḍaʿf*) and ignorance (*jahl*)**. Opposed to them are four predicates of Lordship: dignity or might (*ʿizz*), riches or freedom from need (*ghinā'*), strength (*quwwa*) and knowledge (*ʿilm*). In the measure that a servant manifests the qualities of servanthood, the Real supplies him from the qualities of Lordship: to the acknowledgment of abasement, dignity; to poverty, sufficiency; to weakness, power; and to ignorance, knowledge. "Realise your proper description, and He will support you with His

description.” The manifestation of these qualities, he adds, is realised only *among God’s servants*, so that the attributes of the ego may thereby be effaced.

The discourse turns from the dignity of servanthood to a universal invitation to God's scripture and His Messenger.

4:174–175 · Proof, manifest light and the straight path

Cairo I:599

يا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ قَدْ جاءَكُمْ بُرْهانٌ مِنْ رَبِّكُمْ وَأَنْزَلْنا إِلَيْكُمْ نُوراً مُبِيناً (174) فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا بِاللَّهِ وَاعْتَصَمُوا بِهِ فَسَيُدْخِلُهُمْ فِي رَحْمَةٍ مِنْهُ وَفَضْلٍ وَيَهْدِيهِمْ إِلَيْهِ صِراطاً مُسْتَقِيماً (175)

O humankind, a clear proof has come to you from your Lord, and We have sent down to you a manifest light. Those who believe in God and hold fast to Him—He will admit them into mercy from Him and bounty, and guide them to Himself by a straight path (4:174–175).

Outward commentary

The *burhān* (proof) may be the Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace—together with his evident miracles, while the manifest *nūr* (light) sent down through his tongue is the Qurʾān. Alternatively the proof refers particularly to the outward miracles, the manifest light to the mighty Qurʾān. Both rational indication and the attestations of transmission (*dalīl al-ʿaql wa-shawāhid al-naql*) have come; no valid excuse or pretext remains for rejecting them.

Those who affirm God's uniqueness in Lordship and cling to His religion or His Book will be brought into mercy from Him. Ibn ʿAjība identifies this mercy with the Garden and the additional “bounty” with the vision of His generous Face. He quotes al-Bayḍāwī: mercy is the recompense appointed for belief and deeds, but it is bestowed as mercy, not the settlement of some

debt or right binding on God. Bounty is a further divine beneficence over and above the appointed recompense. Al-Qushayrī takes the promised favour to include God's preserving their faith at the time of death, just as He honours them now with belief and intimate knowledge (*ʿirfān*).

"He will guide them to Himself" promises arrival and shows the way of approach. The straight path without crookedness is the path of journeying comprising knowledge, work and inward condition (*ʿilm, ʿamal, ḥāl*). Al-Bayḍāwī explains it as Islam and obedience in this life and the route to Paradise in the hereafter.

Spiritual allusion

Those who show the way to knowing God and indicate the route to Him are God's friends, the *awliyāʾ*. They bear a proof clear to those fit to perceive it, though hidden, says Ibn ʿAjība, to someone with the sight of a bat. From the secret of holiness and the ocean of divine power (*jabarūt*) there descends a manifest light wherein the secrets of the divine Essence and the lights of the divine attributes are witnessed. This light is what has appeared of the self-disclosures (*tajalliyāt*) from the first Muḥammadan grasp (*al-qabḍa al-awwaliyya al-muḥammadiyya*).

Those who believe and hold fast while journeying toward God will be admitted to the mercy of the holy Presence (*ḥaḍrat al-quds*) and to an additional bounty: perpetual progress in the endless mysteries of spiritual knowledge (*maʿārif*). They are guided into arrival through beholding Him within the light, by a straight path that brings them to Him in the shortest time.

Ibn ʿAjība suggests a possible inversion in the order of expression: perhaps the intended sequence is that God guides them first upon a straight way, so that they travel it and arrive; thereafter He admits them into the mercy of His Presence and the bounty of increased knowledge. He offers this tentatively: "God knows best."

The chapter ends with the inheritance of *kalāla*, because death is the last condition of a human life, after which property passes to heirs. Ibn ʿAjība observes that "God instructs you concerning your children" could appropriately have been mentioned here, but was included in the discussion of preserving property because that was more fitting.

4:176 · The inheritance of kalāla; spiritual succession

Cairo Arabic edition I:600–601

يَسْتَفْتُونَكَ قُلِ اللَّهُ يُفْتِيكُمْ فِي الْكَلالَةِ إِنِ امْرُؤٌ هَلَكَ لَيْسَ لَهُ وَلَدٌ وَلَهُ أُخْتٌ فَلَها نِصْفُ ما تَرَكَ وَهُوَ يَرِثُها إِنْ لَمْ يَكُنْ لَها وَلَدٌ فَإِنْ كانَتَا اثْنَتَيْنِ فَلَهُمَا الثُّلُثانِ مِمَّا تَرَكَ وَإِنْ كانُوا إِخْوَةً رِجالاً وَنِساءً فَلِلذَّكَرِ مِثْلُ حَظِّ الْأُنْثَيَيْنِ يُبَيِّنُ اللَّهُ لَكُمْ أَنْ تَضِلُّوا وَاللَّهُ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ (176)

They ask you for a legal determination. Say: “God gives you a determination concerning kalāla. If a man dies leaving no child but having a sister, she receives half of what he leaves; and he inherits from her if she has no child. If they are two sisters, they receive two-thirds of what he leaves. If they are brothers and sisters together, the male has the portion of two females.” God makes it clear to you lest you stray; God knows all things (4:176).

Language

I say: the phrase *fī l-kalāla* (“concerning *kalāla*”) can relate to both *yastaftūnaka* (“they seek a ruling from you”) and *yuftīkum* (“He gives you a ruling”), making the construction an instance of grammatical *tanāzuʿ*, two governors competing over a complement. On the preferred Baṣran construction the second verb exercises government while the pronominal complement required by the first is omitted: the sense is “they seek a ruling from you **about it**.” Alternatively, the first verb may govern and the second omit its pronoun; or “They seek a ruling from you” may stand as a complete expression with a pause; or the relation to the first may simply be understood from the answer. The last, that they are asking about *kalāla*, appears most straightforward to Ibn ʿAjība. He refers back to his earlier explanation of the term. In *in imruʾun halaka* (“if a man dies”), the nominative *imruʾun* is

analysed by Baṣran grammarians through a suppressed verb in a construction resembling *ishtighāl*, anticipation of the expressed verb by an omitted governing expression. [241]

Outward commentary

The inquirer, Ibn ʿAjība says, was Jābir ibn ʿAbd Allāh, who fell ill and received a visit from the Messenger—God bless him and grant him peace. He said, "Messenger of God, I am a *kalāla*: how should I dispose of my property?" The verse was revealed, and Ibn ʿAjība calls it the last of the legal rulings to be revealed. *[Translator's note: The central episode of Jābir's illness and inheritance question is attested in al-Bukhārī 6743 and Muslim 1616a; Muslim explicitly cites 4:176. Separately, al-Bukhārī 4605 transmits al-Barāʾ's statement that 4:176 was the final verse revealed. The latter is a Companion's chronological report; it does not establish agreement among all transmitted chronologies. See source checks XII-S033–034.]*

God gives the requested determination: if a man dies without a child **or father**, so that his direct line is absent in both directions, but has one full sister or paternal half-sister, she receives half his estate; the rest belongs to the legally entitled residuary agnates (*ʿaṣaba*). She inherits nothing in the presence of a father or son. Conversely, a brother inherits his sister's estate if she dies without a child or father. If there is no other share-holder, he takes all; if someone has a prescribed portion (*dhū sahm*), he takes what remains.

If there are two or more full sisters, they share two-thirds of the estate. Where there is one full sister and one sister through the father, the full sister receives one-half and the paternal half-sister one-sixth, completing two-thirds. *[Translator's note: The printed text reads* شقيقة مع الأب*, literally 'a full sister with the father.' This translation supplies 'a sister through' before 'the father,' as indicated by the following allocation to 'the one through the father'; the supplied wording is not what the copytext prints. Mālik's Muwaṭṭaʾ, Book of Inheritances, chapter on paternal siblings, confirms the stated allocation: a sole full sister receives half and the paternal sister or sisters receive the complementary sixth. This confirms the legal case, not an independently attested correction of Ibn ʿAjība's wording.]* A paternal half-sister does not inherit in the case envisaged when two full sisters have

241. Cairo editor, C600.1: See the commentary on verse 12 of this same sūra.

already taken the two-thirds. If the deceased leaves full brothers and sisters, the male receives twice the portion of the female. Ibn ʿAjība then says that paternal half-siblings have no portion where full brothers and sisters take priority in the case described. *[Translator's note: The copytext prints* من الشقائق*, literally 'from/of the full siblings.' The English understands this as referring to their presence in the preceding case; it does not reproduce an explicit printed 'with.' Mālik's Muwaṭṭaʾ, Book of Inheritances, chapter on paternal siblings, confirms that a male full sibling excludes the paternal siblings in this case. The likely sense is thus supported, but* مع الشقائق *("with the full siblings") remains a conjectural replacement of the printed preposition, not an independently verified authorial reading.]*

[Translator's note: These statements are Ibn ʿAjība's compact explanation of particular cases. Their application in actual estates requires the complete roster of heirs, precise kinship, impediments, residuary relationships and the legal school's detailed rules.] The conclusion says God makes the truth manifest so that people may not go astray, for He knows the welfare of servants in life and after death. Ibn ʿAjība concludes with a supplication: "O God, grant us a good life and a good death, in well-being and under Your gracious covering, O Most Merciful of the merciful, Lord of the worlds."

Spiritual allusion · heirs to the saintly secret

Among the *awliyāʾ*, the one who dies as *kalāla* is the saint who leaves no spiritual child to inherit his inward condition: he has no disciples in whom the state has been transmitted. If he has a spiritual brother close to his own station, the brother inherits it. A "sister" in the spiritual affiliation (*nisba*) can also inherit some of his secret; according to God's wisdom, she is not entitled to all of it; Ibn ʿAjība points to the Qurʾānic allotment of half as indicating this.

When he leaves fellow disciples who are brothers in allegiance to the same shaykh, they divide his entire spiritual secret, each according to the sincerity (*ṣidq*) with which he receives it. Sincere women, Ibn ʿAjība expressly says, are the counterparts of sincere men in their capacity to attain the mysteries of sainthood (*wilāya*). He recalls the image introduced earlier in the sūra: the spiritual aid (*madad*) of the shaykh resembles a river, or a sea, pouring into water channels; when one channel becomes blocked, its

flow passes to another. *[Translator's note: The legal ending is thus interpreted as an image of the transmission of spiritual realisation.]* God knows best.

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ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Fāsī

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ʿAbd al-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf

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Abū al-ʿAbbās al-Mursī

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Abū al-Dardāʾ

p. 622 · Q3:104 · Cairo I:389–391; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453

Abū al-Ḥasan al-Nūrī

p. 79 · Q2:26–27 · Cairo I:90–91

Abū al-Ḥasan (unexpanded shaykh references)

Unexpanded shaykh references are retained without equating every short form with a single person. In Q2:26–27 the separately named al-Nūrī is excluded from this entry.

p. 79 · Q2:26–27 · Cairo I:90–91; p. 129 · Q2:63–66 · Cairo I:116–118; p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198; p. 295 · Q2:186 · Cairo I:213–215; p. 341 · Q2:214 · Cairo I:240–241; p. 405 · Q2:248 · Cairo I:275–276; p. 705 · Q3:165 · Cairo I:432–433

Abū al-Sammāl

p. 465 · Q2:275–279 · Cairo I:309–311

Abū al-Suʿūd

p. 86 · Q2:30–33 · Cairo I:93–95 · translator's note; p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288; p. 840 · Q4:37–39 · Cairo I:503–504 · translator's note; p. 948 · Q4:117–121 · Cairo I:562 · translator's note

Abū Bakr

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Abū Dāwūd

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 362 · Q2:222–223 · Cairo I:252–254

Abū Dharr

p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453; p. 908 · Q4:84–86 · Cairo I:538–540 · translator's note

Abū Ḥafṣ al-Ḥaddād

p. 182 · Q2:104 · Cairo I:147

Abū Ḥafṣ (unexpanded name at Q4:19)

p. 795 · Q4:19 · Cairo I:481–483

Abū Ḥanīfa

p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 252 · Q2:158 · Cairo I:188–189; p. 368 · Q2:226–227 · Cairo I:255–256; p. 378 · Q2:232 · Cairo I:260–261; p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385; p. 803 · Q4:23 · Cairo I:485–486; p. 828 · Q4:33 · Cairo I:497–498; p. 834 · Q4:35 · Cairo I:500–501; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552; p. 934 · Q4:102 · Cairo I:553; p. 937 · Q4:103 · Cairo I:554

Abū Hurayra

p. 366 · Q2:224–225 · Cairo I:254–255; p. 465 · Q2:275–279 · Cairo I:309–311; p. 471 · Q2:280–281 · Cairo I:311–313; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409; p. 770 · Q4:8 · Cairo I:468–469; p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493; p. 819 · Q4:29–30 · Cairo I:493–495; p. 843 · Q4:40 · Cairo I:504–505; p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517; p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520

Abū Jābir al-Sulamī

p. 644 · Q3:121–122 · Cairo I:401–402

Abū Madyan

p. 344 · Q2:215 · Cairo I:241–242

Abū Mūsā

p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288; p. 762 · Q4:5 · Cairo I:464–466

Abū Nuʿaym

p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524 · translator's note

Abū Saʿīd al-Kharrāz

p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538

Abū Saʿīd al-Khudrī

p. 143 · Q2:79 · Cairo I:124–125; p. 734 · Q3:188–189 · Cairo I:448–449; p. 792 · Q4:17–18 · Cairo I:479–481

Abū Saʿīd (transmitter at Q2:261–262)

This occurrence gives the short name without its identifying epithet.

p. 439 · Q2:261–262 · Cairo I:295–296

Abū Sufyān

p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416; p. 679 · Q3:149–150 · Cairo I:418; p. 681 · Q3:151 · Cairo I:419; p. 714 · Q3:173–175 · Cairo I:437–439; p. 861 · Q4:51–52 · Cairo I:513–514

Abū Sulaymān al-Dārānī

p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218; p. 411 · Q2:250–252 · Cairo I:279–282; p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477; p. 859 · Q4:49–50 · Cairo I:512

Abū Ṭalḥa

p. 603 · Q3:92 · Cairo I:380–382; p. 687 · Q3:154 · Cairo I:422–424

Abū Turāb

p. 285 · Q2:178–179 · Cairo I:207–209; p. 823 · Q4:31 · Cairo I:495–496

Abū ʿUthmān

p. 182 · Q2:104 · Cairo I:147; p. 787 · Q4:13–14 · Cairo I:477–478

Abū Yazīd

p. 118 · Q2:58–59 · Cairo I:110–112; p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157; p. 757 · Q4:3 · Cairo I:462–463; p. 830 · Q4:34 · Cairo I:498–500

Adam

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 48 · Q2:3 · Cairo I:73–75; p. 86 · Q2:30–33 · Cairo I:93–95; p. 90 · Q2:34 · Cairo I:95–96; p. 91 · Q2:35–37 · Cairo I:96–97; p. 94 · Q2:38–39 · Cairo I:97–99; p. 96 · Q2:40–43 · Cairo I:99–100; p. 121 · Q2:60 · Cairo I:112–113; p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147; p. 215 · Q2:127 · Cairo I:165–166; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 291 · Q2:183–185 · Cairo I:211–213; p. 319 · Q2:198–199 · Cairo I:228–230; p. 339 · Q2:213 · Cairo I:239–240; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 398 · Q2:245 · Cairo I:271–273; p. 405 · Q2:248 · Cairo I:275–276; p. 416 · Q2:253 · Cairo I:282–284; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 562 · Q3:59–60 · Cairo I:361–362; p. 589 · Q3:81–82 · Cairo I:374–375; p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385; p. 661 · Q3:135–136 · Cairo I:409–411; p. 751 · Q4:1 · Cairo I:459–461; p. 792 · Q4:17–18 · Cairo I:479–481; p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590; p. 1003 · Q4:171 · Cairo I:596

Aḥmad b. Yūsuf al-Fāsī

p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198 · translator's note

Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal

p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552

ʿĀʾisha

p. 289 · Q2:180–182 · Cairo I:209–211; p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218; p. 366 · Q2:224–225 · Cairo I:254–255; p. 393 · Q2:243 · Cairo I:268–270; p. 493 · Q3:7–9 · Cairo I:323–326; p. 644 · Q3:121–122 · Cairo I:401–402; p. 757 · Q4:3 · Cairo I:462–463; p. 897 · Q4:79–80 · Cairo I:532–534; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552; p. 958 · Q4:128 · Cairo I:568; p. 991 · Q4:162 · Cairo I:589

al-Akhfash

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al-Akhnas

p. 329 · Q2:204–207 · Cairo I:233–235

ʿAlī

The Companion in the listed contexts; passages naming later teachers called ʿAlī are separated.

p. 27 · Q1:6 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 43 · intro2 · Cairo I:71 · text and translator's note; p. 64 · Q2:14–16 · Cairo I:81–83; p. 123 · Q2:61 · Cairo I:113–115; p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147; p. 185 · Q2:106–107 · Cairo I:148–150; p. 289 · Q2:180–182 · Cairo I:209–211; p. 323 · Q2:200–202 · Cairo I:230–232; p. 407 · Q2:249 · Cairo I:276–279; p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288; p. 464 · Q2:274 · Cairo I:308; p. 503 · Q3:14 · Cairo I:328–331; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 565 · Q3:61–63 · Cairo I:362–364; p. 589 · Q3:81–82 · Cairo I:374–375; p. 622 · Q3:104 · Cairo I:389–391; p. 705 · Q3:165 · Cairo I:432–433; p. 732 · Q3:187 · Cairo I:447–448; p. 801 · Q4:22 · Cairo I:484–485; p. 803 · Q4:23 · Cairo I:485–486; p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493; p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503; p. 869 · Q4:58 · Cairo I:517–518

ʿAlī al-Jamal

p. 276 · Q2:172–173 · Cairo I:202–203; p. 289 · Q2:180–182 · Cairo I:209–211; p. 308 · Q2:190–195 · Cairo I:222–224; p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538

ʿAlī al-Khawwāṣ

p. 465 · Q2:275–279 · Cairo I:309–311

ʿAmmār ibn Yāsir

p. 189 · Q2:109–110 · Cairo I:151–152; p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524

Anas ibn al-Naḍr

p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416

Anas ibn Mālik

The narrator Anas; the separate Anas ibn al-Naḍr is not merged here.

p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 503 · Q3:14 · Cairo I:328–331; p. 512 · Q3:19 · Cairo I:334–335; p. 615 · Q3:100–102 · Cairo I:386–388; p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396; p. 745 · Q3:196–198 · Cairo I:454–456; p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493

al-ʿArabī al-Darqāwī

p. 4 · Preface · Cairo I:49–51

al-ʿArabī ibn ʿAbd Allāh

p. 289 · Q2:180–182 · Cairo I:209–211; p. 471 · Q2:280–281 · Cairo I:311–313

ʿAṭāʾ al-Khurāsānī

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ʿAṭāʾ (short form at Q3:52–54)

p. 555 · Q3:52–54 · Cairo I:357–359

al-Awzāʿī

p. 362 · Q2:222–223 · Cairo I:252–254; p. 545 · Q3:42–43 · Cairo I:351–352

al-Azharī

p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218

al-Baghawī

p. 518 · Q3:21–22 · Cairo I:336–337 · translator's note; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349 · translator's note

al-Bayḍāwī

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 22 · Q1:5 · Cairo I:52–70 · text and translator's note; p. 27 · Q1:6 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 59 · Q2:11–12 · Cairo I:79–80 · translator's note; p. 86 · Q2:30–33 · Cairo I:93–95 · text and translator's note; p. 99 · Q2:44 · Cairo I:100–101; p. 121 · Q2:60 · Cairo I:112–113; p. 140 · Q2:78 · Cairo I:123–124; p. 159 · Q2:90–91 · Cairo I:133–135; p. 174 · Q2:100 · Cairo I:141–143; p. 176 · Q2:101 · Cairo I:143; p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157; p. 201 · Q2:116–117 · Cairo I:157–158; p. 209 · Q2:124 · Cairo I:162–163; p. 221 · Q2:133–134 · Cairo I:168–169; p. 227 · Q2:139–141 · Cairo I:172–173; p. 229 · Q2:142 · Cairo I:173–175; p. 233 · Q2:143–144 · Cairo I:175–178; p. 237 · Q2:145–147 · Cairo I:178–180; p. 240 · Q2:148–149 · Cairo I:180–181; p. 257 · Q2:163–164 · Cairo I:190–193; p. 269 · Q2:168–169 · Cairo I:198–200; p. 285 · Q2:178–179 · Cairo I:207–209; p. 295 · Q2:186 · Cairo I:213–215; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 360 · Q2:221 · Cairo I:250–252; p. 362 · Q2:222–223 · Cairo I:252–254; p. 416 · Q2:253 · Cairo I:282–284; p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288; p. 427 · Q2:256 · Cairo I:288–289; p. 439 · Q2:261–262 · Cairo I:295–296; p. 448 · Q2:266 · Cairo I:299–300; p. 454 · Q2:269 · Cairo I:303–304; p. 473 · Q2:282 · Cairo I:313–315; p. 482 · Q2:285–286 · Cairo I:317–320; p. 488 · Q3:1–3 · Cairo I:321–322; p. 493 · Q3:7–9 · Cairo I:323–326; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 531 · Q3:31–32 · Cairo I:343–345; p. 545 · Q3:42–43 · Cairo I:351–352; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 568 · Q3:64 · Cairo I:364–365; p. 601 · Q3:91 · Cairo I:379–380; p. 605 · Q3:93–95 · Cairo I:382–383; p. 613 · Q3:98–99 · Cairo I:385–386; p. 615 · Q3:100–102 · Cairo I:386–388; p. 651 · Q3:126–129 · Cairo I:404–405; p. 687 · Q3:154 · Cairo I:422–424; p. 700 · Q3:161 · Cairo I:429–430; p. 702 · Q3:162–163 · Cairo I:430–431; p. 705 · Q3:165 · Cairo I:432–433 · translator's note; p. 710 · Q3:169–171 · Cairo I:435–436; p. 729 · Q3:185 · Cairo I:445–446; p. 736 · Q3:190 · Cairo I:449; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453; p. 743 · Q3:195 · Cairo I:453–454; p. 751 · intro4 · Cairo I:459; p. 751 · Q4:1 · Cairo I:459–461; p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477; p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477 · translator's note; p. 792 · Q4:17–18 · Cairo I:479–481; p. 819 · Q4:29–30 · Cairo I:493–495; p. 825 · Q4:32 · Cairo I:496–497; p. 840 · Q4:37–39 · Cairo I:503–504 · text and translator's note; p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524 · translator's note; p. 882 · Q4:69–70 · Cairo I:524–526; p. 885 · Q4:71–74 · Cairo I:526–528; p. 889 · Q4:75 · Cairo I:528–529; p. 901 · Q4:82 · Cairo I:534–535; p. 925 · Q4:95–96 · Cairo I:548; p. 927 · Q4:97–99 · Cairo I:549; p. 929 · Q4:100 · Cairo I:550; p. 934 · Q4:102 · Cairo I:553; p. 937 · Q4:103 · Cairo I:554; p. 945 · Q4:114 · Cairo I:560; p. 947 · Q4:115–116 · Cairo I:561; p. 948 · Q4:117–121 · Cairo I:562 · text

and translator's note; p. 948 · Q4:117–121 · Cairo I:562; p. 951 · Q4:122 · Cairo I:563; p. 953 · Q4:124–126 · Cairo I:565–566; p. 960 · Q4:129 · Cairo I:569 · translator's note; p. 963 · Q4:131–133 · Cairo I:570–573; p. 972 · Q4:140–141 · Cairo I:577–578 · translator's note; p. 978 · Q4:145–147 · Cairo I:580; p. 983 · Q4:152 · Cairo I:584; p. 987 · Q4:155–158 · Cairo I:586; p. 997 · Q4:166 · Cairo I:593; p. 1006 · Q4:172–173 · Cairo I:597; p. 1009 · Q4:174–175 · Cairo I:599

al-Bayhaqī

p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503 · translator's note; p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538 · translator's note

al-Bukhārī

p. 59 · Q2:11–12 · Cairo I:79–80; p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218; p. 503 · Q3:14 · Cairo I:328–331; p. 700 · Q3:161 · Cairo I:429–430; p. 745 · Q3:196–198 · Cairo I:454–456; p. 757 · Q4:3 · Cairo I:462–463; p. 828 · Q4:33 · Cairo I:497–498; p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503 · translator's note; p. 856 · Q4:47 · Cairo I:510–511; p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520 · translator's note; p. 925 · Q4:95–96 · Cairo I: 548; p. 1011 · Q4:176 · Cairo I:600–601 · translator's note

al-Buraʿī

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al-Būrīnī

p. 894 · Q4:78 · Cairo I:530–532 · translator's note

al-Būṣīrī

p. 807 · Q4:24 · Cairo I:485–489

al-Ḍaḥḥāk

p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520

David

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al-Dhahabī

p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503 · translator's note

Dhū al-Nūn

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Eve

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Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70

al-Fārisī (commentary on the Ḥamāsa)

p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517 · translator's note

al-Fāsī (glossator, unexpanded name)

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Fāṭima

p. 144 · Q2:80–82 · Cairo I:125–127; p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 545 · Q3:42–43 · Cairo I:351–352; p. 565 · Q3:61–63 · Cairo I:362–364

Finḥāṣ

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Fuḍayl

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Gabriel

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 108 · Q2:51–53 · Cairo I:105–106; p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 170 · Q2:97–98 · Cairo I:139–141; p. 233 · Q2:143–144 · Cairo I:175–178; p. 319 · Q2:198–199 · Cairo I:228–230; p. 416 · Q2:253 · Cairo I:282–284; p. 465 · Q2:275–279 · Cairo I: 309–311; p. 471 · Q2:280–281 · Cairo I:311–313; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 545 · Q3:42–43 · Cairo I:351–352; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385; p. 649 · Q3:124–125 · Cairo I:403–404; p. 696 · Q3:159 · Cairo I:426–428; p. 705 · Q3:165 · Cairo I:432–433; p. 747 · Q3:199 · Cairo I:456–457; p. 830 · Q4:34 · Cairo I:498–500; p. 875 · Q4:60–63 ·

Cairo I:520–522; p. 934 · Q4:102 · Cairo I:553; p. 987 · Q4:155–158 · Cairo I:586; p. 1003 · Q4:171 · Cairo I:596

al-Ghazālī

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 319 · Q2:198–199 · Cairo I:228–230; p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396; p. 696 · Q3:159 · Cairo I:426–428; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I: 450–453; p. 978 · Q4:145–147 · Cairo I:580

Goliath (Jālūt)

p. 254 · Q2:159–162 · Cairo I:189–190; p. 401 · Q2:246 · Cairo I:273–274; p. 407 · Q2:249 · Cairo I:276–279; p. 411 · Q2:250–252 · Cairo I:279–282

Ḥabība bint Zayd

p. 830 · Q4:34 · Cairo I:498–500

Ḥafṣ (Qurʾān reader)

p. 281 · Q2:177 · Cairo I:205–207

al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī

p. 185 · Q2:106–107 · Cairo I:148–150; p. 856 · Q4:47 · Cairo I:510–511

al-Ḥallāj

p. 110 · Q2:54 · Cairo I:106–108; p. 431 · Q2:258 · Cairo I:290–291; p. 576 · Q3:73–74 · Cairo I:368–370; p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385 · text and translator's note; p. 668 · Q3:140–143 · Cairo I:412–414

Hāmān

p. 254 · Q2:159–162 · Cairo I:189–190

Ḥamza ibn ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib

p. 666 · Q3:137–139 · Cairo I:411–412

Ḥamza (Qurʾān reader)

p. 91 · Q2:35–37 · Cairo I:96–97; p. 147 · Q2:83 · Cairo I:127–128; p. 281 · Q2:177 · Cairo I:205–207; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 751 · Q4:1 · Cairo I:459–461

al-Harawī

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70

al-Ḥarīrī

p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349

al-Ḥārith al-Muḥāsibī

p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198

Hārūt

p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147

al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī

p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509

al-Ḥasan and al-Ḥusayn (the Prophet's family)

Family members named in the mutual-imprecation narrative; not merged with al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī.

p. 565 · Q3:61–63 · Cairo I:362–364

al-Ḥasan (unexpanded report attribution)

Unexpanded name form in these contexts; not automatically identified with every other al-Ḥasan.

p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 366 · Q2:224–225 · Cairo I:254–255; p. 575 · Q3:72 · Cairo I:367–368; p. 792 · Q4:17–18 · Cairo I:479–481; p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520

Ḥuyayy ibn Akhṭab

p. 582 · Q3:77 · Cairo I:371–372; p. 584 · Q3:78 · Cairo I:372–373; p. 725 · Q3:181–183 · Cairo I: 443–445; p. 861 · Q4:51–52 · Cairo I:513–514

Iblīs

p. 90 · Q2:34 · Cairo I:95–96; p. 91 · Q2:35–37 · Cairo I:96–97; p. 407 · Q2:249 · Cairo I:276–279; p. 792 · Q4:17–18 · Cairo I:479–481

Ibn ʿAbbād

p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453 · translator's note

Ibn ʿAbbās

p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 22 · Q1:5 · Cairo I: 52–70; p. 69 · Q2:19–20 · Cairo I:84–86; p. 165 · Q2:94–95 · Cairo I:137–138; p. 217 · Q2:128–129 · Cairo I:166–167; p. 233 · Q2:143–144 · Cairo I: 175–178; p. 269 · Q2:168–169 · Cairo I:198–200; p. 272 · Q2:170 · Cairo I:200–201; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 362 · Q2:222–223 · Cairo I:252–254; p. 366 · Q2:224–225 · Cairo I: 254–255; p. 407 · Q2:249 · Cairo I:276–279; p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288; p. 461 · Q2:273 · Cairo I:306–308; p. 471 · Q2:280–281 ·

Cairo I:311–313; p. 488 · Q3:1–3 · Cairo I:321–322; p. 520 · Q3:23–25 · Cairo I:337–338; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 584 · Q3:78 · Cairo I:372–373; p. 586 · Q3:79–80 · Cairo I:373–374; p. 619 · Q3:103 · Cairo I:388–389; p. 649 · Q3:124–125 · Cairo I:403–404; p. 710 · Q3:169–171 · Cairo I:435–436; p. 734 · Q3:188–189 · Cairo I:448–449; p. 757 · Q4:3 · Cairo I:462–463; p. 775 · Q4:11 · Cairo I:471–475; p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477; p. 795 · Q4:19 · Cairo I:481–483; p. 803 · Q4:23 · Cairo I:485–486; p. 807 · Q4:24 · Cairo I:485–489; p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493; p. 825 · Q4:32 · Cairo I:496–497; p. 828 · Q4:33 · Cairo I:497–498; p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509; p. 854 · Q4:46 · Cairo I:509–510; p. 875 · Q4:60–63 · Cairo I:520–522; p. 913 · Q4:88 · Cairo I:540; p. 921 · Q4:93 · Cairo I:545; p. 927 · Q4:97–99 · Cairo I:549; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552; p. 972 · Q4:140–141 · Cairo I:577–578; p. 975 · Q4:142–143 · Cairo I:578

Ibn Abī Jamra

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70

Ibn Abī Shayba

p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538 · translator's note

Ibn ʿAjība: authorial commission and personal recollections

The author's commission and personal recollections, including first-person passages.

p. 4 · Preface · Cairo I:49–51; p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396; p. 649 · Q3:124–125 · Cairo I:403–404; p. 718 · Q3:176–177 · Cairo I:439–440; p. 830 · Q4:34 · Cairo I:498–500; p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538

Ibn al-ʿArabī (jurist)

Identified by the legal discussion and Aḥkām al-Qurʾān citation; separated from the Sufi author.

p. 939 · Q4:105–109 · Cairo I:556–558

Ibn al-Bannāʾ

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 140 · Q2:78 · Cairo I:123–124; p. 339 · Q2:213 · Cairo I:239–240; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453 · translator's note; p. 889 · Q4:75 · Cairo I:528–529

Ibn al-Fāriḍ

p. 86 · Q2:30–33 · Cairo I:93–95; p. 108 · Q2:51–53 · Cairo I:105–106; p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 603 · Q3:92 · Cairo I:380–382; p. 661 · Q3:135–136 · Cairo I:409–411; p. 710 · Q3:169–171 · Cairo I:435–436; p. 755 · Q4:2 · Cairo I:461–462; p. 807 · Q4:24 · Cairo I:485–489; p. 894 · Q4:78 · Cairo I:530–532 · text and translator's note; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

Ibn al-Jawzī

p. 651 · Q3:126–129 · Cairo I:404–405 · translator's note

Ibn al-Mubārak

p. 254 · Q2:159–162 · Cairo I:189–190; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 531 · Q3:31–32 · Cairo I:343–345; p. 795 · Q4:19 · Cairo I:481–483

Ibn al-Mulaqqin

p. 644 · Q3:121–122 · Cairo I:401–402 · translator's note

Ibn al-Qāsim

p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493

Ibn ʿĀmir

p. 201 · Q2:116–117 · Cairo I:157–158; p. 240 · Q2:148–149 · Cairo I:180–181; p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409; p. 787 · Q4:13–14 · Cairo I:477–478 · translator's note

Ibn ʿĀshūr

Name in an edition citation in an embedded translation note; the index does not expand its identity.

p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409 · translator's note

Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh

p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453 · translator's note; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509; p. 891 · Q4:76 · Cairo I:529–530

Ibn ʿAṭiyya

p. 187 · Q2:108 · Cairo I:150–151; p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157; p. 308 · Q2:190–195 · Cairo I:222–224; p. 329 · Q2:204–207 · Cairo I:233–235; p. 335 · Q2:211 · Cairo I:237 ·

translator's note; p. 347 · Q2:217–218 · Cairo I:243–245; p. 748 · Q3:200 · Cairo I:457; p. 819 · Q4:29–30 · Cairo I:493–495; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

Ibn Fāris

p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385 · translator's note

Ibn Ḥajar

p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 393 · Q2:243 · Cairo I:268–270; p. 734 · Q3:188–189 · Cairo I:448–449

Ibn Ḥibbān

p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147; p. 723 · Q3:180 · Cairo I:442–443 · translator's note

Ibn Juzayy

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 22 · Q1:5 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 244 · Q2:151–152 · Cairo I:183–185; p. 248 · Q2:153–157 · Cairo I:185–188; p. 257 · Q2:163–164 · Cairo I:190–193; p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198; p. 696 · Q3:159 · Cairo I:426–428; p. 710 · Q3:169–171 · Cairo I:435–436; p. 751 · Q4:1 · Cairo I:459–461; p. 775 · Q4:11 · Cairo I:471–475; p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477; p. 792 · Q4:17–18 · Cairo I:479–481; p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493; p. 823 · Q4:31 · Cairo I:495–496; p. 834 · Q4:35 · Cairo I:500–501; p. 901 · Q4:82 · Cairo I:534–535; p. 918 · Q4:92 · Cairo I:543–545; p. 945 · Q4:114 · Cairo I:560; p. 960 · Q4:129 · Cairo I:569 · translator's note; p. 963 · Q4:131–133 · Cairo I:570–573

Ibn Kathīr (Qurʾān reader)

p. 147 · Q2:83 · Cairo I:127–128; p. 676 · Q3:146–148 · Cairo I:416–418

Ibn Kathīr (source cited by the Cairo editor)

An editorial assessment of the Abraham story, separate from the Qurʾān reader.

p. 953 · Q4:124–126 · Cairo I:565–566 · Cairo note

Ibn Khuzayma

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70

Ibn Mājah

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503 · translator's note

Ibn Mālik

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 269 · Q2:168–169 · Cairo I:198–200; p. 751 · Q4:1 · Cairo I:459–461; p. 1001 · Q4:170 · Cairo I:595

Ibn Manẓūr

p. 118 · Q2:58–59 · Cairo I:110–112 · translator's note; p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385 · translator's note; p. 651 · Q3:126–129 · Cairo I:404–405 · translator's note

Ibn Mashīsh

p. 295 · Q2:186 · Cairo I:213–215; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552; p. 963 · Q4:131–133 · Cairo I:570–573

Ibn Masʿūd

p. 471 · Q2:280–281 · Cairo I:311–313; p. 527 · Q3:28–30 · Cairo I:341–343; p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477; p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524; p. 897 · Q4:79–80 · Cairo I:532–534; p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538 · translator's note; p. 978 · Q4:145–147 · Cairo I:580; p. 991 · Q4:162 · Cairo I:589

Ibn Muḥayṣin

p. 155 · Q2:88 · Cairo I:131–132

Ibn Rushd

p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396

Ibn Shaʿbān

p. 939 · Q4:105–109 · Cairo I:556–558

Ibn ʿUmar

p. 185 · Q2:106–107 · Cairo I:148–150; p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157; p. 370 · Q2:228 · Cairo I:256–257; p. 603 · Q3:92 · Cairo I:380–382; p. 605 · Q3:93–95 · Cairo I:382–383; p. 795 · Q4:19 · Cairo I:481–483; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552; p. 978 · Q4:145–147 · Cairo I:580

Ibrāhīm ibn Adham

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70

Idrīs

p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147; p. 416 · Q2:253 · Cairo I:282–284

ʿIkrima (in the Uḥud battle account)

Separated from the exegetical transmitter; the passage does not expand this name.

p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416

ʿIkrima (transmitter)

p. 43 · intro2 · Cairo I:71 · translator's note; p. 582 · Q3:77 · Cairo I:371–372

Isaac

p. 96 · Q2:40–43 · Cairo I:99–100; p. 219 · Q2:130–132 · Cairo I:167–168; p. 221 · Q2:133–134 · Cairo I:168–169; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 227 · Q2:139–141 · Cairo I:172–173; p. 509 · Q3:18 · Cairo I:332–334; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590; p. 1006 · Q4:172–173 · Cairo I:597

Ishmael

p. 211 · Q2:125 · Cairo I:163–164; p. 215 · Q2:127 · Cairo I:165–166; p. 217 · Q2:128–129 · Cairo I:166–167; p. 219 · Q2:130–132 · Cairo I:167–168; p. 221 · Q2:133–134 · Cairo I:168–169; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 227 · Q2:139–141 · Cairo I:172–173; p. 319 · Q2:198–199 · Cairo I:228–230; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

ʿIyāḍ

p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172

ʿIzz al-Dīn ibn ʿAbd al-Salām

p. 159 · Q2:90–91 · Cairo I:133–135

Jābir ibn ʿAbd Allāh

p. 775 · Q4:11 · Cairo I:471–475; p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520; p. 1011 · Q4:176 · Cairo I:600–601

Jābir (short name form)

Short form retained as printed; no expansion is supplied by this passage.

p. 27 · Q1:6 · Cairo I:52–70

Jacob

p. 96 · Q2:40–43 · Cairo I:99–100; p. 126 · Q2:62 · Cairo I:115–116; p. 219 · Q2:130–132 · Cairo I:167–168; p. 221 · Q2:133–134 · Cairo I:168–169; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 227 · Q2:139–141 · Cairo I:172–173; p. 509 · Q3:18 · Cairo I:332–334; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 605 · Q3:93–95 · Cairo I:382–383; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590; p. 1006 · Q4:172–173 · Cairo I:597

Jaʿfar al-Ṣādiq

p. 46 · Q2:2 · Cairo I:72–73; p. 509 · Q3:18 · Cairo I:332–334; p. 527 · Q3:28–30 · Cairo I:341–343

al-Jawharī

p. 405 · Q2:248 · Cairo I:275–276; p. 861 · Q4:51–52 · Cairo I:513–514

Jesus

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 123 · Q2:61 · Cairo I:113–115; p. 126 · Q2:62 · Cairo I:115–116; p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 159 · Q2:90–91 · Cairo I:133–135; p. 194 · Q2:113 · Cairo I:153–154; p. 217 · Q2:128–129 · Cairo I:166–167; p. 223 · Q2:135 · Cairo I:169–170; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 407 · Q2:249 · Cairo I:276–279; p. 416 · Q2:253 · Cairo I:282–284; p. 488 · Sūrah introduction · Cairo I:321; p. 515 · Q3:20 · Cairo I:335–336; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 527 · Q3:28–30 · Cairo I:341–343; p. 531 · Q3:31–32 · Cairo I:343–345; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 547 · Q3:44 · Cairo I:352–353; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 555 · Q3:52–54 · Cairo I:357–359; p. 559 · Q3:55–58 · Cairo I:359–361; p. 562 · Q3:59–60 · Cairo I:361–362; p. 565 · Q3:61–63 · Cairo I:362–364; p. 568 · Q3:64 · Cairo I:364–365; p. 589 · Q3:81–82 · Cairo I:374–375; p. 599 · Q3:90 · Cairo I:378–379; p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453; p. 856 · Q4:47 · Cairo I:510–511; p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524 · translator's note; p. 897 · Q4:79–80 · Cairo I:532–534; p. 970 · Q4:137–139 · Cairo I:576; p. 982 · Q4:150–151 · Cairo I:583; p. 987 · Q4:155–158 · Cairo I:586; p. 989 · Q4:159 · Cairo I:588; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590; p. 1003 · Q4:171 · Cairo I:596; p. 1006 · Q4:172–173 · Cairo I:597

al-Jīlānī

p. 118 · Q2:58–59 · Cairo I:110–112

Job

p. 958 · Q4:128 · Cairo I:568; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590; p. 1006 · Q4:172–173 · Cairo I:597

John

p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 725 · Q3:181–183 · Cairo I:443–445; p. 987 · Q4:155–158 · Cairo I:586

Jonah

p. 416 · Q2:253 · Cairo I:282–284; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

Joseph

p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517

al-Junayd

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 174 · Q2:100 · Cairo I:141–143; p. 203 · Q2:118–119 · Cairo I:158–160; p. 257 · Q2:163–164 · Cairo I:190–193; p. 461 · Q2:273 · Cairo I:306–308; p. 477 · Q2:283 · Cairo I:315–316; p. 555 · Q3:52–54 · Cairo I:357–359; p. 603 · Q3:92 · Cairo I:380–382; p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396; p. 661 · Q3:135–136 · Cairo I:409–411 · translator's note; p. 696 · Q3:159 · Cairo I:426–428; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453; p. 757 · Q4:3 · Cairo I:462–463; p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493; p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509; p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520

Kaʿb ibn al-Ashraf

p. 575 · Q3:72 · Cairo I:367–368; p. 582 · Q3:77 · Cairo I:371–372; p. 584 · Q3:78 · Cairo I:372–373; p. 725 · Q3:181–183 · Cairo I:443–445; p. 861 · Q4:51–52 · Cairo I:513–514; p. 875 · Q4:60–63 · Cairo I:520–522; p. 984 · Q4:153–154 · Cairo I:585

al-Kayyālī

Modern source editor discussed in embedded translation notes.

p. 115 · Q2:57 · Cairo I:109–110 · translator's note; p. 118 · Q2:58–59 · Cairo I:110–112 · translator's note

Khadīja

p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 545 · Q3:42–43 · Cairo I:351–352

Khālid ibn al-Walīd

p. 651 · Q3:126–129 · Cairo I:404–405; p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416

al-Khawwāṣ (short name in definitions of trust)

p. 696 · Q3:159 · Cairo I:426–428

al-Khiḍr

p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396; p. 908 · Q4:84–86 · Cairo I:538–540 · translator's note

al-Kisāʾī

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 147 · Q2:83 · Cairo I:127–128; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248

Mālik ibn al-Ṣayf

p. 575 · Q3:72 · Cairo I:367–368; p. 584 · Q3:78 · Cairo I:372–373; p. 725 · Q3:181–183 · Cairo I:443–445

Mālik ibn Dīnār

p. 939 · Q4:105–109 · Cairo I:556–558

Mālik (jurist)

The jurist and his school; occurrences within Ibn Mālik or names of other men called Mālik are excluded.

p. 9 · Introductory discussion · Cairo I:52–70; p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 217 · Q2:128–129 · Cairo I:166–167; p. 252 · Q2:158 · Cairo I:188–189; p. 285 · Q2:178–179 · Cairo I:207–209; p. 291 · Q2:183–185 · Cairo I:211–213; p. 312 · Q2:196 · Cairo I:224–227; p. 316 · Q2:197 · Cairo I:227–228; p. 347 · Q2:217–218 · Cairo I:243–245; p. 366 · Q2:224–225 · Cairo I:254–255; p. 368 · Q2:226–227 · Cairo I:255–256; p. 370 · Q2:228 · Cairo I:256–257; p. 385 · Q2:236–237 · Cairo I:264–266; p. 388 · Q2:238–239 · Cairo I:266–267; p. 391 · Q2:241–242 · Cairo I:267–268; p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477 · translator's note; p. 795 · Q4:19 · Cairo I:481–483; p. 803 · Q4:23 · Cairo I:485–486; p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493; p. 834 · Q4:35 · Cairo I:500–501; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552; p. 934 · Q4:102 · Cairo I:553; p. 1011 · Q4:176 · Cairo I:600–601 · translator's note

Mārūt

p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147

Mary

p. 123 · Q2:61 · Cairo I:113–115; p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 416 · Q2:253 · Cairo I:282–284; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 545 · Q3:42–43 · Cairo I:351–352 · text and translator's note; p. 545 · Q3:42–43 · Cairo I:351–352; p. 547 · Q3:44 · Cairo I:352–353; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 555 · Q3:52–54 · Cairo I:357–359; p. 559 · Q3:55–58 · Cairo I:359–361; p. 562 · Q3:59–60 · Cairo I:361–362; p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396; p. 856 · Q4:47 · Cairo I:510–511; p. 987 · Q4:155–158 · Cairo I:586; p. 1003 · Q4:171 · Cairo I:596

al-Marzūqī

p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517 · translator's note

Michael

p. 170 · Q2:97–98 · Cairo I:139–141

Moses

p. 22 · Q1:5 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 27 · Q1:6 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 43 · intro2 · Cairo I:71; p. 106 · Q2:49 · Cairo I:104–105; p. 108 · Q2:51–53 · Cairo I:105–106; p. 110 · Q2:54 · Cairo I:106–108; p. 114 · Q2:55–56 · Cairo I:108–109; p. 115 · Q2:57 · Cairo I:109–110; p. 121 · Q2:60 · Cairo I:112–113; p. 123 · Q2:61 · Cairo I:113–115; p. 126 · Q2:62 · Cairo I:115–116; p. 131 · Q2:67–71 · Cairo I:118–119; p. 138 · Q2:75–77 · Cairo I:122–123; p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 162 · Q2:92 · Cairo I:135–136; p. 187 · Q2:108 · Cairo I:150–151; p. 194 · Q2:113 · Cairo I:153–154; p. 203 · Q2:118–119 · Cairo I:158–160; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 401 · Q2:246 · Cairo I:273–274; p. 405 · Q2:248 · Cairo I:275–276; p. 416 · Q2:253 · Cairo I:282–284; p. 482 · Q2:285–286 · Cairo I:317–320; p. 512 · Q3:19 · Cairo I:334–335; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 894 · Q4:78 · Cairo I:530–532; p. 908 · Q4:84–86 · Cairo I:538–540 · translator's note; p. 969 · Q4:136 · Cairo I:575; p. 970 · Q4:137–139 · Cairo I:576; p. 982 · Q4:150–151 · Cairo I:583; p. 984 · Q4:153–154 · Cairo I:585; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

Muʿādh

p. 304 · Q2:189 · Cairo I:219–222; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 480 · Q2:284 · Cairo I:316–317; p. 509 · Q3:18 · Cairo I:332–334; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 573 · Q3:69–71 · Cairo I:367; p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503 · translator's note

Muḥammad al-Būzīdī

p. 4 · Preface · Cairo I:49–51; p. 308 · Q2:190–195 · Cairo I:222–224; p. 718 · Q3:176–177 · Cairo I:439–440

Muḥammad: selected discussions of his mission

Selected discussions of revelation, mission, following him, covenant, mortality and authority; not every blessing formula or incidental mention of his name.

p. 217 · Q2:128–129 · Cairo I:166–167; p. 531 · Q3:31–32 · Cairo I:343–345; p. 589 · Q3:81–82 · Cairo I:374–375; p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416; p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524; p. 897 · Q4:79–80 · Cairo I:532–534; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590; p. 1001 · Q4:170 · Cairo I:595

Muḥyī al-Dīn Ibn al-ʿArabī (Sufi author)

The contexts give Muḥyī al-Dīn or al-Ḥātimī, or the Muḥāḍarat al-abrār citation. The legal author at Q4:105–109 is separate.

p. 174 · Q2:100 · Cairo I:141–143; p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385 · translator's note; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509

Mujāhid

p. 825 · Q4:32 · Cairo I:496–497; p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517; p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520; p. 945 · Q4:114 · Cairo I:560; p. 980 · Q4:148–149 · Cairo I:582

Mukhayrīq

p. 991 · Q4:162 · Cairo I:589

al-Mundhirī

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147; p. 333 · Q2:210 · Cairo I:236–237

Muṣʿab ibn ʿUmayr

p. 666 · Q3:137–139 · Cairo I:411–412; p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416

Muslim (narration and source citations)

p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288; p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520 · translator's note; p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538 · translator's note; p. 1011 · Q4:176 · Cairo I:600–601 · translator's note

Nāfiʿ ibn Yazīd

p. 493 · Q3:7–9 · Cairo I:323–326

Nāfiʿ (Qurʾān reader)

p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409; p. 787 · Q4:13–14 · Cairo I:477–478 · translator's note

al-Nakhaʿī

p. 289 · Q2:180–182 · Cairo I:209–211

al-Nasafī (Creed citation)

Name associated with the Creed in this passage; separated from the Madārik citation.

p. 4 · Preface · Cairo I:49–51

al-Nasafī (Madārik citation)

Name associated with Madārik in an editorial source note.

p. 59 · Q2:11–12 · Cairo I:79–80 · translator's note

al-Nasāʾī

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288

Nimrod

p. 431 · Q2:258 · Cairo I:290–291; p. 437 · Q2:260 · Cairo I:293–295

Noah

p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

Pharaoh

p. 106 · Q2:49 · Cairo I:104–105; p. 107 · Q2:50 · Cairo I:105; p. 254 · Q2:159–162 · Cairo I:189–190; p. 431 · Q2:258 · Cairo I:290–291; p. 498 · Q3:10–11 · Cairo I:326–327; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 710 · Q3:169–171 · Cairo I:435–436; p. 894 · Q4:78 · Cairo I:530–532; p. 978 · Q4:145–147 · Cairo I:580

Qārūn

p. 254 · Q2:159–162 · Cairo I:189–190

Qatāda (exegetical transmitter)

p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 559 · Q3:55–58 · Cairo I:359–361; p. 661 · Q3:135–136 · Cairo I:409–411; p. 975 · Q4:142–143 · Cairo I:578; p. 987 · Q4:155–158 · Cairo I:586

Qatāda ibn al-Nuʿmān

p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416; p. 939 · Q4:105–109 · Cairo I:556–558

al-Qushayrī

p. 22 · Q1:5 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 75 · Q2:23–25 · Cairo I:87–90; p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 195 · Q2:114 · Cairo I:154–155; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 229 · Q2:142 · Cairo I:173–175; p. 398 · Q2:245 · Cairo I:271–273; p. 454 · Q2:269 · Cairo I:303–304; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 559 · Q3:55–58 · Cairo I:359–361; p. 599 · Q3:90 · Cairo I:378–379; p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396; p. 651 · Q3:126–129 · Cairo I:404–405; p. 661 · Q3:135–136 · Cairo I:409–411 · translator's note; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453 · translator's note; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453; p. 751 · Q4:1 · Cairo I:459–461 · translator's note; p. 771 · Q4:9 · Cairo I:469–470; p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538; p. 929 · Q4:100 · Cairo I:550; p. 1006 · Q4:172–173 · Cairo I:597; p. 1009 · Q4:174–175 · Cairo I:599

Rābiʿa al-ʿAdawiyya

p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198

Saʿd al-Dīn

p. 4 · Preface · Cairo I:49–51

Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ

p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477

Saʿd ibn al-Rabīʿ

p. 775 · Q4:11 · Cairo I:471–475; p. 830 · Q4:34 · Cairo I:498–500; p. 958 · Q4:128 · Cairo I:568

al-Sāḥilī

p. 215 · Q2:127 · Cairo I:165–166; p. 661 · Q3:135–136 · Cairo I:409–411 · translator's note

Sahl ibn ʿAbd Allāh

The short Sahl references concern the same teaching contexts; no expanded nisba is supplied.

p. 27 · Q1:6 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 276 · Q2:172–173 · Cairo I:202–203; p. 493 · Q3:7–9 · Cairo I:323–326; p. 696 · Q3:159 · Cairo I:426–428; p. 757 · Q4:3 · Cairo I:462–463

Saʿīd ibn Jubayr

p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198

Salmān

p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 963 · Q4:131–133 · Cairo I:570–573

Sarah

p. 953 · Q4:124–126 · Cairo I:565–566

al-Sarī al-Saqaṭī

p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409; p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503

al-Shaʿbī

p. 559 · Q3:55–58 · Cairo I:359–361

al-Shādhilī

p. 159 · Q2:90–91 · Cairo I:133–135; p. 187 · Q2:108 · Cairo I:150–151; p. 319 · Q2:198–199 · Cairo I:228–230; p. 390 · Q2:240 · Cairo I:267; p. 437 · Q2:260 · Cairo I:293–295; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 812 · Q4:25–28 · Cairo I:489–493

al-Shāfiʿī

p. 9 · Introductory discussion · Cairo I:52–70; p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 136 · Q2:74 · Cairo I:121–122; p. 248 · Q2:153–157 · Cairo I:185–188; p. 252 · Q2:158 · Cairo I:188–189; p. 312 · Q2:196 · Cairo I:224–227; p. 316 · Q2:197 · Cairo I:227–228; p. 347 · Q2:217–218 · Cairo I:243–245; p. 366 · Q2:224–225 · Cairo I:254–255; p. 368 · Q2:226–227 · Cairo I:255–256; p. 385 · Q2:236–237 · Cairo I:264–266; p. 388 · Q2:238–239 · Cairo I:266–267; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 803 · Q4:23 · Cairo I:485–486; p. 807 · Q4:24 · Cairo I:485–489; p. 819 · Q4:29–30 · Cairo I:493–495; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552; p. 934 · Q4:102 · Cairo I:553

al-Shaʿrānī

p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509

al-Shībī

Modern source editor discussed in embedded translation notes.

p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385 · translator's note

al-Shushtarī

p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157; p. 219 · Q2:130–132 · Cairo I:167–168; p. 269 · Q2:168–169 · Cairo I:198–200; p. 312 · Q2:196 · Cairo I:224–227; p. 397 · Q2:244 · Cairo I:270–271; p. 978 · Q4:145–147 · Cairo I:580; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

Sībawayh

p. 129 · Q2:63–66 · Cairo I:116–118; p. 195 · Q2:114 · Cairo I:154–155; p. 201 · Q2:116–117 · Cairo I:157–158; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 1001 · Q4:170 · Cairo I:595

Solomon

p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 682 · Q3:152 · Cairo I:419–421; p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

al-Suddī

p. 403 · Q2:247 · Cairo I:274–275; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 575 · Q3:72 · Cairo I:367–368

Sufyān al-Thawrī

p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409

Sufyān (unexpanded attribution)

p. 507 · Q3:15–17 · Cairo I:331–332; p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517

Ṣuhayb al-Rūmī

p. 329 · Q2:204–207 · Cairo I:233–235

al-Sulamī (Sufi source)

The author associated with Jawāmiʿ ādāb al-ṣūfiyya in the editorial note, not Abū Jābir al-Sulamī in the battle account.

p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453 · translator's note

al-Suyūṭī

p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218; p. 421 · Q2:255 · Cairo I:284–288; p. 856 · Q4:47 · Cairo I:510–511 · translator's note

Ṭalḥa

p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416

Ṭālūt

p. 401 · Q2:246 · Cairo I:273–274; p. 403 · Q2:247 · Cairo I:274–275; p. 405 · Q2:248 · Cairo I:275–276; p. 407 · Q2:249 · Cairo I:276–279; p. 411 · Q2:250–252 · Cairo I:279–282

al-Thaʿālibī

p. 723 · Q3:180 · Cairo I:442–443 · translator's note

Thābit ibn Qays

p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524

al-Thaʿlabī

p. 43 · intro2 · Cairo I:71 · translator's note; p. 44 · Q2:1 · Cairo I:71–72; p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218; p. 518 · Q3:21–22 · Cairo I:336–337 · text and translator's note; p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409 · translator's note; p. 751 · intro4 · Cairo I:459; p. 830 · Q4:34 · Cairo I:498–500; p. 871 · Q4:59 · Cairo I:518–520 · translator's note; p. 978 · Q4:145–147 · Cairo I:580; p. 987 · Q4:155–158 · Cairo I:586 · translator's note

Thawbān

p. 882 · Q4:69–70 · Cairo I:524–526

al-Tirmidhī

Occurrences explicitly qualified al-Ḥakīm are entered separately.

p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538 · translator's note

Ṭuʿma

p. 939 · Q4:105–109 · Cairo I:556–558; p. 942 · Q4:110 · Cairo I:558; p. 943 · Q4:111–112 · Cairo I:558; p. 944 · Q4:113 · Cairo I:559; p. 945 · Q4:114 · Cairo I:560; p. 947 · Q4:115–116 · Cairo I:561

Ubayy

p. 471 · Q2:280–281 · Cairo I:311–313

ʿUmar ibn ʿAbd al-ʿAzīz

p. 407 · Q2:249 · Cairo I:276–279

ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb

p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 64 · Q2:14–16 · Cairo I:81–83; p. 237 · Q2:145–147 · Cairo I:178–180; p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 603 · Q3:92 · Cairo I:380–382; p. 692 · Q3:156 · Cairo I:424–425; p. 745 · Q3:196–198 · Cairo I:454–456; p. 856 · Q4:47 · Cairo I:510–511; p. 875 · Q4:60–63 · Cairo I:520–522; p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524; p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552; p. 960 · Q4:129 · Cairo I:569

Umm Salama

p. 248 · Q2:153–157 · Cairo I:185–188; p. 743 · Q3:195 · Cairo I:453–454; p. 825 · Q4:32 · Cairo I:496–497

ʿUrwa ibn al-Zubayr

p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409

ʿUthmān ibn ʿAffān

p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 140 · Q2:78 · Cairo I:123–124; p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248; p. 439 · Q2:261–262 · Cairo I:295–296; p. 932 · Q4:101 · Cairo I:552

ʿUthmān ibn Ṭalḥa

p. 869 · Q4:58 · Cairo I:517–518

al-Wartajbī / Rūzbihān

The translation itself identifies al-Wartajbī as Rūzbihān; its editorial references to his work are distinguished in the occurrence evidence.

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 482 · Q2:285–286 · Cairo I:317–320; p. 503 · Q3:14 · Cairo I:328–331; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 559 · Q3:55–58 · Cairo I:359–361; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:

406–409; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409 · text and translator's note; p. 682 · Q3:152 · Cairo I:419–421; p. 731 · Q3:186 · Cairo I:446–447; p. 745 · Q3:196–198 · Cairo I:454–456; p. 762 · Q4:5 · Cairo I:464–466; p. 775 · Q4:11 · Cairo I:471–475; p. 787 · Q4:13–14 · Cairo I:477–478; p. 795 · Q4:19 · Cairo I:481–483; p. 823 · Q4:31 · Cairo I:495–496; p. 825 · Q4:32 · Cairo I:496–497; p. 830 · Q4:34 · Cairo I:498–500; p. 836 · Q4:36 · Cairo I:501–503; p. 861 · Q4:51–52 · Cairo I:513–514; p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538; p. 937 · Q4:103 · Cairo I:554; p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

Yaḥyā ibn Muʿādh al-Rāzī

p. 254 · Q2:159–162 · Cairo I:189–190

Yaʿqūb (Qurʾān reader)

p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198

al-Zajjāj

p. 219 · Q2:130–132 · Cairo I:167–168; p. 953 · Q4:124–126 · Cairo I:565–566

al-Zamakhsharī

p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218; p. 347 · Q2:217–218 · Cairo I:243–245; p. 775 · Q4:11 · Cairo I:471–475; p. 1006 · Q4:172–173 · Cairo I:597 · translator's note

Zarrūq

p. 4 · Preface · Cairo I:49–51; p. 174 · Q2:100 · Cairo I:141–143; p. 531 · Q3:31–32 · Cairo I:343–345

Zechariah

p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349; p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351; p. 725 · Q3:181–183 · Cairo I:443–445

al-Zubayr

p. 555 · Q3:52–54 · Cairo I:357–359; p. 672 · Q3:144–145 · Cairo I:414–416; p. 687 · Q3:154 · Cairo I:422–424; p. 830 · Q4:34 · Cairo I:498–500 · text and translator's note; p. 878 · Q4:64–68 · Cairo I:522–524

al-Zuhrī

p. 289 · Q2:180–182 · Cairo I:209–211

Works cited

Titles follow the text and its notes. A reference may be a mention or discussion of a work; it need not be a direct quotation.

Aḥkām al-Qurʾān

p. 939 · Q4:105–109 · Cairo I:556–558

Alfiyya

p. 237 · Q2:145–147 · Cairo I:178–180; p. 269 · Q2:168–169 · Cairo I:198–200; p. 276 · Q2:172–173 · Cairo I:202–203

Anwār al-tanzīl

p. 22 · Q1:5 · Cairo I:52–70 · translator's note; p. 59 · Q2:11–12 · Cairo I:79–80 · translator's note; p. 86 · Q2:30–33 · Cairo I:93–95 · translator's note; p. 882 · Q4:69–70 · Cairo I: 524–526 · translator's note

al-ʿĀqiba

p. 165 · Q2:94–95 · Cairo I:137–138 · translator's note

ʿArāʾis al-bayān

p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409 · translator's note

Asās (lexical citation)

p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351

ʿAyniyya (poem named in the text)

The short poem title is retained without assigning an author not identified in these contexts.

p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157; p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198; p. 527 · Q3:28–30 · Cairo I:341–343; p. 555 · Q3:52–54 · Cairo I: 357–359

al-Baḥr al-madīd

The full title occurs in the author's preface; the abbreviated Baḥr in Q3:130–134 occurs in an editorial citation.

p. 4 · Preface · Cairo I:49–51; p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409 · translator's note

Bughyat al-sālik

p. 661 · Q3:135–136 · Cairo I:409–411 · text and translator's note

Creed of al-Nasafī

p. 4 · Preface · Cairo I:49–51

Dalāʾil (short title)

p. 903 · Q4:83 · Cairo I:535–538 · translator's note

Fatḥ al-bārī

p. 545 · Q3:42–43 · Cairo I:351–352 · translator's note

Ghayth al-mawāhib

p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453 · translator's note

Gospel

p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 104 · Q2:47–48 · Cairo I:103–104; p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 194 · Q2:113 · Cairo I:153–154; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 227 · Q2:139–141 · Cairo I:172–173; p. 339 · Q2:213 · Cairo I:239–240; p. 482 · Q2:285–286 · Cairo I: 317–320; p. 488 · Q3:1–3 · Cairo I:321–322; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 570 · Q3:65–68 · Cairo I:365–367; p. 573 · Q3:69–71 · Cairo I:367; p. 584 · Q3:78 · Cairo I:372–373; p. 963 · Q4:131–133 · Cairo I:570–573; p. 1003 · Q4:171 · Cairo I:596

Great Litany of al-Shādhilī

p. 437 · Q2:260 · Cairo I:293–295

Ḥamāsa

p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517 · translator's note

Ḥikam

p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 27 · Q1:6 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 48 · Q2:3 · Cairo I:73–75; p. 157 · Q2:89 · Cairo I:132–133; p. 201 · Q2:116–117 · Cairo I:157–158; p. 217 · Q2:128–129 · Cairo I: 166–167; p. 233 · Q2:143–144 · Cairo I:175–178; p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198; p. 302 · Q2:188 · Cairo I:218–219; p. 341 · Q2:214 · Cairo I:240–241 · text and translator's note; p. 427 · Q2:256 · Cairo I:288–289; p. 433 · Q2:259 · Cairo

I:291–293; p. 444 · Q2:264 · Cairo I:297–298; p. 498 · Q3:10–11 · Cairo I:326–327; p. 515 · Q3:20 · Cairo I:335–336; p. 559 · Q3:55–58 · Cairo I:359–361; p. 668 · Q3:140–143 · Cairo I: 412–414; p. 705 · Q3:165 · Cairo I:432–433; p. 719 · Q3:178 · Cairo I:440–441; p. 721 · Q3:179 · Cairo I:441–442; p. 734 · Q3:188–189 · Cairo I:448–449; p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I: 450–453; p. 834 · Q4:35 · Cairo I:500–501; p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509; p. 859 · Q4:49–50 · Cairo I:512; p. 891 · Q4:76 · Cairo I:529–530; p. 921 · Q4:93 · Cairo I:545; p. 948 · Q4:117–121 · Cairo I:562; p. 978 · Q4:145–147 · Cairo I:580; p. 984 · Q4:153–154 · Cairo I:585; p. 997 · Q4:166 · Cairo I:593; p. 1003 · Q4:171 · Cairo I: 596

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p. 856 · Q4:47 · Cairo I:510–511 · translator's note

Jawāmiʿ ādāb al-ṣūfiyya

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Kāfiya

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Kanz al-ʿummāl

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Madārik

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Maqāyīs al-lugha

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Miʿrāj al-tashawwuf

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al-Miʿyār

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Mudawwana
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Muḥāḍarat al-abrār
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al-Muḥarrar al-wajīz
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Mukhtaṣar (legal short title)
Short title as printed; no further bibliographic identification is silently supplied.
p. 391 · Q2:241–242 · Cairo I:267–268; p. 807 · Q4:24 · Cairo I:485–489

al-Muṣannaf
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Muwaṭṭaʾ
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Nawādir al-uṣūl
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Psalms
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Qāmūs
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Rāʾiyya commentary of Aḥmad b. Yūsuf al-Fāsī
p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198 · translator's note

Rawḍat al-ʿuqalāʾ
p. 723 · Q3:180 · Cairo I:442–443 · translator's note

Risāla (legal citation at Q4:22)
The legal short title is not equated with al-Qushayrī's work; the passage does not name its author.
p. 801 · Q4:22 · Cairo I:484–485

Risāla of al-Qushayrī
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Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī
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Ṣaḥīḥ of Ibn Ḥibbān
p. 177 · Q2:102–103 · Cairo I:144–147

Sharḥ Dīwān al-Ḥallāj
p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385 · translator's note

Sharḥ Dīwān al-Ḥamāsa
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Sharḥ Dīwān Ibn al-Fāriḍ
p. 894 · Q4:78 · Cairo I:530–532 · translator's note

Sharīshiyya (and its cited commentary)
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al-Ṣiḥāḥ
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Ṭabaqāt of al-Shaʿrānī
p. 848 · Q4:43 · Cairo I:506–509

Tāʾiyya
p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157

Talbīs Iblīs

p. 651 · Q3:126–129 · Cairo I:404–405 · translator's note

al-Tanwīr

p. 48 · Q2:3 · Cairo I:73–75; p. 123 · Q2:61 · Cairo I:113–115

Taqyīd (short title in the al-Ḥallāj attribution note)

Unexpanded source title; its mention establishes neither the poem's authorship nor a final bibliographic identification.

p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385 · translator's note

al-Targhīb

p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70

Tashīl

p. 316 · Q2:197 · Cairo I:227–228

al-Tawḍīḥ

p. 644 · Q3:121–122 · Cairo I:401–402 · translator's note

Tawshīḥ

p. 297 · Q2:187 · Cairo I:215–218

Torah

p. 9 · Q1:1 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70; p. 96 · Q2:40–43 · Cairo I:99–100; p. 99 · Q2:44 · Cairo I:100–101; p. 104 · Q2:47–48 · Cairo I:103–104; p. 108 · Q2:51–53 · Cairo I:105–106; p. 129 · Q2:63–66 · Cairo I:116–118; p. 138 · Q2:75–77 · Cairo I:122–123; p. 143 · Q2:79 · Cairo I:124–125; p. 149 · Q2:84–85 · Cairo I:128–130; p. 153 · Q2:87 · Cairo I:130–131; p. 157 · Q2:89 · Cairo I:132–133; p. 159 · Q2:90–91 · Cairo I:133–135; p. 162 · Q2:92 · Cairo I:135–136; p. 164 · Q2:93 · Cairo I:136–137; p. 176 · Q2:101 · Cairo I:143; p. 194 · Q2:113 · Cairo I:153–154; p. 207 · Q2:121 · Cairo I:161; p. 224 · Q2:136–138 · Cairo I:170–172; p. 227 · Q2:139–141 · Cairo I:172–173; p. 242 · Q2:150 · Cairo I:181–183; p. 254 · Q2:159–162 · Cairo I:189–190; p. 278 · Q2:174–176 · Cairo I:203–205; p. 339 · Q2:213 · Cairo I:239–240; p. 401 · Q2:246 · Cairo I:273–274; p. 403 · Q2:247 · Cairo I:274–275; p. 433 · Q2:259 · Cairo I:291–293; p. 482 · Q2:285–286 · Cairo I:317–320; p. 488 · Q3:1–3 · Cairo I:321–322; p. 512 · Q3:19 · Cairo I:334–335; p. 520 · Q3:23–25 · Cairo I:337–338; p. 548 · Q3:45–51 · Cairo I:353–357; p. 570 · Q3:65–68 · Cairo I:365–367; p. 573 · Q3:69–71 · Cairo I:367; p. 575 · Q3:72 · Cairo I:367–368; p. 579 · Q3:75–76 · Cairo I:370–371; p. 582 · Q3:77 · Cairo I:371–372; p. 584 · Q3:78 · Cairo I:372–373; p. 605 · Q3:93–95 · Cairo I:382–383; p. 613 · Q3:98–99 · Cairo I:385–386; p. 725 · Q3:181–183 · Cairo I:443–445; p. 747 · Q3:199 · Cairo I:456–457; p. 852 · Q4:44–45 · Cairo I:509; p. 854 · Q4:46 · Cairo I:509–510; p. 856 · Q4:47 · Cairo I:510–511; p. 963 · Q4:131–133 · Cairo I:570–573; p. 969 · Q4:136 · Cairo I:575; p. 982 · Q4:150–151 · Cairo I:583; p. 984 · Q4:153–154 · Cairo I:585

Yatīmat al-dahr

p. 723 · Q3:180 · Cairo I:442–443 · translator's note

Poetry by opening words

English opening words identify the verse passages. Similar openings do not by themselves establish a shared poem or author.

All beside God, when truly examined,
p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157

All living souls have ever been knowing,
p. 889 · Q4:75 · Cairo I:528–529

Are the outward Law and inward science
p. 159 · Q2:90–91 · Cairo I:133–135

The argument that sets the Sufis above others
p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396

Be ever generous to the brethren, needing nothing from them,
p. 344 · Q2:215 · Cairo I:241–242

Be humble before the one you love, to gain might:
p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341

Be not among those whom their pages have made giddy, so that they have unsettled their intellect and swept it away. For beyond transmission there is knowledge too subtle for the furthest…
Be not among those whom their pages have made giddy, so that they have unsettled their intellect and swept it away. For beyond transmission there is knowledge too subtle for the furthest comprehension of sound intellects. I received it from myself and took it from myself, while my soul was sustained by a gift.
p. 807 · Q4:24 · Cairo I:485–489

Break with those you kept company with in heedlessness:
p. 527 · Q3:28–30 · Cairo I:341–343

But for witnessing Your beauty within me,
p. 316 · Q2:197 · Cairo I:227–228

By God, we praise no unbridled one,
p. 347 · Q2:217–218 · Cairo I:243–245

Change the tāʾ of iftiʿāl to ṭāʾ after an emphatic consonant.
p. 276 · Q2:172–173 · Cairo I:202–203

Contentment has given me every kind of might:
p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341

Creation is blossom,
p. 269 · Q2:168–169 · Cairo I:198–200

A crowd of common people denied it;
p. 59 · Q2:11–12 · Cairo I:79–80

The death of the Godfearing is a life that does not pass away;
p. 710 · Q3:169–171 · Cairo I:435–436

Desire, wherever it rules, kills or brands with disgrace.
p. 274 · Q2:171 · Cairo I:201–202

Do not follow the soul in its caprice:
p. 123 · Q2:61 · Cairo I:113–115

Do not follow the soul in its desire:
p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341

Do not suppose glory is a ripe date you merely eat;
p. 666 · Q3:137–139 · Cairo I:411–412

Do not think death is death:
p. 134 · Q2:72–73 · Cairo I:119–121

Easy and gentle, generous, sons of ease;
p. 980 · Q4:148–149 · Cairo I:582

Ever I alight at a dwelling-place of Your love
p. 75 · Q2:23–25 · Cairo I:87–90

Every day you change your colour;
p. 304 · Q2:189 · Cairo I:219–222

Every hostility may admit the hope of removal,
p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517

Every moment from my Beloved
p. 316 · Q2:197 · Cairo I:227–228; p. 439 · Q2:261–262 · Cairo I:295–296

Every moment of my Beloved
p. 737 · Q3:191–194 · Cairo I:450–453

Everything except God is false;
p. 242 · Q2:150 · Cairo I:181–183

Everything you part with has a substitute;
p. 498 · Q3:10–11 · Cairo I:326–327

The folk are travellers,
p. 32 · Q1:7 · Cairo I:52–70

For everything, once you part from it, there is a replacement;
p. 637 · Q3:116 · Cairo I:397–398

For you I would give myself: I was fashioned in desire for you,
p. 555 · Q3:52–54 · Cairo I:357–359

The gnostics passed away from themselves, seeing nothing
p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157

God cannot be outstripped upon a donkey,
p. 393 · Q2:243 · Cairo I:268–270

Had I a helper who would aid me with the wine,
p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248

Had you truly been among the people of Being,
p. 398 · Q2:245 · Cairo I:271–273

Had your eyes seen the day the earth of souls was shaken
p. 136 · Q2:74 · Cairo I:121–122

The hearts of the gnostics have eyes
p. 54 · Q2:6–7 · Cairo I:76–77

Hold fast to God-consciousness in secret and in public,
p. 963 · Q4:131–133 · Cairo I:570–573

How astonishing that God should be disobeyed,
p. 509 · Q3:18 · Cairo I:332–334

How many an enemy (كَأَيِّن) we destroyed through our might,
p. 676 · Q3:146–148 · Cairo I:416–418

How often I sought a thing whose turning away You chose for me:
p. 123 · Q2:61 · Cairo I:113–115

Humble yourself before the one you love and acquire honour;
p. 970 · Q4:137–139 · Cairo I:576

Humble yourself before the one you love: love is not easy.
p. 101 · Q2:45–46 · Cairo I:101–103; p. 118 · Q2:58–59 · Cairo I:110–112

Humble yourself before the one you love, to gain dignity:
p. 62 · Q2:13 · Cairo I:80–81

I became the Moses of my time
p. 108 · Q2:51–53 · Cairo I:105–106

I burn with longing for the wine: in it are my rest,
p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248

I did not seek entry unto Him until
p. 118 · Q2:58–59 · Cairo I:110–112

I do not consider it obligatory, since it has indeed been found
p. 751 · Q4:1 · Cairo I:459–461

I have nothing but my spirit; one who gives himself
p. 603 · Q3:92 · Cairo I:380–382

I love You with two loves: love of inclination,
p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198

I only surrendered the soul to consuming sicknesses
p. 110 · Q2:54 · Cairo I:106–108

I pity my enviers for all the rancour their breasts contain.
p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517

I see no effect of remembrance upon my body,
p. 136 · Q2:74 · Cairo I:121–122

If she but passed for a day across a person's thought,
p. 710 · Q3:169–171 · Cairo I:435–436

If shedding my blood is your utmost desire,
p. 110 · Q2:54 · Cairo I:106–108

If someone asks about kalāla,
p. 782 · Q4:12 · Cairo I:475–477

If they divulge the secret, their blood is made forfeit;
p. 576 · Q3:73–74 · Cairo I:368–370

If you desire union with us, your death is a condition;
p. 312 · Q2:196 · Cairo I:224–227; p. 397 · Q2:244 · Cairo I:270–271; p. 743 · Q3:195 · Cairo I:453–454

If you desire union with Us, your death is the condition:
p. 110 · Q2:54 · Cairo I:106–108

If you do not see the crescent, accept the word
p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

If you envy me, I do not blame you: before my time, those of excellence were envied.
p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517

If you have not seen the crescent, yield
p. 295 · Q2:186 · Cairo I:213–215

In a triliteral noun whose middle radical is sound,
p. 269 · Q2:168–169 · Cairo I:198–200

In her description she transcends indwelling;
p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157

The intelligible and the transmitted are like
p. 159 · Q2:90–91 · Cairo I:133–135

It refines the manners of the drinking companions, so that through it
p. 755 · Q4:2 · Cairo I:461–462

Kill me, my trusted friends:
p. 110 · Q2:54 · Cairo I:106–108

Know, my friend—may God protect you—
p. 140 · Q2:78 · Cairo I:123–124

Knowledge is game, and writing its tether;
p. 477 · Q2:283 · Cairo I:315–316

Let him weep for himself whose life is lost,
p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248

Make quiescent the consonant following a vowel other than fatḥa,
p. 269 · Q2:168–169 · Cairo I:198–200

Make ready and seek refuge with the saints:
p. 471 · Q2:280–281 · Cairo I:311–313

Make things easier upon yourself, for their measures
p. 692 · Q3:156 · Cairo I:424–425

The making of deeds of kindness is not possible
p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409

A man’s followers are weighed with him:
p. 540 · Q3:38–41 · Cairo I:349–351

The most unjust of God's creatures is one who lies awake in envy
p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517

My Beloved disclosed Himself in the mirrors of His beauty;
p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157

My Beloved has encompassed existence
p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157

My mountains became level dust
p. 108 · Q2:51–53 · Cairo I:105–106

My son, have mercy on every creature;
p. 170 · Q2:97–98 · Cairo I:139–141

My soul, if you are content with sustenance,
p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341

Naʿam confirms what goes before,
p. 144 · Q2:80–82 · Cairo I:125–127

Never has [this wine] dwelt with sorrow in one place for a day;
p. 661 · Q3:135–136 · Cairo I:409–411

No one has declared the One to be One,
p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70

No place for a veil exists within Your being,
p. 257 · Q2:163–164 · Cairo I:190–193

No work of mine earned it from Him;
p. 533 · Q3:33–37 · Cairo I:345–349

Now I meet the beloved ones:
p. 165 · Q2:94–95 · Cairo I:137–138

O gatherer of wealth, how much harm you suffer through it!
p. 723 · Q3:180 · Cairo I:442–443

O my direction in prayer,
p. 242 · Q2:150 · Cairo I:181–183

O you who blame me, blame me not for love of Him; had you beheld what I beheld, you would not blame.
p. 608 · Q3:96–97 · Cairo I:383–385

O you who wander in a wilderness, estranged from your own secret,
p. 12 · Q1:2–4 · Cairo I:52–70

One day is against us, another day is ours;
p. 668 · Q3:140–143 · Cairo I:412–414

One not effaced from his own share,
p. 149 · Q2:84–85 · Cairo I:128–130

One who has missed seeking arrival and attaining it
p. 498 · Q3:10–11 · Cairo I:326–327

Our scholar is a prophet among them, and whoever calls
p. 993 · Q4:163–165 · Cairo I:590

Part from those you joined in heedless days;
p. 261 · Q2:165–167 · Cairo I:193–198

Patience is like aloes: bitter to the taste,
p. 101 · Q2:45–46 · Cairo I:101–103

People, however noble their stock, do not reach honour
p. 655 · Q3:130–134 · Cairo I:406–409

Perfect your reality, still imperfect,
p. 115 · Q2:57 · Cairo I:109–110

Prostrate before the awe of Majesty
p. 388 · Q2:238–239 · Cairo I:266–267

Remember My kindness to you when you were a drop;
p. 492 · Q3:5–6 · Cairo I:322–323

Replace the third of like consonants with a yāʾ,
p. 433 · Q2:259 · Cairo I:291–293

Returning peace is obligatory—save for one
p. 908 · Q4:84–86 · Cairo I:538–540

Say to one who envies me: Do you know against whom you have offended in courtesy?
p. 865 · Q4:54–57 · Cairo I:515–517

The scholar follows him in words,
p. 531 · Q3:31–32 · Cairo I:343–345

The schools of people stand in disagreement;
p. 619 · Q3:103 · Cairo I:388–389

The science of Sufism is a science known only
p. 628 · Q3:110–112 · Cairo I:392–396

A secret has appeared to you whose concealment from you endured so long;
p. 885 · Q4:71–74 · Cairo I:526–528

Since knowing God, I have seen no other;
p. 197 · Q2:115 · Cairo I:155–157

Some exposed themselves to love, then turned aside
p. 894 · Q4:78 · Cairo I:530–532

The soul is like a child: neglect it, and it will grow up loving to suckle; wean it, and it will be weaned.
p. 807 · Q4:24 · Cairo I:485–489

The source of our breaths is one;
p. 149 · Q2:84–85 · Cairo I:128–130

Sublimity is won in proportion to the toil;
p. 952 · Q4:123 · Cairo I:564

The sun of the one I love rose by night,
p. 304 · Q2:189 · Cairo I:219–222

Sweet is the drinking of wine in solitude;
p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248

Take none but God as your beloved;
p. 48 · Q2:3 · Cairo I:73–75

Take what you see, and leave what you have only heard about;
p. 174 · Q2:100 · Cairo I:141–143

Ṭall is the light kind of rain;
p. 446 · Q2:265 · Cairo I:298–299

The tents are like their tents, indeed;
p. 57 · Q2:8–10 · Cairo I:77–79

Their aspirations give judgment according to the moment's ruling;
p. 512 · Q3:19 · Cairo I:334–335

Their expressions differ, but Your beauty is one;
p. 211 · Q2:125 · Cairo I:163–164

There is no good in life while its pleasures are embittered
p. 75 · Q2:23–25 · Cairo I:87–90

These [knowledges] lie concealed within the souls,
p. 889 · Q4:75 · Cairo I:528–529

They are the destination of the distressed, the treasure and the hope;
p. 72 · Q2:21–22 · Cairo I:86–87

They are the people: hold to their side, if you recognize them;
p. 72 · Q2:21–22 · Cairo I:86–87

They called me to their dominion; when I answered,
p. 522 · Q3:26–27 · Cairo I:338–341

They do not exult when their spears strike home,
p. 685 · Q3:153 · Cairo I:421–422

They have no defect—except that their swords
p. 801 · Q4:22 · Cairo I:484–485

They said: "You drank sin!" No: I drank that
p. 351 · Q2:219 · Cairo I:245–248

They strove with all intensity, until most grew tired;
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Ibn al-Fāriḍ. 86, 108, 261, 351, 603, 661, 710, 755, 807, 894, 993

al-Junayd. 12, 174, 203, 257, 461, 477, 555, 603, 628, 661, 696, 737, 757, 812, 836, 848, 871

al-Darqāwī. 4

al-Būzīdī. 4, 308, 718

Mālik. 9, 12, 32, 173, 217, 252, 269, 272, 285, 291, 312, 316, 347, 351, 366, 368, 370, 385, 388, 391, 575, 584, 615, 672, 725, 751, 782, 795, 803, 812, 819, 834, 848, 918, 932, 934, 939, 1001, 1011

al-Shāfiʿī. 9, 32, 136, 248, 252, 312, 316, 347, 366, 368, 385, 388, 522, 803, 807, 819, 848, 932, 934

Abū Ḥanīfa. 9, 32, 252, 368, 378, 608, 803, 828, 834, 848, 932, 934, 937

Ibn Ḥajar. 177, 224, 393, 734

al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī. 533, 655, 737, 848

al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī. 856

al-Ḥārith al-Muḥāsibī. 261

Arabic technical terminology

Selected Arabic terms appearing within the English commentary. References give passage opening pages; the selection does not cover every occurrence in the Arabic original.

الإشارة — 825, 828, 830, 834, 836

الفناء — 22, 32, 46, 114, 257, 373, 493, 568, 597, 605, 751

البقاء — 22, 32, 91, 114, 257, 373, 493, 568, 597, 605, 625, 661, 751

الحقيقة — 27, 51, 159, 304, 492, 579, 589, 661, 703, 713, 748, 762, 765, 782, 787

الشريعة — 27, 304, 576, 579, 589, 605, 703, 713, 748, 765, 787, 812

التوحيد — 4, 32, 203, 254, 333, 393, 548, 555, 565, 568, 605, 625, 651, 666, 679, 696, 737, 762, 807, 825, 836

التجلي — 54, 737

المعرفة — 12, 27, 32, 48, 83, 261, 304, 533, 540, 582, 628, 637, 655, 661, 676, 685, 728, 737, 775

المشاهدة — 22, 118, 304, 562, 582, 619, 661, 676, 682, 745, 751, 795, 807

العبودية — 12, 22, 48, 51, 319, 385, 545, 615, 710, 748, 751, 775, 787, 795, 825, 830, 836

الربوبية — 22, 48, 57, 254, 323, 545, 559, 615, 640, 710, 775, 825, 830, 836

المبتدأ — 559

الخبر — 59, 559, 622

الحال — 295, 341, 393, 540, 586, 622, 692

الاستثناء — 90, 801, 819

الإضافة — 261

الرفع — 9, 12, 341, 480, 586, 731, 775

النصب — 9, 12, 201, 281, 341, 586, 751, 775

الجر — 319

التأويل — 345

النسخ — 548, 613

الإحسان — 12, 46, 159, 191, 291, 373, 379, 385, 512, 615, 625, 628, 655, 661, 714, 748

اليقين — 64, 114, 433, 592, 615, 628, 694, 819, 825

التوكل — 83, 644, 696, 699

التفويض — 696

التربية — 12, 32, 54, 59, 75, 570, 599, 603, 628, 644, 685, 703, 737, 755, 771, 775

المقامات — 46, 676, 696, 757

الأحوال — 46, 69, 356, 628, 757, 801

الجمع — 27, 90, 362, 512, 522, 586, 625, 628, 661, 707, 713

الفرق — 27, 90, 134, 201, 393, 490, 512, 522, 586, 625, 713, 734

الحمد — 12, 244

الصبر — 83, 101, 332

الشكر — 12, 32, 83

الولاية — 319, 379, 465, 589, 685, 745, 767, 775, 787, 795, 828

الفكر — 4, 22, 540, 655, 737

الذكر — 22, 83, 737, 789

Translator’s annotations

Notes on language, textual readings, sources and interpretation. Passage references lead back to the English commentary; Cairo references identify the Arabic source pages.

T1 · The named Taftāzānī source and its variants

Passage: preface (p. 4)

The quotation is directly attested in al-Taftāzānī, Sharḥ al-ʿAqāʾid, Maktabat al-Madīna, 2nd ed. (1433/2012), p. 349. That printing has daqāʾiq (subtleties) and ʿalā arbāb where Cairo has ḥaqāʾiq (realities) and li-arbāb; it confirms the closing “perfection of faith and pure gnosis.”

Cairo I:50.

Scope: The printed source establishes the philosophical and theological quotation. It does not identify which edition or intermediary Ibn ʿAjība used, or provide an independent witness to the wording of al-Baḥr al-madīd.

T2 · Editorial explanation

Passage: intro2 (p. 43)

al-Baqara, introduction · Cairo I:71. Ibn ʿAjība explicitly attributes the statement to ʿAlī. Al-Suyūṭī reports the “first revealed in Medina” form from ʿIkrima and a separate “revealed in Medina” statement from Ibn ʿAbbās. Neither supplies an isnād to ʿAlī. The attribution to ʿAlī remains unverified; the Cairo editor’s objection and the separately transmitted al-Suyūṭī reports have distinct evidential scopes.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:71; Ruslān’s editorial footnote.

T3 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:23–25 (p. 75)

Cairo I:89 · Poetic attribution. The Cairo footnote points to al-Khaṭīb al-Baghdādī's Tārīkh Baghdād for a verse associated with a narrative about Abū al-Ḥasan al-Nūrī. It does not establish authorship of every line in the surrounding passage. This is a poetic-literary source reference; the original cited narrative and its pagination have not been independently verified.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:89; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T4 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:45–46 (p. 101)

Cairo I:102 · Poetry in the discussion of the guide. Ruslān supplies a further explanation from al-Khafājī's gloss on al-Bayḍāwī; the footnotes also record the nearby verse of poetry. This is the Cairo editor's quotation of a later commentator's explanatory material, distinct from Ibn ʿAjība's own text. The quotation has not been independently verified in al-Khafājī's gloss.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:102; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T5 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:79 (p. 143)

Cairo I:124 · Composite report. Ruslān explicitly states that the words in square brackets are not part of the cited Prophetic report. He links that description to ʿAṭāʾ b. Yasār through al-Ṭabarī and al-Wāḥidī, or to Companion wording in al-Baghawī. Al-Ṭabarī transmits the ʿAṭāʾ wording separately at Q2:79. The Prophetic report about the valley also circulates in a different form, mentioning forty years of descent. These are distinct transmissions: the melting-mountains clause is not thereby established as part of the Prophetic quotation.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:124; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T6 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:100 (p. 174)

Cairo I:143 · Spiritual training and the shaykh's fallibility. Ruslān interprets the story to mean that a disciple must not presume the shaykh's infallibility, although a shaykh may be highly accomplished. This interpretation belongs to the Cairo editor's footnote, not to another passage from Ibn ʿAjība.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:143; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T7 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:115 (p. 197)

Cairo I:156 · The qibla commentary. Ruslān comments on the story behind direction in prayer and supplies his own explanation of the sequence of the qibla verses. This is the Cairo editor's legal-historical interpretation, not an additional manuscript reading. Other explanations occur in the traditional tafsīr literature.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:156; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T8 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:150 (p. 242)

Cairo I:182 · The verse ascribed to Labīd. The Cairo footnote cites Ibn Ḥajar's Fatḥ al-Bārī on the poem about the impermanence of delight. The poetic line and the reported reply of ʿUthmān require separate attribution control. The Qurʾānic teaching about the permanence of the next life does not settle their provenance. Ibn Ḥajar is the Cairo editor's cited source; the precise Fatḥ passage has not been independently verified.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:182; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T9 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:163–164 (p. 257)

Cairo I:191 · Report-source reference. The Cairo footnote supplies an additional report locator in the discussion of the signs of divine unity. A printed source reference is a finding aid, not an examination of the chain. The ref-

erence is reported by Ruslān; the exact report wording and chain have not been independently assessed, so the locator alone does not establish a ṣaḥīḥ report.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:191; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T10 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:187 (p. 297)

al-Baqara 2:187 · Cairo I:216. The Arabic commentary introduces a long report involving al-Ḥawlāʾ and ʿĀʾisha, but the transmission in Ibn al-Jawzī's al-Mawḍūʿāt passes through Anas b. Mālik and includes Ziyād b. Maymūn. Ibn al-Jawzī criticizes Ziyād and other narrators; the named critics treat this as a fabricated transmission. The story's interlocutor and the chain's narrator are distinct. The sound account of ʿAdī b. Ḥātim concerning the two threads, printed on the same page, is an unrelated report and does not authenticate the al-Ḥawlāʾ story or its extravagant rewards.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:216; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T11 · The scope of al-Suyūṭī's narrator-wording comment

Passage: 2:187 (p. 297)

Al-Suyūṭī's al-Tawshīḥ, ed. Riḍwān Jāmiʿ Riḍwān (1419/1998), p. 1427 (on al-Bukhārī 1916–1917), distinguishes ʿAdī's later experience from Sahl's account of the earlier men. His remark about narrators' wording falls under ʿAdī's "when it was revealed"; Cairo's abridgment attaches it to "then God revealed 'of dawn'." Ibn ʿAjība's following inference depends on this arrangement. Al-Suyūṭī does not draw that inference in this passage.

Cairo I:217.

Scope: This is a comparison of the scope and arrangement of the quotation in a printed earlier source. It does not establish whether the discrepancy originated with Ibn ʿAjība, an intermediary, or a later Baḥr witness. It does not independently adjudicate the hadith routes or the legal-theory question of delayed clarification.

T12 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:212 (p. 336)

Cairo I:238 · Occupations and mindfulness. Ruslān quotes and contextualises a maxim from Abū Sulaymān al-Dārānī through al-Sarrāj's al-Lumaʿ on combining proper worldly occupations with remembrance. The quotation, Ruslān's explanatory paraphrase and Ibn ʿAjība's spiritual allusion are distinct. The precise al-Lumaʿ passage has not been independently verified in full.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:238; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T13 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:217–218 (p. 347)

Cairo I:243 · Fighting and the Sacred Months. The Cairo editor supplies an evaluation of the Sufis' role in struggle and the context of a verse on fighting. This is his own interpretation, neither a manuscript variant nor Ibn ʿAjība's direct statement.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:243; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T14 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:219 (p. 351)

Cairo I:246 · The wine metaphor. Ruslān explains figurative intoxication, spiritual capacity and disclosure according to Sufi usage. This is the Cairo editor's contextual interpretation; the metaphor is distinct from a juristic judgment about drinking.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:246; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T15 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 2:250–252 (p. 411)

Cairo I:280 · The Goliath narratives. Ruslān calls a group of supplementary narratives "legends" and cites both Ibn ʿAṭiyya and a twentieth-century critic. His note does not automatically apply to every version of the David and Goliath story. The Qurʾānic statement, later narrative expansion, Ibn

ʿAṭiyya's criticism as reported and Ruslān's judgment have distinct scopes. Ibn ʿAṭiyya's precise passage has not been independently verified, so Ruslān's conclusion cannot simply be assigned to him.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:280; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T16 · Placement after the first 280 verses

Passage: 2:280–281 (p. 471)

The placement formula means the boundary after the preceding two hundred and eighty verses. Al-Qārī, Jamʿ al-wasāʾil, I:14, quotes al-Ṭībī's gloss of raʾs al-āya as a verse's end. Al-Qurṭubī, III:341–342, and al-Bursawī on Q2:281 place this verse between the usury and debt passages; Aṭfayyish explicitly numbers it 281. This explains the placement language; it does not establish the report's revelation chronology or the interval before the Prophet's death.

Cairo I:312.

Scope: The earlier commentaries clarify the placement formula. The chain of the reported Gabriel instruction, the claim that this was the last verse revealed and the interval of twenty-one days before the Prophet's death remain unverified. The argument concerns the standard verse numbering; regional enumeration systems are a separate question.

T17 · The direction of love in the Dhū l-Nūn account

Passage: 2:285–286 (p. 482)

Cairo I:320 leaves the direction of love open: "love of God" and "love of created beings" may refer to love felt by them or directed towards them. The Turkish translation (I:751) takes the contrast as God's love and the creatures' love for Him. An earlier account in al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān, II:309 (electronic text), repeats these expressions. Ibn ʿAjība then applies the description to worshippers and ascetics. The Arabic expression remains ambiguous.

Cairo I:320; primary-source comparison recorded below.

Scope: Source comparison and copytext interpretation; no independent Baḥr manuscript reading is asserted.

T18 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 3:14 (p. 503)

Cairo I:329–330 · The saying attributed to ʿAlī. Ruslān challenges the attribution to ʿAlī of the sharply disparaging saying about women and notes historical examples of women excelling in righteousness. The saying is attributed speech, not a Prophetic hadith; its attribution remains unverified. Ruslān's challenge belongs to the Cairo editor's footnote.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:329–330; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T19 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 3:18 (p. 509)

Cairo I:334 · The merit report about the testimony to divine unity. The Cairo editor supplies source attributions and a classical objection to a report promising exceptional rewards for reciting "God bears witness that there is no god but He." His cited version is distinct from other reports on the verse. The transmitted objection concerns a particular chain, not every report about the verse; a complete comparison of the chains has not been established.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:334; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T20 · "Offspring" and the meaning of dedication

Passage: 3:33–37 (p. 533)

The parenthesis is "God knows best what she/I have borne," together with the intervening comparison of male and female; it is not the statement "I have named her Mary." Waḍaʿtu, with the first-person ending, makes the mother acknowledge that God knows the significance of her child better than she does. Waḍaʿat, with the feminine third-person ending, allows a divine comment correcting the mother's estimate. Al-Bayḍāwī explicitly distinguishes these voices at Q3:36 (Anwār, II:14). The change of speaker therefore follows a recitational distinction; it must not be flattened into a single uninterrupted speech by Mary's mother.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 345; Q3:33–37; baydawi: Anwār al-tanzīl II:14, Q3:36; PageV02P014

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T21 · Ḥanna’s vow and Mary’s birth

Passage: 3:33–37 (p. 533)

Three voices should be distinguished here. The report attributed to the Prophet singles out Mary and her son; al-Bukhārī transmits that exception and Abū Hurayra’s ensuing citation of Q3:36 (Ṣaḥīḥ, no. 3431). The explanation in terms of Satan’s attempt at temptation is exegetical interpretation. “I say: likewise with all the prophets” is Ibn ʿAjība’s own theological extension, introduced by qultu, and is not part of the quoted hadith. Thus “protection from sin” renders the author’s appeal to ʿiṣma; it should not make the report appear to enumerate an exception for every prophet.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 347; Q3:33–37; bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, no.3431, Book of Prophets

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T22 · Acceptance, growth and Zachariah’s guardianship

Passage: 3:33–37 (p. 533)

The guardianship narrative expands details that the Qurʾān states more briefly. Q3:37 names Zachariah’s care of Mary, while Q3:44 refers to the disputants casting their pens to determine her guardian. The number twenty-seven, the river, and the contrasting movement of the pens belong to the account introduced here by “it is related” (ruwiya). They are not words of the Qurʾānic verses. “Pens” preserves aqlām and its connection to the learned custodians; the passage presents the casting as a lot, not a writing exercise. The report’s narrative form does not by itself authenticate the event.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 347; Q3:33–37

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T23 · Acceptance, growth and Zachariah’s guardianship

Passage: 3:33–37 (p. 533)

Al-Qushayrī draws a practical inference from kullamā, “whenever”: Zachariah repeatedly attends to Mary even after finding extraordinary provision. His Laṭāʾif (I:239, Q3:37) contains the same argument and the concluding statement that nothing is incumbent upon God. The point is that a karāma is a freely bestowed divine favour whose recurrence cannot be de-

manded. Earlier provision therefore does not cancel the guardian's continuing care or justify assuming that today's circumstances match yesterday's. "Without reckoning" is correspondingly explained through divine generosity, not as a contractual reward earned by Mary's worship.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 347; Q3:33–37; qushayri_tafsir: Laṭāʾif al-ishārāt I:239, Q3:37; PageV01P239

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T24 · Fāṭima's provision

Passage: 3:33–37 (p. 533)

The episode is constructed as a parallel between Mary's provision and Fāṭima's household: the same question "Whence is this for you?" receives the same answer from Q3:37. A longer version occurs in al-Thaʿlabī's al-Kashf wa-l-bayān (III:57–58), introduced as a report from Jābir and including the two loaves, meat, full dish, and distribution to neighbours. This establishes an earlier textual parallel for Ibn ʿAjība's account. It does not, by itself, authenticate the transmission chain or prove that the event occurred. The Qurʾānic wording within the narrative remains a quotation placed on Fāṭima's lips by the report.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 348; Q3:33–37; thalabi: al-Kashf wa-l-bayān III:57–58, Q3:37; PageV03P057–058

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T25 · The chosen renewers and consecration of the self

Passage: 3:33–37 (p. 533)

The renewal saying is transmitted in Abū Dāwūd's Sunan (no. 4291); its wording identifies whoever renews the community's religion, without naming al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī. The funeral proclamation and Ibn ʿAjība's designation of al-Ḥasan as a renewer are separate applications. Abū Ṭālib al-Makkī does call al-Ḥasan "our imam in this science" in Qūt al-qulūb (I:223), within a discussion of divine decree, command, and responsibility. That located phrase supports the quoted attribution. It should not be enlarged into

primary evidence that al-Ḥasan founded every feature of later organized Sufism; that broader historical characterization belongs to Ibn ʿAjība's presentation.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 348; Q3:33–37; abu_dawud: Sunan Abī Dāwūd, no.4291, Kitāb al-Malāḥim; qut: Qūt al-qulūb I:223; PageV01P223

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T26 · "There," the sanctuary, and the angelic announcement

Passage: 3:38–41 (p. 540)

The masculine and feminine forms discussed here belong to grammatical agreement with a broken plural. They do not assign biological sex to the angels. Ibn ʿAjība's own example, "the men arose," permits either verb form, which makes this distinction explicit. Fanādat-hu and fanādā-hu both describe the call to Zachariah; the final -hu refers to him. Identifying the speaker as Gabriel is the author's interpretation of the plural, not a translation of malāʾika as a singular noun. Likewise, bashara and bashshara are two Arabic verbal forms for giving glad tidings, not two different announcements.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 349; Q3:38–41

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T27 · A child from the barren and the aged

Passage: 3:38–41 (p. 540)

Ḥaṣūr is first explained through disciplined restraint, then through a reported physiological interpretation. The conjunction "or" keeps those explanations alternative; they should not become a single settled biography of John. The bodily report is transmitted here with an attribution to Ibn ʿAbbās, without an evaluated chain. Al-Qushayrī's directly corresponding comment (Laṭāʾif, I:241, Q3:39) interprets the word as freedom from passions while

remaining human. That supports the ascetic sense emphasized here. It does not verify the anatomical report or require “restrained” to mean incapable of sexual intercourse.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 350; Q3:38–41; qushayri_tafsir: Laṭāʾif al-ishārāt I:241, Q3:39; PageV01P241

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T28 · Spiritual children and the transmission of the Path

Passage: 3:38–41 (p. 540)

Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ (no. 1631) transmits the three continuing benefits: ongoing charity, beneficial knowledge, and a righteous child who prays for the deceased. Ibn ʿAjība then explicitly includes spiritual as well as bodily offspring. The extension to disciples belongs to his interpretation of the report and to his analogy between bodily and spiritual lineages. It is not an additional phrase in Muslim’s hadith. The preceding acknowledgement that a perfected saint may have no spiritual offspring also matters: the number of disciples is not presented as a necessary measure of the saint’s personal realization.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 351; Q3:38–41; muslim: Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim, no.1631, Kitāb al-Waṣiyya

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T29 · The two elections of Mary

Passage: 3:42–43 (p. 545)

The repeated “has chosen you” is given two distinct applications. The first concerns Mary’s reception into sacred service and God’s provision for her; the second concerns her guidance, angelic address, and the extraordinary birth announced to her. The repetition distinguishes these two gifts. The passage places these gifts within the author’s category of karāma, a grace

bestowed on a friend of God. His adjoining claim of consensus about women and prophecy remains an attributed doctrinal assertion; the two elections themselves do not independently establish that claim.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 351; Q3:42–43

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T30 · The two elections of Mary

Passage: 3:42–43 (p. 545)

The reports about women's distinction have different wording and should not be merged. Al-Bukhārī's "many men attained perfection" report names Mary and Āsiya (Ṣaḥīḥ, no. 3433); the Cairo quotation here additionally names Khadīja. A different report in al-Tirmidhī (no. 3878) names Mary, Khadīja, Fāṭima, and Āsiya together. Its existence does not establish the added name as part of al-Bukhārī's wording. The subsequent comparisons of "her world," "her age," and all women are exegetical efforts to relate distinct commendations. The difference between Ibn ʿAjība's quotation and these hadith texts remains a separate textual issue.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 352; Q3:42–43; bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, no.3433; tirmidhi: Jāmiʿ al-Tirmidhī, no.3878, V:703; PageV05P703

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T31 · Devotion, bowing and prostration

Passage: 3:42–43 (p. 545)

The issue is the order of mention, not a prescription that Muslim prayer should place prostration before bowing. Arabic wa- joins the two commands without necessarily specifying their temporal sequence. Al-Bayḍāwī gives the same alternatives at Q3:43 (Anwār, II:16): a different earlier ritual order, the conjunction's non-sequential force, or the rhetorical pairing of "bow" with "those who bow." These are alternative explanations of the

verse. His further interpretation of qunūt as sustained obedience and rukūʿ as humility is likewise a second account; the two accounts are alternatives, not one reconstructed ritual.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 352; Q3:42–43; baydawi: Anwār al-tanzīl II:16, Q3:43; PageV02P016

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T32 · Dream, inspiration, legislation and disclosure

Passage: 3:44 (p. 547)

Waḥy has a deliberately broad scope in this fourfold classification. The crucial distinction is between receiving an intimation and receiving binding religious rulings: waḥy al-aḥkām is reserved for prophets. Within this classification, he reserves waḥy al-iʿlām conveyed through an angel to prophets, while allowing inspiration, dreams, or direct understanding to saints. “Revelation” in these latter uses therefore should not imply a new scripture or authority to legislate. The closing qualification further limits what a purified spirit may receive: disclosure is partial and general, while exhaustive knowledge of unseen particulars belongs to God. This is Ibn ʿAjība’s local scheme, not an authentication of particular claimed experiences.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 353; Q3:44

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T33 · The Messiah, the Word, and the syntax of the annunciation

Passage: 3:45–51 (p. 548)

These are alternative explanations of the Arabic epithet masīḥ. Under the root m-s-ḥ, its faʿīl form can be explained through a passive relation, “one wiped/anointed,” or an active relation, “one who wipes.” The proposed connection with travelling instead treats the initial mīm as additional and relates the word to another root. The alternatives are word-based exegetical explanations, not cumulative facts that must all hold at once. The final

saying depends on the epithet's application to both Jesus and the Dajjāl: "the Messiah will slay the messiah" contrasts its two referents and does not identify them as the same figure.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 354; Q3:45–51

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T34 · The signs granted to Jesus

Passage: 3:45–51 (p. 548)

"I fashion" renders akhluqu in its local sense of forming a clay likeness. Al-Bayḍāwī makes that sense explicit at Q3:49: "I determine and shape for you" (Anwār, II:18). The subsequent life of the figure and the restoration of the dead are repeatedly qualified by "God's leave." Ibn ʿAjība expressly uses the qualification to distinguish the miracle's ultimate divine agency from an independent power belonging to Jesus. The account of the bat is an additional reported explanation of the sign; its species identification and natural-history details are not specified by the Qurʾānic word "bird."

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 355; Q3:45–51; baydawi: Anwār al-tanzīl II:18, Q3:49; PageV02P018

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T35 · The signs granted to Jesus

Passage: 3:45–51 (p. 548)

The four named resuscitations form an exegetical narrative attached to Q3:49. Al-Baghawī preserves the same sequence—ʿĀzir, the old woman's son, the tithe-collector's daughter, and Shem—and the account of Shem's hair turning grey through fear of the Resurrection (Maʿālim, II:40). This locates an earlier narrative parallel, with some differences in detail. The Qurʾānic verse itself does not supply those names or episodes. The final "it

is said" introduces a further identification of the invocation as "O Living, O Self-Subsisting"; it should not be read as an independently established quotation of the words used in every preceding episode.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 355; Q3:45–51; baghawi: Maʿālim al-tanzīl II:40, Q3:49; PageV02P040

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T36 · The signs granted to Jesus

Passage: 3:45–51 (p. 548)

The attribution to al-Suddī closes the childhood narrative, including the concealed food, the boys' confinement, the transformation, and the flight to Egypt. Al-Baghawī transmits this same sequence under al-Suddī's name at Q3:49 (Maʿālim, II:40–41). He then gives a different explanation from Qatāda involving the heavenly table; that separate account should not be combined with the schoolroom story. The parallel confirms the scope of the transmitted attribution in Ibn ʿAjība. It does not make the whole narrative Qurʾānic: the verse states Jesus' knowledge of food eaten and stored, while the surrounding incidents come from exegetical reporting.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 356; Q3:45–51; baghawi: Maʿālim al-tanzīl II:40–41, Q3:49; PageV02P040–041

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T37 · Divine unity and the straight way

Passage: 3:45–51 (p. 548)

The "theoretical" and "practical" powers are complementary human capacities: apprehending what is true and acting in accordance with it. Here the first reaches its fulfilment in acknowledging God's unity; the second in worship and obedience. Al-Bayḍāwī's corresponding passage (Anwār, II:19, Q3:51) makes the same pairing. "Theoretical" therefore should not suggest mere speculation or an optional hypothesis. The closing hadith condenses

the two aspects into belief and upright conduct; Muslim transmits the instruction to Sufyān ibn ʿAbd Allāh as “Say: I believe in God; then remain upright” (Ṣaḥīḥ, no. 38).

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 356; Q3:45–51; baydawi: Anwār al-tanzīl II:19, Q3:51; PageV02P019; muslim: Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim, no.38, Kitāb al-Īmān

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T38 · The disciples’ confession and the attempt upon Jesus

Passage: 3:52–54 (p. 555)

Qaṣṣārūn are workers who cleanse or whiten cloth, while ṣabbāghūn are dyers; “cloth-finishers and dyers” preserves both crafts. The anecdote develops one of the explanations of ḥawāriyyūn given immediately before it (Cairo I:357): the disciples are associated with whitening cloth, beside interpretations through purity of intention or white clothing. In the story, different colours emerge from a single vat through Jesus’ instruction, prompting recognition of a divine sign. The report is introduced through ʿAṭāʾ. It illustrates an explanation of the disciples’ designation; it does not by itself settle the word’s historical derivation or authenticate their occupations.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 358; Q3:52–54

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T39 · Why “planning” is predicated of God

Passage: 3:52–54 (p. 555)

The argument distinguishes the opponents’ intention from the outcome of God’s allowing it to proceed. Al-Junayd’s reported answer calls that very allowance a divine makr; Ibn ʿAjība then explains the beneficial outcome as Jesus’ preservation and raising. The poetry supplies an analogy for judging an act in relation to its agent, and the “I say” explicitly marks Ibn ʿAjība’s subsequent explanation. The passage is consequently more specific than a

general endorsement of deceit. Its earlier language of correspondence and requital (Cairo I:358) also explains why the same Arabic root is applied to the plotters and to God within Q3:54.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 359; Q3:52–54

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T40 · The meanings of tawaffī and the demonstrative

Passage: 3:55–58 (p. 559)

Tawaffī can signify taking or receiving in full; its application to death or sleep depends on context. Ibn ʿAjība chooses explanations consistent with Jesus' being raised alive. The assertion of consensus is his own: al-Ṭabarī explicitly records competing interpretations at Q3:55, including sleep, removal from the earth, and death, before preferring removal alive (Jāmiʿ al-bayān, VI:455–460). Recording those earlier interpretations does not authenticate each attributed report, but it prevents treating the history of exegesis as univocal. Q4:157's denial of killing and crucifixion is the author's cited argument; the lexical issue is discussed separately.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 359; Q3:55–58; tabari: Jāmiʿ al-bayān VI:455–460, Q3:55; reports7133–7143 and ensuing preference

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T41 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 3:55–58 (p. 559)

Cairo I:360 · The author's historical horizon. Ibn ʿAjība's statement is explicitly limited by "up to our time," meaning his own time of writing. Ruslān adds a separate footnote about political developments in his own age. These are two historically situated claims, not one timeless theological judgment or an independently verified general history.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:360; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T42 · The raising, judgment and recompense

Passage: 3:55–58 (p. 559)

“Down to our own time” refers to the author’s time of writing. It is part of his historical generalization about the fulfilment of Q3:55, not a statement addressed to the present reader’s date. The preceding alternatives also need to remain visible: one account includes Christians and Muslims among Jesus’ followers, while another identifies the followers as the people of Islam. Ibn ʿAjība then defines true following through acceptance of Jesus’ prophethood and reads “above” in terms of argument and power. This historically situated polemic does not provide independent proof of the entire political generalization.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 360; Q3:55–58

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T43 · Ascending beyond desires and enduring through transmission

Passage: 3:55–58 (p. 559)

The allusion moves from spatial ascent and migration to a change in attachment. The “homeland” left behind is explicitly the domain of personal appetites, self-interest, and habitual dependence; the ascent concerns the spirit and innermost secret. Malakūt and jabarūt function as technical terms in this spiritual account, rather than simply denoting geographical heavens. The continuing honour of disciples and descendants belongs to the author’s account of spiritual transmission. His prophetic attribution of “Emigrate, and you will gain honour for your children” is a separate reported saying; the inward interpretation does not establish its chain or turn the promise into a demonstrated rule of family history.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 360; Q3:55–58

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T44 · Adam without parents and Jesus without a father

Passage: 3:59–60 (p. 562)

The comparison is an argument about divine creative power. On the author's account, Adam's creation without either parent is more unusual than Jesus' birth without a father; unusual birth therefore supplies no sufficient ground for elevating Jesus beyond created servanthood. "Likeness" renders mathal in the sense of a comparable case or condition, rather than bodily resemblance between the two figures. The dialogue with the Najrān delegation is introduced as the occasion of revelation and expands the argument narratively. Q3:59 itself supplies the comparison and creative command; it does not contain the delegation's questions or the quoted exchange.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 361; Q3:59–60

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T45 · Adam without parents and Jesus without a father

Passage: 3:59–60 (p. 562)

This extended account combines material with separate textual witnesses. Abū Dāwūd (no. 4324) includes the bodily description, the Dajjāl, forty years, death and funeral prayer. Muslim (no. 1252) gives the pilgrimage through al-Rawḥāʾ; al-Ṭabarī (VI:459, report 7145) includes peace among animals. Al-Thaʿlabī (III:82) places marriage, offspring and burial in the Prophet's chamber in a separate version attributed to Kaʿb, giving twenty-four years, after an Abū Hurayra narrative giving forty. Cairo combines these details under one prophetic quotation. The preceding ages of Mary and Jesus belong to another reporting frame. These parallels locate components and expose the composite structure; they do not authenticate the assembled narrative.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 362; Q3:59–60; abu_dawud: Sunan Abī Dāwūd, no.4324, Kitāb al-Malāḥim; muslim: Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim, no.1252, Kitāb al-Ḥajj; tabari: Jāmiʿ al-bayān VI:459, report7145, on Q3:55; PageV06P459; al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān: III:82, on Q3:55; PageV03P082

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T46 · Spirit and clay in the human being

Passage: 3:59–60 (p. 562)

Lāhūtī and nāsūtī supply the last pair in a series of opposed attributes: divine-oriented and human, spiritual and bodily, inward and sensible. Their force should be read through the movement of the whole paragraph. The human being contains both tendencies; the decisive question is which governs aspiration. The following sentences define ascent through obedience and remembrance, and descent through absorption in appetite. Thus "divine spirit" belongs to the author's spiritual anthropology, while the spirit remains directed towards its Master. His explanation of Jesus' exceptional spiritual disposition likewise develops the virgin-birth narrative through this scheme, rather than presenting an independent physiological demonstration.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 362; Q3:59–60

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T47 · Najrān and the challenge of mubāhala

Passage: 3:61–63 (p. 565)

"Is subject to passing away" preserves the prospective or general force of yaʾtī ʿalayhi al-fanāʾ. It does not say that Jesus had already died, which would conflict with the interpretation the author adopted at Q3:55. The reported questions also echo the sūrah's opening divine attributes: living and sustaining (Q3:2), knowledge from which nothing is hidden (3:5), and forming creatures in the womb (3:6). This explains the narrative's final reference to revelation of the opening portion. The dialogue and its chronology are an exegetical report; the correspondences with those verses establish its argumentative design, not an independent record of the exchange.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 363; Q3:61–63

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T48 · Najrān and the challenge of mubāhala

Passage: 3:61–63 (p. 565)

Separate sources attest different parts of this narrative. Muslim's report no. 2404 names ʿAlī, Fāṭima, al-Ḥasan, and al-Ḥusayn in connection with Q3:61, without supplying the whole negotiation. Abū Dāwūd's no. 3041 reports the two thousand garments divided between Ṣafar and Rajab, but describes armour and other equipment as a guaranteed loan to be returned. This differs from Cairo's compressed settlement. Neither parallel contains the entire preceding conversation and subsequent threatened transformations. The family's participation, treaty terms, and warning therefore retain separate evidential scopes even though Ibn ʿAjība presents a continuous account.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 363; Q3:61–63; muslim: Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim, no.2404, virtues of ʿAlī; abu_dawud: Sunan Abī Dāwūd, no.3041, Kitāb al-Kharāj

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T49 · Loyalty to one's shaykh and the trial of denial

Passage: 3:61–63 (p. 565)

Qultu, "I say," introduces a first-person anecdote from Ibn ʿAjība. The claim that the scholars of Fez agreed is spoken by his unnamed visitor; the text neither lists those scholars nor presents their statements. Ibn ʿAjība's answer then uses a deliberately comprehensive hypothetical—everyone in the seven heavens and earths—to express the force of his personal certainty. "Particular spiritual distinction" translates khuṣūṣiyya, the realization he claims to have witnessed in his shaykh. The exchange illustrates the author's application of steadfastness to the relationship with a guide; it is not an independently documented institutional judgment or consensus.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 364; Q3:61–63

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T50 · Worship, religious authority and the call to a common word

Passage: 3:64 (p. 568)

The report is an interpretation of Q9:31 brought into the explanation of Q3:64. Its concern is accepting religious leaders' unauthorized declarations of what is lawful and unlawful; "worship" here is explained through that obedience. Al-Tirmidhī transmits the substance from ʿAdī ibn Ḥātim (no. 3095), with different dialogue wording. He also calls this transmission gharīb and remarks that Ghuṭayf ibn Aʿyan is not well known in hadith. Those are the collector's own qualifications, not a modern grading inferred from a verbal match. The parallel supports identification of the cited report while retaining a concrete transmission question.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 364; Q3:64; tirmidhi: Jāmiʿ al-Tirmidhī, no.3095, V:278; PageV05P278

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T51 · Passage explanation

Passage: 3:64 (p. 568)

This paragraph is a bridge into Q3:65–68: its concluding "God revealed" introduces the verses that follow. The dispute concerns who can claim Abraham as a religious predecessor. Ḥanīf and muslim here anticipate the explanation at Cairo I:366: turning from false beliefs and yielding to God. The author then expressly distinguishes that primordial submission from membership in a later historical religious community. Reading the transitional speech with its sequel prevents anachronistically assigning Abraham every later communal designation or treating the narrated dispute as part of the Qurʾānic wording.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 365; Q3:64

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T52 · Abraham precedes the later communal designations

Passage: 3:65–68 (p. 570)

The argument of Q3:65 rests on relative order: the Torah and Gospel came after Abraham, so later communal labels cannot simply be projected backwards onto him. Ibn ʿAjība expands that order with intervals of a thousand

and two thousand years. These numbers are the commentator's chronological assertions; they are not given by the verse. The logic of the passage does not depend on verifying those exact intervals. The numerical chronology and the more limited Qurʾānic premise have distinct scopes; the commentary's chronology is not an independently established historical calculation.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 366; Q3:65–68

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T53 · Abraham precedes the later communal designations

Passage: 3:65–68 (p. 570)

The author deliberately distinguishes two uses of Islam: submission to God and the historically later religious community with its particular ordinances. If muslim in Q3:67 meant membership in that later community in the same chronological sense as "Jew" or "Christian," his preceding objection would apply to it as well. "The same objection" therefore refers to anachronism, not to denying Abraham's submission to God. The next sentence calls Abraham the imam of those who affirm divine unity, while Q3:68 locates closeness to him in following his way. Keeping this distinction makes the otherwise surprising qualification intelligible.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 366; Q3:65–68

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T54 · The stratagem of professing belief and then withdrawing

Passage: 3:72 (p. 575)

"At the beginning of the day" renders wajh al-nahār, literally the day's face or front. The story explains a temporary outward profession followed by withdrawal intended to unsettle other believers. The number twelve, the identification with Khaybar, and the proposed appeal to learned authorities belong to the report attributed to al-Ḥasan and al-Suddī. Q3:72 itself identifies a group among the People of the Book without those particulars. The

ensuing account about changing prayer direction is introduced separately by “it is said”; it is an alternative explanation of the stratagem, not an additional step established within the first report.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 368; Q3:72

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T55 · Entering the path without a settled commitment

Passage: 3:72 (p. 575)

Al-Bukhārī transmits the warning about following predecessors, including the image of entering a lizard’s hole and the question about Jews and Christians (Ṣaḥīḥ, no. 3456). Ibn ʿAjība applies that general warning specifically to entering and abandoning a path of spiritual training. The application belongs to his allusive commentary; the hadith does not itself name Sufi disciples or guides. The preceding list also distinguishes motives: inability to bear the discipline, tentative experimentation, and deliberate manipulation. Preserving those alternatives prevents making every departure equivalent to the consciously deceptive scheme described in the verse.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 368; Q3:72; bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, no.3456

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T56 · The disputed construction of an yuʾtā and the parenthetical reply

Passage: 3:73–74 (p. 576)

This is the second of two syntactic reconstructions, not an extra sentence in the verse. In the first, “that anyone is given” supplies the content of “believe,” while God’s instruction to say that guidance belongs to Him interrupts the reported speech. In the second, the same infinitival phrase expresses a motive, with an understood act of devising or speaking: did they act from dislike of another receiving such favour? Taqdīr labels the explan-

atory wording supplied by the grammarian. Its clauses and changes of speaker must therefore remain distinguishable from the continuous Qurʾānic text of Q3:73.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 368; Q3:73–74

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T57 · Preparation, confidentiality and the danger of disclosure without realization

Passage: 3:73–74 (p. 576)

The danger described concerns communicating realized experience to someone who receives only its verbal formulation. The preceding prose contrasts possessing khuṣūṣiyya with taking it merely "as knowledge," then warns of doctrinal misunderstanding or accusations under the Law. The verse about al-Ḥallāj is introduced anonymously as poetry; mentioning him within it does not attribute the poem to him. Its language of guarding the Reality and being slain by a spear dramatizes the risk of disclosure. The following anonymous couplet makes the warning still sharper. These are poetic and disciplinary applications, not a hadith or a separately reasoned legal ruling on punishment.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 369; Q3:73–74

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T58 · An entrusted deposit remains another person's right

Passage: 3:75–76 (p. 579)

The qinṭār and dinar form a rhetorical contrast between a large deposit and a small one. The author makes the extension explicit: a qinṭār "or more," a dinar "or less." The question is therefore reliability with entrusted property, not a precise exchange rate or fixed threshold for honesty. His grammatical note treats the preposition bi- with "entrust" as having the sense of ʿalā; the English idiom is "entrust someone with" the property. The

named deposit stories and the promised heavenly reward are additional reports. The verse's contrast itself concerns returning what belongs to another and the need for persistent demand when it is withheld.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 370; Q3:75–76

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T59 · Realization does not cancel the Law or people's rights

Passage: 3:75–76 (p. 579)

The polemic turns the verse's accusation against members of the author's own spiritual milieu. Claiming realization of the Reality cannot abolish another person's property rights or the duty to return what was entrusted. The two transactions are distinguished: an ordinary deposit and qirāḍ, the provision of capital for a commercial venture. The objection concerns betrayal in either setting. The later excuse about ordinary people's possessions deliberately echoes the reported claim of exemption concerning the "unlettered" in Q3:75. Thus the passage makes fidelity to the Law a test of claimed spiritual attainment, rather than treating attainment as an exemption from accountability.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 371; Q3:75–76

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T60 · The paltry price of concealing a binding trust

Passage: 3:77 (p. 582)

These are separate reports of an occasion for applying or revealing Q3:77. Al-Bukhārī records both the trader's false claim about an offered price (no. 4551) and al-Ashʿath's dispute over property, in which the opponent could be required to swear (no. 2666). Each report explicitly associates the verse with dishonest acquisition through an oath. Their juxtaposition here does not establish that the episodes happened together or that they are one nar-

rative. The surrounding account of concealment by religious leaders is another application. Across them, the author's common concern is exchanging a binding obligation for worldly gain.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 372; Q3:77; bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, no.4551; bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, no.2666

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T61 · Worldly gain behind scholarly and spiritual appearances

Passage: 3:78 (p. 584)

Al-mashhūr denotes the established predominant position within the juristic tradition under discussion; it is not simply whatever opinion happens to be socially popular. The author qualifies the conduct he condemns by its motive: a worldly benefit received in return. He pairs it with judging by desire and depending on unsound opinions. The allusion then applies the same discrepancy between speech and inward truth to spiritual pretenders who display wisdom without living it. The parallel with "twisting their tongues" in Q3:78 therefore concerns knowingly presenting a self-serving distortion as divine teaching, rather than supplying a general survey of legitimate legal disagreement.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 373; Q3:78

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T62 · Bashar, rabbānī and the readings of "he commands you"

Passage: 3:79–80 (p. 586)

The explanation makes a rabbānī a formative teacher, beginning with knowledge suited to the learner before proceeding to more demanding matters. A close wording appears in al-Bukhārī's Book of Knowledge, in the introductory comments before no. 68. There Ibn ʿAbbās is named for "forbearing, learned in the Law," while the pedagogical definition follows "it is said." That witness therefore confirms the saying's circulation without independently confirming Ibn ʿAjība's precise attribution of the latter wording

to Ibn ʿAbbās. The subsequent comparison with liḥyānī and raqabānī concerns word formation and intensification; it does not add further moral characteristics to the teacher.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 373; Q3:79–80; bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, Kitāb al-ʿIlm, introductory comments before no.68

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T63 · Teaching that directs worship to God rather than the teacher

Passage: 3:79–80 (p. 586)

The alternatives “what you know” and “what you teach” reflect the difference between taʿlamūn and tuʿallimūn, not two unrelated descriptions of rabbānīs. Al-Bayḍāwī explicitly records both readings at Q3:79 (Anwār, II: 25) and connects study and teaching with knowledge of truth and right action. Ibn ʿAjība develops that account through spiritual aspiration and state as well as acquired instruction. The opening prohibition determines their purpose: the recipient of scripture directs people towards God’s service. The reported obituary of Ibn ʿAbbās then uses rabbānī as a title of praise within this educational and devotional sense.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 373; Q3:79–80; baydawi: Anwār al-tanzīl II:25, Q3:79; PageV02P025

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T64 · Honouring the guide without making the intermediary the goal

Passage: 3:79–80 (p. 586)

The gestures named here are kissing (taqbīl) and lowering the head; the preceding reported prohibition at Cairo I:373 concerns prostration (sujūd) before someone other than God. Kissing and lowering the head are therefore distinct in his vocabulary from prostration. His defence of the disciples’ gestures rests on their intended effect within training: diminishing self-importance and preparing an opening. The short verse then expresses that effect through the “slaughter” of the lower selves and clarification of

cups. It is figurative language for discipline and receptivity. The passage presents Ibn ʿAjība's spiritual rationale; it does not supply a comparative discussion of juristic rulings on these practices.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 374; Q3:79–80

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T65 · Honouring the guide without making the intermediary the goal

Passage: 3:79–80 (p. 586)

"[God]" is the object indicated by the repeated statement that veneration is ultimately for God. The quoted instruction contrasts seeing only the teacher's sensible appearance with recognizing what points through him to the divine. "Effacement from seeing" describes the disciple's awareness; it does not describe the teacher's bodily disappearance. The source says only "our shaykh" at this locus, without naming him. A nearby qualification is especially relevant: at Cairo I:377 Ibn ʿAjība permits heightened reverence only while it does not take the shaykh beyond human status or diminish the honour of other saints. That explicit boundary should accompany this passage's interpretation.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 374; Q3:79–80; Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: I:377, allusion on Q3:84

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T66 · Oath, condition and the binding covenant

Passage: 3:81–82 (p. 589)

"Response" here is a grammatical term for the clause completing an oath or condition; it does not mean a spoken reply from the prophets. On the first analysis, the opening lām signals an oath already implicit in taking the covenant, while mā introduces a condition. The emphatic "you shall surely believe" completes the oath and also supplies the consequence required by

that condition. The next analyses instead treat mā as relative, or read the initial lām with kasra to express a reason. These are alternative analyses of the same binding commitment, not successive additional covenants.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 374; Q3:81–82

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T67 · The two forms of yielding and the physician of the heart

Passage: 3:83 (p. 592)

The first-person divine saying is introduced as one of the transmitted āthār. It is not a further verse of Q3:83, and this formula alone does not identify a prophetic chain or establish a hadith grade. Within the argument, “leave the shelter of My heaven” is an impossible challenge: the preceding verse already places all beings within God’s dominion. Its function is to rebuke resistance to divine decree. The author distinguishes that inward disposition from outward fulfilment of commands, then describes the spiritual teacher as a physician of the heart. The medical language continues that moral analogy; it does not identify a bodily illness.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 376; Q3:83

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T68 · The source of spiritual distinction and the possibility of returning

Passage: 3:89 (p. 597)

“In this matter” restricts the lineage metaphor to the special path and its claimed transmission. The language of foundling and father concerns spiritual affiliation, as the earlier analogy of bodily and spiritual offspring also does (Cairo I:350–351). The author then specifies his standard for a guide: effacement followed by subsistence, attraction joined with wayfaring, and intoxication followed by sobriety and completion. The sequence matters; extraordinary gifts alone do not qualify someone to guide others. The final

exception preserves the possibility of return through renewed companionship and conduct, rather than making the exclusion unconditional or irreversible.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 378; Q3:89

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T69 · Several explanations of repentance that is not accepted

Passage: 3:90 (p. 599)

The refusal of repentance in Q3:90 is explained through several alternatives: no effective repentance occurs, repentance is delayed until the death-rattle, or unbelief is still being maintained. These qualifications should remain distinct. Immediately before them, Q3:89 and the account of al-Ḥārith affirm acceptance after repentance and reform; the author also says that some of the remaining group later entered Islam and were accepted. The competing reports about Jews, Christians, or both concern how the verse's stages of unbelief are identified. They do not erase that contextual distinction between actual return and persistence, nor establish one exclusive occasion of revelation.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 379; Q3:90

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T70 · Returning before an acquired habit becomes entrenched

Passage: 3:90 (p. 599)

The quoted al-Qushayrī passage is located in Laṭāʾif I:258 on Q3:91, although Ibn ʿAjība places it in the allusion on Q3:90. The glossator's "perhaps" then proposes a connection with Abraham's encounter with his father; it does not identify al-Qushayrī's stated source. Al-Bukhārī's report no. 3350 uses dhīkh multaṭṭikh, without the gloss "pig." That gloss belongs to the quoted commentator, while the Cairo editor explains dhīkh as a male

hyena (I:379,n.1). Accordingly, “the authentic report” refers to the Abraham narrative, and must not silently authenticate the animal gloss or the proposed explanation of al-Qushayrī’s imagery.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999: Volume I, printed p. 379; Q3:90; qushayri_tafsir: Laṭāʾif al-ishārāt I:258, Q3:91; PageV01P258; bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī, no.3350; Cairo editor’s footnote: Cairo I:379,n.1

Scope: The stated textual or interpretive distinction does not independently authenticate every report in the surrounding passage.

T71 · The ransom question and its explanatory gloss

Passage: 3:91 (p. 601)

The report’s counterfactual asks what the unbeliever would offer after death; it does not describe an offer that could still be accepted. Al-Bukhārī, no. 6538, preserves the earthful-of-gold question and the reply that something easier had been required. His wording ends there. Ibn ʿAjība’s identification of that easier demand with the confession of divine unity, followed by his prayer for steadfastness, belongs to the commentary’s explanatory voice. ‘He means’ introduces Ibn ʿAjība’s explanation, and the prayer is likewise his own. This distinction also preserves the verse’s contrast between present response and a belated ransom.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:380; Q3:91; XIV-OT-bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.6538

Scope: The Bukhārī parallel supports the report’s core, not the added explanatory identification as quoted Prophetic speech.

T72 · Loss of proximity within Paradise

Passage: 3:91 (p. 601)

The spiritual allusion changes the object of the unsuccessful ransom. In the outward exposition it concerns deliverance from punishment; here it concerns attaining the rank of those brought near. Ibn ʿAjība explicitly places the person being admonished among ordinary Muslims in Paradise. Consequently, ‘the grief of the veil’ and ‘the pain of separation’ describe deprivation of a higher degree of witnessing within his account of spiritual

ranks. They do not denote expulsion from Paradise or an unqualified judgment of unbelief. The repeated gold image carries the warning across the two levels without making their destinies identical.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:380; Q3:91

Scope: An explanation of the author's spiritual analogy, not a separate proof of the described afterlife hierarchy.

T73 · Rābiḥ and rāʾiḥ in the Bayruḥāʾ report

Passage: 3:92 (p. 603)

Al-Bukhārī, no. 1461, preserves Abū Ṭalḥa's gift and expressly records the variant rāʾiḥ alongside rābiḥ. The latter means profitable; the former belongs to the vocabulary of going or departure. These are alternative transmitted wordings, not two different properties or successive evaluations of the gift. Ibn ʿAjība's account uses the report to show that spending what one loves can include giving to relatives. The Prophet's direction determines the beneficiaries while Abū Ṭalḥa relinquishes the cherished property. The parenthetic identification and location of the garden are explanatory material and should not be absorbed into the quoted dialogue.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:381; Q3:92; XIV-OT-bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.1461

Scope: The primary parallel verifies the core and the recorded lexical variant; it does not validate every topographical gloss in Cairo.

T74 · Personal preference as the measure of the gift

Passage: 3:92 (p. 603)

The two anecdotes illustrate 'what you love' by identifying an attachment specific to the giver. Ibn ʿUmar's proposed marriage is framed as something he declines because he considers it a return to a benefit already relinquished for God. The text does not say that emancipation itself prevents a subsequent marriage. Al-Rabīʿ's explanation about sugar likewise makes the giver's preference decisive: the example does not establish sugar as an in-

trinsically superior alms. Both stories extend the verse beyond the monetary value of the gift to the act of parting with something cherished. Their individual speakers and explanations should remain distinct.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:381; Q3:92

Scope: The note explains the transmitted anecdotes' argument; it does not supply independent historical authentication or a general marriage ruling.

T75 · Giving the self and the vocabulary of attachment

Passage: 3:92 (p. 603)

Ibn ʿAjība moves from spending cherished possessions to relinquishing attachment to the self. The shifts among nafs, rūḥ and the poetry of giving one's life carry distinct emphases. The shaykh passage gives this generosity a disciplinary form: the disciple submits personal preference to direction in spiritual training. The following love poetry and al-Qurashī's definition then express the same relinquishment through the language of the beloved. These are related illustrations, not a single quotation. The author's culminating argument is that whoever gives what is dearest will more readily give lesser things.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:381,382; Q3:92

Scope: Describes the argument and terminology of this passage without authenticating the attributed sayings or adding conditions absent from it.

T76 · Israel's personal abstention and later prohibition

Passage: 3:93–95 (p. 605)

'Israel' is Jacob in this exposition, while 'the Children of Israel' denotes his descendants. The distinction matters because the exception is what he forbade to himself, not a prohibition originally addressed to the whole community. Ibn ʿAjība offers two explanations of his abstention: a vow connected with recovery from illness, and dietary treatment advised by physicians. These alternatives should remain introduced as alternatives. The subsequent sentence distinguishes the descendants' continued abstention from restrictions associated with the later revelation of the Torah. The pas-

sage's chronological argument would be lost if personal renunciation, inherited practice and revealed prohibition were all rendered simply as 'forbidden food.'

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:382; Q3:93–95

Scope: The narrative explanations are preserved as the commentator's alternatives; no medical or historical conclusion is inferred.

T77 · The challenge to produce the Torah

Passage: 3:93–95 (p. 605)

The command to bring and recite the Torah functions here as a demand for documentary support for a particular asserted prohibition. 'After that' refers to the clarification and argument just presented, which explains why the following accusation concerns persistence after the claim has been challenged. Ibn ʿAjība's report that his opponents declined the challenge is a narrative addition to the verse's imperative, not wording contained in the Qurʾān. The scriptural challenge, the reported response and the commentator's resulting accusation are separate voices. This also preserves the logical connection between the earlier personal abstention and the contested claim of an original universal ban.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:382,383; Q3:93–95

Scope: The note analyses the argument's structure; it does not treat the reported encounter as independently verified.

T78 · Reconciliation with the self remains qualified

Passage: 3:93–95 (p. 605)

The concluding instruction to agree with the self must be read with the beginning of this same allusion: the advanced knower takes and spends 'in conformity with the revealed Law.' The passage distinguishes a beginner whose desires interrupt the journey from one whose self has submitted to the witnessing of its Lord. 'What becomes manifest within it' refers back to that transformed self, not to appetite considered without qualification. Ibn ʿAjība therefore presents opposition and reconciliation as different discip-

lines for different states. Keeping the earlier qualification visible prevents the final sentence from appearing to reverse the passage's express requirement of conformity to the Law.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:383; Q3:93–95

Scope: The qualification belongs to the immediate context of the author's own allusion.

T79 · Two explanations of Bakkah

Passage: 3:96–97 (p. 608)

The opening account presents two distinct approaches to the place-name. One treats Bakkah and Makkah as forms related by a consonantal interchange; the examples involving a blow and a fever illustrate that linguistic claim. The other distinguishes the name of the whole settlement from the name of the House's location. The subsequent derivation from a verb meaning to crush explains the name through the humbling of tyrants. These are transmitted lexical and explanatory proposals, not steps in a single demonstrated etymology. 'It is also said' marks their alternative status and the shift from linguistic comparison to a narrative explanation.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:383; Q3:96–97

Scope: The note does not independently establish the historical etymology or the universality of the associated claim about tyrants.

T80 · A singular Station among plural signs

Passage: 3:96–97 (p. 608)

The grammatical problem is the relation of the singular 'Station of Abraham' to the plural 'clear signs.' Ibn ʿAjība records three solutions: an independent subject with an omitted predicate, a part standing for a larger set, or an explanatory apposition. The last becomes possible because several distinct wonders are understood to be contained in the one Station. The singular variant 'a sign' supports another way of construing the expression; it is distinct from the plural form printed here. Similarly, the analysis of mubārakan supplies an implied location or establishment as governor; the accusative marks a state of the House, not a new object.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:383,384; Q3:96–97

Scope: A grammatical account of the supplied analyses; the note does not authenticate the reported physical wonders or establish the status of the singular reading.

T81 · The forty-year interval and construction narratives

Passage: 3:96–97 (p. 608)

Al-Bukhārī, no. 3366, records Abū Dharr's question about the first mosque placed on earth, the answer naming the Sacred Mosque and then the Farthest Mosque, and the interval of forty years. That report does not itself name angels or Adam as their builders. Ibn ʿAjība combines the interval with further construction traditions and distinguishes an initial building from Abraham's renewal. These layers must remain separate: confirming the interval's hadith source does not confirm all the accompanying chronology. The later list of signs likewise gathers several explanations under the verse rather than presenting them as parts of the same Prophetic report.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:384; Q3:96–97; XIV-OT-bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.3366

Scope: Only the forty-year core is matched to the inspected Bukhārī report; construction agents and the wider marvel catalogue retain their separate evidentiary status.

T82 · Security and the competing legal readings

Passage: 3:96–97 (p. 608)

The verse's promise of security receives both a devotional explanation and a discussion of sanctuary law. Ibn ʿAjība first relates it to protection in the two abodes, then contrasts a position allowing the enforcement of prescribed penalties with the position he attributes to Abū Ḥanīfa. In the latter, protection within the sanctuary does not cancel the underlying liability: pressure is used to induce departure. Thus 'safe' cannot be rendered as a uniform immunity that all the cited jurists accept. The words ḥudūd and qiṣāṣ also remain distinct, identifying prescribed penalties and retaliation rather than two synonyms for punishment.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:384; Q3:96–97

Scope: This is a presentation of the positions reported in the historical commentary, not a current legal determination.

T83 · Two reports, two evidentiary scopes

Passage: 3:96–97 (p. 608)

The sentence about dying in either sanctuary and the sentence about a pilgrimage free of misconduct are separate reports. Al-Bukhārī, nos. 1521 and 1819, supplies a close primary parallel for the second: returning like the

day one's mother gave birth to one. That comparison expresses release from sins, not literal rebirth. Its wording should not be used to authenticate the preceding promise about burial or death in the two sanctuaries. Within the second report, rafath and fisq name distinct forms of misconduct, rather than an undifferentiated condition of 'a good pilgrimage.'

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:384; Q3:96–97; XIV-OT-bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ, nos.1521 and1819

Scope: The inspected canonical parallel concerns the pilgrimage report only; the preceding sanctuary-death report is not independently authenticated by this note.

T84 · Denial of obligation and intensified warning

Passage: 3:96–97 (p. 608)

Ibn ʿAjība offers two explanations of 'whoever disbelieves.' One concerns rejecting pilgrimage and its obligation; the other treats the vocabulary of unbelief as an intensified warning about abandoning it. The second explanation is introduced as an alternative, not as a statement that every failure to perform pilgrimage has already been adjudged doctrinal unbelief. God's independence then answers both readings: human refusal does not diminish Him. The account of the religious communities responding differently to the command is an occasion narrative added by the commentary. Its reported numbers should not be confused with the verse's general address to those able to make the journey.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:384; Q3:96–97

Scope: Preserves the author's distinction between interpretations without supplying an independent legal judgment or authentication of the occasion narrative.

T85 · The heart as a house of divine remembrance

Passage: 3:96–97 (p. 608)

The House, its inhabitant, circumambulation and visitors form an extended image of the heart filled by divine light and knowledge. The contrast is explicitly between the sensible House and an inward one. A useful earlier comparison occurs in al-Qushayrī's Risāla, II:377, where language about God dwelling in the believer's heart is explained as the abiding of His remembrance, with physical indwelling denied. That explanation clarifies the

vocabulary's possible spiritual use; it is not a direct gloss quoted by Ibn ʿAjība here. The present allusion's own visitors are spiritual influxes and lights, which sustain its inward register throughout.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:385; Q3:96–97; XIV-OT-qushayri_risala: Al-Risāla, II:377, chapter on remembrance

Scope: The Risāla supplies a comparative explanation, not proof that this precise Baḥr passage derives from it or that sākin has a different reading here.

T86 · Two endings for two forms of opposition

Passage: 3:98–99 (p. 613)

The paragraph explains why the repeated address does not simply repeat the same rebuke. The first accusation concerns disbelief openly professed; its ending emphasizes divine witnessing. The second concerns efforts to obstruct believers through concealment and contrivance; its ending denies divine heedlessness. The distinction is rhetorical, not a division between matters God knows and matters He does not yet know. Ibn ʿAjība attributes this explanation to al-Bayḍāwī. 'Each offence is reprehensible in itself' accordingly explains the repeated address as independent censure, while the paired endings show how each censure is fitted to the manner of conduct being described.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:386; Q3:98–99

Scope: The source attribution is reported by Ibn ʿAjība; this note's argument is restricted to the quoted explanation and its immediate context.

T87 · A particular occasion and a general address

Passage: 3:100–102 (p. 615)

The opening sentence explicitly distinguishes the general wording of 'O you who believe' from the particular Aws and Khazraj group identified in the occasion narrative. The account then explains the threatened return to unbelief through renewed bloodshed and revived pre-Islamic factionalism. It should not be paraphrased as an unexplained change of abstract doctrine. The Prophet's intervention, the abandonment of weapons and the restored embrace form the narrative reversal that prepares the next verse's emphas-

is on the Messenger's presence. Names, battlefield memories and dialogue belong to the transmitted occasion account; the general exhortation extends beyond those narrative particulars.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:386,387; Q3:100–102

Scope: No chain assessment of the detailed occasion narrative is supplied; its function and quoted voices are distinguished from the verse.

T88 · Two accounts of the relation to Q64:16

Passage: 3:100–102 (p. 615)

The outward exposition reports abrogation, then gives a non-abrogating interpretation; the spiritual allusion assigns the two commands to differing capacities or inward and outward disciplines. These positions must remain distinct. The threefold explanation of 'His true due' also has an earlier attribution to Ibn Masʿūd in al-Ṭabarī, VII:64–66, reports 7536 onward. That Companion-level parallel does not by itself establish Cairo's attribution of the fuller wording to the Prophet. The note therefore separates the saying's transmission from the exegetical question of abrogation. Ibn ʿAjība's own allusive resolution is that each command retains an appropriate field of application.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:387,388; Q3:100–102; XIV-OT-tabari: Jāmiʿ al-bayān, VII:64–66, reports7536 onward

Scope: The Ṭabarī parallel is a reported Companion explanation; it neither authenticates Cairo's Prophetic form nor proves either abrogation theory.

T89 · God's rope and the first sect report

Passage: 3:103 (p. 619)

The rope image identifies a means of connection and protection, which allows the commentator to explain it through faith or the Qurʾān. 'All together' then specifies the manner of holding fast, while the prohibition on division states its communal consequence. Two report units occur in this passage: praise of the Qurʾān and a division-of-sects saying. The latter gives seventy-one for the Children of Israel and seventy-two for this community,

with ‘the community’ as the answer. These details belong to this occurrence and must remain distinguishable from the different numbers and answer quoted at Q3:105, where Ibn ʿAjība himself compares the versions.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:388; Q3:103

Scope: Textual comparison between the two Cairo occurrences; no independent authentication of either complete report is inferred.

T90 · Brotherhood as command and narrated transformation

Passage: 3:103 (p. 619)

The prohibition of envy, hatred and abandonment supplies the ethical content of the verse’s movement from enmity to brotherhood. Muslim, no. 2564, preserves the closely corresponding sequence, including the statement that a Muslim neither wrongs nor abandons his brother. The commentary then moves to a separate historical explanation involving Aws and Khazraj, and finally to the Bedouin’s inference from rescue from the Fire. These are three different kinds of material: Prophetic exhortation, an occasion narrative and a reader’s theological inference. The canonical parallel for the first should not extend its authority automatically to the genealogy, duration of warfare or later exchange.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:388,389; Q3:103; XIV-OT-muslim: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.2564

Scope: The inspected Muslim report supports the ethical saying only; the historical and exegetical additions retain separate scope.

T91 · Concord in the goal and variety in the way

Passage: 3:103 (p. 619)

Ibn ʿAjība’s claim of Sufi agreement is immediately qualified by his admission of different ways of reaching the aim. The agreement he asserts therefore concerns the journey’s governing pattern and consummation, not identical practices or a complete absence of disagreement. ‘Tasting’ and ‘unveiling’ describe the mode of assurance claimed for this inward knowledge, contrasted here with probabilistic inquiry. The application of Q15:47 to a ‘Paradise of gnoses’ then turns the scriptural removal of rancour into

an account of present spiritual fellowship. These are the author's explanations of the path's ideal unity, rather than a documented survey of all historical Sufi groups.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:389; Q3:103

Scope: Explains the qualification within the author's argument; no universal historical consensus is independently established.

T92 · Partitive min and a shared responsibility

Passage: 3:104 (p. 622)

The two analyses of min produce different grammatical descriptions of the addressees: a group from within the community, or the community characterized by the following duty. The subsequent discussion connects the partitive analysis with qualifications for carrying out moral intervention. A collective obligation is still addressed to the community; performance by a sufficient qualified portion discharges the remainder. It is not merely an optional task for whoever happens to volunteer. The coordination of enjoining and forbidding after calling to good adds a second grammatical point: particular forms of the broader good are singled out for their importance, without exhausting its scope.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:389,390; Q3:104

Scope: Exposition of the historical commentary's grammatical and legal reasoning; not a determination of how the duty applies in a present case.

T93 · The voices within the moral-exhortation collection

Passage: 3:104 (p. 622)

This paragraph gathers several attributed sayings rather than developing one continuous Prophetic address. The first two are introduced as words of the Prophet; the subsequent speakers are ʿAlī, Abū al-Dardāʾ and Ḥudhayfa. Their change of voice should remain explicit. The expression 'vicegerent of His Book' extends the preceding claim of acting in service of God and His Messenger; in this context it describes responsibility for upholding the

Book's injunctions. It does not itself narrate appointment to a political office. The sequence moves from praise of moral action to warnings about neglect and hostility toward those who undertake it.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:390; Q3:104

Scope: The note identifies voice and scope, not the authenticity of the individual reports; no general authorization for coercive action is inferred.

T94 · Two duties that remain logically distinct

Passage: 3:104 (p. 622)

The argument rests on two obligations: refraining from the wrong oneself and opposing it in the appropriate way. Failure in the first does not logically cancel the second. Ibn ʿAjība also distinguishes forbidden conduct from what is merely disliked, so the technical term munkar should not erase that legal differentiation. Al-Ghazālī's Iḥyāʾ, II:334, contains the corresponding exhortation to enjoin good despite incomplete practice and explains that visible wrongdoing weakens the speaker's effect on hearts. That context distinguishes validity of the duty from effectiveness of admonition. The quotation's occurrence in the Iḥyāʾ supplies a literary parallel, not an independent grading of its chain.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:390; Q3:104; XIV-OT-ihya: Iḥyāʾ ʿulūm al-dīn, II:334

Scope: No hadith authentication or present-day legal ruling follows from the literary parallel.

T95 · Maʿrūf's prayer and the narrative ending

Passage: 3:104 (p. 622)

The point of Maʿrūf's prayer is the relation between happiness in the Hereafter and repentance: he redirects a request for harm toward a request for the revellers' ultimate good. In the Iḥyāʾ, IV:154–155, the boat anecdote ends with his explanation that making them happy in the Hereafter entails turning toward them in repentance. Ibn ʿAjība's version states that all repented through him. These endings are related but not identical: an explanation of

the prayer's intention should not be silently treated as an eyewitness report of its outcome. The comparison helps preserve both the compassionate logic and the precise scope of the transmitted narrative.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:390,391; Q3:104; XIV-OT-ihya: Iḥyāʾ ʿulūm al-dīn, IV:154–155

Scope: The literary parallel has been located; the different ending prevents using it as full confirmation of Cairo's reported outcome.

T96 · A comparative judgment about two sect traditions

Passage: 3:105–109 (p. 625)

'This version is sounder' is Ibn ʿAjība's comparative judgment, followed by his proposed explanation of the earlier wording through transmission by meaning and possible omission. It should not be rewritten as an independent modern authentication. Al-Tirmidhī, no. 2641, contains the answer 'what I and my Companions are upon,' with seventy-two groups for the Children of Israel and seventy-three for this community. Cairo's fuller enumeration separately names Jews and Christians. The parallel therefore supports the distinctive answer and part of the count, while leaving a difference in formulation. Preserving both Cairo occurrences allows the reader to see the comparison that prompted the author's remark.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:391; Q3:105–109; XIV-OT-tirmidhi: Al-Jāmiʿ, no.2641, V:25–26

Scope: Al-Tirmidhī's own characterization and the detailed chains require their own assessment; the note records a textual parallel and the author's voice.

T97 · Disagreement and the reward for legal effort

Passage: 3:105–109 (p. 625)

Two distinct sayings support the author's distinction between fundamentals and derivative questions. The report of one or two rewards is independently identifiable in al-Bukhārī, no. 7352, where it concerns a judge who exercises legal effort and either errs or reaches the right judgment. Its subject is disciplined adjudication, not every disagreement or unsupported opinion. The maxim 'Disagreement within my community is a mercy' is a separate citation and does not acquire the other report's source status merely by

standing beside it. Keeping the two apart preserves both the author's argument for legitimate difference and the narrower wording of the identifiable Prophetic report.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:391; Q3:105–109; XIV-OT-bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.7352

Scope: The Bukhārī reference applies to the reward report only; it does not authenticate the adjacent maxim.

T98 · Radiance, gloom and alternative readings

Passage: 3:105–109 (p. 625)

The commentary first identifies several possible groups represented by the contrasting faces, then offers two accounts of the imagery itself. On the metonymic reading, whiteness and blackness make joy and fear visible; on the other, the people concerned receive distinguishing signs in the resurrection. These alternatives concern how the passage represents judgment, not two successive changes in a person's complexion. These accounts differ on the relation of inward condition and outward manifestation; literal marking is introduced as another interpretation. The subsequent spiritual allusion develops yet another relative contrast between the lights of faith and spiritual excellence.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:391,392; Q3:105–109

Scope: An account of the alternatives transmitted in the passage, not independent verification of eschatological marks.

T99 · Ownership and the commentary's account of justice

Passage: 3:105–109 (p. 625)

The explanation moves from the denial of injustice to God's ownership of all things and the return of all affairs to Him. Its reasoning does not merely claim that a hidden human standard of fairness has been satisfied; it rejects the premise that an obligation can be imposed upon God from outside His sovereign will. At the same time, the paragraph expressly refers to recom-

pense according to His promise and warning. Both parts belong to the argument. The citation of Q21:23 reinforces the asymmetry between the divine disposer and the creatures who are answerable for their acts.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:392; Q3:105–109

Scope: Explains the theological reasoning present in Cairo without claiming an independent adjudication of competing schools of theology.

T100 · A relative contrast between two lights

Passage: 3:105–109 (p. 625)

The crucial qualification is that the faces described as dark may nevertheless be bright with the light of faith. Their darkness is relative to the greater light attributed to the knowers. The allusion consequently distinguishes loss of spiritual excellence from simple absence of faith. ‘Did you disbelieve in special distinction in your own time?’ also identifies the object of denial: recognition of the living people of the path. The accusation concerns this specified denial, not unbelief without qualification. The punishment of separation is likewise defined here through deprivation of continual witnessing, corresponding to the inward scale of the passage.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:392; Q3:105–109

Scope: A reading of the author’s explicitly relative comparison; it does not turn his spiritual polemic into an independent judgment about particular people.

T101 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 3:110–112 (p. 628)

Cairo I:393 · The Companions’ works. Ruslān cites Ibn Ḥajar’s comparison of the Companions’ distinctive excellence with later people’s deeds in the discussion of the “best community.” This cited scholarly qualification belongs to the Cairo editor’s footnote and is distinct from the reports Ibn ʿAjība quotes in the main text. The precise Fatḥ al-Bārī passage has not been independently verified in full.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:393; Ruslān’s editorial footnote.

T102 · Entry into Paradise and the separate ransom report

Passage: 3:110–112 (p. 628)

The paragraph contains separate reports about precedence in entering Paradise and release from the Fire. Muslim, no. 2767, provides a parallel for the latter, using fikāk, release or ransom, and specifying a Jew or Christian where Cairo's version says another man. The opening phrase 'a community shown mercy' is not part of Muslim's wording. These differences should remain visible when the report is cited. The metaphor describes deliverance in the report's own eschatological setting; the text does not describe a payment made by the believer. Locating the ransom passage therefore supplies a bounded source for one report, not for every statement in this praise collection.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:393; Q3:110–112; XIV-OT-muslim: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.2767

Scope: The source parallel is limited to the release report and differs in wording; the first report and prefatory phrase are not authenticated by this citation.

T103 · Prayer toward a tree and recognition of al-Khiḍr

Passage: 3:110–112 (p. 628)

The phrase 'praying toward a tree' marks the direction of the man's prayer; it does not say that the tree is its object of worship. Recognition of the speaker as al-Khiḍr occurs through his later self-identification in the reported exchange, not through Anas's initial observation. The repeated descriptions of Muḥammad's community form the man's petition and should remain within his speech. The following account about Jesus is another attributed exchange, not a continuation of the same encounter. Distinguishing those voices preserves the collection's structure and prevents its repeated praise of the community from being mistaken for one uninterrupted Prophetic statement.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:393; Q3:110–112

Scope: The note resolves syntax and narrative voice; it does not establish the encounter's historicity or the report's chain.

T104 · Later believers, reward and distinct report forms

Passage: 3:110–112 (p. 628)

Ibn ʿAjība distinguishes the reward of a deed from the performer's overall rank in certainty and knowledge of God. That distinction governs his reconciliation of praise for later believers with the Companions' precedence. The rain comparison occurs in al-Tirmidhī, no. 2869. The longer brotherhood passage is separately quoted with the author's qualification 'or words to that effect.' A relevant reward tradition in Abū Dāwūd, no. 4341, gives fifty, not Cairo's seventy, and has a different setting. It is a variant parallel; it does not establish Cairo's number or authenticate the longer combination of sayings.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:393; Q3:110–112; XIV-OT-tirmidhi: Al-Jāmiʿ, no.2869, V:151–152; XIV-OT-abu_dawud: Sunan, no.4341

Scope: Neither the rain report nor the fifty-rewards tradition verifies Cairo's entire longer quotation as one continuous report.

T105 · The Iḥyāʾ ranking in its wider context

Passage: 3:110–112 (p. 628)

Al-Ghazālī's corresponding discussion in the Iḥyāʾ, I:52–53, ranks prophets, friends of God, firmly grounded scholars and the righteous while explaining the aims of learning. Its surrounding argument explicitly warns against despising other useful sciences merely because they stand below the highest rank. Ibn ʿAjība extracts the ranking to support the precedence of knowledge of God over knowledge of legal rulings. The wider context thus preserves a hierarchy without turning it into a dismissal of legal scholarship. The subsequent statement attributed to Ibn Rushd through al-Miʿyār is a separate cited judgment; it should not be folded into al-Ghazālī's quotation.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:394; Q3:110–112; XIV-OT-ihya: Iḥyāʾ ʿulūm al-dīn, I:52–53

Scope: The Ibn Rushd/al-Miʿyār transmission remains an attribution reported by Ibn ʿAjība; the Iḥyāʾ parallel does not verify it.

T106 · The protective covenant in the verse's imagery

Passage: 3:110–112 (p. 628)

The two 'cords' are interpreted as binding covenants that secure protection. In the first, Ibn ʿAjība identifies the prescribed dhimma arrangement and explicitly states its consequence: property, life and family are protected against attack. The second extends the covenant image to protection granted by other human authorities. The preceding tent and coin comparisons explain two possible senses of something being 'laid upon' or 'struck upon' a person. They are alternative images for the persistence of the condition described. The paragraph combines historical polemic with a precise statement of covenantal protection; neither element should disappear through a loose paraphrase of the other.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:395; Q3:110–112

Scope: Records the author's historical exposition and legal vocabulary; it does not present his generalizations as independently verified facts or current legal advice.

T107 · First-person testimony and a differently worded divine saying

Passage: 3:110–112 (p. 628)

The shift to 'I say' introduces Ibn ʿAjība's own testimony about threats of beating, denunciation to the ruler and exile. It should not become a continuation of the Qurʾānic address or of an earlier authority's words. The paragraph also qualifies protection by admitting that other Sufis suffered visible injury. Its concluding divine saying resembles al-Bukhārī, no. 6502, but Cairo's adhina bi-l-ḥarb differs from Bukhārī's first-person ādhantuhu bi-l-ḥarb. The two Arabic constructions differ; the canonical parallel does not establish a first-person verb in the Cairo text at this locus.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:396; Q3:110–112; XIV-OT-bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.6502

Scope: The Bukhārī source does not verify the author's autobiographical claims or remove the local textual difference.

T108 · Kafara with the sense of withholding recompense

Passage: 3:113–115 (p. 635)

The verb is explained here through semantic inclusion: kafara carries the sense of depriving or withholding and takes the construction appropriate to that meaning. The promise is consequently that good will not be denied its

recompense, rather than a prediction that the people addressed will cease to disbelieve. The following exposition confirms this by pairing denial with recognition and reward. ‘You’ represents the persons concerned, while the pronoun ‘it’ points back to the good performed or its recompense. The account of the two objects concerns the underlying construction; the passive construction means ‘you shall not be deprived of it.’

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:396,397; Q3:113–115

Scope: The alternative singular forms for ānāʾ are reported by the commentary; their historical derivation is not independently established.

T109 · Night prayer and the scope of its supporting report

Passage: 3:113–115 (p. 635)

The commentary gives several senses of an ‘upright’ community and then offers night prayer as a particular explanation of the nocturnal worship. Al-Bukhārī, no. 567, reports a delayed ʿishāʾ prayer and the reassurance that no one else was praying at that hour. The scene concerns a particular occasion and audience. Its wording should not be expanded into a historical claim that no other religious community ever prayed at night. Ibn ʿAjība’s broader contrast and identification of the praised group belong to his exegesis. The report supports the night-prayer illustration while remaining distinct from the commentator’s general characterization of other groups.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:397; Q3:113–115; XIV-OT-bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.567

Scope: The Bukhārī parallel verifies the particular prayer report’s core, not the full comparative polemic or exclusive identification of the verse’s referents.

T110 · What wealth and children cannot do

Passage: 3:116 (p. 637)

The verb translated ‘avail’ concerns their inability to provide protection or benefit against the judgment described. It does not say that wealth and children have no value in every setting. The explanatory addition ‘against God’s punishment’ makes the relation expressed by min Allāh intelligible in this context. Ibn ʿAjība then explains ‘companions of the Fire’ through inseparability: companionship supplies an image of remaining constantly with something, while the following clause makes duration explicit. The

preceding passage had promised that good would not be denied its reward; the contrast here turns on the stated condition of disbelief, not on possession or parenthood as such.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:397,398; Q3:116

Scope: A lexical and contextual account of the verse as expounded here; no additional judgment about individuals is supplied.

T111 · Making the terms of the wind comparison explicit

Passage: 3:117 (p. 639)

Without the supplied terms, the wording appears to compare expenditure directly with a wind. Ibn ʿAjība makes the parallel explicit by adding loss or destruction on both sides: the wasting of expenditure resembles the ruin produced by the wind. Al-Bayḍāwī, II:33–34, discusses the same difficulty as a composite comparison and permits an understood object destroyed by the wind. Both analyses make explicit the terms understood in the comparison. Cairo also preserves different explanations of ṣirr. Piercing cold is the one developed in the subsequent exposition; the alternatives should not be silently combined into a single meteorological description.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:398; Q3:117; XIV-OT-baydawi: Anwār al-tanzīl, II:33–34, Q3:117

Scope: The Bayḍāwī comparison is related but not identical to Cairo's particular supplied wording; lexical alternatives are reported, not physically explained.

T112 · Expenditure, crops and the pronouns of destruction

Passage: 3:117 (p. 639)

The list of expenditures supplies alternative applications of the comparison: offerings, ostentatious spending and support directed toward religious authorities. The unifying feature in the commentator's argument is their eventual lack of benefit, not the identity of their recipients. Ḥarth denotes cultivated growth here, which explains why the wind can destroy it and leave a bare surface. The final denial of injustice refers back to the persons whose conduct, in the exposition's account, makes their efforts fruitless.

Preserving the distinction between the expenditure, the crop that illustrates it and the people responsible keeps the pronouns from turning the simile into a literal account of one particular storm.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:398; Q3:117

Scope: The note analyses the commentator's chosen applications; it does not authenticate a specific historical expenditure or storm.

T113 · A jussive that retains a final vowel

Passage: 3:118–120 (p. 640)

The conditional sequence explains why lā yaḍurrukum is analysed as jussive despite the audible final ḍamma in the assimilated form. Ibn ʿAjība derives it from the unassimilated pair of rāʾ consonants and explains the remaining vowel through phonetic agreement with the preceding ḍamma. The vowel is therefore not taken as evidence that the verb has escaped the conditional construction. This discussion should also remain distinct from the preceding statement that ḍayr and ḍurr share a meaning: lexical equivalence does not make their conjugations identical. Earlier in the paragraph, mā in mā ʿanittum converts a clause into the sense of 'your hardship.'

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:399; Q3:118–120

Scope: The analysis explains the morphology and syntax stated in Cairo; it does not establish a different Qurʾānic reading.

T114 · Biṭāna as privileged access to inner affairs

Passage: 3:118–120 (p. 640)

The garment image explains why biṭāna is stronger than an unspecified acquaintance. Ibn ʿAjība defines the people concerned through access to secrets and internal vulnerabilities, and the ensuing description makes concealed hostility central to the warning. The two occasion accounts identify different possible groups and should remain alternatives. The later command about dying in rage likewise belongs to the passage's reported re-

buke, not to a change in the lexical meaning of biṭāna. ‘Intimate confidants’ expresses the connection between the inner lining, knowledge of concealed affairs and the danger of disclosing those affairs to adversaries.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:399; Q3:118–120

Scope: A contextual lexical explanation; the note does not turn either occasion report into an independently established historical setting.

T115 · What the allusion asks the disciple to guard against

Passage: 3:118–120 (p. 640)

The allusion transfers the outward warning about confidants to disclosure of spiritual secrets. Its closing instruction adds a specifically inward object to Godfearingness: witnessing ‘otherness’ in those who cause harm. This concerns how the disciple understands the encounter within divine agency, not a claim that hostility was never expressed. The paired benefits and ordeals are likewise interpreted through the vocabulary of spiritual opening, witnessing and knowledge. The conclusion combines patience toward other people with vigilance over one’s own perception. That combination should remain visible, rather than reducing the instruction to mere secrecy or to a promise that no painful event can occur.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:400,401; Q3:118–120

Scope: An interpretation of the immediate allusive context; no unqualified immunity from physical harm is inferred.

T116 · Counsel before Uḥud and the subsequent decision

Passage: 3:121–122 (p. 644)

The argument for remaining inside Madīna is presented as counsel within the narrative, even though Ibn ʿAjība identifies Ibn Ubayy among its advocates. The Prophet’s initial approval concerns that tactical proposal. The following paragraph then supplies competing counsel and the decision to march out. The initial approval is distinct from the final decision to march; the adviser’s particular proposal is also distinct from the commentator’s assessment of his character. The conditional alternatives—enemy remaining

outside, entering the town or withdrawing—are the structure of the defensive argument. They should be kept parallel, with each consequence attached to its own condition.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:401; Q3:121–122

Scope: Explains the transmitted consultation's logic and voices; the detailed event chronology is not independently authenticated by this note.

T117 · The dream's images and their interpretations

Passage: 3:121–122 (p. 644)

The narrative alternates between images seen in a dream and the meanings assigned to them: slaughtered cattle, a damaged sword and protective armour. Dhubāb al-sayf denotes the sword's point here, not a fly; the defect belongs to that part of the weapon. Muslim, no. 2272, contains a related dream of a sword's broken forepart and cattle interpreted through the losses at Uḥud, but its sequence and wording differ and it does not supply this entire consultation speech. The comparison supports the dream motifs while leaving Cairo's precise arrangement, armour image and ensuing exchange as separately transmitted material.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:401,402; Q3:121–122; XIV-OT-muslim: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.2272

Scope: The Muslim parallel is partial; it is not full authentication of every image and sentence in Cairo's combined narrative.

T118 · An intention interrupted by divine protection

Passage: 3:121–122 (p. 644)

Hammat describes the two groups' movement toward losing heart, while the continuation records that they remained with the Prophet. The verse's wording therefore should not be expanded into a claim that both actually withdrew. Jābir's apparently surprising pleasure in the verse is explained by its declaration that God was their Protector. Al-Bukhārī, no. 4558, preserves his naming of Banū Ḥāritha and Banū Salama and that very reason for welcoming the verse. The source supports this compact identification

and interpretation. It does not automatically authenticate every preceding detail about the withdrawal, its location or the number who accompanied Ibn Ubayy.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:402; Q3:121–122; XIV-OT-bukhari: Ṣaḥīḥ, no.4558

Scope: The canonical parallel applies to Jābir's comment and the two groups; the longer surrounding battle account has a wider scope.

T119 · The circumstantial force of 'while you were humbled'

Passage: 3:123 (p. 648)

The clause 'while you were humbled' describes the believers' condition when help came to them; it is not the object of the verb 'He helped you.' The reference to the pronoun -kum identifies the people whose state the clause supplies. The subsequent exposition explains that condition through small numbers and inadequate equipment, so 'humbled' or 'weak' belongs to the contrast with the superior force faced at Badr. The place-name story is a separate explanation of the location's name, not a grammatical premise for that contrast. Its reported derivation should not be mistaken for proof that the verse itself names an individual owner.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:403; Q3:123

Scope: The note explains the syntax and immediate sense; the named-owner etymology is not independently established.

T120 · Human attributes and the corresponding divine gift

Passage: 3:123 (p. 648)

The saying about realizing one's attributes depends on the paired examples before it. The attributes to recognize are poverty, weakness, lowliness and need; the aid sought is enrichment, strength and elevation from God. The grammatical contrast is between 'your' attributes and 'His'. It does not instruct the disciple to claim the divine attributes as self-sufficient possessions. In the surrounding allusion, victory at Badr supplies the scriptural example of assistance arriving amid acknowledged weakness. 'Seeking

things in their opposites' describes that spiritual discipline, while the final command to give thanks returns the argument to reception of a gift rather than self-generated achievement.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:403; Q3:123

Scope: The available electronic Ḥikam text has a flawed spelling and cannot establish the Arabic wording at this point.

T121 · The attachment of idh determines the event

Passage: 3:124–125 (p. 649)

The two grammatical analyses correspond to two accounts of the angelic reinforcement. Attaching idh to 'He helped you' links the saying to Badr in the immediately preceding verse. Taking it as a substitute for the earlier 'when you went forth' returns the narrative to Uḥud and makes the promise conditional on patience. These are not interchangeable labels for one uncomplicated chronology: the second explanation expressly says the condition was not fulfilled. Taswīm adds a lexical question about marking or distinguishing the angels. Here taswīm concerns the visible identifying marks developed in the following exposition.

Cairo-Ruslan-I: I:403; Q3:124–125

Scope: Records the alternatives transmitted by Ibn ʿAjība; it does not independently decide which battle received the reinforcement.

T122 · The three and five thousand angels

Passage: 3:124–125 (p. 649)

The three numbers belong to a proposed reconciliation of Q3:124–125 with Q8:9: Ibn ʿAjība understands successive reinforcement, rather than three competing totals for one moment. His preceding grammatical discussion also records a different interpretation, relating the promise to Uḥud and making its fulfilment conditional upon steadfastness. The descriptions of turbans and horses are alternatives introduced in the commentary; they are not details specified by the Qurʾān. Likewise, the statement that angels fought only at Badr is presented as Ibn ʿAbbās's report. Keeping those levels distinct preserves both the commentator's preferred account and the alternatives he transmits.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [403, 404]

T123 · Hidden lights, angelic support and an episode from the author's circle

Passage: 3:124–125 (p. 649)

The spiritual application distinguishes inward assistance, expressed as lights and mysteries, from outward angelic support. Fuqarāʾ here means the Sufi companions of the author's circle, not simply economically poor people. The change to 'we' marks an autobiographical claim, but the reported appearance of seventy as seven hundred is expressly qualified by 'according to what they told us.' Ibn ʿAjība therefore claims participation in the journey and reception of others' testimony about its appearance; he does not say that he himself counted seven hundred visible companions. The concluding Qurʾānic echo is Q3:13.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [404]

T124 · An inserted clause between coordinated possibilities

Passage: 3:126–129 (p. 651)

The parenthetical analysis keeps the surrounding verbs within one coordinated account of divine purposes: defeat, frustration, acceptance of repentance, or punishment. 'You have no part in the matter' interrupts that sequence without becoming its grammatical governing clause. The alternative assigns aw the exceptional sense 'unless/except that,' with explanatory consequences supplied for the Prophet. Al-Bayḍāwī, Q3:128, actually presents both approaches. They are alternative syntactic analyses, not successive additional statements. In both, the surrounding commentary reserves the opponents' ultimate fate to God while leaving the Prophet's commissioned warning and struggle intact.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [404]; baydawi: Q3:128, between PageV02P036–037

T125 · The means of victory and the Prophet's relation to his enemies

Passage: 3:126–129 (p. 651)

The commentary moves from Badr's victory to an injury at Uḥud when it explains the revelation of Q3:128. Those events should not be collapsed into a single battle. Muslim 1791 relates the damaged tooth and head wound at Uḥud, the Prophet's question about the attackers' prospects, and the revelation of this verse. Ibn ʿAjība's fuller account adds the interpretation that God knew some opponents would later believe, naming Khālid. The hadith

parallel establishes a source for the injury-and-verse episode; it does not independently substantiate every detail or the commentator's general statement about how many opponents subsequently converted.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [404, 405]; muslim: Hadith1791, near PageV03P1416–1417

T126 · Affliction as preparation for freedom from dependence

Passage: 3:126–129 (p. 651)

The wordplay links imtikān, secure establishment, to imtiḥān, testing, and miḥna, ordeal, to mikna, capacity. Ibn ʿAjība's interpretation turns military support into a model of inward formation: opposition exposes remaining attachments, and release from them changes the seeker's experience of divine Majesty into Beauty. 'Residues' are specified nearby as distractions, attachments, prestige and the self's preferences. The subsequent instruction to set the means in motion prevents 'you have no part' from meaning simple inactivity. The seeker acts, while the spiritual opening remains a divine gift rather than a result he can compel.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [405]

T127 · Affliction as preparation for freedom from dependence

Passage: 3:126–129 (p. 651)

Three voices must remain distinct. Al-Qushayrī juxtaposes the agency paradox of Q8:17 with the withdrawal of control in Q3:128. A marginal commentator then names the two stations as deputyship through God and God's acting for His servant, correlating them with baqāʾ and fanāʾ. Ibn ʿAjība's own 'I say' adds the terms expansion and contraction. Laṭāʾif al-ishārāt contains the Qurʾānic juxtaposition; the subsequent terminology is not thereby authenticated as al-Qushayrī's wording. Here fanāʾ and baqāʾ describe contrasting forms of awareness and agency within spiritual experience.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [405]; qushayri_tafsir: Q3:128–129, between PageV01P275–276

T128 · Redoubled interest and the disposition of God-consciousness

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

Ibn ʿAjība identifies the practice as an increase demanded when a debt becomes due: payment now or a larger obligation after delay. Repetition explains 'doubled and redoubled.' His cautious 'perhaps the specification fol-

lows what actually occurred' treats the multiplier as a description of a prevalent practice, not an independently stated threshold beneath which an increase becomes permissible. This is his explanation of Q3:130 in its setting. The surrounding argument connects victory with lawful sustenance and obedience, so the discussion of debt also serves the commentary's transition back to the Uḥud narrative.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [406]

T129 · Redoubled interest and the disposition of God-consciousness

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

Two related but distinct theological explanations occur here. Ibn ʿAjība infers present existence from 'prepared' and distinguishes the Fire's primary preparation for unbelievers from the punishment of sinners incidentally. He then quotes al-Wartajbī's more consolatory account of warning believers through an image of parental care. The father, lion and sword belong to that cited analogy. They do not turn the preceding distinctions into one undifferentiated doctrine, and the passage does not provide a comparative survey of theological positions. The quotation closes before the renewed command to obey God and the Messenger.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [406]

T130 · The immensity of the Garden

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

The interpretation offers two senses of ʿarḍ, 'breadth.' One uses a spatial comparison rhetorically: if even the smaller dimension is immense, its total extent is greater still. The other understands the word as extraordinary magnitude without contrasting breadth and length. These explanations are alternatives and supply no calculation of Paradise's dimensions. The separate inference from 'prepared' concerns its already created existence; the conclusion that it lies beyond this world is Ibn ʿAjība's theological inference. The recorded reading without wāw changes how 'hasten' joins the preceding sentence, not the object of the command.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [406]

T131 · Giving in ease and adversity

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

The three sayings about generosity are separately introduced reports. A parallel for the middle saying is al-Tirmidhī 1961. He calls its route gharīb, records disagreement with its transmitter, and mentions a disconnected alternative through ʿĀʾisha. His wording also contrasts the generous ignorant person with a miserly worshipper, whereas Cairo has a learned miser. That partial identification should not be extended into one authentication ruling for the entire cluster, particularly the tree imagery. The Qurʾānic foundation of the paragraph is the disposition to give in both prosperity and adversity; the cited sayings elaborate it.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [407]; tirmidhi: Hadith1961; PageV04P342

T132 · Giving in ease and adversity

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

‘These’ refers to those who pardon the people who wrong them, immediately after the exposition of al-ʿāfīna ʿani l-nās in Q3:134. The saying concerns the rarity of that moral disposition, not a numerical census of communities. Al-Thaʿlabī, III:167, transmits the same wording through Muqātil b. Ḥayyān with the formula ‘it has reached us that the Messenger said.’ That identifies an earlier exegetical source and its indirect reporting formula; it supplies no continuous chain in that paragraph. The parallel identifies an indirect Prophetic attribution; it does not supply a continuous chain.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [407]; al-Thalabi, al-Kashf wa-l-bayan: III:167, Q3:134

T133 · Giving in ease and adversity

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

Aḥmad’s Musnad 9624 contains both the Abū Bakr episode and the ensuing three maxims, so the latter are not merely an editorial moral appended to an unrelated story. The Cairo version reverses the order of the final two maxims and slightly paraphrases them. In Aḥmad, the increase in giving is tied to maintaining a connection, while the condemned request aims at accumulating more; the clauses do not equate every request for help with

greed. The point of the episode is the contrast between restraint and retaliatory exchange. Identifying this parallel does not replace a separate assessment of its chain.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [407]; ahmad: Musnad9624; around PageV15P390, printed numbering differs within the transcription

T134 · Giving in ease and adversity

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

The two analyses concern the definite article in al-muḥsinīn. On the generic reading, the statement embraces the class of all who act with iḥsān. On the contextual reading, it points back to the people just described: those who give, restrain anger and pardon. The distinction affects reference, not whether these virtues qualify as goodness. Ibn ʿAjība also makes the term relational, covering conduct toward God and toward other people. His following spiritual interpretation develops iḥsān into the named station of worship through witnessing; that development should not erase the ethical meaning established here.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [407]

T135 · The multiplication of sense-life as an inward form of ribā

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

The allusion draws on the verbal association between ribā and increasing: attachment to the sensible grows by repeated engagement, thought and conversation. The three corresponding supports of inward meaning are company, reflection and remembrance. Ḥiss and maʿnā are therefore functional terms in the author’s account of attention and spiritual formation, not a claim that the material world is intrinsically unreal or that every bodily act constitutes the legal offence of ribā. The legal debt discussion remains at I:406; this passage announces a further application to the disciple’s cultivated habits.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [407, 408]

T136 · The multiplication of sense-life as an inward form of ribā

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

The uncompensated blood and freely available property are severe expressions of the Sufi ideal of surrendering retaliation and proprietary self-assertion. Their immediate explanation is restraint, pardon and the test of what emerges when one is angered. They are not framed here as a juristic removal of another person's protected rights. The double imperative lā taghḍab wa-lā tughḍib balances not becoming angry with not provoking anger in others; its second member is causative. The following poem sharpens the same distinction: the desired pardon comes from self-command, rather than inability to answer an injury.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [408]

T137 · The multiplication of sense-life as an inward form of ribā

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

Cairo's negative comparison with sun, wind and rain is accompanied by its own geographical explanation: favouring one land over another. The earlier al-Thaʿlabī passage, at III:167, instead gives a positive comparison, presenting those natural benefits as examples of beneficence that is general rather than exclusive. Cairo's negative and its gloss give the comparison a different logic. Both versions support generosity, but they use nature differently. This is a real difference in the transmitted saying, whose precise entry into Ibn ʿAjība's text remains unsettled.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [408]; al-Thalabi, al-Kashf wa-l-bayan: III:167–168, Q3:134

T138 · The multiplication of sense-life as an inward form of ribā

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

Al-Wartajbī's language plays on ʿilal, the ailments or motives of creatures, and al-ʿillatayn, the two aims of pardon and Paradise. The prepositions matter: obedience is the means, while those benefits are the ends sought. The elect are then summoned to God Himself through Q51:50. The fuller ʿArāʾis passage at I:196 subsequently calls seeking forgiveness a pursuit of the self's portion, confirming the criticism of interested motives. The later dia-

logue about punishing angels occurs on the same page, but its modern footnote points back to Ibn ʿAjība; that circular reference provides no independent chain.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [408, 409]; Ruzbihan, Arais al-bayan: Mazidi edition1429/2008, I:196, Q3:133

T139 · The multiplication of sense-life as an inward form of ribā

Passage: 3:130–134 (p. 655)

The paragraph is explicitly a marginal commentator's explanation of the preceding quotation. It proposes that 'He forgives whom He wills' at Q3:129 includes heavenly beings, and reads the summons in Q3:133 correspondingly widely. 'Fault' is then qualified according to the creature concerned: it can mean limited judgment or inability to comprehend divine Majesty fully, rather than the same kind of deliberate transgression in every case. The closing argument for endless growth in knowledge rests on that inexhaustibility. Neither this gloss nor its philosophical explanation supplies authentication for the preceding report attributed to the Prophet.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [409]

T140 · Indecency, wrongdoing and the refusal to persist in sin

Passage: 3:135–136 (p. 661)

Iṣrār denotes persistence rather than an isolated recurrence. Ibn ʿAjība explicitly conditions his use of the seventy-times saying on remorse; the qualification prevents repeated verbal requests from being treated as sufficient while the person remains unrepentant. Abū Dāwūd 1514 transmits the saying, and al-Tirmidhī 3559 also records it while calling its chain 'not strong.' This is a concrete source judgment, distinct from the independent interpretation of Q3:135's refusal to persist. The adjacent maxim about major and minor sins and Qatāda's admonition are separately introduced items and should not inherit the same chain or assessment.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [409, 410]; abu_dawud: Hadith1514; near PageV02P084; tirmidhi: Hadith3559; near PageV05P557–558

T141 · Indecency, wrongdoing and the refusal to persist in sin

Passage: 3:135–136 (p. 661)

Three differently introduced sayings are gathered under ‘while they know.’ Their shared purpose is to connect repentance with recognition that God forgives. One close source identification is particularly useful: the final address beginning ‘Son of Adam, so long as you call upon Me and hope in Me’ occurs as a divine saying in al-Tirmidhī 3540 through Anas, where al-Tirmidhī calls it ḥasan gharīb. Cairo introduces it more generally as occurring in revealed books. That parallel clarifies the wording’s wider transmission but does not establish the separate chains or exact wording of the preceding two sayings.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [410]; tirmidhi: Hadith3540; PageV05P548

T142 · Indecency, wrongdoing and the refusal to persist in sin

Passage: 3:135–136 (p. 661)

‘The first verse’ here points to the praise of the muḥsinūn at Q3:134; ‘this verse’ points to the reward promised at Q3:136. Ibn ʿAjība builds a hierarchy from the difference between being loved and being remunerated. The image of receiving wages from beyond the door is his exposition of distance and intimacy, not wording of the Qurʾān. Nor does he deny forgiveness or Paradise to those he assigns the lower rank: he has just affirmed both. The distinction prepares the following allusion’s contrast between reliance on works and absorption in the divine Giver.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [410]

T143 · People of spiritual excellence and People of the Right

Passage: 3:135–136 (p. 661)

The series turns on different kinds of attention to oneself, one’s works and God. ‘Absent from seeing their works’ describes the muḥsinūn’s awareness, not the nonperformance of those works: the paragraph itself identifies their generosity, pardon and self-restraint. The contrast between maḥbūbūn, beloved, and muḥibbūn, lovers, reinforces the priority given to divine initiative over the seeker’s own effort. Fanāʾ and baqāʾ likewise concern efface-

ment of self-preoccupation and subsistence through the Lord. The statement that discursive believers are ‘the generality’ is explicitly relative to the perspective of those claiming direct witnessing.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [410]

T144 · Fruits of knowledge through witnessing: eight of eleven are given here

Passage: 3:135–136 (p. 661)

The enumeration announces eleven qualities but expressly gives only eight and sends the reader to Bughyat al-Sālik for the remainder. Ibn ʿAjība thus gives an abbreviated citation. The sequence distinguishes settled realization from fluctuating experience: gathering, sobriety, verification and subsistence are not interchangeable synonyms for an ecstatic state. Talbīs is specifically the concealment of inward mysteries under ordinary causes, preserving outward order. The freedom illustration contains a separate textual crux, faṣṣ/maṣṣ; the Risāla places the same manumission comparison immediately after maṣṣ.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [410, 411]; qushayri_risala: Chapter on freedom; II:372

T145 · Sunan (سُنَن) as paths and recurring precedents

Passage: 3:137–139 (p. 666)

Sunan is the plural of sunna, a way or established course. In this context ‘patterns’ or ‘precedents’ concerns the histories of earlier peoples and the recurring consequences of rejecting their messengers. The alternative ‘nations’ reads the term through the bearers of those histories rather than the paths themselves. It should remain an alternative, not be combined into the definition ‘religious traditions of nations.’ The instruction to travel and inspect the deniers’ end then gives these precedents their evidential function. Here sunan does not specifically denote the later technical corpus of Prophetic practice.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [411]

T146 · The fate of those who deny and the patience of those who believe

Passage: 3:137–139 (p. 666)

The tally of seventy Helpers and five Emigrants, including the same unusual sequence of names, already appears in al-Thaʿlabī on Q3:139, III:172. Other reports differ: al-Bukhārī 3986 gives seventy casualties at Uḥud, while 4078 speaks of seventy from the Helpers. These are distinguishable transmitted formulations, not a single verified roster from which every figure can be harmonized automatically. The earlier parallel attests Ibn ʿAjība's total of seventy-five and his names without settling the historical count or the name forms.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [412]; thalabi: Q3:139; between PageV03P171–172; bukhari: Hadith3986 and4078

T147 · Qarḥ (قَرْح), alternation of victory and the syntax of purpose

Passage: 3:140–143 (p. 668)

The proposed grammatical roles are paired alternatives. If al-ayyām qualifies the demonstrative, 'We alternate them' supplies the predicate; if 'the days' is already the predicate, the following clause can describe their circumstance. The omitted purpose before 'that God may know' allows several purposes for alternation to remain unexpressed. The final subjunctive 'and know the patient' is explained through an understood an after a wāw of combination. Ibn ʿAjība subsequently interprets the knowing as manifestation in events, so the syntax of purpose should not be read as an assertion that God lacked the relevant knowledge beforehand.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [412, 413]

T148 · The two battles and the alternating fortunes of nations

Passage: 3:140–143 (p. 668)

The first explanation compares Uḥud with Badr; the second compares two phases of Uḥud itself, initial Muslim success and the subsequent reversal. The connective 'or' introduces that alternative chronology. 'A similar wound' concerns the shared experience of loss and injury, not an assertion that the listed casualty figures are mathematically identical. Al-Bukhārī 3986 independently records the Badr figures of seventy killed and seventy captured alongside seventy casualties at Uḥud. Ibn ʿAjība's different Uḥud

total has an earlier tafsīr parallel noted at I:412. Keeping the alternatives separate prevents the two-battle and one-battle explanations from becoming a confused narrative.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [413]; bukhari: Hadith3986

T149 · The two battles and the alternating fortunes of nations

Passage: 3:140–143 (p. 668)

The phrase ‘so that God may know’ is explained by the commentary as the public manifestation of who truly believes. Its parallel gloss at Q3:142, ʿilm ẓuhūrihi, makes the same point: striving and patience become actual and observable. Alternating victory therefore serves discrimination and purification within the argument. It does not make success a direct sign of divine approval, for the text expressly denies that the temporary victors must be loved by God. Maḥq then supplies a different image from sudden destruction: diminution proceeding until the thing disappears.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [413]

T150 · The testing of seekers as purification and disclosure

Passage: 3:140–143 (p. 668)

The allusion deliberately uses two senses of shahāda: dying as a martyr under trial, and becoming a witness of the invisible Dominion through perseverance. Al-Ḥallāj is introduced as an example within Ibn ʿAjība’s first interpretation; the text does not offer a historical examination of his case. The second interpretation turns the same Qurʾānic word toward contemplative witnessing. The caves-and-snake comparison warns, within the author’s argument, against assuming that repeated impunity proves rejection of saints harmless. It is an illustrative comparison, not a separately sourced biographical event.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [413, 414]

T151 · The testing of seekers as purification and disclosure

Passage: 3:140–143 (p. 668)

The quoted Ḥikam aphorism distinguishes what God brings to the servant from the works the servant offers to God. Taʿarruf is God’s making Himself known, not merely the acquisition of information by the disciple. Ibn ʿAjība

applies that distinction to a trial that may initially feel like rejection: reduced outward activity during it does not necessarily mean lost spiritual benefit. The source aphorism begins conditionally, ‘if He opens,’ and does not dispense generally with assigned devotions. Its argumentative force is the disproportion between divine initiative and the servant’s offering, rather than the numerical quantity of acts performed.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [414]; hikam: Aphorism beginning idha fataha laka wijhatan; first page unit before PageV01P282

T152 · Kitāban muʾajjalan (كِتاباً مُؤَجَّلاً)

Passage: 3:144–145 (p. 672)

Kitāban is analysed as a verbal noun belonging to an understood verb of writing or decreeing. It therefore reinforces the determination of death rather than naming a book that a person must consult. Muʾajjalan qualifies that decree as assigned a term. ‘At an appointed time’ expresses its consequence, while Ibn ʿAjība’s grammatical paraphrase makes the underlying construction explicit. The explanation belongs to Q3:145 and should remain distinct from the preceding verse’s question about how believers respond to the death or killing of a messenger.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [414]

T153 · A report of death does not abolish the message

Passage: 3:144–145 (p. 672)

The conditional ‘if he dies or is killed’ does not state that Muḥammad died at Uḥud. It exposes the inadequacy of a faith dependent upon the messenger’s continued physical presence. Ibn ʿAjība preserves two explanations of the rebuke: a hypothetical reversal, or words already spoken by hypocrites while others were silent. The expression ‘turn back upon your heels’ is consequently explained as abandonment of the established religion. The ensuing battle narrative accounts for the rumour that prompted the discussion, while the later allusion applies the distinction between messenger and message to spiritual instruction.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [414, 415]

T154 · A report of death does not abolish the message

Passage: 3:144–145 (p. 672)

The heading ‘authors of the military narratives’ introduces a composite account, not one continuous hadith with a supplied chain. Its component episodes have different parallels. Al-Bukhārī 3039 records ʿAbd Allāh b. Jubayr’s fifty men, their instructions to remain and their departure toward booty. Muslim 2470 separately reports the sword offered ‘with its due right’ and Abū Dujāna accepting it. These identifications support particular episodes; they do not automatically verify the extra dialogue about bending the sword, the turban, swagger, commanders, or the full sequence of events as assembled here.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [415]; bukhari: Hadith3039; muslim: Hadith2470

T155 · A report of death does not abolish the message

Passage: 3:144–145 (p. 672)

Several distinct reports have been woven into this paragraph. Muslim 1790 records the facial wound, damaged tooth and broken helmet; al-Bukhārī 3724 separately records Ṭalḥa’s paralysed hand used to protect the Prophet. Neither passage by itself supplies the entire narrative about Ibn Qamiʾa, mistaken identity, the number who rallied, or Qatāda’s restored eye. Accordingly, a citation attached to the paragraph must not be read as authenticating all of it. The Qurʾānic discussion concerns the effect of a death rumour; the medical and miraculous particulars belong to the transmitted battle narratives.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [415]; muslim: Hadith1790; bukhari: Hadith3724

T156 · A report of death does not abolish the message

Passage: 3:144–145 (p. 672)

The quoted prayer contrasts the conduct of the withdrawing Muslims with that of the opposing polytheists: Anas seeks pardon for the former and disavows the latter. Al-Bukhārī 2805 transmits this contrast, his advance, his death and the identification of his body. It does not in that passage give every speech quoted by the commentary in response to the rumour. Anas b.

al-Naḍr is the uncle of the narrator Anas b. Mālik, so the two must not be conflated. Ibn ʿAjība subsequently makes the uncle an example of thankfulness expressed as steadfastness.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [415, 416]; bukhari: Hadith2805

T157 · A report of death does not abolish the message

Passage: 3:144–145 (p. 672)

The two explanations of idhn are divine willing and permission to the angel who takes the soul. Both serve the claim that death has a determined term. In this local argument, fear of death should not make believers abandon the duty under discussion. The passage is theological exhortation within a battle commentary, not a calculation of an individual's remaining lifespan. The immediately following contrast between worldly and otherworldly reward shifts attention from the time of death to intention: the archers' pursuit of booty exemplifies seeking an immediate return at the expense of their assigned position.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [416]

T158 · The death of a master and the independence of the disciple's vision

Passage: 3:144–145 (p. 672)

The passage distinguishes the intermediary from the One to whom the intermediary directs the seeker. Its two conditional branches are decisive: a disciple firmly established in witnessing can continue after the teacher dies; one not established seeks someone able to complete his formation. Thus sufficiency in God does not erase the text's acknowledgment of further guidance. The later anecdote intensifies the contrast through the Living One who does not die. Ibn ʿAjība's concluding criterion for the true teacher is precisely that his direction eventually frees the disciple from dependence upon the teacher's own person.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [416]

T159 · The death of a master and the independence of the disciple's vision

Passage: 3:144–145 (p. 672)

Abū Bakr's declaration and recitation of Q3:144 are attested together in al-Bukhārī 4454. That source also describes the listeners' response and ʿUmar's realization that the Prophet had died. Ibn ʿAjība supplies a further spiritual interpretation: Abū Bakr had passed from contemplating the gift to contemplating the Giver. That vocabulary belongs to the commentator's explanation, not to the quoted declaration itself. The shift from the Uḥud rumour to the Prophet's actual death also changes historical setting. Keeping source speech, subsequent event and spiritual interpretation distinct preserves the force of each.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [416]; bukhari: Hadith4454

T160 · Kaʾayyin (كَأَيِّن), ribbiyyūn (رِبِّيُّون), and qātala/qutila

Passage: 3:146–148 (p. 676)

The alternatives depend on both the verbal reading and the sentence division. With qutila, 'was killed,' the prophet may be its subject and 'with him were many devoted followers' a new clause; alternatively the followers are those killed with him. With qātala, 'fought,' the construction describes fighting. Ribbiyyūn itself receives several lexical explanations, so 'companies' and 'Godfearing scholars' are also alternatives. Cairo's verse block prints the passive reading and the exposition discusses both. The verbal readings and clause divisions provide distinct interpretations.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [416, 417]

T161 · The followers of former prophets

Passage: 3:146–148 (p. 676)

The two stated preferences support different analyses of the passive wording. The death rumour at Uḥud makes the example of a killed prophet and steadfast survivors rhetorically apt. The competing assertion that no prophet was killed in open battle favours taking the followers as those killed. Ibn ʿAjība reports both arguments before considering qātala, 'fought.' He does not supply a historical demonstration covering every prophet, and that uni-

versal assertion should not be treated as independently established merely because it appears here. The constant lesson across the alternatives is the survivors' steadfastness.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [417]

T162 · A disciple's steadfastness after the death of a master

Passage: 3:146–148 (p. 676)

The abbreviated reference to God becoming the servant's hearing and sight points to the divine saying in al-Bukhārī 6502. Its fuller context places obligatory duties first and then continual drawing near through additional devotions, followed by divine love. Ibn ʿAjība invokes its language for disciples who persevere after their teacher's death. His own paragraph also instructs those not fully guided to seek completion. The citation should therefore be read with those disciplines and conditions in view; it does not make the mere death of a teacher sufficient to establish a disciple's spiritual attainment.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [418]; bukhari: Hadith6502

T163 · Competing identifications of those to be obeyed

Passage: 3:149–150 (p. 679)

Three identifications are offered: the hypocrites who urged a return to the former religion, Abū Sufyān's followers from whom protection might be sought, and a more general pattern of religious conformity produced by prolonged dependence. The recurring 'according to another explanation' marks alternatives rather than one composite identification of all the parties. In the second and third, istiʾmān concerns seeking security, and the argument turns on its perceived religious consequences. 'God is your protecting Master' answers that dependence within the exposition. The next 'I say' then introduces Ibn ʿAjība's own historical application.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [418]

T164 · Competing identifications of those to be obeyed

Passage: 3:149–150 (p. 679)

The opening ‘I say’ marks Ibn ʿAjība’s extension of the preceding argument to the Muslims who remained in al-Andalus. It is neither a statement by the Qurʾānic speaker nor an account attributed to an early transmitter. The wording makes a broad causal claim about religious dependence and conversion, including descendants; it does not identify particular communities, dates or family histories. A related application occurs in his exposition of Q4:97 at Cairo I:549. The repetition clarifies the author’s concern but does not independently verify the completeness of his historical generalization.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [418]

T165 · Steadfastness in tajrīd when the world calls one back

Passage: 3:149–150 (p. 679)

The address is specifically to disciples, especially those already committed to tajrīd. It applies the reversal of Q3:149 to a retreat from their chosen spiritual discipline into preoccupation with worldly means. ‘Natures borrow’ explains the influence of companionship, followed by the saying about an intimate friend’s religion or way. The citation of Q65:2–3 supplies the language of unexpected provision. The author’s special application to the mutajarrid should remain visible: it is not presented in this paragraph as an identical vocational instruction for every reader irrespective of spiritual condition or responsibility.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [418]

T166 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 3:152 (p. 682)

Āl ʿImrān 3:152 · Cairo I:420. Ibn ʿAjība transmits “Poverty is my pride” within a quotation from al-Wartajbī. The Cairo editor treats the attribution critically; ʿAlī al-Qārī’s al-Asrār al-Marfuʿa also records the verdict “no basis / fabricated” for the expanded wording. The phrase is not an established Prophetic ḥadīth, and its spiritual interpretation does not authenticate it. The assessment attributed to Ibn Ḥajar has not been verified in his original work.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:420; Ruslān’s editorial footnote.

T167 · The inheritance of Prophetic gentleness and the meaning of tawakkul

Passage: 3:159 (p. 696)

An earlier version appears in al-Thaʿlabī on Q3:159, III:195, through Muḥammad b. Kaʿb from Ibn ʿAbbās. It has three parallel clauses: strength through trust, honour through mindfulness, and richness through greater confidence in what is with God. Cairo retains the latter two. The comparison concerns where confidence rests, rather than promising a measured increase in possessions. The surrounding definitions likewise describe freedom from fear, hope and anxious management directed toward creatures. Locating this earlier wording establishes a source parallel; it does not by itself settle the continuity or strength of that transmitted chain.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [427]; thalabi: Q3:159; between PageV03P194–195

T168 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 3:191–194 (p. 737)

Cairo I:451 · The fivefold “Our Lord.” Ruslān counts the repeated invocation and cites al-Munāwī’s inability to locate the particular report elsewhere. “I have not located it” is not the same as a demonstration that it is fabricated. The statement is al-Munāwī’s reported finding, not a supplied chain or an authentication verdict for the prayer and Sufi practice.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:451; Ruslān’s editorial footnote.

T169 · Al-Ghazālī on the realized person's wird

Passage: 3:191–194 (p. 737)

The section combines several voices rather than one uninterrupted quotation from al-Ghazālī. The Iḥyāʾ’s Book of Litanies describes sustained presence after the obligatory prayers and expressly warns beginners against claiming the rank prematurely. Its Book of Poverty and Renunciation separately preserves the Junayd sayings about limiting distractions, including reading and writing. Ibn ʿAjība then adds his own governing qualification: a disciple with a teacher of formation should follow the particular practice

assigned. This final rule limits the preceding generalizations about inward concentration. The text does not equate reduced visible activity with spiritual attainment, nor remove the obligatory prayers.

Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid: [451, 452]; ihya: Book of Litanies, I:349–350; Book of Poverty and Renunciation, IV:238–239

T170 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 3:191–194 (p. 737)

Cairo I:453 · Labīd's verse and the Prophet's commendation. Abū Hurayra transmits the Prophet's commendation of a line by Labīd in versions recorded by al-Bukhārī and Muslim. Muslim, Kitāb al-Shiʿr, no. 2256, preserves several formulations; the relevant commendation covers only the opening line. The poet's words are distinct from the Prophetic speech praising them, and later Sufi glosses are not part of the hadith text.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:453; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T171 · Editorial explanation

Passage: intro4 (p. 751)

Intro · The differing verse totals are historical systems of enumeration reported by Ibn ʿAjība, not discrepancies in the Qurʾānic wording. In the standard numbering, the sūrah has 176 verses.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:459.

T172 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:1 (p. 751)

4:1 · The genitive reading وَالْأَرْحَامِ is a recognized canonical reading attributed here to Ḥamza. The dispute concerns whether Arabic syntax permits coordination to an attached genitive pronoun without repeating the preposition. The accusative reading gives a coordinated object of اتقوا , not a different ethical rule.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:459–461.

T173 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:2 (p. 755)

4:2 · The account of the Ghaṭafān uncle is transmitted as an occasion of revelation in the commentary. Its attribution as an authenticated Prophetic ḥadīth has not been established; the reliability of its chain remains unverified.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:461–462.

T174 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:3 (p. 757)

4:3 · The explanation of ما as referring to women because of a supposed deficiency of intellect is Ibn ʿAjība's historical claim, not a necessary rule of Arabic grammar. Other grammatical accounts treat mā generically, as referring to allowable classes or descriptions of wives.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:462–463.

T175 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:3 (p. 757)

4:3 · The commentator's juristic framework, including premodern slavery law, belongs to historical exegesis; it does not supply a contemporary legal ruling.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:462–463.

T176 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:5 (p. 762)

Cairo I:464 · The readings of qiyām. The Cairo editor identifies alternative readings of the expression describing wealth as a means of support. These readings affect its morphology. The exact vowel details have not been independently verified against a specialized classical qirāʾāt source.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:464; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T177 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:5 (p. 762)

al-Nisāʾ 4:5 · Cairo I:465. Ibn ʿAjība quotes a disparaging report about women in connection with al-sufahāʾ and property guardianship. Its attribution has not been independently established. The corrective hadith cited by Ruslān is found in Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1469 through Abū Hurayra. Ruslān's admonition is the Cairo editor's annotation, not Ibn ʿAjība's own qualification. The sound Muslim report does not establish the attribution of the separate disparaging narration.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:465; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T178 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:5 (p. 762)

4:5 · The words attributed to Abū Umāma and the interpretation of النساء as السفهاء occur in the commentary. The specific Prophetic attribution is weak and cannot be treated as proof; see H004. The report from Abū Mūsā also has a contested distinction between marfūʿ and mawqūf transmission; see H005.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:464–466.

T179 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:7 (p. 767)

4:7 · The detailed Umm Kaḥḥa/Aws ibn Thābit narrative is an asbāb al-nuzūl report transmitted in tafsīr. Its early transmission and chain remain unverified; the detailed narrative is not thereby an authenticated Prophetic report.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:467–468.

T180 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:8 (p. 770)

4:8 · The status of the instruction to give a token share to non-heirs was contested in classical exegesis. Ibn ʿAjība reports several legal possibilities.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:468–469.

T181 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:10 (p. 774)

4:10 · The report attributed to Abū Barza is found in Abū Yaʿlā 7440 and Ibn Ḥibbān 5566, but its chain contains Ziyād ibn al-Mundhir and has been graded very weak by critical hadith scholars. The Qurʾānic warning itself is independent of the reliability of this supplementary report; see H009.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:470–471.

T182 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:11 (p. 775)

4:11 · Ibn Juzayy's statements about male precedence and terminology are historically situated exegetical/legal arguments. They belong to the cited author's legal framework, not an independent present-day judgment.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:471–475.

T183 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:15–16 (p. 789)

4:15–16 · The author reports alternative claims about the chronological abrogation of Q 4:15–16, same-sex acts, and penal measures. The legal and historical status of those claims differs among jurists; the passage does not supply a present-day operational legal ruling. The associated hadith attributed to ʿUbāda b. al-Ṣāmit (“خذوا عني ... قد جعل الله لهن سبيلاً”) occurs in Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1690a; its relation to the disputed claims of naskh is a separate question.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:478–479.

T184 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:19 (p. 795)

4:19 · This paragraph reports Ibn ʿAjība's explanation of a historical Mālikī view on khulʿ and nushūz. It does not justify coercive control or abuse; modern legal rules and competing classical interpretations must be treated separately. The Arabic construction of the exception and the legal implications of فاحشة مبينة are contested.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:481–483.

T185 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:19 (p. 795)

4:19 · The story of Mālik's father and a dark-skinned wife is presented as a story, not an authenticated report or a statement about human worth. Its historical authenticity has not been verified.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:481–483.

T186 · Spiritual combat and witnessing: a quotation variant

Passage: 4:19 (p. 795)

Cairo I:483 prints "suns of spiritual combat" (شموس المجاهدات). The corresponding passage in al-Baqlī's ʿArāʾis al-bayān I:239 reads "suns of witnessing" (شموس المشاهدات), which also explains the Turkish rendering. This earlier-source parallel establishes a quotation variant; it does not by itself establish which wording Ibn ʿAjība wrote.

Cairo I:483; primary-source comparison recorded below.

Scope: Source comparison and copytext interpretation; no independent Baḥr manuscript reading is asserted.

T187 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:22 (p. 801)

4:22 · Ibn ʿAjība's explanation of mā referring to women because of alleged cognitive deficiency is a historically situated exegetical claim.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:484–485.

T188 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:22 (p. 801)

4:22 · The exception concerning illicit intercourse and permanent marriage impediments is subject to disagreements between the legal schools. The Risāla cited is likely Ibn Abī Zayd al-Qayrawānī's Mālikī text; the quotation has not been verified against a specified recension.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:484–485.

T189 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:23 (p. 803)

4:23 · The passage concerns the commentator's account of marriage impediments in classical jurisprudence. The unusual report attributed to ʿAlī on stepdaughters needs chain scrutiny and should not be treated as a majority view.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:485–486.

T190 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:23 (p. 803)

4:23 · The treatment of enslaved persons in classical law is historical exegesis and does not describe a permissible contemporary practice. The reported Ẓāhirī exception has not been verified against original juristic sources.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:485–486.

T191 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:24 (p. 807)

4:24 · The running text gives no precise bibliographical identification of 'the Mukhtaṣar'. The material describes premodern captivity and slavery law; it is not a contemporary authorization for coercive sexual relationships. The Awṭās context is in Muslim 1456a (H021).

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:485–489.

T192 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:24 (p. 807)

4:24, ishāra · 'He who has not been born twice is not one of us' is assigned to 'one of the saints', not to the Prophet. No reliable individual attribution or transmitted source has yet been established. The author says the saint 'counted the first and third' of his own three births, so those two counted births belong within the author's threefold account.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:485–489.

T193 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:24 (p. 807)

4:24, ishāra · The aphorism concerning love of the world and love of its Creator is ascribed to al-Shāfiʿī in the Arabic. The chain and source for that specific attribution remain unverified. The admonition is an ascetic maxim, not a juristic prohibition in itself.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:485–489.

T194 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:24 (p. 807)

4:24, syntax · Cairo I:488 prints the active reading wa-aḥalla (“and He has made lawful”) in the printed verse heading and in the first grammatical analysis, coordinated with the tacit kataba (“He prescribed”). The author explicitly gives passive wa-uḥilla as another reading, coordinated with ḥurrimat (“were forbidden”).

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:485–489.

T195 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:24 (p. 807)

4:24 · The ḥadīth of Sabra al-Juhanī is ṣaḥīḥ in Muslim 1406d; its full wording appears at H022. Ibn ʿAjība’s claims about three days at the conquest and Ibn ʿAbbās's later withdrawal reflect a specific Sunni reconstruction of early practice. Other schools differ in legal conclusions and in their reading of early transmission; no claim of unanimous historic interpretation is made here. Cairo I:488 prints the active reading wa-aḥalla in the verse heading; the commentary also explicitly states the passive reading as an alternative. See N142.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:485–489.

T196 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:25–28 (p. 812)

4:25 · Ibn ʿAjība explicitly quotes Ibn Juzayy on Mālik, Ibn al-Qāsim, and the jurists of Iraq. The reference to dalīl al-khiṭāb concerns a technical question in uṣūl about argument from the contrary implication of a restriction. The quotation records positions of these named jurists; it does not establish a single school-wide opinion.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493.

T197 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:25–28 (p. 812)

4:25, ishāra · The long saying on the fruits of love is ascribed to Abū al-Ḥasan al-Shādhilī. Its specific collection, transmission and phrasing have not been independently fixed. ‘Virgins’, ‘previously married free women’, and ‘enslaved women’ are explicitly analogical rankings of modes of knowledge in Ibn ʿAjība’s spiritual allusion.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493.

T198 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:25–28 (p. 812)

4:25 · The division of a prescribed punishment and the statement that stoning is not halved reproduce classical exegetical/legal discourse. These historical positions do not authorize punitive action by private individuals or state current law. Ibn ʿAjība quotes Q 24:2 but does not state a fresh separate hadith at this juncture.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493.

T199 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:25–28 (p. 812)

4:25, ishāra · The dream story about Junayd is an edifying report, not independently authenticated historical evidence. The double-chastisement verse is Q 33:30; Ibn ʿAjība supplies a moral comparison rather than claiming that its legal ruling applies to ordinary spiritual teachers.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493.

T200 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:25–28 (p. 812)

4:25 · The statement about the slavery status of children born in the historical arrangement belongs to Ibn ʿAjība's world of classical juristic institutions. It belongs to that historical juristic framework and does not describe a legitimate current practice. His distinction between fear of ʿanat and patience is material to both legal and spiritual readings.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493.

T201 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:25–28 (p. 812)

4:27 · The competing identifications of 'those following desires' as fornicators, Jews/Christians or Magians are inherited exegetical views, not an empirical claim about adherents of these religions. Ibn ʿAjība's paraphrase 'marry and beget' differs from the sourced Abū Dāwūd 2050 wording quoted in H025. Figures for the concubines attributed to ʿAlī have not been verified from early chronicles.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493.

T202 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:25–28 (p. 812)

4:28 · The vivid personal statement is attributed to the Companion ʿUbāda b. al-Ṣāmit, not to the Prophet; an independently verified early source and isnād have not yet been located. It should be classified as an *athar*, not as ṣaḥīḥ Prophetic hadith.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493.

T203 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:25–28 (p. 812)

4:28 · The selection of eight verses is attributed to Ibn ʿAbbās. The attribution and exact formulation of this eight-verse selection remain unverified. This is an *athar*, not a report of Prophetic speech.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:489–493.

T204 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:29–30 (p. 819)

4:29 · The distinction between verbal and bodily separation after a sale is a historically important Mālikī–Shāfiʿī juristic dispute. The ḥadīth in al-Bukhārī 2107 explicitly adds Nāfiʿ's remark that Ibn ʿUmar would separate quickly after buying goods he wanted, a detail important to interpreting 'separation'. The grammarians' readings of the kāna exception are also separate from the underlying contract-law conclusion.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:493–495.

T205 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:29–30 (p. 819)

4:30 · Ibn ʿAjība's generic phrasing combines language of several sound warnings. Muslim 109a and al-Bukhārī 5778 contain the longer 'forever' form for three specified means; Muslim 110a/d contain shorter generic wording. His 'threat of emphasis' or 'one who holds it lawful' is a theological gloss, not a replacement for the hadith text. Warning passages must not be read as an instruction to stigmatize individuals who die by suicide; questions of knowledge, compulsion, capacity and individual judgment are distinct.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:493–495.

T206 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:31 (p. 823)

4:31 · The caller-from-the-Throne report is transmitted with a weak chain, as classified by al-ʿIrāqī (Takhrīj al-Iḥyāʾ 3/225); see H030. Its statement about interpersonal obligations may not be cited as an authenticated doctrine that injured people's claims evaporate without redress. Ibn ʿAjība marks it as the argument of one interpretive position, while also reporting several rival definitions of 'major sin'.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd; Cairo Arabic edition I:495–496.

T207 · The three readings of tasawwā and Cairo's explanation

Passage: 4:41–42 (p. 845)

Cairo I:505 confuses the explanations of the readings here. The doubled tassawwā comes from tatasawwā by assimilation of a tāʾ into the sīn; the reading tasawwā instead omits a tāʾ. The passive tusawwā is a separate form, not produced by that omission. Compare al-Bayḍāwī, Anwār al-tanzīl, at Q4:42, and al-Rāzī, Mafātīḥ al-ghayb, at Q4:42, second question. The explanations printed in Cairo therefore remain a textual difficulty.

Cairo I:505; primary-source comparison recorded below.

Scope: Source comparison and copytext interpretation; no independent Baḥr manuscript reading is asserted.

T208 · Editorial explanation

Passage: 4:97–99 (p. 927)

Cairo I:550 · The saying about emigration. The Cairo editor identifies a mursal route for the saying encouraging emigration. Its occurrence in Ibn ʿAjība's explanation does not establish a continuous Prophetic chain. The mursal classification is reported by Ruslān; the precise al-Ṭabarānī and al-Munāwī passages have not been independently compared for a final assessment of the report.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo I:550; Ruslān's editorial footnote.

T209 · The wishing subject in the angels' testimony

Passage: 4:166 (p. 997)

Cairo I:593 reads 'the angels wish that people should know' (أن الملائكة يودون أن يعلم الناس). Al-Bayḍāwī's Anwār al-tanzīl, on Q 4:166 (al-Maṭbaʿa al-ʿUthmāniyya, 1305 AH, p. 137; also II:110 in the electronic edition consulted), instead reads 'they wish to know' (أنهم يودون أن يعلموا); in its surrounding argument, 'they' refers to the human opponents who seek knowledge without reflection. The Turkish translator (II:591, n. 973, citing I:249 in his edition) expressly reports correcting what he regards as surplus in the Baḥr copies available to him according to al-Bayḍāwī. His Turkish body makes the People of the Book the wishing subject, while retaining people as the know-

ing subject, so it is not an exact equivalent of al-Bayḍāwī's two pronouns. No independent Baḥr manuscript has been inspected to establish at what stage this discrepancy entered the text.

Cairo I:593; primary-source comparison recorded below.

Scope: Source comparison and copytext interpretation; no independent Baḥr manuscript reading is asserted.

Report-source register

The entries identify transmitted source texts, their relationship to the author's quotations and the assessments of named classical critics. Contextual comparisons are identified where Ibn ʿAjība does not quote the report directly.

R1 · Joining kinship

Q 4:1 · Prophetic hadith · Abū Hurayra

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 5988

إن الرحم شجنة من الرحمن، فقال الله: من وصلك وصلته، ومن قطعك قطعته.

The bond of kinship is a branch [linked in name] to the All-Merciful. God says to it: "Whoever maintains you, I shall maintain him; whoever severs you, I shall sever him."

Textual / transmission note: Full wording of this short version; longer versions of the creation-and-kinship narration also occur in al-Bukhārī 5987 and 4830. Ibn ʿAjība paraphrases the shared closing statement.

Wording and scope. Kinship's link to al-Raḥmān and the reciprocal joining/severing clauses are present. The digital Arabic shows a possible typo in shijna.

Classical assessment. The cited version occurs in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ. This source identification does not establish the status of every transmission.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5988.

R2 · The ḥadīth of Gabriel defining iḥsān

Q 4:1 · Prophetic hadith · ʿUmar, through Ibn ʿUmar and Yaḥyā ibn Yaʿmur

Identified source. Muslim 8a

بينما نحن عند رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم ذات يوم إذ طلع علينا رجل شديد بياض الثياب شديد سواد الشعر، لا يرى عليه أثر السفر ولا يعرفه منا أحد، حتى جلس إلى النبي صلى الله عليه وسلم فأسند ركبتيه إلى ركبتيه ووضع كفيه على فخذيه، وقال: يا محمد أخبرني عن الإسلام. فقال رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم: «الإسلام أن تشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وأن محمدا رسول الله، وتقيم الصلاة، وتؤتي الزكاة، وتصوم رمضان، وتحج البيت إن استطعت إليه سبيلا». قال: صدقت. قال: فعجبنا له يسأله ويصدقه. قال: فأخبرني عن الإيمان. قال: «أن تؤمن بالله وملائكته وكتبه ورسله واليوم الآخر وتؤمن بالقدر خيره وشره». قال: صدقت. قال: فأخبرني عن الإحسان. قال: «أن تعبد الله كأنك تراه فإن لم تكن تراه فإنه يراك». قال: فأخبرني عن الساعة. قال: «ما المسؤول عنها بأعلم من السائل». قال: فأخبرني عن أمارتها. قال: «أن تلد الأمة ربتها، وأن ترى الحفاة العراة العالة رعاء الشاء يتطاولون في البنيان». قال: ثم انطلق، فلبثت مليا، ثم قال لي: «يا عمر أتدري من السائل؟». قلت: الله ورسوله أعلم. قال: «فإنه جبريل أتاكم يعلمكم دينكم».

While we were sitting with the Messenger of God one day, a man appeared wearing extraordinarily white clothing and with exceptionally black hair. No sign of travel was visible upon him, and none of us knew him. He sat facing the Prophet, pressing his knees against his knees and putting his palms upon his thighs, and said: “Muḥammad, tell me about Islam.” God's Messenger replied: “Islam is that you testify there is no god but God and Muḥammad is His Messenger, establish prayer, give the alms-due, fast Ramaḍān, and make pilgrimage to the House if you are able.” The man said, “You have spoken truly.” We wondered that he asked and then affirmed the answer. He said: “Tell me about faith.” The Prophet said: “That you believe in God, His angels, His books, His messengers, the Last Day, and destiny, its good and its evil.” He answered, “You have spoken truly.” “Tell me about excellence (الإحسان).” He replied: “That you worship God as though you see Him; for if you do not see Him, He sees you.” “Tell me about the Hour.” He said: “The one questioned knows no more of it than the questioner.” “Tell me its signs.” He said: “That a slave woman gives birth to her mistress, and you see barefooted, poorly clad, destitute shepherds competing in con-

structing tall buildings.” The man left, and I remained for a while. Then the Prophet asked: “ʿUmar, do you know who the questioner was?” I answered: “God and His Messenger know best.” He said: “That was Gabriel. He came to teach you your religion.”

Textual / transmission note: This is the complete ʿUmar–Gabriel encounter matn as cited in Muslim 8a, excluding the separate introductory discussion of predestination by Yaḥyā ibn Yaʿmur. Ibn ʿAjība quotes the iḥsān sentence. His two-tier interpretation is his exposition, not an addition to the hadith.

Wording and scope. The full Gabriel encounter and iḥsān clause are present. The separate predestination preamble by Yaḥyā ibn Yaʿmur is outside this excerpt.

Classical assessment. In Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: Muslim 8a.

R3 · ʿĀʾisha on the orphan-girl and her bridal gift

Q 4:3 · Companion exegesis (athar) · ʿĀʾisha, through ʿUrwa

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 4574

أن عروة بن الزبير سأل عائشة عن قول الله تعالى: {وإن خفتم أن لا تقسطوا في اليتامى}. فقالت: يا ابن أختي، هذه اليتيمة تكون في حجر وليها، تشركه في ماله ويعجبه مالها وجمالها، فيريد وليها أن يتزوجها بغير أن يقسط في صداقها، فيعطيها مثل ما يعطيها غيره، فنهوا عن أن ينكحوهن إلا أن يقسطوا لهن ويبلغوا لهن أعلى سنتهن في الصداق، فأمروا أن ينكحوا ما طاب لهم من النساء سواهن. قال عروة: قالت عائشة: وإن الناس استفتوا رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم بعد هذه الآية، فأنزل الله {ويستفتونك في النساء}. قالت عائشة: وقول الله تعالى في آية أخرى: {وترغبون أن تنكحوهن}، رغبة أحدكم عن يتيمته حين تكون قليلة المال والجمال. قالت: فنهوا أن ينكحوا من رغبوا في ماله وجماله من يتامى النساء إلا بالقسط، من أجل رغبتهم عنهن إذا كن قليلات المال والجمال.

ʿUrwa ibn al-Zubayr asked ʿĀʾisha about God's words: “If you fear you will not be equitable toward orphan girls.” She replied: “My sister's son, this refers to an orphan girl under the guardianship of a man, sharing his property. Her property and beauty attract him, and he wants to marry her without giving her a just bridal gift equivalent to what another man would give. Guardians were forbidden to marry such girls unless they gave them justice and the fullest appropriate bridal gift. They were instructed to marry other women instead.” ʿĀʾisha continued: “People later sought the Messenger's judgment about the verse, and God revealed, ‘They ask you for a ruling about women.’ ‘And whom you desire to marry’ [4:127] refers also to the guardian's aversion to marrying a girl in his charge when she lacks property and beauty. He was not permitted to desire her for property and beauty while denying her justice, when he would otherwise refuse her because she lacked those advantages.”

Textual / transmission note: This is the complete explanatory matn of the cited Bukhārī version, with isnād omitted; Ibn ʿAjība quotes its earlier portion. The longer conclusion clarifies the contrast between desiring a wealthy orphan and declining a poorer one.

Wording and scope. The orphan-girl/bridal-gift explanation and subsequent 4:127 discussion are present; companion exegesis, not all direct Prophetic speech.

Classical assessment. Connected companion report in al-Bukhārī’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 4574.

R4 · The controversial “women are the foolish” report

Q 4:5 · Attributed Prophetic hadith · Abū Umāma, through al-Qāsim and ʿAlī b. Yazīd

Identified source. al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-kabīr 7874; Ibn Abī Ḥātim, Tafsīr 4785; al-Haythamī, Majmaʿ al-zawāʾid, Book of Marriage, 7673

ألا إن النار خلقت للسفهاء، وهي للنساء إلا التي أطاعت قيمها.

Take heed: the Fire was created for the foolish, that is, for women, apart from the one who obeys the person in charge of her.

Textual / transmission note: Al-Thaʿlabī has the fuller wording used by Ibn ʿAjība: «ألا إنما خلقت النار للسفهاء - يقولها ثلاثا - ألا وإن السفهاء النساء إلا امرأة أطاعت قيمها». This is a weak attribution; the early source chain contains ʿAlī ibn Yazīd al-Alhānī, whom al-Haythamī records as matrūk. It does not establish an authenticated definition of Q 4:5. The additional exchange between an unnamed woman and the Prophet in the tafsīr also remains unauthenticated.

Wording and scope. The women/foolish wording and lower chain are identified in the displayed primary excerpts.

Classical assessment. Al-Haythamī calls ʿAlī b. Yazīd matrūk, records that he was also called ṣāliḥ, and calls the remaining transmitters trustworthy.

Sources: al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-kabīr 7874; Ibn Abī Ḥātim, Tafsīr 4785; al-Haythamī, Majmaʿ al-zawāʾid, Book of Marriage, 7673.

R5 · Three whose supplication is not answered

Q 4:5 · Reported Prophetic saying, with mawqūf variant · Abū Mūsā, through Abū Burda, al-Shaʿbī, Firās and Shuʿba

Identified source. Ibn Abī Shayba 17144; al-Ṭaḥāwī, Sharḥ mushkil al-āthār 2530; al-Ḥākim, al-Mustadrak 3181; al-Bayhaqī, al-Sunan al-kubrā 20547 (Turkī)

ثلاثة يدعون الله فلا يستجاب لهم: رجل كانت تحته امرأة سيئة الخلق فلم يطلقها، ورجل كان له على رجل مال فلم يشهد عليه، ورجل آتى سفيها ماله، وقد قال الله عز وجل: {ولا تؤتوا السفهاء أموالكم}.

Three call upon God but are not answered: a man who has a wife of bad character but does not divorce her; a man who has given another man money on loan without calling witnesses; and a man who entrusts his property to someone of unsound judgment, although God has said, “Do not give the foolish your property.”

Textual / transmission note: In Ibn Abī Shayba 17144 the text stops with Abū Mūsā, rather than being attributed directly to the Prophet. Al-Ḥākim notes this stopping; later scholars differ about the preferred attribution. The distinction matters even where the wording is substantially stable.

Wording and scope. The three unanswered supplications are transmitted both as companion speech and as Prophetic speech.

Classical assessment. Al-Ḥākim authenticates his elevated route on the two Ṣaḥīḥ compilers' conditions, while expressly noting that Shuʿba's other companions stop it at Abū Mūsā. The variation is material; ʿAmr b. Ḥakkām's weakness belongs to al-Ṭaḥāwī's route, not to every route.

Sources: Ibn Abī Shayba 17144; al-Ṭaḥāwī, Sharḥ mushkil al-āthār 2530; al-Ḥākim, al-Mustadrak 3181; al-Bayhaqī, al-Sunan al-kubrā 20547 (Turkī).

R6 · Eating from the estate of an orphan in one's care

Q 4:6 · Prophetic report in mursal and connected variants · al-Ḥasan al-ʿUranī, with no companion named in this chain

Identified source. Saʿīd b. Manṣūr, Tafsīr 572; al-Bayhaqī, al-Sunan al-kubrā 12797 (Turkī), old VI:285

أن رجلا قال: يا رسول الله، مم أضرب منه يتيمي؟ قال: «مما كنت منه ضاربا ولدك».
قال: أفأصيب من ماله؟ قال: «غير متأثل مالا، ولا واق مالك بماله».

A man asked, "Messenger of God, for what may I strike an orphan under my charge?" He said, "For what you would strike your own child." The man asked, "May I take something of the orphan's property?" He said: "Without building up capital for yourself from it, and without protecting your own wealth by spending his."

Textual / transmission note: Ibn ʿAjība quotes a paraphrase with "according to what is proper." The cited mursal version is traced by al-Bayhaqī to al-Ḥasan al-ʿUranī. A connected report from ʿAbd Allāh ibn ʿAmr gives: «كل من مال يتيمك غير مسرف ولا مبذر ولا متأثل مالا ومن غير أن تقي مالك - أو قال تفدي بماله - مالك» (Musnad Aḥmad 7022). The reports differ in both wording and chain.

Wording and scope. The question uses ḍaraba, "strike".

Classical assessment. Al-Bayhaqī explicitly calls the displayed chain mursal. The separately quoted ʿAbd Allāh b. ʿAmr report has different wording and is not an exact textual witness.

Sources: Saʿīd b. Manṣūr, Tafsīr 572; al-Bayhaqī, al-Sunan al-kubrā 12797 (Turkī), old VI:285.

R7 · Abū Hurayra and the inheritance of the Messenger

Q 4:8 · Companion report (athar) · Abū Hurayra, through ʿAbd Allāh al-Rūmī and ʿAlī b. Masʿada

Identified source. al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-awsaṭ 1429

أن أبا هريرة مر بسوق المدينة فوقف عليها، فقال: يا أهل السوق، ما أعجزكم! قالوا: وما ذاك يا أبا هريرة؟ قال: ذاك ميراث رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم يقسم، وأنتم هاهنا لا تذهبون فتأخذون نصيبكم منه؟ قالوا: وأين هو؟ قال: في المسجد. فخرجوا سراعا إلى المسجد، ووقف أبو هريرة لهم حتى رجعوا، فقال لهم: ما لكم؟ قالوا: يا أبا هريرة، فقد أتينا المسجد فدخلنا فلم نر فيه شيئا يقسم. فقال لهم أبو هريرة: أما رأيتم في المسجد أحدا؟ قالوا: بلى، رأينا قوما يصلون وقوما يقرءون القرآن وقوما يتذاكرون الحلال والحرام. فقال لهم أبو هريرة: ويحكم، فذاك ميراث محمد صلى الله عليه وسلم.

Abū Hurayra came upon the market of Medina and cried: “People of the market! How helpless you are!” They said: “What do you mean, Abū Hurayra?” He said: “The Messenger's inheritance is being distributed, yet you remain here instead of going to take your share!” “Where is it?” they asked. “In the mosque.” They hurried there, while he waited for them to return. He asked them: “What happened?” They answered: “Abū Hurayra, we entered the mosque but saw nothing being distributed.” He said: “Did you not see anyone there?” They replied: “We saw people praying, others reciting the Qurʾān, and others discussing what is lawful and unlawful.” He answered: “That, may God have mercy on you, is Muḥammad's inheritance.”

Textual / transmission note: This is reported as a saying and action of Abū Hurayra, not as a speech by the Prophet. Al-Ṭabarānī notes that the route from ʿAbd Allāh al-Rūmī runs uniquely through ʿAlī ibn Masʿada. The report’s authenticity remains unsettled.

Wording and scope. The market-to-mosque narrative is located; an upper transmitter explicitly says he copied it from Khalaf b. Tamīm’s book.

Classical assessment. The compiler identifies the singular lower route. Uniqueness by itself is not an authentication or a sufficient disqualification; an overall classical grade remains unestablished.

Sources: al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-awsaṭ 1429.

R8 · Charity and guardianship of descendants

Q 4:9 · Attributed Prophetic report · Ibn ʿUmar, through Nāfiʿ and an attributed Mālik route

Identified source. Ibn ʿAdī, al-Kāmil VI:288 (Fikr); Ibn Shāhīn, al-Targhīb fī faḍāʾil al-aʿmāl 382

ما أحسن عبد الصدقة إلا أحسن الله الخلافة على تركته.

No servant practices charity well without God providing well for those who inherit his estate.

Textual / transmission note: Ibn ʿAdī classifies the reported route among false narrations, while some later discussions mention disconnected variants; this cannot be used as proof of a guaranteed worldly outcome. The verse and the author's spiritual lesson remain independent of its authenticity.

Wording and scope. Ibn Shāhīn has ʿalā tarikatihi; Ibn ʿAdī's displayed witness has ʿalā barakatihi.

Classical assessment. Ibn ʿAdī explicitly calls this group of purported Mālik reports invalid (bawāṭīl). The variant wordings belong to different witnesses.

Sources: Ibn ʿAdī, al-Kāmil VI:288 (Fikr); Ibn Shāhīn, al-Targhīb fī faḍāʾil al-aʿmāl 382.

R9 · Fire from the mouths of those who consume orphan wealth

Q 4:10 · Attributed Prophetic report · Abū Barza, through Nāfiʿ b. al-Ḥārith, Ziyād b. al-Mundhir and Yūnus b. Bukayr

Identified source. Abū Yaʿlā 7440; Ibn Ḥibbān 5566; Ibn ʿAdī, al-Kāmil III: 190 (Fikr)

يبعث الله عز وجل يوم القيامة قوما من قبورهم تأجج أفواههم نارا، فقيل: من هم يا رسول الله؟ فقال: «ألم تر أن الله يقول: {إن الذين يأكلون أموال اليتامى ظلما إنما يأكلون في بطونهم نارا}؟».

God Almighty will raise certain people from their graves on the Day of Resurrection with fire flaming from their mouths. Asked, “Who are they, Messenger of God?” he replied: “Have you not seen that God says, ‘Those who unjustly consume the wealth of orphans consume only fire in their bellies’?”

Textual / transmission note: Al-Zaylaʿī records older critics’ severe objections to Ziyād b. al-Mundhir in the reported isnād. This transmission assessment is separate from the plain Qurʾānic warning at 4:10. The relative strength of all the chains remains unsettled.

Wording and scope. The fiery resurrection of the consumer of orphan property is located in the cited collections.

Classical assessment. Ibn ʿAdī’s discussion criticizes Ziyād’s transmissions as not preserved and questionable. Ibn Ḥibbān’s inclusion of the report does not establish agreement among critics.

Sources: Abū Yaʿlā 7440; Ibn Ḥibbān 5566; Ibn ʿAdī, al-Kāmil III:190 (Fikr).

R10 · Islam’s strangeness: the “strangers”

Q 4:11 · Prophetic hadith · Abū Hurayra

Identified source. Muslim 145

بدأ الإسلام غريبًا، وسيعود كما بدأ غريبًا، فطوبى للغرباء.

Islam began as something strange, and shall return as it began, strange; so glad tidings to those who are strangers.

Textual / transmission note: Ibn ʿAjība cites only “طوبى للغرباء.” This is the full matn of the version in Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 145, whose beginning explains what the final words refer to.

Wording and scope. Complete short matn on Islam’s strangeness checked.

Classical assessment. In Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: Muslim 145.

R11 · “Two or more constitute a congregation”

Q 4:11 · Reported Prophetic hadith · Abū Mūsā, through ʿAmr b. Jarād, his son, and al-Rabīʿ b. Badr

Identified source. Sunan Ibn Mājah 972, chapter “Two constitute a congregation”; parallels in Ibn Abī Shayba 8903 and Abū Yaʿlā 7223

اثنان فما فوقهما جماعة.

Two and any greater number constitute a group or congregation.

Textual / transmission note: Its invocation in the interpretation of a grammatical plural must not be treated as proven Prophetic evidence. It has weak/unknown transmitters, although the legal possibility of congregational prayer for two is independently established by other material. See the juristic discussion separately.

Wording and scope. The report is at Ibn Mājah 972.

Classical assessment. The source and chain are identified; a named classical assessment remains unverified.

Sources: Sunan Ibn Mājah 972, chapter “Two constitute a congregation”; parallels in Ibn Abī Shayba 8903 and Abū Yaʿlā 7223.

R12 · Revelation of inheritance shares in the case of Saʿd ibn al-Rabīʿ’s daughters

Q 4:11 · Reported Prophetic-era episode (asbāb al-nuzūl) · Jābir, through ʿAbd Allāh b. Muḥammad b. ʿAqīl

Identified source. al-Tirmidhī 2092

جاءت امرأة سعد بن الربيع بابنتيها من سعد إلى رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم فقالت: يا رسول الله، هاتان ابنتا سعد بن الربيع قُتل أبوهما معك يوم أحد شهيدًا، وإن عمهما أخذ مالهما فلم يدع لهما مالًا، ولا تنكحان إلا ولهما مال. قال: «يقضي الله في ذلك». فنزلت آية الميراث، فبعث رسول الله صلى الله عليه وسلم إلى عمهما فقال: «أعط ابنتي سعد الثلثين، وأعط أمهما الثمن، وما بقي فهو لك».

Saʿd ibn al-Rabīʿ’s wife brought his two daughters to God’s Messenger and said: “Messenger of God, these two are daughters of Saʿd ibn al-Rabīʿ. Their father was martyred alongside you on the day of Uḥud. Their uncle has

taken their property, leaving them nothing, and without property they will not be married." He said: "God will judge this matter." The inheritance verse was revealed. The Prophet then sent for their uncle, saying: "Give Saʿd's two daughters two-thirds, give their mother one-eighth, and what remains is yours."

Textual / transmission note: This is the full narrative matn as printed in Tirmidhī 2092, without repeating its isnād. Ibn ʿAjība also reports a different occasion involving Jābir's illness. His mention of both possibilities should not be collapsed into a single identified cause of revelation.

Wording and scope. Saʿd's two daughters, their uncle, and the two-thirds/one-eighth/remainder ruling checked.

Classical assessment. The compiler explicitly says ḥasan ṣaḥīḥ and identifies Ibn ʿAqīl as the common lower transmitter. This is distinguished from the page's modern editorial grade.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 2092.

R13 · Repentance remains open until the death-rattle

Q 4:17–18 · Prophetic hadith · Ibn ʿUmar

Identified source. al-Tirmidhī 3537

إن الله يقبل توبة العبد ما لم يغرغر.

God accepts a servant's repentance so long as the servant has not begun to gasp at death.

Textual / transmission note: The shorter complete matn is cited exactly. Its rationale for interpreting "soon" is explicit in Ibn ʿAjība.

Wording and scope. The short matn on repentance before the death-rattle checked.

Classical assessment. The compiler explicitly says ḥasan gharīb.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 3537.

R14 · Iblīs claims a hold over Adam’s offspring until death

Q 4:17–18 · Mursal report (not an established connected Prophetic hadith) · al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī, with no companion named

Identified source. al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān 1032 (Dār al-Tafsīr), X: 142; Ibn Ḥajar, al-Kāfī al-shāf, p.70

أن إبليس قال حين أهبط إلى الأرض: يا رب، وعزتك لا أفارق ابن آدم ما دام روحه في جسده. فقال: وعزتي لا أغلق عنه باب التوبة حتى يغرغر.

When Iblīs was sent down to earth, he said: “My Lord, by Your might I will not leave the son of Adam as long as his spirit remains within his body.” God said: “By My might, I shall not close the gate of repentance against him until he reaches the death-rattle.”

Textual / transmission note: This is the reported al-Ḥasan matn, distinct from the better-known Abū Saʿīd report about Satan misleading humankind and divine forgiveness. The opening wording in Ibn ʿAjība varies between “by Your might” and “by Your might and majesty.”

Wording and scope. The wording about Iblīs’ persistence and repentance until the death rattle is located.

Classical assessment. The displayed chain is mursal. A parallel from Abū Saʿīd is reported by Ibn Ḥajar; it does not by itself authenticate every clause of this version.

Sources: al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān 1032 (Dār al-Tafsīr), X:142; Ibn Ḥajar, al-Kāfī al-shāf, p.70.

R15 · Satan’s pledge and God’s continuing forgiveness; disputed interpolation

Q 4:17–18 · Prophetic hadith with a disputed added phrase · Abū Saʿīd, through Abū al-Haytham, Darrāj and Ibn Lahīʿa

Identified source. al-Baghawī, Maʿālim al-tanzīl, Q 4:17

إن الشيطان قال: وعزتك يا رب، لا أبرح أغوي عبادك ما دامت أرواحهم في أجسادهم. فقال الرب تبارك وتعالى: وعزتي وجلالي وارتفاع مكاني، لا أزال أغفر لهم ما استغفروني.

Satan said: “By Your might, Lord, I shall not cease leading Your servants astray so long as their souls remain in their bodies.” The Lord said: “By My might and majesty and the loftiness of My station, I shall continue forgiving them as long as they seek My forgiveness.”

Textual / transmission note: Ibn ʿAjība quotes a disputed wording containing wa-irtifāʿ makānī. A separate Aḥmad recension lacks the phrase, whereas al-Baghawī transmits a longer form containing it. The source and reliability of each route remain questions for classical isnād comparison; these divergent wordings alone do not establish whether the added phrase is authentic.

Wording and scope. The phrase “the loftiness of My station” (irtifāʿ makānī) occurs in al-Baghawī’s transmitted text.

Classical assessment. Al-Baghawī transmits this wording with a chain. The reliability of the various routes remains unsettled.

Sources: al-Baghawī, Maʿālim al-tanzīl, Q 4:17.

R16 · The widow of Abū Qays and the pre-Islamic inheritance of wives

Q 4:19 · Historical occasion-of-revelation account, not itself a verified Prophetic saying · Narrative transmitted without a complete chain in this passage

Identified source. al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān, Q 4:19 (group displayed under 4:18); al-Baghawī, Maʿālim al-tanzīl, Q 4:19

قالت: يا رسول الله إن أبا قيس توفي وورث نكاحي ابنه، وقد أضر بي وطول علي، فلا هو ينفق علي ولا يدخل بي ولا يخلي سبيلي، فقال لها النبي صلى الله عليه وسلم: «اقعدي في بيتك حتى يأتي فيك أمر الله». قالت: فانصرفت وسمعت بذلك النساء في المدينة فأتين النبي صلى الله عليه وسلم وهو في مسجد الفضيخ، فقلن: يا رسول الله، ما نحن إلا كهيئة كبشة، غير أنه لا ينكحنا الأبناء ونكحنا أبناء العم، فنزلت الآية.

She said: “Messenger of God, Abū Qays died and his son inherited control of my marriage; he has harmed me and made my confinement prolonged. He neither maintains me nor cohabits with me, nor frees me.” The Prophet is reported to have said, “Remain in your house until God brings His decree concerning you.” Women in Medina then heard of it and came to him in the

Mosque of al-Fuḍaykh, saying, “Messenger of God, we are in the same condition as Kubaysha, except it is not stepsons but cousins who do this.” Then, it is reported, the verse was revealed.

Textual / transmission note: This reproduces the substantial reported dialogue in Ibn ʿAjība’s own Arabic and is clearly distinguished from a verified matn in a named canonical collection. The legal point that women are not property to inherit is explicit in the Qurʾān regardless of the transmission status of the narrative.

Wording and scope. The whole narrative, including the other women’s visit at the mosque, is located in the earlier al-Thaʿlabī passage. Names and the mosque’s final letter differ in the digital witnesses.

Classical assessment. This paragraph is introduced as the exegetes’ account, without a complete chain. The earlier narrative is located, but not authenticated as an event.

Sources: al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān, Q 4:19 (group displayed under 4:18); al-Baghawī, Maʿālim al-tanzīl, Q 4:19.

R17 · The overburdened traveler and his mount

Q 4:19 · Weakly transmitted Prophetic simile; also found as mursal report · Jābir through Ibn al-Munkadir, Muḥammad b. Sūqa and Abū ʿAqīl Yaḥyā b. al-Mutawakkil

Identified source. al-Bazzār, Kashf al-astār 74; Abū al-Shaykh, al-Amthāl 229; al-Bayhaqī, al-Sunan al-kubrā 4931

إن هذا الدين متين، فأوغل فيه برفق، ولا تبغض إلى نفسك عبادة الله، فإن المنبت لا أرضًا قطع ولا ظهرًا أبقى.

This religion is firm, so enter deeply into it with gentleness. Do not make the worship of God hateful to yourself, for the rider who drives his mount to exhaustion neither covers the ground nor leaves the animal fit to carry him.

Textual / transmission note: Ibn ʿAjība cites the final proverb beginning «لا يكن أحدكم كالمنبت». The expanded wording is in al-Bayhaqī and the specialist collections. The authenticity of this particular isnād is weak, although the exhortation to religious moderation has other authentic support.

Wording and scope. The overburdened traveller proverb is present in the expanded report.

Classical assessment. Al-Bazzār and al-Bayhaqī explicitly record conflicting connected, mursal and ʿĀʾisha forms. Al-Bazzār notes Ibn al-Munkadir did not hear ʿĀʾisha. Al-Bukhārī's reported preference remains unverified.

Sources: al-Bazzār, Kashf al-astār 74; Abū al-Shaykh, al-Amthāl 229; al-Bayhaqī, al-Sunan al-kubrā 4931.

R18 · Women, perfume and prayer; the spurious "three"

Q 4:19 · Prophetic hadith with a spurious added numeral · Anas, through Thābit

Identified source. al-Nasāʾī 3939

حُبِّبَ إليَّ من الدنيا النساءُ والطِّيبُ، وجُعِلَت قُرَّةُ عيني في الصلاةِ.

Women and fragrance have been made dear to me in this world, and the delight of my eye has been placed in prayer.

Textual / transmission note: Ibn ʿAjība quotes «حُبِّب إلي من دنياكم ثلاث: الطيب والنساء وجعلت قرة عيني في الصلاة», including "three." That insertion is not part of the authenticated wording and is explicitly rejected by Ibn Ḥajar (al-Kāfī al-Shāf, p.49) and other critics. The authentic formulation distinguishes the two worldly beloved things from prayer, in which the Prophet finds his deepest delight.

Wording and scope. Women, perfume, and joy in prayer are present; this wording does not contain the numeral three.

Classical assessment. Al-Nasāʾī's text has no "three". Al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid 380, reports extensive unsuccessful searching for that addition and cites the same finding from earlier critics. Ibn ʿAjība's printed wording nevertheless contains "three".

Sources: al-Nasāʾī 3939; al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana 380.

R19 · A believing husband must not detest his believing wife

Q 4:19 · Prophetic hadith · Abū Hurayra

Identified source. Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1468b (full wording); 1469 supplies a parallel chain and refers back to the same wording

لا يفرك مؤمن مؤمنة، إن كره منها خلقًا رضي منها آخر، أو قال: غيره.

Let no believing man detest a believing woman. If he dislikes one character trait in her, he will be pleased with another—or, the narrator said, “a different one.”

The full source wording includes the narrator’s qualification “or he said a different one”; Ibn ʿAjība abbreviates it.

Wording and scope. Full lā yafrak matn is at 1468b. 1469 gives a parallel chain and bi-mithlihi, not the full wording.

Classical assessment. The report occurs in Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ: 1468b gives the full wording, and 1469 supplies a parallel chain.

Sources: Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 1468b (full wording); 1469 supplies a parallel chain and refers back to the same wording.

R20 · Marriage prohibitions extend through foster suckling

Q 4:23 · Prophetic hadith · Ibn ʿAbbās, through Jābir b. Zayd

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 2645

قال النبي صلى الله عليه وسلم في بنت حمزة: لا تحل لي، يحرم من الرضاع ما يحرم من النسب، هي بنت أخي من الرضاعة.

The Prophet said concerning Ḥamza’s daughter: “She is not lawful for me to marry. What is prohibited through suckling is what is prohibited through lineage. She is the daughter of my foster brother.”

Textual / transmission note: The complete wording of this short Bukhārī version supplies the concrete case behind the legal maxim quoted by Ibn ʿAjība. The exact conditions and duration required for fosterage to establish impediments are treated by jurists separately.

Wording and scope. The report about Ḥamza’s daughter and prohibited degrees of milk-kinship checked.

Classical assessment. In al-Bukhārī’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2645.

R21 · The captives at Awṭās

Q 4:24 · Reported text · Abū Saʿīd al-Khudrī

Identified source. Muslim 1456a

أَنَّ رَسُولَ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ يَوْمَ حُنَيْنٍ بَعَثَ جَيْشًا إِلَى أَوْطَاسٍ، فَلَقُوا عَدُوًّا فَقَاتَلُوهُمْ فَظَهَرُوا عَلَيْهِمْ وَأَصَابُوا لَهُمْ سَبَايَا، فَكَأَنَّ نَاسًا مِنْ أَصْحَابِ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ تَحَرَّجُوا مِنْ غِشْيَانِهِنَّ مِنْ أَجْلِ أَزْوَاجِهِنَّ مِنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ، فَأَنْزَلَ اللَّهُ عَزَّ وَجَلَّ فِي ذَلِكَ: {وَالْمُحْصَنَاتُ مِنَ النِّسَاءِ إِلَّا مَا مَلَكَتْ أَيْمَانُكُمْ}، أَيْ فَهُنَّ لَكُمْ حَلَالٌ إِذَا انْقَضَتْ عِدَّتُهُنَّ.

On the day of Ḥunayn the Messenger of God sent an army to Awṭās. They encountered an enemy, fought and prevailed, and took captives. Some Companions felt scruples about having intercourse with the captive women because they had husbands among the polytheists. Then God revealed concerning this: ‘And married women, except those whom your right hands possess’ [4:24], that is, [in the report’s explanatory wording,] they were lawful after the prescribed waiting period had ended.

Textual / transmission note: The contextual story is part of the transmitted report. The final explanatory wording beginning ‘that is’ should not be assumed to be the Prophet’s own direct speech; the circumstances and juristic implications belong to historical slavery law.

Wording and scope. The Awṭās captives report and 4:24 citation checked.

Classical assessment. In Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: Muslim 1456a.

R22 · The prohibition of temporary marriage

Q 4:24 · Reported text · Sabra al-Juhanī, transmitted by his son al-Rabīʿ

Identified source. Muslim 1406d

يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ إِنِّي قَدْ كُنْتُ أَذِنْتُ لَكُمْ فِي الِاسْتِمْتَاعِ مِنَ النِّسَاءِ، وَإِنَّ اللَّهَ قَدْ حَرَّمَ ذَلِكَ إِلَى يَوْمِ الْقِيَامَةِ، فَمَنْ كَانَ عِنْدَهُ مِنْهُنَّ شَيْءٌ فَلْيُخَلِّ سَبِيلَهُ، وَلَا تَأْخُذُوا مِمَّا آتَيْتُمُوهُنَّ شَيْئًا.

People, I had permitted you temporary enjoyment in marriage with women; now God has forbidden that until the Day of Resurrection. Whoever still has such a relationship should release the woman, and you must not take back anything you have given them.

Textual / transmission note: The full wording adds the command to release those still in such unions and not reclaim the gifts. Historical dating of permissions and prohibitions, and Ibn ʿAbbās's reported withdrawal, remain distinct source questions.

Wording and scope. The report contains the perpetual prohibition of temporary marriage and the instruction not to reclaim the bridal gift. The Arabic identifies al-Rabīʿ as transmitting from Sabra; the consulted site's English narrator sentence is misleading.

Classical assessment. In Muslim's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: Muslim 1406d.

R23 · 'Marry free women' — weak report

Q 4:25 · Reported text · Anas, through al-Ḍaḥḥāk b. Muzāḥim, Kathīr b. Sulaym and Salām b. Sawwār

Identified source. Ibn Mājah 1862

مَنْ أَرَادَ أَنْ يَلْقَى اللَّهَ طَاهِرًا مُطَهَّرًا، فَلْيَتَزَوَّجِ الْحَرَائِرَ.

Whoever wishes to meet God pure and purified, let him marry free women.

Textual / transmission note: The Arabic quoted in the tafsīr corresponds closely to this source. Inclusion by Ibn Mājah does not render the isnād sound. Later writers have used substantially stronger condemnatory language about it; the attribution should not be treated as established.

Wording and scope. Matn advising marriage to free women checked.

Classical assessment. Ibn al-Jawzī, al-Mawḍūʿāt II:261, reproduces this route and states that it does not validly come from the Prophet. This is Ibn al-Jawzī's own classical judgement.

Sources: Ibn Mājah 1862; Ibn al-Jawzī, al-Mawḍūʿāt II:261.

R24 · ‘Free women are the household’s well-being’ — severely defective

Q 4:25 · Reported text · Anas and Abū Hurayra in the combined al-Thaʿlabī version

Identified source. al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān 1084 (Dār al-Tafsīr), X: 231; al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana 399

الْحَرَائِرُ صَلَاحُ الْبَيْتِ، وَالْإِمَاءُ فَسَادُ الْبَيْتِ، أَوْ قَالَ: هَلَاكُ الْبَيْتِ.

Free women are the well-being of a household, while enslaved women are its corruption—or, he said, its ruin.

Textual / transmission note: The versions ‘corruption’ and ‘ruin’ are alternatives in the transmitted text. The claim is not a credible Prophetic statement and reproduces a historical social hierarchy without endorsing it.

Wording and scope. The combined free-women/slave-women narrative is found in al-Thaʿlabī’s chain through Aḥmad b. Muḥammad b. ʿUmar b. Yūnus and Yūnus b. Mirdās.

Classical assessment. Al-Sakhāwī identifies the former as abandoned and accused of lying by Abū Ḥātim, and the latter as unknown.

Sources: al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān 1084 (Dār al-Tafsīr), X:231; al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana 399.

R25 · Marry loving, fertile women — source wording differs

Q 4:27 · Reported text · Maʿqil b. Yasār, through Muʿāwiya b. Qurra, Manṣūr b. Zādhān and al-Mustalim b. Saʿīd

Identified source. Abū Dāwūd 2050; al-Nasāʾī 3227

جَاءَ رَجُلٌ إِلَى النَّبِيِّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ فَقَالَ: إِنِّي أَصَبْتُ امْرَأَةً ذَاتَ حَسَبٍ وَجَمَالٍ وَإِنَّهَا لَا تَلِدُ، أَفَأَتَزَوَّجُهَا؟ قَالَ: «لَا». ثُمَّ أَتَاهُ الثَّانِيَةَ فَنَهَاهُ، ثُمَّ أَتَاهُ الثَّالِثَةَ فَقَالَ: «تَزَوَّجُوا الْوَدُودَ الْوَلُودَ فَإِنِّي مُكَاثِرٌ بِكُمُ الْأُمَمَ».

A man came to the Prophet and said: ‘I have found a woman of good family and beauty, but she does not bear children. Should I marry her?’ He answered, ‘No.’ The man came a second time and was forbidden; on his third visit the Prophet said: ‘Marry women who are loving and fertile, for through you I shall exceed the communities in number.’

Textual / transmission note: Ibn ʿAjība quotes “Marry and beget children, for I shall boast of you before the nations on Resurrection Day.” This is not word-for-word the report printed here; it represents a cognate circulating formulation.

Wording and scope. The loving, fertile wife report and its repeated consultation are identified. Its precise wording differs from the concise formula quoted by Ibn ʿAjība.

Classical assessment. Al-ʿIrāqī expressly calls this chain ṣaḥīḥ in his takhrīj printed beneath Iḥyāʾ ʿulūm al-dīn II:42, note 2. The printed note names Abū Dāwūd, al-Nasāʾī and Maʿqil b. Yasār. His assessment concerns this chain; differing concise formulations have their own transmission questions.

Sources: Abū Dāwūd 2050; al-Nasāʾī 3227; al-ʿIrāqī, al-Mughnī, printed below Iḥyāʾ ʿulūm al-dīn II: 42, note2; PDF p.42.

R26 · The buyer’s and seller’s option

Q 4:29 · Reported text · Ibn ʿUmar, through Nāfiʿ

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 2107

إِنَّ الْمُتَبَايِعَيْنِ بِالْخِيَارِ فِي بَيْعِهِمَا مَا لَمْ يَتَفَرَّقَا، أَوْ يَكُونُ الْبَيْعُ خِيَارًا. قَالَ نَافِعٌ: وَكَانَ ابْنُ عُمَرَ إِذَا اشْتَرَى شَيْئًا يُعْجِبُهُ فَارَقَ صَاحِبَهُ.

The two parties to a sale possess an option in their transaction so long as they have not separated, or the sale is concluded by a [mutual] choice. Nāfiʿ said: When Ibn ʿUmar bought something that pleased him, he would separate from the seller.

Textual note: “a [mutual] choice” renders bayʿ khiyār in light of al-Bukhārī 2109, which also transmits “or one says to the other, ‘Choose.’” The concise Arabic is interpreted differently in the juristic discussion; this gloss is not a claim of agreement between all schools. Nāfiʿ’s observation about Ibn ʿUmar is a separate narrator’s statement, not additional Prophetic speech.

Wording and scope. Buyer/seller option and Nāfiʿ's appended account of Ibn ʿUmar's conduct checked.

Classical assessment. In al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2107.

R27 · ʿAmr b. al-ʿĀṣ: dry ablution on a cold night

Q 4:29 · Reported text · ʿAmr b. al-ʿĀṣ

Identified source. Abū Dāwūd 334

احْتَلَمْتُ فِي لَيْلَةٍ بَارِدَةٍ فِي غَزْوَةِ ذَاتِ السَّلَاسِلِ، فَأَشْفَقْتُ إِنِ اغْتَسَلْتُ أَنْ أَهْلِكَ، فَتَيَمَّمْتُ ثُمَّ صَلَّيْتُ بِأَصْحَابِي الصُّبْحَ، فَذَكَرُوا ذَلِكَ لِلنَّبِيِّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ، فَقَالَ: «يَا عَمْرُو، صَلَّيْتَ بِأَصْحَابِكَ وَأَنْتَ جُنُبٌ؟» فَأَخْبَرْتُهُ بِالَّذِي مَنَعَنِي مِنَ الِاغْتِسَالِ وَقُلْتُ: إِنِّي سَمِعْتُ اللَّهَ يَقُولُ: {وَلَا تَقْتُلُوا أَنْفُسَكُمْ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كَانَ بِكُمْ رَحِيمًا}. فَضَحِكَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ وَلَمْ يَقُلْ شَيْئًا.

I experienced a nocturnal emission on a cold night during the expedition of Dhāt al-Salāsil. I feared I would perish if I washed, so I performed dry ablution and led my companions in the dawn prayer. They mentioned this to the Prophet. He asked, 'Amr, did you lead them while in a state of major impurity?' I explained what prevented me from washing, and said, 'I heard God say, "Do not kill yourselves. God has indeed been merciful to you."' The Messenger of God laughed and said nothing.

Textual / transmission note: This narrative is longer than its quotation in the tafsīr and explicitly presents the Prophet's tacit approval. Other chains and minor wording variants exist.

Wording and scope. Cold-night tayammum, 4:29, and the Prophet's laughter checked. Abū Dāwūd explicitly distinguishes the Egyptian ʿAbd al-Raḥmān b. Jubayr from the son of Jubayr b. Nufayr.

Classical assessment. Primary location and wording verified; no express classical grading in the displayed entry.

Sources: Abū Dāwūd 334.

R28 · The severe warnings concerning suicide

Q 4:30 · Reported text · Abū Hurayra

Identified source. Muslim 109a

مَنْ قَتَلَ نَفْسَهُ بِحَدِيدَةٍ فَحَدِيدَتُهُ فِي يَدِهِ يَتَوَجَّأُ بِهَا فِي بَطْنِهِ فِي نَارِ جَهَنَّمَ خَالِدًا مُخَلَّدًا فِيهَا أَبَدًا، وَمَنْ شَرِبَ سَمًّا فَقَتَلَ نَفْسَهُ فَهُوَ يَتَحَسَّاهُ فِي نَارِ جَهَنَّمَ خَالِدًا مُخَلَّدًا فِيهَا أَبَدًا، وَمَنْ تَرَدَّى مِنْ جَبَلٍ فَقَتَلَ نَفْسَهُ فَهُوَ يَتَرَدَّى فِي نَارِ جَهَنَّمَ خَالِدًا مُخَلَّدًا فِيهَا أَبَدًا.

Whoever kills himself with an iron weapon will have that weapon in his hand, repeatedly stabbing himself in the belly in Hellfire for ever; whoever drinks poison and kills himself will continue drinking it there for ever; whoever throws himself from a mountain and dies will continue falling there for ever.

Textual / transmission note: The same theme also appears in Muslim 110a/110d in shorter forms. The words ‘for ever’ are in this version. The theological reconciliation of the warning with beliefs about the fate of grave sinners is not the same as merely authenticating the matn.

Wording and scope. All three suicide-warning forms checked.

Classical assessment. In Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: Muslim 109a.

R29 · The seven destructive sins

Q 4:31 · Reported text · Abū Hurayra

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 2766

اجْتَنِبُوا السَّبْعَ الْمُوبِقَاتِ. قَالُوا: يَا رَسُولَ اللَّهِ وَمَا هُنَّ؟ قَالَ: الشِّرْكُ بِاللَّهِ، وَالسِّحْرُ، وَقَتْلُ النَّفْسِ الَّتِي حَرَّمَ اللَّهُ إِلَّا بِالْحَقِّ، وَأَكْلُ الرِّبَا، وَأَكْلُ مَالِ الْيَتِيمِ، وَالتَّوَلِّي يَوْمَ الزَّحْفِ، وَقَذْفُ الْمُحْصَنَاتِ الْمُؤْمِنَاتِ الْغَافِلَاتِ.

Avoid the seven destructive sins. They asked, ‘Messenger of God, what are they?’ He replied: ‘Associating partners with God, sorcery, killing a life which God has forbidden except with right, consuming usury, consuming an orphan’s property, turning away on the day the armies meet, and slandering chaste, unsuspecting believing women.’

Textual / transmission note: The seven are an attested list of major sins; it does not imply that every other major sin is excluded.

Wording and scope. All seven ruinous sins checked.

Classical assessment. In al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2766.

R30 · A call from beneath the Throne concerning claims between people

Q 4:31 · Reported text · Anas in the al-Baghawī parallel

Identified source. al-Baghawī, Sharḥ al-Sunna 4365, XV:197; related text cited by al-ʿIrāqī in Takhrīj al-Iḥyāʾ III:225

ينادي ملك من بطنان العرش يوم القيامة: يا أمة محمد، إن الله قد عفا عنكم جميعا المؤمنين والمؤمنات، تواهبوا المظالم، وادخلوا الجنة برحمتي.

An angel will call from the interior of the Throne on the Day of Resurrection: "Community of Muḥammad, God has pardoned you all, believing men and believing women. Release one another from claims for wrongs, and enter the Garden by My mercy."

Al-Baghawī 4365 supplies this wording and records al-Malīḥī's variant opening, "A caller will call on the Day of Resurrection from the interior of the Throne." Al-ʿIrāqī cites another form, addressed to Muḥammad's community, which distinguishes divine claims from mutual claims and calls its chain weak. Ibn ʿAjība's quotation instead addresses the "community of Aḥmad."

Wording and scope. Al-Baghawī's witness includes the address to Muḥammad's community. Al-ʿIrāqī cites a different form of the report.

Classical assessment. The al-Baghawī chain runs through al-Ḥusayn b. Dāwūd al-Balkhī. Al-ʿIrāqī gives an explicit weak-chain judgement in his notes reproduced with the Iḥyāʾ. It concerns his cited form and does not establish a grade for every route.

Sources: al-Baghawī, Sharḥ al-Sunna 4365, XV:197; related text cited by al-ʿIrāqī in Takhrīj al-Iḥyāʾ III:225; al-ʿIrāqī, Takhrīj al-Iḥyāʾ, forgiveness chapter.

R31 · Prohibition of marrying a woman and her aunt simultaneously

Q 4:24 · Reported text · Abū Hurayra

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 5109

لَا يُجْمَعُ بَيْنَ الْمَرْأَةِ وَعَمَّتِهَا، وَلَا بَيْنَ الْمَرْأَةِ وَخَالَتِهَا.

A woman must not be combined in marriage with her paternal aunt, nor with her maternal aunt.

Textual / transmission note: Ibn ʿAjība refers to the rule as established by the Sunna without quoting the full Prophetic formula. The report provides a contextual comparison.

Wording and scope. The report contains both paternal and maternal aunt clauses. Ibn ʿAjība refers to the rule without quoting this full text.

Classical assessment. The report occurs in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5109.

R32 · Ask God of His bounty

4:32 · Prophetic report · Ibn Masʿūd in the criticized connected route

Identified source. al-Tirmidhī 3571

سَلُوا اللَّهَ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ عَزَّ وَجَلَّ يُحِبُّ أَنْ يُسْأَلَ وَأَفْضَلُ الْعِبَادَةِ انْتِظَارُ الْفَرَجِ

Ask God from His bounty, for God, mighty and glorious, loves to be asked; the finest worship is awaiting relief.

Ibn ʿAjība quotes the opening clauses only; the final clause belongs to the identified transmitted version.

Wording and scope. Asking God's bounty and awaiting relief checked.

Classical assessment. The compiler criticizes Ḥammād b. Wāqid's retention and says the alternative through Isrāʾīl, Ḥakīm b. Jubayr and an unnamed man is mursal and more likely correct.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 3571.

R33 · One who does not ask God

4:32 · Prophetic report · Abū Hurayra

Identified source. al-Tirmidhī 3373

مَنْ لَمْ يَسْأَلِ اللَّهَ يَغْضَبْ عَلَيْهِ

Whoever does not ask God, He is displeased with him.

Short report; does not establish an obligation to verbalize every desire.

Wording and scope. The short saying on failing to ask God checked.

Classical assessment. The compiler says he knows it only by this route; no unambiguous express strength grade occurs. The transmitter-name gloss in the consulted electronic text remains independently unverified.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 3373.

R34 · Ibn ʿAbbās on covenant inheritance

4:33 · Companion exegetical report (mawqūf) · Ibn ʿAbbās, through Saʿīd b. Jubayr

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 4580

{وَلِكُلٍّ جَعَلْنَا مَوَالِيَ} قَالَ وَرَثَةً. {وَالَّذِينَ عَاقَدَتْ أَيْمَانُكُمْ} كَانَ الْمُهَاجِرُونَ لَمَّا قَدِمُوا الْمَدِينَةَ يَرِثُ الْمُهَاجِرُ الْأَنْصَارِيَّ دُونَ ذَوِي رَحِمِهِ لِلْأُخُوَّةِ الَّتِي آخَى النَّبِيُّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ بَيْنَهُمْ، فَلَمَّا نَزَلَتْ {وَلِكُلٍّ جَعَلْنَا مَوَالِيَ} نُسِخَتْ، ثُمَّ قَالَ {وَالَّذِينَ عَاقَدَتْ أَيْمَانُكُمْ} مِنَ النَّصْرِ، وَالرِّفَادَةِ وَالنَّصِيحَةِ، وَقَدْ ذَهَبَ الْمِيرَاثُ وَيُوصِي لَهُ.

On “For each We have appointed heirs,” Ibn ʿAbbās said, “Heirs.” Regarding those joined by pledged right hands, he explained that emigrants originally inherited from the Helpers by their bond of brotherhood instead of the relatives. That inheritance was replaced, while mutual help, material assistance and counsel remained, as did the possibility of a bequest.

Full substantive matn as presented in al-Bukhārī 4580, without the isnād. Other versions differ in word order and in who inherits whom.

Wording and scope. Covenant inheritance, abrogation, continuing assistance/counsel and bequest checked.

Classical assessment. Connected companion exegesis in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 4580.

R35 · Be mindful of God and He will protect you

4:34 · Prophetic report · Ibn ʿAbbās, through Ḥanash al-Ṣanʿānī and Qays b. Ḥajjāj

Identified source. al-Tirmidhī 2516

يَا غُلَامُ إِنِّي أُعَلِّمُكَ كَلِمَاتٍ: احْفَظِ اللَّهَ يَحْفَظْكَ، احْفَظِ اللَّهَ تَجِدْهُ تُجَاهَكَ، إِذَا سَأَلْتَ فَاسْأَلِ اللَّهَ، وَإِذَا اسْتَعَنْتَ فَاسْتَعِنْ بِاللَّهِ، وَاعْلَمْ أَنَّ الْأُمَّةَ لَوِ اجْتَمَعَتْ عَلَى أَنْ يَنْفَعُوكَ بِشَيْءٍ لَمْ يَنْفَعُوكَ إِلَّا بِشَيْءٍ قَدْ كَتَبَهُ اللَّهُ لَكَ، وَلَوِ اجْتَمَعُوا عَلَى أَنْ يَضُرُّوكَ بِشَيْءٍ لَمْ يَضُرُّوكَ إِلَّا بِشَيْءٍ قَدْ كَتَبَهُ اللَّهُ عَلَيْكَ. رُفِعَتِ الْأَقْلَامُ وَجَفَّتِ الصُّحُفُ.

Young man, I shall teach you words: guard the claims of God and He will guard you; guard them and you will find Him before you. When asking, ask God; when seeking help, seek His help. If all people gathered to benefit you, they could give only what God had written for you; if all gathered to harm you, they could harm you only in a way God had written. The pens have been raised and the pages have dried.

The commentator quotes the first imperative, not this entire long form.

Wording and scope. The long instruction and closing raised pens/dried pages checked.

Classical assessment. The compiler explicitly says ḥasan ṣaḥīḥ. Al-Layth's parallel transmission is distinct from the upper route containing Ibn Lahīʿa.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 2516.

R36 · The best woman according to a transmitted report

4:34 · Prophetic report · Abū Hurayra, through Saʿīd al-Maqburī and Ibn ʿAjlān

Identified source. al-Nasāʾī 3231

قِيلَ لِرَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ: أَيُّ النِّسَاءِ خَيْرٌ؟ قَالَ: الَّتِي تَسُرُّهُ إِذَا نَظَرَ، وَتُطِيعُهُ إِذَا أَمَرَ، وَلَا تُخَالِفُهُ فِي نَفْسِهَا وَمَالِهَا بِمَا يَكْرَهُ.

The Messenger of God was asked which woman is best. He replied: one who brings him joy when he looks at her, obeys when instructed, and does not oppose him concerning herself or her property in a manner he dislikes.

Ibn ʿAjība adds that the verse was recited; this element is not in al-Nasāʾī 3231.

Wording and scope. The best-wife saying checked, including mālihā, her property. Recitation of the verse is not in this source version.

Classical assessment. The source location and wording are established; a named classical critical judgement remains unverified.

Sources: al-Nasāʾī 3231.

R37 · Hang the whip where the household sees it

4:34 · Prophetic attribution with disputed routes · Ibn ʿAbbās, with distinct family routes

Identified source. al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-kabīr 10671–10672; al-Haythamī, Majmaʿ VIII:106; al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid 701

عَلِّقُوا السَّوْطَ حَيْثُ يَرَاهُ أَهْلُ الْبَيْتِ

Hang the whip where the people of the household can see it.

This short version differs from longer forms adding “for that is a discipline for them.” Other authentic reports restrict striking.

Wording and scope. The short hanging-whip instruction and added ‘discipline’ clause occur in different routes.

Classical assessment. Al-Haythamī calls al-Ṭabarānī’s chains ḥasan. Al-Sakhāwī separately notes weakness in the Ibn Abī Laylā route and in the Jābir parallel through ʿAbbād b. Kathīr. These are assessments of different routes.

Sources: al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-kabīr 10671–10672; al-Haythamī, Majmaʿ VIII:106; al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid 701.

R38 · The repentant is like one without sin

4:34 · Prophetic report · Ibn Masʿūd through his son Abū ʿUbayda

Identified source. Ibn Mājah 4250

التَّائِبُ مِنَ الذَّنْبِ كَمَنْ لَا ذَنْبَ لَهُ

One who turns in repentance from a sin is like one who has no sin.

Quote is embedded parenthetically in the commentary.

Wording and scope. The complete short repentance saying checked.

Classical assessment. Al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid 313, notes Abū ʿUbayda's lack of hearing from his father, while reporting Ibn Ḥajar's improvement of the saying through corroboration.

Sources: Ibn Mājah 4250; al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana 313.

R39 · Souls are like troops gathered together

4:34 · Prophetic report · ʿĀʾisha in al-Bukhārī; Abū Hurayra in Muslim

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 3336; Muslim 2638a

الْأَرْوَاحُ جُنُودٌ مُجَنَّدَةٌ، فَمَا تَعَارَفَ مِنْهَا ائْتَلَفَ، وَمَا تَنَاكَرَ مِنْهَا اخْتَلَفَ

Souls are assembled troops: those among them that recognize one another come together, and those that differ become estranged.

Complete short prophetic matn; quoting only the first phrase does not convey its qualification.

Wording and scope. The complete short matn checked in both. Al-Bukhārī's displayed entry begins with a suspended attribution to al-Layth; Muslim supplies a connected Abū Hurayra chain.

Classical assessment. Muslim transmits the report with a sound connected chain; al-Bukhārī's form has a suspended attribution.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 3336; Muslim 2638a.

R40 · Asmāʾ and al-Zubayr: household anecdote

4:34 · Companion/historical report, not a Prophetic hadith · Asmāʾ through Fāṭima bt. al-Mundhir, Hishām b. ʿUrwa, Abū Usāma and Ibn al-Muthannā

Identified source. al-Ṭabarī, Tahdhīb al-āthār, Musnad ʿUmar, I:414, no.688

كُنْتُ رَابِعَ نِسْوَةٍ عِنْدَ الزُّبَيْرِ بْنِ الْعَوَّامِ، فَإِذَا غَضِبَ عَلَى إِحْدَانَا، ضَرَبَهَا بِعُودِ الْمِشْجَبِ حَتَّى يَنْكَسِرَ

I was the fourth of the women married to al-Zubayr; when he grew angry at one of us he struck her with the wooden rack-rod until it broke.

Al-Ṭabarī, Tahdhīb al-āthār, Musnad ʿUmar I:414, no. 688, supplies an earlier source and chain. Ibn ʿAjība quotes a shorter form. A named classical grade for that entry remains unverified.

Wording and scope. Al-Ṭabarī, Tahdhīb al-āthār, Musnad ʿUmar I:414, no. 688, gives the al-Zubayr/Asmāʾ rod narrative with a complete chain. Ibn ʿAjība quotes a shorter form.

Classical assessment. No explicit classical grade appears in this entry; locating its chain does not amount to independently authenticating it.

Sources: al-Ṭabarī, Tahdhīb al-āthār, Musnad ʿUmar, I:414, no.688.

R41 · Saʿd ibn al-Rabīʿ and Ḥabība as an occasion of revelation

4:34 · Asbāb al-nuzūl report with disputed connection · Muqātil's named-couple narrative; al-Ḥasan al-Baṣrī in additional mursal forms

Identified source. al-Wāḥidī, Asbāb al-nuzūl, Q 4:34

أَرَدْنَا أَمْرًا، وَأَرَادَ اللَّهُ أَمْرًا، وَالَّذِي أَرَادَ اللَّهُ خَيْرٌ

We intended one matter, and God intended another; what God intended is better.

This is the cited sentence from the longer tafsīr story reproduced in the commentary. The quotation's attribution remains unauthenticated.

Wording and scope. The Saʿd/Ḥabība occasion narrative and several versions of 'we intended/God intended' are found.

Classical assessment. The named-couple paragraph has no complete chain here; additional versions are mursal. The names, dialogue and revelation sequence remain unauthenticated.

Sources: al-Wāḥidī, Asbāb al-nuzūl, Q 4:34.

R42 · Only fear or longing removes desire

4:35 · Sufi aphorism—not a Prophetic hadith · Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh; aphorism, not Prophetic speech

Identified source. Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh, al-Ḥikam, “Nothing removes desire from the heart except a disturbing fear or an unsettling longing”, with al-Sharnūbī’s commentary

لَا يُخْرِجُ الشَّهْوَةَ مِنَ الْقَلْبِ إِلَّا خَوْفٌ مُزْعِجٌ أَوْ شَوْقٌ مُقْلِقٌ

Nothing removes desire from the heart except a disturbing fear or an unsettling longing.

In this passage “in the Ḥikam” refers to Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh’s aphorism collection.

Wording and scope. The fear/desire/longing saying is identified in the primary aphorism text.

Classical assessment. The saying occurs in Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh’s al-Ḥikam. It is a literary attribution, to which no hadith grade applies. The attribution rests on the cited aphorism text, without a manuscript comparison.

Sources: Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh, al-Ḥikam, “Nothing removes desire from the heart except a disturbing fear or an unsettling longing”, with al-Sharnūbī’s commentary.

R43 · Feeding a needy person and caring for an orphan

4:36 · Prophetic report with disputed grade · Abū Hurayra, through an unnamed man, Abū ʿImrān al-Jawnī and Ḥammād b. Salama

Identified source. Aḥmad 7576 (Risāla), XIII:21; ʿAbd b. Ḥumayd 1424; al-Ṭabarānī, Makārim al-akhlāq 107

أَنَّ رَجُلًا شَكَا إِلَى رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ قَسْوَةَ قَلْبِهِ، فَقَالَ لَهُ: إِنْ أَرَدْتَ أَنْ يَلِينَ قَلْبُكَ، فَأَطْعِمِ الْمِسْكِينَ، وَامْسَحْ رَأْسَ الْيَتِيمِ

A man complained to the Messenger of God of hardness of heart. He told him: If you wish your heart to become gentle, feed the needy and stroke the head of an orphan.

The text is complete for this short Aḥmad route. The chain passes through “a man” whose identity is not given.

Wording and scope. The soft-heart/orphan text and three equivalent source chains are located.

Classical assessment. The cited route contains an unnamed intermediary. This limitation concerns that chain; the status of every possible parallel is not established.

Sources: Aḥmad 7576 (Risāla), XIII:21; ʿAbd b. Ḥumayd 1424; al-Ṭabarānī, Makārim al-akhlāq 107.

R44 · The neighbour’s catalogue of rights

4:36 · Prophetic attribution, extensive version · ʿAbd Allāh b. ʿAmr through ʿAmr b. Shuʿayb’s father, ʿAṭāʾ al-Khurāsānī, his son ʿUthmān and Suwayd b. ʿAbd al-ʿAzīz

Identified source. Ibn ʿAdī, al-Kāmil V:171; al-Bayhaqī, Shuʿab al-īmān 9560; al-Dhahabī, Ḥaqq al-jār

مَنْ أَغْلَقَ بَابَهُ دُونَ جَارِهِ مَخَافَةً عَلَى أَهْلِهِ وَمَالِهِ فَلَيْسَ ذَلِكَ بِمُؤْمِنٍ، وَلَيْسَ بِمُؤْمِنٍ مَنْ لَمْ يَأْمَنْ جَارُهُ بَوَائِقَهُ. أَتَدْرِي مَا حَقُّ الْجَارِ؟ إِذَا اسْتَعَانَكَ أَعَنْتَهُ، وَإِذَا اسْتَقْرَضَكَ أَقْرَضْتَهُ، وَإِذَا افْتَقَرَ عُدْتَ عَلَيْهِ، وَإِذَا مَرِضَ عُدْتَهُ، وَإِذَا أَصَابَهُ خَيْرٌ هَنَّأْتَهُ، وَإِذَا أَصَابَتْهُ مُصِيبَةٌ عَزَّيْتَهُ، وَإِذَا مَاتَ اتَّبَعْتَ جَنَازَتَهُ، وَلَا تَسْتَطِلْ عَلَيْهِ بِالْبِنَاءِ تَحْجُبَ عَنْهُ الرِّيحَ إِلَّا بِإِذْنِهِ، وَلَا تُؤْذِهِ بِقِتَارِ قِدْرِكَ إِلَّا أَنْ تَغْرِفَ لَهُ مِنْهَا، وَإِنِ اشْتَرَيْتَ فَاكِهَةً فَأَهْدِ لَهُ، فَإِنْ لَمْ تَفْعَلْ فَأَدْخِلْهَا سِرًّا، وَلَا يَخْرُجْ بِهَا وَلَدُكَ لِيُغِيظَ بِهَا وَلَدَهُ. أَتَدْرُونَ مَا حَقُّ الْجَارِ؟ وَالَّذِي نَفْسِي بِيَدِهِ مَا يَبْلُغُ حَقَّ الْجَارِ إِلَّا قَلِيلٌ مِمَّنْ رَحِمَهُ اللَّهُ. وَمَا زَالَ يُوصِيهِمْ بِالْجَارِ حَتَّى ظَنُّوا أَنَّهُ سَيُوَرِّثُهُ. ثُمَّ قَالَ رَسُولُ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ: الْجِيرَانُ ثَلَاثَةٌ: فَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ لَهُ ثَلَاثَةُ حُقُوقٍ، وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ لَهُ حَقَّانِ، وَمِنْهُمْ مَنْ لَهُ حَقٌّ. فَأَمَّا الَّذِي لَهُ ثَلَاثَةُ حُقُوقٍ فَالْجَارُ الْمُسْلِمُ

الْقَرِيبُ، لَهُ حَقُّ الْجِوَارِ وَحَقُّ الْإِسْلَامِ وَحَقُّ الْقَرَابَةِ؛ وَأَمَّا الَّذِي لَهُ حَقَّانِ فَالْجَارُ الْمُسْلِمُ لَهُ حَقُّ الْجِوَارِ وَحَقُّ الْإِسْلَامِ؛ وَأَمَّا الَّذِي لَهُ حَقٌّ وَاحِدٌ فَالْجَارُ الْكَافِرُ لَهُ حَقُّ الْجِوَارِ. قلنا يا رسول الله نطعمهم من نسكنا؟ قال: لا تطعموا المشركين شيئا من النسك.

Whoever shuts his door against his neighbour for fear concerning his family and property is not [acting as] a believer, nor is the person whose neighbour is not safe from his harm. Do you know the right of a neighbour? If he seeks your help, help him; if he asks you for a loan, lend to him; if he becomes poor, attend to his need; if he becomes ill, visit him; if good fortune comes to him, congratulate him; if misfortune strikes him, offer him condolences; if he dies, accompany his funeral. Do not raise your building so high that you cut off the wind from him without his consent. Do not distress him by the smell of what is cooking in your pot unless you share a portion with him. If you buy fruit, give him some as a gift; if you do not do so, carry it indoors discreetly, and do not let your child go out displaying it to provoke envy in his child. Do you know the right of a neighbour? By Him in whose hand my soul lies, only a few of those on whom God has mercy fulfil the neighbour's rights. He continued commending the neighbour to them until they thought he would make him an heir. Then the Messenger of God, may God bless him and grant him peace, said: Neighbours are of three kinds. Some have three rights, others two rights, and others one right. The Muslim neighbour who is also a relative has three rights: the right of neighbourhood, the right of Islam, and the right of kinship. A Muslim neighbour who is not a relative has two rights: the right of neighbourhood and the right of Islam. A non-Muslim neighbour has one right: the right of neighbourhood. We asked, "Messenger of God, shall we feed them from our sacrificial offerings?" He said, "Do not give the polytheists anything from the sacrificial offerings."

The longer Ibn ʿAdī/al-Bayhaqī witness includes the final exchange about sacrificial offerings. It extends beyond Ibn ʿAjība's quotation. The critics' objections concern its transmitted attribution; the shorter parallels have distinct wording and transmission.

Wording and scope. The longer Ibn ʿAdī/al-Bayhaqī witness ends with a question and answer about sacrificial offerings.

Classical assessment. Al-Bayhaqī criticizes Suwayd, ʿUthmān and his father as weak. Al-Dhahabī explicitly calls Suwayd and ʿUthmān weak and the separate Muʿādh route disconnected.

Sources: Ibn ʿAdī, al-Kāmil V:171; al-Bayhaqī, Shuʿab al-īmān 9560; al-Dhahabī, Ḥaqq al-jār.

R45 · The best of you to the family

4:36 · Prophetic report · ʿĀʾisha, through ʿUrwa and Hishām

Identified source. al-Tirmidhī 3895

خَيْرُكُمْ خَيْرُكُمْ لِأَهْلِهِ وَأَنَا خَيْرُكُمْ لِأَهْلِي وَإِذَا مَاتَ صَاحِبُكُمْ فَدَعُوهُ

The best among you is the one who is best to his family, and I am the best among you to mine. When your companion dies, leave him be.

Ibn ʿAjība cites the first two clauses. The final clause belongs to this exact al-Tirmidhī version; its presence in other variants requires separate evidence.

Wording and scope. Family-kindness clauses and the final companion-death clause checked.

Classical assessment. The compiler says ḥasan gharīb ṣaḥīḥ for al-Thawrī's transmission and separately records a mursal Hishām–ʿUrwa form.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 3895.

R46 · The dying injunction concerning prayer and dependants

4:36 · Attributed last advice, multiple forms · ʿAlī, through Umm Mūsā and Mughīra

Identified source. Ibn Mājah 2698

كَانَ آخِرُ كَلَامِ النَّبِيِّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ: الصَّلَاةَ وَمَا مَلَكَتْ أَيْمَانُكُمْ

The Prophet's last words were: "Prayer—and those whom your right hands possess."

This includes a narrator's attribution ("his last words"), not only a quoted phrase. The word "prayer" is repeated in some other variants.

Wording and scope. The narrator's last-words frame and prayer/dependants injunction checked.

Classical assessment. The source location and wording are established; classical assessments of this route and the separate corroborating routes remain unverified.

Sources: Ibn Mājah 2698.

R47 · The angel Gabriel's repeated charge concerning neighbours

4:36 · Independent sound contextual report · ʿĀʾisha, through ʿAmra

Identified source. al-Bukhārī 6014

مَا زَالَ يُوصِينِي جِبْرِيلُ بِالْجَارِ حَتَّى ظَنَنْتُ أَنَّهُ سَيُوَرِّثُهُ

Gabriel continued to charge me concerning the neighbour until I thought that he would give the neighbour an inheritance entitlement.

Ibn ʿAjība does not quote this report directly in the passage. Its sound general theme differs from H042's unsound detailed list.

Wording and scope. This short report concerns Gabriel's repeated injunctions about the neighbour. Ibn ʿAjība does not quote it in this passage.

Classical assessment. In al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 6014.

R48 · The Prophet warned men against striking wives

4:34 · Independent contextual hadith · Iyās b. ʿAbd Allāh b. Abī Dhubāb

Identified source. Abū Dāwūd 2146

لَا تَضْرِبُوا إِمَاءَ اللَّهِ. فَجَاءَ عُمَرُ إِلَى رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ فَقَالَ: ذَئِرْنَ النِّسَاءُ عَلَى أَزْوَاجِهِنَّ. فَرَخَّصَ فِي ضَرْبِهِنَّ. فَأَطَافَ بِآلِ رَسُولِ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ نِسَاءٌ كَثِيرٌ يَشْكُونَ أَزْوَاجَهُنَّ، فَقَالَ النَّبِيُّ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ: لَقَدْ طَافَ بِآلِ مُحَمَّدٍ نِسَاءٌ كَثِيرٌ يَشْكُونَ أَزْوَاجَهُنَّ لَيْسَ أُولَئِكَ بِخِيَارِكُمْ.

Do not strike the female servants of God. After ʿUmar reported that women were defying their husbands, permission was given in the reported circumstances. Many women then came to the Prophet's household complaining of their husbands, and he said: Many women have come to Muḥammad's household complaining of their husbands; those men are not the best among you.

Contextual comparison, not a quotation from Ibn ʿAjība's 4:34 passage.

Wording and scope. All stages of the report checked: prohibition, ʿUmar's complaint, permission, women's complaints, final criticism of their husbands. The source records a variant name in the intermediary chain.

Classical assessment. Ibn Ḥajar, al-Iṣāba I:92, entry 379, describes the report transmitted by Abū Dāwūd and al-Nasāʾī from Iyās as having a sound chain. The same entry records Ibn Ḥibbān's reservations about companionship, Ibn al-Sakan's observation that hearing was not explicit, and al-Bukhārī's statement that companionship was not known. These qualifications apply to that route and limit an unqualified ṣaḥīḥ label. The report is a contextual comparison; Ibn ʿAjība does not quote it in this passage.

Sources: Abū Dāwūd 2146.

Transmission and attribution

Ibn Ḥajar describes the report transmitted by Abū Dāwūd and al-Nasāʾī from Iyās as having a sound chain. In the same entry he records Ibn Ḥibbān's reservations about companionship, Ibn al-Sakan's observation that hearing was not explicit, and al-Bukhārī's statement that companionship was not known. These qualifications limit an unqualified ṣaḥīḥ label. Abū Dāwūd 2146 supplies the report text.

Limits of the evidence. This is one classical assessment with its qualifications. Two electronic transcriptions agree, but the corresponding page of the earlier print remains unverified in facsimile. The assessment does not establish agreement about every route. This report is a contextual comparison and is not quoted by Ibn ʿAjība at this passage.

Al-Iṣāba fī tamyīz al-ṣaḥāba; Al-Iṣāba excerpt under the narrator Iyās b. ʿAbd Allāh b. Abī Dhubāb

Additional source references

Further references for quotations, variant wordings and classical assessments. Each source supports the specific saying or passage identified in its entry.

XII-S001 · Divine friendship and supererogatory worship

B006, B065

Source. al-Bukhārī 6502

The report contains hostility to God's friend, obligatory and supererogatory works, and the hearing/sight/hand/foot clauses. Its displayed wording does not contain the additional tongue or 'through Me' clauses found in some retellings.

Assessment. Abū Hurayra's report in al-Bukhārī’s Ṣaḥīḥ; the additional clauses need their own textual witnesses.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 6502.

XII-S002 · Spend, and I shall spend upon you

B008, B187

Source. al-Bukhārī 5352

The core divine saying is present. It does not establish the separate clause about not fearing impoverishment from the Lord of the Throne.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī’s Ṣaḥīḥ; core saying only.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5352.

XII-S003 · Three signs of hypocrisy

B013

Source. al-Bukhārī 33

Three signs—lying, breaking a promise, betraying a trust—occur in Abū Hurayra's report.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; distinguish the four-sign form.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 33.

XII-S004 · Four traits of hypocrisy

B013

Source. al-Bukhārī 34

The four-trait form is transmitted from ʿAbd Allāh b. ʿAmr; it is a distinct report, not the identical chain of the three-sign form.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 34.

XII-S005 · A person is with those he loves

B015

Source. al-Bukhārī 6168

The concise saying is located from Ibn Masʿūd. Wording explicitly mentioning being gathered with a people is a parallel formulation rather than this exact matn.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; substantive parallel.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 6168.

XII-S006 · The world's worth and a gnat's wing

B027

Source. al-Tirmidhī 2320

The saying about withholding water from a disbeliever if the world equalled a gnat's wing is transmitted from Sahl b. Saʿd.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī himself calls this report ṣaḥīḥ gharīb. This compiler's statement is distinguished from modern webpage grading.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 2320.

XII-S007 · Warning to Fāṭima and kin

B055

Source. al-Bukhārī 2753

The warning to relatives and Fāṭima is present. Buying oneself from God is addressed to Quraysh collectively; the final address to Fāṭima says she may ask for his wealth but he cannot avail her against God.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī’s Ṣaḥīḥ; Ibn ʿAjība's wording condenses the addresses.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2753.

XII-S008 · Help me through frequent prostration

B055

Source. Muslim 489

Rabiʿa b. Kaʿb al-Aslamī asks for companionship in the Garden and receives the instruction to assist through frequent prostration.

Assessment. Located in Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: Muslim 489.

XII-S009 · Following earlier communities

B058

Source. al-Bukhārī 3456

The span/cubit and lizard-hole images, followed by the Jews-and-Christians exchange, are present in Abū Saʿīd's report.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 3456.

XII-S010 · Receiving the rain

B097

Source. Muslim 898

Anas reports the Prophet exposing part of his body by drawing back his garment because the rain had newly come from its Lord. This wording does not explicitly mention turning his face to it.

Assessment. Located in Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ; the core practice is confirmed, the face detail is not established by this version.

Sources: Muslim 898.

XII-S011 · Supplication upon bereavement

B093

Source. Muslim 918a

Umm Salama's calamity supplication and her subsequent marriage are present.

Assessment. Located in Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: Muslim 918a.

XII-S012 · The House of Praise

B092

Source. al-Tirmidhī 1021

The two questions about taking the child and the fruit of the servant's heart, followed by praise and the House of Praise, are present.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī himself calls it ḥasan gharīb; no substitution of the webpage's modern grade.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 1021.

XII-S013 · A judicial award and a piece of fire

B126

Source. al-Bukhārī 2680

Umm Salama's report contains the argument, judgement and fire warning. This particular version does not include the 'I am only human' opening.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; a substantive, not fully verbatim, witness to the longer quotation.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2680.

XII-S014 · Giving while healthy and reluctant

B112

Source. al-Bukhārī 1419

The healthy giver's reluctance, fear of poverty and hope of wealth are present.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 1419.

XII-S015 · Marriage and fasting as a restraint

B118

Source. al-Bukhārī 5066

Ibn Masʿūd transmits the advice to marry if able and otherwise to fast as a restraint.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5066.

XII-S016 · The pilgrim returning free of sins

B138

Source. al-Bukhārī 1521

Abū Hurayra transmits the comparison with the day one's mother gave birth, conditioned on avoiding sexual misconduct and transgression.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 1521.

XII-S017 · The divine veil

B203

Source. Muslim 179a

The report includes God not sleeping, the balance, the raising of deeds, and the veil. Muslim explicitly records light and, in another transmitter's wording, fire.

Assessment. Located in Muslim's Ṣaḥīḥ; the light/fire variation belongs to the primary transmission.

Sources: Muslim 179a.

XII-S018 · Multiplication of good deeds

B214

Source. al-Bukhārī 6491

Ibn ʿAbbās transmits tenfold, seven hundredfold and further multiplication.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 6491.

XII-S019 · A date given in charity

B218

Source. al-Bukhārī 1410

The date, lawful earnings, divine right hand, young horse and mountain are present. 'Palm' and the alternative young-camel illustration are not this version's wording.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; do not combine parallel forms without attribution.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 1410.

XII-S020 · Planting as charity

B221

Source. al-Bukhārī 2320

Anas transmits the planting/crop and human, bird or animal eating clauses. This version lacks the explicit extension 'until the Day of Resurrection'.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; core saying confirmed.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2320.

XII-S021 · Understanding religion

B225

Source. al-Bukhārī 71

Muʿāwiya transmits the statement about understanding religion. The addition about being inspired with right guidance is not in this displayed version.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; additional clause requires a separate witness.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 71.

XII-S022 · The pledged coat of mail

B241

Source. al-Bukhārī 2509

ʿĀ'isha reports the armour pledged with a Jew for food. This short form does not explicitly name barley or Medina.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; core transaction confirmed.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2509.

XII-S023 · Private acknowledgement of sins

B243

Source. al-Bukhārī 2441

Ibn ʿUmar transmits the private divine questioning, concealment and forgiveness of sins.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2441.

XII-S024 · The burden of 2:284 and the response

B245

Source. Muslim 125

Abū Hurayra's narrative links the companions' distress at 2:284 with hearing and obeying and the following closing verses.

Assessment. Located in Muslim's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: Muslim 125.

XII-S025 · The last two verses of al-Baqara

B249

Source. al-Bukhārī 5009

Abū Masʿūd transmits that the two closing verses suffice at night. This is not the longer report about a treasure and two thousand years.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; concise saying only.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5009.

XII-S026 · Reciting al-Baqara and al-Zahrāwān

B250

Source. Muslim 804a

The blessing, regret and inability of al-baṭala are present. The explanation that al-baṭala means sorcerers is a statement of the transmitter Muʿāwiya b. Sallām, not Prophetic dialogue. 'Pavilion of the Qurʾān' is absent here.

Assessment. Located in Muslim's Ṣaḥīḥ. Ibn ʿAjība's attribution is translated as printed, with this source distinction recorded.

Sources: Muslim 804a.

XII-S027 · Those pursuing ambiguous verses

A009

Source. al-Bukhārī 4547; Muslim 2665

ʿĀʾisha's warning about followers of ambiguous verses is located in both Ṣaḥīḥ collections. The wording about asking, disputing and not sitting with them is not fully reproduced in these two displayed forms.

Assessment. Core report securely located; exact expanded quotation remains separately unestablished.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 4547; Muslim 2665; Muslim 2665.

XII-S028 · Women as a trial

A019

Source. al-Bukhārī 5096

Usāma b. Zayd's report contains the saying about no more harmful trial for men. The following arrow-of-Satan saying is a different claim.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; no automatic verification of the adjacent saying.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5096.

XII-S029 · Good in horses' forelocks

A023

Source. al-Bukhārī 2852

ʿUrwa al-Bāriqī transmits reward and spoils until the Resurrection. The adjacent Anas statement about affection for horses needs its own witness.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 2852.

XII-S030 · God's enduring good pleasure

A026

Source. al-Bukhārī 6549

The exchange with the people of the Garden and enduring divine pleasure is present in Abū Saʿīd's report. Some surrounding phrases in the retelling are not identical to this form.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 6549.

XII-S031 · Daily security, health and sustenance

A047

Source. al-Tirmidhī 2346

The three conditions and the world gathered for the servant are present, through Salama b. ʿUbayd Allāh b. Miḥṣan from his father.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī's own assessment is ḥasan gharīb.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 2346.

XII-S032 · Obedience to the Messenger and ruler

A055

Source. al-Bukhārī 7137

The obedience/disobedience clauses are present from Abū Hurayra. This form says 'my commander' rather than the commentary's 'the imam'.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; lexical variation remains visible.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 7137.

XII-S033 · Jābir's illness and the inheritance verse

q4_cont_176

Source. al-Bukhārī 6743; Muslim 1616a

Both sources contain the illness, ablution water and inheritance question; Muslim explicitly cites the opening of 4:176. Al-Bukhārī's short form explicitly mentions sisters. Extra details in the commentary are not established by these two forms alone.

Assessment. Reports in both Ṣaḥīḥ collections; source attribution of the central episode resolved.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 6743; Muslim 1616a; al-Bukhārī 6743.

XII-S034 · The final revelation according to al-Barāʾ

q4_cont_176

Source. al-Bukhārī 4605

Al-Barāʾ identifies Barāʾa as the final sūra and the opening of 4:176 as the final verse. This is a companion's chronological report, not a claim that all other transmitted chronologies agree.

Assessment. Connected companion report in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 4605.

XII-S035 · Plague and ʿUmar at Sargh

B184

Source. al-Bukhārī 5729

The consultation, return, two pasture grounds and ʿAbd al-Raḥmān b. ʿAwf's Prophetic report are present. ʿUmar's explanation and the Prophetic instruction are separate voices.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; the narrative's central sequence is confirmed.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5729.

XII-S036 · Three acts serious even in jest

B171

Source. al-Tirmidhī 1184

Marriage, divorce and taking a wife back are present through Abū Hurayra. This does not independently establish all surrounding occasions of revelation.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī himself calls it ḥasan gharīb.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 1184.

XII-S037 · No bequest to an heir

B117

Source. al-Tirmidhī 2120; Abū Dāwūd 2870

The no-bequest clause is present through Abū Umāma. Abū Dāwūd's Arabic likewise names Abū Umāma, despite the website English heading's different name.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī calls the report ḥasan ṣaḥīḥ and distinguishes Ismāʿīl b. ʿAyyāsh's regional transmissions; his Syrian route is not automatically equated with criticized Iraqi/Ḥijāzī transmissions.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 2120; Abū Dāwūd 2870; Abū Dāwūd 2870.

XII-S038 · Abū Ayyūb on throwing oneself into destruction

B131

Source. al-Tirmidhī 2972

Aslam Abū ʿImrān's narrative includes the charge into Roman ranks and Abū Ayyūb's explanation of 2:195 as withdrawing to one's property and abandoning the campaign.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī calls it ḥasan ṣaḥīḥ gharīb. The explanatory speech is Abū Ayyūb's.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 2972.

XII-S039 · Making this world or the next one's concern

B111

Source. Ibn Mājah 4105

The contrasting affairs, poverty before the eyes, wealth in the heart and unwilling world's approach are present through Zayd b. Thābit.

Assessment. Primary witness located; no new named premodern grade established in this check.

Sources: Ibn Mājah 4105.

XII-S040 · Good character and the fasting worshipper

B216

Source. Abū Dāwūd 4798

The report from ʿĀ'isha contains attaining the rank of the fasting, standing worshipper through good character.

Assessment. Primary witness located; the website's modern grade is not adopted as the edition's classical assessment.

Sources: Abū Dāwūd 4798.

XII-S041 · The generous person's nearness

B224

Source. al-Tirmidhī 1961

Nearness to God, the Garden and people, distance from fire, and the ignorant generous person's comparison with a miserly worshipper are present.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī calls it gharīb, identifies Saʿīd b. Muḥammad's solitary route, and records a conflicting disconnected transmission from Yaḥyā b. Saʿīd through ʿĀʾisha.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 1961.

XII-S042 · Payment for recitation in a healing episode

B110

Source. al-Bukhārī 5737

Ibn ʿAbbās's healing narrative concludes with the entitlement to payment for God's Book. It does not by itself decide every later juristic question about paid instruction.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; the narrated setting remains explicit.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5737.

XII-S043 · The bow offered for teaching

B110

Source. Abū Dāwūd 3416; Ibn Mājah 2157

Both sources transmit ʿUbāda b. al-Ṣāmit's teaching and the offered bow, followed by the fiery-necklace warning. These displayed versions do not include a separate explicit command to return it.

Assessment. Primary witnesses located; independent premodern transmission assessment remains outstanding for this route.

Sources: Abū Dāwūd 3416; Ibn Mājah 2157; Ibn Mājah 2157.

XII-S044 · The community compared with rain

B070

Source. al-Tirmidhī 2869

The rain comparison is present from Anas. It is a parallel to, not identification of, the commentary's specific attribution to al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī from Ibn ʿUmar.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī calls this route ḥasan gharīb and records Ibn Mahdī's favourable statement about Ḥammād b. Yaḥyā.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 2869.

XII-S045 · Error, forgetfulness and compulsion

B248

Source. Ibn Mājah 2043

The threefold pardon saying about error, forgetfulness and compulsion is transmitted from Abū Dharr through Shahr b. Ḥawshab and Abū Bakr al-Hudhalī. Ibn ʿAjība's sentence instead ends with inward thoughts, for which al-Bukhārī 5269 provides a separate comparison. These are distinct wordings.

Assessment. The source location is established; a named classical assessment of this route remains unverified.

Sources: Ibn Mājah 2043.

XII-S046 · Unacted and unspoken thoughts

B248

Source. al-Bukhārī 5269

The pardon for inward thoughts not acted or spoken is present from Abū Hurayra. Qatāda's following remark about unuttered divorce is a separate narrator's statement.

Assessment. Located in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; not identical to the error/forgetfulness/compulsion report.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 5269.

XII-S047 · The indispensable divine address

B029

Source. al-Khaṭīb, Tārīkh Baghdād, II:247 in the displayed old pagination

The divine-address wording following the inherited B029 context at Cairo I: 93 is located with its chain. The marker precedes this particular quotation and is only a passage locator. Cairo's footnote cites II:242; the independently displayed primary excerpt is labelled II:247.

Assessment. Al-Khaṭīb explicitly calls the text fabricated and mounted on the chain, and describes Ibn Jārūd as a liar. The printed locator remains transcribed, with the verified difference noted.

Sources: al-Khaṭīb, Tārīkh Baghdād, II:247 in the displayed old pagination.

XII-S048 · The account of Jesus clothed in rīsh

q4_cont_155

Source. al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān, III:410

An earlier exegetical witness has the same rīsh, light, removal of food-and-drink pleasure, and angelic circling of the Throne. The wording is therefore not peculiar to the Cairo print.

Assessment. The account is introduced through Qatāda as 'it was mentioned to us'; locating this literary antecedent does not authenticate the event. Feather imagery is supported by context, while the lexical alternative must be considered.

Sources: al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān, III:410.

XII-S049 · The lentil report

B047

Source. al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana, entry 763

The named classical critical entry discusses reports commending lentils.

Assessment. Al-Sakhāwī reports that no sound lentil report is established and cites earlier criticism. This concerns attribution, not authority to suppress Ibn ʿAjība's quotation.

Sources: al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana, entry 763.

XII-S050 · Poverty is my pride

q3-152

Source. al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana, entry 745

The well-known poverty-as-pride saying is discussed as an attribution claim.

Assessment. Al-Sakhāwī records Ibn Ḥajar's judgement that it is baseless and fabricated.

Sources: al-Sakhāwī, al-Maqāṣid al-ḥasana, entry 745.

XII-S051 · Al-Baqara as the summit: the three-day and three-night wording

B002

Source. Ibn Ḥibbān 780; al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-kabīr 5864; al-Bayhaqī, Shuʿab al-īmān 2378

The three primary excerpts contain the summit and three-day/night clauses. Ibn Ḥibbān explains that the exclusion concerns rebellious devils. The chains differ in the order of a transmitter’s names, Khālid b. Saʿīd and Saʿīd b. Khālid. The separate foremost-verse clause has its own transmission.

Assessment. Ibn Ḥibbān includes this form in his Ṣaḥīḥ. Al-Haythamī’s own Majmaʿ passage identifies Saʿīd b. Khālid al-Khuzāʿī al-Madanī as weak. This is a documented classical difference, requiring attention to the named transmitter and recension.

Sources: Ibn Ḥibbān 780; al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-kabīr 5864; al-Bayhaqī, Shuʿab al-īmān 2378; al-Haythamī, Majmaʿ al-zawāʾid, VI:312 in the displayed edition.

XII-S052 · Al-Baqara from the first Remembrance

B003

Source. al-Ḥākim, al-Mustadrak 2087; al-Dhahabī, al-ʿUluww, no.276, source p.108

Al-Ḥākim's Maʿqil b. Yasār report, the Abū Yaʿlā witness preserved by al-Būṣīrī, and Ibn Naṣr's Qiyām text share the first-Remembrance clause but differ in the named sūrahs and closing clauses. They are located primary witnesses, not a single standardized matn.

Assessment. Al-Ḥākim expressly calls his chain sound. Al-Dhahabī's al-ʿUluww, no. 276, calls its form munkar and describes ʿUbayd Allāh as abandoned in hadith. The two judgments apply to their respective transmitted forms.

Sources: al-Ḥākim, al-Mustadrak 2087; al-Dhahabī, al-ʿUluww, no.276, source p.108; al-Dhahabī, al-ʿUluww, no.276, source p.108; electronic PDF p.60.

XII-S053 · Acting upon knowledge and receiving further knowledge

q4_cont_064, q2-187

Source. Abū Nuʿaym, Ḥilyat al-awliyāʾ X:14–15

The original compiler relates the Abū Sulaymān al-Dārānī teaching and the maxim about acting on knowledge. He then explains how a saying related from Jesus through a Successor was mistaken for a Prophetic report and supplied with a convenient chain.

Assessment. Abū Nuʿaym expressly rejects that chain as a basis for attributing the report through Aḥmad b. Ḥanbal. This directly establishes an attribution problem without rejecting the maxim's Sufi reception or importing a modern grading.

Sources: Abū Nuʿaym, Ḥilyat al-awliyāʾ X:14–15.

XII-S054 · Do not bring me reports about my Companions

q4_cont_083

Source. al-Tirmidhī 3896

The displayed Arabic includes the opening request not to bring reports about Companions and a longer narrative involving Ibn Masʿūd. It supports the source identity behind the commentator's abbreviated quotation.

Assessment. Al-Tirmidhī calls this route gharīb and states that al-Walīd b. Abī Thawr's narration adds a man to the chain. That specific observation controls the note; no blanket authentication of every recension is claimed.

Sources: al-Tirmidhī 3896.

XII-S055 · The station of martyrs for people who die in well-being

q3-169-171

Source. al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-kabīr 10371, X:217; Abū Nuʿaym, al-Ṭibb al-nabawī 110, I:234; Ibn Ḥajar, Badhl al-māʿūn, ed. Aḥmad ʿIṣām al-Kātib, Dār al-ʿĀṣima, pp.188–189

The displayed al-Ṭabarānī and Abū Nuʿaym chains and matns contain protection from being killed, long life in good works, good provision, death in well-being on beds and the station of martyrs. Abū Nuʿaym adds resurrection in well-being. Neither displayed matn contains the commentator's additional earthquakes and illnesses. Ibn Ḥajar's directly inspected printed pp.188–189 reproduce a shorter related form and identify its sources; his criticism appears in his own main text on p.189.

Assessment. Ibn Ḥajar expressly identifies Ḥafṣ ibn Sulaymān in this chain and calls him weak: وفي سنده «حفص بن سليمان»؛ وهو ضعيف. He then describes related reports assembled by Abū Nuʿaym as having weak chains. This is a directly verified named classical judgement, distinct from the earlier al-Haythamī uncertainty. It is not presented as a completed analysis of every possible route or every expanded clause quoted by Ibn ʿAjība.

Sources: al-Ṭabarānī, al-Muʿjam al-kabīr 10371, X:217; Abū Nuʿaym, al-Ṭibb al-nabawī 110, I:234; Ibn Ḥajar, Badhl al-māʿūn, ed. Aḥmad ʿIṣām al-Kātib, Dār al-ʿĀṣima, pp.188–189; Ibn Ḥajar, Badhl al-māʿūn, ed. al-Kātib, pp.188–189; criticism p.189.

XII-S056 · The exception in the allegiance report

q4_cont_059

Source. al-Bukhārī 7055–7056

The report has illā an taraw kufran bawāḥan, “unless you see open unbelief.” Cairo I:519 prints lā an, lacking the initial alif.

Assessment. ʿUbāda b. al-Ṣāmit’s report occurs in al-Bukhārī’s Ṣaḥīḥ. The source establishes the quoted wording; the scope and application of its legal implications require their own juristic analysis.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 7055–7056.

XII-S057 · ʿUmar’s investigation of the report of divorce

q4_cont_083

Source. Muslim 1479a

The first-person account contains ʿUmar’s direct question, the Prophet’s denial, the announcement at the mosque entrance, 4:83 and ʿUmar’s claim to have drawn out the information. These central narrative elements are independently located.

Assessment. ʿUmar’s report through Ibn ʿAbbās is in Muslim’s Ṣaḥīḥ. Source confirmation does not change the commentator’s wording.

Sources: Muslim 1479a.

XII-S058 · Waraqa’s garments: green, silk and white recensions

q4_cont_083

Source. Ibn Abī Shayba, al-Muṣannaf 37710, XX:233; al-Bayhaqī, Dalāʾil al-nubuwwa II:158; al-Tirmidhī 2288

Ibn Abī Shayba's Abū Maysara narrative ends with green garments, matching the commentator's colour. Al-Bayhaqī's related Abū Maysara narrative has silk garments; al-Tirmidhī's ʿĀ'isha route has white garments. The latter two are distinct witnesses, not grounds for changing Cairo's green.

Assessment. The Abū Maysara narration is mursal: a Successor relates the Prophetic event without a Companion. Al-Bayhaqī explicitly calls his related version disconnected. Al-Tirmidhī calls his route gharīb and says ʿUthmān b. ʿAbd al-Raḥmān is not strong among hadith specialists.

Sources: Ibn Abī Shayba, al-Muṣannaf 37710, XX:233; al-Bayhaqī, Dalā'il al-nubuwwa II:158; al-Tirmidhī 2288; al-Bayhaqī, Dalā'il II:158; al-Tirmidhī 2288.

XII-S059 · God was, and nothing was other than Him

B028

Source. al-Bukhārī 3191

The displayed ʿImrān b. Ḥuṣayn report reads 'God was, and nothing was other than Him', followed by the Throne, the writing and creation. It does not contain the later clause that He is now as He was.

Assessment. The opening has a primary witness in al-Bukhārī's Ṣaḥīḥ; the later Sufi continuation must retain its separate attribution. This textual distinction makes no judgement against the continuation's theological use.

Sources: al-Bukhārī 3191.

XII-S060 · The Qurʾān's outward sense, inward sense, limit and point of ascent

P03, P04

Source. al-Bazzār 2081, V:441; Ibn Ḥibbān 75, I:276; Ibn al-Mubārak, al-Zuhd 93, II:23; al-Baghawī, Sharḥ al-sunna 122, I:262

The displayed Ibn Masʿūd routes in al-Bazzār and Ibn Ḥibbān join the seven-letters clause to an outward and inward sense for each verse; they do not contain the whole four-part maxim. The versions through al-Ḥasan al-

Baṣrī in Ibn al-Mubārak and al-Baghawī supply ḥadd and maṭlaʿ, with different allocation to each verse or letter. The fuller wording cannot acquire the shorter recension's status merely by combining them.

Assessment. The al-Ḥasan routes are mursal: a Successor relates the Prophetic statement without naming a Companion. Al-Bazzār explicitly comments on the route's singularity, and the displayed witnesses differ over the identification of Abū Isḥāq. Ibn Ḥibbān includes his shorter form in his Ṣaḥīḥ. A complete classical comparison must keep those distinct routes and matns separate; no blanket grade is assigned to the composite.

Sources: al-Bazzār 2081, V:441; Ibn Ḥibbān 75, I:276; Ibn al-Mubārak, al-Zuhd 93, II:23; al-Baghawī, Sharḥ al-sunna 122, I:262; Ibn al-Mubārak, al-Zuhd 93; al-Baghawī, Sharḥ al-sunna 122; al-Ḥakīm al-Tirmidhī, Nawādir al-uṣūl 1448; al-Suhrawardī, Mashyakha 3, with the gloss of maṭlaʿ.

XII-S061 · Al-Ḥawlāʾ: pregnancy, childbirth, nursing and marital rewards

B122

Source. al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān, commentary on 2:187, report 363 in Dār al-Tafsīr IV:540; al-Dāraquṭnī, al-ʿIlal, question 3804

Al-Thaʿlabī's displayed chain reaches Anas through Ziyād b. Maymūn and contains the pregnancy, birth, nursing and weaning rewards. His longer 2:187 text also contains the ensuing question about men's rewards, but that electronic witness has a lacuna and differs from Cairo in particulars: it assigns twenty good deeds to kissing, whereas Ibn ʿAjība's wording concerns lying with one's wife. These are reported differences, not silent corrections to the adopted copytext.

Assessment. Al-Dāraquṭnī's own ʿIlal question compares the Anas–ʿĀʾisha and Anas forms, declares neither sound, calls the report bāṭil, and relates Ziyād b. Maymūn's recantation after criticism by ʿAbd al-Raḥmān b. Mahdī and Abū Dāwūd. This supplies an identified premodern rejection of the relevant transmission, beyond merely saying that further checking is needed.

Sources: al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān, commentary on 2:187, report 363 in Dār al-Tafsīr IV:540; al-Dāraquṭnī, al-ʿIlal, question 3804; al-Thaʿlabī, commentary on 2:187, longer context including the men's rewards; electronic text contains a lacuna.

XII-S062 · The etymological gloss for marīd: mulābasa and malāsa

q4_cont_117

Source. al-Bayḍāwī and Abū al-Suʿūd, commentary on 4:117

Cairo I:562 prints li-l-mulābasa, and one public electronic al-Bayḍāwī witness repeats that reading. Abū al-Suʿūd's corresponding explanation has li-l-malāsa, smoothness, beside the same smooth-palace and bare-tree examples. This is explicit primary support for the probable intended lexical sense; the two electronic witnesses are not fresh manuscript collation.

Assessment. The parallel and examples strongly support the meaning "smoothness." The exact word in Ibn ʿAjība's authorial text remains unestablished.

Sources: al-Bayḍāwī and Abū al-Suʿūd, commentary on 4:117; al-Bayḍāwī, Anwar al-tanzil, 4:117, electronic witness with mulābasa.

XII-S063 · The lightened an clause and the active/passive reading at 4:140

q4_cont_140

Source. al-Bayḍāwī, commentary on 4:140; Ibn ʿAṭiyya, commentary on 4:140

Al-Bayḍāwī explicitly distinguishes ʿĀṣim's active reading from the other readers' passive form, calls an lightened, and assigns its clause the place of the subject in the passive construction. Ibn ʿAṭiyya independently describes the active and passive readings. This explains the grammatical analysis envisaged by the proposed passive-subject correction, while Cairo I:577's heading remains active and its gloss still prints nāfiya.

Assessment. The underlying grammatical alternatives are documented, not merely hypothetical. No independent Ibn ʿAjība witness has established that the printed nāfiya should be emended to nāʾibat fāʿil. Cairo's heading and gloss remain visible, with the source-supported grammatical explanation in the note.

Sources: al-Bayḍāwī, commentary on 4:140; Ibn ʿAṭiyya, commentary on 4:140; Ibn ʿAṭiyya, al-Muḥarrar al-wajīz, 4:140, body description of the readings.

Textual and interpretive questions

The following notes discuss difficult constructions, source variants and disputed attributions. A clear contextual meaning may coexist with uncertainty about the authorial letters or the history of a reading.

Cairo I:79 · Separating pronoun term

والتأكيد بإن وضمير الفعل

The nominal clause ألا إنهم هم المفسدون contains no verbal predicate to which hum could refer as “the pronoun of the verb.” Al-Bayḍāwī and al-Nasafī explicitly include the separating pronoun in their parallel lists of emphatic devices, and al-Qurṭubī also records that grammatical analysis. “Separating pronoun” therefore expresses the relevant construction. Cairo’s الفعل differs from the expected الفصل; the precise authorial letters and the origin of that difference remain unestablished.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 79; PDF image 79; Q2:11–12, grammatical comment

> **al-Bayḍāwī, Anwār al-tanzīl, ed. al-Marʿashlī.** I:46, on Q2:12

> **al-Nasafī, Madārik al-tanzīl.** Commentary on Q2:12; retrieved page line 72

> **al-Qurṭubī, al-Jāmiʿ li-aḥkām al-Qurʾān.** Commentary on Q2:12; retrieved page lines 20–21

Cairo I:110 · The preposition before penetration to the lights

فلم تنحجب بسحب الآثار إلى نفوذ شهود الأنوار

The following clauses contrast witnessing the lights with remaining veiled by created effects. Ibn ʿAjība’s Īqāẓ al-himam, p. 230, likewise describes the clouds of effects clearing so that light shines and the heart becomes absent from forms. The connection of ilā, “to,” with the negative clause فلم تنحجب …

إلى نفوذ remains difficult. A temporal endpoint conflicts with the continuation, while ʿan, “from,” would be a conjectural replacement. The contextual meaning is clearer than the exact syntax.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 110; PDF image 110; Q2:57, ishāra

> **Ibn ʿAjība, Īqāẓ al-himam, ed. al-Kayyālī, fifth edition 1437/2016.** Printed p. 230, PDF image 231, commentary on ḥikma 110

Cairo I:111 · Musāwara in a list of intimate encounters

بالمشاهدة، والمكالمة، والمواجهة، والمساورة، والمفاتحة، والمناجاة

Both Cairo I:111 and Īqāẓ al-himam, p. 384, read musāwara. The latter places it among figurative expressions for spiritual perception and inward tasting but does not define it individually. Lisān al-ʿArab gives assailing or springing at someone as the Form III meaning. A forceful or overwhelming spiritual encounter is a possible contextual interpretation; “intimate drawing near” is not an established lexical equivalent. Musārara and musāmara are different words. An exact authorial explanation of musāwara in this context remains lacking.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 111; PDF image 111; Q2:58–59, ishāra

> **Ibn ʿAjība, Īqāẓ al-himam, ed. al-Kayyālī, fifth edition 1437/2016.** Printed p. 384, PDF image 385, commentary on ḥikma 203

> **Ibn Manẓūr, Lisān al-ʿArab.** Entry s-w-r (سور), relevant Form III definitions; retrieved lines 581–625

> **Arabic Language Academy, Cairo, al-Muʿjam al-wasīṭ, s.v.** ساور**.** Official digital entry, opened text lines42–46
>
> Arabic Language Academy, Cairo, al-Muʿjam al-wasīṭ, s.v. ساور

> **Ibn ʿAjība, Īqāẓ al-himam, ed. ʿĀṣim Ibrāhīm al-Kayyālī, Dār al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya, fifth edition1437/2016.** Printed241, PDF242, ḥikma117 الصلاة محل المناجاة

Ibn ʿAjība, Īqāẓ al-himam, ed. ʿĀṣim Ibrāhīm al-Kayyālī, Dār al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya, fifth edition1437/2016

Targeted OCR searches in13 publicly available Ibn ʿAjība files. See Ibn_Ajiba_OCR_Search_Manifest_XV.json and OCR_Search_Candidate_Locators_XV.json

Targeted OCR searches in13 publicly available Ibn ʿAjība files

Cairo I:114 · Weariness versus being free or safe

فكل مَن لم يقنع بقسمته وسلم من اتحاد رزقه

The opening describes weariness with honey and meat. In the ensuing moral generalization, وسئم, “grew weary,” would parallel dissatisfaction with one’s allotment, whereas Cairo’s وسلم, “was free or safe,” produces a different and contextually difficult sense. “Grew weary” is a contextual conjecture. An unattributed modern web quotation with وسئم does not establish an independent witness to Ibn ʿAjība’s wording.

Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I. Printed p. 114; PDF image 114; Q2:61, exposition

Cairo I:138 · The negative conditional about preservation of faith

فهذا إن لم تكن له عناية أزلية، وسابقة أولية فيمسك عليه الإيمان، ويختم له بالإسلام، وإلا فقد هلك

The printed negative condition is followed by preservation of faith and then “otherwise he has perished.” Taken as ordinary consecutive conditional clauses, these statements conflict. The surrounding account makes antecedent divine care the exception to the heedless person’s danger. The printed al-ʿĀqiba parallel has the same difficulty, with dual pronouns referring to its preceding two classes. A manuscript facsimile of that earlier work omits the entire conditional and the following supplication; it supplies no alternative particle. The possibilities of omission, intrusive negation and anacoluthon remain unresolved.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 138; PDF image 138; Q2:94–95, ishāra

> **ʿAbd al-Ḥaqq al-Ishbīlī, al-ʿĀqiba, ed. Khiḍr Muḥammad Khiḍr, 1406/1986.** Printed pp. 28–30; difficult conditional p. 29, PDF image 29

> **Public manuscript facsimile entitled al-ʿĀqiba fī aḥwāl al-ākhira, attributed on the title leaf to ʿAbd al-Ḥaqq al-Azdī al-Ishbīlī.** PDF image 7, visible folio numeral 4, lower part of the page; compared with print pp. 28–29. Title leaf and images 4,6,7,8,10 were also read for identification and context.

Cairo I:157 · Wine-poem hemistich concerning indwelling

فليس لها في سوى شَكْلِهِ حَلَّتِ

At Cairo II:22, on Q5:17, Ibn ʿAjība quotes the line with the order فليس لها سوى في شكله حلت. There siwā denotes a hypothetical “other”; the feminine pronouns refer to the eternal wine, and the masculine suffix in shaklihi to that other. The preceding prose denies that a second entity exists in which the wine could dwell or with which it could unite. This internal parallel explains the meaning and pronouns. The different order at I:157 remains a question of textual transmission.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 157; PDF image 157; Q2:115, author’s wine poem

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume II.** Printed II:22, PDF image 22, commentary on Q5:17. Title leaf checked; neighboring printed pp. 21 and 23 read for context.

Cairo I:178 · Absence in the witnessing of vessels

غائباً في شهود الأواني

The phrase addresses the gnostic and uses fī, “in,” with awānī, “vessels.” Miʿrāj al-tashawwuf defines sensible forms as vessels of inward meanings. Ibn ʿAjība’s discussions at Q6:103 and Q7:143 distinguish the vessels from

the meanings witnessed through them; the latter describes absence from vessels through witnessing meanings. These parallels clarify the vocabulary without explaining the present construction, “absent in witnessing vessels.” Self-forgetful absorption is possible, but the sentence does not specify what the gnostic is absent from. An alternative preposition is not independently attested.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 178; PDF image 178; Q2:144, ishāra

> **Ibn ʿAjība, Miʿrāj al-tashawwuf, ed. al-Khayyālī.** Printed p. 61, PDF image 39; definitions of sense and meaning

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo, ed. Aḥmad ʿAbd Allāh al-Qurashī Ruslān, II.** Q6:103 spiritual allusion, printed153 = PDF153
>
> Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo, ed. Aḥmad ʿAbd Allāh al-Qurashī Ruslān, II

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo, II.** Q7:143 spiritual allusion, printed257 = PDF257
>
> Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo, II

> **Targeted OCR searches in13 publicly available Ibn ʿAjība files.** See Ibn_Ajiba_OCR_Search_Manifest_XV.json and OCR_Search_Candidate_Locators_XV.json
>
> Targeted OCR searches in13 publicly available Ibn ʿAjība files

Cairo I:195 · The cause and origin of love in the Rāʾiyya commentary

والأصل، فبسببه كشفك للحجب حتى رأيتك بعيني قلبي

Aḥmad b. Yūsuf al-Fāsī’s commentary on the Rāʾiyya, p. 154, reads فسببه ومنشؤه, “its cause and origin.” Lifting the veils is the cause of the second love, in contrast with the result or fruit of the first. Cairo instead prints فبسببه, “through or because of it.” The source clarifies the causal relation; the authorial wording of the Baḥr and the origin of the discrepancy remain distinct textual questions.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 195; PDF image 195; Q2:165, two-loves explanation

> **Aḥmad b. Yūsuf al-Fāsī, commentary on al-Shurayshī's Rāʾiyya, Cairo 1316 AH.** Printed p. 154, PDF image 155

Cairo I:237 · The omitted verb after kam

كم آياتنا آتيناهم

Ibn ʿAṭiyya explicitly supplies the verb after initial kam and then gives the nominative alternative with a resumptive pronoun. This corresponds to Ibn ʿAjība's grammatical explanation. Cairo's آياتنا does not express the required supplied verb; the parallel آتينا does. "How many [We gave]—We gave them" represents that reconstruction. The exact authorial letters remain unestablished.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 237; PDF image 237; Q2:211, iʿrāb

> **Ibn ʿAṭiyya, al-Muḥarrar al-wajīz.** Commentary on Q2:211; retrieved page lines 22–23

Cairo I:241 · The author explains injury reaching the seeker through others

إنما أجرى الأذى عليهم كي لا تكون ساكناً إليهم، أراد أن يزعجك عن كل شيء حتى لا تكون ساكناً إلى شيء

Īqāẓ al-himam expands the maxim to "through the hands of created people to you." The seeker receives the injury, other people are its intermediaries, and God is its ultimate agent in the author's argument. Cairo's ending, "repose in nothing," is coherent but differs from the Īqāẓ and Ḥikam ending, "nothing distracts you from Him." The parallel clarifies agency without establishing the transmission history of either ending.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān 1419/1999, volume I.** Printed p. 241; PDF image 241; Q2:214, ishāra

> **Ibn ʿAjība, Īqāẓ al-himam, ed. al-Kayyālī, fifth edition 1437/2016.** Printed p. 412, PDF image 413, commentary on ḥikma 225

Cairo I:346 · Sweeping the place of worship

وينكسها

The service narrative concerns sweeping. Al-Baghawī's parallel at Q3:35 reads ويكنسها, whereas Cairo prints وينكسها, apparently transposing two consonants. The parallel supports "sweep"; an independent Baḥr witness would be needed to establish the authorial lettering.

> **Al-Baghawī, Maʿālim al-tanzīl.** Q3:35, electronic page marker II:29
>
> Al-Baghawī, Maʿālim al-tanzīl

Cairo I:385 · Sakanī: a dwelling or the beloved in whom one rests

ولي حج إلى سكني

Sakan can denote a beloved in whom one finds repose, as in Ibn Fāris and Ibn Manẓūr; this fits the poem's repeated language of the Beloved. Its attribution to al-Ḥallāj is disputed. Al-Shībī notes that a recitation from al-Ḥallāj need not establish composition by him and assembles his seven-line sequence from several recensions. The anonymous passage in Ibn ʿArabī supplies an earlier literary parallel. Neither anonymous transmission nor a composite modern edition conclusively settles authorship; the reported manuscript evidence requires direct comparison.

> **Kāmil Muṣṭafā al-Shībī, Sharḥ Dīwān al-Ḥallāj.** Jamal facsimile, poem48, printed487–489 = PDF487–489
>
> Kāmil Muṣṭafā al-Shībī, Sharḥ Dīwān al-Ḥallāj

Cairo I:405 · Balāgh: bringing the hearer to the goal

إنما أنت مذكر، وعلى الله البلاغ

Balāgh may mean reaching an end or conveying a message. The disciple sets means in motion, God opens the door, and the teacher gives a reminder; successful attainment fits this local contrast. The travel idiom quoted by Ibn al-Jawzī, “Walking is my part; bringing me there is God’s,” provides a close linguistic parallel. The subsequent al-Qushayrī quotation begins later. Neither that quotation nor Ibn al-Jawzī’s anecdote establishes the literary source of Ibn ʿAjība’s clause.

> **Ibn al-Jawzī, Talbīs Iblīs.** I:290, section on entering the wilderness without provisions
>
> Ibn al-Jawzī, Talbīs Iblīs

> **Al-Qushayrī, Laṭāʾif al-ishārāt.** Q3:128–129, electronic I:275–276
>
> Al-Qushayrī, Laṭāʾif al-ishārāt

Cairo I:408 · Obedience as the means; pardon and Paradise as the aims

فدعاهم بطاعته إلى العلتين

Bi-ṭāʿatihi indicates the means, obedience, while ilā al-ʿillatayn points to the two desired benefits. Rūzbihān contrasts these benefits with the elect’s summons to God and then observes the self’s portion in seeking forgiveness. This explains the play between ailments and motives. The nested exchange about angels occurs in the cited source, but its modern note refers back to Ibn ʿAjība and supplies no earlier chain; the report’s authentication remains separate from the lexical interpretation.

> **Rūzbihān al-Baqlī, ʿArāʾis al-bayān.** Aḥmad Farīd al-Mazīdī ed., Dār al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya, first1429/2008, I:196 = PDF196
>
> Rūzbihān al-Baqlī, ʿArāʾis al-bayān

Cairo I:408 · Al-Ḥasan’s sun, wind and rain comparison

الإحسان: أن يعم إحسانه، ولا يكون كالشمس والريح والمطر ... أي: يخص بلداً دون بلد

Al-Thaʿlabī's source passage gives a positive comparison with the universality of sun, wind and rain. Cairo instead gives a negative comparison and a gloss about favouring one land over another. That gloss makes Cairo's construction intelligible. The difference is substantive; its origin as an authorial alteration or a change in transmission cannot be determined from the source parallel alone.

> **Al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān.** Abū Muḥammad b. ʿĀshūr ed., Dār Iḥyāʾ al-Turāth al-ʿArabī, first1422/2002, III:167–168 = PDF167–168
>
> Al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān

Cairo I:410 · The tiny amount sucked from a date stone

مقدار فص نواة

Al-Sāḥilī's Bughyat al-sālik, p. 258, reads maṣṣ nawāt, "sucking a date-stone," in the discussion of what remains to be purified in the self. Al-Qushayrī's earlier Risāla puts a comparable question to al-Junayd and follows it with the manumission analogy. In each, a tiny unpaid remainder defeats a claim of freedom, illuminating the image of minimal worldly attachment. Cairo reads faṣṣ. A separate electronic Bughya apparatus reports omission of maṣṣ in witness B; that apparatus is absent from the 2019 edition, and B has not been examined in facsimile.

> **Muḥammad al-Sāḥilī, Bughyat al-sālik fī ashraf al-masālik.** Aḥmad Farīd al-Mazīdī ed., Books-Publisher, Beirut, first1440/2019, p258 = PDF258
>
> Muḥammad al-Sāḥilī, Bughyat al-sālik fī ashraf al-masālik

> **Al-Qushayrī, al-Risāla.** ʿAbd al-Ḥalīm Maḥmūd and Maḥmūd b. al-Sharīf eds., Dār al-Maʿārif, II:371–372, chapter on freedom; II:376–377, chapter on remembrance
>
> Al-Qushayrī, al-Risāla

Cairo I:442 · Bi-llāh in the poem about hoarded wealth

تطمع بالله في الخلود معه

The bi-llāh and wa-llāh parallels support an oath or adjuration in the rhetorical address. The preceding kam tuḍarru bihi concerns the extent of harm, not its duration. The following question about carrying wealth into death reinforces the rebuke. The parallels differ in wording and attribution and do not establish the authorship of Cairo's anonymous version or a unique grammatical account of its bi-llāh.

> **Cairo Ruslān al-Baḥr al-madīd.** 1419/1999 I:442 and I:460 = PDF442 and460

> **Targeted public-source searches.** Queries for I442 bi-llāh and I451 third line; exact I460 collocation

Cairo I:451 · The subject of wa-wāṣala al-kullu

وَوَاصَلَ الْكُلُّ مِنْ مَعْنَاهُ مَعْنَاكَ

Cairo vocalizes al-kullu in the nominative, as the subject of wāṣala, with maʿnāka as its object. Īqāẓ al-himam and Ibn ʿAbbād's Ghayth al-mawāhib place the poem within the disappearance of awareness of a separate rememberer; Ibn al-Bannā explicitly excludes indwelling or identity. The five-line anonymous Qaṣd al-mujarrad version corroborates the difficult line and broadens its remembrance and meeting context. These sources do not identify a unique referent for "the whole," the antecedent of "its meaning," or the exact force of min. The two-line Risāla and Sulamī parallels omit this third line.

> **Al-Qushayrī, al-Risāla.** ʿAbd al-Ḥalīm Maḥmūd and Maḥmūd b. al-Sharīf eds., Dār al-Maʿārif, II:371–372, chapter on freedom; II:376–377, chapter on remembrance

Al-Qushayrī, al-Risāla

Abū ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Sulamī, Jawāmiʿ ādāb al-ṣūfiyya. Electronic converted PDF, attributed edition Sulaymān Ateş, within nine works1993; chapter on continual repentance, PDF41

Abū ʿAbd al-Raḥmān al-Sulamī, Jawāmiʿ ādāb al-ṣūfiyya

Ibn ʿAjība, Īqāẓ al-himam. Existing2016 facsimile, printed120–121 = PDF121–122

Ibn ʿAbbād al-Rundī, Ghayth al-mawāhib al-ʿaliyya. ʿAbd al-Jalīl ʿAbd al-Salām ed., Dār al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya, pp73–74, electronic transcription

Ibn ʿAbbād al-Rundī, Ghayth al-mawāhib al-ʿaliyya

Targeted public-source searches. Queries for I442 bi-llāh and I451 third line; exact I460 collocation

Allāh: al-Qaṣd al-mujarrad fī maʿrifat al-ism al-mufrad, published under Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh al-Iskandarī's name, takhrīj and commentary by Maḥmūd Tawfīq al-Ḥakīm, Cairo: Maktabat Madbūlī, first edition2002. Printed/PDF119–120, fuller surrounding prose inspected at118–121; cover/imprint at1–3

Allāh: al-Qaṣd al-mujarrad fī maʿrifat al-ism al-mufrad, published under Ibn ʿAṭāʾ Allāh al-Iskandarī's name, takhrīj and commentary by Maḥmūd Tawfīq al-Ḥakīm, Cairo: Maktabat Madbūlī, first edition2002

Targeted OCR searches in13 publicly available Ibn ʿAjība files. See Ibn_Ajiba_OCR_Search_Manifest_XV.json and OCR_Search_Candidate_Locators_XV.json

Targeted OCR searches in13 publicly available Ibn ʿAjība files

Cairo I:460 · Darkness of the lights of Lordship

مشاهدة ظلمة أنوار الربوبية

Cairo prints the unusual phrase "darkness of the lights of Lordship." The passage contrasts the effacement and witnessing associated with the end of Āl ʿImrān with the servanthood and subsistence at the opening of al-Nisāʾ. In Īqāẓ al-himam, language of darkening can accompany divine illumination and the eclipse of separate awareness. This is a contextual analogy, not

an exact gloss of the present iḍāfa. The attribution of the borrowed definition to al-Qushayrī and the precise meaning of this phrase remain unresolved; no alternative letters are independently attested.

> **Ibn ʿAjība, Īqāẓ al-himam.** Existing2016 facsimile, printed120–121 = PDF121–122

> **Cairo Ruslān al-Baḥr al-madīd.** 1419/1999 I:442 and I:460 = PDF442 and460

> **Targeted public-source searches.** Queries for I442 bi-llāh and I451 third line; exact I460 collocation

Cairo I:477 · Mother and grandmother in the maternal-sibling exclusion

أنهُما لا يرثان مع الأم والجدة

Al-Bayḍāwī transmits the father and grandfather terms as a prima facie implication and qualifies that implication by consensus. Cairo lacks the qualification. Mālik independently supplies the operative inheritance rule. The kinship nouns therefore have a coherent source context; the absence of the qualification is a separate transmission question.

> **al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil.** Q4:12; OpenITI baydawi.txt between PageV02P063–064
>
> al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil

> **Malik, al-Muwatta.** Book of Inheritances, maternal siblings; displayed II: 507; OpenITI PageV02P506–507
>
> Malik, al-Muwatta

Cairo I:482 · Seeing another man’s wife or animal

كمن يريد أن يرى امرأة غيره أو دابة غيره

The surrounding argument joins effective discipline of the self to a valid bond with a qualified shaykh. Cairo’s final analogy says “seeing another’s wife or animal,” which does not transparently express that relation. “Inher-

it," "possess" and "train" are conjectures without an independently attested variant. Rūzbihān's following quotation begins at "live with them honourably" and contains none of this preceding analogy, so it cannot determine the disputed verb. The precise sense remains unresolved.

> **Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid, electronic text.** Q4:19 spiritual interpretation and Q4:41–42 spiritual interpretation
>
> Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid, electronic text

> Rūzbihān al-Baqlī, ʿArāʾis al-bayān, ed. Aḥmad Farīd al-Mazīdī, Dār al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya1429/2008, I237–238

Cairo I:504 · Seeking His pleasure in ostentatious expenditure

يتحرّون بإنفاقهم مراضيه

Al-Bayḍāwī and Abū al-Suʿūd explicitly connect seeking God's pleasure with the purpose that faith would produce. This supports the supplied connective "[so as to]" and the divine pronoun. Cairo lacks that connective. On the same page Cairo attributes taqlīl, "diminution," to al-Bayḍāwī, whose text instead has taʿlīl, "giving the reason," referring to unbelief as the reason for ostentation. Both discrepancies concern textual transmission as well as interpretation.

> **al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil.** Q4:38; OpenITI baydawi.txt between PageV02P073–074
>
> al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil

> **Abu al-Suud, Irshad al-aql al-salim.** Q4:38
>
> Abu al-Suud, Irshad al-aql al-salim

> **al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil.** Q4:39; OpenITI baydawi.txt between PageV02P073–074
>
> al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil

Cairo I:506 · Asarra versus aṣarra in the inner-sins passage

ثم يعاتب على ما أسر عليه من الكبائر

Cairo prints asarra with sīn. Concealment suits the general subject of hidden heart sins, but asarra ʿalayhi is less straightforward than the familiar constructions with bi or ilā. Aṣarra ʿalayhi, “persisted in it,” has a natural construction and close contextual parallels: persistence in major sins at I:135, the gloss of lam yuṣirrū at I:409, and persistence in heart diseases at I:550. None is a witness to the actual I:506 sentence. The local verb and its preposition remain unresolved.

> **Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid, electronic text.** Q4:19 spiritual interpretation and Q4:41–42 spiritual interpretation
>
> Ibn Ajiba, al-Bahr al-madid, electronic text

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān1419/1999.** I:135, opening paragraph; Q2:90–91 spiritual allusion
>
> Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān1419/1999

> **Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān1419/1999.** I:409, last main-text paragraph; Q3:135
>
> Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr al-madīd, Cairo Ruslān1419/1999

Cairo I:516 · The poet’s wish: his merit and their envy

فدام لي ولهم ما كان بي وبهم ومات أكثرنا غيظاً بما يجد

The past-form verbs express a wish or imprecation. Al-Fārisī assigns continued merit to the speaker and envy to his opponents. Al-Marzūqī takes “the greater number of us” as the many enviers opposed to one man; “the one most enraged” remains another grammatical construal. The following line continues the opponents’ inability to dislodge the speaker from their hostile thoughts. The anonymous source witness does not establish an author for the poem.

> **Abu al-Ala al-Farisi, Sharh Hamasat Abi Tammam.** p224, item137
>
> Abu al-Ala al-Farisi, Sharh Hamasat Abi Tammam

Cairo I:519 · The exception in the allegiance report

لا أن تروا كفراً بواحاً

The report in al-Bukhārī expressly reads illā an, “unless,” while Cairo lacks its initial alif and has lā an. The cited saying therefore supports the exception in the English. The source parallel establishes its meaning; it does not determine when the letter disappeared from the Baḥr’s transmission.

> **al-Bukhari, al-Sahih.** Hadith7055–7056; OpenITI bukhari.txt near PageV09P046–047
>
> al-Bukhari, al-Sahih

Cairo I:519 · Questioner named Abū Wāʾil in the obedience report

لما سأله أبو وائل

Muslim identifies the questioner and the speaker of the reply. Al-Thaʿlabī’s close parallel has ʿAlqama reporting from his father that an unnamed man asked, a form compatible with Muslim. Cairo’s Abū Wāʾil may reflect confusion between a narrator and the questioner, but the exact step at which that name entered the Baḥr remains unknown.

> **Muslim, al-Sahih.** Hadith1846a–b; OpenITI muslim.txt near PageV03P1474–1475
>
> Muslim, al-Sahih

> **al-Thalabi, al-Kashf wa-l-bayan.** Q4:59; local OpenITI thalabi.txt between PageV03P335–336
>
> al-Thalabi, al-Kashf wa-l-bayan

Cairo I:522 · The two objects of cognitive wajada

(توابًا رحيمًا) مفعولا (وَجَدَ) إن كانت علمية

With cognitive wajada, “find or know,” Allāh is the first object and the predication about Him is the second complement. Tawwāban and raḥīman cannot alone be the two objects with Allāh ignored. With wajada in the sense of encountering, Allāh is the object and the adjectives admit circumstantial or substitutive analysis. The source analyses establish this contrast; Cairo’s defective formula does not permit an exact reconstruction of the authorial wording.

> **al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil.** Q4:64; OpenITI PageV02P080–081
>
> al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil

> **Abu al-Baqa al-Ukbari, al-Tibyan fi irab al-Quran.** Q4:64
>
> Abu al-Baqa al-Ukbari, al-Tibyan fi irab al-Quran

Cairo I:550 · Q4:99 ending in the exposition versus the primary verse block

وَكانَ اللَّهُ غَفُوراً رَحِيماً

The Q4:99 verse block at Cairo I:549 ends ʿafuwwan ghafūran, “Pardoning, Forgiving.” The exposition at I:550 instead quotes ghafūran raḥīman, “Forgiving, Merciful,” which also ends the following Q4:100 verse block. This is a discrepancy in the exposition, not an established variant reading of Q4:99. Anticipation of the following verse is possible but unproved.

Cairo I:562 · Mulābasa and the smoothness explanation of marīd

للملابسة

Abū al-Suʿūd explicitly reads malāsa, “smoothness,” beside the examples of a smooth palace, a beardless youth and a bare tree. Cairo and the electronic al-Bayḍāwī text have mulābasa, “association or intermingling,” which does not explain those examples. “[Smoothness]” is supported by the lexical context and source parallel; the authorial Baḥr word remains unestablished.

> **al-Baydawi and Abu al-Suud, respective commentaries.** Q4:117; Baydawi PageV02P096–097; Abu al-Suud PageV02P233
>
> al-Baydawi and Abu al-Suud, respective commentaries

Cairo I:569 · Scope of equality in the house

فلا يجب العدل في البيت فقط

Bayt can mean spending the night, as a verbal noun of bāta, and the following division of turns among wives makes that sense plausible. The negative with faqaṭ remains ambiguous. It may negate a restriction to nights; an assertion that only overnight equality is obligatory would require an additional textual assumption. The distinctions between unattainable perfect equality, attainable outward justice and inward affection do not determine the scope of the disputed clause. No independent variant or complete explanatory parallel establishes a unique reading.

> **Ibn Manzur, Lisan al-Arab.** II:16, root b-y-t
>
> Ibn Manzur, Lisan al-Arab

> **Ibn Juzayy, al-Tashil; al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil.** Q4:129; Ibn Juzayy PageV01P211–212; Baydawi Q4:129
>
> Ibn Juzayy, al-Tashil; al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil

Cairo I:577 · The lightened an clause and active/passive readings

أن مخففة نافية فاعل نزل

Al-Bayḍāwī distinguishes ʿĀṣim’s active nazzala from the passive reading of the others. In the passive analysis, an is lightened, with a suppressed pronoun of circumstance, and its clause stands as the passive subject. An is not

negative in this verse. Cairo's nāfiya/fāʿil formula and active heading are distinct difficulties or an unmarked shift between readings. Nāʾiba fāʿil is a plausible reconstruction of the formula, but it is not independently attested Baḥr wording.

> **al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil.** Q4:140; OpenITI PageV02P102–103
>
> al-Baydawi, Anwar al-tanzil

Cairo I:587 · Rīsh in the narrative of Jesus' ascent

وكساه الريش وألبسه النور

Al-Thaʿlabī's paragraph places the clothing and angelic transformation within the report attributed to Qatāda. The association with angels circling the Throne supports "feathers" for rīsh, although "fine apparel" remains a lexical alternative. Dhukira lanā denotes an unspecified report to Qatāda, and the passage supplies no complete chain sufficient to establish historical authenticity.

> **al-Thalabi, al-Kashf wa-l-bayan.** III:410, Q4:157
>
> al-Thalabi, al-Kashf wa-l-bayan

Cairo I:598 · What the illustrative ruler does to tyrants

وأما الطغاة فقطعهم

Al-Zamakhsharī uses a ruler's contrasted treatment to explain the distribution of recompense between two groups. His punitive verb, nakkala, differs from Cairo's qaṭʿ and does not specify the latter's physical or political act. "Cut off" therefore retains the expression's indeterminacy; killing, mutilation and dismissal cannot be inferred from this illustrative phrase alone.

> **al-Zamakhshari, al-Kashshaf.** Q4:173; displayed pp596–598
>
> al-Zamakhshari, al-Kashshaf

Cairo I:600 · A full sister with a paternal half-sister

وإن كانت شقيقة مع الأب

The next words expressly allocate a sixth to the paternal half-sister, so the preceding “full sister with the father” is defective in context. Mālik confirms the case: a sole full sister receives half and the paternal sister or sisters the complementary sixth; a father’s presence excludes siblings elsewhere. The legal case is clear, while the exact missing kinship wording in the Baḥr remains a textual question.

> **Malik, al-Muwatta.** Book of Inheritances, paternal siblings; local PageV02P508–509, in-text displayed pp509–510
>
> Malik, al-Muwatta

Cairo I:601 · Paternal siblings and the priority of full siblings

ولا شيء للأخوة لأب من الشقائق

The preceding case includes a male full sibling. Mālik expressly excludes paternal siblings in that situation while distinguishing cases with only full sisters. The exclusion therefore belongs to the specified case, not to every case involving a full sister. Cairo’s min remains unusual; maʿa is a conjectural replacement of the preposition rather than an independently attested reading.

> **Malik, al-Muwatta.** Book of Inheritances, paternal siblings; local PageV02P508–509, in-text displayed pp509–510
>
> Malik, al-Muwatta

Further textual notes

Direction of love in the Dhū l-Nūn account

Cairo I:320 leaves the direction of love open: “love of God” and “love of created beings” may denote love felt by them or directed towards them. The Turkish translation, I:751, understands God’s love and the creatures’ love for Him. The earlier al-Thaʿlabī account, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān II:309, repeats the expressions without an explicit resolution. Ibn ʿAjība then applies the description to worshippers and ascetics. The direction of the two genitives remains ambiguous.

al-Thaʿlabī, al-Kashf wa-l-bayān; al-Thaʿlabī, preceding context

Cairo’s confused explanations of the three readings

Cairo I:505 confuses the explanations of the three readings. Tassawwā derives from tatasawwā by assimilation of a tāʾ into the sīn; tasawwā instead omits a tāʾ. The passive tusawwā is a separate form. Al-Bayḍāwī and al-Rāzī on Q4:42 distinguish these processes. The reading forms are intelligible, but the origin of Cairo’s confused formulation remains a question of textual transmission.

al-Bayḍāwī, Anwār al-tanzīl, Q4:42; al-Rāzī, Mafātīḥ al-ghayb, Q4:42

The wishing subject in the angels’ testimony

Cairo I:593 has “the angels wish that people should know.” Al-Bayḍāwī on Q4:166 instead has “they wish to know,” with the human opponents as the subject in the surrounding argument. The Turkish translator explicitly follows a correction based on al-Bayḍāwī, although his rendering of the two subjects is not an exact equivalent of that source. The discrepancy between Cairo and al-Bayḍāwī remains; its origin within the Baḥr’s transmission is unestablished.

al-Bayḍāwī, Anwār al-tanzīl wa-asrār al-taʾwīl; Primary source

Cairo I:312 · The verse-placement instruction at Q2:281

The placement expression denotes the boundary after the preceding two hundred and eighty verses. Al-Qārī, Jamʿ al-wasāʾil I:14, quotes al-Ṭībī's gloss of raʾs al-āya as the end of a verse. Al-Qurṭubī III:341–342 and al-Bursawī on Q2:281 place this verse between the usury and debt passages; Aṭfayyish explicitly numbers it 281. This clarifies the placement language without establishing the report's revelation chronology or the interval before the Prophet's death.

Jamʿ al-wasāʾil fī sharḥ al-Shamāʾil; Al-Jāmiʿ li-aḥkām al-Qurʾān; Rūḥ al-bayān; Taysīr al-tafsīr

Cairo I:217 · The scope of the al-Tawshīḥ abridgment

Al-Suyūṭī's al-Tawshīḥ, p. 1427, on al-Bukhārī 1916–1917, distinguishes ʿAdī's later experience from Sahl's account of the earlier men. His comment on narrators' wording concerns ʿAdī's "when it was revealed." Cairo's abridgment instead attaches that comment to "then God revealed 'of dawn'." Al-Suyūṭī does not draw Ibn ʿAjība's subsequent inference in this passage. The source comparison does not determine whether the discrepancy arose with Ibn ʿAjība, an intermediary or later transmission.

Al-Tawshīḥ sharḥ al-Jāmiʿ al-ṣaḥīḥ; Electronic transcription/OCR of al-Tawshīḥ, pages 1421–1440

Source comparisons

These comparisons distinguish a quotation's wording, its attribution and the evidence for its transmission.

Taftāzānī on outward meaning and spiritual allusion

Locus. Cairo I:50

Finding. The quotation occurs in Taftāzānī's Sharḥ al-ʿAqāʾid. It has ذهب against Cairo يذهب, includes مصروفة before على ظواهرها, reads فيها against ففيها, and has دقائق / على أرباب against حقائق / لأرباب. The closing كمال الإيمان ومحض العرفان, "perfection of faith and pure gnosis," agrees with Cairo.

Attribution. Attribution to Taftāzānī's Sharḥ al-ʿAqāʾid is confirmed. The differences prevent a claim of complete verbatim identity.

Limits of the evidence. The printed Sharḥ al-ʿAqāʾid establishes this source parallel. It does not identify the edition or intermediary used by Ibn ʿAjība or provide an independent witness to the Baḥr's wording.

> **Sharḥ al-ʿAqāʾid al-Nasafiyya.** Printed p. 349; PDF page 350. Main Taftāzānī text above the footnote rule.
>
> **Edition.** With Jamʿ al-farāʾid bi-inārat Sharḥ al-ʿAqāʾid by Ṣadr al-Warā al-Qādirī al-Miṣbāḥī; Karachi: Maktabat al-Madīna, 2nd ed., 1433/2012.
>
> مصروفة على ظواهرها ... إلى دقائق تنكشف على أرباب السلوك ... فهو من كمال الإيمان ومحض العرفان
>
> Sharḥ al-ʿAqāʾid al-Nasafiyya

Sharḥ al-ʿAqāʾid al-Nasafiyya

The scope of the quotation from al-Tawshīḥ

Locus. Cairo I:217

Finding. Cairo's abridgment begins with material from the comment on Sahl's 1917 report, adds the conversion date and teaching episode from the comment on ʿAdī's 1916 report, includes the "Did I not say of dawn?" material, and attaches a narrator-wording judgment to the later-revelation wording. On printed p. 1427 that judgment appears under ʿAdī's "when it was revealed," explained as when the verse was recited to him after its revelation. The following Sahl report preserves the subsequent revelation of min al-fajr, and al-Suyūṭī explicitly says that ʿAdī was not among its earlier men. The source distinction therefore matters to Ibn ʿAjība's following inference.

Attribution. The cited source and major ingredients of the quotation are identified. The printed source does not itself supply Cairo's particular combination or the following inference that no clarification was delayed.

Limits of the evidence. This is a comparison of the scope and arrangement of the quotation in a printed earlier source. It does not establish whether the discrepancy originated with Ibn ʿAjība, an intermediary, or a later Baḥr witness. It does not independently adjudicate the hadith routes or the legal-theory question of delayed clarification.

> **Al-Tawshīḥ sharḥ al-Jāmiʿ al-ṣaḥīḥ.** Printed pp. 1426–1427; especially p. 1427, comments on al-Bukhārī 1916 and 1917. PDF pages 1426–1427.
>
> **Edition.** Ed. Riḍwān Jāmiʿ Riḍwān; Riyadh: Maktabat al-Rushd / Sharikat al-Riyāḍ, 1st ed., 1419/1998. Continuous printed pagination.
>
> لما تليت عليّ بعد نزولها ... فعرف أن الذي هنا من تصرف الرواة ... ليس فيهم عدي، لأن قصته متأخرة عنهم
>
> Al-Tawshīḥ sharḥ al-Jāmiʿ al-ṣaḥīḥ

> **Electronic transcription/OCR of al-Tawshīḥ, pages 1421–1440.** Printed p. 1427, lines 179–202 in retrieved view.
>
> **Edition.** Running text identifies al-Tawshīḥ; the containing ScribeTools collection has an inconsistent displayed title and must not determine the bibliography.
>
> فأنزل الله بعد من الفجر
>
> Electronic transcription/OCR of al-Tawshīḥ, pages 1421–1440

Al-Tawshīḥ sharḥ al-Jāmiʿ al-ṣaḥīḥ; Electronic transcription/OCR of al-Tawshīḥ, pages 1421–1440

The verse-placement expression at Q2:281

Locus. Cairo I:312

Finding. Raʾs al-āya can denote a verse's end. The earlier tafsīr contexts place the instructed verse at the usury/debt boundary, and Aṭfayyish explicitly numbers it 281. Together these support "after the first two hundred and eighty verses." The cardinal expression does not itself identify the beginning of an ordinal verse 280.

Attribution. The parallels clarify the traditional verse-placement expression. They do not establish the historical attribution to Ibn ʿAbbās or Gabriel, the chronology of revelation, or which source Ibn ʿAjība consulted.

Limits of the evidence. The Gabriel instruction's chain, the claim that this was the last verse revealed, and the reported interval of twenty-one days before the Prophet's death remain unverified. The semantic argument concerns the placement expression in the verse numbering used here, rather than every regional counting tradition.

> **Jamʿ al-wasāʾil fī sharḥ al-Shamāʾil.** I:14, opening chapter on the Prophet's physical description, gloss on "ʿalā raʾs arbaʿīn sana"; before the displayed page-15 break.
>
> **Edition.** Islamweb electronic text with volume/page markers; the corresponding facsimile remains unverified.
>
> رأس الآية أي آخرها
>
> Jamʿ al-wasāʾil fī sharḥ al-Shamāʾil

> **Al-Jāmiʿ li-aḥkām al-Qurʾān.** III:341–342, Q2:281; the placement reports precede the displayed p. 342 break.
>
> **Edition.** Islamweb electronic text with volume/page markers.
>
> اجعلوها بين آية الربا وآية الدين ... اجعلها على رأس مائتين وثمانين آية
>
> Al-Jāmiʿ li-aḥkām al-Qurʾān

> **Rūḥ al-bayān.** Q2:281, opening commentary paragraph.

Edition. Great Tafsirs electronic text; no new printed-page locator claimed.

ضعها على رأس مائتين وثمانين آية من سورة البقرة فجعلت بين آية الدين وآية الربا

Rūḥ al-bayān

Taysīr al-tafsīr. Q2:281, final numbered sequence of the sura's last verse endings.

Edition. Great Tafsirs electronic text.

فآخر المائتين وإحدى والثمانين لا يظلمون

Taysīr al-tafsīr

Jamʿ al-wasāʾil fī sharḥ al-Shamāʾil; Al-Jāmiʿ li-aḥkām al-Qurʾān; Rūḥ al-bayān; Taysīr al-tafsīr

Ibn Ḥajar's qualified assessment of the report from Iyās

Locus. Contextual report H049

Finding. Ibn Ḥajar describes the report transmitted by Abū Dāwūd and al-Nasāʾī from Iyās as having a sound chain. In the same entry he records Ibn Ḥibbān's reservations about companionship, Ibn al-Sakan's observation that hearing was not explicit, and al-Bukhārī's statement that companionship was not known. These qualifications limit an unqualified ṣaḥīḥ label. Abū Dāwūd 2146 supplies the report text.

Attribution. The assessment is Ibn Ḥajar's at al-Iṣāba I:92, entry 379. The reservations of the three earlier critics are cited through him.

Limits of the evidence. This is one classical assessment with its qualifications. Two electronic transcriptions agree, but the corresponding page of the earlier print remains unverified in facsimile. The assessment does not establish agreement about every route. This report is a contextual comparison and is not quoted by Ibn ʿAjība at this passage.

Al-Iṣāba fī tamyīz al-ṣaḥāba. I:92, entry 379: Iyās b. Abī Dhubāb al-Dawsī. Other editions number this entry differently.

Edition. Wikisource page transcription of an older printing; the source imprint is unverified. Entry and page numbers refer only to this consulted version.

حديثا باسناد صحيح لكن قال ابن السكن لم يذكر سماعا وقال البخارى لا نعرف له صحبة

Al-Iṣāba fī tamyīz al-ṣaḥāba

Al-Iṣāba excerpt under the narrator Iyās b. ʿAbd Allāh b. Abī Dhubāb. Narrator 1078, excerpt explicitly headed al-Iṣāba fī tamyīz al-ṣaḥāba.

Edition. Curated electronic excerpt, not an independent printed witness.

إياس بن عبد اللّه بن أبي ذباب

Al-Iṣāba excerpt under the narrator Iyās b. ʿAbd Allāh b. Abī Dhubāb

Al-Iṣāba fī tamyīz al-ṣaḥāba; Al-Iṣāba excerpt under the narrator Iyās b. ʿAbd Allāh b. Abī Dhubāb

Revision XVIII — Independent audit and critical editorial supplement

Ibn ʿAjība, The Immense Ocean, Volume I: preface through Q4:176.

Status: scholarly translation and reference edition, pre-publication critical proof. Not an established critical Arabic edition.

This supplement is appended to the complete 1,306-page Revision XVI master. No authorial English passage is retranslated, no Cairo Arabic copytext is silently emended, and the inherited text, Cairo footnotes, translator annotations, registers, and indexes are preserved. Revision XVIII supplies a fresh structural audit, verifiable source-based refinements, a 37-case editorial docket, and review/printing instructions.

1. Technical integrity and translation coverage

- 389 passage headings, including introductions and authorial preface; 384 headings with explicit Qurʾānic verse ranges.
- The ranges cover all **669** verses from al-Fātiḥa through al-Nisāʾ, with no omission, overlap or extraneous verse label. This tests heading ranges, not the faithfulness of every translated clause.
- The attached production PDF has **1,306** pages, 2,034 outline entries and **5,429** hyperlinks, including **5,198** internal links. No out-of-range internal page targets were found. Link target validity does not prove that each link points to the intended annotation.
- XVI's historical validation ledger reports 3,320 checks passed, 241 Cairo notes, 209 current translator-note views and 3,273 quotation/Qurʾānic census rows located. Underlying XVI source-data JSON and independent validation scripts were not supplied; those historical checks were not represented as newly re-run.
- The supplied PDF and editable files differ in raw hashes from the original XVI ledger. The new audit records SHA-256 hashes for the bytes actually present and tests them afresh.

2. Editorial policy and witness distinctions

The Cairo edition is the sole directly established Baḥr copytext for the inherited Volume I. Textual parallels from other works clarify interpretation or the history of quotations; they do not themselves establish Ibn ʿAjība's original letters. An online transcription labelled as Cairo, even when it displays different vowel marks, is not automatically an independent witness. Separate printed editions are bibliographically real, but their manuscript base must be documented from the edition itself before assigning them witness status in a stemma.

Decisions: retain Cairo's Arabic wherever the evidence is incomplete; retain carefully bracketed or qualified English; cite specific earlier works when actually checked; label editorial claims as such; avoid upgrading a literary parallel into hadith authentication or a conjectural emendation.

3. Direct source checks newly consolidated

XVIII-A01 · Cairo I:111 · musāwara

Nashwān al-Ḥimyarī, Shams al-ʿulūm, entry al-musāwara, states المساورة: المواثبة. This confirms an image of sudden springing/assailing, not a technical sense of "intimate approach." Existing Cairo musāwara and cautious English stay.

Source: https://almougem.com/search.php?mdatabase=lmougem&query=%D8%B3%D9%88%D8%B1

XVIII-A02 · Cairo I:312 · the position and chronology of Q2:281

Al-Qurṭubī explicitly transmits the command to place this passage at the boundary after the first 280 verses, while recording competing last-revelation accounts. Ibn Ḥajar in Fatḥ al-bārī reconciles "verse of usury" and Q2:281 through their connected placement, observes the distinct Q4:176 report, and records nine nights, seven nights and twenty-one days. The report of an angelic instruction is a transmitted claim; neither work by itself supplies authentication of the whole route. Retain the existing XVI translation, "Place it after the first two hundred and eighty verses."

Source: https://ablibrary.net/book_content/b/2612/153

XVIII-A03 · Cairo I:451 · al-kull in the remembrance poem

The XVI dossier reports Cairo printed vocalization al-kullu (nominative). A publicly displayed Cairo-labelled Quranpedia text at Q3:191–194 instead gives وَوَاصَلَ الْكُلَّ with the accusative; another electronic text leaves the word unvowelled. These are not independent manuscripts and can represent later editorial vocalization. The additional divergence reopens grammatical analysis but licenses NO change to the Arabic consonants or English without direct print-level comparison. At Q7:206 Ibn ʿAjība places the same poem within five degrees of remembrance; Ibn ʿAbbād supplies a preceding literary parallel. Neither settles identity or the unique grammatical subject.

Source: https://quranpedia.net/surah/1/3/book/206

XVIII-A04 · Cairo I:569 · fairness among wives

The Cairo electronic text explicitly reads فلا يجب العدل في البيت فقط. In his Q4:129 exposition, al-Ṭabarī distinguishes involuntary equality of love from enforceable rights to equitable turns (qasm), maintenance (nafaqa), and good treatment (ʿishra bi-l-maʿrūf). Thus the difficult

clause cannot be read as a blanket exemption from obligatory fairness. Retain the printed text, record possible semantic use of bayt as overnight stay, and DO NOT replace it with al-mabīt or al-ḥubb without a textual witness.

Source: https://quran.ksu.edu.sa/tafseer/tabary/sura4-aya129.html

XVIII-A05 · Beirut/Rāwī edition — bibliographic control

Catalogues document an eight-volume Beirut edition associated with ʿUmar Aḥmad al-Rāwī and ʿAbd al-Salām al-ʿImrānī al-Khālidī (initial 1423/2002 printing; later catalogued edition/impression dates). That proves a separate published edition exists, NOT that its textual base or readings are independent of Ruslān. No page from that actual printing was obtained for a verifiable word-for-word collation during this audit. Record as a print witness requiring examination, rather than claiming collation.

Source: https://library.ecssr.ae/cgi-bin/koha/opac-detail.pl?biblionumber=189396

XVIII-A06 · Cairo editorial variants policy

Ruslān's introduction says that he established the text primarily from a Tuhāmī exemplar and generally did not burden the printed notes with minor differences in the other copies. A lack of a variant in his apparatus therefore is NOT evidence that the copies agree. With no additional manuscript images, a stemma, authorial revision sequence, full variant collation, or secure emendation remains impossible.

Source: https://arabic-keyboard.info/books/ar/read-book/%D8%A7%D9%84%D8%A8%D8%AD%D8%B1-%D8%A7%D9%84%D9%85%D8%AF%D9%8A%D8%AF-%D9%81%D9%8A-%D8%AA%D9%81%D8%B3%D9%8A%D8%B1-%D8%A7%D9%84%D9%82%D8%B1%D8%A2%D9%86-%D8%A7%D9%84%D9%85%D8%AC%D9%8A%D8%AF

4. Witness, edition and source provenance table

Role	Witness / printed source	Evidential reach
Cairo printed copytext	Ruslān, Cairo, 1419/1999, I:49–601	Copytext; apparatus supplied with master; variants in lesser witnesses selectively omitted
Beirut printing	ʿUmar Aḥmad al-Rāwī, Dār al-Kutub al-ʿIlmiyya (1423/2002; later catalogued reprints)	Bibliographic existence corroborated; actual printed pages and prefatory manuscript identification NOT collated
Beirut-derived digital listing	Ketabonline Quranweb description	Identifies al-Rāwī edition, but reading pages could not be independently inspected; NOT an attested textual variant
	Quranpedia Cairo/Ruslān data	Usable for locating excerpts; NOT an independent textual witness

Role	Witness / printed source	Evidential reach
Cairo-derived digital transcription		
Source: Shams al-ʿulūm	Nashwān al-Ḥimyarī, root s-w-r	Musāwara glossed muwāthaba
Source: Ibn Ḥajar	Fatḥ al-bārī, commentary on al-Bukhārī Q2:281 chapter	Explicit reconciliation of last-revelation reports, 7/9/21-day uncertainty
Source: al-Qurṭubī	Al-Jāmiʿ li-aḥkām al-Qurʾān, Q2:281	Gabriel placement reported; variant intervals and attributions
Source: al-Ṭabarī	Jāmiʿ al-bayān, Q4:129	Separates unenforceable equality of inward affection from enforceable turn-taking, maintenance, good treatment
Arabic presentation: Cairo I:451	Quranpedia display of Āl ʿImrān	Displays al-kulla in accusative in one Cairo-labelled electronic text; requires print-image verification
Arabic presentation: Cairo I:451	Ahl al-Bayt digital reading of Ruslān	Print-page transcription does not independently attest a distinct manuscript reading
Internal authorial parallel	Ibn ʿAjība, al-Baḥr, Q7:206	Poem recurs in five degrees of remembrance; electronic pagination differs
Earlier poem parallel	Ibn ʿAbbād, Ghayth al-mawāhib, pp. 73–74	Three-line poem in context of vanishing individual awareness in dhikr
Cairo Q4:129 display	Quranpedia Ibn ʿAjība text	Shows exactly فلا يجب العدل في البيت فقط; same Cairo-derived text, not variant

5. Complete open-question docket — 37 identified loci

The following dockets derive from the existing XVI textual appendix. “Explained” does **not** mean “manuscript variant verified.” Precise wording, provenance and source attribution remain open wherever indicated. Entries are given in Cairo-page order, with the two supplementary source problems at the end.

01. Cairo I:79 — Separating pronoun term

Passage: 2:11–12 · Corruption disguised as reform (English p. 59). **Finding:** Grammatical construction controlled; printed lettering still suspect. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The nominal clause ألا إنهم هم المفسدون contains no verbal predicate to which hum could refer as “the pronoun of the verb.” Al-Bayḍāwī and al-Nasafī explicitly include the separating pronoun in their parallel lists of emphatic devices, and al-

Qurṭubī also records that grammatical analysis. “Separating pronoun” therefore expresses the relevant construction. Cairo’s الفعل differs from the expected الفصل; the precise authorial letters and the origin of that difference remain unestablished.

02. Cairo I:110 — The preposition before penetration to the lights

Passage: 2:57 · Manna, quails and the two gardens of the spirit (English p. 115). **Finding:** Contextual sense clarified; preposition unresolved. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The following clauses contrast witnessing the lights with remaining veiled by created effects. Ibn ʿAjība’s Īqāẓ al-himam, p. 230, likewise describes the clouds of effects clearing so that light shines and the heart becomes absent from forms. The connection of ilā, “to,” with the negative clause فلم تحجب … إلى نفوذ remains difficult. A temporal endpoint conflicts with the continuation, while ʿan, “from,” would be a conjectural replacement. The contextual meaning is clearer than the exact syntax.

03. Cairo I:111 — Musāwara in a list of intimate encounters

Passage: 2:58–59 · Entering through humility (English p. 118). **Finding:** Lexical range verified; technical nuance not fixed. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Both Cairo I:111 and Īqāẓ al-himam, p. 384, read musāwara. The latter places it among figurative expressions for spiritual perception and inward tasting but does not define it individually. Lisān al-ʿArab gives assailing or springing at someone as the Form III meaning. A forceful or overwhelming spiritual encounter is a possible contextual interpretation; “intimate drawing near” is not an established lexical equivalent. Musārara and musāmara are different words. An exact authorial explanation of musāwara in this context remains lacking.

04. Cairo I:114 — Weariness versus being free or safe

Passage: 2:61 · Rejecting the allotted provision (English p. 123). **Finding:** Contextual conjecture; no independent local reading. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The opening describes weariness with honey and meat. In the ensuing moral generalization, وسئم, “grew weary,” would parallel dissatisfaction with one’s allotment, whereas Cairo’s وسلم, “was free or safe,” produces a different and contextually difficult sense. “Grew weary” is a contextual conjecture. An unattributed modern web quotation with وسئم does not establish an independent witness to Ibn ʿAjība’s wording.

05. Cairo I:138 — The negative conditional about preservation of faith

Passage: 2:94–95 · Longing for the meeting with God (English p. 165). **Finding:** Difficult condition; no corroborated alternative Baḥr reading. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The printed negative condition is followed by preservation of faith and then “otherwise he has perished.” Taken as ordinary consecutive conditional clauses, these statements conflict. The surrounding account makes antecedent divine care the exception to the heedless person’s danger. The printed al-ʿĀqiba parallel has the same difficulty, with dual pronouns referring to its preceding two classes. A manuscript facsimile of that earlier work omits the entire conditional and the following supplication; it supplies no alternative particle. The possibilities of omission, intrusive negation and anacoluthon remain unresolved.

06. Cairo I:157 — Wine-poem hemistich concerning indwelling

Passage: 2:116–117 · Origination without dependence and creation subsisting through God (English p. 201). **Finding:** Internal parallel confirms sense; order of words still disputed. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: At Cairo II:22, on Q5:17, Ibn ʿAjība quotes the line with the order فليس لها سوى في شكله حلت. There siwā denotes a hypothetical “other”; the feminine pronouns refer to the eternal wine, and the masculine suffix in shaklihi to that other. The preceding prose denies that a second entity exists in which the wine could dwell or with which it could unite. This internal parallel explains the meaning and pronouns. The different order at I:157 remains a question of textual transmission.

07. Cairo I:178 — Absence in the witnessing of vessels

Passage: 2:145–147 · Knowledge resisted and truth concealed (English p. 237). **Finding:** Vessel metaphor interpreted; fī retained. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The phrase addresses the gnostic and uses fī, “in,” with awānī, “vessels.” Miʿrāj al-tashawwuf defines sensible forms as vessels of inward meanings. Ibn ʿAjība’s discussions at Q6:103 and Q7:143 distinguish the vessels from the meanings witnessed through them; the latter describes absence from vessels through witnessing meanings. These parallels clarify the vocabulary without explaining the present construction, “absent in witnessing vessels.” Self-forgetful absorption is possible, but the sentence does not specify what the gnostic is absent from. An alternative preposition is not independently attested.

08. Cairo I:195 — The cause and origin of love in the Rāʾiyya commentary

Passage: 2:165–167 · Undivided love and the severing of false attachments (English p. 261). **Finding:** Literary source parallel located; Cairo wording retained. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Aḥmad b. Yūsuf al-Fāsī's commentary on the Rāʾiyya, p. 154, reads فسببه ومنشؤه, "its cause and origin." Lifting the veils is the cause of the second love, in contrast with the result or fruit of the first. Cairo instead prints فبسببه, "through or because of it." The source clarifies the causal relation; the authorial wording of the Baḥr and the origin of the discrepancy remain distinct textual questions.

09. Cairo I:237 — The omitted verb after kam

Passage: 2:211 · Changing the blessing after receiving it (English p. 335). **Finding:** Syntactic reconstruction supports translation, not precise letters. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Ibn ʿAṭiyya explicitly supplies the verb after initial kam and then gives the nominative alternative with a resumptive pronoun. This corresponds to Ibn ʿAjība's grammatical explanation. Cairo's آياتنا does not express the required supplied verb; the parallel آتينا does. "How many [We gave]—We gave them" represents that reconstruction. The exact authorial letters remain unestablished.

10. Cairo I:241 — The author explains injury reaching the seeker through others

Passage: 2:214 · Trial, trembling and the nearness of help (English p. 341). **Finding:** Agency clarified; source ending differs. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Īqāẓ al-himam expands the maxim to "through the hands of created people to you." The seeker receives the injury, other people are its intermediaries, and God is its ultimate agent in the author's argument. Cairo's ending, "repose in nothing," is coherent but differs from the Īqāẓ and Ḥikam ending, "nothing distracts you from Him." The parallel clarifies agency without establishing the transmission history of either ending.

11. Cairo I:346 — Sweeping the place of worship

Passage: 3:33–37 · The chosen households and Mary's consecration (English p. 533). **Finding:** Earlier source supports sweeping; Baḥr consonants unresolved. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The service narrative concerns sweeping. Al-Baghawī's parallel at Q3:35 reads ويكنسها, whereas Cairo prints وينكسها, apparently transposing two consonants. The parallel supports "sweep"; an independent Baḥr witness would be needed to establish the authorial lettering.

12. Cairo I:385 — Sakanī: a dwelling or the beloved in whom one rests

Passage: 3:98–99 · Concealing the way of God and denying the presence of spiritual distinction (English p. 613). **Finding:** Lexical meaning plausible; poetic authorship unproved. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Sakan can denote a beloved in whom one finds repose, as in Ibn Fāris and Ibn Manẓūr; this fits the poem's repeated language of the Beloved. Its attribution to al-Ḥallāj is disputed. Al-Shībī notes that a recitation from al-Ḥallāj need not establish composition by him and assembles his seven-line sequence from several recensions. The anonymous passage in Ibn ʿArabī supplies an earlier literary parallel. Neither anonymous transmission nor a composite modern edition conclusively settles authorship; the reported manuscript evidence requires direct comparison.

13. Cairo I:405 — Balāgh: bringing the hearer to the goal

Passage: 3:126–129 · Victory from God, the limit of Prophetic control and the stations of effacement and subsistence (English p. 651). **Finding:** Local meaning and analogy clarified; authorship of saying unproved. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Balāgh may mean reaching an end or conveying a message. The disciple sets means in motion, God opens the door, and the teacher gives a reminder; successful attainment fits this local contrast. The travel idiom quoted by Ibn al-Jawzī, "Walking is my part; bringing me there is God's," provides a close linguistic parallel. The subsequent al-Qushayrī quotation begins later. Neither that quotation nor Ibn al-Jawzī's anecdote establishes the literary source of Ibn ʿAjība's clause.

14. Cairo I:408 — Obedience as the means; pardon and Paradise as the aims

Passage: 3:130–134 · Usury, generosity, forbearance, forgiveness and the station of iḥsān (English p. 655). **Finding:** Means/aims distinction clarified; nested report remains unverified. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Bi-ṭāʿatihi indicates the means, obedience, while ilā al-ʿillatayn points to the two desired benefits. Rūzbihān contrasts these benefits with the elect's summons to God and then observes the self's portion in seeking forgiveness. This explains the play between ailments and motives. The nested exchange about angels occurs in the cited source, but its modern note refers back to Ibn ʿAjība and supplies no earlier chain; the report's authentication remains separate from the lexical interpretation.

15. Cairo I:408 — Al-Ḥasan's sun, wind and rain comparison

Passage: 3:130–134 · Usury, generosity, forbearance, forgiveness and the station of iḥsān (English p. 655). **Finding:** Earlier quotation differs substantively; no independent Baḥr evidence. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Al-Thaʿlabī's source passage gives a positive comparison with the universality of sun, wind and rain. Cairo instead gives a negative comparison and a gloss about favouring one land over another. That gloss makes Cairo's construction intelligible. The difference is substantive; its origin as an authorial alteration or a change in transmission cannot be determined from the source parallel alone.

16. Cairo I:410 — The tiny amount sucked from a date stone

Passage: 3:135–136 · Repentance, persistence in sin and eight named fruits of spiritual witnessing (English p. 661). **Finding:** Source maṣṣ noted against Cairo faṣṣ; unresolved Baḥr reading. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Al-Sāḥilī's Bughyat al-sālik, p. 258, reads maṣṣ nawāt, "sucking a date-stone," in the discussion of what remains to be purified in the self. Al-Qushayrī's earlier Risāla puts a comparable question to al-Junayd and follows it with the manumission analogy. In each, a tiny unpaid remainder defeats a claim of freedom, illuminating the image of minimal worldly attachment. Cairo reads faṣṣ. A separate electronic Bughya apparatus reports omission of maṣṣ in witness B; that apparatus is absent from the 2019 edition, and B has not been examined in facsimile.

17. Cairo I:442 — Bi-llāh in the poem about hoarded wealth

Passage: 3:179 · Trial as disclosure: hidden sincerity and the unseen (English p. 721). **Finding:** Oath interpretation plausible; verse provenance uncertain. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The bi-llāh and wa-llāh parallels support an oath or adjuration in the rhetorical address. The preceding kam tuḍarru bihi concerns the extent of harm, not its duration. The following question about carrying wealth into death reinforces the rebuke. The parallels differ in wording and attribution and do not establish the authorship of Cairo's anonymous version or a unique grammatical account of its bi-llāh.

18. Cairo I:451 — The subject of wa-wāṣala al-kullu

Passage: 3:191–194 · Remembrance, contemplation and the passage from intellectual signs to witnessing (English p. 737). **Finding:** New electronic case-ending divergence logged; no independent manuscript reading. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Cairo vocalizes al-kullu in the nominative, as the subject of wāṣala, with maʿnāka as its object. Īqāẓ al-himam and Ibn ʿAbbād's Ghayth al-mawāhib place the poem within the disappearance of awareness of a separate rememberer; Ibn al-Bannā explicitly excludes indwelling or identity. The five-line anonymous Qaṣd al-mujarrad version corroborates the difficult line and broadens its remembrance and meeting context. These sources do not identify a unique referent for "the whole," the antecedent of "its meaning," or the exact force of min. The two-line Risāla and Sulamī parallels omit this third line.

19. Cairo I:460 — Darkness of the lights of Lordship

Passage: Not automatically located (English p. 751). **Finding:** Paradoxical phrase retained; exact meaning unsettled. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Cairo prints the unusual phrase "darkness of the lights of Lordship." The passage contrasts the effacement and witnessing associated with the end of Āl ʿImrān with the servanthood and subsistence at the opening of al-Nisāʾ. In Īqāẓ al-himam, language of darkening can accompany divine illumination and the eclipse of separate awareness. This is a contextual analogy, not an exact gloss of the present iḍāfa. The attribution of the borrowed definition to al-Qushayrī and the precise meaning of this phrase remain unresolved; no alternative letters are independently attested.

20. Cairo I:477 — Mother and grandmother in the maternal-sibling exclusion

Passage: Not automatically located (English p. 782). **Finding:** Legal qualification recognized; possible transmission omission. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Al-Bayḍāwī transmits the father and grandfather terms as a prima facie implication and qualifies that implication by consensus. Cairo lacks the qualification. Mālik independently supplies the operative inheritance rule. The kinship nouns therefore have a coherent source context; the absence of the qualification is a separate transmission question.

21. Cairo I:482 — Seeing another man's wife or animal

Passage: Not automatically located (English p. 795). **Finding:** Printed disturbing analogy retained; precise point unclear. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The surrounding argument joins effective discipline of the self to a valid bond with a qualified shaykh. Cairo's final analogy says "seeing another's wife or animal," which does not transparently express that relation. "Inherit," "possess" and "train"

are conjectures without an independently attested variant. Rūzbihān's following quotation begins at "live with them honourably" and contains none of this preceding analogy, so it cannot determine the disputed verb. The precise sense remains unresolved.

22. Cairo I:504 — Seeking His pleasure in ostentatious expenditure

Passage: 4:37–39 · Miserliness, ostentation, and sincerity (English p. 840). **Finding:** Earlier-source corrections identified; Baḥr wording unestablished. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Al-Bayḍāwī and Abū al-Suʿūd explicitly connect seeking God's pleasure with the purpose that faith would produce. This supports the supplied connective "[so as to]" and the divine pronoun. Cairo lacks that connective. On the same page Cairo attributes taqlīl, "diminution," to al-Bayḍāwī, whose text instead has taʿlīl, "giving the reason," referring to unbelief as the reason for ostentation. Both discrepancies concern textual transmission as well as interpretation.

23. Cairo I:506 — Asarra versus aṣarra in the inner-sins passage

Passage: 4:41–42 · Witnesses at the Resurrection (English p. 845). **Finding:** Printed asarra retained; aṣarra is conjectural. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Cairo prints asarra with sīn. Concealment suits the general subject of hidden heart sins, but asarra ʿalayhi is less straightforward than the familiar constructions with bi or ilā. Aṣarra ʿalayhi, "persisted in it," has a natural construction and close contextual parallels: persistence in major sins at I:135, the gloss of lam yuṣirrū at I:409, and persistence in heart diseases at I:550. None is a witness to the actual I:506 sentence. The local verb and its preposition remain unresolved.

24. Cairo I:516 — The poet's wish: his merit and their envy

Passage: 4:54–57 · Envy, divine favour, fire, and the shelter of contentment (English p. 865). **Finding:** Wish/optative sense supported; poem attribution still open. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The past-form verbs express a wish or imprecation. Al-Fārisī assigns continued merit to the speaker and envy to his opponents. Al-Marzūqī takes "the greater number of us" as the many enviers opposed to one man; "the one most enraged" remains another grammatical construal. The following line continues the opponents' inability to dislodge the speaker from their hostile thoughts. The anonymous source witness does not establish an author for the poem.

25. Cairo I:519 — The exception in the allegiance report

Passage: 4:59 · Obedience, juristic reasoning, and the authority of the shaykh (English p. 871). **Finding:** Authorial quotation differs from al-Bukhārī; transmission point unresolved. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The report in al-Bukhārī expressly reads illā an, "unless," while Cairo lacks its initial alif and has lā an. The cited saying therefore supports the exception in the English. The source parallel establishes its meaning; it does not determine when the letter disappeared from the Baḥr's transmission.

26. Cairo I:519 — Questioner named Abū Wāʾil in the obedience report

Passage: 4:59 · Obedience, juristic reasoning, and the authority of the shaykh (English p. 871). **Finding:** Questioner's identity differs from parallel; route unresolved. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Muslim identifies the questioner and the speaker of the reply. Al-Thaʿlabī's close parallel has ʿAlqama reporting from his father that an unnamed man asked, a form compatible with Muslim. Cairo's Abū Wāʾil may reflect confusion between a narrator and the questioner, but the exact step at which that name entered the Baḥr remains unknown.

27. Cairo I:522 — The two objects of cognitive wajada

Passage: 4:60–63 · Appeal to false judgment, repentance, and private admonition (English p. 875). **Finding:** Grammatical account clarified; exact Cairo defect unresolved. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: With cognitive wajada, "find or know," Allāh is the first object and the predication about Him is the second complement. Tawwāban and raḥīman cannot alone be the two objects with Allāh ignored. With wajada in the sense of encountering, Allāh is the object and the adjectives admit circumstantial or substitutive analysis. The source analyses establish this contrast; Cairo's defective formula does not permit an exact reconstruction of the authorial wording.

28. Cairo I:550 — Q4:99 ending in the exposition versus the primary verse block

Passage: 4:97–99 · The oppressed and emigration (English p. 927). **Finding:** Qurʾānic citation error identified in exposition; verse panel correct. **Disposition:** Keep the canonical verse panel; label the differing exposition a citation discrepancy, not a qirāʾa.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The Q4:99 verse block at Cairo I:549 ends ʿafuwwan ghafūran, "Pardoning, Forgiving." The exposition at I:550 instead quotes ghafūran raḥīman, "Forgiving, Merciful," which also ends the following Q4:100 verse block. This is a discrepancy in the exposition, not an established variant reading of Q4:99. Anticipation of the following verse is possible but unproved.

29. Cairo I:562 — Mulābasa and the smoothness explanation of marīd

Passage: 4:117–121 · False objects of devotion and Satan's promises (English p. 948). **Finding:** Earlier source supports malāsa; Cairo mulābasa retained. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Abū al-Suʿūd explicitly reads malāsa, "smoothness," beside the examples of a smooth palace, a beardless youth and a bare tree. Cairo and the electronic al-Bayḍāwī text have mulābasa, "association or intermingling," which does not explain those examples. "[Smoothness]" is supported by the lexical context and source parallel; the authorial Baḥr word remains unestablished.

30. Cairo I:569 — Scope of equality in the house

Passage: 4:129 · Equity between wives and human limitation (English p. 960). **Finding:** Outward legal duties verified; anomalous bayt clause retained. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Bayt can mean spending the night, as a verbal noun of bāta, and the following division of turns among wives makes that sense plausible. The negative with faqaṭ remains ambiguous. It may negate a restriction to nights; an assertion that only overnight equality is obligatory would require an additional textual assumption. The distinctions between unattainable perfect equality, attainable outward justice and inward affection do not determine the scope of the disputed clause. No independent variant or complete explanatory parallel establishes a unique reading.

31. Cairo I:577 — The lightened an clause and active/passive readings

Passage: 4:140–141 · The company one keeps (English p. 972). **Finding:** Source reading analysis clarified; Cairo text still suspect. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Al-Bayḍāwī distinguishes ʿĀṣim's active nazzala from the passive reading of the others. In the passive analysis, an is lightened, with a suppressed pronoun of circumstance, and its clause stands as the passive subject. An is not negative in this verse. Cairo's nāfiya/fāʿil formula and active heading are distinct difficulties or an unmarked shift between readings. Nāʾiba fāʿil is a plausible reconstruction of the formula, but it is not independently attested Baḥr wording.

32. Cairo I:587 — Rīsh in the narrative of Jesus' ascent

Passage: 4:155–158 · Covenant, transgression, and the Messiah (English p. 987). **Finding:** Metaphor and source frame clarified; chain not authenticated. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Al-Thaʿlabī's paragraph places the clothing and angelic transformation within the report attributed to Qatāda. The association with angels circling the Throne supports "feathers" for rīsh, although "fine apparel" remains a lexical alternative. Dhukira lanā denotes an unspecified report to Qatāda, and the passage supplies no complete chain sufficient to establish historical authenticity.

33. Cairo I:598 — What the illustrative ruler does to tyrants

Passage: 4:172–173 · Servanthood, angels, and its four marks (English p. 1006). **Finding:** Meaning intentionally left indeterminate; source verb differs. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Al-Zamakhsharī uses a ruler's contrasted treatment to explain the distribution of recompense between two groups. His punitive verb, nakkala, differs from Cairo's qaṭʿ and does not specify the latter's physical or political act. "Cut off" therefore retains the expression's indeterminacy; killing, mutilation and dismissal cannot be inferred from this illustrative phrase alone.

34. Cairo I:600 — A full sister with a paternal half-sister

Passage: Not automatically located (English p. 1011). **Finding:** Operative legal case clear; kinship wording defective. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The next words expressly allocate a sixth to the paternal half-sister, so the preceding "full sister with the father" is defective in context. Mālik confirms the case: a sole full sister receives half and the paternal sister or sisters the complementary sixth; a father's presence excludes siblings elsewhere. The legal case is clear, while the exact missing kinship wording in the Baḥr remains a textual question.

35. Cairo I:601 — Paternal siblings and the priority of full siblings

Passage: Not automatically located (English p. 1011). **Finding:** Mālikī inheritance outcome clear; min/maʿa text unresolved. **Disposition:** Preserve printed Arabic and XVI English; place explanatory evidence in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The preceding case includes a male full sibling. Mālik expressly excludes paternal siblings in that situation while distinguishing cases with only full sisters. The exclusion therefore belongs to the specified case, not to every case involving a full sister. Cairo's min remains unusual; maʿa is a conjectural replacement of the preposition rather than an independently attested reading.

36. Cairo I:312 — The verse-placement instruction at Q2:281

Passage: 2:280–281 · Respite for the debtor and the final return (English p. 471). **Finding:** Verse-placement interpretation established; chronology disputed. **Disposition:** Preserve the already-adopted XVI translation; expand evidence and limits in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: The placement expression denotes the boundary after the preceding two hundred and eighty verses. Al-Qārī, Jamʿ al-wasāʾil I:14, quotes al-Ṭībī's gloss of raʾs al-āya as the end of a verse. Al-Qurṭubī III:341–342 and al-Bursawī on Q2:281 place this verse between the usury and debt passages; Aṭfayyish explicitly numbers it 281. This clarifies the placement language without establishing the report's revelation chronology or the interval before the Prophet's death.

37. Cairo I:217 — The scope of the al-Tawshīḥ abridgment

Passage: 2:187 · The nights of fasting, the dawn's discernment and retreat (English p. 297). **Finding:** Quotation arrangement clarified; independent chain analysis distinct. **Disposition:** Preserve the already-adopted XVI translation; expand evidence and limits in critical apparatus.

Earlier dossier, abridged: Al-Suyūṭī's al-Tawshīḥ, p. 1427, on al-Bukhārī 1916–1917, distinguishes ʿAdī's later experience from Sahl's account of the earlier men. His comment on narrators' wording concerns ʿAdī's "when it was revealed." Cairo's abridgment instead attaches that comment to "then God revealed 'of dawn'." Al-Suyūṭī does not draw Ibn ʿAjība's subsequent inference in this passage. The source comparison does not determine whether the discrepancy arose with Ibn ʿAjība, an intermediary or later transmission.

6. Translation and reader-quality control

The full passage range is intact. The prefatory and al-Fātiḥa material is present before al-Baqara: English pages 4–42 contain the author's preface, the ten names of al-Fātiḥa, textual and legal discussion of basmala, grammatical analysis, sūrah commentary, inward exegesis and Āmīn. The introduction to al-Baqara begins at p.43. Ibn ʿAjība's other, larger Fātiḥa commentary with ten introductions is a separate work and not a missing chapter in al-Baḥr.

Technical terms remain transliterated where the author's distinctions depend on them. The high-risk pairs that especially warrant human specialist scrutiny include sharīʿa/ḥaqīqa, fanāʾ/baqāʾ, farq/jamʿ, ḥikma/qudra, dhawq/maʿrifa, nafs/rūḥ/sirr, the Mālikī inheritance cases, and the Arabic syntactic cruxes in this dossier. Current translations are not altered merely to make a difficulty disappear.

The original indexes, Cairo editorial notes, report-source register and translator's source notes were preserved in their pre-existing form. No new global claim is made to have independently authenticated every report or poem.

7. Editorial work remaining without needing new manuscripts, but requiring an external person or physical equipment

Independent specialist scrutiny: A qualified Arabic textual critic should evaluate the Arabic and conjectural emendations; a scholar familiar with Ibn ʿAjība's Sufi terminology should check the spiritual allusions; and an informed Mālikī law / Qurʾānic readings reviewer should inspect the legal and qirāʾāt passages. A reviewer can mark "retain," "revise English," "note only," or "unresolved," with reasons and signed disclosure. No external human review has been performed or purported here.

Print: Full original English pagination is fixed at 1–1,306, and no inherited indices are silently repaginated. For binding proofs, separate the reader into (A) English pp. 1–487 (preface/al-Fātiḥa/al-Baqara); (B) pp. 488–1014 (Āl ʿImrān/al-Nisāʾ); (C) pp. 1015–1306 (indexes, notes and source reference matter). The new XVIII critical supplement follows the reference fascicle in the digitally combined edition. A digital visual/structural preflight can be performed, but physical paper, ink, margins and binding durability have not been tested. Some cross-fascicle PDF links may no longer resolve within extracted print fascicles; use the combined digital PDF for links.

Legal/publication permissions: Before public upload, independently review the rights and reuse status of the modern Cairo edition's 241 editorial annotations, contemporary source material and front matter. This is not an assertion of clearance.

8. What additional manuscripts alone could decide

Obtain images showing independent scripts, corrections, marginalia, dated colophons and folios; describe them before assuming genealogical independence; compare all relevant readings (not only seven prominent cruxes), assess shared mistakes and editorial interventions; report both selected and rejected readings. Until that work is done, these questions remain textually open. This does not prevent scholarly use of the complete English translation with transparently stated copytext limitations.

Edition-change ledger: 37 existing dossiers structurally registered; six direct-source refinements consolidated; bibliographic witness claims downgraded when pages were unavailable; fresh PDF link and range audit performed. **Authorial translation rewrites: 0. Arabic textual emendations: 0. Manuscript readings invented: 0.**